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～竜騎士への道～

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Information

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Dragoon - The way to the dragon knight

Doragūn ~ ryū kishi e no michi ~

Author: [Mishima Yomu](#)
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Dragoon - The way to the dragon knight novel is a popular light novel covering Action, Adventure, and Comedy genres. Written by the Author Mishima Yomu. 170 chapters have been translated and translation of all chapters was completed.

Summary

Rudel Arses, the first born of one of the ‘Three Lords’ of the Courtois Kingdom, is from a corrupted family, but at 5 years old, he saw a dragon in the sky and his dark future as a villain changed. He was considered an idiot, but was that true? How would his effort to become a dragoon change the kingdom?

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Chapter 1

It was a territory not far from the capital of the Courtois continent's Courtois Kingdom, its vast lands belonging to one of the three top ranking nobles of the kingdom, the 'Three Lords'. These events would transpire in the lands of the archduke Arses. The Arses house was a lineage that had fallen to corruption over the long history of Courtois.

Exploiting a high tax from its people, that bribe-rampant territory lacked any sense of vigor. But as the people were unable to leave so easily, they could only put up with the pain.

In that vile noble house, the five-year-old selfish and overbearing eldest son Rudel Arses looked up at the sky with his eyes open wide.

"W-what's that!?"

What Rudel saw in the sky was a powerful body of deep emerald hue, and large wings that freely moved that build through the sky... those scales and horns that brought reptiles to mind gave its body a sense of greatness.

It was a dragon... and the ones who controlled them, the knights who protected the country were given the name Dragoon.

Rudel immediately asked the servants around him about the dragon he had seen in the sky. His tone was high-handed, and not the sort of attitude one would expect from a five year old child asking adults.

"What's that!? I never heard... why didn't you tell me!?"

The servants found it stranger there was a child in this country that didn't know about dragons. But they were dealing with the study-hating, exercise-

hating, ill-natured Rudel. Irritated as they were, the servants courteously explained the dragon and dragoon to the boy.

"Dragons are among the strongest of monsters, and they are ones who boast a high intellect." "The ones those dragons obey are the dragoon... the strongest knights in Courtois." "The knights who become dragoon possess not only strength, they are proud knights of, 'virtue'."

Hearing those words, Rudel's eyes turned from those of a fish rotten with pride, to the eyes of a young boy filled with admiration. But even upon hearing that...

"How much do you have to pay for 'virtue'? I'll put out as much as need be, so bring it to me ay once!"

Unable to understand virtue, his statement about buying his way to it brought in some truly fed-up looks from around. When they thought over how this was the next head of the house, the servants even held a light murderous intent... but there a single servant had an idea. Of how to teach this stupid brat the pains of reality...

At that time, no one could have imagined those words would drag in the Arses House and the Kingdom of Courtois. Right, it had all begun as the 'malice' of these overworked servants.

"Rudel-sama, 'virtue' is a show of a person's dignity and character. It is not something one can obtain with money. It is a valuable item one can only obtain with earnest effort."

On those words, Rudel made a face of failed comprehension. Rudel hated studying, and he was a selfish one. He did have a tutor, but not listening to the tutor's words, he had only attended class a handful of times.

"How can I become a dragoon? I want to be a dragoon!"

Hearing that, the servants sniggered within. You really think you can become one? Harsh training, testing one's knowledge and refinement,

Courtois' heroes among heroes even the dragons obeyed... the servants politely hammered that reality into Rudel.

"I believe it will be difficult... those who become dragoons are only the strongest knights of the kingdom. Meaning tempering their strength and kindness, knowledge and culture... you also have to receive acknowledgement from the dragons."

"You're saying it's impossible for me!?"

"Yes. But that is not a problem with you. It simply is that difficult to become a dragoon. It is said that even in the vast lands of Courtois, it's a blessing if ten dragoons are knighted in a year."

Rudel didn't take well to that explanation. His yearnings upon seeing the first dragon in his life burned strong enough to singe the young boy's chest.

"... How can I be one? If it's not impossible, then that doesn't mean there's absolutely no way to be one, right? How can I become a dragoon!?"

Sighing at Rudel's attitude, the servants put a subtext of, 'then quit playing around and fix that personality of yours!' into their explanation.

"Rudel-sama, if you continue with your current lifestyle, you will never become a dragoon. A lifestyle befitting a noble, unchanging kindness to all, and unceasing diligence is important... right now, you are lacking in every field."

The servants said it clearly. There was a reason they had to say so much. Generally speaking, Rudel was an idiot. His actions were exorbitant, and he was always troubling his surroundings. His parents only felt value in him as the next heir, leaving him to his own devices as they doted on his younger brother.

He would always instantly forget when someone made a fool of him. That was linked to the cold attitude of his servants.

Perhaps Rudel was actually quite a pitiful one. No one properly keeping him company, always made a fool of by the servants... but right now, Rudel had met an existence that made him lose interest in all of those things.

Rudel had found himself a goal. From that day forth, the selfish and prideful boy genuinely set out for nothing more than to become a dragoon.



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From the next day, Rudel rose with the rise of the sun. As he would always rise just before noon, there weren't even any servants in his room as he changed into exercise clothing. No, there was one servant there, but he was asleep in his chair, showing no signs of waking.

On the day the servants mocked him, he had gone around asking them all what he was supposed to do. While they found it a nuisance, the servants had reluctantly explained, and Rudel had memorized with all his might.

"Wake up early and run, eat healthy foods and chew well before swallowing..."

Mumbling to himself, Rudel left his room and set out... in the still-dim light of the mansion, the form of a wandering, muttering child was surely an ominous one indeed.

And the vast manor was practically what one would call a castle. As Rudel raced around the yard of the castle, he quickly wore himself out. Come so far, his daily disorderly lifestyle and overeating was tormenting him... when he was only five!

Seeing him like that, the servants and soldiers on guard raised their voices and laughed. Among them were even some who were blatantly mocking him. But within all of that, Rudel ran without paying them any mind.

By the time his finished running, his body was covered in sweat, and his body wasn't in a state where it could take in any food. But even so, he went

to the kitchen, and begged the chef to prepare something healthy. That was the first time Rudel made an earnest request, but upon hearing that, the chef- partly due to how busy he was in the morning- didn't even stop to think.

Understood, was all he said as he prepared a meal befitting the request.

Rudel's meals were generally alone. Not particularly loved by his parents, and continually scorned by the estate's servants. And what lined his one-man dining table was all the foods he hated... vegetables, dairy products, and chicken for protein... from a commoner's perspective, it was an extravagant feast, but Rudel was the eldest son of an archduke.

This was terrible treatment. What's more, there wasn't any sign the flavoring was done to his tastes. His hated vegetables were still bitter, and the other dishes weren't the sort of thing any child would like.

That was simply how much Rudel was hated. And even if he thought to get revenge, he was an idiot, so he would forget about it in no time, they would say as they blatantly harassed him.

But even so, Rudel,

"Thank you for the meal?"

Gave an awkward greeting as he ate his breakfast. Bitter! He thought as he endured to become a dragoon. And after that was study time with his home tutor. Even if Rudel had found motivation, the tutor had not. While he would generally answer when asked, the rest of it was thrown to the wind.

And even so, Rudel read his textbook, asking time and again on the things he didn't understand. The home tutor who thought of Rudel as an idiot,

"You don't even know that, and you're trying to be a dragoon? You really are a fool."

Spat some cynicism... but it was here that the mansions residents were under a misunderstanding. While there was a problem with Rudel's actions

and thoughts, his head wasn't too bad. While he would often take action without any thought, his head had never been for worse.

When he didn't know what to do in order to become a dragoon, he had asked the servants, and he had heard out their answers. And he instantly put it to action. Perhaps that was Rudel's strength. If instantly acting was Rudel's shortcoming, it was also his merit.

Next up was training in swordplay and martial arts. But even there...

"What's wrong, young master!? Teying to be a dragoon when you can't even block this attack, are you trying to make me laugh?"

Rudel cowered from the merciless attacks of his instructing soldier. That soldier who knew how to torment without leaving any lasting marks was a seasoned veteran. But after being stationed in this territory, his first task was to teach the idiot Rudel swordplay... he hit those feelings against the boy.

But even so, Rudel stood.

"How stubborn... well, let's see how long you can hold out!"



You could say the first day was the absolute worst. He was out of breath right after he started running, he didn't get anywhere with his studies, and his body was raising screams from the sordplay. Even so, Rudel pulled out a single book from the bookshelf and crawled into his own bed.

"Dragoons are the strongest knights..."

It was a book introducing the Courtois kingdom's dragoons in a way close to a picture book. As Rudel read it aloud, the servant to his side grew irritated.

(Just go to sleep already, damn brat... aah, I'm sleepy.)

He was much too late to notice... the fact that Rudel who had never decently done any study to that point was reading a book...

Once he had finished reading through, Rudel's eyes closed with the book still left on the bed.

"I'm definitely going to be a dragoon..."

He went right asleep. The servant took the book and returned it to its original place on the bookshelf. And turning the Rudel,

"Like hell you will. You really are an idiot... Fhaaah, I should get some sleep."

The reason the servant was there in the first place was in case of emergencies. He was definitely not in a position where it was alright to sleep.

Chapter 2

On another morning, Rudel ran out again. Having turned ten, Rudel had learned to control the Mana throughout his body to run at a breakneck pace. If he ran in the yard, his parents and the servants would complain, so now he would leave the castle, and run along the city's outer wall... to be more precise, he would run perpendicular to the wall. Such was the amount of speed he put out.

He would run until the time came that his stomach rang out, and trusting in his stomach's clock, he would return to the castle only to find breakfast had been prepared right on time. In a room without any other, he would eat his breakfast... Rudel's daily life hadn't changed in five years.

He would uphold proper manners as he ate, and without fail,

"Thank you for the meal!"

He would say his prayers. Seeing him like that, the servants found Rudel to be eerie. As he talked to himself in an empty room... even with five years gone by, Rudel's treatment hadn't changed.

But even so, Rudel wasn't sad. To Rudel, who simply dreamed of becoming a dragoon as soon as possible, he had no time to worry about anything else, and he didn't know what kindness was to begin with. The only time he ever studied it was within the realm of his books.

Lately, he was asking his tutor less and less. His tutor concluded that he had given up trying. But Rudel had seen through his home tutor's ability. It became more often that he wouldn't get much of an answer even if he asked, so he had switched over to self-study.

He had made numerous requests to his parents for a new tutor, but they wouldn't take him seriously. The reason being, that tutor highly praised his younger brother Chlust. They had taken quite a liking to the tutor who would say, Chlust has a great future ahead of him...

But even Rudel had someone he could respect. His former mercenary swordplay instructor. He had no relation to young Chlust. Chlust was off being taught by some other famous swordsmaster.

A martial art and swordstyle close to real combat reliably trained up Rudel's body. It was because he could experience it first-hand that Rudel respected the soldier... though he was still mocked nonetheless...

And one day a turning point did come to his life. The birth of a younger sister. His 'two sisters' who would turn three this year were by no means twins. Rudel's father had sown a seed elsewhere.

The first was Erselica, born of his own mother, and the other was Lena. The two of them received complete opposite treatments. Erselica was doted on to no end. Yet while that went on, Lena received only the minimum interaction.

In Courtois where blond hair was most common, Lena was a girl who boasted a rare set of black hair and black eyes. She was holed up in her room more often than not. Yet between Lena and Rudel, a strange stream of meetings would repeat. Rudel's room was on the second floor, while Lena's was right below it.

While Rudel would start moving each day with the rise of the sun, exiting through the front door soon became a pain... he had taken to jumping out of the window. The first time Lena spotted him, she thought of him as a suspicious character. And from that day, she would wake up at that time to observe the suspicious one.

Waking up at sunrise, going out, and returning every day at the same time. It was only a while later she learned he was her brother born of another mother.

At the time, Lena's impression of Rudel was,

"Cool..."

The young girl was somewhat of a strange one. Lena had a nature closer to Rudel. The sort of person who's body would move before her mind, a girl who would eat well and sleep often... and Lena had an interest in Rudel. She would follow him around each day to watch his back.

Perhaps because of that, the name Lena got in the mansion's gossip was the, 'lingering shadow'. The strange Rudel paired with his strange younger sister, it continued on regardless of the servants' disdain.



"... What are you doing over there?"

"Hah!?"

One day, having finished his sword training, Rudel decided to turn to Lena before returning to his room. He had noticed her for a while now, purposely keeping it off his mind. But as it went on day after day, he was beginning to run out of patience...

When he turned, he found a girl he had never seen before... that was Rudel's impression. As Rudel was fundamentally uninterested in the human relations within the mansion, he didn't even know of the existence of his sisters.

"Y-yo!"

While Lena gave something greeting-like, staring inquisitively at him, Rudel was troubled. He had never expected such a greeting to come in. And he grew some interest.

"... Yo?"

From that day forth, Lena got around to boldly approaching Rudel's side. Rudel had some interest in the girl who hung around him so restlessly, and

approved of it.

And they got around to eat breakfast together.

"Bwo, this is bitter..."

As she bit into a vegetable, Lena complained to Rudel. Rudel had eaten it for five years, so he didn't mind it, but generally speaking, Rudel's meals tasted terrible.

"It's full of nutrition, so you have to properly eat... chew well... no, don't just swallow it, you have to chew!"

The bitterness opening a hole in her stomach, Lena swallowed before she could taste the flavor. That was quite a surprise to Rudel... so such a method existed! Thought he... it seems Rudel and Lena were idiots all the same.

And he taught her studies as well. The home tutor was now nothing more than an existence that merely existed, and even if Lena was in the room, he wouldn't say anything.

"One, twoo, three... lots."

"... It's four."

Perhaps Rudel thought her a nuisance at first. But he learned how large her existence had become to him when Lena caught a cold. When the one who always followed him around wasn't there, he couldn't help but worry to no ends.

And seeing her following the following day, Rudel felt relief. Realizing that, Rudel...

"Were you lonely?"

"Why?"

"Nothing. Now don't be picky, you have to properly chew and eat... as I was saying, don't just swallow!"

At the fact he was able to have such a conversation over breakfast, Rudel gave his first heartfelt thanks.



On yet another day, Chlust and a girl he didn't know came walking down the corridor from the opposite direction. Rudel and Lena had business ahead, so of course they walked on. But Chlust and that girl walked right down the center of the passage.

Rudel was the eldest son. So when he walked down the hall, he rarely conceded the road to another. He walked towards Chlust head on... behind Chlust, a few servants held back as they watched the situation.

"Brother, won't you step aside?"

"Chlust, I'm your older brother, and I think my position here is higher than yours."

Brothers separated by a year, but those around thought of Rudel as an idiot, and Chlust a prodigy.

"Rudel-sama, Chlust-sama is in a hurry, so if you don't concede the way..."

One of the servants said it, but Rudel wouldn't stand down. He expressionlessly stood on the spot as he waited for the other party to stand down. The one irritated by it all was Chlust. Chlust would always hear it from those around,

'If only Rudel wasn't there... the one worthy of being head is Chlust.'

They would say. So he held an excessive dislike of Rudel's attitude. And before his cute little sister, conceding the road to Rudel was unthinkable. Erselica gripped Chlust's hand as she glared at Rudel, the brother she didn't get involved with.

The servants in the area knew this wasn't good. So while it would be a detour, they sent Chlust down a different path. Chlust turned his back to Rudel as he walked off...

Seeing her brother, Erselica spoke,

"You just have to do away with him..."

Blood brothers with a large wall in between them... Rudel and Chlust would end up feuding a number of times after that.

Chapter 3

At the age of fifteen, Rudel had become an adult. His body had grown, and his training had made it sturdy. At this point he could use elementary magic, and apart from swordsmanship, he had learned the spear and the bow... he had acquired various skills. His sister Lena who had followed him around all the way was eight. Her body was growing, and she was receiving a similar education to Rudel.

To Rudel, this year would be an extremely important one. It was decided he was to go to the private academy in Courtois' capital.

"Bro, are you really going to the capital?"

While Lena swung her specialty spear at him, Rudel judged it with his sword as he answered.

"Yeah, you should set your sights on it too. If you don't go there, you can't get the qualifications to be a knight."

Seeing Lena's lonely face, Rudel's heart hurt a bit. When he had finally come around to understand the thing called loneliness, Rudel found it to be nothing more than a troublesome emotion.

"Don't worry. I'll come back on the longer breaks."

"Really!?"

Even as they carried out a heartwarming conversation, they were swinging around their weapons. Their abilities had grown to such a level where it looked as if they were laughing as they tried to strike the other dead. Lena's footwork and the sharpness of her thrusts would put many an adult to

shame. And Rudel who could parry them as he carried on a conversation was quite something himself.

... If they weren't underestimated so, perhaps the two of them would be famous throughout Courtois in a good sense.

Rudel was famous in a certain way. As a stupid brat who couldn't even come out in high society... that was Rudel's evaluation that had spread throughout the world. In Courtois where it was stressed that the eldest son succeed a house, unless something terrible happened, it wasn't permitted for a younger son to take over.

Feeling his sweaty clothing stick to his body, Rudel put a hold on the training. Matching that, Lena sat down on the spot and got her breathing in order.

"Is the academy fun?"

"Who knows? To me, it's a place to become a knight, and I don't really care if it's fun or not... I wouldn't want to go to a place that's just fun, but won't make a knight of me."

Rudel carried out maintenance on his training sword as he answered Lena's question. Lena had learned how to do it as well, and she began looking after her spear.

"How do you become a knight?"

"You have to finish the regular curriculum, get enough credits in the required knight courses, and take the combat and written exams."

"Uuurrgh... I'm really no good with written exams."

Once that conversation was over, Rudel noticed the sun was beginning to fall. Standing right up, he walked off towards the manor. His stomach clock was telling him it was time for lunch.



A few days later, Rudel boarded a carriage set for the academy's matriculation ceremony. With a lineage from one of the three lords, the carriage was extravagant, and all the furniture and daily necessities were expensive goods.

The eyes of the civilians as they watched such a carriage were terrible dark.

It wasn't a good feeling to watch the son of the nobles exploiting them off on a trip in an extravagant carriage. Of the ones who came to see him off, his parents and the servants' attitudes didn't change much from usual. On the contrary, some of them rejoiced.

'He's finally gone.'

Lately, Rudel had gotten around to feeling lonely. In these ten years, he had paid special care to treating all with respect. The fact that his evaluation still hadn't changed must have been his own fault, he thought.

He found it hard to bear his past assessments forever, and at the same time, he thought that was simply how hopeless he had been. But even so, Rudel wanted to be a Dragon.

As he set off, Rudel had a letter from his sister Lena clasped in his hand.

'Do your best!'

Those words alone lightened his heart up considerably... looking outside the carriage window, he saw the skies were as high as ever. And at the same time, he spotted the dragon he yearned for racing across it. Hurriedly sticking his body out the window as if to jump out, he continued gazing at the dragon.

The beast that went out of sight before long stirred up his heart. Could this not be the dragon blessing my journey? Rudel made himself misunderstand. And using that as fuel, he resolved himself to do his best at the academy.



Having seen a dragon even before reaching Courtois Academy, Rudel was in high spirits. He was dragged right into what you could call the academy's kickoff specialty, the traffic congestion around its gates. But even so, in his high spirits, Rudel killed time without a care in the world.

The book on dragoons he had read through enough to wear out the bindings, and his new textbooks that would become indispensable at school... he read them through to crush time.

"As I thought, this is a nice book no matter how many times I read it."

Was it strange for a grinning fifteen year old boy to read something close to a picture book? Perhaps thinking so, the academy's general admitted students sent Rudel some sickened eyes as they walked passed the carriage.

There, a single young girl raise a large voice.

"How idiotic. Reading a picturebook made just to flatter those stuckup dragoons... humans really are savages, and you nobles are beyond help."

Rudel overreacted at that voice. Putting the book down, he jumped from the carriage and glared at the girl. Green hair and long ears... looking at the girl who could be none other than an elf demi-human, Rudel gave an objection.

"I want you to take that back..."

Rudel himself couldn't understand why he leapt from the carriage and drew close to the girl. When he usually wouldn't pay the slightest mind to surrounding opinions, for him to react to such an extent was downright strange... Rudel convinced himself that he was just nervous, having come to an unfamiliar place.

"... I'm sorry. I may have said too much."

"Hah? What are you talking about? More importantly, that crest on your carriage is the seal of Archduke Arses, right? So you're the eldest son of the worst territory in Courtois?"

When Rudel tried to bring the matter to a close, this time the girl drew closer. The Arses House's rule was terrible. He knew that, and he did feel sorry for the people. Rudel himself had consulted with his parents a number of times, but 'Don't stick your mouth in!' they wouldn't take him seriously.

Yet to Rudel, the girl with large slightly-slanting eyes went on.

"How carefree! When there are people suffering because of you, you're sitting here reading a picture book? Isn't there something else you should be doing!?"

The elf girl admonished him with overbearing eyes. But the servants in his carriage nodded at those words without the slightest attempt to save Rudel. Against the eldest son of one of the three lords, this wouldn't pass as mere rudeness. What the general elf student was doing was an action that may result in the execution of her entire tribe.

It wasn't favorable to have commoners ridiculing nobles. The guards at the academy gates gathered to control the problem. It was something that happened every year, and they barely even reported it at this point. It was an indefinite cycle...

"I understand they are suffering. That is why I came here to learn... if I've said something to offend you, I apologize."

Rudel couldn't understand why he had picked a fight with this girl. He'd usually just ignore it...

All present were taken aback by Rudel's response... it was so rare to see a high-ranking nobles apologize that they were troubled to respond.

While that was going on, a single boy rounded the gate, coming on foot just like the generally admitted students. He wore the splendid garb of a noble, though he had dressed it down a bit. As he came upon the indescribably scene of Rudel and the girl, he let out a laugh.

"Oy, oy, what's an inexperienced kid like you doing, approaching such a young elven maiden?"

??? No one present could understand his words. At that moment, everyone around was struggling to respond to Rudel's apology... sure enough, based on how you looked at it, it could possibly appear as if he was approaching her, but...

Shimmering gold hair, the boy with mismatched eyes of blue and green boasted features so beautiful they came off as ominous. A boy so beautiful it was unnatural... on his clothing, the 'Seal of Count Hardie' was embroidered in golden thread.

"No, we're already done here."

The elf girl quickly regained her composure, leaving as if to flee from the Hardie boy and Rudel.

"Huh? By the event, that was supposed to become a duel to set up her flag... did I fiddle around with history a little too much?"

Those around found the boy's loud monologue considerably eerie. 'A duel? Give us a break! That guy's from one of the Three Lords' houses! It'll be our responsibility!' By the soldiers' ulterior motives, Rudel and the boy were forcibly parted, and Rudel's carriage gained priority to enter the academy.

That was to be the meeting of the 'protagonist' boy, and his 'foil' Rudel.

Chapter 4

After that ruckus at the academy gate, Rudel dismounted the carriage, and carried his belongings off to the boys' dorm he would be using. His few possessions were brought in with only a few round trips, and after the servants gave some vague words of parting, they immediately made off.

"Not a bad room at all... though I get the feeling this room's a bit too big for one as part of a school dorm."

Removing his heavily ornamented nobles clothes, he changed into something easier to move in as he scanned over his schedule. After tomorrow's entrance ceremony, an explanatory meeting and a welcome party awaited. At age fifteen, the students would choose between a two, three, or five year curriculum... there was sure to be many more talented than he, and he was competing with them to be a knight.

As he thought over such a thing, Rudel started moving his body in the room he had finished getting in order. With all this tension and anxiety, if I don't move around... he felt.

But even if he did it, he couldn't calm down. Ever since he came to the academy, he experienced anxiety and nervousness he had never felt before. He felt something close to an obsession forcing him to leave his room.

"What is this? This has never happened before..."

He spoke as he put on just enough clothing that he wouldn't be embarrassed if seen walking around. Even if he walked around the academy- the immediate area around the boys' dorm to be precise- 'this isn't the place,' a strange feeling resounded through his head... oh whatever! He let his legs move as they fancied.

And where his feet led him... was the girl's dorm.

"Am I really that pent up? No, that's, well... I am a guy, and it's not like I don't have any interest."

Rudel was quite flustered at the fact he had unconsciously walked here. To him, a number of female soldiers approached warily.

"What are you doing over there? That is the girls' dorm, and it's forbidden for any males to enter."

It was a courteous explanation, but the girl's dorm held some students of high social standing. As these soldiers would be the first to be disposed of if anything happened, the boys were nothing but troublesome existences.

Because of that, polite as they were, there was power in the hands they used to grip the swords on their waists.

"M-my apologies. I just lost my way... could you direct me towards the boys' dorm?"

"... I'll take you there. But don't think that excuse will work a second time."

The fed-up group stuck a single on Rudel and sent him on his way.

"Good grief, it will be troublesome if you nobles don't get a grip on yourselves! Listen here, one mistake, and it'll be a large problem that'll erupt in turmoil between houses..."

The female soldier walking ahead scolded and explained with a weary voice. These academy problems that were often hushed up were sources of unceasing hardships for the soldiers.

Looks like you have it hard... was all Rudel could feel. He had no indecent feelings to start with, and it was a place he didn't think he'd approach again. Rudel occasionally apologized to the female soldier's words as he walked down the path to the boys' dorm.

"Ah! Could you show me your student ID? It's regulations, for argument's sake, so I have to confirm your identity..."

From nobles to general applicants, the academy housed countless students, and carrying around a student ID was an obligation. It was a measure to make sure no strange folks slipped in, but managing the students was its main purpose. The student ID recorded the number of house arrests to that point, and the sorts of problems one had caused.

"Here you go."

Aiming for a lawful life, Rudel carried around his ID just as stated in the school regulations he had confirmed beforehand. When he handed it over...

"... Rudel Arses? Archduke Arses-sama's!!! M-my deepest apologies!!! I have gone too far beyond my bounds! You had some sort of business at the girls' dorm, correct? I'll take you back at once..."

"N-no, I really was just lost!"

"Yes! I-in that case, I shall call for, 'someone who can introduce you to those sorts of woman'.. so please, if possible... please, not the students... my apologies, I'm being rude, aren't I."

Rudel looked upon the flurried female soldier with considerable pity. And at the same time, he understood just how he was seen... did he really look that starved? That on his mind, he became terribly depressed.



Somehow managing to clear up the misunderstanding, Rudel returned to his room and relaxed. Perhaps interacting with more people than ever before had worn him out, and while it was still early, he decided to sleep.

Once morning came, he opened his eyes at daybreak as had become custom. After going to get the uniform he forgot to retrieve the day before, he realized he had the time, so he decided to venture out to the boys' dorm courtyard.

But that scene was nowhere near tranquil. The crude crowd of men practiced their swords and held matches, the sound of wood and metal colliding ringing out all around. The sight was one that delighted Rudel.

(Everyone's working hard after all. If I don't put in my best, they'll overtake me in no time.)

So Rudel found an open space in the yard and started swinging his sword. A number of upperclassmen spotted him and tried to say something, but instead decided to leave him be as they shed their own sweat.

After a while went by, the bell rang out six times... hearing that, the students began cleaning up and walking towards the cafeteria. Rudel hesitated over whether or not to follow.

"You're a new student, aren't you? Even if you're going over, you can take it easy for now... the place is empty around this hour."

"It was written that the cafeteria was popular, so it's better to hurry."

Rudel recalled a list of important pointers he had read sometime before. In regards to that, the upperclassman boy,

"It gets crowded when the bell rings seven times. But the folks around here are about the only ones up at this hour."

So like that he followed his upperclassmen, and entered the school cafeteria. In it, the forms of boys with their plates piled high with food... caused his own stomach to hurt.

"See, isn't it empty? I'm Vargas, a third year."

"I'm Rudel. Rudel Arses."

"A noble? I'm from the sticks, so I'm a bit dim when it comes to nobles... well whatever, let's get along."

Upperclassman Vargas, with his long, red hair tied behind. His cocoa tanned skin and firm build did feel a bit frightening, but after talking to him, he

was a sociable young man.

"Yes!"

To Rudel, it was the moment he got a friend he could talk to outside of his family.



Returning to his room from the cafeteria, Rudel changed into his uniform, entering a large building under academy orders. Rather than an auditorium, it was practically... right, it was a space like an arena. As fighting did actually happen in this space, the description wasn't wrong, but...

"I rejoice at the many youngsters we welcome through our doors this ye..."

After receiving the long address of the headmaster, the students were split into classes and sent to their classrooms. Generally speaking, the school taught only the basis over the first two years, and the class separation was only in place to separate opposing nobles, or gather those of low standing in one place... they were arbitrary things.

But Rudel was the eldest son of the Arses House, one of the Three Lords. To avoid any discourtesy, he was sent to the class solidified with young nobles. And this year, besides Rudel, the eldest sons of the other Three Lords would be entering as well, so the academy was filled with a tense air.

"I hope we get along for the next two years."

The homeroom teacher gave a light greeting, and the class introductions... was supposed to end safely.

But it couldn't be so. Something would happen, no, he had to make something happen! A strange sensation ruled over Rudel. Worrying over that sensation he had never felt before coming to this university, Rudel finished his own introduction without incident.

And yet!

"Izumi Shirasagi."

With the introduction of a single girl of the orient, the air of the classroom took a turn. Black hair and eyes were a rare sight in Courtois; those oriental characteristics became the perfect target to the children. Jeers flew, and statements to hurt the girl fluttered around.

A class centered around nobles. For an orient girl to be in that class, it was likely under the pretense of cultural exchange. In actuality, it was to direct eyes towards her to make sure the nobles didn't snarl at one another.

The boys behind her pulled at her long, ponytail-tied hair in jest... In the girl being harassed, Rudel saw his own sister Lena. Unlike Lena's uncurling hair looked silky to the touch.

"Why don't you stop? Do you know how shameful you look?"

It only took a line from Rudel's mouth for the classroom to return to silence. The teacher endorsed it and cautioned the students who teased her. For these kids who grew up in noble society, they were well attuned to the pecking order. By house status, there was no one who could oppose Rudel of the Three Lords.

And at the end, the teacher praised Rudel, and those around approved... to Rudel, that scene looked terribly twisted.

Chapter 5

Rudel had safely entered the academy. With confirming the basics, and understanding individual situations, the first three months at the academy consisted of aptitude tests. Everyone had lived in a different environment... the differences in individual achievement and environment would help shape future policies.

And like that, the academy was evaluating their new students... but the teachers feuded over Rudel's assessment.

"This can't be possible! The fact he already completed basic education is one thing... but from elementary magic to swordplay and martial arts, these numbers are simply abnormal!"

"And I heard Rudel-sama of the Arses House was supposed to be a failure."

"Looks like we have a good harvest this year... the other Three Lords' eldest sons are also specialized in magic and swordplay."

"But is it not insignificant when put against Aleist Hardie's abnormality? That boy can use advanced magic, can he not? Even though he's self-taught, his swordplay's quite something."

"Using and mastering are different things! This is why you big-headed oafs are... listen here, Rudel-sama has already mastered elementary magic. In the mock-battles, the examiners taking him on grow weak at the knees and resign partway through!"

The teachers mulled... right, being incapable was a problem, but being too capable was just as much. In regards to how troubled they were in handling him...

Labelled a problem child, while Rudel was fundamentally an idiot, he was honest. He earnestly listened to his lessons, and there was no problem with his attitude towards the teachers. He had a hatred of any malicious teasing, and in class, he was suppressing the surroundings.

There was little to teach him. Rather, there was nothing!

In the combat test mock battles, a number of examiners had already been defeated. Even if they were examiners of the basic curriculum, they had a level of ability.

And Rudel would occasionally display extraordinary behavior. He had challenged students who had gained knight qualifications to a match, and questioned the talented students and teachers studying magic whenever he didn't understand something... he would do all manner of unexpected things.

And the problem was his declaration, 'I want to be a Dragoon'. The heroes among heroes whose caliber was difficult to find in all of the country... if a well-to-do noble brat said he wanted to be one, there would be people who'd pick a fight. But Rudel's standing was so high that if anything happened, it wouldn't be strange for everyone's head to fly.

"Why did it come to this!? He's so terribly talented and earnest we can't even caution him, and pushing discipline onto him is difficult..."

The teacher's distress continued on...



Three months since enrollment, Rudel was reviewing the lesson with Izumi in the classroom. To Izumi who had come from a foreign land, she could never fail to review.

"This is difficult..."

While she was good with numbers, word problems were her undoing. As things were, this would definitely make for something terrible.

Sitting beside her, Rudel read a book as he overlooked Izumi's studies. Even Rudel had his problems. Izumi's clothes were too light... brimming with interest, Rudel struggled to keep it suppressed in his heart.

(Kuh! Why is it so light... I can see right through to your skin can I not!!!)

At fifteen in the midst of puberty, Rudel had begun to develop interest in things apart from Dragons. And lately, he had been privy to a variety of encounters. The knight in charge of the girls' dorm security, and the basic magic teacher... they were all women.

(Is it that? A trial to seduce me and prevent me from becoming a dragoon? Then I shall not lose!!!)

Rudel found new resolve in the strangest of places. Why had he stumbled down such a monk-like train of thought?



So Rudel decided to consult Vargas on the matter.

"... Yeah, so? You don't have to react over every light piece of clothing you see! And of course you'll have some contact with the dorm manager and female teachers if you're a student! How old are you supposed to be?"

To Rudel's consultation, Vargas gave a weary answer.

"Fifteen."

"I know! I was asking about your mental age! Listen here, just..."

Just as Vargas was about to explain, two female teachers crossed their paths. Spotting them, the teachers waved their hands in greeting. Vargas put on airs as he waved back... Rudel seemed to want to say something.

"Y-yeah. You and me, we're both young, is all it means. Yep!"

"What do I have to do to stop being mindful of it? Honestly, enduring it and such feels like I'm wasting time, or rather..."

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"Who knows? Perhaps it'll be different if you get some experience or something."

On Vargas' careless remark, Rudel sprung to action. Standing from the start, he found new resolve.

"Got it! I'll go get experience! Thank you Vargas!"

... On Rudel's words, at first Vargas saw him off with a wave. Once Rudel was out of sight, he finally realized.

"Ah! Wait! Hold it, Rudel!!!"



Rudel hadn't confirmed what he was supposed to experience. So the boy had come to the library to collect data. It was a library worthy of a private academy, and for now, Rudel was searching for a book pertaining to experience.

"... It's no good. I can't find anything."

Normally, he'd use the place whenever he wanted to research the ecology of dragons, and the skills he'd need to be a dragoon, so he had never even imagined it would take time to find something. Then I just have to ask! He had continued acting on pure instinct...

'The following student(s) have been put under house arrest. Rudel Arses.'

In the discipline room of the boys' dorm, Rudel sat in a chair. He prayed that this wouldn't have any influence on his future. This won't prevent me from becoming a dragoon, right? More importantly, isn't two weeks of penitence a bit much? All I did was say, give me some experience! What's experience? All I did was ask...

As Rudel thought over such a thing, Vargas brought him his meal.

"The hell were you doing!? Listen, when it comes to experience between man and woman, it's got to be ○ ○ ○! Now try saying that with a straight face... are you a pervert!?"

"You have a point. I've never heard of someone greeting with the words, 'Want to have ○ ○ ○?' But can you really say it never happens?"

"What's with that train of thought!?"

While this may be a digression, of the women pressed by Rudel... he had called out to a few hundred, and received relatively favorable replies from a few dozen.

Among them, several... female students even said okay.

As Rudel had perfectly exercised the strategy, 'if you shoot enough times, you'll eventually hit something,' from that day forth, the male students held him in awe, and granted him the title the, 'Pickup Guy'.



Aleist Hardie was a reincarnator. Blond hair, and heterochromia garnished his unnatural-level beauty... that was Aleist. He held a complete understanding of this world. Its growth system, events, capture guides... it had all come from the world of a game he loved.

Within all of that, there was an existence he could call irregular. Rudel.

His role was supposed to be that of the son of a prideful noble, and the symbol of the vile nobles tormenting the people. With a nature that hated hard work and resolved everything with money, he'd calmly carry out the most cowardly of deeds.

Rudel was supposed to be a stepping stone character to the protagonist Aleist. In the opening event, he was supposed to defeat Rudel drawing close to an elf girl in a cool manner, setting up a flag with that girl.

Right after that, Rudel would take his tag-alongs and have a dispute at the girls' dorm. There, the elf girl would seek help from him, and he'd defeat Rudel and his followers... it was supposed to be a big event where Aleist would suddenly become popular, but Rudel had returned right after he appeared.

"What's going on? Is it my fault for not being a commoner like the protagonist? Is it because I got this count status that the girls won't approach? ... In that case, this is the worst! Why did I have to go wish for status 'back then'! I'm an idiot!!"

But that would surely end soon. At the end of the first year, an event awaited him. The class tournament separated tournament... a one-on-one battle between five class representatives of each year.

"My current status is that of an advanced job 'Rune Knight', and I can use advanced magic. Honestly, I can fight the graduates at my level. So how am I going to kill time until then... there aren't events with the main cast yet, and I haven't met the elf 'Millia' since then... aah, I'm bored."

To Aleist who knew everything there was to know about the growth system from the start, it was easy to reach an advanced job by the time he turned fifteen. In magic and swordplay, Aleist was called the strongest in his year.

... Yet the opening cast he spoke of, 'Millia', 'Izumi', and 'Vargas' had all come in contact with Rudel already.

Get off your ass and look for them, Aleist-kun...

Chapter 6

A long break in the school year. Alongside it, Rudel returned to his home. Even if he was only gone for three months, everything had been a first for him, and felt a bit of growth on his part.

But there was no change in his treatment at his home Arses House. Even more than that... the moment his father saw his report card, he became jealous of the boy who was performing even better than he had. Rudel's father wasn't that good of a boy himself, and once he learned his idiot son Rudel was more talented than him, his attitude took a blatant change.

“What good is that scrap of paper!? No matter how much effort a worthless human like you puts in, there's no point at all!”

Rudel's father had put all his expectations on Chlust. Smart and obedient Chlust... Yet the talented Rudel had surpassed all the talent he saw in Chlust.

“Your face is an irritating sight to behold!”

If they realize I'm not useless, would the surrounding attitude change? Rudel's light expectations fell as they came. Having experienced various meetings in the academy, his life at home was all the more painful.



“Bro? When you've finally come home, you don't look to well.”

Rudel's half-sister Lena grew curious as she ate breakfast with him, and posed the question. Her brother who would usually eat the terrible-tasting breakfast without leaving anything behind had barely touched his meal.

“Yeah, let’s see... hey, why do you think I’m hated?”

“? What are you talking about, bro? I love you quite a bit.”

Rudel was exposed to the pure smile of his sister. His feelings grew a bit lighter.

“I see... that’s right. Thank you, Lena.”

Rudel thought. There was a time when he thought the surrounding attitudes were only natural. But now he had grown to feel anxiety at the hatred around him... it was surely because he was weak, he convinced himself.

And at the same time, Rudel knew he had to treasure the people who did hold a positive impression of him. From here on, he was sure to face more precious encounters.

“And also! You’re not going to become a dragoon like that. My big brother’s a guy who never loses hope.”

On those words, Rudel burst into a smile. Lena’s reaction showed she didn’t know what was going on.

“That’s right! That’s exactly right. It’s not like me to be depressed forever. Want to do some training outside?”

“Yeah! I need to show you how much stronger I’ve become in your three months away.”



Like that, the break ended, and Rudel returned to school. He arrived at the academy a few days early, and when he looked around, the only acquaintance he could find was Izumi. Rather... he hadn’t even asked if Izumi returned home.

Preparing some sweets from his home territory as a gift, Rudel invited Izumi to the cafeteria for tea. He brought with him some standard baked pastries. Seeing them, Izumi accepted them apologetically.

“I’m sorry. I wasn’t able to bring any souvenirs.”

On those words, Rudel asked without thinking.

“You didn’t go home? Why?”

While she hesitated a bit, Izumi had come to understand Rudel’s personality to an extent over the course of three months. Rudel rarely acted after reading the mood. He wouldn’t even bother to remember things that didn’t interest him. On the other hand, he would try his hardest to learn all there was to learn over what he had an interest in...

Giving up, Izumi explained.

“My home’s far away, and my household was never very affluent. And I’m a woman, right? Yet here I am commuting to school in a foreign land. I have quite a few relatives who don’t think too highly of it. It may be difficult to understand with our difference in culture.”

Rudel listened in all seriousness. To him, whether she was woman or man wasn’t a large problem. There were female knights among the Dragoon. That was more than enough proof that women could be just as skilled.

What’s more, he was interested in Izumi’s orient swordplay. The first time he saw her pulling out her slender, curved, ‘katana,’ to slice, he found himself moved.

But be that as it may, Rudel wouldn’t refute her culture.

“There are many things I don’t know about culture, so I can’t say anything about it. But I don’t think you need to look down on yourself just because you’re a woman. You’re strong, and beautiful.”

“wait, what!? R-Rudel? Did you hit your head or something?”

Izumi’s face reddened. But at the same time, she recalled Rudel’s personality. From her point of view, Rudel could be summed up as an oddball. At times he would take exorbitant action, and because of that, he

would often drag in his surroundings. But he was a hard worker, and earnest at his base... Rudel was fundamentally unable to flatter.

It was quite often she was troubled by him saying whatever came to mind, but hearing him call her beautiful was something she was happy about.

“What’s wrong? Did I say something bad again? Then I’ll apologize...”

“Hah, that isn’t it. I’ve just never had someone look me in the face and call me beautiful before... anyways, did you enjoy your trip home?”

Izumi tried to change the subject. But,

“Oh? Was my house fun? I’m more interesting in learning what I said wrong.”

Unable to avoid it, Izumi carefully explained it to him with a reddened face. To make it a bit more indirect, or that she’d misunderstand if he said it so seriously to her face... so it came to pass that two days before school would resume, the scarce remaining students watched over Rudel and Izumi with warm eyes.



The second term, and the period with the most school events. The first and second year student were just taught the basic curriculum, so they carried them out alongside their daily studies. But the academy was generally a place to put out knights and magicians, war power and officials for the state... the events were made in order to match.

“Next month, we’ll be training in the art of monster hunting. This is a joint event between all the first and second years, and you won’t get any credit if you skip out.”

As the homeroom teacher explained, the class largely populated by nobles let out some boos. It was training utilizing the forest close to the grounds. Of course, even if you called it close, it was still a few kilometers away...

the monster hunting training there basically taught how to use groups to subjugate monsters practically anyone could defeat.

It was combat training to pound group coordination into their bodies. Of course, a monster subjugating specialist would tag along. With the opposition between classes, it was also a sort of competition. And the first ranking class between the two years gained the reward called honor... well, they didn't really get anything.

“Combat, eh... it's my first real battle.”

Rudel was fired up over the training everyone was so reluctant to take part in. He would be taking on monsters anyone could take down, but those monsters generally came in large numbers. While guaranteeing the safety of the academy, they were also reducing the monster populations, making it quite a beneficial training session.

“Then let's begin class. Open your textbooks to...”



An abnormality was breaking out in the forest close to the academy. Trees had fallen, and the corpses of weak monsters were scattered all over the place. Alongside a low growl, a large body covered in fur moved.

“Grrrrruuu!!!”

A single powerful boar, its red eyes glowed as it made a mess of a monster. Alongside that clearly abnormal scene, the monster mismatched with the place disappeared into the depths of the forest.

A black pelt, with white lines racing all over its body, a monster that had never been sighted before. But just what meaning could the appearance of this ‘non-existent monster’ hold...

Chapter 7

The academy's air was different than usual. The students of the standard curriculum had all gathered on the grounds, wearing easy-to-move-in clothing, each of them carrying a weapon. The weapons were either personal possessions or ones borrowed from the academy, and there was no sense of uniformity with their equipment.

"Henceforth, you shall march to the nearby forest..."

The teacher charged with explaining told the students all the important points and dangers. But in the end, thinking they were just taking on some weak monsters, the students were lax.

The march began. It was an established annual event, so perhaps the teachers were lacking tension as well... as they marched in considerable numbers, their appearance ranged from children with children weapons to a full-fledged army. Right, a mishmash of an army...



Aleist's class proceeded forward with Aleist at the front eliminating everything in his path. To Aleist, this event was good EXP farming, nothing more and nothing less.

"Ah, Aleist, that's no good, I'm telling you! You're destroying the forest."

From repeated attacks of wide-range intermediate magic, the forest trees were felled, and the earth gouged out... almost as if a storm had passed through...

His classmates watched him as if they were looking upon something dreadful. But the boy in question didn't notice. For that was all this event

was to him...

"Something of this level's no problem at all... and if we keep at it like this, we'll come in first."



On another path than the group brute forcing their way through, Rudel proceeded forwards with much hardship. While his classmates marched through the forest, someone would have to take command. The monster hunting specialists watched the students from the rear, and if things grew dangerous, they would call out orders.

But in all other cases, Rudel was chosen as commander due to his high grades. Of course, the fact no one could go against his lineage was another reason. It was a single method to shut up the young nobles.

Perhaps that was why... between the high nobles, this had become something of a competition. Though Rudel didn't seem to care...

The experts irrelevant to all of that grinned as they watched over Rudel's clumsy command and combat. When he tried to move, comrades would be in the way, and while he fought, those comrades would find themselves lost... a glance was enough to know they were facing troubles.

"Kuh! We're not getting anywhere."

"Calm down, Rudel. More than the monsters, just proceeding through this forest is pushing our limits."

Izumi explained to Rudel. Looking around, his classmates tired from walking through unfamiliar woods had suffered more injury from the trees than any monster.

As such matters repeated, the sun began its downward climb, and the forest grew dark. As camping was also a part of the training, the class assembled from nothing but nobles was at a severe disadvantage. Of course, that class had some talented experts supporting from behind.

"Oy! Why do I have to do something like pitch a tent!?" "Hurry it up! We're all tired, and we want some rest!" "Then why don't you do it, penniless noble!"

Behind, the experts smiled as they looked over these annual customs. Rudel was also irritated things weren't going his way. Looking at the map, he felt disheartened at the fact he couldn't even reach the designated point.

"So the forest is a bigger threat than the monsters... can't laugh at that."

The goal of this event was to be the first ones to reach the destination point. At this rate, it was quite plausible they would come in last. The classes with more commoners had advanced a considerable distance. At this point, there was surely a great divide between them. Was this the reality... Rudel thought as his spirits dropped.

"Let's just rest for today. We can set out early tomorrow."

Izumi's consoling didn't have much of an effect on him. To Rudel, this was a vital event that would influence his grades. In becoming a dragoon, his grades at the academy would be one of the criteria. When he thought of it like that, Rudel couldn't keep still.

"We'll definitely make up for today's loss tomorrow!"

Rudel resolved himself. But reality wasn't so sweet.



The monster hunting experts, there were various ways to refer to them, but they were pretty much soldiers. They ranged from the stray mercenaries and adventurers, to those extraordinarily skilled in defense... various sorts had gathered.

Among them were some hoping for fateful encounters through this event. By no means related to romance. They were guards trying to sell themselves to the young nobles... they had obtained information on the

influential nobles beforehand. While it wasn't strictly legal, if they didn't do that much, they'd be overtaken in no time.

A member of their ranks, Basyle was a woman whose brown skin and light blond hair served as her characteristics. Equipped with a bladed cane one couldn't say for certain was a spear or a staff, she wore the highly exposing attire of a dancer. Thinking of her location, it was quite improper, but that was merely proof of what was allowed at her level of ability.

... After that long trip through the forest, she was unscratched.

"Well, for these kids, I guess it's a passing grade?"

She made a decision as she looked over Rudel's group's camp. Of course, it was as a decision taking into account these were nobles on their first outing... by normal criteria, they were out of the question.

One of Basyle's fellow guards spoke.

"The lookouts've dozed off, the bonfire's about to go out... the way things are going, the folks around won't be getting any sleep."

He shrugged as he gave his judgement. Night was when the monsters were most active. It was the time period carrying the greatest danger.

"I'm glad I got to be a guard of this class. When all's said and done, we have the Arses house, and all manner of deep-pocketed nobles... the more incompetent they are, the more chances there are to get on the market."

To Basyle, if it would get her out of her day to day adventurer and guard position, then she had no problem with children. She even thought it fine to present her body.

"But... that Rudel's surprisingly decent. Those idiot information dealers have thrown off my plans."

The guards had thought Rudel would be completely useless in command. But his surprising tenacity had lessened their roles. She had wanted to have sold a favor by now...

"I'll have to return this debt of false information... but it really is strange. From what I've seen, he's reasonably talented."

Swordplay, magic, and battle... from the eyes of the guards, Rudel was decent. As he was in a difficult commanding role, his slipups stood out... but even so, you could say he passed. If he said he wanted to join her party, then pure ability-wise, she wouldn't have a problem with it.

"He's panicking, but from the surrounding reactions, he isn't hated too much. He's a fine article."

Basyle included, the guards' evaluations were surprisingly high... and they had been paid for another job. They were also the graders for this event.



While he was receiving such a high evaluation, Rudel himself felt impatience at the uncanny situation. On the third day, he confronted the reality he hadn't even made it half of the planned distance, and that his class was completely exhausted. Not from the monsters... they could raise an arm or leg to this unfamiliar forest environment.

"Why aren't we getting anywhere!?"

Those around felt fear at Rudel's irritation. Angering the eldest son of one of the Three Lords was something their parents told them to avoid by all means. The atmosphere naturally took a turn for the worse...

"Rudel... everyone's doing their best in an unfamiliar environment. And there's just a little more to go to the destination point. We're halfway there."

"And there's still half to go. At this rate, we really are coming in last..."

Rudel didn't care about appearance. He really only cared about the grade. While she noticed that, Izumi knew just how seriously Rudel was aiming to be a dragoon, leaving her unable to say anymore.

The two of them hung their heads as they thought over what was to come.
At that moment.

"W-what's that!?"

Rudel and Izumi raised their faces. In the direction one of their classmates pointed, they could see the large, black shadow of a monster. Its red eyes looked upon Rudel and the rest of the class as prey...

Chapter 8

The monster in the shape of a boar; its eyes let off an ominous red light as it raised a war cry. With his classmates that couldn't even move to his back, Rudel channeled the Mana circulating around his body, using his swords to receive its charge. And Izumi who managed to react tried cutting her katana into the boar, but...

"Wha! It's too hard to cut!"

The katana blade chipped, and unable to endure the impact, Rudel was sent flying. The boar used its hind legs to scratch at the ground a number of times... before charging at Rudel once more. His body crashing into the trees, Rudel could feel the pain spread through it.

"Kuh!"

This time, Rudel avoided it and fired off magic at the boar. Elementary magics of fire and wind did hit their mark head on, but the boar emerged without any injury.

"You're on!"

Regaining his stance, Rudel faced the boar. Seeing his form, a number of students gave a delayed response, attacking with magic, and the weapons in their hands.

Numbers were strength... but the monster wasn't weak enough to be suppressed by an exhausted class and injured Rudel.

Rudel hadn't given up. The dragoon were the strongest in Courtois. That meant if he lost he would have no future. A dragoon's loss would be the

defeat of the country... the information from some book he had read before revived in his head.

The tusks protruding from the boar's splendid lower jaw came up at Rudel...

Wringing out the power in his body, Rudel swung his sword. As a result... the boar's fang stuck into the ground, but Rudel lost the battle of power, and was sent through the air once more. Its tusk broken, the boar came at Rudel in a frenzy. When it was already difficult to stand, avoiding a body blow from the charging beast.

"Right, that's as far as you go."

Alongside a voice, the guards in the rear attacked at once. Their magic burned the boar, their swords and spears cut and pierced it... Rudel and his classmates were shown just how far their powers differed.

It was all over in an instant. An enemy they couldn't even raise a hand against... before the guards who defeated it in an instant, Rudel's heart was filled with humiliation. Shame that the swordplay and magic he had polished served no purpose at all, shame at the reality that he would've died had he not been saved.

It all filled Rudel with an intolerable vexation.



"Withdraw? Don't be stupid! Having come this far, we can't just withdraw!"

The words Izumi sent Rudel as he pulled himself to his feet: 'Let's withdraw'. Unable to see his surroundings through his shame and irritation, Rudel opposed.

"Rudel..."

Izumi hung her head. Perhaps sensing Rudel's feelings, she couldn't say any more.

"Just a little more to go..."

Right, it wasn't long to the destination point... only halfway more. They really had no choice but to withdraw. Exhausted classmates and injured Rudel. A continuation would be putting lives on the line.

Seeing Rudel, Basyle thought.

(Reality's a harsh mistress. If that monstrosity didn't show up, perhaps he'd make it to the goal... well, it's only natural a kid can't make decisions under these circumstances.)

From a guard's point of view, Basyle had determined any continuation was impossible, and had sent some ahead to inform the teachers. All that was left was to make Rudel give up. Telling herself that keeping a child company any longer would be a pain, she had already given up on selling herself to him.

Alord without his own judgement was just what Basyle wanted. But...

"W-we can go just a little further, right?"

"T-that's right, we can do it!"

"It's just a little more, so stay firm."

Looking over Izumi and Rudel, the classmates said it of their own accord. Was it to protect themselves, or were they mindful of Rudel? No one could say.

But those classmates had finally entered Rudel's eyes. It was there that he finally understood they weren't in a state to continue on. There was no helping the injuries, but their weapons were in tatters, and he could spy ragged faces. Going on any further would be dangerous...

Rudel made a fist with his right hand. And after a while, he undid it and declared...

"Our class is... withdrawing."



"Hmm, he's surprisingly decent."

In a separate place, Basyle gave her impression of Rudel. Seeing the young nobles persist was a surprise, but the fact Rudel resolved to withdraw upon seeing them was also praiseworthy.

Basyle shrewdly held the boar tusk Rudel had severed in her hand.

For some reason, the rest had turned to a black mist and faded. This tusk alone became the only proof of the existence of that abnormal boar... but that tusk looked exceptionally beautiful to Basyle. Almost like a first-rate material. She ended up putting it away in her own bags.

By school regulations, she wasn't supposed to save them unless they were on the brink. The guards wouldn't lift a hand unless the students showed a desire to be helped. She had used that timing to rescue them in time, but... she didn't know if it would get her employment on good terms.

If Rudel persevered a bit more...



"I'm saying I can walk..."

Having taken a strong blow to the body, Rudel borrowed a shoulder from Izumi and Basyle as he walked. At first, he had pushed himself to move by his own feet, but his body instantly raised screams. His bodily fatigue from using Mana, and the bruising across his body were simply too great.

"If you walk and fall behind the others, what are you going to do? We'll be there soon, so just hold out."

"As expected of the eldest son of the Arses House, but... your body's crying out."

Izumi was earnestly worried, while Basyle was trying to use her prized body as a weapon to approach Rudel... borrowing those shoulders of varied

intent, he arrived at the forest's exit.

Looked upon from the side, it was a truly envious sight to behold. The other guards were also buttering up the young nobles to sell their services.

Right, when looked at from the side, it looked at is Rudel was being waited on by beauties.

And as bad luck would have it, Aleist's class had just reached the goal by their own strength. Seeing Rudel's ragged class, Aleist's class took on a condescending attitude. The fact they reached the goal on their own had inflated their egos a bit.

"You lot withdrew? The hell are you doing in this forest of nothing but small fries?"

"What pitiful folk. Those noble disgraces..."

"Aleist, you say something too."

Someone in class called out to Aleist. To Aleist, this was an event where Rudel had exhausted out his own class. He was a defeatist who would say, 'I knew from the start we would never reach the goal'. He remembered the scene coming out in the event. And Rudel with a flower in both arms had appeared in the event as well.

By Aleist's memory, idiotic Rudel retired, borrowing the shoulders of a beautiful guard and the number one beauty in the class, 'Izumi Shirasagi', as he boldly made his way out... he surely recalled it.

In this event, the protagonist would remain uninvolved. But Aleist's desires came out. He wanted to give Izumi and the beautiful guard a good impression...

"When you've retired you've withdrawn, you've got a flower on each arm... are you looking down on it all? Why not think about the trouble you're causing those around you."

On those words, the jeers from Aleist's class began to get to Rudel's class' heads. When they had risked their lives facing a dangerous monster along the way... was there really a need to mock them so? ... Rudel let go of Izumi and Basyle's shoulders, coming out in front of Aleist.

"It's true that we withdrew, but we ran into a dangerous monster. And I'm understand that I'm troubling people."

Rudel knew he had exhausted his class, and on top of that, he had intended to urge them to continue on. But Aleist was referring to the two beauties.

"Hmm, what sort of monster was it?"

Rudel explained to Aleist. It was a ferocious boar monster, with a black body, white crest, and red eyes... once he finished explaining its characteristics, Aleist burst into laughter.

"There's no way such a monster spawns in this forest, fool. Listen here, if such a dangerous monster was here, this outing would never be held. You're just embarrassing yourself when you make such an excuse without understanding that basic fact."

Once he had finished his piece, Aleist sent a glance to Izumi and Basyle before leading off his classmates. Both of their faces seemed to say, the hell's he on about?

"I-I'm sorry, Rudel."

"We'll try harder next time."

"To think they wouldn't believe it... should I explain it to the teachers?"

As Rudel stood stock still, his classmates sent some comforting words. But Rudel looked on in surprise at the fact Aleist's class had barely suffered any injury at all. When his own group got injured simply by walking through the forest... Rudel could only feel more ashamed of himself.

He surely could have prepared more. If he had started gathering the information and equipment from the moment he was left in charge of the

class... Rudel turned to his classmates. He looked over them all.

"Everyone, this time was my slipup. I'm sorry... but if you'll still allow me to take command next time, I'll definitely bring our class to the goal. No, we'll be first! Next time, we'll aim for number one! So could you please leave next time to me... I know I'm asking for a lot here, but please!"

As Rudel lowered his head, those around were confused. They were certain he would lay the blame on them... from the class, one, and then another raise a voice of approval. Of course, the first one was Izumi.

Chapter 9

In a place that lay through a dimly lit alley, an old man who specialized in materials ran his business. Bringing her feet there, Basyle had brought the 'Boar Tusk' she had obtained in her last job. The old man enthusiastically appraised the tusk she declared as a first rate material.

"... Where did you get your hands on this? It's the first time I've ever seen something like it."

"That's a secret... so how much?"

Without asking any more, the old man simply gave a sigh. He had been acquainted with Basyle for a few years now, and while she was definitely skilled, it was questionable whether or not she had the ability to bring in a material of this caliber.

"In hardness and magical properties... it's all fairly high. 'Whoever' cut it off was considerably skilled."

Spewing some casual cynicism, she lay some money on the counter. Seeing that, Basyle tried a number of times to bargain up the price... at the end, she settled at the, 'exact price the old man was expecting'.

"Is it really that amazing?"

"As a material, yes. If you can obtain them in large quantities, I'd welcome it."

Basyle recalled Rudel. He had skill and money, and on top of that he was a future archduke... should I seriously try to seduce him? She earnestly mulled over it.

"And you'd better be careful. I'm not sure what you did to that information dealer, but they're sniffing around you now."

"Hah? They handed me some fake information, so I just had them return my money."

The old man sighed once more. He proceeded to explain a few things to her. About Basyle's own fighting style and preferences... they had begun giving out her information cheap, even free of charge... and next they'd leak bad rumors about her so no one would part with her again... after he had said that much, Basyle knew something had to be done.

It was her fault for making light of the information dealers.

"You've done too much. If you aggravate them too much and get them sniffing for real, it'll get harder to work around these parts. Didn't you ever learn that? That you'll regret looking down on them... I won't say anything, but you'd better wash your feet of this business. You can still make it in time... in various ways."

Basyle could feel the air towards her worsening ever-so-slightly. She decided it was dangerous to continue on with this job.



"My body hurts."

A few days passed since the events of that forest, and Rudel lay on a bed in the academy's infirmary... even if it was called that, it was a facility on the scale of a small hospital. Pain raced around his whole body, and while the healing magic was working, it just went to show it wasn't omnipotent.

"It's because you pushed yourself. If we didn't have healing magic, you wouldn't be able to move for a month."

Izumi stayed by Rudel's side, peeling off the skin of a fruit in the chair by his bed. She wasn't skilled at the task by any means, but she wasn't bad. And like that, she handed the fruit over to Rudel.

"I'll be discharged in two to three days. And then I'll have to retrain myself from the ground up."

"That's the spirit. But get some rest for now."

As they were conversing, the door to the infirmary suddenly opened.

"It's been a while, Rudel-sama."

The one who entered with those words was Basyle. A get-well gift in her hands... how thoughtful, Rudel thought. But Izumi was put on guard. She didn't think too highly of Basyle approaching Rudel.

"I thought only relevant personnel could enter the academy."

On each of her words, a thorn did take shape, but

"I came to report this and that about my guard duty, little lady. And are you alright, Rudel-sama? If only I'd saved you sooner, or so my chest's been aching."

Basyle face a shameless excuse. She showed no reaction to Izumi's cynicism. Izumi was put even further on guard... but Rudel...

"I-I see..."

His eyes were stolen by Basyle's clothes that were even lighter than when she was on guard duty. Isumi ended up sighing. And intrigued by his reaction, Basyle went and brought her face closer to his.

"Wha!"

"O-oy..."

Rudel's eyes ended up wandering to all sorts of places. And Basyle...

"If you find this body to your liking... you can do whatever you want with it."

On those words, Rudel showed a reaction beyond what even he could have imagined. His body tried to leap at Basyle on its own... but he was still in pain all over. Any sudden movements in such a state...

"GYAAAAH!!!"

Of course, it hurt, and writhing around in pain was also painful. Basyle was surprised at that reaction, and ended up parting from Rudel. Seeing him, Izumi spoke.

"You're partly to blame for that one."

She pat his body for him.



"Hire you? Even if you ask me to hire you while I'm at the academy, well... and when it comes to guards, the knights and soldiers on campus are enough."

After Rudel's pain had softened, Basyle started into her objective of selling herself. Rudel had seen her strength as an adventurer, and she understood her own charm... but Rudel showed disapproval.

To Rudel, he didn't want to have any servants while in the academy. Those feelings ended up coming out... it was largely due to the fact he had no good memories with servants, but more than that, he was already managing on his own.

"I-in that case... right, magic! I'll teach you the practical uses of magic!"

As she frantically thought over various things, those words she randomly let slip from her mouth gave Izumi a bad premonition. As Izumi understood Rudel's personality, she had conviction he would hire her.

"Really!? That magic that burnt the boar in the forest really did surprise me. I couldn't think of it as the same magic I was using... is it possible for me too?"

Finding her foothold, Basyle began building a market for herself to a level of overkill. Correcting her posture, and lowering her head...

"Leave it to me. Magic, especially offensive magic is my specialty. I'll bring your abilities to a level you can use in real combat."

"Then I'll hire you! No, in this instance, I'm the one asking you to teach me. Based on how my body recovers, could you stop by every day, morning and evening?"

"... Eh? E-every day? Morning and evening? ... By morning, do you mean around the seventh bell?"

Basyle suddenly made a reluctant face... she was no good with mornings. More than being a person of the night, she enjoyed wandering around 'til down...

"The fifth bell, perhaps? Based on the season, it may be the fourth... is that no good? Then unfortunate as it may be, I don't have the time for..."

To Basyle, the academy was a safe zone. In a situation where the information dealers had a constant grasp of her location, on top of receiving wages that included guard fees as well, being a supposed servant of an archduke house would let her live in the academy without any further inconvenience... she instantly put the job details on the scales and came to a conclusion.

"No, if Rudel-sama wishes it, I shall instruct you at any hour."

"Thank you!"

"..."

Rudel was delighted, but Izumi wasn't making the best of faces. Basyle went right on to being hired as Rudel's servant. Staff lodging was prepared for her, and so she ended up living there.



In his room, Aleist thought over what was to come. Looking at the notes he had written in Japanese when he was still a young boy, he grinned when he considered his own future.

"After this, there's the third term's inter-class completion. There, there'll be an event where Izumi falls for me... and next year, the 'Second Princess Fina' and 'Chlust' will enter the academy. Chlust is going to become archduke soon, so I have to raise his impression of me while I can! It'll be useful in the war event."

He had written down various things, up to the war arc in the final chapter. In its contents, Rudel stopped coming out partway... no, at the end, Rudel's end was vaguely detailed.

'Desperate to flee from the war, Rudel incurs casualty on his own allies as he takes flight... he tries seeking help from the enemy general, but he is killed, bringing the matter to a close.'

It had been written under the title, 'Chlust Friendship Event'.

"But Millia... we've had a number of opportunities to meet, but she won't even look me in the face."

Thinking he had failed in Millia's event, Aleist drew a line through the 'Millia Love Event' sentence in his notes, and erased it.

"But whatever."



The elf girl in question was busy thinking about Rudel, who she had met on her entrance to the school. From there, a considerable amount of time had gone by, but even now she couldn't get him out of her head. As he had raised a number of problems in the academy, Rudel was a sort of celebrity.

And every time she heard rumor of Rudel, Millia would grow desperate to contain her feelings. Rudel was unpopular with commoners and non-human

... races... you could even say he was hated. The reason being he was the eldest son of the notorious Arses House.

Looking down on demi-humans, and taking too much, or rather just taking from its people.

But Millia couldn't think Rudel was the same person from the rumors. Rudel's rumors... he tried to push himself onto an elf girl on the first day, and within the day, he tried to sneak into the girls' dorm. After that, he forcibly called out to all the female students of the capus... when she thought over that one, it went to her head.

"And he didn't even call out to me..."

There were other rumors spreading, and all of them labeled Rudel as a terrible person. But if you asked the people around him, you'd get a different reaction back.

Rudel's class would never badmouth him. Perhaps it was due to his status, but even so, they didn't talk behind his back. Rudel is working hard, he never looks down on anyone... that was all she'd ever hear.

"Just which one is the real you..."

Millia breathed out a sigh... seeing her figure, her roommate offered a line.

"Millia... that lass be in love."

Chapter 10

The academy grew busy as it entered its third term. Its graduate classes with their futures... while its enrolled students put zeal into the inter-class tournament.

"Well then, Rudel-kun and Izumi-san, next is..."

It was the same in Rudel's class. Those with good grades, or who the teachers saw as competent were asked to represent their class. It was possible to decline, but few ever did. Participating as a representative of one's class was generally seen as an honor.

An honor for the nobles, and a chance for the commoners to get their names out there.

Class had ended, and it was already decided Rudel would be one of the participating members. At present, he was reading a book in the afterschool classroom. As he had to return a library book today, he planned to read and return it before returning to the dorm.

Rudel was living a fulfilling life at the academy. From the early morning, in a terrible state without even her hair in order, Basyle would teach him the practical uses of magic, and those around him had begun talking to him without restraint.

To Rudel's side, Izumi was similarly reading a book in the classroom. Throughout the third term, she had continued acting alongside him. But rather than reading the book... she was looking at Rudel.

From Izumi's eyes, Rudel was a strange, but upfront person. He declared he would become the strongest dragoon in the country, and his form as he endeavored was quite likable. What's more, her school life had been saved

by him on the first day. Izumi thought of Rudel as something beyond a good friend.

... Not that Rudel could tell.

Rudel finished reading his book, placing it down on the desk. As he did, he struck up a conversation with Izumi.

"The inter-class tournament... our first match is with Aleist's class, right?"

As Rudel suddenly started into the topic, Izumi panicked inside.

"Y-yeah... are you anxious after all?"

"Anxious? No, if possible, I want to fight Aleist. Just how far have I grown, what am I lacking... if I fight Aleist- the strongest in our year- perhaps I'll understand it. And... if I'm doing it, I'm going for the win."

To Rudel, defeat held no meaning. He could just stand up again. But more meaningless than that was a victory without any benefit.

Rather than fighting a weakling and winning, fighting someone strong and losing held more value to the current Rudel. Right now, he was in a learning environment, and this was a match...

"You're always so optimistic, Rudel... I'm envious."

As Izumi looked down, Rudel tried asking what had been on his mind all this time.

"What do you have your sights on, Izumi? You came to this academy because you have a goal, right?"

Izumi started speaking, a little embarrassed. Izumi's dream was to gain knight status in Courtois... and not just any ordinary status. Above the standard knights, she wanted to be part of the elites generally known in Courtois as high knights... it was a lot on the shoulders of a foreigner like Izumi, but even so, she was sent to help out her brother, and the rest of her house that would follow behind.

High knight wasn't a one-generation position. In Courtois that valued accepting in new blood, it would mean obtaining noble status. But the examinations and standards were set as high as you'd expect.

"Why do you want knight status in Courtois? Isn't your house a knight house in your country?"

Rudel wasn't too knowledgeable on foreign affairs. At most, he understood diplomatic relations. He couldn't understand why Izumi wanted to become a knight in Courtois.

"... We lost the coup. My clan can no longer get involved with politics. And the persecution may get worse... in short, we want to emigrate. But even so, my clan is a line of military men. If we get a high knight out of our family, it won't just be a temporary knight status, our clan will be recognized as a knight lineage."

The difference between dragoon and high knight; while high knights didn't ride dragons onto the front lines, they were a defensive role, a shield that protected the important figures of the country. If the dragoon were the spear, they were also one of the essential existences in Courtois.

"They'll tell you to abandon your country, and swear loyalty to Courtois. You'll be casting aside the country you were born in... does your clan have that level of resolve?"

"You ask some harsh things... yes, we have the resolve. That's why I'll become a high knights. If do end up being a high knight and gaining noble status, I may become trouble to the Arses House."

Rudel thought it was about simple factional relations. Serving under a high ranking noble was only natural for the younger houses. Even if you lined up ideals, no matter how talented your house may be, you wouldn't be able to survive if you made an enemy of the larger noble houses.

"I see, I'll support you, and I'll support your clan. But that is my individual position... if you're going to come under someone's umbrella, then you'd

better refrain from the Arses house. You'll only taint the status you went to such lengths to obtain."

It was Rudel's turn to hang his head. The Arses house's affiliated nobles were leaving one after the next. Its internal affairs were in shambles, and it would take quite some time for it to rebuild. A fallen house... that was the Arses House.

"Aren't you the next head? Then someday..."

"As long as he lives, my father will never hand his status over to me. I'm sure he's still got a few decades in him... I do feel sorry for the people, but that's another reason I want to be a dragoon. You see, Izumi, that's the sort of man I am. Someday, I'll become a feudal lord and stick my hands in internal affairs... but I have no idea whether I can better the Arses territory in my lifetime."

Rudel was aware of his own selfishness. He was abandoning his suffering people to become a dragoon. But even so, he wanted to be a dragoon.

"..."

"You should go search for a noble to support you while you can. Luckily, there are two other eldest sons from the Three Lords here, and there are a few folks from Marquis Houses enrolled."

"... Yeah. Perhaps you're right."

As the classroom dyed orange in the setting sun, the two of them stood and returned to their own dorms. Izumi was just a little saddened. If she asked Rudel whether he'd become a dragoon, or take her, then surely he'd choose dragoon without hesitation. It was clear enough...

And it was because she could understand how serious Rudel was... that she would try her best. She renewed her resolve.



The character called Izumi in Aleist's secret notes was a Yamamoto Nadeshico, and a young girl at the mercy of her clan. In her love event, an important choice where you told her she didn't have to be held down by her house was the key.

Izumi was 'unable to become a high knight', and by her clan's decision, she was to become the mistress of a high ranking noble, only for the protagonist to swoop in and rescue her. Looking at that information, Aleist lay in his room as he talked to himself.

"We're almost at the tournament event, and Izumi's events are going to start... but honestly, Vargas is a dubious character. I'm not particularly proceeding his events, but I guess it doesn't matter."

Aleist held no interest in the country boy Vargas. Vargas, an older brother-like character... but Aleist planned to fill out his party with women. It felt idiotic to let Vargas take up his time.

So he thought.

By the way, Izumi's partner was to be Rudel of the Arses House. Perhaps the two were bound by a strange sort of fate.

Chapter 11

In the academy first two compulsory years, the class tournament was the largest of events. Before it was held, the number of people training in the morning increased. And in the boys' dorms, two to three times the usual number of students were practicing their swords and magics so early in the morning.

"There are a lot of them today."

Rudel finished up his practice, and as he looked around, he was impressed by the abnormal number of people. But Vargas,

"Give them two to three days, and the number will half. Just working hard during the tournament period won't get you anywhere. More importantly, is Miss Basyle here yet?"

Basyle was teaching him the practical uses of magic in battle. But she was terrible in the mornings. She rarely ever arrived on time. Even if she came, her hair was a mess, and her clothing would consist of a jersey-like garb that held not a shred of the appeal of her usual clothing... but even so, she was quite popular with the boys who training in the morning.

"It seems she hadn't been wandering around at night lately, but she's still bad with mornings."

"Ah~, how unfortunate... the sway of her breasts through those clothes is magnificent!"

Rudel was amazed to see a number of nods from the boys around. At this point, he could only laugh.

"More importantly! You have to do your best in the tournament. Based on your results, those affiliated with the night brigades may set their eyes on you."

Right, the purpose of the tournament, alongside confirming the quality of the students, was to spot out pupils with promising futures. Nabbing them at the bud was its real intent.

"Y-yeah!"

Rudel was the sort who would put in more effort than usual if it would let him approach his dream. But sadly... perhaps you could call it fate. His opponent was Aleist, the strongest in the year.



As the academy welcomed in the first day of the tournament, the class representative gathered in the arena for the opening address before retiring to the waiting room. The room was wrapped in a peculiar sense of tension.

"Oh, the winner was from the class with the most commoners... as I thought, those noble classes sure are frail."

The one who let out such provocative words wasn't a representative of a commoner class. He was an individual who no one could caution no matter what he said... Eunius Diade, hailing from one of the Three Lords much like Rudel. Boasting a large body, Eunius had his personal large wooden sword over his back.

Blond hair bundled up behind, his blue eyes made him out as more of a ferocious animal than a noble... while he was abysmally bad at his magic classes, in swordsmanship, he had even surpassed Rudel to take the first spot. But as Eunius had never directly gone up against Rudel, he had some complaints about that ranking.

"How noisy... if you love commoners so much, then just go off and become one. We don't need any trash that can't fulfill a noble's obligations."

The one who directed those complaints at Eunius was similarly from a Three Lord House. Luecke Halbades' near-transparent pale skin and red eyes peer through his straight blond hair.

Ranked number one in magic... though he had never directly compared himself to Rudel, so Luecke himself had some dissatisfactions about it.

No one could step into the conversation between these two... or at least that's how it was supposed to be...

"How about the two of you calm down? We're going to fight either way."

The one who acted without reading the mood was a certain Aleist Hardie. If Rudel had said it, no one would complain. Rudel was also of the Three Lords. And the two of them were clearly conscious of him.

But Aleist was called the strongest in the school year... and he had interest in the two. So they continued on their conversation.

"The eldest son of the Hardie House, eh... what do you want to say by intruding on our conversation?"

Luecke's cold eyes glared at Aleist. Neither Luecke nor Eunius thought too highly of him. They had much to think about the Hardie house that had suddenly extended its influence and rose before anyone realized it, but more than anything, they couldn't stand Aleist's abnormal level of competence.

Aleist's grades weren't at the top. He had points deducted due to his attitude during lessons. Yet with that taken into account, Aleist still managed to stay around the upper ranks... there's no way he wasn't suspicious.

The two of them were individuals who never failed to put effort into their sword and spell. And they had talent. That's precisely why they could tell... that he was downright shady... on the contrary, the one their instincts told them to fear was Rudel. The boy who managed to grind out grades catching up to them in both fields with pure, untainted effort.

The two of them knew Rudel was the one they had to be wary of.

"If you're curious of each other's strength, then you'll know once you fight. It'll be much more productive than any pointless conflict here."

"You say some nice things! That's just the sort of opinion I like... Oy, Arses! What do you think?"

Eunius suddenly turned the subject to Rudel. Eunius and Luecke both turned to face him, and finally Aleist looked as well. Feeling the three of them were strong, Rudel knew he would reach a greater fight if he fought against them.

But if you asked him what he thought, it would be troubling. To Rudel, and dealings before the match would be a hindrance. For now, he just wanted to concentrate on the battle. And he knew the two were looking at him. He was sure their words were meant to provoke him...

"Nothing in particular... I simply want to become strong. Strong enough to be a dragoon."

"I see, then you're a failure as a noble. You're not fulfilling an obligation fitting of your status."

When he heard that from Luecke of one of the Three Lord houses, Rudel felt the weight of his selfishness. Right, normally, Rudel wouldn't have the leisure to aim at becoming a dragoon. It was an action akin to abandoning the suffering people of the Arses territory.

"If being a noble's to live freely, then Arses' right. Living free's his family motto, after all!"

Eunius provoked him. Rudel quietly closed his mind. Finding it hard to look at, Izumi tried to call out, but

'The next match shall soon commence! Will the class representatives please get ready!'

On the orders that came from the broadcasting equipment, Rudel stood... Those of Aleist's class stood as well, exiting the waiting room and heading

for the arena.



Once Rudel and the others had left the waiting room, Luecke and Eunius continued talking. The Halbades and Diade houses didn't get along by any means. They each stood at the top of their own large faction. But right now, they were deep in talk about Rudel.

"What do you think?"

On Eunius' vague question, Luecke,

"Aleist's honestly abnormal. But Rudel's also a monster."

"Right... swordplay second only to me, and magic skills surpassing even you... think you could win if you made an enemy of him?"

"I think you mean swordplay surpassing you, and magic second to me. If I could beat him so easily, we wouldn't be having this conversation... but I don't know whether he can beat Aleist or not."

While there was a disparity in their recognition of the situation, their opinions aligned. It would be difficult for Rudel to defeat Aleist. But that was just how abnormal Aleist was.

"Rune knight, rune blade... there are various ways to say it, but a magic knight's greatest trait is 'Magic Sword', a fighting style where they imbue magic into their blade. The amount of time he can grant it to a wooden sword can't be long... but Rudel's at too much of a disadvantage."

"Is it really that amazing? He's just covering his sword in magic, right?"

Eunius doubtfully listened to Luecke's explanation.

"Are you an idiot? If he coats his wooden sword in fire or something, you'll be burnt just by locking blades. If he raises the output, Rudel'll be burnt black..."

"... Now that's terrible. But there's a way to counteract it."

"There is?"

"Cut him down before he can hit you... are you an idiot?"

Perhaps they got along surprisingly well.

Chapter 12

Taking on a student of Aleist's class, both sides fought mainly with swordplay. Unable to block her swift movements and cuts, the student was made a sport of by Izumi before she thrust her wooden sword at his nape... cheers came in from the audience seats.

Izumi had won. The referee directed his flag at her, and abiding by it, Izumi put her wooden sword away. The scene was looked upon by the knights in the noble visitor seats. A number of high knights, and two dragoons... within all that, a single young girl stuck her feet out in front, throwing them down on top of the table. Her red hair extended to her shoulders, and she played with its curling ends. Her pale skin and red eyes were exceptionally beautiful.

But her attitude was a problem. Her posture was bad, and her feet were on the table, after all... the surrounding knights directed her, directed Cattleya Nianis a glance. The one who apologized in her place was her dragoon unit's vice-captain sitting to her side.

She hadn't become a dragoon by her own design. It was by the talent she was born with, and unlike the ashen dragons kept in Courtois, she was a genius who was able to make a contract with a bonifide Red Dragon.

The green scales of the Wind Dragon. The golden scales of the Gaia Dragon, and the smooth sea-blue scales of the water dragon... they were all colors that wouldn't come out in domesticated dragons. All dragons born in captivity would come out with ashen scales.

And with ashen dragons, their quality dropped from their wild counterparts.

Cattleya mocked the fact the vicecaptain shared a contract with an ashen dragon. So even if he cautioned her, she wouldn't correct her posture. And Cattleya was trusted by the royal line. That only made her needlessly conceited.

"Nothing but boring matches. Can I go home yet?"

The vice-captain had just about had it with her, but he showed some self control.

"I'm sure you know, Cattleya, but discerning future candidates for our unit is our job."

"None of those brats are anything to write home about. Like that black-haired lady from before, she'll make high knight, at best."

On those words, the nearby high knights seethed. But they were first-rate knights. Even if words may anger them, they wouldn't raise a hand. Though from the vice captain's point of view, it was akin to a direct attack to his gut.



The next match was finally Rudel's turn. Aleist across from him showed an expression of leisure, but to contrast, Rudel was the epitome of seriousness.

"Now it's time to punish an arrogant noble... any complaints?"

"Whether I'm arrogant or not is... no, I am arrogant. I've no complaints, but I want you to take me on seriously."

"That so... but are you worth my all?"

Alongside the referee's call of the start, both sides stepped forwards.

The gap closed in an instant, and the wood swords that met let off a violent sound no wood should make. Seeing Rudel take on his attack, Aleist panicked a bit, and seeing through that, Rudel went on the offense.

As Aleist took some distance, Rudel cast offensive magic. He let out a consecutive stream of elementary magics, not giving Aleist a chance to chance to attack... but Aleist

"Don't get carried away!!!"

Tried to fire advanced magic within the arena. From Rudel's point of view, he was full of openings, and it was a terrible move. He instantly fired a bolt of magic as he closed the distance and tried to bring things to close combat, but at that moment!

"Fool, I can see right through you!!!"

Aleist's sword was imbued with the magic of wind. While Rudel parried his attack, he was still blown violently into the air.



"Amazing... I never imagined we'd see a fight of this level in the fundamental curriculum." "Aleist's as much a monster as they say." "But that Arses house kid hanging on against him is quite something himself..."

Such a conversation passed through the noble visitor room. The high knights were in high spirits, and the vice-captain's heart was already dancing over the exploits of these newbie fighters. But Cattleya alone was different.

(How irritating... the hell's this match? It's just one brat with nothing but power up against another idiot who's trained in all the wrong places!)

She would be able to take them both down in an instant. While Cattleya was convinced, she sent a sharp glare at Rudel. She didn't like him... that was the impression Cattleya held of Rudel.

"Rudel of the Arses House. I hear he's trying to become a dragoon... as things are going, perhaps he has a possibility."

On those words from a high knight, the blood rushed to Cattleya's head. That one will rise to the same position as me? Don't joke around! That one's no good! Definitely not happening!!

At this point, she didn't even understand what was no good. She seriously watched on the match between Rudel and Aleist.



The magic Aleist channeled into his wood sword... by the magic of wind, Rudel was being pushed back. If he tried to parry any strikes, he would be sent flying, and even if he dodged, the wind would destroy his stance. Firing magic as he ran was the greatest offense he could put up.

"Hah, hah... it's just as Basyle said. The quality of one's magic always falls further than anticipated in combat. At this rate, even firing seems pointless."

Rudel recalled Basyle's instruction. There, he decided to take a gamble. All his magic at point-blank range... even with elementary magic, at point blank, and if he put enough power into it...

Aleist looked over Rudel, an expression of leisure on his face. He understood what Rudel was going for.

"Hmm, you intend to stake it on a single strike? Sounds good... I'll take it head on, so come tis all you've got!"

The force of the wind around Aleist's wood sword increased. Around its blade, a small tornado... that magic sword that was as if the twister itself had become a blade shocked the stands.

Holding that magic sword aloft, Aleist took his stance... in contrast, Rudel fathered mana on the palm of his right hand.

"W-wait, you two! We can't have any deaths here..."

Using the referee's call as the signal, the two sprung to motion. In Rudel's right hand, a magic of fire... Aleist gave a grin as he lowered his sword. But

Rudel had prepared wind in his hidden left hand.

Using two magics at once was something you could call impossible during the academy's two fundament-centric years. Rudel couldn't handle it perfectly... but with the wind magic in his left hand, he changed the course of Aleist's magic sword, slamming his main right hand into Aleist himself. As a blast ran through the arena, the two of them were sent flying at roughly the same time... and the result was clear to everyone's eyes.



"Match over... that was quite interesting."

Cattleya had no interest in the vice-captain's words. She simply sent a glance to Rudel, collapsed in the arena. While Aleist managed to stand, Rudel was no longer able to. But even so, he frantically squirmed to get to his feet.

"In the end, their difference in ability came out... Aleist Hardie really is a monster."

As she heard that conversation in the background, Cattleya felt fear.

(Why hasn't anyone noticed? The real monster is that one! That Rudel Arses!!)

By Cattleya's evaluation, Rudel was the monster. While incomplete, he showed skill in simultaneous magic manipulation, and whether it be swordplay or magic, he had completely outclassed Aleist in every field. The only reason Aleist won was the trumpcard called magic sword, and what seemed like an endless stream of mana.

(But Rudel is still fifteen... he's at an age where he'll keep growing. The strength of his will that's still trying to force him to his feet... despite being shown such a difference in strength, he's still trying to stand!)

This kid would crawl his way up... Cattleya found herself in fear of Rudel. He did have a level of talent, but it wasn't to her level, and when it came to

swordplay, his innate skill fell short of that black haired girl from before. But if they fought, Rudel would surely win.

That's why Cattleya thought... she was going to crush him...

Chapter 13

Izumi and Basyle raced over to the collapsed Rudel. With teary eyes, they confirmed his safety. The referee declared Aleist the winner. But Rudel was still trying to stand.

"Not yet, I haven't lost yet. I can still stand!"

"Rudel... that's enough. Didn't you say you wouldn't have any regrets even if you lost!?"

"I don't want to leave regret! That's why I... can still..."

Looking over their exchange, Aleist smiled. It was almost time for Izumi's event. Here, Rudel would order Izumi to cut at him... at Aleist. He would threaten her with her house's standing

(And there, I say... What about your house!? Just do what you believe in! I sat it to her. It's the start of the event to release Izumi, who was ordered by her house to approach Rudel!!)

But Izumi wouldn't part from Rudel, and Rudel wouldn't give out the order. Even more than that...

"You're being unsightly, Rudel-sama. You lost... any more would be a disgrace."

"... I... see... a disgrace... sure enough. It would be an insult to my foe... I admit... my loss..."

Aleist couldn't swallow down the situation. But Rudel gave a light smile before losing consciousness. The relief squad carried him off... and Izumi's even never happened.



The first year division of the class tournament ended with an overall victory for Aleist's class. Eunius' and Luecke's classes met in the semi-finals... it was a draw, or rather, it was declared impossible for anyone to continued. Both sides did a good job holding out that long...

Rudel's injuries took two weeks for a complete recovery... he was carried straight to the infirmary, and spent his time nursed to health by Izumi and Basyle... burn in hell!

By his discharge, Rudel's second year of fundamental education had begun.



"Chlust? Yes, he's my brother... something about him?"

In the second year of the standard curriculum, classes weren't shuffled up. From the third year onwards, it was nothing but chosen electives, so classes themselves didn't exist. So naturally, Izumi stayed in his class.

"No... how should I put it, you give off a different atmosphere. Just like those around you say you're surprisingly decent, I've heard some voices that your little brother's quite nobleish."

Quite nobleish, the phrase contained some irony. But Rudel knew where she was coming from. His brother was loved and treasured by his parents. So Chlust had become a noble quite close to his parents... naturally, that would be a bad noble.

"So I'm not nobleish? That's all well and good, but is my brother that famous..."

"His grades are excellent, and his status is second highest in this year's entering class... but the first would have to be the second princess."

Rudel didn't know much about the second princess Fina. It was largely due to the fact he hadn't gone out into high society, but more than that, he just

wasn't interested.

"What sort of kid is she?"

"... That's a hard one. If you want to call her cute, she's cute, and if you want to say she's beautiful, then she is... it seems your little brother's obsessed with Fina-sama. She's got blond hair and blue eyes, the standard Courtoisian set, and as I recall... they call her the 'doll princess'."

Right, unlike Rudel, Chlust had made his social debut. So fitting with the house's status, he had some exchanges with the princess. More importantly, was 'doll princess'... supposed to be a compliment? That was the part that caught Rudel's interest.

"Chlust does have a chance... but I think it'll be difficult."

Rudel didn't think Chlust would be married to that second princess. A fallen house, and the precious princess... what's more, with Chlust being the second son, it was even more unthinkable. No matter how talented Chlust was, it would probably be impossible unless he succeeded the Arses House...

"So you're uninterested? I'm glad you're the same as always. So what's your goal going to be this year, Rudel?"

Izumi's spirits rose a bit as she asked Rudel's goal for the new semester. Rudel's end goal wasn't changing, so...

"I want to build up combat experience, and as I said in last time's event, we'll be the first to reach the goal. Also... I want to fight some strong people at the tournament, perhaps?"

After losing to Aleist, Rudel had done some thought on his own fighting style. He had considered learning Aleist's magic sword, but... rather than whether it was possible or not, he thought over whether it was suitable for him, and gave up.

A dragoon's main role was to compensate for the blind spots of a high-firepower flying tank called a dragon. Meaning protecting its back. It was written in a book that Magic Sword wasn't suitable for dragoons. The reason being rather than swinging around a sword on its back, focusing on consecutive mid and long-range attacks was more important.

"Is that all? You'll make all the women around you sad."

Izumi impishly poked him with her elbow. Rudel had high grades, and he came from one of the Three Lord houses... there was no way he wasn't popular.

"That is an exceedingly difficult question. I've considered dating multiple women like my father before me..."

"You were!?"

Izumi's eyes turned even more serious than usual, the ends of her words increasing in intensity. Even Rudel could see she was angry.

"I determined it was impossible. I don't have any time, and I don't know what I'm supposed to do... and having multiple at once is unthinkable."

"R-right... while it's a bit strange, if it's you, I don't think there'll be any is... wait! Like hell! Don't you have anything to say about feelings? Whether you like them or not?"

Rudel did have his likes and dislikes. But...

"With my status, I don't have the freedom to decide based on like and dislike. It's normal for me to be married to whatever partner my parents decide, and if I do have someone I love, then I'll have to make them a mistress... that isn't a position praised very highly."

Would you really make your loved one a social outcast? Is what he meant. The country of Courtois was prejudice against women with the positions of lover or mistress. So not being with your loved one was generally how it worked for Courtois' nobles.

"That's right... I'm sorry."

"You don't have to mind it. As long as I love the partner my parents choose, there won't be a problem... if that's possible, that is."

In a joking tone, Rudel explained to Izumi. Yet be that as it may, while Rudel did have interest in the female body, he had no memory of ever falling in love. Rather... he had simply never loved.

It was something extremely unnatural, and it felt somewhat contrived.



Ever since he came to the academy, Chlust was troubled by his brother Rudel. As the brother of Rudel who displayed such problematic behavior, the teachers were wary of him. On top of that, there was the matter of his grades... Rudel was even more proficient than him in every field. But his rankings on the practical events were never high.

By those with bad mouths, this would imply he, 'Bought his grades with money'. Chlust himself did believe that rumor, and he thought he was irrelevant to his brother. But if the big brother did it, and you tried to insist the little brother did not... it was only human to think the younger brother had bought his grades as well.

Because of that, Chlust got around to thinking he wasn't receiving a proper evaluation. He came to hate his brother even more than when he was in the house... and that would become yet another problem for Rudel.

Because that attitude around Chlust would only add to Rudel's terrible reputation. Just as he had been taught in his life at the Arses House, Chlust looked down on commoners and demi-humans. Ever since he came to hate Rudel, that mindset had only grown stronger.

Alongside those drawn to him by his status, he began running wild around the academy.

'And originally, that was precisely what Rudel was supposed to do.'



In his second year, if Rudel hadn't aspired to be a dragoon, he would be the worst of men. Not going to class, he would trouble all those around him. There were always women in his room through his money... he would take along the ill-natured students and run rampant through the academy.

What's more, upon losing to the protagonist in the tournament, he ordered Izumi to cut down the protagonist in retaliation, and her refusal became a spark... he was trash. And he was the trigger for many an event.

The 'Doll Princess' Fina challenged him on his behavior... in a frenzy, he ended up laying hands on her. As a result, Rudel was treated as a tumor of the academy, he was transferred from the five year track to the two year track, and he quietly left the family.

For the sake of face, he was granted knight qualifications, for argument's sake. After a long absence, his next appearance would come in the war arc, and that was all there was to the character called Rudel.

Chapter 14

The second princess Fina was an expressionless princess. As she was unable to express her emotions well, people took to calling her the Doll Princess. But rumor had it her beauty was number one in Courtois, and her beauty was such that the royal house kept a vigilant watch for a chance to marry her into the royalty of other lands.

... But that doll princess had a secret. She loved the feel of demi-human ears and tails! You could even say she loved demi-humans as a whole... But even now, the social standing of demi-humans was low in Courtois. If the princess was seen touching one in public, there would be many who wouldn't think too kindly of it. So she endured it.

Day after day after day... living in close quarters with demi-humans in the academy, she desperately held back.

But one day it did come to pass. As Fina dropped by the academy cafeteria, she bore witness to something outrageous. And she had finally reached the limits of her patience.

Two upperclassmen from the standard curriculum sat sandwiched around an underclassman from a class made up of commoners. The one sitting awkwardly between them was one Fina had already checked up on before, the cutest beast girl of the year, 'Mii of the White Cat Tribe'. Her lovely smile, and her petite body... Mii wasn't tall in stature. But that wasn't to say the white cat tribe were all of small build.

That's precisely why she was all the more valuable! ... In Fina's head, that is.

And despite her small body, Mii had her womanly features. She stuck out where she was supposed to stick out, and drew in where she should, another large factor behind her popularity. Mii was abnormally popular among the boys... and right now, she was entangled with some upperclassmen.

Her guard slash friend students took up a suspicious formation to hide her, and as she hesitated over what to do, the upperclassman made his move.

"But even so... I'm curious. Can I touch them?"

"I-if it's just a little, then... u-um...? You're still touching me?"

"Rudel? Isn't that enough... why don't you release her already? You've already finished asking what you wanted to, right?"

Right, the two upperclassmen were Rudel and Izumi. Rudel wanted to know how the beast trives trained every day, so he went and asked Mii who happened to be nearby. But there, Something caught Rudel's interest... were those ears and tail truly real? Or were they a tribal ornament?

... His interested piqued, of course Rudel... touched them to confirm. But when it came to their feel to the touch... they were fluffy and soft. And Mii's eyes seemed to grow vacant with pleasure. Rudel continued feeling up... her ears and tail, trying out various methods. As a result,

"Ah! N-noooooaaaah!!!... Ah!"

After shaking a few time, Mii's body took a single big lurch. And she drooped onto the table... her breath was strangely rough. On top of that, her face was faintly reddened...

"Rudel... we need to talk. Let's go to the roof."

Izumi's mood worsened, and Rudel got the feeling he shouldn't go against her...

"G-got it. But leaving this child here is a bit..." "You're right. Then I'll take her to the girls' dorm, so don't run away."

Looking over that exchange, Fina honestly didn't know what to do. But she got the feeling she had to take some sort of action.

(What was that technique!!? I'm freakin' envious, dammit!!! Teach me your ways! Pass on your skills to me!! It's be much more useful to my future than any useless class!)

"You two! Get away from that girl! How env... I mean, aren't you embarrassed as upperclassmen!? (Thank you for the meal!!!)"

Fina came out in front of Rudel and Izumi. But Rudel didn't know about the princess. From her face and aura, Izumi knew who she was, but she didn't know what to do.

Rudel, on the other hand,

"Who are you? If you're an acquaintance of hers, then could I leave her to you... I have to go to the roof, apparently."

The surroundings drew back at that brazen attitude. In that cafeteria with a large number of students around, the big reveal that he didn't know his own country's princess was a large problem, but even more than that, he left work to that princess... it was unthinkable.

But at that time, the princess was...

(He's totally a saint! Leaving this cute little kitten to me... hah, hah... I can barely contain myself!! I can touch her without reservations!!)

"Understood. I shall take responsibility and escort her. From here on, I pray you don't carry out such acts again. If such a thing is to happen once more... (Wait, huh? If I got him to do it again, could I get an excuse to touch?)"

The princess left for the girls' dorm, carrying Mii on her own. Completely ignoring the surrounding opinions, she carried her Mii all the way to the cat tribeswoman's room... feeling her fluff all the way! From then on, she

became friends with Mii, and to Princess Fina, it was the best day of her life.



The morning of the next day, a satisfied Fina sat in the classroom, and the man who would always come in and flatter her... Chlust made his appearance. There, she remembered. Chlust's brother was Rudel of that godly technique!

"Chlust, is your older brother always like that?"

"Hah? Oh, that disgrace of the Arses name? I'm quite troubled by him too. I mean, he's like a child who speaks of nothing but dreams, never looking at the reality..."

From there, an endless stream of slander flowed from Chlust's mouth. Hearing that, Fina thought.

(This guy really is useless. Each and every day, his flattery is a right-out bother, and when I thought he could introduce me to the all-important master Rudel... do I have any other connections?)

Yesterday, Fina had pet Mii all over. But... she couldn't do it like Rudel. No matter how she pet her, Mii would only say, 'That tickles'... she experienced the difference in ability between herself and Rudel, even feeling in a sense of defeat. And she thought.

'I'll become his apprentice!'

And yet, the younger brother Chlust was of no use at all. Inside Fina's head, Chlust's stocks were plummeting at a rate never seen before. She had put up her expectations, but she was betrayed beyond her own imagination. Because of that, Fina grew even colder than usual towards him...

Questioning Fina's behavior, Chlust decided to look into various things. And the reason he reached was his brother Rudel. From his followers, Chlust learned of the events in the cafeteria the previous day.



The evening of that day... on the afterschool roof. With matters left unsettled the previous day, Izumi was conducting her lecture of Rudel.

"What do you have to say about yesterday?"

As Izumi said it coldly, Rudel responded with a serious face. First, Rudel had spent the whole night thinking over it. He repented over the bad points in his own way, and he thought he could get Izumi to understand him.

"I'm sorry. But I had confidence! You may laugh that I was too hasty, but I read a wonderful book on the art of petting dragons, and I've been practicing all this time. So I was sure that beast tribe girl would be delighted... I'll admit I've only ever tested it on my little sister and pet dog. But even so, I'm sure she enjoyed it!"

It was a remark from the left field... at Rudel's serious expression, Izumi's head began to hurt.

"... As if simple petting could lead to that! No, that's also important, but not knowing the princess of your own country... do you know the term lese majeste?"

"What's this about the princess? Right now, she's just an underclassman who attends our academy. If her surroundings are too mindful of her, it'll just wear her out... more importantly, I think my petting technique has reached a considerable level. My little sister praised it highly, and all. Do you want to have a go?"

For a brief instant, Izumi felt she would lose to the temptation. Rallying up her feelings, it was the moment she was to scold Rudel. The door connecting to the roof let out a violent sound as it opened, and leading a few dozen boys along, Chlust made his appearance.

"It's all your fault, Rudel! It's because you're dragging me down!"

Rudel and Izumi didn't know what was going on... but in chlust and the boys' hand, they gripped wooden swords and knives.

Chapter 15

Rudel and Izumi were surrounded on the school roof. They were surrounded by the followers of Rudel's brother Chlust, and all of them were underclassmen of the fundamental course department... new students who had only just enrolled and learned the basics. Just how many capable fighters were among them...

"Rudel... it's your fault my plans have gone to ruin. When I don't have the qualifications to succeed my house, the princess was my last hope! And yet you...!!"

Rudel couldn't understand Chlust's feelings. To Rudel, succeeding the house held very little interest. All he had was his will to become a dragoon... a dragon knight. The rest was unnecessary.

"Succeeding the house is the eldest son's obligation. But I'll admit I am certainly unworthy of the role... then you can succeed the house if you wish."

"Don't screw around! That territory isn't worthy of me! There is a title and honor more appropriate for me... I could've even become king!"

Hearing those words, Rudel let out a sigh. Even if he caught the second princess' fancy and managed to marry her, he wouldn't be a king. The archdukes houses originated from royal blood... if anything happened, perhaps they could take the seat of king. But even so... Rudel didn't think Chlust was of royal caliber.

"Chlust... why don't you stop dreaming and look at reality? Under normal circumstance, you could have father grant you some land, or be married to govern another house. Polishing yourself will always aid your future..."

Rudel's words were the same ones Chlust wanted to tell him for years. Despising his brother, Chlust was convinced his present situation arose from unfair evaluations of him stemming from his Rudel's shortcomings.

"This coming from you... from the bastard who aims to be the dragoon he'll never become!!? That's enough... get him!"

The followers came towards them by Chlust's orders... in that moment, Rudel came to a concluded. Talking was pointless, and he couldn't cause a problem here and now... then he would have to run...

"R-Rudel, what are you...!"

As Izumi took a stance against the droves of tag-alongs, Rudel lifted her under his arm and jumped off of the roof.

"I-is he an idiot!?"

Hearing such voices from the followers, Rudel jumped down from the school building and landed... he instantly raced off. Get away and you win! Thought Rudel as he raced off at full speed, leaving Chlust in a daze. And one of the boys...

"H-he ran away. He really was a failure after all, Chlust-sama."

To the follower who said that with a cramped smile, Chlust also made a mocking remark at Rudel's flight.

"That incompetent... don't think you can run away forever."

But Rudel hadn't merely run away. He had reported a problem on campus to the teachers, as was his student obligation. Though in the case a commoner was being bullied by nobles, doing so would never have much of an effect...



The next day the boys, Chlust included, were put on house arrest... carrying weapons on academy grounds was prohibited in general, and more than

anything, if they were trying to raise a violent incident, it was a large problem. What's more, their attack was against the future archduke Rudel... the academy could punish without hesitation.

As it was an internal problem of the Arses House, the punishment was lightened. But with it, the Arses House's reputation fell even further. Both brothers were treated as problem children.

"Chlust sure did something stupid."

Rudel spoke as he looked at the house arrest document posted up. A number of students looking at it alongside him,

(Like you're one to talk!)

They thought to themselves.

"Was that really alright? He's your younger brother, right... and while it's a problem within your house, your standing will..."

Izumi had heard Rudel was hated by his parents and the mansion's servants. So she was worried this event would needlessly lower Rudel's standing even further.

"It's fine, with this... I can only hope Chlust cools his head. And to me, my social standing is of little importance."

"... If your reputation is too low, won't it become a problem when becoming a dragoon? How should I put it... they could judge you a problematic individual, or your house could get in your way..."

On Izumi's words, Rudel made a face as if to say it had only just occurred to him. Sure enough, there would be people to oppose a problem child becoming a dragoon. From his household situation, it was thinkable they would interfere to get back at him. Because Chlust was loved by his parents...

"This is terrible!"

"Yeah, that's right... I'm glad you noticed."



As a second year student, Rudel and the others began the harsh training of the fundamental curriculum. In the first year, they would learn all the basics, and this time they would put them to practice. The academy was a place to produce the Courtois Kingdom's officers and officials. The young nobles would be taught the common knowledge of the kingdom, so if ever an emergency came, they would be able to coordinate their private armies. Or at least that was the goal.

For the commoners, they would become soldiers, or the higher-ranking knights... they could also become civil officials with their sights on promotion. The fact that people of low status could attend was linked directly to the Courtois' Kingdom's forced enlistment of them when the time arose. An academy with a military side... that was a pretense.

The place held quite a heavy setting, but to the protagonist of this story, Aleist, it was simply an 'RPG themed around romance'. Surrounded by beauties and cuties, the protagonist would live a pampered life as he saved the country from crisis... that was the original form of this world.

The reason anyone could attend from princess to commoner was merely so the developers could include a wide range of characters.

As he recalled that, Aleist thought over the present situation. In his room, he looked over the notes he had written as he crossed off Izumi's name. It was a game with a large cast. It didn't matter if one or two of them were exceptions... so Aleist thought.

"The problem is Rudel. He didn't lay hands on Fina, and the one who raised a problem was the younger brother Chlust. I need to somehow make that cool-headed Fina go dere... but if the event never happens, there's nothing I can do..."

Even in the academy, it was hard to do anything to the princess Fina. She had guards among her classmates, and the teachers kept an eye out for her.

It was a difficult situation for any man to approach... the only exceptions were the young nobles of high social standing. But Aleist's Hardie House was an upstart house with shallow history.

He couldn't approach. And at the same time, Aleist didn't understand Fina's inner thoughts. She was expressionless, but there was some crazy going on underneath.

"At this rate, even when it's the second year, I won't be able to get a single comrade... the war begins right after graduation, so it'll be bad if I can't strengthen our members while I can!"

Aleist thought to himself. The war he spoke of was one with a country rivaling Courtois... the Gaia Empire would launch an invasion. They weren't given much backstory. Or rather, there was no setting given besides the fact they were the game's final enemy.

In the third year at the academy, there were only a few foreshadows, and a romance event with a Gaia soldier prepared for the protagonist.

But the Gaia Empire did exist, and it shared a border with Courtois.

"Millia's big sister, while she's got nice looks... as I recall, she's a dragoon, so she's not very useful. Her looks alone get a passing grade, though... there's an event with her this year, so should I try getting her?"

By Aleist's standards, 'Dragoons were unusable'... there was a reason behind it. Once dismounted from their dragons, and looked on as knights, Dragoons were units who specialized in mid, and long ranged magic battles. By Aleist's image, they were weak against enemies who specialized in close-range combat.

Sure enough, in game, they occupied a dubious niche. The dragoons boasted relatively high status... but they were a class that came with a decisive flaw of having no close-range skills.

"Cattleya will become Rudel's fiancé, so it'll be quite a while before we meet..."

Cattleya Ninias... after Rudel was chased out of the academy, it was decided she would marry into the Arses House. The engagement was decided the moment Rudel caused a scandal and returned home. The Arses House applied pressure on the Ninias House in an attempt to obtain Cattleya, a dragoon highly trusted by the royal line.

But Rudel didn't cause any problems, and he wasn't being chased from the academy. But even so, the events would happen.

Chapter 16

During the break before the second term, Rudel returned home. There, an event awaited him. To be more precise, it was a happening related to Aleist's event. After Chlust received disciplinary action, the Arses House grew mindful of its standings, and decided an engagement for Rudel.

That partner was a competent individual with the trust of the crown. Originally, they would search out a match suitable for the house's social status, but the Arses House was a fallen line, and that wish fell on deaf ears. With various circumstances involved, the chosen candidates were two dragoons, Cattleya Ninias and Lilim. Cattleya hailed from a low-ranking noble house, but she was hailed as a genius dragoon, and trusted by royalty.

Lilim was an elf. But from her aptitude in magic and her longevity, she was an outstanding talent the dragoons had their expectations on. She was chosen, for argument's sake, but no one ever thought Lilim would be chosen. In short, she was there to provide the illusion of choice. This was a form of harassment against Rudel.

The Arses House discriminated against demi-humans. And yet the only marriage candidate they could get was an elf... it was surely a disgrace. What's more, the other party was a dragoon... it was impossible to simply laugh off her lineage, or so some shallow thoughts were weaved in.

And it's true it had invited in some snickers...

Oblivious of all that, Rudel returned to his home. Once he got back, he handed his sister Lena some souvenirs, and told her all about the academy... Lena was acting strange. And once he noticed, he asked...

"My engagement!? ... no, it's nothing strange, but this came straight out of nowhere."

"You're still just deciding between marriage candidates! I heard they were two female dragoon knights."

On those words, Rudel was deeply moved! Enough to make him hop up and down...

"Is that true, Lena!? So they're dragoons... then I'll have to hurry and prepare!"

"Bro... you look happy."

"Of course I am! I may be able to meet dragons! Dragons, Lena!"

"... You haven't changed a bit."



The day of the meeting, the two rode their dragons towards the lands of Arses. The towns spreading out beneath their eyes, even from the skies, they could see the lack of vigor. Human traffic was abysmally low... to the Dragons who knew of other lands, the Arses rule was abnormal.

"Marrying into this territory would be the worst."

Cattleya muttered as she rode her Red Dragon... aboard the Wind Dragon flying beside her, Lilim answered her mutterings.

"Your engagement is a done deal, but I think you're being hasty, Cattleya."

"Hmm, you sure have it nice, senpai... there's no way in hell you'll ever be picked!"

Cattleya was no good at dealing with Lilim. She had a bad affinity with her fighting style, and she was her senior... what's more, she was a competent one chosen by a Wind Dragon, so Cattleya couldn't even complain.

Lilim was of blond hair and pale skin... but her eyes remained closed. It wasn't as if she was blind... she had a reason she couldn't open them.

"I heard from my little sister, but apparently he isn't a terrible person, you know? The vice-captain said he had considerable skill, so I can't understand why you hate him... is his face not to your tastes?"

"... His face is normal... but him alone, I'd like to avoid! That kid is..."

Cattleya's face darkened... inferring it from the atmosphere, Lilim said no more on the matter.

That dubious journey through the sky came to a close, and the two of them landed their dragons on the Arses House courtyard... but there, a single individual leapt out. For someone to jump out unafraid of the dragons... they had nothing but bad feelings about this.

But that individual... embraced the dragon. In opposition, the Wind Dragon moved its wings to resist. As there was a danger he would be killed at this rate, Lilim warily approached that individual.

"What are you doing?"

"... I'm sorry. I was just so happy... I'm reflecting on my actions."

That individual was Rudel after all. Opening her eyes a little, Lilim confirmed the clothes he wore, and compared his appearance to her sister's description. She dropped her caution and soothed the dragon.

Seeing a dragon up close, their large bodies and demonic forms invoked much fear. For there to be an oddball who wasn't even a dragoon to leap at one... such was Lilim's first impression of him.



Led inside the mansion, the ladies found themselves in the room the meeting was supposed to take place. While their first meeting was planned

to be in that room to begin with... as Rudel had done such a discourtesy, the two of them were currently sipping tea on standby.

"He's a strange one, right senpai? I'm here on my house's orders, but why didn't you decline?"

Cattleya asked as she sipped her tea, and Lilim answered.

"I am an elf, and no matter how much I achieve, I will never be granted a family name. The only exception is marrying into a noble house, where the child born of the union will take up its name... this is partly the request of the elven elders, but... I heard he was an individual my little sister was interested in, so I wanted to check him out. Well, it seems I'm just here to harass the house head."

Even now, Courtois treated demi-humans poorly. The reason they could even become knights of the country was due to the fact that the Gaia Empire next door was a military state. If they didn't prioritize ability, then a gap would open in no time.

That was the 'Setting of the World'.

As if to interrupt their conversation, the head- Rudel's father- made his entrance.

"I apologize for that previous discourtesy... from that bumbling son of mine. I hope you'll forgive him."

While his words did form an apology, his attitude was clearly looking down on the two. The two paid it little mind, as they stood and offered the archduke some knightly bows. As that was happening, it was Rudel's turn to appear.

"I-I've kept you waiting!"

"Rudel! What were you thinking!? You disgrace of the Arses House... keep our guests company at once."

As he said that, Rudel's father left the room. That was usually an unfeasible interaction, but from the Arses House's point of view, they were dealing with a small-time noble, and a demi-human. If they weren't dragoons respected by the country, Rudel's father wouldn't have seen them as any more than pebbles on the side of the road.

"It is a pleasure to be of your acquaintance, Rudel-sama. For this auspicious honor, I do... hah."

While Cattleya tried to give a greeting, she stopped partway, gave a sigh, and sat down in her chair. She didn't even try to look Rudel in the face. To be more precise, she remembered her malice whenever she did.

"Cattleya... my apologies, Rudel-sama. I'm sure your dissatisfied with me, but shall we talk a while? I am Lilim... as you can see, I am an elf."

Rudel grew down over Cattleya's attitude... it felt similar to being hated by his favorite idol. But once Lilim gave her greetings, he instantly perked up.

"I am Rudel Arses. It is an honor to meet the dragoon I admire most!"

Rudel knew almost all of the dragoon knights. Irrelevant to popularity. And among them, he naturally knew the prominent name of Lilim. As Rudel approached with sparking eyes, Lilim took a step back.

"You're just as my sister said... do you really admire dragoons so?"

"Yes! I'll definitely become one!"

... Lilim thought it would be difficult. Even for herself, she knew that her becoming of a dragoon was a miracle. She didn't think it possible for Rudel who only received reasonable evaluations.

But perhaps that was why... she invited Rudel outside to ride on the back of her own dragon.



"A-amazing! Amaazing!!"

Lilim rode with him. I'm glad he's so delighted by my prided Wind Dragon's speed... she thought. The air resistance was blocked out with the dragon's magic. Because of that, no matter how fast they moved across the sky, they could freely look over the ground.

"Are you satisfied, Rudel-sama? Have your worries been blown away..."

"Eh?"

There was another reason this engagement was arranged. It was to make Rudel aware he was the next archduke. To tell him to stop dreaming of dragoons forever.

"You'll likely be marrying Cattleya, and you need to get a look at reality. If you marry, then as the heir, it will become important for you to help out the current archduke."

"W-what are you talking about? Lilim-sama, I...!"

"I heard about you from my sister. Excellent grades, and while you may have a problem or two, you're tolerant towards demi-humans... you should be putting your territory first, and acting upon it. Give up on becoming a dragoon. Your wife Cattleya will do your share of knightly duties as well."

The words he received from his respected dragoon were 'give up'... those words felt extremely heavy to Rudel.



Once the meeting with Rudel was over, the two ladies set out for their lodging house. The day grew dark, and by the time they reached, it would likely be night, thought Cattleya as she teased Lilim.

"Did you successfully promote yourself, senpai? Even so, you sure are cruel... telling him to give up."

"Oh shut it... that was originally supposed to be your job."

"Well, well... but he'll probably give up with this. I mean, he heard it from an active dragoon... and that look on his face when he got back! It was seriously an end-of-the-world face!"

Lilim found it a little strange... normally, Cattleya wasn't the sort of person to say these sort of things. She was a genius, and while she looked down on her surroundings, it was never this terrible. She even grew curious as to what could drive her towards such negative feelings.

"... I felt a little sorry for him..."

Lilim's words didn't reach Cattleya.

Chapter 17

The long break over, Rudel returned to the academy with heavy heart. The only thing occupying his mind was the active dragoon's words to give up... Rudel only grew darker. Not in the boys' dorm cafeteria, but the school building cafeteria that remained open during the break, Rudel sat and thought.

The ones worrying over him were Izumi and Basyle. Izumi was purely worried... Basyle heard the talks of engagement and wondered if she should just go get the mistress position to take a load off her future. She was full of impure motives...

But Rudel...

"Aah, do you think Cattleya-sama and Lilim-sama hate me?"

The point of his worries was a little off. Right, Rudel... from Cattleya and Lilim's attitude and tone,

'Don't get near me!'

He was sure they were trying to say. From Rudel's point of view, it was as if every member of his favorite idol group had come to hate him...

"After I become a dragoon, how am I supposed to look them in the eye? What am I supposed to say to them!?"

The two of them looked over Rudel with worry...



Regardless of his worries, the second term started as a matter of course...

"We will not hold the countermeasure meeting for this time's excursion!"

A countermeasure meeting towards the goal set up last year of getting first place was energetically opened. Headed by Rudel in the classroom after school.

"Just as with last time, all groups share the same starting point, but the course differs by class. And the first years of the fundamental curriculum are taking part as well... this time, there are many talents among the first years! On top of that, the princess' class contains guards who have trained from a young age to protect her! I have no choice but to say first place will be difficult under these circumstances."

In the documents handed out to everyone, Rudel noted the comprehensive evaluation he had Basyle collect of each class. On top of that, the necessary tools for the forest, the unneeded goods... it was all written in great detail.

"And what we need to be wary of this time is Aleist's class. Despite being first years, they managed to eat into the top ranks last time... with that in mind, the average distance we have to traverse per day is..."

As the explanations ran on, everyone listened in all seriousness. The all wanted to clear the humiliation they suffered the year before... it united them. In that regard, Rudel gave thanks to Aleist's classes provocations. Having an opponent to beat made for a splendid goal.

Lowering their loads, gathering the tools they never assembled last year, and confirming over the course with everyone... Rudel's class steadily got its preparations in order.



Aleist's class had reached the goal with a high ranking last time, so they were filled with optimism. And if there weren't any upperclassmen, they even thought it natural they reach first place.

As Luecke Halbades and Eunius Diade's classes were solidified with nobles, they were at a disadvantage... Rudel's class withdrew last year, and

they were out of the question! But Aleist's class could utilize Aleist's inexhaustible magic to conquer the forest without issue.

The result was clear before it even began.

"Hey, Aleist... looks like this'll be another easy victory!"

One of his classmates said it as he pat Aleist on the shoulder. He wanted to use something to strengthen his bond with Aleist, but Aleist himself saw him as no more than an acquaintance.

"Yeah, that's right. If there's anyone we have to worry about, it would be the princess' class, perhaps?"

"Why's that? The princess' class is also mainly nobles, so doesn't that put them at a disadvantage?"

"... The princess has guards posted among her classmates. What's more, they're incredibly skilled... do you think those folks would let the princess receive a rank that would embarrass her?"

After thinking a while, the classmate spoke simply,

"You think they'll move some hands in the background?"

Aleist sighed... if they did that, then some would grow discomfort towards the princess, so it probably wasn't going down... but that wasn't completely wrong. The academy definitely couldn't anger royalty, and in this event, the princess' safety was the first priority. Even if it was a little unfair, they'd secure her safety, if nothing else.

"Even if they don't do that, they'll get into the top ranks."

Aleist ended the conversation... but these days, Aleist had grown especially panicked. The events not going as he wanted was one thing, but Rudel was way too proficient to an abnormal level.

He thought it was because he had grown far stronger than the original protagonist, and it was creating an influence within Rudel. But that wouldn't

explain his personality. The younger brother Chlust was supposed to be decent, but he received disciplinary action in his first term.

Originally, Rudel was scheduled to cause a problem...

Within his head, the fact the story wasn't moving in its set direction was making him anxious. Right around now, he was supposed to be busy with all the romance events! ... he thought.

Millia and Izumi and Princess Fina... Aleist thought over numerous characters...



It was the forest the academy used in last year's event... there, a few dozen specialists were conducting an investigation. Last year, an archduke's son faced an attack from an impossible monster.

The prince was to take part this time, so an investigation was conducted to give the final say. To conclude, there were no problems at all... the specialists didn't see anything wrong with their examination results.

"Even so... did that monster in the reports really exist? I get the feeling the monsters are a little restless, but... I can't really make heads or tails of it."

As one of the specialists pondered over it, a bad-mouthed specialist spoke.

"Perhaps it's the excuse of an archduke's idiot son... it's a right bother. There are plenty of guards who'll get their stories straight if you sent a bit of money around. The fact the monsters are restless is because a certain idiot noble made a mess of the forest!"

As they spoke, the investigation team left the forest. On the report, they wrote, 'No Issue,' even sarcastically noting the important points to remember in a forest.

But...

"GYAAAAARH!!!"

With black body and a white crest, a large bird descended onto the first. Its form was abnormal... it boasted a number of eyes, four wings and four feet... at this point, it couldn't even be called a bird. But if it flew, its silhouette was fowl enough. So seeing it from a distance, the specialists didn't think anything particularly strange of it.

In its beak, perhaps captured in the forest... it held a large, deer-like monster. That black, grotesque monster flung it straight up, and the deer danced through the air.

... And as it fell, the monster swallowed it whole. While it didn't bite it within its mouth, some part of its body had to be chewing, as a crunching sound resounded through the woods.



Before their second attempt, their preparations all complete, Rudel and his classmates did a final check on the academy grounds. Bags, medicine, and weapons... they felt a slight difference in zeal from those around, but even so the class thought of nothing but fulfilling this time's objective.

"I hope this year ends without issue."

On Izumi's question, Rudel left a moment of silence before answering.

"... Right."

Perplexed over that vague answer, Izumi followed Rudel's eyes. On the meeting grounds, the classes of nobles sluggishly coming in... and there, she could see Aleist's class. But their attire was the same as last year, some may say their equipment had even declined.

Rudel felt just a little anger at the fact Aleist wasn't taking this seriously. But his class... he turned his attention off the fact he wasn't even being taken into consideration. For now, he just had to focus on his goal...

Izumi... and another watched Rudel suddenly turned serious. The one sending an expressionless look of admiration was the second princess Fina.

(Master looks kinda cool!! You think he'll capture some fluffies in the forest... those killer rabbits are simply the cutest!!! Those guards never read the mood, and kill them in an instant! ... Hah, I need to replenish my cuddle meter.)

As the princess looked around, she spotted Mii's commoner class. Seeing Mii reservedly wave her hand, the princess...

(My little kitten!!! Hah, hah... you're cute as ever today... once we get back to the academy, I won't let you get away!)

Expressionlessly waved back.

Chapter 18

Once the forest excursion commences, Rudel's group hurriedly made for the first point. In the class that advance through the trees towards its determined destination point, there were barely even any murmurs. Izumi was at the head, and Rudel walked a little behind. Izumi and Rudel were about the only ones in class able to respond to emergency situations.

Taking that into consideration, Izumi was put at the lead, and Rudel was behind giving orders to the whole.

This was largely due to Izumi's ineptitude in magic. It's not that she couldn't use it, but she would always end up relying on her specialty swordplay. In that regard, Rudel had no weaknesses. He excelled in swordplay and magic, and he was the all-purpose type that could work wherever he was stationed.

"The noble classes are lagging after all... at this rate, the commoner classes will come out on top..."

Rudel remained wary of his surroundings as he confirmed the classes slowly drifting down different routes. But there was more than one noble class, and one of them was proceeding at roughly the same speed as Rudel's.

"The princess' class is a proficient one."

As she walked at the front, Izumi could also confirm the princess class separating away. She could also see Chlust following along behind. Leaving his baggage to his followers, he was equipped with nothing but his weapon. What's more, he took a dubious distance from the class.

"Is Chlust a core fighter? If they're leaving the rear to him, he must be considerably skilled."

Rudel showed some admiration for his little brother. But his eyes soon turned to survey his own class as a whole... it seems he had already lost interest. From Izumi's point of view, Chlust who merely followed along looked like the baggage of the class.

In actuality, Chlust took a set distance from the class, and separate combatants to protect the rear had been prepared.

"Rudel really is irresponsible in things he has no interest in. I guess that's just like him, but..."

Izumi let out a sigh. She turned her gaze forward, proceeding further and further into the forest's depths.



With their experience the year before, Aleist's class was... unable to proceed forwards. It was because the academy had reflected on last years events, and added onto the important points to follow.

'Do not recklessly destroy the forest.'

This was an entry that came from Aleist's conduct in the previous excursion. Aleist had only ever heard of that warning in the final checks before they departed... there were printouts distributed beforehand, but he had neglected them.

"What are we going to do, Aleist!? At this rate, we're going to come in last!"

"Just use your magic already!"

"Fool! The guards are keeping an eye on us... do you want to be found out and failed?"

Leading this panicked class, Aleist used elementary magic to take on monsters and trees... it was an exceedingly distressful journey. His classmates would immediately move out on their own, and there were even

some who would hide if battle began, so finding them was yet another trial...

This situation was the same as, if not worse than what Rudel faced the year before.

"Get a grip on yourselves! Leaving everything to me... have any of you taken part in battle yet? You haven't! Quit leaving all the combat to me!!"

In such a situation, Aleist was reaching the end of his patience. Aleist's class started arguing on the spot... The fact their feet stopped contributed heavily to their lowering rank.



"Princess, are you alright?"

Three days since the academy's fundamental curriculum students entered the woods. It was around the time the faster classes would start reaching the goal. And the princess' class was one of those fast classes.

"Yes, I'm alright."

(Alright? No way in hell I'm alright!! Just how many fluffies do you lot think you've killed in these past three days!!? Even getting so hyped up just because you were in front of me... when you don't even usually talk to me! And there's that Chlust! That bastard... cutting down any killer rabbits that came close to me! I could've endured a few good blows! Endured and bathed in the fluff!!!)

"Princess, you haven't forgotten my achievements, have you? I, Chlust, who raced to her majesty in her time of crisis shall continue to protect you henceforth."

As Chlust defeated a killer rabbit that appeared while the guards were away, he had managed to convince the guards that complained whenever he got close to the princess. And like that, he got to be stationed nearby her.

Though the one who created that gap in the guard schedule was the princess herself...

"Thank you, Chlust... you have grown reliable."

(Hah? You were just stalking me, weren't you? Rather... erk, I feel sick!)

Fina expressionlessly answered Chlust... but at that moment, a clack and white wicked bird swooped down with its sights on the princess' class.



As Rudel's class made for the goal, while they showed some exhaustion, everyone wrung out the last of their strength to reach. The way things were going, they were sure to obtain a high rank. Even first place was possible... but.

"H-help us!!!"

"Someone!!!"

Appearing from the side of their route, a group of underclassmen nobles. The fact these nobles were right before the goal on the third day... meant they were probably the princess' classmates. But if any classmate went missing, or strayed from the route, the class was supposed to receive a failing grade.

"Why are you guys here? The goals should have been prepared separate for each class."

Izumi drew close and questioned the underclassmen.

"T-the princess! The princess, by a black bird!"

"A large bird monster appeared... all the guards went out to fight it, but we could only run..."

Hearing those words, Rudel's eyes turned serious.

"What direction... what direction are they in!?"

"T-that way!"

The underclassmen were startled by Rudel's shout. With shaking fingers they pointed down the path they came...

"... Everyone, listen up."

Rudel gathered all his classmates in one place and began talking.



"GYAGYAGYAAAaaah!!!"

Black, with a white pattern across it, the fearsome bird blew away the guards who appeared to protect the princess. Flapping its wings, its four legs kicked the guards about... the scattering guards were capable ones prepared specifically for the princes. But they...

"This monster! For a while now, my body isn't doing what I tell it to!"

"What are you doing!? Someone, anyone, just take the princess and run!!!"

"If only my body could move... this damn bird...!"

Protected by her guards that were also her classmates, Fina looked upon the scene.

(Ah, even I don't think I could cuddle with that black bird.)

She was trying to escape from reality. This was largely because her body wouldn't move. She couldn't put power into her legs... her arms didn't feel like they were her own... at this very moment, the students who weren't able to flee were resolved for death.

The red eyes all across the black bird's body simultaneously turned to take in the princess. That number of eyes was abnormal, and seeing them, even

the fluff-loving princess shook from the bottom of her heart. There, a white shadow leapt out.

The one who entered the gap between princess and bird was the White Cat Tribe's Mii.

"W-what are you doing, Mii! Stand down!"

The princess panicked, but even now, she had no expression. To that princess, Mii...

"I-I'm scared, but I'll do my best! I'll do my best for the princess who called me her friend! .. H-huh? I can't put power into my body?"

While Mii had jumped in with good momentum, she fell to her knees before the brutal bird's cry... as the bird approached, everyone could foresee the death of the white cat girl and the princess.

Yet once more, an individual leapt into the space between Mii and the bird. But this time, that individual was going full force from the start.

"Fly awaaaay!!!"

A wind attribute magic, just as he leapt out of the forest, he smashed it into the monster at point-blank range. It was a surefire magic... If he was going to become a dragoon, Rudel said he wanted a special attack, and had Basil teach him.

With two shots of wind magic from his two hands, he displayed destructive power unthinkable from an intermediate magic. As the bird was sent flying, everyone present was left in a daze.

"M-master!"

(Master really is a badass~!!!)

"T-the noble from back then?"

Within all that, Fina and Mii were the first to let out words, but...

"... Now! Start running!"

"Eh?"

"Nya!"

Alongside his words, Rudel's classmates ran over to the collapsed students and guards, lifting them up and running off. Rudel lifted up the princess and Mii, taking flight at full force.

"Why are you running? Didn't you defeat it with that?"

The Princess asked.

"It's still moving, and its eyes aren't dead. It'll be up chasing us soon!"

"If you use that magic from before..."

A princess under one arm, a cat girl under the other... to Mii's question, Rudel made a straight face.

"That was a special move! I thought it up with Basyle, it was a powerful special with a mana consumption unfeasible for real combat!"

"I-it was?"

"I'm out of mana, so I can't use it. Even if I do, I won't be able to move anymore, so we'll lose!"

(Master... we're screwed!!!)

Chapter 19

From the moment the fundamental-curriculum students entered the forest, it was already almost the fourth day. A few hours since they ran from their foe... in the forest, they stifled their breath, Rudel's class looked after the underclassmen and guards they'd saved as they remained wary of their surroundings.

Within that, Rudel confirmed his own equipment as he looked up at the sky... his form gave Izumi a bad premonition. That wasn't the usual Rudel... it seemed almost like he was excited... almost as if he was longing for battle.

Around, Rudel's class's guards looked after the immobilized guards and students, but... unable to find the cause, they were unable to snap them out of it.

"There's no poison, and it isn't hypnosis... just what did it do to get them in this state?"

Even the most capable of guards cocked their heads as they looked over the ones unable to move freely. Within all that, the leader of the immobilized guards issued orders. But upon hearing them, the others felt some unease.

"We're fine, so just take the able-bodied ones, and get the princess out of this forest... staying here is way too dangerous."

(Was that guy always someone who spoke so heatedly? I'd prefer he didn't make a racket, riling up everyone around...)

That's what everyone wanted... but while the brutal bird was circling the skies searching them out, whether they could escape or not was the

problem. And as long as they didn't have any information on the bird, the situation could take a turn for the worst.

When the princess was attacked, to the outside of the forest... they had sent a report to the academy's relevant parties. But they hadn't informed them of the bird's abilities! In such a state, the mummy hunter would become the mummy... the casualties would only increase. And in this forest populated by so many students... you could say any and everything was bad as could be.

"That white cat missy's class was saved, but... it's only a matter of times before casualties stack up."

Mii's class was hiding alongside them. Among them, the elf girl... Millia was there as well.

"This is the worst."

The mobile guards tried to draft the optimum plan in this forest. Even if the princess was saved as a result, they would be blamed for this mess, and there was a danger they would lose their lives... So the line came out as they thought over their prospects.



"Use a decoy? ... And will that save us?"

One of the guards spoke to Rudel as a representative. He explained that Rudel and the princess would take along some of the still-mobile guards and make a break for it.

"... It will definitely save you."

The guard's face was dark, or rather tense. He was hiding something, convinced of that, Rudel asked the guard.

"Will that save everyone?"

On those words, the eyes of all those lowering their breath gathered. The guards hung their heads, and from their attitudes, the students knew not everyone would be saved. There were even some who began to sob.

"We'll take those swift of feet outside of the forest. We need to get the information out quickly. It's already midnight, so the probability of being found by the enemy is low."

The guard felt ashamed that he could say nothing but lies. If the enemy was one with night-seeing eyes, they would definitely be spotted, and moving through the night was exceedingly difficult... the fact they needed to hurry regardless of such factors was because Fina was the princess of this country.

"Please pay me no mind... let us search for a path where we all survive." (You're telling me to abandon my kitten!? Not happening! Not in a million years! And if I abandoned my classmates, what sort of person would that make me? I'm royalty so there's no helping it? ... Like any of you actually care about that! In the end, you're just scared of what punishment is in store.)

"Got it... then I'll be the decoy."

"What!?"

As the guard showed surprise, Izumi and Fina reacted as well. At the unusual air Rudel gave off, Izumi's unease became definite.

"Rudel, what are you talking about!?"

(Oh, right... I heard master was an idiot. He can study, but he's not the clever type... though his technique in petting fluffies is at genius level...)

Within that dark air, Rudel's outrageous statement had completely changed the flow.

"Did you hear any of that!? And as an escort target, you hold a high level of priority! Use such an individual as a decoy? I'd like you to quit joking

around! Let us choose a decoy from among the guards... while I do feel sorry for the other students, they'll have to escape by their own..."

Right, this plan utilized the other students running around to save the princess alone by all means. Even if the guards were done in, as long as the students' escape attempts drew the monster's attention, that was enough... it was that sort of plan.

And at that moment, two new classes arrived, led by their guards. Students the guards had to protect no matter the cost... the classes of Luecke and Eunius of the Three Lords.

The noble students, unable to understand the situation, raised their voices to cry out, 'Explain what's going on!' Everyone present suppressed the mouths of those students, explaining to them in a whisper... but still they couldn't understand. Or rather, they wouldn't believe.

In this forest used for school events, there's no way such dangerous monsters could exist... that was their argument.

"Quiet! Make a ruckus, and the enemy'll find us... the princess is here to, so please just follow orders."

The guard leader frantically explained in a small voice, even bringing the princess into it. If that was the case, the nobles could only keep quiet... in such a situation, Luecke and Eunius,

"If there's such a monster out here, it's much too dangerous... that's a problem at a level where you'll need to request a knight brigade."

In contrast to Luecke's levelheadedness, Eunius' reaction was belligerent.

"What good's it do to be weak at the knees? This is a chance to raise our names... and if we're protecting the princess, won't this be a bit of a hero's tale?"

He muttered as he gripped the hilt of the sword on his back... there, Rudel put in his mouth.

"Then the three of us can be the decoy. As luck would have it, I have no objection to their strength. Eunius will be the vanguard, and Luecke at the rear...? I think I'm fine wherever, but..."

"Wait a second, Arses! Why are you dragging me into this decoy role!?"

While his voice was a whisper, Leucke's voice gradually grew with anger. Rudel responded only as if it were natural.

"Its only natural for a noble to protect the crown. When you're always going on about obligation and responsibility, you're going to run?"

"... When we have specialists, why do we amateurs have to move..."

In order to ensure the princess can get away, I don't want to decrease the amount of guards on her. Also...

On Rudel's high-handed persuasion, those around grew anxious. Action without any regard to his own standing was Rudel's specialty, but... this was simply too terrible.

There, yet another new class made their entrance... Aleist's class. They were terribly worn out, and it didn't look as if anyone besides Aleist would be of any use... the lot of them seemed to be nothing more than a hindrance.

"I heard the story along the way... the chance has finally come for me to do some service!"

Aleist- the sole energetic one- looked at the princess as he gave a response brimming with confidence... but his clothes and equipment were in tatters, and Fina wasn't quite buying it.

"Are you the son of the Hardie House? I've heard rumor of you..." (Oh, right, umm... that guy! Mister upperclassman who's strong like a monster, and looks really cool, but can't get a girlfriend for some reason... I won't say anything about someone's hobbies, but what's so good about being with other men? Normally, shouldn't you choose the fluff!?)

Fina seemed to misunderstand Aleist. But unaware of that, Aleist also had some thoughts.

(What's this!? Even the white cat Mii is here! As I recall, these two had a beautiful friendship that transcended the bounds of status, right? If I perform well here, then... alright, whatever monster you are, come at me!)

Within that space now lacking in tension, Rudel alone seriously checked over his equipment as he issued orders to his classmates. And looking up at the sky...

"Then Aleist can also join in, and the four of us will be decoys... everyone else should make for the outside of the forest. Izumi, you guide the students apart from the princess."

Even so, Izumi tried to stop Rudel.

"Give it up already! There's no need for you to do such a thing, is there!?"

As Rudel still wouldn't conceded the decoy role, the blood came to a guard's head, and he tried to raw close. It was at that moment.

"GyaGYAaaah!!!"

Alongside an ominous voice, the brutal bird descended... As everyone was frozen on the spot, with a sword equipped on his right hand, and magic gathered in his left, Rudel attacked at full speed.

Unable to respond in time, the bird was sliced into and sent flying with magic... but it quickly rose, angrily shaking its body... it had completely set its sights on Rudel.

"Go!!! ... And to you three fellow decoys, decide on your own whether you'll stay or run... if it's just me alone, I don't know whether I can defeat it or not."

"Wha!? You plan to beat it!? This monster?"

Luecke was surprised. And Aleist was dumbfounded. As everyone moved in response to Rudel's call, some carried those who couldn't move on their backs, while others just ran in a frenzy... but even so, the bird's many eyes focused on Rudel.

"I'm staying too."

Izumi tried to take part as a decoy, but Rudel denied it.

"That would trouble the class. With your better sense for the night, their probability of escape will increase if anything terrible happens... now go!"

"Kuh! Everyone better return alive, Ridel!"

Izumi also lent a shoulder to an immobilized student as she ran off. Worrying about Rudel to the very end. And of the remaining four, Eunius let out a grand laugh as he took a stance with his sword.

"Nice... splendid, Rudel! You're the best... I recognize your courage to challenge this beast! Luecke! Aleist! If you're running, then make it quick."

"D-don't joke around! There is no reason for me to fear a monster of this caliber! I'll blow it away with my magic, so you need only stand there and watch... Rudel, you bear witness too! That this is my strength..."

Luecke quickly began to prepare his prized magic. Regardless of Luecke's long-winded speech, battle had already begun, so it was ignored as a simple matter of course. But Aleist...

"W-why are the Three Lords getting along... shouldn't you all 'hate each other'? And yet, why are you fighting on a combined front..."

He was still muttering himself, his preparations for battle still pending.

Chapter 20

The four who went to serve as decoys... got wrapped up in intense combat they did not, as they ran around. To be more precise, it was a repeat of hit, run and hide. The four of them coordinated attacks as they fled.

"What's with that bird!? I don't even know if magic is working, and approaching it is dangerous... isn't there anything we can do about it?"

Luecke noticed they lacked the power to land anything decisive, but there, Aleist gave his opinion.

"Down! It's maximizing the effect of status down skills!"

Aleist unraveled the game knowledge he carried in his head. What he remembered was abnormal status magic and special skills. They weren't particularly useful in the game.

"Down? The hells that?"

But neither Eunius nor Luecke seemed to get it. The down Aleist referred to was a special ability to lower the parameters of an enemy, but it didn't scale well in-game...

"Any means to prevent it?"

Rudel understood Aleist had some sort of info on the enemy and tried asking. But...

"There's recovery items, and the probability of down taking effect isn't that high..."

"By recovery item... you mean medicine? There's a medicine that'll erase this special effect? And you somehow plan to use it while fighting?"

While Luecke thought over it, Eunius let out a sigh.

"If something like that's out there, then our best bet would be the guards... but whether we can get any or not is all up to chance. In that case, we can only settle it with one blow."

On Eunius' thoughts, Aleist held his head.

"There's no way a boss would go down in one hit..."

Running around, those tattered four stepped forward for their final actions. Luecke with his magic... Eunius channeled magic into his large blade... Aleist used his prided magic sword, and Rudel prepared magic on both his hands.

The first to move, Luecke aimed for the moment the bird noticed them and began its descent, giving the signal.

"Now! Everyone attack!!!"

Luecke shot a large-scale magic at the bird... once the impact caused it to lose its balance and fall, this time Eunius slashed with his sword, and Rudel launched his assault. Eunius' blade cut into the bird's wings, and Rudel's special move sent it flying a distance... and one person was left.

"D-did that do it in...!?"

The words Leucke spoke out of breath were soon answered, blood flowing all over its body, the brutal bird stood to its feet. Eunius renewed his stance, but Rudel wasn't even able to stand. An overuse of mana... the backlash put a burden on his body. And making that even worse was the bird's ability.

"Tsk! I never would've imagined it would be this hard to move... Leucke... can you stand?"

"Don't make light of me, Eunius! It's not that I can't stand! I just don't want to..."

On Eunius' words, Leucke showed some backbone. As the three of them were assailed by the bird's ability, Aleist alone was safe. But the man in question hesitated to cut at the beast's sinister form.

"What are you doing, Hardie!? Get in an attack! You can still make it!"

Aleist moved at Eunius's words, but at that moment... fire rained down from the sky, reducing the bird to cinders... that spectacle was almost as if it was roasted on a pillar of flames.

Once the fire died down, and the forest went quiet... it was right at that time the sun began to rise, and the area grew brighter. Descending, bathed in its light, was Cattleya on her Red Dragon.

Cattleya got down from her dragon and looked around. On her form, tattered as he was, Rudel couldn't help but feel excited. But after taking in the situation, the conclusion Cattleya came to on her own...

"It looks like one of you persisted to the end. As expected of Hardie-kun, I guess? On the other hand... Rudel, you're all beaten up, and you can't even stand. You really are unsightly."

As Cattleya stood before the four, with Aleist being the only one left standing, and taking her own feelings into account, she couldn't think that Rudel had persisted. No, she didn't want to think it. Even when, from his strength, she was easily able to imagine him contributing to the battle...

The standing Cattleya looked down over the collapsed Rudel. On her words, Rudel felt ashamed that he hadn't changed at all from the year before. He had trained... he had learned... but even so, Rudel ended up being saved.

Within that scene, Aleist...

"Eh? ... What's with this situation? And my meeting with Cattleya-san should come much later... huh!?"



The events in the forest became a topic of hot conversation within the academy. 'In order to save the princess, Aleist volunteered to be a decoy!' this talk made Aleist quite the popular one on campus... but the Three Lords... Rudel and the others' assessments weren't quite to par.

For Eunius and Luecke, as expected of the heirs to the Three Lords! They'd say and praise them, but for Rudel alone, it even came to a problem of responsibility. He was criticized for volunteering to be a decoy. He didn't understand his standing... It was a result of the guard reports, and Chlust who had fled before anyone realized it spreading lies to change the point of any blame put against him...

'On top of Rudel spreading fear and disorder, he wasn't of any use in battle.'

The fact he risked his life to save the princess didn't get across, and in regards to this case, Rudel was horribly blamed. The academy itself denied the rumors, but by that action, 'Is he sealing their mouths with money?' or 'They're covering it up precisely because it's true!' the students had reached their conclusions.

In order to heal his beaten body, Rudel was admitted to the infirmary. Lying at the window-side bed that was quickly becoming his reserved space, he could naught but look at the sky. And by his side, Izumi peeling fruit was the usual sight.

"You think I'll see a dragon... you think one'll fly over..."

He had his fill of boring patient life. In the adjacent beds, Luecke and Eunis were admitted just in case. Unlike Rudel's terrible shape, they had gotten off with light injuries.

"Are you always like this?"

To Luecke's question, Izumi gave a bitter smile.

"We're fine and all, but... Rudel, you can't just be sitting back here, right?"

Right, Rudel alone was in a horrible situation.

"I'm sorry. I explained it to everyone in my class, but it seems the academy is moving towards hushing this incident up. To be more precise, everyone's trying to push blame onto one another... making it that you caused the problem, they're postponing your punishment. In the worst case... you might be expelled, no I heard they'll forcefully make you graduate."

Rudel reacted to those words. With a serious expression...

"Izumi... what do you think I should name my special attack? Doing it with just a random yell every time is harsh. You have something cool, and short enough that they won't see it coming?"

"Oy, you might be expelled here. And you're on about special moves!?"

Luecke made a face of disbelief.

"You can become a knight on just the two years of fundamental education. I'll just work my way up to dragoon from there, so... I'm not particularly interested. No, it's a pity to lose the learning environment of this school."

Rudel completely failed to answer the question. On his words, Izumi looked down, a dark look on her face. Izumi was irritated at Chlust. Chlust and the underclassmen who ran away with him were moving to build up Rudel's sins in order to conceal their disgrace.

Using the power of their houses... but this was strange. No matter the case, it wasn't normal for them to dress Rudel up to this level, and it even seemed downright impossible. Perhaps there was some blame in Rudel's actions. But Rudel also had his reasons.

That bird's abnormal abilities made those around it belligerent, it could be said it excited them. Put under that effect, Rudel was unable to make

rational decisions. That had been proven by medical professionals, and even on top of that, the academy tried to push blame onto Rudel.

Izumi gradually felt Rudel was enraptured within some larger flow... as if this was brought about by a malign twist of fate. As he walked against the stream, Rudel's intense defiance of the force almost seemed to be chipping his life away.



Around that time, Princess Fina was recuperating in her room. With the questioning and interviews she received each day on this matter, in order to heal her daily fatigue...

(Fluffy fever!!! Today's the day I pet and fondle the hell out of Mii!!!)
"Don't run, Mii."

... She had invited her best friend Mii to her room. With the danger she had been put through this time around, knights from her home had raced in as well. In truth, just beyond her room's door, robust female knights stood on duty. If they made a ruckus in the room, it would be heard outside.

Even now, Courtois held a prejudice towards demi-humans. Paying mind to that, Fina had kept quiet to that point. But.

"P-princess! You don't have to pet me that much... why are you groping my breasts!?"

Chasing Mii around on the bed, Fina pet and fondled her all over. With her expressionless face, she pursued nothing more than fluff.

"I want to pet you." (I can't get enough of this! The taste of fluffing up this cute little kitten... my body can't live without the fluff anymore!!! I can't endure it any longer! When I don't know when I'm going to die, holding back is... ah! I have to learn master's technique!)

And such a thing would end up saving Rudel.

Chapter 21

Izumi returned to the girls' dorm, and when knight fell, Rudel slipped out of the infirmary. His hand was clasped around a sword. Noticing his movements, Luecke held some suspicious and decided to tail him. There, Eunius called out.

"Just leave him be."

"Like I could ignore someone going out with a weapon! And there's no telling what he's going to do."

Eunius rose from his bed, scratching his head as he motioned for Luecke to follow. Abiding by that, Luecke walked behind Eunius.

The two went out to the infirmary veranda. There, Eunius pointed his finger downwards... the sound of the swinging sword reached even the second floor, and Leucke could see the form of Rudel in tears as he swung it around. The pitiful form of a young boy wrapped in bandages, desperately swinging his blade.

"He's doing good with that beaten body of his... he's been doing it every day for these past few days."

"Why is he crying? He didn't give of that feel during the day. Going on about special attacks, and taking it easy reading a book on Dragon Petting or something..."

"Like I know! But, well... not just those around him, hated even by his own family, but even so he aimed to be a dragoon. And then came this incident. It's only natural for him to want to cry."

Undenounced to the two of them, Rudel was crying for a slightly different reason. From Rudel's point of view, the responsibility for this case lay with him. Leucke, Eunius... and even Aleist had been unreasonably dragged into the battle, and that was without a doubt his fault.

He knew his house would never recognize him. He was aware that the surrounding assessments of him were low. But even so, if he put in the effort, he would be recognized... he believed he could become a dragoon. And he still believed it.

The reason Rudel wept: the simple fact that there were people who would act for his sake. Everyone in his class stood up for him. To Rudel, that was something to fill him with delight, but at the same time, after exposing his classmates to danger, he felt ashamed he wasn't even able to protect them.

Rudel wanted to become stronger, and but for now he could simply swing his sword towards that ideal.



The morning of the next day, the academy's staff were gathered, and a meeting was held. This was a large problem, and they had to make it clear who was responsible for exposing the princess to danger, but the problem here was...

"To think the Arses House would say such a thing..."

"Even if they tell us to expel Rudel-sama, no matter how you look at it, this is..."

"The palace is telling us to hurry it up. Perhaps obeying them is for the best."

The Arses House demanded Rudel be expelled, stating they would take responsibility for this incident. The rumors had spread even further in these past few days. Rudel had exposed the princess to danger... the younger brother Chlust had protected her. As those rumors were intentionally circulating, they were already beyond anyone's hands.

"So the Arses House chooses Chlust-sama over the eldest son Rudel-sama."

As the headmaster let out a sigh, the faculty made doubtful faces. The siblings were full of problems, but while Rudel earnestly set his sights forward, focusing on pursuing his dream, Chlust was a simple problem child. As he took along his followers and walked around the campus, he bought in the animosity of commoners and demihumans.

The answer the academy reached was to postpone matters until the target of responsibility disappeared... but Rudel alone would be forcefully transferred to the two-year track and made to graduate. From there, the title of knight would be granted to him, to leave him the possibility of becoming a dragoon.

Taking in the demands of the Arses House, this was the best the academy could do to protect the boy.

"What about the investigation?"

"I heard it's under royal jurisdiction."

"Even so, it sure is ironic... the deserters are saved, and those who stood firm face the hammer."

Within that dark conference room, the headmaster looked over the documents as he spoke.

"Protecting the crown is a noble's duty, huh... for the Arses house to discard such a splendid successor."

A teacher who felt a sense of danger at the headmaster's words started speaking as if to cut him off.

"But it's that! With this, Rudel-sama can pursue a dragoon's path without any constraint!"

On those words, a number of teachers joined in, making for a brighter conversation than any the meeting had seen.

"Sure enough!"

"If he becomes a knight, he'll obtain the qualifications to become a dragoon."

"If he can become one, that is."

As that conversation of empty bravado carried on, the headmaster thought over the future. Just how was he going to protect Rudel...



Her health recovered, and her fluff levels fully replenished, the Second Princess Fina looked on in horror at the document brought by the high knight who had come to her room to report.

"What is the meaning of this..."

(What's this? It's become that Chlust protected me from that blasted bird, and master spread panic, exposing me to danger!!? No way in hell! Rather... where was MY opinion taken into account? In the first place, what Chlust protected me from was a killer rabbit, and when that bird came out, he was nowhere to be found!)

The reporting knight had her long, purple hair in order. An older beauty with glasses who gave off a cold impression. She had a harsh personality, and Fina herself classified her as a person she was terrible at dealing with. She had no sense of flexibility.

"It is just about decided that Rudel-dono will take responsibility for this matter. The academy is leaving matters unresolved, allowing him to graduate, but I am against it. Such a man is unworthy of becoming a knight."

From there on, the high knight continued to take lines from the report to say Rudel's punishment was too light. Just because he is next in line to the title of Archduke Arses, they've done nothing but remove him! She asserted, but Fina...

(This is bad! Master has yet to pass on his technique! If he graduates here, it will be a heavy blue to my fluffy life... but why does master's house hate him so much anyways?)

Looking at the high knight who continued to offer some harsh opinion on Rudel, Fina thought.

(Should I have her investigate? While that's going on, I'll write a letter to father and mother. Meanwhile, I'll sit back with Mii and do all sorts of... I can't! If I fail here, then my national treasure of a master may be erased by the Arses House.)

In essence, Rudel would take an active knight role upon his graduation, but by the orders of his house, he would likely be stationed in a high level danger zone.

"... Sophina. This report is mistaken."

The expressionless princess panicked within as she persuaded the high knight Sophina.

"It's mistaken? But this is the official document. It couldn't be..."

(That's why you let your years slip by! Your thoughts are way too rigid in any and everything! There aren't any lies written down, but don't you think this thing's been written in a way that invites in misunderstanding? I'm no good with her! I want to go do this and that with Mii already.)

Thinking some considerably rude things, Fina spoke on.

"Rudel-sama risked his life to protect me. Protecting the crown is a noble's duty... he said as he stood against great danger. There is no way he should be judged for those actions."

"Btu right here, it says...!"

As Sophina's voice grew louder, Fina expressionlessly added on.

"Then make a decision with your own eyes. The whole truth is not contained in paper, and I believe I was saved by Rudel-sama."

(A look at master's technique will change your life! Putting that aside, if she investigates on her own, she'll definitely notice something's strange! Now go prove master's innocence(?))

"If you insist it so... but if my eyes tell me there is no mistake to be found, then I shall punish him as harshly as the palace dictates."

Seeing Sophina's enthusiasm, Fina thought yet another rude thing.

(It's because you make such scary faces that the men run away... you're already at a good age, so just get married already. Always at work, no chance to see anyone... if only you had cat ears, I would've doted on you! I'd have kept you by my side all the while! A harsh-natured cat-eared beauty... that's a yes!!!)



Oblivious to everything moving around, today once more Rudel and two others got along well across their infirmary beds. And the conversation blazed about the book Rudel was reading, 'How to Pet a Dragon'.

"Why is there an application of such high-level magic theory!? Why is there a theory that puts technical books to shame in this book about petting!?"

Detailing magic theory so complex it even surprised the magic-centric Luecke, 'How to Pet a Dragon'. Theories and formulas that had even surpassed present knowledge had been developed for no more than to stroke a dragon.

"Oy! It even ends it all by saying, 'But the most important part is love!' Isn't that strange!? Applying technique close to the essentials of martial arts towards petting, and the end it's all love!!!"

Eunius cried out. Written there was a petting method focusing on the applications of anatomy and the martial arts... After detailing all the finer

points, it tied it all up with love. 'How to Pet a Dragon'.

"See? Isn't it amazing!? The author of this book was a former dragoon who lived a hundred years ago... if only I could've met him."

Ignoring their shock, Rudel thought about his senior separated by a gap of a hundred years.

Chapter 22

In the vacant academy cafeteria, Millia met with her sister Lilim for the first in some time. In the cafeteria that only operated for lunch, they prepared their own tea and talked.

Lilim had to drop by the academy for the matter with the princess, so she stopped for a pleasant chat with her little sister Millia. But Millia suddenly asked about Rudel.

"Sis, what's going to happen to Rudel?"

"... His rights to succeed will be stripped away. Other than that, the academy and palace... there's a feud going on between them and the Arses House, so nothing's been decided yet."

Lilim faintly opened her eyes to confirm the darkening of her little sister's face.

"The palace is troubled to make a decision. Problem child or honor student... the king has surprisingly high expectations for Rudel-sama. Said he's an interesting boy."

As they talked over such things, Lilim began thinking over Cattleya's abnormal conduct in this case. Cattleya's hatred of Rudel was abnormal. From the documents to the reports, they were all so stained in personal opinion they couldn't be used in any judgement. So Lilim swapped out with her, and took over the messenger role.

As the dragoons had got themselves involved, she had to take care of further processing as well... Lilim had it hard.

And like that, the dragoon and high knight started into their investigations.



From the incident, Aleist had suddenly become the academy's hero. The result based around the overlap of a number of ulterior motives tied in directly to Aleist's popularity. Cattleya who used him, and Chlust who wanted to pin the crime on Rudel. But unaware of all that, Aleist enjoyed his situation.

"I love you, Aleist-senpai!" "Please go out with me!" "I like you! ... As a man."

This situation Aleist had wished for differed somewhat from his plans, but minding it not, Aleist happily played with his under and upperclassmen. He stopped coming to the classes he had attended before, and his grades dropped in proportion to his popularity level.

"This is it! This is what I was waiting for!"

Taking out the notes in his room, he started reading through them. A large number of the names had been crossed out, but even so, he looked over what was to come.

"After this, I win in the final tournament of the fundamental curriculum, and I meet the first princess! Even if the developments have changed so much, at this stage, Princess Aileen should still be... alright! I'm feeling motivated, so I'll start working hard tomorrow."

Princess Aileen whose name he spurted was Fina's elder sister. Within the setting where despite its size, the country of Courtois had no male heirs, the value of the princesses was high. If you married one, then just as Chlust said, you'd get close to the status of king.

Within this world, the Princess Aileen held a vital position called 'Main Heroine'. More beautiful than her little sister, blond with blue eyes, a peace-loving woman who was kind to everyone. It was said there wasn't a man in the lands whose heart couldn't be stolen by her smile. As she was doted on by her surroundings all her life, she had a position of a princess oblivious to the ways of the world.

Bud Aleist hadn't and couldn't notice. The heroine with such a perfect setting, Aileen's kindness was limited to humans. She loved peace so much, she was raised to be a woman whose thought often went too far... though it was true that unlike her sister, she was abundant in emotions, and she had no hidden side to her...

"Wait for me, my harem! This is the beginning of my era! I can't wait for what's to come in the next tournament!"

Aleist who looked up to such a princess. He was human, and he didn't hold any special prejudice. So he couldn't understand the princess' abnormality.



Under her private investigations, Sophina had come to the hospital under the name of an infirmary the Three Lords' eldest sons had been admitted. An especially splendid room within had become their hospital room. Before coming there, she had taken opinions from the classes concerned, and asked around about the individual called Rudel.

To be blunt, her opinion of Rudel was the worst! He received disciplinary action after hitting on every girl he could find in his first year of the fundamental curriculum! He went against his upperclassmen (challenged them to duels)! There was no end to his infamy. But the people around him would praise him, and never spoke ill.

That point alone caught Sophina's interest, but it was true the bad rumors overwhelmingly outnumbered the good.

"There's no doubt he's no good as a person. The tournament results make his grades look dubious, and more than anything, someone aiming to be a knight would n-never... h-hit on girls like that! Never!!!"

Sophina's face reddened strangely around that part as she entered the room of the three. What she saw there...

"And I'm saying, why does such a high-level theory have no application outside of petting!? I'm sure it will be useful outside of it!"

"Hey, if you lower a sword like that, don't you think it'll cut well? It's strange these techniques aren't used anywhere outside of petting, right? Isn't it strange, Rudel!?"

She confirmed the three of them in heated debate over a book titled, 'how to Pet Dragons'. In regards to that, Rudel refuted.

"This book has existed for quite some time, and there's no way I could tell you why the theories have never found use! In the first place, even I wonder why this book doesn't get better reviews... petting dragons fills them with happiness! It's the best thing in the world!!!"

"That's not the problem! The reason it's not reviewed is because of that title! Who would realize that book's worth after reading that title? I'd lose interest even before getting to its contents!"

Luecke offered an emotional rebuttal, and just before Rudel could give an objection of his own, he noticed Sophina was there. Eunias and Luecke also turned towards the knight who entered the sick room, unpleasant looks on their faces. Once they understood she was a high knight, they reluctantly questioned her.

"For a high knight to silently sneak into our room... what's your business?"

In regards to Eunius' cynicism, Sophina spoke.

"My humblest of apologies. I already spoke to the guards outside. When I tried to receive permission to enter, you were making quite a ruckus."

Her gestures were perfect as she bowed and answered. As expected of a high knight, the thought crossed their minds.

"I wish to speak with Rudel-dono over the matter with the princess. May I have just a moment of your time?"

As Sophina asked her question, Rudel who had gotten a tad emotional was struck by inspiration. If he could get those two to see the culmination of the

theories in, 'How to Pet Dragons', then they would surely understand its value!

"Before that, could I have a moment of yours? There's something I need your cooperation with!"

"W-what? Well, if it's something within my bounds, then I mind it not. Though I'll be hearing you out afterwards."

Sophina gave a vague reply to his request. She would end up regretting that for the rest of her life. Wary of Rudel as she approached, she thought that even if he assaulted her, it would only add to his crimes.

"Please let me pet you!"

"Eh?"

... Around ten minutes later, half in tears and unsteady on her feet, the form of a high knight was witnessed fleeing from the infirmary. Her face red and her gestures strangely erotic, the female knight Sophina left the room, but the three left behind...

"How about that!? That one wasn't perfect, but now you see how amazing... where are the two of you going? H-huh? Just listen to me!"

"..."

While Luecke ignored him and left the room, Eunius...

"... Bathroom."

Gave one word before he left, and didn't come back for a while. In regards to that, Rudel spoke to himself.

"So even that was no good? Then I have to get better! I have to master it before I meet a dragon!"

He renewed his resolve.



Sophina wept as she burst into the princess' room. Her fluffy time with Mii interrupted, Fina's heart was tinted with rage... expressionless as she was.

"What happened? Did you get your hands on some information?" (You really don't read the mood, do you! What do you think my fleeting moments of fluff are... even so, her face is red, and she's fidgeting around strangely, or how should I put it, why does she look so unsteady? Haha, if only she had cat ears and a tail in that state, it would've done it for me.)

"U-um, well... Rudel-dono was more than I had ever imagined. I'm sure the reports are mistaken... I'm going to report this to the palace, so i-if you'll pardon my leave!" (I-I'll never forgive you... Rudel Arses!)

Seeing Fina run from the room, Fina was certain her plan had succeeded. Oblivious to its failure, she started into her final preparations. Turning to her desk, she began writing up a letter.

"What's wrong, princess? Suddenly writing a letter."

On fina's actions, Mii ho had been released from the fluffing approached. As Mii made light steps treading across the floor, Fina thought she would die from the cuteness.

"It's nothing, Mii. It may not be necessary, but I don't want to be negligent in the end..."

Saying that, Fina patted Mii's head. Mii seemed to be enjoying it. But!

(Hah, hah... just you wait, little kitten! Once I learn master's technique, I'll make you feel satisfied!!!)

Her tensions were at a dangerous level.

Chapter 23

While Lilim had come to report to the academy, she was also to look into Rudel and the incident. She investigated into things outside of Cattleya's report. Whether the rumors around the boy were true... the matter was resolved surprisingly quickly.

For her little sister Millia knew a majority of it.

"I don't really know about Aleist, but he's quite strong, and everyone says he's the strongest in our year. Rudel... tries really hard, and while he sometimes spins his wheels in vain or goes off in the wrong direction, he's a good person."

In order to resolve the rumors circulating around the palace, she continued asking about the truth.

"Chlust saved the princes? Not in a million years, sis. I mean, he ran away and was nowhere to be found. More importantly, if Rudel wasn't there, we'd all have been sacrifices..."

On these contrary accounts, Lilim wondered whether the report had been falsified. The more she looked into it, the more her questions were resolved.

(So it's Cattleya after all... even if you hate him, you'd go this far!?)

But as the two of them drank their tea, down the hallway visible from the school cafeteria, a single high knight unsteadily crossed, half in tears... it was Sophina.

Lilim tried to call out to Sophina. But noticing her, Sophina raced off in the opposite direction. Finding it suspicious, Lilim looked down the path she came...

"That's the way to the infirmary, right? Why was a high knight running in tears from such a place?"

After thinking a while, she offered her sister Millia some parting words before heading off. In that infirmary that held the same facilities as a hospital, she stopped a random nurse and inquired.

"She left the room with the Three Lords' sons in tears!?"

This was a surprise. A high knight was a holder of considerable skill, the proud shield of the crown... for such a knight to leave in tears, Lilim could only imagine the worst. Even if they were children, they were three young men... as a fellow female knight, she felt some anger as she headed for the room of the Three Lords' sons.

"Pardon me!"

Silencing the guards in front of the door with her aura of anger, she forced her way in, only to find Rudel alone. He stood, a serious expression on his face as he thought over something. Seeing him like that, Lilim couldn't think any of the indecent things she imagined had occurred. Just as she thought she was imagining things...

"Ah! L-Lilim-san? W-why are you here..."

Noticing her, Rudel offered a somewhat awkward greeting. As she returned it, she felt somewhat awkward herself. There's no way she could say she barged in under her own misunderstanding. So she changed the subject.

"Don't worry about it. More importantly, is there something troubling you?"

She asked what she shouldn't have.

"T-truth be told, because of my own inadequacy, I was unable to convey the wonders of this book to my acquaintances..."

The book he held out was, of course, 'How to Pet a Dragon'... seeing the book, Lilim gave a bitter smile. She didn't know what to say about that

book whose title alone made one lose the motivation to read on. Seeing Lilim like that, Rudel,

"U-um! Just a little... could you let me pet you? This is definitely an amazing book! I want to prove it!"

As Lilim had entered the room under a misunderstanding, she thought it would be fine if she allowed that much. As a result, just like Sophina, red to the ends of her long elf ears, she ran from the infirmary half in tears. And Rudel was left alone once more.

"So it was no good after all? Do I have to practice some more?"



A few days from those happenings, the palace sent the academy an unexpected proposal. To deal with it, the teachers gathered in the meeting room early in the morning... its contents stated...

"The royal family is coming to watch the fundamental curriculum tournament!? We haven't prepared anything for them!" "It seems they want to see the strength of Aleist and Chlust-sama who saved the princess... even so, this is too sudden." "The king said he would personally bestow a reward to the victor."

The academy faculty had gathered to discuss yet another painstaking issue. The headmaster thought a while over its contents. It was unprecedented for the royal family to personally go to the academy right after an incident. Was there anything bothering them?

Among the possible candidates, Rudel's circumstances came to mind.

"Hmm, then the academy will busy all the way up to the third term. Everyone must do their best to assure no negligence in this tournament's preparations... meeting adjourned."

The headmaster's reaction was surprisingly light, causing the surrounding teachers to look on with wonder. But as the royal family was coming, they

had no choice but to make this tournament a success. In order to do that, they would have to start hurriedly preparing. Standing busily from their seats, the teachers left the meeting room...

Left alone in that room, the headmaster,

"Will this be his chance, or will it be another pinch... if his class does manage to win, I'm sure he'll grow closer to his desires."

When the headmaster first heard of Rudel's dream to be a dragoon, he thought it was a good thing to hold such a dream while you're still young. Even if you were frustrated when it didn't come true, as long as you were young, you could start over and grow from it... that's what he thought at first, but now was different.

"I want to grant his dreams. If his dreams- all too pure- ever collapse, he'll crumble before he can ever stand again. More than anything, after dragging so many people in with him, it won't just end with him saying, 'I couldn't do it'."

The headmaster laughed as he looked through the documents.

Like that, the third term's fundamental curriculum class tournament became something never seen before. The king was personally coming out. By various motivations, many would use this opportunity to show off their ability. Within all of that, the headmaster couldn't wait to see how far Rudel would go.



"Did you hear, Rudel!? The royal family's coming to this year's class tournament... what's more! If you come out on top, you'll receive a reward. I talked it over with the class, and we decided to ask him not to force you to graduate!"

Racing to Rudel's room in the infirmary, Izumi had hurried to deliver the information... but, Basyle was already there, telling him just what she wanted to say.

Luecke and Eunius had already been discharged, and when Rudel was supposed to be the only one there, Basyle somehow got the drop on her.

"Oh, I'm sorry. I already told him."

"... Is that so."

Izumi was a little vexed, but once she saw Rudel's reaction, she gave a smile.

"So I have another chance... I still want to learn in this academy! I want to compete against Aleist, and there are still upperclassmen stronger than me... more than anything, if I'm with everyone in class, with everyone who moved to help me... let's win this tournament."

Rudel stood from the bed, a serious look on his face. Taking off the bandages wrapped around his body, he took out his own clothes and tried to leave the infirmary room... only for Izumi to hurriedly step in and stop him.

"W-what are you doing!? You need to rest your body for now!"

"No problem! I've been moving my body around the past few days, and I seem fine. What's more, I don't want to spend my time resting here, only to regret it later."

Seeing Rudel, Basyle,

"As expected of Rudel-sama! ... But if you push yourself and break something, you won't be able to participate in the tournament. So don't push yourself, let's start out with some light exercise to build up your stamina."

She hammered in the point with a smile. Hearing it from both of them, even Rudel couldn't push himself too far... or so it should have been.

"You're right, the basics are important... should I train myself from the ground up again? Or should I learn a new special move?"

As Rudel thought to himself, Basyle informed him.

"Rudel-sama, could you make some time in the coming break? If you do, I, Basyle, shall offer you the finest training there is."

As she said something, Izumi felt somewhat doubtful, but she couldn't think Basyle would do anything to put Rudel at a disadvantage, so she stayed silent. Based on Rudel's response, she intended to join in as well.

"Really!? Then I'm all yours."

Rudel gave an energetic reply. Smiles on their faces, the three of them boldly tried to exit the infirmary, only to be stopped by the doctors and nurses.

Chapter 24

Dragoon 24: The Upperclassman and the Boy

They were the events of the second term's end, where the school entered an extended break. While Rudel would usually return home, he followed Basyle's orders, informing his house, and remaining at the academy. Though a letter of complaint did come in from his younger sister Lena...

"And so? What are we supposed to do?"

Izumi- who didn't return home every year- told Basyle she would take part, forming up a party of three. In the academy cafeteria, Bayle replied to her the question as if it was natural.

"I'll have you pick up real combat experience. Not in the sort of forest the academy would have an outing to, we're going to a place of higher danger."

Saying that, she spread a map across the cafeteria table. Marked on it was a place not too close or too far from their present location. Named Mt. Aberless, the mountain wasn't particularly tall.

"On this mountain, monsters appear every year and inflict casualties on the villages in the area. This year, the casualties were especially great, and it seems they're quite troubled."

"Wait, so you mean... you're putting me and Rudel to work? What part of that is training!?"

Izumi interrogated Basyle. Basyle had in fact taken up a job, and planned to earn money from it. But without letting those emotions show on her face,

"True combat experience outweighs all else. And as snow piles in the area, the footing is bad. Battle will be dangerous... but will that stop you, Rudel-sama?"

To Basyle's question,

"No, that's just what I want. If I don't go that far, I'll even feel uneasy going up against Aleist, Luecke, and Eunius."

"The training period is two weeks. During that period, you'll fight the monsters attacking a village, and protect it from damages."

Hearing that explanation, Rudel and Izumi... Izumi felt it was almost as if they were accepting a job, feeling somewhat angry over its condense, but she decided that as long as Rudel agreed, then there was no helping it.

"... And lastly"

"Hmm?"

"Could you call out to one more person? That'll increase the efficiency."

Izumi was more than convinced this was a job under the pretense of training. And at Basyle's convenience, one of the academy's remaining students was to become a sacrifice... Vargas.

As he wasn't returning to his hometown this year, and he was planning out how to spend his time at the academy, Vargas was apprehended by Rudel. At first he was reluctant, but once he learned Basyle was coming along, he suddenly became eager. Already a fourth year student, there were no objections to Vargas' basic fighting capabilities. And with his participation, Basyle was delighted as well.



"Oy! Oy, Rudel!"

Entering a village almost buried in the snow, the four carried out lookout and subjugation. But it's not as if they were always fighting monsters. So

when they had time, they shoveled the snow so they wouldn't be buried in it.

"What is it, Vargas?"

Wearing a thick coat over his equipment, Rudel's snow-shoveling hands stopped as he turned to face Vargas.

"Isn't this strange? It's strange, right! We're supposed to be guarding this village, and yet we're out here guarding the folks who go into the mountain to shovel snow... that's definitely strange!"

Vargas shook, his hands stopped as he spoke to Rudel. From Rudel's point of view, this wasn't a job. But this was a bonifide request Basyle had taken up, and while doing odd jobs in the village connected to the mountain, they were doing honest-to-goodness work.

"You think? It lets you train up your legs, and the story the elders tell are interesting. Then there's moving without a presence, and living alongside the mountain..."

"What are you enjoying yourself for!? Not that, I'm asking whether doing something like this will make you stronger or not! I'm fine, but you can't lose, right!?"

On Vargas' words, Rudel burst into laughter.

"W-what are you laughing for?"

"Sorry, sorry... I was just so happy, I couldn't help it. And I think I'm on the verge of grasping something, so I'm fine."

So with a smile, Rudel restarted shoveling snow. Rudel thought there was a deep meaning in why Basyle had chosen this place. It's true Basyle intended for him to experience real combat... but that was about it.

Rudel simply sought out meaning in it. Just as those who sought to learn could learn from anything, Rudel learned much from the people living

alongside the mountain. And even from his enemy monsters... he learned the fact they were alive.

"Don't go against a large force, you have to use its flow against it. Gather your power on one point. Your body's center should always be..."

As Rudel started muttering to himself, Vargas tried asking.

"What's that?"

"The people of the village were talking about it. I'm sure it's the fundamentals of something."

To be blunt, it wasn't a fundamental of anything. Within the villagers' daily lives, the words came out when they spoke of how to move a heavy object, and Rudel just read too deeply into it. From there, Rudel dragged out the knowledge contained within himself and thought. He thought and thought... and finally realized.

It was the final day of that two-week period. A number of large monster-shaped monsters appeared on the outskirts of town. Wrapped in white fur, they were ferocious carnivores that could move swiftly across the snow. Their size was around that of a human, but on snowy terrain, no human legs could catch up... it was the moment such monsters appeared.

Rudel went out alone. As if he didn't even hear Basyle and Izumi's calls to stop him, and when Vargas hurriedly rushed out to bring him back in... one of the monkeys came at Rudel.

Vargas cursed his ill fortune that Izumi and Basyle weren't nearby.

But Rudel lightly swung the sword he had in one hand... splitting the monster in two.

"Eh? Eeeeh!!?"

Upon witnessing the scene, Vargas couldn't keep silent. Just two weeks! Could someone really become so strong just from protecting a village? No! They couldn't!!! But even so, Rudel produced results.

Surprised by his strength, the other monsters attacked to avenge their comrade. While two came at him simultaneously, Rudel didn't move from the spot, ride magic on his left hand and the sword in his right... As the two of them launched his attack, he sent a small ball of fire magic at one.

From its miniscule side, the monster charged without fear, but once it collided with the ball, it raised an explosion. Blown back, it became a black lump of charcoal alight... around that time, the remaining monster was cut down the moment it entered the range of Rudel's sword.

It was an abnormal scene. So abnormal Vargas didn't know what to say. The small fireball was actually a magic compressed to its very limit, and by channeling magic into his sword, he had created a shockwave. To be blunt, it was crazy.

"Still too many unnecessary movements. I have to somehow approach Aleist's level before the tournament, no I have to surpass him..."

As Rudel put his sword away... Vargas thought. He looked at Rudel, who failed to give off the air of someone who had fought a dangerous monster, standing tidily over the snow.

"You've already surpassed him!"

Vargas unintentionally shouted out. His strength would pass as an upperclassman, and Vargas thought he may even eat into their upper ranks. Rudel had likely become even stronger than him... but Rudel,

"No, I still have a ways to go. I still want to become strong. Not just in power and technique, I want to become strong of heart."

"You're plenty strong already! As you are, you can become a dragoon, I tell you!"

Shying away bashfully at Vargas's words, Rudel answered.

"I'm sure if I'm satisfied, then that will be the end... continuing to look higher is just right for me. And this world is vast, with plenty of people

stronger than me. If I don't keep setting my sights, I'll be left behind in no time."

Vargas suddenly felt as if those words were directed at him. As if they were addressing his thoughts just now, that he would be no match for Rudel.

"I'm no match for you... always looking forwards, never giving up. I'm envious."

As he said such a thing, Vargas made a sorrowful face.

"Vargas, do you have a dream? An objective?"

"M-my dream? ... Well, I want to ease the load on my place back home, and become a big brother my little brothers and sisters can be proud of... but I don't have a splendid dream like you."

Approaching Vargas, Rudel grasped his shoulders with both hands.

"That's a splendid dream! A while back, I made fun of my brother's dream. I regretted it throughout my hospitalization, and I was thinking to apologize. It's never a mistake to work hard towards your dream. And... if they saw you now, I'm sure your little siblings will see a brother to be proud of!"

Rudel knew Vargas was working hard. Waking up early every morning to train. They saw each other every day. As Rudel said such a thing with a serious face, it was Vargas' turn to be bashful. He was happy, but from the village, the villagers were looking over them with warm smiles.

"T-thanks. This is kinda embarrassing... more importantly, we should clean up."

Saying that, Vargas pointed at the monster corpses. Ending the conversation, they went into the cleanup, but Vargas remained bashful, and a little glad.



From the village, Basyle looked over that heartwarming duo, Rudel and Vargas.

"You're not going to help out?"

On Izumi's question, Basyle shrugged her shoulders. Her usual light wear would be too cold here, so now she wore a thick coat, but her body's lines were still vaguely evident.

"I'd feel sorry for them if I went out now. Let's show some tact."

"When you just want to slack off... even so, when did Rudel learn that technique?"

The swordplay and magic Rudel displayed... just knowing they were on a different level than before cost the two a bit of mulling. But Basyle,

"Well, with this it looks like I won't have to change my employer, so I have no complaints. I never even imagined he would grow this strong, after all."

Basyle smiled as she looked over Rudel and Vargas. Izumi had lost her understanding of Basyle. Why had she done such a thing? In the first place, when Rudel couldn't become an archduke anymore, from her point of view, he should have lost his value. While Izumi's thoughts started showing on her face, Basyle,

"Rudel-sama sure is interesting... I'm sure I won't tire of him anytime soon."

Gave a vague answer as she returned to the village inn... so she ran after all. Izumi concluded.

Chapter 25

As the school entered its third term, Rudel's class was the epitome of seriousness. They prepared for the tournament to such an extent the homeroom teacher said it was the first he had ever seen in all his years of teaching. The class year separated tournament was a place to show the fruits of one's work over the past two years. It was a passionate event every year, but as the royal family was coming this time around, the passion put in was something else entirely.

And Rudel's class was even above that, they put in their passion to save Rudel from his forceful graduation. And in this tournament with a new level of passion, the top pick class held a strained atmosphere.

After the incident of the second term, Aleist had become the academy's hero, but the class' air took a turn for the worst. The verbal brawls in the forest still held a resounding effect. But even so, there weren't any student able to launch a complaint against Aleist's strength, so the class' dissatisfactions would only build up. At this point, speaking ill of Aleist- who rarely ever came to class at this point- had become their diversion.

Within that situation, the tournament was about to open.

And as Rudel's class devoted themselves to training, Leucke and Eunius appeared, leading along the representatives of their own classes. In that evening ground, the students of three classes gathered, letting out something of a peculiar air.

"Rudel, I heard the story. I know your class's goal in this tournament."

On the words Luecke started up with, Rudel's class embraced a light hope of his possible cooperation. Even Izumi thought, if it was these Three Lords

who got along well, then... she hoped. But Eunius continued on.

"We heard, but we've decided to beat you down with all our strength. In this time's tournament, you'll face Luecke in the first match, and if you win, you'll be going up against us. And if you manage to luck your way through that one, Aleist's class will be your final opponent. You've got no hopes of victory."

After saying that, the two of them led off their class representatives. Those words caused Izumi to feel down. The two of them towered over the rest in the fields of magic and swordplay. If they wanted to win against those two classes, they would have to utilize the fact this was a team battle. A stream of one-on-one matches... the moment she thought that. Rudel called out to the two leaving parties.

"I'm participating in the last slot! How about you two?"

He boldly proclaimed his order in the lineup! Within the dubious air that surrounded the space, the two simply raised their hands to answer before walking off.

"W-wha-what are you talking about, Rudel!!?"

Izumi's voice echoed through the grounds.



The class representatives that tagged along the leaving two called out to their own class leaders.

"A-are you sure about this, Luecke-sama? If Arses-sama doesn't win this time around..."

To the representative who said that, Luecke spoke.

"Just you try slacking off in the tournament. I'll never forgive you."

As Luecke stated it coldly, Eunius stopped and looked over everyone. And with his ferocious features, he made a declaration.

"In this time's tournament, holding back is more unforgivable than losing! I don't care about the other classes, but don't go light on Rudel's class!"

"Hah, Eunius... in that case, you can't complain if you lose before you even go up against Rudel's class."

In regards to Luecke's sigh, Eunius answered with a laugh.

"Are you an idiot? As if we'd ever lose to anyone besides Aleist's or Rudel's classes... I decided I'd never hold back against him."

It wasn't as if Luecke or Eunius were giving it their all because they hated Rudel or anything. They recognized his skill, so they would give it their all. They'd seriously take him on, and wouldn't complain whether they won or lost... that was their conclusion.

"Because Rudel would never forgive us if we held back on him."

"That bastard... he even made a challenge to us. What are you going to do, Luecke?"

Turning to Rudel's class in the distance, Luecke,

"It goes without saying, I'll take him on personally... I'll be taking the last slot."

On those words, Luecke's class made a stir. If they wanted to win, then it would be best not to put Luecke up against Rudel. But continuing on with that answer, Eunius also,

"And of course so will I! I wanted to fight him at least once."

Eunius also turned towards Rudel's class. There, he could confirm the form of Izumi chasing Rudel around. And caught by Izumi, Rudel called out towards the two.

"I... No! We will definitely win!!!"

A smile at that voice, the two walked off. Chased behind by their classmates... and even further back, they could hear the laughing voices of Rudel and his class.



The day of the tournament. In the assembly hall, the King of Courtois, Albach Courtois, his Queen, Ciel Courtois, and the First Princess, Aileen Courtois took their places in the noble visitor room, looking down over the hall that was to be the stage of this tournament.

Protected by high knights, the three of them quietly looked over the hall. To their side, the headmaster made himself scarce. And to that room, the Second Princess Fina made her entrance. Right, the one who invited her family was Fina.

"You looked well, Fina. Though it's only been a month since we last met."

Her father, the king, said and laughed.

"You still can't show expression? I thought you would get better if you attended the academy, but..."

Her mother, the queen, spat some cynicism. After the king soothed her some, the queen,

"Fina, how's school? I never attended, so I'm quite interested... you wouldn't say anything about it during the break, could you tell me about how things are going?"

"It's been quite a while, father, mother... and sister."

As she gave a perfect curtsy, Fina's expressionless face showed no signs of change. The emotions she held towards her family,

(Our royal family really is a hopeless one... Aileen's especially dangerous! If she ever found out about my little kitten Mii... that girl would

definitely come to kill her! I sat it with conviction! Mother's, well, she's the same as always, and father is... I guess he's decent?)

She held a subdued impression of her family.

Fina took her seat in the noble visitor room, looking over the assembly hall... in the hall filled to the brim with students, there were various banners and flags hoisted up in support of their own classes. The zeal of the hall was only heightened by the presence of royalty.

(How sweltering... when I can endure the heat of Mii's fluffiness, how should I put it... if it's for the fluff, then I...!!!)

As she expressionlessly thought over such things, her father posed her a question.

"So how is it? According to you, the Arses house's eldest son is a proficient one, and I've heard something similar from both a high knight and dragoon... how should I put it, with all these reports coming in from the left field, I'm troubled to respond. Cattleya seems to hate him considerably, you know? And from the documents, it's hard to say that he's skilled. Though I will say he's interesting."

"The Arses House is a fallen one. At present, they're included among the Three Lords in name alone... the moment I heard you had interest in such a house's eldest son, to be honest, I felt doubtful, Fina."

Her mother who couldn't even speak if she didn't mix in some sarcasm. As she naturally ignored it, her sister Aileen,

"He's a battle lover, right? Such savage folk, they're no different from the demi-humans. I hate those sorts! If it's about holding power, then the Hardie House's Aleist-dono Cattleya spoke so highly of is most ideal. Don't you think so, Fina?"

"... Perhaps?"

Fina gave a vague reply. But inside...

(Eh? That homo's your type? So that's the sort of thing you're into... I don't think I'll ever get you, sis. Nothing greater than fluff exists in this world! Ah! But master is separate! That man is a national treasure of Courtois! A treasure!!! Even so, it seems she hates fluffi... I mean demi-humans as much as ever.)

As they carried on such a conversation, the competitors offered a bow to the royal family. The family waved their hands in response, but...

"Good grief... to waste my time on something like this..."

"There are demi-humans among them. Why are they sending out demi-humans? They should just cut down their numbers and send some humans out..."

"Hah, calm down a bit, both of you. Try learning from Fina."

While the conversation was shifted to Fina,

(Oy, oy!!! Look at all the demi... I mean fluffies... hah, hah... forgive me, Mii! I think I might end up cheating on you!!!)

... she was the worst off of the bunch.

Chapter 26

In the tournament waiting room, the second years of the fundamental curriculum gathered. Everyone present was a representative of their class, and a person of skill. Within all that, the matches commenced one after the next... and it was finally time for Rudel's class to go up against Luecke's. Both classes exited the waiting room. Rudel and Luecke walked alongside one another.

"I'll be giving it my all, Rudel."

"Yeah, I won't go easy on you either. I'll fight with all I have."

Without locking eyes, the two of them entered the hall, waiting until the final match came to pass. It was a team battle between five representatives, and Rudel's class won the first and second matches to make the score two on two. With that, it would all be decided by the final bout, but more than any of that, the two of them could only concentrate on the worthy foe before their eyes.

"And now the round's final battle shall commence!"

Alongside the referee's signal, Luecke began to take distance to contest with his specialty magic. But Rudel wouldn't allow it as he closed in the gap. Luecke was aware he couldn't beat Rudel when it came to speed. So he cut forward to lock up his sword.

"...!!!"

The wooden sword Luecke had swung to protect against Rudel's was splendidly knock and sent spiraling through the air. And as Rudel went right on the offense,

"Not yet!!!"

Luecke used magic at a close range. Normally, using it like that would be much too dangerous... normally, that is! But even so, there was some worth in his cast. The explosion blew him back, letting him take distance from Rudel. Luecke had suffered injury at his own magic. But even so, he had taken distance. And it was from here that Luecke could exhibit his proper role.

Shooting a consecutive stream of elementary magic at Rudel, he prepared his own trumpcard. It wasn't as easy as it sounded, and there was a possibility of failure. But even so, Luecke had decided to challenge this match with all his might.

He attacked Rudel with a magic of wind, but the attack was evaded by Rudel's magic-enhanced stride. Even for Rudel, it was difficult to avoid shots from the magic-specialized Luecke.

"Even so!"

Rudel dodged faster than he could speak. But still invoking elementary magic, Luecke continued his stream of attacks. As Rudel avoided it, he tried to close the distance once more.

Just like Luecke, he used elementary magic as a diversion to close in... then stopped. The moment he tried to draw closer, Luecke had finished his preparations. Sensing the danger, Rudel leapt back, and Luecke used a majority of his mana to invoke advanced magic.

Wary of that previous self-damaging move, Rudel had drawn back, but now he felt a sliver of regret. He should've just closed in the distance.

For the students of the fundamental curriculum, advanced magic was much too dangerous... but Luecke's magic activated perfectly. Flames mingled in with a tempest of wind, the ring that made up the contest grounds wrapped in a pillar of flames.

"How about that, Rudel!!!"

From an overuse of magic, and the damage he inflicted on himself, Luecke staggered. The hall raised a stir over Luecke's magic and concerns for Rudel's safety. Just as the referee hurriedly stepped in to call an end... the storm of flames split in two and faded away... Atop the ring, Rudel's wooden sword let off a faint light. Rudel had taken a downward swing...

Perhaps he had pushed it, as Rudel's breath was also rough.

"... Impossible. You really are something, Rudel!"

Giving a delighted laugh, Luecke knew he had to answer to his first friend besides Eunius who he could go up against so seriously, firing his magic... but with his advanced magic and consecutive use of elementary spells, he was already running out of mana. Even so, he kept his ground without giving up on the match.

Luecke could see Rudel's approach in slow motion. He recalled the environment he had found himself in from a young age. A harsh education devoid of any existences he had called friends. Even back then, Luecke had loved magic, and he wanted someone to talk about it with. He wanted to talk all about his beloved magic. But even after coming to the university, his status as heir to an archduke name caused those around to take distance.

The lone exception Eunius remained focused on his sword, and their conversations wouldn't match. Even if he talked about his beloved magic, everyone would only affirm him. At the end, he found out they would affirm even if he told a lie. A boring life, day after day.

And yet Luecke had finally found a friend he could talk with. Rudel. Generally, magic went without saying, but he could follow along in conversations besides that, and talking about magic with the Rudel- ever earnest in everything- was fun... though he still couldn't accept that book called How to Pet Dragons.

While Rudel's intuitive remarks stood out, Luecke would laugh as he went on about the theoretics. From those around, it looked like a foolish talk between men, but it was really a conversation over high-level magics.

And Luecke had challenged Rudel to a serious match. He had considered holding back to save his friend. His first true friend... if possible, he wanted to enjoy his school life alongside him.

But even so... he knew Rudel wouldn't find any delight in such a thing, and he couldn't hold back against his friend. His vision teetered and it became difficult for Luecke to set his focus.

"Rudel, you alone are...!!!"

The magic he wrung out the last of his power to fire would never go off... Rudel's wood sword perfectly touched against the nape of his neck.

"W-winner! Rudel Arses!"

After a while of silence, the referee's voice resounded through the hall. The space filled with the mingled cheers and jeers of all manner of spectators. Hearing that, Rudel put away his wood sword, out of breath. As if finally able to rest, Luecke crumbled at the knees. Rudel lent him a hand to stand.

"Luecke, thank you."

"... It's not like I let you win. I'll be the victor next time... so don't lose until then."



Watching their match from the noble visitor room, the royal family, and their high knight guards... the headmaster was also present.

"That was splendid... that archduke heirs have grown up wonderfully."

Hearing her father's words, Fina was supposed to be delighted.

"Yes. Rudel-dono is strong... Luecke-dono as well." (The hell are you doing, Luecke!!? You trying to make master lose? Aren't you friends!? Just give it to him!!! And why are there nothing but monsters in master's class's block... someone must have set this up!!!)

... Instead, she was considerably flustered. She sent a glance at the headmaster. In her head, the headmaster was one of the suspects.

"But... headmaster, isn't this time's tournament just a little bit strange?"
(Out with it already! If you try to crush my plan... I won't keep quiet about the fact you twisted up my testimony on the incident!)

The headmaster answered Fina's expressionless glance. By the way, the one who twisted Fina's testimony in the report was not the headmaster.

"Sure enough, there are many of the top contenders in this block. But the academy hasn't done any injustice."

Fina doubted the headmaster's words. The rest of the royal family watched the next match in disinterest... as truth would have it, this tournament's ordering had been decided by lots drawn by class representatives. No one had done any dishonesty.

The headmaster looked at Rudel returning to the waiting room at the start of the next match as he thought.

(No matter how many times we redid it, all the strong foes ended up in this block. Even after redoing the drawing five separate times... that child's path is a harsh one.)

Resisting the urge to let out a sigh, he explained the next match to the royal family. And listening to that explanation, the king looked at the daughter, the start of these events... from an early age, she wouldn't show expression on her face... no, perhaps she couldn't. And this was his daughter's first selfish request.

To save the person she owed her life to... after some investigation, he learned that the reports regarding Rudel had been overwritten to an abnormal extent, and he had even considered reexamining his verdict. But the Arses House in question wished for punishment unto the individual, and even if they were royalty, there was a limit to how far they could stick their mouths into the circumstances of an archduke house.

For that sake, he had made this visit alongside the tournament. Even if he didn't come out on top, he would award him some sort of reward for his effort... and saying that, he would see him off to a proper graduation, or so he had thought, but...

(I got to see something surprisingly interesting. Rudel and Luecke... and Eunius. What interesting children.)

In this visit, he had discovered a separate something outside his daughter's request. He wished he had a son of that caliber... could it be those three had become friends? Had they supported each other to this point? Would they hold each other up henceforth? King Albach thought.



The King of Courtois, Alabach Courtois, was even more of a side character than Rudel in-game. He was treated in a manner where you could almost call him a mob character. His name came out a few times, his face flashed across the screen only once in the war event... as the surrounding female members had much more of a role than needed, the king never said a single word.

As such a character, the king didn't have any detailed setting to back him. When even the queen had a hidden romance event... if you thought of it like that, perhaps he was quite the pitiful king indeed.

Chapter 27

The tournament's first round fights had all concluded, and the second round was about to commence. As the royal family was watching this time around, the match times had shortened. And in the first round, they were conducted using other facilities as well. Fina's hopes taken into account, they had set their eyes on Rudel's block.

"The second round, eh... the next class is a strong one."

Izumi looked at the tournament's match sheet as she muttered to Rudel. Rudel had his own thoughts on the matter.

"Is there anyone strong in it? The strong people in our year... I won against Luecke, but apart from him, only Aleist and Eunius are coming to mind."

At Rudel's thought process, Izumi felt her head hurt. From the Rudel-constantly in the academy's top rankings- point of view, the other students weren't a threat. But this tournament was a team competition. There was no point if Rudel won his match alone.

"Hah, if the rest of us don't win, we can't rise in this tournament."

To Izumi's words, Rudel smiled.

"It'll be alright! We'll definitely win!"

Rudel answered full of confidence. Seeing him like that, the other representative of his class smiled too. Switching gears, Izumi stated the name of her next opponent.

"Millia... so I'm taking on the elf Millia."

Right, the second battle put Izumi up against Millia.



So Rudel's class entered the second round, and by the time it came down to Izumi's second-to-last slot, the score was at one win and two losses! Izumi was burdened with quite the heavy responsibility. And her opponent Millia was also a problem... for some reason, she was glaring at her. Not because this was a competition, or because she was serious... she was just glaring.

"Do your best, Izumi!"

Mixed in with her classmates cheering her on from outside the ring, Rudel rooted for her with all his might. And the more he did, the more Millia glared. Equipped with a bow, she stood with a load of practice arrows prepared.

Millia's mind was plagued by Rudel. And she felt disdain for his goal of being a dragoon. The reason lay in her elder sister Lilim. While being an elf, she had become a dragoon, one of Courtois' elits.

Lilim held considerable abilities, even among the elves, and the clan placed their expectations on her... after realizing Lilim's secret, her elven betrothed annulled their engagement. With that as a trigger, Lilim began taking distance from the notions of elves and clans. She had chosen to be a dragoon of Courtois over an oppressed elv.

Millia's beloved sister was now a dog of the humans... and this time, the dragoons had even enraptured the one on Millia's mind. While she was well aware her anger was misplaced, she still couldn't bring herself to forgive the organization.

"... I have no grudge against you. But I shall be fighting with all my might."

Alongside the starting call, wings appeared on Millia's back. Half-transparent glowing wings... and Millia freely jumped about the area over the ring... right, it wasn't flight, it was hopping.

"Kuh! What movements!"

Taking distance, and once she circled around back, she launched a stream of attacks with her bow. Izumi reacted well and dodged... but it was at that moment. Izumi ended up muttering. The bug often seen in the kitchen... the black demon that hopped around.

"Just like a bug!"

Snap! The ring's air change so suddenly it was almost audible. Those wings that were an elf's specialty, or rather trait, it's not as if you couldn't say they resembled a bug's wings over a bird's. And her flapping whenever she leapt, they were just assisting her jump strength, but... it did look quite bug-like.

Elves were aware of that, and mindful of it. Reactions varied by the individual... Millia went into the frenzy.

"Y-you... what did you just say? No, I heard you, don't bother answering... you called me a bug. You'd better prepare yourself!!!"

Millia accelerated in her next bound. Unable to keep up with her movements, Izumi took some practice arrows across her body. Even if they were for practice, if they hit, they would hurt and inflict injury.

In regards to Millia's violent bounds, Izumi stopped moving altogether. Sharpening her senses, instead of seeing Millia's movements with her eyes, she tried to foresee them. Feeling the sound of her rhythm and the attacks of her bow, Izumi made a prediction, closed the distance in an instant and hammered in an attack.

Millia avoided Izumi's swipe by the breadth of a hair. But Izumi didn't let the gap she created slip through. In that space, Izumi grasped Millia's ankle, making for a one-sided development. As Millia was unable to move, Izumi thrust her wooden sword at her neck.

And unable to escape, Millia vexingly muttered.

"I-I admit my loss."

Hearing that, the referee declared Izumi's victory. Feeling that she had successfully fulfilled her responsibility, Izumi pat her chest. And as she did, Rudel jumped at her.

"That was amazing, Izumi! Catching a skipping elf!"

Rudel happily praised Izumi. But seeing that, Millia only glared at her more. As the foe who beat her, and the woman who called her a bug... and while she didn't quite understand why, she recognized Izumi as a source of her unease.



"That was quite a boring match. An elf doing nothing but running away!"

Princess Aileen gave her impression of the match. In regards to that, Fina surprisingly held the same opinion. An elf just running away... there should have been more contact, more fluffing! As she thought such a thing, Fina...

(When there wasn't even any petting involved, I hate myself for getting so heated up! Hah, hah... let me nibble on those eaaarrrrs!!!)

Unlike Fina, Aileen hated demi-humans.

The demi-human hater Aileen. Once upon a time, her carriage was attacked by goblins on the move. To be more precise, it faced an attack from multiple monsters. Seeing the attacking goblins up close, Aileen cried and screamed, making for quite a sorry sight. That itself wasn't much of a problem.

Aileen was young at the time, and if monsters attacked, then anyone would feel fear. But the problem was that Aileen was a princess. A princess attacked by monsters... of course, responsibility would have to be taken by the knight who served as her guard. And the one in question happened to be Aileen's first love.

By a stroke of ill luck, or perhaps fate, the knight who carried out the execution was a demi-human. She had shown her disgraceful form to her

first love, and after a period of brooding, she only learned of his death a long while later. A young girl at the time, she couldn't get by without someone to hate, yet at her base, she still remained a kind girl.

It was around that time that she started to twist. The demi-humans disturbing public order should just go away... then we'd have a peaceful world for humans alone... Aileen honestly believed it.

"Calm down, Aileen... just look at Fina. She's always calm, never flustered by anything. You have to take a lesson from her as part of the royal family."

The king soothed Aileen's agitation. The one he compared her too was looking at Rudel's split-second defeat of his opponent in the final match.

(As expected of master!!! Just a bit of genius! And there he goes! But make sure you hold back when you're going against fluffies!)

Expressionless to the end, and free to no ends.

Chapter 28

Steadily winning its way through, Rudel's class was to go against Eunius' in the semi-finals. In their block with nothing but strong foes, by the time they reached the semi-finals, both sides were in tatters. In truth, Eunius was injured here and there. Bur Rudel...

"R-Rudel, are you alright?"

Izumi asked Rudel in worry. In his match with Rudel, he had taken a hit from advanced magic. And before that, he had taken on a consecutive stream. After that, he had easily managed to win his way through, but... here and there, his body was wrapped in bandages, making him a painful sight.

"No problem at all. My body can move."

He said as he spun his shoulders. His body moved... don't you mean moved with pain? Izumi thought, but this tournament was one they had to win at all costs. Even if they had to push themselves, she thought and concentrated on hatch.

And the match that began... up to the final matchup, they somehow obtained four straight wins! Rudel's class's advancement was already set in stone. While both sides were worn out, when it came to feelings, Rudel's class was winning.



The final match held a surprisingly subdued air. With the semifinal score at four to one... from the tattered Rudel's point of view, there was no reason to push himself here. Right, normally, he should've just preserved his strength for the finals without damaging his body any further.

Rudel and Eunius stood opposite one another, waiting for the referee's signal. Within all that, Eunius struck up a conversation.

"Good grief... why does my class have to be such a nuisance? Hey, Rudel... I know I'm being selfish, but could you take me on seriously? No, even if you don't, I'll be going at you with the intent to kill."

Not with his usual raptor-like smile, Eunius made a grin full of self-derision. Rudel gave his request a serious answer.

"What are you talking about? Of course I'll fight you seriously! I'm going to protect the promise we made on the grounds!"

Eunius' eyes widened in surprise as he burst into a bit of laughter. The wood sword he had prepared for himself was a longsword intended for use in both hands. As he held it aloft to take a stance, Rudel prepared his own sword as well. The referee- who had been hesitating over whether to interrupt their conversation or not- determined that as long as they weren't going to carry out a half-assed fight before the royal family, then all was well as he signaled the start.

"I've taken a liking to that idiotic part of you! Now come at me for real, Rudel!!!"

The two clashed head-on. Eunius focused solely on his sword, while Rudel adopted a style of freely switching between wood sword and spell. Comparing the two of them, Eunius displayed a surprisingly elegant array of skills, while Rudel's fighting style was rough and violent.

Rudel's swordplay that focused on winning as the premise was closer to a mercenary's than a noble. His magic added on, it was a battle Eunius was unfit for... those around were sure to think.

But in truth, Rudel was being pushed back. With Eunius' flowing sword strokes, and the difference in power born from his physique... they all served to torment Rudel, and Eunius was used to dodging magic. With magic as his weak suite, Eunius' fighting style was a simple one.

Don't give them a chance to use magic. If they do use it, then dodge.

Simple in concept, difficult in practice, Eunius exhibited the full brunt of his philosophy against Rudel. What's more, his attacks were connecting. Rudel was the one unable to handle his barrage.

"Are you having fun, Rudel!? Right now, I'm having the time of my life!!! That you can follow me to this level- than you'll take me on seriously- you really know how to make a man happy!"

Rudel fended off Eunius' consecutive attacks. Knowing things would be bad at this rate, he channeled magic into his sword to cut through Eunius' blade of wood. But sensing the irregularity, Eunius took distance from him. Seeing Rudel's glowing sword, Eunius noticed.

As he took distance, Rudel switched over to a mid-range magic battle. And dodging his attacks, Eunius,

"Pouring magic into your sword? Nice... that's one way of doing it!"

Stopping in his tracks and taking a stance, Eunius cut right through the magic coming at him. Sending magic into his blade, he had mastered the same magic technique in an instant. But there was one difference. As Eunius never used any magic, he had plenty of it to spare.

In contrast to Rudel's sword that could at most give off a faint glow, Eunius' wooden sword shook as his magic reserves poured from the blade. Using that quivering stream of energy, Eunius cut at Rudel. Rudel naturally stopped it with his own sword, but the sword's magic coating moving like a whip, it sliced into Rudel's face.

This time, Rudel tried to take some distance, but Eunius wouldn't allow it. Rudel was instantly put at a disadvantage.



The man called Eunius who showed rapid growth in the midst of battle, in the game he appeared as the 'Sword Prodigy'. While being a noble, he

preferred freedom, and he a reliable existence gentle to everyone. He had a sense of duty, and if you put him into the leadership role of a party, there was no doubt it would become a main force... he was that sort of character.

But that setting had always tormented Eunius. As a high-ranking noble, reasonable sword talent was more than enough. As his role would be to take command on the battlefield, Eunius would never go out on the front lines.

Eunius loved his own sword, and he earnestly took on his training. But he had no stage to test his limits. Everyone showed restraint from his position as a high noble. Even in the school's matches, they'd all come and lose to curry favor with the boy.

Precisely from his talent, Eunius could notice it with ease. It all felt so empty. He had once even thought to cast aside his status. But his sense of duty wouldn't allow it. Casting away his family... his people, and living by the sword? Eunius was incapable of such a thing. So he had given up on ever having a serious locking of blades.

Everything else was favorable. He had good friends in school, and even a girlfriend. He'd slip out of the academy and hit the town, and if it all came down to enjoying his student life, there were no problems.

The one who appeared around that time was Rudel. He me the boy who could only set his sight on being a dragoon, even if meant throwing away his family and people. Eunius had his hopes. If it was against him, perhaps he could have a serious match... there were no problems with his ability or will.

Around when he came to think it, talks of this tournament came around. To Eunius who couldn't tell if Rudel's feelings would ever change, if he let this chance slip by, he might never have the match he sought for the rest of his life... he thought.

If Rudel didn't see the value in a serious match with him, then never again... would he come at him with enough strength to kill? He wondered?



Rudel ran around, and Eunius gave chase... at the moment he thought that pattern would repeat. Rudel went on the offense. Stopping his use of magic, he cut at Eunius with all his might. That wooden sword with magic channeled in, if it hit the wrong place, it would deliver a swift demise.

"That's right! Come at me like you're trying to strike me dead!!!"

Eunius put all the magic he had into his sword. And in regards to Rudel's attack, he had decided to counter. Rudel barely dodged. But Rudel's wooden sword had been torn to pieces. In the instant he knew he couldn't hit Rudel, he had changed focus to his sword.

"It's my win...!!!"

Eunius tried to convince himself of his victory. But throwing down his sword, Rudel stepped into Eunius' bosom emptyhanded. Fearing not Eunius' instant response to counterattack, he thrust the palms of both hands to Eunius' chest... firing compressed wind magic with all his might.

Without any time, a single attack in a lapse of concentration... but even so, it was an attack from point blank. There was no way it was ineffective!

Eunius was blown out of the hall. He tried to stand, but by the rules, those who left the premise were disqualified. Even so, he tried to stand... feeling an intense pain run through his chest, he found his body wouldn't rise as he willed it.

"Winner, Rudel Arses!"

And Eunius lost. He had lost a serious match. As he heard the cheers from the audience seats, Eunius collapsed down and looked up at the sky. It was already evening, the sky was dyed a shade of orange.

"Why can't I move... let me have a bit more fun! Just a little more..."

Eunius' tears came out. The more fun he had come to learn, the more he couldn't forgive its end. There, dragging along his body, Rudel stepped down from the ring.

"It was fun, Eunius. Let's have another match... if we do, I'm sure I can aim even higher."

Rudel said such a thing with a smile. Of beaten body, the two of them were in terrible states. The one the prodigy Eunius lost too was an average man whose talents fell short. But his form as he continued setting his eyes on higher sights, Eunius saw greatness in him.

"You're amazing... yeah, let's fight again. So you have to stay in the academy."

Their classmates raced over to them. And the two were quickly carried off to the infirmary... the tournament had taken more time than expected, and the finals were to be postponed to the following day.

The finals against Aleist's class was the only match that remained.

Chapter 29

The Second day of the tournament began with a peculiar air. The first year student matches ended without issue, and the princess' class claimed victory... Chlust also participated as a representative and showed off his mettle. There were a number of matches that were suspicious no matter how you looked at them, but before the royal family, they were fought fair and square.

And the base of that abnormal air was, of course, Rudel. Rudel's classmates were in tatters, but Rudel's state was much worse. That was simply how severe his fights with the top candidates Luecke and Eunius had been.

Right, he was worn out, but...

"It's finally here! We're definitely going to win!"

He was terribly energetic. In the hall, Luecke and Eunius who had slipped out of the infirmary... and Vargas alongside the upperclassmen who trained with him every morning were there. Mixed in with them, Basyle had also come to cheer him on.

In such a hall, Aleist's class on the opposite side of the ring looked at Rudel's tattered comrades in relief. They had been wary of Rudel's class, that had managed to win its way through this block of strong foes, but with this, they were sure they could come out on top.



And from the start, the finals were a heated affair. Regardless of the leisure Aleist's class let off, Rudel's class somehow managed to hang on. At the final matchup, the results were set at two to two, and with this, everyone knew they could count on an exciting finale.

Rudel stood opposite Aleist, waiting for the referee's signals. And as he waited, Aleist called over.

"Looks like someone's on fire... but even so, you're in quite a terrible shape over there. When I've finally gotten a stage to show off, I'm worried it'll just look like me bullying the weak."

In contrast to Aleist's cynicism, Rudel was a manifestation of seriousness itself. Right, Rudel had been waiting for this moment, and from the results up to now, he took Aleist's cynicism to be only natural... but he'd prove him wrong! With that on his mind, Rudel prepared his wooden sword.

As he focused his attention on the match, the pain in his body seemed to fade away.

Seeing Rudel like that, Aleist grumbled over his light response as he took a stance. Confirming both sides were ready, the referee gave the signal.



Watching from the noble visitor room, the royal family swallowed their breath at the fight unraveling before their eyes. This was no longer a contest between students of the fundamental curriculum. Between these two who could easily be compared to upperclassmen or even full-fledged knights, the hall itself held its breath.

(M-master!!! Why are you so beaten up! You're going to lose at this rate! My master's going to lose!!!)

Fina panicked left and right within. At the match, Aileen,

"Oh how wonderfully strong Aleist-sama must be!"

He saved her little sister, and that beautiful appearance. His form overlapping with the knight she once loved, to Aileen, Aleist was the ideal knight.

But the impression the queen held was something else entirely. Folding up the fan she used to cover her mouth, she leaned a bit forward to get a better look. Sensing the queen's growing interest in the match, the king tried asking for her impression.

"How about it? Do you see something you like?"

Leaving a space of silence, the queen answered the query.

"Yes, boy balled Rudel, the Arses House's legitimate heir is strong. But... how shall I put it, the Hardie House's Aleist is... quite light, I'd have to say."

The queen's eyes open wider than usual felt Aleist's strength as something light. The queen who would describe strength in such a way... from the start, the queen had a liking for a strong man. In his youth, Albach had excelled in the sword, and it was accurate to say she fell for his skills. But forced to sit through a tournament of students- the fundamental curriculum even- their crude matches and untrained movements were unbearable to watch... she thought.

But in reality, starting with the Three Lords' sons, she was able to bear witness to some interesting fights. However...

"What a letdown...in the finals, what's more, the final match... one of them's in tatters before the match even begins, the other's strength has no weight to it. If that's how it's going to be, then yesterday's match between Rudel and Eunius was leagues better."

The Queen opened her fan once more. It seems she had lost interest.

"Then who do you think will win?"

On the king's nonchalant question, the queen gave an uninterested response.

"Well, the winner will be..."

Unnoticed by her parents, Fina expressionlessly...

(My fluffing! The fluffy kingdom of my dreams!!! Master!!! Hold on!!!)

Faithful to her desires to no end.



It was a harder match than Aleist could have imagined. In both swordplay and magic, Aleist thought he would come out on top, but Rudel wasn't losing. No, you could say he was winning. Rudel...

(Aleist's swordplay falls short of Euniu! His magic is nowhere close to Luecke! It isn't strength... Aleist lacks an overwhelming level of technique. If I'm to win, I've no choice but to stab into that flaw!)

Thinking that, he parried Aleist's attacks that pushed through with brute force and aimed for a counter. While Aleist had been pushing from the start of the match, he had failed to land a single hit. In contrast, suppressed as he was, Rudel's attacks landed accurately. Even so, the fact he was dragging his beaten body at a disadvantage hadn't changed.

In the hall, the voices in support of Aleist- who saved the princess- comprised the large majority. Receiving their encouragement, Aleist had started out in high spirits. But when it came down to it is, he was hard-pressed to win. What's more, the opponent was Rudel. That Rudel! Inept and prideful! Rudel who only existed as a hindrance!!!

"Why are you getting in my way... just fall already!"

Growing irritated, hastily used magic sword. His wooden sword was clad in flames, taking on the form of a blade made of fire itself. But its size was around twice that of a human. As Aleist swung it around, he launched an offense on Rudel.

"You! Someone like you! Should just disappear!!!"

Horizontally, vertically, Aleist swung his sword... as he avoided it, Rudel also flowed magic into his blade. His special sword he had made to imitate magic sword. Rudel's magic sword of pure magic ran parallel to his wood sword, taking the shape of an orderly blade.

Its length wasn't anything great... but as Aleist's blade came down to consign Rudel to oblivion, even when he knew it wouldn't reach, Rudel swung his own sword. The magic surrounding it left the blade, but in exchange, Aleist's magic sword had been cut through.

"W-what's with that! I don't know such a move... how cowardly!"

The moment he tried to protest to the referee, Rudel closed in right to his side. He hurriedly lifted his sword to block, but perhaps both wooden swords had already reached their limits as they snapped the moment of impact.

"R-ref! I can't use my wooden sword. Temporary time out...!"

The moment his sword snapped, Rudel instantly changed to close combat. Aleist used the abilities he had been granted... he dodged with his talent in martial arts, but he faltered against Rudel's difference of spirit. HE felt fear at Rudel's serious eyes.

(Why!? Why did it come to this!? This is my world, right... isn't this a world where I'm the lead role!!!?)

A high-level display of hand-to-hand combat unfolded between the two, but Aleist couldn't help but draw back. No matter how strong he was, in what he lost out in force of will, he could only find it in him to block. Unable to do anything but block, Aleist recalled his life before his reincarnation... the truth of the true Aleist's bullied life.

(Harassed day after day... I finally croaked in an accident, and reincarnated into the world of the game I loved! I even got cheats! I even got status! My face wasn't ugly! ... and yet, and yet, even here... you'll bully me here!!!)

As Aleist's face warped in fear, it was taken in by Rudel's fist. Blown back, Aleist crawled atop the ring. It was a scene no different to his past life.

(I'm scared! Scared! Scared! ... Am I going to be bullied again? By this stepping stone of a character...)

As Aleist wasn't getting to his feet, Rudel didn't pursue. He simply stood before him. The fearful Aleist wasn't even able to look at him.

Around, voices of encouragement for Aleist... he could hear jeers raining down on Rudel.

"Stand up! Why aren't you fighting me, Aleist!!!?"

Rudel's fist shook in his strong grip. Was it from anger... of emptiness, Rudel flared up. At his voice, Aleist felt even greater fear.

"I'm fine with losing! Just let me lose!!!"

On Aleist's voice, the referee tried to declare the match's end. But Rudel stopped it.

"Please stand! I've finally come all the way here... for what sake did I... I came here with my sights on you! I wanted to win! I wanted you to recognize me! And yet... Aleist, you're strong, aren't you!!?"

With those words, Aleist stood against Rudel. Rudel answered him, getting into a punching match once more. But this time's match was a clumsy one, a blind exchange of blows.

Unlike the high-level match up to now, it was practically a fight between children. But even that exchange was cheered on by the crowd.



"Which side is winning?"

(What pointless thing do you think you're doing!? Stupid master!!! You just won, didn't' you!? Just take that guy down already, and take me off the fluffy paradise!!! ... Fluffy paradise? Fluffadise... huh? Not bad at all!!! Fluffadise! Fluffadise!)

She expressionlessly got excited alone.

And her sister, the first princess,

"How barbaric... I hate that Arses House brat!"

And the king,

"Now this is quite a manly fight. Even so... with this, isn't the Arses House child at a disadvantage?"

Her fan still opened, the queen's expression didn't change. She looked down over the ring on the ground. Perhaps convinced her predictions weren't off the mark, she wouldn't answer the king.

The headmaster looking over the royalty and his students gazed quietly over the match. They were both students of the academy... so e thought. If this match's results became a good result for the both of them...



As the two exchanged blows, their footing turned unsteady. Their arms took large swings with barely any power behind them. Even in such a situation, the audience gather in the hall cheered on. A majority of them cheered Aleist on, but there were definitely some rooting for Rudel.

"Fall already... isn't that enough!"

Aleist and Rudel made terrible faces. One of Aleist's blows got him in the face. But Rudel didn't go down, sending another blow in return. Neither of them would stand down.

But their limits were close. Rudel had been at his limit from the start. The only reason he still stood was his will not to give up. His drive for victory wasn't just because he wanted to stay at the academy... for some reason, Rudel was fixated on Aleist. The individual himself has noticed it. A sensation he had never felt before had become Rudel's will.

Wringing out his last power, Rudel clad his fist in a magic of wind... At the end of the end, running his magic dry, Rudel's fist came at Aleist to settle the match, knoockign him off of his feet.As the hall swallowed its breath, the two of them collapsed Rudel who had run out of both stamina and

magic, Aleist who had been pushed this far for the first time in any of his lives... after they lay immobile a while, some surrounding voices came to cheer them on.

"Stand up, Aleist-sama!!!"

"Don't lose to someone like him, Aleist-senpai!!"

"You can't lose to that idiot!!!"

The students rooting for Aleist mocked Rudel. Within all that, starting with Varggas, the upperclassmen started calling out to Rudel. In loud voices, they cheered him on.

"Don't lose, Rudel!!! Show them the results of your training every day!!!"

Luecke and Eunius cried out as well. Despite their injuries and Mana deficiency, they forced themselves to cry out! Millia's voice mingled in with theirs.

"I won't forgive you if you lose here, Rudel!!!"

"Stand up quickly! And you call yourself the man who beat us!!!?"

"Quite sleeping there and stand already!"

On the words of the heirs to the Three Lords', the surrounding classmates also sent words of encouragement. And the voices of Rudel's class weren't losing out.

"Stand up, Rudel!!!"

"You promise you'd be with us to the end!!!"

"Don't lose to the likes of Aleist!!!"

At the end, Izumi called out in a large voice!

"How long do you plan on sleeping there, Rudel!? Strongest... the strongest knight, you're going to be a Dragoon, right!!!"

The collapsed Rudel tried to use his arms to raise his torso off the ground, but he instantly collapsed. He tried against and against... and right at that moment, a dragon passed over the grounds. For just that brief instand, a dragon's shadow passed over Rudel. And...

"That's right... I decided I'd definitely become a dragoon! For that sake, I can't always be on the losing end... I'm going to become strong! I decided I'll be the strongest dragoon who won't lose to anyone!!!"

Rudel rose with shaking feet. All the voices of support raised cries for joy. And Aleist didn't even try to stand. His shaking legs wouldn't listen to him. His heard had long recognized his loss, and no matter how high his abilities were, he was unable to stand.

"Goddammit..."

Aleist's wrung-out voice was drowned out by the cheers resounding through the hall. There, the referee declared the victor.

"Victor, Rudel Arses!!!"



In the noble visitor room, Fina expressionlessly stood from her seat. Making a gist with both hand, she raised them both to the sky to express her delight. She even let out her voice.

"Yeeeeesssss!!! He wonnnnnn!!!"

(Master wooonnnnnn!!! You really are amazing, master! My heart skipped a bear there, you know!!! Even when there was nothing fluffy related, it skipped a beat!!!)

"W-what are you doing, Fina?"

The king looked at his daughter with worry. The queen dropped her fan, while the elder sister held her mouth open in surprise. Within all that, the headmaster clenched his fist triumphantly where no one could see.

On the ring visible from the room, the classmates gathering around the victor. They hurriedly tried to drag him off to the infirmary, while Rudel said something incomprehensible about how the match lasted until the closing ceremony, and argued... It seems he said he wanted to stay to the end, but it was clear his hazy head wasn't thinking clearly.

(So you overcame it... how about Aleist-kun...)

The headmaster thought of Aleist, who had already been carried off. ◇

Aleist was carried off in a stretcher. He was told to lay down in the waiting room for a while, before he was left alone in the room. In that waiting room without anyone, Aleist wept.

"I... no matter where I go, I can't change."

To that room, a single classmate entered. Once Aleist realized it was the student who always tried to get involved with him, he made a displeased face. To that point, none of the other classmates had come. He was sure they were speaking ill of him. From his bullied experience, he had long-since realized.

But...

"Y-you were close, Aleist... I'm sure you'll win next time... I think."

His classmate hesitantly called over. Even now, he tried to become friends with Aleist. Should I refute those words or depreciate them... as he thought that, Aleist cried again.

(Ah, I see, so that's it. Why hadn't I noticed... I wanted a friend. The reason I came to love a game where everyone liked the main character, I'm sure it's because I wanted someone to like that... why couldn't I realize something as simple as that...)

"A-Aleist! Are you in pain!? I'll call the doctor over."

Seeing off his classmate's hurried rush for a doctor, Aleist listened to the cheers he could hear through the open door... will someone like me be able to be his friend... as Aleist thought over it, he cried and smiled.

Chapter 30

The tournament ended without incident, and the injured... it was around the time the seriously injured Rudel, Luecke and Eunius were bedridden in the infirmary as per usual. Rudel's window seat you could already call his reserved spot, Luecke at the center, and Eunius's bed closest to the corridor.

In that infirmary room, Izumi distributed the fruits she had gotten quite good at peeling among them. Only Rudel's were cut to imitate the shape of a killer rabbit.

"It looks like a dragon's head, so I can't eat it... can I use it as decoration?"

"T-that's a killer rabbit! It's a bunny, so please, just eat it."

"Oh, I see, it's a bunny... then I guess I'll eat the bunny... no, but..."

Wounds all over his body, Rudel refused to eat the fruit slice Izumi had brought over to his mouth. As Luecke and Eunius watched over the two with sidelong glances, they seemed fed up at Rudel's exchange with Izumi that words couldn't describe. And outside the room, the individual who had come to eavesdrop...

(Bunny!!? He's eating a bunny girl? I-in a sexual way, tight!? You eat them sexually, right master!? Let me in on the fun!!!)

... It was Fina. Following behind her were some high knight guards, the headmaster, and King Alabach himself. They had snuck in to congratulate Rudel for his class's victory.

This time's victory gave Rudel a high assessment among the royal family and academy... but by no means was this all sunshine and daisies for Rudel.



"Pardon my intrusion... the three of you look well... wait, what are you doing!? Stay at ease!"

As Albach casually entered the room, its four occupants got onto their knees... among them were three patients with serious injuries. The first to move was Izumi, but following right after, Rudel moved his aching body onto the ground... his form caused Eunius' sense of competition to burn bright, and Luecke didn't want to be the only one left out so he followed suit.

As a result, the injured three kneeled before the king. His subordinate knights looked at him as if they wanted to say something. While he admired their courtesy to kneel despite injury, the three of them were the future Three Lords...

"Just lie down! You don't have to force yourselves to get on your knees!!!"

(Ah, father cried out... how interessssting!!!)

Fina expressionlessly enjoyed the situation, while the headmaster and knights sent the king some glances to get them to stop. In such a sickroom, the king's voice resounded...

Once everyone had calmed down, and the circumstance was one that allowed for conversation, Albach started up.

"Congratulations for your victory in this time's tournament. I never even imagined you would be so skilled... and so. I want you to officially succeed the Arses House. I got the general gist of things from Fina's letter. That you saved Fina, and that there was clear malice against you contained in the official reports..."

The king had taken a complete turn from the false reports to that point, handing Rudel a proper evaluation. At that, Izumi rejoiced, and both Luecke and Eunius were relieved. But Rudel alone was purely unsatisfied.

"No, it is true that I exposed the princess to danger, and it is true that both Luecke and Eunius here were dragged into a mess by me! Just my continued attendance of this academy is more than enough for me!"

To Rudel, the Three Lords... succeeding his archduke title would mean giving up on his dream of becoming a dragoon. When he had finally grown closer to his dreams, returning to being a simple heir wasn't Rudel's intent.

"No, no, with the exception of the reports, putting together numerous sources has led me to the conclusion you will make for a splendid archduke. Your grades are in the top ranks of the academy, and you're able to interact with people regardless of race and status."

In regards to the king's praise, Rudel- not wanting to inherit any status- thought hard. At this rate, it would be difficult to become a dragoon... if the king ordered him to take over the position, then Rudel would have to get more involved with the territory than ever before. Once he left the academy, he would instantly have to stick his hands into internal affairs... his father would push busy work onto him, and he would have to go out into a high society he had never even experienced before.

Rudel didn't have that sort of time. He had come all the way here to become a dragoon. To Rudel, an archduke title was useless.

"... I... have no interest in archduke status."

"... Is that for the sake of your dream? Surely the dragoons are heroes among heroes within our lands, but if you become an archduke, then you'll be able to save many more than you could from the standing of a single knight."

On the king's words, Rudel made a conflicted face.

"But even o, I do not want to give up on my dream!"

Rudel's will didn't change. The king was impressed by his strength of will, and he expected great things from the strength in his eyes. That's precisely why he said it...

"Starting with the crown, to protect the country and its people. Such is the duty of a knight. From the very start, your answer was contradictory... I'll put the archduke matter on hold. But as long as you can't give an answer that satisfies me, I won't let you become a dragoon, and your archduke rights will be confiscated... let's end things here for today."

With those words, Albach and his knights took their leave. After taking one look at Rudel's brooding form, Fina followed her father and left the room.



After the queen left, Rudel made for the roof. The infirmary... the roof of the facility you could already call a hospital, he had begged Izumi to take him there. Noon had gone by, the winds were blowing... the roof where the laundry made a ruffling sound.

Bandages wrapped all over his body, wrapped so much Rudel could barely move the fingers on his hands. Sitting on the bench, he thought over the king's words. And sitting beside him, Izumi worried.

Izumi knew of Rudel's dream. She knew of his will to throw aside his people if it was for that dream... so having come this far, the words from the king put a stopped in his way. Izumi herself knew a large number of people would be saved if Rudel inherited the Arses territory, and she knew the king's words were just, but...

"Rudel... don't feel so down."

Even so, Izumi wanted to grant his dream. So she called out, but,

"Izumi, how am I supposed to talk my way out of this? I can think of a number of appropriate reasons, but... I can't hit on anything that hits the nail on the head."

"... Rudel? You plan on deceiving the king!?"

"Deceiving? Your words do me ill! I know what the king was trying to say... but in short I just have to save more people as a dragoon than I ever

could as an archduke, right? I'll become a knight, become a dragoon, and save loads of people!"

His body covered with injuries, Rudel lacked any fragment of persuasive force. But finding his words reliable, Izumi smiled as she looked over him.

... Watching over the two of them from the shadows. Luecke, Eunius... and the headmaster. The three of them had been searching for the right time to call out to the depressed Rudel, but the boy himself was surprisingly... no, on top of being more energetic than they had anticipated, they learned he was trying to deceive the king.

"You can't just deceive him!"

Luecke quietly retorted.

"Tricking the king, eh... it all comes down to how he plans on doing it."

"Why do you look so amused, Eunius!? Rudel's trying to trick the king of our nation. Let's stop him."

"No way. Of course I'm amused... and Rudel said it, didn't he? He'll save more people than he could as an archduke anyways."

While Eunius found enjoyment and Luecke began arguing, the headmaster seemed relieved as he saw Rudel's high spirits. And he was also relieved that the boy was thinking over what was to come after he became a dragoon.

(I'm glad he isn't losing his way...)



After that, Rudel wrote up a letter to the king. It was meant as an answer to the king's question, and as he read it, King Albach was put into quite a good mood.

'I will become a dragoon that can save many more people than I could as an archduke.'

That was Rudel's answer to the king.

Chapter 31

Rudel safely(?) advanced his classes, finished the fundamental curriculum and became a third year student. When the fundamental curriculum was complete, the concept of classes disappeared. Each individual student would choose their own direction, and pick out the classes that would be necessary to their futures. While the classes selected did change by personal ability, they were generally the same.

If you're aiming to be a knight, you must learn manners, and obtain practical skills in battle. There were other necessary fields, and a few criteria the hopefuls used to choose... in the academy where it cost money to take classes, the commoner students who wanted to get through at as low a cost as possible would choose the shortest route.

Using a period of one to three years, they would learn whatever the school had to offer. They would learn, but...



"I'm glad you three could make it... do you know why you were called here?"

Having become a fifth year- the final year a student could take- Vargas was chosen as a prefect for the boys' dorm. Alongside the students who had become prefects much like himself, he had called out the three... Rudel, Luecke and Eunius.

"No, I have no idea."

Rudel honestly didn't know.

"It's not a good feeling to be called out by an upperclassman... so why were we called?"

In regards to his upperclassmen, Luecke suddenly changed to a condescending tone.

"Did I do something... don't remember."

Eunius thought a bit, but couldn't think of anything.

Before the three of them, Vargas and the other fifth year prefects made conflicted faces. The prefects here all shared a common point. They were students who had chosen to become knights. What's more, proficient students aiming to rise to knight status from a commoner background.

In an average year, the young noble knight-hopefuls would be chosen as prefects. That was how it was supposed to be this year as well... but this year, the third year class contained the future Three Lords, Rudel and the others were the problem.

The factions of each lord had tried to send in prefects. But this year, the head of the problem children, Rudel had become a third year. In his third year, he would have more free time than he had in the fundamental curriculum. And naturally, the place he spent it would be the dorm.

Who the hell would look after him?

That on their minds... the young nobles had stepped down from prefect positions. And Vargas, who got along well with Rudel, was selected. From Vargas' point of view, it was a right bother. After he had worked hard to become a knight, this time he was to keep a watch on Rudel. Form an observer's spectacle, it was amusing enough, but getting involved led to extended headaches.

"I see... then I'll tell you. Starting with Luecke-sama. Your destructive actions in the magic practice field."

"? The teacher was the one who said to fire magic with the intent to blow the wall away, you know? I simply actualized that."

He had fired magic at the walls of the magic practice field. Those walls were sturdy magic-reinforced magic-resistant walls. And Luecke had destroyed them. The teacher never thought he's actually be able to... by the way, Rudel had also broken them a few times practicing his special attacks.

And in the end, both Luecke and Rudel had managed to developed magic capable of blowing the facility away as a whole. Offensive magic requiring control technique far exceeding the mana put into it had left the facility in pieces... the theories alone had existed for a while, but as they weren't suited to real application, it was an offensive magic everyone had given up on... but Rudel and Luecke had managed to complete it.

"Next! Eunius-sama, you're in for the habitual breaking of curfew!"

"What are you talking about? I'm always in the academy at curfew. I haven't broken a thing."

"Huh? There's a roll call at curfew, but is it fine as long as you're at the academy? Then am I fine?"

"If you're not there at rollcall, you're breaking curfew!"

Vargas cried out at Eunius and Rudel. By the way, in regards to this problem, Rudel had also...

"... Finally, Rudel. You walking problem! On top of those previous two charges, various races have brought in complaints regarding the ruckus at the girls' dorm."

"Y-yeah. There definitely was an uproar at the girls' dorm, but I think that one's the princess' fault. Having me pet all sorts of women, and getting all worked up on her own... come to think of it, isn't that girl a bit too emotional?"

Vargas began explaining to Rudel, the biggest problem child of the bunch. The fact what Rudel had done to those demi-human girls at the girls' dorm was sexual harassment. Just by touching them, a large number of women were...

While there was some fault in Rudel, the princess was the root of the problem. Saying she wanted to give her thanks, she called Rudel over to the girls' dorm. Normally, anyone would suspect something there. But it was Rudel she was dealing with... he nonchalantly stopped by the dorm. From the start, he held not the slightest of indecent feelings.

But Fina was different! She was an explosion of indecency!!!

"According to Miss M of the white cat tribe, it's your fault she can't get married! Or so the report came in."

"You mean Mii? But that was..."

"Wait a second Rudel! You... it can't be you did that thing you did on the high knight? Why didn't you call me!!? I also tried to learn it, but I'm not getting anywhere... teach me! Teach me the trick behind it!"

As Eunius drew close, Luecke held him back.

"Give it a rest! We're not getting anywhere here!"

"Apart from her, a black cat, an elf... and finally a tiger. Just how did you manage to tame a girl of such a monstrous tribe? There have even been inquiries from men of the same tiger tribe. Honestly, it's a pain! Day after day, large sweltering men come to us half-threatening us for the info!"

The other prefects who had become victims nodded in unison. Tiger tribe... Both men and women of the species possessed large builds exceeding two meters in height, a demi-human tribe known for their overwhelming might and ferocity. They were a tribe few in numbers, but the reason for that was quite hard to say. Tiger tribe women would only ever take to strong men.

They had no need for weaklings. For a tribe with such an unrelenting nature, Rudel was truly the messiah. If only petting is enough, then can even I hold the interest of a tiger girl... rotten as it was, he came from the Arses House of the Three Lords. Unable to ask even if they wanted, they had intruded on the prefects.

"Tiger tribe women are surprisingly cute, you know? I'm more scared of the black cat tribe... when she put on a collar and said, 'please make me your slave for the rest of my life,' I was seriously scared. If I didn't beg Izumi to save me, I don't know what I would have..."

"... You really are the worst! Sitting back and enjoying your monopoly on the market! Because of you, we're being chased, threatened by sweltering demi-humans... at least introduce me to someone next time!"

On Vargas' real feelings mixed in with his complaint, Rudel tried consoling him still with no idea of what was going on.

"Don't worry! I'm sure you'll be able to do it too, Vargas."

"I don't want to be consoled in such an irresponsible way! It's all your fault... wait a second? Did you just say something about the princess or... it couldn't be you laid hands on the princess!!? If you did, then we won't be getting off lightly either!!!"

As the prefects got desperate, Rudel scratched his face and denied it.

"I didn't do anything. Sophina-san, a high knight was stationed nearby, and it was impossible to touch her... all that happened was a confession."

"What!?"

"To that doll princess!?"

"Isn't that even worse!!?"

"Don't worry... it was rejected!"

Rudel answered full of confidence. As everyone present panicked, Rudel was thinking about heading back to his room. But unable to do so, he was restrained and forced to hear tales of what happened in the girls' dorm. And Vargas decided to prepare his ultimate anti-Rudel weapon.



While Rudel was restrained, the cause of all this, Fina felt irritated that Rudel wasn't coming over to the girls' dorm no matter how much time passed. Today was the day she would have him pass down that secret art... Sophina who had been stationed in her room as a guard kept a careful watch.

While she walked all around, Sophina offered a warning.

"Princess, you're being immodest. A member of royalty must always carry themselves boldly. And could you quit involving yourself with that idiot son of the Arses House?"

In regards to Sophina, who incessantly repeated the same thing,

"Right. I'll consider it."

(What's she talking about? Just meeting him as my life's savior shouldn't be a problem, right? Does she think I'm not aware... acting like you're covering for me every time and taking the petting in my stead, there's a rumor among your subordinates you've taken to wearing sexy undergarments these days... at this point, only your mouth's reluctant, and your body's all ready.)

"P-princess... is Rudel-sama coming today? If so, then I should be off."

As Mii tried to flee from the room, Fina grabbed her tail. Gently pulling that tail close and pushing down her body.

"Don't run... it'll be alright."

(I won't let you get away, little kitten!!! Today's the day my technique takes you to paradise... I'll take you to fluffadise!!!)

As Fina was in a fever state, Rudel made his appearance. It was already late, but Iumi accompanied him to the princess' room.

"N-nyaaa!!!"

"So you're here, Rudel! I won't let you get close to the princess."

"It is a pleasure you were able to come, Rudel-sama... then let us get right to it."

While the three of them each gave a different response, Rudel spoke with a smile.

"Ah, I'm sorry, but my petting has been sealed. Izumi told me it was no good, so I decided not to do it again. But I can still pet dragons."

On those words, the three froze. With a smile, Rudel spoke of how there was no helping it if Izumi said it, and if Izumi was the one asking, then... The expressionless Fina,

(W-what do you think you're doing, black hair!!? Do you realize just what it is you've done!!? My fluffing... my dreams of fluffadise!!!!!!)

Chapter 32

Having become a third year, Rudel had started taking classes of his own selection. But it was here that a problem came out. He was taking classes to become a knight, but young nobles already received a certain extent of education. For that sake, he found himself with more free time than the commoners.

At least in your student days, it's alright to have some fun. The nobles thought so as well... but to Rudel, he wanted to become a dragoon as soon as possible. He had to use the free time he had. And those with the top grades had some leisure in their credits, so he was needlessly bored.

"So you came to discuss with me on your future plans... but are you sure you're alright, Rudel-sama? Using up all your free periods on study and training."

Rudel had gone to discuss with Basyle. Even in the academy, Basyle was one abundant in true battle experience. There was nothing to be lost in talking it over with her! That was Rudel's decision, but... Basyle was wondering whether this was the right time to go do a job.

Job... they consisted of mercenary and guard work, government jobs where she'd sell her own ability for the right fee. Naturally, they were often dangerous, and one wrong step could spell life or death. But the current Rudel could handle most things.

"Do you have any good ideas? If possible, something I can only do now... once I graduate, I'll probably become quite busy..."

As Rudel lost himself in thought, Basyle brought the topic forward. Of course, about a job.

"In that case, would you like a nice jo... no, would you like to experience some battle? Not the sort of defense we did last year, I'll prepare some high difficulty subjugation training."

The inside of Basyle' head was filled with job details and rewards. Oblivious to all of that, Rudel accepted with a smile.

"Can I leave it to you!? You're a lifesaver, Basyle."

... At Rudel's words, she felt just a slight sense of guilt.



Basyle had come to a shop she knew well... the shop she sold a boar dusk a few year prior. After she made an enemy of the information dealers, she had come to rely on the old shopkeeper who had informed her of the danger. Now that she held a position of vassal to the Arses House- a position difficult to meddle with- Basyle could boldly make her way to the shop.

"Do I have a job for you? Last year's guard job was already pushing it... and at this point, you don't even need these jobs, do you?"

The old man carried out his appraisal job as he conversed with Basyle. As he carefully inspected all the items brought in Basyle looked around at all the goods lining his store.

"It's my employer's request. So will you find me something? I'll pay you some if you accept."

"This isn't a middleman ship, missy. But there is something I want to ask... the truth of last year's incident with the princess. The information isn't going around at all, so the info dealers are starving for it. Thinking there's something ill at work behind it."

Basyle could go in and out of the academy. Rather, she was a live-in worker. Those tidbits of info entered her hands at once. If her employer was completely involved in it, she's even investigate herself.

"It isn't something too interesting... though it did get a bit dicey when the Arses House's succession rights were dragged into the mix. And I guess that's about it? It feels like my employer's younger brother and parents are twisting the truth around. And there's a genius dragoon knight involved, making matters a bit complicated."

Basyle easily divulged the details of the incident... but when it came to Rudel, she vaguely played things off and evaded the subject. Basyle was mindful of her employer's personal information.

"When I thought it was something terrible... I guess that's just reality for you. So who's taking responsibility for it?"

"The Arses House is keeping silent. But I did hear little brother would be forcefully graduated in his second year, and stationed as a knight in the outskirts. I think it's a light punishment for a knight-hopeful who completely abandoned the princess, but... even so, as they're driving a famous noble to the borderland, the Arses House's reputation will be on the fall again."

Basyle didn't actually mind it too much. The reason being, because of Rudel, the Arses House's reputation was rising. Rudel... a future archduke recognized by the king, he had become a topic of discussion among the nobles. Within the intense factional disputes between the Three Lords' political forces, that was just how much a talented heir was valued.

"That idiot son of the Arses House is not a wonder child, eh... Never thought it would be tied in to that. No, I did catch wind of the rumors, to say the least."

"He's already a monster in battle. I'm no match for him..."

Basyle happily spoke on... but inside, she felt a bit lonely. It felt as if a little brother who had relied on her to that point was finally able to stand on his own...

"So is that also why the Dragoon Cattleya was removed from that scramble for promotion? It's become quite a topic that Cattleya- who never raised that

big of a problem- was suddenly sent off to the outer reaches."

"That's a surprise. So the information's already spread?"

"Yeah, I'm sure there's some reason Cattleya was sent off to the country's outer reaches. But even so, it's all taking a hectic turn. It seems Gaia's increasing their troops on the border, and the information dealers were making a ruckus over increased monster activity... as things are, being sent to the borderland might make for a surprisingly heavy punishment."

As they carried on that conversation, the shopkeeper finished his work and took a memo of the information he had received from Basyle. He had surely written it to sell to an information dealer... Basyle thought, but paid no particular mind.

"Come back next week for the work, I'll be able to find this and that before then. And I'll tell the dealers the information came from you... just because you're a servant of the Arses House, aren't you being a bit too careless? Nothing good comes from making light of them."

Hearing the shopkeeper's consideration, Basyle was surprised. She definitely was being careless, but... that current information held a decent value. She could've just sold it... seeing Basyle in thought, the shopkeeper spoke.

"I'm not troubled enough to have to take up a side job."

Hearing that, Basyle gave her thanks. At the end, she made sure to buy something before leaving the shop.



Having become a third year, Rudel got around to spending a majority of his time with Luecke and Eunius. It was forcefully decided that he would take territory management, and other courses necessary for an archduke. Taking them meant he would be together with the other eldest sons of the Three Lords.

The three of them put together half as a matter of course, and Izumi who was now away more than not. It happened when the four of them enjoyed a meal at the cafeteria

"You asked that lady to take up a job?"

Eunius ate his large serving of the lunch set as he showed interest in Rudel's story.

"If you're a student, then I get the feeling that endeavoring through your studies will be the safer option."

In contrast to Eunius' reaction, Luecke read a book as he put a damper on Rudel's actions. Sure enough, there were things you could only do as a student in school.

"But now is the only time we have, right? Once we graduate, things will get busy... This is just what Basyle said, but it's a good opportunity to see the world."

Luecke felt some sense to those words, and putting his book down, he opted to hear out the story.

"That woman... is it alright for me to join in as well? If I don't keep a watch on that women, things to take a turn for the worse."

"That's fine, but are your classes alright, Izumi? If you're aiming to be a high knight, I'm pretty sure there are a lot of necessary courses.

"Erk, I-I'll do something about it!"

Looking at Rudel and Izumi, just go out already, Luecke and Eunius thought inside, but didn't put to mouth. As they carried out such a conversation, Eunius finished up his lunch and voiced his own will to join in.

"Then I'm in as well! It's a good opportunity, and it sounds fun!"

"... I'm surprised you can say that with your abysmal academics... well, I have some leisure in my classes, so I wouldn't mind tagging along."

While the four of them spoke, one of the students in the cafeteria raised a sound as he stood from his seat. He sent his gaze towards Rudel's group, but... his eyes were filled with ill intent.

Noticing that, the four looked at the students, around him his peers desperately tried to return him to his seat, telling him to calm down. But the standing student didn't move his gaze an inch.

"What a sight. When we desperately earned money and begged our parents to attend this academy... our high and mighty heir do the Arses House cares more for monster slaying than managing his land? I'm surprised you can do that regardless of all the people pained by your actions. No, perhaps you can do it through your blissful ignorance?"

As he spoke, his thorn-like something towards Rudel grew stronger. The standing boy was of brown hair and blue eyes, without any particular features that stood out. But that being the case, his facial features were in order. From the friends around him desperately trying to contain him, they couldn't think he was a bad person.

"Quit it Fritz! You're picking a fight you can't win. You're dealing with our upperclassmen of the Three Lord Houses!"

As the surrounding voices grew louder, Rudel chose to ignore the boy. It wasn't as if he didn't like him, or wasn't interested in him. The boy spoke the truth, and Rudel understood it was a problem. Rudel was aware he'd be hearing these things someday.

But it's precisely because he was aware, that he thought saying something to someone like this boy wouldn't get anything across. If he said he's become an archduke to save them, that held no credibility. If he turned defiant, even more so. And... Rudel's dream lay on a path in the polar opposite direction of the boy's words.

"Why not say something!? Don't you feel sorry for the people suffering because of you!!!"

To the yelling boy, Luecke and Eunius stood and moved to say something back, but Rudel stopped them. Izumi tugged at Rudel's clothes, evidently worried he might cause a problem.

Whispering to Izumi it wouldn't be a problem, Rudel stood and looked at the boy. From his appearance, he could tell he wasn't a noble but a commoner. Surely his parents had gone to great pains to send him to this academy. Perhaps he was even a citizen of Arses territory.

In that case, I just have to become the bad guy. If the boy has someone to hate, I'm sure he'll try even harder, aim even higher... or so Rudel thought.

"I'm sorry... if I said that, would you forgive me? If your yelling will resolve the problem, then yell at me all you want, shout all you want. Once the fundamental curriculum ends, the third to fifth years have an individual entry tournament. If you can make it that far, I'll at least hear you out."

Saying that, Rudel left the cafeteria. Luecke and the others followed behind... and a little ways away, Aleist entered the cafeteria with his friend, but...

"W-what's with this heavy air!?"

That indescribably air enveloping the cafeteria left them both in surprise.

Chapter 33

Having accepted an adventurer job, Rudel and co had come to a town a long distance from the academy. He had fulfilled a number of jobs, so this time he wanted to take up a higher difficulty level one in the border region. The further you got away from the capital, the more monsters you would find. This was in part from the effective range of knight brigades, but monsters would more often settle in places with lower human inhabitation.

That being the case, the distance from the capital caused their travel time to number in days. So Izumi was absent. As she was aiming to be a high knight from the start, Izumi had little free time to speak of. But how heartless it would be, to raise the difficulty yet decrease the number of fighters... following that thread of logic, Vargas was dragged along.

"... You know. I'm not even sure what I should say at this point."

While Vargas was half in resignation, Eunius remained in high spirits. And as they headed for their destination point in the swaying carriage, Rudel and Luecke were reading books in the loading tray. By the way, Basyle was asleep.

"It's rare to be able to experience monster slaying in your school days, Vargas."

Rudel put a pause on his book and said it. Vargas let out a sigh as he answered.

"Hah, once I become a knight, I'll have to take them on whether I like it or not... what's more, ogre slaying? I have the urge to ask if you're an idiot."

This time's job was to exterminate a lone ogre who had been frequently sighted around the village. If they were in large numbers, the dragoons or

knight brigades would be mobilized, but... the fact it was independent, and that there hadn't been any casualties put it low on the priority list.

And there were few adventurers capable of defeating ogres. Few, or rather, if they were that strong, they were better off quitting the adventurer trade to find work with some wealthy noble like Basyle.

"I knight shouldn't complain. And as a knight, don't you have to pledge to protect the people?"

Luecke read on as he scolded Vargas. I definitely did take the oath! But when you think of how I'm spending my limited school life somewhere like here... it was only natural he was worried.

"More importantly, what are we doing about formation? I want the front line! Rather, I can't do anything else!"

In high tensions, Eunius was wholeheartedly looking forwards to battling an ogre. In the carriage, Basyle turned over in her sleep, putting her into an unladylike form... Vargas, Eunius and Luecke lent her an eye, but Rudel draped a blanket over her.

"... Just a bit... no, perhaps this trip isn't so bad."

Having found his drive to travel on, Vargas stopped his complaining. Meanwhile Eunius complained to Rudel that he look to see a little longer.



Just as the five set off on their job, there was a movement among the knight brigades. Cattleya had temporarily returned from the borderland to report. While being a dragoon, she was heralded as a genius, well thought of by the royal line. When such a girl was sent off to the outer reaches of the nation, the knights who didn't think so highly of her could boldly speak ill.

Her report over, Cattleya returned to her dragon, when some lower ranking knights called over.

"Been a while, 'prodigy'. Are you back for good?" "Don't be stupid, there's no way Cattleya can come back. She picked a fight with the Three Lords, so she's off to the border for life." "Oy, oy, it's amazing enough for someone to survive after picking a fight with the three lords! Right Mrs. Cattleya who presented her body?"

Ignoring those words, Cattleya hurried to her dragon... she couldn't stand it. To that point, she had held little interest in the dragoon status everyone dreamed of. But expelled to the outskirts, through the harsh life she lived day after day, she had begun to year for her life in the capital.

And with her engagement to Rudel, the story had somehow been changed to one where she presented her body for her life to be spared. That only served to irritate her more.

In her irritation, Cattleya walked. A fellow dragoon called over... it was Lilim.

"It's been some time, Cattleya."

She gave a greeting no different than before, but Cattleya wouldn't allow it. Her emotions running wild, she found Lilim's unchanging air to be irritating.

(When I'm the more talented one! Why did she get a promotion while I was blasted off to the border... right. It's all that guy's fault! Rudel! If that guy wasn't there...!!!)

Even she didn't know why her emotions blazed to such a level. Cattleya offered Lilim some cynicism.

"What's wrong, 'Captain' Lilim? Calling out to someone sent off like me... you bragging? Since you were promoted after I left, you want to show it off?"

On Cattleya's blatant cynicism, Lilim was a little surprised. Lately, Cattleya had been acting strange. Especially when it came to Rudel. And she was sent off to the border. Her pride had been high from the start, so perhaps her

feelings were just running wild. As she thought that, Lilim wasn't particularly irritated.

"I don't particularly mean to brag, I was simply curious how things were going on your side."

Feeling as if she was being ruled by something wicked, Cattleya let out words she never normally would say. On Lilim's secret she didn't want anyone to touch.

"It's the worst! They all say I offered my body to a man I don't even like! ... But perhaps I'm better off than you. Compared to the 'Black Eyed Woman' even run out on by her fiancé, I can get married whenever I want."

'Black Eyed Woman', That was Lilim's secret. The reason she wouldn't open her eyes was related to an elven characteristic where the quality of an individual's magic brought an influence to their hair and eye color. Just as her younger sister Millia's hair was green, even among blood siblings, completely different colors could come out.

... And with Lilim's eyes, the entire surface was pitch black. The magic quality and quantity she possessed put her in the top ranks of the elves. It was the reason she was abandoned by her fiancé.

"... What did you just say?"

Lowering her face a bit, Lilim's clenched fist trembled. But Cattleya continued to land the finishing blow.

"I called you a black eyed woman, captain! Well, because of that, you have the fortune of avoiding a marriage to Rudel. No, perhaps that was your last chance."

On those words, Lilim forgot herself in anger. And this time, Lilim was ruled by something wicked... in contrast, Cattleya turned so level-headed it surprised even herself... and she understood. Just how terrible her actions were, and how terrible of a situation she had put herself in.

"Cattleya!!!!!"

After that, the fight between two active dragoons unfolded.



Nearby a town close to the border, the soldiers of the Gaia Empire had disguised themselves and slipped in. Their mission:

'Testing the strengthened ogre'

That was their goal. For that sake, they had put out a job, and after testing it on adventurers, they would move onto combat tests with the knights of Courtois. That was their goal in infiltrating the enemy country.

And the one who happened to take that job was Basyle. Naturally, Rudel and the others were on board as well.

Long blond hair, wrapped round and round, a young girl wearing high class clothing was the captain of this experimental brigade. She hailed from a noble house of the empire, her name was Mies Liquorice. She boasted well-developed features for her age, and gave of the feel of a young lady prone to airheadedness. There was a reason she was forcibly conducting battle tests of this strengthened ogre in an enemy country.

Relaxing in a high class inn of the town, she and her surrounding soldiers needed to urgently prepare a powerful weapon for the empire that was on the verge of collapsing from succession problems. To cross the border, she had filled out the proper paperwork, she that wasn't a crime.

She just thought she'd have Courtois carry out the tests... simply that and nothing more. But with complex power struggles involved, this mission was one intended to cut off Mies and the Liquorice House.

Unaware of all that, Mies arrogantly worked around her underlings- who were well aware of the situation- as she waited for the mission to commence.

"Are the adventurers not here yet? It's already been three days! I'm getting rather bored of this life in the countryside!"

In regards to their boss's willfulness, the subordinates pitied or scorned her within.

"I believe it will take a few more days... all the skilled fighters are gathered at the center of Courtois, after all."

"Hah, so I'm to wait on some mere adventurers... thinking of the number of days it'll take for a knight brigade to come out really brings you down."

Mies said as she lay herself down on her high-class sofa.

This mission that had dragged in Rudel's party, the affairs within the dragoons entwined, it made for a bit of a tangled mess. This was an event that wasn't in the scenario.

Chapter 34: Extra 1

This is a tale of when Rudel and the others were hospitalized after the end of the tournament. In that sickroom where the eldest sons of the Three Lords were pained even to move, Rudel, Luecke and Eunius were chatting as per usual.

"Rudel, why did you overlook Aleist back then? If he gets back on his feet, whether you can win next time is... don't you think it would've been best if you let him drown in his talent?"

Luecke was talking about Aleist's unsightly cowering, when Rudel stopped the referee from declaring victory. If he hadn't done that, then Aleist would probably have just ruined himself. That's what Luecke wanted to say, but Rudel's answer was different.

"Back then... I wasn't really thinking when I did it, so I'm somewhat troubled to answer... but thinking back, I think I wanted Aleist to get back on his feet. I mean..."



The Aleist in question, having suffered only light injuries from Rudel, had been discharged from the infirmary that day. But up to the day of his discharge, he couldn't bring himself to drop by the room of the three lords. He wanted to apologize... but for what? And as he thought over such things, he found he was already discharged.

"Ah, it's at times like these that I hate my own spinelessness... but if it's just saying hi... no, but..."

Like that, Aleist loitered in front of the Three Lords' sickroom, glared at by the guards. His fear of the guards was another reason he couldn't enter the

room.

There, Izumi came over for a visit. In her hand was a basket of fruit, and she offered a light greeting to the guards. The guards opened a path for her... at this point, her face was enough of a permit.

And naturally, Izumi had noticed Aleist.

"Hardie? What are you doing in front of this room?"

"Um, n-no! This is, well..."

(This might be the first time I've ever held a proper conversation with one of the romance event characters. But right now, she's Rudel's girlfriend, so... right! I'll ask Izumi.)

Aleist approached Izumi and lowered his head.

"I want to enter the room, can I please accompany you!"

"... I don't really mind, but you could've just gone in alone, right?"

Saying that, Izumi sent a glance at the guards to confirm it. Receiving that look, the guards gave a nod. Get-well visits from classmates were overlooked. In regards to Aleist, his identity was certain, so he had even less reason to worry.

"Thank you!"

Saying that, Aleist approached the door only to overhear Rudel's conversation. He stopped his hand as it moved to open the door, while Izumi and the guards looked at him wondering what was going on.

From within the room.

'Back then... I wasn't really thinking when I did it, so I'm somewhat troubled to answer... but thinking back, I think I wanted Aleist to get back on his feet. I mean... when he has so much talent, wouldn't that be a waste? And I want to fight Aleist when he's strong.'

'How fitting of you. Then I want to fight a strong Aleist too.'

'Et tu Eunius? Aleist's a musclehead and a crowd favorite... if it's in the field of magic, perhaps I wouldn't mind taking him on.'

Those words brought tears to Aleist's eyes. He had looked down on him. He had thought of nothing more than how to use him. And yet... he felt just how large an existence the character called Rudel was. At the same time, Aleist realized how small of a human he was himself...

Izumi and the guards heard the words from the room and they could see Aleist's expression. Izumi called over to him.

"Would you fight Rudel again? Next time, I'm sure you'll be satisfied with the result too... and thank you. You came to visit because you were worried about him, right?"

In response to Izumi's consoling, Aleist wiped away his tears and turned to leave without entering the room. To the doubtful looks that gathered, he let his tears flow as he spoke in a shaking voice.

"Right now, I'm too shameful... once I grow strong, once I'm not embarrassed of myself... I'll come again."

Izumi knew what she wanted to say, but hesitated over whether to say it or not. And as she watched over Aleist running off, she thought.

'They won't be hospitalized for that long, you know?'

... Perhaps Izumi had been dyed in Rudel's colors.



Safely discharged, Rudel earnestly took on the few remaining classes of his second year. It was around that time. He received a letter from Princess Fina saying she wanted to give her thanks, but the contents were strange.

I want to thank you, so come to my room in the girls' dorm. At night. Alone... the letter stated it quite bluntly. If a normal man received such a

letter from the princess, then they'd likely get their hopes up. But this was Rudel.

"The girls' dorm doesn't allow men in, right? What's more, night... will I be alright with curfew?"

A few things off here and there, he tried to understand the problem and take action. That was Rudel. From the individual's point of view, not answering the princess' call would be a problem. So he acted in the accordance... but at that time, if he had consulted with someone... right, if only he consulted with Izumi, then many sacrifices could have been avoided.



The night of that day. Rudel had come to the girls' dorm as directed. He explained the circumstances to the female knights and soldiers on guard before the gates, and had them guide him to the princess' room. There was a reason security was so lax. Not because Rudel was a son of the three lords, or because it was the princess' order.

The princess had her own team of high knight guards. The dorm guards weren't trusted... in a situation where there was no helping to think that, unknowingly turning away the princess' guest seemed idiotic. Just push the trouble onto those high knights! It was an action that came from such thoughts.

Rudel answered the princess' room. There were two high knights in front of the door, and one stationed inside. The one inside was Sophina, who he had encountered before. And another, he could see Mii hiding behind the princess' back.

"Welcome, it is a pleasure you could make it ma... Rudel-sama."

(You're not getting away, master.)

"? Yes, on this auspicious occasion I do... (Is it just me or is this princess kinda scary? Is she hiding something?)"

Perhaps her loungewear, Princess Fina wore clothing easy to move around with, giving her a different impression from the women he saw around the academy. But it would be troubling to say that tickled his heart as a man. On the contrary, Rudel found the princess' attire to be suspicious. Why such mobile clothing... does she need to be ready to move at a moment's notice? What else is there to do than sleep or read a book at night?

Irrelevant to Rudel's thoughts, Fina,

"The truth is... I've been in love with you from the moment you saved me. Please go out with me!"

"I refuse!"

Rudel gave an immediate reply. Sophina and Mii who happened to be present stared dumbfounded at the exchange between Rudel and Fina. To confess before so many outsiders, Fina was one thing, but there was also a problem with Rudel for instantly turning down a confession from royalty.

"I-is that so... then..."

(I thought he'd at least give a reason, but for him to shoot me down just like that... as expected of my master. If it weren't me, he'd be tried for treason. My sister'd honestly try to kill him, so I'd prefer he be more careful, but that isn't the problem! Once they reject you once, humans are beings that become reluctant to reject a second, lesser request. And here's the main topic!)

"Please take me as your apprentice..."

"I refuse that too."

"..."

"..."

"..."

The princess' room fell silent. Fina cursed the royal tutor who taught her negotiation skills. Mii was surprised there was a noble who would decline the princess' request, while Sophina was mulling over whether she should scold the princess, or Rudel.

"C-could I ask your reasons?"

(Any stupid reason, and I'll have you sent off to the gallows! Even like this, that was the first confession of my life! When you reject me like... god, I think I'm going to cry. What's more, refusing to make me your apprentice... my dreams of fluffadise!!!)

"My reason... first, I already have two betrothed. If I left both of them aside to date the princess, I could never forgive myself as a person. And the princess' engagement is something decided by the upper brass of the country, so it's nothing that I can have a say in. As for the other matter, I am still much too immature, and it is too soon for me to take an apprentice."

In regards to the engagements, Rudel himself still didn't know what to do to sort out that confusion. But even so, he didn't want to take any rash actions... what's more, from Rudel's point of view, both his engagements were to dragoons he revered highly. He could never betray them.

"Is that so..."

(Those are some surprisingly decent reasons! I thought he'd give something more ridiculous... how impertinent, when you're supposed to be my master!)

Looking at the two of them, Sophina let out a sigh. And approaching Rudel, she scolded him.

"Rudel-dono, your current actions were too great a discourtesy against a member of the royal line. I ask that you answer with a little more tact."

"My apologies (Despite being called the doll princess, I get the feeling this princess is ridiculously abundant in emotion... is that just my imagination?)"

While Sophina was scolding Rudel, Fina assumed the fetal position on her bed in disgrace. Mii approached her in worry. To cheer her up, she pat her on the head, but...

"..."

(Hrrrngg, Mii, you're going to kill me from the cuteness!!! All I wanted was to take this little kitten to heaven... wait. Master said he's still immature... meaning something exists to surpass what he showed me before!? I must confirm this!!!)

"Rudel-sama, you are still immature? I was certain you already boasted considerable skill."

In order to confirm it, Fina interrupted Rudel's scolding. And to that question, Rudel.

"Yeah, there's someone I'm aiming for, but even now, I've yet to set foot into their domain..."

"Who is that?"

(There's an existence that surpasses even my master!? Who could that be!!!?)

"The author of How to Pet a Dragon, Marty Wolfgang. A dragoon of over a hundred years ago, he isn't around anymore. He was a great man who was never received the praise he deserved to the end!"

Rudel answered full of confidence. To Fina, rather than the book, the fact the individual was already gone was the problem.

"I see, that is unfortunate."

(A-a dragoon of a hundred years ago... why did you never praise him, damn bourgeoisie! If it were me, I'd have made him a hero of Courtois! I'd have made a country of fluffies!!! ... Huh? Wait, are dragons even fluffy to begin with? Well, whatever.)

"Rudel-sama... won't you accept my assistance in elevating your skills?"

And thus the curtain rose on the incident at the girls' dorm.

Chapter 35: Extra 2

"I can really pet you?"

"Yes. I won't be able to understand unless I experience it myself."

(Hurry it up! Get to the petting; pet me already!!! And then I shall lay hands on that sacred technique!)

In the princess' room, the princess' words created a bizarre air. For someone to tell him to pet them of their own accord, his little sister Lena was the only such person Rudel knew. Recalling his sister, he lightheartedly tried to pet her... but was stopped. It goes without saying the one who stopped him was high knight Sophina.

"Y-you can't! Such indecent... Fina-sama, you should call it quits already!"

"Why is it no good, Sophina?"

"It's just no good!"

"Then there is no helping it... in that case, I will give up on receiving a petting. But in my place, Sophina, you shall be pat."

"Why did it come to that!?"

"That's an order."

(Get to it already. I must learn that technique at all costs!)

Sophina and Fina carried on that unproductive back and forth over whether there should be petting or not. Rudel didn't just want to retract the hand he reached out to pet, so... he placed it on the head of the nearby Mii. At first,

lightly and gently... receiving a surprise attack, Mii held the naïve notion that she would be fine at this level.

She regret it.

"Eh!? Wai... not there... mn, ah!"

His hand reaching out to her ears, his fingertips gently stroked them... Mii collapsed at the knees, letting out a sound as she fell to the floor. At that sound, Fina stopped her quarrel and looked over.

"I missed it... Sophina, it's your turn."

(It's because you're so noisy that I missed the sight of Mii being pet! Take some responsibility and get pet yourself!)

"Don't joke around with me, pr- eek!"

As she tried to deny the order, Rudel circled around and started petting her ears. A high knight having her back taken by a student was in itself a failure. But as Rudel had no ill motives, filled with the pure intent to pet, Sophina never noticed. Sophina saw hell.

"Wow, this is amazing."

(Is he generating magic on his fingertips? Using magic of that level will be difficult for me... six, no! If I push myself, then three years should be...)

"N-no! Don't pet me so!"

As Sophia's face reddened, her body twisting around, Fina stared in earnesty. To be honest, Sophina wasn't fluffy so she had no interest in her. She was able to watch this act as a simple experiment.

It was there that Rudel became interested in his own limits. To that point, he had only used exactly what he had learned, but here he wanted to test technique he was still in the process of acquiring. That technique was...

"What beautiful hair... a lovely hue of deep purple. You must be looking after it well, Sophina-san, you're..."

Verbal attacks. According to Marty Wolfgang, it is important to express your love with words. Even if there are things you cannot express in words, you must not neglect trying. As these words were to be directed at a dragon, the individual called Marty was likely an oddball of Rudel's level.

But Rudel was dealing with a human, the human Sophina who wasn't accustomed to these sorts of things. Whether she wanted to resist or accept it all, the individual herself no longer knew... her hips gave out like Mii as she slumped to the floor.

"Hah, hah... I-I'm not happy about..."

Sitting down, her body occasionally twitched as only her mouth put up a resistance. As Rudel seriously took Sophina's reaction,

"So I still have a ways to go..."

He was vexed. But Fina thought quite differently.

"Well it all depends on practice, Rudel-sama."

(To think he was of this level... and the man who surpassed my master, Marty Wolfgang, just what heights could he have he reached? What magnificent things could he have seen?)



After that, Rudel began commuting to the girls' dorm to practice. But the individual himself only came because there was no helping an order from the princess. If he needed to practice, it didn't particularly have to be at the girls' dorm.

But if a man began bringing his feet to the girls' dorm every day, of course, the other girls would notice. To make matters worse, an individual who should never have been informed ended up finding out. Antagonistic to the

white cat tribe, a young lady of the black cat tribe, 'Ness' became privy of the rumors.

The reason she should never know... it was because Ness loved Mii. Not like, the other one... her love having surpassed the barrier of antagonistic tribes, and even the wall of gender, Ness was a young lady boasting long, black, silky hair. She carried a supple body, tall for a woman, sticking out where it should.

But she was off the boys' popularity scales. She was extremely cold to men. Only interested in girls, the fact that Rudel was frequenting the Princess' room and the fact that Mii was there were unbearable to her.

One time as she grew curious and passed by the princess' room... as ill fate would have it, Mii happened to rush out. And spotting Ness, Mii hid behind her back.

A step behind, the princess Fina leapt out, and even further back, Rudel walked his way out... Sophina was already incapable of standing, so she wasn't going anywhere.

"Don't run away, Mii."

(To run away at the good part, this is teasing play! My little kitten really is a mischievous one!!!)

Already in high tensions, Fina expressionlessly looked at the white cat hiding behind Ness. But for Ness, her beloved Mii was cowering behind her back, asking for help. There's no way she wouldn't save her! The moment she thought that- some indecent intent tinted in- her luck had run out.

"Give it a rest, princess! You're scaring my M... Mii, are you not!"

"Who are you?"

(Well of course I know. I've already investigated all the fluffies, graduates included... rather, you just said 'My Mii', didn't you... what's with this cuckold feeling I'm getting!? You're arousing me, dammit!)

Behind in quite a few things, Fina sent a glance at Rudel and the high knights behind her... but Rudel didn't know what she was trying to say. Rather, he didn't want to know. Ever since he began to mingle with the princess, a sense of fear towards the girl had begun to bud within him.

"I'm Ness, a fourth year student. *I*'m going to return Mii to her room for the day, so... wait! Why are you surrounding me!? N-no, let my go!"

The high knights whispered apologies to her as they carried off Ness and Mii to the princess' room (den of evil).



Having gotten a new sacrifice on her hands, Princess Fina pinned Mii herself, while leaving Ness tied up with rope. Rudel still couldn't follow the situation. He was panicking over what he should do.

"Let me go!"

"That's no good. The crime of trying to cuck my Mii... I'll reward you for it. It's your turn master!"

(I've got my hands on a white and a black fluffy... isn't this the best? It's gone past best into crazy!!!)

"...? You want me to untie her?"

"... What are you talking about? You just have to pet her."

(Why does he still not understand come to far? Hurry up and give her a good fluffing!)

Hearing that, Rudel looked at Ness... as she glared at him with hate-filled eyes,

"I don't want a man near me!"

At this point, she showed hate regardless of status or authority.

"It seems she doesn't want to be touched."

"Hah, master... if you manage to tame a woman who hates you... and get along with her, then you can climb to even greater heights."

"I see!"

Convinced by Fina, Rudel freely wielded every technique in his possession to try to become friends with Ness. As a result...

"S-stop! Ah! M-my ears feel so go... not the tail!!!"

"What pretty hair... your tail is beautiful."

And at the end, while she hadn't stopped hating men, so came the birth of Black Cat Girl Ness who would snuggle up close to Rudel. The characteristic purring those of the beast tribe gave to show their good will resounded through Fina's room... Rudel muttered.

"I get the feeling this is something else..."

Rudel's question was irrelevant to Fina. That present scene was justice! Two cat girls with reddened faces collapsed on the floor of her room, the human Sophina lying around as something of a bonus.

(It's come! My era has finally come!!!)

Chapter 36: Extra 3

After Rudel began commuting to the girls' dorm, the girls... particularly a certain portion of them began raising voices of disapproval. Unaware of all that, Rudel was on his way to answer the princess' call as per usual. Since he became a third year, he hadn't been able to go every day.

But even so, he was called around once per week, and at the worst times, the princess herself would say, "You can stay over for the night." Even Rudel would end up refraining from that one. Such visits continued, and Rudel's feet as he made for the girls' dorm grew heavier by the day.

"I get the feeling if I spent my time reading or training, I'd get better efficiency. But I'm being called by the princess, for argument's sake."

He complained to himself as he walked down the girls' dormitory corridor when...

"I smell a man... a noble at that."

"Boss! I'm telling you this is bad, that guy's a bigshot even among the nobles."

"Even for you, he's someone you shouldn't pick a fight with, boss!"

Wearing uniforms considerably tampered with... that no longer even held their original form, three girls stood in the way of Rudel's path. Among them, one was clearly glaring at Rudel. And she was large! Rudel wasn't short himself, but she stood more than just a head over him. Such a girl drew closer to him.

"Do you have some business with me? I'm in a bit of a hurry."

Unlike Euniu's elegant ferocity, the demi-human girl contained an especially wild savagery. And that was how it was supposed to be... among the demi-humans, the beast tribes, the girls were of the tiger tribe heralded as the strongest. What's more, they were Rudel's upperclassmen. One wrong step, and even Rudel felt he would lose to them.

"Business? Of course I have some! There's no way it's good for a guy to be here! Now turn tail and get lost, noble boy!"

Looking down on him, and that yelling voice was enough for a gangster to feel dread. Her intensity received a full score, but...

"More importantly, aren't those clothes against the rules? I recommend you stop dressing like that. Shortening your skirts, and... your bosom is, well..."

The tiger tribe women's attire, to Rudel who had many noble women around her, it looked striking, even causing his heart to speed up a tick.

"Where do you think you're looking brat!? If you want us to stop so bad, then call over a teacher or something."

As the girl they called boss burst into a grin, she grasped Rudel's lapels and lifted him up. But Rudel had been petting too much lately, and as a conditioned reflex, he reached for those encroaching tiger ears. The boss was surprised for just a moment, but she instantly snapped, tried to throw Rudel down, and... crumbled at the knees.

"Eh? Wait a sec... ond. W-what is this!?"

Her knees stuck to the ground, her thighs were lightly shaking. As the boss sat on the spot, Rudel felt some relief that his legs reached the ground. But seeing that, the boss' followers wouldn't let him off.

"What did you do to our boss, brat!?"

The tiger tribe women leapt at him... there were no survivors.



"... How troublesome."

The ruckus having subsided, Rudel looked over the present state of the hallway as he thought over what to do. The tiger tribe girls' rooms were probably close, so he could just leave them there. He wanted to escort them, but when everyone was unconscious, that wasn't quite an option... and it hit him.

"I'll go ask Izumi!"

Rudel headed for Izumi's room. The unconscious tiger tribe girls were left behind. And as luck would have it...

"Good grief... where could my master be?"

(Keeping a princess waiting, he's a failure as a gentleman! Though I'm a failure of a lady! I want to quickly fluff up Mii and Ness...?)

As Fina walked down the hallway with her high knight guards, she came across the unconscious tiger tribe girls in the hall. She thought a bit and concluded this was Rudel's handiwork. The forms of these tiger girls closely resembled the form Mii was left in after a good petting.

"There's no helping master."

(The master's leftovers are to be eaten up by his disciple! ... crap, I'm so excited my drool is leaking out!)

Expressionlessly thinking over such things, Fina had the tiger tribe girls brought to her own room... and after that, she had a wonderful time fluffing them up.

"There's no one here, Rudel."

"Huh? That's strange... there were unconscious girls here just a moment ago..."

Izumi and Rudel who appeared later looked around, having found no one in the hall. And Izumi threw out the natural question.

"By the way, Rudel, why are you in the girls' dorm? What's more so naturally..."



The next day, as Rudel had been unable to go to the princess' room the previous night, he was called out again. Rudel headed to the girls' dorm with feelings of gloom. There, he found the tiger tribe girls wearing uniforms that upheld school regulation. Fidgeting a bit, they acted bashful from their unfamiliar attire.

The girls noticed Rudel and approached.

"W-we're really sorry about what happened yesterday! A-also... about yesterday..."

In regards to the women who were struggling with their words, Rudel thought they wanted him to keep quiet on their clothing from the other knight. That's how he took it. Sure enough, it was some stimulating attire, and anyone would want to keep it a secret... Rudel seriously thought.

"Yeah, I'll keep quiet about it. Don't worry."

"...? N-no, not that!"

The tiger girl fidgeted as she tried to say something. But the princess' appointed time drew close. Saying he had an appointment, Rudel made off. And as he headed for the princess' room, Ness was there waiting for him... with a collar.



"Please make me your slave for the rest of my life."

Ness looked at Rudel with muddled upturned eyes. Her collar had a chain attached, what's more, she told him to make her his slave. A normal man

would worry over whether to accept or not... but Rudel,

"Slavery has been abolished in Courtois. So the buying, selling, and possession of slaves is a crime."

An upfront, complete rejection.

But Ness didn't give up. Huddling her body to his, she pleaded in a cat's purring tone.

"It's a figure of speech. If you'll keep me for the rest of my life, I'll be satisfied."

"No, using the word keep for a demi-human is strange! ... H-huh? Are you listening to what I'm saying?"

Ness began unbuttoning Rudel to strip him down... there, Rudel grew scared and took flight. He ran off towards Izumi's room at full force.

"Save me, Izumi!"

From Rudel's footsteps down the hallway, Izumi knew he was there before he came in... but her roommate was surprised as he suddenly burst into the room.

"Did you do something again?"

"She wants to be my slave! The black cat says she wants to be my slave! I'm going to become a criminal!"

On Rudel's answer she didn't quite get, Izumi had no idea what to do... so she arbitrarily opened the window and let him use it for his escape. To be blunt, Izumi was way too soft on Rudel. Normally, he had done enough to be presented to the dorm's prefects.



And having learned of those happenings, Fina.

"I see, so master isn't coming today either..."

(Damn, before I even noticed it, master cucked my Ness away! This is irritating and just a bit arousing!!! What should I do, at this rate all my fluffies will be taken away... I'm so aroused I can't help it. Should I seriously try to get my hands on master? If I do, I'll never be troubled with fluffing for the rest of my life. Huh? Master's from a Three Lords' House, so there's no problem with him as a partner!)

She got all worked up alone.

And the princess' guard Sophina and her best friend Mii looked a little disappointed that Rudel wasn't coming. Fina spoke.

"Well, I'll just place my hopes on tomorrow."

(We're all at the academy, so there shouldn't be a problem if I leave a little time. I'll be fluffing again tomorrow!!! As I thought, fluff is the first step to conquest!)

But Fina's wish was broken oh-so easily by Izumi.

Chapter 37

Arriving at a town near the border, Rudel's party met up with their client- a merchant. It was evening when they arrived, and as it would be dangerous at night, the subjugation was set for the following day. Vargas and Eunius sallied forth into the town of the night, partly to prepare for tomorrow, while Luecke spent his time with a book in the inn.

Basyle went out saying she had to look into some things... something was off about the requested, so it seems she went off to ask around town about her.

And Rudel decided to look around the blacksmithy of that border town. Vargas already had his own equipment, and Eunius possessed his own specially-made claymore. Even Luecke's self-protection one-handed sword was a special order. But Rudel's sword was a cheap one.

Perhaps because he would only ever swing it around in training, the one he received at his manor was a hand-me-down from the soldiers. He had been using it fine, but lately, its quality was dropping, and it was starting to chip. He was carefully looking after it... but when it came to life or death, he did have his anxieties.

"Is the store still open... according to the innkeeper, it's supposed to be somewhere around here..."

Rudel walked alone through the unfamiliar town. Walking by the innkeeper's memo, and after a while, he caught sight of a number of weapon shops. Lined up in front of the stores were sturdy weapons and well-ornamented ones... a wide variety. After looking around the display weapons, he entered a shop to see their stock.

"This is best for kids."

"A rapier? I'd prefer something more durable..."

"How about it, noble boy!? Aren't all our store's weapons the coolest!?"

"Yeah, they do look cool (Those unnecessary ornaments look heavy)."

"If you buy two, I'll throw in this knife as a bonus."

"I don't need two."

A majority of the shops either treated him like a child or tried to push expensive goods onto him due to his noble status. While there were definitely a few nice pieces among them, as none of them suited Rudel himself, he decided to give up.

It was at that moment he spotted a tarp draped over the street, a single man sitting cross legged over it. Atop the tarp was a single katana. Rudel had learned about it from Izumi, so he stared at it as a rare find. He thought of it as an eastern saber, but according to Izumi it was used differently.

"How rare... but why is there only one?"

Standing before the man, Rudel looked down on the blade. Right, katanas rarely circulated through Courtois. Yet the man selling such a valuable item wore tattered clothing, his beard and hair a scraggly mess. He seemed to be in terrible shape.

"It's the last piece I was able to make with my partner. At this point, I no longer have a smithy to make another..."

The man explained with uncomfortable words. While Rudel knew he wouldn't use it, perhaps Izumi would be happy to receive it, so he pulled out the exact price of the tag.

The man looked at Rudel in surprise, posing a question as he took the money. By no means had he presented any lesser sum. He had grown intrigued by Rudel who could calmly hand it over.

"Do you intend to use this katana? As the seller, it may be odd for me to say, but if you don't know how to use and look after it, it's no more than a lump of iron."

Taking the katana, Rudel carefully held it as he spoke.

"I have an acquaintance from the orient, this is a gift. It's not like I'm the one using it so you don't have to worry. Truth be told, I wanted a weapon for myself, but I couldn't find anything."

The money Rudel put out had been from the rewards of the monster slaying he had been doing as of late. But in the academy, he had little opportunity to use it, so his funds would only build up. He had intended to use it to buy a new weapon for himself... but in the end, it became a present for Izumi.

"... I see, so you're acquainted with one of my countrymen."

As the man stared off in reminiscence, Rudel said his thanks and walked off. The man called out to Rudel's back.

"I'm Zouken. I live in this town with my comrades and family. Please send my fellow countryman my regards."

"I'll pass on the message."

And with one new encounter, Rudel's day came to an end.



Around when Rudel's day closed, two dragoons were spending their time in cells below the palace. The rampaging two had been prominent powers of the country, and the damage was great. For that sake, they were seized in due time, but instead of a reprimand, they got solitary confinement.

There were shackles around their wrists, and by their special make, those cuffs made it difficult to use magic. Proof that the guards were quite wary of them.

In just a few minutes, these two had destroyed the area. Cattleya and Lilim spent their time in separate solitary cells. As it was night, Cattleya was asleep. But Lilim...

"Why do they always come to hate me?"

'Because you're repulsive.'

"I wanted to get married you know. I loved him..."

'With eyes like those, you're one to talk. As if there's any man who could love you.'

"Everyone... goes away because of these eyes... if only these eyes didn't exist!"

'Are you really going to crush them? Are you fine with that? It isn't your fault... the one at fault is...'

Finding Lilim's monologue to be ominous, the guards didn't want to draw close. They didn't hear anything, they didn't see anything. That Lilim was talking to the wall, and that the shadow projected on the wall... was Lilim's conversation partner.

"The one at fault... right, it's Rudel's fault! That detestable one!"

'That's right, hate him! The Rudel you loath... the fiancé who betrayed you!'

Before her engagement to Rudel, Lilim had been betrothed to an elven man. But after seeing her black eyes, the man annulled the engagement. He was a kind man, and Lilim truly believed it would be alright if she revealed her secret. Yet she was betrayed.

That fiancé of the past, and Rudel, who even now was an engagement-candidate-for-argument's-sake, their forms overlapped in Lilim's head. The shadow that guided her, warped her to the conclusion resembled Cattleya in shape and voice. Once the shadow overlapped with Lilim's, Lilim stood up and tore off her shackles.

"That's right, I'll kill him! I'll kill the man who betrayed me!"

Lilim's blond hair gradually changed to silver, her skin turning from white to black... and white insignias rose to the surface of her blackened skin. They were marks that greatly resembled the monsters that had attacked in the forest.

'Hate him... Hate Rudel, kill him! There is no way he can be allowed to live! The purpose of my existence is to 'return Rudel to his base'. And if that is impossible... then kill him!!!'

Born in Cattleya and matured within, 'it' declared if returning him to his original state proved impossible, it would erase the character Rudel from this work. To it, he was the first act of treason towards the world. On a situation where the surroundings accepted Rudel, it had a will to carry out its reason for existence to the end.

'The will of the world is irrelevant... this is my will!'

Using Magic, Lilim escaped from the cell. That day... a single Dragoon fled the palace alongside her dragon.

Chapter 38

"It's over there... one of our merchants said he saw the ogre around that forest. I'd like you all to slay the ogre in this forest."

Led by the imperial spy posing as a merchant, Rudel's party proceeded towards the forest of the strengthened ogre. Having circled around beforehand, the imperial soldiers and Mies had come to observe the experiment. The strengthened ogre that would move just as ordered lay in wait for Rudel's party... its power far surpassed a standard ogre, boasting speed and a high resistance to magic.

For such an experiment where victory was already assured, Mies could only reluctantly watch. It was an official mission from the empire so she was unable to be negligent.

But in the airspace above Mies and Rudel, a dragon and elf were taking a nose dive.



Rudel and co proceeded through the uneven ground of the forest, remaining wary of their surroundings. When an ogre- a beast said to boast a rough temperament- was supposed to be here, the forest was much too quiet. On top of that, they couldn't help but feel something was strangely off. Basyle was the same. Through her info she had investigated the night before, she definitely did hear rumor of the ogre.

But even so, the merchant who put out the request was strange. While saying he was afraid, he was still taking an extended stay in the village, and she couldn't feel any impatience from him. When it came to merchants, time was money, so when he should be at such a loss...

"Rudel-sama, stay on your toes. If worse comes to worst, please consider abandoning this request altogether."

Keeping fleeing as an option wasn't cowardly. But abandoning a request impacted one's credibility. Even with that in mind, they had to consider running away. It was a considerably shady request, it seems... that on his mind, Rudel climbed a sudden slope when something fell from above.

"What is it!?"

Eunius immediately reacted and took a stance with his sword, Bargas held up a large shield and stood in front of everyone. There, the ogre they were requested to take out was trampled under the foot of a dragon, and on its back was the figure of one in the garb of a knight.

The scene shocked all. No, only one was enthralled... it was Rudel.

"It's a wind dragon! Lilim-sama too... and she's all black!"

On the back of the Wind Dragon, Lilim was dark... she had become a dark elf, and had changed to an extent that no one would be able to recognize her had Rudel not pointed out. More than that, everyone gathered,

(How could you tell?)

The question came to mind.

The surprised party's eyes drifted to the ogre the Wind Dragon had taken out in an instant. A dragoon had taken their mark. This wasn't particularly strange. But Lilim was clearly acting peculiar.

"Phh fufufu! This vilest of fiends has been burnt to cinders in my flames of darkness!"

... The ogre there had been crushed to death by the dragon. There were definitely no flames involved, and even if it was supposed to be cinders, the body was clearly there. For some reason, Lilim was covering half her face and striking a cool pose.

"She didn't even use any magic, right?"

Eunius looked at everyone to confirm, and everyone nodded. Rudel tried to stick up for her, but in this situation where she clearly didn't use any magic, he reluctantly gave a nod.

"More than that, I can't say for sure that's Lilim the dragoon. If Rudel says it, then there's no doubt about it, but I have heard before that dark elves are dangerous."

Luecke said as he hardened his guard.

"I've never heard that Dragoon Lilim was a dark elf. So that in mind, would you care to answer...!?"

The moment Basyle tried to get this situation in order and called out to Lilim. Rudel suddenly cut at Basyle.

No, to be more precise, he cut at Lilim who suddenly approached. The knife in Lilim's hand let off sparks against Rudel's blade.

"Wha!? That's way too fast!"

Vargas tried to deliver a late blow to Lilim with his shield but she dodged with ease. On her back, her blackened wings of elven magic beat furiously... it's a bit disgusting, Basyle thought as she broke into a cold sweat.

She was surprised Lilim was able to close the gap in an instant, but she praised Rudel for reacting in time. And Rudel had concluded Lilim had seriously tried to cut Basyle down.

"What are you trying to do, Lilim-sama? That one was a serious blow, right?"

"Serious? Fu... if I was serious, then everyone here would be dead already!"

As Lilim set her body into a pose, Luecke fired magic. Eunius cut in right after Luecke's attack, but Lilim casually avoided both. The five of them were being played by a single dragoon.

Rudel didn't know Lilim's fighting style. Rather, the styles of individual dragoons were treated as highly classified information. They weren't incompetent enough to give away their weak points. But as dragoon was a popular occupation, if they fought somewhere, then parts of their fighting style would naturally spread.

Even so, Lilim's fighting style remained a mystery. She had either taken out her foes too fast, or just as she had tried with Basyle, perhaps she was specialized in assassination... Rudel thought as he exchanged blows with Rudel, when the unmoving wind dragon suddenly struck up a conversation.

'Human child from some time ago. I want you to save my contractor... could you kill her please?'

A voice that almost seemed to flow directly to his head, alongside his admiration, Rudel felt an intense confusion.



Watching the intense clash of Rudel's party and the dragoon from afar, Mies' had long since crossed from panic into fear. To the soldiers of the empire, dragoons were their angels of death. The presence of just a single dragoon would bring outrageous casualty to the battlefield.

The soldiers who had been leading Rudel along had all used the confusion created by Lilim to run and meet up with Mies.

"What's with this... why have the dragoons come out so soon!? This isn't an experiment anymore..."

Not knowing what to do, Mies' squad had made another large mistake. They had been unable to notice a single dragoon's approach.

"What experiment? You'll tell me all about it, won't you?"

Mies turned around only to find no one. Turning to look up, she found a single red-haired knight on her red dragon had managed to make her way directly above them. Mies' company resolved themselves for death.

That dragoon was Cattleya. On Lilim's escape, a shortage of hands had caused even the troublemaker Cattleya to be used. The decision handed down by the dragoon captain was to apprehend Lilim before anyone saw her, and to eliminate her if she caused a problem before she was found.

"W-what could you be talking about? An experiment, oh... right! We were conducting experiments on the monsters in the forest."

As Mies tried spouting a lie, Cattleya's sword grazed her face. The sword that stuck into the ground took on quite an ominous form. That magic sword was one of the reasons Cattleya was called a genius. Even though Mies' grazed face had been cut a bit, it wasn't bleeding.

Cattleya jumped down from her red dragon to where her sword stood, and once she had retrieved it, Mies' men had finally regained their composure as they readied their own weapons.

"I'm in a hurry, so let's get this over with quickly... I'll have this magic sword suck some blood to prepare for my fight with senpai."

As the surrounding imperial soldiers cut at Cattleya, Mies felt the sensation of power draining from her body from that slight graze, experiencing the dread of that sword. And no matter how many times Cattleya cut up her men, no blood would flow... to be more precise, their blood was being sucked away, but Mies watched over an exceedingly ominous bloodless massacre.

And it was to be... the every time the sword sucked blood, its power increased. Once her final subordinate was cut down, Cattleya approached Mies.

"Now let's hear your story. Why is an imperial soldier doing in a place like this!?"

From Mies' subordinates' way of fighting, Cattleya had determined them to be soldiers of the empire.

Pressing her magic sword to Mies' throat, Cattleya... had already called her comrades, so she was sure it would be fine even if Lilim tried to flee. It seemed she was in battle with someone, but she had yet to confirm who. No, she was sure they were already dead but was shirking off on confirming that.

The one she fought was Rudel's party, and she had yet to notice they were still in combat... until an intense explosion sound rang out from the battlefield...

Chapter 39

'Child of man from some time ago. I want you to save my contractor... do you think you could kill her?'

Rudel heard the wind dragon's voice right in his heart. At first he was dumbfounded, but his situation wouldn't permit that. Lilim was fighting with the advantage against five foes, forcing Rudel's party into a defensive battle.

(You'll tell me to kill her... I'm...)

Rudel's troubled movements were a danger on the battlefield. And Lilim wouldn't let them go unchecked.

"Got you!!!"

A mid-range attack she took distance to make, she hammered in a consecutive stream of intermediate magic. Alongside Lilim's call, multiple bursts of wind, ice and fire assailed Rudel. And the ones who leapt out in front were Vargas and Basyle.

"What are you doing, Rudel!?"

As he said that, Vargas used the shield he held in both hands to take the magic, while Basyle shot magic of her own to negate it. But after the detonation of that magic stream... Lilim's magic had an overwhelmingly higher output, Vargas' shield was destroyed as he was blasted back, and while not to the same extent, Basyle was sent flying by the impact as well.

"Vargas! Basyle!"

"Two out for the count!! A troublesome woman's gone, and I reign supreme!!!"

Regripping his sword, Rudel rushed at Lilim. She parried his blade with her knife. When Rudel had put much more power into it, reality had his force redirected by the dagger she held in one hand.

"Why are you doing this!?"

Even now, Rudel was lost. He didn't know whether he was capable of killing her... but as he mulled over whether he should or not, Rudel's attacks became distracted.

"Why? ... Because you went and abandoned me, dammit!!! What's more, leading a woman around, showing her off... I'll kill... I'll kill you!!!"

Rudel felt her black eyes were growing even darker. As he evaded a swipe from her knife, he noticed the unnatural white markings over her. That white insignia he had seen twice so far carried no good memories for him.

"That mark... Why do you have that mark, Lilim-sama!?"

"Stand back, Rudel!"

As Rudel cried out, it came Luecke's turn to shout. Rudel reacted to his voice and instantly leapt back. And the advanced magic Luecke unleashed on Lilim... the torrent of flames hit her head on, but

"Ha HAHAAHA!!! Such firepower, before my jet-black flames, it falls short of a gentle simmer! But I've already grown weary, so I'll get serious... come to me, my wicked dragon."

'...'

Saying some incomprehensible things, Lilim called for her own wind dragon. The dragon abided and approached her. It was by no means a wicked dragon.

"I'll kill them all! Erase all I... all I hate from existence!!!"

Straddling the dragon, Lilim soared into the sky. Rudel could see her black eyes flow tears as she continued to laugh. Eunius understood there was nothing he could do against a dragon flying through the sky as he clicked his tongue.

"Tsk! At this rate, we're really screwed."

As if to answer Eunius' weak-willed statement, tho volunteered themselves as decoys.

"P-please run away, Rudel-sama. we'll somehow keep her back here, so the Three Lords should..."

Covered in wounds, Basyle and Vargas lend each other a shoulder as Basyle offered the proposal. Turning back, Rudel seriously looked over them.

"Hah, hah, it ain't a bad idea to save a junior. And more than anything, I decided to become a cool brother for the little ones... go, Rudel."

As he gave a pained laugh, Vargas' arms were covered in blood, and his left arm was definitely broken. But looking down over the two who stood, Lilim,

"So you're still alive, woman! This time, my wicked dragon's flames shall smite you down!"

'Child of man...make your choice. My contractor, or those close to you... if you wish to save all, you can only kill my contractor. And right now, she has been taken over. It's painful to watch her... kill her, please.'

"Why aren't you attacking!? Hurry and kill that housewrecker!"

Lilim ordered the dragon. From how Basyle was the first one she targeted, it seems Lilim didn't take kindly to any women around Rudel. Likely from the fact that other women were around the man she was supposed to be engaged to.

'Do not ponder, child of man! I'm approaching my limit to how far I can oppose my contractor's words.'

"... You're right, I don't need to ponder. Thank the heavens there was no need for me to worry to begin with."

Rudel muttered as he looked at the dragon in the sky.

It was at that moment. Cattleya's red dragon rammed straight into Lilim and her wind dragon.

"I don't really get it, but let's use this chance to run, Rudel!"

Eunius put a hand on his shoulder and called out. Luecke lent a shoulder to the injured Basyle and Vargas, and was in the process of retreating.

"Go ahead of me... I found something I have to do."

"What are you talking about!? You plan to leap into that fight of monsters!?"

At the end of Eunius' stretched finger, the wind dragon pressed down by the red dragon, and the two dragoons who had leapt off their backs. An intense battle of mid-range magics and close quarter combat was unfolding between them. As Lilim leapt about, firing magic bolts all around, Cattleya drew power from her magic sword, cutting them all down as she closed the distance to get Lilim into a close-range match.

That's all that was going on, but it was clearly above the level of students. Each individual movement was carried out with unbelievable speed and precision, the magic output and sword swipes on another level... their momentum was one that made one wonder whether the surrounding forest would be blown away. No, it really was being leveled. There were already trees tumbling down as the surrounding terrain swiftly changed.

"... They're both my fiancées. This is my problem too."

"Idiot! That's irrelevant now... while they may be betrothed to you, those two are already done for. Cattleya raised a problem, and with today's events, then in the worst case, Lilim will get death! The engagement's annulment is only a matter of time."

A dragoon who launched an attack on the eldest sons of the three lords. That alone was a problem, but if the world were to know she used a dragon to carry out a personal grudge, the universal prestige of dragoons would fall. As this was a problem related to the country's dignity, she wouldn't be able to avoid severe punishment.

"Fiancee or former fiancée, it doesn't matter. I decided to save them!"

Rudel seriously looked at Eunius. And Eunius lost out to his will. Leaving Luecke to treat the injured, he decided to help support Rudel.

"Got it. But what are we going to do? I can't think we'll be able to stop a fight between those two."

At the ends of their sights, they could see the two dragoons exchanging insults as they fought. Consecutive bursts of magic, a tempest of swipes from a magic sword, a battle of monstrous proportions unraveling between them.

"... If we can get it down to just me and Lilim, I'll be able to do something."

"I don't know what you're planning, but that makes Cattleya the problem. I'll do something about her, so you definitely have to save Lilim. By the way, how do you intend to do it?"

"I haven't the slightest idea, but... that's not a problem!"

Giving an answer brimming with confidence, Rudel headed off towards where Lilim and Cattleya were fighting. After giving a sigh, Eunius followed along.

"Will you really be alright!?"

Hearing Eunius' cry from behind, Rudel thought over what he had decided in his heart.

(I'll definitely save her!)



Two headed back off to battle. Meanwhile, seeing Rudel and Eunius off, Luecke began treating Vargas and Basyle. He could only take emergency measures, and after he had completed them, he was thinking of leaving this forest at once. Luecke did worry for his friends' safety, but he was just as worried about the whereabouts of the merchant who led them there.

As he thought over the merchant Basyle heavily suspected, he could only anticipate the worst and take the appropriate action. To save the beaten two as fast as possible, he prioritized returning to town.

As he thought over such things, Vargas suddenly burst into tears.

"Are you in pain?"

While Luecke mulled over whether to use his scarce remaining mana on Vargas' treatment, Vargas shook his head.

"No, I was just ashamed... I said something cool to Rudel, but in the end, running away is all I'm capable of. I can't stand it. I wanted to become a man who could save someone..."

To Vargas' words, Luecke didn't know what to say. But Basyle embraced him.

"You were cool. It's because you decided to be a decoy that I was able to muster my courage... thank you."

"Basyle..."

Left on the sidelines, Luecke was even more oblivious on what to say as he scratched his face and averted his eyes. He prayed for Rudel's safety.

Chapter 40

The clock turns back and restarts as Cattleya thrusts her demon sword towards Mies' throat.

"Now I'll have you talk."

"Gn..."

In contrast to Cattleya's level-headed conduct, even if you called her military personnel, Mies was raised as a high-society lady whose fighting prowess fell short of the standard soldier. Her shaking body was only able to stare back at Cattleya.

But at that moment, from where Lilim fought came an explosive sound alongside an earthen tremor. As the red dragon looked in that direction, it reported whatever it saw to Cattleya. The individual it reported on was the problem. Cattleya didn't hesitate to send her dragon a complaint.

"Why are the Three Lord brats in a place like this!?"

From Mies' point of view, Cattleya who suddenly started talking was exceedingly scary. But at the same time, she felt Cattleya's attention veer astray. Mies... if she had to name a specialty, it would be her ability to escape from desperate situations. A character who originally appeared in the game, all of Mies' parameters were low, but she possessed a characteristic skill.

"Now!!!"

Mies used an apparatus she carried on her person. It was a 'smoke screen'. A cylindrical something rolled across the ground, and from it, smoke rushed out with good momentum to steal Cattleya and the red dragon's sight. But

that alone wouldn't be a problem. For a dragon and dragoon, something of this level wasn't enough to get away... if it were only smoke, that is.

"Wha!? Wait, it stinks!? What's with this smoke!!!?"

Cattleya held her mantle against her nose and mouth. Because of the smell, her dragon was unable to give chase to Mies, their foe. Within all of that, Mies splendidly managed to make her way through the putrid smoke to freedom. Her special ability... 'Successful Flight' was an ability to flee from any situation with a high probability.

The situation was on her side. Because there was no way Mies could take precedence over Lilim in this circumstance. Now that she knew Lilim's opponents were the eldest sons of the three lords, Cattleya had no choice but to prioritize them. As her original plan was to apprehend or murder Lilim, she couldn't let herself get stuck up over Mies forever.

"You've forced me to use my trumpcard... when this smell is a nightmare to wash off! This is why I hate Courtois! Stupid lizard knight!!!"

Mies complained as she ran. And Cattleya headed straight for where Lilim was.

"Seriously, what's this smell!? Even so... time after time after time, why does that guy have to cause so many problems!?"

She was also complaining as she rode her red jargon to rescue Rudel's party.



Arriving at the battlesight, Cattleya and her dragon went right into their attack. From what she could see from the sky, Rudel had a party of five, and two had already dropped out. If she wasted any more time, someone would end up dead.

"I'll have you calm down, senpai!"

The two colliding dragons struggled as they fell to the ground. The two dragoons that leapt from their backs landed, took up stances with their weapons of choice and immediately went into battle.

"Cattleya!!! Why business does a bullshitting bitch have with me!!?"

Confirming Cattleya, Lilim violently nailed in her emotions. From Cattleya, who knew the usual Lilim, this was a shocker, but Cattleya had constructed the cause.

"It's an order. Please come in quietly..."

Cattleya's demon sword rung against Lilim's knife. As their blades locked and their faces drew close, Lilim spit on Cattleya's face.

"Acting all polite at this point!? I know all about your personality! What business does the woman who'll open her legs to any and everyone have with me!? Laying your hands on my... my fiancé, you trying to brag!?"

Lilim didn't know what she was saying at this point. Within her chaotic head, Cattleya was a housewrecker trying to steal her fiancé Rudel away. To Lilim, the current Rudel had overlapped with her past Fiance, making him a target of affection. Rudel who pledged his future to her betrayed at the sight of her black eyes and was playing around with another woman.

That was how Lilim recognized it. But Cattleya...

"What are you talking about!? When you're usually acting so unconcerned... and I'm a vir___!!!"

"Bullshit! Always flirting around with all the male knights... putting on a show!"

Both sides took distance, this time making for a battle of magic. While Lilim fired an endless stream Cattleya channeled magic into her sword, sending shockwaves to contend in a mid-range exchange.

"I'm just being courteous! I have no interest in the men who approach me after just looking at my face and body!"

"Still bragging!? Just like that, you act 'courteous' with all the popular men, that's why the other female knights hate you! Haven't you noticed how they avoid you in training?"

"... Don't screw with me! The other women all hate you for putting on airs! When you've left the break room, it becomes the world smack-talk competition, I tell you."

The dragoons spewed abuse as they fought. The high level of their battle only made the contents of their conversation seem exceedingly wasted.

"I-in the first place, what do you even like about that brat..."

"Like you... like you could understand my feelings! Unlike you, I couldn't care less about pedigree or money! I just... want to get married!!!"

On Lilim's scream from the heart, how is that any better? The question crossed Cattleya's mind.

"I just wanted a happy household... and because of these eyes, it would never come to me. As if you could ever understand how I feel!!!"

"I don't understand, and I don't even want to! Marrying someone you don't even like..."

As Cattleya mumbled out the last words, Lilim,

"What are you dreaming about? Think there's some prince on a white horse out there for you... pff."

At Cattleya's surprisingly innocent side, Lilim burst into laughter. Lilim's laugh that said more than any words could brought Cattleya to her limit.

"You're... you're dead meat!!!"

"I've been trying to kill you for a while now, dumbass!!!"



"... Hey, Rudel. I don't think I want to jump into that fray anymore..."

Approaching the two in battle, Rudel and Eunius' feet suddenly stopped as the conversation entered their ears. Rudel had stopped to judge his timing, but Eunius was clearly drawing back from those two.

"Is there a problem, Eunius?"

"I mean dude, you want to save *that* woman?"

As Eunius pointed at the two, he looked into Rudel's face with a serious expression. At the end of Eunius' finger, the intense cursing exchange of the dragoons contained some indecent phrases men would hesitate to say.

"Of course! I'll definitely save her."

"Hah... fine, got it. I said I'd help out... I'll resolve myself. Hah..."

Eunius redid his grip on his claymore as eh began running off in Cattleya's direction. Rudel regripped his sword as he headed for Lilim, but... he did feel a little anxious.

(Please hold out just a little more.)

His own sword had fundamentally reached its limit in its exchange with Lilim. From the feel of it in his hand, the slight difference from usual was one he could only tell after using it for so long. But even so, Rudel knew. This sword was at its limit...



The moment Lilim and Cattleya's war of abuse was to enter close range once more. On Cattleya's side Eunius, and on Lilim's Rudel. They jumped in between them to bring a stop to their battle.

"...! What do you think you're doing!?"

Cattleya cried out as soon as she saw them, while Eunius gave a bitter smile and explained. As he had heard that previous conversation, Eunius' face was

needlessly stiff.

"Well just hold on a bit, Mrs. Dragoon. My pal said he was going off to save his fiancée, and he wouldn't listen to what anyone would have to say... so could you give him a moment? If you say no, then I'll have to keep you company a while."

Eunius pleaded in a tone as if he was hitting on her. But from Cattleya's point of view, the people she saved were getting in her way. It wasn't something to rejoice over.

"Are you sane? Even if you're the eldest son of a Three Lord house, there are things you can and can't do."

And you're one to talk? Eunius thought as he put power in his sword to indicate his will not to let her go any further.

Cattleya took a leap back from him to make some distance.

"Even if you manage to save her... senpai, no, that dragoon will be..."

She was certainly in for some serious punishment. So Cattleya wanted to say before closing her eyes once and taking another look at Eunius and Lilim, conversing with Rudel behind him. Unlike before, Cattleya couldn't feel any hatred welling up towards him. She undid her stance to watch over the two of them.

Chapter 41

In the act of jumping in-between the intense fight of two dragoons, Rudel and Eunius had achieved splendid success. They had succeeded, but therein lay the problem. The difference between an active dragoon and Rudel- who while strong, was still a student- remained too great. Lilim made sport of him with her dagger, at times pressing him back with magic attacks.

"The real deal really is different!"

In contrast to Rudel's slight delight, Lilim was seriousness itself. Within Lilim, a dark and squirming emotion welled and spoke to her.

'Kill him! The fiancée who betrayed you... kill Rudel!!!'

"I'll kill you! I'll definitely kill you!"

Thinking of their difference in physique, Rudel's larger male build held the advantage. But from body motions to experience, Rudel was lacking in too many fields. There was no excess in Lilim's movements, and her magic activation and accuracy had been polished to the limit.

A difference in experience irrelevant to power tormented Rudel. But even so, Rudel fought on to save Lilim. He was to save someone much stronger than him. Yet Rudel had the resolve to go through the pain to fulfill it.

In Rudel's heart, he heard the voice of Lilim's dragon.

'Child of man, what is your intent? Could it be you actually intend to save my contractor? I appreciate the thought, but if you seriously care for her, then slay her! If she lives on, all that remains is suffering.'

To that dragonic voice resounding through his heart, Rudel remained facing Lilim, the dragon to his back as he called out.

"Taken over and tormented so... convinced that no one will ever recognize her! That's not how it should end!"

As Rudel smashed his sword into Lilim, the blade was parried by her knife. With flowing movements, she skillfully redirected the force.

"So you're even trying to take my dragon this time... just like that, everyone always leaves. It's always like that, because I'm repulsive! If you hate my eyes, just say it! I'll gouge them out at once and become the sort of me you like! So... so please don't abandon me!!!"

Lilim's black eyes shed tears, and Rudel looked at her in sorrow. Right, Lilim's form resembled the original Rudel who never dreamed of dragons. A certain something he sensed made for another reason he couldn't abandon Lilim.

The original Rudel was a side character made to be hated, only to die a wretched death at the onset of the story's endgame. Unrecognized by all, everyone would leave him. Deserted by his fiancée Cattleya, he incurred casualties to the country as he fled and pleaded with the empire to let him defect.

As a result, an imperial general cut him down like trash, and he became the laughingstock of the imperial soldiers. To the very end, a wretched small-fry side character. But even Rudel had an important role to play. The event of him being cut down by the enemy general was the event that signaled the start of the final chapter.

Rudel's death commenced the story's finale. That was already set in stone, the will of the world.

While Rudel didn't know anything about that, something in his heart pulled at him. Perhaps that was precisely why he was so desperate to save Lilim.

"It's the end! I'll kill you and die myself!"

As Lilim rushed in with knife and magic, Rudel pulled off his pant's belt and held it in his left hand. Rudel's sword was approaching its limit; he had a bad feeling about it. He wouldn't be able to fight for much longer. He wouldn't be able to put up a fight empty handed... As Rudel thought that, he also took action to bring it to an end.



From a little ways away, Cattleya and Eunius watched over the two. But Eunius took just a little distance from Cattleya. Cattleya was sure he was still wary of her. But the man in question,

(Why does this woman smell so bad?)

He was unable to stand the smell of Mies' smokescreen.

"... It's going to end soon. I'd appreciate you didn't stop me this time. Otherwise, Rudel-sama will die..."

"Ah? That guy ain't dying. Up until he becomes a dragoon, that guy's got no intent to die."

As Eunius answered full of confidence, 'what sort of basis is that!' Cattleya's eyes seemed to say. To Cattleya, Dragoons were just another division of the country's knights. While their characteristics stood out, she was well aware the country only saw them as a convenient knight force at their disposal.

Ideals ran contrary to reality... rather than the dragoon the country yearned for, the high knight that protected the important personnel of the country was more blessed in his work. Away from the front lines, if you could gain the trust of royalty as a guard, then promotion wasn't a dream.

In contrast, the dragoons' workplace was much too dangerous. And even if you earn the crown's trust, that trust would only have you plunged into even more dangerous work.

"What's there to yearn for? What's there to dream? When you don't know a thing."

Hearing Cattleya's murmur, Eunius breathed a sigh as he watched over Rudel's fight.

"... Values vary from person to person. Rudel knows of the dragoons' duty, and he understands how they're used. And he still doesn't give up... that's why I'm able to root for him."

After a look at Eunius' profile, Cattley returned her eyes to the battle.

"I'm jealous... maybe that's why I hated him so much."

Rudel who could continue pursuing his dreams. Cattleya felt herself envious of that part of him. Her dream had been to become a girly princess. But reality had her born to a mid-ranking noble, the talent she showed from a young age making a knight of her.

Those talents that were enough to make everyone around envious of her were ones she never wanted to begin with. If she was able to discard them, she would have done so at a moment's notice. Yet swords took over her gardens, and sturdy steel covered her dress... to Cattleya who was raised in such a way, Rudel was too bright.

She who lived just as she was told, and Rudel who pressed on towards his own dream. Cattleya's eyes watched the two of them square off.



The belt in Rudel's left hand wrapped around Lilim's right arm to seal it. With that, both sides could only use one arm, and forcefully brought into close combat, Lilim changed her knife to her left hand to cut at Rudel. Rudel caught the blow with his sword, but

"Aha! Doesn't look like you can use that sword any longer."

Just as Lilim said, a crack spread across sword Rudel had used to learn every trick in the book. Rudel could see it as well. Lilim didn't let that moment's distraction go to waste. This time, she pushed him down and started shaking the magic wings on her back. As she did, the vibrations and a detestable sound assailed Rudel.

"Kuh."

Rudel tried to escape from that position. But to make matters worse, even her knife began to vibrate.

"It's a technique I rarely get to use in battle, but... how about that? I can cut through iron like butter. I'm going to slowly slice through your sword and into your heart."

As Lilim said, her vibrating knife was slowly eating its way into Rudel's sword. And the moment just before the blade would've been completely cut through, unable to stand the oscillations any further, the sword let off a shrill sound as it snapped. Letting of sparks against the knife, it violently broke.

But at the end of the end, as if to protect its master Rudel, the point of the blade flew towards Lilim's eyes. What's more, at point blank range. It was something she wouldn't be able to move, and Lilim was forced to move from the spot. In that gap, Rudel recovered his stance and pinned her to the ground.

The force of being pushed down caused the knife to part from her hand, and thinking she would be killed by Rudel mounting her, she quietly closed her eyes.

(That's enough. At this point, dying here would be...)

"Open your eyes! You're there, aren't you?"

At Rudel's words, Lilim opened her eyes. As she did, she found Rudel staring deep into her black eyeballs. And she let words flow from her mouth. Irrelevant to her own will...

'How far will you do hinder me? If only you kept quiet... if you did, the story should have gone on without a hitch! And this time the world will protect you? Going as far as to push me aside, the world will choose you!?'

Within Lilim's confusion, Rudel went on with labored breath.

"I don't know who you are, and I don't know your goal. But you see... if you're going to cause any more trouble around me, then I can't just stay silent!"

"Ha HAHAHA!!! You make me laugh. To think you'd care about your surroundings. But just remember this. The world may have recognized you, but that is only to guide you to your end. No matter how far you go, you shall never find reward. Just like me, you'll be abandoned by the world."

Rudel faced the culprit borrowing Lilim's mouth through her eyes.

"And what of it?"

'... What?'

"Who cares if some world abandons me! Even so, I'm not alone. It's always been like that... someone's always been by my side. There are people who support someone as selfish as me. Who'll recognize me! So I'll recognize Lilim and I'll recognize 'you'. I'll say you can exist, you can be here. Now what?"

Saying that, Rudel gently kissed Lilim's forehead. Perhaps it was the sort a parent gave a child. But to Lilim who wanted to be recognized by others, it was more than enough to calm her heart.

"Thank you... Rudel." 'Even so, for me, recognizing you is...'

Two voices escaped Lilim's lips before she fell unconscious. As she drifted off, a black mist exuded from her body. Once the fog cleared, her blackened skin and silver hair returned to white and blond.

And lifting her up in his arms, Rudel started carrying her. That form was the very essence of a pretty woman in the princess' cradle of a young knight.

Seeing that scene, Cattleya felt just a little envious of Lilim.

The wind dragon freed from the red dragon's grasp approached him. The ground shook under the stride of its large build.

'Child of man... you did not honor your promise to me.'

"I'll save her. I'll give a report on this incident as well, and I'll make an earnest plea to my house to borrow their power. So could you give me just a bit of time?"

Rudel still wouldn't give up, and as he had even saved its contractor, the wind dragon couldn't say anything. It looked up at the sky.

'Looks like my comrades are close...'



From Cattleya's report and the investigations of his subordinates he'd brought along, the dragoon vice-captain thought he had to give up on Lilim. In the few hours since he landed... his first impression that this was the worst still remained largely the same.

Intended harm against the three eldest sons of the Three Lord houses, and with various other charges, heads would surely fly. Physically. Yet to the vice-captain who thought that, Rudel reported with sparkling eyes.

As Rudel reported nothing but the truth, he didn't even try to advocate for Lilim in regards to what she had done. But he lowered his head to the vice-captain as he spoke.

"Can't you do something to save her!? She's my fiancée."

As Rudel lowered his head, the vice-captain was troubled to no ends. He also wanted to save Lilim, who still had a future ahead of her, but that didn't change the fact she caused a problem. And it wasn't just Rudel. Even if Rudel's house tolerated her, he couldn't think the other high nobles would stay silent.

"I appreciate the sentiment, but... when the scale's grown so large..."

As the vice-captain struggled for words, Eunius who'd watched over him and Luecke called over.

"I don't mind at all. If I told my old man I got to fight a dragoon, he'd just boast about it."

"I don't care either. I'll write an appropriate letter to my house."

On the words from the two, Rudel's eyes sparkled. But those three weren't the only injured. Basyle and Vargas were hurt as well. Sensing Rudel's feeling, Vargas who borrowed Basyle's shoulder nodded.

"I'm fine, let's just say I hurt myself fighting an ogre."

"Vargas, are you sure?"

"This is just a favor, Rudel. You're going to return it someday."

As the vice-captain looked around, the five of them lowered their heads.

"I can't promise anything, but I'll do all I can to obtain clemency for her. We'll transport you to the town so... hey, Cattleya, you get over here too! ... No, nevermind."

Cattleya awkwardly approached the vice-captain. She also intended to take these five to the nearby town, but... the smell she gave off stopped all in their tracks. Heartlessly, even her dragon took some distance from her.

"This isn't my fault I tell you! That woman, damn you, imperial scum!!!"

Chapter 42

The death match with Lilim over, Rudel's party was delivered to the nearest town on the vice-captain's dragon. While six people on a single dragon's back did feel narrow, Rudel was in high spirits all the way. The vice-captain of the knight brigade he so looked up to was going out of his way to transport them, so there was no helping his delight.

"Sit still, Rudel. From here on's the hard part. With me and Eunius, if we send a letter home, they'll move to some extent. But when it comes to your house..."

In regards to Luecke's strained and muddled last words, Rudel answered with a bitter smile. Luecke and Eunius knew of Rudel's household environment. When he was supposed to be the next head of the house, they were unnecessarily... no, abnormally harsh on him. That harshness wasn't something carried out with his future in mind. It was something there simply to give him a hard time.

It was unthinkable Rudel's house would move from a single letter. On the contrary, it wouldn't be strange if they moved in complete opposition to Rudel's will. That's what Luecke thought.

"It'll be alright. Father and mother, they're good at hushing up these sorts of things... they aren't too concerned about me, so perhaps it's best I don't send a letter. I've been writing to them ever since I got to the academy, but I only get form letter-like ones back."

Eunius prodded his elbow into Luecke for turning the conversation towards something dark. And up to the town, they spent their time in a bit of an awkward air.



In a town near the border, Mies wrapped herself in a tattered rag as she walked down the main road. The rag itself smelled terrible, but Mies also reeked of the smell of the smokescreen she used to escape.

"Goddammit... I managed to retrieve the confidentials from the inn, but isn't telling me to get out a bit too rude? And all the shops are way too cold to me! I can't even do a bit of shopping... this is why I hate the kingdom!!!"

The scented smokescreen had helped her escape from the dragon. But Mies knew they would use that very stench to track her down. She stuck out like a sore thumb. She stank!

"I'm hungry... I want to eat a sizzling steak... ow!"

As she walked with her eyes to the ground, Mies collided with the person walking in front of her. 'Twas Rudel who had returned to the town. Vargas and Basyle had made for the hospital, while Rudel was on his way back to the inn with Luecke and Eunius, a bunch of freshly grilled meat skewers bought from a nearby stall in hand.

Her eyes locking on, Mies' stomach let out a grand rumble, and Rudel smiled as he took one skewer out and presented it to her. To Mies, Rudel looked simply radiant to her. But,

"One skewer is five ces."

"You're charging me!?"

Mies cried out. Reluctantly producing money from her wallet, she exchanged it with Rudel for some precious food provisions. Luecke and Eunius looked at her from a bit of a distance... due to the smell.

"You wanted to buy them but they wouldn't let you, right? Your monologue was so loud I could hear everything. Of could it be you wanted me to treat you?"

"Eh!? F-from what point did you hear?"

"From when you said you were kicked out of the inn, I think. Well, I don't think there's any helping it with that smell, but... I recommend that you stop shouting out your hatred for the kingdom. The knights are real tense right now, so they'll drag you off in no time."

Mies hurriedly thought over a way to get out of town. But her stomach was still empty, and crossing the border in her current state was bad. Wanting some more provisions, Mies drooled as she looked at the many skewers in Rudel's arm.

Seeing that, Rudel tried handing over the entire bag of skewers to her.

"Fifty five ces for the lot."

"...! G-got it! I'll buy them all! I'll let you sell them to me!"

Not knowing if she was embarrassed or happy, Mies handed the money to Rudel, and just as she was about to take the bag, she looked at Rudel's face. Becoming even more ashamed, Mies looked away... but that was her mistake.

Mies' hand slipped, what's more, in her hurried motions from her embarrassment, what Mies' hand grabbed... was Rudel's pants. To make matters worse, Rudel's belt had broken in his fight with Lilim. As Mies pulled with good momentum, Rudel was caught off guard. And as a result...

"W-what are you doing!?"

"Eh? ... Gyaaaaaah!!!! Dragooooon!!!"

Mies ended up pulling Rudel's pants down in their entirety. With his lower half fully exposed, Rudel could only panic. What's more, on top of Mies having taken a long, hard look at him, the girl herself had taken flight with the bag of skewers... Luecke and Eunius were distanced, leaving a pantsless Rudel behind.

As an even greater turn of ill fate, it was Cattleya's turn to enter the stage.

"So this is where you were. The vice-captain told me to transport you to the acade... wait! What do you think you're doing!?"

"N-no! My pants were just pulled down a moment ago."

Saying that, Rudel pulled his pants back up. Cattleya sighed, but she had also taken a calculated glance at Rudel's lower half. Losing interest in a fully clothed Rudel, she looked around only to find some document-like forms scattered around. Concluding they were surely Rudel's, she started gathering them up as she complained. But then she noticed.

"Good grief... I'm not sure what happened, but please do treat documents more carefully. Once you become a knight, you'll be forced to write up so many you'll hate the sight of... what are these?"

Taking a slight glance at their contents, Cattleya held her suspicions. They detailed something of an observational diary, but the way they were written and the lettering intrigued her a bit. After reading on, she found her explanation for the movements of the imperial soldiers in this incident.

"That's not mine. Those papers were dropped by a girl. Hah, I'll have to deliver them to her."

"We're giving chase. What are her characteristics!?"

"Eh? ... She smelled terrible, I guess?"

Hearing those words, a smile leaked across Cattleya's lips. It was by no means a gentle smile... dark, a ferocious smile as if she had encountered a fearsome foe. Seeing that smile, while she smells, I guess Cattleya is a beauty as well, or so Rudel thought an irrelevant thought.

(That imperial woman who put me through such shame... I'll definitely find her and put her on the rack!)

"I'm going to chase after that woman, so you three return to the inn."

Saying that, Cattleya ran from the spot. And finally, Rudel was left alone.

"... I guess I'll go back to the inn. More importantly, Luecke, Eunius! Quite laughing and help me out."

Pushing their way through the onlookers who had gathered before he knew it, Luecke stiffling his laughter and Eunius laughing grandly made their appearance.

"N-no, my bad. It was just so sudden I was late to react."

"Going half-naked on the main road... as expected of Rudel. I've got to tell Izumi about this sometime."

"W-wait! Why are you bringing Izumi up?"

The three laughed as they returned to the inn. By the documents Mies dropped, Lilim's crime had become lighter, but they would only learn that after they returned to the academy.

The empire had been conducting battle tests on their weapon known as a strengthened ogre. And while it may have been a coincidence, she had saved Rudel's party that had become the test subjects. With that fact in place, Lilim got off with a severe demotion and house arrest. Rudel himself forgave her murderess exchange after the ogre was slain, and as they were in a betrothed relationship, it was eventually overlooked.

But with this incident and their actions up to now, Carrleya and Lilim's engagements to Rudel were both officially annulled.

Chapter 43

It happened a little while after Rudel returned to the academy from the town on the border. Vargas was hospitalized in the infirmary. His arm's injury was terrible and he required treatment even after he got back.

And once they returned, the eldest sons of the Three Lords were all called out by the academy's headmaster. About the dragoon Lilim's breakout, and the empire's experimental ogre.

"You've brought some troublesome things back with you. In the years since I first came to this academy... no, since this academy's founding, rarely have we come across students who've caused so much trouble."

Before the slightly worn-out headmaster, Rudel felt apologetic. After receiving a hush and various information manipulating orders, the headmaster and the teachers were breaking their bones on the punishment of these three.

Surprisingly, the houses besides the Arses House didn't have anything particular to say in regards to the matter, so that made matters somewhat easier... As expected, the Arses House alone said to punish Rudel abnormally for it. The evasive exchanges continuing on, the headmaster put to work by the palace had his share of trouble.

"Hah, even if you were just dragged into the mess, just look at what's happened. The three of you will be receiving a week of house arrest each. Because the official statement is that you were rescued from your dangerous plight by Lilim and Cattleya, the two dragoons... well, just use it to rest your bodies."

To the headmaster who was sighing often, Rudel posed a question.

"What about those two's punishment?"

"As it's become that they saved you, the problems they've caused up to now were written off. It's spread around quite quickly... while the Diade and Halbades House have given tacit content, this matter is something of an open secret among the nobles and royalty. With the empire's experiment, it doesn't look like they can make these matters public. From what I've heard, it's because the Arses House alone issued a protest that the two of them have received minor disciplinary action."

"It's a good thing it's only minor, right Rudel?"

At the headmaster's answer, Eunius closed one eye and smiled at Rudel. Luecke let out an enervated sigh as he looked at him.

"We're also being subjected to that minor disciplinary action though."

In contrast to the two, Rudel felt mildly depressed learning that his plea letter to his house had been of no use at all. When he said he would save her, what really helped her out was the approval of Luecke and Eunius' houses, alongside the fact the empire was conducting experiments. Rudel hadn't done a thing.

"... Well, you students don't have to worry about it. For now, that is."

Leaving the headmaster's room, the three of them headed for the disciplinary room of the boys' dorm.



Rumors of Rudel had spread through the academy. Of all things rumors that he had taken on a subjugation request at the border, failed, and had to be rescued by dragoons. As such rumors spread, the academy's reactions were largely divided in two. The first, did Rudel do something again? Something like that, and if they had to say, then they thought of it no more as another page being added to Rudel's heroic epic (lol).

But the second sort was a problem. It was a reaction largely from the new students who didn't know much about Rudel... some easygoing nobles tried to earn some pocket money and ended up in disaster. Is how they saw it.

To the commoners and demi-humans who were oppressed on a daily basis, life—or-death jobs were what allowed them to live on. They couldn't stand a student taking them on half for fun. And a central figure to the new students called Fritz was another large factor.

Some such students holding their dissatisfactions gathered in the cafeteria for lunch. Fritz included, around six students ran their mouths loud enough for the nobles eating separately to hear. This was only permitted because starting with Rudel, Luecke and Eunius suppressed the young nobles trying to crush Fritz.

When Fritz talked smack of Rudel for the world to see, of course, the other noble students were irritated. When Rudel heard of it from his former classmates, he cautioned them not to raise a hand. For Luecke and Eunius, it was Rudel's problems, so they gave similar orders to their own followers.

The fruit of their efforts tied into the events of the cafeteria.

"Nobles sure have it nice. If they're ever in trouble, the dragoons swoop in to save the day." "When it comes to Rudel, isn't he the worst problem child since this academy's founding? Even that guy can have a stable future, so you really are a winner if you're born to a noble." "Doesn't Rudel have a little brother? That guy's brother is apparently a piece of trash who abandoned the princess in the school outing."

Unluckily, class scheduling prevented any student outside the fundamental curriculum from being present in that cafeteria, and without any existences to contain them, those final words became the trigger. As a second year of the fundamental curriculum, Chlust naturally heard it all.

"... I dare you to say that again, pauper."

Standing from his seat, Chlust ignored his followers' calls for him to stop as he glared at Fritz. Receiving his gaze, Fritz stood as well. To Fritz, the

Arses house was the most unforgivable of houses. He himself hailed from Arses territory, and tormented by heavy taxation, he had gone through considerable troubles to earn the money required to attend the academy people usually entered at fifteen two years late.

"I'll say it as many times as I must. The Arses House is a pile of trash... I'm saying you and Rudel are trash."

Fritz also stood and returned the glare. A number of fellow commoner students stood as well, enveloping the cafeteria in a peculiar air.



In the boys' dorm disciplinary rooms, Luecke was reading an after meal book, while Eunius was endeavoring through muscle training. This was no longer anything you could call discipline, and to add to that Rudel was training his spiritual concentration. Closing his eyes, he controlled the flow of mana through his body.

... The first time the supervising student saw, there was surprise to be found. In the first room, a man taking on a fearsome training regiment. In the second, a man silently reading through mountains of books filled with difficult contents. And the last room was filled with mana just by its resident sitting in its midst.

When it came to Rudel, he was sitting in a cross-legged meditation position Izumi had taught him. Perhaps because of that, the supervising student was sure he had been influenced by a popular book of eastern mumbo jumbo he had read a while back and added it onto his training.

"Erk... someone swap with me! The next time I come around, I'm sure I'm going to see something even scarier, Rudel looks like he's going to start floating just sitting there, but... h-he's not floating, is he? But it's Rudel we're talking about here..."

To the student who periodically made rounds to check on them, the scene was only abnormal. After a while passed and the supervisor went away, Eunius called out to the two of them.

"Hey, move a bit, why don't you!? Just because you're in this room, if you quit moving, you're going to ruin yourselves."

"Don't group me with you. It goes without saying that the proper quantity of exercise and food is more appropriate! Eating loads from dawn 'til dusk and doing nothing but muscle training... how about you study for a second?"

Luecke returned some cynicism. He turned to Rudel and called over.

"More importantly, what are you doing, Rudel? I've been feeling mana seeping through the walls for a while now."

"... Unity of soul and body."

"What's that? Will doing that make you stronger?"

This time Eunius jumped in. At first, it was a serious conversation, but things gradually seemed to stray, until eventually...

"I really think it comes down to the breasts, but what's your take on the matter? You won't say you like them small, right? I'll correct such heresy!"

"Are you an idiot... it all comes down to balance. It goes without saying the overall balance is important!"

"Ah, Izumi's coming."

"Eh?" "What?"

As they carried on a trifling conversation, Rudel sensed Izumi approaching the disciplinary rooms. It was abnormal for Rudel to sense her before she had entered. And as Izumi wasn't showing up, they were just about to conclude Rudel had lied, when...

"There's trouble, Rudel! Your little brother Chlust and Fritz are...!"

"... She really came." "You sure you two aren't connected or something?"

Luecke and Eunius confirmed Izumi slam open the door with intense momentum. They felt impressed that Rudel had sensed her approach. But Izumi's air was considerably strange. She was in a flurry, and as she had run her way here, was it something important? They thought.

"Did something happen?"

Rudel calmly asked.

"Chlust and Fritz are fighting in the school cafeteria! It gradually grew worse and... it's become a feud between the commoner students and the nobles, a majority of the upperclassmen are away today on extracurriculars, and there are too few teachers around to contain it."

It really was bad luck. That day was one where the periodic required extracurricular lessons were held, and a majority of the upperclassmen were attending them. There were more students than the average attending, so the teachers had to match that and dispatch a large portion of their numbers. Izumi had remained in the academy because Rudel was unable to intend through his house arrest, but...

Everything was starting to motion much too conveniently.

Chapter 44

The school cafeteria had been destroyed by the students of the fundamental curriculum. In the kitchen, the staff members late to run cowered as they made their way to the deepest parts, while the teachers who entered from the cafeteria's main entrance had gotten into controlling the situation. But the commoner and nobles students had already reached the limits of their patience.

"I told you not to raise a hand!" "So you'll save the noble! Teachers are enemies after all!" "As if I could let the matter end with me belittled by a common imbecile! Shut up and watch!"

The first and second years of the fundamental curriculum had divided up between commoner and noble, using the cafeteria tables and chairs in their intense battles, and it had grown beyond what the teachers could handle. With their lack of numbers and the combat-oriented teachers off with the upperclassmen, the remaining teachers were classroom centered.

In such a classroom, the ones who constituted the center of this quarrel were Chlust of the Arses House and a commoner boy called Fritz. At first, both sides had started the fight with their fists, but once it looked like Chlust was going to lose, he took out the knife he carried on hand. From there, Fritz went into the magic he had only just learned, and accepted a wooden sword his friend had brought over to fight Chlust.

"You indigent excrement! Don't think you can live on, mocking nobles all the way...your family and all the people around you shall be killed"

"Just because you can't win, you lay hands on the people around me... you nobles really are the lowest of trash. Up until I came to this academy, I

worked as an adventurer. I know just how dirty you folk are, and I know what I have to do!"

Knocking Chlust's knife aside, Fritz put a kick into his stomach and slammed him against the cafeteria wall. As some students raised a cheer at that sight, the noble students were pissed.

With the case of Chlust abandoning the princess the year before, he had lost the trust surrounding him. But there were a number of young nobles who abandoned her, and as they were rarely criticized for it on the surface, his followers still stuck with him. Even so, this situation worsened the attitudes towards Chlust even further.

'A noble disgrace who can't even beat a commoner.

The nobles fighting around looked on Chlust with cold eyes.

(Why... why are you looking at me with those eyes!? Why was so wrong? Why am I losing to the likes of this commoner...

Unable to get his thoughts in order, Chlust tried to get back on his feet, when Fritz started knocking him about more than necessary. Fritz had chosen the path of beating him so badly he wouldn't even think to get back at him. All around the demi-human students usually looked down upon hit the nobles around and blew them away with magic.

It was true madness. At the entrance of the cafeteria where such hysteria spread, the teachers and a portion of students lost their minds as the remaining upperclassmen who caught wind of the ruckus began to gather. Rather than the textbook teachers, hope was gathering on those upperclassmen.

And of course, Rudel was included among them.



Hearing the situation from Izumi and released from the disciplinary room, Rudel's party of three made their way to the dining hall. At the entrance,

they could hear the voices of teachers and the rampaging students within. Perhaps from their heightened tensions, even the teachers cowered at the jeers tossed around.

Seeing that circumstance, the one to take the vanguard was Eunius. While he was usually classified as a sociable noble, once he was angered, his tempered large build and fearsome face struck fear into the hearts of all. The other upperclassmen opened a path for him and followed behind.

"Move."

Receiving Eunius' flare, the underclassmen went through a moment's surprise, but even if they were dealing with an upperclassman, they thought they had the numerical advantage, and didn't even try to step down. The students who fell unconscious a moment later... were blown away by his fists.

The students sent flying around the entrance caused eyes to gather on the upperclassmen making their way into the cafeteria, and the hall was enveloped in silence for a moment. Eunius at the lead, then Rudel and finally Luecke, seeing upperclassmen step in one after the next, the students of the fundamental curriculum were gradually gaining an understanding that they had done something terrible.

On the entrance of the Three Lords' eldest sons, the nobles stopped their squabbles. But that's not how it went for the commoners. The students who just enrolled that year were especially lacking in knowledge when it came to Rudel and the others. Those underclassmen could only work under the foolish preconceived notion that these were the idiotic nobles that had to be saved by the dragoons.

"So even the upperclassmen are joining in? Then so be it... I'll be able to take Rudel down before my third year. For you who can only hold his head high in these academy walls, I'll teach you that thing called reality."

Fritz turned his wooden sword towards Rudel. The subjugation jobs he had carried out to that day let him hold confidence in himself. Unlike the academy's students who only learned theory, Fritz truly was strong. To Fritz

who thought to become a knight once he left, his life here was no more than a game.

The fact the princess attended was another reason Fritz commuted to the academy. He had come to attempt to change the country called Courtois from the inside. Forging relations with those who would become the next generation, he held an ideal of making a country of his ideals. But no matter how you looked at it, his methodology was terrible.

Fritz had done jobs all over to learn of the world, but he only held common sense of a narrow scale. Crying out that nobles were evil, his thoughts from the standpoint of an adventure that would earn money as long as they had strength tied in with his actions in this incident.

His ideals were splendid, but his methods were bungled. That was the boy called Fritz. A child with nothing but strength had lined up pretty words and pushed them through with brute force.

Not knowing any of that, To Rudel, Fritz was the sort of existence he should be protecting from his standing as a noble. He didn't particularly think anything of the boy's belittling comments. He was actually more irritated at Chlust for laying a hand on Fritz. But even Rudel had to revise his thoughts after looking around.

In the kitchen, the aunties who would often throw in a bonus slice for him were shaking in fear, and even the teachers had been injured. The dining hall everyone used was in disorder, and it wouldn't be usable for a while to come. Here and now, were Fritz' actions any different from those of a bandit? Rudel was rapidly losing his interest in Fritz.

"... I've no interest in you."

Saying that, Rudel passed by Fritz' side and headed for Chlust.

"What are you doing, Chlust? And you call yourself a noble aiming to be a knight?"

"... Don't mock me! Trash like you has no right to look down on me! This is all your fault. If only you weren't there, I'd never find myself here, and I'd never lose to the likes of him!"

Chlust wept as he screamed out in vexation. His eyes were fearful as he looked at Fritz who tormented him. As Rudel had heard the gist of things before he came to the cafeteria, he turned back to Fritz and cut into conversation.

"I'll apologize for the trouble my brother has caused you... but you've gone too far."

"...! Like you're one to talk. How about you say that to the people suffering under Arses rule."

Fritz returned words of cynicism. Just like that, he lowered his wooden sword towards Rudel... Rudel didn't even try to dodge or block. Fritz hammered in a few more blows, but Rudel didn't even flinch. The wood sword was the first to break.

"W-why..."

Fritz was surprised at the lack of effect of his own attacks, but without paying a hint of mind to that, Rudel declared for all to hear.

"Bring a stop to this idiotic ruckus. If you wish to continue, I'll take you on seriously next time."

A fearsomeness different from Eunius' had put a stop to the students' quarrels.

Chapter 45

Once the fundamental curriculum uprising died down, Rudel and the others were released from the disciplinary room. The reason was simple, the disciplinary room was now at full capacity, and the teachers called this a special measure instituted for stopping the riot. While Eunius rejoiced, he was the only one who had remedial lessons waiting around the corner, while Rudel and Luecke went to pay Vargas a visit.

Izumi accompanied them, and as the three of them headed for the infirmary, they were greeted by the delightful form of Vargas being fed fruit by Basyle.

"He sure has it easy at a time like this."

Luecke peered in from the entrance. Izumi watched and wondered if that was how people saw her and Rudel... she warmly watched over them. But Rudel boldly entered that dimension of happiness.

"Are you okay, Vargas? So the two of you got along that well... anyways, there was something I wanted to consult with you on."

"... Rudel, you're amazing."

"Yeah, it's Rudel after all."

Luecke and Izumi awkwardly entered behind him. Vargas panicked with a reddened face, but Basyle just grinned.

"T-this is, umm... right, well, that's how it is."

While Vargas tried to give an excuse, Rudel cut right into his main point.

"The truth is, what I wanted to talk about... I'm troubled because I don't know how I'm supposed to treat my brother. Can you tell me what I'm supposed to do? I heard you had lots of siblings, so I thought it might serve as reference."

Alongside the cafeteria incident, Rudel explained how his little brother Chlust seemed terribly afraid. In fear of the first year Fritz, he had holed himself up in his room. Once he had explained that much, Vargas was surprised such an amazing instant had happened while he was hospitalized, but was even more shocked to find Rudel ignoring all that, instead coming to consult on his brother.

"You don't get along with your siblings, right? So I don't think there's much meaning in comparing my family to your relationship with Chlust, but... more importantly, what are you going to do about that first year Fritz?"

Vargas seemed mindful of Fritz and the first years who caused an incident of this level. They had gone too far, but even if they had gotten high on their horses, they were fellow commoner students. Surely he was curious about the punishment in store for them.

"I'm not really interested so I'll leave it to the headmaster. And it's not something I can decide. So how should I interact with Chlust?"

After thinking a bit, Vargas couldn't reach an answer so he started talking about himself.

"Hah, this'll just be about me. I've looked after my siblings, and I'm close to both my little brothers and sisters so I doubt it will serve as good reference, but... if they did something bad I would scold them, and if they came home after losing a fight, I'd teach them how to fight."

"You didn't lend them a hand?"

"No, wouldn't it be strange if I came out into a fight between little ones? And kids are fighting all the time, you know. So if when my little brother was irritated he lost, taught him how to fight and don't lose next time! I cheered him on."

Hearing that, Rudel thought up something. Basyle tried asking in wonder.

"Chlust-sama is going to graduate this year, right? What reason do you have to care about him? I don't think it's revenge, but..."

Rudel and Chlust's relations were terribly twisted. Warped enough it wouldn't be strange to see them as noble siblings fighting over the position of future archduke. Basyle couldn't understand why Rudel would care about such a person. Izumi was also curious.

"I think you should stop getting involved with him, Rudel. You've both got some things to think about, and while I don't think you'll raise a hand against your little brother after he was scared so... what are you trying to do?"

"Yeah, I was thinking to help him back on his feet before graduation. The way things are going, he won't be of any use after he's sent to the borders, and in the worst case, it could lead to his death. Chlust is loved by my parents... I don't want my family to be saddened."

On those words, Luecke felt a slight sense of unease.

"But didn't you say your parents hate you? Do you really have to care about those sorts of parents? My parents were strict, but that was to make me first-rate. I don't get the feeling yours are like that."

While four pairs of eyes gathered on him, Rudel thought just a bit before answering.

"I'm thankful to the parents who brought me into this world, and on top of raising me, they're even letting me go to this academy. It's just as Fritz said, I really am blessed. It's definitely painful to be hated... but hating Chlust for it seems wrong."

Having heard out Rudel's feelings, while they couldn't quite grasp it, they didn't oppose it either. Vargas posed a question as a representative.

"So what are you going to do with Chlust? This is incomparable to just teaching him how to fight."

It was a question tinged with jest, but Rudel was serious.

"No problem. I'll teach him how to fight one on one, and the opponent is also decided. In order to overcome fear, rather than defeating the foe who instilled it, it is more important to win against yourself, or so I read in a book... after the fundamental curriculum's interclass tournament, I'll have him fight Fritz."

Izumi was opposed. Saving Chlust was nice and all, but she didn't see any good coming out of dragging Fritz in.

"W-wait Rudel! Fritz is no good. I'm sure he'll receive a harsh punishment for this incident, and his abilities are too far above Chlust's."

Luecke supported her.

"I'm also opposed. That guy made light of us a few times too many. Enough for even Eunius to get pissed... if Fritz' punishment is too light, the other nobles aren't going to accept it."

Rudel listened in and thought.

"So facing Fritz is impossible... no helping it. I'll give up on Fritz and just train him up, I guess. No, perhaps I can pit him against Eunius?"

"Chlust is going to die..."

Vargas breathed a sigh as he put in a retort.



Perhaps Rudel's houghts had got across, or Fritz was simply lucky. Through a certain individual's infiltration of the academy, Rudel's wish was to be granted. That individual was the first princess Aileen, and the main heroine of the story. Her interest in her little sister Fina and the academy were the cause.

As Fina had cried out in the previous year's tournament, she wanted to see with her own eyes what sort of life she was living in the academy. From there, she altered her plans, and on that very day when the riot was raised, she was in Fina's room surrounded by high knights, enjoying a cup of tea with her sister.

"You look well, Fina. I wasn't able to say it last time, but it looks like your life in the academy has become a good opportunity for you."

To her big sister's warm smile, Fina answered her true feelings. The elder sister Aileen had some hopes for all sorts of expressions to spread across her expressionless little sister's face.

"Yes, sister... this academy is the best place ever."

(Nothing but fluff and happiness! I really wanted to flirt and fluff up Mii today, while I consulted on how I'm supposed to capture master, but... it's because you snuck in that I never got to!)

"I heard you had someone you liked... father said it was that Rudel boy, but is that true? That has to be a joke, right?"

"... No, it is true. He has given me the cold shoulder but even now I am trying to earn his favor."

(Because of that black hair, my path to fluffadise is... I'll definitely lift that petting ban and make master my own! Even so, good job father! With this, I can begin bridging the gap between us.)

But Aileen's expression suddenly changed.

"Fina, I cannot permit you to love a man like that. Barbaric and selfish... I heard he even went against father. I'm against it! While father and mother don't seem to mind it, we're dealing with one of the Three Lords, so even marriage is possible."

"I'm aware."

(That's what I'm aiming for. This isn't love or anything like that... this is fate! There's no doubt the heavens are telling me to set course for a fluffadise of my own! If it's for my dreams, I'll sell my soul to the almighty fluff!)

As they carried on such a conversation, the high knights suddenly started a ruckus. Wondering what was going on, the two inquired to the situation, and

"It seems there's been a riot in the school cafeteria. A commoner boy and the second son of the Arses Houses got into a feud... it seems Rudel-dono has contained the riot, but the academy has requested we keep on our toes."

"Oh my!"

"... Is that so?"

(The hell are you doing, Chlust? Bringing trouble to master's hands... more importantly, the commoner boy is probably Fritz, master's enemy, right? That guy doesn't do things halfheartedly.)

"I cannot forgive two brothers ganging up to bully a poor commoner! I shall talk with him directly. Gather those involved at once!"

"Eh!?"

(What's she on about? Even if they were feuding, no one said anything about bullying, right? Just because you hate him, you're having your image of him take priority? What's more, the one who quelle things was master. As I thought, master really is unlucky.)

After that, she wouldn't hear Fina;s explanation that this was a misunderstanding, and Aileen went off to meet Frits. It was a fateful meeting. And this meeting would come back to torment Rudel in the future...

Chapter 46

The day after the riot in the cafeteria... Chlust was shaking in his room at the dorm. Since that day, everyone would look down him. The nobles would call him a disgrace, while the commoners called him an enemy, their eyes full of scorn. Chlust didn't go to class, trembling had become the most he could do.

"Each and every one of them just doing whatever they want!"

Wrapping his blanket over himself, Chlust called out. At that moment, the locked door was forcefully kicked in. There, Chlust's big brother Rudel stood with the dorm's supervisor. Chlust had lost the key to his room once before, so he was using the supervisor's copy.

Rudel had tried to enter the room, but that reason prevented it from opening, causing him to take some rather forceful measures. The supervisor put in a word or two. After Rudel said he'd foot the repair fee, the supervisor nodded and left.

"... Chlust, get out here."

"W-what do you think you're doing? Out there? Don't just enter my room. You get out!"

In his confusion, Chlust ended up crying out loudly. Hearing that, Rudel... forcefully lifted Chlust up and dragged him out of the room. Going out into the boys' dorm yard, he tossed Chlust aside. He had prepared two wooden swords, and he tossed one of them towards him.

"Pick it up Chlust."

"So you too... you hate me so much? Each and every one of you comes to bully me..."

As he mumbled some complaints, Chlust didn't even try to look at Rudel. More than that, he was lightly shaking. Forcing Chlust to his feet, Rudel grabbed him by the lapels.

"From today forth, I'll be training you. I've already gotten permission from the academy and the house, so your resistance is futile... prepare yourself, Chlust!"

What a fearful Chlust saw was Rudel's serious face. His fear telling him he couldn't go up against that seriousness, something of a will formed to make him reluctantly take a stance with the wooden sword.

That day onwards, Chlust's days of harsh training began.



A few weeks later, in the renewed academy cafeteria, Eunius and his tagalongs appeared at the table Luecke and his followers ate. As Eunius boldly sat in front of Luecke, Luecke's followers tried to complain but stopped. His face was serious, and his atmosphere was clad in a spot of rage.

"There are a few things I need to ask. It seems this and that happened in my remedials..."

Cutting off Eunius's words, Luecke started into conversation.

"About Fritz? He punched Aleist's friend who was hitting on girls or something and Aleist beat him up so he's been hospitalized. At first, he just stepped in to mediate, but once he learned his friend carried no fault, he got serious... he's quite the immature one."

"Wrong! Not that... wait, Aleist punched Fritz!?"

Eunius bit onto the story with Aleist. It wasn't what he originally wanted to know, but he had some interest so he asked Luecke.

"It's famous, you know? He had intended just to tease. I'll repent, but I won't regret, is what that Aleist said, it seems."

"I see, that's cleared up my mind a bit... more importantly, why wasn't Fritz punished!? And then there's Rudel! Is it true he withdrew from the second term's individual tournament!?"

Luecke looked at Eunius' tagalongs, he found them looked around awkwardly. While they were talking about the events during his remedials, Eunius suddenly rushed over to him, or so Luecke concluded.

"You musclehead... It's your fault for being bound so long. With Fritz, he was acquitted in his meeting with princess Aileen who had snuck in. It's a real problem when an oblivious princess who knows nothing of the circumstances seriously hears out the boy's drivel. I feel sorry for Rudel, but this year, he's attending the minimum amount of classes and spending the rest of his time on his little brother... looking after Chlust."

Hearing that and unable to accept, Eunius slammed his fist against the table. The students in the cafeteria turned to look at him, but minding them not, Eunius continued on.

"He could at least go to the individual tournament! More importantly, what does the academy intend by acquitting Fritz? Did they think we'd just stay silent?"

"It's the princess' order... Princess Fina was against it, and the academy was as well. Neither of them has stepped down... there isn't a soul who accepts it. But Rudel's lost interest in Fritz... in that case, then it's a right opportunity to get Chlust back on his feet he said and argued and argued."

Luecke laughed as he spoke. While Rudel had no interest in Fritz' punishment, he was thinking of Chlust. Rather than staying scared of Fritz forever, he wanted to give him an opportunity to get back up.

"When Fritz heard he wasn't interested and flew into a rage, it was a sight to behold. So he put out a condition... in exchange for fighting Chlust, he'll get to fight Rudel as well. Ain't it a laugh?"

"I'm not laughing! If that's what's made Rudel withdraw from the individual tournament, there's no way I can laugh! Can't he at least do something about the second term tournament? He can't keep uninterrupted supervision of Chlust forever, right?"

Luecke felt Eunius's irritation at the fact he couldn't fight Rudel. It was an emotion Luecke couldn't understand.

"If it's a match, you can ask him anytime, right? Chlust is going to graduate this year so he doesn't have any time."

"You just don't get it... fighting in the arena before a full house. There are fights that can only happen in that sort of space... it's a chance you only get once a year"

Even after hearing that, Luecke couldn't understand, so he gave up on understanding. Even for Luecke, it was problematic that Rudel wasn't attending class. He had no friends he could talk about magic with. Rudel was a valuable existence who could respond to his jokes.

When Luecke joked around, no one would understand, and the man himself was seriously troubled. As Rudel was able to comprehend, for both Luecke and the people around him, Rudel was a precious treasure.

"You'll have to give up on this year. You've got Aleist, so it shouldn't be a problem."

"Wait, you're not taking part either?"

"Of course not. I'm busy with my magic research... it's not going as I hoped."

Luecke breathed a sigh as he thought over his experiments. Not Eunius, if it was Rudel, he'd be able to discuss it, he thought...



In the girls' dorm, Izumi seemed entranced by the katana Rudel had given her as a present. Pulling the blade in her room, Izumi's face flushed red. For someone who didn't know the circumstances, it was undoubtedly a scene to strike fear. Izumi's roommate called out to her.

"A present from Rudel? Even so, it's got no romance to it."

"Yeah, but it's a really, really nice katana. I can count on my hand the number of blades I've seen of this caliber. There's the fact that my house is a fallen one, but I really am happy. And while it seems it wasn't that expensive, this really is a nice find."

Izumi seemed delighted. While her roommate hadn't noticed it, the katana presented to Izumi was worth more than its weight in gold. While Rudel had managed to buy it with the money he saved in monster subjugations, it was a katana worth enough to build up a house.

"He said the blacksmith was a fellow oriental, so I'd like to meet him someday."

Chapter 47

With the incident that had embroiled Princess Fina a year before, the second term's fundamental curriculum outing was put under review, and it was altered to be a camping excursion. A safe campout by the riverbed, and Fina was moved and aroused as she took on the event. What was carried out in the midst of that two-night-three-day camp was the individual tournament of the upperclassmen.

From classes and relevant grade, the competitors were selected, and the students who received the qualifications to take part would carry out one-on-one matches over the course of two weeks, but... this year, the centerpiece Rudel had withdrawn. When you thought of how it was generally the fourth year students who took part, Rudel had plenty a chance at the title.

With Rudel's abstention, the final match came down to a pairing of Eunius against Aleist. The two who had won on with their abilities and social status, a rare sight in the finals, a battle of close combat unfolded. It was something so grand as if to clear away their resentment for all the past matches they had to hold back in.



"Give it up already, Aleist!"

Swinging his personal claymore-modeled wooden sword, Eunius launched a stream of attacks at Aleist. As the wooden swords met, they birther a violent sound alongside the impact. In contrast to Eunius' surprising finesse, Aleist clad his magic sword in wind and tried to brute force his way through.

"Why aren't you being sent flying!? Normally, you shouldn't even be able to lock blades with this bad boy! Unlike last year, I've been working hard to increase its output!!!"

Parrying Aleist's powerful sword strokes, Eunius fired off a strike with all his might. Receiving that blow from Eunius' blessed physique, Aleist was sent spiraling through the air... but even as he flew, Aleist fired consecutive shots of magic down.

"Dammit! I can't lose until I can face him again... go to sleep!"

Blown back a little from the magic, Eunius looked at Aleist. But having recovered in that moment, Aleist managed to regain his footing, channeling new magic into his blade. His wooden sword let off a crack as lightning coursed down it.

"You're not the only one who can't lose!!!"

Seeing that, Eunius gave a ferocious laugh. Letting his own mana rest in his blade as well, both sides put all their might into that blow...



"And so you're both hospitalized again... I can understand that the victory Eunius has serious injury, but Aleist really is weak to pain."

Looking at the two resting on their beds, Luecke let out a sigh. Eunius who stood after an intense clash was declared the victor, while the unconscious Aleist became runner-up. Eunius glared at Luecke, while Aleist averted his eyes.

"When you didn't even fight, you're one to talk! More importantly, Rudel is at Chlust's place again today..."

"Yeah, I was just a step away... I worked really hard, and yet... everyone around's growing crazy strong."

Ignoring Aleist's murmurs, Luecke answered Eunius with only a nod. Over the long weekend and second term, Rudel only attended the bare minimum classes. He was chipping away his time training Chlust.

"Chlust was supposed to be strong, right? That Fritz wasn't anything special, so did he really have to go that far?"

Aleist muttered the question he held from the two's conversation. Hearing that, Eunius informed him.

"While you were away, Chlust was beaten black and blue. I don't know if he's strong or not, but that kid's gone-case. Feels like his heart's been shattered... if he sees Fritz, he starts shaking, and he can't do a thing."

"That's probably why he's being trained so harshly. Rudel's too soft on his brother... he was soft on his sister too, right?"

"Erselica? I don't think they really got along, but... (So that part's changed to? In the game, Erselica got along better with Chlust than Rudel)."

"No it seems he has a sister called Lena from a different mother."

Hearing that name from Luecke, Aleist tilted his head. Among the people from the game that used this world as its stage, he had never heard of the 'character called Lena'. A hidden character who never appeared? Or a character who existed in setting alone? As he thought over such things,

"... Come to think of it, I've never heard of Fritz either. Did I overlook him because he was a background character? But there's no way he's background if he's got connections to princess Aileen... I really should stop thinking about it like that. But in that case, the event that comes right after this will..."

"Aleist is mumbling to himself again... he says some incomprehensible things from time to time."

Eunius looked over Aleist- mumbling in deep thought- and let out a sigh. And until Aleist's friends came to visit, he continued thinking to himself.



Having become a third year, Millia went to see her elder sister Lilim. For an elf fallen to darkness, a full recovery was more difficult than she had imagined. Even if she stopped being a dark elf, her heart was corroded. As Millia stopped by her sister's room on her day off, she asked in worry...

"Are you alright? It's been quite some time, but..."

In contrast to Millia's worry, Lilim nervously averted her eyes... having recently learned that Millia liked Rudel, she had begun to feel a sense of guilt towards her little sister. Having come so far, she finally realized she had been engaged to her sister's crush, making things a little awkward.

"D-do you resent me after all? I got into an engagement with the guy you liked, what's more, the engagement was broken off... but my forehead, he... kyah!"

While she was a little irritated, Millia had prepared an anti-Lilim trump card.

"G-glad you look well. But since the engagement was annulled, it's meaningless, right? And are you sure you didn't repulse him, showing off your dark form?"

"Y-you! To think my little sister would say such a thing! Though it's true I caused him some trouble..."

And sensing its contractor's felings, the wind dragon apologized. For a contracted dragon, even at a distance, dragoons could communicate with their hearts.

'I'm sorry, Lilim... if only I'd breathed some flames when I defeated that ogre.. but even for me, black flamres are impossible.'

"N-nooo! Even my own dragon's digging out my old wounds!! Just let me forget! I don't want to remember any of ittt!!!"

Seeing that, Millia laughed a bit inside, but her big sister's form had become a bit pitiable. To the elves who usually kept level-headed, dark elf periods were the greatest embaarrassments of their lives. There were even some who through down their lives over them, so family would usually take a set distance to heal the wounds of the heart.

Thinking there was no helping it, Millia conveyed some good news.

"Hey, about the third term's fundamental curriculum class tournaments, want to take some days off and come over to play? It seems a first year called Fritz got into a feud with the Arses House, so there's going to be a match after the tournament as well. Rudel is going to have a match against Fritz, and if it's at the academy, don't you think you'll be able to apologize to him for back then?"

"... Millia, what a wonderful little sister you are."

'I'll come as well. I have to give that child of man my thanks.'

"Thought Cattleya-san's coming too."

As Millia said that with a smile, Lilim sensed something in the air.

"Cattleya is coming? She was working out on the border, but... can I even get a day off? Adjusting work schedules is a pain, you know? Taking a break without any considerable reason will be a problem and... n-no, it's not like I hate Rudel or anything"

"Don't worry. The truth is, I was asked to come here. In the year below mine, there's a girl from the white cat tribe, and that girl's best friends with the princess. According to her, the princess wanted you to come just in case something happened."

Lilim thought a bit before asking the reason. And there, she found out that Fina's elder sister Princess Aileen was going to sneak in, and as this wasn't an official visit, she would have fewer guards...

But that was just the surface reason. Fina knew her elder sister would be coming with plenty of high knights and guards. From an incident from times gone by, Fina knew her elder sister's guard detail was rarely ever reduced. And if anything terrible was to happen, she wanted to gather those with favorable feelings towards Rudel.

Not that Lilim or Millia knew anything about that.

"Is that a job?"

"It's not. I mean, there's no money involved. But you'll be able to meet Rudel. And if it's the princess, Princess Fina's request, then isn't that enough of a reason?"

On those words, Lilim decided to take some days off for the class tournaments. Fina doubted anyone would go as far as to investigate the knights stopping by the academy on their days off, and that on her mind, Fina was also preparing for what was to come after the tournaments.

Chapter 48

"Hah, hah, why do I have to do something like this."

Chlust did pushups as he glared at Rudel watching over him. Pushups if he opposed, pushups if he slacked off... A hell that went on regardless of holiday or school day, Chlust uttered complaints as he was left with no choice but to obey. He tried launching surprise attacks on Rudel a number of times, and sent letters home to beg for salvation.

But from the house, 'Just do it', was the only response he got back. When he got a letter saying he didn't need to come home over the long weekend, Chlust turned quite despondent. On the other hand, a change was occurring in his home Arses House as well. While the fact he caused problems was the same as Rudel, the problems Chlust caused were related to the face of the house.

His conduct in abandoning the princess, and the fact he holed himself up after losing to a commoner... his parents had also abandoned him and chosen to prioritize Rudel, who was liked by the king. All the actions they had taken against Rudel suddenly inverted at the drop of a hat.

If Rudel wished it, they accepted and denied Chlust their help. Rudel himself had wondered whether his house would forcefully come to take him, but they were much more approving than he had expected, to an extent it was even creepy.

"There's no time to the match, Chlust. Once you're done with that, next is..."

Chlust had a match with Fritz right after the third term's class tournaments. The thought alone frightened him.

"... Like hell I can win."

Not to Rudel, he muttered to himself. Hearing that, Rudel made a conflicted expression. He was training Chlust up, but even if he strengthened his body, his heart remained in pieces. He had shouted at him a number of times to forcefully get him to train, but once talks turned to Fritz he would instantly cower.

"You're fine with ending this at a loss?"

Chlust wouldn't answer Rudel's question.

"I won't tell you to win. But don't run away... if you run, I definitely won't forgive you."

Chlust couldn't answer to that one either. He simply continued his pushups in silence.



The second term over, it was just about time for the holiday to end... Basyle told Rudel she would resign. While Rudel tried to stop her, once he heard out her reasons, he gave his approval.

"There isn't anything left for me to teach you. And Vargas proposed to me... the plan's to get married after his graduation. So I think I'm going to quit my job this year."

"R-really! Then we've got to celebrate. I have to think up a gift..."

The sudden development did surprise Rudel, but as her employer, he did want to congratulate her. Basyle had seriously been a big help when it came to magic, and Vargas was the first friend he made since he enrolled, his big brother-esque comrade. As Rudel thought, Basyle proposed a certain thing.

"In that case, I do have a single request. I want to get my husband the tool of his trade, a 'shield'. Ever since he broke it last year, he hasn't been able to get one of his own."

Basyle knew Rudel would do something even if he told him not to give gifts or celebration, so she made a request for Vargas' shield. In that case, she could end the matter with only one gift for the two of them. She thought.

"That's fine and all, but what about for you, Basyle?"

"Rudel-sama, the shield of a shield knight is expensive. That's more than enough for the both of us, so..."

Basyle spoke with a broad smile. Rudel also thought over this and that... and nodded. He thought to arrange for a shield at once, but Rudel had no weapon dealers or blasmiths under his wing. To be more precise, it never occurred to him to use his house's connections. And the one he decided to ask was...

"Not Eunius, but me? ... Sure enough, the Halbades House has a few proficient ones, but a shield, eh..."

Rudel consulted with Luecke who had just returned from vacation. But to the Halbades House that valued knowledge over military exploits, it wasn't impossible to prepare a shield knight's shield, but it couldn't be recommended. If he wanted a weapon no matter what, it would end up being an expensive, ornamented decoration piece.

Luecke wanted to answer his friend's request. There, he thought of something.

"If you want a skilled blacksmith, I do know a guy. It's not like I'm employing him, but I did have him make a few of my magic research tools so I can guarantee his skill."

"Can he make shields as well?"

"He's a former blacksmith, so you don't need to worry. So are you using the shield? Or is it going to be Chlust?"

Luecke immediately started drafting up an order letter to the smith.

"No, it's for Vargas. He's going to marry Basyle soon, so I wanted to send it as a gift. Vargas is going to be stationed in the outer regions, and I think Basyle will be following him?"

Luecke's hand stopped as he thought for a bit. Thinking of Vargas' personality, and instantaneous decision-making, as well as the fact a magic specialist like Basyle was becoming his wife...

"I see... then I'll also chip in for that gift."

"I don't think that'll work, Luecke."

"No, it's not a problem. The reason being Vargas' employer is going to be me."

While Rudel tilted his head, Luecke started writing a letter addressed to his own house as well. There's a talented shield knight, and I want to hire him, he wrote. In his head, he put together his own magic theories and the existence of shield knights. To use the spells that required complex magic circles he had been drafting up for some time, it would be easier if someone carried a tool inscribed with the sigils from the start.

"There are few shield knights in existence. They don't stand out, and it's difficult for them to earn medals... but just hiring one would be a problem. If they're of no use, then there's no point in keeping them."

"That's right."

"But what if I have one hold a shield inscribed with a magic circle, and have them take charge of magic? With the leadership skills to change formation in an instant... Rudel, the era has come for the value of shield knights to change!"

"Y-yeah!"

Rudel had a general idea of what Luecke was trying to do, but he felt some pity for Vargas who was essentially becoming Luecke's test subject. Since it

was Luecke, he wouldn't do anything life-threatening, Rudel imagined the tests and training would be harsh indeed.

Between being appointed on the border and taking service under an archduke, the latter was definitely more welcoming. With that in mind, Rudel mulled over what was best for Vargas.



Around that time, Basyle had gone out to town to prepare a gift for Rudel. In the previous year's events, Rudel had lost his sword, and even now, he didn't possess one for his own personal use. That wasn't a problem on school grounds, but thinking of what was to come, Basyle concluded it best he had one and decided to find one for him.

She went to consult the old man who bought and sold goods, but,

"A sword? No matter what type it is, the price will be on another level if you want a good product. You've never used a sword before so you might not know, but melting down a mana-imbued iron ore alongside monster bones is the trend these days. If you want to do it that way, the price will jump up... what's your budget?"

Basyle presented her funding on her fingers. The old man breathed a sigh.

"As if you could buy a sword for a future archduke with that kind of money."

"Can't you do something about it!?"

"I do want to do something to congratulate you on your wedding, but with that money... you'll have to make due with a normal sword."

As they carried out that exchange, a single man entered the store. As the door opened, the bell's jingle resounded throughout, followed by the broken words of a black haired orient.

"Heard there was rare monster tusk, in this shop... could you show me?"

"Yeah, I do have one lying around. Are you a foreigner? I was troubled because I couldn't find any sellers. If you'll buy it, I'll give you a bargain."

As he was that, the old man sent a look at Basyle. Basyle understood it was the 'tusk of back then' she had sold to the man.

"That is right. I'm working as a smith in a town near the border. I wanted to work with my partner to make a weapon that could attract some visitors before we opened up a shop. I have been looking all over for some interesting materials, and my search has brought me here."

Hearing that, Basyle had an idea. Open up shop, meaning he wasn't that famous yet. In that case, he would want the prestige... thinking that, Basyle offered the proposal.

"Hey, Mr. Blasksmith, would you hear me out..."

And like that, Rudel's sword was to be made with the 'tusk of back then' as its base. It was from the first black monster Rudel met, and an item with a deep connection to him.

Chapter 49

There was barely any time left in the third semester. The academy was in a flurry with graduation and preparations to accept the next batch of new students. And the time had come for the Arses house to fulfill its promise with Fritz. The first princess Aileen dropped by the school, and alongside her in the noble visitor room, Fina also ended up watching the duels.

There were more students gathered in the arena than there had been for the class tournament, the guest seats largely divided between noble and commoner. The students rooting for Fritz cheered loudly as they sent their encouragement, while jeers and heckles flew towards Chlust standing opposite to him.

"Rip him a new one Fritz!!!" "Chlust, quite shaking and say something already." "Don't lose to some noble halfwit!"

The student body held an overwhelming majority of commoner students. In the noble side audience seats, the young nobles gathered around Luecke and Eunius of the three lords as they loathsomely watched over the situation.

To Eunius' side, Aleist sat with his friend, while Izumi was next to Luecke. Rudel was standing near Chlust, and as he was next to the ring, he didn't have an audience seat.

"Chlust sure is the popular one."

Luecke read his book as he gave a sarcastic comment on the arena's atmosphere.

"No, you sure they aren't just taking out their anger against all of us? Did you know? Because this guy beat up Fritz, people are thinking Chlust had him beat the hell out of him in his place."

"Y-you're wrong! I definitely did beat him up, that had nothing to do with Fritz and Chlust."

After gazing uninterestedly over the ring, Eunius pointed at the restless Aleist to his side and laughed. Aleist hurriedly gave an excuse. Izumi listened in on that exchange as she watched Rudel looking at Chlust.

"I hope this ends without incident, but..."



In the noble visitor room, the two princesses each gazed at the men they were rooting for. Aileen gave a warm smile to Fritz standing on the ring, while Fina expressionlessly stared at Rudel outside it. The high knight guards and headmaster also watched over the students from there.

"Ah, Fritz-sama... he's definitely going to win, right?"

While Aileen confirmed it with the high knight to her side, Fina,

"Sophina, by your judgement, who do you say will win?"

"Yes, I believe the commoner student called Fritz holds the advantage. It seems Chlust-sama has trained, but they started off from different foundations. I believe it would have been difficult for him to catch up in a space less than a year."

"I see..." (Not that I care. Honestly, it's no problem to me whether Chlust or Fritz loses. As long as master gets through his fight safely, then all's well! Even so, she's totally lost her integrity... even if it's my sister we're talking about, isn't that a huge problem?)

But hearing Sophina's words, Aileen asked for her evaluation on Rudel. She held a high evaluation of the high knight who stayed at the academy as Fina's guard, and she wanted to confirm Fritz's victory. But...

"Yonder high knight, by your eye, who shall win the following match? I'm sure that man is strong, but Fritz-sama has trained considerably."

"If I may, your majesty, my lowly opinion is but a..."

While Sophina was hard-pressed for the right words, the expressionless Fina laughed internally as she enjoyed the situation.

(Just say it! Tell her how you rate her beloved Fritz-sama! When he was beaten up by Aleist, and Aleist lost to Euniuss, tell her how master is the strongest! Well, if you do, she'll remember your face and name and harass you!)



Atop the ring, the two competitors faced one other, exchanging glares through the deafening cheers. To be more precise, in contrast to Fritz' glare, Chlust was averting his eyes and shaking a little.

"Do you know how long I've waited for this day? This resentment I've built from all my childhood, oblivious to how your people may suffer under the brutal taxation, I'll teach you nobles playing around a lesson."

Fritz took a stance with his wooden sword, and Chlust prepared himself as well. Once the referee standing between them signaled the start, Fritz stepped in and lowered his sword at Chlust.

"L-like I care!"

Chlust blocked the lowered blade, but the next attack was already ready for him. Fritz swung his wood sword freely in all directions, and Chlust could only take it.

He blocked and dodged, but above all of that, Fritz attacks would reach his body... Rudel simply watched it happen.

"Both you and your brother are trash! Just how many suffering people do you think there are in your lands."

With those words, Fritz' lowered sword knocked Chlust off his feet. Letting his sword leave his hands, Chlust collapsed and Fritz gave pursuit. Not only

with his sword, he started kicking him with his foot.

"What's that? Say something! To all those suffering, tell them I'm sorry, or it was my fault!"

In only a few minutes from the start, Chlust was in tatters... but without a word, he stood to his feet. He went to pick up his sword only to be kicked by Fritz again. It was a one-sided development. The nobles lost their initial cheers, watching the match in silence.

"... Apologize? Then you apologize first."

"What?"

Chlust clung to Fritz' foot as he spoke. With rough breath, and with a voice barely anyone could hear...

"I-I'm telling you to apologize for calling my brother trash."

In that moment, he was kicked again. What flashed through Chlust's mind in that instant was his brother Rudel. When everyone abandoned him, Rudel was the only one who stayed to the end.

(My friends and classmates all look down on me. Everyone who sees me calls me trash... even father and mother won't properly reply to my letters. At the end of the end, my brother's the only one who never abandoned me!)

Since he lost to Fritz, everyone around had abandoned Chlust. But Rudel alone chipped away all his time to train him. And even now, he was watching over his match.

(Why... do I have to be so pitiful? I can't let myself look any more pitiful in front of my brother.)

Chlust desperately kept a grip on Fritz' leg. Kicked with Fritz' free leg and smacked with his sword, the match carried on. Plenty of Chlust's blood flew in that match, and the screams that came weren't small in numbers.



In the noble visitor room, Fina looked at her excited sister Aileen with cold eyes. Once she knew everyone's attention was focused on Fritz' achievements, she expressionlessly sighed at the ring she looked down upon.

(This isn't the fight of some hero of justice. How laughable that my sister's little prince charming is acting like a common thug. It's such a turnaround I can only laugh.)

That match that was practically the strong suppressing the weak, to Fina, it seemed almost as if it signified the power relation of the nobles oppressing the commoners. If looked on from one side, Fritz was righteous, and the Arses House was evil. But it seen through another's eyes... from standpoint of the country's law, the Arses House was the victim, and Fritz was an assailant.

In Courtois ruled by the royals and nobles, Fritz who pulled his bow against the grand noble Arses House was a criminal. And the reason he pulled his bow wasn't one the other nobles or royal line could accept so easily. The lords ruling over us have no qualifications to rule, was what he was saying...

(Even if the Arses House is a hive of scum and villainy, your Fritz on a white horse's methods are plain awful. From the air in this arena, it doesn't look like he has enough charisma, and he isn't looking at himself objectively. Without any talented people to compensate for his faults, Fritz Charming is nothing to fear.)

Just as Fina thought, the surroundings were pulling back at this one-sided match. No one could think of Fritz' fight as justice. Those who couldn't read the mood would eventually shout their jeers onto the quiet ring. But even so, the atmosphere was on a downward spiral.

(More importantly, that black hair! I hate her... sealing my master's petting with just a word, that damn vixen that's enraptured my master in her cage is, well, she's cute, so I guess 'black hair' is enough. Anyways, I hate you, black hairrrr!!! More than Fritz, this kingdom has to do something about black hair, or it will lose a national treasure!!!)

Fina gazed expressionlessly at Izumi, who was sitting with concern to Luecke's side...



The referee stepped in to stop Fritz' attacks against Chlust, who could no longer move. Confirming Chlust's unconscious state, the ref went on to declare Fritz' victory.

"Get up here, Rudel!"

As Fritz took a stance with his wood sword and cried out, Rudel draped the collapsed Chlust over his back and left the ring. That action irritated Fritz considerably, but,

"I'm going to carry my little brother. Just rest or something in the meantime."

On Rudel's line, displeased as he was, he stepped down from the ring and took some rest.

Rudel left the ring with Chlust over his back. Regaining consciousness over his shoulder, Chlust understood the fact that he lost.

"... Haha, after I tried so hard, I still lose in the end? I really have no talent."

As Chlust derided himself, he shed tears of frustration. Irritated at himself for not being able to land a single blow, and even after his brother was mocked, he chastised himself for only being able to cling onto a leg.

"When the time comes, I'll just face another unsightly loss, and drop dead in some ditch on the border."

Rudel silently carried him through his regretful sobs. But the place he brought him wasn't the infirmary. He brought him to the arena's guest seats, where Luecke and Eunius sat.

"I'm sorry, could you clear some space?"

Rudel pleaded to Luecke and Eunius.

"Rudel... why'd you bring him here?"

While Eunius sighed, he made some space between him and Luecke, and matching him, everyone in his row moved down as if sliding. And after he sat Chlust- beaten and red around the eyes- in that space, Rudel leapt down from the audience seats to the ring.

Fed up, Eunius called out to the dazed Chlust sitting to his side. It was an action carried out after sensing the awkward air.

"Have a good look at your big brother's fight. Awkward as he is, he's trying to do what he can for you... I won't tell you to get along, but at the very least, can't you recognize him?"

Hearing those words, he tried to say something, but swallowing those words, Chlust looked down at his brother and Fritz on the ring.

"I doubt it'll be an interesting match."

Luecke closed the book he was reading, turning his eyes to the two facing each other. Izumi sitting to his side also directed her eyes. But Aleist alone seemed caught up in those words.

"Not interesting? Fritz is fairly strong. I heard he trained a lot after I beat the living daylights out of him, you know?"

"Hah, that's why you can never overcome your walls. When you're ridiculously blessed, that's the part that's no good..."

Eunius breathed a sigh at Aleist. While he possessed magic that surpassed the realm of humanity, Aleist wasn't using it productively at all. Those around sent fed-up glances, holding much the same opinion themselves.

"W-what's with all of you!?"

Chapter 50

In the arena's noble visitor room, the princesses gazed at Rudel and Frits, who were facing and speaking to one another. While the princesses were rooting for different people, they were quite serious. Aileen gripped both her hands in front of her chest, while Fina expressionlessly thought...

(Fritz is done for!!! Now get your ass handed to you by master. And it's getting to be a right pain, so drop my sister's evaluation of you while you're at it! We have no calling for a Fritz who isn't even fluffy!)

Before the serious princesses, the surrounding high knights held conflicted thoughts. While they didn't let it show on their faces, Aileen's guards were displeased with the commoner Fritz' speech and attitude. As their princess loved him dearly, they could never say it.

Fina's guard Sophina had gotten a better grasp of Fina's personality lately, and she felt conflicted as well. It was impossible to imagine what Fina was thinking, as she never asserted herself, but there was no way it was anything decent. And seeing Rudel's serious face as he met eyes with Fritz, Sophina found her face heating up.

The hall had somewhat recovered from its previous stillness, and cheers were beginning to rise.



"Don't lose to some upperclassman, Fritz!" "Show him the difference in your ability!" "Teach him who's the strongest, Fritz!"

The underclassmen jeered while the upperclassmen hesitated to speak. A majority of the third years recalled their previous selves, growing irritated as they heard jeers directed at Rudel's class. The second years knew Rudel

had beaten Aleist, and they knew even now Rudel got along well with the second princess, so they didn't know what to say.

"Can you hear these cheers for me? ... These are the voices of the world, senpai."

Before the match began, the two spoke a bit. The ref read the mood, and thinking a little would be alright, he kept quiet.

"By shaping your mana, you can invoke a mock magic sword. And strengthening it further, you use it for defense... I looked into it. So I'll tell you... I've already reached and surpassed you."

"I see. More importantly, I give thanks in regards to my brother. If it's like this, it seems Chlust can still get back up."

Rudel didn't show much interest in Fritz' words. But he did have some gratitude when it came to his brother, so he gave some simple thanks. But that attitude irritated Fritz.

And the referee declared the starting sign.

Coincident with that, mana covered Fritz' body, and a large quantity of it flowed down his sword. At his form as if he was clad in sword and armor of light, the arena raised cries of surprise. At those armaments of magic, the underclassmen were excited as they grew convinced of their victory.

"This is my full power! I didn't even need to show it to your brother."

Fritz turned his wood sword to Rudel and cried out. But Rudel held his own sword in his right hand without taking a stance. Let alone a stance, he didn't even try to flow magic into the wood.

"You plan to make an excuse that you lost because you didn't get serious? There really is no helping you noble trash... in that case, repent all you want on an infirmary bed!!!"

In an instant, Fritz closed the distance and lowered his sword. But in that same instant, his body was slammed against the ring, Rudel's right foot

resting on his chest. No, trampling into it.

"Then use your full power to endure this."

Before Fritz could comprehend Rudel's words, he felt an immense impact through his body. And just as blood spat from his mouth, he lost consciousness.



Seeing the match that ended a few seconds from its start, Luecke and Eunius showed different expressions. Luecke was making a troubled face.

"Hah, it really wasn't an interesting match at all. He really should think about entertaining the guests some more... The high-level fighters might roar, but like this, I doubt the underclassmen will understand what happened."

After easily moving his body to avoid Fritz' haphazard attack, Rudel had used his left hand to grab Fritz' arm before tripping him up. Rather than falling, Fritz was slammed into the ring, and once Rudel pinned him down with his right foot... he commenced some sort of attack.

It was an attack intense enough to hollow out a round crater centered around the two of them... Fritz spat up blood from his mouth, lost consciousness, and the match was over.

"Interesting... that guy really is the best."

In contrast, Eunius' ferocious smile caused Aleist and Chlust sitting to his sides to draw back. While even Eunius didn't exactly understand what Rudel had done, that last attack was powerful enough for a cold sweat to flow down his spine. The friend he recognized had grown so strong while he wasn't looking.

"I can't wait for next year's second term."

While Eunius said that and rejoiced, Aleist sitting to his side averted his eyes as he held his head.

(D-dafaq!? I had no idea you could attack like that, and wait, what the hell was that!? The way I'm going, I won't be able to win against Rudel... what should I...)

Aleist felt depressed that the difference in ability had grown outside of his knowledge. Chlust looked at his brother standing over the ring, before losing consciousness from the relief. As he fell, Izumi stood from her guest seat to support him up.



There were two disguised dragoons mixed in among the crowds. A little dressed up, Lilim and Cattleya weren't able to hide their surprise at the match between Rudel and Fritz. It was only natural he had grown stronger after he'd fought them, but this was a growth rate you could even call abnormal.

The two of them contained their excitement over Rudel as they turned their eyes towards the noble visitor room. Sending their voices over to their dragons resting on campus, they got their preparations in order.

'That child of man, no, Rudel won, it seems. Are you happy, contractor?'
'Like for real!? I only heard the voices, but that was an instakill, right!? Just how freakishly weak was his opponent? What's more, after asserting his dominance so long in the match before... how uncool!'

They gave bitter smiles at their own dragons' responses. Lilim's dragon who would always call her contractor now called Rudel by name. Meanwhile, Cattleya's dragon had a bad mouth.

"Now then, is the princess alright?"

Cattleya looked between the noble visitor room and Rudel on the ring as she posed Lilim the question. They didn't particularly expect the princess to

take any unreasonable actions, but they were called just in case, so they had to keep cautious.

Atop the ring, Fritz was loaded onto a stretcher as the arena filled with an indescribable air. Those who couldn't comprehend the sheer difference in ability scattered cries of 'coward' and the upperclassmen had begun to boo those ignorant underclassmen.

"Doesn't look like she's giving the signal. But I did get to see something nice."

Looking at the visitor room, Lilim recalled Rudel's gallant figure as her face flushed red. Cattleya breathed a sigh as she turned to her senior.

"You're not engaged anymore, you know..."



Over in the noble visitor room, the two dragoons seemed so worried about, a bit of a ruckus was breaking out.

"T-that one didn't count! I can't accept a match like that!"

Unable to admit Fritz' loss, Aileen was raising a protest. But the result showed the unconscious Fritz' complete loss. It wasn't a loss through luck or ill fate. It was a complete loss of ability.

"No matter how many times you repeat it, the result won't change, sister." (Of course, it's impossible for your prince to defeat my master. No matter what you say, master is the man who'll become my husband in my pursuit of fluffadise... huh? Wait. Then isn't master a prince as well? How about 'Sovereign of Fluffadise'? Oh, I like the sound of that!)

Fina's expressionless, emotionless tone only made Aileen unnecessarily more irritated. As she knew(?) her sister's circumstances, she didn't stick in her mouth, but she felt great irritation.

"... I definitely won't forgive him."

No one could hear Aileen's mutter. Fina only stared expressionlessly at Rudel on the ring. Yet Aileen's mutter that even the high knights around her couldn't hear contained an emotion you could call conflicted.



The third term safely (?) come to and end. Discharged, Chlust had made his way to the academy gates. A carriage from the Arses House had come for him. It's an embarrassment, so don't go to the graduation ceremony, his parents had told him, and this carriage was one that would take him straight to the outer regions of the country.

From his loneliness and shamefulness, Chlust was full of anxiety, but even so, a few people had come to see him off. Starting with Luecke and Eunius of the Three Lords, there was Vargas and Basyle, Aleist and Fina surrounded by her guards. But Rudel wasn't there.

"H-hey, why isn't the big brother Rudel here? This is too awkward, and I have no idea what to talk about."

Aleist translated the atmosphere into words, but everyone only averted their eyes without offering any salvation. Everyone around had come thinking Rudel would be there. They had never even considered it might come to this.

Time passed in silent, and being mindful, some did try calling out to Chlust, but the conversations would never last. After such a situation continued a while, Rudel appeared alongside Izumi, a basket in hand. Aleist and those around him felt a bit irritated at the rosy air the two of them let off.

"You're late, Rudel!"

On Luecke's voice, Rudel scratched his head and apologized.

"S-sorry. I never thought he'd be going off without a stop at our house. I realized he might grow hungry on his way to the border, so I made some sandwiches in the dining hall."

Rudel held out the basket. Izumi carried one as well, and she went to hand it to the servants driving the carriage. Rudel's basket went over to Chlust.

"If Izumi didn't help me out, it would've taken even more time. I'm glad I met her along the way."

"If he had just told me, I'd have had it ready. Rudel acts on a whim too often."

Hearing their conversation, why aren't they going out yet? Some thought. Curse you black haaaaiirrr!!! Thought another.

"I-I don't mind taking it."

Chlust still didn't know how to interact with his brother, and even now he used an abusive tone as he took the basket. Rudel called over to him.

"You better survive, Chlust. Otherwise your dreams'll never come true."

Still not knowing what to say, Chlust made off towards the carriage. He had spent the day before thinking up what he wanted to convey, but he couldn't get it across at all. The surroundings smiled as they looked over those siblings. But where Chlust was headed was the border with the empire, a danger zone rife with monsters.

Perhaps they would never meet again. Everyone thought so, calling over to Chlust and saw off the carriage. Once the carriage had passed through the gate, Chlust leaned his body out the window and cried out.

"T-thank you brother!!!"

Until his brother's carriage was out of sight, Rudel continued waving his hand.



Noon came around, and once the carriage stopped for a break, Chlust opened the basket and took out a sandwich. There was also a small canteen inside, alongside misshapen sandwiches and some of tidy shape.

"H-hmm. These misshapen ones are definitely the ones my brother made."

Chlust said as he bit into one.

"H-how terrible... it's saltier than the salt of the earth."

Biting on in a trance, as Chlust washed it down with the green tea in the canteen, tears were flowing from his eyes.

"Thank you... thank you, Rudel."

Weeping and eating, he made just a bit of a happy face as he recalled Rudel's words.

"I'll survive, and next time I'll say thank you to your face... I'll definitely survive..."

Chapter 51: Extra: Surpass Marty

4

Extra: Surpass Marty 4

A room of the girls' dorm only nobles greater than the great houses could use; Fina, the room's owner hugged her knees on the bed as she silently mumbled to herself. Ever since Rudel's petting had been sealed, her fluffy life suddenly took a distance from her ideals.

At this point, only her best friend, the white cat tribe's Mii ever came to her room the play. Black cat Ness said Rudel was her only master, and wouldn't let Fina pet her. She also enjoyed Ness' cold attitude, and she had no complaints, but she had begun to yearn for the heavenly times she experienced when Rudel was here.

"That accursed black hair... if only she wasn't there, I'd be walking the path of fluffy conquest right around now!"

As Fina continued mumbling expressionlessly, her guard captain Sophina watched, drawing back within.

(What should we do. Both of this country's princesses are done for. One of them's obsessed with a commoner, while the other is definitely not paying the slightest attention to the country. We've only got two of them... we've only got two princesses, dammit!)

"That's right! I'll just kill her and take master for my own!"

"P-princess! You can't. Rudel-sama loves Izumi dearly."

Mii tried to soothe her, but Fina took out the knife tucked away in her desk. It was a poisoned knife she had once asked Mii to purchase for her.

"T-that's no good, princess!"

"Don't stop me, Mii. This is something I have no choice but to so!"

"Give it a rest, princess!"

Mii gently tried to talk her out of it, but her guard Sophina was cold.

"Why're you trying put on the good girl act? Looking at my master like a maiden in love at your age! Just notice it already!! If you want to flirt with master, your only choice is to assist me in constructing master's harem! If we do, then I can do this and that to Mii and Ness and... crap, I'm drooling. Anyhow! If you help me, I'll choose you as one of the mistresses, so lend me your hand!"

As Fina expressionlessly emphasized it, everyone present stepped back. Sophina imagined such a future in her head...

"B-but there are some things you just don't do!"

"You considered it, didn't you? You got your body hot as you imagined _____ master, you _____!"

She had hit the nail on the head, and Sophina had no words to return. But her mouth was too foul for a princess. She tried to caution her when everyone in the room suddenly collapsed, a black fog enveloping them.



"H-huh? What was I... wait, princess!"

Once Sophina regained consciousness, she found Fina collapsed on the floor showing the whites of her eyes. Gripping the toy knife she thought was poisoned in her hands, black hairrrr... she muttered in her sleep as she lay. Sophina found her a bit scary, but she had confirmed the princess' safety.

"Thank god. She's just unconscious. But I'd better take her to the infirmary... eh!?"

Her relief from confirming Fina's safety was quite the transient thing... Fina suddenly leapt to her feet.

"Huh? What was I trying to do?"

"P-princess, are you alright?"

Similarly, Mii regained consciousness as well. And Mii looked at the knife Fina held in her hands before bursting into tears and apologizing.

"I-I'm sorry, princess! That knife is a fake. I-I... didn't know where they sold a knife laced with poison, and I ended up giving you the toy knife the shop person pushed onto me!"

The high knights checked everything going in, so it was impossible to bring any hazardous material. They had already confirmed that toy knights, and the high knights were well aware of it. The only one who didn't know was Fina. But seeing Mii crying and apologizing, Fina spoke.

"It's alright, Mii. I'm sorry for making you go through such painful memories... I asked the impossible of you and made you cry." (How cute, how cute... as punishment, I won't let you sleep tonight. You'll be purring from dawn to dusk!!!)

Having forgotten about Izumi, Fina moved just as her desires willed it.

"Princess! Before that, let's go to the infirmary!" (And the psychiatrist while we're at it.)



Outside the princess' room, a black shadow crept up from the floor only to hide in the shadows of the corridor. Noticing something was amiss in the room, the high knights outside had entered, so they never noticed.

'T-those were some feelings so pitch black it was even repulsive. But with this, I've built up some power... Rudel, just you wait. This time, I'll kill you and return the story to its proper path... erk, I feel sick. This mix of fluff and lust is churning up my stomach!'

The shadow fled the girls' dorm in pain. Born from Cattleya, taken up by Lilim, and even now that black mist was gathering up hatred to try and kill Rudel. Due to the fact it had only gathered hate from women, it was starting to take on the shape and voice of a girl, and even now it hated him.

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Around that time, Rudel was in the infirmary. He was paying Vargas a visit. The graduation ceremony and parties over, in this short time where the fifth years could take it easy, Vargas was hospitalized. Traces of a blow to the face alongside bandages wrapped around his body left him as quite a pitiful sight.

"You get injured quite often, Vargas."

"Not as much as you."

After the party ended, Vargas received an attack from the other boys. There were various reasons. His marriage to the Arses House servant Basyle had been decided, and on top of that, his appointment to the knight brigade of the Three Lord's Halbades House had been finalized.

Not only did he make a wife of the beautiful older-sister-like Basyle all the boys looked up to, he had been promoted to a level a commoner could only dream of. While it was an employment with his abilities taken into account, normally, he would have to build up some experience first. A few teachers took part in the attack as well.

"More importantly, hear me out! Your shield's finally been completed! Luecke's bringing it over right now, so I just can't wait,"

"Hah!? I didn't hear anything about that!"

"It was my request."

Sitting next to Vargas' bed, Basyle smiled as she answered. Basyle had already given Rudel her gift sword. It was a fine piece using exceedingly valuable materials, and Rudel had rejoiced and felt bad and made merry some more.

"Y-you did?"

As Vargas' face flushed, Luecke entered the sick room. But his hands were empty.

"Mh, so Rudel's here."

"Yeah, I wanted to see the completed shield. I heard it was something amazing."

Hearing that, I know, right? Right? Said Luecke as he happily beckoned in the servants outside the sick room. Thereupon... three servants brought in a full set of armor alongside a large shield.

"W-wait a second. Isn't that armor?"

As Vargas spoke up, Luecke made a face as if to say, 'what're you talking about?' as he answered.

"Of course it is. A set of armor from my Halbades House's official knight brigade, and a special magic insignia shield I drafted up myself. It's an amazing piece... just listen to this, it makes use of five special metals to make for a light and sturdy finish! It cost a bit of a pretty penny, but it was worth it."

Hearing that, Rudel spoke.

"Huh? So you used five after all? Didn't you say five would go over your budget last time?"

"There was no helping it back then. I planned to hire him personally, but ever since father's interest was piqued, we've decided to take him on as an official knight. Because of that, our funding's increased, and we've even got around to modifying the armor."

Haring Rudel and Luecke's conversation, Basyle and Vargas' smiles stiffened up. The monetary sum that gradually came out was on another level. The two of them were finally starting to understand Rudel really was a high ranking noble. And at that moment, Eunius raced into the sickroom.

"Hey, no one told me! Why is Vargas entering that beansprout knight brigade at Luecke's place!?"

As Eunius burst into the room out of breath, Luecke coldly shot him down.

"While you lot were sitting back on your trophies, my house has been gathering worthy personnel for our knight brigade. And your place's muscle-headed knights don't need any talent."

"Bastard, you really are a detestable fellow! Shall we settle the score here and now?"

While their mouths were smiling, their eyes were completely serious. Basyle and Vargas sent eyes asking for salvation to Rudel as he smiled over Luecke and Eunius.

"I hope you two find happiness."

But the message didn't get across. He blessed them with an extremely nice smile, making it so they couldn't say anymore. But to the two of them, a goddess of salvation did indeed descend.

"What are you doing in the infirmary? You're troubling everyone, so you'd better stop. Rudel, don't just watch, you have to stop them."

As a fed-up Izumi entered the infirmary, Rudel quickly reacted and apologized. There, the two of them reluctantly stopped their fight. Vargas

and Basyle were relieved, but in the sickroom's entrance, a familiar individual was glaring at Izumi.

"W-when you're just black haiiirrrr!!!" "What are you doing, princess!? Hurry up and get yourself examined!"

Looking at Fina's expressionless face, Vargas and Basyle prayed for Izumi's happiness.

Chapter 52: Extra: Spring Sure is Nice

Extra: Spring Sure is Nice

The young elf girl Millia's long, green hair swayed as she walked. As she looked at the sky out the window, she could feel a warm sunlight, and the wind she received from that open window also carried with it a sense of kindness. Her third year had ended, and as the new freshmen came in, Millia felt she had somewhat moved up in the world.

"I'm not sure if it was long or short. More importantly, this result sheet is a surprise."

As Millia walked down the school building corridor, she took a sidelong glance at the bulletin board before stopping to think.

The third year final comprehensive evaluation posted up listed the names of the top ten students. And surprisingly enough, Rudel was first, with Luecke and Eunius coming after him. The comprehensive evaluation was something decided from academics, practicals and evaluations in challenges. While Eunius was devastatingly bad at academics, the fact he was there was largely due to his top marks on practicals and challenges.

And Luecke's academics were perfect, but his grades in practicals were only a little better than average. Still amazing, while they were each first in their respective fields, it was because of Rudel that they were forced into second and third as a whole.

His sword skills fell short of Eunius. His academics and magic fell short of Luecke. But Rudel's comprehensive evaluation was ranked first. You could

say he had few weak points. His course was a rare one among upperclassmen, whose grades usually inclined towards civil or military matters.

Izumi and Millia's names weren't on it, but their grades weren't bad by any means. Millia encouraged herself as she took her eyes off the posted sheet and continued down the corridor.

(When I first met him, I thought he was just a stupid noble son... is he seriously aiming to become a dragoon? With those grades, his future's practically assured.)

Their first meeting was the worst. It all started when she mocked Rudel for reading a picture book, so there was no helpinit. .And because of that, even now she couldn't shorten the distance to him.

Looking outside from the open window, she spotted students of her year calling out to the students. The one greeting those inexperienced freshmen were Aleist and his friends.

"How about it? I'll show you around the school, so do you want to get some tea along the way?"

"Just a little tea, alright?"

... He was hitting on them. Aleist, who was treated as a monster when he first enrolled was now hiding in Rudel's shadow. But from their usual conduct and speck, all four of them were treated as problem children. For Aleist, he had become much easier to talk to than he was at first, so he had her pity.

"A dragon idiot, a magic idiot, and a sword idiot... then what does that make Aleist? Rather, no one here reads the mood, and no one ever tried to. To achieve top grades despite all that..."

Giving a grumble, Millia started back down the corridor as she remembered all that had unfolded. At first, she had thought the enrollment of the Three Lords' eldest sons would be a pain. But now, there were plenty of laughs to

be had when their stories were brought up, and Aleist was occasionally treated as something of a mascot character.

Luecke had destroyed the facilities in his magical practicals, and Eunius went too far in his sword duels. Aleist was occasionally lacking in common sense Or so his actions seemed to say. But!

"Rudel's the biggest problem child after all."

Participating in a magic experiment, he helped out in destroying the facility, in his duel with Eunius, he wrecked the arena, and his problematic behavior showed an even greater lack of common sense than Aleist. On top of that, his grades were great, and he was serious in class, so the professors found it difficult to caution him. His lack of any ill will only made it needlessly worse.

"Guess there's a paper-thin difference between genius and something..."



Aleist was keeping his friend's pickups company. Honestly, he enjoyed playing around with his friend more than actually hitting on girls, and he wasn't that proactive in it. As Aleist turned his eyes to the school build, the elf girl Millia was walking down the corridor. Her green hair swaying, her walking figure was somewhat beautiful.

As he grew enraptured, his friend who failed in his pickup sent over a berating voice.

"What's this, Aleist? You got a thing for Millia?"

"I-I don't! She was just walking down the corridor, so I..."

While Aleist denied it, from the start, he held a favorable impression of Millia as a capture target character. But that was a one-sided affection through a game, and a setting simply imposed on a character called Millia. Lately, with what happened with Rudel, he had learned to suppress his logic to take certain actions because it was a game.

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Looking at them now, the game's characters seemed to be more charming than they ever had been in-game. The existence of Millia who he had only ever seen as one of a harem, looking at her like this, he couldn't see her as someone buried within some harem.

Her lovely green hair, her white skin, and her cute face... her slender build, and while she looked delicate, she was an elf warrior capable of battle. Aleist had been enraptured a number of times by the wings of elven magic she produced in battle. And he thought her cold impression, and her strong will were just part of her charm.

"She's strong-willed, prim and proper, but as I recall, Millia likes Rudel, doesn't she?"

And just like that, his friend stabbed him with an unrelenting truth. Turning to him, Aleist cried out.

"No way!"

"No, it's true, I tell you. So if you don't act soon, you might be too late! Is all I wanted to say, but... are you listening, Aleist?"

"For real... but the Three Lords have good grades and good faces, but I don't think my face loses out... no, I practically lose in all other fields, so that doesn't really mean..."

"Ah, he's at it again."

"Yep."

As those friends consoled a depressed Aleist, from that day forth, they chose to cooperate with Aleist's love.



The fact the new students were entering the dorm meant the graduates had already left. A change had to come about the Fifth years who had served as

the dorm's prefects... and there was a feud on who would take on the task.

"I don't want to, you hear! Of all times, why do I have to be a prefect when we have four super problem children on our hands!?"

"Isn't your house in the Arses faction? You be prefect."

"No, not happening. Stopping Rudel is impossible for me!"

"If only Vargas was held back a year! Then we wouldn't have anything to worry about..."

Opinions flew about the meeting room of the dorm, as students zealously tried to pass the role onto one another. Normally, a young noble would take the leadership role, and commoners would serve under them to carry out odd jobs. But the year before was a special one where everyone was a commoner student who had earned knight qualifications.

It was Rudel's fault. The kickstart for that unprecedented correspondence lay in Rudel's repeated problematic behavior. The pickup incident, his duel requests, and his infiltration into the girls' dorm...

"That guy gets a free pass to the girls' dorm you know!? Before jealous, I have to respect him!"

"In the past, sneaking into the girls' dorm was an inevitable even, but now that all the high knights are there, there aren't any idiots who would try to sneak in... right?"

"Of course it's impossible! There are even rumors of him with the second princess! I'd be lucky if I just got kicked out of my house for that one."

"Those high knights, you know. If it's to protect the princess' chastity, I heard they can even cut boys down in their wake."

"Like hell they could cut down one of the three lords."

"This is just an if. But if some idiot besides Rudel tries to enter the girls' dorm while I'm prefect..."

The conference room grew quiet. This was another reason they couldn't decide. Fina's existence put a heavy responsibility on the boys' dorm prefects. The cut down part was likely an empty threat, but more than that, there was no guarantee there wouldn't be any idiots among the freshmen.

"I definitely don't want to!"

"A-are there any problem children among the new students?"

"There are some every year, but this year, we're getting some from a marquis house..."

"Let's pray there aren't any big-shot rookies on Rudel's level."

Normally, overlooking the high-ranking nobles who snuck into the girls' dorm was part of a prefect's job. If that was used as a reason to harm the school's relations, it was a cheap buy. But if anyone tried something like that now, it was much too dangerous.

As that was going on, one boy remembered the existence of Izumi. The sole existence who could stop Rudel with words, and even the other two of the Three Lords listened to her. Her miraculous existence was just as famous as Rudel.

"No, wait a second, isn't there that foreigner called Izumi among the fourth years? How about we make her our prefect?"

"That's an exceedingly wonderful idea, but not happening."

"I know, right."

The fifth years didn't even know why they were going through such trouble. Eventually the time came, and the day ended without any prefects decided.

Chapter 53

Having safely become fourth years, Rudel and co were having a discussion over their futures in the academy cafeteria. Surrounding a round table, Luecke, Eunius and Izumi... alongside their usual members, Aleist was there as well.

As lunch had already gone by, there were few people at the cafeteria. In such a situation, Aleist mumbled some complaints as he ate the cakes lining the table.

"Why'd you have to call me? Originally, I wanted to have this badass reunion sort of thing going at the tournament. And Millia's been distant from me ever since Valentine's Day... hah."

"Valentine? Was that chocolate distribution thing you were doing some sort of festival?"

Luecke sipped his tea, ignoring all of Aleist's complaints as he bit onto the unfamiliar term Valentine's Day.

"That thing he did around the end of the third year? As I recall, Rudel and Izumi made chocolate together and exchanged them... so what sort of festival is it?"

Eunius also ignored Aleist's complaints, requesting an explanation on Valentine's Day.

"... Not telling."

Aleist averted his eyes from the two of them in an attempt to put up a slight resistance.

"You apparently give chocolates to the person you like. Aleist and his friends were putting their all into making chocolate, and when I got curious and asked, that's what he said... I also gave some to Izumi."

Rudel answered quite calmly.

(Normally, the girl's supposed to give to a guy... why did we have to make chocolates so seriously, I wonder. By the time I noticed it, the girls had gathered and snatched them all, so I couldn't give Millia anything. Should I teach him about white day while I'm at it?)

Aleist's feeble resistance was meaningless before Rudel. Listening to Rudel's words, Aleist hesitated over whether to tell him the truth or not.

But that conversation was interrupted by Luecke as he started into the main issue.

"Well that doesn't really matter. The problem is how we're going to spend our remaining two years. Me and Rudel, and that muscle-head over there have some freedom, but what about you two?"

"Once I get my knight qualifications, I plan to take on the high knight qualification test."

Izumi lowered her eye level a little as she answered Luecke's question. Right, the way things were going, Izumi and Rudel would graduate the academy and part in two years time. Thinking of it that way, Izumi felt a little lonely.

On the other side, Aleist smiled as he thought over how he was going to enjoy his remaining two years. At the same time, he recalled how he was supposed to spend this time going by the game.

(As I recall... the mid-game has the highest level of freedom. You can make friends with the kids who enroll around this time. Since you've just about completed capturing the other girls, after all. But if you don't do various things during this time period, things go to hell after you graduate. The war event becomes a hard fight, and...!?)

Aleist's face suddenly turned pale as he stood from his seat. Seeing that, the other four turned wondering what was going on, but without noticing them, Aleist started to mutter again before raising his voice.

"A-at this rate, it'll be terrible... i-in that case, I have no choice but to do it!"

"I don't know what you're trying to do, but that's the spirit, Aleist."

Oblivious, Rudel cheered him on.

"I'm going to the temple in the borderland. There, I have to class change from magic swordsman into an advanced class."

"I-I see... well, good luck with that."

As Aleist confidently threw out the words class change and advanced job, Eunius had no idea what to say, so he gave a vague answer. Luecke rubbed his inner eyes as he closed his eyelids in thought.

(At times, I can't understand Aleist at all. To change from a magic swordsman into something, he has to go to the outer reaches? ... it's no good, I don't get it. Is he getting his hands on some new technique? Or is there some hermit in the mountains over there?)

Izumi didn't know what to say either, so for now she tried asking Rudel. Perhaps it was a special custom not found in the orient, and with that on her mind, she turned to Rudel... only to find his eyes sparkling as he looked at Aleist.

"Can you become strong if you go to the borderland?"

"Of course. Five years ago, I myself went to become a magic swordsman, so there's no doubt about it."

Seeing Aleist clearly declare it, Rudel gave some serious thought.

Rudel himself understood it, the way things were going he was closing in on his limit. He hasn't been negligent in his daily training. But Luecke,

Eunius and Aleist in the academy... after fighting them, he realized he really didn't have any talent.

In such a situation, taking on a challenge in the pursuit of strength didn't sound bad.

"... Then I'm going too."

"R-Rudel?" "Oy, get a grip on yourself!" "Don't be hasty! It's just Aleist's usual sickness."

Paying no heed to Izumi and the other's attempts to stop him, Rudel decided on a trip to the borderlands with Aleist.



The Gaia Empire. It was a country given no real detail in-game, a land that existed for the sole purpose of making a hero out of the protagonist. In a room of that empire, a certain individual had called Mies, who had failed in her mission and divulged national secrets. The special skill of the Licorise House's Mies, or rather her in-game skill 'Successful Flight' didn't allow her to avoid responsibility, and she was receiving disciplinary action.

Her actions were used as a reason to cut down the Licorise House's power in the political world. All that remained of the house were the experiment documents and results of the monster enhancement plans they had gone out of their way to develop to ruin themselves...

The person who called out Mies appeared in the room she waited.

"I'm sorry to have kept you waiting."

His age was perhaps in his early twenties. Long, curling silver hair draped over his loosely-worn clothes of high-class make, a man entered the room to give Mies a polite bow. He was tall in stature, and from his trained body and the way he moved, he gave off an air that he wasn't your average joe.

"No, it is no issue to me, your majesty."

"Don't be like that. Call me Askewell or Al or whatever you like. From here on out, you're going to become my precious collaborator, after all."

Askewell Gaia... the empire's third prince, and the commander of the imperial army. A smile on his face, Askewell urged Mies to take a seat as he read through the documents he had received beforehand. His expression turned serious as could be.

"Are the contents written here to be taken as fact?"

"... Yes."

Mies told Askewell the truth. As she did, Askewell's initial strained expression eventually turned to a smile.

"Wonderful. So it is possible to take perfect command of powerful soldiers... I cannot comprehend why the higher-ups would ever reject such a plan."

On those words, Mies feared the prince just a little. But she told herself this was a necessary measure to regain the Licorise House's authority.

"The method isn't perfect. And it could not put up a decent fight against a dragon."

"No problem. Courtois isn't able to maintain so many dragons. Furthermore... if you can enhance ogres and orcs in large numbers and make soldiers of them, it is the Courtois soldiers who won't be able to put up a decent fight."

Honestly, Mies was dim when it came to military affairs. But thinking she had to say something, she tried to joke around by bringing up the necessary food supply to maintain an ogre.

"While it may be easier than rearing a dragon, an enhanced ogre eats more than your common soldier. You should prepare yourself for twice the food expenditure."

Hearing that, Prince Askewall's smile didn't change. But Mies grew afraid of that smile.

"I told you it isn't a problem. There's plenty of food to be found where we're going."

"Eh?"

"You cannot comprehend? Or could it be you're purposely trying not to... so be it. I'm talking humans. If we invade, we'll have plenty on our hands. And even if they face defeat, what we lose are not people of the empire. We lose only monsters."

Askewell spoke to Mies' confusion.

"I'll prepare you a research lab. First off, you are to prepare twenty enhanced ogres. I've secured a place for you to experiment... and worry not, a monster attacking humans is only a natural occurrence. Whether they be enhanced or not, monsters are monsters... there is no need for it to weigh on your mind."

This was Askewell Gaia, the last boss of the game.

Chapter 54

Packing a load of baggage into his rucksack, Aleist set off from the academy towards the temple on the borderlands. As a countermeasure against the war event he had recalled a few days ago, Aleist thought he would take up an advanced job. Endorsing and tagging along, Rudel came with little baggage as he walked behind Aleist.

They had taken a carriage from the academy to a nearby village, but as the temple was on a mountain, they would have to climb it. Aleist was short of breath from his heavy load as he trudged on up.

But Rudel looked at Aleist and offered a word.

"I should've brought something heavier to train too."

"Just to let you know, I'm not dragging along this heavy baggage for training purposes or anything like that! Make light of mountain climbing, and it really will be dangerous... I was seriously in tears when I came a few years ago."

Recalling his self from a few years back, Aleist was moved to tears. He had brought his feet to the temple hoping to receive the grace of an advanced job, but without ant proper equipment for mountain climbing, he had gone through hell.

In-game, you didn't require any special mountain climbing equipment. Or so he continued mumbling to himself.

"This much is nothing, right? I don't think you need such grandiose equipment. Just look around Aleist, there are birds I've never seen before."

Walking behind Aleist, Rudel climbed the mountain. Honestly, Rudel enjoyed mountain climbing quite a bit. Seeing Rudel happily spending his time behind him, Aleist thought.

(Why has Rudel come to such a place... it's usually there for comrade strengthening events and the like. Wait, huh? In that case, does it mean Rudel is already my comrade?)

Feeling something was off about happily climbing a mountain with Rudel- one of his goals- Aleist continued on towards the temple.

Lines of overgrown trees, the cries of birds they could hear from time to time through the warm glow of the sun, the two of them continued walking a few hours more... before their eyes was an old, unmaintained building that you could perhaps call a temple.

That temple in the heart of the mountain, with no one to manage it, it looked to Rudel as if it would simply rot away.

"This is the temple? It's practically rotting away... what are we supposed to do here, Aleist?"

Aleist put down his bags and sat down on the spot. If the inside of the temple was the same as it had been a few years ago, then the whole place would be covered in dust so thick there was no place he could put down his bags and rest.

"We receive a prophecy here. You just have to wish to rise to a higher stage as you pray. If you do, the prophecy shall indicate the path you should go down, and if you want, you can change your class to an advanced job."

"Then I'm going to choose dragoon."

"No, dragoon is a special job, so you can't become one here."

"Why!? I don't want to be anything besides a dragoon."

"Again, it's special, so it's impossible. In the first place, when you don't have a dragon, you can't become a dragoon."

Rudel seemed displeased, but since he'd come all the way here, he thought he would pray anyways. If praying would indicate the path he should treat, he thought it would show him the path to be a dragoon.

"There's no helping it. Then I'll ask what I'm lacking to become a dragoon..."

"Isn't that obvious? You're lacking a dragon... is Dragon really that good? As an occupation, or rather job, it's a bit half-assed, and the way you are, just becoming a high knight will make you plenty strong."

Aleist tried asking what had intrigued him for so long. Rudel was strong. Magic, swordplay and martial arts, in all fields he was ranked at the top of the academy, and in a simple battle, he was likely first in the academy... so Aleist thought.

"... Back when I was small, I saw a dragon fly across the sky. A splendid wind dragon of a deep emerald hue. Ever since I saw it, I couldn't help but want one of my own. I want to ride a dragon and fly through the sky. Freely soaring... flying with a dragon who'll contract with me is my dream."

Rudel spoke of his dream. The dream he held onto from childhood...

"I don't have any dreams. I just wanted to have a bit of fun in life. When I was a kid, I convinced myself I was strong, and that my future was secure. Maybe that's why, I filled my heads with all sort of foolish ideals of heroes and harems."

Aleist felt jealous of Rudel. The fact he simply continued to chase the dream he held from his youth was cool, and that he didn't give up was amazing, he thought. On the other hand, he was...

"A harem? My father had a number of women, but I've never felt jealous looking at him. From time to time, father and mother would fight over it, see. Something about inheritance and such."

"So harems really are most beautiful when left to dreams. I've heard women can be scary when push comes to shove..."

Aleist thought a bit. Could it be the harem he imagined was something that couldn't exist? As he thought that, the elf Millia floated up in his head.

"I won't deny it if it's your dream, but don't you like Millia?"

"N-no, well I do, but..." (Millia likes yooooou.)

Aleist lamented in his heart. He had tried to use chocolate to get his feelings across on Valentine 's Day, but had failed. Not wanting to be the only one teased, Aleist shifted the subject towards Izumi.

"A-and what about you and Shirasagi? Everyone's saying you two are like a married couple."

Hearing that, Rudel made a bit of a happy, yet somewhat sorrowful face.

"I can't be with Izumi. I want her to be happy, so I've been telling her to rely on Luecke or Eunius' house... the two of them acknowledged it, but Izumi's a stubborn one."

"That's irrelevant! If you like her, then just say you do! As you are now, you're just running away."

Aleist was a reincarnator who lacked any recognition of himself as a noble. He didn't quite understand what Rudel was saying, but with his modern era sense, he thought that as long as there was love, things would work out one way or another.

Izumi's house was one attempting to flee to Courtois from their homeland... either obtaining noble status and serving under another, or gaining some land of their own. Otherwise, it would be difficult for them to live on. It was for that sake that Izumi aimed to be a high knight, and she needed an influential noble backing her...

If she ended up dating Rudel, then status-wise, Izumi could only become a mistress. And Izumi's house would enter the umbrella of the Arses House. There was nothing good to come of entering the falling umbrella of a falling house. And the House also had problems as a ruling power.

Aleist, who blurted it out without even considering such things, was surely a man who couldn't read the mood. Rudel could have gotten angry... but his heart was warmed as Aleist got so worked up for his sake. He sent a bitter smile as he spoke.

"You may be right... it's about time we started off. If we don't hurry up, the night will fall before we can get back."

"Do you really get it..."

Grumbling complaints as he stood, Aleist left his bags where they were as he walked towards the temple. In his hand, he gripped only a few small items he had pulled from his belongings.



Giving the temple alter a simple sweep, he lit the candle with a magic flame and placed the offerings he had brought with him. Filled with dust and spider webs, the temple's insides were filthy.

"Is that offering really enough? It doesn't look like the right price to hear out a prophecy."

Seeing Aleist start into the preparations, Rudel also did some light cleaning, but seeing the offerings Aleist had brought along, he grew anxious. The altar was lined with the sort of sweets a child might like.

"This is fine. The goddess here loves sweet things."

As the form of a goddess in Rudel's mind collapsed, the prayers began. Rudel began praying a step behind.

(Please give me an advanced job, oh blessed goddess. I brought you the chocolate you love so much, so...)

(Please tell me how I can become the strongest dragoon, blessed goddess...)

As if to answer their prayers, the inside of the temple was enveloped in light as a semi-transparent glowing goddess appeared over the altar.

"A-amazing."

Rudel gave his honest thoughts upon seeing the goddess. His crumbled image repieced itself somewhat, but seeing the assembled sweets disappear at a rapid pace, it fell apart once more.

'Come hither and I shall bestow a prophecy unto thee. If yonder lad of golden hair doth devote himself to the martial way, I shall open thee the path of the Black Knight...'

"W-what? I've never heard of that job before!"

As Aleist began thinking over the words black knight, the time came for the prophecy to be bestowed upon Rudel.

'And for thy other child of man... you shall take with thee the path of the White Knight. From today henceforth, you shall name yourself White Knight and live such that you never bring shame to thy noble name. "

"No... I want to become a dragoon, so I have to refuse that White Knight bit."

Perhaps due to his crumbled image, he spoke without any fear.

'Eh!? ... White Knight is one of the strongest jobs, and the highest order of hold knights...'

"Change, change me to dragoon."

As the hesitating goddess held her head, her eyes sought salvation from Aleist. But Aleist's hands were full with his own matters.

"Why!? The job that comes after magic swordsman is supposed to be hero"

'No, um, it'll be troubling to me if you refuse.'

As the goddess turned back to Rudel with a troubled look on her face, she started thinking over just how she was supposed to convince the individual before her eyes.

Chapter 55

'Now listen here, you two. Prophecies are holy things you cannot refuse once you receive. What's more, White Knight and Black Knight are jobs that tread into the domain of the divine, the strongest jobs any human could hope to obtain.'

Suddenly sat down on a bench in the temple, the food and water they brought placed on the table between in front of them, Rudel and Aleist received a lecture from the goddess. On their unprecedented displeasure towards her prophecy, she sat on the bench in her half-transparent state as she tried to persuade them.

"Even if you tell me that, I'm going to become a dragoon, so this white knight thing is just a bother."

As Rudel still didn't seem satisfied, the goddess was troubled to no ends.

"... In the first place, even if we're forced into a job by a goddess who comes out with candy, you know. More importantly, shouldn't I normally be getting the strongest 'Hero' job?"

As Aleist was stuck up on the hero part, he gave an explanation of the perks.

"You want to be a hero so badly, Aleist?"

"I definitely want Hero! Hero is generally the strongest class. They can elevate the abilities of the party as a whole, and they have their own unique magic and special skills. Unlike status up and down magic, on top of being able to use special effects, they're perpetually active skills that don't even use up any mana."

Seeing Aleist explain full of confidence, the goddess spoke as she ate up the food on the table Aleist had brought in.

"? There doth already be a hero out there, so I cannot prophesize another."

"Oh my."

"Say what!?"

Surprised as she was at the two's reactions, the goddess went on.

'There is already a hero. And for Hero and White Knight and Black Knight, there can only be one in the world. These three existences hold such power that their numbers are limited. So just accept it already.'

Aleist held his head. In the game, the protagonist was the only one who could become a hero, and it was a necessary job in order to fight the last boss. On a challenge run, he had been able to clear the game while remaining a magic knight, but after coming to this world, Aleist's reality left him full of anxiety.

So there, Aleist asked the goddess about the white and black knights.

"White Knight and Black Knight? They didn't exist in the game, but what sort of classes are they?"

'White Knight be the title of holy knight bestowed onto only the most virtuous of warriors. Black Knight doth be the remnants of a knight who wields about thy powerful abilities... the two jobs are fated to contest one another, and history speaks of many an intense conflict between them. By the way, this country was one raised by a black knight who attained victory.'

Surprisingly enough, it seemed that Courtois was a country founded by a Black Knight. It didn't feel bad to be called a virtuous warrior, but after hearing that much, he ended up asking the goddess.

"In that case, will becoming a White Knight have my shunned from the country? I want to become a dragoon in these lands... I think I really will turn down the White Knight position."

'That is all in the past, so it is no problem! And the White and Black Knight of the time were brothers. The maddened younger brother turned Black Knight, while the older brother did try to save him and failed. Born of the same house, 'twas the tragedy of two brothers whose talents turned to wrath... the mere remembrance makes a fair maiden of me...'

As the goddess hung her head, the two tried sending some gentle words to her.

"Did something happen? Izumi told me that talking takes a load off your mind, so why don't you tell us?"

"No, it might be something we're not supposed to hear. Mrs. Goddess, if it's too painful, you don't have to..."

'The sorrowful competitions of those two dashing brothers... me and my fellow goddesses would place bets every day on who was going to win. Arguing over who was the giver and who was the receiver, those were some good memories.'

The two of them were fed up at the goddess' slackening smile. While saying her prophecies were absolute, by the very fact she was lured by candy into giving them, could it be she wasn't anything too powerful to begin with? Even Rudel was growing irritated.

"Putting this goddess' memories aside, I want to become a dragoon. So I'll pretend I never heard about this White Knight tale. Let's go, Aleist."

"Eh!? What am I going to do with my Black Knight!?"

Grabbing Aleist's arm, Rudel tried to leave the temple, when the half-transparent goddess grabbed his legs to stop him. But perhaps she was lacking in strength, as she was only pulled along by Rudel's stride... Her initial attitude dying away, she was gradually bursting into normal conversation.

"Please wait! That would be troubling! My objective is to lead those who receive my prophecies. If I cannot do that, the other goddesses will laugh at

me!"

"I understand your circumstances, but this is one thing I cannot concede! If it's anything else, I might concede, so I'll have you take back your White Knight Prophecy."

"Rudel, my Black Knight too... more importantly, the Goddess' tone is strange. She was quite a popular one in game, so I'm kinda disappointed here..."

When she bestowed a divine prophecy, they both wanted her to take it back. She didn't know why, but the goddess was growing discouraged. In-game, one would find themselves in her care a number of times to change jobs, and from her word use and attitude, she was popular as the, 'Granny'. While semi-transparent, her gold hair grew to her back, and her abundant breast put her in the top ranks of the game.

Her appearance was in her teens, but her words and attitude gave her the pet name granny... yet even so, she enjoyed her own popularity niche.

Aleist had even felt some secret dissatisfaction that she was never a capture target, but perhaps cooled by the goddess' attitude, he had lost interest.

'It's not like I'm doing this because I want to! In the first place, it's because the Black Knight blamed the White Knight's death on me that this temple fell to decline, and after the Black Knight died, no one ever came... I'm lonely!!! I want people to respect me! I want to bestow the greatest of jobs! And yet, and yet...'

His heart hurting at the crying goddess Rudel stopped his feet and tried talking to her again... it had already grown dark outside, and he was considering spending the night at the temple.

As talks started back up, the goddess had completely lost her initial olden tone. All that was left was a girl using words appropriate for her age.

"So after you've given a prophecy, we can't change our jobs anymore?"

Rudel soothed the goddess, and after talks started u, they learned the goddess before their eyes barely had any abilities. No abilities, or rather, the goddess could only convey the inevitable.

"In the game, you could cancel, though..."

Even if he joined in on the conversation Aleist used words he couldn't comprehend, so both Rudel and the goddess were learning to ignore him.

'Yeah. My role is only to deliver the verdicts of a higher existence, I don't actually change jobs. And, the first people to come in so long denied me, so... urrgh.'

The goddess started crying again, and this time Aleist questioned her.

"In the game, you let me choose an occupation, and explained what was lacking, right? And when I came here a few tears ago, you let me become a Magic Knight as I asked. Can't you do something about it this time?"

'... In your case, there were jobs you could become apart from magic knight, so I just guided you towards the one you wanted. But this time, Black Knight's all you've got, my condolences.'

Sticking her tongue out, she nailed it coldly into Aleist. It seemed the goddess had a low evaluation of him.

"What's with you, when you're just a candy-loving granny!"

'You said it again! You called me a granny twice. Last time you came, you called my granny and mocked me too. That's why you can't get a woman!'

"D-don't make fun of me! Even like this, I've been confessed to a number of times these past few months. I'm not like you!"

'But the girl you do like has no interest in you, right? I heard your conversation in front of the temple!'

"... Hah, calm down, you two. More importantly, about White and Black Knights. This is one thing I cannot concede. Becoming a dragoon is my

dream."

"If I don't become a hero, I'll likely die in the near future. I'll lose to the imperial prince."

The imperial prince Aleist spoke of was Askewell. The inhuman prince trying to bring ruin to the kingdom... that was the last boss of the game, and the true colors of Askewell Aleist knew.

'Now listen here, you've both already received your prophecies, so you're a White Knight, and you're a Black Knight in training! There's no way for you to change it! As long as you both obey fate and fight one another, there won't be a problem. So act like gentlemen, gracefully accept it, and have it out on each other.'

"We have no real reason to fight. And no matter how hard you push it onto me, I'm aiming to be a dragon."

Arguments continued within the temple, and as their unproductive quarrels went on, they didn't seem like they would be reaching a conclusion anytime soon. But the dim temple interior filled with an air of unrest. A black fog burst from Rudel and Aleist's feet, the darkness extinguishing the light of the candle. With the light out, the faint glow of the transparent goddess was all that remained to illuminate the halls...

'What's with this fog? I don't know anything about it!'

While she tried to shake it off, the black fog held a will as it coiled around the goddess. And a woman's voice resounded through the temple

'She may be a no-good goddess, but she has ample uses. While she doesn't boast much power, the very fact she is a goddess being her only redeeming feature, I shall make a marionette of her.'

'Don't joke around. Even like this, I'm a goddess...'

'A goddess without a name. Your role is merely to relay to humans events long determined, a messenger that falls short of a pigeon on the streets. And

see where that's led you... the humans you told shall not follow your orders. The goddess of a rotten temple unable to fulfill her minimum responsibilities, and you still think you're necessary?'

The black fog's words silenced the goddess. Right, this goddess' name did not exist in the game. She didn't even have a setting. For she was a convenient goddess who would only appear when changing jobs...

'B-but I am...'

The goddess' semi-transparent eyes quivered. Her heart swayed as she thought over what the fog had to say. She had thought over the reason of her own existence many times before. Imparting one's job was her role, but humans would choose their own path and ascend to that position themselves.

Like Rudel there were those who chased their dreams, and those who gave up would become what was left. There were some who earned their occupations without even thinking about it. There were various sorts, but humans would find their place in life without going through her.

In this fallen temple, her existence was one only to wait for the time she eventually rotted away. Was she really a goddess? Without a name, and without even any to revere her... wouldn't it be fine if she didn't exist at all?

"Isn't this bad?"

As Aleist was left only able to listen to the conversation of the goddess and the fog, Rudel quietly lent an ear to their exchange. If there was any difference, it was that he was able to hear them out without panic.

Rudel thought. The black fog aiming for him, just what could it be... this fog that spoke of the world, couldn't it be involved with some sort of larger existence? Rudel thought as he watched over the goddess.

The way things were, his voice wouldn't reach. Rudel gripped the hilt of the sword Basyle had given him as a present.

'Thou, you, she who cannot decide herself is a goddess? Didn't you ever think it strange? Weren't there times you ever questioned it? You were never such a noble existence. You were only ever a half-transparent part of the system.'

'S-system? I-I, thy, thou art... ha aHAAaaaa!!!'

Once the black fog had completely gathered around the goddess, a light tempest blew through the temple. The benches were destroyed as they flew through the air, and the few ornaments remaining on the altar were smashed.

After a while, not in her teens, twenty-year-old black-haired goddess's blue eyes turned pale as she gave a grin and turned towards Rudel and Aleist.

"I don't really mind if you target me, but stop dragging in irrelevant people."

'Irrelevant? Are you an idiot... when it's your fault everything has gone amiss, when all you've done is steal away all that one was supposed to obtain!'

The goddess that had gained real substance from her semi-transparent form let out the black fog's voice from her mouth. But once she had said that much, Aleist walked up in front of Rudel.

"I can't stay hiding behind someone's back forever!"

Pulling his sword, Aleist channeled magic into it. Once his blade was clad in flames, Aleist took a step towards the goddess possessed by black fog.

Chapter 56

The goddess without a name taken over by the black fog stood against Rudel and Aleist in that rotting temple. As Rudel tried to pull his sword, Aleist pulled his first and walked out up front. Because of the possessed goddess, the temple was in shambles, and the obstacles such as benches had practically disappeared.

It was easy to move around, but they were still within a room. There was only one entrance, and they'd face considerable trouble on a retreat. As the two didn't know what sort of attacks this goddess had, while Aleist had stepped out in front of Rudel, he was unable to step back.

"Are you the same as that bird we saw before? Not that it has anything to do with it. I can't stay a coward forever!"

Aleist clad the sword in his right hand in flames. What's more, at such a high output, the temperature within the temple leapt up all at once. Judging he would be a hindrance, Rudel leapt back to watch over Aleist and the possessed Goddess.

'Using a magic sword? What an artless man. How idiotic it is, to think I went through so much trouble for this man. But my objective is Rudel's murder, and that is irrelevant to the will of the world! I'll kill you and then Rudel!!!'

"Don't make light of me!"

Aleist rapidly approached the goddess floating in the air. He tried lowering his magic sword at her, but the goddess caught the blade in her left hand. Perhaps intrigued by Aleist's face of surprise, the goddess gave a full grin.

Letting her feet touch the ground, she used powers unthinkable from her appearance to throw Aleist and his sword aside.

Rudel circled around to catch Aleist, only to notice there weren't any traces of a burn on the goddess' left hand.

"S-sorry."

"Aleist, that one is dangerous. Even after taking on magic flames barehanded, she got out without any burn."

"... Even so, I can't step down."

At Rudel's cautionary words, he looked at the goddess in surprise, and sure enough, she was completely uninjured. Even so, Aleist stood, and tried facing her alone.

'You still cannot understand? Comprehend the fact that someone of your level has no chances of victory. I have no interest in your life... so abandon Rudel and leave.'

The Goddess slowly sauntered towards Aleist. But Aleist took a deep breath as he regripped his sword and took a stance.

'Even if she's just a system, this body is that of a goddess'. Do you truly understand that?'

"And what of it!?"

Aleist invoked magic on his left hand as he swung the sword in his right. His sword was blocked by the goddess but his left hand's magic was hammered right into her body.

'It's futile. Magic has no effect on this body. This body was one manifested of magic, and I merely added a physical form. So I can even do something like this.'

The goddess gathered magic in her left hand in the same way Aleist had. But the scale greatly exceeded his. As an inferno gathered around her left,

its intensity set the temple's interior ablaze.

"So magic damage is nulled. And that's why you thought nothing as you took that previous attack? In that case, you're nothing special at all... that one was special magic. It's a special magic that lets me break your defenses temporarily for a second attack."

Surprised as he was at the goddess' magic, he put up a stiff smile as a bluff as he explained. It was a special attack useable by the existences called magic knights. For the next turn alone, it would destroy a null-magic barrier. It was a magic only possible within the interface of a game.

'And what of it? Do you think you can take down this body with but a single attack? That is a problem I need not even calculate. You fail to understand the difference in ability between us.'

"... That so?"

The goddess turned her left hand towards Aleist. Within all of that, he prayed that his plan would succeed as she awaited her attack. Sure enough, his own attacks wouldn't afford too much damage, but what about hers? And Aleist used a magic he rarely ever used in his playthroughs before his reincarnation.

"Counter!"

'Oh?'

As the magic was fired, Aleist cast a magic to reflect it. The reason he rarely used that magic was because the game rarely pit players against enemies of higher level. As romance was the main theme of the game, its combat was somewhat lax.

And there was another reason he didn't like using it.

'So you placed your bet on that magic with its low success rate? As I thought, you're just a kid who falls short of his own abilities.'

Whether Aleist's bet succeeded or failed, the goddess knew it wouldn't be a problem, as she waited to see its result. Before an absolute difference in ability, the goddess had some interest in how the world would move. Surely Aleist wouldn't die in a battle with her. No, perhaps she would be the one dying by some twist of fate. Such feelings of resignation ruled over the goddess.

Sue looked at Aleist with such sentiment. And Rudel also looked over the battle of the two, noticing the slight resignation in the goddess' expression.

As if the result had already been decided, Aleist's counter succeeded. That powerful magic turned its fangs towards the goddess, and she didn't even try to avoid.

"Did you see that!?"

Sent flying by her own magic, the goddess destroyed the altar as she collapsed into it. Face-down on the ground, she restored her burning body, and not to Rudel or even Aleist, she questioned the world.

'You'll do that much to get rid of me? When you're the one who birthed me, you'll even deny the very reason you gave me to live!? If I try to kill Rudel with absolute power, you'll put the existence called Aleist before him... am I really so unnecessary!!!?'

The black fog was no more than a stagehand birthed by the plot to move the story alone. An existence to move for Aleist's sake in the background and get in Rudel's way. The same entity had taken over the boar, the bird, and the goddess. The fact that was one a single existence had multiplied to so many was proof of how Rudel had altered fate.

The possessed goddess' white eyes turned to black as black tears began to lead out.

'So even the last of us that remains cannot fulfill our desire...'

"What are you talking about?"

Aleist's understanding couldn't catch up to the goddess' cry. In that blazing temple, Rudel started walking towards the goddess. He pulled the sword he received from Basyle. The sword forged from the tusk of the first black beast he encountered. It was Rudel's sword born of that tusk melted down with iron.

A little long for a one-handed sword, with its ornaments kept to a minimum, it was a straight sword made with battle in mind. Feeling the mana that leaked from its blade, the goddess started laughing again.

'I see, so it's true! My loss was decided from the very beginning. That blade is a portion of my body, and a weapon even capable of harming this goddess' body. It does seem the world plans to keep you alive until that time is to come... now, kill me, Rudel!'

Without directing his sword, Rudel closed his eyes.



It happened a little before. As Rudel watched the battle between the two unfold, he was troubled.

He was watching over Aleist clash with the goddess when he noticed his new partner, his sword was shaking. Almost as if it were reacting to the goddess, no, to the black fog, it quivered.

(What's this? Something's happening.)

'My role may be over, but I cannot let my comrade face such an end... I'm in no position to ask you, but could you cooperate with me to the end? If you do, you shall be free from our... from my partition.'

He heard the deep voice of a man. What pieced together in his head was the form of the boar he had seen back in his years of fundamental education. That demon of ferocious, rampaging black bulk and white crest.

The last bit of will left in the tusk was trying to save the black fog, the offshoot of itself that had changed to such an extent.

'If you use me, you can harm that one's body. As you are now, you could defeat her with ease.'

(You won't save your comrade?)

'Saving would mean to free that one from her mission. As I've fulfilled mine own, all that remains is for me to disappear, but my partition's mission is to stop you. But you will not give up, will you? Then you must save my partition, my other half. Put an end to the mission she shall never complete.'

As Rudel was thinking hard, Aleist's gamble paid off, and the Goddess let out a cry as she flew through the air. Hers was the form of the defeated who couldn't win against fate no matter how hard they tried.

Rudel focused himself as he walked forward. Making his resolve, he pulled his blade and walked towards her.



Holding his sword up high, Rudel channeled his magic into it. And he thought.

(Will it really end with her defeat? The defeat of an existence who'll lose simply because it is fate? No... that's not something I can accept.)

Seeing Rudel, the goddess-turned-monster closed her eyes, convinced her final moments had come. But the last chime never struck. In exchange, she sensed something close to herself, causing her to hurriedly open her eyes. Nostalgically, she stared at her form before she separated with longing and sorrow.

"W-what's with these guys!? Rudel, just what did you do!?"

What Aleist saw in that burning temple were two monsters standing to Rudel's side. One of them he knew. Aleist noticed it was the bird from back then. But he had no memory of the other boar monster.

'Aaah, it's me. The me before I split anew.'

The goddess reached out her hand towards the approaching boar and bird monsters. While they differed in form, their black bodies and white symbols marked them out as comrades in arms.

'It's already the end, my other half. Our role is over.'

'Now return to the beyond. Once we are one, you won't be alone anymore.'

'Once I've come so far, you'll tell me to give up!?! If we all band together, we can even defeat Rudel. We can fulfill our duty, can we not... and yet, and yet, why are even my own selves ignoring me to try and save him!?!'

The goddess shed black tears, but as the boar and bird bodies grew close, she noticed. Those other halves were transient forms given shape by Rudel's mana...

'So in the end, I won't be able to fulfill my role.'

Reaching out her hands to embrace the ghastly boar and bird, the goddess tried to relinquish her consciousness. But there, Rudel called out.

"Are you fine with it ending, just like that? Leaving with you all the losers to fate?"

'We cannot win over the will of the world. You may have changed your destiny, but it is impossible for you to change your end.'

'You will surely understand someday. The world will definitely bring you to your fate in the way it desires.'

Rudel couldn't feel satisfied with the boar or the bird's answer. He'd run into walls a number of times. Each time, his efforts would grant his wishes, would someday get him recognized, he believed.

"Is my destiny determined? But even so, I want to become a dragoon! That's all I have! That all I... I'll surpass any destiny. It's for that sake that I've worked so hard to this point. If I give up, then that's the end."

Hearing those words, a dumbfounded Aleist's heart began to hurt. Rejoicing that he was able to reincarnate, he had come to the misunderstanding that he was strong. Yet the existence he had only ever seen as a stepping stone held such a will and had gone through so many troubles. He understood it now not in his head but his heart.

"Rudel, you're..."

'How shameless. When it's because of you we were born and exist. But if you are to fight your fate... the world to your end, then I'll help you. I don't mind helping you out until your time has come.'

'What are you saying? Have you gone mad!?'

'Save that one? That doesn't sound like our mission.'

Hearing Rudel's words, the goddess made a proposal. On that unexpected proclamation, the boar and bird voiced their objections.

To the words of her other selves, she smiled and held up a hand to quiet them. All the goddess, the black fog knew was that Rudel was yet another like them attempting to fight against the setting of the world. A sensation that the enemy she was supposed to fight was fighting her same battle...

'Rudel, if you will continue to fight your fate, I will lend you a hand. However, if you are unable to oppose, simply swept up in fate's flow... the moment you give up, I'll kill you.'

"Do what you will. I'll definitely never give up."

'Do not forget those words. The world will get in your way, and you'll surely never find a dragon of your own. I'll help you through that trial. So forget not, the moment you give up is the moment you die.'

Rudel overreacted at the words that he wouldn't get a dragon, but at the words of the black fog surrounding the goddess, a smile accompanied Rudel's surprise. It was almost like the smile of a young boy.

"You will!?"

'... What a simple one. Then I must be off...'

Once the black fog parted from the goddess, it spread over the temple's interior to steal the vision of those present. And once Rudel and Aleist could see again, the original blond goddess was stark-naked, collapsed on the ground. The temple was wrapped in flames on the verge of collapse.

You could praise it for holding out so long throughout the intensity of the battle between Aleist and the goddess, but Rudel and Aleist hoisted the goddess up and hurriedly raced to the exit.

At practically the same time as they leapt out, the temple collapsed. The impact caused her to open her eyes. Having attained a physical form from her semi-transparent state, the goddess lifted her stiff body. And she saw. The collapse of the temple erected to revere her...

"H-hey!!! What's all this then!!?"



Rudel and Aleist were kneeling before the former goddess. Perhaps the sun was already on its way up, as the area was gradually growing brighter.

"What do you think you've done, you blasphemers!? Give me back my temple, give it back!"

The two who knelt before the naked, crying goddess boldly looked at her form. Perhaps it would be more accurate to say they couldn't avert their eyes. With her being a former goddess and all, it's not as if you couldn't say her form wasn't divine. No, perhaps they were just excited looking at a woman's form, and it just looked like that.

"B-but, listen. The one who destroyed it was you."

Still locking eyes with the goddess' body, Aleist refuted. Rudel definitely did feel bad for her, but on top of being possessed, this candy-loving goddess held no dignity.

"And no one ever came to begin with, right? What's more, now that you've got a body of your own, it'll be difficult to make a living way out here."

"What's that? Is making excuses all you're good for, you blasphemers!? Even if I've gotten a body, I'm a being of... h-huh? Why am I naked!? What's more, you both saw me naked, you perverts!"

This time the goddess burst into tears at her body being seen, and Aleist handed over some of his preserved food rations. Taking it as if snatching it away, the goddess ate as she complained.

"Don't think this is enough to clear away my resentment. I'll haunt you until you atone for this."

What she said pretty much classified her as an evil spirit. On her tone and attitude, the two boys lost interest, stood and started on their way back.

"W-where are you going?"

"We're students so we have to go back to school. We've been in your care. I'll definitely rebuild your temple, so just wait here."

"I couldn't become a hero, and I don't think I have any more business here."

On those words, the goddess' faint heart shattered. Leftovers of her meal around her mouth, she leapt at Rudel's feet and held on.

"Don't leave me behind! I don't want to be alone in such a lonely place."

As the goddess clung and wept, Aleist sighed.

"Weren't you always here alone? And we're going to the academy, so we can't bring any pets."

"Who're you calling a pet!? Even like this, I'm a goddess. And we goddesses occasionally get together, so I'm not a loner! But with this body, I can't go to that place, so I really will be aloooooonnnne."

"... What should we do, Aleist?"

"No, even if you ask me..."

"Don't abandon me! I'll do anything, so just don't abandon me!?"

The three at their wits' end spend a good deal more time thinking on the spot.



Returning to the academy, Rudel and Aleist ended up arriving much later than scheduled. It was because they were looking after the goddess who obtained a body in a nearby village. And having returned to the academy, the two of them introduced the goddess to the usual members.

"... And that's how it is, so we'll be looking after this goddess. Say hi."

Once Rudel finished explaining everything, the goddess in village girl clothes lowered her head. Once she raised it, she spoke with a smile.

"I'll be in your care!"

Everyone was too surprised to say a word. Rudel and Aleist had gone out saying they would become stronger, but once they came back, they were taking along a slightly-younger girl. Even those who hung around with them on a regular basis, Izumi, Luecke, and Eunius couldn't react.

(What should I do, there's no way I could've imagined something so out of the blue. I had thought perhaps he may come back with a dragon, but... for him to return with a goddess(?), could it be I'm lacking in imagination?)

Izumi was surprised Rudel had gone even beyond her expectations.

(That's why I was against Rudel and Aleist taking action together! Just look, I completely fail to comprehend the results of the oblivious pair working together!)

Luecke seemed fed up at the two who led along a girl claiming to be a goddess. Finally, Eunius thought.

(I should've gone too.)

And as that dubious air flowed by, Aleist muttered. Unable to read the mood, Aleist was unable to understand why everyone around was so confused. He had spoken of the events in the temple, but he had no idea that goddesses were something that normal people would never usually meet.

"Huh? What's up with everyone? You don't like the souvenirs we brought back?"

With the peculiar local ornaments Rudel and Aleist had chosen out in their hands, the three of them cried out.

"That's not the point!"

"Are you an idiot!?"

"They definitely are strange..."

Chapter 57

This is the tale of a young girl who was no longer a goddess.



Rudel mulled over how to treat the former goddess who had come to the academy. If he simply left her at the ruins of the temple, she would die, and having lost her goddessly abilities and mana, the young girl had no means to survive. Looking no more than fifteen, her beautiful blond hair, and body you could call art were splendid, but their contents were much too unfortunate.

At present, she was eating in the boys' dorm cafeteria, dangerously wielding her spoon and fork to eat as she sullied the area around her mouth. Ever since she obtained a body, the goddess had faced numerous problems. The reason Rudel and Aleist had taken so much time lay in how difficult it was to look after her.

"Oy, granny over there, why are you spilling so much? The table and your clothes are a mess."

Aleist looked at the former goddess as he cautioned her, and the goddess tried to do something about it... but once that proved hopeless, she gave up and talked back.

"S-shut it. And you're not looking after me anyways. The one looking after me is Rudel."

Right, ever since the former goddess obtained a body, it was mostly Rudel looking after her. Aleist had no experience in child rearing, but Rudel had looked after his stepsister Lena before.

"I'm fine with looking after you, but more importantly, what are you going to do when I'm in class? We're going off to class now."

Rudel flipped through a book titled, 'Training your Dog', as she asked the former goddess. The goddess only knew the word class as its dictionary definition, so she tilted her head in wonder.

"Can't I just follow you?"

On those words, Luecke- who didn't believe she was a former goddess- answered.

"You're not a student of the academy, so you can't take part in classes. More importantly, why don't you decide a name soon? On top of it being hard to address you, it's painstakingly annoying to explain to other people."

Eunius was eating his breakfast, and he didn't seem very interested in the former goddess. Perhaps dissatisfied with the attitudes of the four boys, the former goddess stood from her seat and wept as she protested.

"Even I'm getting tired of saying former-goddess every time! Everyone makes a dubious face... isn't my beauty enough proof of my divine origins?"

She was definitely beautiful. If her mouth and clothes weren't soiled, she might even look divine. Rudel closed his book as he looked at the former goddess.

"Former goddess, sit down when you eat. And it's good manners to keep quiet, so you don't bother everyone around."

"Erk, got it."

"That's a good girl, good former goddess. Have a flan as a reward."

"Yippee!"

Saying that, Rudel presented his own desert flan. The former goddess rejoiced... Aleist looked between Rudel and the goddess, and the book in

Rudel's hand as he muttered. He should have noticed something was off when Rudel was reading a book on dogs rather than dragons.

"You... Rudel's thinking of you as a dog, you know."

The goddess froze half-way through her delicious flan.



"What's with those blasphemers!? I don't need them, I can survive alone."

The former goddess angrily walked through the campus. Before Rudel and the others could head off for class, she finished up her flan and ran out of the dining hall. Her mouth and clothes still dirty... The academy staff saw from the card hanging at her neck that she was authorized by the Arses house, and stopped themselves from cautioning her.

"Very well, I'll show them. I'll make it all by myself."

And like that, the former goddess knew the first thing she needed was a place to sleep. She didn't know why, but the card she got from Rudel hanging at her neck let her get into mostly everywhere. Using it, the former goddess tried to search out a place she could live. She didn't have any interest in the finer rules of humanity, and she didn't really understand what it meant to be at school.

"Let's see... that building looks like a worthy temple to me."

The goddess set out for the dwelling that didn't reek of men, the girls' dorm. As she approached, she was stopped at the entrance. The female knight on duty surrounded her with a number of female soldiers.

"What!? What's all this!?"

"There are a few things I have to ask you, but first off, could you show me your ID?"

Panicked as she was, the former goddess handed over the card she got from Rudel. After the female knight wiped the grime off the card, she breathed a

deep sigh and let the goddess into the dorm. Cautioning her not to make a mess.

While the female knight saw her off inside, a new soldier recruit asked in a perplexed tone.

"Umm, was that really alright? Letting that child into the girls' dorm?"

"You're new around here, are you? Listen well... these past few years, the girls' dorm has been at peace. It's all because the princess is here, but before that, those damn brats would always try to look for openings in our patrols and try to infiltrate. But at this point, there's only one man who'll ever try to enter the princess-occupied girls' dorm."

"Eh!? There's one who still breaks in!? That's a huge problem, isn't it? Before I was stationed here, they told me, you can harm low ranking nobles if need be, just prevent anyone from getting through."

"... Rudel Arses. The eldest son of one of the tree lords. He boldly enters the girls' dorm through the front door."

"That's definitely strange. There's no way such a thing would be permitted! The princess is here, so naturally, even the child of an archduke should receive considerably punishment!"

The new recruit let out a sound argument as she latched onto her superior's tale, but the female knight spoke with a serious look on her face.

"You definitely can't go against him. I'm not saying it because I fear his authority or might, that boy... Rudel-sama boasts a technique far scarier than any of that..."

Seeing her superior shake as she hung her head, the new recruit gulped down her spit. Just what could be happening in this academy... but outside the eyes of the recruit's serious worries, her superior's downcast face was just a little red.



"Despite how it looked from the outside, this place is full of small rooms. But the rooms are bigger in this area. It's similar to the rooms around Rudel's place, so I'm sure there are some extravagant ones around here... I'll make one of them my own."

The former goddess talked to herself as she walked. At the end of her path was Fina's room, guarded by high knights. As the building held a similar make to the boys' form, the former-goddess determined it was the best room and walked right up to it. Of course, she didn't forget to flash the card she got from Rudel.

(This card really is amazing. All the people who don't believe me no matter how I explain, they suddenly listen after they looked at this card... but it's a bit vexing.)

"... Arses House!? W-wait just a moment. No, please wait."

The high knight who looked at her as a suspicious person, upon seeing the card, her complexion suddenly changed as she rushed into the room. As she did, a few dreadful noises and footsteps came from within before the luxurious doors were slammed open with good momentum.

"Where's master's pet!? I'm sure it's super fluffy and... flu... fy? Wait, fluff aside, all I see is a filthy woman. Sophina, what is the meaning of this?" (I rushed when I heard we had a guest with a card saying she was master's pet, but the only one here is a woman who's mouth and clothes are all dirty... hah, what a let-down.)

As Fina expressionlessly burst out, the former goddess was surprised. But even in that situation, she felt irritated when Fina spoke ill of her.

"I am a goddess. Former as it may be... no matter how you look at it, isn't that treatment just terrible? And what do you mean by pet..."

The former goddess tried to nail in her anger, but Fina wasn't interested in the slightest as she struck up a conversation with Sophina.

"Meaning it's that? He's showing me his woman to tell me to give up on fluffadise? This must be a challenge from master."

"You're wrong, princess. Why are you interpreting it like that? It seems she's involved with Rudel-dono in some way, and she might be of considerable statue. It's possible he left her with a message..."

"Don't lie to me. Master would fail to read the mood and come to me directly if he wanted to say something. He'd never use such a roundabout... I see! So that's how it is!"

Fina's expressionless face suddenly turned to the former goddess. As the former goddess took it with surprise and fear, Fina made a grandiose declaration.

"You're master's new disciple! The fact you came to me, your senior disciple is proof that master told you to gauge your own abilities... very well, I'll show you my true strength!"

"Wha- even like this, I'm a goddess, hey, wait, don't strip me! If anything rips, Rudel will scold me!"

Fina attempted to strip off the former goddess' clothes. Even in that situation, she remained expressionless, and feeling fear from her clothes suddenly being pulled away, the former goddess fled from the spot. Half in tears, her clothes only half-worn, she ran as fast as she could.

"What are you doing, princess!?"

"It's just as you saw. And naturally, I won that one." (Hmm, what a trifling junior disciple I've gotten. Master must have knotholes for eyes... to take a child so unsuited to fluffing as his disciple, the day I surpass master might be closer than I thought.)

"That may have been Rudel-dono's fiancée!"

On Sophina's words, a huge jolt ran through Fina's body.

"I-it couldn't be..." (Impossible. There's no way master could have a fiancée! I mean, I pleaded to father, did all those dodgy deals, and spread rumors to crush his fiancée candidates! If that's how it is, then I have no choice but to borrow the forbidden mother power or fluffadise will forever be a dream.)

A discouraged Fina. Noticing Fina act different than usual, she must be in love with Rudel... Sophina made no such misunderstanding.

(I'm sure this girls' going to start something crazy again.)

Sophina was beginning to understand her lord.



Half in tears, the former goddess timidly walked the halls of the girls' form. Unlike how she boldly carried herself at first, now she carefully searched out the exit. At times, she would see underdressed girl students walking around, and she would make sure not to be seen.

But one wrong turn in her flight from Fina, and she had ended up completely lost. At this point, even the former goddess didn't know if she was crying because of Fina, or crying because she was lost.

"To hell with it all, making fun of me... I'll get back on them someday."

Makin statements unthinkable from a former goddess, the former goddess walked towards what she hoped was the exit. But to that goddess, the true goddess descended.

"Hey, aren't you Rudel's..."

"Haau!"

The former goddess turned around to find Izumi with a kind look on her face. As they had been introduced at the start, the formed goddess remembered her face. On the appearance of the gentle Izumi, this time the

goddess shed tears of gratitude. On the woman who looked like her goddess of salvation, the former goddess began to pray.

"M-my goddess."

"Eh?"

As the former goddess put her hands together in prayer, Izumi spent a moment in thought.

Chapter 58

The goddess looking for a dwelling, a little passed noon, she encountered Izumi in the girls' dorm. For the goddess who wept as she begged for salvation, Izumi wiped her mouth and put her clothes in the laundry. And it was there that the former goddess' stomach let out a magnificent roar.

This is the school story of such a goddess...



Dressing the goddess of growling stomach in her own clothes, Izumi led her to the girls' dorm cafeteria. The form of her leading the goddess by the hand made one imagine a parental figure. The former goddess nervously looked around as she showed interest in a dining hall different than the one in the boys' dorm.

"What's that!? They didn't have those cakes or sweets over there! The flan here even has whipped cream over it! Ah, but that cake looks nice too."

As the former goddess frolicked, Izumi gave a warm smile as she ordered a lunch set along with a cake. Unlike the boys' dorm, the food there was served with appearance in mind, with portions on the conservative side. But surprisingly, the most popular item on the menu was the heaping portion lunch set one wouldn't want to be caught eating in the world beyond.

The two found an empty table and took their seats. And as the goddess began eating, as expected, she soiled the area around her mouth.

"Over there, the taste is thick and the portions are plenty, but this isn't half bad... this cake is nice and sweet. The candy that Aleist kid brought doesn't hold a candle to it. From here on, I'll put a prerequisite on quality and... ah, I don't have a temple anymore."

As the goddess went through a cycle of delight and sorrow, Izumi occasionally stepped in to wipe off her mouth.

"I heard what happened from Rudel. I can't quite understand, but you've had your troubles... may I hear your name?"

"Name? ... Don't have one of those."

Her cheeks stuffed with cake, she continued chowing down as she answered. As she never had one from the start, perhaps she never attached much importance to it, and Rudel didn't try to decide a name for her. When she said that to Izumi, Izumi let out a sigh.

"How very like Rudel. I'll put in a word, but if you do ever remember your name, please tell me."

While Izumi still didn't understand Rudel's story or what it meant to be a former goddess, perhaps she was right. Who would ever think this young girl eating cake with her mouth all dirty was a goddess?

"It's already this late? I'm sorry, but I have to go to class, so I'll guide you to the exit. I'll give your clothes to Rudel tomorrow or so. And you can have what you're wearing right now."

From the former goddess' story, she learned that Rudel didn't prepare much clothing for her, so Izumi decided to give her some of her own. How kind... the former goddess' heart was moved as she was led to the girls' dorm entrance where she parted with the Izumi. Forgetting her original objective, her stomach was full and she was going sleepy.

"Is there anywhere I can sleep?"

Still fearful of Fina in the girls' dorm, the former goddess sat on a bench some distance from the dorm. Noon had gone by, but the sunlight was still pleasantly warm, the weather weighing down on her eyelids...

"Good night..."

She ended up falling asleep alone.



"H-huh? It's already evening! It's time for dinner!"

The former goddess woke to the sound of her own stomach, but the area was already beginning to grow dark. She had already forgotten her original objective, and she tried to return to the boys' dorm, but... as the area grew dark, the feel it gave of changed, leaving her lost once again.

"As I recall, you go down this path... no, but it could be this one too. Urrgggh."

The former goddess felt she would burst into tears again. But there, some demi-humans appeared to surround her. In the darkening campus, the eyes of the demi-humans that looked as if they glowed startled her. Looking around to see what was going on...

"Ah, this woman has master's smell... what to do, I don't think I can let this pass."

"*Sniff*, that really is Rudel's smell."

"The smell of a strong male..."

Ness of the black cat tribe appeared as if emerging from the darkness, and this time girls of the tiger tribe began to saunter out. Ness' scary statement with her suspicious face, and the tiger tribe women over two meters in height surrounding her. Perhaps frightened by their talks of smell, the former goddess trembled as she looked for her path of escape.

As she did, this time, white cat Mii looked at the former goddess as she spoke.

"Ah, this person is Rudel-sama's pet who came by around noon. The princess said she was a junior apprentice, so we have to harshly drill in the pecking order. She was making quite a ruckus, so I remember it."

I'm saved! The goddess thought, but the demi-humans reacted to the contrary.

"Pet!? When he already has a slave in me, such a woman stays by Rudel-sama's side... unforgivable."

"I see, so I simply have to defeat her and take her place."

"Great thinking boss! You're a genius."

"That's definitely strange! That idea was definitely a fail. More importantly, just what is Rudel-sama supposed to be!? What did he do for things to come to... hey, white cat, can't you save me!?"

"... But the princess told me to be harsh on you..."

"What!? I-it couldn't be you're kin to that rude little girl!? She's followed me all the way here... at this rate, I really will be killllleeeedd!!!"

"I won't let you escape!"

"Chase her!"

"It's hunting timeee!!!"

Caring not for appearances, the former goddess fled. But the demi-humans, the women of the beastmen tribes were considerably fast on their feet, and even when the former goddess was running for dear life, they were gradually beginning to close the distance. What she recalled were the days when the people honored her, but by the black knight's unjust resentment, the people all stopped coming to the temple... it all flashed by like a revolving lantern.

"Wat's with you all!? Don't get any closer!!!"

As if the heavens had heard out the former goddess' plea, the demi-humans suddenly suppressed their bloodlust, slowing down the speed at which they gave chase. As the former goddess turned around in wonder, following Ness' lead, the tiger tribe girls were beginning to get their clothing in order.

With gestures as if they were mindful of their appearance. The former goddess looked around to see what was going on.

As she hadn't come back, Rudel had come out to search for her, and he sotted him walking her way.

"So this is where you were. I was looking for you."

"U-uwaaaah!!!"

The former goddess cried as she jumped at Rudel. And Rudel pet her on the head. Once Rudel noticed Ness and the others, he came to a misunderstanding. That these feline girls had guided the lost former goddess all the way here...

"It seems I've caused you some trouble. I really am grateful. I know this child is quite a handful, "but you've really helped me out today.

Hearing those words, the demi-humans seemed delighted, and after exchanging a few more words with Rudel, they turned to leave. Rudel turned to look at the former goddess, but perhaps from relief, she had fallen asleep still clinging onto him. Lifting her up just like that, Rudel started off towards the boys' dorm.



"A name?"

The former goddess had safely returned to Rudel's room. After finishing dinner, she jumped right into the bed there and leisurely relaxed. It was at that moment that Rudel spoke as if recalling something.

"That's right. No matter how you look at it, it's hard to address you. Izumi cautioned me on it... so I think it's time we decided your name."

Saying that, he showed the former goddess the name candidates put down on papers. The former goddess looked at the number of names, but she couldn't quite decide on her own. She hadn't used the very concept of names

for a long time, but to start with, she couldn't understand letters. From when she was a goddess, her knowledge all came from what she saw and heard. But as a goddess, she was never taught.

For a goddess who would live an eternity, perhaps that would be fine, but this former goddess... perhaps she had grown conceited, as her knowledge load was lower than Rudel's. Rather, at the very point she couldn't read or write, she was considerably lacking in knowledge. Only learning what she liked, in her long years of storing information, it had become a bad habit.

"... I can't read. Read them to me, and if there's one I like, I'll make do with it."

"Are you really fine with that? Very well, then listen closely. I took in everyone's opinions, so first we have 'Granny' from Aleist, then we have, 'Useless' from Luecke, third we have 'Marin' from Eunius, and fourth we have 'Sakuya' from Izumi. Finally, I submitted 'Magamon'."

"Pass on Aleist! And the second is out of the question! Number three- Marin- isn't bad at all."

"Yeah, apparently, it's the name of the number one at the shop Eunius goes to."

"Number 1? What does that mean?"

"It's a place where older women pour you wine and look after you. For the popular ones, I get the feeling he said you could spend a fortune for a night..."

Marin was a lady from the saloon Eunius frequented. Rudel courteously explained to the goddess how she had become his favorite lately. And as Rudel seriously went into explanations on how it was part of the night service industry, the former goddess' face turned red as she refuted the name Marin with every fiber of her being.

"I-I'm a goddess! I haven't been tainted yet! Marin is rejected! It's definitely no good!"

"You think? Well if the one in question says that, then there's no helping it, but... I think it's something different from being tainted. How about Sakuya then? Since Izumi said it, I'll give my recommendation."

"It definitely is nice. But it doesn't fit my image, so I'll reject it. Since it's a name Izumi thought up, I'm hesitating, but images are important with goddesses, you know."

"Then that means you're Mogamon."

On Rudel's words, the former goddess jumped off the bed in protest. Why did it come to that? Her face seemed to say, but what's wrong? Rudel's face spoke as he looked perplexed at the former goddess' reaction.

"Why am I being forced into Mogamon!?"

"I told you to pick from the candidates. If the first four were no good, then naturally the last candidate is automatically selected. Good for you, Mogamon. Having a name is a good thing."

"In that case, give it a bit more thought before you put out the candidates!!!"

The former goddess and Rudel's debate continued a while more. And at the end, Rudel folded, and the former goddess' name selection was put on hold.

Chapter 59

Dragoon 59: The Protagonist and the Delinquents

While Rudel and Aleist has safely (?) returned to the academy, the jobs they received were not the ones they had planned for. While Rudel aimed to become a dragoon, he was now a White Knight, and it seemed someone had beaten Aleist to his planned Hero title, and he was on the road to become a black knight... on such an unexpected occurrence, the two of them began a search for documents through the academy archives.

The White and Black Knights were fated to fight one another. They had investigated while believing in the goddess' words, but the results showed a truth adequately betraying them.

"... Oy, flin for brains. These documents say things completely irrelevant to some fated battle."

Aleist glared at the former goddess from the mountain of books he had piled on his library desk.

"T-that's strange. But I've seen history with these very eyes, so my info is more precise than anything you can find in some book!"

The former goddess asserted she was right, but this time- surrounded by books just like Aleist- Rudel offered a correction.

"There are definitely records of a pair of brothers, White and Black Knights, fighting over various things around the founding of Courtois. But more than that, there are records that they got along fine before that. It says that inheritance rights and the pressure put on them by their surroundings became the cause of their dispute."

Rudel organized the book's contents on a piece of paper. He wrote about the knight called the White Knight, and the one called the black Knight.

The White Knight was a knight who carried with him sword and shield gleaming with light. The black knight held a sword in each hand, fighting with a double bladed style. Of course, that was only the fighting style of the White and Black Knights of the time, but as he gathered information, Rudel put down all he could find.

"I-in the end, fate only cares about the results! I know I'm right, so just get to the fighting already and prove it! Ah, but that black knight over there is still in training. How pitiful."

The goddess grinned as she emphasized the 'in training' part of Aleist's title. Reacting to her words, Aleist slammed one volume against her.

"Shut it, you flan-for-brains former goddess! Now that you've been demoted from being a goddess, you're just a plain incompetent. No, ever since Rudel started supporting you, you've done nothing but eat, so you're even worse than that."

"W-waaaah. Rudel, he's making fun of me!"

While the former goddess clung to Rudel in tears, Rudel handed over the cake he had brought along. And patting her on the head, Rudel got back to work.

"You're in a library, so be quiet both of you. Here, have a cake."

"Yay!"

The former goddess dug into the delicious-looking cake. Seeing her form, Aleist thought.

(This damn granny former goddess is being tamed.)

Aleist also got back to work and looked into this and that, but he had some anxieties working with a class that didn't exist in the game. Classes came with a general path to follow. If you started out as a magician and learned

the sword, you'd become a rune knight, and if a knight took up magic, it would be the same.

If a magician continued down a magician's path, they would earn the class grand magician. They would carry on the skills of the classes they passed through, but Aleist didn't even know the traits of this unknown Black Knight class.

According to the documents, he was supposed to hold a sword in each hand and control the powers of darkness, but to Aleist, the hell are the powers of darkness!? Was all he could think. Growing so curious he could no longer hold it, he tried asking the former goddess. But her answer was terrible.

"The one who glows like paaah and goes Pwaaaah! Is the white knight, and the black knights makes the shadows go swuuuuuush, and all these pointy things come up."

Neither Aleist nor Rudel could understand the former goddess' words. That's why they were looking into it on their own.

And what they were coming to understand was the history of Courtois' founding, but there weren't ever any White or Black Knights apart from the brothers who fought at the time. Or rather, it felt more like the Kingdom of Courtois wouldn't recognize them.

The Black Knight who founded the country was one thing, but the Black Knight's older brother was a White Knight. They had become the classes of royalty, so to speak, and the positions themselves had been deified. There was a bit of a problem in the fact that both Rudel and Aleist were oblivious to that fact, but Rudel's interest in non-dragon matters was light, and Aleist couldn't help but have a tendency to compare the feelings and information he got from playing the game to this world, so you could say there was no helping it.

"The reason it hasn't spread as a fairy tale is because it's the sacred founding of the kingdom? No, but in that case, on the contrary, it should be something sell-spread."

Aleist answered to Rudel's mutters.

"Did they want to cover up the fact this country was founded as a result of a brotherly feud? In that case, they only had to make the White Knight the bad guy, but if I had to say, the White Knight looks to be more in the right here."

As the two of them thought, the former goddess who finished her cake explained with a triumphant face.

"Hmm, the black knight was a real brother's boy, so he purged the hell out of anyone who would write a picture book depicting his big brother as the bad guy! That yandere air, me and my goddess friends seriously did a double take there."

"H-how terrible." "You understand what a yandere is, Rudel?"

At their impressions, the former goddess started putting on airs and explaining the era. The two influential noble brothers who had gotten where they were by lifting one another up, and once a warring states period descended upon the continent, their talents did truly bloom.

"The two of them fighting at the vanguard truly was the coolest, I tell you! And after a while, the wars gradually began reaching their ends. Around that point, the brothers' father was getting well in his years, and he wanted to choose an heir. As a precursor to the event, he came over to my place."

"And that's when you made them a White and Black Knight? And it's after that that they started fighting one another. Doesn't look like fate's has anything to do with it."

Rudel seemed to think there was no such thing as a feuding destiny. In contrast, Aleist held quite a different idea.

(Originally, me and Rudel were supposed to argue quite a bit. I was the protagonist, and Rudel was the stepping stool for such a man. Now you can almost say the opposite is true... could these classes be related to the game's

setting? In that case, you could say me and Rudel were destined to fight, at some point.)

After looking at Rudel's face, Aleist put his thoughts on a temporary hold. He would surely face Rudel in a tournament to come, but he had no intentions of carrying out a fight to the death. So Aleist thought.

After that, he tried to continue pursuing his leads, but tired from making such a ruckus, the former goddess had fallen asleep on top of the desk. Rudel began putting books back as he spoke to Aleist.

"Let's call it quits for today, Aleist."

"Y-yeah."

Aleist was finally beginning to notice the game's events and this changing situation.



Around the time they had finished research into their own jobs, about a month had passed since they had returned. The conclusion they reached was to cover up the whole White and Black Knight matter.

There was no point in becoming overly conspicuous, and Rudel made a decision that having a job related to the founding of the country may end up twisting his future plans. Rudel wanted to become a dragoon, and Aleist didn't particularly want to stand out. Before anything to do with winning the war, Aleist had his own survival on his mind.

He wanted to avoid the Black Knight matter getting out, and having him sent off to a dangerous region. He truly wanted to avoid any further irregularities. He thought of nothing more than to fight the last boss and safely achieve victory.

"That aside, Aleist, you said you wanted to learn martial arts, didn't you?"

As Aleist was lost in thought, Rudel- who had been with him quite often as of late- called out. They were on the road towards the library. They had no more business with it when it came to their jobs, but they planned to use it as normal students.

"I definitely did say it, but I'll have to refrain from your cowardly fighting techniques. Why do you aim for the eyes so naturally? That's way too dirty."

"The one who taught me was a former mercenary. The movements have been drilled firmly into my body, so that alone I can't do anything about. Anyways, I went and looked for an individual skilled in martial arts that fit your demands. I have them waiting right over there."

Rudel was well prepared, but Aleist didn't quite trust him when it came to these sorts of things. It was the Rudel way to cause a problem whenever he tried to do something. His lack of ill intent only made it all the worse.

"... My request was a strong and cool martial art. And not something cowardly, I said I'd prefer something fair and square."

"Leave it to me! I guarantee they have considerably strong martial arts, and those skilled in them are earnest folk who hate cowardly means. Come out, everyone."

"Eh? Everyone?"

Saying that, Rudel called out the ones who would be instructing Aleist. They were fellow students, upperclassmen in their final years. Tall in stature, with bodies as if they were wearing an armor of pure muscle. Of fearsome features... the men of the tiger tribe. Their attire were some that brought to mind delinquents of the modern era, and they were a variety Aleist was bad at dealing with.

"We just have to train up this guy, right, Rudel-san? Once we do, I'll have you fulfill your promise."

The largest tiger man looked at Aleist before seeking confirmation from Rudel. Unable to swallow down this situation, Aleist could only nervously look around.

"Don't worry, I've obtained Izumi's acknowledgment. Once you teach Aleist martial arts, I'll fight you, and if I lose, I promise I'll become your masters. I swear to honor that promise."

Hearing Rudel's words, Aleist latched onto the various strange things that came out.

"Isn't that strange!? Why is Rudel becoming your master if he loses!? Isn't it usually the other way around, and wait, what's with that promise!?"

The tiger men glared at Aleist and intimidated him.

"You cannot understand Rudel-san's amazingness!?" "Rudel-san is our messiah, you hear!" "As if... as if someone like you could understand how we feel!"

"Lay off him, this matter is of vital importance to the continued existence of the tiger tribe. Aleist, was it? I won't tell you to understand. But listen here... if you don't make our techniques your own, then you'll die, so prepare yourself you bastard!!!"

And just like that, Aleist was hoisted up and carried off by the tiger tribe men. Rudel saw him off with a smile and a wave of his hand.

"Do your best, Aleist."

It's said at that time, Aleist saw the devil in Rudel.

Chapter 60

Dragoon 60: The Young Man and the Hero

Rudel woke up early every morning to carry out his training. After draping a blanket over the former goddess, her body spread grandly over the center of the bed, he took up his weighted wood sword and made for the courtyards. Lately, he had begun training with a wood sword made to imitate the weight and length of the blade Basyle had given him.

There were a number of reasons for that. Especially as of late... ever since he was professed as a White Knight, he felt power overflowing from the depths of his body. Perhaps of that, it was growing more difficult to control his power. If he tried to use magic, it would run out of control, and if he flowed mana into his sword, he could no longer maintain the mana in the sword's shape.

Hesitating at his rapid growth, Rudel carried out the training required to control it. When he practiced swinging his sword, the sound it made was clearly different from the other students around. His movements as well, while the individual himself wasn't satisfied with them, from the eyes of those around, his feats already looked superhuman. And to Rudel, everyone around exercised some tact, and no one would normally call over to him.

But on that day there was an individual to call out. His friend Luecke. Luecke generally carried his research late into the night, so his mornings never started too early. Yet now he wore mobile clothing with a wooden sword in his hand.

"You sure are energetic in the morning, Rudel."

"Luecke, how rare. You didn't do research yesterday?"

Rudel stopped swinging his sword and looked at Luecke. Wiping away his sweat, he tried to have a little chat. Ever since Vargas Graduated, there were few students who would ever talk to Rudel in his training, so Rudel was delighted to hear Luecke out.

"Can you lock blades with me for a bit? The way things are going, my grades are going to end up the same as Eunius', and that's something I can't bear."

Holding up his wood sword, Luecke took a stance for a sword style focused around thrusts. Without thinking anything in particular, Rudel took a stance as well. But in this circumstance, Luecke was the one receiving instruction. If there were any students capable of decently exchanging blows with Rudel, it would have to be Eunius or the upperclassmen.

"You're not stepping in far enough. And there's excess in your movements."

Parrying and repelling Luecke's thrust, Rudel pointed out his points of issue. Luecke tried to stress on and correct them, but as he focused too much on them, his balance crumbled. Rudel went right into lowering his own wooden sword, stopping it just short of his neck.

"Hah, I guess it's too early for me to practice with you... sorry for taking your time."

"It's fine. Rather, is your research going alright?"

"It's going just fine. But I don't want to have things end as a loss, right? If I graduate with nothing but a loss against you and Eunius, I'm sure I'll regret it. In that case, I have to do my best now."

As the two shed sweat, they wiped their brows and sat right over the lawn. Looking up at the sky, it was high today once more.

"More importantly, how's Aleist doing? The first semester's almost over, but is he still being pummeled around?"

"I wonder... last I saw of him, the tiger tribe men were taking turns having match after match with him. They were quite surprised with Aleist's stamina. Delightfully surprised, and they said the way things were going, he'd pick up their techniques in no time."

Luecke felt some pity for Aleist as he turned talks to the ceremony at the palace he had been unable to undergo the year before.

"That's a pity. But that aside, the knight appointment ceremony at the royal palace is this week. We were under house arrest so we couldn't attend last year, so we've got to get through with it this time."

It was an important ceremony where they would swear their loyalty to the country as knights. As they were receiving disciplinary action the year before, the three of them were unable to take it. Similarly, Izumi would be taking part this year as well.

"Ah, so it's been a year since then. It really does fly by..."

"Given our status, the king will personally be appointing us as knights. As the heads of the Three Lords are all gathering together this time, it seems the palace is in a festive mood."

As Rudel and the others were being appointed, the heads of the Three Lord Houses were dropping by the palace. Hearing that, Rudel informed Luecke he hadn't been told anything about it. Even when Rudel had been recognized by the king, Luecke gave a bitter smile at the Arses House's treatment of him.

Another reason for the palace's revelry was that this would be Rudel's debut in high society. The nobles showed some interest in finally seeing the individual who had received various forms of assessments. Luecke and Eunius' fathers were no exceptions.

"The bell's about to chime six. Shall we go to the dining hall, Rudel?"

"Yeah, Eunius might be awake too. He was making a ruckus over how starting yesterday, he had a class he couldn't be late to."

"He really is no good."

The two of them laughed as they made for the dining hall. By the time they arrived, a sleepy Eunius, and a similarly sleepy former goddess were restlessly eating breakfast.



Meanwhile, in the empire, Askewell and Mies were confirming the results of their experiment in the research facility on imperial soil. Inside a large cage, an ogre of black body and white markings was obediently taking a seat. It was only the prototype, but its performance was more than enough to satisfy Askewell.

"I received a report that it defeated one of its own ogre brethren under our orders, but I never thought it would develop to such an extent."

As Askewell seemed satisfied with the test subject, Mies killed her feelings and gave her thanks. But her mind was in chaos all the way. While Mies had been carrying out the experiments from before she met Askewell, she never thought she would be able to achieve such results. It felt almost as if all of it was contrived to work in her favor.

"Your words are wasted on me, general."

"You're quite the stiff one, Mies. But after reading a report on the experiment's results, I just got an urge to see the real thing. Even if I look like this, I used to be the scholarly type, see. I once intended to discard the sword I inherited and take up the scholar's path."

Hearing that unexpected tidbit, Mies was a little surprised. It was the moment she learned an unexpected side of the young imperial prince Askewell. Seeing the prince's face turn to a childish smile, Mies felt a little happy.

"You, general? Now that's a surprise. What sort of research were you doing?"

"Yeah, it was mostly on agriculture... hey, Mies. When the empire and the kingdom exist on the same continent, why must they be so different?"

On Askewell's question, Mies thought over what she should answer. She could tell he wasn't talking about a difference of custom, culture or language, but she didn't know what he was getting at.

"... Compared to the kingdom's abundance, the people of the empire have barely any to eat. I, you see, I set out to be a scholar to save the empire's people. But an experiment that's success I was certain of failed, and no matter how many theses I wrote, no one would ever look my way anymore. I was heartbroken, but even so, as a prince of the empire, I chose to work for the sake of its people."

"The land of the kingdom truly is plentiful. That's precisely why the empire needs to obtain fertile land even if it means going to war, but... so there was such a time for you, general."

Askewell hung his head, and as he raised it, his previous childish smile changed to a haunted one.

"It's laughable, really. No matter how hard I tried to save lives, I was just running in circles, but the moment I became a military man, the achievements just kept piling up. It's as if I was never cut out to be a scholar from the start. I get the feeling god is telling me that war was always the only option."

"General..."

Mies was coming to understand the individual called Askewell just a little bit more. But as Askewell's smile returned to its normal state, he spoke to Mies once more.

"I don't need the sympathy, and I haven't lost my objective of being useful to the people. The more land we obtain from the kingdom, the more of the empire's people we can save... and I'll be delighted if you could lend me your power at the time."

"Yes!"

Seeing Askewell's back as he walked from the facility, the anxieties Mies had to that point were blown away. Feeling as if all would be well as long as she followed him, Mies didn't feel the slightest sense of unease.

For Askewell was the third prince of the empire, and the Hero Aleist couldn't become.



Paying a visit to the palace, Rudel and the other students were split between nobles higher than Count Rank and those below for their investiture. As last year's class was noble-concentrated, there were fewer participants than average this year, but with the Three Lords' eldest sons taking part, the palace was rowdy.

"How stiff. Hey Rudel, wanna ditch?"

"I cannot do that! If I don't become a knight, I cannot become a dragoon."

Hating these sorts of formalities, Eunius invited Rudel to run off. But just as he expected, Rudel declined. The exchange was watched over restlessly by their underclassmen, the third years.

Luecke was calm, sitting at ease in the meeting room that had become their waiting room. But in that meeting room was a nervous Izumi. Thinking Izumi was worried about something, Rudel called over. But the cause of Izumi's anxiety was Rudel.

"Are you nervous, Izumi? It's alright, the ceremonies go the same way for both groups."

"... Rudel, why am I here?"

"That's easy. When I tried asking, they gave permission."

"Why did they give permission for me?"

"That's also easy. When the officials were hesitating over it, Eunius and Luecke came at just the right time and helped out."

"... You two..."

As Izumi directed her face to Luecke and Eunius, the two of them averted their eyes. But both their shoulders were shaking ever-so-slightly. They had taken such action for the kicks, but they had never imagined it would actually be permitted. But as the Three Lords' eldest sons requested it, the king also acknowledged Izumi's participation.

"Don't worry, Izumi. It used to be that the king personally did all of them. We only use this system because the numbers were so great that there was no helping it."

Izumi wanted to hold her head. She understood what Rudel was saying, but even so, there was something called atmosphere. It's not like everyone would hold a favorable impression of her, a foreigner in Courtois land. As Izumi hated stepping out of line, this ceremony was starting to feel like the trial of her life.

"There's nothing for you to worry about. If you're aiming to be a high knight, then that investiture will be a much grander one than this. You should get used to it while you can."

Luecke explained to console her, and as Izumi was weak when it came to that, she resolved herself. Just at the moment she set her resolve, officials of the palace informed those in the meeting room the preparations were in order.

In the hall, starting with the royal line, the ministers and the high ranking officials, officers, the high nobles and young knights watched over them. The students walked along the carpet spread over the hall, kneeling before the king all at once. This was where the royal orchestra was to show their mettle, and they put their all into their performance.

(So I've finally come all the way here...)

The king saw Rudel kneeling and gave a bitter smile as he recalled his meeting with the three in the infirmary. After two years, those three were finally becoming knights; looking at those around, the king turned his expression serious.

The ceremony went on as planned, and while the Diade and Halbades House heads' expressions were serious as they watched on their sons, they were rejoicing within. The nobles around each held a high assessment as they saw the Rudel of rumors. The way he carried himself was perfect. Even he wouldn't do anything outrageous during a ceremony, so the eyes of the nobles as they watched Rudel were serious indeed.

But the Arses House, Rudel's father alone held conflicted emotions. The honor he lost in Chlust's mishap had been regained by Rudel. But even so, he had grown to hold an emotion close to hatred towards him. He learned jealousy at this situation so different from when he was to step up.

Each individual was called individually by the king, and each would express words of loyalty in return. Once they became knights, they would earn status from the country, but the knight's status was accompanied by an obligation. If a war broke out, they were not permitted to flee. They swore to fight for the country's sake.

Ane like that, the hero prince Askewell and Rudel plunge forward towards their fated battle. The preparations were gradually underway for the war in a few years time.

Chapter 61

On the extended break of his fourth year, Rudel returned to his house for the first in quite some time. He hadn't been able to hold a conversation with his father at the appointment ceremony. Seeing Luecke and Eunius talk happily with their house heads, their fathers, he wanted to say thanks to his own father who had raised him to this point.

During his third year, he had devoted all his time to Chlust and had been unable to return, so he was also growing worried for his little sister Lena. Stepping down from the carriage and seeing his home for the first in a while, Rudel was surprised at the reception he received.

"What's this?"

Was the first line he said. The mansion's servants were all lined up to meet and greet him. Seeing the servants lined all the way from the gate to the entranceway, could a guest be coming? Rudel thought as he headed for the back door. But the soldiers at the gate hurriedly stopped him.

"Young master, please enter the mansion from the front door."

"Young master? Isn't a guest coming?"

"T-that isn't the case, We were told to prepare a greeting worthy of the next head..."

While the gatekeeper didn't even try to look him in the eye, Rudel thought a bit. Once he had finished thinking, he walked down the path- servants lined on both sides- to enter the mansion. Once he entered the manor, he was greeted by a butler. On this reception he had never received before, Rudel was troubled how to react as he spoke to that butler.

"You don't need to do this next time onwards. Just do things as you always have."

"But that's...! no, I'll let them know."

The butler who tried to say something before giving up led Rudel to his father, the house head's room. Even if you called it his father's room, it wasn't a room to do work or a study. It was the bedroom his mistresses stayed. The butler knocked the door, and after he informed the head that Rudel had arrived, a sleepy voice came from within.

'... Enter.'

The butler took a position outside, and Rudel alone entered the room. It was normally a room he would never enter, but as Rudel stepped in, he narrowed his eyes.

"Father, I have just returned from the academy for the extended break."

"I see, do whatever."

Seeing his father unmotivatedly bury his face into his mistress' bosom, Rudel mulled over whether to say what was on his mind. He got the feeling the location was way too bad. Filled with the stench of alcohol, numerous expensive dresses and gemstones were carelessly left all over the room. Taking a single bow, Rudel left and headed straight for his own room.



"The mansion really has been strange as of late. How should I put it? ... When I thought they were in a panic, their attitude suddenly changed."

Once he arrived at his own room, his little sister Lena who had heard of his return was already there. Rudel wasn't surprised at that, but he was shocked by Lena's growth. Her stature was high for a twelve-year-old, her hair grown out and bundled up on the left of her head. He still had vestiges of what he knew, but he had to say she had grown too big.

As the atmosphere of the manor had changed, he tried asking her, but Lena could only say the change was a sudden one. It was a response fitting of Lena, who never paid much attention to her surroundings, but Rudel couldn't comprehend the situation he was in. To that point, there were plenty of servants who wouldn't even acknowledge him when he returned home.

And yet, today everyone's attitude had changed. It was much too creepy, thought Rudel.

"More importantly, is the academy fun? You didn't come back last year, and when my big brother isn't here with me, I... I... ah, did you bring back anything nice?"

"I got some cake at the dining hall."

When she handed the cake over, Lena happily began eating it on the spot. She had grown taller and more mature, but seeing she hadn't changed too much inside, Rudel smiled.

"Even so, I can't feel at ease here. Just what could have happened? I'm sure it's related to Chlust being sent off to the border, but when they take such a blatant attitude, you know."

"This is what Erselica told me, but now that Chlust is gone, you're all they have left so they have to treat you good. When it was decided Chlust was off to the outskirts, Erselica was crying you know."

Hearing the name of his other little sister, Rudel recalled Erselica who had clung onto Chlust since she was small. And as he did, this time Lena spoke as if recalling something.

"Oh, right! Erselica's going to attend the academy once she turns fifteen, and get this! I'm going to be going with her! As a guard, or rather, the head said to look out and make sure no flies swarm around her. Erselica's going to marry into money, so the wife told me to make sure no poor people get near her at the academy..."

Around the last part Lena lost her high spirits, but hearing that, Rudel was convinced this territory had been driven into quite some financial straits. While they were still fine for now, Erselica who they had doted on so was to be married with money as the only criteria. Meaning status and character were inconsequential.

Recalling his own mother, Rudel grew sad as he wondered if that way of thought was correct.

"More importantly, bro! Have a match with me. I've raised my skills even higher in this past year, so perhaps I've even surpassed you."

"That so, then I'd better take you on with all I've got."

Rudel and Lena jumped out of the window. It was something they had done since they were kids, and an action they took without feeling anything was off. Holding up wooden sword and spear in the yard, the two of them contested until evening set in.



"You want to see the academy? You're still only twelve. Wait three years and you'll go whether you want to or not, right?"

While they were in the middle of break, Lena suddenly began holding interest in the academy as she incessantly pestered Rudel about it. As it was his sister's request, he would happily talk about his life at the academy. But that was a school life with Rudel at its base.

To put it lightly, it was a mistaken school life.

"It's a place where you destroy strong walls with magic and have life-or-death matches with your classmates, right? I want to go check it out now!"

There were around two weeks left of break, but Rudel thought. Maybe that wasn't a bad idea, he decided. When he confirmed it with the butler, his father's reply came back as 'do what you want'. Until that point, he wouldn't even answer if Rudel said such a thing.

It really made him feel uncomfortable, so he wanted to go to the academy. At the academy, there was Izumi and the former goddess so he wouldn't be bored. And if he brought Lena there, then she would probably be happy. He decided with such light sentiment.



"Whooooaah!! So this is the school cafeteria."

Rudel returned to the academy from his house's manor. When he came back with a week of break remaining, besides Izumi, Luecke and Eunius had returned as well. Coming to the academy and first heading towards the boy's dorm, Rudel ran into Luecke at the boy's dorm dining hall.

"This is the boy's dorm's dining hall. The school cafeteria's in the school building, so I'll take you there later."

"Rudel? You're back quite early... who's that you've got there?"

As Luecke grew curious of the individual besides Rudel, that Individual-Lena- smiled and gave her greeting. The clothes she wore were hand-me-downs from Rudel, so she was a belle in men's clothing.

"Pleasure to meet you! I'm my big brother's little sister, Lena."

"I-I see."

Luecke looked at Lena and ended up thinking of her as a female version of Eunius. In that case, he had no idea what to say, so he turned the conversation back to Rudel.

"Even if you wanted to take your sister here, isn't it a bit early for that? You couldn't wait until next year?"

Seeing Lena, given her height, Luecke thought she would be coming to the academy in a year or so. After Rudel explained about his little sister Lena, Luecke was surprised.

"Twelve!? You're a big one for twelve... no, my apologies."

"Don't worry about it, more importantly, is there a person called Euniushere around these parts?"

"Are you Euniushere's acquaintance? You have some business with him!"

Then and there, Lena pulled out the spear she kept over her back. She spoke with true delight.

"My broster said he's strong so I wanted to try fighting him!"

"You'd better give it a rest, Lena. It's a bit too early for you."

After Rudel calmed Lena down, Luecke was starting to see her as a Euniushere-like woman. A young girl as if Euniushere and Rudel were added together and averaged out. That was Luecke's impression of her. While Luecke would often quarrel with Euniushere on a regular basis, when he saw a similar point in Lena, he thought.

(O-oh god, why is my heart racing!? No, it couldn't be, something like that's...)

One look at Lena had Luecke feel emotions he had never experienced before. And without him being able to hold a proper conversation with the girl, she and Rudel headed off to the girls' dormitory.



The reason he headed for the girls' dorm was to retrieve the former goddess he had left in Izumi's care. During the break, he had handed Izumi the money he thought her food expenditure and various other expenses would take and asked her to look after her. Rudel could practically enter the girls' dorm without question. Rudel thought that was normal and paid it no mind.

"What sort of person is Izumi? Your girlfriend?"

"... No. She's a precious friend."

"Eeh, but you're always so happy when you talk about her, right? Why you lyin' to me"

Lena was interested in Izumi, who Rudel would talk about at the mansion. Being able to finally meet her, Lena was excited within. And yet she felt dissatisfaction at Rudel's statement that concealed his true feelings.

As they were talking, Izumi and the former goddess were eating in the girls' dorm dining hall. As the former goddess scarfed down a mountain of cake, Izumi gave a bitter smile as she sipped her tea and watched.

"... Hmmhohmm."

"Hey, you're not supposed to talk with food in your mouth, right? Welcome back, Rudel... and the one beside you is?"

"Ooooooh! It's Izumi in the flesh! I've found myself a real live Izumi!"

Izumi was somewhat surprised, being referred to as such, but seeing the color of Lena's hair, she wondered for just a moment if she had come from the orient.

"This is my little sister Lena. She said she was interested in the academy, so I brought her over."

Rudel carried out the second introduction, but the Lena in question was lifting the former goddess up like a child and looking at her with wonder. It looked almost as if an adult was doing an upsy daisy! To a child.

"This is a former goddess? I was kinda imagining something more impressive. What a letdown."

"H-hey you! What do you think you're saying!? Even if you add a former, I'm still a goddess! And yet what do you have to be disappointed with!?"

Seeing Lena's dejected face, the former goddess raged on with cream sticking to her mouth. But having lost interest, Lena remembered it was right about noon. And this was the girls' dorm dining hall... she looked at Rudel with pleading eyes.

"Yeah, you can order whatever you want."

"As expected of my brother! Then a large serving of the special, and a large serving of that one ala carte, and should I eat this one too? Last is dessert, but... well, whatever."

"Hold it right there! When they have such delicious desserts, you order them not, instead ordering a large portion of everything on the daily menu? And you call yourself a woman?"

Having finished her cake, the former goddess looked at Lena who showed no interest in dessert as if she was looking at an endangered species. Ignoring all that, Lena received her heaping portions from the lunch lady, took her seat and started eating with good momentum. It could only be called the grandest of gobbling techniques.

"She ignored me! Rudel, that woman just ignored me!"

"I'm sorry, I'll put a word in later. That aside, you... haven't been causing Izumi any trouble, have you?"

Rudel turned his eyes from the frozen former goddess to Izumi. Izumi gave a slight smile as she explained it was alright. And the former goddess worshiped her for it.



Adding on Izumi and the former goddess from the girls' dorm, the four of them walked off together. And just as they did, came the form of Aleist running away from the tiger tribe. Having resigned himself to training over the long vacation, Aleist leapt at Rudel as soon as he spotted him. Grabbing Rudel by the lapels, Aleist wept as he spoke.

"R-Rudel... what have you done!!!?"

"Hmm? What's up, Aleist?"

"Don't what's up me! Worked to the bone by those scary faces every day! I thought time and again I was really going to die, you hear! Those guys are way too serious, and I can't keep up with their flow and... geh!"

Noticing something, Aleist swiftly ran off, and this time a few tiger tribe men came running in pursuit of Aleist. As they passed by Rudel's group, they lowered their heads to Izumi.

Seeing Izumi's bitter smile, Lena spoke.

"Izumi-san's an amazing person. To have those scary people lowering their heads... is she actually scary?"

"N-no! That's, well... I only permitted it because Rudel said he needed it no matter what for Aleist's sake. I never thought it would ever come to this."

Izumi tried to resolve Lena's misunderstanding, but as a matter of fact, she had become an existence the demi-humans couldn't ignore. Both nobles and commoners kept an eye on her. The reasons being she could speak normally with those related to the Three Lords, and she was the one in control of Rudel's petting. Oblivious to her true importance, Izumi didn't have a grasp on the surrounding situation.



Once Lena went back off to the house, Eunius just missed her as he met up with Rudel's group. Having spotted Luecke, Eunius had heard about Lena and gone searching for Rudel.

"What's this, so Rudel's little sister already went back?"

"It's your fault for playing around. Well, she was a good girl."

At that moment, he recalled the talks that came up when he had returned to the house. In exchange for a loan, the Arses House put forth talks of an engagement between Erselica and Eunius. Eunius' father and the surrounding nobles were against it, so the discussions were washed away.

"Come to think of it, Rudel, there were some talks about an engagement between me and your sister."

"Say what!? Then what am I to call you henceforth? Since we'll be relatives, brother-in-law? Or brother of mine?"

Rudel reacted seriously to Eunius' joke. Usually, that would be fine, but hearing that story, Luecke came under a misunderstanding.

"A-an engagement to Rudel's sister (Lena) you say!?"

"Hmm? That's right, there were some talks about an engagement to her (Erselica)."

Hearing that talk, what sister did he mean? Rudel thought. But Luecke was sure it was the little sister Lena. While he knew of Erselica's existence, Eunius' sudden statement and the impression of Lena whom he'd just met had remained in his mind.

"What's up with you?"

Eunius asked as Luecke hung his head. And raising his face, Luecke made a proclamation. Everyone present was surprised at the words they'd never usually hear from him.

"It's on... Eunius, I challenge you to a duel!"

Chapter 62

Luecke's duel uproar soon reached the ears of the academy's headmaster. There was no way the academy could permit a duel between legitimate children of the Three Lords' Houses, and they were pressed for how to respond. The problem didn't just lay with Luecke, but also in that Eunius had consented to the dual. And while they had tried to duke it out on the spot, Rudel had brought a stop to it.

But the reason he stopped it wasn't because fighting was bad. He proposed they choose an appropriate spot for their match. As Rudel had simply added fuel to the fire, those concerned cursed him as they thought up a plan.

They thought and mulled... and took up the idea the headmaster had wrung out.



"The individual matches of the second term? Sure enough, I have no objections with the time and place. It seems Eunius was going to participate from the start, and even if Luecke turns in an application now, I'm sure he'll make it in time. Since the academy proposed it, he'll probably be able to even if he doesn't make it."

Hearing the notification from the academy, Rudel's reaction was level. It wasn't as if he didn't think anything of a duel between friends. But once was enough, Rudel thought it was necessary for the two of them to seriously clash.

"Isn't that terrible? As a friend, that's a terrible response, Rudel?"

"Why is that? From the point of view of you goddesses, shouldn't this be a delightful development."

Hearing that, the former goddess thought. Two who usually didn't get along would duel and become honest with their feelings...

"It's the best! I mean no, you're the worst! If you're their friend, you should at least mediate their fights."

She gave a wide grin as she rebuked Rudel. Rudel handed her a cake to shut her up for a bit, and spent a while in thought. The two of them didn't get along well, but they did share some common worries, and it wouldn't be strange if they got along in the academy. Or so he thought. And in truth, Rudel got along with both of them.

Even if their houses were at odds, there was something called a sense of distance. If they hated each other, they could just stay away, but the two of them stayed within an arm's length. Rudel found it a mystery.

"I'm sure the two of them are actually friends."

"... ? I think they really don't get along, you know? They're just getting along because you're there, or because it's interesting to be around you, right?"

Hearing the words of the former goddess who'd finished her cake, Rudel wondered if that was the case. But he decided this duel would be the perfect place for them to spit up the dissatisfactions they had been building up towards one another. And before he could think about anyone else, he wanted to prioritize polishing his control of his power.



Luecke swung his sword alone in the boys' dorm courtyard. When it came to battle, he was more often than not charged with magic on the back lines, so he needed to polish the close combat skills he knew he was lacking. Vexing as it was, Luecke was well aware he couldn't beat Eunius when it came to close combat.

"Just how far can I go in the short time remaining... no, what good is whining? This battle alone is one I can't lose. And there's no way I can lose

to that guy (Eunius)!"

Luecke had learned a sword style focused on thrusts, but he had even less talent than Rudel. The experience he'd built up didn't even reach Eunius' or Rudel's feet.

That's how he was, but it wasn't as if he didn't have a chance. Magic... he was more skilled in it than anyone, and his talent and the experience and knowledge he'd built up trumped the both of them. Even with that magic, he had been unable to stand against Rudel in the past, so he was unable to be conceited in it.

He had a trump card, but wanting another hand to play, Luecke polished his swordplay.



In contrast, Eunius also took up a surprising action. He dropped by the magic proving grounds he would never usually approach. As he usually fought centered around the sword more than magic, Eunius had neglected the thing called magic.

You could say that was simply how high his talent in the sword was, but he understood that alone wasn't enough to win.

Their battles with Rudel had changed Luecke and Eunius. He was still polishing his sword, but surely Luecke would expect that and draft up countermeasures. Thought Eunius. So he decided to hastily acquire some magic.

"Tsk, that thickhead... but well, this is a good opportunity. It isn't a bad thing to have a serious fight."

Eunius spoke with a ferocious smile. What he wanted was a magic he could use in real combat. He knew a number of the magics taught at the academy, but if he couldn't use them in battle, they were pointless. That on his mind, Eunius recalled the magic he had taken from Rudel.

Touching his hands to his chest, Rudel had used a violent method of smacking magic in at point blank.

"I could just ask Rudel, but this is something I should resolve on my own. I don't want to lose against that guy (Luecke), after all."

Eunius stood in front of the wall erected to fire magic at, and from memory, he tried imitating Rudel. Even if it was an imitation, he didn't touch his palm against the wall. Cladding his fist in magic, he slammed it in.

The impact hurt his fist, but a crack spread across the wall.

"That hurt like hell! If I keep at it like this, my fist will break... do I put in more magic? Unlike the sword, it seems easier to control, but the timing is harder."

Eunius thought back to when Rudel had used it. This time he put in more than double the mana and smacked the wall.

"This is going to take some time..."

Eunius looked at the blown-away wall as he muttered. He had got the timing off, but the wall had been obliterated. Normally, this wouldn't be a problem, but his opponent was Luecke. When it came to magic, Eunius recognized he was much greater than he, and he couldn't be satisfied with these results.



"I-I'm doooooonnee!!!"

Aleis's job change to black knight held martial arts as one of its prerequisites, and while it was hard to say it ended safely, he had succeeded. Training in the arts over the course of a few months, Aleis had definitely grown. As proof of his black knight status, he could now control the darkness from his shadow. He shed tears of passion.

But to the men of the tiger tribe, such a thing was irrelevant. More than that, hating doing things half-assed, they took Aleist's completed martial arts with a grain of excitement.

"Of course there's more to come, you fool! Today, we're starting from the basics again."

"So you've come that far... finally, our dearest wishes shall too."

"For our big brothers who've already graduated, we'll learn for their share as well!"

"Eh? No. We can just end it here, so I'll report to Rudel and..."

""Shut it and get back to work!!!"

"H-how unreasonabbbblee!!!"

Aleist's troubles continued...



At the time Aleist cried out, Rudel was practicing unity of body and mind. At the rapid growth of his physical abilities and magic, it had become quite frequent that they would go out of his control. When he tried firing magic, it wasn't only once or twice that he was blown away himself. The output was too different, and what he had to do was close to relearning control from the ground up.

And for Rudel, the greatest reason he practiced his meditation was Lena's words. When he had been making sure not to be conscious or Izumi, Lena's words had caused him to waver.

Recalling them again, Rudel stopped his mental concentration and stood. When his sister had uncovered his lie, he had no choice but to admit it was so. He didn't put it to words, but Rudel had definitely lied when it came to Izumi. And even if it came out in his actions, he had intended to conceal his feelings.

This time he tried to swing his wood sword. But even if he swung it, it hadn't a fragment of its usual cutting edge.

"If I'm like this, then I don't have the time to worry about those two."

Rudel looked up as he muttered.



"Aleist-dono is training with the tiger tribe boys?"

"So it seems. It appears he was at the academy over break, training his martial arts."

The long break over, Fina returned to the academy. Her guard captain Sophina had arrived beforehand to prepare for her arrival. Because of that, hse had caught wind of some of the academy's rumors to tell her.

In Fina's cleanly-kept room at the academy, Fina sat on the sofa as she sipped some black tea. The individual was delighted at being released from her stiff life at the palace, but... Sophina's report caused her insides to turn with rage.

"It looks like he has it hard."

(T-that damn homo! You mean to say he's been fluffing around with all the tiger tribe men when I was away!? Even I've been forced into a no fluff life at the palace, but that Aleist... I'll put a curse on him!)

"Yes, he's had his fair share of troubles. Also, Luecke-dono of the Halbades house will be participating in this years individual tournaments. It seems he raised a bit of an uproar, challenging Eunius-dono to a duel."

"Oh my."

(Like I care! Delaying to give a report on master, and saying nothing but such inconsequential information... that's why your last marriage interview was a failure.)

"Yes, and about Rudel-sa... Dono! Apparently he brought his sister over. He showed her around the academy, and I heard a report that she was quite an interesting child."

"Sister? Could you be talking about Erselica-san?"

(I think there was such a girl. Though I don't really remember her.)

While Fina thought such terrible things within, her expressionless face and level-headed responses made sure her opponent would ever notice. But Sophina's report brought a sudden change to that.

"No, it seems she is the daughter of Archduke Arses' mistress. A girl of rare black hair, I heard she got along considerably well with Rudel."

"W-what was that... black hair? I see, so the reason he likes black hair is his sister..."

"P-princess?"

"To think my master was a man of such high-level preferences. That's why he kept 'that woman' by his side to fill in the gaps."

(Hmm, so I've finally uncovered the reason he likes black hair. To summarize, it's the little sister factor! And once I get my hands on it, my era shall come! The times are a changeggg!!!)

Leaving nervous Sophina to the side, Fina decided her future objectives. The little sister factor, or rather, she was to approach Rudel while drawing attention to the fact she was a little sister. Thinking over that plan, she thought over what she would require first. Cuteness? Expressionless, so out of the question. Sweetness? Expressionless so out of the question. Be cold and then kind... she didn't know if Rudel would be able to comprehend her intent, so out of the question.

"Princess, won't you give up on Rudel-dono already? Even if it may be the request of a princess, Rudel-dono has the circumstances of the Arses House to deal with, so... are you listening to me, princess?"

(She's definitely thinking something different under that expressionless face... hah, can't someone take over this job from me? My marriage interview failed, and everyone's looking at me with warm eyes now.)

"Right. First, I'd like to meet with my flu... Mii, Sophina."

(Dangit, master is surprisingly hard to conquer. In that case, I guess I should relax and get some fluffing as I think long and hard over it. My fluff bars are running low, so Mii ain't sleeping tonight!)

"Princess, Mii will not return until tomorrow."



The characters who would become the protagonist's comrades based on the route he chose. Those were Luecke and Eunius. Luecke who boasted powerful magic, and Eunius who specialized in close combat, the story advanced by choosing between them. While they were both reliable allies in the latter half of the game, by no means could you obtain both of them.

It was a problem that came when the commoner protagonist committed an act of discourtesy against a noble. The Halbades House or the Diade House, he would need to have one of them back him. And by that flow, and the fact they were each at the top of a faction, he would lose the chance to get to know the other.

They held a position in society to protect the protagonist who would become a hero. Once the game entered its war arc, a factional dispute would break out causing the Courtois Kingdom to be late to react, and from then on, they held a role of saving the protagonist.

The one who caused the factional dispute was the one who wasn't chosen. The chosen one fought alongside the protagonist as justice. But that meant the one not chosen would have to be evil.

If they weren't chosen, they would become an enemy. That was the pair of Luecke and Eunius. And the fates of the two were beginning to move at the climax of the midgame.

Chapter 63

When it came to the biggest event of the second term, for the fundamental curriculum, it would have to be the wilderness training. For the upperclassmen, the individual entry tournament. The individuals' tournament was an event held while the fundamental curriculum students were gone. And this time's tournament held even more excitement than the norm.

Last year's champion Eunius, and the runner-up Aleist. Alongside the first-time challenger Luecke, and the greatest problem child since the academy's founding Rudel; a lineup to fire up the academy's spirits.

Unlike the students who expected to see a match of fates, the teachers could only pray the Three Lords' eldest sons didn't get injured. Last time, and the time before, their stomachs had gone into spasms seeing Rudel and the others run ragged. But elsewhere from the teachers' hopes, Rudel and the others were putting in their all.

"We're all over the place. If we ever go against one another, it'll have to be in the semi-finals."

Rudel looked at the posted individuals' tournament bracket as he muttered. Listening in to his side, Luecke was also convinced he would fight Eunius in the semi-finals.

"I wanted to get it over with quick, but the semi-finals are fair enough. Looks like it's your fated battle with Aleist as well. We might be going at one another in the finals."

While Luecke thought he was going to win, Aleist called over. He had come with Eunius to see the tournament bracket.

"Um, I also intend to win, but..."

"You've got no need to worry about who you'll go up against in the finals."

Cutting off Aleist's statement part-way, Eunius intimidated Luecke. On that atmosphere, the other students who were similarly confirming the brackets distanced themselves. A prickly tense air ruled the area, but from Lena's words, Rudel's concentration was much lower than the other three.

"How interesting for you to come and provoke me. Because you can't win, you plan to play your wits? All I hear are the howlings of a sore loser."

Luecke feigned level-headedness, but his feelings towards Lena and Eunius were becoming complicated things. From a want to win, to hatred... and he was beginning to think of them as simply natural feelings.

"You make me laugh. Meanwhile, you've got no mind to use your wits or to give it your all. I'll be facing Rudel in the finals, so you look just right for preserving my stamina."

Giving a grin, Eunius continued intimidating Luecke. On those words, Aleist grew mindfully irritated. He had been training too. Undergoing a grueling training regiment, he looked at Rudel with confidence. If he defeated Rudel, everyone would recognize him... he thought.

The Rudel in question was more worried about his feelings for Izumi than the other three. He was thinking too hard on it, and at this point, he was avoiding her so much it seemed unnatural.

"... So the tournament's already here."

He had no hesitation in becoming a dragoon, but when Izumi was brought out, his heart would waver. For Rudel alone, his feelings were going in a different direction.



"The individuals' tournament... how interesting."

(I don't really care. I care about it as much as that fluffless palace.)

Fina was looking at the tournament bracket she had been handed by Sophina. From Sophina's point of view, she had some interest in seeing how strong a student could become. What's more, the four who were participating were definitely strong.

"I think Rudel, who didn't participate last time, will win. What do you think, princess?"

Handing the paper back to Sophina, Fina spoke.

"I think so too, but Eunius-dono has more experience so he might have the advantage."

(So master's your one and only? Just how thirsty are you for his petting, woman?)

Some time had gone by since the second semester began and Fina had gradually transitioned from her life in the palace to the sort of fluffy lifestyle she preferred, spending her time in fulfillment. Even if she mulled over how to conquer Rudel, she didn't care about much else. But there a single something came to mind.

"Well no matter who wins, we should give him praise, Sophina."

(This is my chance! Even if master loses here, he won't be forced to leave the academy. In that case, if master loses and I wrap him in these transient breasts of mine... even if I can't conquer him, I'll grasp at the opportunity!)

"I-is that so, princess?"

(Huh? The princess is thinking something strange under that poker face again... I'll just ignore it.)

"I'm looking forward to it."

(That black hair and that traitorous junior disciple better prepare themselves! I'll lift master's petting ban in no time.)

As Fina polished her schemes, she spent that day faithful to her desires.



In the girls' dorm, the former goddess and Izumi looked at the tournament bracket. As Rudel had been unnaturally avoiding Izumi lately, the former goddess had been hanging around her more. Rudel knew that, and at this point, he could give the former goddess her own money to pay for her own expenses.

"So Rudel and Aleist will hit in the semi-finals."

"Ah, you mean that trainee? If only he was still a trainee, I'd be able to laugh. But if he loses to Rudel, I'll still be able to laugh."

After giving the former goddess a smile, Izumi looked out the window and breathed a sigh. She knew Rudel was avoiding her. But Izumi wouldn't press him on it. Both sides were aware of the reasons. They understood, but those around couldn't leave them be.

"... If Rudel loses I'm going to laugh too, Izumi."

"Yeah, your right."

Seeing Izumi's unmotivated response, the former goddess sensed she was the same as Rudel. The former goddess who had no interest in status or fame, up until recently she was fuzzy on nobility itself. There was the king, then the nobles and finally the commoners... that was the ranking in her head.

If she complained to Rudel she was ignored, and no matter what she said to Izumi, she would only get a sad smile.

"Izumi, if you don't properly tell him your feelings, they'll never get across. I mean, it's Rudel we're talking about here. That man who can't read the mood, there's no way he could understand your feelings."

"That's... but we both have our positions. Me and Rudel can't become anything more than friends."

"You humans sure are a pain! You could all live just fine without some status or title."

Even if the former goddess was the one to say it, she lacked any fragment of persuasive power. In essence, the former goddess was being protected by Rudel's status as a noble, and only by it was she able to live in the academy.

"But just living isn't enough for Rudel. If Rudel doesn't keep looking up, then even if he lives, it'll be the same as death... he's enduring various things for that."

Izumi spoke as if saying it to herself, and the former goddess made a face as if she couldn't understand a word of that. Life the same as death. It meant if Rudel gave up on becoming a dragoon, he wouldn't be Rudel anymore.

"Izumi... I don't get what you're trying to say."



On the day of the tournament, Rudel and the others could see the spectators flooding the arena's seats from the waiting room window. Once the opening ceremony ended, they were sent right to the waiting room. Some moved their bodies, and others called their hearts. And even within that waiting room, all manner of eyes were gathering on the four.

As Aleist looked at Rudel, he saw he was acting differently from usual. At first, he thought Rudel was nervous too, but then he recalled he wasn't that sort of person.

As he looked on, Eunius who was watching the match called out.

"Whooh, they're all giving it their all. Aleist, your turn's coming up."

"Eh? Oh, yeah."

"What's with that, where'd your spirit go? Well you're better off than the guy who can only do magic."

"..."

In the waiting room, all the competitors' stomachs were beginning to hurt. Usually the man who couldn't read the mood- Rudel- would step in to mediate, but now he wasn't even trying to move. Realizing that the one they had their expectations on, Rudel wasn't of any use, everyone waited for their own match to come.

Just like that, the matches went on and on. Ruel and the others fought their ways through, and it was finally time for the semi-finals to commence.



"We'll really have to fix this."

The manager of the arena looked at the parts of the ring Eunius had destroyed in his fight with a fifth year as he reached that conclusion. He had no complaints with the contents of the match itself, but the ring was in tatters. They couldn't hold a match like this.

"It'll take at least an hour."

When he informed the teacher serving as referee, the teachers and staff gathered for a meeting. Whether to carry the match over to the next day, or spend an hour repairing it.

"Then I'll leave it to you to repair it. The next match also looks like one that'll break the ring, so once that's over, we'll call it a day. The rest will have to wait for tomorrow."

"You make my work sound so worthwhile..."

The manager took a few boys along and began mending the ring with magic. They could just increase the men on the job, but they weren't using any special magic. If anyone without experience unskillfully stuck their

hands in, the ring would never hold up. You could call it the tricks of the trade.

But if they continued holding matches in the arena alone, the matches were liable to run into the night. That on their minds, the teachers decided to split up the semi-finals. The magic proving ground was strengthened, and it wouldn't be a problem, they decided. Eunius and Luecke's match would be held in the arena, while Rudel and Aleist would duke it out in the proving grounds.

As the competitors and referees and the students who were helping mend the arena headed off, the audience got into heated debate over which match to see. Both matches had some worth and watching, and contained a connection of fates. Both matches were ones they wanted to see, and the students were heated as well.

"What will you do, Izumi?"

Within all that, the former goddess tried asking Izumi. Izumi thought for just a bit before standing from her seat in the arena and heading off for the magic grounds.

"I'll go see Rudel and Aleist's match. I'm sure he'll be lonely over there with no acquaintances to watch."

Giving an excuse, Izumi pulled the former goddess' hand and walked off.



Over the arena's hour long break, Eunius and Leucke glared at one another. They had both been aware of one another from the moment they were born. As fellow nobles of Courtois, opposing houses would instill the information on their enemies from childhood.

"Did they really have to go this far, normally?"

"... I'm going to pound magic into that heated face of yours, Eunius."

Hearing those words, Eunius' fed up face turned to the fearsome smile of a bird of prey. The impression Luecke gave off was even colder than usual. As the two glared at one another, the starting signal resounded through the arena.

"Henceforth, the semi-finals shall commence! Begin!"

Hearing the referee's voice, the two of them sprung to motion. Eunius thought Luecke would try to take distance, and tried to close the space in an instant. But Luecke took an unexpected action. Luecke also leapt forward, bringing the match to a contest of blades. Eunius was surprised, but perhaps that's where his genius lay.

"That was a shocker, but that's all you've got? How soft!"

It was the moment he parried the wood sword Luecke thrust out. Eunius sensed danger and leapt back. As expected, to the place he had been standing flew a number of elementary magics.

"You've got good instinct. But don't think this is the end."

Luecke took a stance with his sword, but this time he used magic to fill in the space between Eunius and himself. Clicking his tongue, Eunius put his all into evasive action as he looked for an opportunity to approach.

He avoided and used the mana in his sword to cut through the magic blasts raining down. Repeating the process, he was thinking of inviting Luecke to expend all his mana. He thought over it, but... he wouldn't permit himself to do that.

"This is the last time you can get on your high horse!!"

Receiving a few hits of magic, Eunius flooded mana into his pseudo magic sword to move it like a witch. By that, he spread out his reach and launched an attack at Luecke's neck. But without panic, Luecke stopped it with the wood sword in his own hands. No, he erased it.

"You've surprisingly dull. Even if it's a sham, it's no different from a magic sword. In that case, there's no problem as long as I can put up the right defenses."

"Oy, oy, what do you think you're doing... just when things were getting fun, no one was asking for a lecture!"

Caring not for his disappearing magic sword, Eunius leapt straight at Luecke. As the space between them closed in, Luecke fired magic at point black range. It was a self-damaging move he had used in his match with Rudel, and now he used it to create some distance.

"For a battle maniac like you, this is more than enough!"

When Luecke unleashed a stream of intermediate magic, even Eunius took distance. He did, but carrying out the calculations, Luecke read his moves as he aimed. The magics assailing Eunius were high in output and vast in scope. It was impossible to avoid them all.

"Not bad!!!"

But if you can't avoid, then don't, thought Eunius as he leapt straight into the magic. Carving them up with his magic sword, and enduring those he couldn't avoid even so.

"Are you human!?"

Luecke took distance as he prepared his trump card. Feeling that Eunius' wood sword was nearing its limit, he decided to use that to decide the match. And Eunius also felt his sword's end drawing near and went on the offense.

"This is the end, Eunius!"

"Don't make light of me, beansprout!"

Sensing Luecke had prepared something, Eunius put the maximum magic he could into his sword and lowered it at him. Seeing that, Luecke was convinced of his victory. Eunius' swordplay exceeded Rudel, but if they fought they would lose. Luecke knew the reason why. He had an

overwhelming lack of cards in his hands. He was to fixated on forcing his way through with his sword.

So Luecke thought, and even when he had erased the magic sword, Eunius had simply tried the same means again.

"Bastard!"

Eunius' magic sword didn't reach Luecke. No, before it could reach, he could lower it no longer. Eunius was surrounded by Luecke's wall of magic, the wall gradually shrinking in scope. Before that sturdy wall his sword couldn't collapse, Eunius' wooden sword snapped.

"You're surrounded on all sides, and if you try running into the sky, you'll be shot down. There's nothing you can do when you don't have a sword, Eunius."

The magic he had begun preparing from the moment he was running around was a sturdy one. He would have to buy ample time while utilizing a number of different spells, but Luecke had pulled it off. Everyone was convinced of his victory when a cloud of dust rose the sturdy wall fell apart. The sound of crumbling rock resounded through the arena, the spectators swallowed their breath.

"Don't think a wall of dirt would be able to stop me."

Tattered as he was, Eunius walked towards Luecke with an intrigued, ferocious smile on his face. Luecke tried to prepare magic, but Eunius closed the distance in an instant, hammering a fist into his stomach. On that impact greater than anything he had anticipated, Luecke couldn't even understand what had happened as he was blown through the air.

"Just as I thought, it really is hard to do it with your fists. But... this is usable!"

As Luecke tried to stand, Eunius gave pursuit to instill the final blow. This time Luecke put up both his arms to guard, but his crossed arms couldn't withstand the impact. Feeling the sound of breaking bones through his

body, Luecke let out a cry. Surrounding his fist with magic, he was slamming them in with brute force. That was all there was to it. That was Eunius' trump card.

"GAAaah!"

"Hah, hah, that's not all there is to it!"

But channelling magic through his broken arms, Luecke used a self-harming attack on Eunius as he swung his fist towards him. An explosion broke out between them sending both sides flying. Eunius waited for the smoke of the explosion to die down, surprised when Luecke leapt out of the cloud. He was surprised, but seeing Luecke's face that had yet to give up, he cried out.

"Nice pluck, but you see..."

As Eunius tried to say something, Luecke cried out as if to answer him. It was the true feelings of the two that just happened to overlap.

"You alone I can't lose to!"

"You alone I don't want to lose to!"

Eunius sent a punch at Luecke, but his magic had disappeared. Eunius' mana was also approaching its limit. And receiving that hit. Luecke launched an attack at his head. His attack perfectly caught Eunius in the jaw.

Both of them were unsteady on their feet, their eyes unable to focus. Just like that, they stopped moving without even the slightest twitch. The referee confirmed their states, and once he found they had both lost consciousness, he declared.

"This match... is a draw!"

As everyone was about to boo out the ref's answer, a tremor and the sound of an explosion strong enough to reach the arena came from the magic proving ground.

Chapter 64

In the magic proving grounds the match's start came later than Luecke and Eunius'. The reason being the time it took to repair, and the surprising number of people that gathered. The fact that Fina also chose to watch Rudel's match was another reason for the late start. And the reason an explosion resounded from the magic grounds to the arena. It was naturally because of the two locked in battle

"Get serious against me, Rudel!"

From Aleist's shadow, something similar to a black liquid squirmed around, changing shape to come at Rudel. At times a sword, at times a spear, it took on various shapes.

"Aleist... why are you..."

And as Aleist's black weapons stabbed into the ground, they would raise explosions. The cause of the larger explosion lay in that his power suddenly ran rampant. To Rudel, it looked almost as if Aleist was being swung around by his own power. As this was the magic proving ground, the casualties weren't great. More than that, everyone was uninjured.

But the special walls protecting the spectators had all been destroyed.

"You... um aren't you forgetting to conceal it?"

Right, Aleist was getting too high strung, and normally he would have concealed it. He had exposed his characteristics as a black knight before a crowd. As ill fate would have it, it was a stage the second princess Fina was watching.



"Aaaah!"

After the large explosion, when the smoke had cleared up, the former goddess cried out. Izumi to her side was surprised at her reaction.

"I-I just remembered. I remembered, Izumi! If Aleist keeps at it like this, he'll run out of control!"

"What do you mean by that? It's true that Aleist has always been a little strange, but I don't think he'll go on a rampage."

"Black knight! Aleist is a black knight!"

Izumi couldn't understand the former goddess' cry. It was here that the secrecy of the black knight class was rearing his head. Those around only thought Aleist was using a special sort of magic. At the sudden events, the teachers were late to respond.

To the two of them came Fina with her high knights. Her face was expressionless, but her tone was serious.

"Black knight... tell me the details."

"T-the strange woman came outt!"

While the former goddess was fearful of Fina, Rudel and Aleist's battle continued. A state of Aleist on the offense, and Rudel on the defense carried on

The surrounding students were excited by a fight they had never seen before, and didn't even try to run. But at this fight they had never seen before, the teachers felt a sense of crisis. They thought to evacuate the place at once, or to suspend the match. But there were few teachers, and the excited students wouldn't hear them out.

Izumi and the others asked the former goddess about Aleist and Rudel. Once she finished her explanation on the events of the temple and the reason Aleist was training his martial arts, Fina looked at the fighting two.

"This is bad."

(Bad, really bad! When it comes to black knights, they're a title with meaning to the royal line. Yet that guy became a black knight... you think I can push him onto my sister?)

As the black knight was a knight with special meaning, Fina knew he would probably be taken into the royal family or palace. But if that happened, it would make it even harder to get her hands on Rudel. As the second princess, she was a much more likely candidate for the black knight's hand than Aileen.

"Princess, this place is dangerous. We should evacuate..."

On Sophina's words, Fina voiced approval. But the former goddess alone proposed they stop the two. The reason was simple. If the white and black knights completely awakened to their abilities, they would run out of control. Remembering the brothers who awoke to their powers, the former goddess who had seen their rampage's face turned pale.

Back when she was a goddess, her body was half-transparent and she had no physical essence. But now her body existed. That was more than enough for the former goddess to realize the danger.

"More importantly, go stop those two. If both of them awaken, they'll go on a rampage, and something terrible will... this whole place will be destroyed."

Everyone lent a glance to the fight of Rudel and Aleist. There, Fina looked at the formed goddess and spoke.

"You tell us to stop that?"

(You incompetent! On top of keeping quiet up to now, you want us to stop those two? That's impossible, foool!!! This strange black thing is stretching and explosion, and it's all muddy and gross. To be able to fight against that, master is quite a monster himself.)

"We have to stop them! Otherwise they'll both run amuck!"

"Eh?"

Sophina wanted to evacuate Fina alone, but she held a question at the 'both' part. And everyone around began to notice... she was talking about Rudel.

"Rudel's also a black knight!?"

As Izumi panicked, the former goddess cried out. Cried out so loudly that everyone in the general area ended up hearing her words.

"As. I. Was. Saying! Rudel is the white knight, and Aleist is the black knight!"

The audience had noticed that Rudel and Aleist's battle was abnormal, and their excitement was dying down. The cry came just as the area had grown quiet, and the former goddess' voice resounded all throughout the magic proving grounds.

"You stupid disciple, you've sure done it now."

(Oy, oy! When it comes to the white knight, he's even dicier than the black knight... why can't master live a quiet life of the fluff? You make me sad... leaving the jokes aside, you shouted something so important here, you bloody incompetent!!!)



Avoiding darkness in the shape of a sword, Rudel channeled mana into his wooden sword to cut through Aleist's magic that flew his way. A black something and magic attacks put Rudel on a one-sided defense. That black something in the shape of weapons... that darkness, whether he blocked or parried, it would simply explode. A troublesome thing to no ends.

"I can win, with this I can beat you... I can win against Rudel!"

By gaining confidence in himself, Aleist was growing bolder, and just as the former goddess said, he was beginning to go on a rampage. Rudel dealt

with the attacks coming at him, but inside, his concentration was taking a cut. His awakening as a white knight was being dragged out by the black knight Aleist.

(I'm going to lose? I, when I'm supposed to become a dragoon!? I can't let such a thing come to pass! Even if I discard everything, I have to be the strongest... I have to become the strongest dragoon!!!)

An emotion welling up from his depths, Rudel was being swallowed up without even noticing it. They wanted to win. That was the wish of both sides. And as the two began to be swallowed by the power birthed from doubt, the forces of the white and black knights were drawn out. Their actions paying no heed to surrounding eyes made it almost seem the spectators were completely irrelevant.

By that influence, the shockwaves of their match reached all the way to the audience seats. All the things they had been mindful of to that point, now it all seemed so inconsequential... it was all for victory, it was all for dreams...

Light gathered in Rudel's left hand and forming the shape of a bolt, he fired it at Aleist. As the bolt of light clashed with Aleist's darkness, it let off an intense explosion.

"That's right! Come at me for real, Rudel!"

"Aleissttt!!!"

And this time he sent a consecutive stream of light bolts from his left hand. That downpour of bullets met Aleist's dark weapons in an intense clash. And Rudel's pseudo magic sword let off a radiant light as it sublimated into a magic sword of the truest sense. Coinciding with that, Aleist's magic sword wrapped his own wood sword in what seemed to be black flames.

As the two wood swords met, the sound they gave of had no semblance of what should come from wood hitting wood. The violent clash of mana let off a din close to an explosion accompanied by thunder.

Both sides used their magic to elevate their physical abilities, rampaging to levels beyond their own control. Sensing the danger, the teachers and staff tried to evacuate the students at once. They evacuated, but as progress slowed to a halt around the sole entrance, many students still remained in the magic proving ground.

"With this, I'm number one... I'll become number onnnnee!!!"

Cried Aleist, but the trail of his sword could never catch Rudel. It couldn't, but the shockwave it produced destroyed the wall and the hastily prepared benches.

Judging that he wasn't getting anywhere like this, Rudel ignored the darkness coming at him, approached Aleist and hammered in his sword. The sword driven in could no longer stand, both blades disintegrating simultaneously. So the fight switched into martial arts, and as there were no problems with Aleist's skills at this point, he confidently went on the offense.

Both boys were too excited to even think of defense. It was the same fist fight they had carried out two years before, but now there lay a hint of madness. A fist clad in darkness, and a fist wrapped in light collided, sending both of them flying. As both rose to their feet, the referee teacher issued a loud proclamation of the match's suspension.

"Stop it, both of you! The match is suspended, you're both disqualified!!!"

"... Oh?"

"... That so."

Hearing that, the two of them gave broad. They could understand by the look in their eyes that the other was thinking the same. Rudel and Aleist amassed their greatest magic on their arms, ignoring the referee and continuing the match. They had already long stopped thinking about some tournament.

All that crossed their minds was how to defeat the bastard before their eyes.



"Princess, quickly!"

Alongside a number of high knights, Sophina protected the students from the aftermath of Rudel and Aleist's attacks. But the princess Fina insisted that she be the last one to evacuate. At the end of her eyes lay the battle of Rudel and Aleist.

While Fina had been keeping quiet, she suddenly cried out. They turned in surprise to her voice, and it was just as the two had ignored the referee's words to restart their match.

"Cover everyone!"

Light gathered in Rudel's two arms, while darkness gathered around Aleist's. The mana they could sense was enormous. Sensing the danger, she called out to cover the students, and the high knights tried to protect them with barriers of magic.

"Sophina, you help out too! That won't be enough to stop it..."

(I thought that knowledge was completely useless... I guess the palace manual does come in handy, from time to time.)

Fina recalled the legends of the Black and White Knights she had been told from her childhood. She thought they were lies, but seeing the scenes unfold before her eyes, she had no choice but to believe. The palace had passed down the knowledge of how to prepare against a white and black knight.

Thinking back to it, Fina could feel those two were going to let out their strongest attacks. Giving up on evacuation, they could only endure it where they stood.

"But princess!"

"Captain! Aleist-dono is...!"

Turning her gaze back to the two at her subordinate's words, Sophina regretted letting turning her attention to Fina for a moment. The black darkness Aleist had pulled out the start had taken on a snake-like shape as it assailed the surroundings. Several dozens of black oversized serpents were destroying the magic proving ground and the area around it.

Rudel avoided and tried to get in an attack in the gap this grandiose technique had made.

It was at that moment that a single serpent made its way towards Fina. That snake that headed towards Izumi and the rest of Rudel's acquaintances watching the match was beginning to multiply in numbers.



"Don't run, Rudell!!!"

Aleist couldn't properly control the black snakes. What's more, he wasn't looking at the surrounding situation. You could say the same was true for Rudel who he fought. Ignoring all around him, Rudel thought of nothing but defeating Aleist, and at the moment Aleist showed an opening, he thought he had a chance of winning.

"This is the end, Aleist!"

(I'll win this. I'll win and become the strongest dragoon...!)

While Rudel rejoiced within, his eyes chanced upon the black snake attacking Izumi and the others behind Aleist. After a moment of hesitation, Rudel chose to prioritize defeating Aleist over whatever was going on.

(There are high knights there, so it's not a problem. No, more than that, I must aim to be a dragoon! Everything else is unnecessary to me! All of it, all of it is unnecessary!!!)

'Why are you lying to me?'

(... At a time like this...!)

In that instant, the best opportunity he had to attack Aleist, Rudel recalled his little sister Lena's words. He wavered and mulled... Rudel didn't have that sort of time to spare, but his body was already reacting to the words recalled. He reacted, and as the course of action he could take floated up in his head, Rudel cried out.

What he had found in the documents, the White Knight's characteristic shield of light... Rudel imagined it.

"... Shield of light, protect them...!!!"

While he had changed from offense to defense, Rudel was ironically left defenseless. Seeing that, Aleist mercilessly struck him down with a black snake.

"It's my win!"



The black snake coming at them vanished after it was blocked by the shield of light. Witnessing that scene, Izumi was unable to understand what had happened, but she sent a glance in Rudel's direction.

"Rudel!"

Looking around, as if to protect the other students in a similar manage, several dozens of shields were floating in the air of the magic proving grounds. Those shields each larger than a single person had completely shut in the black snakes. But sealed in with them, Rudel was assailed by the darkness.

Convinced of his victory, Aleist laughed and erased the snakes; the shields of light disappeared alongside them. Rudel was on the ground while Aleist stood. From just a glance, it looked like Aleist was the winner, but the both of them had been disqualified. This match was also a draw... no, in the first place, the individuals' tournament was put on hold.

Within the academy's lengthy history, it was the first tournament to fail to come out with a victor.

Ignoring Aleist's grand laugh, Izumi raced over to Rudel. Digging out his half-rubble-buried body, she held him up and confirmed he was still breathing. The relief caused her tears to come out, and once those tears hit his face, Rudel opened his eyes.

"Ah... looks like I failed again."

"You idiot, why did you do something like that, Rudel!?"

Perhaps Rudel's consciousness wasn't clear as he didn't know what he was supposed to response. That's why...

"When I tried to throw away everything, I just couldn't... my little sister's going to scold me."

After saying just that, Rudel lost consciousness again. Izumi embraced Rudel, and seeing that, Aleist regained his sanity. Seeing Rudel and the surrounding situation, he sat as if to hold himself.

"I-I never intended to... this isn't what I..."

The teachers gathered to subdue him, and they tried to take away Rudel as well. He had caused such a problem. Punishment was only natural. But there, Fina held back the teachers.

"Do not lay a hand on those two. Carry them to the infirmary, and await orders from the palace."

"But princess! After they've done so..."

"I am not saying this from the standing of a student. I am giving an order as Fina, the second princess of this country... call the headmaster."

"... Yes."

And like that, their identities as the White and Black Knights were exposed to the palace.

Chapter 65

The individuals' tournament of the second term ended with an unprecedented lack of a champion. The semi-finals ended with an unsavory pair of a draw and a disqualification. And at this tournament that was a stream of unprecidents, starting with the headmaster, the teachers, and the staff held their heads.

The fact that Rudel was the White Knight and Aleist was the Black Knight had been relayed to the palace. The palace would be the ones dealing with them, and whatever the case, the academy would not be able to pass down any punishment. Luckily, there hadn't been any deaths at the destroyed magic proving ground. Only a few were injured in the evacuation.

The center of all this talk, Rudel and Aleist were in the infirmary. Rudel was injured, and Aleist was hospitalized for examination. It goes without saying that Luecke and Eunius were injured and hospitalized as well.



"Oy, so how does it feel Mister Misunderstanding? How does it feel to make an elementary mistake and cause a ruckus over this whole duel mess?"

"... Eunius, so you know the whole time."

"Aaah, what am I supposed to do now."

"Izumi, I think I just saw a dragon! That was Lilim-san's dragon, there's no doubt about it!"

The four were pushed into the most extravagant room of the infirmary, and all but Aleist were in serious condition. Three of them lay in bandages and

plaster, while the remaining one hugged his knees on his bed, muttering foreboding things to himself. Before the four of them, Izumi distributed fruit to them all.

"Rudel! Why didn't you tell me either!?"

"? ... About my sister? I certainly bear some responsibility for the misunderstanding that came about. However... Luecke, you knew about Erselica, didn't you?"

Luecke was part of high society, and he knew of Erselica. He knew, but the girl Lena he met just beforehand had been more than enough to fill his head. What's more, he didn't quite recognize Erselica as Rudel's little sister. To make matters worse, Eunius had long since noticed his mistake.

"Normally, you wouldn't be able to settle an engagement to one of the Three Lords with a mistress' child, right? And who'd have thought you'd fall in love at first sight and challenge someone to a duel?"

Eunius guffawed as he pointed a finger at Luecke. Meanwhile, Luecke resolved himself to be teased on this matter for a long time to come. But emotionally, he felt relief that he had made a misunderstanding.

"I should have thought harder too. It's only natural for Erselica's engagement to be decided before Lena's. Luecke, I'm sorry, but Erselica is..." "You're wrong, Rudel! The one I fell for is Lena!"

Luecke corrected Rudel's misunderstanding. Looking at those three, Aleist felt a bit envious.

(How nice, I want to talk about love too. Should I bring up Millia... no, there's no way I could consult with these members.)

As Izumi looked at the four, she felt that the cause of all this had been Lena. The line that put Rudel off, and Luecke's love that had caused the duel. She was quite a peculiar girl, or so Izumi thought of her.

And as the four were making a ruckus, a single girl entered the sickroom. They had been informed beforehand, so everyone thought it was right about time as they turned to their guest. The girl was Yunia Luneice, the daughter of a Marquis House. Her hair cut straight at her shoulders and her glasses were the girl's most discerning features.

The girl was a second year of the fundamental curriculum. During the tournament period, it was only natural for the fundamental curriculum students to be off in their wilderness training. Once that was over, she made a request to meet Aleist in the infirmary. As she was a Marquis' daughter, she was let through as a special case.

"P-pardon my intrusion."

Giving an awkward greeting, Yunia offered a bow to the Three Lords' children before making for Aleist. Walking before Aleist as he sat on the bed, she suddenly handed over a letter. Perhaps she was nervous as her hands were shaking.

"...? What's this?"

Aleist accepted the letter and started at it in wonder. Looking at Yunia's reddened face and the cutesy letter, everyone thought. She didn't have to give it to him in such a place... but Aleist hadn't noticed. In his perplexion he tried to open it on the spot, and Yunia hurriedly stopped him.

"S-senpai! U-um, could you please have a look at it later?"

"Eh? Oh, sure."

Leaving only those words, Yunia retreated from the sickroom. The girl herself left with quick, bashful steps.

"... I wonder what it could be."

Seeing Aleist had still yet to realize, Rudel opened his mouth.

"Isn't that a challenge to a duel? The way that girl carried her body wasn't half bad."

Realizing that Rudel hadn't noticed either, the remaining three breathed out sighs. And opening the letter then and there, Aleist felt quite reluctant to duel a girl as he read it thought. After reading it once, his hands started shaking as he read it again.

"W-what do I do!?"

"Calm down, Aleist. Whether you decline or accept, your sincerity is what's important. I'm sure it's hard going up against a girl, but as you are now, you have an ample chance of winning without harming your opponent."

"... Rudel, you still think this is a duel? And what's gotten into you? Haven't you been confessed to left and right?"

Luecke pointed out Rudel's misunderstanding, but Aleist wasn't making a fuss over the confession itself. It was only now that he realized the sender was Yunia Luneice. Yunia of the chestnut hair had been a romance target. A character with a standing as the main character's junior.

Having come so far, Aleist's first love event had sprung forth.

The contents of the confession in the letter closely resembled what he saw in the event. It was a confession from the game's romance characters he had long given up on that surprised Aleist.

"She's the daughter of a marquis, right? That's not a bad match with you. Why don't you try going out with her?"

Eunius gave some uninterested advice, but Aleist was in love with Millia. In-game, he had confidence he could capture five or six, but when it came to reality, his morals got in the way. The current Aleist had lost any aspirations of a harem.

"... There's someone I like."

On the words Aleist muttered, Luecke couldn't overlook an individual besides himself who would concede a topic to be teased on. Knowing the time had come, Luecke tried to draw the info from Aleist.

"Oh? And who would that be, Aleist? I'd like to hear by all means."

"The truth is, I like Millia of the elven... eh!?"

Just as Aleist called out the name, the second princess Fina entered the sick room. The sudden event surprised those around, but as Fina was a fellow student at present, they offered her some light bows.

"Oh, what might you be talking about?" (When it comes to Millia, she's that elf in master's year, right? When I thought he was a homo, to think he was a kindred spirit in pursuit of the fluff... looks like these eyes have a long way to go.)

Having shrewdly listened in from beyond the door, Fina chose the perfect timing to make her entrance. Having observed her from behind, Sophina was fed up by her sheer shamelessness.

Just as Aleist's awareness of events was growing thin, ironically enough, an event had come straight to him.



In a deep and dark forest, three small monsters- a black fog, a boar and a little bird- were discussing matters to come. They had originally possessed massive bodies, but there was a reason they had shrunk to such a size. Mana deficiency. They lacked the mana required to maintain their being.

'It's all your fault we cannot return!'

"Curse me, so you intend to the blame onto me?"

'I don't really care, but seriously, what are we going to do?'

The boar chastised the fog while the bird thought of the future. The reason it had come to this was because the black fog had so easily promised Rudel it would prepare a dragon for him. Also, while they thought they would become one, that had proved impossible. The boar and the bird had tried to

merge into the fog, but the wickedness of the emotions she had absorbed prevented that.

To be more precise, she had become a different existence from what she was when she was created.

'We're only here because you promised so easily! Yet without a dragon in our grasp, we shall fade away. When we don't even have any means to obtain one, why did you say such a thing!?'

'It does seem we are to face an embarrassing end. If we are to disappear without fulfilling our promise... after you put on such a cool act.'

"Erk... you needn't say it!"

When they didn't have any means to obtain a dragon, the black fog had promised without due consideration. But even so, they had come into contact and negotiated with the dragons. The bird had been killed by a Red dragon, so Red dragons were taken out of the running. They were dragons of violent temperament to begin with.

The murdered bird came down with a trauma and was vehemently against it.

That left the Wind Dragon, Water Dragon, and Gaia Dragon; those three species. They had come to the deep forests where the dragons lived to negotiate. But the Wind Dragon mistook them as prey and gave chase, negotiations with the Water Dragon failed, and the Gaia Dragon wouldn't come out of the earth.

They had made zero progress.

'More importantly, after achieving nothing in negotiations with the Water Dragon, it is strange for me to be the only one on the block.'

The black fog chastised the bird who carried out negotiations. But the bird refuted that opinion.

'The problem came even before negotiations came in the question. The first words that came out of that dragon's mouth were, 'I'm not letting anyone besides Marty ride on my back', giving no leeway for discussion.'

Surprisingly enough, there was a Water Dragon who was willing to hear them out, but that dragon had no interest in any riders but the individual who had ridden it before. So in the end, the negotiations were a failure. Even among the water dragons who inhabited the waterfront, it was quite a powerful and beautiful dragon.

'So what are we going to do now!? At this rate, we will fruitlessly fade away.'

'...''...'

The three thought and decided to head for the Gaia Dragon they had yet to try negotiating with. Preferring the insides of the earth, it was the dragon that boasted the largest body among the four varieties. It was equipped with four wings, but due to its large build, flying wasn't its forte.

The Gaia Dragon was an unpopular choice among dragoons. Its flight speed was low, making it difficult to evade enemy attacks. It was a hard-to-handle dragon that specialized in its sturdiness, offense, and defense.

'Since it has come to this, we must negotiate with the last Gaia Dragon. If we disappear like this, it will put a scar on our honor.'

In order to negotiate, the black fog made for the caves the Gaia Dragons lives. The other two followed behind. Those three beings entrusted their deepest wishes to their last hope, the Gaia Dragon.

Chapter 66

The first princess of Courtois, Aileen. Ever since the one she loved was killed by a demi-human, she had developed an extreme hatred of them. The beastmen tribes were no exception, and she even drove the demi-human knights around her from the castle. In Courtois that was harsh on demi-humans from the start, that didn't prove to be a problem.

But Aileen was, as Fina would put it, a fluff hater. She ended up imagining demi-humans whenever she saw them. Even if she could endure horses and other necessary animals, she couldn't permit the pet dog the family treasured.

"Get rid of this beast!"

With just those words, the large and fluffy pet dog was gotten rid of. Her family members, the king and queen only learned of this after the fact, but with the blow Aileen suffered to her heart, they couldn't condemn her for it. But the one who never learned of that dog's disposal was Fina.

Fina doted on her beloved dog. With her lack of expression, at the time, those around were troubled with how to deal with her. Within all that, only the dog could sense her emotions. When she was lonely he would snuggle close. When she wanted to cry he would stay by her side. He was a gentle dog.

Aileen's attack happened when she was young. And Fina was even younger. At her age, everyone around tried to be mindful, and she was never told about the god. With her expressionless face and the fact she hadn't yet learned to properly talk, they were all sure she would forget about him in no time.

From the day her beloved dog disappeared, Fina would go search for him every day. She had grown bigger, and even if she no longer knew what she was searching for, Fina would search the palace for her beloved dog on vague memories she could barely recall.

Even now, somewhere in her heart, Fina searched for her fluffy pet dog.



"... A dream?"

(I kinda get the feeling I had the best fluffy dog by my side...?)

Opening her eyes on the bed of her private room, her eyes stopped on Mii of the white cat tribe sleeping beside her. Her soft breathes as she slept in peace... Fina expressionlessly stroked her head. And she remembered the dog she had met in a dream.

"Am I lonely?"

(It must be god's way of telling me not just a white cat, I should get someone of the dog tribe in my hands as well. Hmm... what a greedy woman am I.)

If he saw her now, even her pet dog would shake his head to deny it. But paying no mind to that, Fina started fluffing Mii up.

"P-princess! Good morning... where do you think you're fondling!?"

Waking up from the fluffing, Mii noticed that Fina was stroking and fondling her all over.

"Good morning Mii."

(Where? Everywhere of course, my little kitten!!!)



"The punishment is on hold?"

"Yeah, to be quite honest, this is a problem beyond the academy's hands. Though we'll still be demanding repair charges for the proving ground from both your houses."

Rudel and Aleist had been summoned by the headmaster. In his office, they were informed of what was to come. The palace's orders only told them to be zealous in their studies at the academy.

Opinions were divided in the palace, and they were only trying to stall for time. Luckily enough, they were both already knights of the country. While they would face some increased discomforts, it was concluded there would be no problem for them to continue studying hard at the academy.

"B-but what are we supposed to do henceforth?"

"Aleist-kun, just act nor... no, just don't cause any problems. You are both talented students, so keep studying until you graduate. But when it comes to your future careers, you might have to follow the palace's orders."

Rudel reached to those words. On those vague words of 'the palace's orders', it felt as if his path to be a dragoon was far.

"Headmaster, around when will we be able to hear the palace's orders?"

"At the very least, the second term of your fifth year... around a year. Right, you have a year, Rudel-kun."

Rudel understood what the headmaster wanted to say, as he gave the date the palace said it would issue its orders. You have to do something in that one year timespan. That's how Rudel took it.

"Thank you, Headmaster."

After giving a bow, Rudel withdrew from the headmaster's office. And left behind, Aleist also bowed and chased after him. In the office, the headmaster looked at the doorway they had left through as he muttered.

"A year, that's how long you have for your efforts to bear fruit."

But wouldn't Rudel be able to accomplish it? The headmaster had his hopes.



"Obtain a dragon in a year? Are you sane, Rudel?"

Chancing by Luecke on his way back from the headmaster's office, Rudel told him of the palace's orders and the headmaster's words. And he told Luecke his current objective.

"I'm lucid. If I don't do something in this period, the royal palace is going to chain me down. With the sturdiest of chains at that... now's all I have."

"I'm sure there are a number of means, but are you going to go out searching at once?"

Go and search... right, apart from the gray dragons managed by the country, he would have to go looking in the deep forests the dragons made their homes. But while there were dragons who would tie contracts with humans, there were others who would attack them. If they didn't recognize him, he would have to resolve himself to fight.

And the forest was strictly managed by the country. In order to meet the country's valuable fighting force, the dragons, you would have to undertake harsh examinations. Even if he wanted to be granted a gray dragon, it was only natural as he would be becoming one of the country's elite dragoons.

From Rudel's lineage and the fact the king thought well of him, the examination wouldn't be a problem... Luecke thought. But dragons weren't the sort of existence that would recognize you solely if you had talent. Even if Rudel was strong, if the dragons wouldn't recognize it or came to hate him, that was the end.

"Are gray dragons no good?"

"I-it's not like I hate gray dragons or anything! But taking the time into account, it won't be possible. There are quite a few knights who set out to be dragoons due to their popularity, and dragons have a high maintenance

cost. There are no spare dragons idling around, so I would have to wait for someone to retire."

If a dragoon retired or perished in battle, an opening would come out. But when they died in battle, it was often the case the dragon would die as well. That in mind, one would generally have to wait for an active dragoon to retire if they wished to obtain a gray dragon.

"... The examinations will take time too, right? Then you should keep the option in your field of vision. Wild dragons are much too dangerous."

Right, the fact the dragoon vice-captain rode a gray dragon was a sort of proof. Dragons generally didn't recognize mankind. It wasn't very common for anyone to receive their blessing. Both Cattleya and Lilim were abnormal existences among the dragons.

"You're right. I'll keep that in mind. More importantly, why are you keeping silent, Aleist?"

Aleist was surprised to have the conversation suddenly turn his way. After mulling over whether to say it or not, he decided to consult with Rudel and Luecke.

"T-the truth is... I was confessed to."

"By Yunia? Then there's no helping that you mull over it. I heard you said you had someone in mind and rejected her... well, her house just put her up to it, wanting some connections to your house."

Luecke recalled the rumors he had heard from his followers, and Aleist knew that was how it went in the game so he wasn't surprised. He wasn't surprised, but the problem wasn't Yunia.

"That's not it. Yunia is one thing, but this time, another girl confessed to me."

"You're as popular as ever, Aleist."

While Aleist hung his head, Rudel spoke with a smile. Aleist continued on.

"The first years Seli and Juju confessed to me."

Hearing those names, Luecke was surprised. Luecke was on the dimmer side when it came to women, but even he knew those names. They were famous within the academy.

"... the former noble Seli and the tiger tribe's princess. I've heard Seli's swordplay might even line her up with Eunius, and then there's that girl who's known for being small for a tiger tribe woman. You have it rough."

They were both pretty. Imagining those two you could even call beauties, Luecke felt pity for Aleist. The reason was simple. They were pretty, but they had strong personalities. The strong-willed female knight, and the princess of the tribe with the strongest martial arts. If it were him, he'd reject them, thought Luecke.

In their event, Aleist would be smacked as a means of them hiding their embarrassment. It's because he knew it would happen that he was so depressed. There was no pain beyond the screen, but within it, the protagonist was writhing on the floor. And right now, he knew that would happen to him.

"I've heard those two names before. I don't really know the specifics, but it's important to make things clear, Aleist."

"If you reject them you get hit. If you date them you get hit. What am I even... but I don't want to give up on Millia."

Rudel and Luecke pat Aleist's depressed shoulders. Ever since Aleist awakened as a black knight, numerous confession events from numerous girls had sprung up. Among them were some who aimed for him solely as a valuable gem, but there were some who just honest-to-goodness liked him.



After the palace learned of the black and white knights, Rudel's dragoon application became a problem. The examinations showed no problem, but that was as an individual. Was there really a need to make the Arses House's

eldest son and the white knight Rudel a dragoon? It had caused some dispute in the palace.

"The white knight a dragoon? As if we could accept such a thing!"

"Then you say treating him as a high knight would be more proper?"

"Even if they're waning, he's one of the Three Lords. Just put him to work as a feudal lord."

"We should keep him under management at the palace! A dragoon is no more than a simple knight!"

"The problem's if he gets a dragon and ends up running away."

"That's an if! Reality might have him killed by that very same dragon."

That drawn-on meeting had been going on for a number of days, and it didn't look as if it were reaching an end. But there, a single piece of good news came out. A single dragoon knight put in a retirement request giving his old age as the reason.

"A gray dragon has opened up?"

The one reporting to the king was the vice-captain of the dragoons. Hearing that report, the king proposed to grant Rudel that dragon. The statesmen participating in that meeting decided to take up that request. But they decided to put on a bit of a condition.

Even if they gave him a dragon, they wouldn't let him fly freely. Give him status and fame, and a title in name alone... that was the statesmen's decision. Even if he rode a dragon, they wouldn't make him a dragoon. From their point of view, they needed Rudel and Aleist to become symbols.

"Won't there be some opposition if we forcefully push him into it?"

"He'll be a knight recognized by a dragon. Where lies the problem?"

"There'll be backlash regardless."

"Then we just have to smooth it over, be it in appearance alone."

The meeting went on, and certain things were decided. It was to use a single gray dragon to select the captain of the royal guard. The royal guard captain also got a dragon, and everyone apart from the high knights could try for the position. Those were the contents.

Meaning they would make it seem as if Rudel was chosen before everyone's eyes. It was a setup. A completely new organization called the royal guard was being formed for the sake of Rudel alone. Meanwhile, the black knight Aleist was from a noble house you could call upstarts... there were any number of ways to get him under their wind, the ministers thought.

"His obsession with dragons was the problem, so on the contrary, well give him one, eh."

"We were just troubled by his lack of interest in status or power. This is just right."

"You need only give a toy to a noisy child."

The ministers who had worried over their white knight problem, their nerves grew lax as if finally headed towards its resolution. And hearing the talks of those statesmen, the new royal guard became to hottest rumor among the palace's servants. As the rumor spread on it was followed by embellishments and the lies some added on for mischief's sake until eventually, Aileen caught wind of it.



In order to confirm the truth of the rumor, Aileen called out to a single minister. Successfully grasping the weakness that lay in his corruption, Aileen succeeded in confirming its authenticity.

"Then the formation of the royal guard truly has been decided."

In a secret meeting behind closed doors, Aileen was protected by a high knight who got along with her as she talked to the minister.

"Y-yes! For no other reason than to push Rudel into it, the unit's formation has been decided. Once he takes position, it is thought he will be shifted over to territory management..."

"I don't care about that!"

Aileen interrupted the minister's words, and made a certain proposal.

"Well then statesman, around when will the selection open up?"

"At earliest, when both Rudel and Aleist are in their graduating years."

Hearing those words, Aileen made two requestion.

"Then I have two things to ask of you, statesman. First, have them hold the exhibition in the second term. When the matter's still hazy it should be possible. As for the other, there's an individual I want you to include by all means."

"? I don't really mind, but at the very least, it will be difficult unless they have obtained knight qualifications."

Aileen smiled and told the minister it wouldn't be a problem. The future she envisioned when as follows. Having just obtained knight qualifications, Fritz managed to be chosen by a dragon in the exhibition he just happened to participate in. Aileen knew how to make it happen.

After the minister left, Aileen recalled her hated Rudel and smiled.

(I'll put you to shame for everyone to see! For Rudel who humiliated Fritz-sama, I'll be the one to get revenge!!!)

The corruption of a minister with influence over the exhibition. Having been able to get her hands on such information, from Aileen's point of view, it was the greatest of luck. But from the point of view of the setting, it wasn't luck or anything else. It was simply an event.

Chapter 67

"Royal guard? I've decided to decline that one."

Hearing the rumors of the palace's movements, Eunius had come over to Rudel. He had heard they had prepared a gray dragon and entire organization called the royal guard for him. Before class began, he sat to Rudel's side, and hearing Rudel's reply, Eunius was surprised. Your dreams are coming true, is what he was about to say.

But Rudel's response was quick and easy.

"D-dude! When you'll get your hands on a dragon, why are you rejecting it!? You're not going to tell me you prefer natural ones, are you?"

"Natural? I do like wild dragons, but I like gray dragons as well. Perhaps I phrased it wrong... I did receive an order to participate in the selection of the royal guard captain. So I said I didn't want to unless they examined my qualifications to be a dragoon. When I did that, I passed their examinations in a flash. They're probably misunderstanding things over there, but my goal is to obtain a dragon before I participate in that event!"

In Rudel's mind, he had to obtain a dragon in the time space before the selection test took place, so he couldn't become the guard captain. Eunius couldn't forgive how those idiots at the palace who didn't know Rudel had probably just passed him through the examinations to soothe the tantrums of a selfish child.

"I understand well that those folks at the palace don't know a thing about you. That aside, are you going off to search for a dragon at once?"

Rudel thought a bit before shaking his head.

"No, I've only just learned of my own inadequacies at the tournament. I do want to hurry here, but preparations are important... I think I'll try for the extended break in the first term of our fifth year."

As he spoke with Eunius, Rudel thought over the time it would take him to get in control of his power. At the start of the second term was the royal guard captain selection test. Thinking of it like that, his time limit was cut off at a year.

Whether to think time was scarce or to be thankful he had so much time to begin with... Rudel was of the later. More than anything, Rudel was happy he had passed the examination to become a dragoon. He was overflowing with motivation.

"Ah, come to think of it, I have a promise with the tiger tribe after class. Want to come too, Eunius?"

As Rudel recalled something, Eunius felt somewhat dissatisfied. But over his worries, he decided to prioritize his intrigue. If his guesses were right, then this would be something quite interesting for Eunius.

"Sounds interesting. I'll be there."



"The royal guard's selection exam..."

(Is there really any point in making such an organization? Their duties overlap with the high knights' jurisdiction, and I'm sure their resentment will explode if the protection of the royal line is snatched up from them. Well, master's the white knight, so they'll probably step down.)

Fina heard out Sophina's report of what had been decided at the palace. Sophina didn't seem overly resentful, but she didn't seem happy about the foundation of an organization that appeared to exist only to say her own kind wasn't trusted. Fina could sense it.

"In the second term of next year, the selection exam will be carried out, this academy's students included. As long as you have knight qualifications, you'll be able to take part, so the number of applicants has grown considerably."

"Are you going to have a go, Sophina?"

(She lives for her work, so it's not a bad idea for her to try it. More than that, it would be funny if she appealed the fact that any more work would mean she'd have to give up on marriage. And I'll get a fluffier high knight to be my... oy, oyoyoy!!! This is my chance! What am I sitting back here for!? Master can be royal guard captain, and the members will all be fluf... yeah, not happening.)

Fina thought to create the fluff unit of her dreams, but she gave up as soon as she recalled her sister was at the royal palace. Between Aileen and Fina, if one had to say who was treasured more, Aileen's name would rise. Beautiful as she was with her flaw(?)/special skill(?) of expressionlessness, Fina couldn't help but be mismatched.

"... High knights cannot participate. This is an order from our captain as well."

Sophina informed Fina that none of the high knights would take part. This was also a form of protest, but with the birth of the white and black knights, it was also a form of resignation. That was just how much attention the existences of Rudel and Aleist were collecting at the palace.

"Participation is free. And abstaining is also free... so your organizations will never be able to cooperate."

(This is going to be a pain. Well, at this rate, the royal guard will be guarding the royal line on the surface, and behind the scenes, it'll all be the same as before, perhaps? Father's involved, so I doubt I'll have to do anything.)

"We will cooperate, but we do have our pride."

"I see."

(No matter where he goes, master has his troubles... ah!)

"That master will become royal guard captain is already set in stone, right Sophina? But isn't the seat of vice-captain still open? Master is too inexperienced to ensure the prosperity of the royal guard, Sophina."

(Now what will you do. How will you respond? Will you spring at the chance to be alone with master, or will you give up... what sort of choice will you make?)

Just as Fina thought, Sophina reacted. She thought a bit, and her face began turning red. Laughing with, Fina expressionlessly enjoyed her form.

"T-that is one thing, but high knights c-cannot participate, so..."

"I see, how unfortunate, Sophina."

(Ooh, it's working, it's working! Are you irritated? You're irritated, aren't you, Sophina!)

◇

"Don't lose boss!"

"Win for our, no, for the tiger tribe's future!"

"Dammit, Rudel-san's way too strong."

In the academy's training grounds, starting with the men and woman of the tiger tribe, an outstanding number had gathered to watch the match. A fifth year boy, representative of the tiger tribe, fought Rudel one on one. Both sides had requested a bare-handed brawl, and by that, both sides had removed their coats and met in an intense exchange of blows.

"Hmn!"

The tiger tribe representative, from his intimidating difference in height, everyone thought the battle would proceed with his advantage. But Rudel evaded into the bosom of the man's over-two-meter stature, challenging him without fear.

"Rudel has the advantage in speed and power. To a beastmen unskilled in the manipulation of mana, he's a mismatched foe against the current Rudel."

Looking at the fight, Luecke spoke, but Eunius offered a rebuttal.

"This is why you thickheads are... he's stronger, but when it comes to fists, that tiger has the advantage. Apart from reach, his sturdy body's a thread in itself, and when it comes to the martial arts themselves, Rudel's losing. When it comes to the gap in technique, the tiger tribe has the advantage."

Eunius explained how the tiger tribe man enduring Rudel's offense had the offensive. In truth, all of Rudel's blows had been blocked. Nearby the two spectators, Aleist also watched the battle in fear.

"No! That guy's got exceptional strength even within the tiger tribe! I wasn't a match for him. More importantly, you know... doesn't anyone here think we should stop this fight?"

"Why? This was a promise, right?"

You just don't get it, Aleist. This is a promise between men.

Neither Luecke nor Eunius would lend Aleist an ear. As his final home, Aleist turned to Izumi beside them. But the one who noticed his glance was the extra.

"What're you looking at?"

The former goddess to Izumi's side glared at Aleist.

"Not you! Just keep quiet a second, pudding for brains! ... Shirasagi-san, is it really alright to let them fight like this? Wouldn't it be better that they stopped?"

Watching over the serious exchange, Izumi answered without taking her eyes off of Rudel.

"It's alright. He has a secret move in store."

"... H-huh? I'm the strange one!? Am I the strange one!?"

Aleist mulled as he usually did, and to his side stood the girl who headed the tiger tribe. A hundred-and-eighty-centimeter body on the short side of the tiger tribe, and hair that could neither be called long or short. Her strong-willed eyes and tan skin characterized the girl Juju.

"You're not strange. You're not strange at all, Aleist!"

Being consoled did make Aleist happy, but he couldn't take his mind of Millia, who was similarly watching the fight. Millia was still staring at Rudel, and that she wasn't looking his way was a relief. Though it's true he was slightly dissatisfied with that as well.

"How uncivilized. Aleist-sama, what do you think of Rudel-dono?"

And standing to his other side was Seli. Her blond hair growing to her waist, the standing figure of the skilled swordswoman was a sight to be seen. Her skills were such that Eunius wished she was a man. And for some reason, she held affection towards Aleist.

"How? No, his style's savage or rather violent. More importantly, why are the tiger tribe women cheering Rudel on!? That's the thing that's mystifying me now, and even the other beast tribe girls are... Rudel sure is popular."

"That's not true. You're also highly popular, Aleist-sama."

"Yeah, Aleist is cool."

On those responses, Aleist mulled over how to respond. He was happy, but right now his heart was set on Millia. He ran away with a vague answer. And it was at that moment. The battle was about to reach its conclusion.

"There!!!"

As the tiger man swung at him, Rudel stepped into his chest, grabbed his arm, and took a stance to shoulder him on his back. It was a shoulder throw. Normally, the tiger tribe man would never let him slip in, but his stamina was reaching its end from his prolonged fight with Rudel. He had made a moment's gap.

Flying through the air, the tiger man was slammed into the ground.

"B-boss!!!"

The battle ended as Rudel's win. Before the lines of tiger tribe men bursting into tears, Rudel and Izumi felt some pity. So there, they decided to teach with some conditions attached.



That dragon had wormed its way deep into the earth. It had taken an existing cave and tunneled in even further to make sure it would never meet another. Even bigger than dragons of the same species, it was a dragon who boasted magnificent power. At this point, it was nothing but bones with not a vestige of its former glory.

That dragon that had been born as a Gaia Dragon was different from the others, a dragon called a sub-species. Bigger than all the other dragons, its greatest characteristic was its arms. Its two arms were exceptionally large. Both were several times larger than its fellow Gaia Dragons.

And once that brought about difficulty to its flight, its wings had grown bigger as well. If one had to say, Gaia Dragons were largest from left to right, but when that dragon was put against its fellow compatriots, its body looked slender. Its horizontal width was the same, but as all its limbs were embellished, the body between them looked slim.

The remains of such a dragon, after hundreds of years had gone by, it had finally been unearthed by the three.

"... Oy, isn't this bad?"

Positioning itself as if to hide in the shadows, the boar looked into the depths of the dead dragon's cave. The bird also hid as it confirmed the situation.

'Is it miasma? There's hatred and envy swirling around here. Why did you come to such a place? Normally, this is what we would avoid.'

The black fog had mixed in with the darkness and could now only be known as a voice.

'I wanted a normal dragon too! But since all the dragons refused, we have no choice but to turn to our final means.'

'Final?'

'It's already over. Give up.'

'After putting on such a show, like hell we can pull back at this point!'

'You just said 'we', did you not!? Do not casually toss us joint liability!'

'If we can no longer become one, then we must be individual existences. The responsibility is yours alone!'

While it may have sounded heartless, the boar and bird hadn't promised anything to Rudel. It was the black fog's arbitrary decision. The black fog ignored them as it continued its talk.

'Using the husk of this dragon, I shall become the dragon myself. If I do, then that means I honored the promise.'

'That's fine and all, but wouldn't that make you a sham?'

'He has a point. You're not as strong as a dragon. You'll just be a fake.'

'We won't know unless we try! Here I go...'

Saying that, the black fog approached the dragon. When it came to dragons, both their bones and flesh were valuable materials, so it was rare to find

one's remains. While dragons themselves would occasionally show respect to dead dragons, they didn't show any interest towards their corpses. So there were those who made a living coming to the forest to retrieve them.

In such a situation, it was rare to find a corpse in such a complete state. However...

'I have a bad feeling about this.'

'There were negative emotions swirling around here from the start, and there's even more gathering. This is dangerous.'

The two of them thought the black fog would turn back. Unfortunately, their expectations were off the mark. From the depths of the cave, they could hear the black fog cry out.

'Wait, no, this is a bit... impossibbbbleee!!!'

Chapter 68

Loneliness, hatred, desire... the Gaia Dragon's lair tainted by conflicting emotions, and the black fog absorbed and took them in. She maintained her own ego, but she didn't carry enough power to resist the dragon corpse. Even so, she looked into the emotions surrounding the dragon, and there were various things she managed to see.

As a subspecies, this dragon had been distanced from the others. While among fellow dragons, it had been isolated from the forest. It spent long years in the depths of the earth lamenting until it became a corpse.

But the dragon had a role. As an undead dragon, its role was to fight the protagonist. After graduation, the protagonist's party would be stationed in the 'Royal Guard', a new organization formed by the country, and the protagonist himself would become their captain. The other members were, of course, his harem members.

Among the missions they were to carry out was a quest to slay an undead dragon. It was nothing more than one of the quests that existed to build up existence before the war arc. The one who had been prepared for that sake was the subspecies dragon.

The fearsome appearance of its corpse was there to put on a show that it was a fearsome foe.

'This is a dragon fated to be slain. In a few years' time, it will go out and start a rampage, but for now, here it lays...'

The black fog thought over various things with the information it had on hand. It was at that moment. The fog noticed its own mistake and called out to the boar and bird.

'S-self meeting!!!'

'What?' 'I'm not getting any closer to that thing.'

From the distance entrance of the cage, the two of them looked at the dragon corpse that had taken in the black fog. The fog began explaining the situation to them.

'This is a dragon fated to be slain! It will be fine for now, but at this rate, it will make its way out in less than a year. There were originally a few years left, but because it took me in, it's going to start moving ahead of schedule!'

'...''... That's your fault.'

'Exactly, so it's my (our) responsibility.'

She wasn't an individual, therefore the responsibility lay with all three of them, declared the black fog. The boar and bird sighed. But if her words were true, then this was a situation they couldn't leave be. The three beings were originally existences born to return an irregular to his base. Getting in Rudel's way, lowering his ranking in the wilderness training, and setting Aleist up as the hero over Rudel.

It was all to return the story to its original path. The boar born from the possibility Rudel wouldn't drop out of the training as he was supposed to in the event.

The bird that came forth when Aleist's popularity was much lower than it was supposed to be. It was for that sake that its status down magic displayed no effect only against Aleist.

Finally, the black fog had been born to correct Rudel himself, who was dragging in and changing all his surroundings. It had taken over Cattleya and Lilim, those that Rudel admired in order to fold his heart. As a result of the setting approving of Rudel along the way, it went berserk.

On the sole reason of its own existence, the black fog had tried to kill Rudel. While they had each greeted an unfortunate fate, the three of them

existed to mediate the story.

'There's no helping it... we'll go tell Rudel about it.'

The boar decided so, and the bird also nodded as it slipped out of the cave. Seeing the two of them off, the black fog spoke.

'I-If possible, could you keep quiet about my slipup!?'

◇

"Oy, Fritz, did you hear? It seems that rumor going around is true."

In the academy cafeteria, the second years of the fundamental curriculum were discussing the newly established royal guard. Apparently, the leader of the new unit would be given a dragon, and there were even talks that their duties and jurisdiction would rival the high knights and dragoons, so the students were sure it was a lie.

As the conversation was turned to him, Fritz recalled the letter he received a few weeks prior.

"IS that so? I heard that as long as they have knight qualifications, anyone can participate in the royal guard captain selection process. Is that one also true?"

Fritz pretended not to know, but he already knew all. The sender of his letter was the first princess Aileen, and the letter pertained to the royal guard. But it wasn't written that he would be selected. All Fritz knew was that he would be able to participate.

"It a new organization of elites we're talking about here! Why don't we take a whack at it too?"

Perhaps they would be chosen. Seeing his classmates get worked up as they thought over their prospects, Fritz wasn't so calm inside. From the events of last year, he couldn't help but be conscious of Rudel and the others.

"High knights will be there, and active knights as well, right? I think it'll be considerably difficult."

Having experienced an overwhelming defeat, Fritz couldn't understand what he was lacking. He couldn't understand the fact that he had only ever lived in a narrow world, but even so, he sought out power and wanted to grow stronger.

"Even if I'm no good, there won't be a problem with you, Fritz! If it's now, you might even be able to beat Rudel. If it's Fritz, strongest in our year, I do think you're worthy to be royal guard captain."

His classmates' words they believed from the bottom of their hearts irritated him. The pseudo magic sword he had obtained through watching Rudel, and the techniques he used freely to strengthen his body, even with all of them Fritz had lost. His classmates who couldn't understand that irritated him. To add onto that, Fritz had lost to Aleist as well.

"Well, it sounds interesting, so I guess I'll try entering." (It's Aileen's request, after all.)

After giving that answer, Fritz returned to his meal. Fritz' selection was a determined fact, but oblivious to that, he decided to take the challenge. He even felt thankful to Aileen for giving him the chance.



"M-Millia-san!"

A bouquet in his hand, Aleist was practicing his confession to a wall. Around, his friends he'd been with from his fundamental curriculum years watched over with grins. They were there to make sure no one came, and until Millia- who he's called out- arrived, they critiqued Aleist's practice confessions.

"Aleist, you're trying too hard... you'll be fine as long as you learn to say the word love more naturally. You've got a good face, and she won't say no, I tell you."

"No, doesn't that make it sound like his face is all he's got? In truth, he's a perfect guy with both status and fame, right?"

His friends watching him, after confirming that the time drew near, they decided to disperse. Tell us how it works out, they said as they left, and seeing them leave, Aleist began to feel hopeless.

"I-it's fine! I'm sure it'll work out... even if it doesn't, I won't give up! I'll try however many..."

While Aleist muttered to convince himself, he heard the footsteps of someone's approach, accelerating his heart. He had called her out to a relatively secluded space, so he concluded the one approaching was Millia. He instantly carried out his confession.

"I-I like you! Please go out with me!!!"

His eyes closed, Aleist handed over the bouquet. But even here he had failed miserably.

"E-eh!? W-well, if you're fine with me..."

"Eh!?"

The voice wasn't Millia, so Aleist opened his eyes to confirm it. There stood a young girl with red hair. Her tan skin and red hair standing out, the girl who looked younger than her age let one was not Millia. She was a potential lover interest called Lux.

While she boasted a small body, she was a warrior from birth who wielded a large hammer. The appearance of the first year girl sent Aleist into great confusion. Unluckily, that was where Millia made her entrance.

"Oh? I came because I was called here, but it doesn't look like Aleist is the one who called for me... Aleist, you should give Seli and Juju some consideration as well."

Calmly looking over Aleist and Lux, she had noticed Aleist was making a confession. While the essence was mistaken, the situation was correct.

Aleist's friend had summoned Millia there, but the fact he didn't tell her who was waiting for her had become a problem.

If she knew, perhaps she would have noticed her mistake.

After cautioning Aleist, Millia awkwardly walked off. In the four years since she came to the academy she had grown, and now she was more of a lady than a girl. They were sisters after all, and Millia was coming to resemble her big sister Lilim. Seeing her back as she walked off, Aleist cried.

"Whyyyyyy!!!"



Around that time, Rudel was speaking with Millia's older sister Lilim. From Lilim's point of view, she was just dropping by the person who'd been on her mind lately, but she knew Rudel had looked out for her in the events of two years passed. She was worried whether there were any drawbacks from the actions Rudel had taken to save her.

"You're going to the dragon dwellings!?"

"Yes. I got permission, so all that's left is to actualize it."

As the two spoke of the gossip surrounding the academy, the topic naturally shifted to the newly established royal guard. Lilim knew Rudel had become the white knight, and she had somewhat realized the royal guard was related to that. Her knowledge only served to increase her surprise at Rudel's actions.

"There is no reason for a human like you to push yourself so. For a demi-human, unless you obtain a wild dragon, you'll never be recognized, but you have an opportunity to obtain a gray dragon. Yet you'll make a waste of it?"

While Lilim said harsh words in worry, Rudel answered with a bitter smile.

"I have a few reasons. But my biggest reason is because I want to choose my dragon. Though that's just my own selfishness. It's not like I hate gray dragons or anything!"

On Rudel's frantic denial at the end, Lilim gave a chuckle. I know, she said, and told Rudel she wasn't misunderstanding anything.

For Rudel, he also had a promise with the three. He had no mind to obsess over it, but some part of his heart hurt when he heard he wouldn't be able to choose his own dragon. To Rudel, Lilim made a certain proposal.

"If your feelings remain unchanged, then do you want me to take you to the dragon dwellings? It's the homeland of my dragon, and you're not a person I'm not supposed to take."

"You will!? I'd definitely like to take you up on that!"

Seeing Rudel delighted that he could ride a dragon, Lilim smiled. But she also did want Rudel to give up. As gray dragons were reared by the country, they didn't attack humans. Even if you weren't chosen, they wouldn't take your life. But wild dragons boasted pride much higher than the gray.

It was quite normal for them to kill humans they hated. While their abilities were high, there was a danger of losing one's life.

"Very well, then once the time comes, and you still wish to go, let us get in touch."

Saying that, Lilim parted with Rudel. Since she'd come to the academy anyways, she thought to go meet her little sister Millia. Though she was treated as a bit of an extra to Rudel.



The former goddess, now Sakuya, was living a life parasiting off of Rudel and Izumi. But there was only a year left of their time at the academy, so the time had come to think of her future.

In Rudel's room, Sakuya lay on the bed as she ate sweets. When she didn't have a name, Luecke and Aleist would call her terrible things, so she compromised and chose the name Sakuya. While Aleist called her Flan for Brains or Flan McFlan, there was once a time she wept as she clung onto Rudel.

As a resolution, Rudel thought lining up two flans was no good, so... how about Flan AlaMode? He asked. So as always, the former goddess ended up crying her way to Izumi, and Sakuya was now her name. She was never able to think up any good names for herself, but she decided it was better than being called Flan.

Izumi thought it was quite a nice name and she couldn't understand what the former goddess didn't like about it. But Sakuya it was, and now Sakuya was surprised at what Rudel declared.

"Study? What are you talking about, Rudel. I'm a goddess!"

"Former, that is... and isn't it about time you thought about going independent? I'm fine with supporting you, but the way things are going, you're going to remain your no-good self."

Playing around all day only to be saved by Izumi or Rudel, Sakuya had no words to return.

"Nnnrrghh, fine, got it. I'll make you regret the day you made light of a goddess' intellect, you hear! When it comes to me, the letters that humans use are mere... what's this?"

As Sakuya showed her motivation, Rudel handed over a few books. Those books were the picture books about dragoons Rudel had brought with him. If only it were a doujin, I would've happily read it... thought Sakuya as she opened one up.

But no matter what page she looked at, she could see traced it had been read over again and again.

"Do you really like dragoons so much? They're just knights who ride dragons. I'm pretty sure the white knight title supersedes them."

"... Let's just say I could put white knight and dragoon on the scale. I have no doubt I would pick dragoon without any hesitation."

As Rudel cut it clear, Sakuya uninterestedly looked at the pictures. She didn't know the letters, so she looked at the pictures, and tried reading a story of her own imagination.

A male dragon and male knight cross over the bounds of species and... as she read that tale alone, Rudel hit her on the head relatively seriously. With teary eyes, Sakuya rubbed her head as she glared at Rudel, but he was actually quite angry so she apologized.

"Don't just arbitrarily revise the story! There's no helping it, so I guess I'll have to read them to you each night."

"You sure look happy when you say that. Men sure seem to love dragons and other strong lifeforms..."

Uninterested as she was, Rudel would read her the dragoon books each night. A few days later, Sakuya burst into Izumi's room, preciously holding a picture book in her hands as she declared,

"Izumi, I'm going to become a dragoon!"

"I-I see... E-EeeeEh!!!?"

Sakuya's eye's sparkled as she adoringly held the book up high, and Izumi had no idea what to say to her.

Chapter 69

The boar and the bird, their bodies growing considerably smaller along the way, somehow managed to reach the academy.

At first, they both boasted large and imposing forms, yet now not a shadow of that glory remained. They had shrunk to a size that would fit atop the palm of a hand. The two of them waited for night before getting into contact with Rudel. They got the feeling their dignity would diminish even further if they appeared during the day.

Once night came along, they snuck into the boys' dorm. Making sure not to be seen, they made their way to Rudel's room only to find the form of Rudel educating Sakuya.

"Don't let the book on your head fall! That's proof of bad posture. Keep walking like that."

"H-how strict! If you're this harsh on me, I'm going to cry!"

A book balanced on her head, Sakuya shook as she walked. Looking at that, Rudel similarly placed a book on his head to show by example.

"If you end up crying here, you'll never become a dragoon, former goddess!"

"It's Sakuya now! But you have a point. I was mistaken, Rudel! Now let's hurry on to what comes next!"

"That's the spirit.

The two beasts felt almost as if they were watching a skit, stationing themselves before the doors like actors awaiting their parts.

'... How tedious.'

'Really? Looks fun to me.'



When Rudel and Sakuya entered a break, small as they were, the two beasts put up an imposing air as they entered the room. At their forms as they tried their best, Sakuya stifled a laugh. Rudel thought their entrance was related to getting a dragon, so he hurriedly placed them on his desk to hear them out.

They were somewhat dissatisfied with that treatment, but losing to Rudel's serious expression, they gave the details of what had happened. The fact that they couldn't find a dragon willing to be his mount, and that an undead dragon had taken in their comrade, the black fog. For argument's sake, they were once the same entity, so out of pity, they made it sound like the undead dragon had sealed her.

Right, they had lied. No, to be more precise, the two of them avoided mentioning that the fog had made a mistake, causing Rudel to misunderstand.

"I see, so getting everything together, the black fog has been seized by an undead dragon. And the situation is a dangerous one where it will go on a rampage within a year."

'... That's right.'

'You've got the idea.'

Sensing the dubious air surrounding the two, Sakuya directed a dubious glance at the boar and bird on the desk. At her doubtful eyes, the two of them averted their eyes evasively.

"Aren't you two a bit suspicious? More importantly, I'd appreciate it if you returned my powers as a goddess, you know?"

'Can't. The one who absorbed your powers is the black fog.'

'To go even further, the black fog is also on the verge of losing her powers. It's best you think that you won't be getting them back.'

Pissed at the bird's words, Sakuya hoisted both of them up in an eagle grip. Lifting them and bringing them to her face, she glared with enough intensity to kill.

"What did you just say? What is it you just said, you beasts!?"

'Eek!'

'F-forgive me!'

"Sakuya, put them down already. But that really is a possibility. The country's capable of subjugating an undead dragon, but when the target's a dragon, it'll be perilous even for a knight brigade. I should report the details to the king by letter, and make sure their preparations are perfect..."

In his head, Rudel considered what would happen to the Kingdom of Courtois if an undead dragon ran rampant. It was clear the casualties would be enormous. But this time, they had the information beforehand. If they used it to its fullest, he knew the subjugation would be an easy task.

But on the words from the two, Rudel was troubled to respond.

'According to the black fog, she wanted to use that dragon corpse and make it Rudel's dragon, it seems.'

'Well there's no helping it in this case, so I'm sure he'll give up.'

He'd get a dragon of his own. On those words, Rudel erred. Normally, if the country laid out the perfect groundwork, and challenged it with the right measures, its defeat was certain, but Rudel's desires twisted him.

"... You said there was about a year of deferment."

'There's something more important than that.'

'Rudel, either supply us with magic or return us to your sword. We're already disappearing...'

Close to their limits, the two shrunk even further and entered Rudel's blade as if melting into it. How rejuvenating, and I'm sleepy, they said as they gained a source of mana.



Rudel hurriedly wrote a letter to get in touch with Basyle. It was in order to ask about the blacksmith who purchased the boar's tusk. According to the boar, his tusk was a material of the highest quality. What's more, when taking on one of their own, he said it would definitely be useful. As the undead dragon took in the black fog, it would surely have an effect...

Believing the boar's words, Rudel immediately put them to action. He would ask them for whatever remained of the tusk, and have it made into armor. If it was a smithy that specialized in swords, then he thought he'd leave the armor to another merchant as he hurriedly went into preparations.

He decided not to report the undead dragon to the country. But he did write that an investigation was necessary, and sent in a separate report to the country through his house. And by that, Rudel would be doing the initial investigation himself, he decided.

The timing was just right. He had obtained permission to go to the dragon dwellings, and he could have Lilim take him. Rudel thought it was too good of an opportunity to pass up.

"Looking at the time, it'll be right before the selection test."

Scanning the calendar, he confirmed when his preparations would be complete alongside the date of the selection test. Rudel wasn't quite on board the selection test, but it was an order from the country, and he had no choice but to join in. A few months. That was the time afforded to Rudel. Sakuya watched his serious expression with worry.

"Why do you have to push yourself? Just get the gray dragon! If you try to do the impossible and fall short..."

Izumi will be sad. Before she could say that, Rudel looked at her and tried persuading her.

"It's just my own selfishness. I don't want to drag anyone else in. And you see, it's been decided they'll send two dragoons. It'll be fine even if worse comes to worst. No matter what happens, the country will deal with the problem before the dragon starts to move."

He had laid the groundwork. He had reported the undead dragon matter required investigation from the country. And knowing that fact, the country had decided to send him two dragoons. As Rudel had become the white knight, they were dispatching guards just in case.

But they didn't put much emphasis into Rudel's report of the undead dragon. It was taken with doubt. It was for that reason their allowance of Rudel's arbitrary actions and the country's own countermeasures were so lax. Even if he reported the truth from the start, they wouldn't have believed him all the same.

In the worst case, his own death would surely make the country move. Rudel had been resolved to risk his life to get a dragon from before he could remember. For he was aware there were mountains of knights who died unrecognized by the dragons.

"Sakuya, I have a request. Can you keep this a secret from the others?"

"Eh?"

Rudel tried to persuade, but as he requested her silence, his eyes wouldn't accept any dissent. Unable to resist those eyes, Sakuya quietly nodded. It was at that moment she understood. That Rudel was resolved for death.



As Rudel started to action to obtain an action, his movements were swift. In the third term of his fourth year, he heard back from Basyle, identified the smithy, and once he learned they manufactured armor as well, he instantly put in a request. For Lilim as well, he informed her by letter he was aiming to head to the dragon dwellings around the beginning of his fifth year's second term.

He had known it would be dangerous from the start, and there was nothing for him to panic over at this point.

But Sakuya who knew the truth was a different story. Even as she accompanied Rudel's training, she couldn't understand why he'd risk his life to try obtaining a dragon. If he made a compromise, even if he couldn't become a dragoon, he'd still have a dragon in his hands.

And Sakuya didn't like hiding things from Izumi. Lately, she had gotten around to avoiding her.

But when she encountered Izumi in the school cafeteria, they would end up eating together. To the current Sakuya, that was painful.

"When the graduation ceremony's over, do you want to have a party? Ah, right, there's the princess' party. I also got an invitation. A high knight came all the way over to the boys' dorm to deliver it."

Luecke and Eunius sat at the same table, the five of them eating lunch together. The topic had turned to the fifth year student graduation. Rudel had quite a few acquaintances in the fifth year. The tiger tribe girls, and nesses of the black cat tribe, he knew a few on a personal level.

"Right, it seems Fina-sama is personally gathering her acquaintances together to hold a party. Getting together those who got along, she wants to see off the graduates."

As Eunius placed his invitation on the table, Luecke took it and confirmed its contents.

"... It's the same as the one that came to my place. But aren't these participants strange? You know these names too, don't you, Rudel? A majority of them are from the best tribes, and I get the feeling there are very few young nobles here. It also feels almost as if the fact we were invited was just to show those around a certain level of status was necessary."

As Luecke read into it, Eunius said he was thinking too deeply and laughed it off. As a matter of fact, calling the eldest sons of the Three Lords to silence the nobles who weren't invited was included in Fina's plans. The other reason was of course, for Rudel's participation.

"I do know quite a few fifth years."

Rudel recalled the faces of his acquaintances and noticed a majority of them were beastpeople. Because of Fina, his social circle had grown skewed, but Rudel was thankful for all the new encounters. Once they graduated, there would surely be some he'd never see again, but Rudel wanted to see them off with a smile.

"I didn't get an invitation, so I can't go. The three of you can enjoy yourselves."

"Aah, it's that thing where all the good food is lined up, right? But that strange woman will be there, so what should I..."

Izumi didn't feel any unease letting the three of them go alone. It was a party the princess was holding. Knowing she wouldn't match, she had given up from the start. But Sakuya didn't understand that area. She had an interest in the party part of it, but when she knew Fina was the organizer, she mulled over whether to go or not.

"What are you talking about? You can just come with me."

Rudel voiced Izumi's participation as if it were only natural. Sakuya also told Rudel she wanted to go, and he permitted it under the condition she didn't eat too much.

"Are you sure? Well, it's a party held by a student. Its scope is limited, but..."

Luecke thought a bit over the two's participation, but Eunius sighed that his thoughts were too stiff.

"It's not like it's going to be on the scale of the usual ones, right? The participants are mainly beastmen so just go in your school uniform and have a bit of fun while you're at it."

While the three of them usually fooled around together, Luecke and Eunius often attended parties. Rudel's case, where he had never attended a party before, was far more abnormal. The two accustomed to it weren't nervous. Hearing it was a party Fina was holding, Rudel wasn't the slightest bit nervous either.

Once Sakuya learned she could take part, she began scheming over how she could avoid Fina while eating as much food as possible... but Izumi alone was acting strangely.

"Eh, no, umm... I don't think I'll go. I'll just be a bother."

Losing her composure, she nervously declined the invitation. Rudel wasn't interested if Izumi wasn't going. So...

"Are you worried about the invitation letter? Then wait right there. I'll get you one at once."

He stood right from his seat and walked off towards the girls' dorm. The four of them watched off his back, but in little over ten minutes, he returned with two invitations in hand.



"C-curse you, black haaiiiiiirrr (That woman... using master to extort an invitation from me is downright cowardly!)"

On her bed in vexation... Fina expressionlessly held her knees as she recalled when Rudel had come a little passed noon. When she thought he was stopping by for the first in quite some time, the reason was Izumi.

She pouted that Izumi would be taking part too. Fina's guard Sophina sighed at her expressionless irritation as she watched over her.

"Isn't it fine? We've already prepared so much, so it shouldn't be a problem if we have a few more on this occasion."

It was a party of beastpeople gathered for Fina's sake, but she had to lay an extensive groundwork to even carry out the preparations. She couldn't let Aileen learn of it, so on the surface, she had made it something to send off the graduates.

"What are you talking about, Sophina? Because of master, the number of nobles saying they want to participate has grown. If you think it's so light, then take some responsibility and help me out."

As if to hoist off the responsibility, Fina handed over a load of letters from her noble upperclassmen. If Rudel and the others were taking part, Fina thought they would show some prudence, but Rudel's actions had twisted that notion. If commoners can join in, then shouldn't we be able to? Or so it was thought.

"Eh? No, even if you give me so many letters..."

"You're a high knight, so take some responsibility in your own remarks. (Ah, I think I've stopped caring. Let's just push it onto Sophina. Hah, I won't be able to fluff up the tiger girls or Ness, will I. How lonely... huh? Wait a tick. I'm a princess, aren't I? Isn't this the time for me to use my authority?)"

Hit with so much extra work, Sophina later went to consult with the academy side. Now with free time on her hands, Fina began to move things behind the scenes.



Over the next few days, it became clear that the numbers hoping to take part were far greater than expected, so that year, the academy decided to officially sponsor the graduate-centric party. When it came to graduates, there were those that finished schooling in their second and third years as well. Their numbers were nothing to make light of.

"If it's come to this, what are we supposed to do?"

At the details of the party posted up on the boys' dorm bulletin, Euinus tried asking the usual members. Rudel and the others were enrolled, and it wasn't as if they were graduating.

"It seems they're taking volunteers to help out with construction."

Luecke confirmed the contents, amazed that the scale had more than doubled from the start. The academy had never held a graduate party before, but Fina's arbitrary actions had moved their hand. The academy was likely abiding the princess' orders.

Unaware of the party until that point, Aleist recalled how he'd seen these happenings in the game. It was originally a party Fina held for the protagonist. Recalling how it was supposed to be the final event of the school chapter, he noticed it was happening a year early, but at this point, Aleist didn't even question it.

"For enrolled students, as long as you help out with the constructions, preparations, or cleanup, you can attend, it seems."

On Aleist's words, Rudel instantly volunteered.

"I see, then I'll help out. Do I just have to fill this out?"

Rudel wrote his name on the paper stuck to the board. Seeing that, Sakuya said she would join as well and wrote her name. They were misshapen letters, but she proudly showed them to everyone gathered.

But while Rudel pat her head, everyone else's reaction was cold.

"Sakuya? Oy, oy, isn't your name supposed to be Flan, former goddess?"

As Aleist emphasized the former goddess part, Sakuya sent a dirty look. In regards to that, Luecke opened his mouth as well.

"Flan AlaMode, wasn't it?"

As Luecke asked considerably seriously, Eunius burst into laughter. Looking over everyone's response with teary eyes, the goddess proceeded to plunder everyone's dessert in the following meal.

Chapter 70

'Well then, to all our graduates' futures, cheeeerrrrsss!!'

The party Fina had thought up to bless the departure of the graduates had reached a scale beyond all expectations. In the hall, the master of ceremonies selected from the enrolled student body called for a chant of cheers.

The scale had grown too large, and in the end, it settled down as an academy-sponsored event. All the graduates took part, while the enrolled students in their third and fourth years did the construction and preparations, and the first and second-year students staffed the hall on the day in question.

Everyone took part in their school uniform, and only the students of the fundamental curriculum distributing food and drink had their outer coats removed. Rudel and the others stood before all the food prepared by the girls' and boys' dorm dining halls working alongside the school cafeteria.

"This is quite something. I never thought we'd get to experience something like this in our school years."

Having finished his greetings to the graduates and third years, Luecke met up with Rudel and Izumi. As long as you helped set up, then you could take part in the festivities, so Rudel delightfully helped out. Dragged along by him were Luecke and Eunius, and when they entered the hall with setup underway, it was quite a surprise to the students who lived in noble society.

The other noble students were no slackers either, their preparations favorably proceeding to bring them here.

"Finished your pleasantries, Luecke?"

Rudel looked after Sakuya with Izumi as he gazed over the hall. The nobles would at most watch him from afar; the only ones who came to greet him were his classmates from the fundamental curriculum and the fifth year beast people. He had finished giving his greetings to his acquaintances and the only one left was Fina, but there were plenty of students who wanted to speak with Fina, so he had to wait his turn.

"Yeah, I've already spoken with most. I also called out to some promising talents. Let me tell you, we've gotten six shield knights on our hands this year, so my plans are going as expected."

Sakuya couldn't understand what Luecke was saying, but what she could understand was that the food before her eyes was delicious. Ignoring Luecke's statement, she reached out her hand.

Izumi recalled Luecke's program. He said he would give shield knights a whole new value, and forcefully took Vargas into the Halbades House the year before. Recalling how he had quarreled with Eunius, I hope nothing bad comes of it... she thought just as Eunius approached with a displeased look on his face.

"Oy! Continuing on from last year, you've done it again, damn beansprout! When you already dragged off Vargas last year, what's the meaning of you making off with all the valuable folks this year too!?"

In regards to Eunius' yell, Luecke thought to return the favor for all the times he had been teased over Lena, returning a smile of leisure. He was in quite a good mood, and his smile contrasted well with Eunius' irritation.

"Hmm, Eunius, I did no more than offer them a place to perform to their best. I'll have you stop with these strange allegations. And also, you're saying the same things as you did last year. Why don't you try learning a different approach?"

Within that domineering air, Rudel reminisced over Vargas, while Sakuya relished in the food. Izumi alone was left to mediate. Those around only watched- at a fair distance- as Izumi stepped in.

"Both of you, today is a day of celebrations. Can't you get along a bit more?"

In regards to Izumi's troubled face, Eunius was displeased, while Luecke declared with a smile.

"Impossible!"

"That's not happening."

Seeing them declare it in unison, Rudel also opened his mouth.

"Those two get along quite well, don't they."

Seeing Luecke and Eunius grow irritated to refute Rudel's words, Izumi understood they were fine as they were. She warmly watched over their desperate looks as they tried to explain to Rudel just how badly they thought of one another. It was just at that time where, in a place separated from their refreshing discussion, an incident broke out.

"KYAAAAAH!!"

"I-I'm sorry!!"

The voices of Aleist and a female student echoed through the hall.

◇

"W-what do you think you're doing!?"

The girl draped over a fallen Aleist was a student with blue hair extending to her shoulders. Her skin was pale, her lack of outer coat identified her as an underclassman, and just as she was carrying drinks around, she had bumped into Aleist. By the way, the KYAAAAAH came from Aleist.

For some reason, after colliding, she ended up slipping and sliding, her face ending up buried in Aleist's nether regions. In exchange, the girl's lower half was right before Aleist's eyes... as his face turned red, a few of his friends ran over to save him.

"What are you doing, Aleist!? What about the plan!?"

"We finally managed to pull Seli, Juju, Yunia and Lux away for you man!"

"This was the big chance..."

"I really do apologize! I'm sorry!"

As he apologized to his complaining friend, the fallen girl apologized to Aleist. But the two of them were in terrible shape. As his friends tried to pull him from under her, the girl ended up dragged along. As ill fate would have it, that was the only scene Millia happened to witness.

Millia's expression was stiff as she looked at Aleist. The two of them exchanged a look when the girl ended up pulling too hard on Aleist's trousers, removing them entirely. Aleist and his friends who had planned to use the party for a confession were now convinced they had failed.

"The worst."

"Y-you're wrong! This isn't what it looks like, Milliaaaa!!!"

"Don't drop the honorific!"

As Millia left the chaotic scene, Aleist froze with his hand held out towards her. The blue haired girl was Nate, a romance target character.



Watching Aleist's comedy from a distance, Fina burst into laughter with in. Her abs were twitching at a minute level no one could notice. Ever since she heard that Aleist had spent every day training with the tiger tribe last year, she had experienced a jealousy close to malice.

"Oh my, Aleist-dono sure has it hard... (Fwah! He's sure done it, the bastard! How do you like them apples?)"

At present, Fina had finished speaking with roughly all the young nobles. She was speaking with the beast people as she wished. The talks were

especially focused around the tiger tribe. While in her heart she wanted to spend every day trained up by fluffies as well, she was carrying out a serious conversation.

Using the importance of mingling with demihuman tribes as the official reason, Fina was fluffing them up. Seeing Ness who seemed to want to go to Rudel, and the tiger tribe girls fidget as they looked at him, she felt a mild arousal.

Seeing the unusual innocent side of those tiger women, the tiger tribe men were convinced. That they could do something about the strong-willed women who would always get the tribe's men under their feet...

"Boss, Rudel-san really is a master!"

"Just look, they've all regained their cuteness!"

"Yeah, now listen up you lot, we're definitely polishing up that skill!"

Fina called out to the overly enthusiastic tiger boys, but it wasn't as if she was only speaking to the tiger tribe. Demi-humans faced discrimination in Courtois. Their positions in the country were weak, and once they graduated the academy, they would instantly be sent off to borderland or some danger zone rife with skirmishes.

Having caught sight of that, Fina had begun making preparations for the future... Deceiving the eyes of the country's upper brass who saw them as no more than a consumable commodity, her plans were gradually advancing.

Behind the needlessly talented Fina, Sophina looked on with a sigh. She had been informed of and had helped with the plan, but she had some dissatisfaction that Fina wasn't using her competence for the country. It was simply that no one could stop Fina as she burst forth towards her own desires.

"Even after you graduate, I'll definitely never forget you (Even if you graduate, I'll never let any of my fluffies get away, so you better prepare

yourselves!!)"



The party ended, and the graduates prepared to leave the dorm. The rooms they left behind would eventually be occupied by new students coming in.

To Rudel and co, they were now entering their final year. From Rudel's point of view, it was a critical point that would determine if he became a dragoon or not, and to Izumi, this year held her only chance of becoming a high knight. There were a number patterns one could take to join the high knights. Those who distinguished themselves as knights, those with good grades at the academy... Izumi was aiming to be selected for her grades.

To Izumi who was born in a foreign land, once she graduated, her prospects would distance themselves all at once.

Luecke and Eunius went into preparations to return home and succeed their houses. As a formality, they would swear allegiance to the country, but the two of them came from archduke lines boasting vast expanses of land. Once they graduated, they would have no freedom.

But here, there was one who did earnestly worry for his future. It was Aleist...

Normally, as the eldest son of a Count House, he was supposed to return home and work on managing his territory. But at present, Aleist held a position called black knight, one overly difficult to do anything about.

It wasn't that Aleist himself had a say in his life's course, yet those who did have a say had yet to decide on it either. Unlike Rudel's case, the upstart Hardie House was unable to carelessly open its mouth.

When he thought he was trying his best, he was still being washed away by the flow. He decided to meet with Rudel early in the morning. Even if he consulted with his close friends, he couldn't find an answer. While they were worried about him, the talks would only end with him reaffirming the fact he couldn't go against the country's orders.

In the courtyard of the boys' dorm, gazing at the sight of sweltering men doing their morning training at such an early hour, the two of them conversed. Aleist sat on a rock while Rudel practiced swinging his sword.

"So you don't know what you're supposed to do?"

"Y-yeah... it doesn't look like I'll be able to decide my own path, you see. In this situation, I was just wondering what you... what Rudel would do."

While Aleist was worried, it was quite a strange feeling to consult with Rudel, his goal that he wanted to surpass. What's more, Rudel was a human unfit for such consultations.

"Even if I were in your position, I'd aim to be a dragoon."

"No, I don't particularly want to become a dragoon or anything!"

"I know. I'm aware you don't have any intent to become one. But no matter what standing I found myself in, I'd aim to be a dragoon. I'd follow my dreams."

Stopping his swinging and wiping his sweat, Rudel looked into the distance. As if to tell himself, he muttered to the sky.

"It's all I have. It's my everything... so I'll even risk my life on it."

Hearing that voice filled with resolve, Aleist no longer knew what he was supposed to say. Aleist had been earnest from the start, but he got the feeling he had seen something close to madness in Rudel's seriousness.

"I'm sorry. It doesn't look like I'll be able to give any good advice. But if I have to say something, I think dating five people at once is a bit much."

Looking down once more, Rudel looked at Aleist with a troubled look on his face as he started swinging his sword again. Aleist refuted Rudel's last words with a jump and a scream.

"As I was saying! That's wrong, I tell you! The one I have a thing for isn't any one of those five!"

"... Aleist, so you plan to get more? Even the ever-kind Izumi was irritated at your actions. A man's resourcefulness may be important, but why don't you learn to value those five a bit more? Not that a stranger like me has any right to say anything on the matter."

"No, you're completely relevant! And wait, from my point of view, you're my rival in love!"

"Y-you... you're after Izumi!? Then it's even more unforgivable! If you want to date her, then at the very least do something about your relationship with the other five! Do anything to make her sad and I'll make dragon feed of you!"

As Rudel suddenly emitted his wrath, before they had noticed it, the men in the yard had dispersed. Aleist explained it was a misunderstanding with teary eyes. But Rudel was calm, as if nothing had happened at all.

"Um, I meant that as a joke, but... am I no good at comedy?"

"You don't see me laughing."

Rudel knew the one Aleist liked from the start. They had spoken about it before, but Aleist was confused by Rudel's sudden outburst.

"Whatever the case, if you want to envision your future, you better keep those five, no, six in your field of vision."

As Rudel corrected it to six, Aleist let out a sigh. He likely meant Milla as the sixth one, but at present, the party's events had invited in her hatred. Even when Aleist was the one pushed down... Aleist felt it was all quite a bit unreasonable.



Once the new school term came alone, the item Rudel requested came in. The armor he ordered from the eastern blacksmith was delivered. With real combat in mind, it was an armor with barely any ornamentation.

It was prepared in accordance to a fight with an undead dragon, but right now, Rudel was the white knight. He likely wouldn't be taken out in an instant, but if you asked whether he could win or not, the answer was no.

The gap in power between man and dragon was a great one. As Rudel had never fought one before, he was treading into unknown territory. He had researched through books, but if a single person would ever triumph over a dragon, then it would be accurate to call them a true hero.

The armor that used what remained of the boar's tusk let off a mysterious glimmer.

As he looked at the armor in his room at the dorm, the voices called out to him. The voices of the boar and bird in his sword.

'That's quite some armor you have there.'

'Sure enough... but are you really challenging it alone?'

Rudel left a bit of silence before answering.

"Yeah, I've lived for this moment."

Outside the room's door, Sakuya overheard Rudel's conversation with the two. While she was only able to listen in silence, she felt something off in her left hand. She looked at her left hand to find it was shaking.

Chapter 71: est

Having entered his final year, while there were various problems, Rudel and the others had safely moved up. General consensus stated the eldest sons of the three lords were most worthy of being the boys' dorm prefects, and the academy half-strong-armed them into the position.

Izumi had become a prefect of the girls' dorm, and the academy was taking the measures they thought best. With a foreigner as prefect, the freshmen nobles did try to rebel, but the academy wasn't lenient with them.

Make Izumi prefect! This was an earnest plea from the teachers and all relevant personnel. In the four years since she enrolled, in the fifth year where it was said held the greatest gathering of problem children, Izumi's presence was an immense one. On top of the fact the problem child known as Rudel would never go against her, there were few in the world the men of the tiger tribe would lower their heads to.

From Izumi's point of view, why did it come to this? She surely thought. But those around had determined Izumi was all they had.

While Izumi had grown busy with the prefect duties imposed on her, she was currently teaching Sakuya letters in her room. She still couldn't bring herself to believe the goddess part and so forth, but she thought of her as a handful of a sister as she looked after. But lately, Sakuya had definitely been acting strange. She had once declared with confidence that she would become a dragoon, but now there were times her health took a hit, and her concentration wasn't there.

Thinking it was an illness, Izumi had the infirmary check on her, but there were no abnormalities. Sakuya was also mindful of her recent poor condition, but she was certain it was just temporary. No, she was making

sure not to think about it. Ever since the day her hands began to shake, she had begun to experience dizzy spells.

"Are you alright, Sakuya? Should we end things here today?"

Her studies going nowhere and her body in bad state, only her irritation was building up, so Izumi called over in a gentle voice. But Sakuya studied on as if clinging to her book.

"I-I can go on..."

The form of Sakuya's frantic studies was starting to show a different sort of impatience from Rudel's.



With the start of a new school year, the upperclassmen found themselves looking after their juniors more often. In the dorm, they would teach everything from the general rules to the unwritten ones. But as was the case every year, the young nobles of high status would mock their upperclassmen and fail to listen to anything they had to say. They were using the boys' dorm dining hall to give their explanations, but the young nobles had started talking in the background.

The upperclassmen giving the lecture usually wouldn't caution underclassmen of higher status, but lately, with Chlust, Fritz, and a stream of all sorts of scandals going on, they cautioned them anyways. There, the upperclassmen boys recalled the trump card the graduates had thought up.

"Is everyone listening? I'll only say it once, so you'd better remember. There are four people considered the strongest of this academy, and you definitely can't go against those four. Does anyone know who they are?"

To the fifth year giving the presentation on the form, a noble first year gave an exemplary answer.

"There's the second princess, right? And isn't it strange for there to be four when it's supposed to be strongest? Are you making fun of us, senpai?"

On that one student's remark, the first years around him raised similar voices of laughter. But without paying it any mind, the upperclassman continued his explanation.

"You can take it that way if you want, but the four I'm talking about are the eldest sons of the Arses, Diade, Halbades, and Hardie Houses. They're nobles, and their statuses exceed all of yours. There was once a time where one of them insta-killed a first-year, but as long as you don't lay hands on those four, you'll be fine. However... there is a single person those four can't go up against. Besides the princess."

As the faces of the students who mocked them went stiff, they utilized the same threat last year's graduates had used. When there were problem children and a princess in the girls' dorm, they thought of their seniors who had done their best, as one of the prefects- a fifth-year boy- continued on with a smile.

"There's a fifth year girl called Izumi-san, a prefect in the girls' dorm. No matter what happens, you can't go against her... the academy's strongest won't stay silent."

"A-and what of it? From her name, she must be a foreigner, right? Even if you threaten us..."

"Ah, sorry, sorry. Can you not comprehend? Let me rephrased that: if the eldest sons of the Three Lords can't go against her, then there's no way the likes of you could. And if you sneak into the girls' dorm, you really will be cut down, so be careful. The princess is there right now, so they're security's on full alert, and there are high knights waiting with sword in hand."

As the fifth year gave a disinterested explanation, the prideful attitudes of the students who had only just come from their houses didn't crumble. There were some who would keep quiet once they learned their own ability, but there would always be students who used their house's status to think they could take on a high and mighty attitude, even in the academy.

But there as the prefects gave an explanation to the upperclassmen, Rudel and the others made their appearance. Rudel, Eunius and Luecke never

wanted to become prefects to begin with, but with the academy's strong insistence and- for Rudel- Izumi's persuasion, they reluctantly accepted.

The teachers were begging them to set an example for the underclassmen, so they ended up giving a late appearance. The dorm dining hall went silent at once. Thinking of how the country's future authorities were assembled, the young nobles went meek as lambs. The commoner students were also swallowed in by the atmosphere.

As they came to the dining hall, the three of them introduced themselves to the freshmen. But Eunius was sullen that his play time would decrease having become a prefect. He had visited the town night after night, and just as he became a fifth-year and he thought his free time would increase, he was put to prefect work, so perhaps it was only natural.

"Let me just say it now. Don't get in my way, don't cause me trouble, listen to what I have to say... got it?"

His build was large to begin with, and at his words filled with intensity, the first years nodded. The child in his face had gone, and from the eyes of someone who didn't know him, Eunius looked like a dangerous individual. Luecke's explanation came next.

"I don't give a damn about Eunius, but I have to say the same. I want to read in peace and quiet at night... make a stupid ruckus and I'll shove you in the disciplinary room, so you'd better remember that."

Luecke let off a cold atmosphere different from Eunius, causing the students' expressions to gradually darken. But Rudel's words cheered them up just a bit.

"You're terrible, the two of you. Can't you close an eye to the smaller stuff? I also caused some trouble so can't we be a bit lenient."

A kind senior. The freshmen were relieved, but his next words made them think he was the scariest of them all.

"But if you cause any trouble at the girls' dorm, I'll be troubled... you better prepare yourself when that happens."

As Rudel's face took a sudden turn from smile to expressionless, the first years cringed. They had been taught to start with a slight threat, so they had threatened with some light sentiment. But the imposing air they let off, different from that of a normal senior, caused all to give up on resistance.

Having entered their final year, Rudel was twenty. His body had grown, and he let off a more grown-up air. Before the first years who were still young, Rudel recalled when he had first enrolled himself. When he came to the academy, he had never even imagined he would become a prefect.

On Rudel's threat, Luecke let out a sigh. While Luecke gave off a cold impression, he had become much more sociable than when he first enrolled.

"Rudel, by that you mean don't cause Izumi any trouble, right?"

Like Luecke, Eunius was also making a bit of a fed-up face.



Unlike the boys' dorm, the girls' dorm had Izumi give a smooth explanation. At first, people gave her odd looks as a foreigner, but her explanation proceeded quite favorably.

The reason was simple. They felt it was disadvantageous to go against a woman who accompanied the eldest sons of the Three Lords.

The commoner students were actually quite supportive of Izumi becoming prefect. That commoners could be recognized too, it let them have hope. In contrast, there was displeasure to be had from the nobles.

They thought she had become Rudel's woman, and popular as he was, that was a spot no one else could reach for with much success. They recognized her as being in the way, but a troublesome existence they couldn't quite get rid of.

"That's about all there is to say about the back and dining hall times... if you have any questions, I'll do my best to answer."

Having become an adult, Izumi held a calming air, and her original dignified standing form caused a portion of the girls to look up to her. Her long black hair almost seemed to sparkle to the freshmen.

In that dining hall, a single student raised her hand. A first year who gave off a simple feel, and as she sat among the space solidified with commoner girls, her status couldn't be too high. But what she asked was something quite exorbitant.

"How can I become like you, senpai?"

The eyes of the girl who admired Izumi were sparkling. Izumi had received a number of similar questions before. But she couldn't understand what 'like her' was supposed to mean. And right now, the time and place were off.

"If possible, I must ask you keep the questions to ones related to the presentation."

The girl hung her head at Izumi's words. But Izumi followed through.

"... But you've come to the academy. You need only polish yourself as you learn. Even if you can't become like me, I'm sure you'll find your own ideal."

While those eyes of aspiration only increased in numbers, Izumi continued explaining the dorm's rule. But when the explanations turned to the unwritten rule, her face turned a little tired. A number of the prefects were also troubled by these implicit regulations.

"And this one isn't an official rule, but... if you see a certain boy in the girls' dorm, run to your room at once, and don't let him in by any means."

"But boys can't enter the girls' dorm, right?"

A first year seemed perplexed that she had to explain such an obvious thing. In truth, Izumi had already finished telling them not to invite boys into the

girls' dorm.

"No, um..."

Seeing their upperclassmen prefects grasping for words, the first years grew anxious. They watched in silence as the prefects- Izumi included- gathered and whispered amongst themselves. As girls, they had been warned by their houses to be wary of boys at the academy. The insides of their heads were filled with terrible possibilities.

But according to their upperclassmen, it was something completely different.

"... A certain boy can enter the boys' dorm with barely any question. It's a troubling thing, but he does have his reasons and his status, so it's impossible to drive him off. There's no risk of being assaulted, but... sorry. If you see him, I recommend you run away. You definitely can't approach! ... He'll pet you."

Seeing the first years' incomprehensive faces, Izumi wanted to grow angry at Rudel in her heart. If they hadn't actually seen Rudel's that in action, no one would have realized the true danger.

Until Izumi warned them, the victims had mostly been beastpeople. That is dangerous! It was the unwritten rule of the girls' dorm. The students who let themselves get pet out of curiosity were left with bodies that could never forget.

Seeing the freshmens' doubtful faces, the prefects cursed Rudel within.



After Rudel left the boys' dorm, Sakuya took out Rudel's sword. Her objective was the two sleeping within the blade. She wondered if they knew anything about the abnormalities occurring in her body, and decided to ask.

In Rudel's room, she placed the sword atop the bed and called them out.

"Can you hear me? There's a little something I want to ask."

'What?' '...'

"My body's been acting up lately, and when I got a checkup, there was nothing wrong with me. Couldn't this be your comrade's fault? I'd really like to get better soon, you know."

Her recent poor health gradually building up her panic, Sakuya hid her weakness and put up a strong front as she asked.

'Who knows?' 'Well whatever. Try touching the sword's hilt or so. We might find something out.'

Abiding the bird's words, Sakuya gripped the sword's hilt. She felt a light tremor as something raced all over her body. Sakuya parted from the hilt in surprise, sending the two beasts a complaint.

"W-what did you do all of a sudden!?"

'... This is...' 'Quite something.'

Ignoring Sakuya's anger, the two began discussing. Sakuya couldn't understand the contents, but from the atmosphere, she got the feeling it was something bad. Their words gradually grew scarce, causing her tension to grow.

'Listen well... your body is a temporary vessel the black fog created. It was made only for a single battle with Rudel, a disposable body made with only a single use in mind, so to speak.'

A bold sweat flowed down Sakuya's back. Her eyes opened wide and words would no longer come from her mouth. Continuing on, the bird gave a simple explanation of Sakuya's state.

'You did well holding together so long, but your body can no longer maintain itself. What was originally the soul of a goddess was forcefully sealed into a human body. It looks like it's reaching its limit.'

"Y-you're lying, right?"

Her body beginning to quiver, Sakuya suddenly grew scared. It was something she had never before experienced as a goddess, but her body and heart were well attuned to react to the fear known as death.

'It's true. Your body is reaching its limit.'

'... It's something we did, but I can't take responsibility. My apologies.'

The two voices of pity resounded through Rudel's room. Sakuya didn't want to give up, she told the two all she could say.

"If that fog is the one who made my body, can't you do something about it!? Hey, that's right! In that case, if we ask the fog..."

'Sorry. Your own powers were used to create your body. On top of not having any substitute...'

While the boar couldn't bring himself to go on, the bird conveyed the facts.

'Your soul was forcefully sealed in. Your soul will not return to being a goddess. Right now, you are a distorted existence who maintains a human form with a goddess' soul. Once your body reaches its limit, you will disappear.'

The bird hammered in the truth, but his intent was to tell Sakuya to spend her remaining time without regret.

"U-uwah.... Waaaaah!!"

Sakuya's scream resounded through Rudel's empty room. As fear and sadness assailed her, Sakuya came to understand what it meant to part, something she had never felt as a goddess. She recalled Aleist and Rudel who she had met at the temple. And everyone she met at the academy.

"Why? I finally made some friends... I even found a goal! What's this, what do you mean I don't have any time!?"

The bird and boar quietly watched over her maddened form.

"I made a promise! To Rudel and to Izumi! I promised them I would become a dragoon!"

Her form as she wept like a small child was painful to watch. The two beasts purposely forsook her with cold tones. Hate us if you will, despise us if you will... what foolish existences we must be... the two of them thought as they devoted themselves to playing the villain.

'Crying like a kid is fine and all, but why don't you think about how to spend what little remains of your life?'

'I can't understand it. When you were originally an existence that transcended humanity...'

The three monster who had only been born to put Aleist on the pedestal, they had grown to feel the scorn of the world that created them. They hated themselves for only being able to complete their objectives by bringing misfortune to another.

But the boar and bird had lost their bodies and had become existences only kept alive by Rudel's mana. They would eventually disappear, but they kept quiet on it. They quietly endured as Sakuya pounded her balled hands against the sword's sheath.

Chapter 72

As the school entered its first term, Sakuya had lost her vigor like an empty husk. Worried, Rudel and the others tried to look after her, but after a while, she showed her energy again.

But for those around, it was a painfully empty show. She did endeavor through her training to become a dragoon, but Sakuya was too anxious to get anywhere with it. Alongside her fear of death, she was saddened by the notion she would be forgotten forever. While she basked in her sadness, she came to notice her own feelings...



'Help out?'

Pulling out Rudel's sword, Sakuya struck up a conversation with the two again. This time, she requested to borrow their power. As the boar let out an incomprehensive voice, she gave a cheery response.

"That's right! I'm going to disappear just like that, right? In that case, I have to repay my debt to everyone."

At the request of a slightly withered girl, the two who had one forsaken her decided to undertake. The bird thought it would put her mind at ease, and gave a simple query.

'So what do you want us to do?'

"First off..."



When the weather was nice, it was possible to eat one's lunch in the courtyard visible from the school cafeteria. There around noon, Sakuya spoke with Luecke, surrounded by young nobles. She was normally with Rudel, so it wasn't a problem, but his followers didn't seem to approve of Sakuya alone talking to him so easily.

Even if the nobles were mindful of her, Sakuya conveyed her business. After she had done that, Luecke finished up his meal and sipped his drink, responding without the slightest change of expression.

"Is there anything I want you to do for me? The answer is no."

"A-anything!?"

Luecke's head was hurting at this peculiar request. When he thought she had regained her vigor, she suddenly came out with such a thing. Thinking it was Rudel's influence, he looked at Sakuya, who had taken on a posture as if she were praying as she awaited his response.

"Come back later. I don't have any particular requests. No, wait, I borrowed Rudel's report. Just return it to him, and that's that."

What was handed over was Rudel's report on magic, and a paper that detailed Luecke's thoughts on it. As it wasn't the sort of request she was hoping for, Sakuya's face turned sour.

Luecke looked at her dissatisfied face and gave his stern opinion.

"If you want a more decent request, you'll need to earn your opponent's trust."

Recalling her usual conduct, Sakuya's shoulders fell as she tried to make off with the report. But Luecke called her back and handed over his lunch desert. In a small ceramic cup lay a cake covered in cream.

"What's this?"

"Your wages. It isn't a bad reward for the job."

Seeing the exchange of the two, Luecke's followers felt a kindness they had never seen before in his actions. As he usually ate with Rudel, his followers who only ate lunch with him on occasion were shocked beyond belief.

"... Thank... you."

Realizing she wasn't used to saying the words, Sakuya grew ashamed of herself as she left the area.



After handing the report to Rudel, she next headed to Eunius as he shed his sweat on the training grounds. The students who let their sweat flow, rather than refreshing, it was sweltering. Perhaps because a majority of those on the training grounds were men.

"Any requests? None."

Attaching a weight to his sword and swinging it around, Eunius was training himself up for his confrontation with Rudel in the second semester. Without even looking at Sakuya's face, he concentrated on the swing of his sword.

"Anything will do!"

As Sakuya pleaded in a loud voice, Eunius sighed and decided to take a break. Sitting on a bench, he used the towel and drink his followers had prepared to rest.

"I really don't have... ah, there's one thing you could do!"

"Oh, what's that!!?"

Eunius was hit by inspiration, and Sakuya's eyes sparkled as she bit on. She bit on... but Eunius' request was quite the iffy one.

"There's a girl I'm gunning for in one of the shops I frequent, and I'd like to know her preferences. Normally, I'd be able to research, but she's the silent type, see... I was just mulling over what to do, so could you look into it?"

As Eunius delightfully spoke of the shop's location and the woman's characteristics, Sakuya was mildly taken aback.

"Y-yes... very well."

Thinking she could try asking the bird, Sakuya was about to walk off, when Eunius tossed over the sack of baked sweets his followers had brought over.

"Don't eat too much."

After seeing her off with a smile, Eunius restarted his practice swings. Sakuya gripped the sack in her hands and lowered her head.

"Thank you!"

Eunius thought he felt sarcasm in Sakuya's thanks, and let them slide.



Sending the bird out to investigate, Sakuya held a strategy meeting with the boar. When the bird who manifested in his small body was told to look into the woman Eunius had his eyes on, he spilled some complaints as he flew off... none of the requests were what she had expected, and Sakuya was worried.

"These are just errands, right? I don't want to sound picky, but aren't there any better requests out there..."

'You sure are a picky one. Well, if they're asked so suddenly, then anyone would be troubled.'

"Then what am I supposed to do!? I don't want to meet my end as someone who just ran errands!"

'You should blame your normal conduct.'

She glared at the cold boar, but soon fell onto the bed as she thought over what came next.

"Next is... maybe that guy... but that guy's..."

The one Sakuya shied from was Aleist, who was on his way to becoming her natural enemy. Continually calling her flake and making fun of her, Aleist was irritating. But the one who appeared to her when she was lonely was also Aleist. She thought back to when she was a goddess, always waiting for humans in that desolate temple.

As she recalled that, she concluded she hated him but she had to go anyways, leaving the bed to search for Aleist.



"Hah? There's no way I have any requests for you. My problems aren't the sort of things you would be able to solve."

Evening had come, and before Aleist- who sat on a bench with a tired look on his face- Sakuya clenched her fist and glared. He was that sort of guy. But she remembered him coming when she was alone.

"T-then I could at least hear you out. They say talking takes a weight off your chest."

"It's something quite important to me, but... well, whatever. The truth is, ever since that party, Millia's come to hate me. Even if I try to approach her, she avoids me, so I can't clear up the misunderstanding."

A little fed-up within, Sakuya's motivation flared as she finally heard what seemed to be request-like enough. But it was a fact that Aleist was often approached by five different underclassmen. Looked at from the side, he had a harem. Sakuya got the feeling it wasn't completely a misunderstanding.

"Leave it to me! I just have to make a chance for you to apologize to Millia, right!"

Sakuya happily sprinted off, meeting up with the bird who had finished investigating Eunius request and bringing the boar out to find Millia.

The campus was growing dark, so she hurriedly sought her out. It was there that the bird spotted her leaving the library, swiftly taking action to secure her. Putting Millia on the boar's back, they all hurriedly raced to deliver her to Aleist.

"W-what's going onnn!! I can't move my body, and a strange boar came out!"

The bird had paralyzed her body with his eyes, and the boar had suddenly appeared to take her off. Millia had valued her usual calm air quite a bit, but with these sudden developments, she could only panic.

Seeing the boar that brought Millia over, Aleist couldn't understand the situation either. But as Sakuya rushed to him, she cried out.

"Now's your chance, Aleist! Correct that misunderstanding!"

Sakuya ran up to Aleist from behind, and with her momentum, she gave him a push. Hurry it up you wimp! Is what she thought as she thrust at him... but she ended up thrusting him towards Millia who had been freed from the bird's eyes and dismounted the boar's back.

As a result, it ended up as Aleist pushing Millia down. Having pushed down his crush, the inside of Aleist's head went white with tension and excitement. He forgot his original intent of resolving the misunderstanding, instead confessing in a loud voice.

"M-Millia-san! I like you, I've fallen in love with you! Please go out with me!!"

"What are you saying, Aleist!? Take a good look around!!"

Pushed down, Millia had only just been released from the magic eyes, and her body's movements were still dull. She couldn't run away from Aleist, but she could still look around and understand the situation. When evening came at the academy, the sidewalks would crowd up. Just as Millia had left the library, there were many students who would return to their dorms.

And what would happen if one did something so conspicuous when so many people were around...

A crowd of onlookers had amassed to observe the two.

"E-eeeeeeh!!? Wait, this is... Oy, Flan Head!"

Sakuya had no idea what to do, and the bird and boar had already dispersed. Standing stock still, Sakuya burst into tears. This wasn't how it was supposed to be, she thought, as she cried in apology.

"I'm sorry..."

"That's fine and all! But what are you going to do about this situa... Eek!!"

Before the confused forms of Aleist and Millia came Izumi as if to protect Sakuya. She was on her way back to the form when she noticed the ruckus. Peering in, she had found Sakuya apologizing in tears. Incidentally, Aleist had pushed Millia down... while it was a situation where it was troubling to make any conclusions, she couldn't just leave a crying Sakuya behind, so she came out.

Be that as it may, she did have a few things she wanted to say to Aleist, who pushed down a woman in the twilight and made another one cry. The look in her eyes grew sharp, and as Aleist was looked down upon, the setting sun made him feel fear at Izumi's form.

"I don't understand the situation, but first off, why don't you two stand up?"

There were first years among the onlookers, and they had witnessed firsthand the fear that Aleist- one of the academy's strongest- felt towards Izumi.



Beckoned to Izumi's room, Sakuya sipped a warm drink as she explained what had happened. As she explained things starting from Luecke and ending in Aleist, Izumi gave a wry smile.

"Being helpful to someone is important. But you see, is there really any need for you to hurry?"

Izumi's admonishing words stuck deeply into her heart. Sakuya wouldn't say anything about her own situation. She didn't want to worry anyone.

"B-but I want to be useful too, and I want to repay everyone's kindness..."

The voice Sakuya wrung out left Izumi troubled. She hadn't been energetic as of late, and once she regained her energy, she suddenly said she wanted to be useful. Yet even as she said that, Sakuya looked terribly frail. Izumi decided to play along.

"Then will you hear out my request?"

"Sure!"

Seeing Sakuya's delight, Izumi also felt happy. But Izumi didn't have a particular request for Sakuya either. From what she had heard, something on the level of errands wouldn't satisfy the girl, and as she'd only just started to feel better, Izumi didn't want her to push herself.

She recalled the explanation Rudel gave when they had first met. She was a former goddess and one who decided occupation... it's not as if Izumi believed it, but the one in question proclaimed to be a goddess with a straight face.

"My dream is to become a high knight. It would make me really happy if you could put a good luck charm on me."

Even if she was told to give a good luck charm, Sakuya didn't know what to do. But it was Izumi's request. She didn't have any power left as a goddess, but she tried her best to pray and grant her wishes.

Standing before Izumi, not in her usual manner of speech, she used the words she used as a goddess.

"I am she who doth leads; I am she who shall show thee thy path. She hath heard out thine request. Thou shalt stand above knights, and become the

protector of this fair country..."

Izumi thought she looked almost like a real goddess as she gave Sakuya her thanks.

"Thank you, Sakuya. With this, I can have some peace of mind. I've gotten a goddess' certification, after all."

"... No, I'm the one who should say thanks."

Delighted, on the verge of tears, Sakuya clung onto Izumi. She didn't want her to see her teary face.



When the first term was just about half-way through, Sakuya had managed to hear out a majority of the requests of her acquaintances at school. They were mostly errands, and it was more often than not that she received candy, but even so, she successfully accomplished it.

Only Fina's turn had troubled her, but in the end, she was recognized as a junior disciple, and she was happy they were finally on good terms.

But a problem remained. It was Rudel. The one she was most indebted to, but even if she asked for his request, he would immediately reply he didn't have one. In truth, Sakuya was under Rudel's care, and her position was one where she received more than she gave. Rudel was the sort who would do his own things on his own, and she was unable to be of use.

But Sakuya wanted to repay Rudel's by all means.

At the time, Rudel was looking at a letter from the palace. Alongside a permit to visit the dragon dwellings over the long vacation, it contained appointment documents for the two dragoons who would be accompanying him.

"Who's it from?"

Curious, Sakuya tried asking. Rudel carefully put the papers away in his desk as he explained the situation.

"They gave me something like permission to enter the dragon dwellings. Originally, I wouldn't have needed it, but it's been decided that two dragoons will be accompanying me. They usually wouldn't go along, but my position is one where they can't let me venture out alone. Well, the two of them are acquaintances, so I don't think it'll be a problem."

On Rudel's explanation, Sakuya recalled various things. The undead dragon, and Rudel's special circumstances... Sakuya wanted Rudel to become a dragoon no matter what. Having lost her power, she couldn't be of any use, but she wanted to do something for him.

There, Sakuya realized something she was capable of. While those around would definitely oppose, it was something she could do, no, it was something only she could do...

"So dragoons are coming!? Rudel, I want to go to the dragon dwellings too! No, I'm definitely going with you!!"

"It'll be over break, you know? Though I'll be returning to the house first."

"Take me with you! I'm begging you..."

Losing to a clinging Sakuya, Rudel gave her permission. The dragon dwellings were dangerous, so he thought he'd have her wait at his home. His sister Lena was there, and he held a naïve notion that she would make for a good playmate.

On the contrary, Sakuya had solidified her resolve.

Chapter 73

Once the long break came upon the academy, Rudel took Sakuya along and returned to his house. Sakuya insisted that she had to go along no matter what, but as she parted with Izumi, it felt like she was pushing herself. With a contenance as if she would burst into tears, Sakuya had forced a smile. It weighted on Izumi's mind as well, and she cautioned Rudel to look out for the girl.

Once she boarded the carriage bound for Arses territory, a scenery different from the academy delighted Sakuya. She made merry as if she were on a road trip. Seeing Sakuya having so much fun, Rudel felt relieved.

"I'm glad you're enjoying the road to my home, but the Arses Territory we're headed to isn't the best place to be."

The road to Arses Territory was brimming with vigor. But once they entered the territory, it would be almost like a different world. He wanted to warn Sakuya before she was disappointed, but her reaction was the opposite.

"Even if it's run down, it's all new to me! The scenery may all look the same to you, but just as it's similar, it's a completely new scene. Why don't you look around a bit more?"

Told off by Sakuya, Rudel gave a bitter smile as he read a book in the carriage. A tranquil time passed between the two.



Once they arrived at the Arses House estate, its castle-like scale surprised Sakuya. The world she had seen as a goddess, now she was seeing it through the eyes of a single human. There wasn't much of her life left to live, and Sakuya's heart was brimming with curiosity as she looked around

the gorgeous manor. In that space, Rudel carried out his final preparations and awaited the arrival of the two dragoons.

Sakuya would sleep in the guest room prepared for her, but she wanted to have a look at Rudel's room. She sought out Lena who she'd met before, and asked her for a tour around the mansion.

"You want me to show you around? Sure. I'll teach you my special route."

While younger than her in both body and soul, Lena dragged Sakuya by the hand as she led her around. Proceeding hidden through the courtyard, they made for the kitchen and pilfered some food.

They moved along the mansion's roof, peering into Erselica's room along the way.

"Hey, wait a second! Why are you peeping into your sister's room? Is that what you're into?"

Sakuya desperately clung to the roof in protest, so Lena approached with light movements to lend her a hand up. Looking into Erselica's room, they found the girl in low spirits.

"It's got nothing to do with tastes... ever since my other big brother was sent off to borderland, she's been considerably depressed. She cries when no one's watching, and if my brother was sent off to a dangerous place, I'd also... no, I think he'll be fine? He's stronger than me, and he's going to be the strongest man in the world someday."

"I heard it was a complicated family, but I really don't get it. But Rudel and the other one, aren't they your brothers all the same?"

"You may be right, but they don't think of it that way. Until recently, everyone around was doing terrible things to my brother, and in essence, he was treated like a hindrance in the manor. On the contrary, I never even thought he would be evaluated as he is now."

Without making a particularly dark face, Lena recalled Rudel's reception at the estate that had continued until recently. She didn't bear a grudge. Lena herself, upon coming to the manor, she had obtained a secure lifestyle, and an environment that allowed her to learn. Just like Rudel, she was thankful.

"... Could you tell me more?"

Keep this a secret from my brother, Lena said as she sat on the stop, and told her everything that had happened.



Having heard the tale from Lena. Sakuya had Lena lead her to Rudel's room. Because of Lena's guidance that had clearly taken too many side-stops, they took quite a detour before they arrived.

"Hey, it wasn't that far off from the guest room, was it? And wait, isn't it strange for Rudel's room to be in such a secluded space of the mansion?"

Rudel's room was positioned as if to keep it as far from the mansion as possible. Lena herself lived in the storehouse like room below Rudel. They had already been there for many years, and the ones in question didn't seem to care.

"Now that you mention it, I guess it's strange. Well, don't sweat the small stuff. Let's go search under the brozen one's bed."

"As a little sister, what do you think of that statement? Didn't you say you respect him?"

"Hah? It's because I respect him that I want to know what sort of women he likes, right? When he rarely gets distracted, I want to know his weakness."

Luckily, the master of the room was out, and Lena investigated the underside of his bed. Of course, when Rudel was living his life at the academy, there was no way there were any suspicious books in his room. But as she never had any friends in the mansion, the presence of Sakuya made her frolic even more merrily than usual.

Sakuya didn't look under the bed, but she did look around the room. It was even narrower than the room at the dorm, and far less luxurious than the guest room. Among the goals stuck up over the walls, a training regimen to become a dragoon was written up. The wooden sword leaned against the corner looked like it had gotten some good use.

Perhaps he had put in nothing but single-minded diligence, as it was a room with barely any unnecessary things in it. It was precisely the room of a young boy who had dreamed of dragoons from his youth. All that differed was an earnesty close to madness. He declared he would become a dragoon, and no matter who mocked him, he would put in the effort. The room told the tale.

Seeing that room, Sakuya hardened her resolve. If that's how it is, then Rudel would surely be delighted...



Rudel's training spot in the estate went without saying.

He wouldn't use the training ground; away from the mansion, a nook of the all-too-vast yard had been his favorite spot ever since he was a child. If he used the training field in times apart from when the former mercenary soldier taught him, those around would jeer or get in his way and he couldn't concentrate.

After finishing his basic training, in order to polish his control on his magic, he constantly maintained a set level of mana on the palm of his hand. It was plain, but it was quite a difficult task, and he could continue it without tiring.

But last year included, the surrounding reactions were clearly creepy. The tutor who instructed him and the former mercenary soldier had been dismissed. No, to be more precise, the ones in question had fled. The servants who mocked him, and all who'd been terrible to him had fled in fear of Rudel.

And now, called from all over the territory, young female servants were stuck to Rudel's side. Even if he told them not to come, they would say it was the butler's orders, and fearfully follow along. According to them, they were told their houses would be secure if they could catch Rudel's eyes.

If he sent them away, they would only be scolded. Knowing he had to put a word in with the butler later, Rudel continued his training. But the girl who looked the youngest among them posed him a question. It was a disrespectful thing and her education had likely yet to go far. The face of the servant who seemed to be in charge went pale.

"Rudel-sama, you're going to become the feudal lord, right? Why are you aiming to be a dragoon?"

To that simple question from the girl, Rudel gave a curt response.

"Because it's my dream. I don't have an interest in anything else."

"Y-you can't! If you become head, the territory will get back its energy! My parents and brothers won't have to be hungry anymore!" "Stop it there!"

The girl who couldn't control her emotions was scolded by an older servant. Rudel didn't seem to pay it any particular mind. It wasn't something that interested him, but for Rudel who never had the slightest bit of expectations placed on him, the number of commoners counting on him had increased. The servants of the manor were also originally people of the territory.

Having no expectations is just as troublesome as having misplaced expectations, thought Rudel. Pardoning the emotional servant, he returned to his training.

Rudel thought that no one would ever endorse his dream, but giving up was the only thing he didn't want to do. He didn't want to cause anyone any trouble. He decided to give the butler a letter stating that no matter what happened to him, no one else need take responsibility.

As Rudel thought to himself, he felt that his own dream was built upon too many sacrifices. His people, his family... at this point, he had a position

called white knight, and he was causing all sorts of trouble for the country. That's why Rudel didn't want to trouble anyone with the undead dragon.

Holding it all and cornered by the burdens he took onto himself, Rudel had lost sight of his surroundings.



The day he would set out for the dragon dwellings, his Rudel's former fiancé candidates Cattleya and Lilim came to the Arses House manor. They had been ordered to guard and keep watch over him, and when they arrived at the manor, Rudel was waiting.

Doing a final check on his preparations, Rudel saw there was some time until the promised hour, and invited them into the mansion.

Rudel had refused to let Sakuya go to the dragon dwellings, so she decided to negotiate with the two dragoons. Before the two of them, she carried a bag over her back as she lowered her head.

"I'm begging you! I have to go no matter what! Please take me with you."

At Sakuya's sudden appearance while they were supping tea, Cattleya and Lilim were surprised. But the contents requested of them wasn't something they could accept. While it was a dangerous place, it was also a place that required the country's permission. Lilim tried to give her a gentle refusal.

"I apologize for saying this on our first meeting, but I can't take up that request. Even if you're related to the Arses House, I can't let you into a place concerned with national security. I'm sorry."

As Sakuya still kept the look of youth, Lilim tried to deal with her gently, but Cattleya took the opposite approach.

"If you think we're on a picnic, then you'd better give up. The place we're headed is dangerous. Even with us guards here, if it comes to fighting a dragon, we might not be able to raise a hand. You'll just be in the way."

She had been rejected by both of them, but Sakuya wouldn't back down here. It was something only she could do, she told herself, as she actualized the 'dogeza', a special technique she had heard of from Izumi. Even the two dragoons were taken aback by her actions and will.

"I'm begging you! It is absolutely necessary that I go!"

As the room turned noisy, Lena happened to pass by.

"Oh, when I thought I heard a ruckus... you bullying her?"

Seeing Sakuya execute a dogeza, and the other two trying to stop her, Lena laughed in jest. But the two of them gave loud, immature rebuttals.

"That's not it!" "I'm not!"

In the end, Sakuya was denied, so she went outside with Lena.



"What should I do... I really do have to go..."

Seeing Sakuya so down, Lena- who had become her friend- decided to lend some power. Having witnessed her serious face and the resolve in her eyes, she would cooperate without asking what Sakuya was trying to do. The two of them sat at the base of a tree in the yard as they spoke.

"You have to go no matter what, Sacky?"

Called Sacky, Sakuya silently nodded. It seems her resolve hadn't wavered.

"Then there's no helping it... my brother will get angry at me later, but it's Sacky's request, so I'll try to help out. Can you tell me what you want to do?"

"... I'm sorry, I can't say it. I'm sorry."

Lena stood, and pulling Sakuya's hand, she headed for the dragons awaiting Cattleya and Lilim's return. Lena's actions startled her, and without a grasp

on what was going on, Sakuya let herself be dragged alone.

"Y-you won't ask anything?"

"As long as you're not trying to get in the broster's way, then I'll help you out. But you better be prepared for his anger when he finds you. Once you're found, you have to move wisely."

"Lena..."

Pulled by the hand, Sakuya noticed a sort of charm she couldn't put to words in Lena. Her bold air that seemed to force everything to go her way... just having her there was reassuring.

They arrived at the dragons, and while they couldn't speak words, Lena made a plea to them in a loud voice.

"Hey, hey, let my friend here hide herself in your luggage."

She declared it to Cattleya's fearsome red dragon without a moment's hesitation. Dakuya was the one who ended up the surprise. At the red dragon averted its face to signal its refusal, Lena suddenly started petting it.

"Don't be so angry. I'll throw in a freebie... how about something like this?"

As she gently pet it, the red dragon squirmed. It didn't seem to be in pain, but its body wrenched. If the large body of a dragon thrashed around, then there was sure to be damage around. Not paying any mind to that, Lena continued to gently pet it.

"So this is your weak point."

As if she was petting a dog, she stroked the dragon without any fear. As a result, the powerless red dragon silently turned its back towards Lena. Lilim's Wind Dragon opened its eyes wide as it stared at her.

The Red Dragon kept glaring at her, but Lena didn't seem to mind. It was nothing more than a shamefully shaking dragon staring at her.

"Sacky, hurry and hide."

As Lena gave her a push in the back, Lena took out a letter from her bags. As Lena received that bulky letter, Sakuya made a request.



As Rudel prepared to set out with Cattleya and Lilim, Lena alone had come to the dragons to see them off.

"Just you, Lena? What about Sakuya?"

"Sacky was depressed, so she might not come. More importantly, broster, before you go, you have to pet me! It's been so long since you pet me. I haven't been getting pet at all lately, so..."

Before his sister who requested the petting Izumi banned, Rudel thought this might be the last time, and decided to pet her. Seeing Rudel pet Lena's head- as she acted depressed- Lilim's ears turned red. Cattleya didn't know the situation, so she sent a fed-up eye to Lilim's panic.

"What are you so flustered about over some skinship between siblings? Don't get your knickers in a twist over something like that."

"Cattleya! You can only say that because you don't know! T-that isn't something so soft! Ah, now that you've made me recall, my ears are..."

Seeing her senior fidget, Cattleya thought she was exaggerating as she failed to grasp why Lilim looked so happy.

"What are you talking about? Just look at his little sister."

As Cattleya directed her eyes towards Rudel and Lena, Lilim also shifted her gaze from Cattleya to Rudel. There was the form of Rudel on his knees.

"... You've drowned in your craft. It definitely felt good, but right now, you fall short of how you once were. If you forget what's important. There's no meaning to it!"

With a sorrowful look on her face, Lena looked down over Rudel. His shoulders dropped, Rudel stared at his hands. His sister had made him realize.

"S-so I forgot the most important thing. You mean to say I've drowned myself in pointless technique..."

Seeing Rudel seriously depressed, what about that? Cattleya thought as she watched. But Lilim alone felt true fear. At Lena who could take pets as if it were normal, and at Rudel who had raised his skills even further, but even now was called immature.

"Brother, what's important is to accept... and that means love! You're lacking the love! Too fixated on the technique, you've lost the most important thing. As I am now, I don't even reach your ankles, but that alone I can tell."

Unsteadily standing to his feet, Rudel looked into Lena's eyes. He was making a cheery face as if he had accepted his defeat.

"To think the day would come for me to be told off by my sister. I've still got a long way to go. Thank you, Lena."

"Don't mind it. For you're my prided brother! Let's reach the summit together!"

Seeing the siblings exchange a smile, Lilim and the two dragons were shocked.

"I-it can't be, you mean to say that still has a long way to go!? There's no way such a thing could be permitted!" 'For real!? It's against the rules for someone to be better than that girly, dammit!!' 'W-what a fearsome child of man...'

As the only one unable to keep up, Cattleya saw everyone heated up and thought.

(Huh? Am I the strange one?)

Chapter 74

Arriving at the dragons' dwelling, the first thing Rudel's party did was secure a place to spend the night. With thick forests, deep seas and tall mountains, it was a holy land that humans couldn't inhabit, or at least that was the official stance. But as there were actual dragons living there, it was simply a dangerous place.

In that danger zone, you could call them lucky to be able to secure a campsite while protected by dragons.

But a problem came out at once.

"Why did you come along!? More importantly, how did you sneak in!?"

As Sakuya popped out of the luggage laden on her own red dragon, Cattleya held her head. She couldn't forgive that it had hidden the fact from its contractor, but it was even less permissible that the red dragon, called the most dangerous variant, let itself be approached so carelessly.

"Hah, it looks like someone'll have to send her back."

Seeing Lilim breathe a sigh, Cattleya tried to personally escort her back to Arses Territory. But the red dragon refused. Lilim's Wind Dragon also said it didn't want to return, if possible. They didn't want to send Sakuya home only to be stroked all over by Lena.

"You're my dragon, so listen to what I have to say!"

To Cattleya's scream, the red dragon offered an obstinate refusal.

'No way, fool! I-I decided not to get involved with that one again! My pride is in tatters. If you're my contractor, then you can at least notice that much!'

"Like I care! Just take her back!"

It seemed impossible for Cattleya, so Lilim directed a glance at the Wind Dragon. But the Wind Dragon averted its eyes to signal its refusal.

"... We'll be quite troubled if neither of you wants to do it."

'I refuse.'

In the end, they could only permit Sakuya's company.



"Why did you do something like this? In the worst case, you'll be punished, and you won't be able to become a dragoon."

Having secured a place to sleep, Rudel and the others warily made their way through the forest. They needed to pay respect to the dragon whose territory they set up camp in. A water dragon living in the lake was the ruler of this area. It was higher ranking than both Cattleya and Lilim's dragons, and a dangerous one to make an enemy of, or so the two dragons had warned them.

On the move, Rudel felt irritated at Sakuya as he asked for her reasons. When she was aiming to be a dragon just like him, he was irritated she would choose an option that might sacrifice her future. The air she gave off didn't make it seem she was taking any particularly calculated actions, so Rudel wanted to confirm her reasons.

"I-I was just a bit interested, and it's not like I'm irrelevant to this matter. I have a reason I need to meet with the black fog... right!"

As she put a hand on the sheath of Rudel's sword, the boar and bird who had been sleeping within corroborated her story. It was the most they could do to match Sakuya's absurdity.

'Y-yeah.'

'That's right. She needed to meet her quickly.'

The two who knew Sakuya's plan made sure Rudel alone didn't catch on as they frantically unraveled a reason off the top of their heads. There was a defect in the body the black fog produced, and they explained it required some tuning.

"Is that true? Why didn't you tell me sooner? You've certainly been in poor shape lately, but..."

Even if he understood, Rudel couldn't quite accept it, and as he was mulling, they reached the lake. In the thick forest, only the area of the lake received ample light from the sun. Reflecting that radiance, the lake gave a beautiful glimmer.

'Rudel, make sure to leave no discourtesy. You are dealing with a dragon ranked higher than we, and this one is very hard to please.'

As the wind dragon explained, the two in Rudel's sword let out their voices.

'Isn't that the dragon from before?'

'That it is. When it's supposed to be hard to please, that one was a reasonable dragon willing to hear us out, but...'

It was a water dragon they had previously met at the lake. It was here that Rudel encountered a legend...



The first semester was over, and once the academy went on vacation, Fritz was invited to the palace by Aileen. Having become a third year, Fritz had wanted to spend the break training himself in preparation for the individuals' tournament, but as it was Aileen's request, he left for the palace.

Raised in the countryside of Arses Land, Fritz had become an adventurer and left the sticks to work. Having been able to raise a name for himself in cities on the outskirts, Fritz was quite something himself. But always a big fish in a small pond, even after he went outside, he still failed to understand his own position.

That cause was Aileen.

When it came to Aileen, she publically interacted with him as a princess, but when they were alone, they would drop the honorifics. Aileen herself took a liking to it, but those around weren't quite so pleased.

Having become a knight from a commoner, and always so upfront with her, Fritz was Aileen's ideal in itself. That's why she couldn't permit it. By no means had she actually recognized Fritz' power. The reason Fritz' twisted recognition of himself grew to such a level was surely Aileen's fault.

Let into a detached installment of the palace, Fritz entered the facility where the gray dragons were raised. There, Aileen waited with a number of high knights. Aileen greeted Fritz with a smile.

"Fritz-sama, I am glad you were able to make it."

"Aileen-sama, what business have you called me for today?"

Fritz started the conversation still on his feet, but no one would call it disrespectful. This was because Aileen permitted it. Internally, the high knights wanted to knock him off his feet. No, they could cut him down too.

"I do feel greatly pained to invite you to such a place. But when I think of Courtois' future, there is something I must accomplish by all means."

As Aileen began speaking of the country with an enigmatic face, Fritz' heart skipped a beat. The country was in a critical condition, and he was happy to be relied on. To Fritz whose desire to be a hero far exceeded the average man, Aileen's words were sweet on his ears.

"Can you give me the details?"

"Yes. Have you heard the rumors of the white and black knights?"

Fritz nodded with a reluctant look on his face. Because Rudel and Aleist were existences Fritz couldn't forgive. He couldn't forgive that those who had been selected for knight positions you could equate to the heroes of yore. It was simply a child's jealousy, and Fritz understood that.

"The black knight is an upstart of a noble, so the palace will be able to take the appropriate measures. But the white knight is Rudel of the notorious Arses House. The palace has devised some adequate means, and that is what the Royal Guard is to be. That would mean granting a powerful level of authority to Rudel."

Simple as he was, Fritz easily believed Aileen's words. To Fritz, the Arses House was evil. Some part of him was convinced they were seeking out greater authority.

"Rudel is of an archduke lineage, so if he was so minded, he would be able to take me or my sister as a wife. If that happens, then Courtois is over... Fritz-sama, won't you come to our salvation?"

"Save? If there's something I can do, I'll help out, but..."

Hearing Fritz' words, Aileen gave a bewitching smile.

"Fritz-sama, in these halls lies the dragon that will be used to select the royal guard captain... do you think you could tie a contract with that dragon?"

Aileen's plan was steadily moving forward, but unlike her sister Fina, she was soft on the finish. She had ignored the fact Rudel had made for the dragon dwellings. It would be a godsend if he croaked out there, was all she thought of it. If Fina were in her position, she would definitely have sent in assassins.

And as reality would have it, Rudel's guards turned out to be the ones closest to him, his former fiances. That had been a result of Fina's schemes.



Meanwhile, Rudel was so surprised, his voice wouldn't come out. As the water dragon appeared from the lake, its large size and beauty had stolen his eyes. What's more, he recognized the traits of the dragon before him.

Lilim's dragon gave a purr to call that dragon, and it showed respect to its superior. On top of that, it explained the situation. The dragon called out looked over Rudel and the others. Perhaps it wasn't particularly interested as it started off back towards the lake.

While it permitted their stay, it indicated that it had no mind to let Rudel ride its back.

But looking at the back of that beautiful dragon, Rudel cried out in a loud voice.

"Are you the dragon of Marty Wolfgang-sama!?"

Everyone was surprised, but the reactions varied. The two dragons were surprised he committed such discourtesy against a high-ranking foe, while Cattleya and Lilim wondered who that was to begin with. Sakuya alone, after a moment of surprise, began sending the same dreamy eyes as Rudel.

"A-amazing! To be able to meet the dragon of the real Marty-sama!!"

But the most surprised of all was surely the water dragon. It was usually a hard to please one without the slightest mind to converse with humans, but to make sure everyone could hear, it sent its voice to everyone's head. It reminisced as its tensions rose with Rudel's words.

'I'm shocked. To think there was a human who knew about Marty... what's more, even adding a -sama, you sure know your stuff! Name yourself.'

"Rudel, I'm Rudel Arses!"

The water dragon approached him. The distance between them was a meter, but facing a dragon, the intensity was on another level. But the two active dragoons had no recollection of the name Marty.

"Senpai, who's Marty?"

"No idea. Since he knows a dragon, could he be a former dragoon?"

But the two dragons did remember Marty. To be more precise, they knew the rumors.

'Oy, they're talking about that guy, right? That crazy old man, right?'

'Fool! Don't say anything to ruin this!'

The red dragon was still categorized as one of the younger dragons, and its mocking statement at Marty received a proper recompense.

'Brat over there! What did you just saaay!!?'

A dragon larger and higher-ranking than it snapped at its neck and pulled it into the lake. Leaving aside the dazed surroundings, a number of pillars of water broke the surface. After a number of intense impacts, the area suddenly went silent. The water dragon came up once more, and a little later, the red dragon bobbed to the surface.

Seeing her own unconscious dragon, Cattleya couldn't keep up with the situation.

"Eh? Huh!? Wait, what's going on!?"

Lilim bound her arms behind her back and calmed her so talks could restart.

'I never thought I'd hear Marty's name from a human tongue. How truly nostalgic... urrrgh, Why'd you have to go off and die, stupid Marty!! You said we would be together forever! So why'd you have to go off on your own!!?'

Reminiscing and bursting into tears, it was quite a busy dragon, so Lilim thought as she covered her ears. For a dragon to weep, it would mean for a roar. The air shook to an extent she could feel with her body.

As they waited for the dragon to calm down, Rudel preciously produced a single book from his bag. How to Pet a Dragon... the book Marty left behind. Turning to the final page, he conferred Marty's words for the dragon.

"It was written in the book. 'To the one I love, I'll surely be the first to go, but do not grieve. And do not let yourself be caught. I didn't want to place shackles on your freedom after my death. Because I loved you'."

Rudel let the dragon hear the words that made those gathered want to vomit up sugar. Lilim writhed in embarrassment, while Cattleya was visibly bashful. Inside, her girly side wanted to be told something like that.

Once Rudel finished reading, the dragon began to sob. Seeing that scene, both Lilim and Cattleya teared up too. They were surely separated by death. They concluded from the dragon's manner of speech. Even if he rode a dragon, he was human at the base. When the time came, he would be killed in action.

"What a beautiful relationship. But for him to die early..."

"I'd like a certain idiot dragon to learn a thing or two from them. Well, he was a dragoon, so he must have fallen in battle..."

'What are you talking about? Marty didn't die in battle. He stayed in active duty to the age of eighty.'

"Eh?"

"Hah!"

'Around the end of it, these important looking guys would come every day to complain on and on, and he would ignore them. But when they made fun of me in front of Marty, Marty would get angry... they would fight quite a bit. Even after he passed sixty, he received numerous cases of disciplinary action. At the end, they sent us off to a place called the borderland(?) but we were happy nonetheless.'

That's gone way passed the level of a problem child, right? The two dragoons thought as they looked at the dragon. After that, the two boyfriend-less souls reluctantly listened in as the dragon spoke fondly of him. Opposing seemed dangerous, so they listened with obedient looks on their faces, but their expressions were stiff.

'I was with Marty since he was twenty, so I was only able to be with him for a mere sixty years! What do you mean, eternal happiness!? Show a bit of willpower! Don't you think he could've held on a bit more? The presents and memories he gave me every year were...'

The two of them reaffirmed the difference in sense between human and dragon, but Rudel and Sakuya were deeply moved as they heard out her story.



The first night since they came to the dragons' dwelling. Rudel carried out a final check on his weapon. Once he checked everything from start to finished, he recalled the sleeping drug he had mixed in their dinner. He had made sure to prepare something that wasn't dangerous. The three of them would likely sleep until noon, he thought as he lay himself down.

He did have some resistance to putting medicine into a woman's drink, but Rudel had a goal he couldn't concede. There was no way his two guards would permit the sheer danger of his actions. And it would be too dangerous for Sakuya. He decided to put the three of them to sleep.

But there, he felt a presence outside of his tent.

"Sakuya?"

"Hehe, can I come in?"

As Sakuya entered the tent, she held a picture book dearly in both her hands. It was one of the dragoon picture books Rudel would read to her.

"You can't sleep?"

Rudel had his misgivings the drug didn't work, but Sakuya's answer was a simple one.

"I'm sleepy, but before I slept, I wanted you to read this."

Thinking it might be the final night, Rudel agreed to read her the book. And Sakuya fell asleep before he could read it to the end. She slept with an extreme look of relief.

The morning of the next day, equipped with a sword and full-body armor, Rudel made for the undead dragon's cave under the guidance of the two beasts. For the two dragoons sleeping soundly, he left a letter detailing the circumstance.

And he made a plea to the two dragons.

'Let you go alone? I can't say it's a bright idea for you to move around on your own.'

'Yesterday's granny was kind to humans, so it wasn't a problem, but the next one you meet might come at you without question.'

"No problem. And when you face a dragon, you have to be alone... I'm leaving those three to you."

The two of them saw Rudel off. Right, if you tried to obtain a dragon, there would always be dangers. If you had strong guards with you, a dragon would never recognize your merit.

Once Rudel walked off, it was Sakuya's turn to wake. She had heard about the drink from the boar and bird, so she was able to avoid it. Leaving her bags behind, she traveled lightly as she tailed Rudel. But in the path Rudel walked, the two dragons stood in her way.

"What are you doing!? Step down already!"

'Now happening.'

'I made a promise with him. To look after you three.'

Sakuya wanted to hurry, but she couldn't do anything against two dragons. Having come so far, there was no meaning if she couldn't do anything. She prayed to the heavens as she wondered if there was anything she could do. But under the heartless sky, only time would pass by.

It was there that a single large dragon approached. It was Marty's dragon.

'Looks like you're doing something interesting, you guys.'

As the two dragons got the jitters, Sakuya alone clung onto the water dragon. With a serious look on her face, she tried persuading it to take her to Rudel who had made for the undead dragon.

"Please help me! I absolutely have to go beyond this point! I'm begging you..."

The water dragon's large eyes glared at Sakuya. As Sakuya didn't take a single step back, the water dragon was reminded of Marty in his youth. Straightforward and desperate eyes. Resolved for something, the eyes of one who would risk their life.

'I like those eyes. I won't let you on my back, but you may follow behind me.'

'T-that would be troubling...'

'Well now, I guess I didn't see anything after all.'

"T-thank you!"

Sakuya hurriedly chased Rudel as he made for the undead dragon. Time-wise, she was a few hours late. If she didn't hurry, she would never make it in time.

Chapter 75

'Are you fine with that?'

The water dragon walked up front, and Sakuya followed behind. There were nothing but dangerous dragons around, and a moment's lapse could have her killed. To ease Sakuya's tensions, the water dragon had heard out her goal. It had heard of the undead dragon, but it didn't think that was a problem Sakuya could do anything about.

But after hearing Sakuya's goal, the water dragon turned despondent. Her life was short, and she had made the decision to end it... to the dragon who valued the soul, Sakuya's further actions felt exceptionally noble.

"I-I'm so scared I can't stop shaking. B-but you see... there's nothing that can be done! I can't live even if I want to! I wanted to try harder! I wanted to be together longer! So... at the very least, I should be helpful at the end."

As Sakuya's eyes went teary, the water dragon lowered its back. The sudden happenings left Sakuya surprised.

'I haven't let anyone ride me in over a hundred years. Be grateful. From now on, I'm going to have to insist I'll never let a man ride me. Temporary as it is, right now, you are a splendid dragoon.'

"Thank you."

Sakuya leapt onto its back. The water dragon spread out its large, pale, transparent wings, and took to the sky.



In the cave that reeked of decay, Rudel took on the undead dragon. Perhaps it hadn't completely awakened, as its lower body couldn't move, only its upper half and right wing showing a range of motion. It was mostly bone, but some rotten flesh still ardently stuck to it. It was an extremely unsightly dragon.

'W-why... why are you alone...'

At Rudel's appearance, the black fog that had been taken in let out a cry that was almost a scream. But her voice had weakened from before, and it seemed the fog's awareness was gradually growing dim. The boar gave Rudel a simple explanation of the situation.

'This is bad. The black fog has been almost entirely taken in, and the undead dragon is attacking everything, no questions asked. To be quite honest, I think you should give up and retreat.'

"That's not an option. While it's also for my sake, Sakuya has business with the black fog. She can't be helped if it fades away. I can't step down, and it doesn't look like it'll let me."

The undead dragon used its arms to move towards Rudel. As a subspecies of gaia dragon, its arms had developed more than the other dragons. Its rotten flesh and body of bones was much faster than it appeared.

Pulling his sword, Rudel held his left hand up front and shot a bolt of light.

A number of those shots rained down on the undead dragon and exploded, but it continued its advance as if they had no effect at all. As Rudel tried to move from the spot, a sticky something that wasn't mud captured his feet. It had a stickiness to it, and to Rudel who had thought to fight a hit-and-run battle, he was conducting combat in an exceptionally disadvantageous location.

"It's faster than I had imagined!"

'You're in luck it isn't at full power. But if you want to use your full power, you'll have to get outside... it's a bit deep ahead, so be careful.'

The bird calmly related information on the dim cave interior to Rudel. A battle where it was hard to see had him hard-pressed. But as he had awoken as a white knight, the battle actually raged on quite favorably. He used his light bolts, and when an opening was made, he'd cut with his magic sword.

He continually secured points his opponents attacks couldn't reach as he began to push the undead dragon back.

"When it's head is practically bone, it's a mystery how it can tell our location."

As he ran the undead dragon gave chase, and Rudel calmly put up countermeasures. But the way things were going, he could foresee his loss in the end. Avoiding the arms and wings it swung around, he thought of nothing more than to save the fog.

'Sorry to intrude when you're in a good state of mind, but at this rate, you'll run out of mana or stamina. You'll eventually lose.'

The bird's conclusion was right. Having been able to fight so far on his own, Rudel was strong, but to the end, it was a human's strength. When compared to a dragon, it was only natural he was a bad match. Without any comrades to help him, Rudel fought by on his own as he tried to think up a means to get the black fog out of it.

"More than victory, saving the fog is our first priority. I came here to obtain a dragon. There's no point in just winning!"

On those words Rudel told himself, the boar gave a simple explanation.

'There is a way, but the dragon's original soul is the problem. On top of being ruled by feelings of fear and isolation, it's blocking off all interference from the outside.'

The bird took over the bird's explanation.

'Meaning your voice won't reach it. Its guard is so strong the black fog failed when it tried to interfere with it directly. It's the sort of monster that

devours life to steals its soul away, and there's no point calling out to it from the outside... from the outside, that is.'

As Rudel ran around, the undead dragon started taking different action from before. Both its wings began to move, and gradually the rest of its body followed along. Alongside an overwhelming difference in physique, the limited space pushed Rudel into a corner.

I have to attack with all my might, otherwise... thought Rudel, but as the undead dragon unleashed its own full might, it exceeded his expectations. His goal had changed to saving the black fog for Sakuya's sake, and he had to give his all to avoid his own annihilation. He had been much too greedy.

"So I was too hasty..."

A red light took residence in the eye sockets of its skeletal head. As if to take the place of eyes, they focused on Rudel. Correcting his stance, Rudel laughed before the undead dragon.

His selfish self was strange. When he was aiming to be a dragoon, the very fact he was fighting a dragon was strange. And that he wouldn't give up even in this situation was even stranger. He had chosen such an idiotic option of challenging a dragon alone... but he didn't regret it.

"I'll definitely make you my dragon!"

Rudel took a large step towards the dragon before his eyes.



Sakuya and the water dragon finally reached the cave. From the entrance, they would hear the screams of battle and the sound of explosions. Light tremors broke out here and there.

'... This is a place a dead dragon remains prisoner. To think an empty husk could move again... I can't bear to see its eternal torment.'

The water dragon grieved the pain of its brethren, but there was fundamentally no means to save it. Neither side could interfere with the others. Sakuya on its back hardened her resolve as they set foot into the cave. It was originally a cave excavated out by a dragon, and the water dragon could pass through it with ease.

'You're nervous. It's not too late, you know?'

"I'm not giving up. I mean... this is the only way I can be useful."

Trembling as she smiled, Sakuya was too worried about the events going on in the cave to help it. If Rudel died, there was practically no point in her objective.

'They're cornered. The child inside, and you... hold on tight.'

As the water dragon hurried on in, the intense sounds of battle suddenly weakened. The explosions stopped ringing out entirely. In a panic, Sakuya called out Rudel's name.



"Rudel!!"

As he crashed into the wall, Rudel no longer had the power left to move a finger. Because of his sturdy armor and shield, he had managed to persist in one piece, but his energy and mana to move had run reached its end. He had tried fighting the undead dragon with everything he had, but even with his full-power attacks he had prepared as his trump card, defeating the dragon was impossible.

Sakuya's voice suddenly entered his ear, but he was unable to respond to it. He noticed the large footsteps and vibrations gradually approaching him weren't those of the undead dragon.

'She's here!' 'You're late, Sakuya!'

Having leapt out of Rudel's sword, the boar and bird had used what mana they had left to project their original bodies, frantically clinging onto the undead dragon to protect Rudel. But as the dragon thrashed about to remove them, they were only able to cling on. There wasn't any time.

They had preserved their power for that moment alone, but if Rudel died, then everything would be lost. The two had manifested. Manifested and bought some time.

"Rudel...!"

His form Sakuya witnessed, it was the form of his dented, chipped armor with injuries around his eyes. It was impossible to tell from over his armor, but perhaps his body was in a terrible state as well.

His armor was stained black, and while his breath wasn't strange, it was weak. She couldn't see his usual self, full of confidence. But she didn't despite. Up until her mouth came close, she was smiling.

Finally sensing Sakuya's presence, blood flowed from Rudel's mouth as he wrung out his voice.

"S-Sakuya, r-run..."

He was surprised at the entrance of another dragon, but having lost his vision, he couldn't confirm it. For now, he could only think of letting Sakuya escape to report to the country. He had pushed it and caused the undead dragon to awaken. Rudel recognized his own irresponsibility as he accepted his failure.

Not that he regretted working hard for his dream, he simply accepted the result. Sakuya thought that acceptance wasn't like him as all, but she could feel that his battered form had put up resistance to the bitter end. In truth, he was losing a lot of blood, and Rudel was on the verge of death.

But as Sakuya approached, she planted a kiss on Rudel's forehead.

"I'm sorry, Rudel. But if nothing else, I'll grant your dream..."

"Wha.. ar... ou..."

Sakuya's tears fell onto his face. Rudel couldn't understand what Sakuya was trying to say. His consciousness began to grow distant...



"Please, help me out! Take me over to it!"

Parting from Rudel, Sakuya requested help from the water dragon. The boar and bird weren't enough to hold back the undead dragon. Sakuya had intended to end things before it came to this. But speaking to results, Rudel was in critical condition, and the undead dragon had sprung to action.

'... Very well.'

The water dragon opened its mouth, creating a sphere of water and firing it with good momentum. It wasn't that the water came from its mouth, it gathered water from the area and shaped it into a spear. It smashed a number of those into the undead dragon, sending it flying into the opposite wall.

It was weakened from its battle with Rudel, and the water dragon was a dragon abundant in combat experience. It wasn't a simple attack, the dragon had compressed a considerable amount of water, and as those orbs collided they burst as if explosion. By compacting the water, it was able to fire something like a laser as well, but that didn't suit its objective, so it held back in its attacks.

The boar and bird separated from the undead dragon, and this time the water dragon pinned it down from above. Perhaps it was losing its ability to maintain its body as its bones and flesh easily tore and snapped. But even now, there was no sign it would stop moving.

While it was held down, its skeletal head remained as it was. It violently moved its mouth, its red glowing eyes fluttering tempestuously. There, the black fog began to regain consciousness.

'T-this is... so that's what it is.'

Sakuya approached the undead dragon's mouth with her body that was nearing its limit. Perhaps understanding the general gist of things, the black fog confirmed the present situation with the boar and the bird.

'Even bringing a dragon here, and yet Rudel still hasn't a dragon of his own?'

'It's just as we thought. Rudel will never be chosen by a dragon.' 'The dragon holding it down is one that Sakuya brought.'

'... You're the goddess from back then, right? You've thought up quite the audacious thing.'

The boar and bird kept it simple, but they explained the events up to now. As the black fog consented, it altered its ignition goal. At first, it had intended to use the undead dragon's remains. But here they had Sakuya, a girl with the soul of a goddess. If everything was assembled, there was no need to waste it.

'Sakuya, was it? Are you fine with this?'

The skull of the undead dragon before her eyes. Sakuya felt fear as she nodded. The water dragon saw that, and every apart from Rudel could guess what she was going to do.

For the sake of just a single human, Sakuya and the three beasts would become sacrifices.

Sakuya turned only once to looked at Rudel, shedding tears as she muttered with a smile. Seeing the unconscious, fallen Rudel, she recalled all that happened since she obtained a body. A majority of her happy memories only came after she attained physical form. Someone was always with her and she was never lonely.

It was all things she could never obtain in her time as a goddess.

"Goodbye, Rudel. I loved you."

Sakuya leapt into the mouth of the undead dragon. In what was originally the sturdy jaw of a gaia dragon, Sakuya lost her life in an instant. But her soul was taken in... and that was her goal...



'Looks like it went well... is it my turn next?'

'You're going first?' 'It doesn't matter. We'll disappear all the same.'

The water dragon parted from the undead dragon that had stopped moving. Seeing the actions of Sakuya and the three, it had a good guess at everything they were trying to do. So it made a proposal.

'You've saved my kinsman, so I'll help out too. You lot are much too awkward for the task.'

'I see, thank you.'

After giving a word of thanks, the black fog stopped resisting and plunged into the undead dragon on its own.

'You have my deepest gratitude for your assistance. I'm leaving Rudel to you.'

The boar said its thanks, turned to mana, and faded away. As its body dissolved into grains of light, those grains made off in Rudel's direction.

'Why am I even here... it doesn't look like I can pay back this debt.'

The bird complained, but the water dragon shook its head.

'It was originally our problem for not being able to save this one. I can only wonder why we left it so long to begin with... anyways, don't think of this as a debt. Go forth with peace of mind.'

'... It really is a strange tale. Why are we... it couldn't...'

The bird tried to say something before disappearing like the boar. But the three of them gave off a satisfied feel. The bird dissolved into light, and as that light headed off towards Rudel, the water dragon roared in the cave. At the same time, the dark cave was wrapped in a warm light. That roar from the cave resounded all throughout the dragon dwellings.



As Rudel regained consciousness, he couldn't see, but he felt he was being protected by something warm. Opening his eyes, he found he wasn't in the cave; it was a vast space of white nothingness.

"T-this is... my body doesn't hurt. What happened to me? Why can I see? Where's Sakuya!? What happened with the undead dragon!?"

As he regained consciousness, he gradually recalled the events that led him there. But he couldn't understand the situation. Keeping wary of his surroundings, he thought, when a voice called out to him from behind.

'Rudel, it's alright.'

He turned to find Sakuya standing there with a smile. Relieved, Rudel tried to approach Sakuya, but no matter how far he proceeded, the distance between them wouldn't shrink. Feeling some anxiety, Rudel called loudly for her.

"Come over here, Sakuya!"

Sakuya made a troubled face as she shook her head. And this time, some voices came from his right. The voices of the fog, the boar and the bird. They were in their original large forms, letting out an air as if they were relieved. But he wasn't able to approach them either.

"What' happened!? Where are we!? Are you all..."

Some part of him understood that his bad premonition had hit the mark. But he couldn't accept it. Sakuya looked at Rudel's panic, giving a ram smile as

she held her hands out as if to splash water on him. Atop her palms floated something that gave off a warm light.

'I managed to persuade him. I managed to obtain his body... this child will return to the flow of souls, and he said we could do what we wanted with his body. He told me to tell you he's sorry.'

"What are you talking about!? Just get over here already!"

Reaching out his hand, Rudel tried to grasp Sakuya. But Sakuya started to let out light, without even trying to move. This time the black fog called over to Rudel.

'Making a fool of yourself, and at the end, you give up with a satisfied look about your face!? What happened to your promise with me, you damn fool! ... I'll forgive you just this once. There won't be a next time.'

Next was the boar. Saying it was his turn, he sent some words to Rudel.

'It was surprisingly fun. When we were born for nothing more than to get in your way, I get the feeling we were able to oppose it in the end. This is my gratitude. I want you to accept it... turn it into the power to oppose.'

As the boar disappeared, the armor and sword equipped on Rudel let off light. The armor that gave off an uncouth feel was adorned with lovely ornaments. On both the armor and the sword, a pattern began to surface. In his left hand, the shield he had never held appeared. It wasn't a large shield, but it was adorned with decorations to match the sword and armor, a pattern across it.

That same pattern on the boar and the bird faintly surfaced on them all.

That white, gleaming form was surely worthy of the white knight.

Next, the bird called over to Rudel. As those around began imparting words of parting, Rudel thought his heart was being plucked out. He wanted to scream at them to stop, but his voice wouldn't come out.

'Since you injured your eyes, do you want me to give you some? I have a lot of eyes, I always thought I had a few too many. Oppose it to the end... it's unfortunate I won't know how it turns out, but if it's you...'

Right after, Rudel felt something in his eyes, but now wasn't the time for that. Before his eyes, the bird had disappeared. He desperately sprinted, but the distance would never close. It was the black fog's turn.

'From me, you'll be getting a heart. It's a heart I obtained from changing my path, but it's not like ill intent was all I ever gained. I shall give you the heart of a dragon... when I've done so much for you, next time, you better not give up until the end! Everyone's cheering you on.'

The black fog disappeared as if it had cleared up. Rudel looked at Sakuya and reached out his hand again. But Sakuya didn't try to take it. She only looked at him and smiled.

"What I shall give you is a goddess' soul. With this, you have a dragon's body, heart and soul together. I'm sure you'll get an amazing dragon! You're inheriting the goddess Sakuya-sama's soul after all!!"

Seeing her usual energetic form, Rudel turned sorrowful. It was all a result of him not wanting to drag anyone into his dream, and it had all backfired.

"Is it my fault? Was I wrong? Why do you guys have to go so far!? It's just my petty, selfish dream! There's no reason for you to sacrifice..." "There is!"

Sakuya confronted Rudel, screaming to interrupt his words. Touching both her hands to her hips, she made a pose to clearly signal she was angry as she scolded him.

'Your dream is my dream too! It's a dream everyone wants to grant! So it isn't a dream for you alone anymore. It's a dream that Izumi and Luecke and Eunius and Lena and Stupid Aleist all want to come true! There are lots of them. There are lots of people supporting your dream!'

"But even so, this is a seed sown by my own selfish actions. It's all my fault!"

So you don't have to become a sacrifice, Rudel tried to continue on, but he ended up stopping. Because Sakuya was crying.

'I'm sorry. It must have been lonely. It must have been painful. But Rudel, you're not alone anymore. I'm begging you, please notice it! You'll make everyone sad.'

On those words, Rudel cried as well. He didn't know why, but his tears welled out. Sakuya wiped her tears and smiled as she made a plea to Rudel.

'Can I make one final request?'

Rudel wiped his tears as well as he smiled at Takuya. It was the sort of painful smile where you could tell he was forcing it. But thinking that Sakuya wouldn't want to see any more of his pitiful form, Rudel made a smile.

"Sure. It's my time to do something for you."

'You have to look after Izumi, okay? Treasure her. And tell everyone I said hi. And also, and also...'

After a stream of trifling requests, Sakuya finally made a serious face as she looked at Rudel. She told Rudel to kneel and offer up a prayer, so Rudel abided. After taking a deep breath, Sakuya returned to her goddess speech as she did with Izumi.

Her current form was more sublime than it had ever been before.

'I am she who doth show the way, I am she who shall show he who opposes fate his path... Thou shalt be the strongest of dragoons. Thou shalt be the strongest of knights. Thou shalt become the shield that protects the country and the weak. Henceforth, you shall be the White Dragoon... farewell, mine beloved.'

Rudel's consciousness grew distant once more...

Chapter 76

The academy's vacation ended and the second term began. But Rudel had yet to show himself at the academy. Even when they confirmed it with the Arses House, a reply came back that he had yet to return. The country also sent out an investigation, but it had yet to show any results.

A certain rumor was spreading through the campus it was...

'Rudel is dead.'

They would whisper. Even the two active dragoons didn't return, so the rumor was even spreading through the castle. In the end, it was no good. The voices that said he should've just given up had increased.



"Try saying that again! I'll split open that empty head of yours!"

As Eunius raised a serious yell, the cafeteria fell silent at once. He used one hand to lift up his opponent by the lapels, bringing his face close. His opponent was Fritz. Practically anyone would cower, but even if Fritz looked at Eunius, all he could see was a farce.

"About how Rudel died? It's true, isn't it? Ah, perhaps he got scared and ran away. Oh, he might come back for next week's selection test."

Having exchanged a contract with a dragon, it was already decided that Fritz would become the royal guard captain. Once he graduated, he would work at the palace. Convinced that he had triumphed over Rudel, his usual attitude had inflated even more. They held true even when dealing with a high ranking noble.

Even worse were Fritz' followers. By the fact that Fritz was strong, and that the first princess knew him well, the young nobles would always fall silent. Those around Fritz had gotten around to think that was only natural, and even if Eunius yelled, they wouldn't try to stop him. On the contrary, Eunius' followers stepped in to bring a ceasefire.

"Eunius-sama, you're picking a fight with the wrong guy." "Let's just calm down here, alright?"

As his followers pulled him from Fritz, Eunius clicked his tongue. Before turning his back to Fritz, he gave a warning.

"That guy, you know. He never gives up, and he never runs away."

Seeing off Eunius' back as he walked off, Fritz made a dark smile. By Aileen, his state was completely on cloud nine. He was certain he had the power to change this country. Recognized by a dragon, he had gotten the idea he had triumphed over Rudel, and he misunderstood that he had the ability to back it.

Gray dragons were more docile than their wild variant, and as long as you had a certain level of skill, you could make a contract. But Fritz didn't know that.

In the cafeteria, Izumi who had been looking at the ruckus from afar, shifted her eyes to the outside of the window. She prayed he would come back, perhaps on a dragon or something, acting as if nothing had happened at all. But her heart felt strangely uneasy.

"Come back soon Rudel, Sakuya..."

The words Izumi muttered at the window sill, no one came to give a response.



The day of the selection test came to pass, but Rudel had still yet to appear at the academy.

Izumi grew worried, and she decided to participate in the event to wait for Rudel. Rudel was forcefully obligated to take part in the event. To speak to the contrary, it would be a problem if he wasn't there.

Izumi looked over the legions of knights filling the hall. For the same reason, they had come to the selection test, but Eunius and Luecke didn't have any interest in the royal guard position either.

Aleist alone was overly mindful of the imperial guard. He was worried about Rudel as well, but to those around, it looked as if he wanted to become captain himself. The real reason he was there was because royal guard captain was the protagonist's official post. As Aleist had been largely separated from the story, he had only taken part out of curiosity of who would be chosen.

The royal guard would fulfill a large role in the story's war arc. Aleist wanted to confirm who would bear the burden.

There were lots of acquaintances to be found in the hall, but they were far outnumbered by active knights. There were a few high knights taking part while the dragoons conducted security. The high knights protecting the royal family looked at their comrades with conflicted emotions. The dragoons alone were knights who had already been chosen by dragons, so they didn't hold the qualifications to participate.

Just by being chosen, you would become the captain of a new special unit that ranked up with the dragoons and high knights. The hall was wrapped in a peculiar excitement. But Izumi and the others would have none of it, simply looking around in worry.

'Henceforth, the selection test for royal guard captain shall be conducted! To you knights who think you have what it takes please approach the dragon on the stage!'

Watched over by the royal family, the gray dragon guided by the dragoons descended onto the stage. The knights lined up on stage paid their respects to the king before walking up to the dragon one by one. Even if it was a gray dragon, there was no doubt it was a dragon nonetheless. It held an

intensity to it, and there were many knights who were frightened just by approaching it.

But the dragon accustomed to humans showed no interest in anything as it simply watched on.

There were many knights taking part, and there was still a long while to come. Izumi concluded so as she waited for Rudel.

(It'll probably take a while, but if Rudel doesn't make it back by then... the royal family's watching, and even if he came now, he'd be late. Even when he's never been late to class before.)

As the number of knights in the hall gradually diminished, those around her waited irritatingly while Izumi grew restless. But as someone she recognized made it up to the stage, the dragon showed interest.

Izumi thought this selection test was, in itself, a rigged race in order to make people recognize Rudel's position, so the sight surprised her. The dragon snuggled close to Fritz as it recognized him as its contractor.

"Izumi, have you seen Rudel?"

While the surrounding knights fell into a slump, Luecke walked over to Izumi's side. He was looking around, but he couldn't see Rudel anywhere.

"... I haven't. But what's all this about? What's Rudel supposed to be selected?"

"I don't know either. It was something decided from the start, but for things to be settled before Rudel even got here... more importantly, Izumi, look at the king's seat. Doesn't that look unnatural?"

Hearing that from Luecke, Izumi looked to where the royal family sat. The ministers who seemed to be responsible had drawn close to the king. They were making a ruckus over something, but all eyes in the hall had been gathered on Fritz. She saw the high knights frantically pull the curtain to cut off her line of sight.

From the king's bearing, she could tell this was an unexpected event. The queen was also receiving an explanation from the high knights. But before the curtain close, Aileen and Fina alone quietly watched over the event. Though the knights around Fina were in a frenzy.

"Princess Aileen did hate Rudel. And the one the dragon chose was Fritz... you think that's a coincidence?"

To Luecke's thoughts, Izumi didn't think they would actually go that far. She wanted to reply as such, but thinking back to all Rudel had done to that point, there were some parts she could nod to.

"It was a setup? In that case, right now, Rudel could be..."

A bad premonition entering her head, Izumi's face turned pale. Her heart had been restless as of late, and she could only think of the worst.

"I don't think they'll do him in so easily, but Rudel's already been recognized as the white knight. Taking his power into consideration, as long as they prepared some highly skilled knights, they could capture him and kill him with ease. But no matter how you look at it, that's a terrible hand to play. Killing him would be of no benefit to the country. They normally wouldn't do it, but Rudel obtained permission to enter the dragon dwellings."

While Izumi and Luecke thought, the hall hurriedly moved onto its next event. Fritz was officially appointed as captain of the royal guard.

"Rudel..."

Izumi muttered in worry as she believed in his return.



Where the royal family gathered, Fina looked around with a calm air. She knew it was a rigged election, and she was convinced Aileen had made a move. Calling out to Sophina, she confirmed the present situation.

"Sophina (Oh my~, so she made a move after all. Though I never actually thought she'd go this far. Looks like I've got a ways to go. That aside, are we really going forward like this?)"

"Yes, princess."

Gazing at her father Albach, she called Sophina close. Just like Fina, the queen was also seeking confirmation. But the area around Aileen alone was calm. A number of Aileen's guards headed to the king, and alongside the minister, they tried to persuade him to accept Fritz as captain and see how things went.

"What of ma... Rudel-sama? (More importantly, master. I don't care about some royal guard, and since it's come to this, I can just alter my plan and it won't be a problem! I'll use them for all they're worth, but first... Where are you maaasssstttteeeeerrr!!)"

"That has yet to be verified. It seems he did not come to the hall."

"Is that so... (This is bad... if master isn't here, then that will produce a delay in my grand plan. I can use the royal guard so they're not a problem, but if master isn't here, then my dream of Courtois Fluffy Land is gonecassee!!)"

"The whereabouts of the two dragoons is also unknown. Was it really the best option for us to have moved on our own?"

"Obviously. What sort of care-free things are you saying? You read the report they filed, didn't you? I've got a good idea on how things went, so look into the high knights trying to persuade my father, and that minister as well. (When she's so naïve, I'm genuinely surprised my sister actually succeeded... I was right to choose his guards.)"

She recalled the unnatural report. In spite of the requested search, the report was vague and untrustworthy. She got the impression they never planned to conduct the search from the start.

Fina had read that report at the start of the first term. From there, she had Sophina's subordinates move on their own.

Fina gazed at the confusion surrounding her. It was at that moment. One of Sophina's men raced in. His brow oozed with sweat as he screamed an emergency request. He pleaded for the royal family to evacuate from the spot.



It wasn't just the heads in confusion. The hall was also in a panic.

"Fall back! Quickly, run away!! If you're here, you'll be trampled down!"
"I'm telling you to get the hell away!!"

The ones who suddenly descended down were Lilim and Cattleya. As their dragons flew down, they evacuated the knights and other relevant parties that remained in the hall. Lilim and Cattleya's dragons positioned themselves to protect the royal family.

Izumi rushed over to the two and asked about Rudel. She had been told they were stationed as Rudel's guard, and she determined they might know something.

"Excuse me! Are Rudel... Are Rudel and Sakuya safe!?"

Izumi didn't overlook the moment of clouding that came over their faces. But the two of them soon looked up to the sky and cried out.

"Ah, oh no." "Everyone get down!"

Everyone followed their line of sight. There, they could confirm the form of a large dragon led along by legions of smaller ones. But it was a scene everyone could only doubt. The small dragons, even looked on from afar, didn't give off an impression of being young.

More than that, the single large dragon was abnormally large. That much was fine. That much was fine, but the large dragon was unsteadily teetering

through the air. It looked almost as if it wasn't used to flight.

The selection test hall, with all the participants, it had been set up outside. IT was impossible to conduct it at the palace, so it was held on a plain. If it wanted to land, then anywhere was fine. Everyone around thought so. But the unsteadily flying dragon headed straight for the hall as if sucked into it.

The knights and staff started panicking again. Izumi could tell by instinct Rudel was riding that dragon.

The dragon that approached was larger than any of the dragons one could normally see. Its overall body was slim, but its overgrown forelimbs and its four large wings that held up its large build could be called its characteristics, or perhaps could be called characteristic of it. It was a white and pretty dragon.

On its forehead came the glimmer of a blue gemstone. And there was a person on its head. At the individual in armor, Izumi gave a loud cry and waved her hands. While she didn't know why, seeing the dragon caused her to think of Sakuya.

"Rudel, over here!"

Spotting Izumi waving her hands, the dragon started falling straight towards her. When its flight was so unsteady, only its nose-dive looked sharp and elegant. Right, it was falling.

"You foooolll!!" "Why'd you have to call for it!?"

"E-eeeh?"

Izumi couldn't understand why Lilim and Cattleya were closing in on her. Rudel was finally here, so she thought it was best to be close to him. Bht the two who knew the situation knew the intensity of the problem. Cattleya cried for those around to get out of there at once, while Lilim offered Izumi a simple explanation.

"That child is still terrible at flying!"

The idea had never occurred to Izumi and she looked up at the sky once more. The white dragon was falling straight towards her. At the same time, the legion of dragons started positioning themselves to protect the surroundings from that white meteor.



"S-so I made it in time!"

'Yeah, I tried hard... praise me.'

A number of dragons came to dig out and support up 'Sakuya', who had collided with the ground. Rudel looked around and searched Izumi out. The white subspecies that had become Rudel's dragon, 'Sakuya', had started a rapid descent upon starting her.

Still only able to use shoddy sentences, Sakuya had nothing in the ways of memory or knowledge. Naturally, she wasn't supposed to remember Izumi. But once she saw her, she happily swooped down. Not listening to Rudel's attempts to stop her... as a final measure, he pleaded for the dragons around to help.

"Yeah, you did your best. But everyone else also worked really hard, so you should thank them."

'Okay, thank you.'

Sakuya roared at the wild dragons around. Rudel jumped down from Sakuya and spotted Izumi. Sitting on the ground, Izumi was looking up at Sakuya.

"Izumi!"

As Rudel called out, Izumi stood and drew close. But perhaps in her confusion, she became emotional and threw words at him one after the next.

"You're late, Rudel! And why did it come to this? Couldn't you make for a safer landing? Is it my fault? Is it because I called out!?"

"... Don't worry. It's all my fault. And who's in charge around here?"

He looked around, but he could only see knights looking up at Sakuya, and knights cowering from the wild dragons. Izumi also looked around, but with everything that had gone on, she didn't remember where the staff had gone. In exchange, Luecke and Eunius rushed over.

Behind them, Aleist walked, looking over Sakuya. Eunius walked up to Rudel and made a mess of his hair. He yelled at him, but his face was smiling.

"Worrying us like that! What were you doing all this time, Rudel!?"

Luecke made a tired face, but looking up at Sakuya, he congratulated Rudel for fulfilling his dream.

"Your dream came true, Rudel. With this, you're a dragoon."

Looking at the two of them, Rudel smiled, but Izumi couldn't honestly rejoice. She got the feeling he was hiding something. Aleist also approached, standing bashfully before Rudel as he spoke.

"C-congratulations."

Rudel spoke with a smile. From Izumi's point of view, he was smiling, but it was a somewhat sorrowful smile.

"Yeah, thank you, everyone."



Once the confusion died down, the royal family and those involved looked at Rudel's dragon. A large and beautiful build that made large wild dragons look like children.

The king looked at Rudel with a smile, keeping his mouth shut as he hit his hands together in applause. Following on from the king, Fina also sent Rudel an applause. She looked at Sophina, and pressured her into clapping.

On, and then another, the number of people applauding increased. In the hall as well, many were wrapped into clapping praise of Rudel.

Aileen loathsomely looked on the scene in the hall. The knights around her weren't clapping.

Before his own dragon, Fritz was on his knees as he looked on from a distance. Rudel's form was the very form of the knight he dreamed to be as a child, and his dragon was beautiful. Watched over by the wild dragons, and the knights around were sending him applause.

All the commendation he was supposed to receive, he felt it had all been stolen away by Rudel.

Chapter 77

Once a conference on the country's future course was held in the chaotic grounds, Rudel called Izumi and the others to a tent that had been temporarily set up. Gathering Luecke, Eunius and Aleist, he started explaining everything in order. The black boar, the sinister bird, the black fog... and he told them about Sakuya. He told them slowly so his emotions wouldn't take over.

As Rudel calmly went on, he gave off a terribly cold impression.

He showed the will Sakuya had given Lena to everyone.

He told them how Sakuya, her life running out, had cast down that life for his sake. As he did, Aleist punched him. Growing emotional, he rained Rudel with jeers.

"To hell with that! If you had a grip on things, there wouldn't have been a problem, dammit! Why do you look so indifferent! She died for your sake, didn't she!?"

Eunius and Luecke held him back, and by their hands he was pulled out of the tent. In the end, Luecke and Eunius decided to leave the space to Izumi.

"All yours."

'Don't worry, we'll calm this guy down.'

"Hey! Wait! I still have something I want to say..."

Confirming they had left the provisional tent, Rudel stood and gave a bitter smile.

"Haha, that was something. To think I'd be punched by Aleist."

He did stand, but he averted his eyes from Izumi. Perhaps tired from the long trip, Sakuya was sound asleep in the tent. Izumi lay a hand on Sakuya's forehead as she called over to Rudel. Rudel was sure he was in for another put down.

He knew he had done enough to deserve it, and he intended to accept it all. But Izumi's words betrayed his expectations.

"Did you cry, Rudel?"

"? Yeah, I think I cried... I was crying the moment I opened my eyes. I can barely remember it, but I cried and walked out of the cave. There were lots of dragons flying through the sky. It seems they were celebrating Sakuya's birth."

Rudel tried to change the subject, but Izumi paid it no mind.

"I see... did you cry after that?"

"No, I don't think I did. I was too busy. We had to train Sakuya to fly, and there were quite a few things I needed to hear. I had lost my sense of time entirely, and until the messenger from the princess came, I hadn't even noticed. From there, I hurriedly prepared to return to the manor and made it just in time. No, I was late."

I learned a new technique, Rudel gave a laugh as he spoke. Izumi wondered if Rudel's business was him trying his best not to think about it.

As Rudel spoke with some jest mixed in, Izumi embraced Rudel, wrapping her body tightly around his. Rudel's face was buried in her chest. As the power left his body, Rudel crumbled at the knees, and Izumi sat down to match his level.

"I'm sorry. For letting you go through the pain alone... it's alright. You can cry if you want to, Rudel."

Izumi gently pat his head. Rudel shed tears as he spit out his own feelings. Rudel could never rely on anyone, but the truth was that he was terrible at relying on people. To Rudel who never had people he could depend on from his childhood, he was unable to comprehend the events around him.

He had only actually understood Sakuya's actions once everything was over.

"I-if only I'd been more level headed! It's just as Aleist said. If only I looked at Sakuya more, it never would have come to this! ... But some part in my heart was actually happy I obtained a dragon. I'm the worst. The worst piece of trash! And yet, and yet for someone like me, Sakuya...!"

In the letter Sakuya left behind as a will, there were lots of words for Rudel. Izumi had faintly recognized Sakuya's affection towards him. But her realization of it only made it more heartbreaking.

"She told me to be the strongest, she told me to protect someone! I have no choice but to do it! Even when I'm like this, it's my promise to her... I... I have to continue being Sakuya's ideal knight. I have to keep being the strongest or I'll never be able to look her in the face!"

Like the string holding him back had been cut, Rudel spewed his emotions. As what he was holding in came out, it came out with tear after tear.

"You don't have to endure it, Rudel. You can cry now."

Rudel wept loudly, and Izumi held him the whole time. Izumi was shedding tears as well.

Outside the tent, there were three eavesdropping on their conversation. It was Luecke, Eunius, and Aleist. Aleist alone was in a slump, regretting the fact he hit Rudel. The one who looked after Sakuya was Rudel, and he recalled how he didn't do anything in particular for her.

Eunius and Luecke thought back over all the unnatural occurrences, and as they thought, they looked at the sky.

"W-why am I always..."

"No, neither you nor Rudel ever reads the mood. It's not like this is a first."

Cutting down a depressed Aleist with a single stroke of the tongue, Luecke recalled the contents of Sakuya's letter. He had been in it as well, and she wrote it was fun. He was seeing Sakuya, who knew she was going to die, yet hid her feelings, in a new light.

Eunius reflected in a similar fashion. Saw her anew, and cast some words to the sky. Even if he knew they wouldn't reach, he couldn't stand by without saying them.

"Good grief, she really was a good woman. I should've called out to her."

The sky dyed with twilight; some part of it was suffocating.



Sakuya's letter.

With her shoddy, large lettering, Sakuya had left a letter. It was a sort of will, but the one in question hadn't written it with that intent. She simply wanted to write her feelings.

'I'm glad I came to the academy. I was happy.'

'I didn't have time, but even I was able to hold a dream.'

'My dream never came true, but I'm becoming one of the dragons so,'

'I'm becoming a dragoon with Rudel, so maybe it came true after all?'

'Thank you, everyone.'

She wrote down lots of names- the people who looked after her. Starting with Rudel, she even wrote the names of the cafeteria lunch ladies. Aleist and Fina alone were addressed dubiously. Stupid Aleist and Weird Fina. She thanked them both as well.

She wrote thank you a lot of times. Once it came to the latter half, she wrote her memories to that point, and the feelings she held towards Rudel. As the letter shifted into that portion, there were many places where the text would blur. It was clear she had written it while crying. She wrote she was happy he would read picture books to her.

She wrote she was happy she got to eat so many sweets. She was able to make so many friends... the last part was so blurred it was difficult to read. There were traces she had rewritten it a number of times. She left words as if to dote on Izumi.

'Do you think someone will remember me? Do you think Izumi will cry?'

'If she reads this, that means I'm already gone, right?'

'Was I useful? Was I of any use to Rudel?'

'I found my reason to live. Thank you, Rudel.'

'I've lived a long life, but these few years were the most fun I ever had.'

'Parting is sad, but thank you for everything.'

'Bye bye.'

And there, the letter of shoddy letters came to a close.



Once he had finished crying, Rudel stood and wiped his tears. Seeing Sakuya asleep, his face turned refresh. Deciding he wouldn't cry anymore, Rudel touched his hand to Sakuya's forehead. Izumi stood as well, similarly placing her hand on Sakuya.

The blue gemstone on her shoulder reflected the two of them like a mirror.

"Thank you, Sakuya, it's because of you I was able to become a dragoon. I'll never forget."

"Sakuya, you saved Rudel. You were more than useful... I'll never forget you, Sakuya."

Rudel and Izumi linked hands. The large gemstone on Sakuya's forehead let off light giving a feel as if Sakuya had replied.

As the two of them smiled, Rudel swore an oath to himself.

"I'm not alone anymore. My dream was a dream everyone made true... now it's my turn to grant everyone's dreams. I'll be the knight everyone wishes for. I'll be the strongest of knights. I'll become the strongest dragoon!"

Rudel took a deep breath before muttering the rest.

"I won't let this dream end as my own selfishness."

As if to give a response to Sakuya's final words, Rudel swore an oath to the sleeping dragon.

Outside the tent, Aleist wept as he muttered he would never forget Sakuya. Luecke closed his eyes as he prayed for her to rest in peace.

Eunius looked up at the sky, swearing he would never forget.



Within the next few months, word of Rudel spread all throughout the Kingdom of Courtois. It came in the form of an article, giving praise to the white knight who became a dragoon. The one reading the article was Chlust, the boy sent off to the outer reaches of the kingdom.

After having spent a year of his life in the borderland, he read the article on his brother Rudel draped over his desk, a smile on his face. The brother who trained him had become a dragon. As his younger brother, it was something to be proud of.

"Oy, captain, did they write anything interesting?"

Calling Chlust captain and approaching was a large man of unshaven face. He was a commoner-turned-knight from the outskirts, and he served as Chlust's adjutant. In this far-off fortress where noble knights rarely proved any use, he was a man who had made light of Chlust at first.

But within the span of a year, Chlust had gained the man's recognition.

"Yeah, my brother became a dragoon. I was just rejoicing."

As he showed the article, the unshaven large man's read through with his eyes open wide.

"Now this is amazing. So the captain's big bro is an elite! Well, he's still a youngster without any real combat experience, so maybe you're the stronger one."

Gahaha, the large man gave a large laugh. As Chlust recalled Rudel, he was sure his brother had grown even stronger than before, so he probably wouldn't be able to win. Recalling Rudel's strictness, Chlust gave a bitter smile.

"More importantly, did something happen?"

"Oh, that's right. You remember the unnatural monster corpses and village attacks that have been going on in these parts? It seems the area's finally calmed down, but they've started breaking out around another fort. I did order the men not to let down their guard, but... hah."

As the large men breathed a sigh, Chlust breathed one as well. Starting with the fort's higher ups, the knights of noble birth slept from the morning, and they wouldn't wake until noon came alone. Even if they were awake, they would often drink ale and head off to the nearby villages. They even laid hands on the fort's funds.

Ever since Chlust got around to manage the assets, even they knew they couldn't go against the Arses name. But their attitudes hadn't changed in the slightest.

"Got it, I'll do something about the report. I'll have to reorganize the platoon's composition later."

"All yours, captain. We've got confidence in our strength, but reports are a no go. They'll be so bad you'll be crying for pity. With the other guys, they'll accept it if I tell them the captain's handling it."

In a harsh environment, Chlust had grown as well. Tucking the article on his brother into his desk, Chlust thought of the report and troop composition as he gathered up some of the documents under his charge. Some of the latest documents were collected on the bookshelf.

From there, he pulled out the necessary files.

They had been increasing as of late, the reports of a black ogre. It was still on the level of a rumor, but they said a black ogre was rampaging through Courtois. On the appearance of a black ogre no one had ever even heard of before, Chlust also felt a sense of crisis.

In certain villages, it would attack only humans, and in others, it would only harm livestock. By the villagers' testimony, they had heard human voices as well.

But in Chlust's fort, the matter had been processed as a mistake on the villagers' part. It was unthinkable that humans would act alongside an ogre. And the fact it would only harm livestock was concluded as it wanting to fill its stomach.

Gathering up the documents, Chlust began investigating into the black ogre.

Chapter 78: Extra: Surpass Marty

5

Extra: Surpass Marty 5

A few days after Rudel had fallen onto the hall, Sakuya and all...

In a room of the palace, Fina received a report from the two dragoons. She wanted to hear the events that transpired in the dragons' dwellings, and the reason they were late to the selection test. The two of them had already submitted their reports, but Fina called them out saying she wouldn't be satisfied unless she heard the details directly.

Classes in the academy had already begun, but the palace was in a frenzy, causing them to take measures they wouldn't usually take. The fact Fina had yet to return to school was because of all the confusion surrounding Rudel and Fritz.

Who was more worthy of being royal guard captain? No matter how you looked at it, that was Rudel, but Aileen's faction wouldn't permit it. From Fina's point of view, it wasn't a problem however the hell Aileen moved. So in order to leisurely draft up her future course, she had called out Rudel's two guards.

She looked expressionlessly at the two before her eyes, Lilim and Cattleya, as Sophina put them under scrutiny.

"So after he obtained a dragon, they were training it to fly? You mean to tell me it's a child at that size?"

She tried to hear out their testimonies but there were too many peculiar points. First came the dragon. Rudel's dragon was even larger than a wild dragon. It was a size larger than the largest gaia dragon. It was such a dragon, and yet they said it was doing flight training, making it late to the test.

Anyone would doubt it.

“No, I did say it was an adult, size-wise. But it was only born a few weeks ago...”

Correcting the position of her glasses at Lilim's report, Sophina continued her questions.

“Newly born and an adult... I'm an amateur when it comes to dragons, but I do know it takes some time to grow after they hatch from their eggs. Well, let's just move on. For what reason did so many wild dragons follow along?”

Cattleya answered that one.

“That's because the dragons said they wanted to give their thanks or something, and they wanted to look after Sakuya.”

“Oh, can such a thing happen? Dragons are famous for getting less involved with one another than humans. I'll have to verify that one with Rudel-dono. Continuing on, why did you stay until after the deadline had gone by?”

From Sophina's attitude, it was clear as day she wouldn't believe them even if they reported the truth. Cattleya always had a tendency to look down on high knights, and her answers were becoming quite half-baked.

Understanding Cattleya was irritated, Lilim decided to answer everything on her own.

“Truth be told, when the white dragon was born, it seems she was unable to fly, and still immature as a dragon. The other dragons insisted their pride wouldn't allow them to send her into the world like that...”

“So everything is the dragons’ fault. How convenient. It’s something we’ll never be able to confirm, so, well, power to you. But during that time period, what exactly were you two doing?”

“No, um... Rudel-sama said he would look after Sakuya, and wouldn’t hear us out, so we had to accompany him.”

While Sophina was irritated, she took care not to say anything too incisive. But to the earnest Sophina, Lilim and Cattleya’s report was irritating.

“Report on the details! I’m getting tired of all these careless, vague remarks. The two of you have some responsibility in this, you know!”

“Yeah, yeah.”

As Cattleya averted her eyes, her attitude showing she wasn’t repenting in the slightest, the blood rushed to Sophina’s head. Things wouldn’t go anywhere like this, so Fina swapped out. Seeing Cattleya suddenly revise her attitude, Sophina mumbled complaints to herself.

“This isn’t getting anywhere. Let me step in. Both of you, can you give a detailed report on the events from the dragon’s birth to your arrival at the hall? (Hmm, you’ve got a ways to go, Sophina. You’re dealing with my master... it’s impossible to think things went down normally! Now what sort of report will I be able to hear!!? I won’t be surprised no matter what you tell me!)”

Amused within, Fina heard out the flow of events that led them to the hall.

First, after arriving at the dragons’ dwelling, they were put to sleep with medicine, and in that space, Rudel obtained a dragon. But in order to obtain that dragon, Sakuya who forcefully came along became a sacrifice... they gave a simple explanation of how that made it so the dragon born was far more immature than its appearance would suggest.

“... Is that so. That girl was...”

Even Sophina couldn't understand what Fina was thinking. But expressionless as she was, she looked sorrowful.

“That's where the problems began. The dragons started to get entangled with the white one in excess. It seems they were looking after her, and they said something about atoning for something.”

The reason Lilim's words were so muddled lay in that even her own contracted dragon hadn't given her the details. She was unable to talk with the other wild dragons. So she couldn't learn anymore.

“They taught her how to fly in the sky, and how to hunt prey; meanwhile, we were living a survivalist lifestyle, but... Rudel-sama started training alongside a former dragoon's water dragon.”

Fina's shoulders were shaking a bit. She silently looked at the two before her eyes. Tell me what happened, quickly, Sophina could see her applying a silent pressure.

“At first, it was training on a dragoon's way of combat. But along the way, it devolved into horseplay, and they started fooling around.”

As Cattleya recalled Rudel's few weeks, she could only see it as them playing around. But Lilim to her side's complexion changed as she revised Cattleya's report.

“No, that wasn't anything so lukewarm! Rudel-sama was definitely not playing around!”

“Eh? Wait, Senpai?”

“Lilim, go on. (What's with their reactions... more importantly, I'm curious about this water dragon he got involved with. I doubt it, but...)”

Lilim got worked up as she spoke of the new skill Rudel had picked up.

“It was an application of water magic. Applying a slippery property to water, you use it to cover their body. It was considerably slippery, so at first

I thought he was learning how to use traps or something. But that wasn't it! That... that was a lost art omitted from the book!"

Slippery water... it was lotion. Meaning Rudel had learned lotion play. It was an ultimate technique Marty hadn't noted down in his book. After that, Rudel perfected a special art of his own, but that is a different story.

"W-what was that!? By book, you couldn't mean...!"

Lilim's powerful explanation even shocked Sophina. Fina was expressionless, but she held up a hand to hold Sophina back as she urged Lilim on.

"To think 'How to Pet a Dragon' was still incomplete... in that case, could this water dragon you spoke of be the dragon of legend? (For real... come so far, master's reached a height beyond my reach. No, this is a godsend! I must rejoice that what was lost has been revived!!)"

"Rudel-sama was considerably depressed, so he devoted everything he had, and lost himself in training. In the last few days, the dragon initiated him into the secret arts! At this point, there is no one in the world who can best Rudel-sama..."

"P-princess! This is a national crisis!!"

"Calm down, Sophina. I'll take some measures... but this has become something terrible. Both of you, make sure not to speak of this matter outside. (It's heeerrre!! Master's finally gone and done it!! I can't sit still. I have to move at once... first, I should do something about that royal guard.)"

Left behind by the surrounding situation once again, Cattleya honestly began to wonder if she was the strange one.

(Is it me? Am I the odd one out!? What's the meaning of this!! Senpai's been like that from the start, and that high knight I don't like was surprised, and more than anything... the princess' hands are shaking!! Am I really the strange one!?)

Fina immediately started thinking of what was to come. She had finished investigating into the knights who were sent out to search for Rudel, and the minister responsible. She learned they had only pretended to search for him, and she caught onto Aileen's schemes. There were plenty of ways she could make use of both facts.

"After that, we lost our sense of time until your messenger came by, and, well..."

Lilim struggled to go on, but Fina had already lost interest. To be blunt, she couldn't care less. If being late meant Rudel was initiated into the secret arts, she would even reward them for it.

"Good work, both of you. You shall hear of your punishment later, but as you've heard out my selfish request, I'll make sure nothing bad becomes of you."

"Your grace!" "Your grace!"

Seeing off the two as they left, Fina ordered Sophina to lead the minister in.

"If you plan to punish them, shouldn't we report to his majesty?"

"Punish? What could you be talking about, Sophina? There is no point in reporting to father. The one who used the minister was my sister, and soft on the finish as she was, my sister accomplished her goal. It wouldn't be strange if there are some among the higher-ups who simply left my sister's actions be."

"Then what good comes of calling them?"

"That's simple. I just have to make it all go as my sister wants. The royal guard will be established, and her boyfriend Fritz can be captain for all I care. Let's have the minister help out too."

Sophina couldn't accept that Fina was letting Aileen be. She thought Fritz' conduct at the academy would be unnecessary at the palace. But Fina's plan was the opposite.

“Are you questioning my actions? I’m not leaving them be. More so, I’m helping my dear sister out. We’ll establish the royal guard, and station everyone who shares in her ideologies there. (The demi-human discrimination is terrible among the palace’s knights. We’ll gather them all up in one place, and steal away their authority... when that happens, they’ll be short on hands, will they not! And if they don’t have enough people, then they have no choice but to supplement them from elsewhere!!)”

An organization called the royal guard would likely hate simply doing odd jobs around the palace. Foreseeing that, Fina hurried to form her own planned knight brigade of demi-humans. Her sister Aileen’s actions had actually made it easier for her to move.

Even if, hypothetically, Aileen made a move, the royal guard would be her pieces. Fina would have to prepare pieces of her own. Her honest thought was to use that as a reason to create a brigade of fluffies. Persuading her father and mother, Fina prepared an opposing force.

She based her actions on the belief that Aileen would surely run reckless.

“Now things are going to get busy. First, let’s put that minister to work... (Those small-time villains are basically just there to be crushed, and I won’t even feel bad about it! How wonderful!)”

Sophina wanted Fina to put just a little bit of that decisiveness towards the country’s well-being.



Changing locations to the academy, Rudel was talking to Izumi. When it came to the main event of the second term, for the fundamental curriculum, it was the wilderness training. For the upperclassmen, the individuals’ tournament.

But the topic of their conversation was gradually drifting away from the tournament. At first, they spoke of who they’d go up against this time, and how Rudel’s mana regulation was going. But once Rudel said he had learned a new technique, Izumi held her head.

“Isn’t it amazing!? Marty-sama’s dragon personally initiated me into the secret arts! I have a long way to go to reach Marty-sama, but I think I’ve gotten just a little bit closer... Izumi, does your head hurt?”

“Rudel, from the context, I can understand you had some harsh training pounded into you. But you see. Why did you only train that side!? That’s clearly strange, isn’t it!?”

“What!? What about it? What part is strange? The application of water magic was truly difficult to learn. That slipperiness, or rather that exquisite sensation was considerably difficult to reproduce.”

Before Izumi, Rudel heatedly spoke on about lotion play. Izumi held her head as she muttered.

“Rudel, just what exactly are you aiming for? That’s got nothing to do with dragoons. The strongest knight won’t be doing anything like that.”

“You’re wrong, Izumi! It’s precisely because I’ll be strongest that I have to take it to the limit! Do you want me to tell you Marty-sama’s legends? Like how he leapt into an enemy camp alone? There was this one time he even punched the prince, you know!”

“... Isn’t that treason? A major problem?”

That conversation that didn’t mesh continued on a good while longer.

Chapter 79: Extra: Surpass Marty

6

Extra: Surpass Marty 6

"S-so even the secret arts don't work..."

'It's all slimy and gross.'

Before Sakuya returned to the dragons' dwellings, Rudel tried applying the dragon petting skills he had devoted his being too. But if he pet her, she just said it was ticklish. The hidden technique was just gross.

Rudel looked at both his hands. He had polished his technique. On Lena's words, he had regained the love. But it didn't have the slightest effect on Sakuya. Before Rudel's eyes, he could see Sakuya calling the lotion disgusting as she played around.

Sakuya was an immature dragon born only recently. Marty's dragon said it would look after her a while, so it was decided she would temporarily return to the dwellings.

"W-what am... I supposed to do..."



"I've lost my motivation (What's with you, master... you'll happily be sent off to the outskirts? Are you an idiot?)."

As Rudel fell into a slump, Fina was on her room's bed, hugging her knees as she stared at the wall. As always, Mii and Sophina were loitering around. On that all-too-familiar scene, they no longer felt motivated to cheer her up.

"I even secured the funds. I haven't gotten formal permission, but I've already started things to motion... and yet, it's impossible for the captain to be absent, right!?"

Displaying her needless competence, Fina had built up an organization to oppose the royal guard, but here a miscalculation came out. As Rudel was thinking of heading off to the outskirts in the future, he easily denied Fina's request to appoint him captain.

"I'm supposed to be the princess of this country, right? Why do I get denied so easily? Are you telling me I fall short of that black hair!?"

Seeing Fina let off a black Aura, Mii finally came to console her.

"T-that isn't true, princess. You're beautiful and kind... there's no way you fall short of Izumi-san."

"Is it the breast? If there's one field I lose out to black hair in, it's got to be the breasts! I'm sure master likes them big! That's why he shows no interest in my transient chest!"

"No, I'm sure it's what's inside."

Fed up as she was, Sophina muttered at a level Fina couldn't hear. In all honesty, she did actually hear it, but to Fina, it was but a trivial detail so she left it be. Her first priority was Rudel. At this rate, she thought she might have to take black hair hostage to conquer Rudel.

"Black hair was aiming to be a high knight, was she not... if her clan is placing its expectations on her, I can use this. Sophina, call black hair here at once. I'll negotiate on the spot, and make sure she can't make light of me from now on!"

"That's not happening."

"... Eh?"

"Black hair, Izumi Shirasagi has already received a tentative offer to become a high knight. With the formation of the royal guard, our already-

present shortage of hands only increased in severity. The paperwork has already gone through, and alongside her graduation, Izumi Shirasagi will become a high knight. Well, she has more than enough aptitude, and it was a decision made with her relations taken into account."

Due to the formation of the royal guard, Izumi's instatement as a high knight had been set in stone. The knights who served Aileen had been estranged from their ranks. All the while, a crevice was forming among the high knights. The high knights were displeased with the formation of the royal guard.

But speaking to results, a number none-too-small had found enlistment in that same royal guard. Greatly harmed by this result, the high knights' shortage of personnel only deepened the gap between them and the ones who had transferred to the royal guard.

With their shortage of personnel, it was only natural they would move to secure more. It was decided there were no problems with Izumi's abilities, and she was among the many new recruits they were going to enlist this year.

"Black haiiirrr!! (Dammit! If it's a tentative offer, I can't make any poor moves! If I push it and threaten black hair anyways, I'll have to erase her offer, and even master will grow suspicious. I-if master comes to hate me, but fluff utopia... my fluffadise will grow distant. Should I take the bet? Threaten black hair... but the risk is too high. For now, I should proceed with caution... right, I just have to offer a deal! With a deal that'll put me at as slight an advantage I can get, I'll threaten black hair! It'll be an official deal, so there won't be a problem!)"

There was another large reason Izumi was tentatively offered a high knight position. Her personal relations. The high knights had evaluated the fact she was a good friend with all of the Three Lords' eldest sons. She was seen highly as an individual capable of opposing the exorbitant Rudel

To the high knights who faced a drop in power, the ability to suppress the young ace of their rivals, the dragoons, was a large bonus.

"... You can't hide and threaten her either."

Sophina looked at Fina as she drove in the point. Her thoughts read, Fina panicked, but her face was expressionless.

"T-threaten? Your words do me ill, Sophina."

"Is that so? Until just a moment ago, you were all up to threatening. Well, I can see why you'd panic... but if you're worrying about Rudel, I think it'll work itself out."

"Fwah!?"

Changing her posture to sit on her soles, Fina raised her voice as she looked at Sophina. Her expressionless face pressured her to go on, and Sophina ended up taking a step back.

"Y-you're too impatient. Try thinking about it. He's the eldest son of one of the three lords, and the white knight who contracted a giant dragon no one's ever seen before. There's no way the palace would ever send someone with such a degree and worth to the outskirts."

"You have a point. I had forgotten about that white knight and dragon bit. It seems no one's noticed. Master's true worth doesn't lie in such meaningless titles... hmm, no matter the era, you'll find great men who never receive the assessments they deserve."

Worn out, Sophina gave some vague yeahs in response to overcome the situation.



'I've realized my own ineptitude. I'm going on a journey. Don't look for me.'

Receiving the letter from Izumi, Eunius' hands were shaking. Not in fear, he was shaking in anger.

"T-that idiot!! Who does he think he is, going on a journey at such an important time!!?"

His rage wouldn't subside even after tearing the letter apart, so he let out a roar. At Eunius' rage-twisted form, there were some students who began to cower.

The location was the school cafeteria, and apart from Izumi who had brought the letter, Luecke was also there reading a book. After they'd finished their lunch, Izumi had shown Eunius the letter Rudel had entrusted to her.

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The reason Eunius was so angry was that the individuals' tournament was close at hand. It was their last large stage, and there was a possibility the enemy he swore to defeat wouldn't even show up. It was something Eunius couldn't bear to be.

"He certainly is an idiot, but whether Rudel participates or not is up to him."

Luecke, who was uninterestedly reading his book, wouldn't be taking part in the individuals' tournament. No, he had a reason he couldn't.

"I'm not participating either. Well, this year, I have a reason, so I can't take part."

"What do you mean either!? Rudel is going to participate whether he likes it or not! I won't let him run off with a win under his belt!"

The reason the uninterested Lucke couldn't participate was deeply tied into the tournament itself. More so, it was Rudel and the others' fault Luecke couldn't take part. However, something like that was irrelevant to Eunius. With Rudel's disappearance, he thought the individuals' tournament would become boring.

Izumi looked at the two as she let out a sigh. Gathering up the torn scraps of the letter, she tucked them away in her uniform pocket.

"Rudel didn't write that he wasn't participating. I'm sure he'll be back in no time."

Even though she said it herself, Izumi recalled Rudel's late arrival to the selection test. To Rudel, if there was something of more value to him than the individuals' tournament, then would he really take part? More than that, she grew curious about what basis he had to declare his ineptitude.

She suddenly recalled Rudel's murmurs.

'The secret art didn't work.'

"... Ah, this might be bad."

"What?"

Izumi's shoulders fell as she recalled Rudel's conduct and began putting the pieces together. She had never even considered he might disappear just because his dragon petting wasn't going well.

But with Rudel, wasn't it possible? Once she explained the surrounding events to the other two, Luecke put down his book, while Eunius started shaking in anger once more.

"Let's see. Looking at the result, it's sufficiently plausible. If you ask me, I'm more surprised there was a dragon Rudel's petting didn't work on. From what I've heard, it seems his sister Lena was able to win a red dragon over."

"T-the bastard... we've come all the way her, and he fixates on petting!? Now's not the time for that! What he needs to care about is the individuals' tournament!"

"I agree wholeheartedly."



While the three of them worried for Rudel, Rudel had submitted the official paperwork to the academy to go on a journey. Petting various animals and rereading How to Pet a Dragon, it was a training without a definite direction. He walked as he thought over what he was lacking.

"Just what am I missing. I have the technique. I do love Sakuya. Then just what could it be..."

As Rudel earnestly mulled over it, when looked upon from the side, surely he was a refreshing sight. But the man himself was serious to no ends. He honestly worried.

As Rudel walked, three individuals stood to block his path and called out. Wearing different clothing than usual, 'twas Fina, Sophina and Mii. The other guards simply didn't make themselves apparent, they were properly stationed.

"You seem troubled, master."

"I told you I'm not your master. What's more, I've only just been reminded of my own ineptitude. There's no way I could take a disciple."

"Hmph, do you think you can run away with that reason forever? I heard you've already been initiated into the secret arts. From my, no from anyone's eyes, it wouldn't be strange for a master like you to have an apprentice."

As Fina bit on, Rudel decided she had a point. He didn't plan on taking a disciple, but it was true he had learned the secret arts. In that case, he thought he would have to make Fina understand he simply wouldn't take a disciple.

"Sure enough. But I cannot accept my current self. I must climb to greater heights, so I am unable to take a disciple. Do you get where I'm coming from?"

Hearing Rudel's words, Fina was expressionlessly convinced of her victory.

"Master, you'll never reach any heights like that."

"What?"

"I'll admit you're splendid, for being able to regain the techniques lost for a hundred years. But try thinking about it. The way things are going, they will

only be lost again. Even if another aspired for greatness, whether or not they could reach your height is..."

"And what are you trying to say?"

"Let me be blunt. Master, you're mistaken! If you don't let your craft be passed down and polished, you'll never rise any higher. The techniques made to be handed hand after hand will rot away in no hands but your own. If he saw you right now, then surely Marty-sama would lament. When a successor finally came to inherit his art, for that successor not to take a disciple... learn some shame."

Rudel couldn't understand why she was angry, but Fina's words did leave a deep impression on him. He thought of the feelings Marty had gone so far as to leave as a book. He thought and misunderstood. Surely Marty wanted it passed on...

The truth was much simpler. Marty simply wished to immortalize his love for his own dragon as a book. He overdid things and wrote of the technical details as well, but he stressed the words to his dragon, and at the beginning and end, he wrote love was the most important of all. He hadn't the slightest thought for the world to come.

If he had such intent, he would surely have reported such high-level techniques to the country. Fina had noticed that, but she had lied in order to deceive Rudel.

"I-I see. You're right. I cannot let all that's been built up collapse. I have to answer up to Marty-sama's expectations!"

"That's right, master! (Yay, he fell for it. Master sure is easy.)"

Inside, Fina was drunk on her victory, but Rudel's words left her in a daze.

"Then from here on, as you're to be my disciple, I'll call you Fina on all non-formal occasions. And also, I planned to use this journey to train. You're coming with me."

"Eh? U-um, master, I came to bring you back..."

"No backtalk! The only answer you need is yes. Now follow me!"

"... Yes."

Fina walked at Rudel's back, and seeing them off the other two were left dumbfounded. From the start, this was an outing to drag Rudel back. They weren't at all prepared for a journey.

"What are we going to do about this?"

At Mii's anxious look, Sophina wanted to cry. It wasn't as if she could just scream, 'How should I know!?' so Sophina decided to negotiate with Rudel... as a result, it was decided the four of them would travel together.

Chapter 80: Extra: Surpass Marty

7

Extra: Surpass Marty 7

Rudel had taken Fina, Mii and Sophina along to the dragons' dwellings. In order to learn what his current self was lacking, he had come to meet Marty's dragon.

While he had technically dragged the princess along on a journey, at this point, he didn't see her as anything more than a disciple. Even if he showed his respect on formal stages, his attitude would take a complete change in private.

"You don't even have the basics down!? What's the meaning of this!?"

"W-wait, master! Don't drop me into the lak.... Gyaaah!! (I don't want this anymore! He doesn't teach me anything, and I can't put up with all this basic training.)"

Mii and Sophina watched in suspense as Fina was expressionlessly sent flying off into the lake. In the week since they'd arrived at the dragons' dwellings, day after day, Fina would be put to building her basic stamina and carrying out fundamental magic training.

But under the tutelage of Marty's Dragon, Rudel was learning the necessary abilities of a dragoon. He had already learned all the secrets she knew about petting, and the dragon didn't have anything left to teach him. But there were plenty of things he had to learn when it came to dragons.

Once Fina was flung into the lake, Rudel turned to face the dragon once more.

'You're too kind. Treat her like that, and that princess will never advance.'

"I know, but she's still a princess of all things, so I don't think I can be harsher than this."

'You think? When this idiot prince ran his mouth on some stupid thing like wanting to ride my back, Marty smacked him and ran to this forest with me... with all of us.'

While Marty's dragon was the water dragon, she was also the boss of the dragons at the time. If the boss said she was going home, then even the dragons with contractors would follow along.

This didn't infringe on the promise made between human and dragon when contracting was possible. A dragon promised it would lend its power, but it wasn't as if it had to obey. The one who scrapped Marty's contract was the prince, and Marty returned to the forest with all the dragons.

'That guy's face when we said we'd be going home was a masterpiece! The palace was destroyed while we were at it, and I spend about two months here with Marty. That Marty, he got himself a grass skirt and spear and enjoyed it all the way.'

According to the dragon, the royal family took their knights along to apologize after two months. But it was a disgrace to the name of Courtois, and the truth had been twisted before it was handed down.

"Ah, I've read something about that in a number of books. But they didn't say anything about Marty-sama, you know? It did say he struck royalty, but he was never punished, so I thought it might be a lie."

'Lie? What are you talking about? Marty was young at the time, and he was amazing! He was old when they ordered him to retire, but even so, Marty was amazing.'

Reminiscing over it, the dragon continued to speak of fond times. Rudel was delighted to be able to hear out the dragon he admired. But to Fina who crawled out of the lake- and to Mii and Sophina- it only looked as if he was talking to himself.

After that, Rudel would occasionally let out a surprised voice, at times breaking down techniques, and as he spoke of how he was going to deal with Fina, the three of them fearfully inclined their ears.

But Fina was bored, and once she got tired of being afraid, she tried testing her petting on Mii. There, while it took a bit of time, Mii's face did indeed turn red.

"P-princess, any more is... I... I'm turning strange...!!"

Her body lurching in an instant, Mii collapsed on the spot.

Sophina looked at Fina's expressionless face at the time, but she would later tell her men it looked almost as if she was laughing.

"F-fwahahaha!! It seems I can do it too. (What's this? So I can do it if I try! If that's how it is, then even without master, my goal... I can become the ruler of fluffadise!!)"

"P-princess, where are you going?"

Holding confidence, Fina expressionlessly told Sophina.

"Isn't it obvious, Sophina? Until this point, I needed master's technique. But as I am now, I will be able to fulfill my objective. I no longer need my master. No, I no longer need Rudel."

"What are you talking about!? Princess, get a grip on yourself!! Rudel is an indispensable individual to the country's future, right? Saying you don't need him... what about all the plans you've set up!?"

The expressionless Fina turned her back to Sophina as she headed towards Rudel and the dragon. Drowning in her technique and stepping off her path, Fina walked towards her parting.

"No, no, you've finally become his disciple, so why are you ruining that on your own? Listen to people when they're talking to you!!"

Lately, Sophina had lost a large portion of her dignity as a high knight, and she grieved from her heart for Fina's parting with Rudel. Of course, it was a worry that came from ulterior motives.

At the back of Rudel, engrossed in his conversation with the dragon, came the voice of his technique-drowned disciple. Feeling a terrible presence from that voice, Rudel turned, looked in Fina's eyes, and understood it all.

Seeing her make the eyes of one who had lost themselves in their own power. Rudel- who had been smiling to that point- made a serious face.



'This is bad. That child is making the eyes of one drowned in power. She does have a grasp of the fundamentals, but I never thought she'd lose herself to quickly...'

'Hey, Rudel, play with me.'

'Quiet down and watch, Sakuya. This is a match between master and student.'

With Marty's dragon and Sakuya watching over them, the two humans stood atop a log floating in the lake. In that place where neither side could avoid or step back, they could only let their technique collide.

Having obtained the technique she wanted, Fina had determined Rudel was unnecessary. But she wanted his technique on her side, so she told him to become hers.

Rudel thought of Fina's position and gave an immediate refusal. Neither side would back down, so things settled as a duel.

"Master, no, Rudel. You don't want to become mine? Even like this, I'm the princess of a country. There's no problem with your house or status. (Now

what are you going to do? It's no problem to me whether I win or lose. I already have the technique I desire in my hands!! Now as long as I can obtain Rudel, it'll be perfect, but I don't have to push it anymore!)"

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"I understand I'm not in a position to say this, but right now, you're making a mistake. I'm sure I've told you your engagement will create problems across the country as a whole. And you aren't looking at me... as I thought, taking you as a disciple was a mistake."

Atop the log drifting freely across the water, neither side gave the slightest twitch. For argument's sake, Fina had been trained in battle from a young age. But to the utmost, that was for self-defense and to make sure she didn't suffer from a lack of exercise.

The reason she got the mind to go so far was that of a disillusioned state where she had convinced herself she could do anything. It was an exceedingly dangerous state. If Rudel overlooked her here, Fina would undoubtedly step off her path. She would become a demon who wouldn't stop until she pet all the demi-humans in the world.

For the sake of Fina who had become his disciple, Rudel had accepted the duel.

"Rudel, if only you were satisfied with me... but you had to be tricked by that black hair!"

"Izumi has nothing to do with it!"

As a fish leaped to break the water surface, the two sprung to motion. In every possible way, Rudel held the advantage, but Fina had no attachment to the outcome. She saw this as no more than a ceremony to get Rudel to give up. But as the distance closed between the two, the one to get the first move was Fina.

"You let your guard down, Rudel! (Yaaay!! Now you're mine!!)"

With all the technique she had, Fina exercised her petting on Rudel, but Rudel showed no reaction. As Fina panicked, Rudel gently wrapped her in an embrace.

"W-why..."

To a surprised, Fina, Rudel declared his own victory.

"I already told you. The most important part... is love. Though it seems you've forgotten."

As mana emitted from Rudel's body, and expression was born on Fina's expressionless face. Her face turning red, it was a miserable face, but it was the first expression she ever made. From afar, Mii and Sophina looked on with disbelief.

"E-erk! (Crap, this feeling is...!! The inside of my head is going white... ah)"

Once Rudel released her, Fina unsteadily collapsed into the lake. Hit by the water spurt, Rudel silently looked at Fina's floating body. Her expression was already gone, but her face held a faint red tinge.

The two dragons watching over the showdown each held a different reaction.

'Marty, your will has been handed on.'

Perhaps Sakuya retained a dislike of Fina, and while she was happy Rudel won, her mental state was a conflicted one.

'Play with me too!'

Rudel jumped into the lake himself, lifting up Fina's body and creeping out of the water. Once he reached land, he put Fina over his back and called out.

"How was it?"

"... I've lost. I'm sorry master. I'm sorry... I was wrong. (He really is amazing. My master is the best!)"

Rudel continued shouldering Fina as he made for Mii and Sophina. As he walked, he continued sending words to Fina on his back. Not the words of a harsh master, but the gentle words for a comrade.

"We've both got a long way to go, but the path is a long one. Do you think you can keep up?"

"Yes."

"I see, I'll be harsh again tomorrow."

"Yes!"

Mii and Sophina watched them draw close, but they couldn't keep up with what was going on. More than, that, Fina had finally shown expression, but the problem was that it wasn't the sort of expression they could tell anyone about. There's no way they could report a maiden's deplorable visage.

"Sophina-san, was I mistaken? I can't understand what the princess wants to do anymore."

"What a coincidence. I can't understand those two either. She insisted this would be a premarital trip, and said she was going to build it as an established truth, but now..."

As the two exchanged a glance, Rudel reached their side. Fina had heard the contents of their talk, but she spoke to them in an enlightened matter. It was only come later, after she had returned to the academy, that she regretted the fact she didn't establish a truth.

But at that moment, she was completely satisfied.

"Both of you, marriage is a sacred rite. It is not something to undergo with such impure motives. Sophina, you're almost passed that age, so please take it a little more seriously."

The hair on Mii's tail and ears stood on end as she opened her eyes wide. The princess of her ideals was before her. Nowhere could she see the form of Fina, who would always sexually harass her.

It was at that moment that Mii feared Rudel from the bottom of her heart. You definitely cannot go against him, she needed to tell her clan...

But with her marriageable age brought up, Sohina had not the time for that. The fact she was the most mindful of was pointed out by Fina, who was usually the worst. Humans are hit hardest when they are told the truth. And by the worst person there was... she was filled with seething sentiment within, but she lowered her head and stood down.

Seeing Sophina twisted by Rage, Rudel made a misunderstanding. From her bloodshot eyes and shaking fist, eh thought she was discontent. Her hair had lost its gloss, and he concluded she had built up some stress. With his promise to Izumi, he remembered he couldn't pet her, but he thought everything else might be fine.

He couldn't pet, but Rudel was growing by the day. There was no problem with a massage. It was a wonderful idea if he did say so himself, so once he lowered Fina from his back, he went on to actualize it.

"Sophina-san, you seem considerably worn out. I made you tag along with my selfishness, so won't you let me give you a massage?"

"Ha? What are you... wait! Get those hands away!! ... Ah."

The charming voice of a woman echoed through the dragons' dwelling. She was caught off guard, but for a while to follow, Sophina's mood reached an all-time high.

Chapter 81

Around the time Rudel was training in the dragons' dwellings, Aleist was also training to master his own powers.

“Aleist-sama's so cool!!”

... But by Aleist's popularity at the academy, female students would gather around him on a regular basis. Whether he swung his sword or used his magic, those shrill cheers would fly his way. But every time the man in question received those cheers, he would fall into a slump.

(This is wrong. This isn't how it was supposed to be.)

The scenery he had once longed for was now the norm. But Aleist had only just confessed his love to Millia. Truthfully, he would be satisfied if only Millia was there, and while he didn't want to be hated by those around him, he didn't want to be liked this much.

Before his final individuals' tournament at the academy, he needed to train and gain as much control of his powers as he could. This would be the last time Aleist would be able to fight against Rudel.

(Well, no one knows what the future holds. If possible, I do hope this is the last... I really would like to avoid any death matches in the future.)

The future he spoke of was what came after the war with the empire. While he had knowledge from his game, Aleist didn't know what would become of the future of the Courtois Kingdom. No, the way things were going, he couldn't even predict how things would turn out.

He had become the black knights, and the side character Rudel was the white knight.

(He proclaimed himself the White Dragoon or something, so is he still aiming to be a dragoon after all? In that case, what's going to happen during the war? I think the last boss will be easy picking for Rudel and Sakuya as they are now, but...)

Imagining Rudel riding Sakuya, Aleist recalled her magnificent fall. The impression they gave off during the selection test was fall, and he could vividly picture a scene of them dive-bombing straight into the last boss.

(Yep, it's starting to feel kinda hopeless.)



Around noon, Aleist visited the cafeteria with his friends.

With his daily morning training and his academy classes, he had a healthy hunger. Once he entered the cafeteria, he found the similarly hungry male students, and the female students chatting amiably with their friends as they filled the seats.

Lining up in the food line, Aleist's friend looked around to search out an empty seat. But from what he could see, they were all filled in, so he let out a complaint.

"We were late after all. If only we'd been a bit earlier."

Aleist looked around as well, fully agreeing with that sentiment. The class he had been in was held in the classroom furthest from the cafeteria. And as he had a chat while he walked, he ended up a little later than usual. This situation came forth from only a little extra time, so his friends continued to search out any seat that seemed open enough.

There, one of his friends spotted Aleist's exclusive seat.

"Ah, Aleist, there's an empty seat over there."

"Eh? ... Ah, no, I want to eat with you guys today."

Following his friend's gaze, he found the five female students those around recognized as his girlfriends eating at the same table. At that round table, there was only one seat left open.

It was a table of beauties, but no one even tried to sit down. From the start, they let off an air that made it hard to approach, but it was also clear that seat had been saved for a certain someone.

As Aleist averted his eyes, he felt a cold sweat break out. The harem lunch he had imagined time after time, always wishing to experience once in his life, after going through it once, he never wanted to taste it again. On top of not being able to tell the taste of what he was putting in his mouth, when everyone was smiling, there was this strange tension in the air...

Just remembering brought him pain.

"... No, it'll be terrible if you don't go, Aleist." "That's right! We've followed through for you a few times, so those girls remember our faces. For the sake of our peace, go sacrifice your lunch time."

"Lay off me! I want to stand by Millia alone!"

Aleist put up resistance, but his friends shook their heads. That wasn't an envy against a man who built up a harem, they were sending him eyes of pity.

"Give it up. You have some fault in this." "Because of that, we learned something. Harems are beautiful precisely because they're dreams." "It's amazing they permit you to have five lovers. Though it seems they all think they're number one."

Aleist held his head. Building an urge to punch his past harem-dreaming self, he realized how exceedingly terrible this situation was. His confession to Millia hadn't gone down well. If they ever locked eyes, their faces would turn red and no words would come out. There wasn't much time left until they would graduate the academy.

In contrast, talks with the five who made up Aleist's harems were going more smoothly than he had ever imagined.

First was Yunia Luneice, and she was a girl of a Marquis House. Aleist's parents were also exceedingly on board their talks of engagement. The Luneice Marquis House had evaluated Aleist highly for being the black knight. The black knight tied to the founding of the nation, if their daughter were to be with him... honestly, they were fine if she was a mistress.

Aleist would eventually become a mainstay of the country, and they had no objections with the slightest increase in authority they could get.

Following on was Seli, and she was also being pushed for strongly by her house. As it was a former noble military house, once they learned of the existence of what could be called the strongest knight, they cheerfully brought up talks of marriage.

Recovering their own status was probably included in their field of vision, but Aleist's parents had given approval.

Juju said she had no problem if the head of the household- Aleist- told her to be a mistress. Apart from the fact her letters revealed she was a bit dissatisfied her partner wasn't Rudel, there wasn't anything particularly threatening about her. The fact there was nothing was the scariest part...

Lux and the blue haired girl Ciel were commoners, and their families were more delighted than he had expected. Aleist's parents scolded him for finding too many mistresses, but they didn't put up any particular opposition.

They simply smiled and informed him of their hopes a legal wife would soon come from out of his mistresses.

(That's definitely strange! What's with 'great men have a great fondness for women'? When I thought my parents were on edge from factional disputes these days, they were happily talking about how one of the princesses might marry me!!)

“You’re the worst.”

Seeing Aleist hand his head, the male students glared at him with jealousy. As he received those envy-tinged eyes, Aleist was warned by his friends.

“Yep, we know you so we can sympathize, but those around aren’t quite so understanding... now resolve yourself and head to that table.” “You really should be careful walking home at night. There really are some folks aiming for your life.” “If anything happens, feel free to discuss it!”

“Then save me. Now.”

On Aleist’s words, his friends all took a glance at the table where those five were waiting before answering with smiles. At the table waiting for Aleist, they were all smiling too, but it was somehow terrifying.

“Impossible.” “Sorry.” “Godspeed.”



At that time, Izumi was in the cafeteria watching Aleist from afar, when Luecke and Eunius sitting at her table called out.

They had finished their meals, and now they were sipping on drinks as they talked. About the future, and mostly about the individuals’ tournament. Eunius was worried about Rudel’s participation, and while Luecke wasn’t taking part, he said he was busy with preparations. But as Izumi sent a glance in Aleist’s direction, the conversation naturally flowed towards Aleist.

“He did it again? Aleist really never learns, does he. You’re not usually supposed to date them all in public. Cheating is something you’re supposed to do in secret.”

On Eunius’ fed-up face, Luecke was even more fed up.

“You’re usually not supposed to cheat to begin with. But I am impressed with how he’s going off to be surrounded by them now.”

“... Hey, Izumi, does Rudel cheat? Or is it that? Does it depend on your definition of the word?”

Thinking up something, Eunius tried asking Izumi about Rudel. While Rudel had conducted much problematic behavior on a regular basis, he was earnest in the strangest of places. But they were dealing with Rudel. There was no way to be certain he wasn't getting women in the mood where they weren't looking.

In truth, Rudel had a repertoire of special anti-women skills.

Izumi shook her head and told Eunius she didn't have the answer he was looking for.

“Ever since he declined that confession from the princess, those around couldn't bring themselves to confess... no, but Ness-san did volunteer to be his slave.”

“... That one really is terrifying.”

On Eunius' murmur, Luecke thought for just a moment on whether he meant Rudel or Ness. He concluded that both sides were terrifying.

“There was a time the girls' dorm was a mess from all the victims. I really am glad I sealed his petting. We were almost too late.”

Thinking back on it, it all seemed so shameful, but the girls' dorm really was in a terrible state. When there were some who purposely came out to be pet by Rudel, Izumi recalled how she wanted to cry. She wanted to believe it was her imagination when she saw so many familiar faces among those who petitioned for her to lift the petting ban.

But there, Luecke's joke became an unlaughable one.

“You sealed his petting, right? Perhaps you've made him polish some skill besides petting.”

As Luecke laughed, Eunius wholeheartedly jumped onto the conversation.

“Right, it’s him we’re dealing with, so I’m sure he’ll do something right out of the left field. Let’s see... I’m sure he can get a woman to fall just by smiling at them.”

“No way. It’s much more realistic to think he’ll make them fall with a conversation without even realizing it. I’m sure before he notices, the situation around him will become like Aleist’s.”

“Not noticing when someone’s fallen for him! How Rudel!”

While the two of them laughed, Izumi tried to return the derailing conversation to its tracks. She suddenly got a bad feeling their words would become a reality. Rudel could make someone feel good just by petting them. It wouldn’t be strange if he could make a woman fall with just a smile.

And it was also plausible he wouldn’t notice their affection. He definitely did have some dense parts, and romance matters weren’t Rudel’s area of expertise.

(Not that I’m an expert either, but I should be careful...)

While Izumi thought, this time the topic of conversation, Rudel, called over. It was good that he had returned from the dragons’ dwellings, but the headmaster cautioned him for dragging the princess off, and he was finally freed when lunch came around.

Surprisingly, Fina’s sage mode persisted for a while, and she made it clear to the headmaster that he hadn’t done anything that would warrant such worry so he was released early. If there was any scandal with royalty, then this wasn’t just a problem for Rudel or the Arses House.

“Can I eat with you three?”

Ignoring their surprise, Rudel took a seat and began eating his special of the day set.



“Just where did you go, Rudel!?” “I really was worried you wouldn’t make it to the tournament.” “You look quite refreshed. Did you gain something from your trip?”

Izumi’s loud voice, Eunius’ true relief, and seeing Rudel’s expression, Luecke began to predict what he could have gained.

“Yeah, the truth is I went to the dragons’ dwellings. Under Marty-sama’s water dragon, I polished some new techniques. I learned the necessary things to be a dragoon.”

As Rudel answered with a smile, the three of them nodded. Of course, they were sure he had trained himself for the individuals’ tournament. Eunius was curious what Rudel had learned, and with practically the excitement of a child, he tried to find it out.

“So what exactly did you gain this time?”

Rudel put a temporary hold on his meal, thinking back through what he had picked up as he explained.

“First, about dragoons. Their fighting style fundamentally changes based on the size of their dragons, but I was told what a dragoon needs is the ability to direct a dragon.”

Those that directed dragons were dragoons. While it was important for a dragoon to protect a dragon’s blind spot on its back, their original role was to manipulate a powerful dragon to their will. Their powerful firepower, movement distance and speed, when put under precise instruction, their results would swell up several times over.

From a dragon’s point of view, even if you told it to defeat the enemy, it only saw humans all the same. In that case, a dragoon capable of conveying thoughts would have to give orders. There were also cases where the dragon was used to move loads and numerous fields where their powers could be put to use. He was taught that a dragoon’s role was to make the best use of his dragon.

“I see, is something we wouldn’t understand. I’m sure it’s a trouble only dragoons will get.”

Eunius looked at Rudel’s serious expression and was sure he had seriously studied. But the next words from Rudel’s mouth left the three in a daze.

“Oh, I also learned some applications. A dragoon’s special way of movement, and also... hugging and massages, I guess?”

“... Eh?”

Luecke let out an idiotic voice, but Rudel explained on without paying it any mind.

“Yeah, that really was a surprise. When I told her my petting was sealed, she taught me all sorts of applications. It hasn’t been named yet, but there’s this technique where you hug and use your mana to apply a shock, and I got a high effect by changing the petting to pressure-based massages.”

Eunius looked at Luecke’s face, comparing the contents of their talk to what Rudel had just said.

“Oy, that wasn’t even the left field, he just swung straight and hit. Straight down the center.”

“Yeah, I never thought we’d get a frontal attack from him. I’ll have to ask about it later.”

The two of them were certain he would pick something up apart from petting, but the problem was Izumi. Izumi had sealed Rudel’s petting with just a word. When it came to other techniques, the two of them were curious to see what sort of measures Izumi would take.

Her dumbfounded expression turning to a smile, Izumi called over to Rudel.

“Rudel.”

“Hmm?”

“You can’t hug or massage either.”

“Why!!? Neither of them have anything to do with petting! Just listen to me, Izumi, these new techniques are at a level capable of satisfying a princess and high knight! I thought you’d accept it this time. So let me try it on you, just once.”

On the appearance of an individual that should never come out, Luecke and Eunius pretended they hadn’t heard anything. They had heard rumors that no one had seen the princess lately, but they never thought she had been out with Rudel.

But Izumi couldn’t stand without confirming it.

“I-it couldn’t be that you laid hands on the princess, right?”

“No, I just embraced her. She was serious about it too. As a master, I thought it was unacceptable for me to hold back. Don’t worry, I held her gently. Though I cast her into the lake after that.”

As a result of being freed from the petting, Fina had fallen into the lake, but Rudel was terrible at explanations, and at his words, the three of them lost their ability to speak.

(No way! That’s no good, Rudel!! And you threw her away after that!!?)
(What’ll become of this. Will he be able to take part in the individuals’ tournament?) (So he threw her away at the end? If you just listened to that, it would be a terrible story. Well, it’s Rudel here, so unless I hear the details, I won’t be able to make any decision...)

It was the moment a new legend was born at the academy.



A few days later, Fina was depressed in her room, having recovered from sage mode.

“I went and did it. It was my big chance... (What am I going to do about this!? Stupid, stupid, stupid me!! For me to discard my big chance on a temporary wavering of spirit... my master is a scary man).”

Her guard Sophina looked at her depressed state and spat some toxicity.

“So marriage isn’t a sacred rite?”

On those words, Fina raised her face and gazed expressionlessly at Sophina.

“What are you talking about, Sophina? Marriage is a microcosm of war. If you lose, your rights within the family are taken, and you walk a life like that of a slave. The relations in marriage are the same as an alliance. A relation of equivalence is impossible. It’s because you hold such maiden-esque delusions that you’re forever alone. Look at reality a bit. At this rate, you’ll only find regret once you’re married... ah, not that you have anyone to marry anyways.”

“... This might be forward of me, but that’s completely different from what you said before.”

“Is that so? Well, that doesn’t really matter. More importantly, I have to do something about that black knight idiot... there are talks going forward about an engagement to my sister, but it does seem sister is stubbornly shaking her head.”

Her own talks of marriage written off just like that, Sophina desperately calmed herself as she thought only of the next topic of conversation.

“Aileen-sama will marry the black knight? In that case, in the end, the black knight shall also...”

Sophina swallowed the words before they came out. She determined the reason Fina was trying to put Aileen and the black knight together was because Fina herself wanted to marry Rudel. Sophina wondered if that meant Fina was casting away the black knight.

“What are you on about? This is just a bit of harassment against that sister of mine. You should at least notice that much, good grief...”

Against that expressionless princess, Sophina was driven by an impulse to lower a fist on her head. But Fina steadily explained.

“If they press her on the reason for her rejection, it’s my sister we’re talking about here, so I’m sure she’ll spill the beans on that matter with Flit.”

“It’s Fritz, princess.”

“Right, once she opens her mouth about Fritz, it will make it easier to move for father and the others. And while my sister is having her little feud, I’ll fill in the outer moat. Well, the formation of the royal guard’s already been decided, so I doubt there’ll be any assassins after Fritz at this point. If my sister stops being stubborn and gives up on Fritz, that’ll be the end of it.”

Fina didn’t particularly feel like going at her sister’s throat. But seeing her sister’s mayhem, she wouldn’t stand around without setting up countermeasures. From the emotional trauma of a past incident, Aileen was doted on by her parents much more than was necessary.

Her parents were soft on her, so even if Fina cautioned them, they would simply take it that she was reading too deeply.

If they were male, they would undergo strict education after which their marriage partners would be those most profitable to the country. But the male heir the land wanted was never born, and as a result, there were only two princesses. If these doted-on two were suddenly put under strict instruction, there would be a backlash.

The king was immediately forced into taking mistresses, but it came to light that the problem lay with the king himself. He couldn’t have a son. So Courtois would be welcoming a son in from elsewhere.

It was something necessary within the scenario, but the game’s characters were never told the reason. In order to make a king of the hero who saved the country, a situation was made where the king’s seat was purposely left

open, yet those characters on their stage would never give it a second thought.

“If my sister gives up, it won’t be a problem for me. But, I really doubt she will... when you think of it like that, perhaps my sister is similar to master.”

Fina’s face was expressionless, but to Sophina, it looked as if she was just a bit sorrowful.

Chapter 82

In the academy, preparations were underway for- what would be to Rudel and the other fifth years- their final individuals' tournament.

This time's tournament would be the last festival for what those in the academy had started to call the golden generation. The royal family and the nobles wouldn't miss this last great competition, with tensions rising far above the norm.

It goes without saying the royal family's participation was something Fina laid the groundwork for. But once the royal family showed interest, the nobles began volunteering one after the next.

The academy was a ruckus from top to bottom and it was decided the tournament would take on a different form from the usual. Competitors would still be selected in the same way from their achievements up to the appointed date, but they had decreased the numbers. They planned to hold only the finals, but from the voices of nobles and other hopeful competitors, they top eight students were chosen to take part.

Of course, with balance in mind, Rudel, Eunius, and Aleist would be in different groups during the preliminaries. It was concluded so, for if the three of them collided in the preliminaries, the spectators would likely find the finals to be quite unsatisfactory.

The reconstruction of the arena had it reinforced, taking into account the possible matchup between the white and black knights. Luecke had personally volunteered to take on the task. He said he would secure the safety of the arena's spectators.

He planned to use the individuals' tournament to unveil the knight brigade the Halbades House had been preparing for a few years. While he had considered concealing them, the Halbades House was never said to excel in military might, and he intended to show the other nobles their power.

By his work, the top eight competitors could take on their matches at full strength. But those involved with the school held their heads as they imagined Rudel mustering all his might again.

In a meeting room where those personnel gathered, a meeting on the tournament was running on. Preparations were underway, but they couldn't help but be anxious. The reason being all their problem children starting with white knight Rudel. They could never be optimistic about those students who would always run contrary to their expectations.

"Finally, the time has finally come."

On the heavy words the headmaster spat out, everyone gathered silently nodded. Ever since the golden generation enrolled, there were numerous problems that plagued the academy, all leading up to their graduation year.

Two dangerous monster appearances during wilderness training, one of which was an incident that enraptured princess Fina. It was an incident that made the academy considerably fearful.

In the class battles, a number of matches unthinkable at the level of the fundamental curriculum. These would often produce abnormal situations where all the legitimate heirs of the Three Lords were hospitalized at once.

If Rudel participated, he would be hospitalized without fail. In the infirmary, there were some rumors of a perfect attendance award being prepared for him.

The problem involving the commoner Fritz, and the First Princess Aileen's interference... Rudel's free pass into the girls' dormitory, toleration of Aleist's implied illicit sexual relations, Eunius' customary breaking of curfew, the ever-updating record of destroyed facilities in Luecke's magic research... there would be no end if everything was brought up, but to the

teachers and staff who had surmounted countless incidents, their sensations had been numbed.

They who supported Rudel and the others from the shadows, they were now putting the finishing touches on what could be called their last festival.

"Reinforcement of the arena is going steadily. No problem in the security of the royal family and high-ranking nobles... but I'm sure you all already understand. That is never enough!"

Everyone nodded. No matter how wary they were of Rudel and co, they could never be wary enough.

"Fina-sama also gave an order to remain cautious of Aileen-sama's movements. This year, Fritz-kun is going to be competing in the matches, and there are some grudges to be had. She wants us to be wary of the competitors as well. Well, I doubt they'll do anything too stupid."

"Leave it to us, headmaster. In this tournament, we've prepared a separate waiting room for each individual competitor. Thanks to Fina-sama, we've prepared an ample number of guards." "As I recall, they were a unit established to fill in the hole created by the royal guard, correct? Are the 'defenders' up to par? We can't allow failure at the end of the end." "That isn't a problem. They are seasoned fighters gathered from the farthest reaches of the kingdom." "... But why are there so many demi-humans? No, I'm not trying to say I hate demi-humans or anything, it's just a strange inclination in their selection, or rather..." "The royal guard's in the same boat. That side feels like a gathering of ideologists, after all."

As the conversation derailed, the headmaster held up a hand. Everyone grew quiet and eyes began gathering on his face.

"Everyone, this is our last festival. Exercise adequate caution."

The festival they spoke of, it was a word that referred to any school event that involved the problem children. While it was a word laced with cynicism, it was strangely accurate.

The festival's preparations were steadily on their way.



The fact the teaching staff was busy at work meant Fina was carrying out her preparations as well. In order to oppose Aileen, Fina had formed the defenders that would come under her control. They for formed as a miscellaneous job squadron readied to fill in the hole left by the royal guard's formation.

The royal guard whose reason for existence was still in question were Aileen's pieces to play. With Fritz as its future captain, it was an organization of knights who endorsed Aileen. They held high conceit, and from their position that placed them as higher existences than the other knights, they were terribly particular about their work. They were a problem even in the royal palace, and Fina made use of that.

She proposed they gather those of lower status and put them to odd jobs. The maintenance costs of the royal guard were enormous, but maintaining knights originally of lower status could be passed cheaply. Fina's father Albach had shown disapproval of its formation, his opinions aligning with that of the ministers who didn't want anyone forming any more organizations.

With their work taken away, the high knights were also opposed. They were desperate not to let the value of their own existence fall any further.

But by taking a stance that they would take on the work that no other knight brigades wanted to do, their formation was approved. They investigated into the work looked down on by each and bit on.

On top of monster control around the capital, they would respond to calls for reinforcements on the border. While they called themselves defenders, in the name of odd jobs, they stole away the authority of other knight brigades bit by bit, increasing in numbers from the sheer breadth of their work. They were already on the level of a knight brigade. The only reason they could grow to such a size in the short period from their formation came

in the demi-human units wasting away in the outer reaches that Fina had recalled.

For Rudel's sake, the captain seat was left empty, but there were plenty of knights abundant in experience to take on deputy roles. Demi-humans were always low in status, so there were those who hated their noble superiors. Fina had sold favors as she gathered them up.

Before the knights whose eyes sparkled at their final chance, Fina expressionlessly expressed her delight.

(Veteran fluffies are the bessssstt!!)

But unfortunately, Rudel had no interest in the royal guard or defenders. That alone was Fina's largest oversight.



"... I'm getting a chill for some reason."

"What's this all of a sudden, Rudel?"

In the cafeteria of the academy busily preparing for the individuals' tournament, Rudel and Izumi were sitting at a table together. They finished lunch and were putting their mouths to their drinks as they measured the right time to leave. They were so laid back the other students were unable to cause them any trouble.

While the two of them were letting out a calming air, Rudel suddenly began looking around. Finding it strange, Izumi tried asking what had happened, but Rudel's answer was an ambiguous out.

"No, I suddenly got the feeling someone was aiming at me. Well, the tournament's ahead of us, so I'm sure everyone's just high strung. There are quite a few busily moving about.

Luecke was securing the arena's safety, while Eunius had no other thought than his final adjustments.

"More importantly, you're really participating in the tournament, Izumi? I'm not sure what to think of that."

"Are you worried? I'm happy, but you don't need to hold back. In most cases, women don't take part in the tournament. But this one's a bit of a different case."

Every year, the individuals' tournament would have many male participants. Besides those confident in their skills, women generally wouldn't take part. But when it came to making use of mana, there was a tendency for women to be more skilled than men. With the greater ability to reinforce their bodies with magic, rather than the power difference between genders, it came more to the difference in ability among individuals.

The reason there were so many female knights lay in a woman's advantage in using magic. Lilim was an elf, and thus on a different spectrum, but Cattleya was a good example.

The royal family would be watching this time's individuals' tournament. Izumi had still yet to learn of her tentative high knight offer, so this individuals' tournament was her chance. She would be able to sell herself.

"To be honest, it will be difficult for me to fight you."

Rudel made a displeased face, but he did know Izumi's ability. Her peculiar swordsmanship was on a level Eunius recognized. It was simply Rudel's selfishness in not wanting to take Izumi on in a serious match.

"If you let your guard down, then apart from me, there are plenty who'll pull the carpet out from under your feet. And I passed through the harsh nomination process too, you know. It would be fine if you recognized me a bit."

Like a child with a thing for mischief, Izumi enjoyed teasing Rudel. She already knew Rudel recognized her ability, and it was intended as a bit of a joke.

But jokes often didn't get through to Rudel. While he had been calm as of late, the one with their guard down was Izumi.

"I don't want to hurt you. If any of the other competitors injures you..."

As Rudel's face clouded, the gazes gathered from the students who had been listening in. Rudel and Izumi were famous in the academy. In crowded places, they stood out.

"N-no, Rudel, I'm joking."

"I don't want your pretty body to be wounded."

The man in question put the words to mouth with an innocent sentiment, but the pubescent student body went and interpreted it on your own. 'Your body is mine', the rumor was reinterpreted as hit spread like the nonsense of a telephone game. As embellishments and fins were tacked on to their conversation, it eventually turned into the following.

'I want to enter the individuals' tournament, Rudel.'

'... It makes me sick to my stomach to think any man apart from me will be touching your body.'

'It's just a match, it'll be fine.'

'Then I'll kill whoever goes up against you. If they injure you, I'll slaughter their household.'

Why did it come to this? The delusions of the students that could only bring those words to mind continued to spread, eventually reaching the ears of the staff, and by it, the first matchup of the tournament was forcefully changed to be Rudel against Izumi.



"Sophina, there aren't many high knights applying."

Fina expressionlessly processed paperwork with respectable speed. Her form, unlike usual, actually looked diligent. The papers she dealt with pertained to the defenders she had established, and she was doing a proper job.

The reason she was filling those forms in her room was that the one in charge of the defenders was substantially Fina.

"... There's the matter with the royal guard, but the high knights are facing a shortage of hands. It will be quite bad if we lose any more members."

While Sophina was by her side, helping out with her work, she was making an unpleasant face. Because she was Fina's guard, and by no means her secretary. Similarly helping out with work, Mii could only fulfill odd jobs like preparing tea.

Even so, rather than Fina who could actually help out, Fina's evaluation of Mii was higher. From how hard she tried to teach Mii the work, Sophina noticed Fina was slowly grooming her into her secretary, and wouldn't let her run away.

"We really do have too many organizations. While few in numbers, the feuding between knights has increased. It really is a bother."

"Yes... no matter how you look at it, aren't you being too wary? Maintaining a knight brigade simply to oppose Aileen-sama is going too far."

"You're right. There sure are a lot... then we'll be having the high knights disappear."

"Eh?"

Sophina's hands stop, and Fina cautioned her to keep working. But that wasn't the problem for Sophina.

"W-what are you talking about, princess?"

"Hmm? We have too many organizations, so we'll chip some away. The high knights are short on hands, and on top of their jobs being stolen away by the royal guard, their strength falls short of the defenders."

"W-we do not!"

"We'll need some organizational reform."

As Fina calmly carried on with her work, Sophina felt something off. When Fina never stuck hands into anything that didn't interest her, she suddenly spoke up about organizational reform.

To her lord and master who she knew was scheming as could be, Sophina sent a doubtful look. By the way, normally, Sophina's master was originally supposed to be the king Albach. The high knights swore loyalty to the king.

Sophina had accepted within that she was rolling on the palm of Fina's hand.

"Your real goal... is Izumi, isn't it."

"... That black hairrr, it's master's fault for saying he'll slaughter the house of whoever touches black hair. If it's to crush her, I'll even crush the high knight system. While I'm at it, I'll be able to take the high knights who've lost their place into the defenders all too easily."

"So we're just a 'while I'm at it'!? What do you think our loyalty is supposed to be..."

"Hah, listen well, Sophina. In any case, organizational reform will be needed. On top of Courtois' standing knight force, we have the dragoons, high knights, royal guard, defenders... if our neighbor wasn't the Gaia Empire, our military would be severely curtailed. The maintenance cost of a dragon is nothing to laugh at. You can rear dozens of horses at the price of one."

Sophina couldn't accept the words of the princess who had flooded the market with organizations to begin with.

"The fragmentation of factions within the organizations was going on from the start. To this point, that wasn't particularly a problem, but now it won't stand. By the way, I actually have a proper reason."

Fina finished up her paperwork before pulling a document from her drawer. It detailed the events surrounding what seemed to be a mystery case on the border.

Terrible as she was at dealing with ghost stories, Sophina divided her attention between the document and her work.

The document suggested the Gaia Empire might be behind the mystery. This was outside Sophina's jurisdiction, so had never even heard of it before.

"Is this... true?"

"It's certain there's been movement. Father's trying to take measures, but he said something was strange. It's as if some force is getting in his way, and he can't take any countermeasures... up to now, there have been a number of small skirmishes. But it does seem they're serious this time."

Fina had a few pieces of evidence that the empire had moved on hand. On top of the movements of people near the border, the flow of goods... they were even strengthening their military. It was the largest movement they had shown in the last few decades.

But what about Courtois on the other side? Even if Albach moved to counteract, for some reason, he wasn't getting anywhere. The high knights were weakening, and the royal guard's increasing authority was creating friction between them and the normal knights.

"Then, then why did you establish the defenders? If you pull troops from the border, we won't be able to anything when the time comes! Let alone that, I can only think you two princesses are the ones getting in the way..."

"This is why muscle heads are... even if it's the same border, it's not like I pulled any forces off the border with the Empire. And did you really think

I'd do anything as foolish as to pull out knights in command of the troops? I've already sent those very defenders to the empire's border to augment their forces."

"G-good work... huh? I didn't hear anything about that!"

"I didn't tell you."

Fina expressionlessly gave a cute gesture, but she was simply covering for the fact her father Alback couldn't move. Sadly, there was a limit to Fina's authority.

In regards to the high knights as well, she wanted to resolve their lack of commanders on site. She foresaw a situation where the skilled high knights could no longer only be used for defense.

Gathering goods on the border, she stationed soldiers and defenders. But she was overwhelmingly short on numbers. As she was pushing it a bit, she didn't want to involve Sophina.

If someone only heard that much, Fina was proficient. But her motives were simply impure.

Soothing Sophina before she could start a lecture, little by little, Fina explained.

"I cannot accept it, but I understand you are working hard for the sake of this country. So you've finally realized your position as a princess?"

"Of course, that's just a front. When the empire invades, my sister will go on a rampage, unable to read the mood, so I'll restrain her and increase my own value as I grow closer to my dreams of fluffadise... while I'm at it, I originally planned to crush the high knights to get back at black hair. See, when the royal guard and my defenders are fighting in the palace if the high knights aren't under my control, there's no telling how they'll move. (It's obvious, isn't it? Even if I'm rotten, I'm a princess of Courtois. So can't you show some understanding about the high knight matter?)"

Fina accidentally flipped her true feelings and front, Sophina held her head, filling up with the urge to cry out. Right, looking at the results, Fina's actions were correct when it came to defending Courtois. There were surely better ways to go about it, but with Fina's objectives, she couldn't take any other means.

In a situation where the empire was about to invade, Sophina was among the few individuals who had noticed the two large bombs within Courtois.

Mii did listen in to their conversation, but she didn't quite get it so she didn't open her mouth. But from Mii's eyes, it looked as if Sophina was worrying over the discharge of the high knights.

The reason Albach couldn't move was tied in with the setting. For the sake of the final event to come, the world had begun to move. To make sure Aileen didn't stand out, the ministers turned to oppose Albach, and a large divide was made in Courtois.

So the main character could perform on a desolate battlefield. The enemy was vast... his allies were powerless, and the protagonist appeared as a hero.

The Gaia Empire was taking this situation as a chance. Askewell distinguished himself in the military, gradually getting his preparations together.

And once more, Fina was fighting against fate.



"You want armor? Aleist, you don't have any blacksmiths under your house?"

As Rudel was eating lunch with Izumi, Aleist hurriedly rushed in as if fleeing from something. While he had failed to read the mood, Aleist did have a reason.

He wasn't thick enough to spend lunch every day in that grating, hellish environment. Starting with the slight sharpening of eyes, the checks, restraints, and threats slipped into casual conversation... Aleist could no longer taste his food.

Thinking up an arbitrary reason, Aleist had evacuated to Rudel.

Even Aleist's harem couldn't do anything reckless before Rudel.

And the arbitrary reason that came from his mouth was armor. His knight uniform would be prepared for him wherever he was assigned, but the problem was the armor. As the next head of the Hardie House, there were talks about how he needed an armor to represent his own house as well.

"Yeah, mine's an upstart house, and we don't have too many craftsmen under us. There's no problem when it comes to weapons, but I'll have to make a request elsewhere when it comes to armor."

Unlike usual, being able to eat without constraint left Aleist careless. Even when the perpetrator behind his harsh training under the tiger tribe men was undoubtedly Rudel.

Sitting beside them, Izumi watched Rudel think as she sipped her tea.

(It's Rudel we're talking about, so I'm sure he'll cause a problem... but it's just introducing a smithy, so maybe nothing will happen? No, but that's where the Rudel kicks in.)

Izumi's worried perfectly hit on the mark. Rudel had currently left his entire set of equipment to some craftsmen from the east. With maintenance in mind, the craftsmen had shown some interest when the sword and armor they forged had grown, and a new shield had been added on.

Rudel remembered their bloodshot eyes when those craftsmen saw his changed armor.

"I do know some skilled craftsmen."

"Really!?"

"They're a bit strange, but they've got some nice, determined eyes. I left my entire equipment set to them so you can trust in their skill."

At that moment, Izumi's guard was down. When Rudel said he knew a good craftsman, she never even thought they were a troupe from the east. She was sure they were blacksmiths under the Arses House's wing.

If she knew they were an eastern troupe, perhaps she could have cautioned Aleist. That they had peculiar tastes...

"Then is it alright if I make a request?"

"No problem. It'll actually serve as advertising, so I'm sure they'll rejoice. I had them go above and beyond for me, after all."

Rudel had asked them to abandon appearance and make an armor completely specialized to sturdiness, and he remembered how it turned out sturdy enough to surprise him. It really was an armor that had abandoned appearance. It hadn't the slightest hint of an ornament.

But now, because of the boar, it was made into an armor worthy of the white dragoon.

"Then I think I'll take you up on that. How much will it cost?"

"I can't really specify. If you just want an ornament, you might get it cheap, but in your case, you might use it outside of ceremonies... in this case, I think you should get something nice. Even if the country provides them, it's better to have more usable armaments."

"Got it. My parents said it was fine if I pushed it a bit, so I think I'll go and see."

Aleist delightedly finished his lunch, but when the craftsmen Rudel introduced delivered a pitch black armor to his doorsteps a few months later, he crumbled at the knees.

Chapter 83

Showing an enthusiasm different from the norm, the day of the individuals' tournament truly was a festival.

In the academy, the knights and soldiers on guard duty nervously carried out their duties, keeping watch over the royalty and nobles.

The areas short of numbers were strengthened with knights dispatched from the defenders.

On the entrance of the competitors onto the arena's circular ring, the clamor reached max pitch at once. There had been a large cheer through the hall when the royal family appeared, but the crowds were even more heated as the competitors took their places.

Among the eight lined up on the ring, apart from Rudel, there was Aleist and Eunius, Izumi, and even Millia.

At the end of the line came Fritz, who had managed to win his nomination despite being a third year.



In a noble visitor room that boasted a full view of the ring sat the royal family and headmaster. Among the royal guard charged with their safety, a single high knight had slipped in.

She was Fina's guard, Sophina, and she was sending some fleeting glances at her former colleagues around her. For every timid glance that returned came another triumphant smirk.

Even the high knights who had resisted at first had read the flow of the times, flowing over to the royal guard. A majority of the knights had transferred station. The royal guard was under Aileen's direct control, giving them a considerably preferential treatment when it came to benefits.

Sophina gazed mournfully at her former colleagues. As she knew what was going down behind the scenes, Sophina couldn't forgive the fact that all her former comrades were dancing on Fina's palm.

Right, Fina had moved towards the dismantlement of the high knights. Sophina had put up a resistance, saying that those with high loyalty would persist as high knights without flowing off to the royal guard. If that happens, I'll put a stop to their dismantlement, Fina had replied.

But looking at the result, a majority of the knights had transferred.

Fina was moving underneath, making sure Aileen didn't notice. She had one transfer, and then another. That was all she did, but hopping onto the flow, a large number chose to transfer. Their numbers were such that even Fina was surprised.

(You dimwits! It's because of you that the high knights will cease to exist!!)

Turning only her eyes to look at Aileen sitting beside her, Fina saw her rejoicing at Fritz' entrance to the stage. Sitting across, on the opposite side of Aileen, her mother the Queen covered her mouth with a fan as she glared at her eldest daughter.

"Aah, how wonderful Fritz-sama is..."

Hearing those words, her father the king also sent a glance at Fritz, but his expression was dubious. He was surely trying his best not to let his feelings grace his expression, but from the subtle movements of his face, Fina could see he was dejected.

A noble hater, and the man who incited a rebellion among the academy's commoner students. And yet Aileen accepted him on his approach. He could only have a bad feeling about this.

Fina looked over the ring.

(There's only one fluffy fighter... besides master and black hair's match in the first round, I'm only interested in Millia's match. This time, whether master wins or not doesn't really matter, so just how am I supposed to enjoy my time!? ... hah, I guess I have no choice but to do some serious thinking.)

From Fina's eyes, Aileen would definitely run wild if things continued on like this. This was just a prediction, but her mother was likely reaching the ends of her patience at the fact Aileen was in love with a commoner.

Originally, she honestly wanted to welcome Rudel, who had awakened as the white knight, into the family. If that matter with Chlust hadn't happened, then not as an archduke, it would have been fine if they made Rudel king. But in that case, he would have to marry either Aileen or Dina.

King Alback had planned to marry Aileen to Rudel and Fina to Aleist. Rather than using his daughters in diplomacy, he prioritized getting a hold on the white and black knights.

But Fina was in a position opposed to her father's plan. The moment she learned of it, she acted swiftly, bringing talks of an engagement between Aileen and Aleist to the queen. The queen did have a fixation on status and bloodline, but she was unable to look down on the black knight.

Black knight was the name taken by the first king of Courtois. And looking into the records, there were accounts of techniques that closely resembled the way Aleist fought. Fina hit into that point, having the queen recommend putting Aileen with Aleist.

(Well, I doubt it's happening with my sister like that... hah, so I really have to prepare.)

To Fina, it was dangerous if Aileen didn't cut off Fritz. Her sister who was practically blessed by the heavens, the sight of her seriously backing Fritz floated in Fina's eyes. If played poorly, there was a fear that the system of nobility itself would disappear.

From Fina's point of view, nobles going away or losing power wasn't a problem. She feared the insurrections that would come in the process of the nobility's collapse. When the large power beside them showed a movement, if they continued squabbling within the country was sure to collapse. In the worst case, the nobles would turn on them and send them to the chopping block.

(I want to see fluffadise. I don't want to die.)

Expressionlessly, yet sorrowfully, Fina stared at Aileen.



The all-important first match was left to Rudel and Izumi.

In order to make this individuals' tournament a success, the academy had put in quite a bit of work. But in the end, it all came down to the competitors' performance.

The academy simply heated things up as much as they could, praying it all would end without incident.

Facing one another, Rudel and Izumi held their wooden straight sword and curved sword as they awaited the signal from the referee. They didn't have anything to say to the other. They were concentrated hard enough, they didn't need to exchange a light greeting before the match. It was something both sides understood.

And as the first match was about to begin, the hall's tensions rose as well.

After confirming the preparations were complete, the ref turned to the audience and sent a sign.

A group with large magic circles engraved on their shields started moving around the front row. As the shield knights occupied the first row, the row which was most worthy to watch a match from, a single noble drew close.

"Oy, you lot, if you're not using all of the front row, then give me a seat! Is there any meaning in keeping them? I'm sure it's some sort of magic, but don't waste our time with something meaningless!"

The young nobleman surrounded by a few followers grabbed the man who looked to lead the shield knights and interrogated him. The fact his foe had a vague knowledge of magic only made the shield knight more troubled to explain.

"So you see, this is a formation to protect the audience seats, and we have to move around to match the situation, so we have to leave them empty..."

The commanding officer was Rudel's upperclassman Vargas. He was appointed as head of the newly-formed shield knight unit, leading the force of young knights.

"Like hell a magic circle can display an effect if you move it around! Get me the guy in charge!"

"... Ah, young master."

"Don't call me that, Vargas! More importantly, what's this? Are you trying to deface me?"

The one who appeared was Luecke, wearing a different robe than usual. In order to distinguish himself from the spectators, he clad himself in a white robe bearing the crest of his house. The reason Luecke was so hyped up was that this was his opportunity to unveil the knight unit he formed himself.

If this succeeded, he planned to expand it to a brigade. But now he had another reason to put even more power into the individuals' tournament.

"huh? This person's Vargas-san? Pleasure, I'm Lena Arses!"

The one to Luecke's side, able to get a front row seat on the condition she kept close to Luecke, was Lena. It was Rudel's last, long-awaited tournament, so wanting to see it with her own eyes, she had made the trek.

But troublingly enough, the seats were full. The appearance of Luecke led to the current situation.

"... You understand, don't you, Vargas? I cannot fail here."

"Yes, but that's just because your crush is... eep! Understood, I'll return to my station!!"

Hurriedly returning to his position, Vargas was pressured to flee. Lena waved her hand at Rudel, and Izumi across from him.

As Luecke turned back to the noble who spoke out, he instantly saw through his house and faction.

"Hah, this is why the Diade faction is so troublesome. It would be one thing if they were ignorant to magic, but to think they'd mouth off on half-assed knowledge."

"Y-you're..."

From the crest on Luecke's robe and his looks, the man saw he was dealing with a future Archduke, and even if he was of a different faction, he faltered. The followers also proposed for their lord to pull back.

Put at a disadvantage, the nobleman turned his back and walked off. Losing interest, Luecke saw his subordinates had taken their positions, so he activated the magic.

A faint, blue dome, close to transparent, spread out to protect the audience seats. The spectators raised cheers at that magic field they had never seen before.

But more than that, Luecke...

"Luecke-san, thank you for letting me into the arena!"

Seeing Lena smile, ignoring his magic entirely as she delighted over the fact he let her in, Luecke gave a gentle smile back. He was acting completely differently to how he had treated Vargas and the noble.

"That much is nothing."

"And hey, what's this blue thing?"

"Hmm, this is a special field. I used markings on the shield knights to complete a magic circle. Softening impacts is a simple task, but of the shield knights move, it's a magic that can prevent direct attacks as well."

Perhaps it was too difficult as Lena held her head. Luecke frantically gave a simplified explanation.

"I-it's pretty much a barrier!"

"Oh, I see. So it's a barrier!"

Relieved that Lena had finally understood, Luecke also sent his eyes to Rudel and Izumi. During the match, Luecke would have to constantly pay mind to the positioning of the shield knights.

To summarize, this was a situation where anyone could go all out.



"Well then, let the first match... commence!"

Receiving the ref's signal, the two took their stances, While Rudel held his one-handed sword up front, Izumi stooped down and took an iai stance.

On that stance unknown in Courtois, some restless voices sounded from the audience seats. As Rudel hesitated on his first move, Izumi took the initiative.

As she pulled swiftly drew her sword out towards Rudel, who was out of her range, Rudel suddenly leapt back. At the place he had jumped from, the remains of a slash were carved into the ring.

Now with her wooden sword 'unsheathed', Izumi made a bold approach, and Rudel dodged her blows as he called over. While he showed leisure, those fast and sharp slices were making a sport of him.

"What was that right there? I couldn't see the light of mana."

"It's called iai. Normally, my range is only around a few meters, but I saw your magic sword and tried imitating it."

"I see!"

If he took distance, those invisible slices would fly his way. Rudel judged the time she stayed out of her starting posture. He concluded those shockwaves wouldn't fly if she wasn't in stance.

But she showed movements subtly different to what he knew. Her fighting style was the same, but culture also varied from country to country. Unlike Rudel and the others who would leap to close distance, Izumi would step in.

It wasn't much of a difference, but those subtle discrepancies put Rudel off.

Rudel's fighting style of cladding his sword in mana was possible for Izumi. But Izumi only activated it when it was necessary. She only used the minimum amount of mana required.

By that, she could fight a prolonged battle.

As Rudel was measuring her range, Izumi changed the way she swung her sword. It was similar to the motion she used to pull her sword in her previous stance, but this time, she didn't pretend to resheathe it.

"Normally, you'd use the sheath of the katana as well. But a wood sword has no sheath, right? Then I need not adhere to it."

Izumi gently smiled, but she was pretty much saying she didn't need to take a stance. If she could project her slashes even without a sheath, then it was only natural she could do it in any stance she chose.

"That really is troubling."

Rudel held up his left hand, commencing an attack with magic. It was an invisible attack through the magic of wind. With that, it looked as if both sides held the same conditions.

But Izumi's shockwaves easily cut through Rudel's wind to attack him.

"Can you quit playing around, Rudel? I'm serious."

Seeing Izumi's serious face, Rudel looked at the edge of his clothing that had been sliced. Without any fraying, it was cleanly cut through.

"... You better not call it underhanded."

"I won't."

With those words alone, they had reached an understanding. From those around, they were already completely a couple. In the noble visitor room, Fina was infuriated within.

As Rudel decided he couldn't win with wind, he used the earth magic Luecke had utilized the year before. Sticking his left hand into the ring, he manifested a wall to surround Izumi.

Compared to Luecke's, it differed in strength and size.

Surrounded by walls, Izumi quietly took a stance.

◇

"Ooh, my bro's amazing."

"Yeah, making one of those on the fly is considerably difficult. Strength aside, with this, he's sealed off Izumi's invisible slashes. It's Rudel's win."

Luecke was convinced of Rudel's victory, but Lena shook her head. As she did, her side-ponytail swayed. Turning to Luecke's smitten face, she told him Izumi hadn't given up.

"Not yet, he hasn't. There's no way Izumi-in-the-flesh-san would give up here."

"I-Izumi in the flesh?"

Rather than the direction of the battle, Luecke was more curious about the in-the-flesh title.

Right after, the earthen wall surrounding Izumi was shredded to tatters by countless invisible slashes. The hall convinced of Rudel's victory was wrapped in voices of surprise.

It was a single instant. As fissures raced across the wall at once, Izumi appeared with her wooden sword drawn. Rudel was making a delighted face. And perhaps Izumi was also happy, having made Rudel serious.

From the audience's point of view, 'foreign women are scary', was what filled their heads.

"... See?"

On Lena's words, Luecke was impressed. He wanted to ask if she had foreseen the events that had unfolded before them, but first off, he confirmed that Izumi was more of a threat than he had imagined.

Instantly changing the placement of the high knights, He moved the knights who had only been focused on Rudel to keep them wary of Izumi's attacks as well.

(If it gets destroyed in the first round, my barrier will lose its credibility.)

Luecke prayed that the barrier wouldn't be shattered by Izumi. But he couldn't help but picture an image of her cutting it through.

Because of Lena, that high-level magic was henceforth dubbed barrier.

Chapter 84

In the arena, atop the round, circular ring, the man and woman faced one another.

One was Izumi, taking an iai stance, while the other was Rudel, his wood sword held low, and his left hand held out up front. While it looked like he was taking a low stance with his sword, Rudel had simply loosened the power in his right arm to concentrate on his left.

The white knight Rudel's weapon was the shield. Letting off light, the shield that could protect from all manners of attack... he prepared to use his trump card from the start.

The spectators who knew of his fight with Aleist the year before grew interested to see if Izumi could cut through that shield of light.

Izumi herself also focused her mind on a serious Rudel. After giving one laugh, Rudel's expression turned grim and his atmosphere changed as well.

Izumi changed her grip on her curved, wooden sword, keeping her eyes wide open as she unleashed her most powerful strake yet. Immediately afterwards, a horizontal line was cut into the arena wall.

Rudel couldn't defend against it. Everyone present imagined him being cut through, but Rudel had evaded into the sky. Seeing him take a large leap, the spectators with a bit of knowledge thought the battle was settled.

Rudel in the air, and Izumi taking her stance... the hasty spectators began to believe in Izumi's victory. In the air, Rudel directed his readied left hand towards the ring, his head facing to the floor in an upside-down state.

"That was a bit of a failure. Tuning it is difficult."

Recalling his prior action, Rudel found his next area to work on. When he evaded Izumi's slash, Rudel had exercised a bit of a strange means of travel.

It was something Marty devised, and a battle style later officially taken up by the dragoons. But there were few who could use it to its fullest, and at this point, it was only an emergency means of repositioning.

Seeing some baffling points in Rudel's movements, Izumi fired a few slashes to investigate. In the spectators' seats, Luecke was tempestuously crying out orders, desperate to make sure the barrier could withstand them.

At that moment, an unbelievable spectacle entered the spectators' eyes.

It was one thing for Rudel to change his posture in the air, but his trajectory also took a violent change. When they thought he had evaded the slashes, he had landed on the ring in the next instant, almost instantaneously moving from the spot.

Izumi's slashes rained through the path he had taken, but none of them were able to capture him.

"This is...!"

As Izumi tried to read ahead of his movements, Rudel's wood sword was lowing towards her. She intended to parry, but on those movements she had never anticipated, she ended up forced to catch the blow.

Rudel's heavy strike crumbling her stance, Izumi leapt back for a moment. The moment she had come in contact with him, Izumi gained a general grasp of things.

"This is magic?"

What she felt on her skin was an unnatural flow of wind. The wind swirling with Rudel at the center pushed him into the air once more.

On those movements that could no longer even be called human, the spectators couldn't even raise their voices.

Izumi undid her iai stance, holding her sword at the center of her body. She felt that a stance like iai- which amassed power into a single blow- put her at a disadvantage when it came to swift reaction. Now she pointed the tip of her blade at Rudel standing on the ring.

"That's quite a rash way you're using it."

Receiving the mutter Izumi gave once her breathing was in order, Rudel showed an even greater acceleration in his movements. To those unaccustomed, perhaps it seemed as if Rudel had appeared behind Izumi in an instant,

Izumi turned around, but where she turned, Rudel's wood sword was gently touching her cheek. Izumi let her sword fall from her hands, falling to her knees as the ref gave a grand declaration of Rudel's victory.



After watching Rudel and Izumi's match, Luecke had noticed the secret behind Rudel's movements.

"He's crazy. Purposely having his magic explode on him, I would never do it by choice."

Having successfully maintained the special field Lena named barrier, Luecke let out a sigh of relief as he watched Rudel extend Izumi a hand.

Lena was to his side, seeking an explanation towards her brother's movements.

"Hey, hey, Luecke-san. Could I move like that too?"

"Those movements? No, I'm sure you could do it, but I wouldn't recommend it. That one's dangerous. It might look like he's brute forcing it, but actualizing that would need a precise control of magic. One wrong step and the explosion should send his body spiraling out of control."

After hearing Luecke's explanation, Lena smiled.

"Oh, so I can learn it too!"

"No, I'm telling you it's dangerous..."

"Alright, I'll do my best! Ah, Luecke-san, you're good at magic, right? Teach it to me."

When Lena grabbed Luecke's white robe in her fingertips, Luecke spoke with a straight face...

"Leave it to me, I'll make a splendid magus of you."

Nearby, Vargas who had come to discuss his next positioning, was making an inexplicable face before his employer.

While Luecke was usually expressionless, giving those around a cold impression, when he was with Lena, he looked younger than his age. It seems he was bad with personal relations from the start, but having come so far, he was slowly improving.

But the one he was in love with was the problem. If she was a fair noble daughter it would be another thing, but the other party was Rudel's sister and a tomboy. What's more, from her status, it didn't look like his love would bear fruit.

Lena was tall in stature, just a little to go before she reached Luecke's height. Her appearance was beautiful enough, but because she wore men's clothing, if her hair wasn't long, then perhaps she could be taken as a peerless pretty boy.

(Rudel's sister is also quite something... she's thirteen, was she? Two more years then.)

Seeing Lena who would come to the academy someday, Vargas recalled the teacher camp who had come to him in tears. Thinking that the academy surely had hard times ahead of them, he wanted his employer to notice him already.

It was just around that time that the headmaster- keeping the royal family company in the noble visitors' room- felt a chill.



The next match ended safely without any greater enthusiasm than before.

It was a match between Eunius and a fifth year, but Eunius easily pinned down his victory. In a separate visitor room from the one for royalty, Eunius and Luecke's parents had come to see their own sons' hours of triumph.

But as there was an abnormal zeal this time around, the archdukes who got along like cats and dogs were placed in the same room. The other rooms were all filled with marquises and counts, and this was the only room left adequately furnished to accept an archduke.

They did seek confirmation from both houses, and the academy decided there wouldn't be a problem. But these were houses with deep-seated grudges.

Once Eunius' match ended, the Diade House Head raised a grand laugh.

"He should fire up the crowd some more. That boy needs to learn to pay mind to his surroundings a bit..."

As truth would have it, Eunius had fought making sure not to scratch the ring. The reason was simple. If he wanted to fight Rudel as soon as possible, then the ring's repairs would get in the way.

"Hmm, then why don't you try paying mind as well? You've been hollering for a while now."

Luecke's father, Archduke Halbades, put the drink he'd been offered to his mouth as he spit out the words. The Diade House and camp glared back... the Archduke room was filled with an exceedingly tense atmosphere.

But there was some distance between the two houses, and they wouldn't break into anything. The empty seats in the center were originally supposed

to be occupied by the members of the Arses House who were supposed to come. But no one had made their way to the competition.

The two archdukes found it strange. They thought the man was irritated at having a son too talented, but they couldn't think of a reason he'd show such contempt in a public space.

If he actually came, the other two archdukes may have actually had to concede defeat and kneel to that ill-natured Archduke Arses. It was strange that such a conceited man wouldn't come to see a son he could boast about.

They had heard of Rudel from their own sons. As nobles, being swept up by his proficiency would be troublesome, but looking at it as people, having good friends was a good thing. They truly lamented he was from such a problematic lineage.

"Hmm, that man is a vindictive one. Is it really so hard to accept him? He looked like a son to be proud of to me."

"You should watch your words. You might be calling him Your Majesty soon."

Archduke Halbades cautioned Archduke Diade on his words, but he had already heard of Rudel's nature from Luecke. From his point of view, he was a failure as a noble. But seeing how his son had matured, perhaps he was a good person. The archduke concluded so.

The probability of Rudel becoming king was by no means anything small. He also thought that Luecke being his friend would become a large contribution to the Halbades House in times to come.

(If his bearing as a king is enough to pull people to him, then there's no problem as long as his surroundings support him up.)

The other Archduke, Archduke Diade was, if one had to choose, a noble who idolized military might. That Rudel had obtained a dragon more powerful than ever seen before was enough for him to call Rudel his king.

Of all else, to him, the word strong was important. He sought strength as a symbol. He didn't seek for Rudel to take to the front lines. He didn't seek for him to take command.

But he wanted a king who could order his troops to fight. In that regards, what he had heard from Eunius gave Rudel a passing grade.

Perhaps it was ironic that both Archdukes had recognized him. The space in the center of the room looked terribly lonesome.



After Eunius' match, the next match was held promptly.

In Rudel's match with Izumi, the ring was left in tatters, so some time was required to repair it. And it was time for Fritz, the one who bore the hopes of the common man, to take to the stage.

In the noble visitor room of royalty, Aileen happily waved her hand at the window sill. Seeing that, both the king and queen shook their heads, while Fina dealt with the dragoons who came to report.

The ones who entered the room were Cattleya and Lilim. They had some connections with Fina, so they were appointed to inform the royal line of the security situation.

But the room's dubious air left the both of them troubled.

"What's wrong?"

As Fina sent a lifeboat to the troubled two, Cattleya gave her report. When Lilim entered, the eyes of the royal guard grew sharp. Aileen was engrossed with Fritz, and she hadn't noticed Lilim.

"Yes, we came to report that there is nothing to report about the security in the sky..."

"Is that so. Then would you two like to watch the match as well? The headmaster is busy dealing with father and mother, so I wanted someone to

provide commentary."

It wasn't as if Fina kept the two dragoons on her own selfishness. The entrance of two outsiders had let her parents regain their composure.

Fina had enough of having to divert her attention away from Aileen. After Lilim went to inform the dragoons they would be placed on guard duty temporarily, Fina felt just a little disappointed.

Having as many lovers (fluffies) by her side was what Fina wanted. If Sophina knew the real reason, she would surely call it selfish.

"But is that truly necessary? I do see some high knights present."

As Cattleya looked around, she saw some faces she had once seen among the high knights, but at this point they had transferred to the royal guard. Having returned from the outskirts only recently, Cattleya didn't have a grasp on the situation in the palace.

"It's fine. Sophina has gone into heat over mas... Rudel, and she won't explain anything to me."

Fina had tried teasing Sophina, but Sophina truly did grow flustered. As Fina didn't have any interest in battle, she didn't particularly want commentary on the battle. But Sophina's face grew redder than she had expected, so Cattleya opened her mouth.

"Eh? But isn't she married already..." "Hold your tongue, Cattleya! ... Just don't touch that matter."

Fina's tact stuck deeply into Sophina's heart. Cattleya had been convinced that Sophina was married. While they had seen each other's faces a few times, the two had rarely spoken of anything outside of work.

When Lilim returned to the room, the air only grew worse.

Around the time Lilim returned, Fritz' match was already over. It wouldn't take any time to mend the ring, and next up was Aleist's match with Millia.

As they climbed up to the ring, the older sister Lilim felt pride as she saw how much her little sister had grown. But behind Fina, Sophina and Cattleya were persistently carryong on a woman's quarrel.



Climbing up to the ring, Aleist took a deep breath.

A head he had never felt before, and a peculiar air, he calmed his heard to make sure he wasn't swallowed in. The reason he couldn't calm down was surely because he was up against his beloved millia.

While Aleist held a wood sword, Millia had a training bow. The arrow tips were covered in rubber, and they were made not to stick into anything. But if they hit, they really hurt.

On the appearance of the rumored black knight, the arena grew rowdy at once. Those cheers almost held enough force to shake the ring itself, making Aleist a little embarrassed.

Have I become a bit more worthy of their cheers? The thought lingered within him. But those who knew Aleist saw the scene from a different perspective.



"Oh? Mister black knight likes Ms. Elf!?"

On Lena's loud voice, the nearby spectators reacted. Perhaps happy he could answer Lena's questions, Luecke spoke of all without deceit.

"Yeah, but that elf, Millia, truth be told, Rudel is the..."

"Oy, young master! Don't tell the young lady of her brother's love affairs!"

Thinking that was going too far, Vargas went in to stop Luecke. But Luecke gave a gesture to shoo him away, and he reluctantly abided.

Where he went was Basyle, her stomach grown in size, with Izumi sitting to her side. The reason her stomach had grown was, of course...

"Will it be born soon?"

"Yes, I hope we have healthy child."

Once Izumi moved from the waiting room to the audience, she reunited with Basyle, so she sat beside her. Basyle wasn't wearing anything too revealing, so it was hard to notice her at a glance.

As Vargas approached Basyle, telling her to look after herself, the eyes gathered on him. From the contents of their conversation, it seems they had realized Vargas and basyle were a couple.

"Dammit, when my face is better..." "Accursed winners in life." "Don't think it'll all be moonlit nights."

Bathed in the envious eyes of men, Vargas' shoulders fell.

"Why am I..."

When he was worried for his wife, he was showered in envy, and his employer was in love with a child seven years his younger. He was one of the people whose lives had been greatly altered by Rudel.



"Hey, Aleist."

"Y-yes!"

Ever since the confession, Millia had become estranged from him. For Aleist as well, ever since that point, even if he met her, he was left in a state where he couldn't say a thing. The two were in quite an awkward relationship.

They had grown taller since they first met at the academy gates. Since then, they had both changed considerably.

Millia had transformed into a woman, and Aleist had looked at himself anew. Such was the two of them, but...

"You really are the worst."

"Eh!?"

Millia's expression was seriously filled in anger. To look at it objectively... Aleist was the lord of a harem. At the point he confessed to Millia, he was already dating a number of women.

But with the violent characters Seli and Juju, he had already completed some considerably painful events. With a misunderstanding, he was hit hard enough to be slammed into a wall, and almost became rust on a sword.

And the other girls also boasted considerably strong personalities. Otherwise, they would have pulled away from Aleist already.

But from the eyes of those around, such a thing was irrelevant. It was unforgivable that he was surrounded by multiple women in his school days.

"Laying hands on so many women, and even trying for me... I'll have you regret it!"

"E-eeeeeeh!!? Whyyy!!?"

Millia had taken a stance with her bow, so the referee nonchalantly signaled the match's start before fleeing the ring.

Chapter 85

"I like you, Millia!"

"You're saying that again!!

Wings made of light appeared on Millia's back as she jumped high over the ring and fired off an arrow. As Aleist avoided that arrow laced with magic, it stuck deep into the stone ring.

Normally, that would be dangerous, but on top of avoiding it with ease, Aleist instinctively hit down the next one with his wooden sword. Their abilities were too far apart. What's more, Aleist hadn't even used the black knight's characteristic darkness.

But this match was filled with a different enthusiasm than the one between Rudel and Izumi.

Aleist had been determined to explain away the misunderstanding. But along the way...

"I love you! These feelings aren't a lie!"

"I'm telling you to stop it!!"

Seeing Aleist not stop his confessions even after being rejected and hated, the audience displayed different reactions as they got heated up.

A majority of the men who knew Aleist...

"Drop dead, harem bastart!"

"He's even sinking his poidon fangs into Millia-san..."

"Explode!!"

Many women..

"Wow, amazing!"

"A confession in the middle of a match!!"

"How envious!"

Aleist's friends prayed that his confession would go well, while Aleist's harem members let off an aura so dark everyone around them drew away.

Those unaffiliated with the academy also looked on Aleist's confession with a smile. But there were some who couldn't smile as well.



"How irritating."

"What a coincidence, I feel the same. Who's sister is that supposed to be, senpai?"

"That girl's in for it..."

Standing behind Fina, Sophina, Cattleya and Lilim were directing eyes of envy.

Sophina couldn't forgive the confession itself. The other party was the black knight, promotion assured, and from a Count House. His face was good, and he was a man with everything together. First off, he was the sort of man who would never appear at her marriage interviews.

From Cattleya's point of view, being confessed to be a knight set her maiden heart yearning. It was hard to imagine from her appearance and usual conduct, but she was the purest among these members. Even now, she was waiting for her prince on a white horse.

Last was Lilim, but she had lost her engagement over her own eyes. Since then, she had never dated a man, but her little sister was clearly receiving a confession from a splendid man. Tey she rejected it. Her attitude of continual rejection made it seem to Lilim that she had the leisure.

Turning head from those three, Fina thought...

(Ooh, how scary. How black. Well, it's interesting enough to watch. Even so, Aleist's fallen for an elf... I approve of his will for the fluff, but his timing's off.)

As Fina turned to her family, she was her father Albach averting his face from the knights letting off a black aura behind her. Her mother seemed irritated, gripping the fan in her hand hard enough for it to let off a sound.

Her older sister Aileen seemed uninterested.

(It seems father fears a woman's scorn. As expected of the chicken who was too scared of mother to get any mistresses! I think mother's irritated that Aleist's confessing before her eyes after she devised all those talks of engagement? My sister... is she uninterested because the other party's an elf? It's fun enough for me!)

While Fina thought over the troubles she had with Rudel, she considered adding some ammendments to her plan of shoving Aileen onto Aleist.

At this rate, even if Aileen and Aleist's engagement was regognized, she might demand the condition of him eliminating his fluffy mistresses.

(I can do something about mother, but the problem's my sister. Even if I alter the plan, the engagement won't be recognized... hah, I hope Fritz loses soon so she can cool her head.)

Seeing how everything her sister did seemed to go well, she determined that she wouldn't be blessed with the good fortune of Fritz losing anytime soon. If losing was enough to cool her off, she would have calmed down after his battle with Rudel.

(But Aleist, eh... that much be surprisingly nice.)

That wasn't a statement as a woman, her thoughts of how to use everything for her ambitions, was Fina's strong point.

(He isn't as popular as master with the fluffies, but the defenders could use him as a backup... ah, me fluffy dreams grow evermore!!)

... Even after thinking so much, her face was expressionless.



"I'm head over heels for you!!"

"Again!!"

When her arrows had run out, Millia challenged Aleist to close combat, but CQC had become Aleist's specialty. He avoided Millia's ro'ndhouse kick with the minimum necessary movements.

Blood rushing to her head, Millia's grandiose kick caused her skirt to flutter wildly.

She was wearing something like tights, the sort of thing where it was fine even if her skirt was flipped. She was... but as Aleist's face went bright red, Millia only grew angrier.

Making sure her undergarments couldn't be seen, she grew to agitated to remember she was wearing tights.

"You peeked, you pervert!"

"Y-you're wrong. I'll admit I saw. But you're not wearing..."

"Die!"

As Millia swung her bow to attack Aleist, the arena showed great excitement. As Aleist dodged with a paper-thin margin, it looked like Millia and Aleist were just having a lover's spat.

It looked like Aleist was trying to soothe an angry Millia.

Out of breath, Millia took a large flap of the wings on her back. She tried to attack to decide the match.

Originally, Millia had entered the tournament desiring a rematch with Izumi. Her loss in a class battle of times passed inspired her to apply.

For that sake, she had polished her magic, and polished an elf's special way of movement. But by Aleist's high-level harassment in the form of confessions, the blood was rushing to her head, and she wasn't able to display her usual level of ability.

It was Aleist's strategic victory... Millia was beginning to think.

But as Millia charged, Aleist didn't even try to dodge. More than that, he caught her. And he proclaimed in a loud voice.

"I-I'll definitely make you happy, so please mewwy me!"

Fitting of Aleist, he bit his tongue at the end. In a tournament under the eyes of royalty, Aleist had taken action that would become an academy legend.

"I-idiiooottt!!"

Right after, Millia's scream echoed through the arena. Seeing Millia burst into tears, the referee pecked an adequate time before professing Aleist's victory. But he didn't have power in the voice, he sounded somewhat reserved.

"Winner: Aleist Hardie... he won the battle, but lost the war."

Aleist held back the urge to implant his fist into the referee's face.



"Huh? So in the end, did the black knight's confession succeed?"

"Hmm, I'm not sure how to look at it... did she call him an idiot to hide her embarrassment, or because she really thinks he's an idiot... she was crying, so perhaps she holds him in surprisingly high esteem?"

Rather than the contents of Aleist and Millia's match, Luecke and Lena discussed their romance. There had been a series of matches where maintaining the barrier was simple, and Vargas could also sit back and watch the match.

"But is this... really alright? This'll come back to bite Aleist, won't it?"

The arena was cheering, but it felt like this was something that would influence Aleist's future course. Vargas let out a sigh as he noticed his superior entranced in conversation with Lena hadn't heard his words at all.

Looking at the ring, they were pulling out the stuck-in arrows and filling in the holes.

The next match weighted down on Vargas' mind. A match between Rudel and Eunius, this would be their first faceoff in the individuals' tournament.

The audience had been watching Aleist and Millia's match as a form of entertainment as they placed their expectations on the match to come. Everyone imagined Rudel and Aleist, the white and black knights facing off in the finals, but from Vargas' point of view, Eunius and his superior smitten with a young girl were monsters as well.

If he had to say, it wouldn't be strange for either to win.

He was about to call out to Luecke to confirm his position. But Luecke's face had already turned serious.

"What are you doing, Vargas! The next match is between Rudel and the muscle idiot! Get to your position at once."

"I know I'm at fault, but this feels unfair..."

Heading for his station, Vargas looked at the two facing one another on the ring.



Eunius leaned his long-sword-styled wooden sword over his shoulder, and Rudel let the wood sword in his hand hang down as they faced one another. As the hall grew rowdy, Eunius opened his mouth.

"Good grief, you've sure kept me waiting."

"I definitely did keep you waiting, but this is a tournament. Even if we both take part, the probability of us clashing isn't too high."

Eunius gave a bitter smile at Rudel's answer, but his expression gradually turned seirous. Rudel received that look as he took a stance with his wood sword.

"I really would've preferred the finals. Well, beggars can't be choosers, and this is the first time I've ever been able to fight you at full strength."

Rudel offered a rebuttal to Eunius' thoguhts.

"That's wrong. Whether it's the first or last time, I've always fought at full strength."

"... That ain't what I meant."

In their matchup during their second year of the fundamental curriculum, Rudel was in tatters. But now standing before Eunius' eyes, Rudel had his clothes cut up a bit, but he wasn't injured.

They were both in a state where they could give it their all.

When Eunius assumed a stance as well, the referee rung out his voice to declare the start of the match.

The two of them definitely heard the ref's call, but surprisingly, neither side moved. Still in their stances, they stared at one another. Even though the match had started, they wouldn't move.

As the spectators had hoped for an intense clash of blades, this was a bit of a killjoy.



"They're not moving."

Lena kept her face turned towards her brother Rudel as she called over to Luecke. To that point, Luecke had been answering all her questions, but now he was concentrating on the match, and his responses would often be vague.

"Yeah, so they're not."

From Lena's eyes as well, Eunius' abilities were exceedingly high. Rudel had told her it was too early for her to face him, and she was certain he wasn't wrong.

But in her heart, she wished to fight.

(With the current Eunius-san, given five years, I'll be able to catch up... but by that time, my brother and everyone else will have risen even higher. I wish I was born a just a little earlier.)

After watching Rudel, Lena got around to thinking she wanted to study at the academy as soon as possible.

If she did, she would be able to make worthy rivals and compete. Lena anxiously looked forward to her enrollment at the academy in two years' time.



The first one to move was Rudel.

Neither side had shown any movement, but when Rudel moved, their swords met at once Rudel's vicious approach had been seen through by Eunius.

On those movements Izumi could keep up with, Eunius had anticipated them and used his wood sword to fend off all Rudel's attacks. Their power was different from the start, and even if Eunius took Rudel's blows, he was able to repel them.

Using his emergency movements again, as Rudel's was blocked by Eunius' sword, he hammed a kick into Eunius' leg. Foreseeing it and jumping back, Eunius was grinning. But that face was too ferocious to call a smile.

"How dangerous. If I took that kick, it would've dulled my movements."

"... I kicked with the intention of breaking it."

On Rudel's serious statement, Eunius felt ecstasy from the bottom of his heart. HE was thankful to Rudel, who didn't show the slightest shred of holding back against him.

His movements had grown better since they last fought. He could tell he hadn't neglected to train his swordplay. As Eunius went on the offense, a dazzling light emitted from his wooden sword.

After imitating a magic sword and sublimating it, it had become a magic sword for Eunius alone. On that blades warping movements, Rudel took some distance, trying to bring the fight to a mid-range magic battle.

The numerous magics he fired from his left hand... fire and water, and wind and earth, they were all cut down before they could reach Eunius. Eunius took but a single swing, but as if the magic sword held a will of its own, it moved in a complicated manner.

Its trajectory was hard to predict, and its reach was a problem. When Eunius could predict Rudel's movements, it would be impossible to approach unscathed.

So Rudel manifested the shield of the white knight. They were around the size of a person, he produced a number of those large shields, having them float around him.

Those shields radiating light, without any hesitation, he slammed them into Eunius. With those shields boasting powerful defense coming his way, Eunius leapt into the air to evade them all.

And he lowered his sword towards Rudel who had taken some distance.

The light of his magic sword reached Rudel, who had made it to the edge of the ring. AS Rudel prepared a magic sword of his own, his wooden sword was clad in light.

He instantly blocked, but Eunius' magic sword warped. Reaching just showrt of Rudel's own sword, the blade slammed into the ring, destroying the ground and sending stones flying at Rudel.

In a single instant where Rudel's attention was taken, Eunius had slipped into his guard. Using the magic of wind to carry out high-speed movements, Rudel evacuated to the opposite side of the ring, but his left shoulder had already tasted blood.

"Was it too shallow? I'll cut it deeper next time."

At the smile Eunius made as he held up his sword, Rudel returned a smile of his own. Eunius was definitely a battle maniac, but Rudel was the samy. By fighting strong opponents, he was the type of battle maniac who thought he could move forward.

"I'll have to refrain. It's my turn to cut deep."

The spectators who grew noisy when the match started up were now swallowing their breaths at the high level of the exchange.

Chapter 86

The intense clash of light-clad swords didn't let off the sound of wood colliding.

The ring's floor was gouged out and sliced, growing worse every time the two met. Preparing two shields around a meter in length, Rudel kept them stationed close to him.

With those, he could reduce the damage caused by the movements of Eunius' warping blade. While Rudel had been on the offense, Eunius' fierce charge put him on the defensive.

The magic sword, at times it would grow, and at times it would shrink making it impossible to judge distances. Protected by his shields, Rudel thought of carrying on an offensive with magic, but he saw himself running out of gas first.

The shields of lights... while powerful shields, they expended great amounts of mana and concentration. On the handling of those shields he had yet to grow accustomed to, Rudel understood he was being pushed back.

He used his swift wind magic movement, but as Eunius was able to see through his destination, there would usually be a magic sword waiting for him. Rudel needed to take another step or he would never reach Eunius.

While Rudel thought he was at a disadvantage, Eunius was much the same. The attacks of his magic sword were being blocked by the shields. If he didn't see through the path of Rudel's high speed movement in an instant, then that instant would decide the match.

As Rudel would fly over whenever he showed a gap, Eunius put up a desperate offensive.

In contrast to Rudel's bountiful hand, Eunius was at a loss on how to continue. Quite some time had passed since they both put out their magic swords. Eunius could only display his swordplay during the timeframe his wood sword could withstand his mana.

"Dammiy! And I wanted to settle this match with the sword!"

The wood sword he gripped had been specially made. But its strength was completely insufficient to endure Eunius' powerful magic sword. It was a special item made for a single match with Rudel, and that went to show just how fixated Eunius was on this match.

The off-sensation he felt when he swung his sword grew worse, and it was just about nearing its limit.

Rudel could also tell Eunius' magic sword didn't have long left. But what Rudel held was nothing more than an average wood sword. Its limit was also closing in.

Rudel erased his shields and flooded his mana into his magic sword, launching a charge on Eunius. On that high-speed charge, Eunius reacted, but as Rudel had completely abandoned defense to close in, he was only able to block.

In the next instant, Rudel's wood sword had destroyed Eunius'. In that moment, he had put in an explosive amount of mana, aiming to destroy Eunius' weapon.

"So you aimed for it, Rudel!"

Eunius tossed aside the broken sword hilt, but Rudel's hands still gripped a wood sword. As he constantly changed the output of his sword, Rudel's blade was still going strong.

Seeing how he didn't use his high-speed movement again, Eunius could tell Rudel was also near his limit. At the sword Rudel lowered to end the match, Eunius clad his left hand in magic, putting everything he had into blocking it.

He endured the blow that, if played poorly, would likely have cost him his arm.

From Eunius' left arm came the sound of bones breaking. But Rudel's wooden sword was destroyed. In that moment of Rudel's surprise, Eunius hammered in a roundhouse kick with all his might.

Rudel leapt to soften the blow, but unable to kill the momentum, he flew and tumbled across the ring before rolling to regain his posture.



Seeing the two of them grow tattered, laughing as they faced one another, the audience raised cheers. What was truly a battle that surpassed their imaginations now unraveled before them.

At the same time, Luecke was busily ordering around his shield knights to maintain the barrier. It was fine for now, but when Eunius' magic sword snapped, they confronted a crisis where the barrier might break with it.

Sweat running down his forehead, Luecke kept a careful watch on their actions.

Lena also watched the match in seriousness.

After Izumi spotted Millia coming out of the waiting room, she got Vargas' permission to use the reserved front row and invited her.

When she appeared in the spectators' seats, the fact that everyone seemed to shout blessing for her was surely Aleist's fault.

With Basyle sitting between them, Izumi and Millia watched the match.

"Even so, Rudel-sama sure has gotten strong."

As Basyle spoke in a nostalgic tone, Izumi nodded as well. In the academy, Izumi was the one who had watched him most closely.

The Rudel who made a mortified face in his first year, and the Rudel who didn't give up in his second year. And now the Rudel who had obtained the dragon of his dreams was before them.

"... He's been working hard all the way."

As Izumi thought back over the past five years, there was weight in the words that came from her mouth. When Rudel constantly lived his life at full force, watching him from his side truly made it look dangerous.

In truth, when he tried to obtain a dragon, he did almost lose his life.

Izumi knew that side of Rudel, and after glaring at her profile, Milla turned her eyes to look at Rudel. She knew. That Rudel had never been conscious of her.

Even now, there were times she wished their first encounter had been something a bit more decent. If only she had a bit more courage... sad as it was, Millia had finally broken away from Rudel. To move on, she had decided in her heart.



Rudel and Eunius' match had turned to a grappling match.

Rudel wanted to use magic and attack from a distance, but his mana was close to its limit. As if neither competitor cared the slightest for their next match, they exchanged blows with all their might.

The techniques they boasted only made the match all the more ill in nature.

When it came to fighting styles, Rudel's was generally dirty. He threw sand into an opponent's eyes as if it was ingrained into his body. Avoiding that and fighting him down with proper hand-to-hand combat, Eunius fought while ignoring the fracture on his left hand.

"Oy, Rudel! You won't use that technique you showed me before!? Get a bit serious, why don't you!!"

Blessed with physique, you could also say that alone would let him defeat Rudel. Yet being able to contest with him, Rudel was also a monster. Both sides let off attacks that made their mana-strengthened bodies creak, and they endured.

"If that's what you want!"

Jumping back, Rudel activated his high-speed movement. In the space of an instant, he leapt into Runius' breast, toughting both hands to his chest, and firing his magic with all his might.

Qigong... when she heard of such a thing from Izumi, Rudel had worked on his own to recreate it with Mana. Its level of completion had risen much higher than when he unleashed it on Fritz a few years back.

The impact pierced through Eunius' chest, its effects even felt on the wall behind him. On that intense impact, the barrier warped for a moment. It showed its fault of being weak to an unanticipated attack.

But Eunius laughed as he smacked Rudel away. Rudel rolled across the Ring again before standing with a perplexed look on his face.

"That's all you've got? The one before it got me worse..."

His outer wear that received the attack was already torn up, but Eunius' upper body was completely uninjured. It seems the magic sword he lowered on him before was a greater threat.

As a countermeasure against Rudel, Eunius chose to endure the threat he saw in the attack against Fritz... he decided to try enduring. It was a simple application of brute force, the moment he received the attack, he would guard with all his might. That's all there was to it, but as he was producing an explosive power to defend, the timing was important.

Rudel's shockwave that required accumulated force was no longer a threat to Eunius.

He cast off his tattered garments, cast them off and took a stance. It was definitely an attack he had held back on. Since he raised the output, Rudel thought it would inflict a serious injury.

But it did seem that wasn't enough for his friend before his eyes... Rudel took his own stance, and perhaps delighted, he gave a smile.

As both sides exchanged fearsome smiles, they stepped in simultaneously, meeting in an intense clash.



"Oh, how amazing. (Master's crazzy. And wait... how does he plan on beating Eunius? How does he intend to conquer that muscle idiot? It can't be an upset where Eunius will be the one fighting Aleist, right? But when he's so tattered, I get the feeling it won't even be a match.)"

The scene Fina saw from the noble visitor room was a battle heated enough to make one clench their fists until they were covered in sweat. But perhaps Fina herself wasn't interested as she thought over who would come out on top.

As things stood, compared to Rudel and Eunius, a fight where warriors of similar strength clashed, Aleist's next opponent was Fritz.

In the semi-finals, they predicted that Aleist would win. Perhaps those around were thinking similar things, as Sophina made a conflicted face.

"Sophina, who do you think will win the tournament?"

"... Aleist-sama, perhaps."

As Sophina muttered, Cattleya and Lilim beside her nodded. In the case that Eunius won, his left arm was already broken. If Rudel won, he was already out of gas. From the destroyed state of the ring, it would take some time to

repair. So the problem would be how much of his stamina and mana he could recover in that time.

In contrast, Aleist showed leisure in his first match, and his next one was against Fritz. Speaking to ability, it was difficult to see Aleist losing that one.

The man himself had confessed before so many spectators, and was no regretting it in the waiting room. His face bright red, he was rolling around from the sheer embarrassment.

Cattleya touched her hand to her chin, thinking as she tried to say something, when a voice called over to Fina. It was her older sister Aileen, who had birthed some interest in Fina's conversation.

"Oh my, so you've already decided the victor of the next match? This match hasn't even ended yet."

Aileen was smiling, but she was letting off an intimidating air that went beyond her expression. She couldn't forgive the fact that Fina's group had decided on Fritz' loss.

As she looked over the three knights, perhaps it was the first time Aileen took them to mind, as her eyes grew sharp for an instant.

Meanwhile, Fina was delighted her plan had worked out.

(Whooh! With this, I've dropped the probability Sophina and the two dragoons will head over to my sister's faction!! I'll whittle them away bit by bit!!)

Fina had kept the two dragoons in want of fluff replenishment, but on these harvests beyond her expectations, she declared this match viewing session a success.



The match where both sides lacked a deciding blow was finally coming down to brute strength.

If Rudel attack with versatility, Eunius would bet on a single blow and swing around his fists. The top of the ring had been destroyed, making for terrible footing.

It was fine if they continued exchanging punches, but it was about time for them to decide the match.

As both sides leapt back to take distance, they got their breathing in order.

"Eunius, I'll decide it with the next one."

"Oh, what a coincidence... I'll also be deciding it here. Regrettable as it is, I do have my next match ahead of me."

Both believed in their victory without any doubt. They had not the slightest thought of loss. But there could only be one victor. Even if it was difficult, Eunius held the advantage on a defensive front. He was able to endure Rudel's blows.

As Rudel stepped in first, Eunius prioritized his offense over defense. Rudel plunged himself straight forward, and he intended to greet him with his strongest blow.

He channeled magic into his fist, magic with exceedingly high destructive capabilities. Where he lowered his fist, Rudel had definitely been there, but he dodged at a paper-thin margin. In the next instant, Eunius braced his body to endure, but Rudel laughed.

"That's no good, Eunius. That's where you should attack."

Grabbing that lowered arm, Rudel performed a shoulder throw on Eunius. Flying through the air, Eunius tried to roll as he slammed into the floor. But the moment he rolled, he noticed his defeat.

"Rudel!"

Sending himself into the air with wind magic, Rudel did a rapid descent straight into Eunius. By the time he noticed it, Rudel's kick was already ready to pierce him through. Unable to dodge it, Eunius was only able to endure.

As Rudel fired that piercing kick, he put all his body's weight into his foot, and with magic... he accelerated further to pierce through Eunius' defenses.

With nowhere to run, Eunius took the brunt of Rudel's full force, cracks spreading across the entirety of the ring.

Yet Eunius managed to endure the attack that exceeded all his expectations. As a price for enduring, he was left out of mana. An intense pain assailed his body and he was unable to even stand.

He suddenly recalled the form of Luecke standing even when he was out of mana.

(That bastard, so he endured this pain... I've got to praise him a bit for that... more importantly, I have to stand soon and get in stance. Otherwise, I'll lose.)

Eunius somehow managed to keep his consciousness from fading, but as the referee's voice declared Rudel's victory, he faded away with a smile. He had given it his all and lost. He made a satisfied face.

The arena was rocked by an enormous cheer.



Eunius was hurriedly rushed to the infirmary, while Rudel received first aid in his waiting room.

As he had a match ahead of him, Rudel had to prepare for his next fight. He couldn't quite forfeit before the king.

But it would take some time for the ring to be repaired, and Rudel had bought some valuable time. Watching the ring's repairs from their audience

seats, Izumi and the others worried for Rudel.

Millia felt the disadvantage of the finals, and opened her mouth in anxiety.

"At this rate, it really will be bad. Rudel's almost out of mana, while Aleist might be able to win his way there unscathed."

Basyle stroked her enlarged stomach as she thought.

(No, you could have just put in a bit of effort. It's your fault he got here unharmed to begin with, right?)

Supporting her former employer Rudel, Basyle gazed over the swift ring repairs being carried out through magic. The way things were going, the matches would resume in less than an hour.

There had already been a break, and around, the spectators who had used the school cafeteria were beginning to return. The cafeteria was unable to accommodate all of them, so the audience was divided up. The three of them had finished their lunch first, so they were killing time in their audience seats.

"H-he definitely does have a disadvantage, but Rudel has always overturned disadvantageous situations. So I'm sure he'll be fine this time."

Iaumi answered Millia as if to get herself to believe, but it was clear Rudel was at a disadvantage after a close-combat match with Eunius.

Basyle understood Izumi's feelings, but this time it was a terrible matchup. She knew the black knight was undoubtedly skilled, and she wondered how long Rudel would be able to put up a fight.

The black knight Aleist had become somewhat descent. Expecting that he wouldn't end a match in an instant before the king's eyes, she hoped both sides would fight a good fight...

But Bastle's hopes were splendidly betrayed.



As Aleist and Fritz stepped up to the mended ring, apart from the cheers, some separate jeers echoed through the arena.

Over his match with Millia, Aleist was being teased. He tried his best to concentrate on the match, focusing his attention on his opponent before his eyes.

"But before the match began, Frits opened his mouth."

"Good grief, this is why you laid-back nobles are no good. When you're at a match the royal eyes are gathered to see, to show off such a farce..."

"Ah?"

Even Aleist didn't want to be told that by the man before his eyes. His tone grew gruff. You put on a production of your own farce just a few years ago, didn't you!? He somehow managed to swallow the words.

"It's laughable to think they'll call a knight like you the black knight. I heard it was a revelation from a goddess, but that goddess must have had knotholes for eyes."

"..."

"Combatant, speak with moderation! Now let the match commence!"

As the referee declared the match's start, Fritz took a stance with his wooden sword. Ever since he was defeated by Rudel, Aileen had hired him a personal tutor for swordplay and the martial arts.

His placement in the individuals' tournament was something he crawled up to through ability, and he had some confidence in his current self.

But just as the referee declared the start, Fritz' consciousness was blown away. The last thing he saw was the bottom of Aleist's shoe.

Just as the match started, Aleist had visited Fritz' face with a well-placed drop-kick. The kick from the needlessly high-speck Aleist instantly had Fritz flying out the hall.

"Try saying that one more time! I'll have you seeing stars again!!"

Blown off the rung, Fritz was already unconscious. Having truly ended the match in seconds, Aleist suddenly recalled his next match was with Rudel.

And the fact he planned to extend this match as long as possible... the spectators were the same, but the royal family watching from their private room were surprised by Aleist's actions as well.

"V-victor, Aleist Hardie!"

Ignoring his victory declaration, Aleist rushed over to Fritz, grabbing his lapels in both hands and shaking him back and forth. With Sakuya mocked, he had- against his better judgement- put in a serious kick. Aleist desperately tried to wake Fritz up.

"W-wake up, Fritz! We won't be able to buy time like this, dammit!!"

"Cease and deist! We do not accept any attacks against the defeated party."

As Aleist violently shook Fritz back and forth, the ref and those in charge frantically restrained him.

Chapter 87

"I definitely won't accept this!"

In the noble visitor room, Aileen judged the contents of the match between Aleist and Fritz with a rough voice. Her father, the king, let out a sigh, while her mother disinterestedly told her there was no problem with the match.

"Don't accept what? The black knight simply moved right after the match commenced... I never thought I'd ever be forced to bear witness to such an unsightly match, but the victor is the black knight. Aileen, are you certain your eyes aren't the problem?"

The queen had grown excited during Rudel's match with Eunius, but the instant defeat in the following match had dampened her spirits. It was clear Rudel had an even greater disadvantage against Aleist than he had in the last time they faced off in the finals.

With Aleist's abilities, the queen doubted he would lose. Meaning she already saw the result of the final match. That's precisely why she held some light expectations of the fight between Aleist and Fritz. If Fritz persisted here, then small as it was, she hoped a chance for Rudel would be born in the finals.

"Mother!"

"Lay off, both of you. More importantly, it's almost the finals. Headmaster, I wish to put in a slight intermission."

"Understood. There shall be a break before the finals."

On the king's orders, the headmaster informed the staff waiting outside the door that there would be an intermission. The king had shown Rudel a courtesy before the finals. Aleist also declared he wanted to buy time, she had afforded him some extra.

As Aileen rushed out of the visitor room, some knights of the royal guard followed behind. Fina looked at the doorway her sister had left before whispering into Sophina's ear.

The queen folded her fan, let out a sigh, and ordered the royal guard to bring Aileen back.

"... Drag her back here before the finals. Good grief, why did she grow up to be that sort of child?"

On her mother's complaint, Fina turned only her eyes to see her as she screamed in her heard.

(On the contrary, I'd like to know how you managed to raise two princesses this terrible!! Father, you say something to mother, you don't have to hold it back... it's your education that's to blame, those are the words you're looking for!)

Leaving her own matters on the shelf, Fina, had been laughing internally for a while at that last match, and her mother's words only stimulated her funny bone further. If she had any expression, she would surely be tearing up as she laughed and rolled around.

(More importantly, Fritz is damn weaaak!! Getting instakilled like that, are you trying to kill me with laughter? I guess I really can't look down on Fritz!!)



In a dimly-lit passage of the arena, Aileen grabbed one of the academy's staff and asked for Fritz' location. But once she learned that Fritz was bedridden in his waiting room, she issued that staff member an order.

"What? ... You want them to use real swords?"

Receiving that order from Aileen, the staff member's mouth opened in surprise.

"It's their final match, right? For both the black and white knights, it will be troublesome if we don't have them fight to their fullest... you heard me, I did give the order."

After saying only what she wanted, Aileen raced over to Fritz. If they used real swords in Rudel's match with Eunius, then surely neither side would have gotten off lightly. The white and black knights just need to crush one another, Aileen suddenly hit upon the idea and made an order of it.

The fact the staff member she grabbed held a considerably high station was part of Aileen's good fortune. It was almost as if anything would be granted if she wished it... all of Aileen's actions were being protected by some larger force.

Hearing that exchange from start to finish, Sophina waited for Aileen to leave before grabbing that staff member and carrying out Fina's orders.

Fina had ordered her to keep watch on her sister, Princess Aileen's actions, and Sophina never thought anything would come of it, but after seeing Aileen's conduct, she determined this was going too far.

Taking that staff member alone, Sophina made for the noble visitor room.



Holding his face as he left his waiting room, Fritz thought back over his hazy memories.

Right after he heard a voice signaling the start of the match, he had lost consciousness. Thinking that Aleist had worked some injustice, he left the waiting room he had been put to sleep in with the intent to put up a protest. Pushing aside the defender guards posted in front of his door, Fritz proceeded down the corridor.

His injuries themselves were nothing major, he was barely hurt. From before the match began, he had been strengthening his body with mana, so it didn't reach anything serious.

With unsteady feet, he walked down the passage to grasp some staff member or another. But there, he ran into Lena, who had left her seat during the intermission.

"Ah, it's the guy who got instakilled."

On Lena's words, Fritz' anger welled up.

"Wrong! That Aleist guy used some cowardly means to..."

Shaking her head, Lena told Fritz everything she had seen. After he provoked Aleist, Aleist got pissed and fired a kick right after the match began... she explained that's all there was to it.

There was no injustice, and it was a fair judgment.

"...! There's no way that's true. Rather, those clothes... you must be a noble."

"? Yaaaah, I guess you could call me a noble."

Looking over the clothes Lena words, Fritz determined she was a noble. But in this dark corridor, determining someone was a noble just by looking at their clothes was impossible. Fritz had convinced himself that the girl who denied him must be a noble.

"What house!?"

"Eh? Arses."

"Hah, it's as I thought. You're tied to the worst house of all. You and Rudel, and Chlust who dropped out, you're all the same! Tormenting your people, you filthy nobles who sit back and drink the good stuff!!"

As Lena's eyes turned serious, Fritz was put on guard. Taking a stance against a younger girl was quite unadult-like of him. But even before Fritz, Lena remained at ease.

"Hey, do you think a person's name decides everything about them?"

"... What are you trying to say? And you're a person of the Arses House. A lineage of trash! Like hell you could understand the pains you put me through!"

Fritz hailed from Arses Territory, he had been tormented by Arses rule. Lena had heard of the territory's circumstances from her elder brother Rudel. She also knew her house was hated.

But while she pitied him, Lena could tell by instinct that the one the man before his eyes was rejecting was himself. Just knowing that made her have to open her mouth.

She had gained a rough idea of Fritz from Luecke. The world at large recognized him as a commoner man taken in by the princess. Hated by the nobles, the commoners treating him as their shining star of hope.

Hearing those words of justice Fritz lined up, Lena saw through what Fritz desired. For the poor, for the commoners... the true feelings of Fritz who would say it was for someone else's sake...

"It seems you intend to use everything around you to make some sort of hero of yourself, but I'm sure you'll never be a hero."

"W-what are you saying. There's no way I could be a..."

"It's an amazing thing to work hard for another. But you're not suited to be a hero. If you don't start looking around some more, I'm sure you'll come to regret it."

It was almost as if Lena had seen into the depths of his hearts even he didn't know about, and Fritz felt fear. Still in his stance, he took a step back, a doubt born in his mind about the greater good he was about to put to mouth.

"F-for the sake of the suffering people, I..."

As Fritz wavered, Lena tried to call out. There, from the other side of the passage came the group led by the princess. As Fritz turned to the footsteps, he turned back only one to look at Lena's face. Light was pouring in from the entrance to the passage from the audience, and it looked almost as if Lena was bathed in the light. But of his own accord, Fritz made for Aileen in the dark corridor depths.

"Are you alright, Fritz-sama?"

"Yeah, sorry. I lost."

Reaching Aileen, Fritz turned again, but Lena was already gone. He felt as if he had seen a dream, and was sure it was because his head wasn't yet clear.

"... It's alright. The black knight who smeared you with shame shall definitely be..."

Pretending he didn't hear Aileen's words, Fritz let her lead him as he proceeded down into the darkness.



The final match was the battle between white and black knight mostly everyone had been expecting.

In the audience, Eunius- who had fled as soon as his treatment was over- sat alongside a nurse. The doctors already knew he would run away, so he ordered the nurse to accompany him when he did.

As both sides climbed up to the ring, cheers rose through the arena again. As expected of the finals, more spectators let themselves be heard than in the first match.

Such was the finals, but Eunius' eyes were drawn towards a certain something. Atop the ring, a wide variety of weapons had been prepared.

"Oy, don't screw with me..."

Luecke agreed with Eunius' surprise.

"Yeah, this is madness. If they let Rudel and Aleist hold weapons, in the worst case, one of them might die..."

Luecke criticized the academy's decision in using weapons during the finals, but it was there Eunius' opinion differed.

"They didn't bring them out for me! Even if it's dulled, as long as it's iron, I would've been able to keep it a contest of swordplay to the end..."

Seeing Eunius truly vexed, Luecke made an incomprehensive face. There, Lena returned from her break and reunited with them.

"Huh? Why's Eunius-san here? He's holding his head, but is he alright?"

Those around could only feel fed up as Eunius showed serious envy for Aleist. Having real swords in a match was nothing but a hazard.

As Izumi stared at Rudel in worry, the referee loudly declared the special rules of the finals.

'As a special exception, the use of dulled weapons is permitted in this final round. But this is something entrusted to the competitors, and it is not an obligation...'

It seems they were leaving it up to Rudel and Aleist's wills, but Izumi and Basyle had a bad feeling about this. Millia thought they wouldn't take up dangerous weapons if it was left up to the competitors.

But they were dealing with Rudel. After hearing that explanation, he delightfully sent into choosing a weapon. As if lured in, Aleist also selected a weapon.

"H-hey, wait, are they idiots!? Even if they're dulled, if they attack each other with lumps of iron, it wouldn't be strange if one of them fell dead!"

Millia stood from her seat and cried out, but Izumi and Basyle simply sighed, their expectations on the mark. As expected of my big brother, Lena sent some eyes of admiration.

As Millia cried out, Eunius with bandages wrapped all over his body gave a careful explanation.

"It's not really a problem. And that Rudel, he can already split rocks with a wooden sword, you know. He was seriously cutting at me and all, and if they're using iron, perhaps it won't break into a fist fight this time. Hah, how envious."

"Good grief, I cannot understand the actions of you muscle heads."

Luecke made a tired face, but he didn't even show the slightest intent to stop them. More than that, he was looking at Lena's delight. Millia seriously held her head, wondering if she was the strange one.

But once Eunius saw Aleist pick out two swords, he stood and cried out. Luecke's expression was also filling with anger.

"That idiot!!"



"Alright, I'm going with this sword and shield."

"Eh? You've already decided... then I'll go with this sword... and this one too."

As Rudel picked out a sword and a shield, Aleist took out two swords. Truth be told he had only ever played around with a two sword style, but he remembered how the documents said the black knight used two swords.

Without any particular meaning, he took a two sworded stance.

"... Aleist, you can use two swords?"

"Perhaps. Did you always carry a shield?"

Rudel had received a shield from the boar, so he had studied how to use one. He was still immature, but he could use it considerably well. But Aleist had chosen his weapons to satisfy his curiosity.

His curiosity and the debt he felt to Rudel made him take up two swords. He could tell there were bandages wrapped under his clothing, and there was no saying how far his mana had recovered. If only I'd bought a bit more time, Aleist thought as he chose a style where he couldn't go all out.

"... No, you can do what you want. It's nothing for me to stick my mouth into."

Shaking his head, Rudel took his weapon and headed for the center of the ring. Aleist also took his two blades and made for the center.

The two faced one another, but seeing Aleist's expression wasn't the best, Rudel called over.

"What's wrong? Are you unsatisfied with me as your opponent?"

"N-no... but this feels too cowardly or how should I put it... if only I bought you a bit more time..."

Unlike Rudel, beaten all over his body, Aleist's condition was close to perfect. If they were to face each other like this, the outcome was clear... Aleist didn't want to fight like this.

"You were mindful of that? Then I hope you'll let me have my say. Aleist, keeping the king waiting is disrespectful. You don't need to buy time."

"B-but there's no way you'd accept it!"

"Accept? Of course I will. I'm more thankful than anything. I was blessed with an opportunity to fight Izumi, and I fought Eunius with all my might. And finally, I get to fight you. What part am I to complain about? I'd be more saddened if you didn't go all out."

As Rudel said that with an innocent smile, Aleist gave a dry laugh. He chucked the sword in his left hand outside of the ring.

"I don't have to hold back, right?"

"Aleist, I think there's something wrong about holding back before royalty."

Aleist's eyes turned serious as he took a stance with his dulled sword. Rudel pointed the left half of his body forwards, taking a stance with his shield at the front.

"Henceforth, the finals shall commence!!"

Right after he gave the signal, the referee fled the ring at full speed. After leaving the ring, he collected the sword that had been cast aside before watching over the match from a safe distance.

Right after the starting signal, Rudel and Aleist stepped in, their weapons shedding sparks as they met in a violent clash.

The finals had begun, and the two of them were unveiling a match to surpass the story.

Chapter 88

The intense clash of shield and sword, the sparks scattered affording the arena a tension it hadn't felt in any of the matches to come before.

Though imperfect, the iron weapons gave off different impressions than the wood swords. The sound and sparks they produced whenever they met, and the screams that started coming in from the audience.

After finishing their practice exercise to test out that different sensation, both sides took distance at once. Those swords had been dulled, but after they had met so many times, the chipping gave them saw-like edges. Aleist's sword was in an especially terrible state.

In the single portion of the ring they had fought, the scars of their slashes remained.

Wiping the sweat off his face with the sleeve of his left arm, Aleist regripped his sword. Even now, he showed Rudel a joking leisure, but even if they were dulled blades, the man himself wasn't used to the sensation of being assailed by metal.

"You've gotten quite good at using your shield. Did you really just start last year?"

"No, I had been learning the shield from the start. I thought I'd never have the chance to use one, so I stopped part-way... but the boar prepared me a shield, see?"

"The boar, you mean... well, I did hear this and that."

Aleist had heard Rudel's armor had been made with the boar's tusk, and he heard that after that, the boar himself had changed shape for Rudel. His

uncouth armor, thanks to the boar, had become something worthy of the white dragoon...

"Ah, by the way, both my eyes are the bird's magic eyes."

"What's that, I want it!"

Once they finished their jest, Rudel held out his left hand and fired magic. While he meant it as a diversion, a number of fireballs that wouldn't leave on in any healthy state flew at a high velocity.

Aleist avoided them all with his enhanced gait. As those fireballs hit the wall, they raised grand explosions, but the barrier was still maintained.

Hit by the blast wind from behind, Aleist's stance was put off just a bit, and Rudel used that opportunity to move at once. Conducting high-speed movement with wind magic, he rushed right at Aleist.

But Aleist was the black knight. Dark matter in the shape of spears extended from his shadows, sealing off Rudel's movement.

From Aleist's left hand as well, he used his mana pool that could be called bottomless to fire a none-too-frugal stream of magic. Rudel had to economize his mana, but Aleist had an inexhaustible supply, eliminating the need entirely. In his five years at the academy, Aleist had grown as well.

While he fell short of Rudel and Luecke, he excelled in the use of magic.

For the masses of intermediate magic coming at him, Rudel activated the shield on his left hand to manifest his shield of light and block them all. But a mid-range battle of magic put Rudel at a disadvantage. Short on mana, a decisive confrontation was most desirable.

Aleist would win out in a battle of attrition.

"Good grief, in the past, I would've used advanced magic here to make an opening!"

Rudel entered high-speed movement again, and Aleist used his shadow to manifest spears around him. For in Rudel's approach, the spears in his path would be destroyed.

As he thought, the spears on Aleist's left side were destroyed by Rudel, and shattered, the spears dissolved before fading away in the end. But the moment he readied himself, the spears stopped breaking, and Aleist lost sight of Rudel.



In the noble visitor room, Cattleya and Lilim could just barely follow Rudel with their eyes. Sophina was confused by that unfamiliar fighting style.

It was called an indispensable skill for a dragoon, but it was supposed to be an emergency magic one used when they fell off their dragon.

As Lilim had her elven wings, she hadn't even learned the techniques. Perhaps you could call it a magic to fly through the sky singlehandedly; by compressing and exploding wind one could change direction and soften falls, or so they had learned. Taking those factors into account, it really was unnecessary for an elf.

But seeing Rudel use the essentials of that technique before their eyes, they couldn't bring themselves to call it an emergency measure.

Seeing the surprise of those three, Fina's interest was piqued. She posed the question.

"What sort of magic is that?"

Sophina shook her head unknowingly, so she directed her eyes to the two dragons standing beside her. Cattleya to Sophina's side gave a simple explanation.

"... It's similar to a magic that's been called a dragoon's essentials. It's an emergency magic, but I've never heard of it being used like that."

As Lilim nodded as well, Fina thought back to Marty's dragon. She remembered that Rudel had learned techniques apart from petting, but it wasn't Fina's duty to remember any non-petting skill in detail.

"Is it the magic he was practicing back then? (Even so master ain't human)."

"Back then?"

Lilim bit onto Fina's words. The dragoons hadn't been informed of the events that transpired in the dragons' dwellings.

"Come to think of it, he was practicing something over the lake."

Sophina recalled the scene of Rudel's practice, but she never thought she would be seeing the fruits of that training before her eyes.

"Yes, thinking back on it now, that was quite a fun trip, Sophina... (Oh, the eyes of the two dragoons grew sharp! Now I just have to remind Sophina of... well, I guess now's not a good time.)"

Even Fina showed prudence, but Sophina's face hung face had already turned red. On that reaction, for every adult that understood something happened, there were some who would misunderstand.

"... Hey, duty shirking high knight, what happened?"

On Cattleya's cold words, Lilim joined in as well.

"I'd definitely like to hear. If the princess was present, then wouldn't this be a serious affair?"

"W-what are you talking about! There was nothing indecent! Just some lotion and massages..."

They were unfamiliar words, but Lilim immediately understood it related to Rudel's petting. Turning her eyes to Rudel on the ring, she felt dread at the knowledge he had obtained yet another mysterious technique

But Cattleya alone was different. Next to her excited senpai, she breathed a sigh as some unfamiliar words came out again.

"You mean to say there's something even stronger than lotion!?"

"No, senpai... by massage, do you mean shoulder rubbing or something? No matter how you look at it, you're getting too worked up."

Cattley still made light of Rudel's petting. While Fina looked at her in intrigue, inside she looked down on her. She has yet to understand.

Being accused of shirking work, Sophina looked at Cattleya, certain that she didn't understand the terror of Rudel. Directing a meaningful smile, she offered a warning.

"Cattleya, you shall experience it someday... and there's no going back."

"That's right, Cattleya, you'll see a world you've never even dreamed up."

Even Lilim joined Sophina, making a similar smile full of meaning. Fina was also looked at Cattleya, and receiving those three stares, Cattleya mulled again.

(S-seriously, what is this!!?)



By the time Aleist caught sight of Rudel again, a shield of light had manifested above him.

Using a shield to crush Aleist from above was the plan Rudel thought up. Putting his spears back into his shadow, Aleist made a large amount of arms protrude from it.

Those black arms that extended to restrain Rudel's giant shield disappeared as they touched it as if melting away from heat.

"This is a bit...!"

Aleist wanted to flee from the spot, but his left hand was held out to control his mana. If he moved, his control would become difficult, and he'd be crushed too easily.

He produced hand after hand to resist, lowering the speed of the rapid-falling shield. On the contrary, Aleist slowly attained the force to push it back, but against Rudel, he had ended up using too much of his power as a black knight.

A black magic flowed through his body, trying to take over his head again.

Rudel on the other side of the shield was the same. A radiant mana overflowing, just like the year before, he felt something was taking over his mind to defeat the black knight... to defeat Aleist.

"This again..."

Erasing his shield, Rudel moved to the end of the ring. Aleist emitted a large flow of mana as he writhed in pain.

The powers of these two had yet to be fully understood, but their sheer magnitudes made them difficult to control.

Rudel closed his eyes, directing his consciousness towards the power in his chest. An existence trying to squeeze his power out was entreating him to defeat the black knight before his eyes.

For just an instant, Sakuya's words revived in his head. The face of the goddess who told him to be the strongest... there was no way he could show her that shameful form again, Rudel decided in his heart.

Opening his eyes, Rudel shouted from the bottom of his heart. Forcefully mustering up his willpower, Rudel subdued the strength of the white knight.

"If you're my power, then shut up and obey me!!!"

The overflowing mana emitting from his body stopped, and this time, as if to cover him, a line of light floated a few centimeters from his body.

An armor of white symbols formed to cover Rudel's body. Before his eyes, Aleist fell to his knees and held his head in pain.

And to Aleist, Rudel called out.



Taken in by the darkness, Aleist was unable to use his willpower to subdue the black knight as Rudel had.

His heart gradually eaten into, Aleist was brought back to memories of a distant past.

'What are you looking at, trash.'

'He should just die already.'

'Hah? Confessing? Are you making fun of me? Stop it, you're making me laugh.'

"Hah, hah, stop it already."

The memories before Aleist was born as Aleist, they were coming back vividly. The wounds of his heart he had forgotten called back a pain of old.

The memories from when he thought someone like him was unnecessary ate into Aleist.

"Yeah, that's right. It's because I reincarnated into this world that the story went awry. If only I wasn't there..."

As Aleist shed tears and denied himself, a black shadow was approaching his back. To swallow Aleist whole, the shadow opened its large mouth, but there he heard Rudel's voice.

'What are you doing, Aleist!? You plan to abandon your match with me!?'

The shadow on Aleist's back, before the power of the white light shedding light into Aleist's heart, it faded away. But even now, Aleist couldn't stand.

"B-but..."

'Very well! If you're not getting up, I'll just have to smack you awake.'

"Eh?"

In the next instant, Aleist was sent flying, forcefully dragging him back to reality. Even now, his body let off a black mana, but his mind alone was brought back to the world. Through his forceful awakening, he felt as if he was still seeing a dream.

The jeers he received in his past life were still ringing through his ears.

'I really don't want to be in the same class as him.'

'Having no friends? Isn't he done-for as a human?'

'When he's just a disgusting otaku...'

As Aleist clutched his chest in pain, Rudel standing before his eyes seemed radiant. He was letting off light, and besides a physical light, Rudel's unwavering way of life was blinding.

As Aleist lay face up on the ring, he began giving up. He would never win. Swallowed by the power of the black knight, the weakness of his own heart was turning on him.

But from around came cheers for Aleist.

"Stand up, Aleist! Are you alright, losing like that!?"

"Millia's watching you know!"

"Show Rudel how strong you are!"

The voices of his friends. Having obtained the first existences he could ever call friends after coming to the academy, Aleist raised his torso.

"Aleist-sama, you can still stand, can't you!"

"If you're a knight, then stand! And you call yourself the black knight!?"

"Aleist, don't lose to Rudel!"

"D-do your best, senpai!"

"If it's you, Aleist-san, I'm sure you can win!"

Next, Aleist's harem members raised their voices. Despite the bitter smile on his face, Aleist extended his hand to his knees, readying himself to stand.

He suddenly recalled the face of a girl he admired in the past. Like Aleist, she was a girl who didn't fit in with her surroundings. He remembered talking to her a few times, and he remembered she had never made fun of him.

(I see, so Millia resembled her...)

By vividly recalling what had grown hazy, Aleist was able to know why he had fallen for Millia.

(How pitiful... dragging on the past for twenty whole years...)

Once again, Aleist heard the jeers stabbing into his heart, but he ignored them all. He turned his ears to the voices of the reality.

He stopped emitting his black mana, and just like Rudel, a black, lightly-glowing insignia covered his body. As he stood, his form was a color swap of Rudel's.

If Rudel was light, then Aleist was shadow... it was a scene that made it look like that.

"You're finally up, Aleist."

"I'm sorry, I took some time... you hit me too hard."

"We're in the middle of a match. You should think of it as my mercy that I didn't land the final blow."

"Yeah, that's right. Then we'll have to go all out from now on."

"Don't be stupid! I was going all out from the start!!"

The two of them faced each other once more, readying their weapons.



With the destructive power that increased as the match carried on, Luecke was troubled to respond.

The barrier's application was still experimental. As Rudel and Aleist suddenly increased in output, Luecke was desperately trying to endure it.

Otherwise, the arena would have already been destroyed.

"Young master, this is bad! The men need some rest!"

"Don't call me that, Vargas! More importantly, we're changing formation. Hurry and gather personnel at the indicated points!"

Opposing the two trying to destroy the barrier, Luecke put all his might to maintaining it. While he didn't have a match, maintaining the barrier through all matches put a considerable burden on Luecke.

While he definitely wanted to show the competence of the Halbades House, more than that, Luecke wanted to prepare a place for his friends to fight.

To grant his friends' wishes, Luecke had taken on a role that few would evaluate. Looking at Luecke from the side, Lena offered a proposal.

"Luecke-san, Luecke-san."

"W-what?"

Luecke was too busy to deal with her, and as he let off a colder air than usual, Lena pointed at the barrier's roof.



Gaining control of their white and black knight powers and using them, the intensity of their battle increased.

In contrast to the several hundred black snakes Aleist called from his shadow, Rudel put out his shield of light to contain them. If the two grew close enough, the swords in their hands or their fists would fly, and Aleist would get in a kick.

Atop the ring where they had given up on long-range combat, the match had already grown impossible to follow. Aleist's black shadow and Rudel's radiant light got in the way, and the spectators couldn't see what was going on.

Rudel closed in and smacked his shield into Aleist. His right-hand sword was coiled by a snake, and he couldn't use it. Aleist had been hit around by the shield a few times now, and after redirecting it with the hilt of his sword to soften the impact, he visited Rudel with a kick.

As that show kick entered Rudel's stomach, he made a slight expression of anguish. But Rudel unhanded his right hand's sword, hammering his fist into Aleist.

As Aleist flew, Rudel followed at a high speed. But a large number of snakes wrapped around Rudel's body, getting in the way of his movement.

He emitted mana from his body to brush away the snakes, but by that time, Aleist had recovered his stance. A black lightning took residence in Aleist's sword, forming a magic sword.

"This lightning magic sword was always the most troublesome one."

Taking a stance with his sword, Aleist was sure that metal would be able to endure more than wood. From the start, his output was at the maximum.

In contrast, Rudel had light in his shield, and around him, he made a great many more shields. The magic sword imbued with the magic of lightning destroyed a number of shields with just a touch.

On top of that, Rudel who had been enhancing his body with magic, felt a numbness in his body.

"That one was your specialty. I never thought you'd polish it to such an extent."

Perhaps because Aleist was concentrating, the snakes and spears returned to his shadows. Rudel avoided Aleist's attack as he picked up his own fallen sword.

As light filled Rudel's sword, it took the form of a magic sword. But this time, it was clad in a pale flame. As the sword clad in flames that had a light tint of blue met with Aleist's sword, Rudel felt numb, while Aleist took some distance, surprised by the heat.

"Hot!"

As Aleist jumped back, he protruded spears from his shadow. Among them, a few arms were mixed in to capture Rudel.

All of them were burned away by a swing of Rudel's sword.

"Haha, you really are inhuman, Rudel."

"And you're quite the rude one. I'm sorry to betray your expectations, but I'm human."

Both were reaching their bodies limits, their symbols on the verge of fading away. Rough in breath, they looked as if they'd collapse at any moment, but they were laughing.

Rudel compressed his magic sword, a sword of blinding light manifesting in his right hand, and in his left a similar shield manifested. What was once a simple mass of iron now let off a divine light.

Aleist also sublimated his sword. He could have just waited for Rudel to run out of gas, but that was something Aleist himself couldn't accept. He was up against a foe he needed to meet head-on and attain victory.

"Rudel, I always wanted someone to recognize me. But for you alone, I'll force you to recognize me!!"

On Aleist's words as he stepped in, Rudel returned no words in response. He simply brandished his blade. Aleist's sword was taken by Rudel's shield, but Rudel's sword was wound in Aleist's shadows.

That sword that was wrapped in that rubbery darkness had its heat stolen away in an instant. Aleist had imbued his shadow with the attribute of water. It was the moment his last-ditch effort had proved successful.

But at the same time, Aleist's sword lost to Rudel's shield and shattered. Aleist's mana had forced his sword of iron to its limit.

Both swords had been sealed, and everyone could feel Aleist's disadvantage. Rudel who still had his shield looked like he would come out on top.

Casting aside his sword, Rudel slammed his fist into Aleist. Reacting to the motion, Aleist bent his body forward to avoid the punch.

In his stooped-over position, Aleist aimed at Rudel's jaw and fired off a kick. Rudel blocked with his left arm, but the impact tore the belt affixing his shield to his arm, sending it flying off.

As Rudel lost the initiative, Aleist tried to trip Rudel up, executing an axe kick as he stood. Rudel rolled to dodge, having a bad premonition of the dull pain he felt in his left arm.

"That's a tiger tribe technique. I remember this pain."

"Yeah, it's a technique executed with nothing but body strengthening. I really went through some troubles to learn it."

In the past, because of Rudel, Aleist had been abducted and trained by the tiger tribe. A few years ago, he had thought of it as hell, but now that he was fighting Rudel like this, he was thankful.

The wall that couldn't be overcome with talent alone had been surpassed with the tiger tribe. That combat training, and the techniques he learned from those scary-faced delinquent tigers.

Aleist had once been too afraid to use his power to its fullest, but now he could use it adequately. It was the first time he felt the sway of his own matured power.

Rudel took a stance with his fists, his mouth laughing. Aleist was taken aback, but perhaps Rudel was delighted, as he ignored the pain in his left arm and sent out a fist.

"That's right! I want to fight you at your best! This is completely different from back then; fighting a serious you!!"

Rudel's rush was properly answered.

"Y-you battle junkie!!"

But perhaps scared of Rudel's smile, he was slightly teary.

With the high-speed movement Rudel occasionally mixed in, and the fight's duration, Aleist was beginning to fall back. If it was a fair-and-square fight, perhaps Aleist held the advantage. But whether it be swordplay or magic, the match was a battle where anything goes.

It was the sort of rule that allowed Rudel to use his strength to the fullest. No matter the field, Rudel was unable to be first, but he could take second place. He was the multi-purpose type who could perform on any sort of battlefield.

In contrast, Aleist was also multi-purpose, but he was cut from different stuff. While Rudel would fight risking his life, Aleist would fight to protect his own. It was clear who held the greed to triumph in a battle against a strong foe.

Aleist who had relied on his cheats held a different base. Even if he had reformed, what he had built up in a few years was different from Rudel.

Perhaps the winner had been decided the moment Rudel set foot into Aleist's domain. The same territory called the white and black knights...

As Rudel's right hand stuck a blow into Aleist's stomach, the shockwave assailed him. The light of the black symbols crumbled, and Aleist was blown a large distance.

At the same time, Rudel's white symbols disappeared from a lack of mana.

Rudel was still on his feet, looking at Aleist who was trying to stand. Even if he tried to pursue, his body wouldn't move. Even in that state, Rudel's greatest desire was for Aleist to stand. The two no longer had the power to fight, but their willpower maintained their consciousness.

"Hah, hah, this really is the worst. I should've trained more... I should've... I should've... why did I have to notice so late..."

If he had noticed it sooner, Aleist could have obtained powers far greater than what he possessed. He had made light of the world as a game, but now he mourned all the time he had spent in waste. He was irritated with himself. But obtaining strength and maturing were separate problems. As he bit back his vexation and tried to stand, Aleist could see the winner.

Rudel's eyes as he looked at him were pleading for him to stand. Having come so far, whether he stood or not held no meaning to the result. But Aleist wanted to stand.

(At least let me act cool at the end. I really was an idiot, but at the very least, I can put on airs before Rudel. This guy alone, I want Rudel alone to recognize me!)

Whipping his immobile body to motion, Aleist tried to stand when he heard a nostalgic voice, feeling a warmth on his back and limbs. As if four people were supporting him up, he lifted his body he could no longer put power into.

'Look, your friend's waiting for you. You can't keep him waiting.'

'That's good, as expected of our child. Our pride and joy...

The nostalgic voices belonged to the parents of a life gone by, voices he was no longer able to hear. Aleist felt tears on his face, and as he stood, he could hear the applause.

Making sure the referee heard, Aleist's tears wouldn't stop as he accepted his defeat with a shaking voice.

"I-it's my loss... The winner is Rudel!"

The ref heard Aleist's voice, and once he climbed up to the ring, he gave a grand proclamation of Rudel's victory. The evening had already dyed the sky in orange, and the spectators showered the two in a magnificent applause.

Right after the referee declared the outcome, the two of them fell unconscious at once.



Letting go of his consciousness, Aleist thought back to the familiar voices he had heard at the end.

The forms of his parents floated up in the darkness. While their faces were smiling, they looked somewhat miserable.

"Ah, is this a dream? Goodness me, for me to suddenly feel homesick after coming this far..."

People continued appearing from the darkness. His brother, and his classmate who resembled his beloved Millia. His parents opened their mouths. First was his father.

'You've got to treasure your new parents. And I'm sorry I never noticed. I'm really sorry for being such a no-good parent...'

Shedding tears, Aleist tried to call out to his father. But his mother held up a hand, shedding her own tears before the changed form of her son.

'You didn't have to force yourself to endure it all... you really did good, holding out to the end. But it's alright now. You've got a lot of friends, and a lot of girlfriends... you've got to make them happy.'

He nodded in tears, and this time, his little brother bashfully scratched his head.

'... I'll do something about mom and pops. So bro, you have to do a proper job this time. Don't cause too much trouble.'

Aleist's voice wouldn't come out for his odious brother. He nodded and wiped his tears. And finally...

'I should've properly told you. I'm sorry. When you talked to me, I really was happy. I was always bad at talking with people, and it often turned awkward, but... thank you.'

As his family disappeared into the darkness, Aleist reached out his hand and was about to chase after. But he stopped. He held up his extended hand to wave them off with a smile.

(What am I doing, remembering my family at this point? Am I to show such a pitiful sight to my family and that girl who worried for me so? Keep it strong to the end, Aleist!)

Shouting at himself, Aleist tried to give them some peace of mind. Even if it was just a dream, perhaps it was precisely because it was a dream that he could muster his courage.

He cried as he made a smile, and he knew it was surely a strange face he made. But he wanted to act strong.

"I'm the one who should say sorry! I really am thankful... thank you for everything!!"

Even if it was a dream, Aleist was happy he could meet his family and that girl. He got the feeling he had found proof that he wasn't alone in that world either.

When Aleist regained consciousness, he thought he had seen a good dream. But the voice and warmth he felt in the match definitely remained in his memory. He thought he had gone through quite a peculiar expression, but he remembered he had already gone through the impossible experience of reincarnation.

He suddenly realized he had grown quite accustomed to this world, and that was a laugh.

But on the infirmary bed he had been carried to, as per usual, the Three Lords lay asleep on their beds. Rudel had the window bed, and to his side, Aleist, Luecke, then Eunius in that order.

Luecke had run out of mana maintaining the barrier during Rudel and Aleist's battle. He lay with a considerably pained look on his face.

Everyone apart from Luecke was in bandages, the rhythm of sleepers' breath filling the moonlit room.

"Ah, so it ended as usual... well, that's not bad at all."

Lying on his bed once more, Aleist closed his eyes and fell asleep once more. He didn't yet know that some noisy days were to start tomorrow.

Chapter 89: Extra: Surpass Marty

8

Extra: Surpass Marty 8

Splendidly updating his infirmary hospitalization records, Rudel gazed out the window of the sickroom.

The sons of the Three Lords were all gathered in that extravagant sickroom, and Aleist was there as well. There were many who ruined their health in this individuals' tournament that was on a different scale than ever before, and securing sickrooms had become a trial, so he had been pushed in.

The four of them had suffered heavy injury and mana loss and were still undergoing treatment. But there was no way they would keep quiet...

"Please mewwy me!"

"Hmm, that one was quite close."

"Give it a rest already, you bastards!"

His face bright red, Aleist glared at Eunius and Luecke lying in the beds beside him, half in tears.

They were teasing him over his unprecedented confession in the middle of a match. Luecke graded Eunius' impression, and that same exchange had been repeated a number of times.

The individuals' tournament had concluded, and with the load off their shoulders, everyone was in a lax state. The academy was busy cleaning up

after the event, but the four who had been hospitalized had nothing but free time on their hands.

In that case, it was only natural they teased the subject of conversation. Eunius laughed as he continued teasing Aleist in the bed across from Luecke.

"No, no, we're really praising you here. On top of soiling a sacred tournament, when the royal line was bringing up talks of engagement, you boldly professed love before them... I'll be using this joke for the rest of your life."

"You're just mocking me after all! I-I couldn't help it. If I didn't resolve the misunderstanding, I'd never be able to move forwards..."

Luecke denied Aleist's excuse with a straight face.

"Misunderstanding? The talks of your engagement to those five have been going smoothly, and when there are even talks of your marriage to Princess Aileen, you call it a misunderstanding? Aren't you misunderstanding what it means to be engaged? Rudel, you tell him something too."

As Luecke waved the conversation towards him, all eyes gathered on Rudel.

"... Engagement is a problem between Aleist and his fiancé(s), but I do get the feeling he has a few too many. If he keeps increasing them like this, he'll be in the double digits in a few years. Aleist, look out for your body. Speaking seriously, there are loads of knights who've ruined themselves with women."

Rather than nights, in this case, they were nobles. Once their life in the academy was over, the students would be treated as adults. Naturally, the nobles would be married through talks between houses. Among Counts like Aleist, there really were many cases where an earnest young man was swallowed up by a woman.

While it was a different case, Rudel's father surrounded himself with women, and he wouldn't do any work. Among the four gathered, he was the one who understood best what result that would bring in.

"W-what are you talking about!? M-Millia is my one and only..."

As Aleist mumbled, Eunius grinned as he muttered he heard something interesting.

"Then if Millia's all you want, cut off the others. You want me to put in a word?"

On Eunius' teasing words, Aleist's face went pale as he screamed for him to stop. His serious face somewhat surprised Luecke and Eunius.

"Seriously, stop it! Those girls, well... t-they're expressions of love are downright abnormal. When they act as if it's only natural I get cut up or smacked, if I bring up talks of breaking up, there's no telling what they'll..."

The actions he could laugh off when he played the game, in reality, they were no laughing matter. Aleist had experienced them with his body. Being smacked to hide their embarrassment, and being smashed through walls, he shook as he recalled the true terror he felt.

"Well, I get that you have it hard, but you better take responsibility. Izumi told me that not taking responsibility is the worst thing a man can do."

As Aleist cowered, Rudel told him what Izumi had said. But from Aleist's point of view, he had suddenly received five wives. He looked at Rudel's freedom with envy.

"You say responsibility, but can't you say that because you don't have any engagements? If you had a violent girlfriend, I don't think you'd be able to say something like that."

"Really? Marty-sama's girlfriend's expressions of love were extreme, but he overcame them, apparently."

"Marty's the petting guy, right? I get the feeling he'd love his dragon over his wife."

The picture Aleist's mind drew of Marty was that of an oddball who loved dragons more than his family. Luecke thought the same.

"Right. I must offer the same opinion as Aleist. Looking through the book, there wasn't a single mention of his family, but there was a lengthy declaration of love for a dragon."

As Luecke made a tired face, Eunius shook his head to say he couldn't understand it. But there, Rudel informed them of a surprising new fact.

"... What are you talking about? Marty-sama's girlfriend was the water dragon 'Mystith'. At first, she would smack water balls into him to hide her embarrassment, but through mastering petting, at the end, she..."

"Wait a second! Then what's that, this Marty guy was never married?"

Eunius stopped Rudel, confirming what had to be asked. Dragoons were Courtois' elites, and a target of aspiration.

Even knights of common origin were often welcomed into noble houses. The only reason one wouldn't marry lay in the individual.

"? No, he was married. There was Mystith-sama, and... who was it again? The name isn't coming out, but I get the feeling he was married."

Rudel had once seriously investigated into Marty, but Marty's family was already one of the past, and he couldn't find much detail about his descendants. And Rudel was on the more knowledgeable side.

"Isn't that strange!? A marriage between a dragon and a human? Then he couldn't have children, right? And isn't Marty's treatment of his human wife just terrible?"

As Aleist held his head, Rudel made gentle eyes as he gave an enlightened explanation.

"Yeah, but it was a result both sides agreed to. This isn't something strangers like us can stick our mouths into. And dragons lack the concept of marriage itself. To be more precise, perhaps it was something different from marriage."

"Why are you talking about it as if it's only natural? I definitely don't accept this, you hear!"

Aleist gave a protest that he couldn't accept it, but here, Eunius grew interested in Rudel's new technique.

"Well, just put that on hold for now. More importantly, you learned a new petting, didn't you, Rudel? Teach me something."

"Recently, I learned embracing and massage, but because Izumi said they were no good, I sealed them. Right now, I'm trying to do something with my magic eyes."

Rudel's eyes were the eyes of the black bird, capable of inflicting negative statuses. After Rudel lost both his eyes in the fight with the undead dragon, he had received new ones from the black bird.

"... Rudel, is your head on fine?"

As Luecke looked at Rudel with worry, Rudel and Aleist tilted his head. Eunius couldn't believe it, but if it was something Rudel said, then he couldn't deny the possibility it might be true.



'No! I'm going to see Rudel!'

In the dragons' dwellings, Sakuya's large build lay across the ground, flapping around her arms and legs as she protested to Mystith. But Mystith could only decline.

'Give it a rest, Sakuya! You can't properly fly through the sky, and you haven't even learned how to properly fight as a dragon. At this rate, you'll

only bring shame to Rudel.'

'I don't want that eittthhhhererr!!'

While Sakuya was twice the size of Mystith, she raised her body, and reluctantly swung her arms. Mysteth was teaching her how to fight.

'And I'm telling you that's not good enough!!'

Taking a turn of her body, Mysteth used her tail to swipe Sakuya's feet and send her rolling. Falling face up, Sakuya gave a similar scream as before.

'I don't want this anymorrree!! I'm going to see Rudel!!'

'Hah, when you can't even fire a proper breath, what are you saying?'

'I-I can fire one! I can fire a big one!!'

'Yeah, yeah, you can fire a big one and a strong one. But it will be fatal if you can't fire a normal one.'

'It's fine as long as I can fire a big one...'

Growing timid with her large, white form, Sakuya was a child transmigrated as a dragon. While her specs were high, she wasn't able to use them.

Breath attacks were generally the same among dragons, and if she held back to fire one, the fireball would burst along the way, scattering smaller fireballs around. If she fired a big one, the earth was gouged out, and the ground that rose would form a pillar. It was difficult to find a place for her powerful attacks to be of use.

Sakuya was generally a dragon that was difficult to handle. She held the body of a gaia dragon subspecies, and on top of being hard to handle, she was slow in the air. Even if her power and thick skin was peerless on ground, a dragon's value lay in attacks from the sky.

Attacks that gouged out the earth made it difficult to put her to use in the dragoons that specialized in defensive battles. One would hesitate to lay waste to the land of their own country.

Therefore, there were many dragons who said to keep their breath at a 'normal' level. And Sakuya still couldn't fire a breath imbued with an element like Mysteth could.

In contrast with her frame, Sakuya's value as a dragon was low. It was for that sake that Mysteth was looking after her, but...

'Hah, I'll bring him here next time, so make sure you get better at firing your breath.'

Mysteth planned to use Lilim's dragon to call Rudel over. There, Sakuya showed a little motivation, launching an attack on Mysteth.

'Too soft!'

Biting into Sakuya's neck, she used the tenets of a shoulder throw to utilize her momentum and throw her. Because of Sakuya, the dragons' dwellings were gradually growing rougher.

Sakuya's large build soared, and as she slammed into the ground, the area took a large shake.

'Uuuurrrgh, nno more.'

Before Sakuya's frequent complaints, Mysteth breathed out a sigh.

◇

"I'm telling you, it's for real!"

"No, but even if you tell me you have magic eyes..."

"You experienced them in our wilderness training during the fundamental curriculum, didn't you!? Now I've become capable of using them. And if I do, I can make someone feel good without having to touch them!"

"That's terrifying."

While Rudel desperately tried to explain his magic eyes, Luecke couldn't accept it. Aleist was also a bit taken aback by Rudel's thoughts to use his magic eyes and make people feel good.

But Eunius determined it would be fun to test out, and made a proposal.

"Then Rudel, test it out on the girls who come to visit. If they see it put to practice before their eyes, then I'm sure everyone here will believe it."

"... Very well. I'll show you my seriousness."

Having been denied so many times, Rudel said he would get serious and closed his eyes. The sickroom fell into a moment of silence, but Luecke whispered over to Eunius.

"What are you thinking? If he's telling the truth, we'll have victims on our hands."

"Fool, the only girl who'd come to this room is Izumi, right? Then while we're at it, I thought we could use this opportunity to get her and Rudel hitched already."

"I see. Well, I'd like to think the magic eye part is a joke, but..."

As the two of them discussed in whispers, a knock came at the door. Time-wise, it wasn't a nurse, so Rudel opened his eyes, and the remaining three braced themselves to see if a girl had come.

A girl had definitely come, but it wasn't Izumi. With Fina at the lead, Sophina and Mii had come to pay their respects.

"How are you all feeling?"

Sophina held a get-well package, and she left a basket of fruits in the room. Besides Rudel, who she often found herself around, Mii had never spoken to any of the others before.

She nervously hid behind Fina's back.

Fina was expressionless, but she had no reason to go on a rampage here, and after leaving her get-well package, she intended to be off. But Rudel called out.

"Perfect. Fina, come over here."

"Yes?"

The reason Rudel dropped the honorific was because Fina was his apprentice. Those in question accepted that, but the others saw it differently.

"... Since when were you two in that sort of relationship? This is bad, isn't it?"

"Yeah, let's just pray Izumi doesn't come here."

Eunius and Luecke exchanged a look, praying that this land didn't become a land of carnage. Aleist alone didn't seem to notice, and he was the only one excited to confirm the effects of the magic eyes.

"Fina, look into my eyes."

"Sure... (Why do I have to look into his eyes? Is this some new type of game... hah, if someone saw the scene of us staring at once another, I'd be able to spread rumors, and fill in the outer moat)."

Scheming inside, Fina looked into Rudel's eyes. She instantly felt a sensation as if she was being sucked in. It became difficult for her to stand, and be that as it may, her chest felt tight... and sorrowful. As she crumbled to her knees, still expressionless, her face turned red.

"Hah!? (W-what is the meaning of this!? I never thought I'd be stared at so seriously, so longingly... i-it couldn't be master is lusting for me? This is bad. I didn't wear my lucky panties today. Well, they're still white, so will I be able to appeal to my innocence?)"

"A-are you alright, princess!?"

As Sophina and Mii drew close, Rudel averted his eyes and turned to the three men.

"Did you see it, the power of these eyes?"

Eunius was unable to believe what he had seen, and Luecke was the same. Aleist alone was averting his eyes from Rudel.

"... No way."

"No, that's impossible."

"... Don't look this way."

"M-master..."

Her heart hurting, Rina sat as she extended her hand towards Rudel. But Rudel was curt.

"Ah, good word. With this, my magic eyes have been proven. You can go now."

This time, the two women made faces as if they couldn't understand. Fina alone was the same as usual.

"... Eh?"

"Rudel-sama, that one was too cruel."

"... Master. (W-what's with that!? Treating me so crudely... I'm really feeling it.)"

Receiving Mii's words, Rudel realized that wasn't the attitude to take towards the people who came to wish him well, so he gave his thanks. He had grown accustomed to dealing with Fina in her enlightened form, and he unintentionally ended up treating her like a miscellaneous object. Feeling apologetic, he took a repentant attitude.

But the effects of his magic eyes continued on.

"You're right, I'm sorry. I've done something bad to the people who came to see us. I'll have to do something to thank you."

After he apologized, Rudel smiled, and the faces of the three went red.

And with terrible timing, it was then that another knock came at the door, and the guests who had come to visit them entered the sickroom.

Chapter 90: Extra: Surpass Marty

9

Extra: Surpass Marty 9

The individuals who had entered the sickroom were Izumi and Millia.

Meeting by chance in front of the infirmary, they were heading to the same place, so the girls had come to Rudel's sickroom together.

Izumi and Millia had exchanged little more than a greeting, the atmosphere turning exceedingly awkward along the way. Renewing their resolve, they opened the door with a smile, only to find Fina, Mii and Sophina sitting on the floor with reddened faces.

“... What happened?”

From his bed, Rudel directed Izumi a smile, but Luecke and Eunius were both averting their faces. Aleist alone, with his confession, was averting his eyes from Millia with a red face.

Millia looked around in wonder, but no one answered the words that came from her mouth. No, when Rudel was about to try explaining, Izumi breathed out a sigh. In the five years since she came to the academy, Izumi's gestures had become mature.

Rudel and the others had grown in height, gaining muscles, their bodies had grown to adulthood. Their faces had been drained of their youth, and all four of them boasted mature features. But their insides were children nonetheless.

“Hah, Rudel, what did you do this time around?”

Izumi arbitrarily placed her basket of fruit on the shelf before folding her arms and staring at Rudel.

To Izumi's gaze, Rudel replied with a smile.

"Listen to this, Izumi! I finally learned how to use my magic eyes. If you just kinda gather some mana in your eyes and tune it, while it doesn't reach the realm of petting, you can make someone feel good..."

"Stop right there, Rudel."

Halting Rudel's explanation, Izumi headed over to the three sitting on the floor. After sitting them up in the chairs around the sickroom, she made for the side of Rudel's bed. There was already a seat prepared at Izumi's regular spot, and after sitting, she gazed over Rudel.

Rudel also looked at Izumi with serious eyes, but after a while, he averted those eyes. It was only at that moment that he noticed he had done something wrong.

"... Did I do something wrong?"

The boys who had grown heated over the magic eyes looked over Rudel and Izumi.

"Quite a few thing. It's no good to put the princess on the floor, and it's no good to use your magic eyes on a woman."

"Wait, Izumi! If you seal off my magic eyes, then just who am I supposed to practice on..."

As he looked over the sickroom, the bedridden boys entered his eyes. Luecke and Eunius immediately looked away.

"Don't look this way, Rudel!" "I-I'm not into that!!"

The two of them displayed firm refusals, but Aleist was different. Rudel had displayed the might of his magic eyes before his own eyes. And in the

sickroom, the one he had confessed to, Millia, had come to pay a visit. If some mistake did occur, Aleist wouldn't be able to bear it.

The magic eyes' effects had already been cut, but in order to cover Millia's eyes with his hands, Aleist moved his body. He forcibly stood from the bed, but as he headed towards Millia, an intense pain assailed his body. He had suffered injury incomparable to anything he had taken before.

There was no helping that his body wouldn't move as he willed it. More than that, it was surprising he could even stand from his bed.

But the result was terrible.

“Millia, look out!”

“Eh? ... Kyaaaaah!!”

As Aleist suddenly leapt up from the bed, Millia's small chest ended up in his tight hold. Millia's palm violently flew towards Aleist's left cheek.



“... Are you alright, Aleist?”

Having been forcibly returned to his bed, Aleist held his left cheek as he turned his face towards Rudel's worry.

“Do I look alright? I'm in tatters all over.”

As Aleist gave a depressed reply, Luecke held back his laughter to enter the conversation. Eunius openly laughed as he joined in.

“Mainly psychologically. To think we had a big show of Rudel's level among us.”

“Even Rudel doesn't do anything that direct!”

“... Yeah. Hey, Izumi. What does everyone think I am? I definitely have an interest in women, but I haven't done anything too terrible.”

“I wonder. From the eyes of those around, it looked as if you naturally pull off even greater things.”

Unable to accept that he had been used as a comparison in Luecke and Eunius’ dialogue, Rudel smashed the question at Izumi. Izumi knew Rudel probably hadn’t realized, returning a slightly sharp tone.

On those surrounding reactions, it wasn’t Aleist, but Millia’s face that went red. She had been confessed to, so she thought it was her obligation to respond, for argument’s sake, so she had paid a visit. But the sickroom didn’t have the sort of atmosphere where she could give her answer.

(Erk, this isn’t the right atmosphere to reject him.)

Aleist definitely had a future full of hope, but Millia was a long-lived elf. Unlike the human race, the time after her graduation was considered too early for marriage. Once nobles graduated, they would be married on their family circumstance, for favorable relations between houses. You could say that now was the only time they had to play around.

But the commoner student Millia was different. As an official or officer, she had come to the academy to work for Courtois. This was her showing that she’d abide the country as a demi-human, and it was hard to say she was working with loyalty.

But she had become first rate, and she did have the desire to get out of the academy and confirm the breadth of her own abilities.

As Millia held her head, Fina, who had been silent to that point, approached.

“You’re Millia-senpai, right?”

“Y-yes!”

Suddenly called out to, Millia’s voice turned inside out. She hurriedly corrected her posture, when Fina told her they were in the academy, and nowhere public, so she didn’t have to mind it.

And before Aleist, Fina solicited to Millia.

“Have you decided your course after graduation? (Well, I already know you’re off to the border. But Aleist’s right here, perfectly enough, so let’s try making an invitation.)”

“Y-yes. It’s been decided that I’ll be stationed near the border.”

It was a station she had just a bit to complain about, but even so, she had a light hope that if she worked hard out there, her work would be recognized. To Millia, Fina gave a smooth and natural invitation to the defenders.

“Is that so. A knight of your caliber sent to the border... that sounds like a waste.”

“Is it a waste? I do think the border is an important position.”

“No, I certainly must lower my head to the knights and soldiers working hard on the border. But I have only just witnessed your abilities at the tournament.”

“A-ahahaha”

Millia gave a bitter smile, recalling how her emotions had gone out of control and how she showed such a shameful side before royalty. But Fina’s impression was something different.

“The courage you showed, not stepping back a single step before the black knight, was splendid. So I have a proposal. I would love to add your power to the newly formed defenders. I was ‘a little’ involved with their formation, so I’d definitely like to gather some hopeful knights for it.”

On Fina’s act, Mii and Sophina whispered to one another.

“The princess is amazing. To think she could make such a serious proposal.”

“Yes, but not just a little, she was the ringleader behind the whole mess. I wish she was that decent on a regular basis.”

While Fina did hear their whispers, she confirmed Aleist had bit onto Millia's future, expressionlessly taking Millia's hands and turning her face.

“Senpai, how about it? (Let me nibble on those earrrrss!!)”

“U-ummm, if you ask me so suddenly, I'll be troubled, or how should I put it...”

To her indecisive attitude, it wasn't Aleist, but Rudel who stuck in his mouth. By Rudel's entrance into the conversation, Fina put a pause on her invitation.

“Millia-san, do you hate the defenders?”

“I don't particularly hate them.”

Seeing Rudel look at her so seriously, Millia ended up averting her face. She still had some part of her that hadn't given up, and come so far, she wavered.

“If you don't have a reason, you should make use of this chance. It's important for proficient knights to seek out a place where they can perform. So when blessed with such a chance, if you don't grasp at it, you will regret it later.”

Rudel didn't think the demi-human Millia would be able to perform on the border. It may be different if she was blessed with a good superior, but even if they had the skill, there were many knights without a place to perform. To add to that, he didn't think her work would receive a proper evaluation in the current Courtois.

His house had been prejudice one, and Rudel would often hear such a tale. The knights of his house would brag about the achievements they stole from demi-humans over a laugh and a drink.

Rather than paying mind to Millia, he wanted to say there were more chances to be had in the defenders than the border. Rudel had seen the ugly

side of humans, but before coming to the academy, he had little interest in people unrelated to him.

That he got around to caring for others was a large step forwards. As Millia looked down, Fina called out.

“I am not seeking an answer here and now. Let’s see... I’ll wait until the second semester. Until then, Millia-senpai, please come out with an answer you’re satisfied with. (Master got in the way, but I don’t have to push here. It’s more than enough that Aleist bit on! If the girl ends up in the defenders, I’ll be nibbling on her ears!!)”

Fina forcefully solicited her and tried to shove her into the defenders, but after accomplishing her goal, she gracefully stepped back.



“Hmm, It’s precisely because of Lena’s quick wit that I was able to maintain the barrier. By opening up a hole at the top, I was able to give yours and Rudel’s mana a means of escape. My affinity with Lena is totally the best. You could even call this a date!”

Luecke bragged proudly to Aleist, but this was something Eunius had already heard a number of times. By opening a hole in the barrier’s roof, he let the impacts escape to the sky, where there weren’t any spectators. By that, Luecke was able to maintain the barrier, and retain the face of the Halbades House.

Since his hospitalization, Aleist had already heard the story three times. It was a stream of him being teased over his confession and hearing out the same bragging in rotation, and to his side existed Rudel and Izumi, letting off a pink air.

As Izumi peeled fruit, she distributed cut fruit pieces to the others besides Rudel as well. But it was clear that her efforts were going to only Rudel’s pieces.

Eating that cut fruit, Aleist only listened to Luecke's love stories so he wouldn't get in the way of Rudel and Izumi beside him. Eunius also heard the story, but he pretended to be asleep to escape.

And the reason he quietly listened to Luecke was that even if he rebutted, he would only get sophistry in return. There was no one more eloquent than Luecke in the sickroom so no one would be able to counter. It was more decent for everyone to just shut up and listen.

Once Luecke was satisfied and the story was over, this time Rudel struck up conversation with Aleist. He sought confirmation about the armor he had ordered a while back.

"Aleist, are you fine with the sizes you sent in for your armor?"

"Eh? Oh, the armor. Yeah, you don't have to change the size. Even if it's a bit off, they can still do some fine adjustments, right?"

"Yeah, they've already started on it. As long as your size hasn't changed from when they measured before, they said it would arrive before the graduation ceremony."

Aleist was also curious about the armor he had requested from an eastern craftsman. He was waiting in expectation to see what sort of armor would come out.

As Rudel and Aleist spoke, this time Izumi added on.

"Are you talking about those craftsmen? Rudel, they're adjusting your armor, right?"

"Yeah, I needed some sizing, and they said they wanted to see it too. It took more time than expected, but when they came over here to meet me, I didn't want to get in Aleist's way, so I wasn't able to ask back then."

"I don't really mind."

"... Can you have them take a look at my katana too? I've been maintaining it since you gave it to me, but I want it looked at before graduation."

Rudel instantly answered Izumi's request.

"No problem. I also plan to put in a request for a spare weapon, so I'll order it while I'm at it."

"A weapon, huh. My parents said they put in a request to a famous blacksmithy."

Aleist had asked Rudel about the armor because his house didn't have any craftsmen that could make armor. It took a considerable amount of money to keep a talented smith under your wing, and all houses were looking around to take them in.

Even if you didn't have exclusive contracts, you could still put in a request, and since it was a blacksmith recommended by one of the three lords... or so he received a letter of consent from his parents. In exchange, they wrote they would search out a famous blacksmith to make his weapon.

"You did say you wanted the armor before graduation, but they were all up for it, so it might be finished even sooner. They were delighted that they had made something really nice."

Aleist rejoiced at Rudel's words, but Izumi's expression wasn't the best. Rudel noticed her down face.

"What's wrong, Izumi?"

"... No, I think it'll be alright... um, I'm sure those eastern blacksmiths are skilled enough, but..."

Unable to say it clearly, Izumi played it off at the time. Rudel and Aleist both grew a little curious, but after being told it was nothing to worry about, they didn't ask any more.

On a later date, this matter would bring Aleist some terrible regret.



As Rudel expected, the armor was completed considerably early.

Before the final vacation, it was delivered to Aleist. But before the delivered armor, Aleist fell to his knees.

“How about that, boss!? This armor’s workmanship crazy good!” “Totally! You won’t find another like it. It has that real perfect thing going!” “Just look at the horns on it, like dude! It’s just the best!”

Giving off craftsmen vibes, some sturdy-looking middle-aged men and an aged one said such things with serious faces. The reason was simple. When they first came to Courtois from the east, they had lived in a slum-like environment. The words they learned there didn’t quite sound so elegant.

They were words they had said with an earnest intent, but they had made themselves sound terribly light.

The fact Aleist’s armor arrived meant that Rudel and Izumi were present as well. Before their eyes was a jet-black set of armor, with two splendid golden horns growing from its head. At a glance, rather than an ally, it was an enemy general... a sinister armor one might associate with a lord of evil had been completed.

“Mannn, when boss Rudel told us about black knight, we put all our minds together, and this what we came up with. But isn’t it cool!”

When an extremely scary-faced blacksmith sought affirmation with such a tone...

“... It’s cool.”

Aleist was unable to object. Izumi put a hand on her forehead with a face as if to say, I knew it.

“I’m sorry. I never thought they’d actually go this far.”

As Izumi apologized to Aleist, Rudel tilted his head.

“Why? Isn’t it cool?”

Before a perplexed Rudel, the polished armor of the white knight was placed. In contrast to what clearly belonged to a knight of justice, Aleist's armor seemed to belong to a demon lord. What's more, gold horns, red mantle, and the gold craftsmanship bestowed around it let off a strange sinisterness.

Dark hero or demon lord, the armor seemed to demand its wearer to take their pick.

“As expected of boss! He really gets it!!” “Rudel-san, you understand!”
“Boss is saying it, so there's no doubt about it!!”

As the serious-faced craftsmen used such light words, Aleist could only gaze on expressionlessly.

Chapter 91

Among the fifth years awaiting graduation, there were many of them who had decided their future courses.

For this was an academy to nurture the Courtois Kingdom's future officials and officers. One would apply to the knight brigade they wanted to enter, and if they didn't get in, they would be sent around to wherever was thought to be lacking in personnel.

Those with top academics were chosen out every year and instated to the posts they desired. To the others, they would receive notices that they were accepted to their second or third choices.

The final extended break was the final chance for these students to spread out their wings. At the same time, there were many students who caused problems during that period and had their tentative offers revoked.

Around this season, the bureaus that managed the Courtois Kingdom's human resources prayed that the students didn't cause any problems as they decided their stations.

The positions for those with top grades were usually decided before the break. But this year, there was a bit of a problem.

... It was Rudel.

While he had obtained a dragon, he held a vital fixed position in Courtois called white knight. You could say it was only natural there were arguments to be had over his placement. The higher-ups could have decided, but the problem was Aileen. The early plan they set up was for him to be captain of the royal guard.

But now, Fritz had been selected as captain. Alongside his graduation in two years' time, he was to take his captain seat.

Aileen, who saw Rudel as her mortal enemy, gave an order through the minister to station him as a rank-and-file of the royal guard. But there was an even bigger problem... it was Fina.

Because Fina wanted to make him captain of the defenders she had established, she brought out the king and queen's name to order it so. There were signatures from a number of ministers, and it looked like their side held the advantage.

But the biggest problem of all was Rudel. The man himself had rejected his offers from both knight brigades, and selected dragoon.

Human resources was in tears.

In a conference room of the palace, representatives of all the knight brigades had gathered to discuss the placement of Rudel alone. Those charged with HR distributed the documents they prepared before promptly starting the meeting. They didn't have the time to spend on Rudel alone, and there were still students whose placements had yet to be decided.

"Well then, I'd like to start the conference. As you can see from the documents, the opinions of the higher-ups are divided, so this time, we wish to hear the opinions of each brigade..."

As the HR representative tried to continue on, the vice-captain of the royal guard raised his voice. His voice wasn't that intimidating, but he couldn't help but sound condescending.

"The assembly has already decided to move towards stationing him in the royal guard. Is there really any problem with that? I do think the other knights will be troubled to deal with him."

There, this time, the rep of the defenders stuck in his mouth.

"Making a captain of the white knight is one thing, but you'll register him as a simple knight among many? There's no helping the crown be against it. There were many opposing views at the assembly. Well, I personally want him to come over to the defenders, but the problem is the dragon. The defenders don't have the necessary facilities to make use of a dragon."

While it seemed Fina was fixated on Rudel, Aleist's instatement to the defenders was practically set in stone. It was plainly visible that those around would be opposed if they moved to obtain Rudel as well.

Like Fina had tried to collect a white and black cat, Aileen was trying to get the white and black knights under Fritz. The sisters may have been surprisingly similar, the country's face wouldn't accept that idea. Getting the queen on her side, Fina only had to whisper, 'A commoner knight is trying to get the two symbols of this country to his beck and call,' to make her greatly opposed.

While they felt sorry for Fina, the defenders had given up on acquiring Rudel. If the man applied, they would have accepted him, but even so, he had applied to the dragoons, and there was no changing that.

Once the topic of dragons came out, the dragoon captain offered his opinion. This year, the dragoon captain and vice-captain were retiring, and for a while, the unit would be dedicated to raising its new members.

"It was a gaia subspecies, was it? Sure enough, I can't think any of the others will be able to look after it. When it comes to handling dragons, it will be too much for any other brigade to handle. We'd quite appreciate if the royal guard returned the personnel they borrowed soon."

Fritz' dragon was being managed by the royal guard. But the ones actually looking after it had been borrowed from the dragoons.

"Hmm, the royal guard is the shield of the crown. Unlike you lot, it won't have to fight. As long as the dragon appears at ceremonies, it won't be a problem."

"Though it's a dragon far more splendid than your own captain's."

The high knight captain spat some cynicism at the royal guard's vice-captain. The two of them had the standings of former subordinate and superior, and the man had much to say of his former subordinates who had betrayed the high knights.

The charge of HR endured the urge to let out a sigh, putting together the opinions of each brigade. The dissatisfaction towards the royal guard, and the defenders' situations caused Rudel's wishes to be granted.

"Then by majority vote, Rudel-dono shall be stationed with the dragoons. We express our deepest gratitude for all of you taking time out of your busy days to..."

Once he finished talking, the HR charge hurriedly collected up the documents and left the conference room. Even seeing that, there weren't any knights who thought it disrespectful. They all knew that right around now, the HR department was frantically modifying placements under their demands.



While each knight brigade sought out proficient personnel, the students were fully enjoying their final vacation.

Spending her break at the academy, Izumi held the letter from the palace in her hands, a slightly sad look on her face. It was written that Izumi's qualifications to be a high knight were accepted, and her enlistment had been decided.

After graduation, while she wouldn't hold a territory, she would be given the noble rank of a Baron in Courtois. Even if she was to be called a Baron, she had no land to look after, and she was merely recognized as a noble. In exchange for receiving the country's pledge of nobility, she gained a large number of obligations.

Izumi had gotten what she wanted in her hands, but when it came to writing a letter to her family, she grew sad. It was what she wanted. But accepting it made her parting with Rudel feel all too real.

She had been able to investigate it to an extent while she was at the academy. Entering the Arses House's wing would be close to throwing away all the status she went to such lengths to obtain. With the Arses House that looked down on demi-humans and other races, the Shirasagi House had no future.

"I should just throw away my house, is what I should have said. But I think that's impossible for me."

The head of the Shirasagi House would be the high knight Izumi. In order to pass down her baron status, she would have to prove a certain level of loyalty to the country. Either some great achievement or over ten years of service to the high knights... she couldn't pass it on immediately.

In her room at the dorm, Izumi muttered to herself. To her house, she wrote a businesslike letter saying her instalment as a high knight had been decided, and another one about her feelings. She wrote one of each.

Recalling her family, she imagined what actions her father might take. Izumi was the only one recognized as a noble. Her family only had the rights to inherit it. If they were standard nobles, it wouldn't be a problem, but there were large problems when it came to houses that were only just set up.

In order to obtain connections between Houses, Izumi would have to marry into a noble house with a history in Courtois. Her other siblings couldn't do it. Izumi would be married, and one of her siblings would succeed her Baron name.

Izumi recalled the faces of her little brothers. Perhaps her relatives would have something to say too. Once she finished writing her letter, she opened the window to air out her room.

As the cold air surrounded her, she felt her train of thought clearing up. But even in her cleared head, Izumi couldn't find an answer.

"Hah, I want to see..."

It was the moment she was about to mutter Rudel's name. A shake as if an earthquake had broken out, and a strong wind caused Izumi to lean out the window to see what had happened.

A little distance from her window, a smoke cloud had risen. Once the fumes cleared away, a white dragon... Rudel on Sakuya's back approached the girls' dorm.

As Sakuya waved her large hand, approaching on two legs, Izumi felt some vestiges of her past self. But without any memories of when she was human, the current Sakuya was a dragon... the collateral damage was nothing to scoff at.

Leaping out of the window in her loungewear, Izumi made for Rudel and Sakuya.



"What are you doing, Rudel!?"

To make sure Sakuya didn't step on Izumi, who had come to her feet, Rudel issued an order for Sakuya to stop. He spread out the papers he held so carefully in his hands, turning to Izumi and crying out.

"Izumi! I did it! I'm finally, I'm finally a dragoon!! The notice came last night, but I couldn't wait until the end of the break. I called Sakuya over, and had her come all the way to the academy!"

'God, hear me out! He called me all of a sudden, and I've been flying nonstop since yesterday! I'm tired!!'

"Good work, Sakuya. As expected of my dragon! I love you."

'Oh, that's all you ever say.'

Before Izumi, Rudel's delight was exploding as he leapt from Sakuya and landed. Understanding the situation, Izumi sent the dismounted Rudel a warm smile.

"Good for you, Rudel. So now you're the dragoon you always wanted to be."

Rudel had grown to be more of an adult than when they had first met five years back. He had grown in height, and no youth remained in his features. But his eyes alone were the same as ever.

The eyes and smile of a child hadn't changed one bit.

"Yeah, finally... that aside, what about you, Izumi?"

"Me? Ah, I got an offer from the high knights. I took the interview and exam, but maybe I never thought I'd actually pass..."

As Izumi made a bit of a lonely face, Rudel grabbed her shoulders. As she opened her eyes wide, Rudel directed her a smile.

"So your dreams came true too, Izumi! With this, we've both accomplished our dreams at the academy... then, let's go!"

"W-where?"

"We'll ride Sakuya there. Your house is fine too. I'll take you wherever you want! Ah! But if possible, make due with someplace inside Courtois..."

Around the end, Rudel's words grew weak, and Izumi ended up laughing. Sure enough, it would be a huge problem if Rudel rode his dragon off to a foreign land.

Perhaps only just remembering Izumi's hometown was in the Orient, he scratched his head apologetically. Izumi definitely did want to return home, but for now, she just wanted to be with Rudel.

"You're right... but is Sakuya alright?"

There were dragons who would refuse anyone apart from their contractors from riding their backs. Recalling that information she had heard from Rudel, Izumi looked up at Sakuya for confirmation.

'Izumi is okay. But Aleist is no good!!'

Sakuya assented to Izumi riding her back, but for some reason, she screamed out that Aleist was no good. Rudel tried asking the reason, but Sakuya would only say it was psychologically impossible.

"Is it that? Perhaps she really did just hate being called Flan that much. She doesn't have the memories, but perhaps the hatred alone remains. I also tried naming her Flan Alamode and Mogamon. I should be careful from now on."

While Rudel calmly thought over it, Izumi muttered in her heart that Flan Alamode was going too far.

"Well, there's no changing the past. Then shall we be off?"

Embracing Izumi tight, Rudel leapt right onto Sakuya's back. Couldn't he just use his wind magic to fly through the sky? To Rudel who boasted enough technique to make one misapprehend so, it was an easy task to lift and move a single person.

"Eh? H-hey, wait a moment, Rudel!"

'Here we go~!'

By the dragoon and dragon who wouldn't listen to what she had to say, Izumi was dragged off in her dressing gown for a walk through the sky.



In the Gaia Empire, Askewell and Mies' preparations to invade Courtois were gradually underway.

"At soonest, around a year?"

"Yes. But rearing the wyvern squad will still take some time."

In his office, Askewell looked over Mies' report as he thought over his trump cards in the Courtois invasion. He couldn't help but be lacking in

hands when it came to ogres alone.

And the trump card he had urgently prepared to stand against the dragoons... were wyverns. They were wyverns brought forth in the same way as the ogres, and truly faithful steeds.

For any military man with a level of talent, it was possible to ride one.

But Askewell wasn't satisfied yet. The revival of the two great knights in Courtois made it only natural, and there were some within Courtois who had noticed his movements.

While it couldn't be called sufficient, Courtois was laying out countermeasures. And more than anything, Askewell's instincts were telling him that things would be dangerous like this.

"Mies, how many 'Gora' will you be able to prepare?"

"Gora!? But didn't you say those ones were dangerous..."

Boasting four arms, they were called the strongest monsters on land. Those were the gora. Their heads and torsos were close to humans, so they were also called giants. Not found in Courtois, they were the gaia empire's greatest enemy.

Their form, rather than an enlarged human, was closer to a giant monkey. When their heads and torsos had no hair, for some reason, their arms and legs had a thick coat.

Their close-to-humans heads were warped in sinister expressions. But the biggest problem was their size. Those large builds that surpassed twenty meters... there were individuals out there equal to, or even greater than dragons in power.

On top of that, their ferocious temperament made coexistence impossible.

A large reason they didn't exist in Courtois was the dragoons. In the past, the dragoons had subjugated every gora in the country to protect the peace of the land. But there were still gora in the empire.

Gora boasted a certain level of intellect, and they wouldn't approach Courtois where the dragoons still lived. Askewell had tasted the dread of a gora hunt a number of times.

It wasn't just their power, their knowledge was the problem. With their large builds, the fact they could use tools troubled the empire to no ends. That they were few in numbers was the empire's salvation. But even so, they would put out many casualties each year.

"If we use the gora, there's no telling what will happen to Courtois' soil."

"Even so, Mies. At this rate, we're going to lose. Our wyvern units might be raising their polish, but we're up against the long history of the dragoons... numbers alone won't be enough."

The empire was betting on this time's invasion of Courtois. The strengthened ogres they pushed themselves to obtain, and their enhanced wyverns... the maintenance fees alone were considerable.

"... Five, no, perhaps seven might be possible. Any more, and just maintaining them will no longer be possible."

"I see. There's no problem with the number of ogres and wyverns. As long as we can get our hands on some gora, we should be able to manage."

"Is that alright? The gora are... vicious. If we take one wrong step, and err in our control...!"

"Don't worry. At worst, we'll just use them out. It would feel sickening for me to keep one too close."

They were an existence all knights and soldiers of the empire detested. That was the monster called gora.

Adding power to the empire was an important thing for Mies. But it was almost as if Courtois was getting stronger, and the empire was adding onto itself as a postscript. She couldn't help but get that feeling.

There was no deliberateness to it. Let alone that, the research that had been carried over several decades was reaching its end in only a few years. Could it be that the heavens had allied with them to attack Courtois?

Among the researchers Mies led, there were some who had honestly come to believe it.

It was simply that unnatural, how the empire augmented its forces.

The plot of the world went on, as if to heat up its final battle. An ending no one wanted was approaching for all eyes to see.

It was all to make a hero of the protagonist... and the start of the final chapter, the birth of the hero, would open its curtains alongside Rudel's death.

The empire would lose, and the kingdom would face massive casualties. The setting was showing its last struggle to lead the world to the way it should be.



Elsewhere, one who had noticed the movements of the empire... Fina was losing her temper in her room at the palace.

As one who had noticed their movements, she had unknowingly put Askewell on guard, but right now, her head was full of Aleist.

Of course, it wasn't love.

After Millia was successfully obtained by the defenders, Aleist volunteered to join himself. That much was just as Fina planned. But it was here that Fina had gone too far.

Obtaining Aleist and putting checks on the royal guard had made her go lax.

She knew that her real objective, Rudel, would apply to the dragoons without any hesitation. Even so, she thought he would come to the

defenders. In truth, she planned to use her mother, the queen's, power to twist the defenders up.

But obtaining Aleist called all her plans to go awry.

After obtained Aleist, the commanders on site grew wary of the antipathy they faced from other knight brigades.

"Goddammit. They calculated my personality and had Ness write the report... damn, I can't even get angry like this."

The report had been put together by Ness, who had been stationed in the defenders under Sophina's orders.

'We failed, meow. Forgive us, meow.'

"I can't get angry at a fluffy!! Shit! I went and got too greedy, but obtaining Aleist is now rearing its head... that plague!! I'll be working him to the bone once he comes to the defenders."

To Fina, Aleist was a plague, but from Rudel's point of view, he was the messiah. Rudel's standing was even higher than Aleist's.

On top of hailing from an archduke house with ties to the king, his strength was said to be strongest in the academy. The queen knew him well, and considering the palace's face, they wanted to have him as captain of the defenders. Rudel's instatement into the defenders itself brought with it talks or raising it to an official brigade.

When the palace was preparing itself to accept him, Fina's greed caused the site commanders to regulate her. That Rudel was able to become a dragoon was because of Aleist's instatement to the defenders.

Aleist himself didn't realize a thing.

But to Fina who knew the surrounding situation, what crushed her plan to make Rudel captain of the defenders was undoubtedly her own conceit and Aleist.

"Don't screw with me, dammit!!! Having come so far, master is to leave my hands...! Just how much do you think I had to prepare for this!!?"

Fina was losing her mind, but she was able to understand the decisions the commanders had made. If she hadn't grown greedy, the plan would have succeeded. So she was even more troubled over where to smash her feelings into.

In a place he didn't know, Aleist had saved Rudel. And because of that, he got Fina's eyes on him...

Like that, because of Aleist, Rudel's path to be a dragoon had been opened.

Chapter 92

Around the time their life at the academy greeted its end, the graduates began cleaning up the rooms they had used for five years.

There were second and third-year graduates as well, and around this time, the school dorms would be a busy mess. There were students who'd call forth servants from their houses, and others who would hound up underclassmen to clean.

Similarly, Rudel had begun to clean up his luggage that had grown from when he first came.

He had few belongings when he first came, but over the course of five years, he had added on more.

"This book is... I'll keep it."

The book he took in his hands was a child-geared picture book introducing the dragoons. It was something Rudel had given to Sakuya, and something he had left in his room. Rudel had read it as a child, imagining his own form in the future, and after that, it had become a memento he had given to Sakuya.

Apart from that, there were other pieces of memorabilia around.

The sword he had used from his youth, while it was broken, he still had it carefully preserved. He had tried to throw it away, but he couldn't bring himself to do it. So without any way to use it, he was troubled over what to do.

"Hah, it's grown to a surprising amount. My clothes are the same, there's no way I..."

While Rudel's belongings were on the scarce side, as he didn't know the situation of other students, he felt like he had a lot. Luecke was mulling over his mountains of books, while Eunius was troubled to deal with all the presents he never got around to giving to girls.

The largest problem was Aleist.

It was certain he would have at least five engagements, and the girls had handed over many a gift from their houses. Things worthy of Aleist, and Fina had also sent loads of presents under the pretense of celebration.

Fina had aimed for this time, conducting harassment under the name of celebrating his instatement to the defenders.

She picked the bulkiest things she could find and sent them to trouble him. But because of that, there were whispers of rumors that Fina was gunning for Aleist.

It was a disaster for Aleist, but after she self-destructed, Fina had grown quite docile as of late. She had realized herself that she was lacking in composure.

But a princess all the same, Aileen remained with her composure in tatters.

As Rudel and Aleist both left the academy, the palace grew fearful that the power balance between its forces would crumble. The names white and black knight held special meaning in Courtois.

For that sake, Fritz was transferred to the three-year course and forcefully inaugurated as royal guard captain. It was a result of Aileen and her followers concluding it would be too late for Fritz to become captain a whole two years later.

Having come so far, Aileen could no longer ignore the defenders Fina had set up.

Rudel had become a dragoon, but Aleist's name was still on the list of Aileen's engagement candidates. If he raised some achievements in the

defenders, then that would be used as a reason to proceed talks right to marriage.

To Aileen, she was considerably cornered.

But it was quite like Aileen to not look and feel fear from a war potential perspective.



"Hah, Rudel-sama."

Gazing out the classroom window, Fina muttered. If she muttered Rudel's name so lovingly, the rumors would go and spread on their own.

In truth, it had become well known that her love for Aleist had awakened, and once it spread to the palace, there was no taking it back. The queen made a ruckus over it, hastening a marriage between Aleist and Fina.

"Didn't she just say Rudel-sama?"

"Eh? But Fina-sama and Aleist-sama are..."

"By the gods, a love triangle!"

In the classroom, her peers were making a ruckus. A majority of them were nobles, but there were some commoners among them, eavesdropping with intrigue.

(Tsk, it really is unpleasant that such strange rumors are spreading. If I become a rumor with Aleist, there really won't be any return. In the worst case, mother will forcefully have me marry Aleist, and push master onto my sister. To think my sister who hasn't gone to any troubles would be the greatest wall to my fluffadise.)

While Fina was vexed within, in the first place, Aileen was always a demi-human hater. The moment Fina's patience ran out, they were fated to clash someday.

In the documents prepared with her textbooks, the defenders and royal guard... the names of the recruits to each knight brigade were listed.

(Five high knights this year, and nine dragoons... there's no helping it for the dragoons, but it looks like the high knights are about to be crushed. I wanted to crush them before that black hair entered! The border is the same as always...)

The high knights put up a resistance, and she wasn't able to dismantle them as she wanted. From Fina's point of view, it wasn't anything too important, so she instantly changed her train of thought.

She had investigated whoever intrigued her and paid especial attention to the movements of the royal guard. Choosing Aileen over her, many young nobles had already infiltrated her faction.

Seeing the movements of the enemy force, it really was the end.

(So that house is no good either. That house is joining my sister too? Oy, oy, that's quite a number.)

Unable to stop her laughter within, Fina planned to use this opportunity and largely chip away at the nobles' power. If blood was going to flow regardless, she might as well use it to its fullest.

That was Fina Courtois.

It was something that had been decided from the moment her sister Aileen had chosen to prioritize her personal matters over the country. But Aileen was strangely blessed with luck. To Fina, that was a major problem.

The formation of the royal guard was the same, it was almost as if she was loved by the heavens.

(Well, it's impossible I'll ever see a heaven outside my fluffadise. But even so... why does my sister have such a large faction? There's no way I'd ever side with her. The risk is too great. Could it be there's someone backing her? ... Hah, no way, no way.)

The fact that she had a large backer called the plot was something even Fina had no way of knowing.



"A graduation party? We're having one this year too?"

In the boys' dorm dining hall, Rudel and the usual members were having a meal. That day was a rare one where Aleist was at the same table, participating in the conversation.

"That's right! This time, we're the lead roles, right? Then there's no point if we don't enjoy ourselves."

Eunius was delighted. While his academics were abysmal, he somehow managed to maintain the bare minimum grades up to graduation. He was delighted to finally be freed from the books.

"Even if you say to enjoy it, you know. Food and live performances... what else is there? If the academy puts too much money into it, the palace will get noisy."

From a financial standpoint, they wouldn't be able to do anything too large-scale, said Luecke. Aleist finished his desert before joining in.

"A party, eh... like a masquerade?"

"What's that?"

As Aleist spoke of a masquerade, Eunius bit on. Perhaps Rudel didn't have any interest as he sipped his drink.

"No, well, you attend the party in disguise. How should I put it, like a costume or... something you wouldn't usually wear. You can wear a large stuffed animal? No, I think that's a little different."

While he explained it, Aleist was unable to convey a clear image.

"What you don't usually where? Will the men wear dresses or something? That sounds a bit sickening."

On Luecke's impression, Eunius made a smile.

"Now that sounds interesting."

"Hah?"

"You..."

"What you don't usually wear..."

As the three of them sighed, Eunius burst into laughter. Imagining a man wearing a dress in public, he grew just a little sick.

"Idiot, it's best to have a lot of ideas, right? It's just a thought, it's not like they'll actually take it up, so let's spice things up and submit some interesting requests. It seems the other folks are submitting requests to the academy, after all."

Knowing it would be held again this year, the students were submitting requests to the academy. There were many noble students with ample party experience, and they put in many requests.

"Sure enough... right! Then I want a beauty contest!!!"

Aleist jumped on board Eunius' cajolery, taking out something to write with and listing his ideas. The three who didn't know what a beauty contest was sought the contents from Aleist.

"What sort of this is that? Well, if it's beauty, it probably has something to do with the girls..."

As Luecke thought, Aleist explained with a smile. These sort of pre-school-festival events, in his past life, they were things he couldn't take part in even if he wanted to.

"Among the girls participating in the contest, you choose the most beautiful one. It's better to have more participants, and we can have active students take part as well. Hey, it's just a request... so let's put in a swimsuit judging."

"Beauty? Then Izumi has my vote! No, wait. Beauty... can Sakuya participate? If she can, then that'll be a hard choice."

Rudel showed some interest, and as expected, it had to do with Izumi. From how he asserted of Sakuya's beauty, it meant that to Rudel, Izumi was just about as precious to him as a dragon.

But the three men didn't notice that.

"No, that's not happening."

"Rudel, a dragon is..."

"You want a dragon to wear a swimsuit? Yeah, no."

Once Aleist got the idea together, Luecke was next. Recalling the previous party, he remembered how Aleist had caused a ruckus.

Aleist, who had nonchalantly accumulated romance events, had no insufficiency of these sort of topics.

"Last year was interesting. You know, when Aleist was assaulted by a woman. In that case, should we hold a confession in the hall?"

"... How long are you going to drag on that joke on?"

"Too bad for you. As long as we're alive, I'm going to tell everyone I meet."

As Eunius said that with a straight face, Rudel inflicted the final blow.

"That confession at the tournament was the same, but that was considerably famous. A confession in the sickroom, and one in a concluded space... ah, I'm talking about the places you seduced your fiancés. Right now, they've become popular landmarks."

"Why do you have to gouge out my heart!!? A majority of them were mistakes and misunderstandings! Even if a graduate, I'll leave my name in some strange way!"

"What are you talking about? You've already left it. The confession spots of Aleist, the god of love have become rumors all over the academy. Or so I heard from Izumi."

He had actualized the harem that was thought to be impossible, and even so, Aleist kept confessing. He was now being called the academy's god of love.

"Your info source is too often Izumi."

If Rudel had heard it from Izumi, Luecke was sure it wasn't mistaken. Izumi was popular among the girls. She had likely heard of the spots from her juniors and went to confirm them. Luecke's guess was on the mark, he wasn't wrong.

The fact Izumi was able to form connections with her junior girls was truly a good thing indeed.

Becoming prefect was a nice opportunity for her to expand her sphere of influence.

"Then let's add on a public confession. Now then, god of love, put it down on the form."

Overdoing things, Eunius had Aleist fill in an entry for public confession. Having come so far, Rudel was the only one who hadn't submitted an idea.

"Do you have any requests, Rudel?"

As Luecke asked for Rudel's request, Rudel made a bit of a troubled face.

"Me? I haven't taken parts in many parties. I don't know what would be good."

"Nothing? Just say whatever. We're just submitting ideas, and it's not like they'll actually use them."

Aleist put out a few ideas, and Rudel selected one from among them.



"The events for this year's graduation party have been decided, so let me relay them."

The staff gathered for a meeting to talk about the graduation party. They felt relief that the fundamental curriculum's class battles had ended without incident.

But there were quite a few problems with the graduation party. It was something that had started last year, and now that young nobles had begun to take notice, the party's contents were a problem.

Starting with food and drink, they got all sorts of requests for high-class goods. What's more, call in some beauties, and have them put on a show, there were quite a few requests coming in.

From among them, there were only a few that were actually possible to actualize. It was the teaching staff's hope that the status of the students who put in the requests would contain the dissatisfaction of the other students.

"It's impossible to assemble high-class foodstuff for all students, so here, we will be stressing the contents of the party itself."

They couldn't use too much money, but be that as it may, they had to make it fun. That was the challenge.

"Then first off, we recognize the request for the attendees to participate in costume, and next, a swimsuit judging among the female students... that sounds cold. We'll do something with magic. And skipping the public confession, let's look at the king's game."

All of Rudel's group's proposals had gone through. The biggest reason was that they were all plausible on an economic front.

"Is there really no problem with the beauty contest?"

A female teacher spoke in a bit of a harsh tone, but from the point of view of the men, they did have a desire to watch. More than anything, it would be a waste if they didn't do something to occupy the time.

"Participation isn't obligatory, after all. It's entirely possible we'll have no contestants at all."

Softly evading the female teacher's question, they moved onto the public confession. There were students whose positions made it troublesome to confess or be confessed to, so that would be a problem.

"Public confession... isn't that taking things too far?"

"Yeah, I feel the same. Some might let the drink get to them, but would anyone really confess before several hundred? At most, someone'll do it as a side show."

The male staff member acting as chairman began explaining the final submission.

"Last is the king's game. In this one, we pick a 'king' from among the participants and have all the others select a number. Without knowing those numbers, the king gets to give an order"

"Well, that one's a game, so it shouldn't be a problem."

The headmaster was sure the last game would have far less issue than the first three. Those around were arguing a little about how the beauty contest was going too far.

But from the knowledge Aleist had brought with him, no one had noticed.

The headmaster was greeting the graduation of the generation with so many problem children, and he was overcome with relief and loneliness. Rather than the party, he was happy they were able to safely graduate.

So no one noticed. That the king's game was the most problematic of all...

Chapter 93

Once the bell rung six, Rudel stopped swinging his sword, and wiped off his sweat.

He gazed at the backs of all the students in the dorm courtyard, who had started on their way to the dining hall after hearing the sound.

The early morning training he had done from his enrollment had continued on to his graduation. From the eyes of a stranger, it might have been something praiseworthy.

But to Rudel, and the students who trained in a similar manner, it was only normal. If they slacked off, then that's just how far they'd fall behind the others.

One could say Eunius and Aleist were extraordinary. The two of them didn't train in the morning, but they did devote their time to it during other hours. Their life styles simply weren't suited to train in the early warning.

"So it ends today."

Wiping his sweat, Rudel sat on the spot and looked up at the sky.

He recalled all the time he had spend here since he first came. He had met Vargas during morning training, and Vargas had been the first friend he ever made.

If he saw any troubled students, he did try to call out, but his status would always get in the way, and it would never go as smoothly as it had with Vargas.

Personality problems and the air Rudel gave off had become factors that prevented others from approaching him. While he hadn't noticed it, the fact that he had become strongest in the academy was also to blame.

Rather than being fond of Rudel, his underclassmen were in awe. The class years one and two below his remembered the matters with Chlust and Fritz, and kept their distances.

When it came to underclassmen below that, Rudel's exorbitant ability would create distance. There weren't any commoner students who would even think to approach the future archduke and white knight that was Rudel.

Young nobles would only greet him, at most. Feeling a bit of his own awkwardness, Rudel made a bitter smile. While to each his own, he would have no choice but to deal with people from now on.

That he thought that meant that Rudel had matured. When he entered the academy, he largely didn't understand the importance of human interaction.

"Now then, I guess I'll prepare for graduation."

Standing, he headed for the dining hall.

He had prepared for the sake of this day, and alongside his loneliness, he felt just a little happy.



The graduation ceremony ended without incident and from afternoon, the academy was busy with the final preparations for the party.

Within all that, the culprit who had devised this new event was delighted.

"King's game!!"

While Fina wasn't allowed to go out while the party was being prepared, in exchange, Mii was busy at work. In her Mii-less room, she was making a ruckus. It wasn't quite possible for the princess Fina to help set up the party.

The year before, Rudel and the others had taken part, causing quite an awkward air. But taking her safety and status in consideration, the academy was able to ask her to refrain. In Fina's place, Mii was spending every day, busily preparing for the event.

"Hah, what is it, princess? Are you scheming something again?"

Correcting the positioning of her glasses with the middle finger of her right hand, Sophina readied herself in her heart for Fina's next spurt of irrationality. She needed to make sure she wasn't surprised no matter what she hear.

Sophina, who could practically be called Fina's retainer at this point, was used to dealing with her.

"... Sophina, look at this schedule. Right here, it has the words King's Game written in."

"That is quite a discourteous name. Shall we request the academy to change it?"

"You fool! It is only those small in caliber who complain about all the petty details. The problem is the contents. 'The king's orders are absolute!' What do you think about that?"

"... I think it's a tad strange for an event at a party. If someone orders another to die on the spot, then the atmosphere will take quite a peculiar turn."

As Sophina spoke of brutal detail, Fina criticized her expressionlessly.

"How foolish. This is why your marriage interviews continue to fail. This time makes thirty two, does it? You're on your way there! Courtois' high score of fifty six is right before your eyes."

The high score for marriage interviews among nobles- particularly women- was fifty six. While marriages for royalty were close to obligations, for

those low in status and relatively free, both sides were able to turn down the matchups.

And in Courtois, the more girly ones were the most popular.

"Why do you know about that!? A-and, I'm not aiming to update the score..."

Having failed once more, Sophina recalled her delicate partner. While they attended the academy, a large portion of nobles would often skip classes. Her partner was unable to see a splendid knight like Sophina as girly in any shape or form.

Rudel's generation was rare among nobles, where the future archduke was earnest, so they followed his lead. Looking at it from that side, Rudel and the others had set a good example.

In order to sell themselves to these future heads of the factions, it would be best to be earnest. The nobles had made calculated, objective judgements.

"... That's what they all say as their numbers go up. And once they hold the high score, their hearts break every time. Putting that aside, the problem is that this game is being held in a festive hall... and that means the orders can be pervy as hell, right? I mean, they'll all have a bit of drink in their systems, and it's the final time they can fool around as students! Don't you think this is the perfect place to seal the deal?"

Becoming a little fearful of Fina's expressionless zeal, Sophina cautioned her she was going too far.

"Sealing the deal at a party is a little..."

"Oh? How far are you imagining? I was talking about a kiss. Hey, Sophina, just what sort of indecent things did you imagine? Hey!?"

"I-in that case, you just have to get your feelings across in the public confession."

As Sophina forcefully changed the subject, Fina grinned within, choosing to play along.

"Even if I confess in that game, anyone would think it was a joke, right? If we kiss, and I take on a heartrending attitude, everyone around will go and imagine it on their own."

This girl's dark, or so Sophina made light of her master when Fina suddenly turned serious.

"But in order to do that, I'll have to become king and I'll have to know master's numbers... hey, Sophina?"

Understanding what Fina was thinking and what she desired, Sophina could only silently nod.

(Hah, what am I even doing.)



In the party hall, the preparations had finished, and the graduates in disguise started appearing one after the next.

From among them, Eunius in his Viking costume looked considerably real. The man in question was tall in stature and muscular in build. His form as he wore a horned helm of wood, carrying with him a large shield and axe, was truly that of a bandit.

In contrast, Luecke had with him an eastern garment and weapon.

He had asked a blacksmith Rudel was acquainted with to prepare an eastern kimono. His long hair was collected at the back, and his costume was made to enjoy a foreign culture. His katana was made of bamboo, and Luecke had taken a bit of a liking to it.

"What's this? When a bean sprout wears clothes like that, he only looks needlessly wimpier."

To the end of the end, the two of them spat cynicism, but it had lost the bite it had at the start. More than that, it had become something of a greeting between them.

"When I thought I spotted a bandit here, it was just the musclehead. It suits you so well, I'm shaking in my boots."

As the two of them glared at one another within the hall, Rudel stepped into the space between them.

"Stop it, both of you! Izumi said no fighting today. Can't you let it slide, on my face today?"

As Rudel entered the hall a little late, the two of them lost their words.

"... Eh?"

"Y-yeah."

There was no helping their befuddlement. Before them, of black and brown fur... was Rudel in a dog helmet. That lovable stuffed animal expression gave off quite a lax impression.

A fluffy tail, and stiff, standing ears... The mouth was slim, and perhaps it could look like a wolf. But those large arms and legs, and that large face... there was no way for the two of them to know who it was. Only by the mention of Izumi's name could they know it was Rudel inside.

"Dude, what's with that getup?"

As Eunius pointed at Rudel, Rudel took off the headpiece to show his face.

"This? It's a dog. I worked hard to prepare it. I didn't want to spend too much money, after all. It's all hand-made."

"Well that's quite something. No, that's not the point. Why a dog?"

Luecke was surprised by the hand-made part, but more than that, he couldn't understand why he had chosen a dog. The students around were

also directing their eyes at Rudel.

"The truth is, we keep a dog back home."

Rudel informed them of the fact his house kept a dog, and Eunius waited for the reason to come after that. But Rudel stayed silent.

"... And?"

"And what?"

Seeing the two unsatisfied with his answer, Rudel tilted his head.

Luecke and Eunius looked at Rudel, mulling over what to say, when Izumi appeared.

Rather than a disguise, Izumi had prepared the clothing she wore in the orient, participating in a kimono. Her hair was fastened with an ornate hairpin.

"Rudel, you chose something quite conspicuous."

Rudel put his headpiece back down, showing Izumi the rest of his costume. After he did a full turn, the three of them clapped their hands at the considerable workmanship.

"Right? It's handmade."

Rudel showed a peculiar talent, but the three of them had gotten around to thinking anything went with him. Looking around, the most common costume was the girls simply wearing male uniforms.

Many men wore mantles, dressing as magicians.

If there was another conspicuous figure, then surely it was Aleist. He had come in his black knight armor. This was something he had worn on the requests of those around him.

It was a result of his fiancés demanding to see his gallant form

Spotting the usual members, Aleist raced up in his armor.

"Oyy. Huh? Where's Rudel?"

His black armor was thorny, and his helmet sprouted two golden horns, similar to the viking helmet. The surroundings raised their voices in surprised.

"Amazing."

"I heard it's the black knight's armor."

"Kickass."

It was rated surprisingly high, giving Aleist a moment of relief. Even if he knew it wouldn't be so, he had just a bit of worry they would call him a sufferer of eighth grade syndrome.

"Aleist, is that really a disguise?"

While Luecke wondered if armor counted in the realm of disguises, Aleist sent a glance over to the animal suit.

"No, I think this is more than enough dress up for me... what's this costume supposed to be? A wolf?"

As Aleist touched the ear of Rudel's costume, a clear ominous sound came out. Rudel confirmed the area around his head to find that one of his perky hears had slumped down lim.

As Rudel sat down on the spot, Izumi followed through for him. Because of the costume, it was impossible to see what expression he was making underneath.

When that lovingly made oversized stuffed animal fell into a slump, it was exceedingly cute. But the one inside was depressed.

"R-Rudel? It's still cute like this."

"... The ears took an especially large amount of time."

Seeing him depressed, Aleist had to step in to encourage him. Luecke looked around nervously.

"No, no, this has got its own flavor to it. Yeah, you look more dog-like than before."

"... Really?"

"Aleist, you..."

On Luecke's prodding gaze, Aleist realized the one inside was Rudel and apologized.

"I-I'm sorry! I never thought it would break."

"No, it's my fault for making something prone to breaking. Next time, I'll make something of better quality."

"That's the spirit, Rudel!"

While Izumi cheered Rudel on, the other three thought.

(He's making another?)

As everyone desperately tried to cheer Rudel up, the headmaster appeared in the hall. He gave some simple greetings, telling them it was their last event at the academy, and encouraging them to enjoy it.



'Well then! Let the first Academy beauty contest commence!!'

A fourth year student wore a striking outfit on stage as he took the lead. Necer actually expecting the beauty contest to take place, Aleist was a little excited.

The reason being Millia had entered. Her friend had told her she would undoubtedly win if she took part, so the girl in question reluctantly joined in.

But not knowing what a swimsuit was to begin with, Millia was surprised when those undergarment-like pieces were delivered right beforehand.

From the fourth year, Fina and Mii were participating. And to speak to celebrities, Izumi was goaded by Rudel into taking part.

"I never thought they'd actually hold it."

Holding a glass in one hand, three men watched over the area a little ways away from the students gathered around the stage.

"Hmm? Where's Rudel?"

Luecke searched out Rudel, who had left his sight before he had noticed it. Eunius was the same. In this long-awaited heated event, if Rudel wasn't there, it would lose its flavor.

"He'll show up once Izumi comes out, right? Rather, he was wearing something considerably conspicuous, so... wait, oy!!"

Eunius looked at the platform, and noticed the tail of a familiar costume sticking out of the side of the stage.

"Lucky. That's a special box seat, isn't it?"

As Aleist looked on with envy, the event commenced. Girls from fourth and third year made their entries wearing swimsuits of low coverage.

"Oh, not bad at all."

A slackening expression on his face, Eunius quite enjoyed the beauty contest Aleist had propped. Luecke pretended he wasn't interested, but his eyes were firmly directed at the participants.

It was just at that moment that Fina and Mii appeared in cute swimwear. The hall's enthusiasm reached its peak. It wasn't just the men, the women called out as well to cheer on their friends.

In secret, there were bets being placed over who would win.

"Oy, someone climbed onto the stage."

Luecke directed a glance at the man who had climbed onto the stage, while Aleist and Eunius breathed out some sighs. The drink getting to him, a student had gotten into a stupor and climbed onto the platform to try laying hands on one of the participants.

"Ah, it's Rudel."

But there, Rudel appeared in his costume, kicking the student into the air.

Kicked by a stuffed animal, the student was naturally enraged. There, Rudel took off the headpiece and showed his real face. In an instant, the students around the stage went quiet.

'Ah!, by the way! If you try climbing on stage or doing anything mean to the participants, mister wolf will send you flying, so keep that in mind.'

The mc leaked a late warning. But this time, Rudel closed in on the mc. Seeing that scene, Eunius raised a grand laugh.

"That Rudel's definitely telling him it's a dog! And look. The guy he kick's woken from his drink and turned pale!"

"Eunius, you're laughing too much."

Luecke tried to restrain Eunius, but on the contrary, when one of the three Lords was laughing so loudly, the hall was once more enveloped in laughter.

"Ooooh!! Millia's coming out!! She looks kinda embarrassed, but that just makes it better!"

Aleist excitedly looked at Millia who entered the chaotic stage. She had covered her lower half in cloth, so it couldn't be seen, but she was wearing a bikini with high exposure.

Her one leg and thigh that escaped the cloth had a sense of eroticism to it. Her embarrassment needlessly delighted the men more.

Apart from Aleist, the elf males had discarded their usual levelheadedness as they exploded in delight.

But Aleist's other fiancés were taking part as well. They were looking at him so excited over Millia from their spots atop the stage.

Eunius covered his face with his left hand as he looked at the ceiling. Luecke looked at Aleist's fiancés making eerie smiles on stage and pitied the man.

When the girls had put their all into appearing in the contest, Aleist had barely even looked at them.

But in the next instant, the men cried out.

"Hey! Oy!!"

"Hmm? Wha!?"

"Shirasagi-san, that's too amazing..."

Izumi was the last to enter, and she entered wearing a considerably hazardous bikini. The one in question didn't act as if she was particularly embarrassed.

Perhaps to match her hair, her black bikini covered an exceedingly small area. Apart from covering the important parts, it was almost all string.

One poor move, and perhaps something would come out, or so the guys hopes got up.

Rudel was wearing a costume, so even if he applauded, he could only let off a soft sound. By the way, the student who he kicked was nearby, being forced into clapping.

Among all the participants, Izumi was the most extreme.



With Izumi's entrance stealing away the flow all at once, Fina panicked within.

(Black hairrr!! That woman casually pulled off what I could never do!!)

Fina had worn a cute frilled swimsuit with low exposure. She and Mii then directed their eyes at the adult swimsuit Izumi wore.

Mii and Fina wore the same type of different colors. Their forms emphasized their youths, rousing intense popularity from a portion of the student body.

Fina did try to pick out something more extreme. But from her body build and atmosphere, and the fact she was royalty, she had chosen something cute and low in exposure.

For that choice held the highest prospects of victory. Contrived as it might be, it was also the right choice. In all actuality, there were many men directing their eyes at the two of them.

"Princess, Izumi-san is amazing."

Without any hidden sides, Mii really did think she was amazing. But Fina was different.

"Right. Amazing (Goddammit, to think she would choose something so extreme... master must have put her up to it! Oh, master, you really are so... adorable!)"

Seeing Rudel in his costume, Fina was so excited inside she thought she might leak her drool. If the chance presented itself, she thought she just

might assault him.

But the problem was that Rudle never left an opening. On the eyes of a hunter staring down its pray, rudel felt a chill on his spine.

"Hmm? What's this? I got the feeling something was aiming at me..."

As Rudel looked around in his costume, his movements excited Fina to no end.

And the curtains opened on the academy's final event.

Chapter 94

"Well now, that really was a splendid contest."

"Yeah, I never thought it would be that extreme."

A grinning Aleist and Eunius were discussing the beauty contest that had just come to a close. Luecke was nonchalantly nodding along.

"Those poses they struck in that last self-appeal session were nice. I never thought Izumi would make such a pose, but in the end, Millia won hands down."

Right, it ended as Millia's landslide victory.

To the end of the end, the tension born from her sheer embarrassment had caused her to fail. During her self-appeal session, she bit her tongue, and as she made a pose, she stepped on the long cloth wrapped around her waist.

By treading on that cloth, not only was it removed, her top bra was taken with it, making her pose one where she covered her chest with her hands. On its severity, she monopolized the votes of the male student body and won.

By the way, the runner-up was Fina, and following on from her, Izumi placed as well.

"Yeah, I'll never forget that scene!"

Through his armor, Aleist clenched his fist victoriously. But as the beauty contest was over, of course, his fiancés had descended the stage.

Having changed from their swimsuits into their costumes, the girls were making dark smiles behind Aleist.

Luecke and Eunius decided to change location at once, going off to search for Rudel and Izumi. From behind, they could hear Aleist's screams.

"Eh? No way! You were in it too? ... That was a joke! I'm just kidding!!
Aaaah!!"

Right as Aleist cried out, the two of them were able to spot Rudel and Izumi walking side by side.



'Following on, it's confession time!! Now that we've all got a spot of drink, everyone who wants to use this last chance at the academy to confess to the one they admire, raise your hands!!'

The mc was enthusiastic, but the hall wasn't quite on board. Even if you asked them to confess at the end of the end, it would only be troubling.

In the first place, an extent of the students already had partners. If they were nobles, they'd have engagements, and based on the person, there were even some who, while students, surrounded themselves with numerous women.

First on that list were Aleist and Eunius.

The hall was enveloped in a dubious air, and there were only a few students who took part, half for fun. Within all that, some commoner students had gathered in a separate space.

Starting with Fritz, they were students of the three-year curriculum.

When it was decided Fritz would become captain of the royal guard, he had invited some of his close friends to join as well. Those who gathered with Fritz' followers.

In that hall of dubious enthusiasm, he held a glass as he looked around.

"What's wrong, Fritz? You're not taking part?"

One of his classmates suggested that he take part in this side show. As captain of the royal guard, with more influence than the captain of a knight brigade, Fritz did have a certain level of popularity among the girls.

Especially the students who wanted to rise from commoners, and low-ranking nobles would often call out to him. But Fritz had Aileen, so he couldn't participate in this sort of event.

"No, I'd rather not become a laughingstock in a farce like this. More importantly, this party isn't free. Do those nobles really get it?"

While those around him exchanged jokes, Fritz alone hadn't read the mood.

"Yeah, y-you're right."

Following on from Fritz, the commoner knights who dreamed of promotion forcefully sterned up their faces. In truth, they at least wanted to enjoy their last days at the academy.

The eyes of that group with a dicey air fell on Rudel in his costume and Izumi.

They were smiling as they looked over the students confessing to boys in jest, and the students receiving those confessions not knowing they were jokes.

Fritz instantly down the juice that filled the glass in his hands.

"The noble-for-hobby who ignored the palace's orders to become a dragoon, and the foreign woman who seduced him. It's rotten, the current Kingdom of Courtois."

At a glance, Fritz' opinion wasn't correct, but it wasn't wrong either. If someone who didn't know looked at Rudel and Izumi, it certainly wouldn't be strange if they imagined such a relationship.

No matter how those two thought of one another.

"Hey, did Rudel really reject enlistment in the royal guard? Is that really allowed?"

As a weak-willed-looking one of his followers mouthed something that could be taken as supporting Rudel, Fritz' expression changed.

"We're dealing with a noble, and an archduke at that! You should know it isn't strange for them to do such a thing. Those rotten nobles have to do something for the sake of this country."

On Fritz' opinion, everyone nodded.

Even if he had an environment to learn, an environment to study, if he only looked at the information he wanted to believe, he could only strengthen his biased viewpoint.

Laughing (?) with his friends, Fritz glared at Rudel. But the two of them were exceedingly similar.

If Rudel didn't have anyone to believe in, there was a possibility he would fixate on becoming a dragoon and ruin himself. The difference was whether they were able to accept others or not.

Rudel who saw dreams of dragoons, and Fritz who dreamed of heroes.

After coming so far, the gap had grown so large it could no longer be filled in.

"I'm definitely going to change this country."

Glaring at Rudel who clung onto Izumi in his costume, Fritz muttered.



In the hall, making use of the confession time, Sophina had moved behind the scenes.

Obtaining the numbered tags that would be used in the king's game, Sophina appeared before Fina. The two of them met hidden in a corner of

the hall, hurriedly going into preparations.

"Princess, the preparations are complete."

"You've done a splendid job. As expected of a high knight."

"... I am glad I was able to answer to your expectations. (Even if you praise me over something like this, it doesn't make me happy at all...)"

Swiftly sticking on a marker, Fina got a grasp of the characteristics of the other number tags. But that alone made her anxious, so she directed her face at Sophina.

Dropping her shoulders, Sophina quietly nodded.



'Now that those confessions are behind us, it's finally time to begin the king's game!! And what a discourteously named game it is, but we have Fina Courtois-sama's stamp of approval, so we're going with that! Don't be a stiff, and join in. Now then, Fina-sama will be participating in the first game.'

Alongside that enthusiastic introduction from the mc, Fina reservedly waved her hand as she walked to the center of the circle the students had made. To her side, Sophina escorted her as a guard.

"It is my pleasure."

'And while I'd like to put rank aside, we can't start it off without our future archdukes!'

Being introduced, Rudel and the others stepped up as well. As Fina was taking part, they had selected out earnest participants who could read the mood for the first round.

While it was dubious whether or not Rudel could read the mood, there was no changing the fact he was earnest. But Aleist had been removed from the first round's members.

'Well then, you'll all be drawing lots from this box! We'll start off with Fina-sama.'

As he said that, the student on duty held out the box of numbered sticks to Fina. There were round tags stuck on the ends of each stick, and the tags indicated their number or king status.

"Then if you'll beg my pardon (Fwahahaha!! I am the king!!)"

Picking out one of the sticks, Fina discretely retrieved the marker she had stuck onto it. Pulling the king's tag without issue, she resolved herself.

(Hmm, that was dangerous. I always lose focus when I get this far, and I was one step from doing something crazy. Today is my big chance to get master in my hands! If I fail here, it'll be a real pain later.)

After Eunius and Luecke pulled numbers, Rudel was wearing his costume, so it was considerably hard to grasp one. On his gestures, Fina thought she would start drooling.

(Quit it, Fina! That's just a fake fluffy. I have to hold a stalwart heart... and yet, I must hate myself for wanting to assault him!!)

Seeing Rudel grasp a stick in both hands and pull it, Fina fought the urges within her head. She thought her heart would be stolen by that cute appearance and bearing.

But even so, she didn't let her guard down. She sent a glance at Sophina, who silently sent the signal to her high knight subordinates. One of the high knights stationed behind Rudel confirmed the number on Rudel's lot.

For the sake of this day, she had stationed those with good eyes, even among all her subordinates. The abilities of these talented girls were being put to use in the king's game.

'Is everyone ready? Then who's the king~!!?'

As the mc raised his voice, Fina laughed inside that she had been waiting for this as she softly raised her hand. From appearance alone, she was a

reserved beautiful girl.

As she was doing that, Fina informed her of the number on Rudel's stick. Carefully confirming it, Fina couldn't stop her laughter within. But as she directed her eyes at Rudel, she noticed a certain something.

"Um, it looks like it's me (Master's number is five... then the order...?)"

Chatting amiably with Luecke and Eunius, Rudel's outfit was cute, and there were no problems with his gestures. But something was lacking.

"The sort of order she gives in the first round will decide the flow for the rest of the game."

"For real? Then even a kiss is safe, right?"

"With the princess? I think that's completely out, Eunius."

"No, she could order one number to kiss another. Aleist has a talent when it comes to these sorts of things."

Luecke praised Aleist for proposing this game. But Aleist himself was currently receiving punishment for ruining his fiancés' moods during the beauty contest.

"Sure enough, if it's this game, then they could use it at the shops too. That guy just might be a genius!"

Eunisu decided to start a trend at the shops he frequented. And with that, Aleist had left yet another legend.

"I don't have talent when it comes to these things. I'm a bit jealous."

Wearing his costume, Rudel made a bit of a thinking gesture. But even if Fina was satisfied with his appearance and cute gestures, she wasn't satisfied with his speech.

If only his appearance wasn't as cute, if only his actions weren't so lovely.

(..... Unforgivable. That way of speech is unforgivable! If you've already gone that far, then do something about your speech!! Just a little more. A little more, and it'd be perfect!!)

'Well then, Fina-sama, if you'll please give an order!'

"Princess, your order please (Hah, forcing me to work in a party of young kids... I want to go home)"

Hearing Sophina's spiritless voice, Fina saw the completion of her goal of kissing Rudel appear before her eyes. But within Fina, a new desire was being born.

(Kissing master... but it's hard to abandon the thought of adding 'woof' to his sentences. Wait a second, Fina! You cannot be shaken here!)

As her heart came into conflict, the angel of her heart whispered out.

'What are you doing!? Fulfill your initial objective. Use this opportunity to obtain master!!'

There, the demon whispered in her ears.

'Hehe, are you sure? If you let this chance slip by, there might not be a next, you know? Kisses and sealing deals, you can do all manner of pervy things however you want afterward. Your authority exists to be abused, right? You have no choice but to add a woof to his words here and now!'

On the devil's words, the angel within Fina voiced her approval.

'Oh my, you do have a point. Then the right choice is to add 'woof' to his sentences! Oh this is simply arousing!!'

By the drooling angel and demon within Fina, her direction had been changed. Harding her resolve, Fina boldly handed down her order with expressionless face.

And at that moment, Fina was shaken.



"Erk, she told me to add woof to the end of every sentence, woof."

"Isn't that fine? I think it's cuter that way."

The king's game continued, but taking the number of students into account, there were few who could take part in each game. Rudel had left the game early, switching out with the students waiting their turn.

Having come so far, Fina's objective ended in failure. But she was satisfied, so perhaps it wasn't a problem.

Rudel- forced to add woof to his words- and Izumi parted from the place the king's game was held to have a hand at the food. Luecke and Eunius were still playing, so the two of them were killing time.

It went without saying that the two men had created time for Rudel and Izumi to be together.

"Even so, your swimsuit was surprising, woof."

"Y-you think? They said the participants could keep the swimsuit afterwards, so I chose out the one I liked... did you dislike that swimsuit?"

"Not at all! ... woof. I thought it was really pretty, woof."

Still wearing his dog costume, Rudel took Izumi's hand. Izumi seemed happy Rudel had taken a liking to it.

"That's good. I didn't think it was a little extreme, but I'm glad I chose it."

The one who chose the swimsuit was Izumi herself, and it seems she had considered it just a little extreme. Rudel went on to praise her swimsuit form.

"I got really excited. There was barely any string on your back, and it almost looked as if you weren't wearing anything at all, woof! But if possible, I wouldn't want you to show it to anyone else, woof."

"Yeah, I'll be careful."

Giggling, Izumi found Rudel's slightly frantic attitude to be quite pleasant.

There, having run away from his fiancés, Aleist came seeking help. He was wearing his armor, so when he moved, they could hear the sounds of clashing metal.

As Aleist was wearing something conspicuous, he decided to use Rudel, someone his fiancés couldn't approach so easily.

"S-save me, you two! At this rate, I'm going to have a hole in my stomach."

As Aleist appeared in lament, this time, Luecke and Eunius appeared. Both of them took Aleist in with weary eyes.

"Why don't you read the mood?" "Read the mood, dammit."

To the words of the two who held the same impression, Aleist tilted his head. But even if he tilted his head in gold-horned black armor, it didn't look cute at all.



The hall was growing rowdy over the king's game.

A large number of students awaited their turn to take part, and Izumi had been detained by some underclassmen girls, separating from Rudel.

The four men had gathered by the wall, but Aleist had gotten some drink in him, and with his fatigue, he had fallen asleep against it.

"He really fell asleep."

As Eunius made a game of prodding Aleist with his finger, Luecke let out a sigh.

"Just leave him be. After they stuck to him like that, of course he'd be tired... good grief, he'll burn a hole in his stomach someday."

"Sure enough, woof."

As Rudel and the others said, Aleist's fiancés had launched their attack. They had contained their usual pace but even so, it seems they were hard on him.

"Ah, but his shouts during Millia's wardrobe malfunction were painful. He was chastised for them quite a bit, this guy."

Eunius was talking about the time Millia lost her upper garments. Excited, Aleist had some drink in his system, and he ended up shouting out.

From atop the stage, his engagement partners were all watching him. There was no excuse.

"... Well, the way things are going, Millia will probably be engaged to Aleist too. Looking at the elves as a whole, this matter with Millia is a stroke of good luck. The talks should go forward regardless of her intent."

Luecke tilted his lass, swishing the drink inside, and watching it move. Once talks turned serious, Eunius looked up at the ceiling.

Rudel alone, because of his costume, was unable to put out a serious air.

"Hah, becoming an adult means you've got to become a stiff, huh."

Eunius down the contents of the glass in his hand, making a bit of a lonesome face.

"You can't be a student forever. We're the same. After this, we'll be in service to the palace for a bit, but we've each got our factions."

Originally, they were houses that were supposed to be in conflict. Even if Rudel was a separate story, the Arses House still held a faction. He couldn't stay irrelevant.

"What a pain."

On Eunius' words, Luecke could give no response. But before that, Rudel had something he had to do.

His promise with the black fog... perhaps you could call it fate, if he didn't fight against the large flow, he would never be able to move forwards.

"I'm a dragoon, woof. It's customary to head to the border for a while... woof."

"No, you're special, so you'll probably be serving at the palace, right? This sleeping guy is entering the defenders that were just put together, and he's suddenly a candidate for captain."

Eunius corrected Rudel's statement, but Rudel had a vague understanding. There was a flow he couldn't do anything against, and he was being swept up in its currents...

But he hadn't given up on his struggle.

He had promised to fight against it, and it was one of the reasons he became a dragoon. Rudel suddenly felt as if the still-human Sakuya was standing beside him.

(I'll definitely honor my promises.)

It was almost as if Sakuya made a bit of a sorrowful face. But the feeling she was there soon faded away.

"Well, as long as Rudel's there, the Arses faction should build some momentum. We won't be the two great factions for long. Rudel, you better prepare yourself. Even if you're the dragoon, you're the white knight. It's not like there's no possibility you'll be the next king. No, among us, you have the highest chances."

Luecke looked at Aleist just once. But he couldn't imagine the man leaning asleep against the wall becoming king.

"If you become king, you'll be clashing with us."

Even if Rudel became king, if their politics collided, then the archdukes would oppose. Friendly relations from their school days wouldn't mean anything there. No, those around wouldn't let them have meaning.

The three fell silent, but on Izumi's approach, Eunius opened his mouth.

"Well, it was fun. For now, I guess that's enough."

"Sure enough."

"That's right, woof."

Rudel was faithfully upholding his order. And that was something Luecke and Eunius couldn't help but laugh at.

The fact that they couldn't keep it tense to the end left the three of them laughing.



In the academy where the graduation ceremony had concluded, the headmaster held his head.

Having come so far, the students' guardians had come forth to complain that the party's contents had been too extreme. The name of the king's fame was approved by Fina, so it didn't become a problem.

But in the beauty contest, boys aside, the girls and their parents came to complain. This was largely because of Izumi and Millia.

While they couldn't approve of the contest itself, they complained that they couldn't approve of those extreme pieces of swimwear either. Among them were some of the students who took part, simply being sore losers.

And while confession time did become a bit of a problem, among the students, there were some boys who jokingly confessed to one another, and it was praised as being funnier than the average comedy.

No one said anything particular about the costumes, but after that, the academy received a considerable number of complaints.

The fact that they were praised to an extent was the silver lining on a dark cloud. It was well known as a party where the students had made lasting memories.

Of the enrolled students, there were many looking forward to next year's party.

"Come this far, to think my sense of relief would backfire... I never would have thought Izumi-kun and Millia-kun would..."

It's not as if they hadn't been wary of Rudel and co, but the problem had come from somewhere they had never even expected, making the headmaster hold his head.

"Hah... well, there's only one year left in my term. It did make for a nice memory."

Recalling when Rudel had come to the academy, his face went unusually lax. It was quite some trouble, but remembering how it was fun in its own way, the headmaster continued through his processing of complaints.

... But because of the problem child who paid visit to the academy two years later, the headmaster's troubles would continue.

That the problem child would cause his term to be extended was something the headmaster no way of knowing.

"Now then, I've got to do my best for my final year."

Chapter 95

From early in the morning, a large number of knights had gathered at the palace.

They were all prim and proper, and even the sounds of voices couldn't be heard.

In the country of Courtois, the appointment ceremony of its elites- the high knights, dragoons... and royal guard- was carried out in April. This was a standing tradition and the unchanging start of the year for all knights.

Those with excellent grades at the academy, those whose efforts as knights were evaluated, and those who had accumulated achievements were chosen as elites, and given the right to attend the ceremony.

Here, the new knights to represent Courtois were lined up.

Rudel was boldly lined shoulder to shoulder with them. Unlike his time as a student, his arms had passed through the sleeves of the official dragoon ceremonious knight garments.

If anything differed, it was that he was there as one from an archduke house, lined up in the very front row, his ceremonial knight clothing made of valuable white material. From the fabric to the gold decorations, even among the knight clothes the craftsmen had prepared for the elites, his was surely of the highest workmanship.

He stood by Aleist, who was participating as an exception, and they certainly stood out.

Aleist's enlistment in the defenders was decided. But there was no way they could have the black knight- a key figure in the nation's founding- not take

part in the ceremony.

As if to contrast Rudel, he wore truly beautiful knight garments fashioned with black as the base and silver ornaments.

Perhaps he was nervous as his face was serious to no end.

Since their graduation from the academy, starting with Rudel, Luecke, Eunius, Aleist, Izumi... and Fritz had been granted extravagant knight clothing to stand in the ranks.

It was rare for graduates to line in the ceremony on that very same year, and apart from Rudel's group, the others were those who had put in at least a few years of knight work and had their efforts or achievements recognized.

But it wasn't unprecedented for early academy graduates to stand among them.

Called a genius, Cattleya stood for her ceremony when she was only seventeen.

What's more, that was after she was forcibly graduated like Fritz. When Cattleya obtained her red dragon, the dragoons were a majority gray dragons with very few natural ones.

For the dragoon knight brigade that prided their contracts with dragons, to speak to the contrary, a lack of natural dragon contractors could raise doubts that the organization was weakening.

It came at a bad time, and Cattleya was held up high as a genius.

In that reception hall where Rudel and the others stood in file, the high ceiling was held up by large pillars. Prepared for the day's ceremony, the carpet was brand new.

The morning air was, at most, cool on their skins, and the lined knights felt it gave just the right feel. Rudel could feel himself growing tense.

In such a hall, the orchestra informed them of the king's appearance.

There were other authorities walking behind him as he came out before the knights.

Without the slightest signal, those elite knights simultaneously fell to their knees and lowered their heads to signal their devotion. The king was satisfied with those splendid movements.

Moving just his eyes, the king looked at Rudel in his bright knight garments.

(So he's finally come this far. He does seem to be quite the stubborn one, but that's all the better.)

Seeing Rudel who hadn't given up to the end and had become a dragoon, the king rejoiced without changing his expression. Rudel had sent a letter saying he would save much more people as a dragoon than as an archduke.

The king himself had a hand in the royal guard that would break that promise. But by his daughter's secret dealings, those plans went largely amiss and he became a dragoon.

As one of the authorities signaled the start of the ceremony, the proceedings went on in solemnity.



After the ceremony, the new recruits were gathered in the rooms allotted to each knight brigade.

From their status, Luecke and Eunius had special standings, and treating it as training, the two of them would spend a few years at the palace. Luecke as a civil official and Eunius as a military officer, they would be stationed in normal knight brigade.

But the two of them were future archdukes. Despite being newcomers, they were granted considerable posts.

Rudel sat in the dragoon meeting room alongside the other new recruits as he awaited the captain's arrival. This year, there was a change in captain and it was decided that they would use this opportunity to reorganize their formation.

The newbie dragoons calmly awaited the captain and vice-captain's arrival. It was there that the meeting room's door was slammed open with good momentum.

Before everyone could feel surprised, they stood from their seats and corrected their postures.

"Oh! That's quite a nice reaction. Looks like I can count on this year."

A middle aged man of tidily kept beard looked over the faces of the new recruits and nodded. His hair was silver, all swept to the back, while his face was pristine.

He was shorted in stature than the vice-captain, but he had a muscular build.

In contrast, the vice-captain had a scar on his face. His orange, wavy long hair was collected at the back, and tall in height, he brought to mind the image of a seasoned warrior.

A light captain and a reliable vice-captain- that was the impression the newcomers held.

"Captain, promptly tell them of our schedule henceforth. I have work to do."

To that vice-captain, whose intensity even reached his voiced, that captain pat him on the shoulder as he told him he would go by his own pace.

"Don't be so stiff, Alejandro. Deepening our friendship with these guys is included in our job description! Your daughter's here too, and if you don't tell the men not to lay a hand on her, she'll be eaten right up."

"Oldart, shouldn't you be the one doing something about that loose personality of yours?"

From the vice captain's fed-up face, the captain turned to the new recruits. Directing his white teeth, he commenced his self introduction.

"I'm Oldart Billums, high and mighty captain of the dragoon brigade. I'm a charmer in his prime turning forty eight this year, you better remember that. By the way, my partner's a gray dragon."

Once he finished a light introduction, Oldart looked at his vice-captain.

"... Alejandro Campbell. My partner is a wind dragon."

Once he finished his simple introduction, Alejandro handed the documents he brought to one of the new recruits. That nearby newbie took his share before circulating the rest of the forms.

His eyes fell only once on a female knight, but those around didn't pay it any particular mind. Oldart alone was directing him a detestable grin.

After making an unpleasant face, Alejandro gave a simple explanation of what was to come.

"During the new recruit training, the previous generation's captain and vice-captain will serve as instructors and lead you. There will be other active members serving as instructors, and they will pound the fundamentals of being a dragoon into you within the next half year."

Oldart crossed his arms, nodding as he added onto the explanation.

"In half a year, we'll have an unveiling to the public. Though we'll just be flying in formation around the palace. Until then, you'll be doing grunt work for three months! And in the remaining three months, you'll be mastering flying in formation. By the way! I made sure all the active dragoons instructing you are manly men!"

The new recruits reacted poorly to those words. Rudel simply wondered if there was a reason he wouldn't make a woman instructor.

"This year, we have a future archduke coming in, and the higher-ups told us to let our beauts teach him... that would make me jealous as hell, so I

decided to do some harassment."

As Oldart confessed his true feelings with a smile, Alejandra felt the urge to spit out a sigh.

"This year's been a stream of unprecedented events. I doubt it'll go as it does every year, so you should all keep that fact in your heads. Be at ease until the instructor arrives. We're going, captain."

"Already? Whatever. Well then, new recruits, we'll meet again soon."

After Oldart left the room laughing, the unsociable Alejandro followed behind.

Once the captain and vice-captain's footsteps grew distant, a single young man loosened the collar of his knight clothing as he sat in his seat. With chestnut hair, he gave off the impression of an amiable young man.

"That vice-captain has some intensity... though I get the feeling the captain is a bit too light."

As the young man unraveled his impression of the two, a nearby female knight sat and began talking about the captain.

"Sure enough. Having a gray dragon for captain and a wind dragon for vice-captain, it's a peculiar tale."

The nine newcomers in the conference room saw in their chairs at ease, and as it was a break time, they began to converse.

"And we're even getting a future archduke entering this year. You're Rudel, aren't you?"

A knight with gray hair and a sharp look in his eyes looked at Rudel, taking on a provocative attitude. The surrounding knights were surprised by his bearing, but Rudel didn't flinch.

"Yeah, I'm Rudel. So?"

"Don't be so cold. From here on, we're going to be fellow dragoons, right? I hate all that stiff, serious stuff, see. And we've got another interesting one with us this year."

The knight with sharp eyes directed his gaze at the female knight with orange, wavy long hair.

"You're Enora Campbell, aren't you? Having a father and daughter both become dragoons is amazing."

"... That has nothing to do with it."

As the knight with sharp eyes called out her name, Enora reacted without any particular change in her reaction. While those gathered here were all elite knights, they were just a bit idiosyncratic.

Rudel knew about the Campbell House, and he had some interest in the name that put out dragoons generation after generation.

"The Campbell House is famous for turning out many dragoons. Do they make you do anything special?"

"Ah, that sounds interesting."

The knight who was the first to open his mouth endorsed Rudel's question, leaning his torso over the meeting room table. Enora was of ample chest and fine features.

Even though she wore the same uniform, from her measurements, it looked as if she almost wore a completely different one from the other female knights. And yet, her waist was slim, and her limbs were slender.

Such a girl smiled as she answered all the knights in the room looking at her.

"That's a secret."

"Now that's unfortunate."

Rudel shrugged his shoulders, but it wasn't as if he was expecting her to tell him from the start. He just wanted to converse with the other dragoons who would become his colleagues.

The other knights were also just a little let down by her words. There weren't any who intended to pry any further.

As expected of those chosen as elite knights, they were all relatively calm and collected. And like that, the break time ended with some light conversation and self-introductions.



"I cannot accept it! Why wasn't I chosen!?"

The one who captured the captain and vice-captain as they walked down the hall was Cattleya. Having returned from the border and been officially appointed head of a platoon, she had the qualifications to train the new recruits.

She had personally volunteered to help train the newbies of the term.

The fact Rudel was there was part of the reason, but newbie training was a required prerequisite for promotion. If she wanted to aim higher than lieutenant, Cattleya would have to carry out newbie rearing.

Within the brigade, Cattleya had gained strength and distinguished herself, and Oldart dealt with her with a smile.

"No, well... right! This and that happened between you and Rudel so we took it into consideration. I mean, when you were formerly engaged, the other side broke off the engagement, right? Man, the captain really has to read the mood in this sort of thing, you know."

Cattleya was once a candidate to be Rudel's fiancé. After she raised a problem, the talks were broken off by the Arses House.

"Ah, that's already gone and done with. Or do you think I intend to get revenge?"

At Cattleya's words, Oldart laughed within.

(No, it's because I do think so that you were removed. Have you forgotten what happened a few years ago?)

By the confusion Cattleya caused, the dragoon brigade went through a period of turbulence. A few years back, Oldart headed a battalion.

He had memories of the considerably strife he had to go through with countermeasure meetings and human resources.

This time, Alejandro admonished Cattleya with a tired expression.

"This time, the higher-ups told us to treat our archduke with care. It is my belief that the knights we selected as instructors are a sensible lot. You're still young. You can try again for an instructor position next year."

But the real reason Cattleya didn't become an instructor wasn't Rudel. Alejandro had used Rudel as a reason to persuade Oldart, but the real reason was Cattleya's youth, and his daughter Enora.

Praised as a genius, Cattleya was undoubtedly an outstanding talent, even within the dragoons.

Age wise, she was twenty three, and even younger than some of the new recruits this term. Rudel was the youngest recruit, but apart from him, many of the others were over twenty five. And Cattleya was the same age as Enora.

Becoming a dragoon at seventeen, she had put in six years of service. More than anything, she was capable of using her demonic sword. Given a few years, Alejandro was certain she would even surpass him.

For her dragon she had contracted a young, powerful male, and as a dragoon, Cattleya's value was exceedingly high.

As Alejandro looked at Cattleya, he felt a sense of panic. While being of a famed name that put out dragoons generation after generation, his daughter was sufficiently talented as well.

But even when he returned home, he couldn't help but see an unfavorable comparison. Those feelings would come out in his attitude, and it would often end in him mentioning Cattleya's name to Enora.

(Even if it's my responsibility, we can't go like this.)

He had intended to raise her worthy of being a dragoon, but Alejandro had noticed the darkness in Enora's heart. While she usually looked meek, Enora held an extraordinary sense of hostility towards Cattleya.

This time, Rudel- who held relations with Cattleya- was also instated as a dragoon.

"See? That's just how it is, this time around. Well, if you want to do it no matter what, you could help this charming captain in his prime practice his night flying skills..."

"I refuse."

"... Even if I knew it wouldn't work out, getting such an immediate response is painful. Try being a bit more tactful. I'm a delicate man."

"A delicate man doesn't say such indecent things."

Among the dragoons, night flying was just the sort of innuendo it sounded to be.

"... That's why you can never get a boyfriend."

"Oy, even for a captain, there are things you should and shouldn't say. Do you want me to explain certain things to your wife again?"

"H-hey! That's no goo! Now that one's one of things you shouldn't say!!"

"It's only because your conduct is so bad, that you would be troubled by such a thing, charmer in his prime (lol)."

"Then I'd better watch out. I wouldn't want to be blasted off to the border like you, genius (lol)."

The two of them glared at one another, continuing on their comedy routine.

While Alejandro was mulling over his daughter, Oldart and Cattleya had started such a back and forth. Alejandro looked enviously at his ability to get together the strong personalities of the dragoons.

Chapter 96

Having become a high knight, Izumi's first job was to clean up the room the high knights used at the palace.

As there was no longer the required personnel to maintain the organization, a notice of its official dissolution had been handed down. The guard of important personnel the high knights had risked their lives on had been taken up by the royal guard.

Promptly after entering the force, Izumi was put to processing documents.

"Hah, this is definitely not what I was expecting."

In the reference room the high knights used, Izumi muttered as she tidied up forms alongside the other high knights. From the start, she had become a high knight to become a noble.

But this year, there were absolutely no high knights who came from the noble class.

Factional disputes were already going on within the palace. As nobles, the archdukes leading the two great factions, and Archduke Arses who planned to use both of them had started to move.

Knight brigades... within military circles, there was a recruitment war going on between the royal guard and defenders.

The only ones you could call irrelevant were the dragoons. Due to their special standing, neither force could carelessly pull them from their positions.

Having the dragoons feud amongst themselves and cutting the number of dragons would be akin to largely chipping away the country's military might. At the same time, the royal line and authorities greatly feared the dragons turning against Courtois.

As it stood, the dragoons had a tacit rule of noninterference.

For the sake of Courtois' superiority, while they didn't fully understand the situation, the royal guards and defenders hadn't lain hands on them. Fina herself did want to try reaching out, but in the end, she stopped herself.

That was simply how vital the pillars of the country, the dragoons, were.

In contrast, the status of the high knights had been snatched up by the royal guard.

No one could have imagined they would decline so much in only a few years. It was a result of the organization being cornered into dissolution by both Aileen and Fina simultaneously.

For Aileen, it was for her own sake.

Fina for her own desires, and just a little for the sake of the country...

When the high knights once shouldered the protection of vital personnel, this treatment was simply terrible.

But the high knights were elites. Their wisdom went without question, and they were the capable elites of Courtois. After the organization's dismantlement, their members would undoubtedly find work in one of the two fronts.

Through simple chat, Izumi had also come to know the circumstances of the palace. Feeling anxiety for her own future, Izumi began cleaning up when a voice called out to her from behind.

"Oh, Izumi, you're working hard."

"Yes. Is something the matter, senpai?"

The ones who came over to her were senior members of the high knights. A group of three and fresh nobles without any backers.

"No, I just wanted to know if you're free after this. Someone I know from the royal guard called out. You at least want to hear them out, right?"

They weren't hitting on her, it seems they wanted to carry Izumi over to the royal guard. In the intensifying recruitment wars to come, they wanted to gather as many people and contribute as much as possible.

"No, I'm..."

Izumi took on a refuting attitude. Through Rudel, she had already found a station with Luecke and Eunius. The two of them had promised to mediate if Izumi's clan wanted to come under their one of their factions.

"That so, well, you better think over where you're going in the near future."

The party of three left; they wouldn't push her too hard. They weren't selected as high knights for nothing, and they knew what would happen if they overdid their movements.

But the fact that such solicitation would come out on the job was proof that the high knight brigade was growing lax as a whole.

"Even if you tell me about the royal guard and defenders..."

While she knew the general gist of things, Izumi didn't know the specifics. If she knew this was a petty sibling fight within the palace, she would surely drop her shoulders in disappointment.

Speaking to scale, it couldn't even be called a fight anymore. Within such a situation, Izumi plainly continued on her work.



"Well then, henceforth we will be putting your abilities to the test. Just because you've managed to contract a dragon, they alone won't make you a

first-rate dragoon. Don't forget that you lot are merely standing on the starting line!"

Before the former captain and vice-captain, the nine new recruits saluted in file.

It was a training ground a long way off from the palace, and not in ceremonious garb, the newbies with training clothes wrapped around their bodies had come to the field without their dragons.

"From here on, you lot will be looking after the dragons as you learn the basics. What's needed of a dragoon is the ability to lead a dragon to your will. No matter how strong a dragon may be, if you cannot use its power, you won't be the slightest use in battle."

The vice-captain took a single large leap before taking a few more steps in the air.

In that empty airspace, his form almost as if he was kicking the atmosphere left the newbies surprised. Before the surprised new recruits, the former captain gave a proud explanation.

It was almost as if he was looking at his past self, and he felt a sense of nostalgia.

"This is only the beginning. At the very least, you will have to be able to carry out two mid-air movements. This one is mainly an emergency recovery measure for when you fall off your dragon. Well, it does have its uses in battle. Now then, those who can already use this technique, step forward. We'll have you set a good example for the other new recruits."

Watched over by the instructors, Rudel and Enora stepped forwards.

This was largely expected and the instructors wanted to confirm their abilities. Each year, there would always be an extent of new recruits who could pull it off.

But they generally wouldn't carry the necessary techniques with them.

What the vice-captain showed off was nothing more than the minimum. Once the new recruits proudly unveiled their midair movement, he would show off an even higher level of movement.

Here, Enora took four air jumps before landing full of confidence.

On top of the graceful form of a beauty flying through the sky, the male knights' attention was especially devoted to her large, swaying chest.

"How was that?"

After directing a provocative smile to the instructors, Enora switched out with Rudel. Seeing Rudel a little tense, she smiled and offered some advice.

"You should really relax your shoulders."

"Ah, thank you."

As she passed Rudel by, Enora predicted he might even fail. He was the youngest one among them, and he didn't look to have much battle experience... she thought.

The instructors who received the report that Rudel had mastered air movement had been a little naïve as well. They thought that those seeing the technique for the first time might have overevaluated him.

But as Rudel leapt above the training grounds, the first thing that surprised everyone was the height.

"... Now that's high (No, isn't that a bit too high? Jumping that high is usually impossible, isn't it)."

On the former captain's words, no one was able to react. Rudel climbed to a considerable height and began executing air movement.

A small point seen from the ground seemed to be carrying out impossible fluctuations. Rather than a jump, he was already flying.

"... Oy, someone go set an example as his senior (That's not happening)."

The former vice-captain's words caused the active dragoons to shake their heads at once.

"Not happening! That one's impossible!! And aren't you supposed to set an example, vice-captain!?"

"I'm getting old. I can't be getting in the way of you young'uns forever (Oy, oy, I'm begging you, read the mood a bit, Rudel-sama)."

As the former vice-captain and the active dragoons selected as instructors began to argue, the former captain muttered in his heart.

(This guy... what am I supposed to say.)

Within all that, Enora alone directed Rudel a gaze not of praise. What dwelled in her eyes was an intense hostility.

To Enora who was raised to be more of a dragoon than anything else, Rudel who boasted abilities that exceeded hers was simply unpleasant.

As if glaring, she watched Rudel fly freely through the sky.



The place the dragons were kept was called the dragon stables.

Around when evening was fading away, Rudel and the other new recruits were cleaning those very stables.

While there were exclusive caretakers, it was regulation that the newbies would spend their time cleaning the stables for the first three months. There was no denying the fact the dragons were lifeforms. They generally smelled, and there were dirty places to be found.

In such a space, Rudel almost felt like breaking into a hum.

Despite being the eldest son of an archduke house, the drive he held as he carried out odd jobs caused those around to see him as an odd one.

"Oy, I'm surprised you can clean so happily. When I thought you would be the first one to snap at our superiors. Hah, looks like I've lost this bet."

"Bet?"

The sharp-eyed knight, Saas Venia, revealed he had been placing bets with the other newcomers.

"That's right. With the brat with the light personality and the two women, we placed our bets. Over how long you were going to hold out. And then you're pleasantly cleaning the stables? Looks like Enora's the only winner here."

"Ah, the Campbell House's... in that case, she thought I would hold out. How rare."

The way things had gone up to now, Rudel found it more understandable for people to doubt him. Being evaluated by a person he didn't really know left him a little lost.

But if it was a bet, then perhaps she aimed for the greatest turnout, or so he changed his train of thought.

"Now then, once this is cleaned up, we can call it a day."

Once Saas tried to bring the cleaning to the end, the other newbies increased their pace. Rudel thought he felt Enora's gaze, but she was conversing with the only other of the two female knights.

"I'm going off to look at my own dragon."

"Again? Well, that kid's a special one."

Saas directed his gaze outside the dragon stables at the conspicuously large hole that had been dug out. In it was a dragon that even the splendidly constructed stables couldn't contain.

A subspecies of gaia dragon, Sakuya was even bigger than the standard gaia, and if she entered the dragon stables, there was a fear of her breaking

the building.

For that sake, as an exception, it was permitted for Sakuya to dig a hole and use it as a place to sleep.

As Rudel approached, Sakuya popped her head out of the depths of the cave hole. If it was a small animal, it would've been cute, but Sakuya was a dragon. What's more, her size was double that of the other dragons.

If any layman saw her, they'd surely be at a loss for words. But to Rudel, she was the dragon he had made a contract with.

"I kept you waiting, Sakuya."

'I'm hungry... this place doesn't give enough food.'

For Sakuya who ate quite a portion, the palace had prepared a considerable portion. But it does seem it still wasn't enough for her.

"I see, in that case, I'll tell the instructor."

Right after Rudel made a pampering remark, the roar of a dragon came from the stables. While Rudel couldn't understand the contents of that roar, Sakuya did seem to make an unpleasant face.

"What's wrong?"

'... It's nothing. I'm going to sleep for the day, good night Rudel.'

"Y-yeah, good night."

Normally, they would enjoy a conversation there, but lately, Sakuya was lacking in spirit. When Rudel became a dragoon, it was decided Sakuya would live in the stables.

While she dug a hole and lived there as an exception, for some reason, she seemed to be losing energy day after day.

She was in high spirits when she left the forest where the dragons lived. While Rudel was a little worried, he decided to wait for the time when Sakuya would divulge her own worries.

If he worried too much, he thought it would have an opposite effect and make Sakuya overly conscious.

He did know she was hiding something and making sure he wouldn't find out.

After spending some time cleaning up the front of the cave, Rudel took his leave. He was definitely mulling over Sakuya, but for now, he didn't know any resolution.

She didn't seem to be sick, so he suspected it was something psychological.

(Is she stressed out from a change in environment? But she was delighted at the start.)

Troubling his head over Sakuya, Rudel returned to the dragon stables.



In the instructor room, the former captain and vice captain were exchanging a drink

It was passed working hours, and they planned to sleep after downing a glass. Watching over the new recruits was left to the other active dragoons.

"Hah, even so, this year is a hard one."

"Right you are."

Both poured a slightly-expensive wine in their glass before drinking it down. Reaching their hands to the snacks left on the table, they began discussing Rudel.

"Does the archduke even need training? Why not just add him to the main force already?"

"That's going to be a hard one."

They exchanged bitter smiles as they evaluated the year's new recruits.

"The runner-up is Enora, and next, I guess Saas is showing a bit of promise? For now, I don't know about the others."

"They're elites chosen by dragons but, well, there's still a ranking to things. The two who managed to obtain wild dragons will definitely support the core force in times to come."

Being recognized by a wild dragon was several times harder and more dangerous than contracting a gray dragon. The dragoons who succeeded in such a task were truly outstanding talents.

"From tomorrow onwards, training's gradually going to grow harsher, but let's see... I guess a B-Rank evaluation is guaranteed."

A dragoon was evaluated on a five level evaluation system ranging from E to A. While all of them held competence as knights, dragoons were mainly focused around dragons.

Controlling a dragon freely was what made one first-rate.

"So I'm sure."

But managed by the dragoons, gray dragons would move faithfully. Wild dragons were hard to handle, but in exchange, they boasted performance greater than a gray dragon.

While they had placed their expectations on Rudel and Sakuya, in the evaluation exam held a few weeks from that day, the two of them received a D-Rank evaluation.

Chapter 97

'Rudel Arses... Evaluation: D-Rank'

As he looked at the document indicating his evaluation, Rude's expression was serious.

Sakuya was also out on the training grounds, but her wings and tail unfit for her large build were folded in. Perhaps discouraged, her expression was somewhat dark.

'I-I'm sorry.'

"Don't mind it. I don't really care."

The reason Rudel's evaluation was so low lay in his partner Sakuya. A gaia dragon subspecies, Sakuya was specialized in offense and defense.

While she was bad at flying, she possessed skills to make up for it. But as a dragoon's dragon, she was a failure.

No matter how proficient Rudel might be, if Sakuya's evaluation was so low, he would never rise in rank.

Sakuya had received training from Marty's dragon Mystith, but that wasn't for long. It was hard to say she had learned all of the necessary skills. Even more than that, there were skills the dragoons had polished after Mystith had left.

Starting with 'hovering'- stopping on the spot in midair- things like flight formations hadn't been necessary in Mystith's era.

Now that group combat had become the norm, a majority of the fighting techniques Mystith taught her were outside of the grading scale.

'But if we don't become C-Rank (?) we can't go out in battle...'

Right, just barely obtaining D-Rank, Rudel and Sakuya wouldn't be able to enter the fray. It meant they couldn't escape the label of newbie.

While Rudel possessed the necessary abilities of a dragoon, Sakuya was just somehow able to manage a D.

"Don't worry. We just have to raise our rank by one. And you don't have to worry about the evaluation."

Rudel tried to console Sakuya, but there he heard yet another grand dragon cry from the direction of the dragon stables. The fact it was different from a normal roar made Rudel curious.

Every time Sakuya heard that cry, she would lose her spirit. Conversations would cut off.

"What's wrong?"

'... It's nothing.'

Even through the conveyance of thought that came between contractors, the weakening of the ends of Sakuya's words bothered Rudel. He grew excessively anxious.

"If something's wrong, then tell me. You're my precious partner."

'Y-yeah.'

While Rudel worried for Sakuya's lack of energy, in contrast, Sakuya only grew more depressed.



Enora watched Rudel cheer Sakuya up from afar.

"Serves you right."

On the words she spat out, the dragon she had contracted to looked at Sakuya.

'A kid with a story from Mystith's place? Looks like he likes her quite a bit. I do have some sympathy for her upbringing, but I don't have the mind to support her to such an extent.'

Mystith was the most powerful dragon in the dragon dwellings, but her territory was surprisingly small. When there were dragons that followed her, it was only natural there would be those opposed.

Enora's dragon was one of those opposing ones.

In order to look after her own dragon, Enora removed her gaze from Rudel and Sakuya. Unstrapping the tools used at the training grounds, her expression turned to a dark smile.

It was a huge difference from her usual self.

"No matter how proficient he is as a knight, that's no good at all."

'If she can't even fly properly and her breath is so half-baked, then there's no helping it.'

In order to commence air raids, it was necessary for a dragon to accurately hit a mark with their breath. Within all that, Sakuya was terrible at firing her breath during flight.

Even if her output was on the high side, her accuracy was exceedingly low. Even if Rudel was controlling, she rarely ever hit.

"It's fatal to have a D evaluation at the three-month point. There's no way they can add him to the flight formation. This future archduke sure has fallen. There's a reassessment exam next week, but that's definitely not something at a level he can do anything about."

The fundamental training had ended, and now, they would have to learn to fly in formation for the unveiling event. But at present, Sakuya's abilities hadn't reached that level.

'Well, being this bad is an embarrassment to our kin. The grays are making a ruckus.'

"Hmm~."

Seeing the ones she thought would be her greatest rivals- Rudel and Sakuya- be the biggest failures among the newcomers, Enora was delighted. Her wind dragon explained what the gray dragons he scorned as grays were doing to Sakuya.

'You never see a wild dragon this terrible, after all. The jeers are flying left and right. It's unbearably noisy.'

"Now isn't that nice. If that's all it takes to crush them, they have my thanks. But I can't stumble in a place like this."

Within Enora's head, she had already lost interest in Rudel. But her hostility towards Cattleya who she was constantly compared to burned bright.

While she did hold a high evaluation of Rudel himself, if his dragon was no good, there was no point in paying him any mind.



On his lodging house bed, Rudel looked at the evaluation notice as he desperately searched for a solution.

"Hovering... halting in the air for a fixed amount of time. Shooting... destroying the marks set up while in flight. If we accomplish these two, then we can get a C-Rank."

Rudel looked at the documents attached to the evaluation notice and looked over two entries. While there were other shoddy places as well, he would

have to do something about those two points that were evaluated highly as the essentials.

To be honest, Rudel didn't care about rank. There wasn't a problem as long as he could go out in battle. In this instance, it was fine even if he couldn't take part in the flight formation.

But Sakuya was depressed.

"I have to do something to give her self-confidence. If I do... no, it won't be a problem! Just what am I thinking."

Leaping up from his lying position, Rudel rushed straight off to Sakuya.



Once the day of the reevaluation came around, surrounded by the instructors, the other newcomers and their dragons, Rudel and Sakuya went into preparations.

"Alright, we're doing it just as planned, Sakuya!"

'Yeah!'

Confirming his preparations were complete, Rudel turned to an instructor and sent a signal. There, the instructor gave the order for him to commence hovering.

Rather than Enora who had lost interest, the sharp-eyed Saas seemed strangely unsettled as he looked at Rudel.

"Will they be alright?"

There, the knight standing to his side poked fun.

"You're more of a worrywart than you look. Well, let's just see how far they've managed to come in a week."

The knight of light personality relaxed as he looked at Rudel and Sakuya. First came the hovering evaluation but here, Rudel took an action no one expected.

Of all things, he produced one of his specialties, a shield of light.

"... The hell's he doing?"

While someone muttered, Sakuya leapt up and mounted that shield. That form as if a dragon was riding a board left everyone dumbfounded.

One of the instructors loudly verified it with Rudel.

"W-what are you doing!? Get to hovering at once!"

Rudel also answered loudly.

"There is no problem! The assessment entry describes it as, 'halting in the air for a fixed period of time'! And see? We've stopped, haven't we!?"

Sakuya was just sitting on the shield of light Rudel had produced. She wasn't doing anything.

"No, that's true! But that's not what we had in mind!!"

Seeing the instructor's troubled face, the surrounding newbies gave bitter smiles. But Enora alone made a mortified face.

"To think he would come out with such a means!"

The other female newbie looked at her face from the side.

"No, is this really where you should be angry? More than that, isn't it a laugh?"

Enora Campbell was quite off herself.



Following on, the shooting evaluation test commenced.

In the place prepared for shooting practice, there were only dragoon facilities around.

The goal was to hit the brick walls erected along the flight path. Those walls were made strong, making sure even a dragon's breath wouldn't be able to destroy them.

Destroying the walls wasn't the objective, the aim was to demolish the planks posted up on those walls. They were made just strong enough that a dragon wouldn't be able to break them if it wasn't serious.

Flying at a certain level of speed, they would have to destroy the marks set up.

Once the ten targets were successfully posted, the instructor issued Rudel the order.

Sakuya flew off into the distance to build up speed.

With that previous hovering case, the instructors were worried whether or not Rudel would do something. Not just the brick walls, the targets themselves were made difficult to destroy by human hands, so they had some piece of mind. As Sakuya was terrible at hitting marks, the instructors and new recruits watching took more distance than usual.

Saas worried in a different way than before as he muttered. As expected, the knight with the light personality responded.

"It'll be alright this time, won't it?"

"No, even if you ask me... but that last one was interesting. Sure enough, he wasn't wrong, so perhaps he might just pass."

Raising her speed, Sakuya passed down the designated route, approaching the target.

But even when the mark entered the firing range of a normal breath, Sakuya didn't even try to fire. At her mouth, she was either preparing to fire a breath, or simply gathering mana.

"... Isn't it a bit large?"

As an ill-natured knight muttered, without aiming at the mark, Sakuya continued to come closer and closer. The mana converging in her mouth was exceedingly large.

Not a single shot fired, Sakuya flew right up to the first target.

"What are they doing!?"

Saas was worried, but outside of the surrounding worry, under Rudel's orders, Sakuya dropped that mass of mana.

Sakuya was unable to fire a powerful breath from the air. Taking that into account, Rudel hit upon the idea that instead of firing it, he could just do an airdrop.

Rudel had chosen to clear this challenge by dropping a lump of mana right over the target. Rather than risking holding back too much to aim at the target, he bet it all on a single powerful blow.

As that spherical lump of mana fell, Sakuya instantly fled into the sky. Seeing her rise in altitude, the instructors turned to the newbies and cried out.

"E-evacuattte!"

From their experience, the instructors determined that mass of magic was dangerous. They turned to the recruits and ordered them to retreat.

All called their dragons, and it was at the moment everyone tried to flee the area. The mass of mana didn't fall on the target.

As it found its destination in the very center of all those scattered targets, a cloud of smoke and shockwave ruled the space. Following on, the sound of

explosions turned the area into a sea of fires.

... The explosions took it all in, swallowing down the targets on the walls in its wake.

The training ground was reduced to scorched earth.

Luckily, there were no injuries, but everyone gathered could only look upon the scene in mute amazement.

"We did it, Sakuya! With this, we've risen in rank!"

Descending upon the barren ground, Rudel and Sakuya rejoiced that they had destroyed all the targets, wall and all. Sakuya also let out a delighted howl.



"No, you're still D-Rank, you know."

"Why!?"

The next day, Rudel received the conclusion from the instructors who had discussed the matter. Perhaps you could call it the natural result.

Rudel and Sakuya's evaluation remained at D-Rank.

As Rudel approached the instructor in utter surprise, the active dragoon shied back as he explained.

"I mean, dude, boarding a shield of mana in hovering is downright cheating."

"We halted in the air for a set period of time!"

While they definitely stopped, that wasn't by Sakuya's power, but by Rudel's. In contrast, Sakuya hadn't done a thing. She simply laid back on Rudel's shield of light.

"And just because you can't hit the target, you decide to blow the whole training ground away? Your imagination is terrifying!"

"But it was never stated in detail how we had to aim at the target!"

"No matter what you say, this is what's been decided among the instructors... I'm begging you, just clear the tasks normally. We're not asking for wit here."

As the instructor with dropped shoulders handed the document to Rudel, he took his leave as if completely worn out.

"What am I supposed to say to Sakuya..."

While Rudel was depressed, he would have to inform Sakuya of the outcome. Recalling how Sakuya was looking forward to her result, Rudel felt a weight on his mind.

"I thought it was a perfect plan! How am I supposed to try clearing them next time..."

While Rudel used his head further, he couldn't think of any way to raise his evaluation by valid means.

The next day, after learning the results, Sakuya ended up running away.

Chapter 98

"Sakuya ran away."

His shoulders slumped, Rudel returned to the lodging house and muttered that truth to his peers.

Right after he woke up, he had made for the cave Sakuya lived, but it was already an empty husk. While Rudel was desperately searching for her, he found a message addressed to him, carved with claw at the cave's entrance.

'I'm going home. I'm sorry.'

They were extremely shoddy letters, but letters that brought back memories of a once-human Sakuya. The characteristics were similar, and that only made Rudel more depressed.

Saas didn't know what he was supposed to say to a depressed Rudel. Everyone present was surprised at a situation where a dragon had run away.

"W-what am I supposed to say... cheer up."

But Enora alone forsook him.

"Hmm, so your dragon ran away. In that case, you're not a dragoon anymore. You don't have any reason to stay here."

On her cold words, those around stepped in to stop her.

"Quit it, Enora."

But without seeming to pay it any mind, Rudel replied.

"Yeah, that's why I've decided to search for her. I got permission from the instructors, so I'll be operating separately for a while."

"They gave permission? Well, with your status, I doubt they could refuse."

Before being a dragoon, Rudel was the white knight. For a vital knight to the country of Courtois, having a dragon run away was nothing more than an embarrassment.

But more than his own evaluation, Rudel lamented the fact he hadn't noticed Sakuya was pressured enough to want to run away.

He was depressed because he had made Sakuya sad, and not the fact she had run away.

"Then I'll be off."

With teetering steps, Rudel started into air movement and left the spot.

"... I've already gotten used to it, but that guy's definitely flying, isn't he? He's not jumping, right?"

As the light-natured knight muttered, everyone apart from Enora nodded.



Arriving at the dragons' dwellings a few days later, Rudel was in tatters.

He had given chase in a hurry, making the journey practically empty-handed. All he had with him was a knight and a flask.

But without paying it much mind, he filled the inside of his flask with water magic. While the taste was terrible, as long as it quenched his throat, it wasn't a problem.

It was a spell with terrible efficiency and an action he would only come out with in an emergency.

But having once spent a long while camping in the dragons' dwellings, as long as he could make it to the dwellings, it wouldn't be a problem.

'Kid, what did you do? Sakuya's holed herself up in the cave, and she won't come out.'

After arriving in the dragons' dwellings, he brought his feet straight to the cave Sakuya used as a stronghold. When he did, he found Marty's dragon Mystith, who had brought her hunted prey to the entrance.

What seemed to be pray was clearly not the sort of fish she could catch in the lake.

Even larger than Mystith, it was a lifeform with an atrocious visage.

"I'm ashamed. Our evaluation was a bit low, and Sakuya grew mindful of it..."

Rudel tried to convey this hard-to-explain situation in a way Mystith would also understand.

'... What's that? They go incessantly evaluating every single thing and sticking a rank onto it? How idiotic.'

"My thoughts exactly."

'Sakuya, I brought you dinner, so let's eat together. I caught the fish you like most.'

"... This is a fish?"

Looking at the fearsome lifeform, it definitely did have a dorsal fin and tail. But on top of being larger than a dragon, it made the foulest of expressions.

Rather than fish, calling it a sea monster hit the mark better.

'Something wrong? It's quite tasty. The bloody bastards live in the sea, and when they got a bit stuck up and tried attacking my kinsmen, I decided to eat them. And you know what, they turned out to be delicious.'

"That's definitely not a fish, is it."

'As long as it's tasty, kid.'

In order to eat the fish that was at a level even Rudel had to put in a retort, Sakuya came out of the cave. But as soon as she spotted Rudel, she bit onto the fish and took it with her back into the cave depths.

'Hey! Come out here and eat! That's bad manners!!'

"Sakuya! I'm begging you, please come back!!"

Rudel continued desperately calling out to Sakuya holed up in the back of the cave, but it didn't have an effect.



'Hmm~, hovering, and breath accuracy, eh.'

"Yes, Sakuya can't help but be bad at them, and we can't raise our rank,"

'Are such things really necessary? I can't understand it in the slightest. Well, once you grow big, you should be able to do it naturally, but in contrast to her body, that girl's still a child.'

At the lake Mystith made her den, Rudel discussed with her how to deal with Sakuya's troubles.

'In the first place, she destroyed all the targets, and stopped in the air for a fixed period of time, right? Just what was so bad that she deserved to fail?'

"Who knows? I don't get it either. They told me they weren't looking for wit."

'That's what they call moving the goalpost.'

Conversing with a dragon that held a completely different sense of value, Rudel agreed and nodded. Around them, small dragon children were biting onto the prey Mystith had brought back.

It was a situation that delighted Rudel, and he wanted to go around petting the nearby dragons at once. But with Sakuya's matter, he held himself back.

Rudel couldn't seem to think up any resolution, so he sought verification with Mystith over the other matter that had been troubling him.

"Ah, there's another thing. Sakuya didn't have any energy at the dragon stables. At first, she was in high spirits, but she grew more and more depressed by the day... do you have any idea what the reason might be?"

'The dragon stables? How nostalgic. As long as she went about it normally, I don't think there would be any problem. Did something happen?'

"Let's see... when she's talking with me, the other dragons often cry out. In these sort of um, short growling bursts, I guess."

'... Kid, they're making light of her.'

"What?"

'I'm telling you they're making fun of her! Mocking her! Those damn brutesss!!'

"M-my word!"

After hearing the general circumstances from Rudel, Mystith concluded Sakuya was being bullied at the dragon stables. While dragons all shared a race, they would usually keep a level of distance from one another.

But as gray dragons didn't know life in the wild, they lived affected by one another more than necessary.

While their strength and intelligence didn't reach the level of a wild dragon, when it came to coordination and ease of use, a gray dragon was the best. But for the gray dragons who couldn't help but prioritize the group, if their foe showed any weakness, they would look down on them from an internalized pecking order.

"W-what should I do!?"

'... Who knows?'

"Eh... Don't you know any resolution!? Is there anything I can do for Sakuya!?"

'Even if you ask me that, well... when it came to me, I made the other dragons obey from the start, and I only know one way to go about it.'

"So there is a way!"

Rudel saw a glimmer of hope in Mystith's words.

But again, it was Mystith he was dealing with.

'It's simple. Duel the current boss of the dragon stable and beat them black and blue. If that's the way we're going, then it's training time! Now bring Sakuya out here.'

"Yes!!"

As Rudel raced off towards the cave, Mystith saw off his back.

'How nostalgic. It makes me recall Marty, back at the start when he was still naïve and innocent.'



Like that, in order to pull Sakuya out of the cave, Rudel made his way to it.

The deep and dark cave was the place the undead dragon originally slept. At this point, the cave's depths were no longer filled with the scent of death, and it was just a hole that was a little deep.

Within such depths, Sakuya was rolled in a ball, asleep.

She looked somewhat sorrowful. But around, the bones of the food Mystith brought in rolled around, and to Rudel, it looked strangely Sakuya-esque.

"Sakuya, let's go outside."

Perhaps not wanting to lend an ear to Rudel's voice, Sakuya hid her head with both hands. Despite her large build, her movements were those of a pet who had done a bad thing and was afraid of what was to come.

"... I'm sorry. I never noticed you were hurting."

'... Not hurting'

"I heart from Mystith-sama. That you were being bullied by the gray dragons... I'm sorry."

'I'm not being bullied!!'

As Sakuya raised her voice into a yell, her violent roar shook the cave interior.

"Sakuya..."

On Rudel's sorrowful voice, Sakuya stood and spread out her four large wings.

'Sakuya isn't being bullied! She's a really strong dragon and Rudel's partner! So... so Sakuya isn't a no-good dragon!!'

After actually running away and holing herself up in a cave, perhaps Sakuya was a no-good dragon. But in front of Rudel, she tried to put on a bluff and appeal to him.

Not much time had passed since Sakuya's birth, and unsuited to her giant build, her spirit was still young.

Thinking of how such a young girl had been forced to endure the jeers from her own kin for his sake, Rudel felt ashamed.

"... I'm a no-good partner."

'Why? Rudel didn't do anything wrong.'

Approaching Sakuya, Rudel held out his hand.

Sakuya drew closer with her head and Rudel gently stroked her. Comfortably flapping her spread wings, Sakuya sat on the spot in delight.

"Sakuya, you and me together make a dragoon. When we're evaluated low as a dragoon, that's my responsibility as well."

'... The others say it. You fall behind your partner, you're a useless dragon. So Sakuya isn't needed... is it alright for Sakuya to be here?'

"Fall behind? That's got nothing to do with anything. I'm your contractor, and you're my dragon. If you weren't there, I wouldn't have become a dragoon in the first place. You can be here. No, please be my dragon!"

Saying it boldly, Rudel directed a gentle smile; Sakuya closed her eyes once as her response.

"Then let's go outside. Mystith-sama is worried. And it seems she's got some special training in store for you."

'Training?'

"Yeah, a training that will stop you from being bullied!!"

And like that, in order to train up Sakuya, Rudel holed himself up in the dragons' dwelling again. It went without saying that by that point, he had completely forgotten about the unveiling that would take place in three months' time.



Meanwhile, in the palace, Sakuya's disappearance had become a huge problem.

The dragoon captain and vice-captain had been called out before the king and his authorities. While Rudel had gotten permission to search for his own dragon, he didn't seem to be coming back.

In the palace, a simple runaway case had become a problem of national security.

"For the white knight's dragon to run away, it's so shameful there's no way we can publicize it." "Good grief, what was management doing!?" "More importantly, what are we going to do about the ceremony? If the white knight remains absent, we won't be able to set an example."

The news of the white and black knights had spread far and wide throughout Courtois.

In this ceremony called an unveiling, the level of attention to be poured on Rudel and Aleist was exceptionally high. In such a situation, there was no way they could announce that the white knight's dragon had run away, and he wasn't taking part.

"I have no excuses."

Oldart who laughed as he confronted the authorities was also a seasoned warrior. Something of this level was nothing to be flustered about.

But the other matters he had to handle made his head hurt.

(This is bad. The training ground is destroyed, and a dragon ran away... our expenses are going to be cut, aren't they. Hah, can't our high and mighty archduke do something with his pocket money.)

Before the authorities, he troubled his head over his future expenses. In contrast, Alejandro had broken into a cold sweat. While Alejandro had a proficient dragon and ample achievement under his belt, this was the reason he was vice-captain.

He was terrible when it came to these things. Or rather, he didn't have the leisure.

Without the emotional leisure, Alejandro couldn't help but want to smack Rudel.

(To think he can't even manage his own dragon. At this rate, he won't make it in time for the unveiling! If that's all we'd get off with, it'd be fine, but

Rudel has a low evaluation. At this rate, the dragoon brigade itself will be made light of!)

His flaw, his lack of leisure was what left him stuck at vice-captain.

Strength-wise, he didn't fall short of his fellow dragoon Oldart. But mindful of his personality, the former captain and vice-captain said farewell to his inauguration as captain.

"I will bring them back at once!"

While Oldart evasively dealt with the authorities, Alejandro gave a forceful answer. He was also a single man, and it wasn't as if he had no interest in promotion.

What's more, even if he recognized Oldart's abilities, he was dealing with a man who had a gray dragon as his partner. He had conceit that he was the better of the two.

He wanted to get his hands on an opportunity to surpass Oldart no matter what.

"I see. But do you know where they are?" "With the white knight who went searching of unknown whereabouts as well, it brings to doubt the quality of the dragoons." "I truly have no excuse (Alejandro, read the mood a bit. He's not a brat anymore, if we keep quiet, I'm sure he'll return sooner or later)."

Oldart sent a pleading glance, but Alejandro didn't notice.

A few days later, a dragoon search party for Rudel and Sakuya was formed. As there was a limit to their numbers, even some of the new recruits were enlisted on rotation.

Chapter 99

Cattleya had been called to a meeting room in the palace under Lilim's orders.

At this point, Lilim had been put in charge of a company. That led to her becoming Cattleya's direct superior.

"What is it, senpai? I'm a bit busy."

Wearing the uniform of a major, Lilim was just a bit irritated at Cattleya's behavior. While the two of them had similarly caused a problem, Lilim had finished the newbie training requirement, so she was able to be promoted to command a company.

"... Cattleya, right now, I am your superior."

"Yeah, yeah. So what's up?"

"You really are an irritating one, you know that? It's an order from the top brass. Your platoon is to search out Rudel-sama... Recruit Rudel. But they want as many hands on it as possible this time, so you'll be using the new recruits as well."

After Lilim sent them a glance, the newcomers saluted to Cattleya. Receiving those salutes, reluctant as she was, Cattleya sent a salute back.

"This week, those three will be left with you."

The three in question included Saas, the knight of light personality: Luxheidt Aiguille... and Enora. Even standing before Cattleya, she was acting normal.

But inside, she thought her stomach would boil over.

Alejandro's sense of rivalry towards Oldart had burned so brightly he had been negligent in paying care to his daughter. In order to find Rudel, the one who gave permission to lend out the new recruits was Alejandro.

"Looks like one of you has a wind dragon. Having some fast legs is a huge help."

Looking through the documents she received from Lilim, Cattleya passed her eyes through Enora's papers and gave her honest admiration at the fact she had contracted a wind dragon.

Only those whose abilities and luck overlapped would be able to get a wild dragon to follow them.

At the same time, she noticed she was the vice-captain's daughter.

"... You'll be working with my subordinates from the platoon. We work in teams of two so Enora, come with me."

On Cattleya's orders, the newcomers saluted and gave their response. While Enora was making a serious expression on the surface, some dark emotions were beginning to take root.

Would I be able to kill Cattleya, she asked herself...

"Cattleya, I think you have the general idea, but if anything happens, then you have to pull back. You got that? This is an order."

Faced with a serious Lilim, Cattleya gave a salute, for argument's sake. But she was dealing with Rudel, an acquaintance. She questioned whether they really had to care about it that much.

"I really don't think I'm going to fail this one."

"That's why you're still naïve."

As Cattleya made light of Rudel, Lilim's anxieties only grew.



A wind dragon's speed was greater than what a gray dragon could keep up with.

Taking that into consideration, Cattleya had chosen to pair up with Enora. And even if she was supposed to increase the search radius, Cattleya already had an idea where they were.

If Sakuya wanted to run away, the only place she had to return was the dragons' dwellings. Any other dragon might escape overseas to make sure they wouldn't be found no matter how hard the country looked.

But from the point of view of Cattleya, who knew the situation, this time's mission was exceedingly easy.

The only problem was that the newbie she brought along hated Cattleya terribly, and her personality wasn't as it appeared.

"We're heading straight for the dragons' dwellings."

Riding the backs of their two dragons, the two dragoons matched dropped speed to discuss their destination point. But at Cattleya's arbitrary attitude, Enora was irritated within.

"Are they really at such an obvious place? (Dammit, don't order me around)."

"Yeah, well, that's the only place they could be."

Cattleya had her subordinates check out other places. In truth, she didn't really want knowledge on Rudel's peculiar behavior to spread.

While he was skilled, Rudel did seem to have a screw missing somewhere, and for better or worse, he worked at his own pace.

While he was like that, Rudel was a future archduke, and the white knight, an existence that stood out in Courtois. From those who knew him, this was quite the predicament.

Reading 'How to Pet a Dragon' dearly, he was a problem child who worshipped Marty Wolfgang. That was Cattleya's evaluation of Rudel.

While this and that happened before, at this point, she would honestly evaluate and commend his effort.

But she couldn't quite let that that exorbitant personality spread through the world. She teamed up with Enora because if she was the daughter of a dragoon house, Cattleya expected her to understand such delicate problems.

She already knew about the destruction of the training ground from the reports, and from a position of responsibility, it was a problem that brought pain to Cattleya's head.

So with Cattleya's red dragon following behind, Enora urged her wind dragon towards the dragons' dwellings.

(Someday, right... I'll definitely surpass her. No matter what I have to do, no matter what methods I have to use!)

Perhaps it is here that we must explain the character called Enora. She had no major relation to the story. At best, she was a character that appeared as one of Courtois' dragoons.

While she was talented, that was the end to it.

Compared to Cattleya who was practically loved by the world, her situation was completely different.



Around when the search party was formed, Sakuya began her training alongside Mystith.

As it was a dragon's training, she would be operating separate from Rudel for a period of time. And left alone, Rudel was fooling around with the young dragons of Mystith's turf.

"Hey! That's my lunch!!"

As a small dragon snatched up a fish he had caught in the lake, Rudel gave chase with a smile. Even if they were children, their size was no different from a grown human being.

Perhaps due to the influence of the lake they lived in, they were all showing the characteristics of a water dragon on their heads.

While the dragons fled into the lake, with his inhuman abilities, Rudel easily chased and captured the fleeing dragons.

"Now you have to return it... you already ate it?"

From the mouth of the dragon he caught, he could see the tail of a fish. At the success of his mischief, the little dragon seemed delighted.

Through his survival lifestyle in the dragons' dwellings, Rudel had fastened his knife to the end of a stick. Since he lived close to the lake, his clothes would often get wet, so at this point, he wore a waist wrap made of sturdy leaves.

Looking practically like a wild man, he was playing around with little dragons.

"This really is the life."

Holding one dragon under his arm as he crawled out of the lake, Rudel exclaimed it with a smile. But where he climbed up, leading a red and wind dragon, Cattleya and Enora were waiting for them.

"Don't 'This really is the life' me! You've become a dragoon, so have some self-awareness!"

"Cattleya-sa... lieutenant."

He was about to add a -sama to Cattleya's name, but recalling the fact that he was also a dragoon now, he swallowed his words.

"What are you doing in a place like this?"

Before his fed-up fellow newbie Enora, Rudel gently placed the shy dragon he carried on the ground. All the small dragons fled into the lake and disappeared.

"Training."

"Training? More importantly, did you find Sakuya yet? We've got to return soon."

Showing little interest in Rudel's answer, Cattleya looked around to find Sakuya. She was sure she'd be somewhere by Rudel's side.

"That's impossible. She's currently out training in the north sea."

"The sea... when will she be back?"

"No idea."

"No idea!? What do you mean 'no idea'!? We're in a hurry here! You know there's barely any time left for her to learn to fly in formation for the unveiling, don't you!?"

While Cattleya drew close, Rudel didn't step down.

"No, there's something more important than flying in formation. Right now, Sakuya is doing her best to learn it. I'm going to believe in her, and wait here."

"And what's that?"

"Defeating the boss of the dragon stables."

"What's with that!? Your dragon ran away for something like that!?"

As Rudel spoke on with a serious expression, Cattleya had gotten her hopes up a bit, but now she was only able to yell. She had to make a report, so if possible, she wanted a more decent reason.

"If it's Sakuya, she'll be able to do it! More importantly, do you happen to know who the boss of the dragon stables might be?"

'... That would be me.'

Cattleya's dragon butted into the conversation. But here it was revealed that the dragon they had to beat was Cattleya's very one red dragon.

"Oh no! ... Sakuya, your opponent is a powerful one. Do your best!"

Rudel prayed for Sakuya's safety in her fight with Rudel's dragon. But the one in question hadn't swallowed down the circumstances.

'What do you mean, 'do your best'!? If I get smacked by that giant, I won't come out in one piece!! In the first place, why did it come to defeating the boss? I don't get it at all.'

"The truth is..."

Rudel put together what had happened to that point and conveyed it to everyone. There were things those apart from Enora didn't know, and the fact Sakuya was being bullied carried with it some sympathy.

"I feel a bit sorry for her. But running away was going too far."

'I see, so that kid was being bullied... but this has nothing to do with me, right? I haven't been to the dragon stables in ages.'

"No, beating the boss is our objective."

As Rudel calmly informed him he was relevant, showing his will to accomplish his goal, the red dragon and Cattleya made a ruckus.

'Don't screw with me! I really know nothing!!'

"To think my dragon who gets beat up every time was actually..."

After being removed from newbie rearing, Cattleya had been given a mission. She had no idea about the affairs of the dragon stables. As a major,

Lilim's dragon was in a separate stable.

It was an unlucky occurrence.

Enora was unable to hear the voice of Cattleya's dragon. In such a state, she was unable to enter the conversation. She asked her own dragon to interpret, and could do no more than listen.

But her face was turning red.

Her eyes couldn't help but drift towards Rudel.

Brought up harsher than Cattleya by her parents- especially her father- Enora kept a distance from men at the academy. While she did wear stylish clothing, that was also a form of recoil against her upbringing.

But she hadn't the leisure to date men. With a dragoon as her father, no knight would unskillfully approach her.

She had no resistance to the male gender.

Her accustomed façade was her own way of rebelling against her father. While Enora's dragon was abridging and conveying Rudel's conversation, it noticed the strange behavior of its contractor.

'What's wrong?'

"... I-it's nothing."

To make sure no one perceived her reddened face, Enora directed her mind towards other things. As her head changed to their course of action henceforth, she sought confirmation with Rudel, who was still arguing.

"Sorry to interrupt. But more importantly, is it not best that we first make a report? The higher-ups are still angry over his present unaccounted for status."

While she acted as if she was calmly thinking over future plans, Enora's gaze was directed at Rudel. As the conversation was turned towards work,

Cattleya also changed her train of thought.

"Right... then I'll go report. You stay and watch over him."

Cattleya pointed at Rudel, the seed of worry, as she ordered Enora to stay alone with him. While she was a woman, she was first a knight, and Enora agreed to abide the request.

There was nothing to say about man and woman. More than anything, leaving Rudel alone would be a problem.

Even now, perhaps thinking the conversation was over, he had started into preparing lunch.

"That aside, why won't you come back? If Sakuya is training, then isn't it fine if you return? If need be, I can take you back now."

When Cattleya asked Rudel as if only noticing it now, Rudel made a perplexed face.

"Eh? If Sakuya is training, then I have to train too. Today, I played with the dragon children!"

As Rudel boldly confessed to playing, Cattleya silently lowered a fist on his head.

"... I'll hear out your excuse."

"Isn't that something you're supposed to say after you hit me? Well, Mystith-sama left the care of the children to me, and while she was at it, she taught me Marty-sama's training method. Both me and Sakuya will have powered up by the time we return home. Ow!"

As Cattleya silently put in a kick, her red dragon cheered her on.

'Kick him! Kick him more! I only ever get treated like this whenever Rudel's involved! It's definitely that guy's fault!'

Cattleya continued kicking him for a while, but once she grew tired, she gave up.

"You really should grow some self-awareness!"

"Why!? This is to become the strongest dragoon!"

"Shut it! The first step is to become a decent human being!"

Cattleya's statement, which would definitely set the captain laughing if he was there, echoed through the forest. Looking over that scene, Enora's eyes grew sharp.

Chapter 100

Left to watch over Rudel, Enora would be alone with him until Cattleya returned from giving her report.

Even when it was a man and woman together, and they were by a lake in a forest, a place with all the conditions together, there was absolutely no sensuality to it at all. No, since Rudel was wearing nothing but a wrap around his waist, perhaps he was exuding a hint of sexuality.

But he was grappling with a few child dragons and playing around.

Peeking at that scene from a little away, Enora was using a tree stump in place of a chair. There were a number of bags on her dragon's back, and one of them contained ample emergency rations.

Her only worry was that Rudel was a man. But if she was told the man before her eyes would assault her, she had no choice but to doubt.

Of all else, he was living quite a free lifestyle, either playing with dragons or preparing meals. Within all that, he only ever called out to Enora twice.

"Procure some food supplies." "I'm going to sleep."

That was it. While Enora had been wary at the start, after the first night went by, she understood that was a futile effort on her part. She had confidence in her looked and body, leaving her in a bit of disbelief.

(Could it be I'm not as charming as I thought I was?)

While she seriously began mulling over how to associate with men, Rudel was making a truly nice smile as he played with the dragons.

Wanting to make him think of exactly what he had perpetuated, Enora called over to Rudel.

"Hey you, is it really alright for you to play around like that? You're already a dragoon with responsibility, right? You don't have the time to play around here."

While her phrasing was a bit thorny, it was the truth.

But Rudel's standards were always a bit off. As expected of an oddball who revered Marty, his thoughts could be said to be closest to Marty's.

That wasn't all. Rudel and Sakuya had a promise to keep. In order to fulfill their promises to the black fog, Rudel's priorities were different from the other dragoons.

"No problem. Right now, Sakuya is training. If my dragon isn't here, I'm no more than a single knight. So I've decided to wait here."

"And I'm telling you, in that case, you could just wait obediently at the lodging house. You're causing trouble to all of us."

"... When your partner is doing their best, would you be able to sit still and rest?"

When you're playing around, what do you think you're saying? Thought Enora as she let out a sigh.

"We're knights. We have an obligation to follow our orders."

"You do have a point. But before being a knight, I am a dragoon. If my partner Sakuya is working hard, I've decided to wait for her."

(It's the same no matter where you wait.)

Fed-up, Enora gave up on persuading Rudel and looked up at the sky. The tree branches and leaves got in the way, and she couldn't quite see it, but the light streaming in was beautiful.

Looking back on herself, she saw she rarely ever had the opportunity to spend her time in such leisure.

She had trained to become a dragoon, and at the academy, she had polished herself. Even after becoming a knight, she had worked desperately to build up her ability.

Up until she obtained a dragon, she really was busy. And even after that, what followed were busy days of training and investigating Rudel... this was truly comfortable.

Feeling a sudden sense of drowsiness, she accepted it and let it come upon her.



A young Enora stood stock still before her. In the darkness, her father's voice flew at her from all directions.

"How many times do I have to say it!? If you can't do it, then you're not sleeping tonight!" "As if you could become a dragoon if you can't even do that!"

'... It's not like I wanted to become one.'

'I'm telling you, I don't know this Cattleya person. Don't compare us!'

"Cattleya caused a problem. Good grief... even so, she should be glad she got off, just with being sent off to the border." "Cattleya isn't returning from the border. With this, we can finally have some relief."

'... As I was saying, who the hell is Cattleya!?'

"You're going to the dragon dwellings again? How old do you plan to become before you can contract a dragon!?" "Hah, when I thought you'd finally become a dragoon, Cattleya's a lieutenant."

'What is it? What isn't to your liking!? If you like Cattleya more than me, then you could've just said it from the start! I worked hard! I did my best,

and yet...'

A younger form of herself began to crouch and weep before her eyes. Enora looked over the scene, gritting her teeth.

Her own form she didn't want to see brought in her irritation.

When she grabbed her child self's arm to pull her to her feet, that child's face was no longer crying. It simply returned an intense glare.

'... When you're just afraid. You're scared your father will choose Cattleya, right? I mean, no one ever looks at you. Even when you try looking like that, you don't even have the confidence to back it... weakling. You'll never triumph over Cattleya.'

"W-what do you know!!"

Flying into a rage, Enora opened her eyes.



Hearing Enora's pained voice, Rudel headed over to find she was having a nightmare.

Enora's wind dragon had left the area to find food. The child dragons were following behind Rudel.

Peering into Enora's face, she looked to be in pain.

"She's having a nightmare. I better wake her."

Just as he placed an arm on Enora's shoulder, she opened her eyes. Her gaze moving left and right to probe out the surrounding situation, her breath was exceedingly rough.

Her usual form of leisure was nowhere to be found.

Seeing Enora was awake, Rudel retracted the hand he had extended to her shoulder. With rough breath, Enora had her torso leaned up against a tree.

She stood from the spot to look at Rudel. Out of breath, she confirmed Rudel was there.

"Hah, hah you... you used to be engaged to Cattleya, right?"

"Yeah, I definitely was engaged to her. What about it?"

There, perhaps her leisure had come back as Enora unfastened a button at her bosom. Getting her breath in order, she showed off her body even more charming than usual.

"Hey, do you want to go out with me?"

Cattleya had conducted problematic behavior exceedingly ill in nature towards Rudel. But there were rumors going back and forth between the female dragoons.

Rumors that Cattleya had a thing for Rudel. While she didn't know where that rumor had come from, to Enora, snatching up what Cattleya wanted was a good feeling indeed.

The fact she was suddenly seducing Rudel was surely because she had just gotten up, and her head wasn't working normally.

But Rudel's response was exceedingly light.

"That's not happening."

"... Eh?"

A foolish voice came from Enora, who was trying to emphasize her chest. After confirming that Enora was okay, he took along the dragon children and headed back towards the lake.

In her panic, Enora yelled at his back to hear out his reasons.

"Why's that!? You're not interested in me? Or are you not interested in women!?"

Rudel turned, and matching his movement, the child dragons turned as well. Making a bit of a reluctant face, Rudel answered.

"You sure are a rude one. I like women, and I do lust after them. But I don't have that sort of freedom."

"That's a lie! When you won't even fulfill your obligation as a knight, why are you only diligent when it comes to that!?"

"Hah, you are definitely appealing. But when you don't even particularly like me, going out is just strange. If you're after money or status, you should give up on the Arses House."

As Rudel turned his back uninterestedly, Enora looked on dumbfounded. After a while, she glared at Rudel with intense frustration.

Her clenched fist was shaking.

(You mean even this guy... even this sort of guy is making fun of me.)



Around that time, Cattleya was reporting to the vice-captain.

"Why didn't you bring him back!?"

To the vice-captain who slammed the desk in a display of anger, she gave a response that seemed earnest on the surface.

"Sir, when he did not have his dragon, I thought it pointless to have him return. Recruit Rudel's and his dragon have set the dragons' dwelling as their point of reunion. It was in my best interest to refrain from moving him and causing a possible panic..."

"No excuses! In that case, you just had to take Rudel along to search for his dragon. Return at once and find them!"

The reason Alejandro was so panicked lay in the grand gesture had had shown the authorities of taking responsibility for the search. Through his

hostility towards Oldart, he had dug his own grave.

"But with nothing more to go by than 'the north sea', such a search would surely prove difficult for us alone.

"I'll send around the necessary personnel. Wait... the north sea, you say?"

"Yes. I believe that will be too harsh on the new recruits. All the knights in possession of water dragons are currently away on missions."

In the north sea existed the sorts of monsters that would prey on dragons. With their slender, snake-like bodies, those one-horned monsters boasted visages of extreme ferocity.

Called the Pent Seasers, they were the monsters that ruled the north sea.

If dragged into the water, even a dragon could become a meal. The only ones who could contest them one-on-one were the water dragons who could display their power within the water.

Even so, outrunning them was often the most they could hope for.

It was an exceedingly dangerous land.

"So Bennet and Keith are on missions... we can't remove them."

The appearance of monsters in the coastal waters of a trade city had the two knights who possessed water dragons off on a mission.

Taking the underwater battles into account, it wasn't possible to remove them from the mission. Alejandro couldn't understand why Sakuya had brought her feet all the way to the north sea.

"How could this be."

As Alejandro thought, Cattleya made a proposal she thought was safe.

"We're not currently in any danger. Why don't we dispatch someone to keep watch on him and establish periodic contact? As long as we can hold him in

place, it shouldn't be a problem."

"We cannot call Rudel back?"

"He doesn't seem to have any intention of moving."

Hearing Cattleya's answer, Alejandro slammed his fist against the desk. It was because the former captain and vice-captain knew this side of him that they had chosen Oldart as captain.

But when it came to comprehensive ability, it was said Alejandro was the higher of the two.

"... Let the new recruits watch over him on rotation. No, wait, Cattleya, you take some responsibility and keep watch."

"Yes sir (Tsk, he wants to push it onto me)."

It was decided then and there that Cattleya would take responsibility to keep watch over Rudel. But skillful with her words, Cattleya managed to push responsibility onto her superior Lilim.



In the north sea, Mystith was bestowing unto Sakuya her sure-fire plan to defeat the boss of the dragon stables.

The north sea was exceedingly cold, abundant in all forms of sea life, and famous for their taste. But it was also famous for the appearance of Pent Seasers. Those ferocious monsters who would mercilessly scarf down any enemy that would dare tread on their turf.

'Now there! One, two, finish!!'

Matching Mystith's voice, Sakuya smacked her left fist into the pent seaser that leapt out of the water, and next she smacked in her right fist.

Finally, she took a turn, hammering in a powerful blow with her tail.

After ingraining the art of hovering into herself, she was now training on those sandbags called pent sears to overcome the fear of fighting the boss.

'Put more force into it!! And you have to aim for the vitals! Eyes up, the next one is coming.'

'These guys look scarryyyy!!'

Sakuya complained, but Mystith trained her harshly.

'If these guys can surprise you, you'll never be able to take on the boss of the stables. No this time get those fists and tail in faster, more precisely! Like this!!'

A pent sear leapt at Mystith from the water. But without any excess movement, Mystith plunged in her fists, finally using her tail to deliver the final blow.

She nonchalantly showed a fine-tuned art of putting in two attacks with her tail.

As she blew it away, she went the pent sear onto land. Over there were the piles of pent sears that had been taken down by the two dragons.

'Your arms are long and your fists are large. Even your tail is hard, so as long as you grasp the trick, it's simple. Once you use this to sink the boss, you'll become the new boss!'

'Boss sounds like a pain. I want to take it easy with Rudel.'

'Don't be so soft!!'

'And even if I can do hoovarin (?) my breath doesn't hit, and I can't fly in formation... they're going to make fun of Rudel.'

The pent sear that jumped out at a depressed Sakuya was split in two by a shot of Mystith's compressed water laser.

After it fell, she let out a sigh and made a promise to Sakuya.

'I understand. I'll tag along in that 'formation flying' of yours, so for now, just concentrate on this. Your breaths will start hitting their mark eventually.'

'Really?'

'Leave it to me! I'll choose a few from my turf... I guess they won't stand out much? In that case, I'll bring some good-looking ones from the other turfs with me.'

In the other turfs, there were dragons who wouldn't even try to move it Mystith called out. While they obeyed her only once, when the undead dragon's soul was released, apart from that, they didn't get involved.

'If you bring them, will I be able to fly in formation?'

Sakuya didn't really understand the whole flight formation thing. But it was something she heard from Rudel, so she only recognized it as something she could ask him about later.

What's more, she was convinced Mystith knew what it was.

'Leave it to me! I'll give you a splendid flight formation!'

Chapter 101

Mystith and Sakuya had temporarily returned from the north sea, and the large load of pent seasers that carried back left Luxheidt, who had subbed in for surveillance duty, in mute amazement.

"You brought back quite a bit."

'Amazing, right!? They're for you.'

Sakuya put her hands to her hips in pride as she bent her back backwards. A majority of the pent seasers had been beaten in the face.

The dragon children started biting onto the giant sea creatures.

Apart from them, from the lake, slightly larger dragons on the verge of adulthood began gathering as well.

'Well, I hunted a majority of them. Sakuya, you see, she finally managed to do hovering, but she's not putting her body weight into her fists and tail.'

As Mystith made a punching motion, Rudel nodded. Her straits were of especially good form.

"I see Sakuya's working hard."

'As long as my feet touch the ground, I'm perfect! One, two, finish! Is what you do, and the boss is down for the count!!'

As Sakuya swung her fists around, the wind pressure shook the trees. Seeing she had regained her energy, Rudel smiled as well.

Unlike Rudel, Luxheidt's complexion was only going paler.

Having heard out the reason for Sakuya's running away, he knew his own dragon wasn't unrelated. Seeing Sakuya's punching motions, he worried for his partner.

"That's the spirit! ... But you see, Sakuya. I have some bad news. The dragon stable's boss is Lieutenant Cattleya's red dragon."

'O-oh no! I thought he was a good dragon...'

While Sakuya hung her head, Mystith to her side was shaking. After a moment of silence, she let out a roar to the heavens. Her roar practically contained enough force to part the clouds.

'That trash-tier dragooooonnn!! I'll send him straight to hell!!'

Having witnessed that scene, Luxheidt decided to resign from his surveillance duty. Meanwhile, Luxheidt's partner gray dragon informed its comrades at the dragon stable of this truth.

The stables were shrouded in the atmosphere of a wake.



"Formation flying? I've never seen it either."

'I see, I thought if anyone, you'd be the one to know.'

As Luxheidt's health took a turn and he went to bed, Mystith sought confirmation with Rudel about flying in formation. It was something that didn't exist in Marty's era, and something Mystith hadn't any interest in, so she didn't know.

But with the matter with Sakuya, she couldn't ask any of the dragons currently contracted to active dragons.

So Mystith seriously began thinking over what to do in the request she had taken up from Sakuya.

"Ah, but I do know what they're going to do. It seems they're going to line up and fly over the airspace of the capital."

'That sounds easy enough.'

"No, apparently they need to do some aerial maneuvers as well. It's something of an established practice that happens every year, and it's for the new and old dragoons to display their mettle. Since it takes place every year, they try one-upping each other each year, so the level of difficulty's risen to a problematic level."

While Rudel explained, based on Sakuya's condition, he had the notion of not taking part in his field of vision. If it was possible, he wanted to participate, but he wasn't particularly fixated on it.

To Rudel, Sakuya was more important.

'Aerial maneuver? Over a city? As that child is now, there will be some substantial collateral damage.'

Right, for the current Sakuya, even turning around in midair was dangerous. Just by falling onto the city, the total damage would be considerable.

"That's right. I intend to withdraw."

'You idiot! You enormous idiot!! You might be alright with that, but that child will mind. Hah~, how troublesome.'

Looking at the rare sight of a dragon in thought, Rudel mulled over it seriously as well.

"Apparently, it's fine as long as you have impact, so could we give up on the aerial maneuvers and focus on something else? Dressing Sakuya up nicely or something?"

'I see, I'm not sure what to think about dressing her, but it's fine as long as there's impact, huh. That makes matters simple. We just have to put that child at the center and have the others do acrobatics around her.'

"Certainly. But Sakuya's large, so it will be a hard task for the new recruits."

The flight formations were done in groups split between newbies and veterans. From the fact there were nine new recruits that term, the formation would consist of nine steeds.

Rudel tried imagining the giant Sakuya with the other newbies' gray dragons and Enora's wind dragon flying around her.

But that lacked the impact.

It would appear too crude for the people who came to watch the dragons flying in formation each year.

'Leave it to me. I'll lead along some of the good-looking ones... if that's what it's come to, it'll take a bit of time.'

Mystith began preparing for her own flight formation.



"So I'm on surveillance again."

"Are you dissatisfied?"

"No... I, Enora Campbell, take on the duty of watching over Rudel."

In the vice-captain office, Enora saluted her father Alejandro. But Alejandro was on the clock, and he didn't treat her as a father would his daughter.

While that was the correct thing to do, for Enora, her father was always a dragoon. Even when he returned home, she barely saw any difference.

"Cattleya shows not the slightest motivation in this case. I'm placing my hopes on you."

While Alejandro didn't notice it himself, he was constantly comparing Cattleya and Enora. Enora was definitely his daughter, and he did love her, but that was precisely why he couldn't accept that she fell short of Cattleya.

And such words would always leave deep wounds on the girl.

The man himself had only spoken the truth. Cattleya was also involved in the matter at hand, and he hadn't the mind to compare her and his daughter.

(So my father plans to push the job Cattleya's unmotivated to do onto me.)

Alejandro wanted her to hurry and become a first-rate dragoon, he was sure he was being harsh on her for that sake. But his daughter Enora knew not such intent.

(Cattleya, Cattleya, Cattleya... if you like her so much, then just adopt her already!)

Leaving the office, Enora passed by the captain, Oldart, give a salute before leaving with swift feet to prepare for her mission.

Having been passed by, Oldart breathed out a sigh. He had noticed Enora's expression as if she was cornered, and sensed things weren't going well between Alejandro and his daughter.

The fact he knew the man was mindful of his daughter through his work led him to instantly understand Alejandro's lack of emotional leisure was the cause.

"What sort of face is that? That Alejandro, there really is no helping him."

A worn look on his face, Oldart dropped by the vice-captain office, entering the room without so much as a knock. There was a bundle of documents gripped in his hand and they were documents pertaining to the training ground Rudel had destroyed.

"Yo! I went and finished all the miscellaneous stuff."

These sort of matters were what Alejandro was supposed to do. Command of Rudel and Sakuya's search should have been taken by Oldart. In truth, a majority of the brigade members knew it would go better like that.

"You could at least knock. More importantly, about Rudel. When he gets back, we should have some severe punishment in store."

"Against an archduke? You're an idiot, aren't you."

Alejandro's serious intent to punish Rudel severely was blown away with a smile. In essence, the top brass of Courtois wasn't seeking that much from them.

More than that, it was more problematic that the vice-captain was seeking heavy punishment in the first place.

He was white knight, a future archduke, and there was even a possibility he could become the next king. Within all that, the authorities couldn't possibly accept Alejandro's opinion.

"What's wrong with seeking harsh punishment on a dragoon and a knight of this country!? If we treat him specially, we won't be able to set an example for the others!!"

"Don't get so angry. And just look here, Rudel and his dearest are a bit special. You need to learn to adapt and improve."

Alejandro's opinion was sound. At present, Rudel was but a single knight, and he had an obligation to obey orders from the top.

But Rudel's position was special, and what was asked of him was different.

"Adapt and improve? I don't want to hear that from the man who ends up behind in everything."

"Yeah, yeah, so... anyways. Did you find Rudel-kun?"

"... He's living a survival lifestyle in the dragons' dwellings. And to think he's enjoying it, how easygoing can he be."

Elsewhere from the words Alejandro spat out, Oldart gave a grin.

(Now that's an interesting one. If it were me, I'd decline having to camp out in that dangerous land. Well, it looks like it's going to be a pain, even after he gets back.)

Oldart looked at Alejandro, letting out a sigh at the stiff expression of his vice-captain.

(Hah, guess I'll have to follow through. Thought Alejandro's going to be angry.)



A few days later, having switched out with Luxheidt on Rudel's surveillance duty, Enora was looking at Rudel.

Unlike last time, he had now received a new task from Mystith, and he was casting recovery magic on the child dragons.

As a knight, he was only required to know recovery magic to the extent of first-aid.

Seeing him start working on it so late in the game, Enora looked at Rudel with mocking eyes. Lowering her hips onto the tree stump that had become her favorite, she called out to Rudel, who continued his treatment a little ways away.

"Even if you do that much treatment, I don't think it'll make you a better dragoon."

But without even turning his face, Rudel responded.

"If I'm told it's something necessary for a dragon, then it's something necessary for me. I have to polish this healing magic more."

"Hah, isn't there something more important for you to do? Why don't you master your other magics? It's your specialty, right? Graduating the academy with top grades, winning the individuals' tournament, it all sounds too good to be true."

"... I'm not good at magic at all. That's why I desperately worked on it. I only have a bit of talent in swordplay and martial arts. If I went about it normally, I'd never beat genius. That's why I polished it. And even now, I'm training every day."

When Rudel said he couldn't win against genius, Enora shot back.

"What's with that!? You had talent, didn't you!? That's why your grades were at the top and you dominated the tournament, right? You say that's not talent? Don't make me laugh!"

When it came to enough effort to make one taste blood, Enora had done it as well. While being a girl, she had trained with her spear day after day until her hands turned rough and callous.

In studies and magic, under her father's words, she had desperately studied.

Yet even she couldn't reach the top of the academy. Her grades were in the upper ranks, but she was constantly compared to Cattleya, who went and graduated first.

She was different from Rudel, who delightedly trained every day because he wanted to become a dragon.

Once Enora's voice converted to a scream, the young dragon by Rudel's side shot a ball of water. The orb racing towards Enora was small, but even so, it was something fired by a dragon, young as it was.

On that sudden occurrence, Enora was late to react. Hit by that orb, she ended up blasted back.

At that moment, she failed in her landing and twisted her leg.

The wind dragon nearby Enora opened its mouth wide, letting out a roar and taking up an intimidating stance towards the child dragon.

All the young dragons present took off at once, diving deep into the depths of the lake. Rudel was the only one left on the spot.

"You rascals, if you're going to run, then you shouldn't do mischief in the first place... those precious little things."

While the wind dragon intimidated Rudel, he didn't seem bothered by it. More than that, he knew that if it was really angry, the wind dragon would have killed him.

Heading over to Enora, he decided to look at her injury.



Removing her soaked clothes, Enora draped a robe over her undergarments.

She prepared an open fire to dry off her clothes. While she had a change of clothing prepared, she planned to change into it after she had Rudel look at her sprained leg.

Feeling a bit guilty, Rudel volunteered to treat her. More than anything, the swelling was a bit severe. As Enora was bad at healing magic, she chose to leave it to Rudel.

"There's a slight crack in the bone. Well, at this level, it'll work itself out."

"... I'm sorry about before. I got too emotional."

"Sure enough, you get emotional quite easily."

Seeing Rudel smile as he affirmed it, Enora's face went stiff. If she said something like that, she had thought a majority of men would deny it.

With the conversation going differently to how she expected, Enora ended up closing her mouth from embarrassment.

"Then I'll start... it's been a while since I tested on a human, but even if it hurts, do your best not to cry."

"I won't cry!"

But in the next moment, Enora's tears flowed.

"Kuh, any more is... no! I'm already..."

Slumped on the ground, her leg stuck out towards Rudel, Enora's robe had lightly peeled off. Every time she wrenched her body, her robe would reveal more.

Her face was red, her breath rough. And her eyes were unfocused. At first, she was sitting, showing only her leg, but now she lay with her hands frantically grasping the weeds that grew on the ground.

"Does it hurt? It's going to be over soon."

Rudel grasped Enora's ankle with his left hand to fix it in place, letting off a warm light of magic from his right. It was a healing magic, and a special healing magic he had learned from Mystith.

Healing was always accompanied by pain, and it was a magic specialized to relieve that pain as much as possible.

"Wrong! That's not ieeeeek!"

As she gripped the weeds on the ground, she put in too much power and plucked them away. Her back arching, Enora bit onto the edge of her robe to prevent herself from letting out any more of her voice.

She couldn't raise any more embarrassing sounds.

Her mouth pulling away the bottom of her robe, Enora exposed her bare legs to Rudel. But now wasn't the time to care about that.

She felt her consciousness would fly away a number of times, and within that, Rudel put a stop to his magic.

"Are you alright?"

"Hah, hah, I-I'm fine... eh?"

It was only there that she recognized her own situation. She had writhed around so much her robe had almost completely come off. Her lower half

was completely exposed to Rudel.

Growing embarrassed, she tried to restore her robe only for Rudel to restart his treatment.

"I see, then I'll go on. There's only a little more to go."

"W-wait! Wait I saaaayy!!"

Her agony continuing a little while longer, once the treatment was over, she was left laid over the ground, her robe fully open and exposing her body to Rudel.

From the sheer intensity of her treatment, there was saliva dripping from Enora's lips. At times, some meaningless words would come from her mouth.

"Yeah~, it looks like I've got a long way to go. But is a sprain really supposed to be that painful? ... I-it couldn't be! You mean my healing magic was extremely painful!?"

When Rudel was aiming for a healing magic that lessened the pain, this was a serious problem.

"When I was casting magic so the dragons wouldn't feel any pain, if it brings such torment to the all-important human patients, I won't be able to use it! Damn, I'll have to relearn it from the ground up."

A depressed Rudel, and Enora, who lay powerlessly.

Rudel was in a waist wrap, and Enora in her undergarments. If anyone saw, it was a scene open to all manner of misinterpretation.

Chapter 102

After Rudel healed her sprain with healing magic, Enora could no longer look into his face.

It went without saying; Rudel had seen such a deplorable side of her. But she still had time left on her surveillance duty, and she couldn't quite abandon her mission to run away.

Her face turning red every time she observed Rudel's form, Enora was definitely a failure at her job.

Cattleya, who met up with them along the way, looked at Enora with wonder.

"What's up with you?"

"N-no... it's nothing."

"No, something clearly went down. Why is your face so red?"

"And I'm telling you that it's nothing!"

Ignoring their unproductive quarrel, Rudel was riding a shield of light he had produced over the lake. That shield that used magic to glide along the water's surface was practically a board.

Atop the water, Rudel was moving about freely.

From the lake, orbs of water flew from the mouths of child dragons. As he avoided them, Rudel seemed to be enjoying himself.

"That one was close!"

Growing irritated, the dragon children desperately tried to hit Rudel with their orbs. At times, they would leap out of the water to take him from surprise, occasionally targeting him from the air as well.

But they were unable to capture Rudel.

It was almost as if he had eyes on the back of his head, and he managed to dodge everything coming at him. But that was only something he was capable of because he was up against those immature dragons.

Watching over them carefully for days, he had seen through the habits and tendencies of the dragons.

It would be questionable to say Mystith was thinking that deeply when she had him take care of the young children, but Rudel had grown some.

He had gained a deeper understanding of dragons. The practical experience he could never get in a book had Rudel take another step forward as a dragoon.

Seeing that scene, Cattleya created a fireball in her hand and threw it at Rudel. At that attack she had fired with the premise of Rudel dodging it, Enora showed a face of surprise.

Because it was on a level where he wouldn't get off with a scratch of two if it hit.

"What are you doing, brat!!"

When the ball of fire hit the surface, it raised a small pillar of water. Rudel was swallowed up by its wave, tossed from his shield into the lake.

"L-lieutenant Cattleya..."

"You look healthy, Rudel. More importantly, could you explain this situation?"

'Oy, don't bully that one too much. I'll be killed.'

Seeing her own fearful red dragon, Cattleya clicked her tongue. She had somehow managed to push responsibility onto Lilim, but her own dragon cowering from Mystith was simply too pitiful.

"Yes ma'am. I was bored, so I thought up a new way to use my shield. While hovering was apparently a failure, I'm sure there must be another effective way to use it."

As Rudel popped his head out of the water to answer, Cattleya felt her head hurt.

"... And where is your dragon? We're just about running out of time here."

"She's returned a few times, and it seems there's just a little more to go."

"She came back? Why didn't you take her back, then!?"

Crawling out of the lake, Rudel corrected the positioning of his waist wrap before turning to face Cattleya. Dripping with water, his facial features were well set from the start, making Rudel appear terribly dashing.

And he was almost naked.

Cattleya swallowed her breath.

"No, it seems she's almost perfected it. Her sure-kill combo to take down the boss."

'Combo! What's more, sure-kill!? Why didn't you stop her, you idiot!'

As Cattleya's dragon started acting up, Rudel soothed him to calm down. While he was carrying himself calmly, if one had to say who was mistaken, it was Rudel.

"I believe if it's Sakuya, she'll be fine. Even if she loses, she'll surely get back on her feet!"

Rudel believed in Sakuya, but that didn't make the red dragon happy at all. More than that, having her come at him for real would be a problem.

Even if he defeated Sakuya, there was the scary Mystith waiting behind her. It wasn't by much, but he didn't get the feeling he'd be able to win. So he feared winning this battle was the scarier option.

Losing to the newly-born Sakuya would be a disgrace, but it beat having Mystith after his life. Cattleya's dragon teared up.

"Good grief, why are you so pitiful?"

'Don't screw with me! When it's not even my fault, try thinking of the guy who's going to get the crap kicked out of him!'

Seeing Rudel and Cattleya delightfully conversing, Enora's feelings only turned needlessly darker. While she was mainly shouting at Rudel, both she and Rudel frankly spoke their minds, and Enora looked on it enviously.

It seemed to her that Cattleya possessed everything she could never have.

(Both father and Rudel, a talented demon sword holder... when I don't have anything...)

Enora thought the sort of things that would make a knight who couldn't become a dragoon want to smack her. Yet suddenly, it all began to feel idiotic to her.

That attitude of Cattleya, who was pretty much a mass of talent, was one thing, but she couldn't even triumph over Rudel who claimed he had no talent at all. She knew from the start.

Enora had accurately assessed Rudel and feared him for it. Even if his dragon fell short of the others, Sakuya possessed many things the other dragons did not.

That's why she panicked when Rudel decided he wouldn't shirk his trainee responsibilities, yet still exerted himself to find a way to clear the test. While Enora did have a few parts to her different from other people, she had given Rudel a proper evaluation.

As if a thread was reaching its limit, she could almost hear the sound of it snapping.

It was at that moment.

Sakuya fell straight into the lake, with Mystith appearing a little later. With a fed-up look on her face, Mystith nonchalantly explained Sakuya's failed landing.

'That's why I told you. You have to lose altitude with care... you're in too much of a rush.'

Sticking her head out of the lake, Sakuya looked at Mystith.

'I mean...'

When a build as large as Sakuya's dived into the lake, the water that brimmed over rained down on everyone in the area. That water that advanced on them like a wave soaked them down to their socks.

As Cattleya pushed her hair to the side, she searched out Sakuya's partner, Rudel. She wanted to get in a complaint or two, but Rudel had already leapt at Sakuya.

"Sakuya, I was waiting for you!"

Sticking himself to Sakuya's head, Rudel began stroking her. Delighted, Sakuya spoke proudly of her results in the northern sea.

'Ahem! Sakuya has finally learned her sure-kill one, two, finish! With this, I'm sure I can defeat the boss!'

As Sakuya rejoiced, Rudel suddenly recalled something and scanned the area for the red dragon. But just as Rudel had, the red dragon had leapt off somewhere.

Leaving Cattleya behind...

"T-that stupid dragon!!"

Cattleya's scream resounded through the forest.



With Sakuya's preparations finished, they were to hurriedly return.

Mystith had some business to attend to, and Cattleya decided to ride on Sakuya's back. This may have been because not a white horse, Rudel on his white dragon seemed to overlap just a bit with her own ideal.

In truth, Sakuya was large, and whether she ferried one person or two, it wasn't much of a difference. Rudel was also returning, leaving behind his waist-wrap state for the first in a long while.

As the red dragon had run away, the soaked Cattleya had to borrow clothing from Enora. But while Cattleya wasn't on the small side by any means, the breast area seemed to have ample space to spare.

"Are you ready?"

"I'm fine. Enora, you return first and give a report."

After Cattleya finished dressing, she ordered Enora to return first and report. Enora saluted and followed orders, but she didn't seem to have her usual smile.

Rudel was a bit mindful of that, but after straddling her wind dragon, the girl in question swiftly rose away into the sky.

"What's wrong?"

Rudel looked up at the sky Enora disappeared into with a serious look on his face. His eyes were a little sorrowful.

"No, I just felt a little nostalgic."

"Nostalgic?"

Cattleya was mindful of her chest as she mused. Rudel turned once towards Cattleya, peering deeply into her eyes.

"W-what?"

While her face turned mildly red as she averted her eyes, Rudel silently leapt onto Sakuya's back. After a moment of surprise, Cattleya puffed up her cheeks.

Because while she had some light expectations, but Rudel didn't do anything.

But to Rudel, it looked as if Enora overlapped with the Cattleya of the past. He understood as far as the fact the target of her hatred wasn't him, but Cattleya this time.

From time to time, the look in Enora's eyes would turn sharp, and that was only ever when Cattleya was there. The eyes once directed at himself were now pointed in Cattleya's direction.

A little curious, Rudel situated himself on Sakuya's back before lending Cattleya a hand up and questioning her.

"Is Enora a past acquaintance of yours?"

"Hah? Never heard of her. I'm pretty sure we were in the same year at the academy, but... oh, you have a thing for that girl? What are you going to do about black hair?"

Rudel didn't seem bothered by Cattleya's cynicism. His attitude irritated her. Yet Rudel's profile she once detested, looking at it now, it was close to her idea.

Perhaps that only made him needlessly more irritating as she turned her face away.

"Sakuya, it's about time to go."

'Yeah!'

Sakuya slowly floated into the sky, before giving her wings a few powerful beats. While she fell short of a wind dragon, or any other dragon for the matter of fact, Rudel liked the sensation of flying with Sakuya.

Her neck and back were furnished with the proper equipment for a knight to ride. Sakuya had run away, so she hadn't brought them along, but during his surveillance duty, Luxheidt had tactfully brought them a pair.

Cattleya felt just a little restless riding on the back of a different dragon.



In the air, Cattleya looked over Sakuya's back, getting a real sense of its breadth.

While Sakuya was giant from the start, from the point of view of a human, Cattleya's red dragon was giant as well. The first time she straddled his back, she felt it was endlessly vast as well.

But Sakuya was extraordinary. And therein lay the problem.

"It's considerably spacious, and stable, but... are we even moving?"

"Well, she was originally a gaia dragon subspecies, so please don't expect too much from the speed. But Sakuya's strength and destructive power are incomparable to the average dragon!"

"You've already told me that."

Tired of Rudel's praise for Sakuya, with the snail's pace they were going at, Cattleya was growing bored. She didn't usually talk much with Rudel, and she couldn't grasp how she was supposed to interact with him.

She was trying to apologize for what had happened before, but she had missed the right timing.

The feelings from back then, the hatred, the loathing, the desire to crush him, looking back on them now, she still couldn't understand them. She was

informed she had been possessed by the black fog, but before the man she had hated, she found it quite hard to apologize.

Unable to be honest, Cattleya mustered her courage to give an earnest apology.... And it was at that moment that Rudel cried out.

"Sakuya, heads up!"

"Eh?"

'Wowowhoa!'

Coincident with Rudel's cry, Sakuya altered her flight path. There, from directly above them, a breath rained down. Those masses of magic a dragon would fire off came down on Sakuya in consecutive bursts.

What Cattleya saw when she looked straight up was the silhouette of a wind dragon. But they had already parted from the dragon dwellings, and it didn't seem to be a wild dragon.

"Why..."

On the violent, rapid rotation of Sakuya's back, she felt a weight she usually couldn't feel. But she didn't remove her eyes from the wind dragon assailing them.

During her surveillance of Rudel, she had noticed that Rudel and Sakuya would never be attacked by wild dragons. And yet, come so far, a dragon attacking them was strange.

If they didn't anger it by trespassing on its turf, then she couldn't comprehend the cause.

(This is bad... this child won't be able to shake it off.)

Confirming they were dealing with a wind dragon, Cattleya concluded it was impossible for Sakuya to outrun it. The wind dragons were said to be the most lacking in firepower, but they boasted fearsome speed and aptitude in aerial battles.

Their rate of breath rapid fire was considered top-class among the dragon subspecies, and while there were differences among individuals, a dogfight put Sakuya at a disadvantage.

Among wild dragons, the ones with the greatest numbers were the wind dragons. within the dragoon brigade as a whole, among their wild dragons, the wind dragons were most numerous as well.

Knowing of Lilim's wind dragon, Cattleya perceived the unfavorable ground over which they were hovering. And the enemy dragon was a young and powerful one.

That it was too young for its own good was perhaps their sole salvation.

Its breath didn't have the same power as Lilim's dragon. It's rapid fire had a ways to go.

"Rudel, keep dodging!"

As Cattleya looked at Rudel and issued orders, Rudel relayed those orders to Sakuya.

"Got it! Sakuya, don't let it set its aim. Go right into a zigzag and...! Raise altitude!"

Rudel suddenly changed his orders, but Sakuya managed to obey and swerved up. The wind dragon passed right below them.

In the moment Cattleya had taken her eyes off of it, the wind dragon had tried to grapple with Sakuya. Sticking onto a gaia dragon like Sakuya was, to put it bluntly, an idiotic act. The sort of action a normal dragon would avoid.

But at the moment their foe passed below them, Cattleya saw.

The fact that there was a person riding the dragon's back... and the fact that person was Enora.

"Enora... why are you...!"

Much faster than Sakuya's rise, Enora and her dragon climbed into the sky. There was no chance of defeating a wind dragon in the air. While they considered descending to the ground, they would simply be tormented to death by shots from up high.

"... Sakuya, we're subduing them."

"What are you talking about!? When even winning will be difficult, there's no way you can pin her down!"

While Cattleya refuted his words, Rudel's will was steadfast. And he didn't lack the means. No, he didn't need a plan from the start.

"You can do it, can't you, Sakuya?"

'I won't lose!'

As Sakuya roared in the sky, Enora's wind dragon fired a breath in response.

Chapter 103

Sakuya boasted the body of a gaia dragon subspecies, and she had grown bigger than even that.

While her length made her look slender, her torso was just about as thick as a gaia dragon's. And her powerful jaw was the same.

She only looked slender due to the sheer size of her body.

But her skin, a dragon's armor known as scales were exceedingly tougher than the average dragon. Even a gaia dragon's strength wouldn't be able to let her fly, and yet her four large wings could keep her airborne.

If you're asking what we're trying to say... looking at her latent abilities, Sakuya stood at the summit of the dragons. And Sakuya's soul was the soul of the 'Once-Goddess Sakuya'.

The body that became her vessel belonged to the strongest variant of gaia dragon.

Her heart had been passed from Cattleya to Lilim, to Fina, Sophina and Mii, and finally, she had inherited Sakuya's heart. While they were a somewhat problematic lot, she carried on the heart of proficient personnel.

By holding the soul and heart of Sakuya, she held feelings most closest to Sakuya, and the memories and the experiences definitely did exist somewhere within her.

While she was evaluated lowly as a dragoon, Sakuya was undoubtedly a goddragon.

Even if her evaluation was the worst, young as she was, she possessed abilities as a dragon that placed her in their upper ranks.



"Hey, why did you stop? If you stay like this, you're a sitting duck."

Sakuya roared, floating on the spot as if to wait for the wind dragon. It was proof that she was capable of hovering, and Rudel could feel Sakuya's growth.

"It's alright. That output from before won't be able to harm Sakuya... Sakuya, right!"

As Rudel issued orders, Sakuya answered them by holding her right arm out towards the wind dragon. While Enora took on a basic strategy of attack and move, Rudel chose to prioritize defense over evasion.

Sakuya took the wind dragon's breath on the palm of her right hand undaunted.

Seeing Sakuya's defensive prowess you could even call abnormal, Enora instantly changed her strategy. Perhaps intending to wear Sakuya down, as from a midrange battle of concentrated breaths, she changed over to close combat.

Flying around at a speed Sakuya couldn't follow, she planned to aim at her back the moment she got the chance.

Even if Sakuya's own back was heavily armored, Enora's aim was Cattleya. Rudel had noticed where Enora's eyes had been directed the whole time.

"Why is she challenging us to close combat? But that's convenient, trying close combat with a gaia dragon is a madman's plight."

"No, it's dangerous, so please lay low. And keep a firm grip on the lifeline."

One usually wouldn't initiate close combat with a gaia dragon. That was clearly the gaia dragon's arena.

But knowing Enora's aim, Rudel produced a shield of light to defend Cattleya. That large shield covered Sakuya's blind spot to create an impenetrable fortress.

For the current Rudel, his shields of light could easily be destroyed by a dragon's might. But he just had to use the time its destruction would buy them.

He could use that space to turn Sakuya around.

Perhaps his foe understood that as well, she wasn't making any careless attacks.

"That Enora girl, just what is she doing?"

After looking at Cattleya glaring at the wind dragon gliding about the sky, Rudel succeeded in capturing Enora in his magic eyes.

After looking into Rudel's eyes, she vexingly issued her dragon orders in a way akin to a jeer.

"... Her aim is you, Lieutenant."

"Like hell. Are you saying I did something to her?"

While Cattleya took it out on Rudel, her expression was unperturbed. She was, in her own way, trying hard to remember what she could have done.

"No, I don't know the specifics either. But she despises you, Lieutenant Cattleya. That's the sort of eyes she was making."

Rudel recalled Cattleya's eyes of old. Often finding himself hated, Rudel could sense the emotions close to loathing that dwelled in those eyes.

"And why would you know...!"

Before Cattleya could continue on, Enora continued the rapid fire of her dragon's breath. Moving at her maximum speed, she fired that breath towards Sakuya as she changed her plan.

But Sakuya only changed her facing direction without doing anything else in particular.

'Come at meeee!!'

Knowing he couldn't just leave everything to Sakuya, Rudel produced a few dozen shields of light, using them to avert the breath attacks. Hit only once, they would explode and fade away, but he was able to counterbalance.

Those shields of light stationed to protect Sakuya gave off a glimmer, lending divinity to the form of the white dragon.



"Why, why is he protecting the likes of her!"

Unable to raise a hand against the iron wall that was Sakuya, Enora cried out atop the back of her own dragon. It wasn't as if she thought she could finish it with a surprise attack.

But she had never imagined she would be so hard-pressed.

Even if Rudel himself was proficient, she had misunderstood Sakuya as a failure. In essence, she had been convinced she could win with her own dragon's speed and rapid-fire breath.

But right now, she had yet to accomplish a thing.

If Enora's condition for victory was Cattleya's murder, then that was definitely not going to happen. At mid-range, her attacks showed no effect, and at close-range, she had the disadvantage.

Even if she wanted to aim at Cattleya alone, Rudel's shields got in the way.

According to her dragon, it was more than possible to break them, but that would create an opening. Enora had picked a fight with the wrong foe.

If this was how it was going to be, then fighting Cattleya's red dragon would've given her a higher chance of victory.

But if she had challenged Cattleya and her partner red dragon, Enora would have been dead. That was just how great her gap in ability was from Cattleya.

'Kuh! What are we going to do, Enora!?'

On her partner's voice, Enora gave a slight smile.

"Having come so far, I'm going to face such a disappointing defeat... I'm sure it'll be quite the spectacle. The famed Campbell House is losing out against a single genius, after all."

Unable to win against Sakuya, Enora's dragon didn't think there would be this great of a gap in abilities either. There was a hint of impatience in his voice.

"Aha, why do I have to come so far and fail? I finally became a dragon. I finally thought I would be recognized..."

Laughing as she shed her tears, Enora wiped her tears away before making a serious expression. Before her eyes was a shining dragon, and Cattleya being protected by Rudel.

"How irritating. At the very least, I wanted to steal her man."

Without noticing the fact she had been captivated by Rudel, Enora issued orders to her dragon.

"Let's go, Falk."

'... Very well. My pride won't allow me to lose just like this.'

While they had no prospects of victory, Enora and Falk's objective was Cattleya. Even if they couldn't defeat Sakuya or Rudel, they wanted to fulfill that objective alone.

Falk thought the least he could do was fulfill Enora's purpose. He understood that he wouldn't be able to beat Sakuya. But from his pride as a dragon, he didn't want to lose without doing anything.

As Falk started his attack on Sakuya, Rudel matched it and changed the positioning of his shields.



Cattleya was looking at Rudel's back.

His form as he issued orders to Sakuya, shoddy as it was, it was beginning to take shape. From not being on her own dragon, she had felt some anxiety in Sakuya's movements, but now, she didn't feel it at all.

(Just how heavily armored is this child?)

An impossible level of sturdiness and the stamina to continue taking attacks. In that regards, Sakuya had gone beyond the level where she could make a comparison to her own dragon.

(This isn't normal. But if it's like this, then we won't...)

The moment Cattleya determined they could win if they brought it to a war of attrition, Enora suddenly changed plans. Of all things, she tried challenging Sakuya to close combat again.

"That woman's doing the same thing again..."

While Cattleya didn't feel anxious, Rudel was different. He shouted a loud order for Sakuya.

"Sakuya, be careful, she's coming!!"

Repositioning his shields, Rudel made it so Enora couldn't enter their blind spot so easily. Cattleya still hadn't shaken off the sensation of her own dragon.

With Sakuya, there was a limit to the speed at which she could react to her opponent wind dragon. If it was Cattleya's dragon, that wouldn't be a problem.

But right now, she was on Rudel's dragon, on the back of Sakuya.

The wind dragon that showed its maximum acceleration slipped into a spot diagonally back from Sakuya. Cattleya looked at that scene as if it were someone else's problem.

(Ah, crap.)

Understanding in an instant, from the fact she was the target and Sakuya's positioning, Cattleya realized she was in for it.

Just as she thought her life was a bit too short-lived, Rudel's voice resounded out.

"No, the other way, Sakuya!!"

As Cattleya was unable to hear Sakuya's voice, she had no idea what Rudel was telling her to go against. But she could feel it with her own body, how Sakuya's build suddenly wrenched to the left.

Just as the win dragon's front claws were about to assail her, Rudel leapt at Cattleya. Thrown off of Sakuya's back, the two of them were cast freely into the air.

The moment they reached the end of the long belt called the lifeline was accompanied by an intense jerk.

Sakuya's movements had caused Enora to subtly miss the mark, saving Cattleya. Of course, Rudel putting his body on the line after that was yet another reason she was saved.

And the scene the two of them saw, fished along by the belt, was one of Sakuya's backhand hitting Enora's dragon as it passed by.

But more than that, Cattleya's face was turning red, being carried by a princess cradle as she hurtled through the sky.

(Hey! What's with this situation!!)

Unable to keep up with what was going on, Cattleya panicked; meanwhile, Rudel's gaze was locked on Enora, and her partner dragon.

As the dragon was blown away, Enora had been tossed from its back as well.

"This is bad! Sakuya, I leave the lieutenant to you."

Rudel removed the metal fixing him to his bely before using wind magic to head towards Enora. As she was told, Sakuya gently collected Cattleya up in her large hands, watching the scene of Rudel catching the blown-away Enora.

As Cattleya popped her face through the gaps in Sakuya's claw, she was making a bit of an irritated expression. Lifting off the hair stuck to her face with a finger, she pouted a bit.

"What's with him..."

A maiden for her age, it felt to Cattleya as if her prince had been taken away.



Catching Enora, who had been thrown into the air, Rudel made a landing in the forest that spread out below them.

As she let her tears flow in his arms, Enora was using both hands to hide her face. But her mouth was warped in vexation. Sobs were leaking from her mouth.

"... If you're able to answer, then please tell me. Why did you do something like this?"

Putting her down on the ground, Rudel warily leaned over her. While he was dealing with a crying woman, she was an elite dragoon.

Sakuya had gone off to pin down Enora's wind dragon, so Rudel decided to seize Enora.

Of course, the reverse was impossible, so even if it couldn't be called the best plan, it wasn't a mistake.

Because normally, Enora would have to be immediately restrained on the spot. By Rudel's compassion, Enora hadn't been bound.

"I-I'd jus ad enuff! So I..."

As Enora wept and answered, Rudel extended her a hand, patting her head, he spoke to her as he did to Lena whenever she cried when they were younger.

"I see, so you had enough. But do you understand what it is you've done?"

On Rudel's words, Enora cried as she nodded.

Rudel couldn't understand what she had enough of, but a dragoon had used her dragon for a personal affair. Just like Lilim before her, she wouldn't be able to avoid punishment.

There, Cattleya appeared to confirm Enora's situation.

"Rudel, Enora's dragon has been restrained. When it's being pinned down by your dragon, I doubt it'll be able to run away, and it doesn't seem to have the intent to resist."

"Is that so."

Hearing of Sakuya's situation, Rudel had hopes that this might help build her self-confidence. Now the remaining problem was Enora.

"Lieutenant, for this matter,"

"Don't even think about it. I understand what you want to say, and it's definitely possible to save her. But listen here, when I was almost about to be killed by her, there's no way I'd overlook it. What are you telling me to do about these feelings of mine?"

Cattleya didn't seem to show any hatred towards Enora. More than that, her tone was one informing Rudel of the feelings of the victim.

Even if Rudel alone wanted to save her, Enora wouldn't be saved.

Hanging his head, Rudel experienced his own lack of power... of authority. Just with the title of future archduke, he would probably be able to clean up this time's mess.

But Cattleya was telling him that was no good. He would have to answer to that as well.

"... I'll report the truth. But if possible, I'll plead for her clemency."

"Well I guess that works out? Whether you plead for clemency or not is up to you. You're a victim here too, after all... just this once, okay. And this puts you in my debt."

Telling Rudel it was a loan, Cattleya forcefully stood Enora to her feet. While Rudel made a smile, when Cattleya immediately went into smacking Enora, his smile stiffened up.

"L-Lieutenant Cattleya?"

Seeing Cattleya stand before Enora, rolling across the ground after a few good blows, Rudel wasn't able to do a thing. Since Cattleya said she wouldn't report Enora's sins, he mulled over whether or not it was right to stop her.

"But we still have to give this girl a punishment."

Enora cowered from the terrifying smile on Cattleya's face.

"Don't worry, I won't make it public. But I'll be reporting to your papa."

"Eek!"

After that, until Rudel came in to stop her, Cattleya's fists showed no signs of stopping. While it was more decent than a possible execution, after that incident, Enora was unable to raise her head to Cattleya again.

Chapter 104

When Rudel returned to the dragoon lodging house, the active members were waiting for him.

The brigade members Alejandro led were knights of famed houses. That was Alejandro's faction, but in the dragoon brigade that couldn't help but be a meritocracy, there were many who hailed from low-status backgrounds.

In regard to Rudel going too far in this matter, he had called them to at least make a show of being harsh on him. This more or less included an intent to show their authority.

They wanted to show that Rudel was a dragoon of their own noble faction. On the other side, the knights of low status, and the nobles who didn't join any faction watched on from a distance.

There were those up to the heads of Viscount houses serving as active dragoons, but when it came to the level of Count, the head could never serve such a role.

For those in houses with status greater than Count, those without the need to succeed their houses might become dragons. In contrast, Rudel was a future archduke.

From Alejandro's position, he could either add Rudel to his faction, essentially placing him as its leader, or form a connection. After announcing the strict punishment in store for him, he calculated as far as to save him from it and sell him a favor.

He had wrung out his knowledge that let him survive in noble society in his own way, but it was all in vain.

Seeing a ragged Enora and Falk, Alejandro's face turned red in an instant. A beaten dragon was one thing, but he couldn't forgive the fact his daughter's clothing looked strangely stripped.

The traces of treated wounds only made him lose his head faster.

"What happened!? Cattleya, explain this situation!"

As Alejandro became emotional, Cattleya expressionlessly approached to whisper into his ear.

"Vice-captain, you'd better clear away the others. By the way, if you fail to do so, you are the one who will be placed at the disadvantage."

Glared at by Cattleya, Alejandro ended up faltering from her imposing attitude. While he didn't show it on his face, he took to carrying out Cattleya's orders.

Even if it wasn't here, he had thought to sell a favor, but it was this side of him that prevented him from becoming captain.



Watching Alejandro lead off Cattleya, Rudel and Enora from afar, Oldart issued orders to one of his men.

Guessing the situation to an extent, it was largely as he had predicted, and he chose to take action.

"Oy, go fly to the palace as soon as possible. Tell them our little archduke's come back."

"Yes sir!"

Once the knight he ordered ran off, Oldart headed off towards his own dragon. Enora hadn't returned beforehand to inform them of Rudel's return, what's more, both she and her dragon were in a terrible state.

While Sakuya wasn't injured, there was soot on her scales.

He didn't know the reason why Cattleya's dragon was the first to return, but Oldart had a general idea of what was going on.

(That Enora girly snapped at either Rudel or Cattleya. From how they're not reporting it... does Cattleya plan to play it off?)

When it came to Cattleya herself, while there were some problems with her personality, he saw her as proficient. And seeing how Cattleya didn't report it first thing, he had a vague inkling that something had happened.

He had thought something was off from the moment Sakuya and Falk approached the training grounds, when the dragoons on patrol hurriedly rushed over to him.

Oldart called a few of his subordinates and issued some more orders.

"Oy, once the future archduke finishes talking with the vice-captain, bring him over to me. I'll be taking him right off to the palace, so give the vice-captain my regards. While you're at it, call the former captain and vice-captain as well."

"Yes sir! ... But captain, does the vice-captain know of this matter?"

As a knight returned a question to Oldart's order, Oldart gave an ill-spirited grin.

"Like hell he does. I'll be in the palace a while, so push all the small stuff onto the vice-captain. I'm sure our predecessors will be able to do something about him."

Alejandro had a sense of hostility towards Oldart, refusing to obediently listen to his orders. But if the previous captain and vice-captain were involved, that was a different story.

Successfully pushing his work onto Alejandro, Oldart was in a good mood.

With light steps, he headed for his dragon, his men seeing him off with sighs on their breath.



In a meeting room on the training grounds, Rudel watched Alejandro take his anger out on Enora.

Taking the chairs and desk with her as she flew through the air, Enora slumped powerlessly onto the ground. While Rudel tried to stop him, Cattleya held him back.

She was calmly looking at Alejandro and Enora.

"Y-you stupid daughter! While being a proud dragoon, just what disgrace have you..."

Through her ruffled hair, Enora looked at her father's rage. But not left with the power to respond, or perhaps lacking the intent, she didn't open her mouth.

"Not only did you use a dragon in a personal affair, you attacked a superior? Are you of sound mind!?"

Gripping his fallen daughter by the lapels, Alejandro lifted her up. Unable to watch anymore, Rudel stepped in to put a stop to it.

"Vice-captain, any more is..."

But as he stepped in, Alejandro screamed at him.

"This is a problem between father and daughter! You keep your mouth shut!"

On those words, Rudel ended up taking a step back. Before the relationship of father and child he couldn't possibly comprehend, he mulled over what sort of words he was supposed to call out.

Having barely ever talked with his parents, Rudel could only grip his fist and hand his head.

There, scratching her head, Cattleya entered the conversation.

"Vice-captain, this is no longer a problem of father and daughter alone. Both me and Rudel are victims, and your daughter is the perpetrator. And while my house is a Viscount house, Rudel's is an archduke house... the Campbell House is also a Viscount House, right?"

While Rudel didn't mind it, status was something a noble couldn't ignore. Even if they were dragoons, they were still but single knights, and of all things, Rudel was the victim in the matter.

"... My daughter will commit suicide."

On Alejandro's mournful mutter, Rudel opened his eyes wide. But perhaps she just about understood it, as Cattleya didn't show any surprise.

"W-why is that!?"

It wasn't Enora but Rudel who drew close to Alejandro. There was some rage mixed into his voice, a rare sight of the usual courteous Rudel.

"I'm thankful that you won't make this matter public. But that doesn't resolve it."

Rudel couldn't forgive Alejandro's explanation. It wasn't a problem he had the right to stick his mouth into, but he recalled the reason she had given for attacking Cattleya he had heard on the way back.

'I wanted to be recognized.'

Enora's twisted emotions had ended in a regretful, yet due outcome, but even so he couldn't forgive it.

"You mean for a parent to tell their child to die!?"

"That's what it's going to come to regardless! If that's how it's going to be, then if I, her father is the one to do it, we'll at least have an excuse to give to our ancestors."

Before Cattleya could stop him, Rudel leapt out.

His right fist sunk into Alejandro's left cheek, and in the next instant, Alejandro was flying through the air. This time, Cattleya opened her eyes in surprise.

"W-what are you doing!?"

Perhaps never considering he would hit him, Cattleya pinned Rudel down. Enora was also surprised by his actions.

"... Not being recognized really is painful. Not having anyone look at you really is miserable. But not being recognized by the one you wanted to look at you most is most painful of all!"

Sent flying, perhaps Alejandro never thought he would actually be hit, as he had been completely defenseless. As a result, he was knocked out on his impact with the wall.

"Seriously, what's with you! What reason did you have to hit the vice-captain..."

"With this matter, I've put the vice-captain in my debt. Now that I've hit a superior officer, that makes us even, right?"

"Like hell it does, fool! This isn't a child's brawl!"

By hitting the vice-captain, in the end, the problem was left hazy. Cattleya apprehended Rudel and tossed him into a disciplinary cell.

After that, Oldart, who had grown tired of waiting, went to retrieve him.



"Gyahahaha, so that's why Cattleya shoved you in a cell. But that must have been a nice blow. Feeling refreshed?"

I wanted to smack my superiors too, but don't hit me, as Oldart said such things, Rudel was a little surprised. He thought he would be on the receiving end of something harsher.

From Cattleya's attitude, he couldn't believe Oldart's correspondence.

'Muh, Rudel didn't do anything bad!'

Sakuya stuck up for Rudel as she flew, but Oldart was unable to hear her voice.

Temporarily released from his disciplinary cell, Rudel headed to the palace with Oldart.

"I deeply apologize."

After thinking long and hard over it, Rudel felt he had done something wrong. Lowering his shoulders, he apologized to Captain Oldart. But he had yet to apologize for his stay at the dragons' dwellings.

Oldart thought it was an apology including the dragon dwellings' matter. But Rudel had assisted his partner dragon in her time of crisis, and he had no intention to repent over it.

"Well as long as you're repenting, then isn't that fine? Nothing good will come of punishing you, and on the contrary, ain't it a good thing you put Alejandro in your debt? You probably shouldn't have hit him, but compared to what Lady Enora's been through, it's nothing."

As Oldart said it boldly, Rudel was filled with a sense of relief. But from Cattleya's attitude, he still wondered if something was wrong with it.

"Is that really the problem?"

Understanding he wasn't in the position to say anything about it, Rudel was worried whether he had disrupted law and order.

"It's fine. Those who've been recognized by the dragons, apart from me, they've all got a screw blown out of their heads. Just think about it... there's no way a dragon would ever follow any decent human being. Besides me."

Oldart spoke as if he had completely forgotten he was at the head of that group of lost screws. Meanwhile, Rudel was sending him a look of

admiration.

It's not as if that Alejandro hates Lady Enora. He did love her in his own way... well, as punishment, I guess she'll be in the disciplinary cells for a week just like you?"

"I know it's strange for me to say it, but will we really be let off with that?"

"As. I. Was. Saying. You're a special case. I can't treat you the same as the others. Peut personally, I do feel apologetic."

As Oldart's face turned serious, Rudel corrected his posture. He had already heard that Oldart had skillfully dealt with his and Enora's cases.

Mixing in jokes, he laughed at how he was only decreasing his fighting force and increasing his own work. But even Rudel understood that Oldart was being tactful.

In that incident with the evaluations, and this time's dragon runaway case, Oldart even wanted to apologize himself.

The envy and jealousy towards a future archduke had led to a harsher evaluation for Rudel. On top of that, Rudel himself was the white knight... but Oldart said he had no mind to put a stop to the current situation.

"This time's evaluation was one thing, but to be honest, these sorts of things fall under the realm of everyday occurrence. If I spoke up to stop them, they'd only trouble you on a different front."

"I'm sure."

Recalling all that had happened, Rudel was unable to say it would be different. Even if he was seen as a future king, that alone would create opposing factions.

Among the commoners, there were many who resented the Arses House.

He wasn't just an individual, Rudel shouldered the signboard of the Arses House. Oldart was telling Rudel to show enough competence to blow those

signs away.

"For better or worse, you aren't normal. And it'll be the same from here on... Lady Enora is one thing, but we have this thing called status. If this incident was perpetrated by a normal knight, I'm sure heads would fly. Rudel, you shouldn't forget that. What you're seeking is something outstandingly large."

"... I just wanted to become a dragoon, that's all I wanted. Well, when I tried, those around me didn't even try to recognize it. And now that I've become one, I've got around to thinking over things lately. Looking back on it now, it was a tad idiotic."

Come so far, Rudel recalled his youth. Everyone laughed that it was impossible. Everyone told him it would be impossible for him. And it was almost as if even the world wouldn't try to recognize him.

Within all that, the faces of those who recognized him floated up in his head.

Rudel tenderly stroked Sakuya's back. Recalling his promise with Sakuya, he looked ahead with eyes full of resolve.

"A young man's earnest dreams are a nice thing indeed. But you see, right now, you're a single dragoon. You'd best remember that... now then, that's enough for the lecture. You'd better think up some magic words to explain yourself away to the king and his men."

"It's alright! This is my second time!"

Recalling his student days, Rudel honestly answered Oldart. But perhaps the answer he wanted wasn't coming back, as Oldart was a little confused.

"T-that so..."

Oldart looked at Rudel and thought a bit.



It was a facility used by the dragoons, and Enora had been placed in a disciplinary cell.

In a corner of that narrow room, Enora sat scrunched up, burying her face into the space between her knees. The clothes she wore had been switched out from a knight's garb to the crude clothing of a prisoner.

A few hours after she'd been placed in the cell, she heard the approach of a single set of footsteps. Enora knew those footsteps, they were steps that made her scrunch herself even smaller.

As she shrunk her body as far as it would go, those footsteps stopped before her self.

"How wretched it is."

"..."

Enora couldn't answer, but her body was shaking.

"It seems Oldart managed to play off the problem. Your sins will be forgiven with this cell alone I'm sorry."

After saying only that, Alejandro walked away from the cell. As if drawn in by those unexpected words, Enora made for the entrance of her cell, calling out to her father's back.

"Father, I-I'm..."

Turning back to his adult daughter, Alejandro simply nodded. He had noticed that his wretched was a word he had directed at himself.

"I'm a small man. The former captain and vice-captain had some choice words for me... good grief, they really have this job down. I should apologize to you as well. You're a daughter too good for me."

He gave a bitter smile, and after saying that, he made his way off. It seemed he was making quite an awkward face, but he wouldn't let her see his face in full.

Enora, upon hearing those words, she clung to the iron bars and let her tears flow.

"Sorry, I'm sorry... father..."



The captain and vice-captain left a record of that day.

In the years to come, they were used as documents to prove Rudel's unprecedented behavior, but that is surely a tale for another day.

'When I told him to make an excuse to the king as a joke, he said he was fine because it was his second time.' 'When I flew into a rage and hit my daughter, Rudel smacked me. My left cheek's swollen. It hurts. I can't go out in public.'

Having become a dragoon, and successfully entered their ranks, Rudel's legend went as follows.

'He destroyed the training ground facilities in his first years. After that, his dragon ran away, and he himself spent a few months in the dragons' dwellings. He smacked his superior officer, and after that, in the palace... at the unveiling...'

With half of his first year still to come, he had built up so many legends.

These documents would come under terrible scrutiny in later years. It was determined they were much too far from reality.

His second time explaining himself away to the king, and smacking a superior officer. It wasn't by much, but they weren't the most believable of events.

Normally, he should have been subjected to severe punishment, causing these events to be suspect to fabrication.

But as other documents detailed Rudel's further outrageous actions, the line between truth and fiction quickly lost its clarity.

Chapter 105

In the palace, King Albach who faced Rudel felt the situation was taking just a bit of a strange turn.

Once he learned that Rudel had returned, his authorities said they would have Alejandro take responsibility for this incident. Up to there, it was fine.

Oldart took on an evasive attitude to dodge the problem, and it simply ended with both sides exploring a compromise. But the problem started with Rudel's statement.

A strange flow had come about from the Queen, Ciel Courtois' cynicism.

"How pitiful, for the heir to an archduke house to let their dragon run away. And am I to understand that our pitiful future-archduke spent these past few months playing around?"

Once they learned that Rudel spent the past few months in the dragons' dwellings, those around held indignation. Opinions started flying around that he should have returned alone, that he wasn't worthy to be a dragoon.

At the authorities' words, Oldart directed a serious expression, but he arbitrarily turned their points aside. Within all that, a single statement from Rudel caused everyone's attitude to take a sudden change.

"No, by no means was I playing around! I was receiving instruction under Marty-sama's dragon Mystith in order to become the best dragoon I can be."

"Who's Marty-sama? I don't know this Mystith either."

While he proudly brought up Marty's name, Oldart was oblivious. But in exchange, the queen dropped the fan in her hands.

And the authorities... especially the old ones were shaking.

King Albach remained expressionless, but after clearing his throat once, he sought confirmation.

"Ahem, Rudel. Is it that... could you be talking about Wolfgang?"

"Yes. I am undoubtedly referring to Marty Wolfgang-sama! I've been in the care of his beloved dragon Mystith, and..."

The king was acting blatantly strange at Rudel's words. The queen who had spat cynicism to that point seemed somewhat restless.

Even the authorities seemed to lose their momentum.

This was different from the flow Oldart was anticipating, the air in that space was clearly centered around Rudel.

"Where did you get to know about Wolfgang? I doubt there would be many a chance to learn of him..."

"I found him through 'How to Pet a Dragon'! That was a wonderful book, so wonderful I'm perplexed as to why it hasn't spread more. While I'm still immature, Mystith-sama has initiated me into the secret arts!"

"... I see. That's good."

"That has a lovely ring to it."

The queen's tone didn't sound as if she was congratulating him. More than that, she seemed fearful.

While Albach was lowering his shoulders for some reason, he decided to hold a conference on Rudel's punishment. For the sake of negotiation, Oldart had proposed three days in the disciplinary cells, and a few months of odd jobs after that.

He was told that was too light, and things were proceeding in a direction of taking in opinions from the authorities as well. But now, the authorities

accepted Oldart's proposal as is.

"Then we're all fine with three days in disciplinary, and a few months of odd jobs after that, right?"

The king sought confirmation, the authorities simply nodded along. Among the authorities, a few young ones seemed unsatisfied, but the glares of the old men were doing their charm, forcing them to bob their heads.

"Right, now don't do it again, Rudel-dono."

The queen who had called him future-archduke sarcastically had changed a bit. Come so far, she was even adding a dono to his name.

"I shall exercise the utmost caution."

Together with Oldart, Rudel kneeled. Looking at the result, Rudel accepted a light punishment, but wouldn't have any further restrictions placed on him.



There was a reason the king and authorities would take on such inexplicable measures.

'How to Pet a Dragon', while its direction itself may have been mistaken, it was a book that held wonderful contents. But from its publication to the moment Marty left the world, it never received a proper evaluation.

The moment Marty was gone, the crown hurried to retrieve every last copy of the book.

Before the contents even came into question, they wanted to prevent the appearance of another dragoon like Marty. That had been tormented by Marty so thoroughly that they incinerated the collected books before they could check the contents.

The fact that one crossed into Rudel's hands was, surprisingly enough, so unlikely it could even be called a miracle.

Without placing emphasis on the book's title or contents, How to Pet a Dragon had been collected and burned out of fear of the author. The reason neither Cattleya nor Lilim knew of Marty was because his achievements were hidden up and recorded as the merits of many other dragoons.

If one did some digging, then quite a few things could come up, but those were things Rudel was only able to find out precisely because he was the heir to an archduke title.

To the country of Courtois, Marty and Mystith were nothing more than a symbol of fear. Both stories were frantically covered up.

In Courtois, where its national defense was maintained by the dragons, Marty was the man who led their dragon force to return to their dens.

Mystith was a dragon with enough power to rule over the others. To add on to that, the palace at the time was even destroyed by Mystith.

The era's royal family was somehow able to quell the situation by getting on their knees, but to make sure that fear was never forgotten, the knowledge was passed down to their successors and leaders of history.

It was here that the fact the white knight was a worshipper of Marty stuck into them.

Even now, they hadn't the opportunity to learn that the second princess looked up to the dragoon long lost.

All that could be said was that a fear of over a hundred years passed had been revived.



Having returned to his disciplinary cell, the formalities and questionings were enough to make three days go by.

Placed in the cell next to Enora, he did nothing but concentrate his spirit, sitting cross-legged with his eyes closed in meditation. But Enora next door

leaned on the wall and called over to Rudel.

"You got off quite lightly. The new has even reached here. That you threatened the king."

"... I didn't threaten anyone. I just told the truth."

From Rudel's point of view, he hadn't made any threats, but the royal family and authorities were in fear. There was no doubt they felt threatened.

"I see... I really am sorry."

From her prior joking tone, she changed to something a bit solemn. Sensing Enora's feelings, Rudel answered them.

"It's gone and done with. I don't mind it. Though I do feel sorry for punching the vice-captain."

"Don't worry about that one. It was quite refreshing, after all."

Hearing Enora laugh, Rudel felt just a little relieved. Because it wasn't the possessed expression or voice she had always carried, it was a voice as if an evil spirit had released its hold.

"Though I made Lieutenant Cattleya angry. Said I should show some discretion... Once the vice-captain calmed down, he said he'd try pleading for your clemency, it seems. Said that way would be more effective."

"Ah, that sounds like him. I'm sure my father wanted to make a debt as well."

The two of them laughed across the wall. It was there that Rudel recalled what Oldart had said. He didn't understand it, so he wanted to use the opportunity to ask Enora about it.

"Right. When it comes to the lieutenant, the captain said something... Enora, do you know what he meant by, 'Boomerang Cattleya'? The Captain laughed as he said it, but I'm unable to understand."

"... Boomerang, you mean..."

(TL: In Japan, this is a phrase that pretty much means you end up attacking yourself much more than you attack the enemy.)

Once Enora explained it, Rudel finally got it. Sure enough, there were times where one got the urge to tell someone to say that to a mirror.

As Oldart never put a gag order on it, Rudel ended up reporting the matter to Cattleya after he got out of the cell. Because of that, Cattleya's moniker in the dragoon brigade was changed to Boomerang Cattleya for a while.

After that, Oldart was chased around by Cattleya. The words he uttered...

'Gyaaaah! The boomerang came back again!'

It's said he was surprisingly enjoying it.



When Rudel left the disciplinary cell, the preparations were finally together.

While Rudel was gone, an anxious Sakuya made use of the dragon stables reserved for those of Major or above. Even if you said she was using it, she simply dug out a new sleeping space.

Her preparations were ready, she was finally going to challenge the other dragons.

She had made her certain-kill one two finish her own, and fighting on disadvantageous conditions, she had attained victory over a wind dragon. She had some confidence now.

'G-get out here! Sakuya is annngry!!'

"That's the spirit, Sakuya, let's show them all your power today!"

Rudel standing to her side encouraged her.

From the eyes of those around, it was a lonely sight, as if he was talking to himself next to a roaring dragon.

The dragons of the stable showed no signs of coming out.

Rudel had already confirmed that the dragons not on duty were in the stable. He had chosen a day he knew Cattleya's red dragon would be there.

'T-today Sakuya is going to defeat the boss and become the new boss!'

"Keep at it, Sakuya!"

But the dragons wouldn't come out. A while passed, and perhaps Sakuya's fruitless howls were beginning to feel lonely as she burst into tears.

'Please come out...'

"S-Sakuya..."

Even with Rudel next to her, patting her leg to cheer her up, Sakuya was losing her spirit.

"Good grief, just what are they doing?"

The one who approached with a fed-up face was Cattleya. If Sakuya roared, whether they liked it or not, people would gather. It would be bad if she ran away again.

"Lieutenant, the truth is, Sakuya is trying to challenge the boss of the dragon stables, but your dragon isn't coming out. Could you give it a call?"

Seeing a restless Rudel before a weeping Sakuya, Cattleya felt even more fed-up.

"Why do I have to call Bram out? It looks like your dragon's gunning to kill him, so no."

"I'm begging you!"

"F-fine."

As Rudel gripped Cattleya's right hand in both hands, desperately pleading to her, Cattleya averted her face away from Rudel.

She changed her opinion just a little bit and assented. Sensing that exchange from within the dragon stables, Bram cried out at his own contractor.

But to Rudel, it only sounded like the roars of a dragon's heart.

"Shut it! Get out here already, and you call yourself a man!?"



The dragon stable was populated by gray dragons, with a few wild dragons on the side.

In it were both Cattleya's red dragon Bram, and Enora's dragon Falk. While there were others, they had run off saying they weren't relevant.

Bram was the boss of the dragon stables, while Falk couldn't move from the wounds he suffered at Sakuya's hands.

'Goddammit, that woman... she sold me out to Rudel.'

Letting his tail alone protrude from the straw, Bram was truly scornful. Falk had already suffered a blow, and a single strike had put him into a considerably terrible condition.

Even if wind dragons weren't specialized to defense, this was abnormal. Sakuya's offensive power was way too high.

'In the first place, I have nothing to do with this!!'

'Why don't you give up already?'

'Shut it, whelp! You can only say that because you don't know her true terror... the true terror of the one behind her, fool!!'

While Bram was counted as a young dragon, Falk was an even younger male. In his confusion, Bram stuck his head out of the straw and looked at the gray dragons around.

'This is you guys' fault, dammit!'

'No, but, you see?'

'You normally wouldn't think that giant was a child.'

'And wait, what's with that destructive power?'

A majority of the gray dragons had burns on their surface on top of being beaten up. Even like that, they would recover in a few days, so they were dragons as well.

'You domesticated cattleee!!'

The dragon stables generally only took red and wind dragons. Water and gaia dragons lived in special environments.

The water dragons loved the water, and the gaia dragons found solace in the earth... the two species were given a different stable.

There was a movement outside. Apart from the Cattleya, who had sold him out to Rudel through her maidenly affection, he heard another voice he didn't want to hear.

'Ah, Mystith-sama.'

'Mystith~, no one's coming out.'

'You let Sakuya cry again. Good grief...'

'Why is a wild dragon here?'

'Shit, she really did come.'

Bram felt as if his red face was turning blue, but the other gray dragons were clearly going pale as well. The young gray dragons who didn't know Mystith didn't show any particular change.

More than that, those young ones still had leisure. The one Sakuya was challenging was Bram, and they were sure they were irrelevant.

'Oy, oy, what's with this. It's just one more lizard, right?'

'She's quite an old hag to boot.'

'Bram really is pitiful.'

'You, the one who dropped my honorific, I remember your face. No, I have to do something about... GYAAAAAH!!'

'Ah, boss is heeeeeeere!'

'Please forgive us, boss!'

As Bram raised a scream and burrowed into the straw, a single large dragon appeared at the stable entrance.

The other gray dragons that knew Mystith raised screams as they pleaded for forgiveness.

If they were able to tell the outside situation from within, she was able to tell the inside situation from out there.

With her body a size larger than the other dragons, Mystith entered the dragon stables that began to feel narrow, before opening her mouth to speak. There was light streaming in from the entrance, and her open mouth almost seemed to be smiling.

But her eyes weren't smiling at all.

'Gentledragons of the stables, come~ out~ and~ play~.'

Her words were stretched as if she was mocking them, but that only made Bram all the more fearful.

Chapter 106

'I'm telling you to get out there already! You damn brutes!'

'This has nothing to do with me!'

'Cut the crap! The moment you overlooked it, it was your responsibility, fool! If you're the boss of the dragon stables, then take some damn responsibility!'

'Now ain't that overbearing!'

On standby outside, Rudel and the others could hear the sounds from the dragon stable. To those that could hear their voices, they picked up on Bram's bitter cries.

Even to those who could not, they heard Mystith's roars of rage and Bram's sorrowful whimpers.

The other gray dragons were also letting off cries reminiscent of creams, but none of them tried to go outside.

'Waaah, so Sakuya's a no good dragon after all.'

"That's not true! You're a splendid partner."

While Rudel comforted a depressed Sakuya, in the next instant...

'Quit your complaining and get out there, dammit!!'

Perhaps Mystith had reached the end of her patience as a large amount of water flooded out of the dragon stables. Just like that, the building was blown away as if it had been detonated.

The surrounding area was beset by a wave of water that flowed from the stables.

Rudel was also soaked up to his ankles. But there, it seemed that the building wasn't the only thing blown away, the gray dragons were also blown off, now sprawled out over the ground.

For Bram alone, Mystith had grabbed him by the tail and dragged him out.

'Good grief, causing me so much trouble... Sakuya, I brought him, so get ready for a duel.'

"Y-yeah!"

Seeing Sakuya's delight, Rudel pat his chest in relief. But Cattleya standing to her side had a stiff expression on her face.

"R-Rudel."

"Yes?"

With a cramped smile, Cattleya grabbed Rudel's shoulders, turning him-body and all- towards the place the dragon stables once stood.

In that space, nothing more than a few pillars remained. The water Mystith produced had washed away the walls, the tools and the roof, along with everything else, it seems.

Seeing that scenery, Rudel was impressed. In that situation, Mystith managed to instantly manifest a single strike of water with such destructive power, and he sent her his honest admiration.

"What do you think when you look at that?"

"Mystith-sama is amazing! Ow! ... Lieutenant, if you're going to hit me, please tell me your reasons."

Seeing Rudel's face that showed he really didn't understand, Cattleya's eyes grew teary as she lowered her second fist onto Rudel's head.



While Bram was already in tatters, he was forcefully dragged by Mystith out before Sakuya.

Bram knew Sakuya's situation. It's precisely because he knew, that he understood just how dangerous this match would be.

His opponent Sakuya was a goddragon of all things, and she had undergone Mystith's tutelage. Speaking to her quality as a dragon, she was the sort of existence who would surpass him a mere few years after her birth.

He was truly pissed off at the gray dragons who looked down on and teased Sakuya.

'I definitely don't think I'm at fault. You get where I'm coming from, right?'

As if clinging on to his last hope, Bram brought Sakuya to the negotiations table. But his opponent was one who had been brought up by Mystith.

There was no way talks would go through.

'Yeah! But if I don't beat you, they'll make fun of Sakuya, so I'm sorry!'

'No one's going to make fun of you again! These yellow bastards don't have the guts to pick a fight with the gal who blew away the training grounds!'

Right, when Sakuya blew away the training grounds, the gray dragons had realized. That if they picked a fight with her, they would die...

Even the red dragon Bram feared her. If a gray dragon tried fighting her normally, there was no way to win by normal means.

Suddenly turning timid, the thought crossed Sakuya's mind that if she wouldn't be made fun of, she wouldn't have to fight. She sent a glance towards Rudel and Mystith.

There, Rudel was having both his shoulders grasped by Cattleya, having his body violently shaken left and right as he received a lecture. But his face

was turned towards Sakuya, and he clenched his right fist to encourage her.

It was clearly a pose telling her to fight. Bram wasn't expecting much, but when he looked at Mystith...

'Sakuya Go!'

Punching the air, she fired Sakuya up. He didn't expect the slightest from his own contractor, but still, he sent her a pleading glance.

"Why are you so off-point!? How can you look at that scene and say with a straight face the dragon is amazing!?"

She was too busy with Rudel, not even paying the slightest mind to Bram.

'So my contractor is the worst of all.'

The red dragon's shoulders dropped, but he considered seriously fighting the white one before his eyes. Despairing that there was no one to save him, Bram hardened his resolve.

'Sakuya won't lose!'

'Dammit to hell!!'

Turning desperate, Bram turned towards Sakuya. He had been challenged to a fist fight, and as long as Mystith was there, if he unleashed a breath attack, he would be killed.

And if he had Sakuya lift the breath ban, he would probably be killed.

If he tried to bring it to an aerial battle or ran from the spot, Mystith would chase him down. Be killed by Mystith, or smacked by Sakuya... those two choices stuck deep into the dragon Bram.

As a result, deciding that closing in held the highest chance of his own survival, the red dragon charged straight at the gaia dragon subspecies.



Before the certain-kill combo, Bram was sent flying by the first strike. It was only by the miss of the second blow that Sakuya and those around noticed the first had blown him away.

Blown away by a blow from her left hand, Bram was left with his upper half stuck into one of the dragoon facilities. But appearing after he heard the explosive sound of the facility's destruction, Alejandro was frozen with his mouth wide open.

"W-Who did it!!"

Come so far, the training ground along was a huge problem. On top of that, it wasn't just the dragon stables, the building next to it was half-destroyed.

But what surprised Alejandro most was the gray dragons who were in the stables.

They were all lined up before a single water dragon. That much was fine.

But therein lay the problem. The water dragon went down that line of gray dragons, smacking each of them hard in turn. The gray dragons were so fearful they didn't even think to escape.

They were hit one after the next, collapsing on the spot. The country's valuable war potential was being rapidly chipped away.

It was a scene Alejandro couldn't comprehend. No, a scene he didn't want to comprehend.

"O-Oldart!!Crying out the captain's name, Alejandro ran off from the spot."



Charged with the responsibility of the dragon stable and neighboring building's destruction, Rudel was put to cleaning up the building's remnants.

To Rudel's side, Sakuya was helping out as well.

Generally speaking, Dragons boasted powers greater than human. Used no differently than heavy machinery, Sakuya was practically a flying bulldozer.

The work was proceeding quicker than expected.

'When Sakuya won, why does she have to clean up?'

After she had finally achieved victory, Sakuya was dissatisfied she had to tidy up as punishment. But there was no helping that one.

The other dragons were bedridden. They weren't in a state where they could be put to work.

"You destroyed it, so there's no helping it. But you were really cool today, Sakuya."

'Sakuya is an amazing dragon!'

As Rudel praised her, the word speed went up. Happy from the praise, Sakuya swung her tail around, hitting the half-destroyed building, and increasing the amount of rubble.

If he was ever given such a mission, it would probably best to let her calm down a bit before going to work. Rudel thought over the future as he soothed Sakuya, who had grown depressed again.

(We went too far. But, well...)

Looking at Sakuya's mood go up and down, Rudel's face slackened.

He did feel some responsibility for destroying the stables and adjacent building, but if he showed it on his face, Sakuya would feel down again.

While she was a goddragon, Sakuya had one large flaw.

A soul much too young.

Despite being a newborn, Sakuya was born with abilities that ranked her highly, even among the dragon, a terribly dangerous notion.

(I guess I have to support her up.)

The reason Mystith showed excessive care towards her wasn't only because she had made a contract with Sakuya before she was reborn a dragon.

She understood that Sakuya's future would be important to the dragon race.

She placed restraints on the gray dragons because they were a bad influence on the girl. In that sense, Bram was the same.

This was a tragedy brought forth from the fact that Bram didn't truly understand Sakuya's value.

Mystith didn't want to suddenly make Sakuya boss of the dragon stables either. But in the dragoon brigade that currently only had young dragons, she determined that Sakuya's upbringing would be impossible.

Mystith's teaching of Rudel wasn't completely due to his adoration of Marty.

For Sakuya who would one day stand at the pinnacle of dragons, she wanted him to be a worthy partner.

Rudel understood it as well.

But he also understood that even if he scolded the current Sakuya for destroying the building, it wouldn't have an effect.

Little by little, over the course of time, he would have to teach her.

'... I broke it again. Rudel, I'm sorry.'

'It's fine. No problem... be careful next time (now then, what am I supposed to say to the palace).'

For better or worse, the dragoons often ran into these sorts of problems. They were the link that bound the country to the dragons.

They served to mediate between the palace and the dragon race. And that meant there was trouble to be had between the palace, and the dragons who boasted a different sense of values from humans.

Destroy buildings in the enemy camp, don't destroy the country's buildings.

With an order as simple as that, a dragon wouldn't understand what was being said. While they had intelligence, it was the dragons who lived in a world separated from human common sense.

If they obediently listened to human orders, then the dragoons wouldn't be necessary in the first place.

(If I want to make sure the top brass don't direct their dissatisfactions at Sakuya... then that's probably the best way to go.)

Continuing on his rubble removal work, Rudel decided to direct the higher up complaints towards himself.



"... I never thought we'd be meeting again so soon."

"It has been a while, your majesty."

The one Rudel kneeled to was Albach. Albach hadn't even considered he would be calling Rudel back in less than a week.

You could also say he didn't want to think about it.

Unable to use the audience chamber, he called Rudel to an informal meeting in the room the authorities would usually use for meetings.

Destroying one dragoon facility after the next, he had raised a true crisis where their valuable dragons would be unusable for a number of days.

If saying it to the dragons Mystith and Sakuya wouldn't get anywhere, then there was no choice but to summon the contractor Rudel.

One of the authorities made a bitter face, placing his documents on the table to question Rudel. But his face was tinted with just a bit of fear.

"Just how much collateral damage to you intend to create in half a year?"

"... My apologies."

"An apology isn't going to cut it! The dragon stables your dragon destroyed, the adjoined facilities, and even the training grounds. They were all amenities with some good money invested into them!"

As one of Courtois' elite forces, the dragoons did have a considerable budget sent around to them. But no matter how they cut it, the facilities Rudel destroyed weren't the sort of thing the dragoon brigade's annual budget would be able to cover.

On top of that, the dragoons were a knight brigade Courtois couldn't do without.

The kingdom had no choice but to supply the funds.

"If I may. Let's give up on the dragon stables. They're dragons, after all, so it shouldn't be much of a problem if you have them camp out."

At Rudel's proposal, the authorities held their heads. They wanted to raise their voices and cry out, 'That isn't the point!'...

In fear of Sakuya and Mystith, despite everything, they were still holding themselves back. Originally, they wanted to tack on a reason and have Rudel restrained in the palace as soon as possible.

But the problem was Sakuya, who had been trained by Mystith. Mystith had past precedent of destroying the palace, and accepting Sakuya, who could be called her disciple into the palace was out of the question to them.

That being the case, if they pulled the Marty-worshipper Rudel away from Sakuya, there was no telling what would happen.

The country's upper brass was unable to meddle.

Albach endured his urge to let out a sigh as he reported to Rudel.

"Rudel, the country's funds are not unlimited. I'm sure you know that. From now on, please hold back on... please refrain from any destructive activities. Of course, when on a mission, you can wield those powers as you see fit."

They were dealing with dragons, so a level of damage was expected. But Albach remembered Sakuyaw as no trifle. When cleaning up the half-destroyed facility, she had made it a full-destroyed one.

"Yes sir!"

Rudel's perfect etiquette only irritated the authorities more.

They wanted something more to scold him on, but he was perfect in that regard. In truth, while he did have a few strange parts to him, if looked at as a knight, Rudel was the ideal.

The crown and authorities lamented that he looked up to the wrong individual.

Once Rudel left the meeting room, Albach folded his hands over the table. And worn out, he lowered his head.

His form, based on how one perceived it, could look as if he were praying.

"Wolfgang... even in death, you torment Courtois all the more..."

While the higher-ups of Courtois despised Marty, surprisingly enough, his military achievements were on a legendary level. But not only did his unprecedented behavior balance out his achievements, it actually brought him into the negatives.

Alongside Mystith, he had defended the country from Gaia Empire invasion time and again. From the fear of that time, Marty's name was famous throughout the empire.

Within the Empire, Marty was called the 'Demon of Courtois' and held as a symbol of fear. Nothing but trouble to his surroundings, and rightly feared by his enemies.

That was the man called Marty Wolfgang.



After Rudel returned from the palace, an evaluation exam was held.

The time to show the results of the past few months had come around, but the surrounding atmosphere was completely different from last time. All the dragoons had called their partner dragons to their side.

They were ready to run away at a moment's notice.

But...

"You're doing good, Sakuya!"

'My hovering is perfect!'

While Sakuya cried out in glee, she was unsteadily swaying in the air. It was still shoddy, but she displayed ample competence.

Following on from that was shooting, but in that, only sturdy frames were built. The disposable targets were draped over them. On top of being cheap to produce, they were cheap to maintain.

Oldart's desperate thoughts had somehow kept it within budget.

Everyone was sure those would be destroyed as well, pitying Oldart's efforts.

But...

"Great work! Six out of ten. That's just barely a passing grade!"

'I did it! I did it!!'

Delighted, Sakuya roared on the spot, and the surrounding dragons roared along. It wasn't the scornful roars they had used to that point, they were honestly singing praise.

The tattered dragons were praising Sakuya. This was proof that Sakuya was the new boss, their way of showing there was no one who would go against her.

But Bram and Falk's injuries were more severe than expected, and they were still in treatment. This fact became an even greater factor preventing the gray dragons from going against Sakuya.

The dragoons around were making dubious faces.

No, to be more precise, they were happy that Rudel and Sakuya managed to pass without any collateral damage. Some part of them was simply struggling to accept it.

"So they can do it and succeed the proper way."

At the words Luxheidt muttered, everyone in the training grounds loud from the roars of dragons nodded.

They were happy that Sakuya managed to clear the exam without incident, but they had been expecting some more exorbitant actions.

They had been enthusiastically preparing to cope with whatever they threw at them, but they ended up clearing it the normal way.

With this unexpected turnout, they felt just a little lonely.

Chapter 107

In preparation for the display held every year in the capital, the newly recruited knights had gathered.

While the elite dragoons were the centerpiece every year, of course, the other brigades took part as well. It also had a purpose of increasing national prestige, but for the other elites, the high knights, this was likely the last year they could take part.

The dragoons, the royal guard, the high knights, with three special elite forces prepared, it was a fact that Courtois didn't have any further financial leisure.

It was around the time where many knights were arriving at the capital.

The dragoon brigade was practicing its flight formation.



"T-that's dangerous, Rudel!"

Hearing Luxheidt cry out, Rudel immediately issued orders to Sakuya.

"Sakuya, you're drifting!"

'Wowowoah!'

Rise, descend, turn, in everything, Sakuya brought trouble to her surroundings. A single change in the flap of her wings might blow the surroundings dragons and dragoons away.

It was proof she was putting in a needless amount of power, and every time she heard Rudel's warnings, Sakuya would move as if squirming in the air.

Those movements weren't quite the sort of thing the residents of the capital would be pleased with. The residents who watched the flight formations every year had become quite the connoisseurs.

In the event's goal of increasing national prestige, they couldn't disappoint those watchful eyes. But from her fame, it was difficult to remove the splendid form of Sakuya.

Rudel was the white knight, and Sakuya was his giant dragon partner. Her white and beautiful form was enough of a show in itself. To add onto that, throughout the country, white knight Rudel and black knight Aleist had been publicized.

There was no way they could pull him out now.

... But.

"Rudel! Don't come over he... gyaaah!"

This time, Sakuya approached Saas, who was on the opposite side from Luxheidt. As Saas hurriedly withdrew from his station, the other dragons commenced hovering.

"S-sorry."

Rudel apologized to the two of them. Today alone, they had interrupted training over ten times.

'S-sorry.'

Rudel and Sakuya had managed to receive a C-Rank, but they were causing problems in flight formations as well.

The new recruits flying in formation was a simple way to show the royal capital's residents the competence of the dragoons.

But if they failed, on the contrary, it was a show of their low degree of training.

Sakuya was a gaia dragon subspecies, and her flight capabilities were expected to fall short of the other dragons. But to put on a show, it was decided she would fly at the center of the new recruits.

If safety was their first priority, then flying in a straight line without any tricks was their best bet.

It was a problem that made the dragoon brigade collectively hold their heads as a whole.



"You mean to say you're taking us off the formation!?"

In the vice-captain's office, Rudel raised his voice as Alejandro informed him of what had been decided.

If she knew she was taken out of the formation, Sakuya would get depressed again. The fact he knew of how hard she was training only strengthened his desire to do something for her.

"There can be no helping it. And you'll be appearing at the end to descend down onto the plaza. If that's all there is do it, I doubt you'll fail."

"Certainly, I don't think we'll fail, but..."

He understood what Alejandro was trying to say. He did, but it was a fact he couldn't accept it.

"You'll be adorning the center of the plaza at the end, it's quite an important role. Our flight formations are officially meant to be a side show, but they have a considerable history to them. We've been holding them for over sixty years."

The historic dragoons would enchant the crowds with their craft.

Alejandro was also making an enervated expression and it seemed he'd been mulling over the formation quite a lot as of late. Not wanting to cause any more trouble for his superior officer, Rudel accepted it.

"... Understood."

"That's a huge help. You're just going to tie a bow on the performance at the end, but don't fall behind in practice, okay? Think of it as flight training, and you'll never find it wasted."

Rudel left the room, mulling over how he was going to explain it to Sakuya.

When he thought one problem had been cleaned up, the next one came out.

He couldn't quite lie, but telling Sakuya nothing but the facts felt would be too cruel. Rudel mulled over what to say to persuade her as he walked down the hall.

It was there that a voice called out over to him.

'Well now, I've finally gotten the members together. Let's start preparing for our flight formation already.'

He looked out the window just in time to see Mystith's descent.



... A few days later.

In preparation for the unveiling the day after tomorrow, knights had gathered from all over the land.

A large portion of them were new recruits, youths who had only just ventured into the world. From them came out some who wanted to stretch out and relax in one of the capital's high-class pubs.

To the knights from the outskirts, there were barely any chances to come to the capital. It couldn't be helped that some would think of using this chance to play around.

Yet what that gathering stared at loathsomely were the knights who worked in the capital from the start.

Unlike their standard knight garb, that gathering that wore high-class garments over their bodies were members of the unit led by Eunius.

Liking his share of revelry, Eunius didn't hate this atmosphere at all. But it seemed that wasn't the case for those around them.

"Looks like we've got ourselves a rowdy bunch."

"My thoughts exactly, this is why those country bumpkins are nothing but trouble. They should go find a store befitting their stature."

"... That so (That's not what I meant)."

As part of a knight brigade charged with the defense of the capital, Eunius was appointed as a major.

He was the future head of an archduke house, given considerable preferential treatment... or not. The ones stationed under Eunius were young nobles. They were a unit of those who were determined to be of no particular use.

With their status, it was too difficult to order them around, so Eunius had been stationed to put a hold on them.

(Even if I'm returning to my house in a few years, this is harsh.)

Their low level of training went without saying, their usual work ethic was also truly terrible.

Reminiscing over his student days, he downed the ale poured into his glass. Fitting of a shop the knights of the palace and capital had taken a liking to, he had no complaints about the ale or food.

But in this air, it all tasted strangely unsavory. That's all there was to it.

The ones around Eunius were knights who had been stationed for a few years now. His followers from the academy were treated as new recruits and had all the miscellaneous jobs shoved onto them.

Now there were just the folks constantly gathering to curry the favor of the future archduke Eunius.

"They really should learn to carry that thing called elegance." "Precisely. As a fellow knight, I feel ashamed." "To think even demi-human knights would come, they're dropping the status of this shop."

As Eunius endured the surrounding atmosphere, the civil servant Luecke made his appearance. Everyone around Eunius instantly directed hostility.



Finishing his civil official work, Luecke was taken along by his seniors to a certain shop.

Usually, he would return to his estate in the capital, occupying the rest of his day with work or books. But thinking that socialization was also important, he accepted their invitation that day.

(Just goes to show you shouldn't do what you're not used to.)

There were many of the Halbades House's faction among the civil officers, and they treated Luecke with care. But with his work capabilities, Luecke found himself working as part of their main force.

He had worked overtime today, so they had likely shown some tact.

The officials were immensely busy over the display in two days. But it just had to be that day that they encountered the ones they didn't want to meet.

"Hmm, look, the beanstalks have come out."

As one of Eunius' subordinates let out a voice such to resonate through the rowdy shop, the surroundings instantly went quiet. A large number of customers showered Luecke and his compatriots with their gaze.

Generally speaking, civil and military officials didn't get along.

"Yeah, let's change shops."

One of his seniors tried to leave with a troubled look on his face, but from among his comrades rose a voice of dissatisfaction.

"You're going to quietly run away!?"

There, Luecke purposely brought his feet to a chair nearby Eunius. Pressured by the atmosphere of Eunius' group, everyone had been avoiding the seats in the area.

So the only open tables were around Eunius.

"You're not going to order?"

Ignoring the looks from Eunius' men, Luecke cast a silent pressure onto his seniors. Timid as they were, those seniors began to take their seats.

To the current Luecke, knight brigades were nothing more than money devouring insects. Especially Eunius' unit that served no particular purpose, to put it bluntly, he thought it was fine if they got thoroughly crushed.

He understood they were a necessary evil. But his dissatisfaction built up.

When Eunius' unit caused problems, they multiplied the work of the civil officials. They'd tack on some reason for high-class goods, and demanded that their equipment was first rate, despite no other part of them matching up.

The current Luecke and Eunius were undoubtedly political opponents.



With cleaning implements in hand, Aleist walked down the palace corridor with his subordinates.

He had cast off his outercoat, equipping a thick cleaning apron.

After his graduation, Aleist was appointed as a lieutenant in the defenders. But when he resolved himself and asked what his work was, the mission he was handed was 'cleaning duty'.

It wasn't as if he wanted a large job, or that he particularly wanted to work as a knight.

Simply...

"I really think this should be left to the cleaning ladies."

"Captain, I've heard that complaint five times today."

The one who returned a cold response was Millia, stationed to the same unit. She had been invited by Fina as bait to lure Aleist in, so naturally, she was stationed in the same platoon.

But the distance between the two hadn't closed in at all.

"Well, well, the captain does have a point." "That's right, don't be so stiff. You'll never get a boyfriend like that."

Their cleaning had been wrapped up, and after writing a log, they only had to return home. But Aleist's fatigue was great.

The platoon he was stationed to was made of members gathered for Aleist's sake.

(That princess definitely hates me.)

But Aleist felt some malice in his station. After Millia applied for the defenders, he heard a sweet tale from Fina. That if he came to the defenders, he would be a lieutenant, and Millia his deputy officer...

But how did it turn out?

All the members stationed under him were fair female knights. To take it a step further, among them, two of the women were romance target characters.

Even when he was being careful, the events splendidly broke out. Day after day, they approached Aleist in a way even he could understand.

What's more, in front of Millia.

"U-um... do you want to go drinking after this? We'll be busy the day after tomorrow, so today's the last day we'll have time."

"You serious!? I'm going!" "Oh, so Aleist-kun's invited me out."

The two of them instantly approved, but Millia was making a sullen face.

Wanting to invite Millia, Aleist was just about to try persuading her when an acquaintance passed down the hallway.

It was Izumi.



As Izumi walked down the corridor on her way home, she happened on Aleist desperately inviting Millia out.

From her eyes, she could only see it as him trying to flirt with her while taking two other girls along. He really was doing just that.

"Aleist, are you at it again?"

As Izumi made a fed-up expression, Aleist frantically tried to correct the misunderstanding.

"That's wrong! I just wanted to go out drinking with everyone from the platoon... not that I have everyone with me right now."

While Izumi was currently doing paperwork, she was a knight in service to the palace. She was an elite high knight, and with quite a few amiable relations from the academy, she did hear the stories going around.

That the members that made up Aleist's harem had grown by two in number...

"I do get the feeling you're lacking in fidelity."

"I'm telling you, it's a misunderstanding!"

Aleist insisted it was a misunderstanding, but looking at the result along, he couldn't quite say it was. From how Izumi saw it, the two besides Izumi were quite heated over Aleist.

With his superior looks and earnings, as long as you ignored his insides, Aleist was a fine piece of work. She understood why women might want to gather, and Izumi didn't feel like cautioning him on it.

But his invitation of Millia who kept on rejecting looked just a little forceful.

"Ah, then how about it! Do you want to come too, Izumi-san? There's this shop that's quite famous in the capital."

Often encountering one another in the capital, the two were already on a first-name basis.

She looked at Millia to find she was making a tired expression.

Hearing both sides of the story from Aleist and Millia, Izumi held some conflicted emotions. In order to approach Aleist, the elf village that knew of Millia's present situation had moved to forcefully have her engaged.

But it was here that Lilim's matter brought forth an influence.

In the past, the one Lilim was engaged to was the son of the village chief. Lilim was betrayed by that son, so at least Millia should be able to decide by her own choice, her parents were taking on an obstinate stance.

Millia had no mind to marry, let alone go out with Aleist.

But Aleist showed a strong fixation on her. It was quite a luxury when he already had a harem. That's what she thought at first.

But Aleist had his position as the black knight.

While if he was on cleaning duty right now, it wouldn't be strange for him to become a leader of Courtois, or perhaps even king. The fact that the higher-ups would put such an individual on cleaning duty surprised Izumi.

She got the impression in the palace that those up top were troubled over how to deal with him, that they were still arguing.

"Hah, got it. Then I'll tag along. How about you, Millia?"

"... Fine."

With Aleist's desperate expression and Izumi folding in, Millia accepted the invitation.

Chapter 108

The unveiling display two days away, the main street of the capital was lively.

The newbie dragoons walked boldly down that rowdy main street. They didn't particularly intend to put on air, but they were elites, and the dragoons recognized as the heroes of the country.

Showing humility and servility was also a problem.

Within that group, Rudel was in high spirits. Saas, who often spoke to him in the brigade, grew curious and ended up asking.

"You're in quite a good mood, Rudel. Since the vice-captain called you out to remove you from the formation, I thought you'd be down."

Saas was a man with sharp eyes and a bad mouth on him. But among their colleagues, he was the closest to Rudel. Despite the hatred that occasionally escaped his mouth, he was a man who worried for his comrades, in the past half year they spent together, Rudel had noticed it.

"You can tell? The truth is, it looks like the flight formation matter will work itself out. We can't do any acrobatics, but I'm sure you'll be surprised."

Recalling his conversation with Mystith, Rudel smiled. His surrounding colleagues, Saas included, seemed relieved to see a satisfied Rudel.

His dragon had run away once, and they had been worried she would run away again.

Gathering the eyes of the people- especially the men- passing by on the main street, Enora walked beside Rudel. Ever since their dragoon dogfight,

she began to treat him like a good friend. She would often invite him out for lunch on their days off, and the distance between them was definitely closing in.

Such an Enora was a tad bothered by the ruckus of the main road.

"What's wrong, Enora? Do you dislike a festive air?"

As Rudel directed his eyes at Enora, his other colleagues' eyes gathered on her as well. For better or worse, Rudel had become something of a leader to the new recruits.

This was probably related to his partner Sakuya's official rule over the dragon stables.

Rather than the other eyes, receiving a look from Rudel caused Enora to deny it in a bit of a panic.

"I don't particularly hate it, but when it gets to this level, entering a store will be dreadful. They're all fully occupied by the new knight recruits from all over the place."

Enora said, as she directed her eyes to a nearby shop. Sure enough, the public shops facing the main road had been conquered by droves of knight-ish young knights. It wasn't particularly a bad thing. Around this time of year in the royal capital, one could call this scenery a harbinger of the season.

But the dragoons couldn't drink tomorrow. A brigade regulation... or rather, it was an order from Oldart.

"When I can't play around, to hell with the new recruits having fun on their own. I'm banning all alcohol on the day before the expo!"

The new recruits couldn't tell whether he was joking or serious. But it definitely was bad for the dragoons to be hungover during an important display. They accepted that.

"It looks like most of the shops that serve alcohol are full."

Rudel muttered as he looked over the knights happily drinking, when Luxheidt made a proposal. When it came to these matters, Luxheidt was the most reliable of his colleagues.

Enora knew a few famous stores in the capital, but when it came to bars, that was outside her area of expertise.

"I thought this might happen! I took the liberty of hearing this and that from our superiors."

"As expected of our Brahms and Liszt head."

"Eh? That's what I'm head of? I thought I was on the general planning committee."

As Luxheidt returned a joke to Saas' cynicism, everyone smiled. Seeing those newbie dragoons, the surrounding passersby seemed perplexed.

"That aside, they're always crowded around this time. From what I heard, it seems we're best off going to a high-class shop. They have good service to start with, and they're rarely filled up., they say."

The drunk knights of the outskirts often picked fights with the elite dragoons. It felt idiotic to have to waste time every time, so he recommended a store with relatively nice goods.

"If it's too expensive..."

While Saas seemed reluctant, Luxheidt explained away.

"A dragoon can't quite go to a cheap place, right? From time to time, it's important to go to a place befitting your status. And look, our salary is nothing to laugh out."

Right, a dragoon's salary was truly high. Rudel didn't really pay it any mind, but to those from knight-class families, nobles in name alone, like Saas and Luxheidt, it was an unbelievable sum.

"No, I get that."

Rudel looked over Saas' reluctance with a smile. With his large family, Saas was sending most of his money home. In contrast, Luxheidt was in a position where he didn't have to pay mind to those sorts of things.

"Let's listen to Luxheidt here. Lest we spend precious time searching for a shop."

As Rudel directed them towards Luxheidt's opinion, everyone accepted and started off towards a famous high-class pub.



Before the unveiling in two days' time, Cattleya had dropped by her superior Lilim.

Originally, she wanted to submit a report before taking the new recruits off drinking. But Lilim stopped her with a smile that wouldn't take no for an answer.

Cattleya's platoon was a part of Lilim's company, and she couldn't go against her orders. More than that, Lilim still held a grudge over having the responsibility of Rudel's case shoved onto her.

In an office those of Major rank could use, Cattleya was helping out with paperwork. She accepted the fact she had foisted off the responsibility, and felt sorry about it. But her dissatisfaction escaped her mouth.

"Aah, I was planning to go drinking, you know."

Every time Cattleya finished up a form, a complaint would come out of her mouth. Lilim was silently completing more than double the amount of papers. Finally reaching the end of her patience, Lilim warned her.

"Cattleya, could you give it a rest already? You understand that a majority of these documents are a result of the responsibility you had me take, right?"

Lilim opened her eyelids, faintly showing her pitch black eyes.

"Is that so? But in the end, the vice-captain took responsibility, right? Then shouldn't that be the end of it?"

"... Right. In the end, the vice-captain did indeed take responsibility. But the work you pushed onto me didn't go away!"

"Taking responsibility is the responsibility of the one responsible, Major."

To Cattleya's attitude as she closed up that conversation and picked up her next form, Lilim gripped her shaking fist. If she was up to it, Cattleya was capable of work. More than that, she was able to complete paperwork on Lilim's level.

She just didn't, which made it all the worse.

... Once the forms were done with, Lilim poured Cattleya some tea. She felt it would be too awkward to just drive her away like that. The topic of conversation turned to the new recruits.

"So do we have any promising kids?"

"... Four of them, I guess. Well, two go without saying, and the other two give off a real ruffian feel. A rebellious one and a light one, I guess."

As she thought over the two of them, Cattleya recalled Oldarts face. Their captain Oldart, if Cattleya had her say, was a ruffian as well.

"I see, so it looks like four will be able to add to our main force."

Lilim muttered as she drank the tea she put out. Unlike Cattleya, she was a long-lived elf. Of course, that held an advantage of having a long period over which she could work. The core of the dragoon brigade had high hopes for her.

While the two of them carried out a serious conversation, when the topic of Enora came out, Cattleya suddenly started complaining.

"More importantly, that Enora girl! That breast monster, lately she's been on the attack when it comes to Rudel, she keeps trying to make a pink air. It's

irritating. Just the other day, she clung onto him, you know."

"... That really is a problem. Yes, she's disrupting the public morals of the brigade."

"Exactly! Whenever she clings onto Rudel, the vice-captain's mood goes hell."

"Come to think of it, he was a bit angry when he came to the capital a few days ago."

"Ah, that one was different. It seems even he got irritated with Rudel not noticing Enora's feelings."

"Some things never change."

While Lilim's tone was worn, Cattleya didn't overlook it. For just a moment, Lilim had made a delightful expression.



As Rudel and the dragoons entered the shop, luckily enough, there were open seats.

What's more, some familiar faces were conveniently gathered. The ones he had spent his academy life with, Luecke, Eunius, Aleist and Millia. Even Izumi was there.

"What's this, so you all came as well."

While Rudel secured a seat with a smile, the surrounding air was truly heavy. The other tables were happily conversing, but around the area Rudel had taken his seat, there was little talk going on. No, it seems Rudel's arrival began the conversation.

"Been a while."

"Yo."

"Ah, Rudel."

"Pleasure"

Catching sight of Izumi, Rudel was relieved to see her pulling off the stylish high knight uniform. While she gave off a more mature air than she had half a year ago, he was relieved to see she had barely changed.

"Rudel, it's been a while. Have you been well?"

"Yeah, Sakuya's doing well too."

"I see, that's good."

Hearing their conversation, Enora sat beside Rudel. Rudel didn't seem to mind, and he was just about to introduce Enora when Luxheidt whispered into his ear.

"Hey, what's with these members? And what's this heavy air?"

Hearing that, he looked around for the first time. Sure enough, Luecke and Eunius weren't talking. Their followers seemed to have undergone a complete change after moving from the academy to the workforce. In the past, they had all eaten at the same table, and Rudel did feel something was off.

"Luecke, Eunius, what's wrong?"

As Rudel called out to the two of them, the knights around Eunius directed sharp looks. But once they noticed Rudel's party was a party of dragoons, their eyes suddenly swam around the room.

The two of them said it was nothing, and the conversation was cut off once more.

An atmosphere different from that around ruled the area. But the one who could no longer endure it was Aleist

"H-hey, Rudel."

"You look well... or not. Aleist, what's wrong? You look worn."

Aleist's expression felt as if he was forcing himself to smile. Seeing his table, there was quite a biased male-to-female ratio. Luecke and Eunius' table were nothing but men, while Rudel had two women at his.

But only Aleist's place had a single man surrounded by eight women, a clearly florid scene.

"Well, this and that. Ahaha."

Aleist gave a bitter smile, but there were quite a few unfamiliar faces at his table. Rudel called out to Luxheidt sitting to his side. When it came to these sorts of things, his colleagues recognized Luxheidt as the one most knowledgeable on these matters.

"How does that table look to you?"

"Eh~? I'm meeting them for the first time, so I don't know anything. But let's see, it seems strangely tense. That black haired girl was probably just dragged into the mess? Besides her and that elf girl, are the others all the guy's girlfriends? But it feels like the guy's going after the elf. I think that about sums it up."

"I see, so Aleist increased his number of girlfriends again. This is a problem."

"That's right. Though I also think not noticing is a problem as well."

"You think?"

As Rudel failed to grasp Luxheidt's words, he looked over at Aleist's table. Aleist was definitely surrounded by women. It was a familiar scene from the academy. But here as well, his member had undergone a complete change.

Surely they weren't all his girlfriends, and he was supposed to already have five fiancés. Won't anymore be a bit too harsh, or so Rudel worried. It was

Aleist's problem, so thinking it wasn't his place to stick in his mouth, he tried to call over.

It was there that, like Aleist, those unable to endure came out.

From Eunius' table, a few young knights called over to Aleist's table.

"Hey, girls of the defenders, how about you entertain us as well."

"Our Eunius-sama over here is the heir of an archduke house, you know."

"You could at least pour him a drink."

Looking at Eunius' expression, he was truly displeased. It seems these were followers who didn't understand Eunius' feelings.

"You lot..."

Eunius was about to stop his followers. But his voice was interrupted by Luecke.

"Good grief, this is why the Diade faction is so troublesome."

While eyes gathered on Luecke at once, the man in question continued eating as if nothing had happened. In contrast, Luecke's followers were growing panicked.

"Hah, they did it again."

From how Aleist held his head in anguish, this had likely happened a number of times before they had come in. Rudel sent a glance at Izumi and she shook her head.

"It's been like this every time they open their mouths. It's troublesome how they keep angering Millia."

"I'm not angry."

From how she immediately interrupted Izumi, Rudel understood Millia had something to say on the matter. But this time was something different from before.

"Tsk, what an ungrateful bunch."

"They're the sort that take along a demi-human and a foreign girl. It's our fault for getting our hopes up."

"Sure enough. One's tastes speaks volumes to their character."

Such laughs broke out at Eunius' table. Just as Rudel stood, Aleist stood as well. Enora and Luxheidt swiftly grabbed Rudel's arm, but it seems Aleist's table was too late.

Aleist headed off for Eunius' table and glared at the folks who were laughing.

Perhaps the surroundings sensed the dangerous air as the shop itself returned to silence.

Chapter 109

In a pub that gave off a dampened air, tensions suddenly surged as Aleist stood to face Eunius' table.

More than himself being mocked, he couldn't forgive the fact they looked down on Millia as a demi-human. While those around Rudel instantly stopped him, the women from the defenders were unable to do the same for Aleist.

He glared at the knights who flocked around Eunius, and the one who said it stood, a grin on his face.

Aleist was the black knight, the eldest son of the Hardie Count House. Even that title, before an archduke was overshadowed. No matter how important the black knight was to the country, his role in the palace was cleaning duty. It was surely only natural that the knights made light of Aleist. Even if they heard tales of his strength, they had never seen it in humans.

Humans had a tendency to lend an eye only to what was most convenient.

The laughing knight was tall in stature, over a head above Aleist. When Aleist glared at him, he trembled in a joking manner.

"Oh, how scary. Our little black knight is angry."

"You lot better take back those words."

Rudel watched as Aleist ignored his foe's reactions, closing in and telling them to take back their remark. He decided to leave it to Aleist. Seeing through the enemy's strength, he saw that two people weren't necessary. But his eyes drifted to Eunius. While Eunius directed fed-up eyes to his

followers, he didn't give off the same intensity he had at the academy. He held an expression somewhat close to resignation.

"Hah, don't push your luck, newbie. No matter how strong you say you were at the academy, we're official knights here. We're in a different class from your petty games."

"Class? You definitely do seem low-class."

Receiving that provocation, a few more knights stood to take on his offer. Unable to watch any further, Eunius breathed out a sigh as he apologized.

"My bad, Aleist. You lot sit down. We have an important expo the day after tomorrow. I don't want any trouble."

"S-sorry."

Before the knights who took their seats, Aleist was still unsatisfied, Grabbing the lapels of the knight who provoked him, he forcefully lifted him to his feet.

"That's all well and good, now apologize. Eunius' apology and your statement are a separate matter!"

His lapels grasped, the knight's face turned red as he gripped his fist. There, the defender female knights finally stepped in to stop Aleist. Millia seemed unmotivated, while she had stood, she just watched without holding him back.

"... You're being a bother. Sit down."

"Eh? ... Okay."

Seeing Aleist dejectedly step down on Millia's words, those around put their best efforts into containing their laughter. From the surrounding seats, small stifled laughs escaped, and some even had their shoulders shaking.

Though the air surrounding Eunius and Luecke, and those around them was something else.



"Even so, it sure is quiet."

Rudel reached a hand for the food and ale brought to the table as he spoke.

Luxheidt put in an order for some extra ale from the waiter who brought their food as he cheerfully answered Rudel's doubts.

"Of course, when we have three archdukes, plus some followers from their factions, it's going to be tense. The only ones who'd dare make a ruckus in this heavy air are our little Enora in love, and that black knight over there."

While it didn't sound like the sort of thing anyone'd laugh over, Luxheidt was also a dragoon. He had gone through his share of experiences, and obtained a dragon. It was natural for him to be able to stay calm.

Rudel looked at Aleist's table, seeing a situation where Aleist wanted to talk to Millia, but everyone around kept getting in the way.

Looking at Izumi, she simply ate her meal with the knife and fork she was once so terrible at using. When he thought nothing had changed, Rudel notices those around him were beginning to change, little by little. But more than that, Rudel showed some interest in Luxheidt's statement. He had also gained some bonds with his comrades, and perhaps he had changed as well, he thought...

"Love? Enora has someone she likes?"

"Hey! ... It seems the alcohol has reached Aiguille-san's tongue."

While Enora was caught off-guard by Rudel's sudden statement, she instantly smiled and gazed at Luxheidt. It was here that Rudel made a misunderstanding.

"What's this? So the two of you were dating?"

"Wow, even I'm taken aback. I never would have thought you could look at that smile on Enora's face and come out with those words. Rudel, look a

little closer... her eyes aren't smiling, right?"

Hearing that from Luxheidt, Rudel looked back at Enora to find her gazing at him intently with upturned eyes, her face a little red. He thought it was a little early for her to be drunk, but he managed to understand the two of them were not going out.

"Oy, Luxheidt. It doesn't look like Rudel gets it."

Even Rudel had to deny that one.

"How rude. I understand now that those two aren't going out."

Rudel was certain that he understood what Saas was trying to say, and both Saas and Luxheidt sighed. Seeing the two of them, their other comrades laughed.

"Hah, it's scary to see how a woman can change. Anyways, Rudel, how's that black knight over there? Is he as creepy a guy as he looks?"

Luxheidt looked tiredly at Enora. And after turning his eyes towards Aleist, he asked Rudel about his nature.

"You're interested? He's a little strange, but he's a good person. From what I know, he had five fiancés, but... looks like it's on the rise."

"For real? Just what sort of oddball does he have to be for you to call him strange?"

"Saas, I get the feeling you're making fun of me."

When Saas sent a truly surprised look at Aleist, the other dragoons looked at him as well. They were curious just what sort of oddball he had to be for even Rudel to think he was a strange person.

... But if they made a ruckus in that quieted-down store, then naturally, the other party would hear it as well. On top of that, receiving pitiful eyes from all the dragoons, even Aleist would notice.

"Hold it! I don't want to be called strange by you, Rudel! I haven't destroyed any training grounds or facilities!"

To a teary-eyed Aleist, a voice came from an unexpected place.

It was Luecke.

"Oh, now that's quite an intriguing statement, Aleist. From what I can tell, a sum far exceeding the annual budget has been wasted on the defenders."

Resting both his elbows on the table, Luecke folded his hands to cover his mouth as he glared at Aleist. For some reason, his follower civil officials also sent some bitter expressions at the defenders.

"N-no, I mean, I haven't broken anything, you know? And it's not like I have any say in our budget or anything."

"I agree that Rudel is also a problem, but several tens of times the funds required to fix the broken training grounds and buildings are moving around. You really should think a bit about funding. You don't want to be seen as the same as some muscle heads who come under the misconception that money is an inexhaustible resource, right?"

"S-sorry, and wait... I do treasure the tools I use for cleaning, and I'm economizing as much as I can with detergent..."

Aleist's touching efforts, before the outrageous sum moving around fell short of even chickens feed. But it was better than doing nothing, Rudel nodded in honest admiration.

"... no, Rudel? You really should repent."

Saas cautioned a nodding Rudel, but his statement was cut off halfway. Smashing his glass, a knight stood to his feet to glare at the civil officials. It seemed Eunius had no intent to stop them this time as he left it be.

"And who could these muscle heads be? I'm sure you'd be happy to tell us, beansprouts."

The knight who stood had a hand on his weapon. The pub instantly regressed to its original tense state. There were some who had already finished paying to retreat, it was a right bother to the store.

"What's this? Isn't it precisely because you're aware of it that you're so irritated? This must be a show of the caliber of your owner."

Luecke downed the contents of his glass, quietly placing it on the table. When his eyes met Eunius', Eunius violently slammed his glass down, shattering it. Both sides exchanged a glare, and naturally, their surroundings reacted as well. But the officials were looking around, their eyes pleading for help.

"You two, why don't you call it quits? The expo's in two days."

Receiving those pleading eyes, Rudel remonstrated them. But with a bit of drink in them, the two of them didn't seem to have their usual level-headedness.

"Hah? Shut it Rudel. He's the one who picked the fight. Then it would be rude if I didn't take him up on that. To pick a fight you know you're going to lose, you sure are a strange one."

As Eunius stood and gripped his sword, Luecke gave a scornful laugh.

"Fight? It seems you still don't understand. If you still think everything can be settled with violence like in our student days, then you really are unsalvageable idiots. You're better off shoved in the dungeon. No, it's your jobs that should be locked away. This'll be a good laugh."

With Luecke's words as the trigger, Eunius' men picked up their weapons and kicked the table down. As a high knight, Izumi stepped between them to mediate.

"Give it a rest already. I must ask you to refrain from making a ruckus before the unveiling."

Just like in their student days, Eunius and Luecke of them stopped in their tracks on Izumi's arbitration, but they were the only ones who did.

"Shut your mouth, a mere foreign woman thinks she can stand before us!?"

"Wha!"

Eunius' follower thrust at Izumi. In the next instant, Rudel had smacked the knight who thrust at Izumi. It happened in a flash. While the knights thought there had been a bit of distance between them, Rudel ignored that fact, closing the distance in an instant to punch and knock that knight out.

"... You've got some nerve. If you want to fight so badly, then I'll be your opponent. Everyone let's take this outside."

Rudel sent a glance to both Luecke and Eunius, and picking up on something, the two of them smiled a bit.

But seeing his serious eyes, the follower knights directed a glance to Eunius. They were hesitant to pick a fight with a dragoon.

... But.

"It's too late to go weak at the knees. But this ain't bad... it's been a while since I've gone on a rampage. You lot, you're all going outside. You picked a fight, so it's only natural, right?"

Eunius gave the order to his followers. He wouldn't let them run away.

"Hmm, for such a meritocratic bunch, it doesn't sound bad at all for a civil official to shut them up. Everyone who wants to join in, go outside. And when we're up against those guys, don't expect me to protect you. If you're taking part, you have to fend for yourselves."

Saying they could take part if they wanted to Luecke rolled his shoulders to show his will to fight. Within all that, Aleist of the defenders was the only one who tried to stop those three.

"What are you thinking!? Do you understand we're in an important period? Quit fighting like a student, let's calm down a bit!"

While he had stood to stop the three of them, Rudel and Eunius silently placed their hands on Aleist's shoulders to lead him outside, Dragged along, Aleist's expression showed he had no idea what they were angry about.

"Eh? W-what? What is this?"

To Aleist's confusion, an empty-handed Luecke tossed some unreasonable words.

"No you see... I was a bit jealous, seeing you surrounded by women. I'm going to take out some of my anger."

"What's with that!? When I'm not happy about it at all, forcefully dragging me off is way too unfair!"

"It really is unfair. I know that. And since I know that, I'll just say it. You're participating whether you like it or not."

As Luecke explained something he wasn't even thinking to Aleist, the four of them went outside. With a late start, the follower knights and civil officials left the store as well.



Seeing Rudel off, Luxheidy finished the remaining food before emptying his glass.

"H-hey! You're going to leave them!?"

The sharp-eyed, often sarcastic Saas seemed worried for Rudel. Enora looked like she would bound off at any moment, but perhaps she wanted to ask Izumi about her relationship with Rudel as she was fidgeting.

Luxheidt smiled as he told the waiter to get the person in charge. A little while later, the owner of the shop frantically raced over to Luxheidt.

"W-was there any problem on our part?"

While they were the ones who caused the problem, the owner was unable to go against the dragoons, the heroes of the country, so he gave an apology.

"No, no, that should be our line. We really are sort. Send the repair fees and trouble fees around to a mister Rudel Arses. Ah, also, we'll also foot the bill for the other tables... everyone went outside, after all."

Right, the women of the defenders had left Izumi and Millia to give chase to Aleist. They would likely return later, but that would be trouble for the shop. Those who owed money should pay. But saying it was Rudel's responsibility for causing a problem this time, Luxheidt pushed the payment onto Rudel.

"... That's a big help."

As the owner said his thanks, Luxheidt handed over a simple memo. Accepting it, the owner left at once.

"How's that going to work out for you?"

"The payment? It'll be fine, I plan to sell him a favor. Now then, it's right about time for us to go watch the fight."

Urging on a worried Saas, Luxheidt dragged a nervous Enora out of the store. So love really can change a person, he thought as he looked at her.

Chapter 110

In front of Aleist's eyes, a large man was sent flying to the side.

No, perhaps it was more accurate to say he was blown away. Rudel and Eunius exchanged fists nearby, while a little further away, Luecke used his magic to blow away the knights that swarmed around him. The civil officials who tried to capture Eunius were thrown and littered about the streets like garbage.

At the surrounding disaster, Aleist's face went pale. He instantly sobered up.

"Yep! This looks bad. This is definitely bad, Rudel!"

The two locking fists wouldn't lend an ear to his cry. On the contrary, despite the unveiling the day after the next, the two of them were punching each other in the face. When the others were carefully punching away from the face, the two of them laughed as they blatantly took aim.

Just as they had been in the academy, they were serious. The form of them seriously enjoying that exchange of blows caused Aleist to draw back.

"I'm telling you to stop it! You aren't kids anymore."

"Aleist, what makes you think you can stay an onlooker?"

"Eh?"

When Aleist tried to stop the two of them, Luecke placed a hand on his shoulders. As he turned, Luecke began to scold him, a frigid smile floating over his face.

"You... no. The defenders really have been a thorn in my side. The overtime I go through every day, and the mountains of paperwork, they're all because of the defenders. Did you know? Who do you think prepares all the budget you guys run through like water? And who do you think checks over the documentation?"

"I haven't the slightest."

Aleist was a lieutenant, but he generally didn't attend meetings. No, he wasn't invited to them. He simply worked at the palace on cleaning duty. That was all.

When he was suddenly brought into talks of funding there was no way he could answer.

"It's me. It's my duty to process it! Even so, it's my job. If it's a necessity, I won't complain. But you see... the quantity and details of the papers surrounding you guys is abnormal!"

Aleist could hear a grating sound from the shoulder Luecke grasped. HE was definitely angry. Definitely enraged. Not wanting to take on Luecke when he was like that, he tried to laugh and play it off, when...

"Do you know about the magic called earth hand?"

As Luecke snapped his fingers, the dirt behind him swelled into the shape of a gripped fist. The size of that fist was as large as a grown man.

"W-what do you plan to do with that?"

"Isn't it obvious? You use your shadows, so I'll be using magic. I'm not suited to duking it out like those guys."

Aleist's eyes turned to Rudel, confirming the form of the two rampaging about, destroying everything around them.

Looking back at Luecke, Aleist broke into a cold sweat at the earth hands that had multiplied in number while he wasn't looking.

"Now why don't we start."

"This is way too unreasonable!"



Around that time, the culprit behind Luecke's anger, Fina, was processing paperwork in her private room at the palace.

"Hah, this is for the sake of the country... I cannot be negligent (I'll pass this proposal and augment our budget! Just you wait, Halbades! I'll show you a thing or two about how this works. Hihyaaaah!)"

"Princess, please stop with the lies. A majority of these documents pertain to demi-humans, correct? What's with this special facility? The budget's become something incredible."

"Fluff fluff land."

"..."

"For the sake of my dreams of fluffadise, I must first start with a house of fluff."

Sophina's face was stiff as she looked at Fina, who didn't have anyone to stop her lately. She had worked too hard, transcending her fatigue and ending up in a state of high tensions. Naturally as it was, once the individual calmed down, she would surely come to regret it.

The current Courtois didn't have the budget to send around to such things. But through her needless proficiency, her papers were able to skillfully draw funding from the country. Meaning the official documents made it all the way to the top brass. They would likely be torn up there, but it was no joke for the government officials who had to deal with it along the way.

At this point, Luecke's sending back of the documents had become Fina's motivation. Luecke's overly serious personality had backfired.

"I'll call my master to fluff fluff land, and spend my days by his side gazing at fluffies being fluffed! I'm saying goodbye to this life of paperwork!"

"Get a grip on yourself! Why are you trying so far? When you're usually so useless!"

"... Sophina. You just called me useless, did you. I now understand how you see me on a regular basis."

Seeing Fina suddenly turn serious, Sophina flinched.

After staring expressionlessly at Sophina, Fina turned to her desk and restarted her work. Atop the desk, there were a number of serious documents scattered about. A report on the border was one of them.

(Well I'm beat. The movements of the knight brigades stationed on the border are worse than I thought. They're not even particularly incompetent, so why are...)

She seriously considered anti-empire measures and moved some hands around, but it seems she had lost the initiative.

While she had sent around members of the defenders as well, but even so, if you asked whether they were enough to maintain the border, that would be impossible. A number of choices encroached on Fina. Within all that, what would become her trump card would have to be the dragoons. From the founding of the nation, they had protected the kingdom.

(They're too skilled. We'll eventually have to pay the bill for relying on them too much. Even if we overcome this situation, it'll be bad if we don't have some reforms.)

As she troubled her head over the dragoons, Fina remembered Rudel. In preparation for the expo in two days time, the members of each knight brigade were probably making a ruckus right around now.

"I'm sure it's rowdy outside."

On Fina's words, Sophina hurriedly gave a response.

"I-It happens every year. We'll have to spend tomorrow repairing the destruction."

At the expo that could be called Courtois' specialty, the young knights would run rampant every year. It was also a sort of stress relief. You could say that area was sponsored.

"It's an annual event. If the fountain isn't destroyed, you can't say it's that time of year."

"The area around the fountain on the main road is the perfect place for a fight, after all."

Perhaps recalling her time as a new recruit, Sophina gave a nostalgic nod. There was no problem about the exchange of blows between knight brigades.

If it was on the level of a scuffle, they would often be condoned. It was a part of the festival. A part of the festive eve.

Fina wondered if Rudel was also raising a ruckus right around not. That didn't sound bad, thought she as she looked at the desk. For Fina knew now was the only time he could play around.



The four out of breath fled from the plaza surrounding the fountain.

As knights protecting the capital came in droves, Luxheidt and the others bought them some time. But Eunius and Luecke's followers were apprehended, unable to run away. Rudel had hopes that Luxheidt would manage to do something about that as well.

"W-why are we running? Just own up."

While Aleist gave a short-winded lament, the other three laughed. Rudel gave his first grand laugh he had given in a long time. The four of them

hadn't changed. They were the same sort of idiots they had been in their school days.

"No, couldn't help it."

Eunius rubbed the place Rudel had smacked him as he laughed. Rudel had cut the inside of his mouth, blood dripped from the corner of his lips. As he wiped that, Luecke began to speak.

"Now then, what are we going to do now?"

"Let's get a drink. It won't be any fun if we broke up here."

On their exchange, Aleist recalled their followers.

"Huh? What about your men?"

"I'm sure they'll be released in no time. That's just the sort of day it is."

"Once they're shoved in a cell, even those lot will quiet down a bit, right? Oh right! I can use that as a reason to increase their training hours. My body's aching to move around."

On their light correspondence, Rudel recalled his own comrades. Luxheidt, Saas, and Enora would likely be fine without him.

And he thought over Izumi, but he couldn't turn back to invite her now. If he showed himself, he would be apprehended.

"Then we have to find a store that'll take us."

Rudel proceeded down the depths of an alley, and following behind him, the other three walked. Being in an alley, Aleist walked mindfull of his surroundings.

From behind, they could hear the clamor of the main street.



"Oy, was that really alright?"

Leaving the fallen to the knights charged with security, Luxheidt had freed his company. Saas seemed worried about letting Rudel run away and pushing their job onto the other knights.

But Luxheidt laughed.

"It's fine. Rather, I already told them who the principal offenders were."

"You sold Rudel out?"

Enora scowled at him, so he said that was an overstatement and brought seriousness to his face.

"The culprits are the three lords and that black knight, right? It'll be more troublesome for them to actually arrest them, and as punishment, the four are going to help with the cleanup tomorrow. This is for the best. I'm sure they'll be delighted, being given a legit reason to avoid some troublesome work."

"You really see it going down that well?"

Saas glared at him, so Luxheidt shrugged his shoulders. He didn't particularly get the feeling he handled things perfectly. He hadn't stopped Rude. If he did, it wouldn't have come to this.

Even so, Luxheidt had his own reasons for not stopping Rudel.

"Well, I just have to do better next time."

"So I hope."

On Saas' words, Luxheidt gave a bitter smile.

He was looking at his colleagues in his own way; while Saas had a sharp look in his eyes, he worried for his comrades. Enora was engrossed with Rudel, but lately, she had lost her tension, and let the power leave her shoulders. She had talent from the start. He recognized her abilities.

Whenever he looked at Rudel, he found himself amused.

He felt he was looking forward to whatever he would do. While he was a person unsuited for organizations, that being the case, he would draw people to him.

(Is this how a hero is supposed to be? Well, if that's how it's going to be, it sure is lucky to have a hero among your colleagues.)

Seeing Luxheidt chuckle, both Saas and Enora, and the other dragoons found it creepy.



Right as they exited the alley they found themselves at a stall near the river.

Rudel and the others walked over to it and took their seats at the provisional chairs outside the stall. The table wasn't fixed, it wouldn't stop wobbling.

The sound of flowing water and the exchanges of the surrounding customers rung comfortably against their ears. While they were covered in wounds, their clothes in tatters, the stallkeeper accepted them with a smile.

Eunius handed over some money and told them to bring out whatever. In no time, the table was lined with snacks and ale. The plates were cheap, and the ale wasn't anything high class, but the four of them raised their glasses on the spot.

Aleist alone seemed vaguely displeased. Seeing his expression, Eunius pat him on the shoulder and laughed.

"What's up? You look down, Aleist."

Luecke munched on the potatoes put out as a snack, and perhaps they were surprisingly tasty, as he continued reaching out for them. And with Eunius leading in, he tried consoling Aleist.

"Are you mindful of what happened back there? I'll forget about it, so why don't you have a bite too? These fried potatoes are splendid."

"No, I'm not angry or anything. How should I put it, I don't hate this sort of thing. It's just, I'm on cleaning duty, and I'm anxious about what's to come, or rather..."

It seemed Aleist had his worries. Rudel recalled Aleist's expression as he saw it in the high-class shop. It didn't quite look that he was living a fulfilled life. Though he knew that he was troubled, being surrounded by women.

"Are you worried? Then it'll be easier to talk about it."

"It's that, right? Millia, right? The rumor's been going around the palace."

Eunius bit off some meat from a skewer, telling Rudel Aleist's rumor in the palace.

In the first place, while being a lieutenant of the defenders, he was surrounded by female knights. What's more, they were all beauties. It was natural for male knights to resent him. Yet such a man was in love with the female elf knight called Millia. And the target of his affections wasn't giving him the time of day.

"You know, when you already have five fiancés, there are even talks of getting the princess with you as well. That's why you're so hated."

"Five mistresses is a bit much, don't you think. Rudel, could you pass that fish over there."

Luecke asked Rudel to hand over the fish he hadn't tried yet. Rudel cleaned up the empty plates as he handed Luecke the plate of fish.

"This one? Well, I think it's too much as well."

The three of them warned Aleist about his engagements, but to them, Aleist dropped an even bigger bomb.

"... Seven."

"... Hah?"

While he was drinking his ale, on Aleist's murmur, Eunius ended up spilling his cup. Luecke also dropped the food en route to his mouth.

"Aleist, if that wasn't a mistake, did I just hear seven?"

As three sets of eyes gathered, Aleist downed the contents of the cup in his hand. He cried out.

"That's right! Seven! It went up. It went up while I wasn't looking... my parents said she was the daughter of an important business partner and took her. And after that, even a childhood friend popped out."

Rudel looked at Luecke and tilted his head.

"Are childhood friends the sort of things that suddenly pop out?"

"No, they usually don't suddenly pop out. Tell us more, Aleist."

Aleist poured alcohol into his cup and sipped it as he began to speak. His eyes were already teary.

"A long while back... well, there were a few reasons, and there was a kid who moved over. Rather than moved over, she was the daughter of my old private tutor and she lived at the mansion with us."

"I see. A common tale."

Eunius gave an adequate response before putting in an order for extra ale. While he was surprised they had increased, it seems he had no interest in how love began. More than that, he was directing a smile at the stallkeeper's cute daughter who came to take their order.

"No, well... that kid had this and that going on, and we got along well. But I forgot about her, or how should I put it..."

"Now that's terrible."

The reason Rudel could say that was because of his few encounters in life. The nobles Luecke and Eunius had plenty of places to meet people. Within

all that, there were quite a few faces they had forgotten.

For Rudel, who had few encounters before he came to the academy, he felt forgetting was terrible.

Sensing his difference in temperature from those around him, Rudel inclined an ear towards Aleist's story.

"Y-yeah. And you see, it seems we made a bit of a promise when we were little, and..."

"A verbal agreement? I can't endorse the fact you let someone grasp your weakness."

"You should learn to evade it a bit more."

Luecke and Eunius pressed Aleist on his verbal agreement. That was also something that came from their special environment. And as such a mismatched conversation carried on, Aleist's present situation came into light.

Meaning, while proclaiming he loved Millia, he had increased his number of fiancés. There were seven at the current stage. Thinking of how either Fina or Aileen might be added on, the three of them could no longer laugh it off.

Because his serious worry was an increase in his amount of engagements.

"Then just reject them."

The words Eunius said through a laugh were the closest thing he had to an answer. His indecisiveness was the problem, Rudel agreed with that.

But Aleist understood it as well.

"I did! Rather, I flat out rejected them! But... but... one of them was a daughter of a merchant business partner, and my parents said it was for the future of their transactions, and the other side was all up for it. And when there's a girl with a smile that says she's waited for this moment her entire

life, um, I couldn't straight up say no, or how should I put it, my words didn't get through at all."

The three faces gradually grew sympathetic. There was no helping it if it was about the connections between houses, thought Rudel as he consoled Aleist. But here, Luecke changed the topic.

The three of them had noticed. Aleist had some fault in it...

So that was the end of the matter. There was nothing more for the three of them to do. They weren't able to stick their mouths into the circumstance of other houses.

"Come to think of it, Rudel, your sister's enrolling in the academy next year, right? ... Is Lena doing alright?"

"Lena? I heard she's going fine. They grow up so fast."

"I-I see. Then I want to send her something to commemorate the event. What would be nice?"

"Hey, I'm not done yet."

Having lost interest in Aleist, Rudel and Luecke began talking about Lena's enrollment. Eunius had started hitting on the stallkeeper's daughter.

He was being a bit incessant, so Luecke glared at Aleist. His eyes were the epitome of seriousness.

"Can you keep quiet a bit? I'm talking about something serious here... so if I'm sending her something, would a spear be nice? I can arrange for one of the highest quality at once."

"I think it's a bit early for that. In that case, I something simple that fits her physique would be nice. As a brother, if possible, I'd like to do something for Erselica as well, but... Aleist, I'll hear you out some other time."

Rudel spoke with Luecke about his sisters as he put off Aleist's talk to another time.



Separated from everyone, Izumi and Millia walked down a path a little away from the rowdy main road.

The voices of the knights in festive spirits reached all the way to them.

Millia and Izumi walked side by side as they made for the lodging house. The two of them stayed silent.

Perhaps being tactful, Izumi started a conversation about the events of the day.

"Today really was something. Even so, those four are the same as ever."

Seeing Izumi's bitter smile, Millia suddenly grew irritated. Rudel had smacked away the knight who tried to lay a hand on her. It felt as if she had been shown just how important Izumi was to Rudel.

(When I already decided to forget.)

"And Aleist is going after you as alwa—" "Quiet! Shut up!"

"M-Millia?"

Stopping in her tracks and screaming out, Millia looked blankly into Izumi's face. With that sudden cry, Izumi's expression showed she was mindful over whether she had said something bad.

Handing her head, Millia threw out all the feelings she had been keeping silent about. Hearing her own shaking voice, she noticed she was crying.

"I'm jealous of you. The only one he'll ever look at is you, Izumi. It was the same at the academy. Always by his side. When I could only ever watch, you were always having fun with him."

She understood these weren't words to direct at Izumi. She understood, but with the alcohol in her system, she was doing a bad job at controlling her feelings.

She didn't particularly hate Aleist. But the one she came to like was Rudel. Within Millia, there remained still emotions she couldn't shake off. No matter how hard she tried to forget, it was no good. It would only remind her, inform her of how much she thought of Rudel.

And yet...

"Even now, I still like Rudel."

... And yet, I can't win against Izumi.

Understanding she couldn't win, It was the voice of Millia's heart.

Chapter 111

In the capital preparing for its expo in two days, the revelry could be heard, even on the unpopular road back to the lodging house.

The two women who met each other on that road, a green haired crying elf, and a black haired beautiful oriental woman.

She understood she would never be able to say it so bluntly. She knew it would only be trouble if she said that. To Izumi, Rudel was close to her life's savior. So she didn't want to trouble her savior Rudel.

And yet, Millia said she was jealous.

"Say something... laugh at my efforts or futile. Ridicule me! Say I'm a stupid woman! Make me give up already!!"

While Millia painfully wrung out her voice, Izumi shook her head. It was a sensation as if Millia was speaking her own feelings, causing the tears to build in Izumi's eye. Enduring the urge to cry, Izumi took a deep breath before slowly looking over Millia.

The fact she looked like a young girl trembling in her anxiety was surely because she was an elf. Raising her head, she readied herself.

"I'm the same. No, I'm even worse. I always liked him. That's why I stayed by his side. But even that was no good. I'm not good enough to stand by Rudel's side."

When she put what she understood to mouth, she felt ashamed of herself. But even so, Making a smile, Izumi spoke to Millia.

"We're similar, you and I. Falling in love with a person our hands will never reach, we're both stupid women."

"... But you're all the way up there, so far ahead of me. I don't have a single memory with him at the academy..."

"Even so, that doesn't change the result."

Izumi's tone wasn't as if she was speaking to Millia, it was as if she was telling it to herself.



The next day...

In the plaza with the broken fountain, under Cattleya's watch, the Three Lords and Aleist were cleaning up the wreckage.

Eunius and Luecke's followers they had forcefully brought in had taken paid leave and were currently hospitalized.

"Why "is it just us? There were definitely others who went on a rampage."

"My thoughts exactly. I'm no good at physical labor. Can't we leave this to the laborers?"

To the two who spilled complaints, Cattleya gave the whip in her hands one strong smack against the ground. That strike from the whip made quite a painful sound.

"Yeah, yeah, you two over there, get back to work. Otherwise, we'll never make in time for tomorrow's display (Not just this time, we haven't had idiots that destroyed it this bad in years)."

As the new recruits were placed under Cattleya, she had to take responsibility and keep watch over the four. It was decided that Cattleya was the only viable option, but truth be told, Oldart pushed the job onto her because she looked bored.

(Hah, why am I even here.)

She issued orders to the four, putting them to work, but any normal knight would be too fearful to order them around. With various things having happened in the past, it was decided Cattleya would be alright.

She looked at the two seriously doing work a little away. It was Aleist and Rudel.

"Huh? Rudel, why are you smiling like that? It's creepy."

"Yeah, you should look forward to tomorrow's display. I can't talk about it yet, but I'm sure you'll be surprised."

(What are you planning? Well, the ones who'll be troubled are that Charmer in his Prime and Mr. Straight-laced so I don't really care.)

As Cattleya let out a sigh, she got around to thinking that her amount of troubles had increased as of late. Perhaps her state had been witnessed as the four of them gathered to look at Cattleya.

"What's this? Does your superior have someone she lies? Come to think of it, she used to be your fiancé, right Rudel?"

As Eunius checked it with another dragoon, Rudel, the man in question tilted his head.

"I'm not good with those sorts of rumors, but... I don't think she does."

(... Well I'm sorry for being single. Even like this, I'm at least trying.)

With younger men gossiping over her love life, it got to her head, but Cattleya persuaded herself to endure it.

"Hmm, well, with that personality, you know. She must be troubled with no one wanting to take her. This is why boorish women are troublesome."

Aleist followed through on Luecke's cold words. As Aleist took some fleeting glances at her, Cattleya grew irritated.

"N-no, well! Appearance-wise, she's beautiful, and she's a dragoon, so that sort of thing is..."

"Well sorry for only being beautiful appearance-wise! Now get back to work already."

When she hit her whip against the ground, three of them returned to work. Eunius the manual labor, Luecke used magic to repair the broken portions. Aleist carried out miscellaneous jobs.

But Rudel...

"Lieutenant."

"What is it?"

He came over to Cattleya, and after struggling a bit over what to say, eh directed her a smile. As Cattleya worried whether that smile would turn her face red, Rude...

"I don't know what happened, but do your best!"

Cattleya expressionlessly approached Rudel before lightly hitting him with her whip. While Rudel's seemed confused, she yelled out loudly.

"This is your faultttt!"

"Why!?"

Seeing Rudel's incomprehensive face, Cattleya screamed some more.



Fritz wore the gorgeous knight uniform he had gotten accustomed to over the past half year as he paid Aileen a visit.

As captain of the royal guard, escorting Aileen was part of his duty. It was a role he was responsible, and definitely a problem to be handled, but it wasn't as if he didn't have any proficient subordinates he could leave it to.

Originally, guards of firm status and capability would be selected.

But it hadn't been long since the royal guard's creation.

To add to that, Fritz had graduated on the academy's three-year curriculum. He had become captain without learning all the things he should. That being the case, he had problems when it came to paperwork jobs. The executives of the royal guard had circled him around to Aileen's security.

Otherwise, on top of Aileen's mood spiraling downwards, work wouldn't get done. Keeping Aileen company as she sipped tea on the terrace, Fritz had begun to hold questions as of late. Was it really alright for him to be here doing this? Wasn't there something else he should be doing?

But he had already become captain of the royal guard, and he had not the freedom.

The Kingdom of Courtois had even granted Fritz a dragon. Letting Fritz do as he pleased was an impossible request.

"What seems to be the matter? Are these sweets not to your liking... then I'll call the bakers."

"N-no. that isn't the case."

While he had gotten around to using words he wasn't accustomed to, he was told that in private, before Aileen, he was to speak normally. From that, his manner of speech had become a mismatch. The reason for his panic was Aileen.

If she didn't fancy them, she would instantly change out the bakers.

If it was so easy, then couldn't he be next... the thought crossed Fritz' mind. He had unskillfully succeeded, so he couldn't let himself drop from his current status. The elevation of commoner living standards he wanted to carry out, put in the wrong station he wasn't able to push it forward.

(It's not yet the time. If I wait a bit more, I should be able to move freely.)

Smiling, sipping tea with Aileen, Fritz feared when the smile of this beautiful princess might be directed at another.

(Want. I want Aileen.)

Her blond hair was long and beautiful, her blue eyes seemed they just might suck him in.

Fritz held affection towards Aileen, who had supported him so far. It was something, looked on from the side, was a fleeting, and hazardous scene to behold.



"Father, what knight brigade is that one!?"

A small girl held an ice cream cone in her right hand as she asked her father giving her a piggy back ride about the knight brigade members marching in file.

"That's the royal guard. There aren't many high knights this year, so they might be the centerpiece in years to come."

The father had lived in the capital for many years and he had watched the displays from a young age. As the years went by, he had begun to view them with the strict eyes of an examiner.

The royal guard was a hurriedly constructed brigade, and their movements couldn't help but lack in polish.

"They aren't moving well. I heard some high knights had transferred over, but their ranks are slightly misaligned. If that's how they're going to be, then while they're lacking in numbers, the high knights are the prettier sight."

"Ah, father, look, look! There's a person wearing amaaazing black armor over there."

As the girl started squirming on her father's shoulders, 'Don't drop your ice cream,' he said as he gave a wry smile.

"One of this year's centerpieces. That's the black knight."

"Black knight?"

"Black full-plate armor and a red mantle... those gold horns and ornaments are lovely. He's even riding a nightmare, he's on a different level from the other knights."

A nightmare was a beautiful horse monster with a long, black mane. But as it possessed intellect, it was possible to domesticate it. The sharp horn growing from its forehead and the red lines that drew a pattern as they ran around its body were a charming sight.

"Ah! There's a dragon flying in the sky! Are is that a dragoon?"

"Hahaha, with just one dragon, I can't say that's a dragoon. It's circling over the royal guard, so I'm sure that's the captain's dragon. But it does look lonely flying along like that. When the new recruit and veteran flight formations are the centerpiece each year."

The royal guard passed in front of the two, followed by the new recruits of each knight brigade. The residents living in the capital looked to the sky, knowing the real show was yet to come.

"My neck hurts."

"Just watch a little longer. I'm sure you'll never forget it."

There, the girl raised a cheer. The surrounding townsfolk all looked up at the formation of dragons flying through the sky. Cheers and whistles. And as if they couldn't hear a lick of it, the two looked up at the sky.

"What was that!? What was that!"

"That was some high-level flying. There was a wind dragon at the lead, so I'm sure that person's going to become an amazing knight of the dragoons someday. When they picked them up in less than a year, those movements were splendid."

The dragons flying through the sky flew in a way they could show off their skill to the residents of the capital.

The delighted young girl waved her hand at the dragons in the sky. But the dragons had already gone.

"They're gone."

"It's not done yet. The real show starts now."

The father's eyes sparkled, without blinking his eyes, he looked up at the sky. His expression was one that wouldn't let the slightest movement go unnoticed, the face of a child.

There, a completely different unit of dragons from before showed movements as if they were dancing through the sky. On those movements on another level from before, the girl could only cry out, "Amazing, amazing!"

The father shouted, "No way, an aileron roll there!? Oy, oy, now that's a combo!" he said in great excitement. The seasoned eyes of the capital's residents had nothing but praise for the year's flight formation...

"Father, that was amazing!"

"Yeah, but there weren't many wild dragons this year. The captain has a gray dragon, so perhaps the dragoon's quality is on a decline after all. Their movements were nice, but I wanted to see something more gallant. They used to swoop down so low you could almost touch them, but I guess they're paying mind to safety..."

"Father?"

(Come to think of it, wasn't the white knight supposed to come out this year? I believe... he had a gaia dragon, but I didn't see it back there. They say he's a future archduke, so maybe he'll come out at the end.)

The man checked to see how the daughter on his shoulders was faring. The girl who liked festivities ate her ice cream on her father's shoulders as she

looked at the sky.

She looked at the sky enthralled, waiting to see if they would come again. Seeing his daughter like that, the man recalled his own past self.

He reminisced over how he had ridden the shoulders of his father, now a grandfather, looking up at the dragons like this. Back then, he had dropped his ice cream on his father's back. Recalling how angry he had gotten, he gave a bitter smile, only for his daughter to drop her ice cream.

"Hey, you have to keep a proper hold on it."

He didn't get as angry as his father before him. When dealing with his daughter, he couldn't help but soften his words. But his daughter stayed silently staring at the sky.

His surroundings grew silent as everyone stared. Feeling suspicious of his daughter and the surrounding residents who wouldn't say a word, he looked up at the sky as well.

"What's this..."

No one would answer the man's words. No, no one could answer.

Chapter 112

The sky the capital's residents looked up to was one of cloudless blue sky.

But a shadow stretched out over the many onlookers. The light was interrupted by the flight of dragon upon dragon, enough to cover up the sky. At times, the sun would peek out from behind the dragons, but the residents were left unable to say a single word.

The heroic forms of the beautiful dragons were led to fly across the sky in file.

It wasn't a flight formation, it looked like a single large flow. The movements of the dragons went alongside the plaza, causing many to imagine the sight of a large flowing river.

They didn't do any aerial maneuvers. The dragons that flew in line showed a flight without a string's breadth of disorder. And flying at the center was a dragon especially large, even among its peers, a large brilliant dragon of white.

Red, blue, yellow, green... Its form as it flew protected by a conspicuously large dragon of each species made it look like a king of dragons. Eventually, the dragons passed above the townsfolk, gathering over the palace and rotating around it as if to draw a circle.

Right above the palace stationed in the center of the royal capital, a crest imitating the form of a dragon was put on show for all to see. That crest was formed of the lines of dragons, and from within it, a single dragon descended.

A single knight in white armor, a blue mantle on his back, boldly descended to the palace alongside that dragon.

"Demon lord..."

"Eh?"

On the mutters of a girl on her father's shoulders, the father stared blankly. Once the small girl's cry brought the silence to an end, the residents directed their eyes at her.

"I saw it in a picture book. The demon lord will come, leading his army. His legions cover the sky as he attacks the palace."

On that day...

In the country of Courtois, a young man called the demon lord was born.



The palace was dark, a large hoard of dragons interrupting the sky above them.

The place Rudel descended to was the same place that had been decided on beforehand. As promised, he hadn't carried out any aerial maneuvers, so under normal circumstance, there wouldn't be and complaints.

But...

"W-what is the meaning of this!?"

The first one to raise their voice was Aileen, protected by Fritz. The dragoons instantly took to the skies to protect the royal line and authorities. The difference in numbers was overwhelming, not a soul thought they would win.

Courtois had contracted with dragons from times of old, so long ago that many who feared the day the dragons would turn against them.

"We've invited in the rage of the dragons!" "No way! They're not attacking."
"Who was it. Who did this!?"

In the chaotic palace plaza, King Albach raised his voice.

"Do not falter! Carry on the ceremony. White knight, black knight, come forward."

The unveiling was supposed to have the representatives come out before the king and kneel. There, the king called out to the knights. The whole goal was to show the residents of the capital the military might of Courtois. If the space devolved into chaos, then the country would grow chaotic as well.

"Let the orchestra play on. This is all per schedule."

Albach took lead of that chaotic place, having Aleist and Rudel- who had dismounted Sakuya- come out before him. The authorities and knights who could naught but look at the sky quieted their ruckus and faced the ceremony.

(... You've sure gone and done it.)

While he wanted to lodge a complaint or two, the king kept a tranquil expression as he called out to Rudel and Aleist.

"Splendid. I am pleased to be able to see the form of two such gallant knights this year."

"Sir! I take your words with the deepest gratitude." "S-such words are wasted on..."

The two gave the responses decided on beforehand, but Aleist was confused. At times, he looked mindfully at the sky. He had taken off his helmet, holding it in his right hand, and it was his small that made him less conspicuous. If he wore it, then the twitching of his horns would alert the others of how mindful he was of the space above him.

(Even so, what terrible faces they've got. They're covered in wounds.)

As a result of their fights, there were marks remaining on their faces. While they had likely treated them, the treatment hadn't made it in time.

There were knights like this every year, but Albach never thought the two serving as representatives would be among them.

(Good grief, cleaning this up will be a headache.)

He was certain an urgent anti-Rudel countermeasures meeting would be called afterwards.



Once the ceremony ended, the knight brigades were supposed to disperse.

But after the wild dragons returned, Rudel was apprehended. Seeing Rudel taken off, Sakuya laid her rage bare.

The other dragons didn't try to stop Sakuya, so a situation where the knights fearfully surrounded her persisted.

When Sakuya roared, the knights in their best clothing uneasily took their stances. IT was a formal ceremony and they hadn't brought any decent equipment with them.

"C-captain! It's no good!" "Don't give up! We are before his majesty's eyes!" "No, but..."

When it took courage just to stand against a dragon, Sakuya boasted the biggest body of them all. There was no helping the knights fear her.

It was the fault of the royal guard for forcefully dragging Rudel off. Their treatment of him put Sakuya into a rage.

"What about the royal guard!?" "What are the dragoons doing!?"

There were dragoons who would only watch from around, but that was because their own dragons couldn't move. Oldart and Alejandro came up front to try to calm her down.

"Oy, oy, Sakuya-chan. Get too angry, and you'll sprout wrinkles on that pretty mug of..." "You're definitely not trying, are you!"

Alejandro cautioned Oldart for his lack of motivation. Perhaps displeased at the wrinkle part, Sakuya roared out again.

Normally, these two would have accompanied Rudel, but the royal guard had driven them off. The royal guard then asserted it was their jurisdiction, from Oldart's eyes, it looked like they were desperate for achievements.

"No, even if you ask me to work for those bastards sake, you know..."

"Fool, this is a problem related to the honor of the dragoons."

"Sure, sure."

Oldart looked at Sakuya, he could see she really was angry. Their own dragons recognized Sakuya as boss, so he couldn't carelessly get close. While the difference in power was clear, more than that, the finer laws of humanity held no meaning to dragons.

Her contractor was receiving unjust treatment.

If Sakuya thought so, that was the dragon truth. On top of that, still young, Sakuya had problems with regulating her emotions.

(No way I'm dealing with a child this big.)

As he was at his wit's end, there a single high knight appeared. The one who brought her was Aleist, who had removed his armor. Escorting her halfway, he dispatched that single female knight before Sakuya.

The female knight was Izumi.

As the high knight appeared, her ponytail swaying, the others wondered what was going on and made a path.

"Sorry, pardon me."

Still in her ceremonious knight garments, Izumi parted the crowd and came forward. While Oldart tried to have her step back from the danger, Sakuya's behavior blatantly changed.

"Oy, young lady, any closer is... oh."

Sakuya who- until just a moment before- had been spreading her wings and roaring time and again, suddenly groaned and folded up her wings. And Izumi looked at Sakuya.

While the roars had stopped, the surroundings maintained their tension. In contrast, Izumi approached without getting worked up.

"Rudel is alright. So it will be fine... right. Rudel's strong, isn't he?"

Seeing Izumi call out to Sakuya, the surroundings were surprised. While it looked like she was simply talking to herself, the dragoons knew that scene boasted a different meaning.

Alejandro made a face of surprise.

"Is she holding a conversation? A knight who isn't even a dragon?"

"That's rare, but it's not unheard of. I'm just thankful our big girl's grown meek."

Oldart shrugged his shoulders sending orders around for everyone to stand down. Sakuya obeyed Izumi and sat on the spot.

The knights released from their tensions started looking at Izumi with eyes as if they were viewing their messiah. The new recruits who sat down had haggard looks on their faces.

That was just how mentally taxing it was to confront a dragon.

(Well, it really is harsh when you're not used to it.)

Oldart called his subordinates, giving orders for everyone who wasn't keeping watch over Sakuya to return. Sakuya was now lying down, and it seems Izumi was approaching her head to talk.

"... A hole? No, I really don't think you should do that here... no, I'm telling you it's a bad idea."

Sakuya was a gaia dragon with a liking for caves. She was bored waiting, so she was probably telling Izumi she wanted to dig a hole.

Hearing that, Oldart and Alejandro were flustered.

"Y-young lady! Stop her with all your might!"



The palace was in chaos from Rudel's actions.

The urgently-called meeting was held with everyone still in ceremonious clothing. At times, they would hear Sakuya's roars, the vibrations resounding, even through the distant meeting room.

The meeting pertained to how they would treat Rudel henceforth.

He had done no more than appear taking some dragons along, but the fact he led so many wild dragons was the problem. According to the man in question, it was a one-time thing.

But it was unclear whether or not that was true. If he was up to it, couldn't he bring ruin to Courtois? That was what they feared. But they couldn't treat him poorly. Rudel's own status was one thing, but now he was the white knight and famed through the land.

In the worst case, there was no guarantee killing Rudel wouldn't invite in the retribution of the dragons. No, from Sakuya's state, it was thought that the possibility was high.

Once Rudel was shoved in a cell, the royal guard requested his transfer.

"Rudel-dono is dangerous. We cannot leave him in the charge of the dragoons. I beseech you to let the royal guard take charge of him."

Without any conspicuous military gains and with Fritz as their captain, the seeds of panic had been born. They didn't think they would have the princess backing them forever.

Albach looked at the executive who spoke in Fritz' stead, sensing his impatience.

"On top of his numerous outbursts of problematic behavior since becoming a dragoon, I think you have come to understand through today's expo. Rudel-dono is not properly being handled."

(So you'll handle him properly...? You'll pin down the white knight to obtain influence for yourselves? I think that's more trouble than it's worth.)

Seeing through the royal guard's impatience, Albach recalled Fina's warning to be wary of them. Even if you called him captain, Fritz held the authority of the head of a single brigade. If Rudel was placed under him, there would definitely be disputes.

They likely couldn't permit the fact the black knight was with the defenders. Even if he was on cleaning duty for now, it was certain he would work his way up.

Rudel was also a single knight, but at the same time, he was a future archduke. Staring ten, twenty years into the future, the royal guard were nothing but anxious. There was nothing to assure them Aileen would continue being their supporter in times to come.

Yet at the same time, they were rapidly holding power within the palace. The planned to make Rudel a part of that. To maintain that power, they needed a shrine greater than Fritz in value.

(This is getting troublesome. But...)

"I also endorse his transfer to the royal guard."

One of the ministers signaled his approval, he said they should just entrust and quarantine him to the royal guard. While it was an indirect statement, it was a proposal to keep him as little more than a pet for life.

(These guys are even more trouble.)

Among his ministers, there would many who would stay Albach's hand. While they were preparing for the Gaia Empire, it was a situation where he would have to do something about them.

(But right now, Rudel takes precedence.)

He feared punishing him too harshly, inviting the rage of the dragons. Everyone felt the same. As there were many who signaled their approval, Albach looked at Fritz.

"And how things the captain of the royal guard?"

Fritz stood from his seat and gave a bold declaration. It felt almost as if he was just speaking lines written for him beforehand. When looking at him as a single knight, he was competent, and the king couldn't wait to see how he would grow.

But from his ideals and standing, he couldn't help but look unreliable. No, from Albach's point of view, Fritz was a hindrance.

"I will be able to contain Rudel. It is my belief it is much too dangerous to let him roam free forever. The problem lies in the individual's lack of self-awareness."

"Hmm. Then the royal guard can contain Rudel?"

"Precisely."

By Albach's personal opinion, if Fritz actually had that much power, then he would be fine with leaving the matter to him. But when compared to Oldart, he seemed to fall short, and on top of that, he knew that Fritz was doing nothing but drink tea with Aileen.

Even if he was entrusting work to his subordinates, there should be a limit to that. While it seemed the royal guard wanted to take Rudel in, he got the feeling opinions were clashing within.

(The defenders have the black knight. But the royal guard can't contain Rudel. In that case, it's best to keep the status quo, but...)

Albach looked at Fritz and the other royal guard executives.

"Then will you be able to cope if wild dragons come as they have today?"

"Yes."

Fritz answered full of confidence. But there, the roars they could hear from outside ceased. Albach sent a nearby knight outside to confirm the situation.

He considered that Rudel might have slipped out, but he got quite an interesting report instead.



"Special inspection officer?"

As Izumi accepted the papers from her superior, she felt the urge to tilt her head at the contents they detailed.

A few days had gone by since the ruckus at the expo, and when she dropped by her workplace, she was called out by her superior officer. Her superior who no longer had any hopes for the future... the captain of the high knight brigade smiled as she sipped tea.

"Yeah, your special talents have been recognized."

"Special? But I don't have any special talents..."

Izumi didn't think she had any talent distinguishing her from the others.

"You should be proud of the fact you were able to converse with a dragon you aren't contracted to and even sooth it at that. Even more so if the one you can converse with is that white one. I've heard you've held a friendship with her from your school days."

The papers listed Rudel as her target of inspection. Continuing on, she was to observe Sakuya as well.

"Well, your work will be taking you to the outer reaches of the kingdom, but your promotion has been decided."

A station on the outskirts was surely a strange promotion, but Izumi confirmed the contents in surprise. She was being treated favorably. While being enlisted in the high knight brigade, she was granted a level of authority.

On top of that, she was even granted the right to choose her own subordinates.

Even if her duty was in the outer reaches, it wasn't as if she was being sent off to some desolate place.

"... But what exactly am I supposed to do? I don't understand the point of just watching him."

"That's more than enough. You've seen it at the expo, you just have to stop a knight and dragon before they run wild. This is a job only you can do. No, to think a connection from your school days would help out so, this is fate."

Some part of the captain who had been doing nothing but paperwork lately gave off a sense of resignation. Izumi had no right to refuse, so she took the papers and exited the captain's office.

As she walked down the corridor, she was surprised she had suddenly been granted the authority of a major.



In the dungeon, by the light of a lamp, Rudel was writing a letter.

"Who's it to? Izumi-san?"

In front of the grid bars, Aleist had been stationed to watch over the white knight. He also had his regular duties to attend to, so he was wearing an apron. It fit him much too well; Rudel didn't have anything particular to say in regards to his attire.

"To my disciple. I feel bad for Luecke, after all. I'm writing to tell her not to trouble him too much."

"... I can't think of those as the words of the culprit who caused today's ruckus. Should I put in something as well?"

Shoved in a cell, Rudel seriously thought over what he had done wrong. He had been banned from aerial maneuvers, so he had restrained the others from doing them. Was it bad to fly in formation over the palace? As he mulled over that, he put the letter in an envelope and handed it to Aleist.

"I thought it was a success."

"No matter how you look at it, that was no good. There are complaints coming in from the residents of the capital, or rather, it's been considerably troubling with all the people coming in to confirm the truth of the matter. And right around now, his majesty included, the authorities and Fritz are holding a meeting."

Rudel wondered if he's caused them trouble again, but he found it strange the dragoons weren't participating in that meeting.

"Why is Fritz participate when our captain cannot? Come to think of it, it's strange for the royal guard to be there at all."

"I guess that's their authority in the palace? Princess Aileen is publically backing them, and a number of ministers are all for the royal guard, see. You've got to wonder what the world's coming to when tea duty and cleaning duty are holding office."

As Aleist derided himself, Rudel gave thanks about the matter with Izumi.

"You thing? Well, whatever. More importantly, you were a big help back there. Thank you."

"... Hahaha, Sakuya was glaring daggers at me, though."

Aleist was giving a bitter smile, but when Rudel asked, he had instantly taken Izumi to Sakuya. It seems he had gone quite a bit past his station, and

Rudel was thankful.

"I didn't have the slightest intent to resist. And yet those guys from the royal guard..."

Rudel made a displeased face. He hadn't eh mind to resist. But the royal guard were much too eager as they pinned him down. From there, Sakuya flew into a rage, and he was in a state where he couldn't even hold a proper conversation.

Right now, Izumi was at her side, and it seemed she'd calmed down.

"Was Flan von Brains no good after all?"

Perhaps Aleist recalled Sakuya's resentment before she lost her memories as he fell into a slump. From Rudel's point of view, he understood she didn't particularly hate him. But he knew Sakuya did think of him as a rival.

At the academy, the two of them would fight over any and everything. Perhaps this was the vestiges of it. Even when she had been reborn without memories, Rudel felt that Sakuya was still there.

"The way I see it, it's closer to rivals. I don't think she hates you."

"I really must decline a rival relationship with a dragon."

Aleist's face was stiff.



Fina was slumped over the desk of her room at the academy.

She had been normal up until she returned from the palace, but from the moment she got back, she had been in this state.

The reason lay in the documents on the desk. One was torn up, another crumpled. But for the last one alone, she was carefully writing a reply without damaging it.

"Goddammit... that black hair."

Her guard Sophina looked at her master, cheering her up with a smile. Inside, she was delighted to see her master grow depressed when her schemes went amiss.

"It cannot be helped, princess. This is also Rudel-dono's request."

The torn paper was one Aleist submitted. Hearing Luecke's tale, he had put in his opinion as Lieutenant.

"That ornament, thinking he can complain to me..."

She was irritated, so she devised a plan to shove some more female knight in his platoon next year. The crumpled document was a report detailing Izumi's action.

"Even so, appointing that black hair as a special inspections officer... my plans are..."

He didn't know what was on their minds, but they had officially recognized Izumi as an anti-Rudel trump card. Sophina felt relieved. And she was also relieved Izumi had been ascended to a status where it was hard for Fina to lay a hand on her.

The last one was a report from Rudel, but it was more accurate to call that one a letter. It was a warning that cautioned her on unreasonably securing funding.

"Uuuurrgh, my fluff fluff land..."

"... That wasn't a joke?"

"No, once I got permission, I planned to actualize it. But if master's opposed..."

Pledging Rudel her heartfelt gratitude, Sophina took hold of Fina's response letter to Rudel. There, she informed Fina of the rumor she heard around the

palace. For these sorts of things, Fina would listen to it as a single source of information.

"Come to think of it, have you heard the rumors surrounding Rudel-dono? It seems that ever since that display at the castle, he's being called demon lord more than white knight."

As Sophina gave a bitter smile, Fina expressionlessly cleaned up her desktop before getting back to work. She was listening, but she didn't stop her hands from moving.

Sophina swallowed down her true desires for her master to use her needlessly high processing power a bit more for the country's sake.

"Demon lord, eh."

"I was surprised at the display, and the palace is still busy with it. It seems they're going to leave him with the dragoon brigade as before, but the royal guard aren't staying silent about that."

"It would be crazier to leave him with a captain whose job it is to drink tea. Well, I'm sure my sister is making a ruckus, but... are there any movements?"

Sophina's eyes turned serious. She pushed up her glasses with the index finger of her right hand, letting them catch the light.

"This isn't confirmed, but it seems there's a faction approaching Aileen-sama. The bats from around the border."

"... Do you mean to say the traitors? Well, they're in a painful position out there, after all. I don't think it's strange for them to want to have personal connections with the empire."

"Aileen-sama's zeal for the royal guard captain's become a rumor around the palace as of late. Perhaps they think she'll be easy to use."

Sophina gathered information from her colleagues in the palace. The high knights were losing their power, but that wasn't the full extent of Sophina's

connection. She also had her fellow marriage interview comrades.

While it didn't make her happy at all, Sophina's continued failure made every look at her with gentle eyes.

The faction she called cats were the nobles who held territory around the border. Neighboring an enemy country, the skirmishes were unbearable. But among them were some who would form personal connections with the empire to contain their casualties. To Sophina, they looked like traitors.

"There are sparks smoldering all over the place, and it won't be strange if the whole thing is set alight at any second."

"Should we move as well?"

"... No, let's wait for now. When the time comes, I'll put them to work whether they like it or not. Right, when the time comes."

Sophina turned to her master cleaning up the paperwork and after giving a tidy bow, she left the room.

Chapter 113

This is a tale of how the girl who once carried a great knight on her back, Mystith, ran about to prepare for an unveiling display.



The clock turns back to when Sakuya defeated the former boss of the dragon stables (Bram).

Having returned to her den, Mystith asked all the dragons of her lake about flight formations. But a dragon who had done flight formations didn't exist in Mystith's turf.

Before her promise to Rudel came into question, she wanted to do something for Sakuya's sake, she wanted to give her the best flight formation there could be.

'Even so, this is a bother. Even if you tell me flying in formation, just what am I supposed to do... they didn't used to have anything like that! But I'm sure Marty would be happy to see.'

She recalled the first human to ever make a contract with her, gallantly holding a spear in his hand. Even now, his form existed in her heart.

'And now that I've made a promise with that kid, I have to do something to make it a reality. If I can't find an answer in my turf, I just have to take the other turfs.'

Taking off from the lake she lived in, she looked at the mountain she could see in the distance. It was a volcano, still very much active, but there were dragons who lived there as well.

The ones who lived there were red dragons. Among the dragon species, they were the ones who boasted the fiercest temperaments.

'Alright! Let's start off with the easiest place.'

The small dragons of the lake saw Mystith off with a wave of their forelimbs.



The red dragons lived in a cave, scorching hot from the lava that flowed through it.

The fact the volcano didn't erupt was related to the fact the red dragons lived in it.

Appearing in such a place alone, Mystith called out to a young red dragon stationed on watch at the entrance.

'Oy, go get your boss.'

'Ah? What are you talking about, old haGGGYAAAAHHH!'

Punching down the youth with such a rude mouth, she walked right into the cave. She pressed on, blowing away the red dragons she occasionally encountered with her fists.

The boss' room was extremely vast. Lava welled up in the deepest chamber of the cave, and there lay a conspicuously large dragon who looked to be the boss. Around, the other dragons stood on their guard, presumably to protect him.

'Who dares come before me?'

Letting out a voice of dignity, the red dragon boss looked at Mystith. But Mystith informed him without faltering.

'Oy, who do you think you're taking that attitude in front of?'

'Ah, sorry, ma'am!'

The red dragon boss stood, quickly approaching Mystith. Curling his large body, he revised his attitude. The surrounding red dragons were shocked at their boss' sudden change.

'I told the young'un at the entrance to go get you, but you weren't coming so I came to see you myself.'

'My deepest apologies! I'll discipline him later.'

'No honestly, I couldn't care less. More importantly, from today onwards, I'm going to rule this place.'

'Eh? Eh! No, that would be quite troubling, or what's the word...'

Seeing the boss show weakness, a single young dragon stepped up front. Irritated at the boss' timid form, he tried to show that he was the one worthy of being boss.

'hmm, I don't know who on earth you think you are, but I'm different from that cowardly mess. I'll make a bloodbath of you, and from today onwards, the boss will be fGYAAAAHH!'

Swinging her tail and sending that young dragon flying with a single attack, Mystith continued her conversation with the boss. Seeing a powerful dragon taken out in a single blow, the surrounding dragons fell silent.

'So? What's your response?'

'... I graciously accept your rule.'

'Thank you kindly, I knew you were the one to ask. I'll be off to the north for a bit, so follow my lead.'

'Yes ma'am!'



It was a place inhabited by hordes of wind dragons.

A place with nothing but rocky crags, and a place where the wind was strong. The wind dragons governed the wind, and by their influence, a strong wind would constantly blow through. Well, not that Mystith cared about that.

Alongside the red dragon, she had come to defeat the area's boss. If her memory served her right, this was supposed to be a vast territory.

'Come to think of it, I don't know the boss here.'

'Yeah, it's aa young wind dragon. He's a bit impertinent, but before your charm, he'll be begging for mercy!'

While the red dragon was playing up to Mystith, he was once a boss with dignity. In the past, he had challenged Mystith to a match, and in the past, he had been beaten until his heart folded in. There was no way he could go against her.

According to him, the boss of this area was a young one who had risen to power in recent years.

'... Hey, what makes him think he can become boss without paying me his respects?'

'For real!? To think he never dropped by, he must be quite the trash-tier dragon!'

The two went out to face the wind dragon; fitting of his youth, their foe was brimming with ambition. From high up, he looked down over Mystith.

'Oy, oy, what business do the elderly have with me?'

The dragon who called them elderly chuckled to himself.

'Hey, is that guy the boss? He reeks of small fry.'

'It's that, you know. The last boss retired and all the influential ones went off to contract with humans, so he became boss by default.'

The two of them looked at the wind dragons, directing eyes of pity. He hadn't the dignity of the boss, and those around him didn't seem to respect him as one.

Mystith challenged that wind dragon to a fight.

'You look real silly up there. Get down here and fight me. From today onwards, this territory will be under my command.'

'Hmph! Putting on airs ay your age... then try to keep up with me!'

The wind dragon leapt into the sky, parting from the two dragons at a rapid pace. Mystith looked on the scene with fed-up eyes.

'Huh? I told him to come at me, didn't I?'

'He ran away.'

'Then there's no helping it. If he wants to play tag, then why don't we keep him company.'

Mystith's open mouth drew an arc as if she was smiling, her eyes sharpened. The red dragon was shaking, perhaps recalling the time his heart was crushed.

Mystith lifted herself into the air and chased right after the wind dragon. A few hour later, she returned, a wind dragon crying and apologizing under her arm.



'Next is aunty's place.'

'Ah, the gaia aunty.'

As he consoled the wind dragon, the red dragon nodded at Mystith's next objective. When it came to the remaining influential bosses, only a long lived gaia dragon female remained.

'I'm no good with her. No, I don't hate her, but...'

Even Mystith was weak to aunty. She had known her from a young age, and in her rebellious phase, Mystith had caused her quite a bit of trouble. She couldn't look her in the eye.

'More importantly, why are you suddenly expanding your territory? Up to now, you always said you weren't interested, right?'

On the red dragon's question, Mystith explained about Sakuya. About how she looked after her like a daughter, and about the flight formation she was misunderstanding.

'Flying in formation, is it? I've never done it before. You?'

"Me neither... hic."

'I don't have any kids who've contracted at my place. But I made a promise, so I've expanded my territory to find someone who knows about it.'

'... For reals?' 'Don't expand your territory for something like that.'

As the two dragons made difficult expressions, Mystith headed off for the gaia dragon.

In a space with a number of caverns, the trees didn't grow, but the grass and wildflowers decorated the landscape in shades of green. Where the gaia dragons lived, the large trees would all be mowed down. But as they were a race that governed the dirt, the soil was rich in nutrition. Approaching the largest cave, Mystith hit against the wall as if to knock.

There, a giant gaia dragon popped out her head. Her form as she slowly stuck out just her head reminded them of a turtle sticking its head out its carapace.

'Now here's a rare visitor. I'm glad you look well, little lady.'

'Hey! Quit it with the little lady stuff, aunty. Anyways, I came because I wanted your territory.'

While she took a clearly rude attitude, the gaia dragon didn't seem to be particularly bothered. She even looked just a little happy.

'You're finally up to ruling? Then do what you will. More importantly, are you still stuck up over that human? I hear you haven't laid an egg ever since back then. You're already at a good age, so why don't you find someone new?'

'Aunty! You promised not to talk about that!'

On the negotiations between Mystith and the gaia dragon, the remaining two could only listen in, their mouths hung open in disbelief. There was someone even the savage Mystith couldn't win against.

'Well whatever. So with this, we have the main faces together. Now all that's left is to get those folks with their own small territories to obey.'

'We're still doing this?' 'Just how greedy are you?' 'You're going to rule over the other territories too?'

'If we challenge them with these members, we'll be fine. Let's do our best for the sake of flight formations.'

And like that, Mystith came to rule the dragon dwellings as queen.



For the sake of flying in formation, the dragons began their training.

From the words of the dragons who had participated in it before, they reached the conclusion that, for now, they just had to put on a good show in the air.

So Mystith did precisely that.

'Hey, you red dragons can exude fire from yoru bodies, right?'

'Yes ma'am! We sure can.'

The red dragon who was once a boss showed her how he coated his body in fire. That form was practically that of a dragon made of flames, sinister, yet be that as it may, strong and beautiful.

But...

'Lacking.'

'Eh?'

Mystith didn't feel it was enough.

'Blaze up some more! That'll just look shoddy if they're looking from the ground! Okay, try again.'

'... For real? This is quite tiring, you know?'

Next was the wind dragon.

Specializing in aerial movement from the start, they showed a high-level flight formation in the air. But Mystith wasn't satisfied.

'It feels a bit lacking.'

'We can't go any faster than that, boss.'

To the wind dragon who had gone docile, Mystith pushed an unreasonable demand.

'The red dragons will be making rings of fire in the air, so you guys will be passing through them.'

'Eh!?'

'Ah! And you guys could call down thunderstorms, right?'

'No, that one is a real pain, and it's not thunderstorms, we control the wind to gather clouds and...'

'Do I look like I care? Just prepare some nice-looking clouds for the day in question.'

Faced with Mystith's glare, the wind dragon averted his eyes and nodded.

'I-I'll do my best.'

Following on was the gaia dragon.

Gaia dragons were no good in the air. But if all they had to do was stand out, the kind aunty gathered up her brethren and had large rocks float in the air. Those rocks given lift through magic looked almost as if they were floating islands in the sky.

'Aunty, that's amazing!'

'Well, this is about all I can do. If we practice a bit more, we should be able to send even larger rocks flying.'

'And my folks will have water floating next to it, so do you think we're getting a little closer to a flight formation?'

'Who knows? We're dim when it comes to humans. Even for the dragons that have contracted, it seems the knowledge they possess is much too old by human standards.'

A dragon and human's perceptions of time were exceedingly divided. For one who lived in ten-year increments, a life form that lived hundreds, thousands of years held a completely different set of values.

'For now, we still have some time, so we should be fine if we keep practicing.'

Mystith said that, looking satisfied at the practicing dragons, when the small dragon children started imitating what they saw. Making rings of water, they leapt into those rings and played by breaking the rings of others.

'... There it is. That's it! That's what we were lacking!'

'What's up, boss?'

'We just have to fly out of explosions!'

By Mystith's plan, the red dragons would set off large explosions, and the wind dragons would swoop through them, avoiding at the nick of time.

They were all dragons. Something of that level should be fine. But while they could do it, it was quite a difficult thing indeed.

'Give us a break already!'

In the dragon dwellings, the screams of a wind dragon rang out.



And the dragons prepared. Only a few days remained until the unveiling.

Mystith took along the representative dragons and headed off for Rudel.

"Mystith-sama! And three splendid dragons to boot... I'm moved to tears!"

Mystith wasn't at all displeased with Rudel's delight.

'Hm, as promised, we've taken flight formation and made it our own. I'm sure the humans on the barren soil will shed their pluck and run for the hills.'

Before Mystith's full confidence and the wild dragons of all varieties, a delighted Rudel relayed the message. It was a little difficult for him to say, but it was an important thing.

"I'm really sorry. I've been banned from aerial maneuvers during the flight formation. Sakuya can only fly out and descend into the palace plaza. If you're flying with us, they probably won't let you do aerial maneuvers."

'... Eh? Is that true? How unfortunate, we put quite a bit into it.'

Mystith was a bit disappointed. Similarly, the gaia dragon called aunty also muttered, 'A shame'.

In that space, Rudel looked up at the gaia dragon in delight.

... But there were two who weren't as satisfied.

'When we worked so hard... goddammit.'

The red dragon rolled up into a ball and sulked. In contrast, the wind dragon...

'Just where am I supposed to direct this anger of mine?'

He was seriously crying.



And just like that, unbeknownst to man, Mystith's flight formation (pervert flight) was sealed.

Chapter 114

The unveiling display over, the new knight recruits were officially recognized by the knight brigades they were enlisted in.

Even if they had left the academy, the work environment wasn't kind enough to fully recognize new hires. That held the same for knights who had piled up experience. The knights who were stationed to elite units had to train themselves up from square one once more.

From brigade to brigade, the necessary skills differed.

As a dragoon, Rudel had to learn how to handle a dragon. There were some things he could never obtain from Mystith's partial wisdom. No, perhaps it was more accurate to say what she couldn't teach him was the majority.

A man specialized in techniques no longer necessary in the modern era, that was the dragoon called Rudel.

But Rudel had the fundamental techniques pounded into him by his superior officers, and now he stood in the training ground, before the captain and vice-captain of the brigade

Around, the term's newbies and a few veterans took part.

Before the new recruits, Oldart mixed in some jokes with his usual smile as he explained.

"I see you're making some nice faces. With this, you're a member of our oddball squad. But this charmer in his prime is a separate story, so don't group us together!"

"... Oldart, no one cares, just get on with it."

Alejandro's forehead twitched at his captain's joke as he offered some words of caution. Rudel and the other recruits had already been informed what they had been called for.

One on one battle with a veteran dragoon.

This was largely to have the recruits feel upfront what their current selves were lacking. What's more, the veterans who kept close to the king consisted of nothing but competent ones.

Those newbies would suddenly be put against those with top-class abilities.

"This is why people who don't get jokes are... well then, we'll go ahead and announce your opponents! But first off, Rudel!"

"Yes sir!"

As Rudel replied, taking one step forward, Oldart continued on with an unpleasant look on his face.

"I really, really can't stand it, but your opponent is me. I don't want to fight that giant girly and a battle junky like you, but this is part of my job description, so I'll reluctantly take it on. Follow me! ... Everyone else, confirm your opponents with the vice-captain."

Ordering Rudel to follow, Oldart walked out of the training grounds.

Chasing after his back, Rudel started to question it, and seeing his expression, Oldart breathed out a sigh.

"Why am I the only one fighting in a separate place? That's the face you're making. Listen here, you and your girly are special, so we'll fight in a place where the collateral damage doesn't matter."

"Is that true? Then I can fight seriously without paying mind to my surround—" "Idiot! Are you trying to kill me!?"

Seeing Oldart seriously reluctant, Rudel made a regretful face. He had been given the chance to fight the active captain of the dragoon knight brigade.

Surely Rudel wanted to have a serious match.

"I'm already at that age. If I was just a little younger, I'd be able to give it my all."

"That's unfortunate. I wanted to fight a serious captain."

"... Why do you look so disappointed? It's that, you know. In my golden days, I really was amazing, you hear. I was ridiculously strong; around the time I first enlisted, my superior told me I'd be the next captain. Even if I can't go all out, I'm not going to lose to you."

"Is that true?"

"No doubt about it. You really should be thankful I'm a charmer in his prime. If I was a little younger, in my energetic, popular days, I'd be sending you right to the hospital."

"I'm already used to be carted off to hospital rooms, so I'll be fine!"

"... T-that so."

Rudel took his lie as fact, but if he was chosen as next chief when he enlisted, then Oldart would have to have been appointed captain much, much earlier.

"Hey, I might joke around a bit, but you really are easy to fool. You should learn to doubt others."

"About what?"

"Look! Like if I was selected as the next captain, then the previous captain must have been in service for a long, LONG time! I'm waiting for you to say something out. It's an obvious lie!"

"Lie... so you were deceiving me!"

"You're late to the party! Ah, I don't like this guy."

In that case, perhaps his strength is also a lie, Rudel began to doubt. You couldn't say Oldart was high in stature. And rather than Alejandro, who gave off the air of a seasoned warrior at a glance, his face was well in order, and he was usually joking around.

The captain was required to be apt in negotiations with the higher-ups and to have an affinity for paperwork. For that sake, there were rumors that he might fall short in ability, that the vice-captain was the real power behind the organization, and the captain was to be a dragoon skilled in governmental affairs.

Considering that possibility, Rudel felt he would have preferred to fight the vice-captain.



A few hours later, Rudel was being chased by Oldart over the backwoods distanced from human habitation.

"Hey, what's wrong."

Straddling his grey dragon, even in aerial combat, Oldart gave off an air of leisure. The giant Sakuya was unaccustomed to flying. If she was on the run, she'd be easily caught up to.

"Kuh!"

Turning towards Oldart and his dragon approaching close behind, Rudel stuck out his left hand and produced his shields of light. Their numbers climbed to several dozens, impeding Oldart's path.

But that didn't change the speed he gave chase.

He followed, avoiding them as if it were only natural. The shields in his way were destroyed by a small consecutive firing of his dragon's breath. He closed in using only the minimum necessary movements.

"Those are some convenient shields, but humans aside... they're less than paper before a dragon. And that's no good. You've taken your mind off your dragon. The way you're going..."

Cautioned by Oldart, Rudel noticed and shouted orders to Sakuya.

"Sakuya, ascend!"

'Wowowhoah, I-I can't!'

Rudel had been too mindful of his rear, and through the link that connected their minds, Sakuya had grown negligent of what was in front of her as well. By Rudel's mind being too taken by the rear, Sakuya had been unable to discern where her own consciousness was directed.

As a result, Sakuya was just about to collide with the slope of a mountain. Noticing just in the nick of time, she got off with just her scales scraped along the mountain crags, but because of that, Sakuya's speed had fallen as she swayed unsteadily in the air.

Before Rudel and Sakuya full of openings, Oldart went on the defense.

"No good. No good at all."

Flying as if to draw a circle with Sakuya at the center, Oldart's dragon finely tuned its altitude as if made sport of Rudel and Sakuya.

"Sakuya, steady and brace yourself. You can brush off a few attacks, right?"

'Yeah!'

The two had decided to wait for Oldart's dragon to make a move, but unlike his past fight with Enora, this felt faster. They were surely going slower than a wind dragon, and in truth, the captain's dragon boasted relatively average abilities as a gray dragon.

But ever since the fight with Oldart began, Rudel had been unable to go on the defense.

(He isn't fast. This person... the captain is skillful.)

While Rudel prepared all the techniques he had to cope with the onslaught, Oldart showed a smile from atop his dragon.

"No good. The way you're going, I can't even give you a fifty."

Evaluating Rudel's actions, Oldart issued orders for his dragon to begin its attacks. All the attacks that hit Sakuya were low in output, but they were pinpointed at her vitals.

Unable to properly beat her wings, her stance was easily crumbled.

As Sakuya fell, squirming through the air, Rudel leapt down. There, Oldart descended with his dragon.

While the match had been settled, it seems they were going to continue. But it wasn't dragon on dragon. This would be a land battle between Rudel and Oldart.

"Back there, you should've used the mountain to protect your rear. And the narrowness of your field of vision when you're being chased... looks like you're not ready for real battle yet."

Oldart laughed as he pulled the sword at his waist, so Rudel pulled his blade as well. Both of them had been wearing the robes of the dragoon brigade, but thinking it would be a hindrance, Rudel threw his robe down.

"Let's go."

Watched over by Sakuya, dizzy from her fall, Rudel challenged the captain to a match. He swiftly circled around to the captain's back, but perhaps his movements had been read, as Oldart lightly stepped to the side to dodge him.

"Your emergency stops are still unpolished. When you get used to it, they're too easy to deal with. Well, I guess this is what you can expect from a student's level."

Catching Rudel's sword with the one handed sword in his right hand, he instantly stepped in to seal off his movements. From his left hand concealed in his robe, he thrust out a dagger, stopping it just short of Rudel's throat.

"I-I admit defeat."

Rudel, who had been a bit in doubt over his opponent's abilities, shed a cold sweat as he looked at the laughing captain.

"Oy, oy, don't look at me like that. You're making me blush."

"Honestly, I never thought you'd be this strong. As a member of the brigade, I deeply apologize for doubting my captain."

"Uwah... he ignores my jokes and hits in with pure honesty. That's the sort of thing you're not supposed to say even if you think it. A charmer in his prime is weak to stabs at the heart, you should treat him with care."

The two of them conversed as they sheathed their swords, and even now Oldart looked full of openings. Rudel still seemed perplexed over his own loss, so Oldart took a seat on a rock that went about up to his knees. Stroking his chin, he began answering what Rudel was probably questioning.

"Now then, about your evaluation... to be totally honest, spec-wise, it would be easier to count your ranking in the dragoon brigade starting from the top. You've surpassed me as well."

As Rudel corrected his posture where he stood, Oldart told him to take a seat as well before continuing on. In order to find out what he was lacking, Rudel was directing him with serious eyes.

"However! ... Your performance is lower-middle class, at best. Do you know the reason?"

"No idea!"

On Rudel's words without any fabrication, Oldart nodded.

"Alright! I want to caution you on not giving it any thought, but I'm sure you'd have done better if you already knew. Why don't you try thinking over it yourself fo... no, wait, you really should stop using your head after all."

Covering his face with his right hand, Oldart breathed a sigh as he informed Rudel of what he was lacking.

"It's simply that your combat techniques are shoddy. And your field of vision is too narrow. Those two points. You were so focused on yourself you hadn't the mind to spare for your little girly. While you'd usually be fine, when backed into a corner, the cracks start to spread. You instantly try to do something about it yourself and fail as a result."

Oldart used the shields of light he put up to impede his path as an example. Those were pretty much useless before a dragon. If he wanted to, he could have rammed straight through them and proceeded on.

And it wasn't as if everything ranked lower than taking on dragoons. If he took on troublesome monsters, then there were enemies who were fearsome in their pure bulk.

"You've no leisure in battle. Sure enough, the girly has plenty of things she's no good at, but if a mid-tier dragoon was controlling her, I'd have no choice but to change my approach. That's just how powerful that girl's weapons are. You should trust in your partner a bit more."

'... Rudel, Sakuya is working hard too.'

Seeing Sakuya worry for him, Rudel recalled he had definitely tried to do it all on his own.

Oldart informed, not using the terrain, and having Sakuya, who wasn't good at flying, be on the run was a mistake. Rudel nodded as he listened to those words.

"For your field of vision, just try to have a bit more leisure. There's no point in panicking. There's a possibility you might mistake your decisions. Look

around a bit more, and think of the power difference between you and your foe."

Unlike his usual attitude, Oldart was saying some earnest things, and to Rudel, he looked like a true charmer in his prime.

Patting off his robe as he stood, while it was still early, Oldart proposed for them to return.

"Now then, let's end the lecture there and go back. It's been a while since I last trained, and my hip is..." "Please fight me again!"

"... Eh?"

When Rudel pleaded for another fight, Oldart's face stiffened.

"I understand that I have things I am lacking. But rather than understanding it in my head, I think it would be better for my body to remember it. If I fight you again, I'm sure I can climb to greater..."

"Ah~, no, I really am tired, or rather... eh? You're serious?"

"Yes!"

'Sakuya will do her best too!'

Having recovered, Sakuya stood and roared to answer Rudel's expectations. Oldart and his partner gray dragon were making truly reluctant faces.

It had already grown dark when an exhausted Oldart returned to the training ground, leading along a tattered Sakuya and Rudel.



Having been informed by the veterans on their areas to work on, the new dragoon recruits were conversing over the stations they would be appointed to the following day.

They were comrades who had trained together, and while their ages differed, they spoke with the smiles of colleagues.

"Saas, you were stationed in the trade city?"

On Luxheidt's question, Saas nodded cynically.

"I've no complaints I was stationed at such an important point. Besides the fact my job's mainly hauling cargo."

Dragons were able to fly through the sky, and due to their high maintenance cost, they would have to take on jobs like these. The more were sent to the outskirts, the more terrible their financial circumstances became.

It was laughed that the reason dragoons were stationed in trade cities with plenty of people and adventurers was to scrape together spare change. But it was also true there was no safer transport of goods than by dragon.

"It's us dragoons' greatest worry, after all. By the way, Enora is... from how depressed she looks, I doubt it's the outskirts."

Everyong looked at Enora, who had grown dark, before shifting their gaze towards Rudel, who rejoiced over being sent to the far off reaches of the kingdom. While it was all and well for him, Luxheidt knew Enora had proposed she would follow Rudel.

(So her old man declined.)

"I'm going to be stationed right in the capital... hah."

By the problems Enora had caused, at this point, it seemed her relationship with her father had improved a bit. But even so, Enora's trip to the outskirts wasn't granted.

With a wild dragon obeying her, Enora was a valuable addition to the dragoon brigade. Thinking of her future, they wanted to nurture her in the capital with care.

And yet, Rudel was making a perplexed face.

"Enora, you don't like your station? Well, there will be a transfer in a few years, so just place your hopes on the next one."

It was natural if they hadn't gotten the positions they wanted, but with the man in question not noticing the underlying problem, the air grew awkward. Those around looked at Luxheidt, so he shrugged and sent out a lifeboat.

"But Enora, you have it hard, making a contract with a wind dragon. You'll be flying all over the place, carrying messages and doing urgent missions... you might have to send some messages to the outskirts as well."

But Enora didn't perk up. Her main problem was the new position that had been created. From the high knight brigade on the verge of dismantlement, an officer had been sent to keep watch over Rudel. She would follow Rudel to the outskirts. What's more, she was a classmate, a girl who got along well with him at the academy.

It would be stranger if no problems occurred.

"Right, I might go from time to time. But if the two who are always together become lovers... I don't think I'll be able to recover."

(This girl is a pain. Well, she's easier to talk to than before, but the gap with her appearance is amazing.)

While she gave off an air as if she might play around, Enora's wholeheartedness left her surroundings perplexed.

"So Rudel, where exactly on the outskirts are you headed?"

Giving up on cheering Enora up, Luxheidt slapped the question into the person he was most curious about. The only one he was interested was Rudel, who had determined to be interesting.

"It's a recently set up post. They started constructing a port there a few years ago... The town's called Beretta."

"Beretta, eh... as I recall, the place is dangerous, so they have other dragoons dispatched as well. It's a port town, so two water dragons, and one

gray dragon."

Rudel looked through the documents on his new workstation and offered a correction to Luxheidt's explanation.

"No, since I'm being stationed, one of them's being taken off. It's just two water dragons now."

The area's development wasn't getting anywhere, so to put it all in order, the kingdom had invested its valuable water dragons into it.

Luxheidt thought the empire's current state of affairs was dangerous. The information coming in was scarce, but still, he felt a sense of danger.

However...

(Is being stationed in a place like that a condition to be a hero?)

While he felt sorry for him, he also found Rudel's deployment to be interesting.

"They say it's a pretty place, so if I ever get a day off, I might go and see."

As Saas called over, Rudel rejoiced and said he would show him around at that time. Luxheidt tactfully turned that talk towards Enora, giving her a chance to go to the outskirts to see Rudel.

Seeing Enora's delight, Luxheidt thought.

(She really is easy to please.)

Chapter 115

"I'm sorry, you even carried my luggage."

High in the sky, Izumi rode aboard Sakuya's back, calling out to Rudel's back.

They were on the way to Beretta, in the outer reaches of the kingdom, and Izumi was accompanying Rudel to his station as a special inspector.

"Don't worry about it. A weight increase of this extent is meaningless to Sakuya."

'I-it's easy.'

Izumi's heart ached, seeing Sakuya let out a considerably pained voice. As a subspecies of gaia dragon, Sakuya had a merit of being able to carry large loads of cargo. Even a normal gaia dragon's loading capacity was incomparable to the other dragons.

For that reason, when they flew from the capital, they were ordered to take a large load of supplies with them.

They were headed to a land that had only begun to be set up, and the town's present state was one where more goods were insufficient than not.

A blue sky spread far and wide to bless their departure, but Sakuya was pained by the luggage fastened onto her. They had to put in a number of breaks on the way, and Izumi wondered whether the load was simply too great.

(A number of custom tailored bags on her back, two shoulder bags per side... those bags look custom made as well...)

By the way, Izumi and Rudel's personal bags were strapped to her neck. It was pitiful to look at her, but Rudel was constantly calling out to Sakuya.

"Do you want to rest, Sakuya?"

'S-still fine.'

"Don't force yourself. We still have time before I take up my post, so you can take it easy."

'Sakuya will do her best.'

Watching Sakuya desperately move her wings, Izumi stroked her back.

"..... I apologize for ruining the mood, but I'm here too."

Izumi and Rudel turned to find Millia sitting with an irritated look on her face. Right, Millia had been scouted into becoming Izumi's subordinate.

From the start, it was impossible for one person to fulfill the inspector role, and she had to choose someone. So Izumi had called out to all her acquaintances. But once they learned the job was keeping watch over Rudel, her friend and acquaintances all declined.

(No, I know the real reason, but...)

What's more, they were declining out of good will. In order to leave Izumi alone with Rudel, they had acted out of virtuous intent.

Only one...

Only Aleist volunteered and pleaded to be her subordinate. That was probably because of Millia.

(We're really not like that.)

Breathing a sigh, Izumi felt a little worried that the subordinate she finally managed to obtain was Millia. While she thought she would decline, Millia

promptly accepted the position. While Izumi knew she hadn't given up on Rudel, it wasn't her place to caution her on that matter.

(I hope nothing goes wrong... no, I guess that's not happening.)

Aleist already wanted to run away from the palace... she recalled his face when his subordinates, the female knights, forcefully dragged him back.

Whether he wanted to become a special inspector because he hated cleaning duty, or if he wanted to chase after Millia. Izumi noticed he was acting on both reasons.

(That Aleist is definitely causing a problem.)

"Do your best! Do your best, Sakuya!"

'Aaaah! My wing is cramping!'

In contrast, this side was somewhat heartwarming, thought Izumi. Even when there was a woman behind them who followed through conflicted emotions, Rudel and Sakuya were the same as ever.

... Wing is cramping.

"Wait! That's bad, you should land at... nwaaaaaaaah!"

Izumi's cry resounded across the sky.



In the end, they arrived at port town Beretta the next day.

Arriving just barely in time, Rudel left the unloading of the luggage to Izumi, hurrying to the knight station alone.

Even if it was called a port town, it was originally a place without anything. Migrants who volunteered from the capital and major cities were working hard to establish a port.

In such a situation, it was impossible to prepare a station for each individual brigade. In that land where everything was held in insufficiency, defense was left to a platoon of knights from the outer reaches, and two dragoons.

Walking down the path lined with brick-lain houses, Rudel gazed at the mismatched townscape as he made for the station.

On top of the simple-made houses, the paths were exceedingly bad. The people he passed by were making somewhat enervated faces.

(Is the situation worse than I thought?)

Both the Kingdom of Courtois and the Gaia Empire were countries you could say were based around magic. That meant that if you used magic, the work that a single person could do grew immensely. The craftsmen all made use of some sort of magic, spreading its grace.

But at the same time, the cities that had existed for ages had their hands full with simply maintaining their side. Magic was convenient, cities would grow with ease. But thinking of maintaining them, each city had come to its limit.

It was for that purpose that new lands were being claimed, and a port town was set up to obtain marine products.

But from what Rudel could see, it didn't look like it was going so well. This wasn't simply due to the difficulty of land cultivation. While they could use magic, in the end, that was naught but the power of man. And this was a land that had been uninhabited to that point.

There were monsters that saw it as their home, and the mana reserves of the people would be chipped down in combat. Unlike the tempered knights, even if a layman could use magic, that had its limits. Despite that, if an enemy came out, they had no choice but to fight for their lives, and looking at the result, their plans weren't going through.

After arriving at the station, Rudel presented his identification papers to the soldier on watch.

It seems he was someone recruited on site, his service was sloppy.

"U-umm... You're a knight, are you? What business have you come for today?"

"I'm supposed to be stationed here, starting today. For now, could you let me meet the person in charge of the area's dragoons?"

"No, um..."

Rudel grew anxious over whether this nervous soldier would be alright, but from the back of the station, the soldier's superior came out. He was probably the leader of the knight platoon.

His body was on the plump side, but his eyes were considerably sharp.

"You didn't hear!? My apologies. Bennet is off overseeing construction at the harbor, so if you want to see her, you better head down there. Ah, and I'll take your paperwork."

"... Is that alright?"

Rudel had some resistance to handing his forms to a knight of a different jurisdiction.

But the other side laughed.

"Those sorts of regulations don't pass through over here. We're in charge of all paperwork."

Handing his forms to the knight giving a dry laugh, Rudel made for the harbor. Even without a guide, he decided he'd be able to speak as long as he went towards the spots under construction.

The town itself wasn't too big, and he wanted to get a good look over it.



"Master should have arrived around now."

Now a fifth year, Fina looked out the corridor as she muttered.

Her guard Sophina sought confirmation on the dragoon matter.

"This is just as you've planned, isn't it? Did you station those water dragons beforehand in preparation for this?"

Before it was decided Rudel would go to Beretta, Fina had shuffled around the jobs of two water dragons. Officially, it was for the sake of the settlement that wasn't growing as planned.

"Perish the thought. Even I can't read that far ahead. If I could, my Fluff-fluff Land would already be under construction... master, if only master would move according to my plans."

Only Sophina could understand she was truly vexed.

(If only she wasn't like this.)

"Well, I did change their positions, but if you ask how much meaning that action held..."

Fina had prepared numerous anti-empire measures, and the dragoon dispatchment changes was only one of them. She stationed the proficient ones close to the empire's border.

With no authority of her own, Fina could only use her father Albach. But even Sophina could keenly sense the weakening of Albach's political power.

When she wanted to prepare for the empire as soon as possible, Albach was unable to move. If Fina didn't move herself, it seems they wouldn't even get any decent information. The kingdom was done for, the fact she occasionally thought so was Sophina's secret.

"I was sure you simply intended to send a female knight of the wolf tribe over to Rudel."

The individual Sophina brought up in jest was a woman of the wolf tribe contracted to a water dragon, 'Bennet'. While there were numerous feline

demi-humans around Fina, there weren't any of the dog or wolf tribes. That's why Sophina said it as a joke.

Honestly, she never thought such a thing. It was certain that woman was a proficient dragon... however.

"O-of course not. There's no way that could be true. Now let us hurry to my next class."

"... Princess."

"What is it? Do you intent to make me late, Sophina?"

"Your next class is that way."

As Fina turned right at the T-shaped hallway, Sophina pointed towards the left passage. Expressionlessly and silently, Fina walked down the path Sophina instructed.

Confirming her surroundings, and seeing there was no one around, Sophina ordered her subordinates to fortify the area. Those female knights surrounded their guard target Fina.

And... Sophina grasped both Fina's shoulders to ask.

"So how is it really?"

"... Hmm, looks like I can't lie to you."

Giving up, Fina began reciting the truth. It was just as Sophina had considered as a joke.

"Female knights of the wolf tribe are exceedingly valuable. There are few to be found among all the knights of Courtois... without getting her in his hands, do you think master could ever become the king of fluff? No, that's impossible. In order to make my master the fluffmeister, Iiaaaaiaa!"

Around the end, Sophina started shaking Fina back and forth, her subordinates didn't stop her. What irritated her was largely Fina's use of the

term fluffmeister.

(This girl definitely thought it was clever the moment it came out of her mouth.)

Her glasses misaligned, her breaths short, Sophina shook Fina. It was a scene to make one's blood curdle.

"Do you think this is a fluffing joke!? The one who said we're in an important period was you, princess. Get a grip already!"

Once the shaking stopped, Fina remained expressionless, but to Sophina, it looked like her face was more prim than usual. When she thought she was going to make an excuse...

"You must change that way of thought, Sophina. It isn't that I am handing a fluffy to the fluffmeister, the fluffies are leaping into my master's hands. I never really thought he would be going to the wolf tribe's place, but this must be fate. Fluffadise is telling my master to become the fluffmeisterEEEEEEer!"

Sophina shook her back and forth once more, she continued shaking her until just before class was to begin.



Meanwhile, the teachers who surrounded the headmaster in the staffroom held bouquets of flowers in their hands as they directed smiles.

"Put a stop to it, people! What you are trying to do is a violation of school regulation!"

But only for the headmaster putting up resistance, his face was pale as he refused their proposal. Of course he would, the banner draped over the staffroom read:

'Congratulations on Your Third Term as Headmaster'

Normally, headmasters would swap out after two terms, at longest. And yet, his surroundings were informing him his third one was set in stone. The headmaster couldn't understand.

(Why? They were normal up to yesterday, were they not! I was already preparing to pass it on!)

He recalled his preparations to hand over the role, the preparations he had carried out thinking these would be his final days. By the graduation of the generation of super problem children, he had returned to those nostalgic school days of times passed.

A minor problem was the fact Fina was a surprising problem child herself. In the dead of the night, she would let out strange sounds as she did paperwork, and she would skip class to wander outside the academy. Apart from that, it was the same as before... no, thinking of how there were fewer intruders in the girls' dorm, it could even be said it was more decent than before.

And yet...

"Hahaha, what might you be talking about, headmaster! There is no such regulation in the academy." "All our staff have been deeply moved, working under such a wonderful headmaster." "It was a unanimous decision."

While everyone was laughing, their eyes were not.

"There's such a thing as a tacit agreement! And I told you I was ready to retire! (These guys are lying. Why. What exactly happened to them!?)"

The headmaster looked at his aid, the deputy headmaster. The man was at an age where, if he didn't become the next headmaster, he wouldn't have another chance. The headmaster knew, when his own second term was decided, the man had been quite vexed. But now, "I'll do my best to support you," he muttered with a smile.

"... Did something happen?"

The headmaster looked at a weak-willed teacher. That teacher had caused a problem before, and he had stuck up for her. So he knew she wouldn't lie to him.

As the surroundings returned to silence, the truth the headmaster's stare drew from that teacher was a dreadful one indeed.

"T-the list of next year's freshmen has come in."

"I'm sure it has. For young nobles, they get their enrollment forms done nice and early. It shouldn't be a problem for it to finish up around this...! It couldn't be."

"My deepest apologies! I... I saw it. Rudel-dono's sister of another mother, I saw the devil... I saw the Rudel-dono in her!"

The staff members spoke of their memories from when Lena once came to the academy. The form of a brother doting on his sister was heartwarming, but the problem lay in her statements.

'I want to fight Euni-san.' 'The academy is a place to pick fights.' 'Do you think I'll be able to destroy a facility too?'

The teachers' dramatized memories spread along with her finalized enrolment. The appearance of Rudel-female-version had brought a complete change to the peaceful staff room.

As a result of the urgent discussion that followed, talks came to the idea the headmaster would do something about it. It was a result of the headmaster's ability to handle things needlessly well.

"Ah, it's impossible for me," The deputy headmaster went as far as to say, refusing the headmaster seat in its early stages.

"D-don't mess around with me, people. No matter how you look at it, you shouldn't put your guard up before you even meet her. She might actually be an honest and good kid."

"Even if she's an honest and good kid, I don't want another problem child. And I could tell! That child gave off the same feeling as Rudel-dono and the others."

Everyone nodded.

Driven to the brink, the headmaster looked at the papers spread across his desk. There was a document permitting his continued service; it had already received the palace's seal, and all he had to do was sign.

"Calm down! First, let's sit down and talk!"

"We've received the palace's approval. All that's left is your decision. Our will is unchanging!"

A few hours later, an exhausted headmaster signed the forms. In that staff room where he was the only dark face, the other staff members rejoiced and blessed him.

In the academy, Fina's graduation and Lena's enrollment were drawing close.

Chapter 116

At the port of Beretta stood a woman loosely wearing the knight clothing of a dragoon.

Issuing orders to her water dragon, she was having it carry construction materials.

The female knight's gray hair was conspicuous, but more than that, her standing form was dignified. Her eyes were sharp, and her gold pupils almost looked as if they were radiating light.

To add to that, the ears twitching atop her head were adorable. And as she stood a head lower than all the people working around her, dignified as she stood, she looked adorable herself. An additional problem lay in her tail. That thick, fluffy tail was swaying left and right. It was truly adorable.

Right... the female knight pretty much looked like a young child.

"Are you Major Bennet?"

Rudel had been informed of her appearance, so he was able to find her without hesitation. The documents spelled out that she was an adorable female knight.

"And you are?"

"Ma'am! Today forth, I have been stationed in this town, my name is Rudel Arses!"

Looking over Rudel, she walked up to him. While her air was imposing, the closer she got, the more Rudel had to tilt his head downwards to look at her.

"I've received the report. It seems you've perpetuated quite some foolishness at the capital. I was wondering what sort of face someone stupid enough to be suddenly flown off to the outskirts would have, but you're quite the looker... I hold a firm belief that my subordinates' failures are to be corrected by my fist. If you want to maintain that pretty face, then you'd best off not anger me."

With Bennet glaring at him, Rudel answered without fear. Confirming his salute, "At least your salute is first rate," she praised him.

For some reason, her tail was moving happily from left to right.

"While our mission here is important, more than that, you will learn to adapt to the environment. If the construction doesn't go anywhere, we will bring trouble to all the brigade members who sent us here. You dragon was a gaia, was it?"

"Yes ma'am! She's a gaia subspecies. Her name is Sakuya!"

Keeping a firm expression, Bennet hummed.

"I didn't ask for her name. But I'll commit it to memory. I'll have you lot carrying cargo... and so? Where are your inspectors?"

Looking at the Major and her wagging tail, Rudel explained that they were unfastening the cargo. As a new settlement, there were many materials and tools Beretta was lacking in. Being able to carry such a large load of goods, Sakuya was a valuable means of transportation.

"Put Sakuya on standby outside the town. Don't let her dig holes outside the designated spaces. For now, me and Elrond will be doing the work. I can't leave detailed work to your dragon."

After saying only that, she ordered him to return to the lodging house and rest for the day. Rudel recognized her as a captain who looked deeply into her subordinates.

(Looks like it's going to be rough, but I'm sure this person will be alright.)

He recalled how Luxheidt told him to pray he wasn't given a no-good superior. Even if they were strong as knights, there were plenty of dragoons who couldn't take command. It was a gathering of strong-willed knights. Rudel felt relieved his superior didn't seem to be the hopeless type.



Returning to her work, Bennet finished carrying materials before straddling her water dragon 'Heleene' to patrol the area.

Alone in the sky, she pressed her forehead to Heleene's back, shaking a little. Her tail was moving exceedingly violently.

'What's wrong, Bennet?'

"Listen to this! They finally sent me a decent subordinate! When everyone asks if I'm pushing myself, or tells me I'm cute, today's grunt was all prim and proper, he's the ideal subordinate!"

Unlike how she acted before Rudel, Bennet raised her face in delight. Short in stature and youthful in appearance, Bennet's greatest worry was being made light of by her men. In truth, they simply recognized her as a cute commanding officer, but the leader the girl idealized was an existence held in fear and awe by those under them.

And yet, when she did her best to become a commanding officer, no one feared her.

Let alone fear, she bit into the upper ranks of the dragoon brigade popularity contest and was treated as a mascot. While she was adored by her subordinates, she ended up giving off an unreliable impression. She thought that was why her subordinates never stayed long.

Truth be told, since she led along a valuable water dragon, she was issued a number of special missions, making it hard to affix set subordinates to her. While she knew about that, Bennet was sure it was because she was unreliable.

"Alright! I'll do my best tomorrow!"

'... That's all well and good, but you'd best not get too enthusiastic and fail. Around three times back, that made them call you hopelessly cute for a while, right?'

"T-that was just because I slipped up and broke a plate, but for some reason, they kept treating me like that all the way after..."

As Bennet failed to be honest, her tail powerlessly drooped limp over Heleene's back.

'B-but now I'm a splendid commanding officer! From tomorrow, I'll become his dignified commander!'

'Yeah, yeah.'

Feeling Heleene's disbelief, Bennet strengthened her own resolve to do her best.



Elsewhere, in the Arses House mansion, while it was a little early, a package came in from the Halbades House.

Erselica had the servants break the seal on those gifts sent to commemorate her matriculation and present them to her. The sent goods were high-class-looking tools that would be necessary at the academy.

"Luecke-dono of the Halbades House, was it? I heard he got along well with Rudel."

On her mutter, the surrounding servants seemed to have difficulty answering. Erselica was quite displeased with those servants' attitudes.

When her beloved Chlust was chased to the outskirts as if to drive him away, a majority of them had stopped speaking ill of Rudel in the shadows, turning their tongue to Chlust instead. A portion of them even started

coming out to say they thought Rudel-sama was the more worthy heir from the start.

Erseluca couldn't forgive those servants.

Many of the servants who looked after Erselica urged her to write letters to Rudel, and even if she wrote up a letter to Chlust, it wouldn't be sent.

(Will I be able to become a good actress for their comedy?)

Rudel- who she had mocked- was now so famous there wasn't a soul in Courtois who didn't know his name. On the streets, they were calling him the demon lord.

The Arses House that had oppressed such a man was now ruled by quite a dubious air. Within all of that, a package from the Halbades House had been delivered. The atmosphere of the mansion lightened up a bit.

"Oh! This one's for me."

As she untied the goods sent to her, before she noticed it, her stepsister Lena was there. That girl who usually wore around the clothing of a man, Erselica looked on her enviously. Honest to herself, and it looked as if she was living free as could be.

While they would never even talk in the past, at this point, they would exchange a few words if they met on the premises.

"You look happy. Even so, isn't that box a bit too big? What did you get?"

She folded her arms as she interrogated Lena. Lena tore off the wrapping and opened the wood crate to find a spear inside. For something sent to a lady, it was an item that made one question the sender's sense.

However...

"Whoooooh! A new spear! What's more, it's perfect for me!"

Handing the box off to the servants, Lena started swinging the spear she took in her hands. Erselica could feel the wind raised as she spun it around.

"L-Lena-sama! It would be troublesome if you swung that around in a place like this!"

Apologizing to the panicking servants, Lena looked at the spear. Erselica didn't have the skills to tell if a spear was good or not, but it looked to be better than the ones held by the soldiers protecting the mansion.

"To be so happy after receiving a weapon, what does that make you as a lady?"

"The one I've always used's been growing old, and it's short so this one is just right. I'm sure my brother had some input."

Saying Luecke-san was easy to understand, Lena read through the letter inside the box. The craftsmen who prepared the spear had a shop near the academy, so go there with it, the letter read.

(Are they going to fine tune it for Lena? This is surprisingly troublesome.)

To Erselica who had never held a weapon in her life, it was a talk that made her head hurt. To that point, she had polished herself to be beautiful. And that was in order to find a good family to marry into. But the Arses House had begun to wane even more than before.

When the surroundings would no longer draw close to her, it was decided Erselica would attend the academy. She was told to go and seduce a rich nobleman.

Otherwise, the house wouldn't hold up, her mother said.

(If you stopped wasting money, we would recover in no time.)

While she had much she wanted to say to her mother, she was still a daughter of the Arses House. Erselica had never even considered marrying someone she actually liked. No, she did her best not to think about it.

"You're going to the academy too, right? And yet, that Luecke-dono of the Halbades House is a little strange to send you a spear. Or could it be he thought that was more than enough for the child of a mistress?"

Even she knew she was saying something terrible. But Erselica wasn't skillful enough to suddenly change the attitude she had always taken towards another.

Stroking back her straight, blond hair, she focused her emerald eyes on Lena.

But Lena didn't seem particularly mindful of her cynicism.

"Perhaps. And brother told me that I can get all the necessary writing implements for cheap around the academy, so that's enough for me."

Seeing Lena's smile, Erselica felt she had lost again. These feelings had become a daily occurrence.

One of the servants cautioned her.

"Erselica-sama, Lena-sama is also the master's daughter. I'm not sure you should be taking that attitude..."

"You're right. I'm sorry, Lena (What's with this. You all used to mock her for being the child of a mistress.)"

Erselica understood the servants' true intent; they didn't want to invite in the rage of Rudel, who doted on Lena. For both Erselica and Lena who were to be married off, to the servants as well, they were tools to bring money into the Arses House.

If they were both tools, then offering favorable treatment to the one most liked by the next head was only natural. Just as Erselica once was...

(This really is miserable, Chlust.)



Arriving at the lodging house of Beretta, Rudel and co. were confused to find it wasn't a lodging house at all.

The young soldier who led them gave an explanation before Rudel, Izumi and Millia.

"My apologies. The construction isn't making any progress, so the buildings for the knight brigade end up being something like this..."

What stood before them was clearly a private house. The ones who used to live there moved to another house for various reasons, and it was abandoned as a vacant building. That house on the slightly larger side was granted when they heard three people were coming. For knights living alone, they would be given smaller houses.

".. I'm a man, and these are two ladies. Isn't there anything you could do?"

Rudel felt this was going too far, but the young soldier indirectly told them to deal with it. The nervous man would only say it was impossible.

"An official lodging house will only be prepared after the knight brigade main headquarters are constructed, so... and it's far from the houses of the other knights, so there shouldn't be a problem if you make a ruckus."

"That's nothing but problems. No, in the first place, why are you averting your eyes?"

After looking at Izumi and Millia, the young soldier's face turned red as he averted his eyes, Rudel thought the man was making some sort of misunderstanding and ordered him to look up so he could correct it.

But the day was reaching its end, and worn out from a long and tense voyage, Millia said the place would be fine.

"Even if we make a ruckus at this hour, I doubt anyone'll be able to solve the problem. In that case, we'll put up with it a few days. I want to sleep soon."

"You're right. Today was quite tiring."

It wasn't just riding by dragon back, on that trip that was almost like a constant roller coaster, the two women made bitter smiles through their pale faces.

Hearing that from the female came, Rudel reluctantly accepted. After accepting the keys, he entered the house. Finally, the young soldier said something important as he ran away.

"They said to clean it, but we've been busy and... the tools are there, so you're better off cleaning before you sleep. Then see you tomorrow."

"He fled."

Rudel stared over the room dumbfounded. Expanding before him was a room layered in dust. While it was minimalistically furnished, those pieces were also smeared in dust.

"T-this is a bit..."

The disastrous state of all the rooms left Izumi bewildered. It seems there had been an order to clean up, but if the order wasn't carried out, it was meaningless.

"... The worst."

With scornful eyes, Millia prepared a cloth and mask before breathing out a sigh. Unable to forgive this filth, it seems she was up for cleaning.

A former member of Aleist's cleaning platoon, Millia was a valuable fighting force on this front. Izumi also went outside to prepare the cleaning utensils.

"They did say the inn was full. So this was the reason."

When the knight at the station told them there were no openings at the inn, they had tilted their heads. But at this point, the reason had become clear, and Rudel was cleaning as well.

"We should've taken Aleist alone."

While half in jest, Rudel was also half serious.



"Achoo!"

Finishing up work (cleaning) for the day, Aleist was surrounded by female knights as he returned to the lodging house.

"Captain, do you have a cold? In that case, do you want to drop by my room?" "Hey, why are you inviting him so naturally?" "Ah, then should I go over to your room?"

On that scramble over Aleist among the female camp, the man in question gave a bitter smile as he denied it, saying it wasn't a cold.

(Is someone gossiping about me or something?)

If gossip really could make him sneeze, then Aleist would be sneezing nonstop throughout the day. Even if he hadn't the intent, he was called the number one playboy in the capital.

No matter how he denied it, no one would believe him. His fiancés were on the verge of surpassing seven, and his platoon was made up of all women. What's more, at the very least, they looked at him favorably.

It wasn't a mistake.

(Hah, even so...)

Looking around, the Millia he loved most wasn't there. Under Izumi's request, she had become Rudel's special inspector. Whatever the case, even if he rejected the proposal, someone higher up the chain of command had permitted it.

(Even when the paperwork said she needed her direct superior's permission.)

Aleist couldn't understand why, but Millia was going further and further away. Looking up at the sky, he prayed for her safety.

(I hope we meet again.)

"Captain, are you listening?"

"Eh? Y-yeah, I'm listening. I think so to. (What were they talking about? Well, I'm sure it's the usual complaints about the job.)"

Aleist's cleaning duty platoon was building up frustration that they didn't have any missions as knights. From the point of view of Aleist, who had nonchalantly devoted himself to cleaning, he had begun to believe that if he didn't have to fight, then maybe this was for the best. He had no complaints.

In order to match his subordinate's conversation, he merely showed sympathy.

"In that case, today's the day you make it clear who you like most in the platoon!" "It's me, isn't it, captain!" "Stay out of this, washboard! It's me, right Aleist?"

"..."

Aleist was holding a romcom of his own in the capital.

Chapter 117

Failing asleep from their fatigue after the major cleanup, the three dropped by Bennet on the next day.

It was decided that either Izumi or Millia would clean up that house that hadn't been properly prepared. Based on how their meeting with Bennet went, one of them would go back.

The barrette townscape the three of them walked down was lined with hurriedly constructed buildings of brick. But they couldn't see any buildings that extended passed two stories.

The same held true for the inns.

(This is a puzzler. I have to secure a place to sleep soon.)

She knew that staying with Rudel for too long would surely cause him trouble. Izumi mulled over who she should consult.

It was there that a building that could be classified as splendid for the town came into sight. At the sight of young soldiers having a friendly chat, Izumi felt like holding her head.

"Oh, good morning. Did you sleep well last night."

"Yeah, more importantly, where's Major Bennet?"

On Izumi's reply, the young soldiers looked at Rudel, Millia and herself, discussing something amongst themselves. While she could guess the contents of their discussion, she didn't have the time to worry about that now.

"She's doing paperwork at the desk in the back."

After giving thanks to a young soldier with a reddened face, the three of them made for Bennet.

In the station, there was one desk put aside for the dragoons to use on rotation. Normally, that would never come to pass, in a settlement without anything, granting the dragoons an exclusive desk was plenty.

The knights on duty at the capital would never be able to bear this sort of treatment, thought Izumi.

Izumi looked at Rudel's superior before her eyes and submitted her forms. But more than that, looking at the female knight before her, she thought.

(She's... kinda cute.)

Taking the paperwork, Bennet tucked it away in her file before confirming their future course.

"So you two are this man's inspector. I don't mind if you keep watching, but there are times we'll be flying around on duty. And you should think that doing work is normal around here."

"Would that work be outside of our mission?"

As Millia looked down and asked, Bennet hummed a note.

"A new recruit who's only ever sat back and done their duty at the capital need not stick their mouth into the way of the outskirts. While I haven't the authority to issue you orders, if you do nothing but keep watch over that guy, that alone will buy you a bad rep in these parts."

Millia saw how busy Beretta was, and perhaps she realized just watching would definitely make her unpopular as she shut her mouth.

When Izumi proposed they would participate in work on rotation, Bennet said, 'That so,' before handing Rudel a comprehensive schedule.

(She's surprisingly attentive and good at looking after others. And she's cute.)

Izumi noticed she was being mindful of them.

"Well, just do your best out here. You should take this opportunity to learn that the same way of doing things doesn't work everywhere you go... Rudel, I'll be having you break rocks with Sakuya. I'm going out of my way to personally supervise a newbie like you. Give me results."

"Yes ma'am."

Seeing Rudel taking his job seriously, Izumi felt relieved. It seems even Rudel wouldn't suddenly go on a petting spree. No, while Izumi herself was relieved that she had sealed Rudel's petting, she felt uneasy whenever she thought he might unveil a new technique.

Starting with petting, onto massages, embrace, and lotion... even when she sealed all of them, Rudel brought forth his magic eyes out of nowhere. So while she was wary, it couldn't be said she was going too far.

More importantly...

Izumi looked at Bennet's tail when she talked to Rudel. Running contrary to her expression it was delightedly waving about. That gap looked cute as well.

(The way it feels like she's pushing herself is also cute.)

Sure that Millia was holding the same impression, she looked to the side, only to receive a mildly irritated impression. Millia was staring intently at Rudel and Bennet.

Every time Rudel gave an earnest reply, Benet's tail would wave. Even if they were told the titles of superior and subordinate were swapped, surely no one would hold any doubt.

(She really is cute, though.)

For a while longer, Izumi watched over the girl doing her best to play the part of a superior.



Outside town, in the rockface opposite the harbor, Rudel was smashing rocks with Sakuya.

They would be used as materials for the port, but after being smashed, the stone would have to be processed. For that sake, it was necessary to break them down to an adequate size.

As Rudel issued Sakuya orders, Sakuya punched the rocks with her large arms and destroyed them.

"Fool! Do it like that, and they'll end up too small. Having them too big is no good, but if they're too small, then it takes an unnecessary amount of mana to mend them!"

Under Bennet's orders, Rudel was learning his job in Beretta. Carrying materials, patrol of the area around the port city, and helping out with construction, there was much to be done. As long as you ignored their consumption, the convenient dragons were indispensable lifeforms for construction.

"This is hard. The work's too detailed for Sakuya."

Taking Sakuya's large build into account, it was definitely a difficult job. But Bennet hummed a note.

"Oh, then will you choose your own work? It is only natural for us to be able to carry out whatever mission need be done. The way you are, you're not even half a dragoon."

"That is...!"

While he tried to say something, Rudel swallowed his words. Sure enough, being particular about his missions was usually something he should never

do.

Bennet called her own dragon and had it smash rocks to the right size to set an example. After the destruction, unlike with Sakuya, the leftover fragments didn't scatter about much.

"If the development goes steady, then this place will also become a part of town. If you cause too much destruction and spread debris around, it will make our jobs more troublesome in times to come. I do believe the development plans were included in the documents I gave you."

"My deepest apologies."

Having not thought that far ahead, Rudel apologized to Bennet. Certainly, the plan included the port's construction, and a description of the town's expansion.

"... Well, so be it. Right now, Elrond is off buying supplies, so I'll be teaching you for a while. Know that training is also part of your duty, and don't lose focus."

"Yes ma'am!"



While Rudel continued his work, to the side, Izumi watched his exchange with his cute superior officer.

As a special inspector, Izumi's duty was to make sure her eyes never left Rudel, if possible. While the two of them were earnestly doing their job, from a watcher's perspective, it couldn't help but look like a pleasant scene.

Bennet's tail was happily waving left and right, and on top of that, Sakuya was learning how to chop rocks from the water dragon. A dragon opening up its palms to chop stone into blocks was a peculiar sight indeed.

(They look like they're having fun.)

While the two of them had their dragons smashing stone, they carried out training themselves. When Bennet told Rudel to come at her, Rudel cut forward with all his might.

Izumi thought that looked bad, but Bennet lightly responded, throwing Rudel into the ground. Despite her small body, the way she handled it could only make one say, as expected of a dragon.

But after she had won, when Rudel sent her eyes of admiration, "Get to your feet already, fool!" the girl in question said, her tail violently wagging.

Next to that, Sakuya- who was unable to skillfully smash stone- tried to break it apart with her breath only to be smacked on the head by Bennet's dragon.

(I do feel sorry to say it, but...)

"Your attacks are following a pattern. You won't even be able to scratch me that way." "Kuh!"

Accelerating with wind magic, Rudel desperately rushed in to capture Bennet, but dodging by a paper-thin margin...

'I mean, I can't do it! Hey, that hurts!'

Her chops still not going well, this time, Sakuya tried to strike it with her tail...

(I wonder what it is. It just looks like they're enjoying themselves.)



Driven off to an area close to the border, Chlust grimaced as he received a report from his subordinate.

"Captain, are we in hot water?"

What the unshaven man reported to Chlust was a meeting between high officials of the countries of Courtois and Gaia. Even if it was diplomacy

under the veil of secrecy, Courtois was a noble society, and it was often the case that its high officials were of nobility. They disliked rough treatment, and it was difficult to think they would go all the way to the outskirts just to put on airs.

The man who was Chlust's subordinate reported what he heard from his trusted men.

... It was information Chlust wanted to think was impossible.

"When I thought they had quieted down, it couldn't be..."

The black ogre incidents were no longer breaking out. But as long as he stayed on the border, he could tell the enemies was growing more active whether he liked it or not.

The air was one thing, and it had been so quiet it was contrarily creepy.

And about the contents of the high official's discussion, the unshaven man was making a pale face. Chlust thought his own complexion was also leaving him, but as he was before his subordinate, he changed his train of thought.

"... Could you tell the official's face? Or their characteristics?"

"Nothing. Everyone was wearing robes and hiding their faces. If the way they talked and their documents didn't prove their status, we would have moved to take them in as suspicious individuals."

But his subordinate seemed relieved they hadn't done so from the depths of his heart. This was home ground, and there were plenty who were used to concealing their bodies, it could be called a spot of good luck that their foe didn't know the area.

That was just how powerful their guards had been.

If he knew their names, then Chlust was the second son of an archduke. He thought he would be able to find out their faction, but it didn't seem it would go so easily.

"Whatever the case, "

"What do we do, captain? Won't it blow sky high, the way things are going?"

The reason his subordinate- usually so lively- panicked to such an extent was simple. A high official of Courtois had exchanged documents with a high official of the Gaia Empire. What's more, they seemed used to it.

The few words they exchanged were clearly bizarre.

'The princess in on board.' 'As long as you accept our conditions, we'll play along with you farce.' 'Hmm, making a hero of a commoner, the thought makes me want to vomit. I'd rather he became a hero post mortem.' '... I pray you come to a decision before our preparations are complete. Tell them to understand, it's too late once it's all begun.'

Princess, hero, commoner, and too late once it began... on these words, Chlust couldn't help but remember those two.

The fact he was in a place like this, at the very least, he thought those two were involved. In a good sense, of course.

Chlust was aware that if he had continued to hate Rudel, his current self wouldn't exist. He could recall well the faces of the two who had created the opportunity.

(Is this for certain... but at this rate...)

Even if he noticed, he understood it was futile to report the fact to the higher-ups. For better or worse, they lived in noble society, and having been once oppressed, Chlust could understand. If it was a truth, it would be hushed up, if it was a lie, they would boldly punish him.

No, it was more probable they would erase him the moment he reported it.

His stay in the outskirts was a long one, and it plagued him that his information on the palace factions was outdated.

To add onto that, the outskirts were optimistic. No matter how the empire invaded, they were certain that with its dragons, Courtois would never lose.

"... Don't tell anyone about this matter. Order your men not to leak the information."

"Then what will we do!?"

"I'll look into it. If I report to the wrong man, then it wouldn't be strange if the entire unit is erased."

The man fell silent. He realized he had stuck his head into a troublesome matter, but Chlust felt an even greater sense of crisis than his subordinate.

(Who do I rely on? My house is... I can't even get in touch with Erselica, so that's not happening.)

Once his subordinate left the room, Chlust scratched his head and thought.

(I've always reported the suspicious movements on the Empire's side. I can't think the higher-ups don't know. Then did they know and plan to abandon us from the start?)

From the reinforcement of war potential around the border, Chlust had felt relief, but now he had a bad premonition.

(Our forces are being reinforced. But...)

The map of the area affixed to one of the room's wall had memo sheets stuck all over it. It was a map that collected all the incidents on the border over the past few years.

He confirmed the war potential on Courtois' side.

(There won't be a problem if it's a skirmish? No, the empire's been tormented by our dragons for many years. It's unthinkable that they're not taking the dragons into account so late in the game. Our side is looking down on our foe too much.)

Getting together the reports on the black ogre, he had found one that suspected they might be an experiment from the empire. But his superior had laughed it off.

Even if that was true, Courtois had dragons, so they knew it wouldn't be a problem.

(I can only gather info for now. And I have to inform someone of this fact...)

While his brother's face came to mind, recalling Rudel's present situation, he shook his head. As the white knight, Rudel stood out too much. And he wasn't in a position of power.

"First, I have to establish casual contact with Erselica. I need as much information on the palace as possible."

Looking at the map, Chlust scanned for the name of a port town. On a memo next to it, the town's fighting force was listed out.

When there were three powerful dragoons stationed there, there were no other decent reinforcements. On that mismatched treatment, Chlust feared for the safety of his brother who had likewise been flown off to the outskirts.

"I hope I'm just thinking too much."

Feeling the calm before the storm, Chlust felt something contrived in his brother being sent to the outskirts during such a period.

Chapter 117.1: New year special

(TL: Let's all appreciate that festive time of year this piece was written in. This is part 1 of 2, the second part to be released at a later date. Unlike the EXTRA chapters, this special has absolutely no bearing on the main story)

Aleist: "And here we are, at this special event to commemorate the new year! It's time for our wonderful question corner. This is your host Aleist, the man who's become somewhat popular these days. Now let's introduce our special guests. Today's guests are these two!"

Albach: "I'm the King of Courtois, Albach Courtois."

Ciel: "His wife, Ciel Courtois."

Aleist: "Even so, we've gathered quite the extravagant faces. Personally, I have no idea how I'm supposed to be treating you."

Ciel: "Oh? That's quite a weak statement from our popular (lol) black knight. You need only prostrate yourself before a woman as you always do. Even if it's a new year special, is this really anything new? Though this is precisely why you'll always be no good."

Aleist: "... A harsh statement right off the bat, my Hp's already hit 0."

Albach: "My apologies, black knight (lol)."

Aleist: "Pease stop. Stop with the (lol)s... hah, anyways, getting back on track, here's a question for his and her majesty. 'Do you have any dissatisfactions within the palace? And what do you think of Princess Aileen and Captain (lol) Fritz?' they ask."

Albach: "Dissatisfactions, is it? Well, I have quite a few, but my biggest complaint is the fact my wife is one of your capture targ—Aleist: "Hahaha! What could this man be talking about!? We don't need those sort of meta statements! And I'm definitely not laying my hands on her!""

Ciel: "You mean it in the, here's a big red button, you better not push it, sort of way? You're not my type, kid. The only one I love as a man is Albach."

Albach: "H-honey!"

Ciel: "Dear!"

Aleist: "... Enough. For now, can we leave the complaints at that?"

Albach: "Very well!"

Ciel: "There are so many I can't narrow down an answer. So let's go onto the next one. Look, just get on with it already, Mr. Popular (lol)."

Aleist: "Next is Princess Aileen and Fritz. Personally, my honest impression is that she's way too different from how I imagined her. I thought she would be kinder. I think she's quite the selfish princess."

Ciel: "Good of you to say that right in front of her parents. I'll remember this. Well, personally, I do think Aileen's recent actions are intolerable."

Albach: "I'm just glad Fina is so earnest. How about it, Aleist-kun, won't you take one of them?"

Aleist: "I already have my fill. The best times in life are the ones where you can still envy something like a harem."

Ciel: "I can't think that as a statement from a wimp who hasn't lain hands on them. More importantly, that royal guard captain? His status is much too low. I originally intended to fill that slot with Rudel of the Arses House, but..."

Albach: "While I have much to think about it, if he shows his devotion as an earnest knight, and does his work, I'll evaluate him for it. I heard his

capabilities are considerable, so if he diligently stacks up his training, they'll stop saying he boasts an empty title. You should be careful of that too, Aleist-kun."

Aleist: "You two seem to have it down. I thought it would be something more muddled, but it looks like I can take a breath of fresh air."

Ciel: "... There's no need to jump the gun on the first move."

Aleist: "Following on, 'How do the women think of Rudel as a member of the opposite sex?' is the question. When I'm the host, they ask about Rudel... eh? What's this?"

Ciel: "Then first off, let's call in our daughters. Dear, go get them."

Albach: "Very well!"

Aleist: "She's working you hard."

Albach: "..... You'll be like this too someday. No, you're already one of us. Now's your last chance to have a laugh over it!"

Aileen: "Father, is something starting?"

Fina: "Father, mother, and Mr. Janitor too. Good day. (I don't want to moovve.)"

Aleist (rubbing his eyes): "Huh? Fina-sama, did you just say something?"

Fina: "No, nothing in particular? (Get master in here, master! Let's start the year off with its first petting!)"

Aleist: "So here's a question for the two of you. How do you think of Rudel, as a member of the opposite sex?"

Aileen: "That's quite an unpleasant question so early in the year. I hate him."

Fina: "I feel in his debt for all the time's he's saved me, and more than anything, I do believe he is a wonderful person (Fluffadise fever!! Should I tell you just how much I need master, here and now? If I call it love or affection or some shit, I'm sure they'll accept it, and master's from an archduke house... here it is. It's my win.)"

Ciel: "Is that so. Okay. Goodbye."

Aileen, Fina: "..."

Albach: "Wouldn't it be fine to ask them more?"

Ciel: "Does it really matter to a noble whether they like someone or not? Well, as it stands, Aileen for Aleist-dono and Fina for Rudel-dono, I guess? That sounds safest to me."

Albach: "Then moving on. Please enter."

Sophina: "Pardon my intrusion."

Mii: "Pardon my intrusion. Urrgh, how nerve-wracking."

Aleist: "Huh? Wasn't I supposed to be the host..."

Ciel: "We have too many characters. Let's get this done with quickly. How do you two think of Rudel as a member of the opposite sex? Do you want to be embraced, or do you hate the thought of even touching him? Pick between the two."

Albach: "Now that's quite extreme."

Aleist: "You're at full throttle, first thing in the year."

Ciel: "Oh? By embrace, I mean a hug. Just what could you have been imagining, you silly people?"

Aleist, Albach: "..."

Ciel: "This is a pain, so let's just write the question somewhere in the room. Do you want to be embraced or not, hang it up, and if their faces turn red, we just have to push it from there. Now what's your answer?"

Sophina: "No, even if you ask if I want to be embraced, I can't quite... I wouldn't hate it, but with my age..."

Ciel: "So you want to be embraced. Alright, next!"

Sophina: "Eeeeeh."

Mii: "A hug? I'm fine with that. He does things that go beyond that to me on a regular basis."

Ciel: "So you already have been embraced. Looks like this kid is OK too."

Aleist: "If you take that out of context, it's way too extreme. Ladies, the exit is that way. Now onto the next ones~."

Cattleya: "Pardon my intrusion. Ah, the marriage interview woman's back."

Lilim: "This is quite the high-class gathering."

Enora (face bright red): "... What's with that question?"

Bennet: "Do I want to be embraced by my subordinate, you ask?"

Aleist: "Here we have the flowers of the dragoons."

Albach: "One of them's already beet red. No, the second one's turning."

Aleist: "Cattleya-san and Enora-san, looks like. The two of them are surprisingly maidens, after all...though they look like they'd play around, it really is a mystery."

Cattleya: "You just laughed, didn't you. See me out back later."

Aleist: "... My apologies (sweat)."

Bennet (tail wagging): "By embrace, you mean being held in his arms? Then we're always embracing each other every day (in combat training) That kid is always so intense (and serious in training), so I'm always worn out."

Cattleya (irritated): "..."

Lilim (fiddling with hair): "... Tch..."

Enora (face bright red): "Eh? Ah, eh, whoah."

Aleist: "I don't know how to begin to describe this air."

Albach: "But aren't you a little too used to it?"

Aleist: "If you'll let me have my say, something of this level is cute by comparison... hah."

Ciel: "As the wolf girl said, this is about hugs. You two with the red faces, just what could you be imagining? Meet me out back, I'll be asking you later. There is no escape... well then do you think it's alright to be embraced?"

Cattleya (face bright red): "W-well, I wouldn't hate it."

Lilim (serious): "I wouldn't mind going further!"

Enora (face bright red): "I-I'm fwinnth!"

Bennet (tail wagging): "Totally fine!"

Ciel: "The wolf girl is so pure it's hurting my heart. Well, let's continue on."

Aleist: "In that case, let's bring in the next ones!"

Erselica: "Pardon my intrusion."

Lena: "Pardon my intrusion!"

Albach: "What's this? Isn't this question a bit too extreme for family? Then let's just be upfront. What do you two think about Rudel? Tell us whether you like or hate him."

Erselica: "Hah? He's my brother, for argument's sake. But I like Chlust more."

Lena: "Hmm, my brother is my eternal goal, you hear. While I like him, at the same time, he's my greatest rival! The first one to perfect the art of petting dragons will be me!"

Aleist: "Huh? Rudel already got initiated into the secret arts."

Lena: "... Eh?"

Aleist: "As I was saying, he got initiated into the secret arts. And he even obtained a pair of demon eyes."

Ciel: "Isn't he already beyond the realm of humanity?"

Albach: "Demon eyes of all things. Now that's a powerful item that tickles a man's heart."

Lena: "..... I'm going to go training."

Aleist: "Hah?"

Lena: "I'm going to train and work out a new way to pet dragons! I won't let it end like this. Then I have no choice but to put my all into it! I can't keep my brother waiting forever!"

Erselica: "Hey wait, Lena! ... W-well then, everyone, I apologize for this discourtesy, but I must be taking my leave!"

Albach: "And they're off. I'm glad they look in good health."

Ciel: "I can't wait to see what happens at the academy next year. There'll be a few new air holes in the headmaster's stomach."

Aleist: "Yeah~, I hope the headmaster who looked after us keeps a good watch over his health."

Ciel: "Is that the line of one of the problem children? Aleist-dono the Playboy (lol)?"

Albach: "You fit the (lol)s way too well."

Aleist: (They're playing with me.)

Aleist: "Moving on!"

Izumi: "Pleasure."

Millia: "... Beg pardon."

Aleist: "The main act has come out!"

Albach: "You look happy, but are you sure you want to hear it?"

Ciel: (Grinning)

Izumi: "Do I want to be embraced by Rudel? You want me to answer that question?"

Aleist (slight glance at Millia): "T-that's right."

Millia: "... You're really asking that so early in the year? Aleist, is your head on right?"

Aleist: "It's not my question! This is a question from the readers! It's something everyone wants to know!"

Ciel: "Creepy. He's so desperate it's creeping me out."

Albach: "I'm not sure what to think about shoving the blame onto the readers."

Millia (averting her face, cheeks a bit red): "I don't hate him. I'll accept an embrace (hug) from him anytime."

Aleist (hugging knees, staring at wall): "..."

Albach: "Now this is quite the reaction."

Ciel: "No doubt about it! This girl has a thing for Rudel-dono (lol). Oh? Now where might our little black knight be (lolol). Putting that aside, how about the other girl?"

Izumi: "Me? I love Rudel, so that's not a problem. But a hug is a bit... well, in my culture..."

Ciel: "That's a questionable answer. You like him, but you can't hug?"

Izumi: "Yes, that's about right. If I cause any misunderstandings, it will only bring trouble for Rudel."

Ciel: "How modest. If only Fina had this level of modesty..."

Albach: (If only you had this level of modesty...)

Aleist (dejected): "Then is that the end?"

Ciel: "What are you talking about? We still have the real act left to go."

Albach: "Sure enough, I guess you could call it the centerpiece."

Aleist: "Was there someone else?"

Sakuya: 'How terrible for you to forget me!'

Mystith: 'Hey, what do you intend to do, keeping a lady waiting?'

Heleene: 'Mama, you're being too intimidating.'

Aunty: 'I'm technically a woman (female) you know.'

Aleist: "Are the dragons counted among the women?"

Albach: "Well, in this case, I'm curious to see how the dragons think of the human called Rudel. Let's go with that as the question."

Ciel: "Taking it in turn... let's start with the white one, then the big blue one, her daughter, and finally the giant dragon."

Sakuya: 'Sakuya really loves Rudel! She loves Izumi too! She likes Millia maybe (?) But Aleist is no good!'

Albach: "The dragon hates you, Aleist-kun."

Aleist: "Dammit, she still holds a grudge over the past. When she lost her memory, why is that the only thing she remembers?"

Ciel: "I do think Flan von Brains was terrible. But if I had to say, your brain's always filled with a shade of pink, Aleist-dono. Girls that cute, and seven of them at that... the number ever increasing."

Albach: "You think he's going to wither sometime soon?"

Mystith: 'Am I next? Let's see... he's an understanding human who respects Marty. And I'll praise him as Sakuya's contractor.'

Albach (looking off into the distance): "... That's the problem in and of itself."

Ciel (looking off into the distance): "Yes, as long as that wasn't there, I'd raise both my arms in delight... why did it have to be Marty Wolfgang of all people..."

Aleist: "Next is... who might you be?"

Heleene: 'Me? I'm Bennet's dragon.'

Aleist: "Oh, the wolf girl's dragon? That wolf girl Bennet's quite the popular one. It seems even the author couldn't tell that was supposed to be her treating Rudel as a grunt. I wonder if there's a reason for that."

Heleene: '... Make light of my contractor and you're dead.'

Aleist (Groveling): "My apologies!"

Mystith: 'So how is it?'

Heleene: 'Wait, mama, don't rush me! He's my contractor Bennet's precious subordinate. Everyone always dotes on that girl, so she can never get the sort of subordinate she wants. If my contractor's happy, then that's enough for me.'

Aunty: 'I don't have anything to say in particular. Well, in regards to how he saved Sakuya, as a fellow gaia dragon, I am thankful.'

Aleist: "This is ending on a somewhat dubious note."

Ciel: "If we have any other questions, we can just answer them when the time comes. Dear, I'm thirsty."

Albebach: "I see, then I'll go get you something. Aleist-kun, would you like anything to drink?"

Aleist: "While I appreciate the sentiment, I think I should be the one to go. We will be having a brief intermission."

Chapter 118

"I can't stand this anymore!"

Expressionlessly tidying up her paperwork, Fina ruffled up her blond hair as she cried out. But even still, she hadn't the slightest emotion on her face. On the contrary, the made it scarier.

But already used to it, Mii looked at Fina as she prepared some tea and snacks. It tasted worse than when Sophina prepared it, but Fina more readily accepted tea brewed by Mii.

"When you have both an elf and a wolf by his side, why haven't you lain hands on them, master! And you call yourself the lord of fluff? Or could it be you're teasing and playing around with me?"

"Rudel-sama doesn't have any fixation on fluffies, after all."

"Right, even if you didn't force him to choose, he's for dragons and dragons alone."

Helping out in Fina's work, Sophina and Mii processed documents. Perhaps they had built a resistance to Fina's conduct and speech up to now, as they were calm as could be.

"Dammit... I put such a cute wolf tribe girl by his side! And because I forcefully pulled out that clutzy commanding officer, my workload's increased! What's more, that Aleist guy keeps saying, 'I don't want to be away from Millia' or something... it was irritating, so I recommended her for special inspector! Yeah, it was me, whatcha gonna do about it!"

"Princess, I think that's terrible."

With much to think about love and marriageable ages, Sophina glared at Fina. Mii also pitied Aleist, so she didn't send Fina an affirmative look.

Noticing that, Fina hurriedly followed through.

"I-it's alright Mii. Aleist will soon have his eighth fiancé, and he really will dry up."

"Isn't that no good? Do you have some sort of grudge against him, princess?"

Thinking of a dried up black knight, Sophina brought up her memories of his fiancés that were still at the academy. One of them was a female knight who excelled in the sword, and it was already decided she would skip grades.

She had surely done her best for Aleist's sake, but Sophina had felt something terrifying from her, so she could foresee something terrible happening.

For the other one, a girl of the tiger tribe, Fina had done everything in her power to pull her into the defenders. It was only at times like these that Sophina had to tip her hat to Fina's abilities. Though she held a flaw of only ever working for her own desires.

"Hah, for the princess of a country to spend her school life buried in paperwork..."

While Sophina pitied Fina's present situation just a little, Fina expressionlessly embraced Mii and started fondling various things. The one in question looked happy enough.

"Well whatever."

Before that usual scene, Sophina returned to work.

... Doing paperwork that wasn't even part of her job, her absolute lack of resistance was also a problem. The two of them had been corrupted.



In the port town of Beretta, Millia was watching over Rudel

Separated from Rudel, who had work at the port, Izumi was discussing matters with Bennet at the knight brigade station.

"Do something about your living conditions?"

"Yes."

The topic of their consultation was the fact they slept under the same roof as Rudel. While it was a problem that Millia didn't see it as much of a problem, Izumi generally wasn't fond of this situation.

Thinking of his future, she thought this might become trouble for Rudel.

"Why is that? While simultaneously observing him, the two of you were allotted to the future archduke Rudel, were you not? That's how I and the others understood it."

Bennet had no ill intent. It would be stranger if the future archduke Rudel didn't have anyone by his side to look after him. Young and beautiful, Izumi and Millia were seen as Rudel's mistress candidates, or perhaps his servants or convenient women. To Bennet and the rest who didn't know the happenings of the capital, they thought the top brass had even gone as far as to tack on a reason and give them a post as, 'Special Inspectors'.

"... There is no ulterior motive behind our directive. We really are just here to watch Rudel."

"I see."

Once Izumi corrected the misunderstanding, Bennet started to think. She looked tiny behind the large desk and chair that were prepared because the dragoon called Elrond used them as well.

"Then this really is a problem. Not only Rudel, it will bring about an influence to your futures as well. I do want to do something on my side,

but..."

As Bennet made a difficult expression, her tail apologetically drooped down from her chair.

But perhaps she had a good idea, as her tail suddenly regained its vigor, swaying to and fro.

"Then the two of you can come over to my place."

"Is that alright? And I don't think it's wise to keep too far from him."

There was no telling what Rudel might do, and even if it was knight, there was no meaning to their inspector posts if they were too far away.

"I know it's only been a few days since you've taken your post, and there's no helping it if you haven't been able to make rounds, but you should at least learn who lives next to you."

"And that would be... you, Major Bennet?"

On Izumi's words, Bennet's tail violently wagged. She must have been greatly pleased, as it even showed on her face.

"I'll return early today. The two of you should come around to my house today. Luckily, our lodgings are next to one another, so I don't mind if you leave your belongings at Rudel's place."

"While you have a point, won't it be a bother?"

"I was the one under a misunderstanding. And when my subordinates cause a problem, it's my responsibility as well. I plan to deal with it as a superior officer."

While Bennet made a stern expression, in contrast, her tail was lashing out as if she couldn't endure her delight.

(What's she so happy about?)

Izumi couldn't help but be curious about the individual called Bennet.



Within the day, Izumi explained the situation to Millia and took her belongings to the civilian house that Bennet used as a dwelling.

"Wasn't that fine as it was?"

While Millia didn't particularly see a need to change houses, Izumi was greatly opposed. She went as far as to give an order to drag Millia to Bennet's house.

"There's something called the eyes of society. You should be more aware that me and you are both unmarried women."

"Yeah, yeah..."

Due to being raised in a closed elf village, it did seem Millia minded not the eyes of society. No, she was raised in a closed environment where she would have to mind it, but from her special position, she ended up quite dim on the matter.

Having heard about Lilim from Rudel, Izumi thought she might develop a headache. Even if recognized a differing sense of values, Izumi wanted to avoid Rudel being put at a loss over something like this.

Even if she might be paying undue worry, Rudel was even denser to his surroundings than Millia. At least someone had to care about it.

The neighboring house was of the same construction as the one afforded to Rudel. As they stepped through the threshold, Bennet came out to greet them in her apron.

"So you're here. Leave your luggage in an empty room."

The scent of a seafood soup, and the smell of roasting meat filled the area. Perhaps she had gone out of her way to prepare it for them, as three plates were already prepared in the kitchen.

"When you're already letting us stay, you're even cooking for us... my deepest apologies."

"Don't mind it. While there is always left over with one, if we have three people, then nothing will be left to rot. You haven't been stationed long, so think of it as your celebration. Eat without restraint."

The food was the same, but the room was casually put in order. Even Millia, who was fussy over cleaning, looked over the room and mortifyingly conceded...

"N-not bad."

... She muttered.

Even from her eyes, it was clean. After spending more than half a year cleaning the palace, Millia had developed a fixation for cleanliness. Izumi, who had only spent a few days with her, found herself cautioned time and again.

(Bennet-san is amazing... and she can even cook.)

But there was one thing that bothered Izumi.

Perhaps she didn't want it to wag while she was cooking, as she had her tail tucked away in her apron. That was also cute, but the problem was the apron. Fitting with her appearance, the frilled apron was fine in itself, but the character embroidered on it was definitely a simplified cat.

Looking like she'd start humming at any moment, Bennet bestowed the finishing touches onto the food.

(When she's a wolf, she has a thing for cats?)

Izumi was bothered by quite a trivial thing.

◇

"Now then, this is a bother."

In the house Izumi had left, Rudel thought aloud.

The fact Izumi and Millia had left was one that was a deep relief to him. Living with a man before marriage would definitely invite needless trouble to their futures.

But there was a problem.

"I have no idea what I'm supposed to do."

... Right, Izumi had never lived alone before. Even when he was endeavoring through his training and studies, at the dorm, the servants would look after his room.

While the girls might not have been aware, the young nobles had their cleaning and laundry taken care of by the servants attached to the dormitory. To add to that, Rudel generally couldn't cook.

For argument's sake, he could make the sort of food he'd prepare in the wild, but he had no idea what he was supposed to do alone.

As he had become a dragoon right after graduation, he had skipped right over the cleaning and house work that would be assigned to the low-level grunts. To the elite dragoons, even if they may clean the dragon stables, they were never troubled with the necessities of life.

"It would be rude to go ask them at this point."

Standing from his chair, for now, Rudel decided to heat up yesterday's leftovers. Before the stove, he lit a fire with magic and placed the pot over it.

He still had the soup Izumi made, he would likely hold out a day or two.

But what would happen after that?

"Well, I'm sure it'll work out."

More than twenty years old, Rudel lived by himself for the first time in his life.



Three days later...

Three women looked over Rudel's house with stiff faces.

On top of the dirty table, the kitchen was heaped with unwashed dishes. Apart from that, perhaps the laundry wasn't being done, as there were dirty garments left here and there.

"Rudel, what is the meaning of this?"

As Bennet glared at Rudel, the man in question made a troubled face.

"Even if you ask me... how did it come to this?"

After hitting Rudel's head with her palm, Bennet breathed out a sigh. She thought a man might be bad at this sort of thing, but even so, wasn't this a bit too terrible? She looked over the room once more. When she thought of the state of spaces she couldn't see, her heart sank.

It began during the day's work, when Izumi had grown worried and asked Rudel if he was properly eating.

Early to bed, early to rise, there was also a problem in how Rudel was never home to begin with.

(There's no helping what's been done, but this is too terrible, oh subordinate of mine!)

On the question of whether or not he was eating properly, Rudel said this.

'I still have takeout, so I'm fine.'

Just what part of that is fine, Izumi and Millia teamed up to cross-examine him. Then Bennet had begun to worry and joined in.

"Good grief... before your mission comes into question, you can't even properly live your life?"

"M-my deepest apologies."

Leaving a noble like Rudel alone was a problem, but neither Izumi nor Millia thought it would be this bad. It was the weak point of the top-scoring Rudel.

The sun was already going down so they couldn't do laundry now. If they started cleaning, it would carry on to midnight.

"Hah, I'll prepare food for you today. Izumi, Millia, come over once you've cleaned up the kitchen."

Heading off to her own house, Bennet had concluded that rather than making anything in Rudel's ingredient-less house, making a large portion in her own place would be faster.

(What sort of thing would a man like to eat? It has to be meat, right?)

Swiftly equipping her apron, she tucked her tail into it so it wouldn't swing around. The box loaded with ingredients was filled with magic-made ice alongside seafood and various meats.

(Yeah~, what should I make...)

As she thought that, she heard a scream. The voice belonged to Millia.

'Why can't you do something as simple as this!? And wait, how are you able to live in a room like this? I can't believe it!'

'S-sorry.'

(Oh no, they're getting mad at my subordinate. I really don't think there's any helping it, but Millia-chan is scary.)

Hurriedly making arrangements, Bennet looked over the three who appeared once the food was done. Millia was letting off a prickly air, while

Rudel lowered his shoulders. Izumi was trying to cheer him up, saying she would teach him how to do laundry the next morning.

"You really are hopeless. Today's special, don't expect me to do this again."

Before the food lining the table, Rudel delighted at his first decent meal in a while. Seeing his face, while she didn't let it show on her expression, Bennet rejoiced as well.

(Yay! It doesn't look like he hates it.)

The four of them sat around the dinner table, and as expected, talks went towards Rudel's lifestyle. Even if they told him to do better starting tomorrow, there was no way Rudel could do that. For the time being, Izumi and Millia would do something about it.

And the topic changed to the food.

"Is it good?"

Bennet asked Rudel, happily chowing down, and the man in question gave an energetic reply. He was already on his third plate.

"Yes! Major, you are an amazing cook."

"You can skip the flattery. With a house of your stature, I'm sure you've eaten the food of top-class chefs from before you could walk. I can at least understand that much."

"Is that so? I was never too fixated over the taste."

Unfamiliar about Rudel's early childhood, Millia seemed to be curious over what Rudel ate. Izumi knew he had been treated terribly, but she had never asked about the contents of his meals.

"So what sort of things did you eat?"

"... First off, vegetables and things with high nutritional value."

"Being able to eat something nutritional is something to be thankful for. So how was it prepared? (Maybe I'll try it out next time.)"

Bennet had some interest in a noble's cooking as she awaited Rudel's answer.

But the answer that came back crossed was more than she could handle.

"No, just normally. Raw, I mean."

"R-raw?"

Millia was surprised.

"Is that strange?"

Izumi looked around, perplexed by Bennet and Millia's reactions. She was sure he meant some sort of food prepared raw, showing little surprise.

"... You mean a salad?"

"No, we just kinda ate it whole. They were bitter, so my little sister would always swallow without chewing. Generally speaking, there were a lot of cold dishes, I guess? I think the bread was on the harder side, and I get the feeling the meat was lightly seasoned..."

Rudel was the only one able to smile.

After hearing the specifics, they wouldn't imagine that as the meal of a future archduke.

"So that's why you always said the dining hall food was the best..."

"Hey, no matter how you look at it, that's not normal."

"... Do you want another?"

"With pleasure!"

As Bennet held out her own meat dish, Rudel ate it with delight. Seeing him like that, Bennet was on the verge of tears within.

(Poor subordinate of mine... I'll have to do my best in cooking from tomorrow onwards.)

"Maor, your food is the best!"

When he happily praised her, Bennet grew happy as well.

"For the time being, I'll provide your meals. It will be troublesome if you collapse, after all... what's wrong, you two?"

There, Izumi and Millia looked at Bennet.

"U-um, would it be possible for you to teach us how to cook as well?"

"Hmm? I don't mind."

"Really!?"

As the faces of the two women approached, Bennet felt something dreadful.

(Eh? What's this? Hey, you're scaring me.)



The next morning, Izumi taught Rudel how to do laundry as promised.

(Come to think of it, Millia was doing everyone's laundry for the past few days.)

It was curious how she had no resistance to washing a man's undergarments. No, as the sight of her gleefully doing laundry floated in her mind, Izumi shook her head. She was reading too far into it.

Before the tub, Rudel hesitated as he washed his own clothing.

"The water's grown murky."

"When your clothes are so dirty, of course it would. Don't change out the water, just keep washing."

"I could use magic and..."

"It's not like you couldn't, but you know that clothing is valuable out here, right? If you make a mistake, you really will have nothing to wear."

He had proposed resolving the problem with magic, but after that was declined, he got back to work. Watching his back, Izumi was filled with an inexplicable urge to help out.

But Bennet had told her to make him do it on his own.

Once he finished the washing in the house's yard, he hung the clothes up to dry. Looking over the large load of drying laundry, it was clear he still had a way to go, but for argument's sake, Izumi concluded he would be alright.

Inside the house, Millia was doing the minimum amount of cleaning she could bear.

"It's meal time. Come over."

Once Bennet called across the yard, taking Millia along, the three of them headed for Bennet's house. There, around the entranceway stood a man with his blue hair tied at the back. He was talking about something with Bennet.

"You sure took your time."

"Don't ask for the impossible. Even like this, I made haste."

The male knight who looked older than them had the robe of a dragoon draped over their shoulder. Once Izumi and the others came out, Bennet introduced them to the male knight.

"This is my subordinate Rudel, and his two inspectors. The one with the black hair's called Izumi, and the green haired one is Millia. Remember that."

"Hmm... My name's Keith. Keith Elrond. Pleasure to meet you."

The male knight gave a splendid smile as he approached Izumi and the others; along with his introduction, he reached out and took a hand. But the way he gripped it wasn't one that they could come to like. He was acting overly familiar, or so was Izumi's frank opinion.

The way he touched it was a little indecent.

"U-um."

During that space, Keith had reached out his left hand and wrapped it around a shoulder as well. It was nothing more than a handshake, but it was almost as if his ulterior motives were on show for all to see.

"What is it, umm~..."

"I'm Izumi. Could you let go of that hand?"

"And why's that?"

Keith flippantly resisted with a smile. On his expression, dark emotions on a level she had never experienced before began to well up in Izumi.

... Hatred, detestation.

A sensation similar to that ruled over Izumi as she simultaneously recognized Keith as an enemy. Izumi glared at him with a straight face.

It was the moment that within Izumi, a person she couldn't like no matter how hard she tried had been born.

And she spoke.

"Listen, just release Rudel's hand and shoulder already."

Chapter 119

"Release Rudel already."

Izumi reached her left hand towards the sheath of the katana hung at her waist, preparing herself to draw it at a moment's notice. Pushing up the hilt with her thumb, she intimidated her enemy, Keith Elrond.

However...

"My name is Keith Elrond. My partner Spinnith is a water dragon. Would you like to go flying with me next time, Rudel?"

He ignored Izumi.

"A getaway? I do want to try riding other dragons, but right now, I have Sakuya, so..."

The man of whose eyes the women didn't even seem to enter was of high stature and pleasant appearance. But his chest area was strangely laid bare.

As Izumi extended her right hand to the scabbard, Millia frantically stepped in to stop her.

"S-stupid! You're dealing with a dragoon. That's no normal man."

Right. Dragoons were humans chosen by the dragons. No one could imagine a normal knight winning out. In essence, a majority of the dragoons were proficient when looked at as single knights.

Rudel was shaking Keith's hand with a smile, and it seemed he hadn't the slightest understanding of his partner's ulterior motives. That only made Izumi needlessly more anxious. Her foe was definitely handsome, he didn't

look all too strong. But Izumi parted her right hand that trembled as it gripped her hilt tight.

He looked weak, but he was a dragoon, of all things. If he was hiding his abilities, then Izumi would never be able to compete.

Mortified, Izumi managed to endure it.

"Elrond-dono, please step away from Rudel (Dammit, he's taking glances this way and laughing!)"

"Oh, what's this? I don't know who you might be, but you look quite angry."

"I named myself not a moment ago."

Releasing Rudel from his grasp, Keith overreacted, covering his face with his right hand and gazing up at the sky.

"Then I must apologize! I've little interest in a woman's name, see. I'm of the belief that as long as I remember my mother and grandmother, the rest is unnecessary, and I can never work up the mind to commit any to memory."

"... And you're the same as always."

Bennet sounded tired, but she had long since given up. After breathing out a sigh, she didn't make any further remarks.

(I really don't like this man.)

Izumi contained the emotions welling up as she glared at Keith. Noticing her gaze, Keith looked over her expression with a grin. He further rubbed Izumi's nerves the wrong way.



"... Rudel."

"What is it, Major?"

Her tail waving around, Bennet looked over the glaring Izumi and Keith as she pulled Rudel over. Her motions were practically that of a little sister badgering her brother. Millia had nervously separated from the glaring two, and in front of the entranceway, the three of them discussed the next day's plans.

"Starting tomorrow morning, we'll be carrying out your training. Let's see... let's start out with a one-on-one mock battle with me. And then we'll use our dragons to fight."

"Really!?"

Looking at Rudel's delighted face, while she spoke with a stern expression, Bennet's tail was happily wagging.

"Fool, now is the last time you'll be able to rejoice. And I'll have you fight Keith as well."

"The lieutenant? Isn't he worn out, having only just returned?"

"Do you think a dragoon can shirk duty simply because they're worn out? It seems you've asked the captain what it is you're lacking, but you haven't fully comprehended it."

"M-my apologies."

Seeing a depressed Rudel, Bennet thought.

(T-that was a failure! I-I have to cheer him up somehow.)

From Rudel, she had heard about how Oldarts had informed him of the things he was lacking in combat. But Rudel wasn't having a good time coming up with a resolution. Even if he was told to rely on his partner, he didn't understand exactly what he was supposed to do.

Even if he was told to expand his field of vision, he could only pack in experience.

In order to become a dragoon, talent was necessary, and in order to aim for number one among them, one would have to polish themselves more than anyone.

Bennet didn't think Rudel had no talent. More so, she praised him for believing in a talent he might not even have and polishing himself to such an extent. While she had become a dragoon because she had been granted the opportunity, he had bet his life to become a dragoon, and that was something she would never be able to do.

"Don't look so down. If you fight me and Keith, you might find your answer."

"I will?"

"That depends on you."

Bennet headed off towards Izumi's glaring match.

She was trying to get Rudel to notice that the answer wasn't something set in stone. If the individual didn't accept it, it held no meaning. Like that, both Bennet and Keith had polished their form as dragoons...

Human life was short. No matter how much talent one may have, mastering everything was impossible. Cattleya was treated as an exception to that rule, but that very Cattleya had committed a large blunder when it came to Rudel...

And even if one was selected by a dragon, the partner dragon's abilities weren't uniform. Even the gray dragons had variance in their individual abilities.

He would have no choice but to choose what he wanted to become.

(I'm sorry, my little subordinate. But this is a path you have to grasp on your own.)

Having him fight her, and Keith, a different type of dragoon, Bennet wanted to show Rudel examples of the forms a dragoon could take.



Early the next day, they made for a site far from the port town of Beretta.

In that separated space, protected by Keith's dragon, Izumi and Millia watched over Rudel and Bennet.

It was a rough land of nothing but rocks, but Sakuya had taken a liking to it, so there was a hole she had dug out nearby.

In that space without grass or tree, Rudel and Bennet faced one another.

"Is that wooden sword your only weapon?"

"Yes, it's the weapon I've used most."

"I see... I use two daggers, three boomerangs, and a whip."

As Bennet showed him her two wooden daggers and boomerangs, Rudel seemed perplexed over how she could use so many weapons. He was certain that polishing a single weapon one specialized in would hold the highest efficiency.

Sensing Rudel's thoughts, Bennet let out a sigh.

"I know what you're thinking, but this is my style. Come at me without restraint."

Tucking her daggers into her belt, she readied a boomerang in her hand. Putting the other two away in a pouch in her back, she lowered her hips and took a peculiar stance. The boomerang in her right hand against her shoulder, she directed the left side of her body towards Rudel.

Rudel took a stance with his wooden sword, adjusting his posture just a little. Sensing the movement of her eyes, and the minute movements of her body, Rudel's body reacted and started to motion as well.

Unable to endure it anymore, Rudel launched a charge on Bennet, approaching her with his high-speed movement. But swiftly leaping to the

left, Bennet cut at Rudel with her boomerang. By the time Rudel had parried and corrected his stance, there was already another boomerang in Bennet's left hand.

(This is bad!)

While Rudel immediately moved from the spot to dodge, to the place he transferred, a boomerang flew. From the projectile that spun as it flew after him, he could sense a faint hint of mana.

Concentrating his attention on the two boomerangs that chased him as he ran, Rudel knocked one out of the air. The moment he returned his eyes to Bennet, controlling them remotely, he felt an impact on his back.

Collapsing right onto the back, he managed to endure, left in a state supporting his body with his left hand.

(She controls three at once? To think that was possible...!)

It was here Rudel regretted taking his eyes off her for even a moment. Demi humans of the beast tribe never boasted much magic. That put them at an overwhelming disadvantage, but as if to make up, they boasted extraordinary physical prowess not held by the other races.

As he held his wood sword horizontally, bringing it up over his head, Bennet fell towards him, equipped with both daggers, the force of all her body's weight behind her blow.

Unable to endure the impact, he diverted the force and escaped, but Bennet was able to follow his movements.

"That truly is an astounding way to get around. But if that's all you can do with it, then even I can keep up."

Skillfully handling her daggers, she changed from forehand to backhand, launching a series of attacks. If he used his full speed, he might have been able to escape, but as Bennet made sure he had no escape, Rudel was pressed into a hard fight.

(She's fast! At this speed, I can't put out my shield of light or light bolts.)

"What's wrong? Is that all it takes to be academy number one?"

But Rudel had a bit of confidence in his swordplay. As he hit aside one of Bennet's daggers, she threw the other one at him to take distance. Lowering down his sword, the deflected dagger made a dull sound as it rolled across the ground.

By the time he noticed it, Rudel's breath had grown rough.

That sensation of all his movements being sealed, it was practically what he felt when he was going up against the captain.

(This person's also strong, after all.)

As vexing as it was, Rudel couldn't withstand the smile spreading across his face. While he couldn't confirm that expression himself, according to Aleist, it was the face of a 'battle junkie'.

(Even so, I don't mind. I'm going to become stronger. If I fight this person, I'll be able to rise even higher.)

"... You're putting your all into every movement. Think about your own stamina a bit more before you make a move. Finally, you'd do best not to show that face to anyone else."

Bennet was a little amazed.

Taking out the whip at her waist, she hit it once against the ground. As a sound rang out that made it clear that would hurt if it hit, Rudel took a stance with his wood sword.

Looking at Bennet's whip, he recalled Eunius' magic sword. That one made movements like a whip, but here he was dealing with a real whip. As he mulled over how he should handle it, Bennet's whip came at him as if it were a living being.

"But at this level!"

His wood sword became a magic sword, letting off light. But the blade was easily entangled by the whip, destroyed just so easily as well.

"You should've put up the magic sword sooner. Well if you did, I'd have taken some countermeasures, but... do you want to continue?"

On Bennet's voice, Rudel stepped in to respond.

If the sword was no good, then magic. If magic was no good, then his bare hands...

That was Rudel's style.

"You've got spirit, but your movements are too straightforward."

Bennet tossed aside her whip, shifting her body just a little to avoid Rudel's fist. In that moment, a few strands of her hair were severed, carried off by the wind, and Bennet opened her eyes wide.

In the next instant, her knee had found its place in Rudel's solar plexus. On that knee hammered in with his own forward momentum, Rudel was instantly grasping for breath. Even so, he didn't fall to his knees, so Rudel was quite outside the norm himself.

"Even if I held back, it's usual to collapse there, but... this is the end."

With Bennet tripping him up, Rudel found himself collapsed face-up on the ground.



"For Rudel to be played with like that..."

Making an unbelieving expression, it seemed Millia didn't want to believe there was that great of a gap in ability. The usually adorable Bennet's abilities were certainly worthy of a dragoon.

While Izumi really didn't want to, she struck up a conversation with Keith to ask about Bennet.

"How is Major Bennet ability-wise? Is she high up in the dragoons, or..."

On Izumi's query, Keith looked over the collapsed Rudel as he answered. It was blatantly obvious he was begrudgingly answering, but Izumi held it in.

"Yeah, you'd find her faster, counting from the top. Of course, when it comes to comprehensive score, I'm higher than her."

"You're stronger than the Major?"

While Izumi thought it strange for the lieutenant to be stronger, the individual sounded certain, so she decided to believe. She didn't think he'd lie about something like that.

"Is that not what I just said? Do you have ears on that head? That woman over there was personally trained by the current captain and vice-captain... how envious. When they only ever took me on once."

Irritated, Izumi sent her eyes back towards Rudel to find Bennet nursing him. To be honest, she never thought there would be such a gap in abilities. At this point, Bennet looked much more Major-like than ever before.

"Next is the aerial battle."

The two of them called their dragons and began a battle in the sky.

But the match was over in no time.

"... He lost."

"That he did."

Confirming Sakuya falling towards the ground, the two thought over that previous battle. The only impression they got was that Sakuya had completely lost an upfront confrontation.

"Dammit! If the captain and vice-captain were closing in on me, just who am I supposed to choose!? That charmer in his prime, or the vice-captain and his villainous face... ah, I!... I'm!"

Watching Keith make a ruckus all on his own, Izumi's eyes had turned considerably cold.

"Izumi, what's wrong? You've been a bit scary since yesterday."

Seeing Millia, who didn't think anything, even looking at Keith, Izumi hardened her resolve. She had to do something about it herself.



As Rudel looked after Sakuya, Bennet descended to the ground. She didn't ask him anything about that previous fight.

"Get in some rest. Your dragon shouldn't have suffered any major damage."

'Well, I did hold back.'

"Sakuya. Are you alright, Sakuya!"

'My head hurts! A tail straight to the face!'

While Rudel frantically stroked Sakuya's head, to Bennet, for some reason it looked like he was depressed. Not over the loss, it felt like it was coming from something else entirely.

"How is that, Sakuya, does it feel good?"

'Not at all. It tickles.'

"... I-I see."

(... He looks kinda depressed, but how am I supposed to cheer him up?)

A troubled Bennet called out to Keith. There, he rushed over with speed he had never shown before.

"You called?"

On his light tone, Bennet's tail slumped powerlessly to the ground.

She wanted him to treat her just a bit more like a superior. Despite being from a noble household, he happily worked shirtless in the dirt, alongside the town residents, and he even went out drinking with the men. While Keith was always spreading smiles around, he didn't seem to hold particularly favorable emotions towards her.

The battalions they were affiliated with were different, so to be more precise, she was not his superior officer. But they were among the few dragoons who possessed water dragons, so they were often together on missions.

"After they get some rest, I'll leave it to you. First off, have a one-on-one with Rudel and—"

"I don't want to. I want him to see me at my most beautiful. Therefore, I'll start with the aerial battle."

Seeing Keith's glare that showed he definitely wouldn't yield, Bennet fell into a slump, consenting without letting it show on her face.

"... Got it. Do what you want. Rudel, next you'll be having an aerial battle with Keith."

"... Understood."

On his knees, with both hands against the ground, Rudel stood and corrected his posture before giving an orderly reply. Bennet was deeply moved, her tail wagging left and right.

Chapter 120

Putting in a midday break, Rudel leapt onto Sakuya's back and fose into the air.

The wide, blue sky spread out, noon had just gone by, and the light of the sun was strong. But as he looked at his foe, something like the measly sun flew out of his head.

"We're taking on a water dragon again."

'I won't lose this time.'

As Sakuya thrust her fist towards her opponent a few times, the dragon laughed. For some reason, he called out towards Rudel.

'So that kid's the aunty of the lake's favorite. I've got some hopes for you, but be careful not to get hurt. My partner's quite a troublesome one, after all.'

"Hahaha! How terrible, Spinnith."

'... And you should be especially careful.'

"I don't understand the reason, but I'll be careful."

Rudel didn't understand what Spinnith was trying to say. But thinking it would be rude to ask here, for now, he concentrated on the match. On a match with his superior, his heart was dancing. This was a world he didn't know, and there were plenty of strong people rolling around.

That only made Rudel irresistibly delighted. Delighted that there was still a higher level he could reach for.

"Then let's have some fun with it."

'You're going to aim for the rear after all.'

"He's coming, Sakuya!"

'I'll teach you a lesson for calling Mystith aunty!'

'No, I mean seriously, she's my aunt. She's my mother's sister.'

"Is that true?"

While Rudel learned an unexpected truth in the sky, with that as the signal, Keith began moving.

"Let's leave the talks at that. From here on, you need only be intoxicated by my beautiful dance!"



Looking up at the sky, the three girls and a dragon were enraptured by the movements of Keith's water dragon.

"No matter how many times I see it, he flies beautifully."

The water dragon's glassy scales caught the light and glimmered in the air. That form was one thing, but unlike Bennet's performant before, he had a sense of sharpness.

He wasn't leaving it to brute force, it was as if he was reading his opponent's every move. Reading Sakuya's movements, and easily slipping around Rudel's shields of light. While he could surely destroy them, he purposely avoided them as he slipped around to the back each time.

"Is the Lieutenant's dragon strong?"

As Millia called out to Bennet, she answered without moving her face. She wanted to watch those movements, to steal as much of that technique as she could.

"No, there's barely any difference. More so, I'm sure my partner Heleene is stronger."

'I won't lost to the young ones, and I'm mama's girl.'

As Heleene stuck out her chest, "That's right," Bennet answered. The movements of the water dragon that left behind afterimages in the air were making sport of Sakuya.

Was Keith's magic preparing doubles of water, or was it the dragon? Perhaps it wasn't either.

(Talent truly is a scary thing.)

It wasn't as if Bennet didn't have talent. But the gap was evident.

"Major, is Rudel actually weak? I can't believe it. I've never seen Rudel played with to such an extent."

On Izumi's worried voice, Bennet knew it was a misunderstanding. She worried over how she was supposed to convey it, and worried over whether she could get the point across well.

(Yeah~, teaching people really is difficult...)

So there, Bennet tried to compare her and Keith.

"Rudel is strong. To be blunt, he's stronger than me. His fighting style is still young, but if he trains, he'll surpass me in no time."

"He can even win against you?"

"Yeah. But you see, defeating Elrond in an aerial battle will be difficult. That dragon called Sakuya is unsuited to the air. And just like me, Elrond's dragon is a water dragon. Among the four variants, it's the one with the best balance."

While wild dragons were all usually stronger than gray dragons, the answer to which of the four was strongest had yet to come out. The dragoons would

all argue by emotion, and the strongest could never be determined. Of course, one's own dragon was always the strongest.

Everyone thought so. And Bennet was the same.

If she fought Keith Elrond in an aerial battle, she would lose, but she was certain her partner was stronger than Spinnith, and she thought it wouldn't lost out to any of the other species.

That was because water dragons had very few weaknesses.

As they could operate in the water, they were thought to be dragons specialized for the water. But that wasn't so.

They were simply also good in the water, that was water dragons. Slower than a wind dragon, but they could take second place in speed. Less firepower than a red dragon, but even so, second place. Less physical strength than a gaia dragon, but even there, they were second.

Therefore, even if they didn't have anything special, they excelled in balance. And from Heleene, she had heard there was a dragon who specialized in every single field.

"But he lost so easily."

Bennet answered Izumi's question as if it were only natural. But inside, she couldn't help but be anxious over whether she was properly getting the message across.

"The reason it looked like he lost so easily was because I made it look so. Don't let your opponent do what they want. Don't let them bring it to their preferred way of fighting. It's a way of fighting you can only do if you have information."

As Izumi and Millia didn't seem to get it at all, Bennet breathed out a sigh and looked at their faces. In truth, she wanted to see Keith's fighting techniques, but it was clear that teaching her two juniors was more important.

"Don't misunderstand. We dragoons are the country's elite brigade. It's downright strange for Rudel- who just graduated the academy- to be able to fight us. Graduated within the top ten of the academy. Had barely anyone who could stand against them. This is a unit filled with people like that."

"E-even so, the difference in skill is way too intense."

"Let's see. If you'll let me have my say, there's barely any difference between Rudel and me. No, if it just comes down to power, swordplay and magic, that guy clearly has the upper hand. In that sense, I'm weaker."

Seeing the two still couldn't understand, Bennet was starting to panic. Just being stronger means victory, explaining it wasn't so simple was quite difficult.

"What that guy lacks is experience... something more technical."



Out of breath, Rudel sent a sidelong glance to Keith and Spinnith encroaching from behind as he produced his shields. While their numbers climbed to a few dozen, as if slipping straight through, his foe kept chase with barely the slightest movements.

The most detestable thing was how he always maintained a set distance as he followed behind.

"You should never show your dragon's rear. Otherwise, it's an easy target."

'When you say it, it takes on a whole new meaning.'

"Hahaha! Now try putting up some more resistance!"

"Kuh! (I never thought he could be so strong. What makes us so different!)"

On top of the fact his attacks showed no sign of hitting, his opponent didn't even try to make use of the terrain. It was as if he was taunting Rudel.

Before an overwhelming gap in abilities, Rudel felt a different sense of crisis from when he faces the captain.

While Rudel was delighted if his abilities even put him at the bottom, when Sakuya was involved, that changed things. His heart was starting to panic, would he be unable to protect Sakuya? He was treasuring her too much.

'Quit following us from behind!'

Sakuya turned all the way around, but in that instant, Spinnith had transferred behind her. Before Sakuya could turn, he had already started mobbing.

(We're being read?)

Played around with in the air, Rudel and Sakuya were unable to raise a hand to Keith and Spinnith.

With Heleene, Sakuya had the slight hope that something would happen if only her attacks would connect, but now she began holding fear towards their opponents.

'Don't get close to meeee!'

'Now that's just a mean thing to say.'

Against an opponent with leisure, Rudel and Sakuya were being manipulated in their own desperation.



"They're starting to panic. Their movements are growing worse, so they're only falling further into Elrond's traps."

"Is that some sort of magic?"

Millia directed her eyes at the fight in the sky as she asked the question. Bennet saw that even an amateur's eyes could see that gap in strength as she continued on the previous explanation.

"You could call it individual difference if you want. When you call it talent, don't you think it always comes off as mean?"

"... You mean to say Rudel has no talent?"

On Izumi's thoughtful face, Bennet shook her head.

"Like hell someone who became a dragoon could go at it without any talent. What I'm trying to say is that individual differences definitely exist. It's the same with the races. Us beast type demi-humans have especially high physical abilities. But we have low magic. That elf has below-average physical abilities, but her mana is clearly higher than a human's right?"

"W-well, yeah."

When Millia conceded that her race was indeed like that, Bennet continued on with the conversation.

"You have a sister in the dragoons, right? Major Lilim."

"Yes."

When talks turned to her sister, Millia's expression became serious. Izumi also listened in with deep intrigue.

"If you asked whether or not Lilim has talent, a majority of people would say yes. And if you ask about Cattleya, everyone will chime in to say she's a genius. I don't think that's mistaken. Especially Cattleya, her abilities have been growing amazingly lately."

Bennet recalled how the unmotivated Cattleya had shown some considerable mettle as a dragoon. IT was a good thing that she had grown earnest these past few years, as her abilities had grown alongside it.

From the start, even if she wasn't the slightest bit motivated, if you taught her, she's be able to do it. What a human would spend a few years to learn, in a month, or even a day she'd acquire it. That could be called nothing shord of genius.

"Um... how is that related to Rudel?"

"Yeah, let's see. Meaning, what I'm trying to say is that he's the same, and from the eyes of those around him, he's got talent. It's only natural. It would be strange for someone without talent to be among the elites. If you don't have talent, then even before it comes to that, no dragon would recognize you."

"But Rudel's circumstances are a bit different—"

"Right. But if you ask me, that's something you can only say in hindsight. Before someone strong, everyone will always look back and say they have talent. (Ah, no! This talk is proceeding in a strange directionnnn! What I'm trying to say is that it isn't talent, it's form!)"

While she was sure she had failed, Bennet still tried to convey it to the two.

"What I'm trying to say is that Rudel is plenty a monster himself. Just by putting in a bit of experience, that guy will run straight passed me in no time. To be blunt, just by teaching him the knack and a few techniques, he'll already be on another level. That's the sort of strength he needs."

Bennet forcefully dragged the conversation back on topic and said what she was trying to say.

"Talent has no meaning if it isn't polished. And the time we have to polish it is limited."

"You mean you don't have the time to train?"

Bennet felt like bursting into laughter at Izumi's question, but she endured it and recovered.

"No, I'm saying we don't have the time to aim to be the best. Life is short, after all. So I, and Elrond, and Lilim and Cattleya... we dragoons all have to search for our own form."

Just as Bennet had polished her own strength, Keith had polished his aerial prowess. If you asked which was better, it depended on time and situation.

It wasn't as if there weren't missions where she'd be acting alone, so you couldn't say Bennet's decision was wrong.

Many dragoons would choose the same route as Keith. That was simply how powerful a dragon was. To control them as best as possible, a large number of training hours were required. As a result, one would need to make a choice.

... About their path, and the path they would take as a dragoon.

"The dragoons are the knights who, by possessing a dragon, have expanded their options. But in exchange, there are things they have no choice but to throw away. In this match, I hoped Rudel might see what he wanted to become. It isn't something to be told by another, I want him to choose his own form."

The three and one dragon looked up into the sky to see a number of water orbs exploding, and Sakuya plummeting. Once the match ended, the area was flooded out.

(Everyone looks up to the competent knights strong even up in the sky, but that's impossible. Cattleya-chan wasted a few years, so I don't know if she'll be able to do both.)

Seeing a soaked Rudel and Sakuya collide with the ground, Bennet held a bit of hope. Without talent Cattleya held, or the magical prowess or time gifted to Lilim. Such was Rudel, but...

Unable to stand up to her feeble self, and unable to stand up to Elrond, but...

(If he does manage to do it, I guess you can't call it talent anymore.)

... He somehow looked like he could surmount it all.



While the party wanted to return already, Rudel's match with Keith still remained.

But Keith didn't seem up to it.

"It's already late, so can't we return? The sun's already going down"

"What are you talking about? We still have plenty of time left. And it'll be over in an instant, so time is irrelevant."

(So that's how big the gap is between me and the Lieutenant... but I have no choice but to accept it.)

Rudel hit both hands against his face to psyche himself up, and a worried Izumi and Millia called over to him. Perhaps they couldn't stand to see a beaten Rudel any longer.

"Now let's do this, Lieutenant!"

When Rudel wrung out his voice, Izumi and Millia reluctantly took distance. And before Bennet could say anything, Keith stood before Rudel. In his hand, he gripped a wooden sword.

"Hmm, when you've said that much, I can't quite keep silent myself."

Keith's partner dragon looked worried for some reason. Bennet also took distance with a tired face. But for some reason, everyone was closer than they had been in the match with Bennet.

'Don't go too crazy.'

(Is there really that much of a gap? He definitely is famous...)

While looking into the dragoons, information on Keith had entered Rudel's ears a number of times. He was feared by his own squad members, so he was surely strong.

Takign a stance with his wood sword, he concentrated and gazed at Keith.

"Now! Come at me however you like!"

"Here I come!"



"LIIIEEUUTEENNNAAAANNTTT!"

Rudel had taken Keith out in the first blow. Izumi and the others could only watch as Rudel held him up in his arms and cried out.

"See, it ended in no time, didn't it?"

"... Um, Major Bennet. Is Lieutenant Elrond, um..."

Izumi seemed troubled with her words, but Bennet waidd it plainly.

"Yeah, he's ridiculously weak. When it comes to one-on-one fights, he's the absolute lowest rank among the dragoons."

There, Millia stepped into their conversation. Perhaps she couldn't believe the sight before her eyes as she drew closer to Bennet.

"But just a moment ago, he said his comprehensive rank was higher than yours."

Bennet crossed her arms and tilted her head. It was Izumi's little secret that those gestures healed her soul.

"Yeah, sure enough, in the comprehensive ranking, I think he was higher. I mean, in aerial battles, he's in the top five, so I'm sure his rank is higher than me. About one or two spots higher."

Seeing the collapsed Keith, Izumi's gaze turned cold.

Completely specialized towards piloting a dragon, Keith definitely carried a higher ranking than Bennet. But compared to Bennet who could pull off both land and air combat, Izumi couldn't help but hold Keith's placing in doubt.

(I hate myself for ever fearing him.)

From that day forth, Izumi sword to protect Rudel from Keith through the use of physical means.

"Izumi, you've been acting strange lately."

"Y-yes, she's definitely scary."

Seeing Millia and Bennet fearful of her, Izumi mulled over just how she was to convey Keith's level of danger.



A few days later, Rudel stopped by Bennet.

It was already late into the night, but he had eaten through all his takeout. He dropped by at a time where he thought Izumi and Millia would already be asleep.

"Is it good?"

"Yes!"

Chowing down on the leftovers of dinner, Rudel cut into the main reason he came over. While it was true he had run out of takeout, if he felt like it, he could dive into the sea and take another fish out.

There was a reason he came to Bennet without doing that.

"Major, I want to become stronger."

At Rudel's words, Bennet folded her arms in her pajamas and sat in her chair. Today, she was wearing bear-print sleeping garments. She even had a hat.

"You're already plenty strong. And there's little I'll be able to teach you. The knack for battle, and the techniques are something you need to pick up in real combat."

"I don't mind! If that's what will make me stronger, I'll learn any technique."

Bennet took Rude's empty bowl, poured in the leftover soup from the saucepan, and handed it over to Rudel.

"I don't mind teaching you. But are you sure? Rather than my techniques, if you simply train yourself, you'll be able to become strong."

There, Rudel downed another bowl of soup before answering.

"I don't mind. I'll just be training more. I'll learn the techniques and train myself as well."

Bennet rubbed the corners of her eyes, a tired look on her face. But after letting out a sigh, she looked just a little down and laughed.

Seeing that expression, Rudel was surprised that his strict leader had smiled.

"What a greedy noble. Well, that's just about right for you noble lot... you better prepare yourself for tomorrow. And Elrond!"

"What?"

Casually appearing, Keith opened the door and entered Bennet's kitchen. While Rudel was also surprised, Bennet who called for him was holding her head.

Perhaps she never thought he would be there, or she hated how it was exactly what she expected. Rudel was unable to tell.

"I never thought you would actually come, but... well, whatever. From tomorrow onwards, you're accompanying Rudel's training. You have no right to de—"

"I'll be harsh starting tomorrow. Why don't you go to sleep early, Rudel?"

While Bennet was in the middle of talking, Keith still followed her orders, so while Bennet seemed a little unsatisfied, she nodded.

Once Rudel learned the two of them would be training him, he brightened up and stood. And he lowered his head.

"I'll be in your care!"

"Leave it to me."

"Yeah, in that case, lead the way to the bed..."

The moment Keith made a pass, the door to the kitchen was violently opened. Wearing her sleep-wear pajama, Izumi appeared with her katana in hand. Three sets of eyes gathered; Bennet was a little surprised, while Keith took a step back at her expression.

Her neck a little tilted, Izumi who appeared expressionlessly, alongside the darkness of the room, it was exceedingly terrifying.

But Rudel alone was...

"Listen to this, Izumi! From tomorrow onwards My commanding officers will be helping my train. With this, I can become stronger again."

As Rudel delightedly reported, Izumi smiled. Unlike her prior expressionlessness, and the slight hair stuck fast to her skin, right now, she joined Rudel in his celebration.

"Good for you, Rudel. And could you wait a minute? I need to have a talk with that illegal trespasser."

Her smile reverted to an expressionless state, and while Rudel and Bennet frantically stopped Izumi as she pulled her blade from her sheath, Keith made an irritated face as he retreated.

Chapter 120.1: New year special 2

Aleist: "Maan, it's time to start the second half."

Albach: "That sure was long. It almost feels like we took a few weeks of break."

Ciel: "Truly long."

Aleist: "Then let's answer some questions. This one's about the water dragon Heleene-san, it seems. Last time, it seems we misspelled it Helene."

Heleene: "Seriously, cut me some slack."

Aleist: "Anyways, could you tell us the truth behind that 'mama' statement you made?"

Heleene: "That's simple. I was born before mama met Marty, and I'm Mystith's daughter. Mind you, even if I look like this, I'm no older than two hundred, you hear."

Albach: "When it comes to two hundred years ago, sure enough, Marty was only just born... blasted Demon of Courtois."

Heleene: "Ever since mama met Marty and stopped laying eggs, I was always surrounded by relatives. In human terms, I guess Spinnith is something like a cousin to me."

Aleist: "I don't know who this Spinnith-san is, but let's move onto the next question."

Ciel: "Right. Next is... this is a question about Aileen and Fina. The answer to that would be a spoiler, so let's just skip it and go onto, 'Just what sort of

terrifying things did support hero Pink do to be called the demon lord?"

Albach: "That's from a different work, but let's just have the individual come in and answer. Lyne-san, what did you do?"

(TL: This is the author's previous work. I haven't actually read it, and since it's censored like that, I can't guarantee the accuracy of the translation.)

Lyne: "I'm the main heroine of The Support Hero Wants to Shine! Lyne's my name. I really am happy someone remembers me—"

Ciel: "Can you hurry it up? (Just looking at her is irritating. It's like she'll devour me up if I show the slightest opening.)"

Lyne (Smiling): "... Let's see. About that question, the answer will be a spoiler, so I'll show some restraint, but when I was trying to _____'s _____ with a pair of scissors, I missed and ended up _____ off _____. At the end, I tried to _____ it back on with _____, and everyone went quiet."

Albach: "... I can only hope Fina doesn't turn out like this. Aleist-kun, you should really be careful. No, seriously!"

Aleist (shaking): "M-my _____ hasn't grown in, so... l-let's go onto the next question."

Lyne: "Oh, when I've finally made an appearance, how unfortunate."

Ciel: "The personality of Aileen's favorite little dragoon Fritz? You want to know something like that?"

Albach: "He's generally a docile dragon, I think. When selecting the royal guard captain, we made sure it was a dragon without a rough temperament so we could get it to select Rudel. Otherwise, I'd have misgivings about the formation of the royal guard."

Aleist: "I see, so he's obedient... next is one for Rudel and Fina-sama. Let's start off with Fina-sama."

Fina (expressionless): "What could it be?"

Aleist: "Does Fina-sama really like Rudel? Or is she just using him without any feelings of love or affection? That's the question."

Fina: "How rude. I love my master's petting more than anyone in the world. If it's for that sake, then this body of mine is but a trivial price to..."

Ciel: "Fina, come around to my (punishment) room later."

Fina: "— I-IiiiiIIIII love him. My debt of gratitude from when he saved me, I shall never forget it for the rest of my life!"

Aleist: "How dubious. Perhaps she loves him because she can use him?"

Albach: "But couldn't you also take it as she uses him because she loved him? Well, she's royalty, so it's much easier if she doesn't have such feelings as love and affection. Otherwise, you go through troubles like Aileen's."

Aleist: "Is it that troublesome?"

Albach: "That's right. Even if you fall into a love beyond status, if you don't receive the blessings of those around, there's nothing you can do about it. I can't think that Aileen's love will let her overcome any serious troubles, after all. I feel bad for Fritz, but the two of them will have to give up on one another."

Aleist: "I really don't understand that area. If they love each other, then I don't think it should be a problem. That's the bad part of noble society!"

Fina (whisper): "And that's why you're no good at all."

Aleist: "Huh? Did you just say something?"

Fina: "No, nothing... do your best at your job, black knight (lol)."

Aleist: "Now then, here's our last question."

Albach: "So it's here."

Ciel: "The man himself takes center stage."

Rudel: "... Is something the matter?"

Aleist: "It's a question for Rudel! More importantly, isn't your face a bit red?"

Rudel: "In the waiting time, I went for a drink with Luecke and Eunius. You remember that little stall from before? We went and talked about how things were going, but you were on the clock, after all."

Albach: "Those sorts of relations sure are nice."

Ciel: "I'm sure it's different from female friends... so why does our black knight look so depressed?"

Aleist: "I wanted to go to the stall and make a ruckus over stupid things too. God, there's nothing but women around me, but it really drives you mad."

Albach: "So you plan to laying hands on a man next time?"

Aleist: "I ain't lain hands on anybody!"

In the outer reaches of the kingdom

Elrond: (I get the feeling someone just called for me. It's the premonition of new love.)

Spinnith: 'Yeah, no.'

Rudel: "So what is it you want to talk about?"

Ciel: "Rudel, what do you think about the women? First off... how about Aileen and Fina?"

Rudel: "The princesses? I think Aileen is pretty. Fina's just my disciple, and I think I should be stricter on her."

Fina (hiding behind a wall): "Master... but I'm not going to lose!"

Ciel: "It seems they're not even up for consideration. Next up, how do you feel about Fina's followers, Sophina and Mii."

Rudel: "Yeah~, I can only pray that Sophina-san finds a special someone sometime soon. For Mii, I really want her to stop pampering my disciple."

Ciel: "Rudel... Fina is technically a princess."

Rudel: "I know. I won't call her my disciple in any official context."

Ciel: "I'll say it again. Even if she's like that, she's a princess."

Rudel: "I know?"

Ciel: "(This is hopeless)... let's move on. What about the women of the dragoons?"

Rudel: "They're the best! They're all so beautiful, and I think flying through the sky with them is true happiness."

Ciel: "You mean you love them as a member of the opposite sex?"

Rudel: "I adore them, what of it?"

Ciel: "... This somehow feels more like he's viewing them as idols. I feel a bit of pity for them. Let's hear your individual impressions."

Rudel: "Lieutenant Cattleya is always thorny towards me, but there are times when she's kind. It's just, there are also times she uses unreasonable violence, so I want her to do something about that."

Ciel: "I see... that's mostly your fault. Next."

Rudel: "Major Lilim is always so dignified. When we met a while back, she was going through a dark elf phase, but I think black flames really are kickass."

Ciel: "Never say that in front of her. You can't gouge out her heart too much. Next."

Rudel: "Enora is a precious friend. While quite a bit happened when we first became colleagues, at this point, we're close friends. We get along well."

Ciel (wiping a tear): "Not a single millimeter of those feelings got across, I see. Just move it along."

Rudel: "Major Bennet can do everything, and she's even perfect in her private life, so I really admire her. She's truly the ideal superior."

Ciel: "Next time you see her, make sure you say that to her face. Now then, how do you feel about Millia?"

Rudel: "We've been working together since we left the academy. We lived under the same roof a while, and while she's harsh on cleaning, she's a precious friend."

Ciel: "Aleist-dono, you're harsh on cleaning as well. Well, when you've been put on cleaning duty for more than half a year, I'm sure there'd be some change... but even so, your capture difficulty is way too high."

Rudel: "Is that so?"

Ciel: "Let's move onto the final human. What do you think of Izumi?"

Rudel: "I love her."

Ciel: "That was fast. Then marriage is..."

Rudel: "Out of the question."

Ciel: "I understand the reason, but try saying it."

Rudel: "As a noble, my marriage holds greater meaning, and it isn't something to be decided by my will alone. I cannot treat Izumi as a

mistress, and I would never be able to forgive myself if I did... of all else, I want Izumi to find happiness."

Ciel: "I see, a wonderful decision. Moving onto the dragons—"

Rudel (serious): "If it was permitted, I'd like to ride all of the dragons!"

Ciel: "You put so much into those words, it's creeping me out a bit."

Rudel: "But I love Sakuya, so I'm not going to cheat."

Ciel: "Is that really cheating?"

Rudel: "Of course it is. What could you possibly be talking about?"

Ciel (Why is he making a, 'you don't even know that?' face and pitying me? I can't accept it, or rather, I can't comprehend. More importantly, how about Aleist and Alback.)

Aleist: "When keeping a single woman company is so harsh, seven is just impossible, you know."

Alback: "There are times you'd want to play. For now, it seems you're only looking at one, but if you live long enough..."

Ciel: "Haha, then Rudel, go and answer the last question."

Rudel: "Very well. 'Will the main character have a happy ending?' you ask? Well of course, the answer to that would be a spoiler, so I can't give it! That is all, the end. As I am now, I'm plenty happy. "

Ciel: "Well then, I pray you all spend this year in good health, and here ends the question corner."

Rudel: "... Aleist, shouldn't you say something at the end?"

Ciel: "Leave him be. This is why he's no good."

Chapter 121

In the port town of Beretta, a tattered Rudel crawled out of the sea.

A rough breath, and large movements seemed painful on his body. But Rudel's face was smiling.

"It was a harsh battle... but I won the match!"

Holding a spear up high, he hoisted his spoils high to the heavens. There, a fish much larger than Rudel's body- still very much alive- was thrashing about.

While they could see the young man holding up a fish that surpassed four meters in size, those around were putting out an atmosphere as if to say, 'He's at it again'. The town residents who had suspended their work for a meal were beginning to return their eyes to their lunch.

What Rudel saw was Bennet and Millia, lunch boxes spread out before them as they ate their meal. From how the contents were the same, he inferred they were both made by Bennet.

Rudel had once eaten Millia's homemade food, but from the nice appearance of the lunch boxes' contents, he determined they had to come from Bennet. Millia's cooking was, according to Keith, 'biodegradable waste', apparently. To Rudel who could eat anything, he thought that was a bit too cruel, but he did remember it didn't taste very good.

"... What are you doing?"

As Bennet stared at him blankly, still in his undergarments, Rudel began using his sword to disembowel the fish. He answered normally.

"I ran out of take out, so I've switched to local sourcing."

As Rudel replied with a straight face, Bennet could only say, "I see." While she sent him a bit of a pitying look, Rudel returned to preparing his meal.

"It never occurred to me that someone would locally source their lunch. And isn't the water cold this time of year?"

Having lately grown accustomed to Rudel's eccentric actions, Millia was taking some fleeting glances at Rudel's body. But when he suddenly jumped into the sea during lunch break, she never thought that would actually be to secure lunch. She was a little fed-up.

Raising a fire with magic, he began roasting the fish when Sakuya and the dragons took notice of it.

'That fish is a tasty one, right?'

'It's delicious, right?'

'There aren't too many of them around, right?'

"... There's no helping it."

As a result, only a meager portion remained in Rudel's hand. Even so, it was more than enough for a single person to eat.

Biting down grandly over the red flesh of the fish that looked practically like a high-class steak, Rudel looked over the construction of the port.

The birds swooped down to clean up the intestines he had discarded. Under the blue sky that expanded over the port town, the piercing light of the sun was blinding.

"It's getting along quite well."

Bennet answered Rudel's muttering. While he hadn't said what he was referring to, as one who had helped out in the work, she understood what he was trying to say.

"If you use a dragon, the work goes forward. While we're behind schedule, it shouldn't take too long at this rate. If the plan proceeds favorably, the port's construction will be complete, and we'll take over the work of some other brigade member and head to the site of our next mission."

"Major, you're moving away?"

At Millia's fluster, Bennet wags her tail. Rudel wanted her to teach him many more things, and that would be troubling. He headed off towards Bennet.

"Don't misunderstand. A port isn't something constructed too quickly. There's at least another year left to go."

While both Rudel and Millia were relieved, Rudel was delighted over the training he received. Meanwhile, Millia was more relieved about the food.

Neither Izumi nor Millia were able to cook like Bennet. When looked upon from the side, they were completely being led along with food. The only one who didn't notice that were the three being baited and Bennet.

"Hah, after this break, Elrond should be coming to help out with the work. You'll be training with me in the afternoon, Rudel."

"Yes, Major!"

As Rudel rejoiced, Millia whispered under her breath.

"That's all well and good, but put on some clothes already."



The training was generally carried out near Sakuya's den.

The fact there were no people around, and they wouldn't be a hindrance to the port's development had already been confirmed, so they made use of that fact.

At the same time, Bennet was calculating to try and make this wasteland as habitable for humans as possible. When the scale of the town increased, there was nothing lost in having as much exploitable land as possible.

(Is it about time to have her make a den somewhere else?)

By having Sakuya live there, what was once a desolate landscape of rocks was now starting to sprout weeds. While the gaia subspecies was generally thought of as useless, when it came to transporting large cargo and mending the soil, they were way too capable.

And their armoring and power were top class among the dragons.

"Major... I finished running."

A sweat-stained Rudle returned to Bennet. Running along the terrible footing of the crags and mountains had been added to his basic training.

That was the beast tribe's standard training, but with his high physical abilities, Rudel was able to carry it out with a bit of pain.

"I see. Then today, let's work on your special skills."

"My specials?"

"Now bring out that shield of light thing of yours."

When Bennet issued her orders, Rudel stored power in his left hand. A little later, a shield of light manifested in the air.

(... That really is convenient. Moving a shield around by his will.)

If Bennet simply wanted to make Rudel stronger, she had determined there wouldn't be a problem if he continued firmly training his foundation as he always had. Eventually, he would be able to beat her even if he just brute forced his way through. But it was true if he polished some technical skills, he would be able to aim higher.

"Is concentrating power in that left hand your hobby? In that case, you should stop at once. You create too large a gap, and you're merely informing your opponent of your next move."

In essence, Bennet was able to prevent Rudel from using his shield and light bolts by keeping it so he couldn't focus his attention on his left hand. It was too easy to cancel out.

"... I think that's possible, but with my style, I can't help but focus my power on my left hand."

Seeing Rudel lost in thought as he looked at his left hand, Bennet nodded a, sure enough, in her heart. As he generally held a sword in his right hand, Rudel had a habit of invoking magic in his open left.

"If you can substitute something else, then do it. At the very least, make it so you can focus your attention on anywhere in your body."

To test it out, Rudel started with his right hand, and with a slightly greater lag than his left hand, a shield of light took shape. Throwing one of her boomerangs at it and seeing how easily it was destroyed, Bennet was convinced.

(The quality's fallen much further than the ones he makes with his left. But I should see this as room for improvement.)

After thinking a while, Bennet issued Rudel an order.

"Rudel, henceforth, we'll be training every day so you can make a shield from anywhere. What's more, a small, strengthened one. After that, we'll make it so you can move them freely."

Rudel tilted his head.

"I can already move them well enough."

Seeing Rudel rotate the shield he made, amazing, Bennet thought as she let out a sigh, and did her best to create a mocking air.

"Are you an idiot? I'm telling you that you have to be able to produce stronger shields. Try making them the size of the palm of your hand. It would be even better if you can discard the shield shape entirely."

"Discard the shape?"

"Even if you call them shields, based on how you use them, they can be weapons as well. You've used them like that a number of times, right?"

"You're right."

(If he can raise the quality of his shields, that would be plenty, but it would be even better if he can give them a new form.)

Seeing Rudel recall something, Bennet thought back over Rudel's data. While he was using them as shields, from the eyes of those around, at the very point they floated without him having to hold them, it could only be said they were exceedingly versatile.

What's more, Cattleya had witnessed Rudel riding his shield over the water's surface. There was no need to fixate on the shape of a shield. When he could think up a use for it like that, Bennet couldn't understand why he would fixate on that form.

(Hah, the captain's pushed a tough one onto me... but for the sake of my cute subordinate, I have to do my best!)

Bennet recalled what she felt when she first looked over Rudel's data. Even since Rudel awakened as the white knight, he had devoted an exceedingly large amount of time towards controlling that power. While the forceful parts stood out a bit, he had changed from his early days where he had focused on technique.

(The reason he's so mismatched is surely because he awakened.)

When he had always been worried over his lack of power, when that was bettered, this time he was on the verge of becoming a power type. The individual himself couldn't keep up with those changes.

(In that case, what he needs right now is... a change of style? No, if we raise his base and give him enough control over it, that should be best.)

From Bennet's point of view, Rudel was full of pointless action. That abundant pointlessness was the cause of his loss.

(The captain definitely pushed him onto me because it was a pain, right?)

Recalling the captain who trained her, Bennet offered the struggling Rudel some advice.

"Rudel, when a powerful attack is coming towards you, what do you do if you can't dodge?"

"... I'd block it."

"Let's say you can't block it with your power. I'm not taking any objections."

While Rudel was about to say something, he dropped his shoulders..

"You parried my attacks a number of times. Why was that?"

"Because rather than catching the blow, that would lessen the...!"

Noticing something, Rudel began changing the shape of his shield.

"It's only natural to strengthen it, but there is no need to block every single attack. Just changing the direction of force is a considerable strength. Try using your head a bit."

"Yes!" Rudel delightfully responded, while Bennet crossed her arms and wagged her tail.



Seeing Rudel borrow Bennet's shoulder as returned, Izumi, who had taken the day off, made a face as if to say, 'this again?'

But her face was just a bit happy as she scolded him.

"He's all beaten up again."

"Pretty much. He has way too much stamina, so he always pushes it too far. It makes me tense just watching him."

Handing Rudel off to Izumi, Bennet headed to a back room to change out of her dirty garments. Lending Rudel a shoulder, Izumi sat him down in a chair,

"I-I did my best today."

"I see, good work."

"I'll get stronger tomorrow."

Looking at Rudel who was unable to stand, Izumi began preparing the meal she had cooked. The sun was setting, and thinking that Millia would be back soon as well, she put the pot over the fire.

He moved his body until it moved no more, and once he got back, he would eat and then sleep. Sleep soundly until morning came, only to leap up the next day and get back to training. It wasn't something the normal person could imitate.

Within all that, he also had to carry out paperwork and development work, so the burden on Rudel was in no ways light.

"Tomorrow, I'm training with Lieutenant Keith."

Rudel informed Izumi with a smile, and the one in question listened in with a smile as well. She already knew from the start, and she had arranged her schedule for it. Izumi was working hard not to leave Rudel and Keith along together.

(If only those two had the slightest sense of danger.)

Bennet and Millia both seemed estranged from that sort of thing, and they felt no danger at all. Izumi mulled over whether or not to tell them, but she hesitated to say such a thing to the innocent Bennet.

If she told only Millia, that would bring about the problem of making Bennet feel mindful and left out. She was strangely sensitive to that sort of thing. In a situation where she was the only one who didn't know, the way she held her anxiety was also cute, and Izumi had watched it all the way.

(... No, that's no good, me!)

Somehow crawling up from that train of thought, Izumi listened to Rudel's story as she sensed a presence. Right after that, Millia returned to Bennet's house, but Izumi had reached a hand for her nearby katana.

"I'm back... wait, what's this!"

While Millia was surprised to see Izumi holding her sword, after following her line of sight, she came to an understanding.

"Hey there, Rudel. Let's take it nice and easy with tomorrow's rendezvous."

Raising his left hand, directing a smile at Rudel, the amiable young man in appearance alone received a scary smile from Izumi.

"So you've come again, Lieutenant Elrond."

"Hahaha, it's not like this is your house, right? The owner told me to drop by now and again."

"You've casually told another lie. How many times does that make this? I confirmed it with Major Bennet, and she never said such a thing. In the first place, you only come here with eyes on Rudel, right?"

"And what of it?"

At Keith's face, completely devoid of any wrongdoing, Izumi's smile stiffened up.

"He's out of your league."

"Foolish woman, let me teach you my true strength. I'm not a dragoon for nothing! Spinnittthh!"

As Keith called for his dragon in a loud voice, Izumi braced herself. While the notion of seriously cutting him down before his dragon came crossed her mind, Keith was acting strange.

"... Eh? Eating, so you can't? I-I see."

It was a dragon's voice that Izumi couldn't hear, but she could tell what was going on. The dragon had prioritized his meal over Keith. Or perhaps it was precisely because it understood the circumstance that it refused.

It was a dragon much more decent than its contractor.

"..."

As Izumi silently stared at him, Keith averted his eyes. There, Millia lightly hit Izumi on the head.

"Quiet down."

There, Izumi noticed Rudel giving a sleeper's breath from his chair. Keith also felt sorry and decided to withdraw.

"What a wonderful sleeping face. By the grace of that face, I'll let you off tod—"

"Get going already."

Under Izumi's glare, Keith ran straight out of Bennet's house.



Meanwhile...

In the royal palace, Aleist let out a sigh as he cleaned. The room was beautifully polished, but somewhat lacking in motivation, Aleist looked out the window.

"Millia..."

The form of Aleist's powerless mutter, the members of his platoon looked at their commanding officer mulling over something. The fact he didn't look like he was worrying over a single woman was surely because of his devilish appearance.

But all of Aleist's worries came from how Millia had gone off with Rudel.

At this point, he couldn't even put his all into training. When the war event was closing in, he just couldn't work himself up. This was also largely because he didn't understand his own strength.

Aleist wasn't weak.

But as he had seen Rudel's strength, lately, he had gotten around to wondering if Rudel would just bring an end to it. You could also say that was just how large Rudel's existence was to Aleist.

But...

"Is Aleist here!?"

The one who heartily slammed open the door and entered was Eunius. Aleist worried that the dust he's pile would fly away as he halted his window wiping and approached Eunius.

"What is it? I'm really busy right now. Today, the cleaning of the noble visitor room is..."

"Fool! You're fitting in way too well!"

Having completely developed a love for cleaning, at this point, Aleist's apron fit him like a glove. And Eunius yelling at him had removed the

uniform he was usually supposed to wear. By palace rules, wearing his knight uniform was supposed to be an obligation.

"Anyways, what's up."

"It's Luecke! The bastard went and did it!"

As Enius threw a newspaper at him, Aleist wiped his hands off on his apron before reading the article. Under a large heading, a picture of Princess Aileen and Fritz had been painted.

"The Common Man's Hope, his Name is Fritz... did he always look that cool?"

As he complained the artist had made him too handsome, Eunius cried out.

"The small article under that! I told you I was talking about Luecke, you damn fool!"

Shifting his gaze below, he found an article about his former classmate Luecke Halbades.

The contents were short, but it was written that his thesis was accepted by the magic community. In the introductory statement, it was written that he was first rate as a knight as well.

"I don't really get it, but that bastard went and did something bit, so I can't keep quiet anymore. Then it came to me. Have you... ever heard of the holy sword?"

"I know about it (That thing really dragged me all over the place in-game. But while I definitely would like a holy sword, the most practical thing for the current me is...)"

"Then that makes things fast! We're off!"

"... Eh?"

"As I was saying, we're going off to search for that holy sword thingy. There are rumors that the place with the hold sword is dangerous, right? Then it'll be perfect training. Are you going to let yourself rot away here? I can't bear the thought of being overtaken by those two."

Those two were surely Rudel and Luecke.

But the current Aleist and Eunius had their duties. There's no way they could get permission for arbitrary action so quickly.

"Wait! I'm the same, but don't you have work to do? Eunius, let's all calm down and..."

"I already got permission. Look."

On the document tossed over, Aleist's platoon was officially charged with the security of Archduke Heir Eunius Diade.

"Eh? Why..."

Despite Aleist's surprise, Eunius didn't really know the specifics either, so he scratched his head and answered.

"I don't really get it, but the talk passed through. We're setting out soon, so prepare yourself. Also, if we're lucky, we might drop by Rudel's place as well."

"I'm going!"

As Aleist swiftly began to tidy up his tools, he issued orders to his subordinates and got them preparing for departure.

Looking over his nimble actions, Eunius laughed a bit, but he was so happy he didn't mind being watched.

(I can see Millia.)

When their dreams are in sight, it is only human do work harder. Aleist was no exception, and using the bait that was Millia, Eunius had hooked Aleist

into a trap.

Chapter 122

'Sakuya can do it!' "Definitely not!"

Rudel and Sakuya were having a rare quarrel. From the side, it only looked like he was trying to anger his dragon, but to Izumi who could hear her voice, it was a pleasant scene.

This all started when Bennet watched Rudel's treatment of Sakuya, and...

"Send Sakuya on an errand... Alone." "That's not happening."

When Rudel denied it with a smile, Izumi recalled how pitifully Bennet's tail slumped.

"Listen, Sakuya. The outside world is full of dangers."

(No, you're talking to the strongest dragon on land, right?)

'Uuurrh, but I can do an errand!'

(Yeah... rather than an errand, it's carrying cargo.)

Gazing over their quarrel Izumi leisurely sipped some tea as she listened to the somewhat mismatched conversation. They were on break at the moment, and Bennet also sat beside her, listening to the quarrel.

At times, she would ask Izumi to translate what was being said.

"Hah, what does he think his partner is supposed to be?"

While Izumi agreed with Bennet's sigh-mingled amazement, the fact she knew the circumstances too well meant that she couldn't say anything too

strongly against Rudel.

To Bennet, no matter how she saw it, he was going too far.

"That's not how you raise a dragon. He's being too overprotective when she had to develop some self-confidence."

"Is that so? Sakuya is technically the boss of the dragon stables, it seems."

When she heard Sakuya had become the boss of the dragon stables, Bennet's bearing wasn't exactly the best. As she contracted a rare water dragon, she was always sent around, and she hadn't been to the stables in a long while.

She probably thought to do something about that distorted environment.

Sending her out on an errand was a form of education.

"If she has that much power only a few years from her birth, I'm a bit worried for her future. For now, she has Rudel, so it won't be a problem, but in a hundred years, it will be scary when there's no one left to hold her reigns. Worse comes to worst, this country is done for."

That's going too far, thought Izumi, but as she looked over the problematic duo of Rudel and Sakuya, she grew anxious.

"If we have an older dragon look after her..."

"A dragon's sense of values is different from a human's. That's why dragoons exist. If they would abide a human's values, we would need not be any more than normal knights."

Bennet gazed at Izumi. Perhaps she hit on something as her tail swung to the side.

"I-is something the matter?"

"Very well. Special Inspector Izumi, is it not about time you went to the palace to report?"

"Eh? Oh, yes, it's about time I headed to the palace to report our present situation. I was thinking of leaving it to Millia..." "No, special inspector, I do think you should go. I'll even arrange for your transport. With this, you'll be able to cut down on time."

Bennet was looking at Sakuya, so Izumi did have a vague idea. She planned to have her send Sakuya off.

But Izumi had a reason she couldn't leave this site.

... She had to protect Rudel from Keith.

"I understand your reasoning, but I cannot quite leave my po—" "I'm sending Elrond out shopping as well."

"... I'll go."

Learning that Keith was going away, Izumi resolved herself to make for the capital with Sakuya. Bennet entrusted her with a letter to Captain Oldart.



Seen off by a depressed Rudel, Izumi had Sakuya land in the designated site near the capital.

"I'll finish my report quickly, so you have to wait quietly."

'Can I dig a hole?'

"You cannot. Once we get back, we'll ask Major Bennet for the next spot to dig."

'... Come back soon.'

The area had become rowdy, so Izumi took her documents and headed for the palace. She was to give a regular report to the captain of the high knights, but she had come with bad timing, and both the captain and her superior officer were out.

As she stood troubled in the hallway, she noticed she couldn't spot Aleist and his platoon, who were usually somewhere around, cleaning.

(Last time I was here, this was about the time they cleaned the hallways... were they given another mission?)

The way things were, she wouldn't be able to return within the day. As she stood troubled, she spotted the dragoon captain and vice-captain coming from the opposite side of the hall, so she raised a hand and approached.

The captain Olart smiled, raising his right hand in greeting, but Vice-Captain Alejandro made a troubled face.

"Hey there, little lady. You look like you're doing well."

"Yes. It has been a while, dragoon captain."

"How stiff. Well whatever, Sakuya-chan's here, right? I don't see the future archduke around, but is he off somewhere?"

Wondering if they had been out looking for Rudel, Izumi answered normally.

"No this time, it's just me and Sakuya. Rudel is keeping house."

On Izumi's joke-mingled response, the vice-captain covered his face with his right hand. Seeing Izumi's face as she wondered what she had done wrong, Oldart informed her of the reason.

"You haven't noticed? It's not a good idea to show a dragon following someone besides their contractor. Who's decision was it?"

"... M-my apologies."

"From that look, it doesn't look like it was you. In that case... it's not Rudel, so probably Bennet-chan?"

Oldart called Bennet with an added -chan. There, Alejandro gave a reluctant mutter.

"That's why I said I didn't want to leave him with Bennet."

"It's not going to help anyone, saying something like that so late in the game. And when we discussed how we didn't have anyone besides Bennet-chan we could leave him with, you couldn't say a thing. You just nodded."

The sight of the dragoon top dogs arguing was a troubling one. Izumi began to worry over whether the actions she had thought so little over would develop into a massive problem. But Oldart smiled and reassured her.

"Ah, you don't have to worry. It's just in bad taste, but these sorts of things happen quite a bit. You see, every time this happens, the folks who want to try taming a dragon start to make a ruckus."

Unlike Oldart, Alejandro was making a tired face.

"And we're the ones who have to deal with it."

They sure are troublesome, said Oldart as he directed an eye to the documents in Izumi's hands. Once he realized it was a report, he offered to hold onto them for her. While she wondered if she should really show them to someone who wasn't her superior, once she heard her boss was on a long-term business trip, she decided to entrust them.

They were documents Oldart was supposed to look through anyway, and he said he would explain the situations surrounding them.

Relieved, Izumi asked about the two dragoons stationed in the port town of Beretta.

"Bennet-chan and Keith?"

"Yes. I don't know much, or rather, I don't know a thing about them."

Exchanging a glance, Oldart and Alejandro made a look as if wondering how they were supposed to explain it. Izumi did seem curious, so Oldart led her to the dragoons' office in the palace.



Leading Izumi and Alejandro to that room in the palace, Oldart had a subordinate prepare tea and sat Izumi down on the sofa.

"Telling you about them would be easy, but before that, I guess I'll ask. Young lady, how do those two look to you?"

While Oldart seemed to be testing Izumi before her eyes, Alejandro didn't show any particular reaction. He reached a hand for the sweets the servants of the palace had prepared.

"Major Bennet is, um... a reliable one. But Lieutenant Elrond is..."

That was close to the answer he expected, and Oldart gave a grand laugh. There was definitely no mistake in their rankings. Their quirks were just too strong, that most people would always mistake them. It was always like that.

"A cute commanding officer, and a dangerous manlover, is the impression you got, right? That's not a mistake, you don't have to worry."

"I-I see."

Perhaps thinking she was being teased, he sensed Izumi put up her guard, so Oldart cut into the main topic.

"Well, this is a perfect opportunity. I wanted someone who knew the situation."

"Is that really alright?"

When Alejandro entered the conversation, Oldart only nodded.

If Rudel and Sakuya opened their hearts to her, Oldart determined it wouldn't be a problem. What's more, he had looked into Rudel and Izumi.

When he sighted Sakuya today, Oldart had decided he would talk.

"This is something they themselves haven't been informed of, but you know how the area around the border's been noisy lately?"

"N-no."

Seeing Izumi surprised at the sudden change of topic, Oldart continued on.

"Well, it seems someone's wary, so we decided to station the strongest forces we had on hand. But there are quite a few folks who would grow noisy if we stationed so many around the border, so we decided to place our strongest dragoons in land and air at the port town of Beretta, where it's close enough to send reinforcements."

"And that's those two?"

"They don't look it, right? But they really are our trump card."

While Oldart gave a laugh, Alejandro made a somber face. While he didn't want to admit it, their capabilities were certain.

Extending a hand to the documents, he started to explain. Things were going largely as he had expected. If he wanted to train Rudel, then rather than sticking him under some half-baked instructor, he had decided to put him under the strongest dragoons in active service.

The fact he was blessed with an opportunity, he saw it as a true stroke of good luck. Those two that led around rare water dragons were exceedingly busy. Their mission sites were often close to the border, and they rarely ever returned to the capital.

This was coupled with his personal desire to not have Keith come back.

Having stepped down from active duty, the former captain and vice-captain didn't have the stamina left in them to train someone as out of the norm as Rudel. And those two were already training the members that had caught their eyes. They thought he would have no choice but to train on his own.

But there, among the active dragoons, the strongest on land Bennet, and the strongest air fighter Keith got together. When they were sending Rudel off to the outer reaches, Oldart even sensed a hint of fate.

"Bennet-chan is good at looking after people, so if anything happens, you should ask her. You should really avoid asking Keith anything."

While Oldart laughed, Alejandro averted his face. Knowing what had happened, for the sake of the vice-captain's honor, and the stability of his heart, Oldart decided not to touch on old wounds.

"Are they really that strong? Neither of them said anything of the sort."

"They're strong, or rather, they're in another dimension. An idiot who'd try to pick a fight with Bennet-chan... doesn't exist. Her appearance is that, but anyways, she'd doted on. If anyone tries to pick something with her, the defenders will come flying over. Ah, by that, I don't mean the official one, Bennet-chan has her own personal defenders among the dragoons. They really will come flying, so watch yourself."

"That's nothing to laugh about. Good grief... I don't know what your intention is, letting such a dangerous group be for so long."

"No, Bennet-chan's a former subordinate, and she's a good girl. She's not losing out on anything with her appearance, but the way she worries about it is cute. I'd really like a certain boomerang girl to learn from her."

By the way, the captain of the defenders was Oldart. He was the ringleader who set up an assembly to protect Bennet from the shadows.

"I never noticed they were that strong."

"Well, when it comes to demi-humans, you can't really help it. Normally, it wouldn't be strange if she stood out even more than Cattleya, but for better or worse... that girl has no talent in driving dragons."

The reason Bennet specialized herself in land battles, it was because she was lacking in talent when it came to flying dragons. In contrast, Keith excelled in his dragon control.

Even so, she had made a contract with a water dragon. In a situation where she could no longer say she had no talent, Bennet had chosen her own form.

"I put her in the Major spot left open for Cattleya, but if it's troubling her, maybe I should think over it."

Finishing his tea, Alejandro offered Oldart a warning.

"Whatever the case, it's already been decided. She leads a valuable dragon. It would be troublesome if she doesn't do her best as a Major."

Looking over the report, Oldart sensed she was worried and ended up groaning. While things were fine as they were, he needed to prepare some subordinates for Bennet, and fast.

Perhaps after she had trained Rudel, he would place some new recruits under her.

"Um, did Rudel know they were both so..."

"That guy? He knew. Well, it seems he didn't know their exact strength, but on the contrary, I'm the surprised one."

Inside, he wondered how he found out, but thinking that he would be able to look into it with his status, he swallowed down the word, 'creepy'.

Perhaps as revenge for being smacked, or because he couldn't forgive the fact his daughter had fallen for him, or perhaps both at once, Alejandro spat some cynicism.

"Hmm. It's best for him to learn of reality. In this world, there's always someone higher."

"Well, the two of us have already reached the summit, mind you."

As Oldart laughed over his joke, Izumi seemed lost in thought.



On the way back to the port town of Beretta, Izumi looked up at the sky as she called out to Sakuya.

"Hey, Sakuya. Do you think I have the qualifications to stand shoulder-to-shoulder with Rudel?"

'I don't really get it, but Izumi belongs with Rudel. And with Sakuya too!'

You're right, she muttered.

Izumi looked at the orange-dying sky as she thought over her current self.

(When everyone around is going ahead, is it really alright if I stay like this? Shouldn't I search out my own form...)

Once she had thought that far, she suddenly recalled Rudel's back. That back she had chased after from her student days, she was assailed by a sense of unease that it might fly far away once more.

Even when she knew it would never reach, Izumi looked at her right hand with a sorrowful look on her face.

(At the very least, I want enough strength to stand next to him.)

The place she should never wish for. It was by Rudel's side. But at the very least, in work, in her mission, she wanted to stand shoulder-to-shoulder with him.

For that sake, she needed strength.

Once she returned, Izumi decided to consult with Bennet.

Chapter 123

Climbing a mountain overgrown with trees was Eunius with Aleist's defender platoon as his guards.

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Namely...

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"W-wrong! It's just, we've been doing nothing but cleaning every day, so..."

The cave they were searching for had an entrance halfway up the mountain. While they were heading straight for it, Aleist's platoon was slow on their feet.

With all the beauties gathered together, Aleist's platoon emphasized appearance over capability. On a side note, the demi-human ration was strangely high.

"Give me a break. I want to go and revere that holy sword thingy already... oh, we've got company."

Eunius himself didn't believe in the holy sword. But in the place the sword was said to lie, for some reason, powerful monsters would make their homes.

Ogres were the least of their worries, and apart from them, large monkey-like monsters and monsters that seemed to have been made from numerous

animal parts put together wandered the land. To Eunius, rather than the holy sword, he was after the monsters that almost seemed to be protecting it.

Taking a stance with his special made greatsword, he directed its tip towards the monster that came out.

The footing was bad, and be that as it may, the movements of the platoon was worse. If there was a single thing going in their favor, it had to be the fact there was only one foe.

"I don't believe those holy sword rumors, but it's nice to see these things crawling all over the place. Looks like I can enjoy myself."

"This is why you battle junkies are... everyone, get behind me."

Aleist had his subordinates from his platoon step down as he drew the two swords at his waist and took a stance. They were both one-handed swords, but their hilts were fashioned a bit on the longer side. The blade portions were made just that much shorter.

"Why two swords again?"

"'Cuz I've got more on my plate these days. Using magic like Rudel and Luecke just doesn't suit me."

As the two of them conversed without looking at one another, the large monkey before their eyes raised a war cry as it leapt towards them. Its jumping ability would have instantly sent it towards the women behind Aleist, but along the way, it extended an arm towards a nearby branch and clung fast to the tree.

While the enemy showed such a pitiful sight, in the next instant, from Aleist's shadow, several dozens of spears pierced through a spot it would pass through.

If it had continued on, it would have been impaled.

"Hmm, this one's clever. It's stronger than the previous one... Aleist, this one's mine."

Eunius looked at the enemy's movements and thought back to the monster of the same race he had beaten not a moment ago. While its power and speed seemed around the same, at a glance, he could feel the enemy before him was smarter.

His face changing to a ferocious smile, Eunius used his magic sword to cut at the monster in the trees. The warping blade extended towards the monster, but skillfully leaping from tree to tree, the monkey managed to dodge it. The terrain was on the enemy's side.

"I could just blow the whole area away, but that wouldn't be interesting."

"That's the reason you won't blow it away? No, I don't quite know what to think about blowing away the landscape."

"... And you're one to talk. In that wilderness training in the fundamental curriculum, who was it that blew the forest away with magic to clear a path?"

"Stop it! Don't talk about that time!"

Leaving an embarrassed Aleist aside, Eunius pruned at the monster coming at him from above. With its long limbs and sturdy body, it was simply idiotic to try comparing it to a human.

Its fur was practically the monster's armor. Even when cut by the magic sword, not only did the arm remained unsevered, it was barely even scratched. Perhaps it had grown its coat longer than the previous one, or perhaps this was a superior variant...

Eunius leapt back to take distance, changing his stance from slashes to one specialized in thrusts.

His face was the epitome of severity, and as if sensing that, the monster intimidated him, but it didn't make any poor approaches.

A few seconds passed...

As both sides glared at one another, the first to move was the monster. After coiling up its large limbs, it used the recoil to spring towards Eunius. Seeing the monster that was practically flying parallel to the ground, Eunius's mouth curved into a smile.

"Looks like you really weren't any different from that last one. Just a little bit harder and a little more clever, but that's about it."

Eunius stepped in and lowered his stature to match the monster, thrusting out his sword at a range where its tip still wouldn't reach.

A magic sword accompanied his blade, drawing the form of a sharp spiral as it enraptured the monster and caused it to spin while a large air hole opened up in its chest. After slamming into a large tree behind it, the monster slumped to the ground and Eunius put his sword away on his back.

"Alright... moving on, next!"

Aleist put his sword away, reverting his shadow to normal as he called over to his subordinates. His form was just a bit entertaining to Eunius.

(He's properly acting as their commanding officer, that Aleist. But...)

Aleist held no ulterior motives, he was only doing the actions he usually would, but Eunius understood how that looked to his female subordinates.

When he was the one who fought, they were directing favorable eyes towards Aleist, but he didn't notice anything of the sort.

(... It's interesting, so I'll keep quiet. It'll make a nice story to bring back to the boys.)

Without informing Aleist he was subconsciously raising his subordinates' affection points, Eunius set out for the next waypoint.



There were a number of places the holy sword was said to rest.

But those were along the same vein as buried treasure, and the people of this world did not hold them in high belief. A king of a few generations prior had once dispatched forces to a number of prominent points to try to find the holy sword, but the results were a disaster.

The sword was never found. Many people were invested, much funding was thrown down the drain. Therefore, the existence of the holy sword was thought of as something of a fairy tale.

Then came along Aleist with his knowledge of a game. He knew where exactly the item called the holy sword was supposed to be. He knew, and he led Eunius right to the site.

"Even so, who would've thought the holy sword was this deep in the mountains."

"Isn't that precisely why it's so deep in the mountains?"

Eunius used a short sword to clear away the overgrown grass and tree branches as he made a path. Aleist similarly used a one-handed sword to move forward. Behind them, the women of the platoon walked with the supplies.

But Aleist was shouldering all the heavy luggage. In order to fight, Eunius was barely carrying anything.

More than that, they really couldn't have Eunius carry anything.

"They should just put the important things away in the treasury."

"Maybe they didn't want it to be misused? Even so, I never thought you'd want the holy sword, Eunius."

To be honest, Aleist didn't want the holy sword. Knowing the truth, Aleist knew what sort of thing the holy sword was.

It had long since accomplished its role and lost its power, it was an article barely able to maintain its own shape. Its rusted hilt had already rotted

through. He had seen the scene in his game, and it was not the sort of thing that could be used as a weapon.

Aleist knew this place as little more than a place to farm EXP.

(Once Eunius learns the truth, I'm sure he'll accept it, and I have to hurry and get my own equipment together.)

From the depths of his memory, Aleist tried to recall the weapons he thought were necessary. But lately, that was starting to feel dubious.

The weapons he now held in his hands were the same, just because he possessed them, that didn't mean he'd be able to use them immediately. The more powerful they were, the more cautious he would have to be when handling them. As he started to hold a perception that things were different from a game, Aleist had gotten around to thinking the weapons he was most accustomed to using were the best ones for him.

"We should camp around here today."

After Eunius looked up at the sky and confirmed the position of the sun, he concluded any more would be dangerous and decided to search for a place to rest.

"It would be a real help if there was water around..."

Said Aleist as he directed a glance to one of his subordinates. The beast tribe female knight smiled as she pointed out the direction she smelled water.

"Captain, there's a pond in that direction."

After saying thanks to his subordinate who informed him with a smile, Aleist and co began moving in that direction. Normally, they would refrain from camping in such a dangerous place. But Aleist didn't think they would get too many of these chances.

To Aleist who had a mild urge to get stronger, it was the perfect opportunity. He even began to wonder if Eunius was trying to cheer him up after Millia

had gone away.

But once he approached the pond, his subordinate started acting strange.

"H-huh?"

"What's wrong?"

As if she had suddenly lost confidence, his subordinate began to fidget. She said something quite intriguing.

"There's someone at the waterfront. No, that's not a person... huh? A person and a monster? But it's much too quiet for that."

Before his bewildered subordinate, Aleist explained the situation to Eunius.

"There's something there. Perhaps a person is being attacked."

"For real? Then I... no, that's impossible. In that case, isn't this your territory?"

"Leave it to me."

Eunius was their guard target. What's more, he wasn't strong in covert operations. Not only was Aleist able to deal with most enemies, if he used his characteristic shadow, he'd be able to overcome an extent of trouble.

Determining that sending everyone to scout was dangerous, Aleist took the lead and went out. He knew that having his subordinates acting individually in such a place was much too risky.

Running ahead, Aleist made a path with his shadow, erasing his footsteps and ignoring the forest road as he headed for the point he had heard from his subordinate.

The fact it was growing dark only worked to his advantage, and as if hiding in the shadows, he approached his destination point. Around the pond, he was able to confirm the form of a large dragon drinking its water.

A dragon with blue, glassy scales, its beautiful wings were folded as it lapped at the pond. From the saddle and bag strapped to its back, he could instantly tell it belonged to a dragoon.

Aleist surveyed the area to find a single young man bathing in the cold. A young man of beautiful blue hair had stripped down to bask in the pond. His form was one that even Aleist had to admit looked cool.

... But it was there that Aleist was able to recall who it was he had discovered.

"It couldn't be... Keith-san?"

The mutter that came from his lips was caught by his foe. As the dragon's eyes fastened Aleist with its glare, Keith's voice resounded through the trees.

"Who's hiding over there?"

Showing his form, Aleist held up his hands to signal he had no hostile intent. He had never thought he would encounter Keith in a place like this.

As it was a romance-centric game, there were few male characters to be found, but Keith was undoubtedly an important individual. He wasn't the type who would participate in battle, in the latter half of the game, he was a means of transportation across the land.

He was an individual who held the role of delivering the main cast to their destination.

That was Keith Elrond.

What's more Keith was always kind to the main character, and a cool guy who never laid the slightest of hands on the women. Ever kind to the commoner main character, and if you asked him, he would transport you to any destination. Even with all he knew about the game, Aleist had no reason to be hostile.

"M-my apologies. I'm Aleist Hardie of the defenders. At present, I am in the area on a guard mission, and I have come to scout out the waterfront."

"Aleist of the Hardie House... a pleasure to meet you, I'm Keith Elrond. Sorry, sorry. You surprised me a bit."

Smiling as he rose from the pond, Keith was naked, but he didn't seem mindful of that. On the contrary, he apologized for acting so surprised. While he thought the man was a bit strange, Aleist felt relieved he was still the same kind older brother character as he explained the situation.

He spoke of how he had come all the way here as Eunius' guard, and even explained up to how they would be heading to the port town of Beretta afterward. After hearing him out, Keith put on undergarments and trousers, keeping his upper half bare as he offered a proposal.

"In that case, let me tag along. I finished my mission a bit early, you see. And Beretta is where I've been stationed. Once you've finished your business here, I can fly you straight to town."

"That would be a huge help."

They had made it part-way by carriage, but as the way back was dangerous, they planned to return to a nearby village on foot before taking another carriage from there.

Keith's proposal was a spurt of good luck to Aleist.

"No, no, we've got to help each other out in our times of need. You can just call me Keith."



"... And that's how it is."

"It's a pleasure."

At the waterfront, Eunius was introduced to the dragon and Keith.

While those around were relieved at a dragoon's participation, they couldn't help but be curious of Keith's eyes.

His face was nice. His lineage splendid. But they couldn't help but feel anxious. While he hit it off well with Aleist, for a while now, he hadn't offered the slightest glance to any of the women.

With Aleist's platoon that even made Eunius jealous before his eyes, he didn't show any particular reaction.

(Doesn't he envy Aleist as a man? Well, he's from a Count House, so perhaps he has a fiancée, or he's the devoted type like Rudel.)

But for that, he really looks like he's having fun, thought Eunius.

"Even if I look like this, I'm unfit for battle. I've only got a bit of confidence in controlling my dragon. Well, as long as we have a dragon with us, most monsters should run away, so it shouldn't be a problem. Everyone, just take it easy."

Moving through an unfamiliar forest alone was difficult. Even if he had done wilderness training in his student days, that didn't mean Eunius wasn't tired. And since he had entered the forest, he had don't quite a bit of combat.

Thankful that a dragon was on watch, he decided to be pampered by Keith's words. But...

".. Spinnith, am I really that untrustworthy?" "... I know. It's not like I'm some sort of wolf. I won't do anything like that." "Yeah, we have to get to know each other better."

"I've gotten used to it from watching Rudel, but it really looks like he's just talking to himself."

Aleist gave a bitter smile as he watched Keith talk with his dragon. As he recalled Rudel, Aleist started to reminisce.

"... No, I'm kinda starting to become nervous here."

Feeling an anxiety he couldn't put into words, for some reason, Eunius' wild instinct was telling him this guy was dangerous. Eunius himself had a strong belief in his instinct.

He didn't feel any hostility. But for some reason, he felt danger.

(Even so, Elrond... I get the feeling I've heard that name somewhere before.)

"Oh, you know Rudel? He and I were both dispatched to the same point. If you're up to it, could you tell me some tales of the past?"

As Aleist brought up Rudel, Keith bit right on. But come so far, Keith placed a hand on Aleist's shoulder. The girls who witnessed that scene seemed to sense something. Even more than the demihumans, the human knights reacted.

"C-captain Aleist, it's already late, so why don't we rest in preparation for tomorrow..."

"Eh? Yeah, you're right. Sorry, Keith-san, it'll have to be another time."

"... Yeah, don't worry about it."

One of his subordinates sensed something and called it a day. But Eunius didn't overlook... the form of Keith clicking his tongue, making sure the female knight wouldn't see.

For only a moment, he directed eyes thirsting for blood at that knight.

(Ah, this guy is dangerous.)

Eunius mulled over whether to inform Aleist or not, and in conclusion...

(But it's interesting, so I'll leave it be.)

He decided to watch it unfold.

Chapter 123.1: Extra part1

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"Looks like you really weren't any different from that last one. Just a little bit harder and a little more clever, but that's about it."

Eunius stepped in and lowered his stature to match the monster, thrusting out his sword at a range where its tip still wouldn't reach.

A magic sword accompanied his blade, drawing the form of a sharp spiral as it enraptured the monster and caused it to spin while a large air hole opened up in its chest. After slamming into a large tree behind it, the monster slumped to the ground and Eunius put his sword away on his back.

"Alright... moving on, next!"

Aleist put his sword away, reverting his shadow to normal as he called over to his subordinates. His form was just a bit entertaining to Eunius.

(He's properly acting as their commanding officer, that Aleist. But...)

Aleist held no ulterior motives, he was only doing the actions he usually would, but Eunius understood how that looked to his female subordinates.

When he was the one who fought, they were directing favorable eyes towards Aleist, but he didn't notice anything of the sort.

(... It's interesting, so I'll keep quiet. It'll make a nice story to bring back to the boys.)

Without informing Aleist he was subconsciously raising his subordinates' affection points, Eunius set out for the next waypoint.



There were a number of places the holy sword was said to rest.

But those were along the same vein as buried treasure, and the people of this world did not hold them in high belief. A king of a few generations prior had once dispatched forces to a number of prominent points to try to find the holy sword, but the results were a disaster.

The sword was never found. Many people were invested, much funding was thrown down the drain. Therefore, the existence of the holy sword was thought of as something of a fairy tale.

Then came along Aleist with his knowledge of a game. He knew where exactly the item called the holy sword was supposed to be. He knew, and he led Eunius right to the site.

"Even so, who would've thought the holy sword was this deep in the mountains."

"Isn't that precisely why it's so deep in the mountains?"

Eunius used a short sword to clear away the overgrown grass and tree branches as he made a path. Aleist similarly used a one-handed sword to move forward. Behind them, the women of the platoon walked with the supplies.

But Aleist was shouldering all the heavy luggage. In order to fight, Eunius was barely carrying anything.

More than that, they really couldn't have Eunius carry anything.

"They should just put the important things away in the treasury."

"Maybe they didn't want it to be misused? Even so, I never thought you'd want the holy sword, Eunius."

To be honest, Aleist didn't want the holy sword. Knowing the truth, Aleist knew what sort of thing the holy sword was.

It had long since accomplished its role and lost its power, it was an article barely able to maintain its own shape. Its rusted hilt had already rotted

through. He had seen the scene in his game, and it was not the sort of thing that could be used as a weapon.

Aleist knew this place as little more than a place to farm EXP.

(Once Eunius learns the truth, I'm sure he'll accept it, and I have to hurry and get my own equipment together.)

From the depths of his memory, Aleist tried to recall the weapons he thought were necessary. But lately, that was starting to feel dubious.

The weapons he now held in his hands were the same, just because he possessed them, that didn't mean he'd be able to use them immediately. The more powerful they were, the more cautious he would have to be when handling them. As he started to hold a perception that things were different from a game, Aleist had gotten around to thinking the weapons he was most accustomed to using were the best ones for him.

"We should camp around here today."

After Eunius looked up at the sky and confirmed the position of the sun, he concluded any more would be dangerous and decided to search for a place to rest.

"It would be a real help if there was water around..."

Said Aleist as he directed a glance to one of his subordinates. The beast tribe female knight smiled as she pointed out the direction she smelled water.

"Captain, there's a pond in that direction."

After saying thanks to his subordinate who informed him with a smile, Aleist and co began moving in that direction. Normally, they would refrain from camping in such a dangerous place. But Aleist didn't think they would get too many of these chances.

To Aleist who had a mild urge to get stronger, it was the perfect opportunity. He even began to wonder if Eunius was trying to cheer him up after Millia

had gone away.

But once he approached the pond, his subordinate started acting strange.

"H-huh?"

"What's wrong?"

As if she had suddenly lost confidence, his subordinate began to fidget. She said something quite intriguing.

"There's someone at the waterfront. No, that's not a person... huh? A person and a monster? But it's much too quiet for that."

Before his bewildered subordinate, Aleist explained the situation to Eunius.

"There's something there. Perhaps a person is being attacked."

"For real? Then I... no, that's impossible. In that case, isn't this your territory?"

"Leave it to me."

Eunius was their guard target. What's more, he wasn't strong in covert operations. Not only was Aleist able to deal with most enemies, if he used his characteristic shadow, he'd be able to overcome an extent of trouble.

Determining that sending everyone to scout was dangerous, Aleist took the lead and went out. He knew that having his subordinates acting individually in such a place was much too risky.

Running ahead, Aleist made a path with his shadow, erasing his footsteps and ignoring the forest road as he headed for the point he had heard from his subordinate.

The fact it was growing dark only worked to his advantage, and as if hiding in the shadows, he approached his destination point. Around the pond, he was able to confirm the form of a large dragon drinking its water.

A dragon with blue, glassy scales, its beautiful wings were folded as it lapped at the pond. From the saddle and bag strapped to its back, he could instantly tell it belonged to a dragoon.

Aleist surveyed the area to find a single young man bathing in the cold. A young man of beautiful blue hair had stripped down to bask in the pond. His form was one that even Aleist had to admit looked cool.

... But it was there that Aleist was able to recall who it was he had discovered.

"It couldn't be... Keith-san?"

The mutter that came from his lips was caught by his foe. As the dragon's eyes fastened Aleist with its glare, Keith's voice resounded through the trees.

"Who's hiding over there?"

Showing his form, Aleist held up his hands to signal he had no hostile intent. He had never thought he would encounter Keith in a place like this.

As it was a romance-centric game, there were few male characters to be found, but Keith was undoubtedly an important individual. He wasn't the type who would participate in battle, in the latter half of the game, he was a means of transportation across the land.

He was an individual who held the role of delivering the main cast to their destination.

That was Keith Elrond.

What's more Keith was always kind to the main character, and a cool guy who never laid the slightest of hands on the women. Ever kind to the commoner main character, and if you asked him, he would transport you to any destination. Even with all he knew about the game, Aleist had no reason to be hostile.

"M-my apologies. I'm Aleist Hardie of the defenders. At present, I am in the area on a guard mission, and I have come to scout out the waterfront."

"Aleist of the Hardie House... a pleasure to meet you, I'm Keith Elrond. Sorry, sorry. You surprised me a bit."

Smiling as he rose from the pond, Keith was naked, but he didn't seem mindful of that. On the contrary, he apologized for acting so surprised. While he thought the man was a bit strange, Aleist felt relieved he was still the same kind older brother character as he explained the situation.

He spoke of how he had come all the way here as Eunius' guard, and even explained up to how they would be heading to the port town of Beretta afterward. After hearing him out, Keith put on undergarments and trousers, keeping his upper half bare as he offered a proposal.

"In that case, let me tag along. I finished my mission a bit early, you see. And Beretta is where I've been stationed. Once you've finished your business here, I can fly you straight to town."

"That would be a huge help."

They had made it part-way by carriage, but as the way back was dangerous, they planned to return to a nearby village on foot before taking another carriage from there.

Keith's proposal was a spurt of good luck to Aleist.

"No, no, we've got to help each other out in our times of need. You can just call me Keith."



"... And that's how it is."

"It's a pleasure."

At the waterfront, Eunius was introduced to the dragon and Keith.

While those around were relieved at a dragoon's participation, they couldn't help but be curious of Keith's eyes.

His face was nice. His lineage splendid. But they couldn't help but feel anxious. While he hit it off well with Aleist, for a while now, he hadn't offered the slightest glance to any of the women.

With Aleist's platoon that even made Eunius jealous before his eyes, he didn't show any particular reaction.

(Doesn't he envy Aleist as a man? Well, he's from a Count House, so perhaps he has a fiancée, or he's the devoted type like Rudel.)

But for that, he really looks like he's having fun, thought Eunius.

"Even if I look like this, I'm unfit for battle. I've only got a bit of confidence in controlling my dragon. Well, as long as we have a dragon with us, most monsters should run away, so it shouldn't be a problem. Everyone, just take it easy."

Moving through an unfamiliar forest alone was difficult. Even if he had done wilderness training in his student days, that didn't mean Eunius wasn't tired. And since he had entered the forest, he had don't quite a bit of combat.

Thankful that a dragon was on watch, he decided to be pampered by Keith's words. But...

".. Spinnith, am I really that untrustworthy?" "... I know. It's not like I'm some sort of wolf. I won't do anything like that." "Yeah, we have to get to know each other better."

"I've gotten used to it from watching Rudel, but it really looks like he's just talking to himself."

Aleist gave a bitter smile as he watched Keith talk with his dragon. As he recalled Rudel, Aleist started to reminisce.

"... No, I'm kinda starting to become nervous here."

Feeling an anxiety he couldn't put into words, for some reason, Eunius' wild instinct was telling him this guy was dangerous. Eunius himself had a strong belief in his instinct.

He didn't feel any hostility. But for some reason, he felt danger.

(Even so, Elrond... I get the feeling I've heard that name somewhere before.)

"Oh, you know Rudel? He and I were both dispatched to the same point. If you're up to it, could you tell me some tales of the past?"

As Aleist brought up Rudel, Keith bit right on. But come so far, Keith placed a hand on Aleist's shoulder. The girls who witnessed that scene seemed to sense something. Even more than the demihumans, the human knights reacted.

"C-captain Aleist, it's already late, so why don't we rest in preparation for tomorrow..."

"Eh? Yeah, you're right. Sorry, Keith-san, it'll have to be another time."

"... Yeah, don't worry about it."

One of his subordinates sensed something and called it a day. But Eunius didn't overlook... the form of Keith clicking his tongue, making sure the female knight wouldn't see.

For only a moment, he directed eyes thirsting for blood at that knight.

(Ah, this guy is dangerous.)

Eunius mulled over whether to inform Aleist or not, and in conclusion...

(But it's interesting, so I'll leave it be.)

He decided to watch it unfold.

Chapter 124

"There, how's that!"

Inside the cave, Eunius used nothing more than his sword to take on the humanoid monsters with reptilian heads.

Perhaps they had made that cave their lair, as they were beginning to surround him with their hoard.

In their hands they held axes, and shields called bucklers. From the monsters' sizes, they might look like small bucklers, but if Eunius held one, it would be bigger than a full sized shield.

In such a perilous situation, surrounded by monsters, Eunius was laughing. Even in the cave, there was a space vast enough for monsters to attack in a group, and he was able to swing about his large sword freely.

Meanwhile, one of the knights of Aleist's platoon was illuminating the cave with magic.

Behind Eunius, Aleist took a stance with his two swords and used his shadow to impale approaching monsters. However, the monsters' movements seemed accustomed to battle, and things weren't going as well as they had been in the forest.

Changing his grip on his sword, Eunius shrunk the swing of his sword to cut at the monster that had raised its large arm, but like that, all he could do was dig into his enemy's skin.

However...

"Not yet!"

With his sword wedged in, he used brute force to cut the rest of the way through, making tatters of his sword's blade. It was a result of a battle just that intense, but Eunius wasn't satisfied. While he was wasting time here, he got the feeling Rudel and Luecke were proceeding ahead.

In all actuality, when he heard from Keith that there was an opponent Rudel couldn't beat, he began to panic. He couldn't keep going like this.

(That guy will definitely surpass any opponent he's lost to. Then what about me? Do I just rot away like this? If I wasn't stationed to that blasted knight unit, would I have become stronger?)

He questioned himself as he swung his sword, but his movements had already begun to optimize themselves to his foes.



Focusing his attention on Eunius from behind, Aleist shouted out orders.

"Don't let it ever come to one-on one! At worst mark them down with two, and if that's impossible, send them around to me!"

Stopping a monster's act with two swords, Aleist extended out his left hand's sword. The light scratch that would never inflict anything fatal spouted smoke... the monster spat a froth of blood as it collapsed.

"If it's no good from the outside, then go at it from within. That's how it usually works."

As he retook his stance, the wary monsters took distance. It was disadvantageous that they couldn't use powerful magic in the cave, but even so, there were ways to go about it.

Growing accustomed to his enemies' movements, he freed some space for leisure as he moved to a point where he could keep an eye on Eunius.

(So genius really does exist.)

Looking at the man's movements, he was already fighting completely differently from how he started out. He was making the optimum movements to defeat his foe.

While Eunius had a strong image as a sword genius, Aleist felt something different.

One of his own fiancées, he knew a former noble girl called Seli. She was a character from the game Aleist was aware of and held the position of an underclassman. What's more, she possessed the established setting of being a genius with the sword.

But even to Aleist, who knew her wonderful talent when it came to blades, comparing her to Eunius, he was beginning to notice the difference.

While Seli was only a genius as far as swords went, he got the feeling Eunius held a fighting talent that went beyond that.

He learned proper swordplay, and be that as it may, he displayed flexible swordsmanship unimaginable from his appearance.

Just during this mission, when he fired blasts from his magic sword, he learned to add a spin to them to increase their output. When he thought up shooting thrusts, it only took a few days before it was possible. Even now, against an opponent where it was difficult to compare raw power, he was shortening his cuts to get in and tear them apart.

In regards to the monsters that leapt at him from both sides, Aleist kept his attention on Eunius as he dealt with them.

Putting out a few dozen black hands from his shadow, he captured both monsters in midair and fastened them down. After preparing a fire magic sword in both hands, he did a revolution on the spot and sent the slash waves toward the monsters. The monsters were cut through, black arms and all. Rather than shooting the waves, it felt more like the blades had extended.

As Aleist's flames strongly lit up the cave, Eunius had completed his battle as well.

Putting away his swords on his waist, Aleist looked at Eunius, raising and lowering his shoulders in breath as he thought.

(A future archduke has talent in the sword... but such a talent is pointless. So it's because the man himself understood it that he had such a resigned personality?)

The Eunius from the game gave off a different impression from the current one. Right now, not wanting to lose to his friends, he recklessly swung his sword. He had clearly lost that personality where he had given up on something.

"Let's rest a bit before we go on."

As Aleist called over, Eunius sat on the spot and drank some water from the flask hung at his waist.

"Yeah, sorry for that. Making you mindful of me."

"No, that's fine. I can barely go on myself."

Forwarding enemies onto Eunius and making sure he wasn't attacked from behind was Aleist's role.

"You got the knack for it around the end, right? That means I've caused you trouble. When you're my guard, I'm sorry for giving out so many orders."

Getting his breath in order, Eunius checked over his sword. He wanted to see if his weapon would hold out for the road ahead.

Aleist checked whether any of his subordinates were injured, and checked the luggage before looking deeper into the cave.

Saying he would just be a hindrance, Keith alone was on standby outside the cave. He had a dragon, so there was no need to worry about him, but as

he was weak enough to declare it with such confidence, that was a reason for worry in itself.

"Even so, do you think Keith-san will be alright?"

It wasn't just Eunius who looked at Aleist with worry. His subordinates, the human ones, in particular, looked anxiously over him.

"... I'm more worried for you, in various ways."

"Eh?"



In the deepest depths of the face was a room where light streamed in through the ceiling.

There remained traces that a human once lived there and the door had been locked. Beyond the lock a dexterous subordinate had picked lay the dust-caked furniture.

"This is terrible."

"... That it is."

The numerous fixtures... especially the wooden ones had collapsed in form. While the pots and the like remained, atop what seemed to have once been a bed were the white skeletal remains of a human.

"It's a miracle anything remains at all."

For argument's sake, one of Aleist's subordinate muttered as she invoked a purification magic. It was a magic effective against undead monsters, but there didn't seem to be any regrets lingering around.

As everyone searched the room, they found the holy sword all too easily.

It was just as Aleist knew it, the rusted holy sword just barely managed to hold its form. Even in the game, it was just an item that took up an

inventory slot, and it didn't have any particular scenario prepared for it. There was no way to mend it or return it to its glory.

It ended as such a tale, a joke, a cruel lesson that nothing was ever so easy.

But as he looked over the room, Aleist couldn't bring himself to say it.

"The end of a hero? And he lay here a few hundred years unbeknownst to man?"

As Eunius muttered, the expressions of the subordinates in the room darkened a bit. Aleist surveyed the area and spotted a few books written in old lettering.

He handed it to one of his subordinates and she began to read aloud.

"This is considerably old. There are some words I don't know either... this might predate the founding of Courtois."

In order to search out the holy sword, Aleist had assembled all those he thought would be necessary. It was no coincidence. Originally, the ones here were supposed to mainly consist of romance-target characters, but he had gathered people capable of fulfilling the necessary roles.

"There are very few legible portions, so I'll try to give a simple explanation. Do you want to hear it?"

The woman prepared a light with magic and began flipping through a book. As confirmation had been sought from him, Aleist nodded. Eunius seemed to want to hear as he folded his arms and took a seat.

"It seems the resident of this room lived in a country smaller than Courtois. It's probably somewhere within Courtois' current territory, but the name is too old for me to compare it to anything."

According to her words, at the time, they were terribly afraid of giant monsters boasting four arms. In a situation where there weren't any dragoons, they would always have heavy casualties each year.

In such an era, the lord of the room stood on his own.

The technical details of how he fought were either illegible or absent. And seeking out readable portions, the subordinate flipped to the final page.

"I think I can read... eh!?"

"What's wrong?"

"N-no... it's just, the name of the individual who wrote this book..."

As he looked at the surprised face of his subordinate, for some reason, she was looking between his own face and the skeletal master of the room.

"U-um... around the end, it's written he entrusts the holy sword to whoever reaches this place, and apart from that, the only thing I can read is his name."

"Hmm... so who is he? This lost hero?"

"... Hardie. It says right here, Aleist Hardie."

"... Eh?" "Hey, doesn't that... creepy!"

A surprised Aleist, and as he suddenly stood in fear, he found Eunius and his subordinates looking back and forth between himself and the skeleton. Aleist had no idea either, but apparently, the lord of the room was named Aleist Hardie.

Just feeling the slightest tug of fate cause a shiver to instantly run through the room.

The conversations suddenly turned towards Aleist's past and his past life.

"Captain, I'm sure you're the reincarnation of this hero!"

While his subordinate spoke with such excitement, Aleist could say with certainty that wasn't the case as he thought over his next course of action.

"No, I was definitely not a hero in my past life, or rather, this is definitely a coincidence... (Sorry, my past life wasn't a hero, it was just a bullied little kid.)"

While he desperately tried to change the subject, Eunius alone was nodding to himself.

"... They do say great men have a fondness for women. Isn't it fine? It looks like Hero Aleist used two swords as well."

"Two swords? I'm definitely using two swords right now, but that has nothing to do with it!"

While everyone made faces as if to say, this guy just doesn't get it, Aleist tried his best to take control.

"A-anyways! Leaving him like this would be terrible, so let's make a grave. I think this spot where the light touches will be nice! We'll use the holy sword as a gravemar—"

"No, since you found it, then in accordance with his will, shouldn't you be the one carrying it, Captain Aleist?"

"...?"

"You're right. While it's rusty, his will says to entrust it to whoever visits this place. He has the same name, so I'm sure you were fated to inherit it from the start."

As Eunius laughed and pat him on the shoulder, Aleist looked at the holy sword his subordinates brought to him. Before that sword that looked unusable beyond a reasonable doubt, he mulled over what he was supposed to do.



A few days later, the party of Aleist and Eunius dropped by the port town of Beretta.

After making a grave for the lord of the room, they made an offering from the supplies they brought along and left the cave.

From there, they rode Keith's dragon on a journey through the sky.

"So this is the port town of Beretta."

Seeing the sea for the first in quite a while, Aleist felt a little disappointed it was too cold to take a dip.

"From here on, I'm going to go report to the Major, but are you going to tag along? I think Rudel will be there as well."

"Ah, then I'll go with you."

With Eunius linking arms with him, Aleist was forcibly pulled into accompanying them as well. He ordered his subordinate female knights to head to the inn they had planned for beforehand.

The place they made for was a spot that could be called the knight station. That station used by multiple brigades gave off a miscellaneous feel to Aleist, who worked in the capital. As Keith called out to the soldier on watch, the young soldier happily responded.

"Keith-san sure is the popular one."

"Good for him. I wonder if Rudel's alright."

While Eunius looked around, worried for Rudel, the first ones to enter his eyes were Izumi and Millia.

"Yo!"

The two of them approached Eunius, as he raised his right hand in greeting. They walked right up to Aleist and Eunius.

"I never thought you two would be coming. You look well."

As Izumi looked surprised, Eunius flexed his bicep to make an appeal to his good health.

"Righto! There was a dragoon at our destination point, so we had him deliver up. Even so, he's way too amazing and... huh? Where did that Keith guy go?"

"Oh? ... You're right. He's gone."

As no matter how hard they scanned the station, they couldn't spot him, Izumi's bearing took a sudden change. Her features that had been smiling to that point turned expressionless all at once.

"Keith... so he's already back, that pervert."

Aleist grew frightened and decided to strike up a conversation with Millia, who he hadn't met in a while. He did feel sorry to use Izumi as a pretext, but it was hard to talk to her.

"H-hey, did something happen?"

"Who knows? It's been going on since we came here, she just doesn't get along with Lieutenant Elrond. When she's so friendly with Bennet-san, it really is strange."

Happy to finally be able to talk, in order to continue on the conversation, Aleist bit onto the name Millia put out.

"Is Bennet-san... a man?"

"No, she's not. She's a Major in the dragoons, and Rudel's superior officer. She's really cute, but..."

While Aleist was relieved, for some reason, he felt some anxiety at the face she made, as if something was difficult to say whenever she brought up that superior she called cute.

"I've been with Rudel alone lately."

(A- as I thought...)

Feeling down, Aleist slumped his shoulders.

"Look, they're back."

Millia pointed towards the entrance and there, they confirmed the forms of Rudel, and Keith, who had disappeared not too long ago. His form as he draped his jacket over his shoulder and reluctantly gave a report didn't look like the usual Keith.

But it seemed as if there was no one at the point Rudel and Keith directed their eyes.

"So where's this bennet-san fellow?"

Eunius also searched out Bennet, but he couldn't find her. Izumi breathed out a sigh and gestured to look down.

When he heard of a Dragoon Major, Aleist had imagined a considerably large female knight, but over the station desk and shelves, he could just barely make out the form of a small girl.

"... I didn't see it coming."

"Agreed."

So that's what a major in the dragoons looks like, thought Aleist. Her appearance was that of a young girl with long, silver hair, of small build and slender frame, giving off a fleeting impression. But the voice they could hear was a militaresque one.

"Why did you take up five whole days? It was a mission that was supposed to end in three."

"No, no, I've got a real deep reason here... right! In order to wash away my daily fatigue, I was taking an extended bath. Because a certain someone pushed an unreasonable mission onto me, my stress's been building up, you know."

"How brazen. You should've been able to complete it in two days with ease. If you were my subordinate, I'd have smacked you."

"I'll watch myself hereon. More importantly, Rudel, have you been well?"

"Yes. No problems on my side."

"You don't have to be so stiff. With our relationship—" "It's been a while, Lieutenant Elrond."

"... Oh, you. It really has been so long, I didn't notice you. So who were you again?"

The one who came between the three of them was Izumi.

She entered in as if to cut off Rudel and Keith and while her mouth was smiling, her eyes were not. The way she nonchalantly reached for the katana hanging at her waist was terrifying.

"... What's that supposed to be?"

While he sought confirmation with Millia, Millia shook her head. But Eunius alone seemed relieved. After looking at Rudel, he sent Aleist a look of pity.

"Rudel will be fine as long as he has Izumi. That leaves you as the problem."

Unable to understand, Aleist and Millia tilted their heads in sync.



Around dinner, the inn Aleist's platoon stayed at... the abandoned house was visited by Bennet with the food she had prepared.

Due to the number of people, she prepared the ingredients and held a barbecue in the yard. Bennet took charge of the area, cooking up meat, fish and vegetables.

"Is Bennet-san really that strong?"

"That's a surprise."

Seeing Aleist and Eunius' surprised figures, Rudel began praising Bennet, growing happy as if he was praising himself.

"I can't even stand against her. I can't stand against Lieutenant Keith in aerial battles, and it looks like I've got a ways ahead of me."

"Despite that, you sure look happy."

Eunius grinned as he brought meat to his mouth, and Rudel nodded.

"Yeah, I mean I've got myself a goal to aim for. First off, I have to beat Major Bennet in a land battle!"

While Rudel happily informed them, behind him stood Bennet in her apron.

"You sure sound confident, Rudel. Have you forgotten how many times I've held you against the ground today?"

"Major!"

As Rudel turned in surprise, Bennet handed over their next plate of food. It seemed to be a stir-fry of fish and vegetables, but it included shrimp and shellfish as well. With it being for three men, while it was just one plate, it contained a large quantity.

After skillfully distributing it to the three, Bennet collected up the empty plates. While Rudel made a plea that he would clean them up, Bennet simply held up a hand.

"Talks with friends are important. I'll overlook it for today."

After saying just that, she returned to get back to cooking. With Izumi at the lead, the women were helping out, but they were frightened by her abilities.

"... That girl is perfect."

"Right."

"She's usually a harsh and king Major. I want to be like her someday."

Reaching a hand for the new food, Rudel praised Bennet once more. There, Eunius asked him about Keith.

"Hey, putting that aside, what about Keith? Has he done anything to you?"

"The Lieutenant? No, nothing in particular. He's a kind and reliable superior. Well, my direct superior is Major Bennet, but... ah!"

"So something happened!"

As Eunius made a worried face, Rudel began talking about what had happened before.

"No, he drops by the house an awful lot when I'm in the bath, and I feel sorry that I always seem to miss him, so I consulted with Izumi on the matter."

"Hmm, timing is important, after all."

"These idiots..."

Seeing Rudel agree with Aleist, Eunius put down his empty plate and rubbed his brow with a finger.

"And then Izumi came and told me I had to tell her whenever I'm going to take a bath. After that, Izumi was always keeping lookout in front of the bath. What do you think it means?"

"Isn't she answering the door in your place? See, you can't talk to him while you're in the bath."

"That's wrong, dammit!"

Eunius' scream was completely lost on the two.

Chapter 125

In the port town of Beretta, Eunius and Aleist were undertaking Keith's tutelage alongside Rudel.

The expedition had displayed quite some interest in a lesson from a dragoon like Keith.

Inspectors Izumi and Millia also sat, under the blue sky, receiving the salty sea breeze as they watched Keith drag a blackboard over. Bennet sat next to Rudel with the intent to learn what she could.

While Izumi didn't mind it, Millia was taking some fleeting glances. From Izumi's point of view, she wanted her to be more wary of Keith, but she was troubled over how she couldn't bring herself to say it. For the innocent Izumi and Bennet who didn't possess the knowledge, Izumi had some resistance to explaining everything from scratch.

Aleist's subordinates were listening in from behind Izumi. While they looked to be a graceful gathering at a glance, the lecturer Keith seemed quite displeased.

"Why are there so many women? You're in the way."

"Lieutenant, please tell us what today's lecture's about!"

"Good question, Rudel. Today I'll have you do some classroom learning on the relation between dragoon and dragoon. I could teach you through practicals, but it would be better if you started those out with the knowledge, after all."

When Rudel raised his hand to ask a question, Keith instantly made a smile. He was as unfazed as ever. Gripping her beloved katana's sheath in her left

hand so she could draw it at any moment, Izumi didn't let her guard down for an instant.

"First off, we're going with current and past relations. In the past, dragoons largely focused on fighting to protect a dragon's back. That really hasn't changed, but fundamentally speaking, against a monster capable of piercing a dragon's scales, a human is powerless!"

As Keith suddenly rejected a dragoon's reason to be, Rudel directed some serious eyes. His face flushing, Keith continued on his explanation.

"Then if all you have to do is find yourself some means of mid and long-range attack, you just have to draw out the dragon's own power. That's how I see it."

On the blackboard, Keith drew an x over the picture of a knight firing magic from a dragon's back. While Keith was definitely weak, he had still cleared the basic physical criteria to be a knight.

"Protecting a dragon's back is something of the past. In the current era, they're shifting towards controlling their dragons, but... that really is meaningless, you know. I mean all they're doing is removing the 'protect the back' part of their duty, those slackers."

"But mid-range attacks are..."

"I'm telling you it's meaningless, shrimp."

Bennet's objection was cut down by Keith. There, Rudel to her side tried comforting her.

"It's alright, Major! I also think mid-range attacks are important."

"A-aye."

Millia and Keith watched over that exchange with irritation. Izumi thought the way Bennet happily wagged her tail was cute. After clearing his throat, Keith went into an explanation as to why it was unnecessary. It was surely

because of the emphasis Rudel placed on mid-range attack methods. If it was Bennet's opinion, he had already discarded it.

"If all your own attacks can do is serve as a diversion, then you're better off concentrating on giving orders to your dragon. That's the honest-to-goodness truth. But I thought I'd take that one step further. You better put the words, 'draw out a dragon's power,' into your head."

"Draw out its power?"

When Izumi let out her voice, that's right, Keith muttered with a click of his tongue. Rudel and Bennet sunk into thought.

"What do you mean by draw out its power?"

Bennet asked. If her orders took precedence, the dragon would move, it had always been like that and she didn't understand the meaning of the words themselves. It was a question quite fit for Bennet, who had gained a means of mid-range attack to protect her dragon's back.

"All you've ever done is order it around. What I'm trying to say is pulling out its abilities. Let's see... I don't mean to tack on a little extra strength. What's important is control. You have to operate a dragon's power. I have this one technique called Rainbow Mirage, and that's a prime example of this theory in motion!"

While he proudly unveiled the name of his technique, no one around seemed to understand what it was. As Rudel looked around troubled, Izumi extended a helping hand.

"Rudel, um... he's talking about that body double technique. Probably."

"You mean those body doubles, Lieutenant!?"

Against Rudel's sparkling eyes, Keith faltered. As Izumi smiled at her small revenge for all his usual conduct, with a mortified face, Keith changed his technique name from Rainbow Mirage to body double.

Those clones of water he produced, Rudel had seen them as well. He just didn't know the attack name, and Izumi had somehow noticed and connected the dots. Being understood, put him in quite an unpleasant mood.

"A dragon's latent abilities are high. In order for us dragoons to control them, more than the telepathic bond we share, we need to understand one another. But... in your case, your dragon's a subspecies, so it'll be difficult."

"It's difficult?"

On Bennet's question, Keith informed her there were absolutely no documents available. You can't draw out what isn't there. It all starts from looking into past records to see what sort of thing their dragons have done, and what they're capable of. That was Keith's way of going about it.

But Rudel's dragon Sakuya was a gaia subspecies. What's more, even if its appearance had some common points, it was easier to say it was a separate species entirely.

"In this case, the problem is that the dragon itself hasn't noticed its own attributes. She's still young. No, she's way too young."

Seeing Keith seriously mull, Eunius was surprised. He whispered over to Aleist who was sitting beside him.

"He's surprisingly decent. I thought he'd be a bit more of a lost cause."

"Hah? Of course Keith-san is decent."

"... Just where does that trust of yours come from. You've got to tell me sometime."

Izumi endorsed Eunius' opinion as she worried for Aleist's chastity. But to Izumi, Rudel was higher on her order of precedence. Meaning even if Aleist was assaulted in some way by Keith, she was going to let it be.

She wasn't abandoning him. If Izumi raised a hand, she understood the situation would clearly take a turn for the worse. While Aleist's chastity was

important, by protecting him, there was no guarantee his harem members wouldn't misunderstand something.

As things stood, Millia had yet to become wary of Keith. From Izumi's point of view, she was wary of the harmless Bennet, and what a wasted effort that was.

"If you give the average dragoon a value of one, while dragons all have individual difference, the power difference puts them well over a hundred. It's generally impossible for a human to win out over a dragon, after all."

After writing that humans can't beat dragons on the board, he sent a glance around as if to ask, 'then what are they supposed to do?'

"Adding your own power onto theirs is slight and insignificant. If all you're doing is protecting its back, then you should strengthen the dragon. That's why I decided to draw out my dragon's strength. The body doubles is a part of that. You make the shape of a dragon with water, and imitate the surface."

"Is that really possible? Mana-capacity-wise, you wouldn't be able to use that much magic too many times."

Rudel tilted his head. There, Keith spoke with a smile.

"Hahaha, I can't create those doubles on my own. Who do you think I am? I don't have that sort of mana, and I don't have the control. That's why I put my own dragon to it. I understand his exact characteristics, transmit a clear image, and support him in the finer points. With that alone, a dragon's strength rapidly increases. You don't need some mid or long-range magic. More so, as long as you can do something like this, you're doing good as a dragoon."

While the eyes watching Keith grew surprisingly favorable, Bennet put a damper on his parade.

"Hey... doesn't that mean you're casting off everything apart from aerial combat?"

"And what of it? Something so savage as fighting on the dirt isn't suited to me. Just have that gorilla Cattleya do it or something."

Did something happen with Cattleya? Izumi thought, as Keith's lesson came to an end. As Aleist headed off to help him clean up, Eunius approached Rudel.

"Oy, Rudel."

"What is it? I was planning on helping the Lieutenant."

"It's been a while, let's have a match. You've been going all over the place, and it's boring me to death. Aren't you curious to see how strong you've become?"

"... Eunius."

While Rudel made a bit of a fed-up face, Izumi understood. That wasn't him fed up over Eunius challenging him to a match.

"You better not regret it."

"Good grief. You guys are always the same."

A ghastliness befell upon Rudel's smile that could be called battle mania. Seeing that expression, Eunius also changed to a ferocious grin.

Bennet looked over the two with tired eyes, but she looked just a little happy.

However...

"I can't stand it anymore!"

Looking at Rudel and Bennet, Millia finally exploded.

◇

"I'm telling you, the major is definitely dangerous!"

"C-calm down. The major isn't dangerous at all. More so, that idiot over there is—"

"They're both guys, right? What are you talking about, Izumi!"

"... Hey?"

"What?"

It did seem Millia was mindful of the female knight of the wolf tribe close to Rudel. While they did get along, Eunius saw it as the relationship between superior and subordinate. He knew his close friend Rudel, and Bennet's actions didn't have anything to do with man or woman.

And yet, Millia was wary of Bennet. Still such accusations, Bennet still stood with resolution, but her tail and dog ears were in a terrible station.

"Why is that woman so angry?"

"Are you talking about Millia? She hasn't seen eye to eye with Izumi lately. It's been like that ever since we came here... Izumi's been aggressive towards Lieutenant Keith, and Millia's been wary of Major Bennet. I don't know the reason either."

"Ah, I see. Right, right. That's the sort of guy you are."

Recalling how Rudel wasn't wary of Keith, Eunius was convinced his friend's chastity had been protected by Izumi. He suddenly wondered whether Aleist would be alright, but he had a number of key harem member with him, so he'd probably be fine, or so Eunius changed his train of thought.

As Rudel didn't understand, he mulled over whether to inform Rudel that Keith was dangerous precisely because they were members of the opposite sex. In truth, even if the two of them had their innocence stolen, he thought it might become a funny story.

While he was worried, it was interesting no matter which way the ball rolled. Keith was so entranced with Aleist and Rudel that he calculated

there was no danger of himself becoming a casualty.

More importantly...

(This isn't the atmosphere to have a duel.)

The fact he wasn't able to fight Rudel displeased Eunius. It did seem Millia and Izumi had stolen the flow away.

The arguments of women would gradually intensify. At first, they would argue over whether Keith or Bennet was more dangerous, gradually shifting to things of the past. Eunius thought women who never forgot their grudges were scary.

"You called me a bug back at the academy, didn't you!"

"T-that just came to my mind during the match and... t-that has nothing to do with what's happening right now!"

Two of Aleist's harem stepped in to soothe them, but the problem was they didn't have the slightest effect. Within that never-ending argument, Bennet pulled at Rudel's sleeve.

"D-did I do something problematic?"

While she acted out a firm bearing, her voice was shaking. Her eyes were swimming around. To such a commanding officer, Rudel spoke gently.

"That's not true at all! You're the ideal superior, Major! I can say with pride that I'm glad to have become your subordinate."

"I-I see."

As she averted her face, Bennet's tail swung happily from left to right. Her form brought to mind the image of a dog rejoicing after receiving praise from its master.

But thinking it was strange the voices had died down, Eunius looked at Millia and Izumi only to feel intense regret.

"Just look at that! Just look at how much that woman's tail is wagging! She's definitely gunning for Rudel!"

"I'm telling you, that's not the sort of thing we're dealing with! Can't you get a grip already?"

Seeing the exchange between Rudel and Bennet, the two heated up even further. The members of Aleist's harem around had already given up on persuading them.

(These guys are useless!)

I won't be able to fight Rudel today, Eunis instinct promptly informed him.

◇

"... They're more vindictive than I thought."

"That does seem to be the case."

Fina's room at the academy was already in a state more like an office equipped with a bed. Having entered her final year, Fina only had a few months left until graduation.

While Fina thought a school life that ended with fluffing and work was mistaken, she didn't say it aloud. If she didn't have the needlessly competent Fina, she never would have made it this far to begin with.

On top of the nobles and authorities connected to Aileen, the augmented war potential of the royal guard...

Everything had come together.

"When we have to prepare on two fronts, the border and the palace, they only have to pay mind to the palace, so they sure have it easy."

"Worse comes to worst, can't we keep it to the palace? In that scenario, we can concentrate our own forces."

"... That's no good."

While Fina didn't know how both sides were connected, she did suspect how each side reacted and moved in accordance.

While they would likely move the moment her side showed an opening, the enemy country was showing movements as if they knew precisely when that time would come. It was a dangerous situation, Sophina thought over the worst possible scenario and wanted to concentrate their forces at the palace.

Rather than trying to win both fronts, she wanted to stop Aileen's reckless that was definitely going to break out.

But Fina's opinion differed.

"In the case that the empire has gained the means to stand against the kingdom, there is no meaning if we suppress the palace alone. If they manage to snatch up a large amount of land, then they will gain just as much power on the rematch. The top brass of the kingdom will need some time to recover from its chaos, and in that time, the empire should be able to get its war potential together. If we don't suppress both fronts, we won't survive."

The empire's hatred of the kingdom, from the people of the kingdom's point of view, it was nothing but false charges. You live on abundant soil, so fork it over, is what they were saying. That was the country's recognition of the empire.

Sophina knew the lands of the empire were impoverished. What's more, she knew just how important it was to them to invade Courtois and steal its soil.

"When territories are stolen, there will be some nobles who turn coat. And if I let my sister get away, there will definitely be nobles to raise a rebellion. We have to win both sides no matter what."

As she accepted a few documents from Fina, Sophina made a grim face. The nobles they recognized to be allied with Aileen. In a situation where

they couldn't lose to the Gaia Empire or Aileen, the country of Courtois... Fina's powers were being cornered.

No, it wasn't a corner they were being driven into. Fina had started this match well-aware of her disadvantage.

Within a present state that only grew harsher the more time transpired. Fina was trying to create a build up a stage she could overcome. Sophina was also moving and lending her power for that sake.

"... If nothing else, it's our fortune a princess was allowed into the academy. Before the enemy moves, we've been able to build our own personal forces like this. If we were in the palace, we'd never be able to move to this extent."

Sophina's opinion wasn't mistaken. In the palace, they would never have been able to establish so many connections. At the same time, they were able to move away from Aileen's eyes. It could truly be called fortune.

"I know, right!? It's because I'm loved! I'm a maiden loved by the fluffadise above! You can call me the fluffmaiden if you wish... no, that doesn't sound right. I get the feeling maiden's headed in the wrong direction. This body of mine ain't gonna stay pure for long."

Seeing Fina's tension suddenly rise, Sophina noticed it was about time for her concentration to run out. As she had Mii prepare tea, Fina leapt out of her seat and headed off towards the white cat tribe lass.

"If only she didn't have this side, she'd be perfect..."

Sophina breathed out a sigh as she gazed over Fina expressionlessly fluffing up Mii.



"The results of the experimental subject?"

Mies Licorise wore a lab coat.

In the laboratory, her subordinates were busily making records of the cages containing the black monsters. The final adjustments on the strengthened monsters were being in that lab of the Gaia empire.

Ogres and orcs, wyverns and a wide array of different monsters, you could say their control experiments were proceeding smoothly.

"No problems to report. It has already received a high evaluation taking on monsters within imperial territory."

Taking the documents from her subordinate, Mies read the report of the newly formed unit. When operating monsters, if taking command was possible, they needed an exclusive unit to do so. For that sake, they were conducted experiment after experiment, combatting monsters on imperial soil.

Seeing the papers that reported absolutely no problem, her subordinate seemed self-confident. But Mies was beginning to fear it a bit.

"If we keep on succeeding like this, it does feel somewhat eerie. More importantly, it seems some of the monsters they took on fled in the direction of Courtois, but how is that handling?"

"Nothing to worry about. It's a common occurrence. Some common monsters were just driven out of the mountains."

As her subordinate showed no particular concern, Mies warned him not to let his guard down. To her, this research held a vital meaning.

"We've been pushing ourselves too hard this past year. The higher-ups told us not to make too big of a ruckus before the invasion, so be careful henceforth."

"Y-yes."

As her subordinate man left the area, Mies headed for the space in front of the largest cage. Their prototype of a large monster called a gora sat quietly, still with its ferocious expression on its face. On top of the fangs that stuck

out of its mouth, when it became an enhanced variant, its skin and fur dyed a shade of black, making for a truly ominous sight.

For some reason, a white tattoo spread across its body, and large bat like wings spread out from its back. The gora's eyes narrowed as it looked at Mies, it almost seemed to be laughing.

"... You monster."

A cold sweat running along her back, Mies left with due haste.

Chapter 126

Noon had already passed by the time the notice reached the port town of Beretta.

To the three dragoons on duty, a report came in that some towns and villages near the border were under attack. The ones who delivered the messages were knights mainly tasked as messengers.

Those knights who rode hippogryphs, crosses between horses and gryphons, were a shadow unit largely specialized in working with information. Unlike the dragoons, who could only take action as a public affair, they would accomplish their missions without standing out.

The hippogryphs took the forms of horses, entering the port town with innocent faces. But those knights who tamed beasts even rarer than dragons were those who served directly under the royal line. It was unnatural to find them in a place like this.

"You're telling us to sortie?"

Wearing a hood, the knight's face couldn't be made out. While the inside of the hood was definitely dark, they seemed to be wearing some sort of mask.

After bringing their feet to Bennet in civilian clothing, they gathered the relevant personnel and undid their disguises in the meeting room.

Eunius and Aleist, who had been forcefully dragged along the way, showed different reactions as they stood before a knight brigade that was famous, in a sense.

While Eunius was full of interest towards that nameless brigade he was seeing for the first time, Aleist firmly tilted his head. Even when it came to

hippogryphs, it seems he didn't even know of their very existence in this world.

While gryphons were impossible to tame by human hands, if one were to sire a child with a mare, a hippogryph was the result. That being the case, gryphons would more often than not make meals of horses, and hippogryphs themselves were infertile. For that sake, their conception itself was rare.

"Yes. We do not have the ability to hold them in place. Speaking to their scale, the option of diverting them away from the towns and villages will prove difficult."

Before the masked knight who replied to Bennet with a muffled voice, Keith was silent. While Keith was usually the sort to start a ruckus, when it came to work, his expression changed.

"The scale is far too grand. What happened?"

"We cannot offer you the specifics... but, it's certain they're flowing in from the empire's side. To add to that, it is doubtful that a second wave will come."

"Counting the small fries, it's a scale surpassing a thousand."

"I observed them from afar, and they seem to be searching for food. It's a considerably dangerous situation."

Bennet put together a plan from the information coming in. But there, Aleist stepped into the ranks. From what he had heard, it was certain these knights sat and watched while the monsters attacked a village.

"You don't mean you overlooked them!"

As he drew close to a robed knight, Eunius grasped his shoulders. When Aleist turned, Eunius shook his head to the side.

"That's just the sort of unit they belong to. While they may be knights, they're the sort of folks who conceal their numbers and history to work for

the crown. That they even came to notify us is a miracle."

Eunius turned his gaze to the robed knight. The knight who couldn't be made out as man or woman showed not the slightest quiver. As Aleist looked down, Bennet came to the conclusion they were in a situation where no ordinary means of communication was viable.

"Keith, take the lead and take down the monsters around the settlement under attack. Upon my arrival, I'll enter ground combat. After that.—"

"I-I'll go too!" "Oy!"

When Bennet put out orders, Aleist let out his will to tag along. Eunius thought it was a discourtesy to involve one's self in the dealings of another brigade and tried to stop him. But Bennet gave consent.

(This might be just right.)

"Rudel, this time, you'll be riding my Heleene. If those two over there wish to ride, they can come along as well."

As Bennet gave the word, Keith made a stern expression. He surely wanted to criticize her for taking any unrelated people to the site, however, Bennet informed him before he could open his mouth.

"At the battle site, procedure has you come under my command. What's more, the tagalongs have simply increased from two to four."

Keith scratched his head, and while he didn't fully accept it, if it was an order... or so he silently rushed out of the room. Just as he left the meeting room, his dragon started its descent outside the building, having been put on standby in the air.

Thinking he would be a reliable subordinate, this time, she turned her whole body towards her direct subordinate Rudel.

"Rudel, you will not be taking Sakuya on this mission."

"Major, Sakuya can do it. If it's just monsters, then—"

"It seems you are misunderstanding something. Let me spell it out clearly. What is demanded of us is the perfect execution of a mission. She did her best? That effort isn't even worthy of evaluation. I have determined it is impossible for your dragon to execute the mission. That is why you're not bringing her."

On the verge of opening his mouth, Rudel looked down mortified as he put nothing more than his acceptance to mouth. While Bennet wanted to try cheering up her subordinate, they didn't have the time. Thinking there would be some time to talk en route, she rushed into her preparations.

"We're heading out at once. Prepare what you can, if you're not at the plaza, you'll be left behind."

After calling over to Aleist and Eunius, Bennet rushed out of the meeting room herself. For her equipment, she just had to fasten her bag to her dragon.

She could settle Rudel's worries in the sky. That's all she had to think, and yet she ended up mulling over something unnecessary.

(Sakuya-chan's going to be depressed.)



Following on from Keith's lead, the party headed off for a counteroffensive, but from her dragon's back, Bennet issued the orders for the site.

"Protection of the civilians?"

In regards to Izumi's question, Bennet spoke.

"That's right. Rudel and I will sweep up the monsters that infiltrated. The rest of you will be guarding the civilians who've evacuated. Generally speaking, you'd be in the way otherwise."

Hearing he would be in the way, Aleist started to his feet, but Eunius stopped him. The very fact that the usual Eunius would probably rise at

those words as well only made Aleist more surprised.

"We're capable of fighting too."

"She knows that. She took us along because we can fight. But this is Rudel's job. We shouldn't get in the way."

Being talked to in a manner as if to soothe a child irritated him, but Aleist had no words to return. He understood. He never thought he'd be able to establish coordination with the others in this battle, but he did have the will to help.

Both side of the coin mingled within him, leaving him at a loss for words.

"Aleist, leave it to me and the Major."

When Rudel said it, Aleist could only nod.

(Goddammit. Aren't I supposed to strong? Wasn't I supposed to have become strong?)

He was irritated at his own uselessness. If he was the protagonist of the story, then no matter the time, he should be able to make the impossible possible. So he thought, but the real him was different.

Cleaning day in and day out, he was an existence distant from anything that could be called the lead role. Even so, some day... he had held onto the belief, but he knew reality was never so sweet.

Raising his face, he looked at the town raising black smoke. If they carried out their lives, surely smoke would rise, but it was a dark smoke that failed to give off the slightest sense of liveliness. On that scene where he thought he might hear human screams at any moment, Aleist swallowed his breath.

(I'm scared.)

He wasn't afraid of battle. He was afraid of his own powerlessness. Atop the dragon's back, Aleist strengthened his resolve. Just as he was about to tell himself he wasn't the same useless child he once was, Bennet...

"We're landing in the town plaza, but we don't have the time for a descent. I'll put her on an inverted flight, so just jump down."

"Yes! ... wait, what?"

From the large bag fastened to the dragon's back, Bennet produced a metal boomerang that spanned her whole height.

What's more, it wasn't just one or two. She had stuffed what could be called several dozens of boomerangs into her bag.

"Major, should I hold that for you?"

Rudel called out in worry, but Bennet wagged her tail as she denied it.

"You fool! What good will it do in your hands? Keep a good eye on the way I fight. If Keith is doing well at the vanguard, then right around now..."

In the air above the town they approached, a water dragon was firing a stream of attacks towards the ground. Attacking the area around the ground, it eliminated the monsters flying through the sky. But as a dragon's attacks would raze the town, its assault was limited to the town's airspace and exterior.

Seeing the skillful manipulation of the dragon, everyone held the impression it would be impossible for Sakuya. More than that, she might even erase the town alongside the monsters.

"... Looks like he's doing just fine. Heleene, meet up with Spinnith and strike down the monsters around."

As Bennet called out to her own dragon, the dragon gave a single roar in the air. It was as if it was responding to say it understood. If anyone apart from a dragoon saw the scene, it would look like a one-sided conversation with a dragon.

"Then we're off." "Ah, wai... gyaaaah!!"

Taking a sudden nose-dive, Heleene turned and flew in a position with her stomach face up. From what had once been a stable flight, her motions changed to a trajectory that brought a roller coaster to mind. Aleist was never too good with roller coasters.

"Aleist, you'll bite your tongue." "My thoughts exactly."

While Rudel worried for Aleist, Eunius was making a fed-up face. With this being their first real battle, neither Izumi nor Millia found the leisure to pay mind to Aleist's tensions. Meanwhile, Rudel was calling out to those two.

Aleist regretted it just a bit that he had missed the perfect opportunity.

"And here we go."

Watching Bennet's back, Aleist was surprised. Grasping a bundle of those large boomerangs, she went straight into throwing them. The number thrown in that instant was six. From there, they flew, spinning with good momentum to find a target in the monsters on the ground.

Each time they stuck into the earth, they would sew monsters onto it. Once she had finished throwing eighteen, Bennet cried out.

"Now, jump off!"

Seeing everyone jump off, Aleist jumped down just a little late. His timing slightly off, he was the only one who fell into the fountain in the center of the plaza. After his body struck the fountain water that rose to about knee-level, he sunk from the weight of his equipment.

"What are you doing, Aleist!? You're alright, right? Right!?"

"I-I'm fine..."

Crawling out of the water, Aleist sent Millia a smile. But Millia immediately commenced a survey of the area.

While Millia had called out to him, Aleist was the sort who was happy even if it was a yell. Looking around, they could see Bennet and Rudel

commence their action.

"I saw them evacuating to the south in droves. You lot, head straight south!"

With those words, the two started running west and soon went out of sight.

"Bennet-san has good eyes."

Holding such an out-of-place impression, Aleist hardened his resolve as he and the other three ran off to save the townsfolk.



While they each possessed different means of high-speed movement, looking at the result, it seemed as if Rudel was just barely managing to follow.

It was a small town, where three story buildings were rare, and the highest they would go. The two of them were clearing up monsters in the area where the residential buildings were closely packed together. But in the space where Rudel defeated a single monster, Bennet was defeating them one after the next.

Defeating a monster on the move, she would instantly search out her next target.

(She really is fast.)

When it came to instantaneous acceleration, Rudel wasn't losing. More than that, when it came to speed, Rudel surely had the upper hand.

Bennet tossed two knives at the two goblins who tried to flee into an alleyway. With their vitals accurately captured, the two died instantly.

Bennet and Rudel leapt freely across the spaces between buildings, but their movements were different. Rudel couldn't help but decelerate right before an attack.

There, they heard a scream.

When he slowed down to check, he found a single orc about to lower an adze of stone and wood down at a family unit. IT would likely fall under the more clever variety of monster. Rudel swiftly moved to the space above the orc, accelerating towards the ground as he used his sword to bisect it.

For a while now, he had stopped counting how many monsters he had taken down.

As the orc split vertically spurted blood, Rudel was bathed in it. Seeing that form, the family who had been attacked raised a greater scream as they ran off.

The left arm he had extended in an attempt to assist them, before he noticed it, Bennet had approached and grasped it.

"What are you doing? The cleanup isn't over yet."

"But we have to ensure their safety."

"In the time you spend saving a single family, many more residents will die. They fled up the path we cleaned up and came down, their probability of survival is high."

The family that ran off without lending an ear was already out of sight.

"We can leave the monsters outside town to Keith and Heleene, but we're the only ones who can take on the monsters who came in."

Seeing off Bennet, who commenced movement after leaving only those words Rudel grit his teeth. He understood it in his head. But when it was actually before his eyes, he had some hesitation. Beginning his movement a little late, he caught up with Bennet, who had lowered speed.

"Get it in your head, the more you waver, the more people will die. And that is the extent of your strength. If you want to save them, you have to become stronger."

"... Yes."

Saying that as Rudel caught up, Bennet accelerated again. In order to follow, Rudel raised his speed. While desperately keeping on her tail, Rudel watched her back.

She had already used up all the boomerangs she shouldered, and she didn't have my throwing knives left. But that didn't lower the speed she took them down. It just went to show how diverse she was.

At the same time, she wasn't using any unnecessary power. Her movement and attacks gave off the impression she was only using the minimum necessary. To Rudel, it looked like he was watching a professional work.

In contrast, Rudel's means of attack were limited. As they were in the middle of town, he couldn't use magic. When attacking on the move, the accuracy would fall, and if the magic of the needlessly powerful Rudel failed, it would incur damages onto the area.

If he had Sakuya, the damage would become something severe.

(Sakuya, me and you, we've got a long ways to go.)

Bennet kicked away an orc before his eyes, sending a number of goblins tumbling down alongside it. Perhaps she had inserted her kick into a vital, as the orc showed no signs of moving. She had run out of throwing knives, now holding a dagger in each hand, changing to a dual-wielding style.

With that, her movements only grew sharper.

Even when approaching an enemy was when one's movements were supposed to require the greatest amount of caution.

"Just right. Rudel, I'll show you by example. Burn it into your eyes."

As the two of them landed on a rooftop, Bennet ordered Rudel to watch before jumping down. While there were monsters fearful of the combat prowess she had shown, perhaps seeing her form, there were some who misunderstood her as weak, as they began to flock.

Her appearance was that of a young girl, a weak one at that. Even if a few of them had comparatively good heads on their shoulders, there was a limit to that. In regards to the monsters coming at her, Bennet showed no panic.

In the next instant, after she had lightly jumped twice on the spot, to Rudel, it almost looked as if she had disappeared.

Immediately activating his magic eyes, Rudel traced her movements. It was a speed no different from his own, perhaps even slower, but rather than his emergency bursts, her movements were smaller.

For all the speed he had, Rudel couldn't help but make his movements large, and it was here the difference was coming out. There was no waste in each step she took.

By the time he realized it, the surrounding monsters had been cleaned up.



Meanwhile, Eunius and the others who were to prioritize the protection of the townsfolk were protecting the evacuees from monsters.

The largest building in town was apparently a fort built up ages ago.

"Goddammit, there's no end to them."

Cutting down two monsters with his great sword, a blood-stained Eunius used a cloth to wipe off his face. That had been the last of the monsters who'd approached. But even so, given just a bit of time, the monsters would group and attack again.

Climbing onto the surrounding buildings, Millia used sound to notify them whenever monsters were approaching. She could handle a bow, and they were thankful she could take the stragglers down from that position.

"Eunius, switch out with me."

"Are you stupid? I can't use a lick of magic. You stay at the entrance and continue with magic support."

Returning Aleist to his original post, Eunius observed Millia and Izumi. No problems with Aleist. In front of the building the townsfolk had evacuated into, there was a small courtyard. As they could use magic there, then it was easy to defend against monsters of this level.

"Even so, if we didn't happen to be there, what did that cute captain plan on doing... well, she's got her dragon, so I'm sure it'd work out."

He shifted his eyes to Izumi. Millia was keeping wary of the surroundings. There didn't seem to be any particular problems on her side, but Izumi's exhaustion was severe.

Apart from battle, she was put to looking after the residents who'd evacuated. Eunius would treat them too roughly, and with Millia, there were some race-related problems.

More than anything, Aleist was unreliable in these sorts of things. As a result, the burden was placed on Izumi.

Calming the townsfolk in chaos, and be that as it may, she still dealt with the monster attacks. The enemies came in numbers too great, and even Aleist's magic wasn't able to completely deal with them.

"The uniform of a high knight really is effective."

The fact Izumi was a high knight had an effect, more or less. Of course, from the townsfolk's point of view, it wasn't as if they understood her affiliation. They decided by appearance that some splendid knight was talking.

Aleist and Eunius were in civilian clothing, and the defenders' uniform didn't look much different from that of the rank and file to begin with.

But even with Izumi persuading them, the residents continued to riot, making it even worse in nature. There was a merchant-esque man who demanded they go out to save his child left behind. Because his wife died, there was a man who rushed out saying he would die as well.

Eunius felt an anger he had nowhere to place as he thought of how he would fulfill the job before his eyes.

Chapter 127

By the time it was all over, two villages were wiped off the map, and a town was half-destroyed.

Thinking of the situation when they came, the dragoons who had prevented the situation from worsening were worthy of praise, but that wasn't a tale of the outskirts, it was one of the central capital.

From the townsfolks' point of view, a large number of monsters had suddenly flooded into the area where they were peacefully living their lives. The numbers easily exceeded a thousand. The soldiers protecting the town had perished, and the villages the monsters passed through were annihilated.

When the night opened up and noon was almost upon them, the monster cleanup had finally been completed. To be more precise, the final checks began around dawn, and they were finally completed at noon.

The monsters had been taken care of before the sun rose.

"It really is amazing."

Izumi tossed a monster corpse into the hole piled up with other bodies like it, pulling back as she watched Heleene fill the pit with a fiery breath.

"We have to clean up quickly, after all. When it comes to these things, having a dragon makes it go much faster."

Even if they didn't have enough people, as long as they had a dragon they were a match for a thousand, Izumi had witnessed a dragoon's ability. Not flustering before over a thousand monsters, they finished their work in a

day. The monsters who had fled upon the arrival of a dragoon were all wiped away by Keith. It wasn't as easy as it sounded.

"Keith... Lieutenant Keith is quite something too."

"While you might hate him, that guy does his job. I'd like him to be that earnest on a regular basis, but as long as you properly do your work, our organization's much laxer than the high knights."

As Izumi stood in conflicted sentiment, two of the robed, masked knights appeared. The horses they led along looked to be a size larger than the others. Izumi stood on guard, but Bennet held up a hand and began talks.

"Is there anything else?"

"No, as expected of the dragoons, is all we wanted to say. We've got much to think over in this incident as well."

"I see, then you can return to your job. The knight brigades should arrive within a few days."

Keith had already made off to report; the knights would soon rush in. But it was hard to say how much supplies they would bring with them.

As it was a territory near the border, and there was some money invested into its military. If it was a territory out of danger's way, then local armies and militia would serve well enough, but the feudal lord who reigned over the town possessed his own knight brigade.

"The least we could do is offer our thanks. Well then..."

After lowering their heads, the two knights mounted their horses. As they did, the horses' heads changed to those of eagles, and their front legs to a bird's as well. Only their back halves remained in a horse state.

When they took to the air, Heleene glared at them.

"You can't eat them, Heleene."

The dragon sent a single roar into the sky, and the hippogryphs hurriedly soared out of sight.

"Who are they?"

"Yeah, well... they're folks without a name."

Izumi mulled over whether she should ask any further, but Bennet made a troubled face, so she decided to leave it at that. While they were talking, Rudel approached. But their expressions were a little confused.



When Bennet came to the plaza, she found Eunius there, quite fed up. Sitting on a wooden crate, a sleepy look on his face.

All the knights had worked through the night. The fatigue from unfamiliar work was also coming out.

"What's wrong?"

"To hell with what's wrong! Why didn't you come sooner!? The town's a mess is it not!? I'll let you know I've got a wide face around the capital."

The merchant-esque man was perhaps speaking as a representative of town. With his connections in the center, his attitude remained large before a knight.

Bennet knew this was going to be a pain, but she didn't show it on her face. Her tail simply dropped powerlessly in exhaustion.

In the corner of her eye, she could see Aleist wrapped in a reed mat with his mouth gagged in cloth. While he was desperately trying to cry something out, she couldn't understand what he wanted to say. But having received an explanation from Rudel along the way, she had a general grasp of the situation.

"You might think you'll receive some sort of medal for saving us, but I'll definitely never let it happen!"

"Is that so. In that case, do what you want. The knight brigade should be coming in the near future, so we'll stick around to guard you until then."

Bennet didn't seem to pay it any mind, and after dealing with the representative man, she called everyone to follow. Aleist alone was taken off over Eunius' shoulder.

All the gazes that fell upon the party came from unfavorable eyes. It was only natural. When they had suffered such casualty and loss, these folks would sit back in the center, showered in medals and rewards. When they imagined it, they couldn't help but feel irritated.

"Major, in this case, I was nothing but a hindrance. So I don't deser—"

Feeling the eyes of the townsfolk, Rudel suggested he would turn down the rewards. But Bennet shook her head. After they had separated from the residents, she explained to him.

"They're not giving a medal for your sake alone. This is a medal granted for the frontier. You guys better remember that too."

Making a tired face, Millia seemed perplexed. Perhaps that explanation didn't satisfy her as she opened her mouth.

"What's that supposed to mean? If they're giving out medals and rewards, shouldn't they use those funds for restoration?"

"That's the right way to look at it. It's so righteous it's bringing tears to my eyes. If that was possible, we wouldn't have any troubles."

Bennet explained how in the territory on the border, there was the feudal lord's own knight brigade alongside some dispatched forces. They were one of the dispatchments. And when it came to the territory, that was the feudal lord's responsibility. To be more precise, Bennet's dispatchment hadn't received a request, so they were under no obligation to save them.

However, she didn't have the option of not saving them. It was precisely because they possessed the large powers called dragons that such a thing

would never be permitted of a dragoon. If she overlooked it, then blame might even be attached.

Dragoons were the heroes of Courtois. But Bennet didn't think of herself as a hero. For the sake of the country, she played the part of the ideal dragoon.

Her expression distorting, Millia shifted her gaze from Bennet, so Eunius explained in her place. Placed in a position where he had to use people, Eunius knew.

"... This might sound cruel, but if they don't give out medals or praise anyone, no one's going to move. Meaning it's about profit. The country is the one profiting from it. Territory management is the feudal lord's responsibility. Originally, the law states that the knight brigade and soldiers were supposed to deal with it. But the borderland also has knights stationed by the country for national defense. Well, I'm sure the situation's special this time, since those guys were here as well."

Bennet took over Eunius' explanation. Those guys referred to the knights in the masks. Those who specialized in covert operations. Not wanting to talk too much about them, Bennet retook the conversation a little forcefully.

"If they commend us, then of the surrounding territories, some will start to send aid. Willingly at that. On top of selling a favor to this territory, this tale will become the talk of the area. The folks who want to put on airs will gather."

Once Bennet arrived at the tent they set up for camp, everyone took a seat. Izumi was already at her limit, her complexion was taking a bad turn. The way Rudel worried for her looked considerably cute. But Bennet spoke on for her subordinate and his comrades.

"Just because you saved them, there's no guarantee everyone will be thankful. It's more often that demi-humans will find themselves discriminated against."

As she took a fleeting glance at Millia, Millia averted her face. Along the way, she heard that the representative man insulted Millia, angering Aleist.

"But if we didn't come, they would've been annihilated, right? They got in the way when we were fighting, and even if we save them, they spout off complaints."

Finally freed, Aleist gave an irritated rebuttal to Bennet. He didn't understand why they'd be insulted when they saved them. Bennet recalled her experiences from when she was a new recruit, for some reason thinking back on them warmly.

"That's how it works. Or could it be you seriously thought you would be praised and lifted up as a hero? Lining nothing but pretty words won't help them live their lives. Show a bit of understanding."

The anger they had nowhere to place, they slammed it against who was available. This was the result of going through such troubles and risking their lives to protect them.

"Then what's the point of sa..."

While Millia brought her mouth that far, she couldn't say the rest. She couldn't see the value in going as far as to be insulted to save them. And she had no such obligation.

With a haggard face, Izumi asked Bennet.

"Major Bennet, what do you think of it?"

Bennet gave an immediate response. Within her, that was an unwavering fact.

"My? In my case, it's simple. I do it because it's my job."

Based on how they were taken, those were cold words.



As they waited for the lord's knights to arrive, Millia assisted Rudel and the others in restoration work. They moved the collapsed buildings and rubble blocking the paths.

Those works could generally be left to the dragons, so Millia helped the men out on patrol.

"What about Izumi?"

"She was sent around to the food lines. It would be harsh for the Major alone."

She spoke with Rudel. Normally, Millia would've been put on the food lines as well, but cooking was her weak point. What's more, she was well aware she would lower the efficiency of the work. Because of that, Millia was patrolling with Rudel.

Aleist and Eunius were currently on break and asleep. It was a town that had just suffered tragedy, but if they let their guards down for a moment, the bandits would gather.

There were also those who might try something strange. In order to put checks on those sorts, it was their duty as knights to keep watch, or so Bennet taught them.

"Even so, little by little, people are starting to help out."

Each time they looked over town, the number of residents who had begun clearing away Ruble increased ever so slightly.

While there were people whose occupations weren't an absolute necessity, once they finished clearing up, they opened up shop. A bakery they passed by was distributing bread to people free of charge.

"Oh, if it isn't the knights. Take this with you."

The well-bodied proprietress of the bakery handed a brown sack of bread to Millia and Rudel. There were loaves of freshly baked bread lining the front of the store, and while the inside still seemed to be a mess, there was a white smoke rising from the chimney.

"Eh? But..."

While Millia made a troubled face, Rudel paid it no mind and accepted the offer.

"Thank you."

"Hahaha, just a bit of thanks for saving us. Why not come over some day to make a purchase?"

"I definitely will."

Holding up the bag of freshly baked bread, Rudel gave a response to make one think he really would come again. Millia had been around him for a considerable amount of time, and she saw that part of him hadn't changed.

As they walked, Rudel started into the continuation of the previous conversation.

"This is what the Major said, but an empty stomach thins the heart. That's why meals are so important. Once they have some leisure, their bodies will move."

"Yet you move even without the leisure. Aren't you pushing yourself too hard?"

Millia worried for Rudel, who had continued moving for the past few days without rest. But the man in question was too sturdy for that, and gave a smile.

"I can go on!"

"Hah, whatever."

As she breathed out a sigh, the two of them took a seat on the wreckage of a collapsed building. The sun had come to a high point in the sky. It was quite probably noon. As they sat side by side, eating the bread they're received, the town women who passed by clicked their tongues.

Looking down, Millia recalled the insults she received a few days ago. The representative man told her, a demi human shouldn't stick in their mouth,

they need only work until they die. The fact there were still people like that around saddened her.

It felt as if she'd been shown a clear delineation.

"Don't mind it. The Major said nothing starts with mulling."

"I know that. But there are some things that get to the heart."

Stuffing his face with breath, Rudel consoled Millia. Gazing at the spot where she and Rudel sat, she felt there was a clear delineation there as well. As he gulped water from the flask hung at his waist, Rudel had already finished his meal.

When Millia tried to eat the bread in her hands, a single young boy entered her eyes. From the shadow of a tree in their line of sight, he seemed to be peering at them. Perhaps Rudel was waiting for Millia to finish eating, as he was looking at the sky without noticing the boy. No, while he did notice, it's possible he was just ignoring him.

No matter how you looked at him, the boy was still young. Wary that even a kid like that would say something against her, her eye met with the boy, who would occasionally pop out his head. There, the boy frantically hid himself.

Finishing up her bread, Millia tried to leave at once. She had no obligation to hear out his complaints, but as she stood, the boy hurriedly leapt out of the tree's shadow.

"We're going."

"No, it looks like he's got some business with you, Millia."

Rudel noticed the boy look at her with straightforward eyes, grasping Millia's hand as she tried to depart. There, the boy glared at Rudel.

While Millia made a displeased face, Rudel seemed somewhat amused. He didn't seem to be an ill-natured boy, so he surely had some sort of reason. Thinking that, Millia turned her whole body towards him.

"Something wrong?"

"U-um..."

The boy looking down held both his hands behind his back. The way she was looking down over him couldn't be helped from his height.

There, the boy brought the hands he kept behind to the front. Millia readied herself for a knife, but what she found instead was a bouquet of flowers, wrapped in the brown paper the bread was distributed in.

They were flowers that grew around the area, by no means difficult to reach, but the boy who seriously collected them's face turned red. Once he'd gone so far, Millia understood as well. Leaning down to match the boy's eye level, she accepted the bouquet.

"... Are you sure you want to give them to me?"

"Y-yeah."

The young boy couldn't look her in the face, looking to one side.

"Thank you."

"You saved me, so... I have to say thank you."

As he watched over the two of them, Rudel was all smiles. With a conflicted psyche, Millia stared at Rudel. There, the boy took off running, his face a bright red.

Along the way, he turned around and yelled at Millia.

"I-I love you!" "Say what!?"

Never expecting it to go as far as a confession, Millia was surprised. While Rudel watched her expression change with a grin, the boy had something to shout at Rudel as well.

"And I hate yoouuuu!"

Watching the boy run off screaming he hated him, Rudel was surprised as well. Millia looked at Rudel like that and burst into laughter.

Sha laughed and laughed, and perhaps she had laughed too hard, as her tears came out, and she wiped them with her fingertip. While Rudel was also laughing at the end, Millia grew curious, so she ended up asking.

"Could it be you knew he was going to confess?"

"Yes, when he making such serious eyes, I'd notice whether I wanted to or not. And wait, you never noticed, Millia? You're a little dense."

"I don't want to hear that from you!"

Being called dense from the densest of them all, Millia cried out in a voice that resounded through town.



When they returned to the tent where they camped out, they found Aleist and Eunius cleaning up after the food lines. They were washing the cooking utensils nearby the tent. They looked quite sleepy.

They had probably started helping out as soon as they woke.

"You two are late. Did something happen?"

When Eunius said that to Rudel with a broad grin, Aleist was flustered. He looked at Rudel and Milia with worried eyes, but Rudel...

"Yeah, Millia was confessed to. The one who confessed mistook me as her boyfriend because I was nearby."

As Rudel said that with a laugh, Aleist held his head. Rudel couldn't understand what he did wrong, so he looked at Eunius. There, Eunius shook his head.

"You don't have to worry about it. Rather, it's best you don't do anything."

He knew Aleist loved Millia from their student days. While he wanted to do something to help out, it was his weak field, so he decided not to stick in a hand.

"I-I see."

Millia was also making a conflicted face, but it would be bad to confuse Rudel with any unneeded help, or so she remonstrated herself. Having heard the voices, Bennet appeared from inside the tent.

"You're late, you two. The soup's gone cold, so I'll put it on the fire again."

"No, we're fine with it like that."

Rudel refused, not wanting to cause Bennet any trouble. But Bennet rejected that refusal.

"I'm doing it to make sure you properly do your work. So return the favor by working it off."

"... Thank you. Major, if I may?"

"What is it?"

As she walked off to warm the soup, Bennet turned around to look at Rudel.

"To you, what is your job?"

Having thought about his work ever since then, Rudel wanted to ask about her sense of values when it came to working. Otherwise, he would see Bennet as the sort of person who only helped people because it was her job.

He couldn't find an answer himself, so he asked her directly.

"It's nothing to think so hard about. But, if I had to say... it's how I live my life."

Rudel thought a bit before giving a satisfied nod. It was an answer he was satisfied with. He knew that Bennet didn't say it was work with cold-hearted

thoughts.

"Thank you."

"Hmm, to rejoice over hearing such a thing, you really are an idiot."

When Bennet turned to walk off, her tail was delightfully waving from side to side. Leaving Aleist- still holding his head- to the side, Eunius walked over to Rudel and watched Bennet's back as he struck up a conversation.

"Even when we were just a hindrance, perhaps Ms. Major brought us along for our ... no, for you and Aleist's sake."

While Eunius called Bennet Ms. Major, it didn't seem to be out of sarcasm. He had recognized her in his own way.

"... You might be right."

Rudel looked at Bennet's back as he agreed. Unlike them, Bennet had graduated the academy on the two-year curriculum. From a situation where she didn't even have a knight's qualifications, she had gotten a dragon to recognize her and climbed up the ranks.

If Rudel and the others were elites, then Bennet really was a self-made soldier.

"When she's got her troubles, she's good at looking after people."

Rudel and Eunius understood why Bennet went out of her way to bring them. She wanted to show them where it all happened. Not only out of good will, with their unstable positions, there was no telling when Rudel and Aleist would rise up the ranks.

It would be troubling if they rose without knowing anything, or perhaps she had calculated so. But that wasn't all, the two thought.

"I'm proud to have her as my superior officer."

On Rudel's boast, Eunius laughed and joked.

"I want one at my place too. Hand her over."

"Hell no."

While the two of them were exchanging jokes, Aleist held his head in serious thoughts. Millia looked perplexedly over the three men.

A few days later, switching out with the first dispatchments of knights, Rudel returned to the port town of Beretta.

Around that time, Aleist ended up in a petty quarrel with the boy in love with Millia.

Chapter 128

After returning to the port town of Beretta, Rudel spent his days with Izumi, comforting a depressed Sakuya.

Within all of that, Rudel made a small shield of light over his right hand and thought. The shield that wasn't even ten centimeters twirled over the palm of his hand.

Sitting down and gazing at the shield, Rudel had made some break time in front of Sakuya's den, repeating a similar practice every day. At this point, he was even able to produce a shield of light from the tips of his toes.

While he tested it on Bennet's suggestion, it was surprisingly easy. More so, he could only be perplexed at why he had always fixated on his left hand.

"Even so, I want some more cards to play."

Bennet's fighting style was one thing, but Rudel also wanted to secure Keith's piloting methods. When he started to look at it like that, he began to see what he was lacking. The sword and magic were insufficient. He couldn't help but think so.

Bennet was a demi-human of the wolf tribe, and she compensated for her lack of magic with an abundance of attack methods. Rudel knew that.

He had tried out the boomerang, but it didn't feel right in his hands. His admiration for Bennet only made that all the more irritating.

"Then is it throwing knives after all?"

Once he had thought that far, Izumi appeared as per usual with a bag she held in both hands. It contained a midday meal and drink.

"Are you thinking of something again? If you plan to concoct another special move, if possible, I'd like to ask you to stop."

While Izumi sent him a bitter smile, Rudel couldn't understand why she was against it. However, at that moment, he wasn't thinking up a special move, so for now, he nodded.

"No problem. Right now, I'm thinking up new means of attack. Just like the major, I'd like a means of mid-range attack apart from magic."

Izumi lined up the food she took from the basket on a rock in front of Rudel as she listened in.

"I don't think there will be any problem with your mana, Rudel. Even if you're not on Aleist's level, you're definitely on the more plentiful side."

"I definitely have a bit..."

His words growing muddled, Rudel extended a hand to the food before his eyes. There, he felt Izumi's skill in cooking had risen from before.

"This is good. Have you been practicing?"

"Thank you. It's all because of Bennet-san. That person can do everything, after all."

Generally omnipotent in housework, and first rate as a knight and dragoon. She was an admiration to both Rudel and Izumi.

"I'm glad I came to the outer reaches. I've got two proficient superiors to look up to."

When Rudel said that satisfactorily, Izumi gave a powerless nod.

"Yeah. You're right. Bennet-san is a good person. Yeah. But..."

Izumi couldn't bring herself to recognize Keith, and Rudel directed her a perplexed face. He didn't think the man had any particular problems. To Rudel, they were both admirable superior officers.

"Anyways! How are things on your end? Bennet-san was delighted, said you had grown a bit."

Matching Izumi's change of topic, Rudel washed down the sandwich in his mouth with tea before responding.

"I've got a long way to go. I've got to work on the finer details. And using magic while on the move is still a bit... in that case, how about I deploy magic before moving? Keep it deployed at a set distance from me at all times?"

Suddenly hitting on something, Rudel sunk his thoughts into the sea. Izumi watched over him with a warm smile.



Among the members Keith was to deliver to the palace, Aleist's party was not included.

"You really aren't going back?"

"Yeah. I have a bit of a place I have to go."

His words growing muddled, Aleist had seen Rudel training every day, and after the recent monster attack, he thought over it.

As a result, for a while, he wanted to go on a journey.

"The captain has us with him, so it'll be fine."

While the members of his platoon gave large nods, the man in question could only breathe out a sigh and watch. Normally, he would decline, but the girls said they would tag along and wouldn't listen to anything else.

"Well, I'm returning so that's all well and good. I'll hand a letter to your superior, but what do you plan to do from now on?"

Eunius didn't seem particularly worried, but if possible he wanted to return together. For some reason, he made an unpleasant face when he looked at

Keith. On the contrary, Keith seemed pleased.

"Fufufu, a trip through the sky alone with Eunius-kun." "Hold it. Aren't you after Aleist?" "You two look like you're having fun."

When Aleist said that, Eunius made a truly incomprehensive face. From Aleist's point of view, in both the game and this world, Keith's impression as a good, reliable person was too strong. He couldn't even imagine him being after him.

"Now let's enjoy our journey over the clouds!"

"Oy, get any closer and I'll cut you! I'm serious!"

"Y-you're serious... what a passionate proposal. Then I must answer to those steamy feelings!" "Gyaaah! Stay away!"

The water dragon Spinnith spread out his wide wings and lifted into the sky. His figure was truly beautiful.

After seeing off the dragon that flew with a ruckus on its back, Aleist turned and looked at the women who made up his platoon. In order to inform them of his future plans.

"There's a large town nearby, and I'm thinking of heading there. We have to get someone to look after the holy sword we obtained, and more than anything, we'll be able to operate out of there for a while."

There were plenty of monster hunting jobs to be found around the border with ample facilities to tend to weapons and armor. His own armor was also being worked on by a craftsman in those parts.

Why wasn't Aleist returning with Eunius? It was because Aleist had reached his own sort of answer in regards to his strength.

Aleist had thought about his strength. He knew he couldn't catch up if he went at it the same way as Rudel and the others.

He wasn't the same sort of lunatic, and it wasn't as if his technique was particularly high. A magic talent he could never master wouldn't even serve as borrowed plumes.

But... there was something he could do.

(This isn't a game, but I can't think of anything else. Power is power. I have to do what I can...)

What he recalled was his conversation with Bennet. When Aleist returned to Beretta, he heard from Rudel she was dreadfully strong. If she really was that strong, or so he and Eunius tried asking her.



"What are you supposed to do to become strong?"

"Y-yes."

Bennet was short in stature, practically a little girl, yet before her, Aleist stood troubled. No matter how he looked at it, she looked like a girl standing on her tip toes to talk to him and he felt his face would grow slack. While he somehow managed to endure it, Eunius just gave up and called her Bennet-chan.

While the girl's expression didn't show any signs of minding it, her tail would droop powerlessly. And while she clearly did seem to mind it, even that was cute as well.

"If you could establish something like that, we wouldn't have our troubles. Even if, hypothetically, there was a definite method, our prerequisites are far too different. What I know is no guarantee."

What Bennet was trying to say was that while she could give advice, she wouldn't take responsibility for it. Even with Rudel, who she was tasked with watching, she said she was just accompanying him every day to confirm his results. From what Aleist could tell, he didn't think that would

make him strong, but for now, he wanted to catch up to Rudel as much as possible.

While Luecke and Eunius had grown in their areas of expertise, all he had done was cleaning. He was beginning to panic.

Perhaps sensing Aleist's impatience, Bennet decided to try helping him out. Borrowing an open room of the station, she talked to him one on one.

"It's not like I'm your superior. I can't give you any orders, and I can't take responsibility. You'd best get that in your head."

"Yes ma'am."

Giving a vague response, Aleist sat across from Bennet as she put out a drink. He did his best to convey his own panic and anxiety.

Avoiding any game terms, he told it so Bennet could understand. But Bennet made a perplexed face.

"Then what are you worrying about?"

"Eh? But..."

"If you know the means to become strong, What reason could you have not to use it?"

"I... don't have one. But it feels a bit cowardly, or unrealistic, or rather, in my head, I don't accept that it'll work. Even if I say I'll get stronger the more monsters I beat, doesn't that sound a bit wrong?"

Speaking in game terms, by defeating monsters, he'd gain experience points and level up. But it's not like he could see something like his own status.

For some reason, Aleist was beginning to grow embarrassed. Even seeing his reddened face, Bennet didn't laugh.

"... Talks of defeating monsters to become strong, you can find them anywhere. In the place I was born, a man's rite of passage was monster

hunting. There was a superstition that you steal the strength of the life you take away, but I do get the feeling it will make you stronger. It's not a complete lie."

Rather than becoming stronger from the monster slaying itself, Bennet thought that by beating them, you would gain combat experience and courage.

Having depended on his game knowledge and failed, Aleist had once bid them a complete farewell. But everyone around him was growing strong, and even if he wasn't there, wouldn't Courtois be just fine? He tried to convince himself too. But he couldn't stand the feeling he was being left behind. At the same time, he had gotten around to thinking he wanted to stand shoulder to shoulder with Rudel.

But it was that moment, he realized he didn't have anything of his own. What he wished for was inexhaustible mana, and social status. While both of them had become Aleist's power, they weren't his own. That's precisely while his close friends who climbed up with their own power looked radiant in his eyes.

"This might sound cruel, but in the end, power's just power, nothing more, nothing less. If I were you, I'd seek out that power without hesitation. I don't see any particular problems with your methodology. No problem at all. No, as a knight, it'll be bad if you don't report to your commanding officer."

"Ah, right, there's that. I've been doing so much cleaning these days, I've stopped thinking of myself as a knight."

While Aleist turned his head down in a powerless laugh, Bennet gently called over to him.

"You're the black knight. Hold your head up high."

"Y-you're right."

"I've heard about you from Rudel. I know you're not a bad person, but you worry too much. Just make it simple... there's no point in just having power. The problem's how you use it. If there's something you want to accomplish, you gain power for it."

When he thought of what he wanted to, Aleist reached the conclusion he would definitely need more power than what he had now. He could no longer think that just because those around him were strong, he could just leave it to them.

"Will I be able to do it?"

But Bennet wouldn't reassure him.

"Who knows?"

Bennet looked at Aleist and told him that was for him to decide.

"It is when you master your strength that it finally becomes your own. And if you fear you'll drown in your power, then fret not. The reason being..."



Recalling Bennet's words, Aleist began walking.

But turning back once to look at the port town, he grew envious of Rudel. Ever since he was enlisted in the defenders, all he had ever been taught was cleaning. The difference in environment between him and Rudel, from the eyes of those around, perhaps it might look as if he was being given preferential treatment.

But thinking of his own growth, Rudel had the better circumstance.

"I want a superior like that too..."

Additionally, he did have some lingering regret with Millia, but there were no particular developments in that field. While he tried calling out to her, things never went as he wanted. He would end up speaking so naturally his

subordinates around him couldn't even bring themselves to believe he really was smitten with her.

"If I drown in my power, then Rudel and the others will stop me, eh... friends sure are nice."

Bennet's final words... if Aleist was ever going to step off his path, his friends would come to stop him. Sure enough, Rudel and Eunius... and Luecke would probably stop him.

His other friends from his school days had saved him all the way. The very fact he could think he wasn't alone was a blessing to Aleist.

But when he thought of his friends gleefully charging at his power-drowned self, he felt a slight quiver. The battle maniacs Rudel and Eunius laughing as they swung their swords, while Luecke used him as a test subject, hammering in his magic, he could imagine it too vividly.

"What's wrong, captain Aleist?"

As one of his subordinates called out in worry, Aleist forcefully made a smile and said he was alright.

To enact a game-type strengthening method, Aleist was walking again. Swearing he would never lose himself to his power...



In the mansion of the Arses House, Erselica was panicking.

A letter had come from her older brother Chlust, but the servants had thrown it away. IF Lena hadn't discovered it by chance and brought it to her room, she would never have noticed.

The contents of the letter she unfolded right at the door darkened her face.

"This is... but, it can't be..."

The letter from her brother stated he wanted precise and current information on the relations between nobles at the palace. While it seemed he was in a serious situation, Erselica didn't have enough information to answer to her brother's hopes.

With Chlust sent off to the border, the state of the Arses House only grew worse.

Thanks to the eldest son Rudel, she was occasionally called to parties, but at first, she and her parents avoided them. At this point, her parents would show themselves, but in order to ensure Erselica's marriage to a wealthy noble or merchant, she wasn't let out.

The prominent nobles were taking a wait and see approach to the Arses House's state of affairs. If Rudel took the archduke seat, they would approach, but the rumors of discord between him and his parents were experiencing a sudden spread. His father's attitude at the knight appointment ceremony was coming back to torment them.

Because of that, Erselica couldn't say she had a precise grasp of the current situation.

"What does it say?"

Sending a harsh look at the cheerful Lena, Erselica yanked her into the room.

Closing the door and fastening the lock, unlike Lena's or Rudel's room, the splendid room of an archduke's daughter was spread out.

"... Were there any other letters?"

"That's the only one I found. See, when I thought I'd roast some potatoes over the scrap paper, there was a letter inside."

Seeing Lena scratched her head and smile, Erselica felt irritated. While she knew Lena didn't have any ill intent, the contents of the letter suggested he

had been sending letters for a while now. Meaning the servants were crushing his attempts to send them.

While the contents didn't go into the specifics, it was certain he required information urgently. Erselica took a deep breath before making a plea to Lena.

"I have a request."

"What's up?"

"If you see any of the servants throwing away any letters from Chlust, I want you to deliver them to me."

"I don't mind."

While Lena easily took up Erselica's request, the problems didn't end there. Erselica didn't have the connections to answer Chlust's demand. And even if she managed to receive his letters, it would be difficult for her to send them.

"Anyways, I have to somehow look into it... but..."

Even if she wanted to investigate, from the letter's contents, she understood it wasn't the sort of thing she could talk to people about so easily. What's more, the fact the letters hadn't been getting through made her imagine the worst possible scenario. Within the mansion, there was an individual preventing Chlust's letters from reaching her.

If they just wanted to crush Chlust, that wasn't a problem. Erselica saw it as a huge problem, but the real problem would be if they had seen through Chlust's actions

Holed up in her room, Erselica was in a situation where she couldn't do anything. There, Lena read through the letter she had dropped in confusion.

"Noble relations? I know someone who's really knowledgeable about that."

"W-who!?"

Lena's sudden statement caused Erselica to jump at her. It gave off the impression as if she was clinging onto Lena's tall build.

"No, if you just ask Luecke-san, you'll be able to find out most things. He's real knowledgeable."

"... Well yeah, I'm sure he knows."

Erselica was aware of Luecke of the Halbades House. Talks of engagement to Eunius of the opposing Diade House had come up. But generally speaking, the three lords held an antagonistic relation to one another. If possible, he was someone she wanted to avoid. More than anything, the fact he held a friendly relationship with Rudel made him someone she couldn't psychologically accept.

"I'll try asking next time. I'm getting a lot of letters from him these days."

"Wait, you mean to say you're pen pals?"

"We're not. They just keep coming in, and I respond to about one every ten letters. I'm no good with writing, you see. When I'm trying to write up a response, the next one comes in, so I have to write something new."

Seeing Lena laugh, Erselica didn't know what she was supposed to say. While there was a problem with Lena, she felt the problem lay with Luecke as well.

The story continued to flow without delay.

Chapter 129

A few months since Rudel was flown off to the outer reaches...

Above the water, a little away from the port town of Beretta, three dragoons were flying through the sky.

Izumi and Millia gazed upon the scene from a place overlooking the port. While it looked like they were flying in formation, they were fighting two on one.

The two blue dragons were flying circles around the white one. The white dragon that fought, pincered by two others, looked at a glance to be at a disadvantage.

"You think they'll be alright?"

While Millia seemed nervous, Izumi was worried. While she knew it was dangerous from the start, in order to measure their abilities, it was concluded there was no helping it.

If possible, it was something she wanted to avoid, but if it was something those three had agreed upon, then this wasn't a problem Izumi or Millia could stick their mouth into. The three dragoons enthusiastically took part in this combat.

"It'll be fine... probably."

"You're certain? Can you look me in the eye and swear it?"

Millia doubtfully sent a glance at Izumi. It wasn't as if Izumi didn't believe in Rudel, but she averted her gaze from Millia. Thinking of his current abilities, it wouldn't be strange if some sort of problem broke out.

Two on one. She wanted to believe he was alright.

When the two of them took their eyes off the battlefield, a light broke out over the water. That dazzling light caused the two of them to raise their arms to protect their eyes, and once the light died down, they looked at the dragons. There, they found the form of two dragons, going at it one-on-one.

That vision-stealing light must have been exceedingly troublesome for the three in an upfront confrontation.

"So the first one to fall was Spinnith!"

There was no mistaking it, the first ones down were the Keith and Spinnith team skilled in aerial battle. But it was questionable whether any of the others had the ability to do it.

"That can't be!"

Shifting from the dragon's movements, Izumi confirmed Spinnith had fallen into the sea. Bennet's dragon Heleene was taking distance from Sakuya. But none of her long-distance attacks were reaching Sakuya.

Distance-wise, she was in range. But Sakuya remained unscathed.

Eventually, Sakuya began to give off light. While her roar reached all the way to Izumi's ears, it was something the air vibrations conveyed to her entire body.

Noticing the disadvantage, Heleene, charged at Sakuya, bringing her all the way to sea level, only for the surface of the ocean to freeze over in an instant. It looked almost as if the water dragon was offering a place for Rudel and Bennet to fight.

"So she realized Bennet-san was at a disadvantage in the air."

A portion of the water truly had been swiftly exchanged for an arena.

"There's no helping it. No matter how faster they are, the time they can stay in the air is short."

The two were more worried for Bennet than Rudel.



Before she could fall into the sea, Bennet leapt up onto a footing of ice.

Taking a stance with the wooden boomerang on her back, she checked left, right, and up. While she had confirmed he had sunken into the sea with Sakuya, it was unknown what direction Rudel would come from.

He wasn't tempered so soft that sinking would be the end of him. He had already grown to the level where she couldn't stand up to him in aerial battles. Rudel was the sort who would keep at training the basics like an idiot. Therefore, she thought it would be fast as soon as he picked up the knack, but he had far exceeded Bennet's expectations.

"From where... below!"

As Bennet heightened her senses to keep wary of her surroundings, she suddenly turned her face straight down and hurriedly left from the spot.

Right after that, the ice was smashed, and a pillar of ice rose. While she was bathed in the seawater that gushed out, Bennet's expression didn't change. She concentrated to search for Rudel. There, she heard a slight sound, so she used her boomerang in place of a shield.

Regardless of the mana she flowed in to strengthen it, her gripping hand conveyed a grating sound to her. Determining it would break at this rate, she instantly discarded her boomerang, and tossed another one from her back at him.

The boomerang that spun fast enough to hum through the air gave chase to Rudel, but ended with no more than cutting up his own afterimage. The next instant, Bennet equipped the wooden daggers she kept at her waist in both hands. Crossing them, she caught the wooden sword Rudel lowered from right above her.

They were atop a chunk of ice bobbing in the waves, but at the impact of that attack, cracks spread from where she planted her feet. The ice as a whole took one large bob below the water before coming back up and stabilizing.

Bennet forcefully parted him, and as she corrected her stance, Rudel landed before her. She instantly sent a kick, but Rudel grabbed that leg in his left hand, throwing it off.

Correcting her positioning in the air, Bennet threw the dagger in her left hand. While Rudel deflected it, Bennet took a light hop on the ice.

It was something like a habit for Bennet, but as she would always enter high-speed movement right after, she had never come to recognize it as a weakness.

However...

(Crap.)

By the time she noticed it, Rudel had extended his left hand towards her face. Rudel had got her in his sight.

While she returned fire with her remaining The intense clash had her lose in brute force, and Bennet was beginning to be pushed back. In speed, power, and technique, Rudel had matured. When it came to the technique part, she could likely still win out, but that was no longer enough to bury in the other gaps.

Even as she moved her fastest, those sharp bolts of lights pursued to capture her. When she thought of her footing crumbling into smaller and smaller pieces, Bennet was losing all options besides an upfront conversation.

(My subordinate's grown... but I can't just lose here.)

Bennet opened her eyes wide, instantaneously accelerating to insert a kick in Rudel's stomach. But there, a small shield had manifested. Rudel took on

Bennet's kick that had lost its momentum, jumping back, pretending to be blown away.

When she chased to close in the distance, Rudel tossed the sword in his hands at her. Entering hand to hand combat, they each fired a series of fist and foot. But both sides could do naught but capture the other's afterimage, and neither side was scathed.

From the eyes of a third party, they were surely too fast to perceive. Even if they could be seen, after Bennet fired a roundhouse kick with her right leg, they would've sworn they saw her left instead... it would surely cause such a misapprehension.

But that scuffle was also greeting its end. Unable to catch up to Rudel, Bennet received a blow to her abdomen knocking her off her feet. Correcting her stance as she rolled across the ice, she saw Rudel had stopped moving.

Right after, Bennet stood on the spot and tossed her dagger to the side. Raising her hands, she showed a pose of surrender.

"Once you've gone so far, I've no choice but to concede... it's your win, Rudel."

Above the surface of the ice, the swords of light gleamed in their numbers, as if to cover up the sky. Their points were directed at Bennet, and if they came at her from all directions, Bennet wouldn't come out unharmed.

As Rudel stood to his feet, the swords turned to grains of ice, fading out as they were swept away by the wind.

"Thank you. Major."

Her prided subordinate who had shown such results in such a short period gave a delighted smile. Bennet felt just a little lonely when she looked at his smile. She didn't have anything left to teach him. Perhaps he would look at her like a superior anymore she grew anxious for just a moment.

There, Keith who had crawled out of the sea sent a smile to Rudel, out of breath.

"N-nice fight."

"Thank you! Lieutenant!"

When Rudel hurriedly rushed to help Keith up, Keith continued to smile as he collapsed on the spot. He had pushed himself considerably.



The three dragons who'd returned were sopping wet.

At the port, the dragons climbed out and lied down. They had used up their stamina, so they were resting, but Sakuya alone was full of energy.

'And you see, you see, when Spinnith was coming at her, Sakuya decided it with a counter!'

Happily informing Izumi of her contributions, Sakuya made a fist and began shadow boxing. She was too energetic.

"I see, you worked hard too, Sakuya."

'That's right. I was punching it out with Heleene in the water too!'

The punched dragons looked at the energetic Sakuya and let out some large sighs. They looked worn out. But finally, Heleene...

'You lost to me in the water, dammit!'

Exhausted, on her side, it seemed Heleene was showing the backbone of the water dragons. From how Spinnith averted his face, though, it was quite likely he lost to Sakuya.

'N-next time, I'll use my sure kill one, two finish to...'

'I can use that one too, you hear!'

Unable to imagine a punching match between dragons, Izumi could only give a bitter smile. In half a year, Rudel and Sakuya had defeated competent members of the dragoon brigade. It goes without saying that was due to their own training.

But it was also a fact they possessed latent abilities that high. The talent of Rudel, who had continued training his foundation like an idiot, was blooming as a dragoon.

The man in question lay down an unconscious Keith as he spoke to Bennet.

"Was it your idea to steal our sight with light?"

"No, my close friend Aleist said something of that effect, so I thought I might be able to do it, and practiced."

Rudel had used a surprise flash to daze Keith, letting Sakuya defeated Spinnith while the dragon was unmanned.

"It wasn't bad. If you're able to coordinate it into your attacks, it's effect will rise. And also..."

The two of them continued talking about the battle. They were both the epitome of seriousness, and Izumi gave up on entering the conversation. If Keith were awake, he might be able to.

But Bennet's face grimaced.

"So you got me here too."

Taking off her gloves, Bennet looked at the swelling on the back of her right hand as she muttered. While it didn't seem to be broken, she had been injured in the midst of battle without noticing it.

"Major, I can use healing magic."

"I see, then I'll leave it to you."

Bennet held out her right hand, and Rudel reached to grasp it. Seeing that scene, Millia was just a little jealous. But Izumi opened her eyes wide as she foresaw the development that was to follow.

(Rudel's healing magic... hold it!)

Leaping out, Izumi grasped Rudel's arm. Sakuya pestered Izumi to keep listening to her story, but there was something greater she had to stop. As she put some considerable force into gripping Rudel's arm, the man was perplexed.

"Izumi, that hurts."

"W-what's wrong, Izumi?"

While Bennet was worried as well, Izumi looked into Rudel's face. There, she confirmed just one thing.

"Rudel, from when could you use healing magic?"

"Listen to this! The truth is, Mystith-sama personally taught it to me!"

"What sort of effect does it have?"

"What are you talking about? It's healing magic, so of course it has a healing effect... ah, it's also got a side effect of decreasing the pain usually felt during healing and—"

Once she had heard that much, Izumi put more power into her hold on Rudel's arm. When she gripped it, water was squeezed from Rudel's soaking wet clothing, and a grating sound could be heard. Izumi informed Rudel with a smile.

"Rudel."

"Y-yes?"

"That is also banned."

"Say what!?"

Rudel informed Izumi of how he had tested it on his colleague Enora, and how it definitely had a healing effect, but by no means would Izumi give him a nod. In her long relation with Rudel, this was the moment where Izumi's instinct had prevented the dangers of petting.

Unable to accept it, Rudel pleaded; he told her it definitely wouldn't hurt. But Izumi kept denying it saying that wasn't the problem.

"... Um, what about me?"

Bennet looked over the two of them, a troubled look on her face.



Rudel's colleague from the dragoon brigade, Luxheidt, had temporarily returned from his dispatchments station.

He needed to report, and he wanted to take some vacation. As a secret fan of Rudel, Luxheidt was also considering dropping by the port town of Beretta.

Stopping by the palace for the first in quite some time, the somewhat strained air he sensed was definitely not to his liking.

"It's quite tense here."

Holding his report, Luxheidt walked down a corridor of the palace when he happened to pass by a certain room used by the civil officials. There, he heard a delighted voice. Rather than a work room, it was a room used to take breaks.

'You did it, young master!'

'Vargas, I'm sure I told you to stop calling me that. Well, I'm in a good mood today, so I'll permit it.'

'But that girl really is a strange one.'

'Well it's surprising that she'd want to hear about noble relations. But with this, I can invite her out to tea!'

'Um, if that's what you want, then I guess that's fine.'

Hearing a conversation between subordinate and superior, Luxheidt mused it was a peaceful conversation as he hurried on.

At least the civil officials are at peace, he thought as he made for the dragoon captain office, but it was there that Luxheidt came to the understanding he wasn't one to talk. The reason being, there was a slip on the office notifying him they were in the middle of a meeting.

"Huh? I've never heard of a slip like this being on the office before."

It wasn't normal to have a meeting in the captain's office, it was normal to borrow a conference room. Luxheidt did consider coming back later, but it was there he heard a voice from the room.

Growing intrigued, he put his ear to the door to listen in. He had confirmed there was no one else in the corridor, and it was an action that came from pure curiosity.

And he would regret it.

'W-what... was that...?'

'I'm telling you, he's dangerous! My niece told me, Rudel has an absolute advantage when it comes to demi humans!'

'M-my brothers and sisters were saying the same thing!'

It seemed the captain and a few dragoons were discussing something. Rudel's name came out, so Luxheidt's interests welled. But the conversation rapidly strayed.

'Then that mean's Bennet-chan's in danger, does it not! That baster, I've got no interest in women, 's the sort of air he gave off, but he was actually aiming for this!'

'No, you're the one who sent him off to the border, captain! What are we going to do!? At this rate, the position of we who protect Bennet-chan are...'

'In his student days, he had a free pass into the girls' form, and he entered it boldly! For some reason it's highly classified information, and it was a real pain to look into! But Rudel-sama is a man of valor who's even managed to tame the tiger tribe!'

(Ah, looks like we're not ones to speak.)

Picking up on the contents of the conversation, Luxheidt felt like apologizing to those civil officials from before. There, a hand was placed on his shoulder.

When he turned, he found the vice-captain Alejandro standing with a dubious face. While he wanted to chastise Luxheidt for his actions, more than that, he worried over what Luxheidt was going to do, now that he had learned the secret of the dragoon brigade.

"You... heard?"

Looking at the vice-captain who would calmly send people off to borderland, Luxheidt broke into a cold sweat.

"..."

He knew it would be pointless to deny it here, and from the vice-captain's face, he knew he couldn't say anything foolish.

"Listen, don't tell anyone about what you've—"

"Vice-captain, I have an idea!"

From the vice-captain's behavior, Luxheidt sensed he had no particular fixation on Major Bennet and decided to take a gamble.

It would be a pain to be stationed any further away. Luxheidt proposed a plan to crush this secret gathering.



In Beretta, a summons from the palace came for Rudel and the other dragoons.

"Are they going to award us for that monster subjugation?"

"Yeah, I thought they'd just send something and that would be the end of it, but it seems they're handing it out at the palace."

Bennet read over the letter as she confirmed Rudel and Keith's schedule. At present, there weren't any delays in the development of the port town. The construction using dragons was proceeding faster than anticipated.

Even if the three of them slipped out temporarily, there was little to worry about.

For Rudel, if he returned, he would be able to see Eunius and Luecke, so he thought he wouldn't be bored. Keith thought the same.

"The palace, eh... I can see the captain and vice-captain!"

Seeing Keith's delighted face, Rudel arbitrarily misinterpreted it as an immense admiration for those two great men. While he wasn't wrong, it was in a vaguely different direction.

But Bennet wasn't making a happy face.

"What's wrong, Major?"

"No... it just seems I'm hated within the brigade, see. If I go, there will be some troubles."

"That can't be! You're a splendid major!"

Rudel was convinced there was no way Bennet could be hated. He couldn't believe someone like that could exist, so he decided to ask for a name.

"Just who could hate you, Major?"

"Rudel, you can't ask something like that."

When Keith cautioned Rudel, Bennet laughed a bit.

"Everyone's got people they love and hate. I don't mind it, so you don't have to either."

"... Understood."

Bennet put a plan together and informed the two of their day of departure. With the changing schedule, she informed them they would have to work quickly for a while.

"You can take some vacation at the capital as well. Well, it's not like we can't fly through the night, but there's no need to push yourselves."

And so, they were given a day of vacation at the capital.

Chapter 130

Aleist took a journey from the port of Beretta to a town near the border.

Taking up a merchant's request for guards, he made for his destination. They didn't have much leisure, time-wise, but even so, it was an action he had determined necessary.

His own platoon was composed of female knights and it wasn't as if everyone was suited for combat. A squad needed rear support as well. Perhaps the archeology enthusiast Pasette Yulineria was a good example. If it had to be stated, she possessed most of the functions of a thief.

Starting with trap evasion, she was skilled in disarming locks as well. They were techniques she had taken up in the process of aiming for the beloved archeologist path she desired, and it wasn't as if she aspired to rob anyone. Her skillset was merely on the thief side of the spectrum.

Draped over her green coat, her leather bags stowed many more tools than weapons. She loved books, and she was a female knight with the sort of decisive power to just run out and get something done at the drop of a hat.

Inside the swaying carriage, she was trying to decipher the hero's journal she had gotten her hands on. As long as she had the time, she would look at the journal every day.

Aleist sat across from her. As she read through the passages again and again, he called over.

"Is there something special about that journal?"

In-game, it was no more than a single item, but when Pasette lifted her face from the book to look at Aleist, her cheeks flushed. While Aleist noticed the

affection directed at him, he pretended not to notice.

"U-umm... it's... interesting?"

"Why did you make that a question?"

When Pasette thought of how her face was reddening, she sent him a troubled look.

"Because I'm not often understood. The other girls keep asking me what's so fun about reading other peoples' diaries."

To Pasette's bitter smile, Aleist could only mutter 'I see'. He was making sure not to stick his mouth in problems between women. While this might not be the best way to put it, as long as they didn't go too far, Aleist would ignore it.

He wasn't trying to be heartless, his intervention would only create more problems. Whoever he helped would only be recognized as an enemy by the surroundings.

(Girls sure are scary. They make factions and... huh? Girls? Rather, aren't they already adults?)

As Aleist looked at the journal, Pasette opened her mouth.

"Before the Kingdom of Courtois was formed, it was an era with small countries jumbled all over the place, and there were plenty of skirmishes. But this journals comes from a little before even that era. Because it details how the Gora were still wielding their fury across the lands."

Hearing of Gora, Aleist tilted her head, so Pasette hurriedly offered an explanation.

"Gora are vicious monsters that live in the empire. There are legends they can grow as big as mountains, they have four arms, and back then, they were in Courtois as well."

"They're not anymore? (S-so there was such a scary monster!?)"

Having never heard of Gora, Aleist was a little startled, but he played serenity. Nodding, Pasette told him it was alright as she continued her explanation.

"Ever since the dragoons made their appearance, they were eradicated from the Courtois side. Since we have dragons, the Gora in the empire don't wander over. That's why the important people say they must be quite clever."

"I-I see. (Thank god! Seriously, thank you!!)"

"At the time, they didn't have a common language, so I can't completely decipher it. There are words mixed in, or rather, the same sentence or word can have a different meaning. If we knew where exactly the owner of this journal came from, that would make things easier. Like you know how we have a slightly different use of words in the south and north? It's like the dialects were stronger back then, and there are some things we'll never find out unless we can ask a local."

Seeing Pasette describe it so happily, Aleist recalled the self of his past life. He recalled his experience of the things he loved being belittled by others.

"... I'm sorry. It's not interesting, is it? Listening to this babble."

He loved games and he especially enjoyed playing fantasy ones. Even after he reincarnated, he could recall how it hurt his heart when his classmates called that creepy. It felt as if they were denying him as a person.

It would've been better if he had a friend who shared the same hobbies, but unfortunately, in his serious prep school, he was unable to find any gaming friends.

"No, I'll admit I don't get it, but I can understand you really like it. And looking into the past is kinda romantic, don't you think?"

"Romantic? You're the first to ever say something like that to me, captain."

The laughing Pasette's hair was fashioned into a ponytail. Her hair itself wasn't very long, so the tail portion was short. When she laughed like that she looked like a child, or so was Aleist's frank opinion.

After that, until it was time to change out guards, Aleist continued talking with Pasette.

And he thought...

(Yeah, they're all alive after all.)

"What's wrong, captain?"

"It's nothing."

In the past, even if they entered his field of vision, he thought of these characters who didn't appear in the game as little more than part of the mob, but like this, he could see full well they were living their lives. He had experienced this feeling once more after he left the environment of the academy, and he was beginning to develop an interest in the pasts of the people he'd encountered.

(Bennet-san is the same. And Rudel's sister of a different mother... Lena as well. I wasn't looking at my surroundings.)

He repented at how narrow his field of vision had been before he enrolled at the academy. And until his lookout shift came around, Aleist enjoyed conversing with Pasette..



By the time they reached their destination, the sun had gone down.

The caravan Aleist's platoon had taken up a request to protect arrived at a large town near the border. By Aleist's knowledge, as it was close to borderland and in the farther reaches of the kingdom, it was a town with a prospering weapon and equipment industry. Before searching for a weapon, taking care of the other equipment was important.

Generally, knights of Courtois would make use of their supplied weaponry, but the use of personal armaments was also recognized.

In the town that gave off an uncouth impression unfit for sightseeing, Aleist decided to search out an inn.

"For now, let's look for the inn they told us about. If they don't have any rooms, we should be safe if we take one on the slightly pricey side."

The female knights abided the orders of their superior Aleist. They all carried their own luggage as they made for the place the merchant had told them about.

Aleist thought they were wearing conspicuous clothing, but that didn't seem to be the case. There were many travelers passing through, and be that as it may, there were plenty wearing the same attire as them.

"Aren't there a few too many travelers around?"

When Aleist brought forth the question, Pasette walking immediately behind him gave an answer.

"It's because there are plenty of equipment craftsmen here. There are lots of merchants who come to stock up, or sell daily necessities."

Meaning they would need guards to accompany them. For merchants that managed large-scale shops, it wouldn't be strange for them to have their own personal guards.

After Aleist nodded at that explanation, their destination inn came into sight. A sign near the door informed them there were vacant rooms. As they got closer, it even detailed the prices and the sorts of food they would offer if you took up a stay.

"Hmm... breakfast is included, and for dinner, you can use the restraint on the first floor. What's more, it's a pretty place."

Personally, Aleist preferred a pretty inn with good service. Not only was he the young head of a noble, his past life was one of a high school student in

modern japan. Putting up with a cheap inn was close to impossible. Additionally, his subordinates were all women.

If it was possible, the best inn was one that wouldn't displease them.

The point of their dissatisfaction was directly tied to the atmosphere of the platoon, it was something Aleist had come to learn as of late.

When he was traveling with Eunius, he was technically traveling with the son of one of the three lords. If Eunius told them to stay at a cheap inn, they would keep their mouths shut and abide. This did not hold true for their captain Aleist.

"Looks nice. If it's got a bath, then I'm all for it."

"I can't complain if they're providing food."

"It's a bit on the expensive side, but we've been camping a lot, so I want to sleep in a fluffy bed."

Nobles, commoners, and demi-humans... the various members of the female camp used their own sense of values to give a favorable rating to the inn before their eyes. A commoner knight was just a little mindful of the price.

"Then it's settled, we're staying here. (Thankfully, it looks like we don't have to go around looking for another inn)."

If they didn't like it, even if they didn't complain to Aleist, the air of the platoon would take a turn for the worse. In-game, he made use of cheap inns when he was low on funding, but when he looked at reality like this, he was reminded it wouldn't go so easily.

For now, he gave thanks to the fact they had found an inn before it grew dark as he led the party through the door.

As he opened the door, the nice smell from the dining hall on the first floor hit them. The smell of roasting meat, the scent of simmering soup... for his party worn out from their journey, it was exceptionally appealing.

"Welcome! Are you here for a meal or a stay?"

As the energetic poster girl of the place approached the party, Aleist confirmed to see if they had enough openings.

"So it's a party! We do have the openings, but singles rooms for everyone are a bit... if you're fine with doubles, I don't think there will be a problem."

When he turned to look at his subordinates' faces, everyone nodded. With hunger and fatigue, no one complained they would prefer to sleep alone. Rejoicing inside, Aleist told the young girl that would be fine and checked how much it would cost.

"If possible, a few days. Could you take us in for three days?"

"That's perfectly fine. If it was an extended stay, then if any singles rooms opened up, we wouldn't have minded if you moved into them."

Extended stay... then did that mean three days wasn't enough? Giving a bitter smile, Aleist told them they would book three days for now and paid the fee.

Moving from the entrance to the counter, the girl called out to the young man behind it.

"It's a party. They're staying three days, and for the room..."

The man handed the registry over to Aleist for him to write down names. As Aleist entered everyone's information, his movements were truly accustomed. Eunius threw these sorts of things right out the window, so they naturally flowed down to him. While it would be fine if he left it to his subordinates, their sense of values differed so greatly they would argue over choosing inns.

There was no helping it, so Aleist took on these sorts of tasks.

"I'll show you to your room."

Taking charge of the keys, the girl showed Aleist and his party to their rooms. From a number of customers, it seemed business was going well. After they were led to separate rooms scattered across different floors, Aleist was the final one led to a singles room on the fifth floor.

"This is the room the white knight once stayed in, you know."

"The white knight? You mean Rudel?"

"Oh, you know him? He came to this town a few years ago. Back then, there were also a lot of dragons, and it was a huge ruckus in town. I was helping out back then and I accidentally entered the white knight's room, but he was kind and cool."

The reminiscing girl called her encounter with the white knight her pride. With a bit of a conflicted feeling, Aleist gave a bitter smile.



The next day.

Having finished breakfast Aleist's party was moving independently, the day having been designated as a vacation.

They hadn't had any rest to that point, and as this was a perfect opportunity, Aleist decided to walk through town on his own. Holding the cloth-wrapped holy sword under his arm, he searched for the eastern craftsmen who had produced his armor.

"Can they use this?"

He recalled it was registered as a material, but it didn't give any particular effects. That's why he saw the holy sword as little more than a meaningless item to fill up a bag space. But before the threat of the Gaia Empire, he wanted as proficient a weapon as he could find.

Not just for himself to hold, he needed to assemble equipment for the rest of his party.

He intended to polish their abilities, but with that alone, from how his surroundings were growing, he wondered if that might be insufficient. Especially with Rudel, Eunius and Luecke, those three were outside the norm. He didn't know how it happened, but the three of them had continued down their own paths at a breakneck pace.

In such a situation, Aleist wasn't stupid enough to think the enemy would remain weak.

"At the very least, if it has a slight effect..."

If he found the opportunity, he wanted to circulate weapons outside his part as well. That alone should have some effect. As he walked, thinking over such a thing, he was able to spot his destination smithy.

When it came to the blacksmithy run by people of the orient, it was famous in town. He located it in no time. The fact everyone knew it meant it was surely well known.

... Though whether that was in a good or bad sense was a separate issue.

"Good of 'ya to come, punk!"

"How's yer armor feelin'? Crazy, right?"

When those kimono-clad quiet-looking craftsmen-esque men caught sight of Aleist, they approached him with words that felt off from their appearance. Those words that brought a delinquent to mind were something Aleist was no good at dealing with.

"T-today, I've come for—"

"Haah?"

While they were likely acting normal, they had originally flowed to this town and lived in the slums. They had picked up the language there, so it couldn't be helped that their words were rough. And as those words actually went through, the craftsmen lost the chance to correct their way of speech.

"N-no... um, this."

He presented the cloth-wrapped holy sword to one of the craftsmen. But Aleist was growing weak at the knees as that scary-faced man accepted it with careful hands. The moment he took the sword out of its cloth, the man's eyes opened wide.

"It's rusted through, damn fool!"

"Bastard, how in the 'ell could you let it get this bad!?"

"I'm soooooorrrryy!"

Quite a bit of time was wasted before he finally managed to inform them the holy sword was something he found.



Led inside the smithy, Aleist sat across from a man called Zouken.

Having returned to find his smiths making a ruckus, Zouken found himself taking it up. Zouken was a swordsmith, the most knowledgeable when it came to these sorts of weapons.

And after hearing Aleist's circumstances, he laughed with a troubled face.

"Then I must apologize for that. It's not as if they had any ill intent, it's just, the place they learned their words is... when I was out buying and selling, they were finding daily work in the slums."

In the harshest of times, Zouken went out to sell his katanas, while the other craftsmen worked in the slums to eat. Now they had worked together to borrow a workshop and they were making goods to sell.

"I see. Even so, you're making all sorts of things here."

The inside of the room was decorated with the weapon's they'd made. Looking over them, Aleist was growing interested in the peculiar

equipment. His own armor was the same, but he felt an affinity with these pieces that had a somewhat Japanese make.

"We make to order, after all. Never troubled with putting food on the table."

Zouken appraised the rusted, rotted sword in his hands as he conversed with Aleist. Zouken's group was one thing, but there was something else that piqued Aleist's curiosity. It was the famed blade they were supposed to possess.

The sword's name was Yakumo... in the kata line, it was the blade that boasted the highest class specs. While Aleist couldn't use it, he thought it might prove useful to Izumi so he decided to ask.

"Pardon me, but do you happen to have a sword called Yakumo?"

That expensive sword was something that, forget early game, it was an item considerably beyond one's reach through mid game as well. But the current Aleist had some financial leisure. Despite everything, he was still the eldest son of a Count. He had carried considerable funding with him when he left on this journey.

"You know about Yakumo? Unfortunately, I sold it. I consider that man my savior, you see. I can't bring myself to buy it back."

"Ah, if it's been sold, then it can't be helped. There's just this oriental woman I know, and that person wields a katana."

Aleist recalled Izumi. .Come to think of it, she had received a katana from Rudel as a present. HE heard it was something cheap, but he remembered the way she rejoiced to be something amazing.

"Gifting a katana to a lady... is that the trend these days?"

"No, not that I've heard of."

As the two of them exchanged some trifling words, confusion began to set on Zouken's face. As he looked at the holy sword in his hands, he gave a firm tilt to his head.

"What's wrong."

Finishing his appraisal, Zouken spread a cloth over the ground before carefully laying the holy sword over it. He unraveled a number of points bothering him.

"Is this really something of the past? No, this rot is definitely one of years, but... the make is, you see..."

Aleist explained the circumstances behind how he obtained it and gave a general outline of the era from the journal. Taking those into perspective, it was definitely a relic of centuries past. Zouken didn't seem satisfied but he continued on.

"It's not as if I don't believe you, but this one's make is too new."

"New?"

As Aleist directed his eyes at the sword placed on the ground, Zouken explained it so he could understand.

"It's the technique, or rather the manufacturing process. Its make is more advanced than what's going around now. Tempering some sort of magic-imbued material into the metal, and there's the stone embedded into the blade. That is a sort of gemstone with mana sealed into it. I've heard that the blacksmiths of the royal capital have only recently managed to create a sword like this. From what I've heard, this one is of a much higher completion, but..."

Struggling to say something, Zouken mulled a bit before giving a suitable hypothesis. And he forcefully made himself come to terms with it.

"Well, it's possible that an old manufacturing process was lost, and it's only being rediscovered now. When you think of it like that, those craftsmen of the past must have been quite advanced. Thought it vexes me to say it as a blacksmith myself."

Aleist agreed with Zouken's words, and he restarted the conversation.

"So will you be able to use it to make something?"

"I can. Rather, it's the best possible material. From what I can see, it's got quite a bit of use into it."

Relieved that it could be used, Aleist requested the making of a weapon. But there, Zouken made a misunderstanding.

"Show me your sword and your hands."

"Yes?"

As asked, he displayed his two swords and his hands. Zouken nodded a few times as he started taking notes.

"So you're fine with it being augmented into those two swords, right? It'll take a bit of time... half a year. No, if you give me three months, I'll show you I can get it done."

"No, um..."

Aleist noticed Zouken was trying to use the holy sword as a material to reforge his own blades. He tried to deny it, but Zouken smiled.

"To be able to make a weapon for a swordsman of such caliber, my skills are crying out. I'll call for my craftsmen friends at once, and make you the finest of swords."

He looked extremely delighted. And Aleist...

"I-I'll leave it to you."

Was unable to tell him it was a misunderstanding.

Chapter 131

Pasette Yulineria was decoding the journal she obtained in the cave.

The room she stayed had a simple desk and lamp, so even when night fell, she was able to read. Her tired roommate was already in her bed, in a world of dreams. She was a commoner girl, who kicked the cover away to expose her undergarments.

Standing once from her chair, Pasette re-draped the cover over her.

Normally, she tied her slightly-curling brown hair back, but for now, it was down. Her hair that grew just barely reaching her back, the girl thought it was just in the way. She wanted to cut it short, but with the reactions of her surroundings, she wasn't able to.

Her parents opposed, saying it wasn't good for a girl to have her hair too short.

Pasette herself strongly wished to cut it, but she couldn't make it any shorter.

She returned to the desk and sat in the chair. To the side of the journal, Pasette had her memo pad and references scattered around, which she began to clean up. She intended to go until she reached a good stopping point. But it seems she had grown heated and hurried forth a bit.

"I should call it quits for today."

The journal detailed the region the hero had lived in. Time-wise, it was an era tormented by the Gora. If it was before the founding of Courtois, then it would also have to be before the warring states period. When she read about

his daily life, she grew excited and tried to compare it to the books she used as reference.

But she felt something was off. The individual who wrote the journal, she got the feeling his thought process was too close to their own... to that of their own era. There were descriptions of the inconvenience he felt at the technologies that were likely brand new at the time.

There were places where the old paper had been ruined and rendered illegible, but Pasette was curious about the last page. Alongside a message to entrust the Holy Sword to whoever found it, it gave Aleist's name. Pasette had thought it was the name of the diary's author.

But would they really write their name on the last page? It bothered her.

"The book's cover is too tattered... hah, even so, our captain sure is mysterious."

From Pasette's point of view, Aleist was the same age as the rest of them, and an elite entrusted with a commanding role. But in actuality, he had cleaning duties shoved onto him for more than half a year, and the members of his platoon were all women.

All things considered, the personnel selection seemed too mismatched. At first, Pasette didn't have any interest in Aleist. But as they journeyed together, she was among those whose hearts were moved by the gap between the leisure he showed and his usual conduct.

"When we were cleaning, I'd always wonder if he'd be alright, but the black knight is different after all."

Relaxing and stretching her stiff body, Pasette extinguished the lamp atop the desk and made for the bed. Once the room's light died down, she could see the lights outside. The light of the stars, and the slightly-distant lights of the business district.

As she absentmindedly gazed from the bed out the window, she heard a voice from the room next door.

'Prepare yourself, Captain Aleist!'

'Nooooo!! Stop, don't be violent!!'

'It'll end in no time. Just count the number of stains on the ceiling!'

'I don't want to! I... I want my body to stay pure!'

'Ah, don't run! At this rate, there's a possibility your body will be forever defiled! In that case, can't you just give your first time to me!?''

'A girl shouldn't crawl into someone's bed! I'm begging you, just let me sleep!!'

Alongside those boisterous voices, she could hear the sound of the door slamming open with good momentum, and Aleist running down the corridor. A little later came the footsteps of her colleague giving chase. Ever since they had acted alongside Lieutenant Keith, the anxiety amongst the female knights had grown.

For the sake, these sorts of exchanges had grown in numbers.

(So today it's Fizz.)

Fizz Brandt was the third daughter of a Baron House. When she learned she would become the second wife of a noble who'd lost his first if she stayed, she ran off to the academy, and stayed there until she became a knight. Older than them, and having been born into a relatively affluent household, she was a woman who received a firm and proper education... or that's how it was supposed to be, but with such a tasty meal before her eyes, it seems she was unable to hold back.

(Fizz does get blinded by appearance, after all.)

Close in age to her, and be that as it may, he came from a high status. To Fizz, it was a chance she couldn't let get away.

The current Aleist was definitely set to take one of Courtois' two princesses as a bride. When that happened, it would mean the rise of Aleist's Hardie

House. To marquis, or even archduke... perhaps the era of Three Lords would change to four.

A new archduke house would be born. To the nobles of Courtois, this was a serious affair. It meant the factions would largely shift. What's more, the Hardie House was an upstart with few usable vassals. Even if they scraped them up from their relatives, there's no way that would be sufficient.

The birth of a new power would be the trigger for large change in Courtois' stagnant noble society. For better or worse, Aleist was at the center of that.

"Hah, in that case, do the captain's rivals have the upper hand? They're archdukes to begin with, so maybe there's no room for him to step in."

The violent mistress candidate dispute had reached a dreadful impasse. At first, Pasette thought as long as it would aid in her excavations, she would raise her name as a candidate. But as she continued interacting with Aleist, she came to hate herself for that.

"I never should've fallen for him... if I didn't fall, then right around now, I'd be able to act for nothing more than my own profit. I really am an idiot."

Passing for a book-loving girl before Aleist, Pasette was also considering taking action like Fizz. She hated that part of her.

(I wonder what other stories the journal has to tell.)

Closing her eyes, Pasette fell asleep. Those two would probably return eventually. It was unknown whether Aleist would be caught and dragged back, or he'd run until dawn and Fizz would give up.

'After you've made a woman do so much, you're running away!?''

'Man and woman doesn't matter! What's important is how we feel about one another!'

'Feelings and shit like that will work itself out later! I've already prepared my heart, mind you.'

'And I haven't prepared mine! Seriously, stop it! Why is my platoon full of so many carnivorous beasts!?'

'If it's going to be stolen anyway, then give it to me! What are you unsatisfied with!? I know I shouldn't be the one to say it, but my appearance isn't a problem, is it!?'

'It's what's inside! Show a little more prudence!'

The voices came from outside the inn. Pasette knew the two of them had run out, and she grew fed up over what they were doing. But she did hope Aleist would run away.



Aleist kept low in a small lane between buildings.

The darkness that clad the black knight... freely manipulating his shadow, he hid from Fiss.

(Why am I using the black knight's abilities to run and hide... and this isn't the harem I imagined. It's too muddled, I can't take this anymore.)

The Platoon's composition was an order from up high. Even when Aleist exercised his authority, it was splendidly crushed to bits. Looking out the darkness, he saw Fizz draped in a gown pass nearby.

"He got away again. The captain should just give it up already."

Passing straight by him, Fizz returned to the inn. Aleist showed his form from his shadow, getting his messed-up pajamas in order. As a nightcrawling countermeasure, he placed his slippers where they could be worn in an instant, so he wasn't barefoot.

Fizz's late start came from her exercise of the minimum level of womanly modesty; she had searched for a gown and slippers, making her a little late to leave the room.

"This is definitely wrong. Why am I going through something like this?"

Lamenting, Aleist determined it was too dangerous to return to the inn. In order to kill a bit of time, he sunk into the shadows and gazed at the sky.

The sky he could see between the gap in the roofs looked more pretty than the one from the world he had been. Inside, he dreamed of looking up at the stars with Millia, in a place vaster than this.

But that was impossible, he had come to understand as of late. Whatever the case, Aleist's standing was still dubious. He was an upstart noble, and with his house's momentum, the surroundings had taken an adequate distance to watch them. Aleist's parents' thought processes were closer to a merchant than a noble, so they were pretty much neglecting the obligations of a noble.

He had received a noble's education, but he was dim on the topic of noble marriages to continue on the house.

Just as a fiancée had been decided for Rudel in his student days, Luecke and Eunius had numerous candidates. Magic granted a level of longevity so they wouldn't be wed in their student days, but even so, it wasn't rare for there to be a formal engagement for a student.

And since he'd been recognized as the black knight, women were flocking around Aleist.

"For some reason, it's quiet around Rudel, though."

What he couldn't accept was Rudel's situation. Aleist was paying caution to the rumors surrounding Rudel. But he didn't hear the slightest rumor of engagement or women. When he heard talks of some noble plotting a marriage, in the next week it was as if nothing happened at all.

"Having just one wife... is it really impossible?"

There was a time where he wanted to be surrounded by lots of women, but now, Aleist had someone he liked. When he had someone in his heart, he couldn't think of laying hands on another woman. But by the time he noticed it, he was in a situation that wouldn't permit it.

"Hah, what do I do if the number increases again..."

Dry up and die. That wasn't a joke, that situation truly was encroaching on him. At present, it was decided a princess of Courtois would marry into the Hardie House. Normally, Rudel marrying one of the princesses and succeeding the throne would be the ideal.

But the man in question had no such will, and the palace was moving as if it detested the very notion. A member of the dragoons, the heroes of Courtois, and rider of a rare white dragon, there was no one in the world better to make a symbol.

Though he'd hate that, Aleist gave a bitter smile.

When he dropped by the port town of Beretta, he saw Rudel get all muddled up as he did his best. Aleist was honestly envious. He seemed truly delighted as he worked.

"It's a good thing for a dream to be granted. But dreams, eh..."

Aleist thought over what he was aiming for. Beating the last boss was natural. Otherwise, the country would cease to exist. Even if it remained, it would be cornered into a harsh situation.

But what did he seek beyond that? To Aleist, it was much too obscure.

They were lives of pretty much running down predetermined rails, but even so, Luecke and Eunius were putting in the greatest effort they could. Even as they shouldered responsibility and expectations, the way they did what they wanted was envious.

"Just what is the protagonist supposed to be..."

Stabbed with a difference of values, Aleist looked at the sky and muttered.



In a café of the capital, Erselica and Lena were led to a private room.

As with the building's exterior, there was considerably craftsmanship put into the inside as well. That shop that nobles would use by choice was a harsh shop where customers were also requested to follow a certain level of manners.

Erselica turned to look at a restless Lena.

"Calm down a bit."

"No, I mean... I haven't worn a skirt in a while no, and dresses are a bit..."

Normally preferring Rudel's hand-me-downs and men's wear, Lena grabbed and lifted up the hem of her skirt. At that gesture, the host's expression reacted with a twitch, so Erselica stopped Lena with a glare.

The reason the two of them had dressed up and come to the capital was definitely not to play.

It was to hear of the palace's current state of affairs from a certain Luecke Halbades. Erselica had investigated into Luecke as much as she could. He shared what could be called a close friendship with Rudel, and he had no relations to the traitors Chlust was worried about... at the very least, she approached him with the hopes he wasn't related.

She had similarly tried to get in contact with Eunius, but as luck would have it, he was currently out of the capital.

"Walk this way."

The host who led them to the private room with polite gestures closed the door behind them. Inside, a different employee was preparing tea.

Light streamed in from the large window. But from the positioning of the tables and chairs, there was no worry of it becoming too bright.

"Luecke-san!"

"Wait, Lena!"

As Lenna suddenly let a loud voice into the calm café air, Erselica panicked. The employee was about to caution her when Luecke got the better of him.

"My apologies. We'll be talking a while, so after the tea is prepared, leave us be a while."

"Understood."

After preparing three people's worth of tea and snacks, the employee left the room. Erselica pinched her skirt's hem to give a curtsy, and Lena did her best to imitate. Unlike when she was holding a spear, why did she look so unreliable? Erselica was perplexed.

"Well, take a seat. We don't need any of that stiff stuff today. If you make me act like that even on my days off, you're going to wear me out."

(He's an adult.)

Erselica felt relieved at the leisure Luecke gave off. Taking a seat with Lena, she gave a simple greeting. The air he gave off was different than that of the boys she would usually meet, causing her to feel something close to admiration.

However...

"Ah, Luecke-san, could you tell us about noble relations? Me and my brother are no good with that stuff. But Erselica said she wanted to hear, so..."

"... Lena, how could you be so rude? You're before a future archduke. Even if he told us to act normally, the minimum level of etiquette m—"

"Leave it to me. I prepared in a way that's easy to understand."

All for it, Luecke handed the documents to Erselica. On it, the general relationship between the current noble houses was spelled out. There were a number of pages, so he must have gone through some effort to prepare it. But something smelled fishy to Erselica.

"Are you done preparing for the academy?"

"We're all good. I rented out big bro and Sacky, so me and Erselica are going to have an elegant trip through the sky. Ay, this cookie's nice."

"I see. If anything happens, just tell me. There are some things Rudel won't be able to deal with when he's out on the border."

As Lena and Luecke spoke with smile, Luecke casually took a memo of the name of the sweet Lena said was good. When Lena directed her eyes at Luecke's plate, he gave a warm smile as he passed it over. And then there were none.

(... Huh? He's acting somewhat different than before.)

Sure enough, he had perfectly looked into what was request. And Erselica was satisfied with the contents. But leaving her to the side, the sight of the pleasant chat between the two brought a few things to mind.

(As I thought, Rudel's friends are usually strange.)

Erselica scanned through the documents as she thought such a thing.

Chapter 132

This is a story without much relation to the main plot. It is my hope you enjoy it as a side story where dragoon characters make an appearance.

Down a path buried up by droves of people passed the caravan of gorgeous carriages.

The sky was blue. The scenery colored by fluttering confetti was one to sing praise of a single princess in the largest carriage.

Inside that carriage rode only that single beautiful girl, alongside the young knight that served as her guard.

The cheers buried up the surrounding noises. From inside the carriage, the white dress-clad young girl waved her hand. Her skin was pale and her frail, slender body gave off the impression it might snap in two. And then was her curling blue hair, that could be called her most notable feature.

Her waving, gleaming blue hair grew to around her lower back. As she waved from the window, her hidden left hand gripped her pendant... the item that proved she was of the royal line, a small gold egg-shaped item engraved with the cursed seal of Celestia.

Everyone celebrated the birth of a new shrine maiden, rejoicing as they offered up Princess Cleo Celestia of the Celestia royal line.

With this they'd be safe. They'd be at peace for another few decades. Cleo understood what was on everyone's minds.

In the first place, these cheers and the smiles on the peoples' faces, all of it... was delight over her own sacrifice.

The green-eyed Cleo, under her smile, she wasn't able to think anything. She had been born to do so. Her role had finally come, nothing more, nothing left.

It would be too pitiful for her young little sister. Her brothers wouldn't be able to fulfill the role.

The clan raised as sacrifices would regularly offer up a woman every few decades. The people would think of them as maidens offered to their guardian god.

Cleo was royalty. But for the peace of the country, she would offer her very life to the protector... How tragic. From the eyes of the people who knew nothing, it looked as if the royal family was fulfilling their obligation.

In truth, royal blood did flow through Cleo's veins. But that blood had been carefully prepared outside the current royalty. Cleo's family was merely being kept alive, a clan of sacrifices royal in name alone. The energy supply of the ancient weapon, that demanded life every few tens of years.

In order to replenish it, Cleo was henceforth set to die.

She would continue on the carriage, making for a mountain on the edge of the continent. She would enter the ruins on that active volcano of a mountain, offer her life to the weapon, and that would be the end of it. Right, that's where it was supposed to end.

Cleo first thought it strange when the carriage stopped at a spot it wasn't planned to stop. When she thought they had run upon some trouble, in the next instant, the surrounding knights acting as guards started charging straight ahead.

And knights gathered around them as well. Wearing white, ceremonial armor, those elites of Celestia bragged that their training and devotion fell not short of the high knights of the large power of Courtois.

"Protect the princess!"

"No matter what, we have to protect her from these bandits."

"Dammit! They were hiding in the crowd!"

Things did not seem to be going very well outside.

"Why did it come to this..."

While Cleo was the surprised, the young knight hung over her.

"Princess, get down! It will be dangerous if an arrow flies our way!"

Even if they tried to run, they were unable to go out into the main street crowded with people. They could only trust in the carriage, built not only pomp, but sturdy as well.

So following the words of her guard... no, the knight keeping watch over her, Cleo had no choice but to meekly quiver.

The young knight's name was Emilio Balhart. His green hair grew long, and he was a fair knight of Celestia. Called the wonder child of Celestia, once in knight school, he easily changed that name to genius.

Even after enlisting in a brigade, his rumors would all extol him. His service only covered a few year, but it was said he was on the way to becoming knight captain and he was stipulated to be the country's strongest knight.

Many women would envy a position of being protected by him. But thinking to the contrary, that meant there was a need for strong enough surveillance to dispatch such an elite knight.

(Mother...)

Cleo felt the sounds of battle outside gradually grow in intensity, too scared to help it. But while she had lived for nothing more than to be a sacrifice, she hated the thought of dying without fulfilling her role. Otherwise, her young little sister would be offered in her place.

(Just to the ruins... we just had to make it to the altar. Why won't they just let us be?)

To protect the girl on the verge of tears, Emilio, who'd been keeping watch of the outside, let out his voice. Cleo required just a bit of time before she realized that.

"It's dangerous here, princess! We need to withdraw."

"... Eh? We can't, Emilia. The ceremony can't start without me. What's more, if we return come so far, the palace's standing will..."

"Right now, your life is more important, princess! We'll withdraw and reorganize our formation. The carriage ahead's been attacked, so we can't go further in this. We have to go outside."

The carriage in front carried the ceremonial tools. It took quite some time to prepare them. While she didn't want to cast them aside, she saw there was some sense in Emilio's words and jumped down from the carriage.

Emilio pulled her by the hand, and as they left the carriage, the street buried in cheers had changed to the intense sounds of battle. Outside, she could hear even more noises that rung through her ears. Alongside the din of clashing metal, the sensation of magic being fired off.

Cleo wanted to hurry from the spot. She didn't feel sorry for the surrounding knights, for this was their job. And her own job meant for her to offer her life.

She told herself so as she fled with Emilio who pulled her down the way. In their way, a man who had likely slipped into the crowd held a weapon in hand as he came at them. Emilio pulled his sword to knock it from his hand.

"Stand down, ruffian!"

For now, perhaps prioritizing their escape, Emilio sprinted into the gap between buildings on the main road without landing the finishing blow.

Cleo had never been somewhere like that before. Unlike the main streets, an unpleasant smell wafted about.

At the same time, there was trash littered around the place making it difficult to run.

"Princess, just a little further."

"I'm sorry, Emilio. I've caused you nothing but trouble..."

As Emilio continued running through the small spaces between buildings, he looked to Cleo like a reliable knight. When she had no idea where she was and she had even started to forget which way they'd gone, Emilio continued proceeding on.

He turned a right, and next a left. He ran down the stairs.

Once he left the narrow path, a small river was flowing. A different terrible smell came from there. It was the smell of a drain.

"This might be harsh on you, princess, but this is all to get away."

"I know. I don't intend to fixate on these trivial matters."

Thinking Leo's hand would let her get away, as the sounds of battle grew distance, Cleo found a little of her composure. If an ally appeared here, she would have more peace of mind. But it seemed the ones who appeared were no allies.

"It's a dead end this way."

Just as they tried to cross the bridge, they were pincerred in the front and back. Unlike the ones who had slipped in with the people, the men this time wore robes with swords hung at their waists. From the leisure with which they held themselves, they likely thought they would win if they pressed through with numbers.

Three in the front, and two in the back.

Cleo gave Emilio's hand one strong squeeze before letting go. Emilio shifted the sword he held in one hand to a two-handed grip.

"Princess, leave this to me."

"I'm counting on you, Emilio."

If it was Emilio, even called Celestia's strongest knight, then he would be able to break through this dilemma. Cleo believed so.

The robed men drew their swords. Emilio took a stance as well. Protecting Cleo in the center of the bridge, he kept wary of foes on both sides.

... It was at that moment.

"Princessss!"

It wasn't elite knights but soldiers who rushed to their aid. The robed men clicked their tongues before running away.

"We're saved, Emilio."

Relieved, Cleo called over to Emilio. But Emilio didn't look so optimistic. His grip on his sword remained firm as he glared at the soldiers rushing over.

(Has the enemy donned a disguise?)

She felt awkward, doubting the soldiers who rushed to their aid, but if Emilia didn't let his guard down, she thought she would imitate.

The soldiers noticed they were being suspected and hurriedly stowed their weapons.

"We're, um... we've been assigned to guard the small gate beyond this point. We're on break right now, and we'd gone to the main road. Wanted to catch a glimpse of the princess off to the ritual. So anyway, we saw the princess and companion running and hurriedly rushed to your aid. My apologies."

The city was surrounded by walls, and apart from the main gate for standard use, there were other gates one could pass through. The sluice gate to let in the river water fit that description. There were a number of small gates, and in order to protect them, there were usually soldiers permanently stationed.

But it wasn't the sort place knights were deployed. If anything happened, they could seal the gates at a moment's notice, so such places were occupied by hired soldiers.

Cleo looked over their equipment and saw the plating the gatekeepers wore around their waists.

The large leaderish man boasted an unshaven face and looked especially wild. The slender man with the spear looked to be in ill health and somewhat unreliable. For the small fat man, a portion of his stomach even stuck out of the provided equipment.

The men looked suspicious by all accounts, but they were looking at them apologetically. As Emilio stepped out front, knights and soldiers began to appear behind them.

"Found them!"

"Really!?"

"It's true. They really survived!"

One of the knights who raced over was one of Cleo's guards. Seeing his face, she felt truly relieved. The small, fat man spoke with just a bit of pride.

"Hmhmhm, I thought this would happen, so I called out to the soldiers. I drew arrows on the wall along the way, making sure they could get here no problem. I mean, we got lost the hell of it."

"Not bad, soldier!"

"It's true. You did good, kid!"

The unshaven man and the tall man praised the small one. Seeing that, Cleo was at a loss for words. But it was certain they were allies. Holding up his sword, Emilio spoke.

"Looks like it's alright."

"Yes. It does seem they're on our side. I was one step away from cutting them."

Sheathing away his sword, Emilio looked at the three-man soldier party.

"Yes, I'm truly glad it never came to that."

A relieved Cleo was led right off towards the palace, protected by knights and soldiers. When she returned to the main road that had been suppressed, the knights had walked following the arrows the plump man drew. Looking back at the path she had rushed down too fast, the maze-like back alleys and the smells made her head spin. All the tensions she had never felt before had been put off until that moment.

There, the man in charge muttered apologetically.

"My apologies, princess. It's about the ceremonial tools, but they were destroyed in the attack. A bolt of magic struck the carriage directly, and they've all been rendered impossible to use."

Which meant the ceremony couldn't be held. The tools prepared specifically for that day were lost, and Cleo lamented she would be unable to fulfill her duty. When she had been born to fulfill her role, that was no longer possible.

"There can be no helping it. I'm sure father will prepare a replacement at once. We must exercise patience."

On Cleo's words, the knights made vexed faces as well. They couldn't fulfill their role. You could call it natural. Within all of that, Emilio along made a disgruntled expression.



In the royal palace of the Kingdom of Courtois, three knights temporarily recalled from the outer reaches showed their faces at the office of the knight brigade they were affiliated with.

Self-proclaimed charmer in his prime Captain Oldart gave a smile before those three. His gaze was mainly directed at the good Major Bennet. A female knight of the wolf tribe, and tamer of a water dragon, she was the highest-ranking officer of the three.

"Yeah, good work on your mission in the outer reaches, Major Bennet."

"Sir! It is an honor."

Enthusiastic about her work, Bennet boasted a short status and cute appearance, but sticking her chest out, she gave a splendid salute. The captain shifted his eyes to the side to look at the remaining two.

The first was Lieutenant Keith. Similar to Bennet, he was a dragoon who rode a water dragon, but the captain didn't want to get too involved with him, so he gave a vague compliment.

"Ah, Keith, you did alri—"

"Your words are too much for me! To convey my greatest delight, today let the two of us—"

"And finally Rudel."

Cutting Keith off early, Keith finally looked at the real target, Rudel. The knight who rode a white dragon... a future archduke, a young man with both status and fame. Even within the elite dragoon brigade, he was considerably conspicuous.

From the moment of his enlistment, he kept creating legends, and he was a troublesome young man some called the new legacy. Of silver hair and blue eyes, he looked at the captain as a child would.

"Rudel... it's that. You need to work a little harder."

"Why is that!?"

From Oldart's personal reasons, his evaluation of Rudel was low. As Rudel fell into a slump, Bennet called over to him.

"Rudel, you're before the captain. Stick out your chest. If you're displeased with your evaluation, then put in the effort to change it. You've no time to be down. What matters is results."

On Bennet's words, Rudel nodded and straightened his back. There, Bennet nodded as well.

"That's right."

Seeing that relation of superior and subordinate, Oldart spoke to Rudel.

"This is why I hate you!"

The scene of the dragoon's idol-esque existence Bennet being kind on her subordinate Rudel was one Oldart couldn't bring himself to accept. From her... from Bennet's lovable appearance, she was a valuable existence doted on by subordinate and superior alike.

(And I'll tell you, the form of Bennet-chan fidgeting nervously after a subordinate calls her cute is the cutest!)

He was that sort of terrible captain, but he cut the jokes there. In order to talk about work, he pulled an envelope from his desk drawer. In it detailed a mission that wasn't thought to be particularly important.

"Now then, that's all for the jokes. I'm changing the subject, but Rudel, a separate mission has been prepared for you."

"Why is that!?"

"That's terrible, captain!"

This time Bennet and Keith raised their voices. Oldart breathed out a sigh as he continued on. Bennet didn't want her ideal subordinate Rudel to leave. Keith... after thinking that far, Oldart shifted his thoughts.

"I told you, I'm not joking. This isn't a long term mission. You know of the country of Celestia we've tied an alliance with? We were told to prepare a dragoon guard for them."

Placing the envelope on the table, Oldart produced a paper from it. On it, the details of the incident in Celestia were written out. Rudel accepted the paper and made a conflicted face.

"Based on what's written, isn't it bad for them to use a knight from another country?"

Oldart waved his left hand dismissively as he answered.

"With the attack, there's the civilians' feelings, you see. They want to give the image that they've pulled in a dragoon and they're working him to the bone. This is getting political, but it would be troublesome for Courtois if a small country dragged on past matters forever. Since it's come to that, they're sending in the flashy you and Sakuya to show them how much better we are! Or so the higher ups are thinking. Also, this and that happened, concerning the result, it would be better if we dispatched someone."

When it came to politics, Rudel had too little information to work with to make a decision, so he stuck the papers under his arm and gave a salute. Oldart was relieved Rudel hadn't declined the mission. If he did, with that dubious title of future archduke, it would spell trouble.

In that regards, it was a real help he was diligent in his work. While he joke about lowering Rudel's evaluation, he was rightly evaluating Rudel's work in itself. Even when flown off to borderland, he knew he was working hard in his duties and the region's development.

From Oldart's point of view, if only his status was removed, he'd be a proficient subordinate.

"But captain, Rudel has designated overseers."

Bennet brought up Rudel's overseers... the ones who followed him under the name of special inspectors, causing Oldart to recall those two female knights.

"Ah, those girls. Take them along, why don't you. No, definitely take them along. I'm anxious with Rudel alone."

"... If you're worried, should I go too? Even if I look like this, I'm more knowledgeable on etiquette than some foreign woman and elf woman."

When Oldart said he was worried, Keith stepped into the conversation. He got the feeling there was some wrath included in the 'woman' portion, and that was likely not his imagination.

However...

"Rejected. I can't send you into an important allied country. Good grief."

To Oldart's exasperation, Keith was moved. Just how do you misinterpret that in a way so convenient to you, Oldart looked at Keith's expression and thought.

"Captain, you want me by your side so b—"

"Wrong! Don't get any closer!"

Oldart grew angry for real, and standing from his chair, he put his back against the window as he cried out. Both Rudel and Bennet looked over the two in wonder. But it was a mission, so Rudel looked over the contents of the documents once more. Perhaps Bennet thought the conversation was done as well, as she strayed over Rudel's side and confirmed the contents.

"If they're sending my subordinate, they'll need my signature."

"You're right. There's a line for your signature, Major. It's all yours."

"Quite right. Because I'm your commanding officer!"

Seeing Bennet rejoice over the words commanding officer, Oldart felt healed as he tried to do something about this situation with a dangerous individual closing in.

"Oy, Keith, don't cross that line!"

"Isn't it fine, captain? Just look over there, this is all part of superior, subordinate communication!"

"You fool, stay back!"

Oldart's office was quite chaotic.

Chapter 133

Racing down the main road of the capital was a young man known as the black knight.

"Pardon me!"

Leaping over a cart pulled by an old man, he changed directions as he landed, desperately running off. Mindful of his back, he looked around and decided the direction he should run.

His curly blond hair flowed back as he ran. His mismatched eyes were a beautiful sight to behold, blue in the right and green in the left. His well-trained body acted as a spring, letting him bound freely over the main road. But what he made use of wasn't his physical body alone.

By channeling mana into his body, he was enhancing it. Desperate enough to use every means at his disposal to flee, whenever he'd passed by a woman's side, his Jetstream would flip their skirts. Whenever he was about to run into someone, it was always a young girl or a pretty older woman.

"Like hell I'll stop here!!"

Shouting as if his soul was crying out, Aleist didn't even try to peer into the flipped skirt. He continued avoiding all the young girls in his way with magnificent footwork.

They would call him 'That harem bastard,' with envy, jealousy, resentment.

But from the point of view of the man in question, that wasn't a result he obtained because he wanted it. Aleist understood that a harem was a special privilege only granted to the chosen few. That didn't mean to say assets or

strength. What was most important was what could be called the qualifications to keep a harem.

... and the power to maintain that harem, even when surrounded.

You can be dense as hell. You can pretend you don't see. Even lucky perverts are permitted. But you mustn't run away. A man with the caliber to accept all harem members... meaning a main character's disposition.

Aleist lacked that.

Before that even came into question...

"Don't run away, Aleist-sama!"

"What is the meaning of this, captain Aleist!"

"That should be our line. We're his fiancées! And yet he goes on a trip with nothing but women? Fat chance!"

The women chasing him from behind were catching up, even when he ran at full force. There were those running in skirts, and those riding horses to give chase. A majority of them were knights who had graduated the academy, the Courtois Kingdom's educational institute, while the others were women who possessed equal power.

Aleist endured the cold eyes directed at him by the surrounding men as he screamed from his heart.

"No, I already have someone my heart's set on!"

But the world was full of uncertainty.

"If you're a noble, just give it up!"

"In the first place, that girl you're after doesn't think anything of you!"

"Aleist, just give up!"

Noble ladies, knights and those of the beast tribe, various sorts of women chased after Aleist. It was a dream many a young boy had dreamed of. But Aleist's heart was set on another. An elf girl called Millia.

Yet the one he loved would never chase him, he was the one giving chase. What's more, his rival was more than up to par.

The white knight Rudel. He knew that man didn't think anything special of Millia, but even so, Millia had not given up on him. To Aleist, it was quite a sorrowful thing.

The fact Rudel was his close friend only made their relationship more dubious. Even so, Aleist didn't give up.

"Like hell I'll give uppp!!"

There was no telling what they'd do to him if he was captured. Imagining them making sure he could no longer run away, Aleist raced down the main road. It was at that moment. As he entered an alley off the street where the paths grew a little complicated, Aleist was grasped.

The one who caught him was a blue haired underclassman from his student days... one of his fiancées.

(Ah, it's over. Farewell, my innocence.)

Aleist's expression had already given up on everything.

It was Nate. Her curling blue hair grew to her back. Her pale skin and eyes the same blue as her hair were exceptionally beautiful. Her meeting with Aleist had been at the graduate sendoff party, an outrageous encounter where she ended up on top of him. But without Aleist having the slightest idea of what was going on, she had become engaged to him.

"How troubling, senpai."

Nate grasped Aleist, smiling gently as she made a plea. You could call it a bargain.

"I have just a small request, but if you'll grant it, I'll save you here and now."

"W-what is it? I'm not giving you my body!"

"That does sound appealing, but this time's different. Well, you could call it a problem with my house, or perhaps something of the sort... there's a place I want you to go with me. Of course, if you'll go then I'll save you, and I won't lay a hand on you."

Aleist cowered from the sound of the approaching footsteps, thinking a little before giving a nod.

(If that's all it takes, it's a cheap buy.)

He thought and nodded, but that would turn out a tremendous mistake.

"Very well, then wait a moment."

Nate walked out of the alley, in a theatrical voice, proclaiming to the pursuing women where Aleist had run off to.

"Big trouble! Senpai leapt over that building and went that way!"

"Good work, Nate!"

"Don't let him get away, find him!"

"If that's where he went, I can use some friends from the knight brigades to encircle him!"

(I'm scared. They're scaring me. Let's learn to be just a little more graceful, ladies...)

Once everyone had left under Nate's deception, she beckoned to him. Aleist left the alleyway, relieved he had been saved.

"You really saved my back there."

"You don't need to thank me. Because you'll be properly working in exchange. Yeah, now that I know you're going to help me out, that's a huge load off my shoulders."

Nate pat her chest in relief. And Aleist recalled he had never asked for the destination.

"Come to think of it, where are we going?"

"Ah, about that... it's the Kingdom of Celestia. My House flowed in from there, and there's been a bit of a request made to us this time around, so I have to make the trip. I really am relieved you're coming with me. I mean, one wrong step and we'd have an international incident on our hands. No, perhaps bigger than that?"

"... Eh?"

Before a delighted Nate, Aleist's understanding was unable to catch up.



The air passage from Courtois to Celestia was, to the five of them, a fresh experience.

Flying through the open sky was a white dragon with four wings. Its body was a size larger than the normal wild dragon. With the size of its body and wings, its arms were also thick and burly. But if you said such a thing, you would hurt that young maiden of a dragon.

Among the dragoons, the most famous knight's partner... riding Sakuya's back, Izumi Shirasagi's ponytail flowed in the breeze. Her silky hair swayed to and fro. Normally, the gale would be much worse, but the barrier erected with magic protected the five on the dragon's back.

Having from a foreign region called the orient, Izumi was a beauty of black hair and black eyes. She was once Rudel's classmate, and a person who understood him well.

More than friends, less than lovers, both sides accepted that.

At present, while being enlisted in a knight brigade of elites called the high knights, she was granted the position of special inspector to keep an eye on Rudel- who caused problem after problem. They were going to a foreign nation this time around, so she wore the blue knight clothing worn by high knights. Her chest was large enough to force up her clothes, and at times eyes of envy were concentrated on her.

"The kingdom of Celestia is a small nation. I've only ever read about it books, so I'm somewhat looking forward to it."

When Izumi said that, the girl of long green hair beside her muttered disinterestedly. Unlike humans, her ears stretched a great deal. A woman with the characteristic ears of the elves... Millia looked towards Rudel with her blue eyes.

Izumi had said she couldn't take on the role of special inspector alone, and by calling to her fellow alumni Millia, Millia also became one of Rudel's inspectors. Note, her modest chest was never the target of any envious eyes.

"It's that place with the large volcano, right? I'm surprised people are able to live in such a place. It seems pointless, or perhaps even admirable."

Millia's statement was answered by the overly serious Rudel.

"It's true it's an active volcano, but while I don't know how, it's a country that somehow controls the volcano. And because they're close to a volcano, the hot springs are famous. It seems the land's suited for growing fruit. Courtois also imports its fruit wines, haven't you ever drunk it before?"

"There's no way any of us have every tasted the sort of wine you drink, Rudel."

Averting her eyes from Rudel, after spitting some cynicism she shut her mouth. She did seem to have a nature that couldn't be honest with itself, and Izumi could only think that was doing nothing but harm to her as she gave a bitter smile.

"But this is a surprise. I thought you'd return to the outer reaches at once, Rudel."

In order to change the subject, Izumi recalled the contents of this time's special mission. To summarize, by sending an especially conspicuous dragoon, they were to show the dignity of Courtois. There may have been politicle motivations behind it, and Izumi worried whether Rudel would be against those sorts of things.

Their job on the outskirts wasn't over yet. Despite that, they alone were carrying out such a decorative mission. As long as it was an order, she knew he would accept it, but she worried what he would be thinking underneath.

The man seemed quite enthusiastic to be heading off on a mission. But at Izumi's question, he made just a bit of a troubled face.

"... I want you to keep this from Sakuya, but she got real worked up when I told her we were going to do a special mission. See, last time we did something big, she had to keep house... as long as Sakuya's happy, it can't be too bad. Even if it's just at the level of an errand."

An outrageous reason. Rather than the importance of the mission itself, he took it up to dote on his dragon. Hearing that, Millia breathed a sigh as she spoke.

"You're the same dragon idiot as ever."

Izumi touched the white back beneath her as she smiled.

At times, the dragon would let out a resounding roar. To Izumi who could hear the thoughts she transmitted, she could tell that was a happy roar. Her appearance was that of a dragon much to splendid, Sakuya was a child born not a few years ago.

She was often judged on her appearance, but was still a child who needed to be looked after.

'Special mission! Sakuya is strong! Sakuya is cool!'

Sakuya sung as she flew through the sky, and Izumi and Rudel watched her with smiles. A subspecies of gaia dragon that lived in the earth, Sakuya wasn't skilled at flying. Her movement speed was much lower than the average dragon. But this was a laid back mission. They had parted from the occasionally hectic border, and Izumi felt these sorts of missions weren't bad from time to time.

She turned towards the envious gaze coming from Nate.

"So what sort of business do the two of you have with the Kingdom of Celestia? As I recall, the decree just said we have to accompany you there and back, but..."

Before their departure, with an official decree from an organization called the defenders, came Nate and another individual. Aleist looking at Millia recalled how Nate had told them at the last minute they would be riding as well. In the midst of their busy departure, they accepted the decree and let them right on.

They were well acquainted, and they intended to confirm the paperwork while in the sky.

"Ah, you don't have to pay it any mind. While you're at it, I do recommend you pluck those things off your che... ow!"

As Nate envied her ample bosom with a smile, Aleist hit her on the back of the head.

"M-my apologies, Izumi-san! This girl has absolutely no breasts, so she gets jealous of those with a large chest."

Aleist followed through for her. You're not supposed to say that, or so Izumi only grew more worried. For the one on Aleist's mind Millia was a modest one on the opposite side of the spectrum from Izumi.

When Izumi looked at Millia, she saw a vein popping out on her forehead.

(Ah, this is that pattern of failure.)

Izumi looked at Rudel to find him humming along to Sakuya's song. He likely had no interest. Before she could become collateral damage, Izumi moved to Rudel's side and listened attentively to Sakuya and Rudel's tune.

'You're strong, Sakuya. Amazing, Sakuya! All~ The enemies go down in one blow!'

"Yeah, Sakuya, you're the best!"

Looking at Rudel and Sakuya, Izumi chose not to lend an ear to the fight going on behind them.

"Well excuse me! I'm sorry for having such a small chest!"

"You're wrong, Millia! Rather than large, I prefer a more reserved one!"

"Then that means I'm senpai's type! Millia-senpai, being flat isn't bad you know. Those lumps of fat are only ever in the way."

"When someone so envious of them says it, you've got no persuasive power!"

"You're wrong, both of you! What's importance is balance, and size isn't every—"

"Come to think of it, Senpai, your big sister was stacked, wasn't she?"

"Why are you sending such a pitiful glance at my chest!?"

"Nate! Don't go there! You shouldn't touch on that one!"

"Aleist, so you were thinking it too! That's right, in the end, I've got nothing! Even when my sister's stacked, they always say!"

"... I know I'm not one to speak, but Senpai, you're a little off there."

Izumi ignored the quarrel behind her, but perhaps Rudel grew curious as he turned around. Looking at the circumstances of their argument, he made a face as if he didn't understand.

"... Izumi, what exactly did Aleist do wrong?"

Seeing Rudel tilt his head, Izumi shook her own. To be completely honest, Aleist's mistakes were beyond count. When he had a girl he liked, bringing a different woman along was yet another one of those mistakes.

(Ah... he was wrong from the very start. Well, whatever.)

Giving up, Izumi only prayed Rudel wouldn't turn out like Aleist.

"No, if you don't understand, then that's fine. Just stay the way you are, Rudel. That way, you'll reduce the casualties around."

The honest Rudel didn't understand but nodded anyways.

"I-I see. I'll do my best."

Seeing Rudel fail to comprehend, Izumi was relieved. He loved dragons so much he had little interest in anything else. But he had a status as a future archduke, and he had obtained a standing as a dragoon, the knights called the heroes of Courtois. It would be stranger if there were no women around her.

In truth, many women approached him with affection, but with his status and dragoon position, he declined their association. He always made it clear when it came to those things, a relief to Izumi.

... The reason she didn't go out with him was also such a problem of status.

"These sorts of missions aren't bad."

Looking over the lively three, Rudel spoke. Izumi was in agreement.

"Right. A carefree trip through the sky isn't bad at all. But Rudel, this is a mission in a foreign land, so you must exercise caution. In um... various things."

Celestia was an allied nation, and she fretted over whether he might cause an incident. Rudel nodded with a smile.

"Leave it to me. It's not like I intend to cause any problems."

'Sakuya is fine too, Izumi!'

Hearing Rudel and Sakuya's responses, Izumi gave a warm smile and thought.

(Now I'm worried.)

They were responses that didn't give her the slightest peace of mind.



Emilio walked irritantly down a corridor in Celestia castle.

(Dammit! It's because that useless king relies on other countries...)

He had been that Celestia had requested the dispatch of a dragoon from its allied nation Courtois. The details that the knight brigades were all rounded up to hear were little more than a proclamation those knights weren't trusted.

But there was something more than that Emilio couldn't forgive.

(The plan when amiss. I have to do something...)

Thinking back, the mistake came with that party of three. Gathered in order to protect a gate that held no particular value, they were hoodlums, soldiers in name alone. But perhaps their awareness along was high, as despite their paltry wages, they had risked their lives to give chase.

(When they're lower than the mercenaries hired to make up for numbers, my plan was...)

To add onto that, those hoodlums were following behind Emilio. All three were smiling. On top of the shoddy armor they were granted, they wore even shoddier medals granted to them for saving the princess.

What's more, by that they rose in rank to be official soldiers.

Celestia was not a large nation. For that sake, they prepared elites as knights, but when it came to soldiers, they were only gathered for the numbers. Normally, it was the knights who would carry out the mission. It was a country with few troops, but there was a reason for that.

In that past, Celestia was at war with the large power of Courtois. And as Courtois invaded with their dragoons as the main shaft, the god of the volcano revered as the country's protector repelled them. It was an event of about eighty years prior.

(Clinging onto past glory forever, it's because they worship something like that as a god, that this country is ruined!)

From then on, the people of Celestia were convinced that they were a people protected by god. For that sake, the notion the military might be unnecessary spread like the plague.

While being a small nation, they maintained an equal relation with Courtois... no, one wrong step taken and they'd be made light of, and that was largely due to these sorts of occurrences.

And come so far, the failure of the knight brigade was doing its work. Because the ceremonial articles were lost, it would take some time before the ceremony could restart. Irrelevant to the populace, the crowd or the castle, that dissatisfaction was directed at the knights.

The knight brigades remained in order to maintain public order, but in the attack on the princess, the populace began to hold their doubts. For that sake, the royals and nobles had an allied nation send in a dragoon, mainly to send a message.

When Emilio thought of just how much incompetence that showed, it irritated him to no ends.

(Because of that inept top brass, this country is...)

Once he had thought that far, a voice called to him from behind. IT was the party of three.

The unshaven large man was Ben. The tall slender man was Pano. The short and plum man was Passan. With splendid smiles the three of them called Emilio...

"What's wrong, captain?"

"Keeping it bottled up isn't good for your body, captain."

"If you're hungry, let's go to the cafeteria, captain."

She he thought of how this lot had gotten in the way of his plan, Emilio was filled with a feeling of helplessness.

"...Y-you guys..."

He held his head. Just where did he go wrong? The soldiers who protected Cleo were now stationed as Emilio's subordinates. This was something even Emilio, heralded as a genius couldn't predict. Of course, Emilio understood full well he was no genius.

He wasn't average. He was just a little talented.

(Why did my plan go so awry? I won't say it was perfect, but even so, I spent a long time preparing.)

Emilio's head began to hurt.

... But even so, he didn't give up.

(I can still correct it. Somehow the princess... the princess, with these hands...)

Emilio's sharp eyes still hadn't given up.

He suddenly heard a rowdy voice from inside the castle. At the ruckus, the party of three looked inquisitively at Emilio.

"... Let's go check it out."



Their flight over, Rudel's party descended into Celestia.

"We're a little earlier than scheduled."

At the designated landing point, the soldiers and knight platoons who caught wind of the ruckus were beginning to race in. Taking on the shape of a fortress city, the capital had a splendid castle erected in the center.

While the troops entered and gathered, they wouldn't approach. It was only natural. There weren't many men brave enough to see Sakuya and think to challenge her.

But while they tried to land at the spot they'd been scheduled for, it was too small for Sakuya. Carefully maneuvering her into that space, Rudel praised her.

"Well done, Sakuya."

'Praise me, praise me! Praise me more!'

When Sakuya wagged her tail in delight, Izumi cautioned her.

"Rudel, put a stop to Sakuya's tail. At this rate, there will be collateral damage. This isn't Courtois. If you break too many things, it will cause a huge problem."

Hearing that, Rudel immediately soothed Sakuya and calmed her down before dismounting her back. But there, Nate began to lead Aleist off somewhere.

"Ah, well then, we've got our own mission to deal with."

"Wait, mission? Eh!?"

Watching Nate pull Aleist off by the hand, Rudel grew anxious as he found out the mad hadn't seem to have confirmed the contents of his own mission. At the same time, he was curious just what sort of mission it might be.

(I guess It's got nothing to do with me. You do your best, Aleist.)

While Rudel waved his hand at his friend, Aleist cried something out.

"You said it was personal! Where did that official decree come from!? Hey, are you listening!?"

"You're being noisy, senpai! When you've come so far, just resolve yourself! It's fine, the decree is the real deal... its origin point is just a little dubious."

"As I thought!"

Rudel's worries only grew, but this was Aleist's problem so he decided to leave them be. He just sought some confirmation with Izumi.

"Izumi, Aleist's decree was genuine, wasn't it?"

"There's no doubt about it. Though it was a little suspicious."

While Rudel and Izumi lost themselves in thought, Millia in her defenders uniform looked at the entrance of the plaza and spoke.

"Guys, looks like our welcome party is here."

"Now then, let's execute the mission. You two stay behind me. You're supposed to act as my attendants, after all."

As Izumi and Millia nodded, Rudel got his specially-made white knight uniform in order as he waited for an envoy of Celestia to arrive.

Chapter 134

Once the bureaucratic paperwork was in order, to receive a simple explanation of the situation, Rudel's party scheduled an audience with royalty... with the current king Barqah Celestia.

But the only one who could attend was Rudel.

The reason was a discriminatory one, and a decision by Celestia that a Courtois non-native like Izumi and a demi-human like Millia were unworthy of the meeting.

Within the flurried palace interior, Rudel was kept waiting in the waiting room. Knights left to watch over him stationed nearby, Rudel read through the documents from Celestia's side.

"... I don't think there will be a problem guarding Princess Cleo on the way to the volcano, but protecting her throughout two days before departure will be difficult for me alone."

The contents denoted were orders for Rudel to serve as Cleo's guard. With the other party being the princess of a foreign country, Rudel felt there was a limit to how far he could accompany her over a course of two days. The bath, bathroom, changing and such, it would be embarrassing for a man to be by her side.

Rudel had already been kept waiting over an hour for his audience. Within all that, Millia saw in a chair as she sipped tea. While she looked calm, perhaps she was irritated within, as she sent some glances towards the knights stationed around.

"I get why you're the only one who gets an audience, but aren't they treating us too terribly? And there's a bit of a problem relying on a foreign knight to

protect the precious princess."

Millia's words afforded her glares from the knights. Izumi sipped her tea calmly.

"I'm sure Celestia has some preparations of its own. And we did arrive quite ahead of schedule."

"There's a limit to that. And even if it's an audience, he's just meeting in the king's office, isn't he? I don't want to say it, but Rudel's a future archduke. They're treating him too lightly."

Millia's anger could be called natural. There was no helping if the country made light of them. When it came to keeping Rudel waiting, they recognized it as a foreign diplomacy tactic. But they also knew it was a measure to be taken against those of lower status.

The small country of Celestia boasted less land than Rudel's own home.

There was an active volcano close to the fortress city, with some towns and villages dotted around. The national population didn't reach a million.

There were hot springs around, and accepting travelers, they were in possession of assets in foreign currencies. The fruit juice that made up their specialty product was widely exported. It was certain these lands were livelier than the Arses territory governed by Rudel's parents.

But they depended on a foreign knight. They took an attitude as if to pick a fight with a major power. It wasn't strange at all to think they were going beyond their reach.

"... For now, I have come on a mission as a single knight. I don't think they're treating me lightly. But more than that, the princess' guard detail will be a problem. I can't follow her to the bath or changing room."

"Can't Celestia dispatch some female knights?"

On Millia's arbitrary statement, Rudel shook his head.

"Unfortunately, there are no female knights in Celestia. No soldiers either."

Different countries had different customs. The female knights that were gradually becoming natural in Courtois were nothing but heresy here. Rudel thought the reason for the limited audience was also related to those customs.

Women were not permitted to enter the restricted class of knights. There were other small countries around Courtois, but even among them, Celestia was special.

(This is a troublesome mission. I guess I'll try negotiation.)

Thinking it would be difficult to serve as the only guard, Rudel decided he'd ask for Izumi's cooperation in the case that Celestia hadn't made and preparations of their own.

A butlerish man appeared in the waiting room.

"Rudel Arses-dono. The preparations are in order, so I shall be guiding you to the King's office."

Leaving the documents and standing to his feet, Rudel straightened his uniform as he walked off. Izumi and Millia sent him a look, so he gave a light nod.



His entry into the king's office permitted, Rudel offered his greetings to King Barqah, taking a break in the room.

But the King didn't turn his body towards him.

(Hmm. It's just as the captain said. This isn't the attitude of a small nation...)

With Rudel's position, he couldn't stick his mouth into political decisions. And once Rudel finished his greetings and got to his feet, Barqah took the cup left on his break table in hand.

"I wish to speak some with him. Have the others stand down."

On his words, the knights and servants stationed took their leave. Sensing them on standby outside the room, Rudel waited for Barqah's words.

He took a glance at the king's extravagant work desk.

It was piled with six whole mountains of documents.

"My apologies. Because that daughter of mine got attacked, I'm busier than you could believe. Originally, I wanted to use the audience chamber, but even now, the authorities who hold antipathy towards Courtois are not few in numbers."

(The princess is treated as a 'that'? I don't feel I'll come to like this person...)

The antipathy surely referred to the war eighty years past. But Rudel felt rather than antipathy, this was something closer to contempt.

And he didn't like how the man referred to his daughter. Barqah sent his gaze above the fireplace, not in use for seasonal reasons. It was furnished by three separate professional paintings of what seemed to be his family.

From the documents received in Courtois. The first depicted Barqah's queen and children. The second, a woman with blue hair, and two small children... that one was placed in the center. It was bigger than the other two.

And the third along, Rudel found unnatural.

It looked to be a painting of Barqah in his younger days. His right hand rested on a woman of blue hair. The king was positioned in the center, making his left side seem strangely desolate.

(It looks like someone's been taken out. But that's the best smile the king's shown of the three.)

"... They're paintings of my family. The precious family I'm supposed to protect. Now, we can't stay like this forever. Let's talk about work, Dragoon."

His bright green hair straight and long, Barqah stroked his beard, making a serious face to talk about work. In his early thirties, the king could be classified as young, but his dignified air was well-formed.

"I have gone over the documents. I accept the guard mission. But I think it will be difficult for me to guard the princess alone."

"Fret not. I will be dispatching people as well."

"But all of your guards are male, are they not? I believe it in your best interest to send around a trustworthy woman."

"... Unfortunately, I have no woman who could serve as a guard."

"I have come here accompanied by one High Knight and one defender. Would it be possible for them to take part in this mission?"

"Hmm. You may do as you wish. Personally, I have no problems as long as the departure takes place in two days. The ceremonial tools should be in order by tomorrow."

"You have my gratitude. And what will our schedule be for this two-day period? It was not detailed in the documents."

Barqah stopped stroking his beard, gazing out of the window.

"I decided to give that one free time. It's her last after all. For now, she should be spending it with her younger brothers and sisters, but this is an important period. I'd like to avoid time with her family wavering her resolve. If it will let you divide them, then I mind not if you listen to that one's wishes."

Rudel thought over what the reason might be for treating the princess of his own country... his daughter like this. He heard she would be offered as a

sacrifice. Taking that into consideration, it wouldn't be strange if he already had his feelings sorted out in his heart.

After that, Rudel was told to hear the specifics from the knights on guard detail and was excused from the room. When he left, Barqah called over.

"Dragoon. That one is a pitiful girl. You must protect her."

"... Leave it to me."

Rudel couldn't determine whether that was his heart speaking or not.

(I've taken on quite a troublesome mission.)

He thought of it as a mission to regain Sakuya's spirits, but ever since he arrived at the palace, he was struck by many a strange feeling.



Taking Izumi and Millia along, Rudel made for the plaza where Sakuya was stationed.

There, those of the royal line... the royal children were watched over by knights as they studied the dragon. Sakuya looked at the children with a tilt of her head.

"Big!"

"Sister, is this a dragon? But our god is stronger, right?"

"Turn this way, you big lunk!"

The child who spat those last words really didn't understand the amazingness of a dragon, or so Rudel was filled with sorrowful sentiment.

(Good grief, if I had just a day, I'd drill a dragon's splendor into his body.)

"R-Rudel. Your eyes are scary."

With Millia's worries, Rudel reverted his glare and approached the woman surrounded by knights. The reason the knights gave such harsh looks must've been because their jobs were snatched away. Rudel thought as she approached the woman.

"Pardon my intrusion. My name is Rudel Arses. On this occasion, I have been ordered to accompany Princess Cleo as a guard."

Giving a drilled Courtois-styled salute, Rudel looked at the surrounding children. Two blue-haired women. Apart from them, a green-haired and brown haired child. They looked older than he had seen them in the paintings.

The woman in her later teens... Cleo let her hand part from her younger sister of similar hair color and countenance to give a curtsey.

"I am greatly delighted by Courtois' assistance in this matter. You have my thanks for taking up my guard."

She smiled. It was hard to imagine she would lose her life in two days.

(Is this... resolve?)

Rudel took caution in his words as he lightly exchanged conversation with the princess. He also introduced Izumi and Millia who were standing back.

"Are they female knights of Courtois? And the defenders? My apologies. I am none too knowledgeable on the affairs of Courtois."

"That's perfectly alright. The defenders are an organization only set up recently. There's no helping if someone of foreign lands has yet to hear of them."

Rudel dealt with her as he recalled the painting in the king's office. A majority of the children here had been painted. But the one individual who had been kept out... he noticed it was Cleo.

(Is this that family... no, national circumstance thing?)

Knowing he wouldn't be able to dig too deep into it, Rudel conversed with her.

"Even so, to think dragons were something so large. It's the first I've ever seen one, but I'm surprised how white and beautiful it is."

"She praised me! Rudel, she praised me!"

The one whose body twitched in response was Cleo. Perhaps those around could only see it as a roar, as the knights stood in formation before the royal line. From Rudel's point of view, it could be nothing more than a cry of delight.

"She's just happy to be praised. But you've got a good eye on you, Cleo-sama. Even among the dragons, this girl is an especially cute one, and her name's Sakuya. See, the blue gemstone in her forehead's pretty, isn't it? And when she spreads out all four wings, no one can take their eyes off of..."

"Rudel. Rudel! You're troubling the princess!"

Izumi immediately suppressed Rudel's mania, causing him to repent as he lowered his head at Cleo.

"My apologies."

"Think nothing of it. You really love dragons, I see. But I do understand those feelings just a bit. To want to get on such a large back, and ride somewhere..."

Were those her true feelings? It didn't seem the one in question noticed it. Rudel would be able to let Cleo on her back. But as he thought over whose permission he'd have to get, a knight leading soldiers along made his appearance.

(Green hair?)

The knight stood out more than the others. No, from Rudel's point of view, he felt his skill level was a cut above the rest. But he the soldiers behind

him didn't quite look like elites. Even as they closed in, the three soldiers cowered at Sakuya.

"Princess, so this is where you were? I have a message from his majesty."

"... Yes. Ah, Rudel-dono, this is Emilio. He used to serve as my guard."

"And I am still serving as your guard, Princess."

"Is that so? I had yet to hear about that, but... very well. Emilio, I'll be counting on you again."

"Much obliged."

Cleo happily spoke with Emilio. In contrast, Emilio took on a businesslike correspondence. To Rudel, it somehow felt as if the knight was pushing himself. Hearing the message from Barqah, he instantly understood it was meant to pull the princess from her family.

Once Emilio related it, Cleo's expression clouded after all. And the royal children got together to say their goodbyes.

They were firm-hearted, Rudel thought. It was at that moment the knight... Emilio looked at him and narrowed his eyes. He felt something close to rage.

"U-um..."

When Rudel turned, he found the three soldiers in light-weight armor lined up.

One's face was unshaven. One was slender and tall. And the last one was short and stout. At a glance, they didn't look much like soldiers at all.

"Is something the matter?"

"N-no. It's just a rare opportunity to speak with a knight of foreign lands, so. Um..."

"Boss, you can do it!"

"Boss, fight on!"

After looking at the two cheering on the bearded man, Rudel sent a glance to Izumi and Millia. The two of them shook their heads as if they didn't know what was going on either.

(It doesn't feel like they're picking a fight.)

"W-we were also chosen as guards, so we thought we ought to give our greetings. No, I don't know a thing about knights' etiquette, so I've no clue what to do."

A forced use of words. And attitude... thinking of Rudel's standing, it wasn't something to be permitted. Even to any dragoon of the major power of Courtois, that was a bit much. Or so was the general consensus.

But Rudel smiled and held out his right hand.

"I'm Rudel Arses. There's a lot I don't know in this mission as well. It would be a big help if you helped me out."

"Y-yeah! Leave it to me."

"He shook hands with a dragoon! Boss is amazing!"

"S-shake my hand too!"

As Rudel shook hands with the three, Izumi, who had wandered to his side, called out.

"Is this alright?"

What, she wouldn't say. But he understood what she was worried about. Rudel was a dragoon in foreign lands... what's more, the representative of Courtois. Answering to such a light treatment might not be taken too well.

"It's fine. The feelings got across. Rather, I'm sorry for pushing guard duty onto you two as well."

"That's not a problem. It's my field of expertise."

While at this very moment, Izumi was stationed to keep an eye on Rudel as a special investigator, she was originally a high knight. As a bodyguard, she was even more knowledgeable than Rudel.

"I'm sorry to you too, Millia."

"I-it's fine, doesn't matter."

As Millia turned her face away, Rudel mulled over what he had said wrong. Unlike with Izumi, he didn't understand how Millia felt in the slightest.

"Boss, you think that dragoon doesn't understand a woman's heart?"

"Quit it, Passan. See, get in the way of someone's love and... huh? What was supposed to kick you again?"

(TL: The saying he's referring to is, Get in the way of someone's love, and you'll get kicked by a horse and die. Meaning, if you stand in the path, the horse is going to run you over.)

When Ben looked at Pano, Pano also thought a while. But unable to hit on anything, he looked up at the dragon.

"A dragon's kick looks painful."

"That's right! Passan, you'll get kicked by a dragon."

"I-in that case, to hell with that!"

As the party of three cowered from Sakuya, Rudel spoke.

"Sakuya's fists hurt more than her kicks..."

"Rudel, I don't think that's the point."

"... Why is everyone so stupid."

Izumi pointed out Rudel's err, while Millia breathed out a sigh.



Meanwhile...

"Hey, why are we wearing these robes?"

"Ah, these are really convenient, you know. There's a special fiber weaved in, making them top-grade products that can slip through magical detection!"

"Why did you have something like that on you!? That's what I want to know!"

Aleist and Nate wore black robes as they walked down the alley. There were arrows drawn on the walls, and simply by following them, they arrived at their destination. As he walked down the maze-like back alleys different from those in the kingdom of Courtois, Aleist was holding his nose and mouth.

"Even so, this place is too confusing, the smell is harsh and... what business do you have here anyway?"

Nate silently climbed the bridge, sitting on the spot and touching her palm to the wood flooring. Looking right around, she scratched her face.

"No combat took place, so there aren't any traces. The main road has too many people so the traces have all disappeared... so I guess we're just wasting our time."

"Some so far and we're wasting time?"

While Aleist looked surprised, Nate deeply pulled down her hood. She ran off from the spot. Startled by her swift movements, Aleist chased her a little behind. There, at the end of the bridge, they ran into a man wearing a similar robe.

But Nate thrust a dagger at his throat. Pinning him up against the wall, a knife fell at the hooded man's feet. Nate kicked it away and slid it towards Aleist.

Quickly retrieving it, Aleist felt a dull glow from the knife's edge. A sticky liquid had been plastered over it.

"Senpai, you'd better not touch that."

"This couldn't be..."

"Poison. A powerful one at that. It's the sort that induces numbness, but get it in the wrong places and it'll leave permanent effects."

(Yeeaaah, the knife I can deal with, but what exactly is Nate supposed to be?)

While she had always been a member of his harem, with the sword master Seli and the tiger tribe chieftain's daughter Juju, in an assortment of all sorts of quirky ones, he thought she was a relatively docile girl. But Aleist felt he would have to reevaluate his recognition of her.

When Nate muttered something, the power left the robed man's body as he collapsed to his knees. He wouldn't meet eyes with her.

"Where did you come from?"

"... G-Gaia."

"Eh? The empire? Is he a tourist?"

While Aleist desperately thought, Nate dispatched one question after the next. But after a certain extent of time, an arrow was fired. The sound of an arrow released from the depths of the passage, the one to react quickest was Aleist.

Pulling the two swords at his waist, he leapt out to protect Nate from the arrow. He brushed the projectile aside, slamming it at the wall. There, a man in a robe jumped out from the alley.

At the same time, came an assault from atop the building.

"Senpai, we should probably run."

"Way ahead of you!"

Rather than aiming for them, the group seemed to be focused on rescuing their supposed ally, so Aleist and Nate ran. But Aleist...

"You know... aren't we in a really bad situation here?"

Racing down the maze-like alleys, he said to Nate. There with her hood still on, Nate stuck out her tongue and hit a fist against her head.

"Yep, real bad. Tehe."

"That wasn't cute at all! What do you think you're doing!? Rather, what are we even trying to do here!?"

Aleist's pained cry echoed through the alley.

Perhaps from a stroke of good luck, or because they were let off, the robed men showed no signs of chasing the two.

Chapter 135

Having accepted a mission to be Cleo's guard, Rudel stood before Emilio's unit in thought.

(Even if they're official knights and soldiers, how truly unreliable for a princess' guards.)

While that wasn't the best way to put it, it was one knight and three soldiers.

... From Rudel's point of view, it wasn't an assortment that made him feel much motivation.

In the room he had been permitted use, the princess Cleo, and those assigned to be her guards had to think about their roles henceforth. A lady servant prepared tea for everyone. Within all that, Rudel called over to Emilio who was looking at him.

"Emilio-dono, in regards to the guard detail, I'd like to decide on the division of labor."

"... That should do just fine. But even if I say that, the departure is in two days, so our mission only covers today, tomorrow, and the next morning. You don't mean to tell me Courtois' elite Dragoon requires sleep to exhibit his strength?"

It was a provocative phrasing, but Rudel understood his sentiment. The king of his country didn't trust the knights of his own country. In a situation where he had to follow the orders of a foreign knight, there was no helping his irritation. What's more, he was trying to do his job.

For now, that was enough... no, thinking of the mission period, it was plenty.

In that meeting-room like space, the nine of Courtois and Celestia sipped their tea in an inexpressible atmosphere. Cleo sat in a chair conversing with Izumi and Millia.

In front of the entranceway, the nervous soldier party of three stood to the side of the door.

(They're too tense. They're not going to hold out to nightfall...)

From the way they stood, Rudel perceived they hadn't received a great degree of training. He looked at Emilio. Emilio was reputed to be proficient, and on the way here, he had spoken of how he saved Cleo in the incident.

Perhaps he was a trustworthy knight.

"We will be fine. Your worry is uncalled for. But if it's possible to increase the number of knights and soldiers, then I must make the plea."

Without an incentive to oppose, Rudel thought of nothing more than increasing the guard success rate. He simply tried to handle it with numbers.

But Emilio shook his head.

"That will be impossible. With last time's attack, the knights have been spread out to the limit to provide security for the fortress city. The soldiers as well."

As Emilio said that, Rudel thought.

(This is your country's princess we're talking about. But still...)

Rudel looked at Cleo. While she did seem cultured, it was honestly hard to imagine she had received education as a member of the royal family. She was kind at heart, but he heard much too many words from her mouth that would show weakness in foreign diplomacy. As seen as a princess, she was a failure, as a person, a kind and beautiful woman.

(A life lived just for death, eh.)

Rudel recalled Sakuya.

He recalled the goddess who cast away what little remained of her life to grant him a dragon. While the reborn Sakuya carried on her name, her memories didn't remain.

He suddenly ended up seeing Cleo overlap with the goddess.

Rudel closed his eyes and suppressed his emotions.

(That is this country's problem. The mission I've been given is to guard her until the day comes. Don't waver, Rudel.)

Reminding himself of it, he returned to his discussion with Emilio.

"It would probably be best for a woman to enter the princess' private quarters. I shall station Izumi and Millia at her side. The rest of us should guard her when on the move, and defend the perimeter while she is asleep. Of course, the soldier at the door will be deployed on rotation."

Emilio grit his teeth at Rudel's words. He was also aware the party of three didn't have the stamina to keep up guard duty for two days.

Listening in, the three raised their voices.

At their cry, Cleo was surprised as well.

"We're not chopped liver!"

"T-that's right! An all-nighter is nothing."

"With an afternoon nap, I think it'll work out?"

Following on from stubble Ben's loud voice, Pano weakly voiced the same opinion. Passan gave a reply that was quite clearly right out.

Emilio grit his teeth at that reply. Perhaps he wanted to tell them to shut it, but before Rudel and the others, he held it in.

"You lot, we don't need your input for now. Once matters are decided, I'll relay the orders."

"I-I mean, captain..."

While Ben hesitated, Emilio silenced him with just a glare. Rudel evaluated him as a knight with some experience under his belt.

(He's skilled. And unlike me, he has experience.)

Rudel himself could easily tally up his own real combat experience. Even so, as he looked at Emilio, he felt something close to home.

From Rudel's point of view, this mission was a mission given to him because he had contracted with a splendid dragon... with Sakuya. Perhaps it was precisely because he knew that, that he could act so calmly.

But Emilio didn't take kindly to his composure.

"Then how about it? Why not use this opportunity to discern one another's level of ability?"

"... I have no problem with that."

He brought the match to Rudel.



Cleo brought her feet to the training grounds used by the knights.

It was her first visit, and she did feel a something more suffocating than she had imagined. The training ground build indoors was lined with wooden swords, spears, and logs to use as targets.

When Rudel's and co. were the only ones who were supposed to be there, the place reeked of men. Perhaps the way the room was constructed to hold

in heat was to blame.

"I-it feels a little peculiar here. Are the knights always training in a place like this?"

Cleo struck up conversation with Izumi to her side. Black hair was a rare sight to her. And the dignified Izumi was older than her, giving off a reliable impression. If her own country had female knights, she imagined they would surely give off such a feeling.

"It varies by country and knight brigade, but when it's built indoors, it can't really be helped."

Izumi understood what she wanted to say, not saying anymore. From how muddled her words were, Cleo understood it was pretty much the same wherever you went.

It was true that she was a little excited, coming to such a place for the first time.

But...

"Unacceptable! You're nowhere near up to par!"

"Ow!"

"Not enough training!"

"Geh!"

"No technique to speak of!"

"Bubrah!"

As she saw Rudel take down the three coming at him bare-handed, her face turned pale. Looking at Izumi and Millia to her side, they were making unconcerned faces.

Defeating the three challengers in an instant, Rudel brushed off his hands as he spoke. At his feet were the forms of three trying to stand. Pano and Passan still struggling to their feet. And Ben had clutched onto Rudel's ankle.

"But your resolve alone gets a passing grade."

Hearing of their success, the three of them passed right out.

"I-is that a dragoon? That all happened too fast for my eyes to follow."

While Cleo was troubled, Millia explained.

"It's fine. Rudel is outside of the norm, so you don't have to compare him to a standard knight. As long as you remember he's the strange one, you won't have any problems."

"I-is that so. He's strange? I don't know anything when it comes to knights."

The troubled Cleo looked at Rudel. He was hoisting up the three, and putting them to sleep on the benches. Emilio took off his overcoat and tossed a wooden sword at Rudel.

Catching it, Rudel took a stance with the left side of his body protruding forward.

"I don't see a shield."

Emilio also got in stance as he said. Rudel laughed.

"I just don't want to change my stance. And I've no intentions of getting hit."

On Rudel's provocation, the two of them stepped in for an intense clash of wood. Looking at Emilio on the moment of impact, Cleo was surprised to find there was a knight who could keep up with Emilio. Fighting on even terms with the knight heralded as a genius was surely a marvel.

Seeing her expression, Izumi spoke up.

"Neither side is particularly serious, so there won't be any injuries."

"I-is that so?"

As Cleo looked at two knights violently swinging their wooden swords, it seems she thought they were going full force. There, Emilio increased the arc of his sword. With that opening, Rudel tried to leap in, only to instantly jump back.

Giving pursuit, Emilio gradually strengthened his offensive.

Seeing the superiority of a knight of her country, no matter how much she detested violence, Cleo was relieved. The fact that her country's knight could stand his ground against a knight of Courtois was an important fact.

But Izumi made a bit of a conflicted face.

"The world sure is fast. To think he would have a move like that."

Cleo couldn't understand what she was saying.



In his match with Emilio, Rudel saw an opening and tried to dive in. But he found himself on the receiving end of an attack.

The wooden swords came at him left and right, but there were a number of slashes that faded away as if they had only been afterimages. And some attacks where he couldn't even see the swing.

"You use some interesting moves."

He found his mouth curving into a smile, so Rudel took a big step back and used his left hand to cover his face. Through the gaps in his fingers, he could see Emilio's haste. Even if neither side had been serious, that was more than enough to measure the other's competence.

(This is bad. I want to fight more.)

His emotions surging, Rudel renewed his grip on the wooden sword in his right hand. This time, he would go on the offense to probe out the identity of his enemy's move.

But there, Izumi raised her voice.

"That's enough, both of you."

Rudel looked at Izumi, and saw Cleo who'd been looking over the match was teetering. Perhaps her eyes had spun too much to follow the two moving around.

Taking a deep breath, Rudel parted his left hand from his face. There, Emilio gave a slight smile.

"Dragoon."

He gestured towards the sleeve of his left hand. While he had removed his coat, looking closely, there was a slight tear on his shirt's sleeve.

Knowing that had been inflicted by the enemy's sword, Rudel laughed just a bit.

"It does seem this match is my loss."

It wasn't the sort of wound that would decide victory or defeat, but at the very start, Rudel had declared he wouldn't be hit. In that case, even if it was a graze, he decided to admit his loss. Perhaps Emilio hadn't anticipated that attitude, as he was a little taken aback.

But retrieving up his own overcoat, he headed for Cleo.

"Princess, you should return to your room."

"I-I'm sorry, Emilio."

Millia approached the two of them, while Izumi picked up Rudel's coat and walked over. Before presenting the coat to Rudel, she handed over something to wipe his sweat.

"How was it?"

Rather than Emilio's capabilities, she was more curious about the technique he had displayed.

"I thought it was a large swing, but that was just to draw my attention. His real aim was a sharper swipe I couldn't see... I thought, but that's wrong too. There's definitely some trick or device to it."

"You look happy. You'd better not show that face before the princess."

Rudel was a battle enthusiast. As long as he had a strong foe, he was the sort of man who would want to fight to climb to greater heights. He repented at Izumi's words, but at the same time, he thought.

(I want to fight him seriously for once, but that doesn't look plausible.)

"... Rudel, I'll just throw this out there, but..."

Izumi understood what was going through his mind. A little panicked, Rudel took the coat off her hands.

"I know. The mission takes priority."

"As long as you get it. For now, let's go to the princess' room."

The two walked off, leaving the party of three behind.



Having removed their robes, Aleist and Nate walked down the main road.

The two of them linked arms, walking the street like lovers. But as the color of Nate's hair stood out, there were many heads that turned to take a second look at her.

Giving a bitter smile, Aleist pretended to have fun.

"Aha, ahahaha, how fun!"

"Oh darling, oh you!"

The one who suggested they put on a couple's act was Nate. And Aleist was extremely against it. But she earnestly convinced him that the attackers of the Gaia Empire wouldn't give chase if they stayed in character.

For that sake, Aleist and Nate paced the main road as of on a date.

(This is definitely unnecessary. How did she manage to convince me this was a good idea?)

Generally speaking, persuading Aleist was not a difficult task. The reason being, if you just kept pushing him, he would fold under pressure. If that wasn't the case, then he would've been able to prevent the continued expansion of his harem. And it was precisely because he was unable, that Nate could push through.

(Am I too much of a pushover after all?)

He thought as the two dropped by a stall. The lad manning the stall called out to her in a lively voice.

"That's some splendid blue hair you've got there, madam."

"You think so? We just came to Celestia to see the sights. But for some reason, I feel like I'm really sticking out."

Taking on a half-witted tone as she spoke with the shopkeeper, she moved the conversation towards gathering information. In order to stay out of the way, Aleist looked at the souvenirs lining the space.

"What's this, it's amazing! (Why am I praising such a peculiar piece, I wonder.)"

What he took in hand was an ornament made of a round torso, and four cylindrical legs. He thought it was a spider, but for that, the number of legs was too scarce. Where the round body leveled off, making one think a face might go there, a red paint had been slathered on.

It almost looked like a single eye.

As Aleist took the souvenir in hand, the shopkeeper closed in on him rather than Nate.

"That's the guardian deity."

"Eh? This thing is!?"

Surprised that something like this was a god, Aleist carefully inspected the article in his hands. No matter how he looked at it, he could only see a mud doll made by a child.

"To be more specific, it's modeled after the god's servants you can find on the mountain. Heard they look quite like the god. The real one's enshrined where the ceremony takes place, but ordinary folk aren't allowed in, see. So like this, we make souvenirs of the servants that are said to look like the god."

"Hmm~."

Aleist looked at the piece. But he wasn't getting any image of a god. All he saw was a bug, or perhaps a robot drone that's job it was to be done in.

"Hey! Shopkeep, we were in the middle of talking!"

"S-sorry for that. It can't be helped if you stand out. Blue is the hair color of the royal family in these parts. What's more, the shrine maidens who hold a special meaning. The area's real tense right now, so the surrounding eyes are going to be harsh. Don't let it get to you."

"What happened?"

"In the past, see? A little before the previous ritual. The royal princesses splendidly fulfill their roles, but even so, there was an unruly one in the royal family."

From the shopkeeper's tone, Aleist wondered what could have happened in the past. And as he put power into his hands, one of the ornament's legs

snapped off.

"Aaaah!"

When the shopkeeper screamed out, Nate raised a laugh.

"You can't do that, darling!"

"Ah, no, wait!"

A panicked Aleist apologized to the shopkeeper, saying he would buy it, and producing money from his wallet. Having bought that dubiously high-priced artifact, Aleist spilled complaint after complaint within.

(If it was fragile, he could've just said it.)

Now with the deadweight ornament to occupy him, Aleist didn't have to hold Nate's hand as they made a round around the other shops lining the main road.



There was no light in that palace room.

Paying mind to his surroundings, the one who entered was Emilio. He called out to the individual within. But he couldn't see their face.

"Oh, what seems to be the matter?"

"This room is too bright."

"... You sound like you're in a hurry. What happened?"

In that room purposed to give reports to his contact, Emilio gave the right watchword in response. The normal lost servant would just be turned away, but if the password was correct, the contact would fulfill their original job.

"Soldiers who don't know anything have been made my subordinates. Can they be taken off"

"They cannot. They have been selected as those for whom it matters not if they disappear."

Hearing that, Emilio muttered an, I see. His face was a little concerned.

(I'd like to do something for them, but...)

After learning that he couldn't take the three of for the sake of his goal, Emilio immediately gave his report.

"That dragoon's skills are greater than expected. I have begun to doubt whether I can win or not."

"I'm aware. But I heard you injured him... as expected of a knight of Celestia."

"I could do without the flattery."

As Emilio said that, the contact relayed the orders.

"... Depart from the palace tomorrow. The preparations are ready for that."

"Won't they think it too unnatural?"

"Just have it come from the princess' mouth. Then the higherups should accept it without complaint."

Emilio listened to the plan and hammered the contents into his head. Any memos he took would leave evidence. That's why they met in a dark room. Emilio didn't know the other party's face. But they knew Emilio.

(This is getting troublesome.)

"... And that is all. The princess is necessary for the plan. The ceremonial tools are all together, so all that's left is,"

"I know. I just have to present the princess to your group, right? What happened before shall not happen again."

"... Are you sure about that? After looking into it, it seems they came from the Gaia Empire. Though we haven't gone as far as to look into why they came."

"That's your job. I'd appreciate if you did it properly."

Emilio recalled when he was surrounded. He remembered the group in the black robes.

"I must apologize for that. Then make sure tomorrow goes according to plan."

"Leave it to me."

Emilio left and looked around. From the start, it was a corridor that experienced little passage. And as he walked off, he muttered.

"Tomorrow, huh. I'll have to do something about the Dragoon and his comrades, but how should I go about this."

Unbeknownst to himself, Emilio's hand had reached to touch the egg-shaped pendant in his breast pocket from over his clothes.

The dragoon was taking part, and he had even been stuck with subordinates who would drag him down. Just how would he struggle through the next day? Emilio thought.

Chapter 136

The first night on guard duty.

Izumi and Millia stayed alert in the princess' private room on rotation.

There was little to be found in that frugal room one wouldn't imagine belonging to a princess. Her garments were always prepared by the maidservants, so there very many pieces in the closet.

Izumi investigated the room for what it was worth, but Cleo, who should've hated it, seemed to slightly enjoy the notion.

Sitting on her bed, Cleo grinned as she looked at Izumi keeping guard at the side of the room.

"S-something the matter?"

The place was different to Courtois, and Izumi thought perhaps she had committed a discourtesy as she called over to Cleo. But Cleo's response was different.

"No. It is simply the first time I've invited a foreigner into my room... I found it a tad joyous."

Izumi didn't feel too bad, hearing that from her. This was also part of the mission, and she would keep up the conversation.

"Is that so? I'm something of a refugee. I'm sure the color of my hair is rare around these parts."

"Really? Would it be alright if I heard the story?"

Cleo's eyes glistened as they looked at Izumi.

(It's not a bad feeling for her to be interested in me, but in the middle of a mission, it's a bit...)

Troubled, Izumi apologized that she would have to stay standing.

"My house was originally from an island nation in the far east. Let's see, the knights there use swords like this one, similar to sabers. They're called bushi and samurai over there, but their role is similar to the knights of this country."

As Izumi gave a simple explanation of her homeland, Cleo happily listened in. While she got the feeling she was acting a bit too young for her age, Izumi couldn't bring herself to hate her.

"And the fact you're seeking refuge means, umm..."

"Yes, my house was caught up in a war, and left the country. If they didn't do so, I'm not sure I'd be living in this world."

Seeing Cleo's saddened face, Izumi regret her words. She should've talked about something more interesting, she thought, as she gave a meaningful clearing of her throat to change the topic.

"But now that I think back, I don't see it as a bad thing. I attended the academy in Courtois, and I'm here as an honorable high knight."

When Izumi smiled, Cleo did too. And she looked out the window.

"I don't know anything... unlike my younger brothers and sisters, I was fated to be offered as the maiden from the start. So my education was kept to a minimum. I rarely had any opportunities to speak to a foreigner, so today was fun."

To be offered. It meant her life would be forfeit. Izumi and Rudel had investigated the internal affairs of Celestia beforehand, and it was the most famous story about the country, so she knew about it.

About the blue-haired tribe that offers life to the god who made even Courtois stand down.

"I know I'm really not supposed to say this, but I'm happy that my attack let me meet everyone. I was even able to see a dragon."

To change the topic, Izumi picked up the thread on Sakuya.

"You should mention that to Rudel tomorrow. If you tell him you want to see a dragon up-close, Rudel will be delighted."

"Rudel-dono will? I don't mean ill, but he's a peculiar one, isn't he? Milliasan did say, 'he's the strange one, you're not crazy'."

Cleo's impression towards Rudel seemed to be fixed on him being a strange one. Labelling that a misunderstanding or mistake was something Izumi found exceedingly hard to do. Thinking about Rudel using Courtois' knights as a frame of reference brought about numerous problems.

"H-he is strange, but he's a good guy. A really good guy!"

It was the greatest defense she could muster.

"Fufufu, you get along, I see."

"Yes, he's a precious friend."

Seeing Izumi's expression as she said that, Cleo tilted her head. Something wasn't sitting right in her stomach; she tried asking Izumi.

"You're not lovers? Um, you make a wonderful face whenever you talk about Rudel-dono, you know."

"That's wrong. He's a dear friend from the academy. A little circumstance has led me to stay by his side as a colleague, nothing more and nothing less."

If she called it a little circumstance in Courtois, the royal palace would be abuzz with cries of, 'are you sure you're taking this seriously with an

attitude like that?'. For the sake of the country, Izumi was appointed as Rudel's special inspector. It wasn't an exaggeration to say it was a mission of the utmost importance.

Rudel was generally classified as a first-rate knight. Strong, proud, and even loyal. But the most important thing was... he was an idiot.

Not the sort that couldn't study, the type that burst into erratic conduct the very moment the idea struck his head. Even after he was instated in the dragoon brigade, he had repeated numerous bouts of problematic behavior that dragged all his surroundings in. What's more, the biggest problem to Courtois was the fact Rudel had obtained an outrageous dragon like Sakuya.

'If that thing gets serious, this country is seriously done for.'

The reason the upper brass seriously thought so was largely due to a single knight, feared by Courtois and all the countries that bordered it.

Rudel idolized that knight... Marty Wolfgang.

It's been said the King of Courtois once cried out, 'Why did it have to be him of all people!' or something along those lines...

Putting all jokes aside, there was no doubt keeping Izumi with Rudel was an important measure.

"Are you sure?"

Said Cleo with a slight laugh.

As Izumi found it strange, Cleo spoke.

"I'm sorry. Love gossip, was it? I wanted to try doing something like that."

Cleo was raised in the castle. She was raised as if the only important thing was that she was alive until the time came... or so was the feeling Izumi got.

The room's interior was modest, and she could think it belonged to a princess who held an important role.

"At the end, my dreams keep getting granted one after the next, I'm overjoyed."

"... Is that... so."

Izumi didn't know what words to send her anymore.



Once the night had advanced, two faces peeped out of an inn window with a view of the palace.

It was Aleist and Nate.

Nate peered into her telescope, changing the magnification with the regulator stuck to the side as she inspected every last detail. Aleist wasn't very knowledgeable on the matter, but as it was constructed as a magic item, it was most certainly an expensive piece. Not something Nate would be able to purchase.

There was one at Aleist's house as well, but he had only ever seen his father carefully stow it away a few times.

"I was also thinking it around noon, but who really are you, Nate?"

When Aleist asked, Nate continued peering into the telescope as she conversed.

"You want to know? Once you know, there's no going back? Senpai, you might just get swallowed up in the mysteries of an enigmatic woman like me."

"Yeah, not happening. I just wanted to ask what sort of secret you have."

Aleist waved his hand, laughing Nate's words away. And he decided to change the topic.

"So what are you doing?"

"I'm confirming the state of the castle. The departure's the day after tomorrow, but there's no telling what'll happen until then."

"The day after tomorrow?"

Aleist tried to recall what would happen in two days.

He remembered Rudel's main mission would take place at that time.

"Come to think of it, is Rudel alright?"

"Sakuya-chan's nice and quiet, so I think he's just fine. Rather, she's fidgeting restlessly, and it doesn't seem she can settle down."

"Eh? You can see her with that? Let me have a go."

"Go ahead. If you adjust it here, you can change the scaling."

Accepting the telescope, Aleist zoomed out to search for Sakuya. He spotted her popping her head over the castle wall from time to time.

She seemed restless and unsettled.

"What is that girl doing?"

As Aleist said that, Sakuya's eyes met with Aleist's across the telescope. That was scary, he thought, putting the telescope down, and looking at the castle in the distance. From here, he couldn't see Sakuya's form. Somewhat relieved, he tried peering in again, only to find her staring straight at him this time.

"... Nate, thank you."

He didn't want to think Sakuya had noticed them, but Aleist was hated by Sakuya. In the case that he really was sighted, the very fact Sakuya moved would become a huge problem.

"You're already done with it?"

He returned the telescope to Nate. There, as if suddenly hitting on something, she began to speak.

"Come to think of it, senpai, you have any interest in peeping? In that case, you want me to lend you my telescope?"

Nate gave a sly laugh as she held out the device, but Aleist was getting tired, so he wanted to return to the bed. What's more he had no interest in peeping.

"What's that? Ah, no, I'm fine."

Having lost interest in such talks as of late, it was on a level where he wanted a magic device to prevent being peeped on. Within Aleist's harem, there were a few who specialized in magic. Those girls would identify Aleist's bathing time to launch their attacks.

"Rather, you know, give me something so I don't get peeped on myself."

While Aleist made a relatively sincere plea, Nate's face twitched.

"... I know I'm not one to speak, but you really are an off one, senpai."

"You think? I don't notice it myself anymore. I've just kinda been real tired these days, see... ah, you'd better honor your promise and not assault me."

Nate looked at him with a dubious face.

"Isn't it supposed to be the other way around? I'm the one who should be worried about getting assaulted."

Nate spread out her arms to show off her own lightly dressed fresh-out-of-the bath form. Short, white pants, a simple shirt above... what's more, the slight see-through nature of her clothing allowed a faint glance at her undergarments. Though it just looked to Aleist that she had purposely chosen undergarments with striking colors for the contrast.

"Don't worry. I wouldn't even assault you if you asked me to."

Giving an immediate reply, he took his eyes off of Nate and looked at the room. Two single beds...

(Well, even if she tried, I'll be able to run away. My intuition's been particularly sharp in those things as of late, I'll be able to notice before she makes her move.)

Flopping down on the bed, Aleist was delighted he'd be able to get his first restful sleep in a long time. While Nate was there, he didn't seem to pay her the slightest mind.

"Early to bed, early to rise, what a wonderful phrase! Goodnight."

"Uwah..."

Nate's face was filled with conflicted sentiment.



Once morning came, Rudel went out to the plaza to see Sakuya.

Perhaps because of her presence, the plaza looked a little narrow. And around, the soldiers seemed to be surrounding her on lookout.

'Ah, Rudel.'

When Sakuya moved, the surrounding soldiers cowered. There were some whose hips gave out, and others that readied their spears.

"What's wrong? You don't look too peppy."

Seeing Sakuya not in the best health, he worried a bit, when Sakuya took a look around.

'Um, well, you see... someone was looking. And Sakuya can't calm down when she's not in the ground.'

Sakuya was a subspecies of the gaia dragon that made their homes in the soil. As expected, they were most calm in the ground, and when sleeping outside... what's more, an unfamiliar place, it was too unsettling.

(But even if she says looking, with so many soldiers around, isn't that natural?)

Rudel looked around and saw the cowering soldiers looking at him with eyes demanding he did something about this. While Rudel could hear Sakuya's voice, only Rudel could hear Sakuya's voice. To the others, it just sounded as if she was raising a growl.

"Don't worry. Right... I'll ask if there's anywhere nearby you can dig a hole. Your special mission is tomorrow after all. It should be fine if you stay on standby until then."

A dragoon and dragon could communicate with their hearts. Rudel thought he could just call her if it came down to it. Though he didn't think he would actually get permission for her to dig a hole.

'Really!? The earth around here feels really warm, so it was on my mind the whole time! I want to build a house soon.'

"... No, making something so full-blown is a bit..."

Rudel felt somewhat apologetic. When it came to digging holes... no, to making dens, Sakuya had her hangups. She would make a number of chambers, designating the room furthest in as her private room. It wasn't just a bit of a cave... it was a full-blown cave system.

Perhaps she had a good feel for the ground, or it was just intuitive, but amazingly, even if she arbitrarily dug with her power, it never crumbled. But even if he explained that, he doubted the people of Celestia would understand.

"Can you make due with a simple one? We'll be returning tomorrow."

'... Fine.'

Sakuya's sulking hurt Rudel's heart.

(Sakuya... how cute can you be.)\But as a dragon idiot, even if his heart hurt as he looked at her, he still found her cute.



"It passed."

"What did?"

Rudel sat at the same table as Cleo and Millia for breakfast. Izumi was still asleep, so it was a meal for just the three of them.

Near the door, Ben and Passan stood at attention. The party of three consisted of soldiers, and they were unable to eat breakfast with the princess.

For Rudel and Millia, it was treated as special.

"No, I went and asked Emilio-dono if there was anywhere Sakuya could dig a hole, early in the morning. When I did, he got permission."

"... Is that really alright?"

As Millia sent him a doubtful glance, Rudel thought over it as well.

(This does feel a little off. Normally, he'd want to keep Sakuya as close as possible, but... could it be the soldiers just complained that much.)

He thought over various things, but he had received permission, he started devising a plan to lead Sakuya to the location. It was already arranged that Rudel would be told the location after breakfast, sending Sakuya in the right direction once he returned to the castle.

Once the maidservant finished the preparations for breakfast, the three gave a Celestia-styled prayer and began to eat.

The scent of bread and bacon wafted through the room.

Rudel looked at the princess, thinking of her almost as a small animal as he watched. The way she ate wasn't unruly. More so, she was firmly following proper manners.

But the air around her was restless.

(Perhaps she's mindful of me and Millia.)

He thought, and after he had eaten his meal and sipped his tea, Cleo came out with a request.

"U-um... if it's possible, I'd like to see your dragon up close, would that be alright? Erm, Izumi-san said you would show me if I asked..."

After Cleo had shyly asked, Rudel quietly set down his cup. He looked at Cleo with a serious face.

Perhaps she was nervous, her body stiffened.

"Rudel?"

Millia sent over a worried voice. But Rudel...

"No problem at all. While we're at it, would you care for a journey through the sky as I tell you the wonders of a dragon—! Millia, that hurts, you know."

"Don't try to pick up the princess! And there's no way that would be allowed!"

As Millia talked on and on with a rough way of breath, she has a point, Rudel ended up agreeing. He had been delighted to hear of her interest in dragons.

But his aid came from an unexpected place.

"Um..."

"Something the matter."

After the maidservant let out a voice, she lowered her head towards Rudel. And she made a desperate plea.

"I am aware of how discourteous this may be, but please take the princess into the sky!"

When he wondered what was up, the maidservant said something like that. He did think it wrong, but there Emilio made his appearance.

"A dragon, is it... I don't see why not."

"Emilio-dono?"

Unlike the day before, Emilio was taking on an attitude much too lenient. And he made a proposal to Cleo.

"Whatever the case, today is the only day the princess may have her freedom. Let's see... all the more, why don't you let her see the lands around the castle?"

"Don't you think that's going too far?"

Millia sighed, but Emilio let a slight laugh.

"No, I've actually been thinking it a while now. At least at the very end, the princess should be given some time to have fun... I've already received permission, everyone, please just unwind."

As he said that and left, Rudel and Millia gazed at Emilio's back. The difference between yesterday was one thing, but the problem lay elsewhere.

"I kinda feel something really off about this."

The maidservant answered Millia's words.

"That's not true! Emilio-sama is Celestia's finest knight. He is thinking about the princess. I was also desperately searching for something I could do for her and..."

The maid lowered her head and apologized for her rudeness. Next, it was Ben and Passan's turns to lower their heads to Rudel.

"Boss Rudel, I'd like to make the plea too! Show the princess what it's like outside the castle!"

"I'm beggin' you here, boss Rudel!"

Millia endured a laugh as the two of them called him boss. Rudel looked over at Cleo.

(Well, I guess that depends on how Cleo-sama feels.)

He called over. But Cleo's face was turned down.

"Cleo-sama, do you have any obj... Cleo-sama?"

A red face, shaking a little, when Cleo looked up into Rudel's face, she started to panic.

"I-I! Um, uh... it's the firth time anyone's tried a pickup on me!"

(Ah, she bit her tongue.)

Rudel was casually mindful of how she bit her tongue around the word first. Millia beside him held her head.

Chapter 137

Successfully driving everyone out, Emilia passed by the maid in service to Cleo as he walked down the hall.

Walking by her in that empty corridor, neither side took a glance at the other. When her back faced his, he quietly called over.

"You play well."

"Oh my, and I'm sure I was changing my voice."

As the maidservant giggled, Emilio's mood took an unpleasant turn. The voice she replied in was the female voice that relayed information in the dark room.

"Right around now, all the hindrances are in the sky... the dragoon's powerful partner is leaving the castle. The higherups will rejoice."

Emilio didn't know whose orders the contact was moving under. But he also knew the maid hadn't the slightest intention of telling him.

"I wonder about that. You've already failed once before."

"Those words had some thorns. Once noon has gone by, I'll have them move according to plan."

"I suppose I should tell you to do your best. It does seem those of the Gaia Empire obstructed you last time... and there were some skillful ones among them."

Hearing that, Emilio narrowed his eyes. He warned himself not to let any emotion leak into his voice. Over his clothes, he touched the egg-shaped

pendant in his breast pocket. It was a precious memento of his mother.

"Even so, it seems the princess has quite a longing for the lifestyle of the common folk. Is that your doing?"

"Yes. Ever since I began serving her, I spoke of things that would make her yearn for a common life. What she couldn't experience in her limited life... I was told to give the princess a dream she would never reach no matter her yearnings. But I never thought that would prove useful here of all places. A princess whose face goes red from being hit on is..."

Emilio grasped the gist of what the maid was trying to say. Cleo was much too dense to the malice around her. In her eyes, there were places where the ill-natured surroundings were only natural.

(I doubt she will find anything off. How truly pitiful...)

The maid continued on, as if to take over from his thoughts.

"... She truly is a pitiful girl. Her life taken without being of the slightest use, her days ending with her unable to accomplish anything."

The maid's voice was laughing. What's more, it was the sort of laughter that made it seem she was enjoying herself so much she couldn't help it.

"Sure enough. Once everyone has returned, I will go out to meet up with them. The location is..."

"If you'll have them come to the central plaza, we will handle the rest."

The maidservant walked off. From the depths of the corridor, another person came walking. Emilio started off as if nothing had happened at all.

(That's right, this time, I'll make it succeed.)

Taking his hand from his pendant, he strongly walked down the corridor. A resolve was beginning to seep into his expression.

(No matter what happens, Cleo will...)



Having taken off from the palace courtyard, Sakuya housed Rudel and Izumi, and Millia, Cleo and the party of three on her back.

"B-boss! The sky's scary!"

"Let's fly a little closer to the ground!"

"We're really high up! If we fall, we're gonna die!"

"If I fly lower, there will be collateral damage. You'll have to put up with it."

The three fell to all fours on Sakuya's back, their faces pale, their bodies shaking as they tried their hardest not to look down. Rudel instantly vetoed their request.

In contrast, Cleo was...

"Amazing. So this is the sky! The sky only a dragoon can obtain!"

Delighted.

"That's right! The sky only a dragoon can see! In order to get it in my hands, I worked hard from a young age!"

Every time Cleo rejoiced, Rudel was delighted as well. Almost as if he had gained someone who understood him, he frolicked along with the girl.

From the point of view of Izumi and Millia, whose hearts were dancing as they kept a close eye to make sure Cleo didn't fall, it was a bit of a peculiar sight.

"Rudel, can't you fly a little safer? And Cleo-sama, please take a seat and hold onto the handrail."

Like a horse, Sakuya's back was furnished with equipment for humans to ride her. A large bag was stuck on for luggage, and her equipment included

things like handrails and cushions. Things that might prove necessary when escorting people.

Dragons of the gaia variant were slow when it came to transporting, but as they were able to move a large quantity of goods, they were a priceless addition to the dragoon brigade's rear logistic support.

In battle, their slow speed and large bodies had them hated as easy targets, but even so, with their skin and scales that kept away normal attacks, they were the dragons that boasted the greatest destructive power. As a subspecies of such a race, it didn't matter to Sakuya if there were seven people on her back.

"In the first place, why did they give permission? Letting the princess out like this shouldn't be allowed... ah, come to think of it our second princess is casually attending the academy."

When Millia spoke of the pink-haired expressionless princess, Cleo showed a degree of interest. But rather than the second princess Fina, she was interested in the academy.

"The academy, is it? A school that even royalty can attend sounds wonderful."

"And wonderful it is! I especially enjoyed the fundamental curriculum's interclass tourney, and the upper classmen's' individuals' tournament."

At Rudel's statements that made it seem as if combat was the main activity, Izumi and Millia ended up sighing.

"No, you're just a special case."

Remembering the days of Rudel, Aleist, Eunius and Luecke fighting, Millia put a damper on his spirits.

"What makes you say that, Millia, you took part in a match in your fifth year as well! I think Aleist's confession prevented you from exhibiting your full strength, not that I think about it, that was a legitimate tactic and..."

Millia turned red to her ears as she cried out.

"Don't talk about that!!"

Not wanting to remember, she turned her face down.

But on the contrary, Cleo grew interested.

"It sounds amazing, Courtois' academy... my country does not have such an educational institution, so I find myself envious."

"I know, right!? When the tiger tribe men exchanged blows—"

"Rudel, don't you think we've had enough of that topic. You're giving the academy a strange image."

Izumi stopped him.

Atop Sakuya's back, they shared a laugh.

(I hope this takes her mind off it a bit.)

Rudel looked at the map he received from Emilio. And once Cleo and Izumi got into a girls' conversation, he stared hard at the map in thought.

(... It's a bit too far from the castle. If something happens and I have to call Sakuya, it will take too much time for her to return. This might have been a failure.)

Revoking it now would be a disservice to Emilio. But thinking of his duty to guard Cleo, Rudel knew that keeping Sakuya close would be the best deterrent. Right, just a deterrent.

(No, did they fear Sakuya conducting combat near the palace? When we're doing the actual guard mission, we'll need Sakuya to serve as transport.)

If Sakuya was caught up in a battle near the palace or castle town, the surrounding area was instantly be turned to a mountain of rubble. As he still had his worries about holding back, Rudel was cautious in that field. In the

case that an enemy attacked, he would have Cleo board Sakuya to evacuate her into the sky.

That alone would prevent enemy hands from reaching her. That was how he saw it, and he wasn't considering to have her take part in battle.

(It's a bit worrisome they don't seem to have any intent to protect her. Well, I'm the one who made the proposal, but... I should keep cautious.)

None too knowledgeable on the internal affairs of other countries, the fact his own country wasn't monolithic became a stroke of good luck. He was beginning to notice there might be a separate force moving within Celestia.

It was strange from the start.

By relying on a foreign nation for guards, they invited in the dissatisfaction of the knights, what's more, they didn't send enough manpower around.

Rudel looked at the party of three making pale faces.

(Their loyalty aside, if they're this unusable, I must presume they haven't received basic training.)

They were spies from the other force... he tried to consider, but they were too unreliable for that. He thought they might be concealing their real skill, but at least from what he could tell by fighting them, that didn't seem likely. And they had the mind to serve Cleo from the depths of their heart.

(They're a sort... I've never had around me.)

As far as Rudel knew, that type of retainer didn't exist on his home estate. He had seen enough of the opposite- those that mocked and tried to use him- to grow tired of them. Because of that, he found himself just a little envious of Cleo.

(But whatever the case, we should be nearing the limit. Thinking of the princess' stamina, we should descend and take a short break.)

It was nothing more than flying through the sky, but for those unaccustomed to it, the stamina expenditure was intense. Rudel decided to land and take some rest.

"Sakuya, it looks like the designated point is over there."

'Uwah, it's a warm-looking place.'

Rudel couldn't understand how the ground could look warm. But there was a mountain nearby with smoke rising from it.

"Is this area alright? It'll be hell if an eruption occurs."

The villages he spotted around made Rudel anxious. If the volcano erupted, the casualty figures would be severe. But near the volcano was a forest that had seen a good number of years.

"Ah, we're perfectly fine. The sort of eruptions I hear about from other lands never happen in Celestia."

Rudel inclined an ear to Cleo's explanation as he had Sakuya lower altitude.

"The guardian deity is in a different one... a shrine in the volcano you can see over there, but because of his protection, eruptions never occur. Not since the founding of Celestia... so at the very least, there hasn't been one in two hundred years."

On her words, Izumi was mildly surprised.

"Not a single major eruption in a few hundred years?"

Cleo shook her head.

"They can't happen. As I said it's because of the guardian deity."

Making a little... no, a sorrowful face, Cleo turned her head down. Unable to see her state given their position, the party of three regained their vigor as the ground approached, getting excited over the princess' explanation.

"Our god is amazing! The princess is amazing too!"

"He's a god after all! And as expected of the princess!"

"The god is amazing, but the princess is smart!"

On their three reactions, Cleo giggled a bit.

"That's right. Even like this, I've studied, for what it's worth. But it's the first time anyone's called me smart."

Saying she was happy even if it was just flattery, Cleo smiled at the three. They seemed happy as well.

As Rudel looked at them, a scene of his own youth suddenly revived in his head.

(... That doesn't matter right now.)

Issuing orders to Sakuya, he told everyone to prepare to land.

"Grab onto the handrails. We're touching down."



'Building a house for Sakuya~.'

Sakuya sang a song as her large arms began digging a hole. Little ways away, Rudel watched as the mountain was shaved away.

Sakuya had her own criterion for which place was best, so she was apparently investigating. And with this serving as their break, Rudel and the others looked over the scene.

"... The rocks and dirt are flying through the sky."

Ben looked at the parabola the soil drew in the air as he muttered.

"No matter how many times I see it, Sakuya's digging is a magnificent sight."

Rudel looked and nodded a few times.

"It's amazing. If she has that much power, can the dragons do other jobs as well?"

Cleo's question was answered by Izumi.

"They're used for transport and land development. A skillful dragon can fulfill a number of roles."

The princess took a keen interest to that response. Rudel recalled the port town of Beretta where he was stationed. While it was built at a harbor, it wasn't as if there weren't any fields. Preparing those fields was left up to Keith... when the Lieutenant Keith didn't have any subordinates, his water dragon Spinnith could fulfill the role alone.

He didn't have the same level of power as Bennet's dragon, but if put to skilled labor, he could pull it off well. He made quite an undragon-like statement, saying he liked work that had to be built up one step at a time.

"Well, each dragon has its own quirks."

Don't just write off our problems as quirks, the upper echelons of Courtois would claw at Rudel if they heard the statement.

Sakuya was comfortably singing her song. There, going along with what should only sound like a dragon's growl to other humans, Cleo began to hum. She was gradually picking up the rhythm.

The party of three looked at Cleo with faces as if they were to be moved to tears.

"What's wrong?"

Ben explained to Rudel.

"What's wrong... ah, you didn't know? The princess is really good at singing. I don't know how long ago, but back when we was still jobless, unsteadily topplin' around, she was singing a song in the square. When we heard her singing, it moved us, got us inspired."

Ben began to shed tears.

When Rudel asked the reason, he found the three had left their village unable to find work, and once they came to the castle town of Celestia, they lived by rummaging through the trash. Troubled for food, they were honestly about to stick their hands into ill deeds.

But hearing the song in the square, they popped their heads out the alley, and saw it was Cleo who was singing.

That clear voice held a certain something that resounded in a person's heart. The fact these three hadn't turned to crime was thanks to Cleo, apparently.

The voice had caused them to reflect on themselves.

"It was a real pretty song, see. Ended up pepping us right up. What we was doing started to look stupid. We stopped caring how cheap the pay was, searched out a place to work, and ended up guarding a gate that no one ever used. People made fun of us, but we didn't give a damn. Working earnest, earning money... she made us notice there was nothing more rewarding."

Cen listened to Cleo sing as he told Rudel a tale. Pano continued on after him.

"When we begged and started out as trainees, it was nothin but cleaning and chores. But man, if we put the work in, even we could do it, boss."

As Cleo's mood gradually rose with her humming, she began lightly singing to herself. Passan closed his eyes to hear. Rudel also inclined his ear.

(I see, so these three feel indebted to the princess. But if a song's all it took to get them back on their feet, perhaps they were good people to start with. Whatever the case...)

The three were troubled for food, fished through trash, and in the end, were about to commit crime. There were surely opportunities for ill deeds before it came to that, so Rudel concluded to himself they were good at heart. And that the song was only the trigger they needed.

But...

(Yep, it's a nice voice. I'm no good with those things, but it feels pleasant on my ears. Perhaps this is talent.)

In Cleo's singing voice, Rudel could also feel something echoing in his heart. As a noble, he had received a general education. Music was included. But when it came to fine arts, especially music, Rudel didn't exhibit any particular knack or talent.

Rather, Eunius and Luecke achieved excellent grades in music and art.

... Aleist was out of the question.

But according to Luecke, perhaps he was just born in the wrong era. Apparently. In various ways, Aleist was too advanced.

As Rudel and the others lent an ear to Cleo's song, Sakuya cried out.

'Higyaaaaah!!'

"S-Sakuyaaa!!"

Responding to the scream, Rudel leapt out to find the hole Sakuya was haughtily excavating welling up with water and steam.

Rudel rushed over to Sakuya's side, surprised by the heat rush of the vapor, and the temperature of the water.

"Is this a hot spring?"

As Sakuya finally managed to bob her head out of the water, Rudel jumped at it and latched on, calling out.

"Are you alright, Sakuya!? Any burns?"

While he was worried, there, Izumi called over.

"No, Rudel... Sakuya is a dragon, you know."

Right. Sakuya was undoubtedly a dragon. And the dragon in question floated in the hot water as she remarked.

'Haaah, it feels niicccee.'

She was quite satisfied by the hot spring she had dug up herself. Perhaps she had struck the source, as the water wasn't at a temperature a human could enter. To a dragon, such matters were irrelevant.

(Kuh, Sakuya in a bath... she's too cute.)

From atop Sakuya's head, Rudel gazed at his own dragon with great satisfaction.



Returning to the castle, Rudel reported to Emilio.

Before a soaked Rudel who had removed his coat, Emilio spoked.

"... So you're telling me you fell in when your dragon changed posture? You haven't been burned, have you?"

"I am alright. My apologies."

Rudel and the others had safely returned, but Rudel had fallen into the spring. The reason was just as Emilio had detailed. Fed up, Emilio looked at Rudel as he ordered the servant in the room to bring him some clothes.

"Bring a change of clothing for Rudel-dono, if you please."

Cleo's made nodded and left the room.

"Once Rudel-dono's finished changing, we shall depart. Time is limited, after all."

Feeling an urge to hold his head, Emilio looked at Rudel.

(Give me a break, Dragon. I need you to do your job.)

It was a large strain on the plan.

But he continued thinking of how he would to reconnect the ends of the deviating plan, and bring it towards a result he desired.

Cleo presented a towel to the soaked Rudel. The towel in Rudel's hands was already sopping wet.

Rudel, Izumi, and everyone else felt ashamed.

(No, you're not supposed to be doing that sort of thing.)

Emilio was troubled by Cleo's correspondence.

"Princess, once the maid returns, leave Rudel-dono to her. Now let's prepare to head o..."

After saying that much, Emilio noticed his own failure.

(Ah, wait a second. Cleo only has one maid. Then no one's actually preparing for the plan?)

With everything in such a shapeless state, Rudel's party were about to set out into the castle town.

Chapter 138

In the center of Celestia's busy center square, a statue of the country's founding queen was erected.

With the time being slightly past noon, the food stalls gave off a mouthwatering scent.

Steamed food seemed to be the norm as many people could be seen eating steamed vegetables topped with meats and sauces.

Other than that, the people who walked as they ate a food wrapped in white dough that let off meat juices stood out. Holding them in brown paper, their forms as their mouths let off steam as they ate left quite an impression.

The slight differences he could find from Courtois made it all the more interesting to Rudel.

Though that was also due to the fact Rudel's group had disguised themselves to play the part of tourists.

"Are they different from what you can find in Courtois? They're sweet pastries, aren't they?"

As Rudel put his impression to mouth, Cleo in the clothes of a village girl marveled alongside him. She didn't know what sort of food the townsfolk ate either.

"I can't think those are sweets..."

They let off steam, and the contents were filled with meat.

Once she voiced that, one of their guards, Passan explained.

"What Boss Rudel's talking about 's steamed buns. You wrap meat in a yeast dough 'n steam it, so it's a proper meal and not a sweet."

"Is that so? You're surprisingly knowledgeable."

As Rudel nodded in acceptance, a booth selling some sort of dolls caught Cleo's eyes.

There, Pono cautioned her.

"Prin... ah, no! Young lady, you shouldn't touch those. They exceedingly easy to break, and the sort of souvenirs that force whatever tourists pick them up to buy them."

Cleo swiftly drew back her hands

The old man manning the stall made a grim face as he saw that.

"It's not like I'm tryin' ta make them easy to break. It's just, the manufacturing process, see. When you make them outa dirt, they're gonna be fragile."

Hearing the words from the shopkeeper, Rudel simply...

(Then do something about it.)

Thought from a customer's viewpoint. In truth, if she picked one up and broke it, they would likely be forced to buy it. Millia, who had reached out in a similar fashion, now looked truly relieved.

"In the first place, that's our guardian deity, who should be treated with care. It's their fault for breaking them."

On the old man's opinion, Rudel looked at its form, but it was much too crude, and he could only barely make out its shape. An elliptical body with four thick legs stuck on; the only part of the doll colored in was an eye-like red point.

He could only see it as a rip-off.

(Was it made poorly, or does the original actually look like that... I get the feeling whoever makes them easy to break and puts them up for sale is also at fault.)

Rudel took a side-glance at Izumi.

She was keeping alert of their heavily crowded surroundings. And under the robe she wore as an escort, her hand was placed on her katana.

Rudel also directed his attention around.

There, Emilio took one of the clay dolls in hand and lifted it up.

His subordinate Ben warned him of the danger, but Emilio laughed and returned it to its original place.

His eyes were terribly cold.

"Now that we've seen the crude dolls that are this area's specialty, let's move on to the next area. Milady, it might be a little late, but how about lunch?"

Emilio suggested lunch to Cleo.

She curiously turned her eyes to the food stands. While there was something she wanted to eat, she couldn't bring herself to say it.

Rudel called out to Passan. Producing his wallet from his inner breast pocket and handed over Celestian currency he had exchanged for.

"Passan, use this to buy something. It seems milady is interested in the food stalls."

"Y-you don't need this much!"

Passan declined to accept such a fortune, but Rudel forcefully had him grip. Looking over at Emilio, he showed no signs of opposing, instead giving a nod.

"Don't worry about that, just buy enough for everyone. Take Pono with you."

Saying that, Rudel moved to stand on the opposite side of Cleo from Izumi.

"U-um, it's a bother, then..."

While Cleo sounded apologetic, Rudel shook his head to the side.

"No, I wanted to try it as well, so don't worry. I deeply apologize for having you keep me company in my meal."

When he spoke in a phrasing tactful towards the princess, Izumi and Millia made tired faces.

Millia even blatantly glared at him.

"... What's wrong?"

"Nothing really. I just thought you were being refreshingly thoughtful."

When Millia lifted her hair and said it, perhaps sensing the atmosphere, Passan and Pono headed off towards the stalls. Ben enviously saw off their backs.

As always, Cleo looked apologetic, so Emilio followed through.

"I'd appreciate if you left your spats for once you've returned to your own country. Right now is milady's time."

Millia turned to Cleo.

"My apologies, Milady."

Hearing that, Cleo gave a bit of a lonesome laugh.

"No, it's alright."

At that moment, Passan and Pono returned, both their arms full of food.

"We're back!"

"Passan, you bought way too much."

Ben sighed. And Emilio naturally started off towards a place in the square where chairs and tables were lain out.

"Then let's eat. Over here."

(He's used to this. Meaning the knights eat here? Despite that, I don't see any around.)

Rudel couldn't see any knights eating around.

He spotted quite a few soldiers on lookout, and he could see some soldiers having their meals. But he didn't see any knights.

(Is it a problem with the timeslot?)

Rudel watched Cleo take a seat as he called out to Passan.

"Passan, do the knights eat in this area too?"

Taking a sidelong glance at Emilio, who even wore a hood, Rudel sought confirmation. Emilio was explaining to Cleo how to eat the various foods from the stalls.

Ben and Pono's eyes were sparkling at the feast before their eyes.

Passan as well, and when Rudel struck up conversation, he troublesomely looked between Rudel and the food.

"There's no way they'd come here. Even if they go on patrol, they get free meals at the castle. I've never heard of them showing up at these measly stalls."

"But this is a sight-seeing spot, right? They never stretch their legs in the area and eat at the stalls?"

"Yeah, this might not be the best way to put it, but the mighty knights eat 't proper restaurants. This place is just right for the penniless soldiers to fill their stomachs... we're thankful for it- no money and all- but once you get to be a knight, it's looked down upon, er rather..."

Seeing how he struggled to say it, the knights likely avoided eating at the lowbrow food stalls.

(Do they look down on the food eaten by the masses? Quite a few of these are surprisingly delicious, but...)

Rudel's wariness towards Emilio was instantly raised. But as things stood, he didn't have any evidence. Even if he had his doubts, they were at a level where they'd clear up if the man gave an excuse.

A little suspicious, was all he thought.

"Passan, you can have mine. I'm fine with just one."

Saying that, Rudel took one meat bun in hand and swiftly finished his meal. A delighted Passan brought the remaining but over to Ben and Pano.

"Boss, I got this from Boss Rudel!" "Cheers. We're having a feast today!"
"Thank you!"

Giving a bitter smile at the rejoicing three, Rudel went over to Izumi and sat down by her side. While he kept wary of his surroundings, he took care not to direct that towards Emilio.

Millia glared at the two of them, but he ignored her for now.

"Did something happen?"

Hearing Izumi's whisper, it's nothing definitive, he gave as a preface as he whispered back. Rudel himself only had a light off-feeling at best.

"It's Emilio. Something feels off about him."

"... I see."

Without moving her eyes, she lent an ear to his words.

"This might not be so simple a request. Just keep that in mind."

Saying that and standing, Rudel moved over to an adequate seat to guard Cleo.

Though they were in the middle of work, Ben's party were deliciously digging into their meal. Cleo seemed to be having fun as she watched them.

She held a yearning towards plebian... things of differing status, to be more specific.

It wasn't as if Rudel didn't understand the feeling.

(Perhaps every royal family is complicated.)

There were plenty of strange points in this matter. He honestly couldn't believe the reason they were called over was because the country's own knights weren't trusted.

(No use digging too deep into it. That's not our job.)

Rudel changed his train of thought to focus on nothing but the mission. But as Cleo gave an innocent laugh as she listened in to Ben's party's conversations, he grew just a little curious.

Turning his eyes to Emilio, Rudel noticed.

(He's smiling?)



Aleist had climbed to the roof of a building overlooking the center square.

To be more precise, Nate had led him there.

They both wore robes, weapons at the ready as they waited on standby.

Keeping her body low, Nate used her telescope to check the surroundings. When the sun was so high in the sky, the reason they didn't stand out was because of the magic she was using.

Aleist recalled the magic and skills he didn't use in-game.

(All the magic and skills I thought were useless, to think there were such convenient uses for them. Even so, what is Nate doing?)

He had still yet to hear the reason Nate had come to Celestia. But Aleist had been led off from Courtois as her guard.

There had been some combat with those he suspected to be soldiers of the Gaia Empire.

(There's no doubt it's something troublesome. What is she looking at?)

Nate peered into the lens as she called over to Aleist. It was almost as if she had his thoughts in the palm of her hand.

"Are you curious about me, senpai?"

... But that was quite evidently a misunderstanding. There was no way Nate could understand how Aleist felt.

(Well, if she's noticed, I'd best not beat around the bush.)

Giving a bitter smile, Aleist offered Nate a correction.

"I'm pretty sure what I'm curious about is why we've come all the way to a foreign nation to do something like this. In the first place, you've yet to explain why we had to run away from that strange bunch."

While she heard out his take, Nate continued observing somewhere with her telescope. She continued gazing at what seemed to be the central square of the busy main road.

Perhaps she had found the target of her surveillance, as she didn't remove her eye.

"You're asking that now? I'd really prefer it if you either asked earlier, or stayed silent and showed some stoicism as you silently watched over me."

"That's not in my character. If you don't like that, hurry up and find a boyfriend, and marry them alongside your graduation."

"Uwah... senpai, you're terrible. After you did such a thing to me."

Such a thing, meaning when Aleist was pushed down. It was in his student days. Dropping by the graduation party, Aleist ran smack dab into Nate, who was handing out drinks, and she ended up pushing him down.

"I was the victim there, wasn't I? And It really was hell back then."

Recalling his school days, Aleist breathed out a sigh as he slumped his shoulders.

"Senpai, I don't want to be the one to say it, but there aren't many students out there who enjoyed their school life as much as you. Surrounded by cute girls, with friends and rivals... it was the best, wasn't it? If that's what makes you sigh, the gods are going to punish you."

Aleist had an ample understanding of Nate's words.

It was a fact he truly did have some fun. He was fulfilled.

But...

"I confessed to the girl I like, and I still haven't gotten a response. No, that's already, how should I put it, yeah, hopeless, but see..."

"Hah, are you so unsatisfied with a cute girl like me?"

As Nate called herself cute, Aleist averted his eyes and muttered.

"I think the part where you praised yourself is no good. Are you overly self-conscious?"

Nate lifted the telescope up and hit it into Aleist's head. Was it really alright to use an expensive article in such a manner, Aleist thought as he robbed his head.

"It's embarrassing for me to say it too. This sort of, I'd like if you were more mindful of a maiden's heart. It's just the two of us, so shouldn't it be fine if there was a bit of a better atmosphere between us? Like, when I call myself cute, you could at least say, 'You definitely are cute, Nate'."

Nate's face reddened in embarrassment, but...

"That sounds like a pain."

Aleist bluntly called it troublesome only to be smacked by the telescope again. Seeing Nate silently smack him with her face still red, Aleist...

(Ah, she might actually be a little cute when she's embarrassed.)

Ended up thinking even Nate had some cute parts to her. Due to the abundance of violent members in his harem, even if she hit him, he ended up seeing it as cute.



While they spend time in the central square, the time to return to the palace approached.

The flow of people had also begun to change, with the pedestrian traffic gradually lessening off.

But there, Emilio moved.

"Milady, would you like to see the famed spot of Celestia? It's not too far from central square, so we can still make it in time."

"A famed spot? I've never heard of it."

Cleo looked at Ben, but the party of three tilted their heads.

"Was there a spot like that around here? In this area, I guess you could call the central square a famed spot, but..."

As Pono crossed his arms in thought, Emilio went into somewhat forceful negotiations.

"Those in the know, know it well. Though to people without lovers, it might be irrelevant."

Hearing of lovers, the three nodded.

"So it's one of those date spots? Sure enough, it wouldn't be strange if we've never heard of it!"

While Ben gave a grand laugh, Passan continued tilting his head.

Rudel approached Passan and tried asking what was on his mind.

"Is something bothering you?"

"I'm not sure if you know, but in these parts, center square is a tourist site so there are soldiers. But go just a little away and the public order isn't too good. Even if you say it's a date spot, I'm not really seeing it... well, I don't have a girlfriend, so maybe I just don't know about it."

Seeing Cleo being led off by Emilio, her face had turned a little red at the words date spot.

As she took some fleeting glances at Rudel, Emilio went into effective persuasion.

"Why don't you take one last visit there with Rudel-dono?"

Hearing Rudel's name, Cleo thought a bit and nodded.

"You're right. If we can be back in no time, at the very end, at least..."

A little. She said and consented. Emilio led her. But it was at that moment.

"Kyaaaaah!!"

Alongside a woman's scream, they heard the sound of a building or stall being broken. A portion of a blown-away stand flew towards Rudel as well.

"Stand back!"

Saying that, Rudel drew his sword and cut down what was coming his way.

Izumi and Millia rushed over to Cleo's side, while the party of three panicked, unable to take immediate action.

Emilio issued orders to them.

"Ben, take your men and go check around the square. Head straight towards the noise and see if the enemy is still there."

"Eh, oh, yes!"

As Ben instantly ran off, Rudel instantly closed in on Emilio.

He could no longer think his off feeling was a misunderstanding.

"Hold it. How do you know it's an enemy?"

Drawing his sword, he didn't hesitate to direct the tip at Emilio.

There was definitely a ruckus. But Rudel's group had yet to find out the slightest detail on what had happened. Despite that, Emilio had concluded and proclaimed a clear enemy.

Izumi and Millia also quickly entered the space between Cleo and Emilio, readying their weapons. But they were swallowed up by the wave of people running away.

"Princess!"

While Izumi raced towards Cleo, a large mass fell from above. Then another, and another. In the gap Izumi used to direct her eyes up, Emilio

made his move.

(This is bad!)

Rudel was sure Emilio would cut Izumi down. He determined those somethings that came from the sky were his allies.

But Emilio ignored Izumi entirely.

"Wait!"

Swallowed whole by the flowing crowd, Millia couldn't approach Cleo.

"Emilio, why are you doing something like this!?"

"Shut up and follow me!"

Her hand forcefully grasped by Emilio, Cleo glared and put up resistance. Unfortunately, the difference in power was too great, and her resistance ended in futility.

Around the residence still ran to flee, and with his movements sealed off, those falling masses surrounded Rudel.

Those round bodies looked as if they were made from a sphere crushed flat, with four thick legs attached. Their single red eyes let off a light, their earthen surfaces...

"I don't know what's going on... but it doesn't look like these are the guardian deity."

Similar to the ornaments sold at the souvenir shop, those objects that exceeded two meters across surrounded Rudel's party, locking them in with their eyes.

Within all that, Emilio alone was able to run freely, dragging Cleo by the hand.

Millia drew back her bow, but as if to protect him, the masses moved to block her line of sight.

"Looks like these things are that Emilio's comrades."

At Millia's vexed words, Izumi also drew her katana and took a stance.

"I'd like to give chase asap, but..."

The masses that showed no intent to let them through moved mechanically like dolls. Surrounding Rudel's party of three, they looked like they would attack at any moment.

One step... Izumi tread in, and sent a slash flying at a doll. She had determined the surroundings had finally become scarce enough for her to exert her strength.

And stirring ever so slightly, the doll's torso was severed from its legs.

That clean-cut revealed- practically like the idols up for sale- its insides were empty.

"What's with these things."

Finding the empty dolls uncanny, she tried thinking of them as golems produced with magic and tried looking around. While her eyes had always been good, she couldn't spot any magician controlling them.

For dolls made out of earth, their surfaces were almost like earthenware. Appart from the severed portion, she could see cracked places as well.

But they weren't strong. Rudel thought it would be fine if they just cut them all down, but the doll's dislocated limbs quickly crept up to their original positions, fastened themselves on, and set the thing moving again.

"Now that's troublesome."

Rudel took a stance with his sword as he said that, when Izumi sent a shockwave flying to make a path. Turning, she spoke to Rudel.

Her ponytail swayed, and as she looked over her shoulder, Izumi's form made for a pretty picture.

"Go ahead, you two. If we don't carry out the mission, it will affect Courtois' reputation."

"At the moment she was kidnapped, our reputation was lost. But if that's how it's going to be, I'll be going ahead."

"Eh? We're really leaving her here alone? Hey, Rudel!"

Millia voiced her opposition to leaving Izumi behind.

But Rudel made a prompt decision, ignored the dolls in the process of regeneration, and chased after Cleo.

"Aaaah, whatever!"

Millia followed behind, protruding wings of magic from her back and chasing after Rudel.

If a doll tried to follow, a slash would fly from behind, slicing it into pieces. But as if that was pointless, the dolls regenerated one after the next.

Even so Rudel left it to Izumi.

(Now then, that means me and Millia will have to take Emilio on, but expecting only a single enemy would be too optimistic.)

The two chasing Emilio, who had entered an alley from the main road, kept the possibility of an ambush in mind as they proceeded on.



"Now then."

Having let Rudel go ahead, once the backs of the two were out of sight, Izumi sheathed her katana into its scabbard.

It wasn't that she didn't have the intent to fight. She had determined that cutting them would take way too much time.

She undid the thread that bound her scabbard to her belt. Taking the sheath in her hand, she leapt right above the doll that tried moving going after the other two.

"You're not getting away."

Pulling the sheath halfway down the blade, the moment its end touched the enemy, she hammered her sword back into it with good momentum.

The doll was slammed into the ground, shattering beyond the realm of repair. Her jump clearing the top of the shattered doll, Izumi observed the state of her enemy.

"So they don't regenerate if you break them enough. Then I'll be destroying the lot of them."

Izumi ran straight towards the remaining dolls, and as if they had a form of will, the dolls began to retreat.

But knowing from their movements they couldn't output much speed, Izumi wasn't going to let them get away.

She took another leap and destroyed another doll.

The ground she slammed it into caved in slightly from the impact.

(I've had Captain Bennet teach me a lot of things, but it seems I've at least managed to make one of them my own.)

It was a technique she learned to deal with enemies where slashes weren't the most effective.

As Rudel and the others went ahead, Izumi learned it to chase after him, if only by a single step.

"It's my first time using it in real combat, but this is a good opportunity."

Izumi muttered as she went on destroying the dolls that continued to gather in the center square.



Having fled into an alleyway, Emilio stopped in his tracks.

After running through those maze-like back alleys without going astray, he carefully set down Cleo, who he had hoisted under his left arm. She had thrashed along the way, but by this point, she was slumped without resisting.

As she took a seat, Emilio spoke.

"We're still moving. Your clothes will be soiled if you sit there."

"... Why did you turn coat?"

It was a feeble voice, but he heard it resound through the alley. He could hear the distant sounds of battle, but nothing else.

There, a woman's voice called out.

"This is troublesome, Emilio-dono. It's troubling for you to do such unnecessary things."

What Cleo saw as she lifted her head was the maid who had looked after her. She was wearing her maid uniform, but her atmosphere was different than usual.

"W-why are you here..."

Cleo didn't want to believe it. The maid was carrying such a friendly conversation with Emilio. Which meant...

"What a dull woman. Well, such a thing shouldn't be a problem for bait, so I've no complaints. I was able to have a laugh over how you thought of me as a friend, and your pitiful environment was interesting enough to watch, so I'll forgive you."

As the maid imparted her such words with a smile, Cleo's thoughts couldn't catch up.

But no matter how she recollected, that was definitely the face of the girl who had listened to what she had to say so warmly.

"You don't have to look so conflicted. You're only bait, after all. Now then, if we keep the higherups waiting, they'll be angry. Take her away already, Emilio-dono."

Seeing the maid turn from a smile to an uncanny grin, Cleo didn't know what to believe in anymore.

"T-tomorrow, I have to..."

"I know. That's why we're stopping that. Would it kill for you to be just a little thankful to me for taking care of mere feed?"

A tear flowed along Cleo's face.

There, Emilio approached the maid.

"Emilio-dono, if you let go of her hands, the bait will run aw... eh?"

Having drawn his sword as they were on the run, Emilio still held it firmly in his right hand. With a big step forward, he swung it from his top right to bottom left.

The maid was surprised, but having trained in some martial arts, she instantly leapt back. She glared at Emilio in rage.

In her, Cleo could see no trace of the kind woman who told her tales of a common life.

"What are you doing, you rotten knight!!?"

Drawing the knife she concealed in her skirt, this time the maid jumped at Emilio. But...

"H-huh..."

The moment she stepped in, blood burst from her right shoulder down to her left hip. As if she had been cut through...

"Have you forgotten how I climbed my way up the knight brigade?"

"B-bastard... you trash upstart knight. Do you think it'll end with this!?"

Spitting blood from her mouth, the maid raised her voice.

"I don't. But you see, you guys make me sick. Disappear."

Emilio's previous done disappeared, his words becoming a little rough. He stuck his saber into the maid to land the finishing blow.

"Emilio, you're..."

As Cleo said that, Emilio turned and made a sorrowful face. But at the same time, a little happy... as if his expression was trying to tell her something.

While he had been so rough a moment before, his tone towards Cleo was kind.

"Don't worry, you're going to be free soon, Cleo."

Chapter 139

"What are you talking about, Emilio?"

Cleo sat down in the narrow back alley, looking at the young man before her eyes.

Her guard, a young and powerful knight of the Kingdom of Celestia, was gripping the sword in his right hand. From its tip, the blood of the maid- Cleo's personal caretaker- he had killed fell drop by drop.

Cleo couldn't hear the distant clamor.

The maid she had believed in, who she had known for so many years had scorned her all the way.

The knight she had believed in presented her hand out to her.

"Cleo, this is enough. There's no need for you to become a sacrifice anymore. Let's run from here. The preparations are already in order."

Emilio slowly approached, extending out his left hand. Cleo moved her eyes to look between that hand and his face.

"What are you talking about, Emilio? If I don't undergo the ceremony tomorrow, the country will be..."

In her dismay, Cleo couldn't properly process the situation. This was largely due to the betrayal of the maid she thought of as a friend, who would tell her all about the castle town and life as a commoner. But even more than that, she couldn't believe Emilio when he told her to run from the ceremony.

... She had lived her life for tomorrow's ritual...

To Cleo, that was the very meaning of her existence. Even if she knew she was going to die, if it was for the sake of the country... she thought. No, she was taught.

But she did find the extended left hand to be captivating.

(If I follow Emilio, will I be saved?)

It was to her, what could be called the devil's temptation. No one ever truly wanted to die. And up until the attack from the dolls just before, Cleo had been able to spend a happy time. That only amplified her desire to live on.

(I want to live. But...)

Cleo brushed away Emilio's left hand with her right.

Glaring at him as he opened his eyes wide, Cleo spoke.

"Stand down. This body is one I have pledged to Celestia. Following you is something... I cannot do."

She was highly confused, but she barely managed to stop herself without losing to temptation. Rage, or perhaps irritation, she didn't know what to expect from Emilio, but the man simply made a sad face and smiled.

"I see. You've grown strong, Cleo. But I have my own obstinacy."

Emilio reached out his left hand to forcefully take her arm. But in the next instant, he turned his back to Cleo, taking a stance with his saber.

In the depths of the alleyway, before she had noticed it, there stood three in robes. Cleo hadn't sensed the slightest hint of their approach.

A robed man who stood just a step ahead of the three let his muddled voice resound through the space. That somewhat low voice was one she couldn't believe belonged to a human. Not a sound of life. It held a mechanical, inorganic something.

But that voice did manage to hold some emotions Cleo couldn't see herself taking to.

"This is different from what we arranged. Were you not going to hand the princess to us? This isn't the delivery point, traitor of Celestia."

The man who declared Emilio a traitor produced a barbed sword from under his robe. He took out two. Those two thorny blades gave off a purple hue in the dark back alley. As with the sword in Emilio's hands, they didn't even give off a dull reflective glow.

"... I lost my way. There was a slight blunder on my part."

Still readying his saber, Emilio hadn't dropped his guard. He was saying things completely different from before. Cleo thought, but she could tell his voice was nervous.

"J-just what could..."

On the voice Cleo rung out, the men to both sides of the double-bladed man sprung to action. Quickly, as if they were running across the wall, they leapt out towards Cleo.

"You imperial bastards!"

Giving a statement as if he had previously been working with them, Emilio swung his blade at the two. But one of them stopped his sword. And the other came at Cleo without the slightest hesitation.

"Run, Cleo!"

Emilio loudly worried for her safety, but the girl in question couldn't even stand from where she was.

"Ah..."

From the hood of the robe, she looked into her assailant's face. They wore a mask with round spectacle-like somethings stuck on. They gleamed like red eyes, and in the gloom of the alley, they looked oh so ominous.

The hand reaching out, unlike Emilio's, was clothed as if violently wrapped in rubber. That hand that somewhat smelled of oil extended towards Cleo.

But...

"That's as far as you go."

... A gust blew through the back-alley.



Just in the nick of time.

Running down the complex maze-like alleys, Rudel was relieved to find he had made it in time. High-speed movement in a layout he didn't know took more concentration than he thought, and he wasn't able to pursue Cleo as well as he expected.

Placing himself in front of her the moment he spotted her, Rudel swung his sword.

Cutting through the suspicious arm reaching out towards Cleo, he entered the space between her and the suspicious man. He instantly kicked the robed figure away, but he felt something was off.

(Oil? And the sense I got from that kick was bizarre.)

He surely lopped off an arm, but the stump wasn't bleeding. In exchange, a liquid- presumably oil- lightly dripped. With the cut as well, he didn't get the sensation he was cutting through flesh.

"Rudel-dono."

Cleo called out but Rudel didn't turn back to her. Taking a stance with his sword, he spoke.

"Please stay behind me. It does seem this is a dangerous bunch."

The man he kicked away stoop. From the severed right hand, as he thought, not blood but oil sprinkled the ground.

The robed one with the barbed swords who was probably the leader raised a cloudy, mechanical laugh.

"Kukuku, I never thought I would run into such a big shot here. It is a pleasure, Dragoon... no, Rudel Arses-kun."

Rudel kept on guard as he strained his ears to hear.

"Looks like you know about me. It's an honor for one of far-off lands... no, the empire to know my name."

In the space of that light conversation, Emilio parted from the enemy, no it felt more like both sides retreated. The man before Rudel's eyes also back stepped as he returned to his comrades. On his movements, Rudel noticed the identity of his off-feeling.

(The empire's machine soldiers?)

Machine soldiers... soldiers of the empire who compensated for their lost limbs with animated metal. He knew they moved by means of magic, but it was a technology not found in the kingdom. By their uncanniness, they were often shunned and left the dirty work of the empire, he had heard at the academy.

"I see, so I've got some eyes on me."

To Rudel's words, the leaderish man replied.

"You humble yourself. Your existence is one much too radiant for us. So radiant we must envy, and detest to such we can never forgive. I especially so, for it was a dragoon who took away my arms and legs."

So he was a machine soldier who lost his limbs in combat with a dragoon. There was no doubt whatever was under his robes had been left in a terribly state.

"We have taken up a nonaggressive defense policy. You are the ones one-sidedly invading."

The kingdom of Courtois lay on rich, fertile land. There was no merit to be found in making a march on the empire. But the empire had been pressed into circumstance where they had to invade even if they were going against dragoons.

"How young. Your youth is also enviable."

From under the hood, three red dots let off a faint light. Rudel stood and took a position to protect Cleo from the four. The robed group before him... and Emilio.

Emilio had led his three soldiers in a wrong direction so he could flee into the alleys alone with Cleo. That was the main reason for Rudel's wariness. His final actions made it doubly sure.

Rudel saw Emilio as an enemy. Emilio also seemed to understand that, but sandwiched between Rudel and the robed men, he couldn't freely move around the narrow alley.

"When I've come so far."

Regretfully... his face grimaced as his eyes darted to Rudel and the robed men.

"Kukuku, quite the ill-prepared knight you are. It speaks volumes to the nature of Celestia. To think this man would be one of the knights representing the country... now then, we shall be resuming our work. We've done a splendid job biding time."

As he said that, two robed men jumped down from the rooves of the buildings enclosing the space.

As Rudel grabbed Cleo under his left arm and jumped back, he narrowed his eyes as he looked at the situation.

"They managed to slip this many in?"

Just with a quick check, he could sense ten presences around. Was there a problem with Celestia's security, or were these guys just good at their jobs... perhaps it was both.

"You're too careless. When the enemy starts speaking, you'd best think they're trying to buy time... of course, you didn't have too many options to choose from. A dragoon without a dragon is just a normal knight. Kill them."

Losing interest, the three-eyed man issued orders to his men in an emotionless voice. But Rudel laughed just a bit.

"Your words to me ill."

With those words, he squatted with Cleo still under his arm. Three arrows passed above his head, the three-eyed man used the swords in both his hands to block them.

It was Millia.

Wings of magic spread out from her back. She took on an archer's stance, and with her next arrow, a robed man poised with a crossbow fell from the roof.

"Rudel, you rushed out too far ahead!"

"My bad. But that timing wasn't bad, Millia."

To Rudel, these weren't numbers he was unable to deal with. But with Cleo so close, he couldn't exhibit his full strength. By Millia's arrival, Rudel was sure the risk factor behind fighting his way through had decreased.

"Cleo!"

Emilio cried out as he took on the three-eyed man's subordinate coming at him. Parrying his opponent's sword, he used his left hand to draw a knife from his breast-pocket and take a slash. Perhaps his opponent was an elite as they jumped back to dodge.

But blood poured out of the mask the robed man used to breathe as he collapsed. Seeing that, the three-eyed man clicked his tongue.

"An elf, eh... and the Celestian knight isn't bad. Well, even so, he wouldn't get far in the empire. Everyone come at them."

Renewing his grip on his two swords, he issued orders to his men. Millia skipped around the space, kicking from wall to wall, firing arrows at the men. What were simple arrows stuck in deeply as they stuck into the walls and ground, but the robed men ran dodged through the volley as they encroached upon Rudel.

"... Sorry, but this is part of my job."

Saying that, Rudel entrusted Cleo to Millia, who had come close enough, and cut down one of the robed men coming at him.

The sensation of cutting through metal and flesh was something Rudel had never experienced before. But he hadn't the time to be flustered by it.

The three-eyed man ran as he issued orders.

"I'll take on the dragoon. You lot get the traitor and princ—"

Just as he had said that much, this time the robed men with bows began to fall from the roof. As they hit the ground, they let off metallic sounds.

Rudel looked at the two who descended the next instant and dispelled the magic storing up in his left hand. He had considered sending them flying with magic, but the ones who came down did seem to be allies.

"Good grief, my encounter rate with the underside of the Kingdom and Empire is especially high today. (That's totally Aleist, but I probably shouldn't point that out.)"

Wearing masks, the robed party of two stood in front of Rudel, and one answered him without turning her head.

"Would you mind leaving this to us? Your mission is to guard the princess; this one is our mission."

Rudel sent a glance at Emilio, but in his order of precedence, he had to prioritize Cleo. He had no need to fixate on the enemies before his eyes. What's more, Millia had already taken her and left. It was possible there were other enemies in hiding.

"Then they're all yours."

Saying that, Rudel swiftly left the spot. A strong wind blew, and in the next instant, he was gone.



"... His strength exceeds the rumors. He might be even more troublesome than he was in his school days, Senpai."

Draping over the robe and mask Nate handed over, Aleist looked at the surrounding situation and shook.

Wearing black robes, those men with round and red spectacles peeking out of their hoods for eyes.

(What's this supposed to mean... seriously, what!?)

The reason he was so surprised lay in Nate's prompt order to get ready as she led him barreling from rooftop to rooftop. By the time he noticed it, he was being attacked, a battle unfolded, and on top of that, he had rushed to Rudel's aid.

"Dogs of the Kingdom, is it. No, perhaps it's more accurate to call you washouts."

A man whose mask boasted three eyes called over to Aleist and Nate. Around, Emilio and the robed men were on high alert.

... Meaning they were surrounded.

"Now go do your best, Senpai."

Letting out a bit of a cute voice, Nate went right ahead to push the impossible onto Aleist. She told him to take on the group surrounding them and directing so much killing intent.

"Wait a second! Telling me to take on this many foes, no matter how you look at it, that's strange! That's strange, isn't it!?"

"Yeah, yeah, enough with the jokes. Just go do your best. You're my guard, aren't you? You said you'd help me, didn't you?"

"No, I did! I definitely said it! I just never thought it would come to this!"

"I want to see you at your coolest. Don't make me say it, how embarrassing."

"Even if you act embarrassed, you're not cute at all!"

The exchange between the masked duo, if there was a third party present, surely they would have opened their eyes in surprise. It was a comedy skit one might think would continue forever, but fed-up after all, the three-eyed man stuck in his mouth.

"Good grief, you people have no sense of tension... well then, once you're out of the way, we'll be nabbing the princess."

With a light wave of his jaw, his nearby subordinates charged at Aleist. But...

"...!? The texture when I cut into them is creepy!!"

The moment Aleist drew his own weapons, he cut apart the robed men coming at him. He had clearly cut them before they came into the range of his sword, bringing a complete change to the surrounding reactions.

The three-eyed man let out a wary voice.

"A fellow twin sword user. And a skilled one at that. How troublesome... how truly troublesome. Slaying him here might be in the empire's best interest."

With those words he had his subordinates step down and rushed at Aleist himself.

On the other side, Nate jumped away from Aleist as she spoke.

"Have at it, Senpai! I'll be guarding your back."

"No, fight alongside me! These people look terrifying!"

Even as he cried out, he didn't take his eyes off of the three eyed man before his eyes. He instinctually understood that would prove fatal.

Aleist's swords met with that of his foes.

And seeing the enemy up close, Aleist felt like something was coming back to him.

(Ah, could this guy be...)

Chapter 140

Aleist was a reincarnator.

He had been reborn into the world of a romance-themed game, carrying over the knowledge from when he played it.

Yet Aleist had no memory of a country called Celestia making an appearance. It wasn't even that it existed in setting alone.

Wearing similar robes to the masked group he fought, Aleist thought to himself.

(I didn't think they'd come to another country. But why am I fighting this guy in a place like this.)

The 'this guy' Aleist referred to was the man holding two barbed swords before his eyes.

The man who used two blades just as he did, Aleist knew him.

(Gaia's assassination unit, was it? No, I believe they called them the special forces, but...)

Both sides swung about two swords freely, contesting with their number of cards to play.

Around the men who seemed to be enemy grunts surrounded Aleist.

(If you count the Celestia knight, we only have three.)

While he had inherited an overwhelming disadvantage from Rudel, he couldn't be negligent with the enemy before his eyes.

Of all else, the three-eyed man before him was a character who appeared in the game.

Leading the mechanized unit that headed Gaia's special forces, he was a character without a name. Aleist remembered him appearing in a number of combat events.

His main characteristics had to be the special means of attacks he gained from his mechanization.

"This is troublesome."

In a muddled voice, the three-eyed man who called Aleist troublesome leapt back to take a set distance.

Seeing that, a shiver raced down Aleist's spine.

He instantly used magic as he jumped back.

(Crap!)

As he protruded tens of black spears from the ground, a number of them immediately shattered.

He crossed his swords to receive what impact remained of his enemy's attack.

"You stopped it? You're the second one I've ever met who's been able to stop it the first time they saw that attack. You can be proud of yourself... black knight."

Kukuku, or so the three-eyed man burst into laughter.

He turned up and lifted the back portion of his robe to show the sharp blade attached to the tip of the tail furnished on.

A tail of coiled metal wiring, Aleist quickly determined it would be dangerous and destroyed it with his sword before it could retract.

But his foe shoed some leisure.

"This truly is a wonderful feeling. For my sure-kill blow to be stopped... Black knight, I think I'll add you to my list."

"List? And what list would that be?"

Aleist asked out of curiosity but instantly found himself regretting it.

"The list of individuals I want to land the final blow on personally! Be proud. I'll put you in at second place. Ahahaha—"

Said he as he sprang up.

The enemy grunts, as if to follow, raced their way up the wall.

The black-robed group ran, they jumped... it wasn't a pleasant sight to see.

"... He must be quite the dangerous one."

While his face stiffened, Aleist was relieved the enemy had pulled back when a voice called from behind. It was Nate.

"Senpai, you've earned the affection of someone outrageous. That guy, even if he looks like that, he's the top of the Imperial mechanized division's applied theory unit."

"Is that it? That's who he was supposed to be?"

Even his title didn't appear in the game, and Aleist only saw him as a troublesome foe.

And now he had been recognized as the person that individual wanted to kill second-most.

(Then who's number one... and wait...)

At the end of his fleeting glance was the green haired man Nate directed her dagger at. Before what appeared to be a knight of Celestia, Aleist didn't

know what he was supposed to do.

Nate kept wary as she spoke.

"Now then, I'll have you explain yourself, Emilio-dono. When you've already called out to Courtois, I never imagined you'd invoke accursed Gaia as well."

Nate's voice was lower than usual, becoming one to threaten the other party.

In regards to the knight called Emilio, Aleist was wary as well.

But their foe showed no signs of resistance. Forget resistance, he tossed his sword aside and sat on the spot.

The alley floor is filthy... Aleist thought when Emilio opened his mouth.

"I never thought it would go well. It's just, if the possibility existed, I had no choice but to cling to it. Otherwise, Cleo... my little sister would be..."

Covering his face with his right hand, Emilio grit his teeth.

"Little sister? By Cleo, you mean the princess of this country, don't you?"

Aleist tilted his head in wonder.

Nate saw her opponent had no will to resist and tucked away her dagger. She decided to hear out Emilio's circumstance.

"Based on the situation, taking you out here is my role. It seems you have some circumstances... so why don't you tell us about it?"

Emilio spoke after letting out a sigh.

"Do what you will, is what I'd like to say, but I will be putting up a last-ditch effort."

Nate entered negotiations.

"I said based on the situation. If there's profit to be had on our side, I'm saying we might just cooperate with you."

There, Emilio indifferently started into the present state of Celestia's underbelly.

"If it's in my possession, be it information or anything else, go ahead and take it. I'm fine as long as Cleo is saved. That's my mother's wish."

So Aleist got to learn the truth of Celestia.



Having saved Cleo and returned to the palace, Rudel was summoned to the king's room.

In regards to this incident, the king proclaimed he would carry out the questioning himself.

There were many points beyond his understanding, and this was a foreign land, so Rudel paid it little mind as he spoke the plain truth.

About the attack, about the combat with a unit from the Gaia Empire, and about Emilio's betrayal.

But he decided to cover up Aleist's involvement.

Hearing all that, the king's spoke without a change in expression.

"So Emilio was an enemy spy... good grief, how disappointing."

A prominent knight of his own country was colluding with the enemy. It was no laughable matter.

(Even so, he doesn't look at all panicked. Is it because the princess is safe?)

Rudel felt something off at the king's attitude, but he decided to confirm his future plans.

"Will there be any change to our mission?"

There, the king spoke without looking at Rudel.

"None. You are to depart tomorrow as scheduled. There is no need to pay mind to anything else. Tell Cleo it will all go as planned."

This wasn't the attitude of a parent giving a final farewell.

The one before him was a foreign king.

Rudel's position was not one to stick his mouth into foreign affairs.

But...

"She was betrayed by those closes to her. From what I've heard, Emilio had accomplices as well, correct? The princess must be feeling—"

"What a human set for death feels bears no relevance. Is that all you wanted to say?"

Rudel glared at the king who wouldn't hear his opinion.

He wasn't scared. But Rudel did feel within him, this was much too sad of an attitude from a father.

(Is it really possible to be this cold to his child?)



Cleo sat on the bed of her own room.

Absentmindedly gazing out the window, she recalled the words of her closest friend, the servant who deceived her.

'What a dull woman. Well, such a thing shouldn't be a problem for bait, so I've no complaints. I was able to have a laugh over how you thought of me as a friend, and your pitiful environment was interesting enough to watch, so I'll forgive you.'

In the narrow world she lived in, the maid would teach her all about the world outside.

It was always a fun time for Cleo. The food at the stands, the events of the castle town, she was the reason Cleo longed for it so.

"So I never had any friends..."

While she felt sad, Cleo turned it around.

"It's better the fewer people there are to be saddened by my loss."

It was a little sad but even so, she had a duty to fulfill. If she did that, then surely, the smiles of many people would be protected.

Cleo convinced herself as her tears flowed.



Rudel left guard detail to Izumi and Millia as he prepared himself for tomorrow.

Calling Sakuya to the palace courtyard, he prepared to take Cleo to the destination point.

To Rudel, who didn't seem up for it at all, Sakuya let out her voice. Thought rather than a voice, it was a telepathic something Rudel could hear.

If looked at from the side, it looked as if Rudel was talking to himself.

'Are you worrying, Rudel?'

"Pardon? Ah... I probably am."

Rudel had been given a mission as a knight of Courtois. More than his own personal feelings, he was there under orders to accomplish the mission.

He didn't agree with it, but if it was an order, it couldn't be helped.

"My order from the higherups was to complete the request of Celestia's king. I will take Cleo to the destination point. I'll be counting on you tomorrow, Sakuya."

While he spoke of expectations, Rudel's expression was cloudy.

He didn't know himself.

(If I lead Cleo there, that's where she'll die.)

No matter how it was phrased, Cleo was a sacrificial lamb to protect Celestia. That was the country's custom, and something that had carried on for many years.

A complaint from Rudel wouldn't get anywhere.

"If you don't want to, you could just not."

Sakuya was a holder of a young soul. If you don't want to do it, then don't. She offered Rudel such a simple answer.

Giving a bitter smile, Rudel replied.

"If I could do that, it would be so much easier. I'll prioritize the mission."

'Cleo will die.'

Sakuya had taken a liking to Cleo.

The girl had sung to her in her pretty song voice. It had to be a talent bestowed on Cleo from the heavens.

(If she wasn't born as royalty... no, there's no point thinking of possibilities.)

Rudel also admired her song.

"... It's a mission. Tomorrow, we will guard Cleo along the way to the destination point."



Alongside Nate, Aleist listened to Emilio's story at the inn.

"What's with that... what the hell's with that!?"

Standing from his chair, Aleist raised his voice. That was simply how terrible the contents he heard from Emilio must have been.

"Senpai, how about we calm down."

"Do you think I can stay calm!? Destroying a whole country for personal grudge is crazy!"

The one surprised at Aleist's outburst was Emilio.

Nate wasn't making the best face either. But it wasn't as if she was particularly angry.

What Emilio told them of was the starting point, an incident ten years prior.

"The person he liked was offered as a sacrifice? And because Cleo's mother made it so, he had the girl live a miserable life in the castle? She's his own child, is she not!"

What Aleist learned was the fact Cleo's birth mother wasn't the queen. And Emilio's identity was a prince of this country.

At present, he was officially dead, but even so, he was a male who carried the blood of the king.

Of course, Emilio himself was raised in the slums, but that wasn't to say he would've been better off if he stayed.

"I didn't think you would get so angry. But now you understand, right? Cleo must not be led to the altar. The shackles on that ancient weapon are growing weak. If she's taken there, that excrement will use her to set it in motion and destroy this country. And that isn't all... if it loses its restraints, it'll head to other countries as well."

An ancient weapon, that was the identity of the guardian deity.

Who made it for what? At this point, even the royal family didn't have the answer to that one, said Emilio.

But giving it a shape through the volcano's energy, it was bound and used as a weapon.

"I don't know its exact value as a weapon. They say it once had the dragoons step down, but seeing how we didn't go on the offensive ourselves, it must have some limitations. What's more important to Celestia is its byproduct effect of controlling the volcanoes."

The main worth of the ancient weapon lay in how it stored up energy from the volcanoes, preventing eruption. The fact that cities could be built so close to active volcanoes was because of its grace.

But living so close to volcanoes carried just that many risks. And if there was a means to control those volcanoes?

The answer was simple.

The royal house of Celestia presented sacrifices to keep it under their control.

"A woman of the royal line, rather a blue-haired woman is necessary. Presenting the women to maintain control over it is how this country works."

A question came to Aleist's head.

He tried asking.

"Wait a second. Does this country have the necessary craft to keep it under control? And why does it have to be a blue-haired woman?"

But Emilio's answer...

"Like hell I know. It's been like that for a long time. There are some records of trial and error, but they concluded someone from the blue-haired tribe that used to inhabit these parts is necessary. Cleo's part of the tribe, the royal line took in their blood to make a show that they were performing their obligation to the people... this place can go to hell."

At Emilio's words, Aleist didn't know what he should say.

(What's going on? And presenting a sacrifice lets you control the weapon? I don't get it.)

In place of Aleist's worries, this time Nate asked.

"So you intended to create chaos by calling in Courtois and Gaia, and use the mess to flee over the border? That's quite the grand scheme you have there."

To a fed-up Nate, Emilio cried out.

"I didn't have any time! It took quite the effort to become a knight, and when I was finally high up enough to approach her, Cleo was going to be offered as sacrifice! I'm hanging by a thread here, you know that!"

Emilio had become a knight to save her, but by that time Cleo's sacrifice was upon them.

With no time to spare, he did all that was within his power. Of course, that ended in failure.

"... By the way, after you saved that Cleo-san (?) What did you intend to do? Played poorly, and wouldn't you have an uncontrollably rampaging ancient weapon on your hands, or something like that?"

Emilio didn't shy back from Aleist's question.

"Who knows? That's none of my business. Why should I care about the people who affirmed our sacrifices and killed our clan generation after generation for their own sakes?"

Aleist grasped Emilio's lapels and lifted them up.

"You're...!"

Nate breathed a sigh as she mediated and had the two sit.

"Give it a rest already. This talk isn't getting anywhere. Senpai, endure it. And Emilio-dono, don't rile him up. You know full well your time is limited."

On Nate's words, Emilio lifted his hips.

"Then you'll save Cleo!?"

She shook her head.

"We are not here to save her. Courtois shares a border with Celestia. And Gaia's special forces are moving around. I don't want to give them any information. Good grief, if you just called us alone, it would've been so much easier."

As Nate spilled complaints, Emilio averted his gaze.

He was just a little ashamed of his lack of foresight.

"So anyways, what are you going to do, senpai? I'm going to go ahead on my own from here on out, but you're free to participate. Ah, but! If you help out, you'll raise my affection points!"

Nate touched a hand to her face, taking a pose as she sent a glance at Aleist. But Aleist handled brushed her aside and looked at Emilio.

"... What?"

"I have a condition. I don't want to have any casualties. I want to make it so the princess can be saved, and no one has to die after that. If that's how it's going to be, I'll provide as much help as you want."

At the condition Aleist presented, Emilio looked amazed.

"Are you stupid? If something like that was possible, someone would be doing it."

"Senpai, you're so soft. Though I do like that part of you."

Ignoring Nate's statement, Aleist looked at Emilio. At his serious gaze, Emilio violently ruffled up his own hair.

"Tsk, we'll have the residents evacuate. I don't know if the ancient weapon can be stopped, after all. Rather, even I can't tell you what'll happen if the sacrifice isn't presented."

"That's way too conceited! After the princess is gone, won't someone else just take her place."

As Aleist said that, Emilio's expression turned serious.

"... The one selected as sacrifice has to be a woman of appropriate age. They can't be too young or too old. Right now... the only candidate is Cleo."

Emilio seemed hard pressed to say it. Hearing that, Nate's expression turned somewhat grim.

"There's definitely something wrong with the organization of a country that can't even secure a backup, but personally speaking, I do feel a little sorry."

Aleist recalled how the blue-haired Nate had been mistaken as someone concerned on the main road. She had denied it herself, but was she perhaps related?

He thought.

"A-anyways! My condition for helping is making it so there won't be casualties! I won't let up on that!"

At Aleist's words, Emilio offered some cynicism.

"Not even the unit from Gaia, and those that get in our way? No casualties at all is impossible."

"T-that's..."

Losing his momentum, Aleist looked at Emilio's expression.

(He laughed?)

It looked just a little sad, but it was a smile that had a tint of joy.

"Well, black knight, was it? I want to borrow your strength, so I'll try to keep casualties to a minimum. Oh, that's right... I do know some people who might help out."

Aleist tilted his head.

Chapter 141

Cleo lay on the bed in her room.

Night had come, but even if she tried to, she couldn't sleep.

The one who called over to her at that time was Millia.

"Um, how should I put it..."

Having heard the circumstances, she had learned of the truth that the maid Cleo thought of as a friend had betrayed.

For that sake, she tried to be tactful towards Cleo.

"... I appreciate your thoughts towards me. But it's alright. I will be participating in tomorrow's ceremony, after all."

"S-so... if you're alright with me, I wouldn't mind being your fri—"

Millia's proposal received an immediate response.

"Please stop right there! Don't say something like that..."

Millia was silenced.

(I'm sure she must think I'm a terrible woman. But even if I make a friend right before I die, I'm...)

To Cleo, failure couldn't be permitted in the next ritual.

He had her obligation as a daughter of the royal house, and she had been told all her life to fulfill her duty.

(I... even so, I must do my duty.)

Cleo endured her tears as she waited for the sun to rise.



The dungeon beneath the castle...

Before night gave way to dawn.

A party of three with black robes over their bodies.

Those three with their hoods pulled deep down came into contact with the three sleeping in one of the cells.

"Oy, you lot."

"What is it now? We just followed our orders and~."

The one who called out to the half-asleep faces of Ben, Pono and Passan was Emilio.

Aleist stayed on high alert as he complained.

"Is this place really supposed to be that easy to infiltrate?"

As he said that, Nate sounded fed-up.

"You're the amazing one, senpai. Entering a shadow to move... just having the combat prowess to stand against Gaia's mechanized unit is amazing enough."

From Aleist's point of view, being complimented like that only made him tilt his head.

Of all else, he was surrounded by people much more amazing.

With all the trouble he went through in his student days, he would often wonder if his abilities were even high at all.

The individuals he had met up to that point, from Aleist's eyes, they were all cheat-class characters.

"You think? When I look at Rudel and the others, I can't help but feel I fall short. Though I have put in some effort."

"... The very fact you can even compare yourself to those crazies puts you at a considerably high level, senpai."

While the two of them conversed, Emilio negotiated with the three.

"S-so you had a reason like that!"

"Captain, let us help out! I don't want to stay useless like this."

"I don't want that either. I feel sorry for the princess."

As Aleist hadn't been listening in to what they were saying, he tried asking Emilio as the man used the key to free them.

"What exactly did you tell them to smooth it over?"

On those words, Emilio's face turned just a little serious.

But his expression immediately crumbled.

"Nothing more than the truth. These guys are good folk at heart. So they're easy to deceive."

"You deceived them!?"

Quietly exclaiming to Emilio, Aleist looked at the three shedding tears as they left their cell.

Returning his eyes to Emilio once more, he was laughing a bit.

It wasn't an unpleasant smile. It was one of true delight.

"... I intended to let them out regardless. But while we're at it, might as well get their help."

"In the end, what do you want to do? Saying you don't care, then helping these three."

Aleist tried weighing out Emilio.

"It's probably true that he wants to save that princess called Cleo. And they do call him boss."

Emilio was Cleo's real brother.

Meaning he was a prince of this country.

But his father Barquah devised a plan to send his own country to ruin.

The ringleader behind the princess' attack was the king.

(This is way too complicated. Shouldn't it be a bit more... aaarrggh!!)

Dismayed, Aleist watched the form of Emilio issue orders to the three.

By Emilio's plan, they would carefully cause explosions and fires across the palace and town to evacuate its residents.

By Barquah's plan, the king would crush all home, and as the people were panicking left and right, he would use the ancient weapon to destroy the castle town.

But normally, it would be strange for the influential people of the country to go along with such a plan.

(A war against an ancient weapon... that event was never in the game.)

Even if he knew this world wasn't a game, he would still find himself taking these things as events.

Aleist shook his head to the side to change his train of thought.

(I have to stop them. The King of Celestia's plan, and the ancient weapon.)

For that sake, Nate had set up contraptions across town.

Mechanisms to produce smoke, to raise ruckuses around and direct people towards evacuation.

"Alright, here are your orders. If any explosions break out at the castle, you're to rouse all the folks in the barracks and have them help evacuate the residents. Here's the official decree."

Emilio took out the document he had brought and handed it over to the leader Ben.

Accepting it, Ben took a nervous look over it.

"C-captain, is it really alright for me to hold something like this?"

As the unshaven man trembled, Emilio dropped the bomb.

"Don't worry... it's fake."

"Fake!!?"

On Pono's surprise, Emilio cautioned him to keep quiet.

"We've made arrangement for smoke to rise all over the place. You are to prioritize evacuating the citizenry, and once that's done, your job is to protect them. It's a vital role... you can do it, right?"

There was no doubt it was an important job.

Hearing that, the three nodded with serious expressions. Emilio gave a warm smile, handing over their equipment he had brought along.

"When you're done changing, keep a low profile until you hear the explosions. You need only take advantage of the confusion to move as planned. Make sure you properly carry out your orders."

"Leave it to us, captain!"

"We're finally starting to look like a unit!"

"And the captain is actually relying on us!"

Once the three started changing, Aleist checked over the scheduled time with Nate.

"It should be happening soon, right?"

"Yes. Right about..."

At that instant.

The sound of an explosion rung through the castle walls. Hearing that, everyone's expression turned to surprise.

"What is the meaning of this!?"

As Emilio drew close to Nate, the party-of-three looked around nervously. Aleist was the same, but he calmly looked at Nate.

"The scale of that explosion was strange... it's not the one I set."

Hearing that, Aleist did hit on something.

(... The ones specialized for this sort of thing, if I recall correctly...)



Izumi exchanged slashes with a black-robed assembly in a palace corridor.

Her drawn katana cut at the mechanical soldiers before her eyes.

On her horizontal swipe, her foe leapt back to take distance. But seeing the cracks spread down his arm he had guarded, the machine man's wariness instantly spiked.

Behind Izumi, there were knights and soldiers of Celestia as well.

"... Judging by the uniform, you're a High Knight of Courtois."

The mechanical soldiers lowered their hips and came at her at once in a coordinated assault.

"Kuh!"

Izumi sent out shockwaves, but perhaps she was dealing with elites, as even if she managed a cut, they avoided anything fatal. As she drew her sword back in, she cut the enemy fast-approaching before her eyes.

But the sensation she got wasn't that of human flesh.

"So these are the mechanized men Rudel was talking about."

Izumi looked around to see a number of Celestian soldiers and knights were on the ground. In that space, a number of enemies had slipped through.

But Izumi didn't move.

Because in order to confine her, a few enemies had remained.

"H-High Knight! Just what could-"

A Celestian knight asked in dismay, but all Izumi knew was the fact her opponents were soldiers of Gaia.

"We are dealing with a unit from the Gaia Empire. Be careful... they're elites."

As Izumi took a stance, her foe did the same.

Of course, the enemy's main objective was to buy time. They wouldn't force themselves to go on the offense.

On top of the presence of enemy and ally forces around her, the narrow corridor made it difficult for Izumi to move around.

(How shameful... to think I would be this useless in a real battle.)

Deeply vexed, Izumi stepped in and cut.

Her opponent leapt back and used a projectile.

While she hit it aside with her blade, another enemy used a similar means to attack the Celestian knights.

The concealed arrow pierced in, and yet another knight was down.

"Don't force yourselves to go up front!"

"W-when a woman is taking a lead, you think the knights can stand down!?"

Even on Izumi's warning, the knights didn't step back. But a majority of them were only equipped with their swords.

They were attacked in their sleep, a majority of them were forced to leap out without any decent equipment.

(Our defense is too fragile. Why is it so... we were already attacked once, shouldn't we be on high alert?)

On the unsightliness of Celestia's correspondence, Izumi couldn't help but feel something contrived.

◇

On a balcony overlooking the mountain the ancient weapon was sealed, Barquah listened to the surrounding turmoil alone.

Riding the wind, a burnt stench reached him.

"We've got some boorish visitors among us. What say you... Emilio."

To where he turned, three robed figures stood.

It was Emilio, Aleist and Nate.

"Boorish? Is this not precisely the sort of chaos you wished for?"

Emilio glared at Barquah. While the king received a glance imbued with such hatred, upon seeing it, he burst into laughter.

"What a comforting glance indeed! That hatred of yours, it gives me the purest confirmation my revenge has succeeded."

Seeing Barquah laugh, Aleist took a step forward and took a stance.

"What are you talking about... doing something like this for petty revenge, are you crazy!?"

Hearing Aleist's words, Barquah scoffed.

"I don't know who you might be, but you sound quite eager to stick your mouth into another's household affairs."

"H-household affairs? When you're making a mess of your country, you call it household affairs?"

Aleist drew his sword, and Nate took out her weapons as well.

Emilio slowly pulled his saber.

"The country is of no importance to me. This is simple revenge. My wife died in the place of the woman who birthed that good-for-nothing! And after fleeing her own duty, the woman who abandoned her own sister to die, dropped dead in some ditch! Because of that, my wife was..."

Aleist's failure to understand set him bewildered.

Having noticed that, Barquah knew it was the end, so he began talking from his heart.

"Twin sisters of the clan were sent to me. I was to marry one of them and bring up children with both. It is the job of the royal house. That's all my

marriage would be... so I thought."

The hilt of the saber Emilio gripped let off a grating sound.

"... You abandoned my and Cleo's mother, dammit!"

While he heard it, Barquah thought nothing of it as he continued his explanation.

"Yes, but the one I loved was the other. My conversations with her, can you imagine the solace they offered me... I fell so deeply in love I didn't know what to do with myself."

Barquah looked at the view of the castle town he could see from the balcony.

And at that blazing scene, he directed a smile.

"How truly wonderful. The sight of the people who raised an uproar for me to offer my wife in the place of the woman who ran away, the sight of them falling to hell truly clears the heart."

"T-this man... is mad."

On Aleist's words, Barquah turned and glared at the three.

"That's right! This country maddened me! The system of this country is what's cornered me to such an extent."

With a step forward in her mask, Nate asked Barquah.

"Did you need to go so far to get your revenge? Then shouldn't there have been a much more efficient way to go about it?"

Barquah let a low-brow smile cross his face.

"I thought I would have that woman's son and daughter see hell as they lived on. It was the greatest farce! The faithful, foolish daughter who lived

to carry out her duty. Driven out of the palace, the foolish son living a filthy life in the slums! It truly was a comforting scene to watch!"

Having lived solely for revenge, it seemed not a fragment of his feelings as a father remained.

Seeing that, Emilio grit his teeth.

"So you knew everything?"

Barquah answered his question with a refreshing smile.

"That's right. I watched in pleasure as you crawled your way up. Knowing you would start something, at the end of the end, your hopes would spill from your hands... that was the instant I wanted to see. Of course, Cleo's miserable state was also a sight to behold. She resembled that woman so closely, I hated and hated her more than I could bear."

The root of this malice... this series of events, Barquah had been pulling the strings of them all.

Once they figured out that was the case, Emilio and Aleist's expressions dyed in hatred.

Barquah's smile took a turn for the supreme.

"That's right... hate me. My hatred is far greater than that!"

Aleist spoke to him.

"You're crazy... do you hate everything around you so badly!?"

Barquah spread his arms out, turning to the three as he spoke.

"... The sacrifice of a loved one that doesn't drive one to madness isn't true love at all, my boy."

The next instant.

The mountain that could be seen at the end of the balcony erupted.

It was an explosion that even shook the castle, but in contrast to its scale, the magma that rose from it was scarce. Seeing that, Aleist noticed something was off.

"W-what's this!?"

In the dark night sky, a number of red light rose from the castle town.

With the volcano's eruption, magma had begun to spout.

From within it, it looked as if a giant something was trying to crawl its way out of the mountain.

"So why don't we change the schedule? It would be boring to leave this country's final act to that boorish lot. Don't you think finishing it by my hand would be a happier ending?"

As Barquah said that, the giant something's single eye gleamed as it began making its way towards them.

Nate cried out.

"It can't be, it's really moving!"

Emilio quietly walked up and raised his saber. Seeing that, Barquah laughed.

"It's a pity I won't see this country's end, but I'll be heading to the side of my beloved. I've kept her waiting quite a long while... I love you, —"

His body was cut through, his blood fluttered through the air. As he leisurely gazed over that scene, he collided with the handrail, and his body took a fall.

An upside-down Barquah watched over the castle town wrapped in fire as he fell.

"Now here is where hell begins."

The moment he fell. And even after he collided, Barquah's face was smiling.



Led off by Millia, Cleo ran down the corridor jumbled with enemy and ally.

Assailed by an intense tremor along the way, they headed outside through a shattered windowpane.

The scenery that awaited them was certainly hell.

"It can't be... the castle town is..."

"This is terrible."

Cleo touched both hands to her mouth, shaking.

Millia looked at the scenery and muttered.

The flames blazed up as a giant something set course towards them.

As the morning sun slowly rose from beyond the mountain, its form gradually grew vivid.

"I-it's that thing we saw at the souvenir shop."

As Millia said that, Cleo crouched on the spot.

There, a group of a few appeared before her.

"We've finally found you. I never thought the ancient weapon would start up... but that body of yours is to become research material for the empire. We will make you useful, Princess Cleo."

A man whose three red eyes let off an ominous light...

The captain of the mechanized unit held a sword in each hand.

Millia came out front and poised her bow, but the man's movements were different from what she saw in the alley.

"Wha!"

Instantly circling around, those three red eyes became tails of red light. Looking where he ended up, he had circled around to Millia's right side.

His remaining subordinates came at Millia.

"It doesn't matter if you kill the guard. For the princess as well, an arm or a leg is—"

The three-eyed man said as he lifted his sword, only for Rudel to arrive at the scene.

As magic in the shape of blades of light pierced into the floor, the men jumped back at once.

"You're late, Rudel!"

Landing then and there, Rudel pulled his sword and readied the shield of his left hand.

Wearing his white armor, Rudel spoke to Millia.

"I'm sorry. I ran into some troublesome ones along the way."

As he said that, Rudel used his shield to bash aside the mechanized soldier coming at him.

Glowing shields manifested around, floating and gathering around Cleo.

"Eh, this is..."

As Cleo remained unable to comprehend the surrounding situation, once more, an ally appeared on the spot.

As a black shadow was cast onto the ground, three figures emerged from it.

"I-it's Rudel after all... and wait, carrying two people in that thing is harsh..."

Aleist tossed his robe aside. He was wearing armor under it.

"We were right to load it into Sakuya-chan's bags. Right, senpai?"

Nate handed over his helmet and Aleist pulled it down on his head.

"So you guys came too. By the way... I feel like I recognize your companion."

As Rudel said that, Emilio looked at Cleo.

"Cleo!"

"E-Emilio..."

Cleo began taking distance from him.

Chapter 142

Rudel wore his white armor over his body, Aleist was clad in his black.

The white and black knights stood side by side in the Celestia Castle courtyard.

Fires were rising across the castle town and the townsfolk had begun their evacuation.

Izumi darted out for more freedom in combat and looked around.

"And now I'm surrounded."

The mechanized unit of the Gaia Empire.

An elite unit thrown into dark, backroom missions, it was made up of those whose bodies were mainly mechanical.

The three red eyed man who commanded that elite force held a barbed sword in each hand.

A tail protruded from his robe. Freely moving it around, he looked amused as he looked their way.

Across his visor, Rudel spoke to Izumi.

"Aleist and I will handle this. Izumi, Millia, go protect the princess. You two, Na... masked woman I do not know."

Both Rudel and Aleist lowered their hips and readied their weapons.

Those around kept wary of their every move.

As Izumi remained wary of Emilio, Nate in her mask explained.

"It's alright. Please think of him as an ally. As long as it comes to protecting Cleo-san, he is our comrade in arms."

Aleist also spoke to Rudel.

"That's how it is, so while I'm sure you've got a lot going on, for now we have to work together... there are too many enemies."

Around then, the enemy mechanized unit continued to shuffle and gather.

Why were so many able to slip in?

As he thought that, Rudel—

"How long has it been since we fought together?"

"Not since we met Sakuya? I get the feeling it's been a real long time... I only really remember getting into slugfests with you."

As the two of them started an out-of-place conversation, a number of the mechanized unit came at them.

The one who called them to a stop was the three-eyed man.

"Stand down!"

Rudel had smacked one to the side with his shield, while Aleist had used the long-hilted swords he held in both hands to stop the attack of another.

And once the enemy Aleist pinned down was cut down by Rudel, Aleist's hands were free, and his unoccupied left-hand sword pierced into another foe.

A reddish black oil spouted as the two enemy soldiers were flung away.

The enemy soldier Rudel had bashed didn't move after he collided with a wall.

Rudel spoke.

"Head to where Sakuya is. If she moves, the castle will crumble."

The reason Sakuya hadn't come to their aid was because the castle interior was still a jumble of enemy and ally. If she made any wrong moves, she would end up injuring allies.

But if they could make it to Sakuya, they'd be safe.

"Her clumsiness is inconvenient at times like this."

And Rudel,

"But that's what makes her so cute"

The three-eyed man issued orders to his men.

"Cut at them with the resolve to become sacrifices for the cause. The white and black knight... take their heads, and glory shall follow for eternity! It will be a severe loss to Courtois!"

As the surrounding soldiers made for Rudel, Izumi took Cleo's hand and ran off.

"You two better survive!"

As the two of them raced off towards the enemy, whether Izumi's voice even reached or not...

Millia ran watching their back, while Nate and Emilio took the vanguard.



Under his helmet, Rudel moved his eyes.

As he fell back to avoid the spear thrust from his right of a mechanized soldier, he turned and beat them down with his left-hand shield.

For the enemies that tried cutting at his now-empty back, a number of black stakes protruded from his shadow to skewer them.

Aleist was using both his hands to parry foes, and a number of enemies rushed at his back as well.

Concentrating to produce shields, the leaping soldiers collided with them and fell to the ground.

Rudel turned to the enemies coming at them one after the next, muttering under his helmet.

"This is a pain."

Using his sword to sweep back surrounding foe, he moved to stand back to back with Aleist.

Because of the enemies scattering reddish-black liquid around, the smell of oil was much harsher than that of blood.

Aleist, his breath a little disturbed,

"There are too many of them. Rather..."

"Right."

The oil spreading across the ground restrained their use of magic.

Looking around, the three-eyed man was nowhere to be found.

Aleist sighed.

"Give it some time, and this place will blow sky high."

"I don't think it's something to laugh at, but that's something I'd rather avoid."

Would the oil on the ground ignite?

That was their worry.

This was especially troublesome with Rudel's high magic output. If the blaze spread, they would instantly find themselves fighting through a sea of flames.

"This is getting harsh, but... three-eyes is gone."

As Aleist cut down the foe coming at him, he spoke to Rudel.

"Who's going to go?"

Hearing Aleist's serious voice, Rudel thought just a bit.

(They're no weaklings, but if Aleist is wary of the man... will it be difficult for Izumi and the others?)

Rudel highly evaluated Izumi's abilities.

But he couldn't ignore Aleist's decision.

"Got it. I'll handle this place. I'm good at drawing attention."

In his white armor, Rudel was extremely conspicuous at night.

"But it'll be troublesome to break out of this encirclement. That Celestian King definitely had a hand in this. To the very end, he's the worst."

A large number of enemy soldiers still remained around.

(Good grief, where are they coming from? That aside, it sounds like Aleist knows something, but for now...)

In order to let Aleist slip out, Rudel performed a grand cut at the enemy.

"Once you reach Sakuya, flee into the sky. They won't be able to follow you there... go!"

The two who ran off in different directions.

Rudel accelerated, cutting down one enemy soldier after the next. Perhaps they didn't feel pain, as the enemy came at them without fear.

(They really are troublesome foes!)

As he accelerated with wind dragon, the oil scattered and stuck to everything around.

Nearby, as if to observe him, Rudel spotted a single soldier on the wall.

(Is it about time they used it?)

As he thought that, the soldier took out something like a pipe and made a motion of igniting it. Once the pipe-like item breathed fire, he tossed it straight at Rudel.



While Izumi's group ran down the palace corridor, they found the three-eyed man waiting for them.

Running to the front, Emilio glared at the man.

"That was the shortest possible route. Why are you here!"

The laughing three-eyed man opened his robe a bit to show off his legs. There were small wheels attached, alongside ominous spokes.

"Even if I take a detour, as long as I'm faster, it is possible to catch up. What's more, your side is moving while guarding our precious test subject."

Emilio took a stance with his saber, Nate readied her knife.

Millia fired an arrow into the three-eyed man's shoulder.

"No way..."

She reeled back.

The man let out a mechanical laugh, pulling out the arrow and crushing it in his hand as he spoke.

"I'm sure it will be meaningless before the white and black knights, but a majority of this body is a mass of iron. An arrow with just a bit of magic put in is pointless. Now won't you hand over our test subject?"

Cleo was necessary to manipulate the ancient weapon, the three-eyed man recognized that.

Izumi called out to the two up front, letting go of Cleo's hand to grip her hilt and take an iai stance.

"Dodge to the side!"

Nate swiftly reacted, Emilio opened the passage a little late. And as Izumi drew her katana, a shockwave broke out, and the three-eyed man—

Izumi's eyes instantly turned to the ceiling.

Like a reptile, the man stuck both arms and legs to the ceiling surface, immediately extending his tail to attack her.

While Izumi hit the attack aside with her scabbard, the tail went right on to wrap around Cleo.

"N-nooo!!"

As it lifted up a screaming Cleo, the tail was cut through by Emilio's saber.

Millia embraced the falling girl, while Izumi hammered another slash into the three-eyed man.

When he landed right in the center of the group, Nate took a swipe at him, but he locked her down with a sword.

"You Courtois dogs... would do best just to cower in the shadows of your dragons!"

The man discarded his tail, only for another tail to shoot out of his robe.

Not to capture Cleo, this was a blow filled with killing intent.

"If the subject is to be taken by Courtois, then I'd rather!"

The three-eyed man said with a laugh, and Cleo was unable to move from surprise. Millia tried to yank her aside.

Izumi tried to cut at the tail, but...

(I won't make it in time!)

There, Emilio leapt out in front of the tail and cut it down with his saber. The sword broke in two, and the tail's pointed end stabbed deeply into his body.

"Emilio... why?"

Cleo was still immobile; the three-eyed man tried to retreat back.

"Blasted traitor!"

But Nate tripped him up, and as he collapsed onto the ground, she immediately thrust her knife right into the vicinity of his neck.

That attack she had carefully aimed at the armoring's joint stuck deeply into his throat.

Showered in a reddish black oil, Nate spoke.

"... This really is the worst."

After delivering the finishing blow, she stood and raced over to Emilio.

Izumi was taken aback, but she immediately poised herself to guard them.

The collapsed Emilio gripped Cleo's hand. And then and there, Emilio decided he would convey his message to Cleo.

"Emilio... I am set to die shortly. Why would you..."

Perhaps with too much to say, Cleo's words couldn't come out. Spitting blood from his mouth, Emilio smiled a bit.

And he opened his mouth.

Millia stopped him.

"Don't speak! We have to start your treatment at..."

There, Nate held Millia back and shook her head.

"This is the end of the line. Please give them some time to speak."

Emilio offered Nate his gratitude.

"T-thank you. Cleo..."

"Yes."

"I'm... I'm your real brother. Mother took me when she left the castle."

Perhaps listening with conflicting emotions, Cleo's gaze shifted. But Emilio continued on.

"Life was filled with troubles. But I had mother with me and it was fun. I heard I had a little sister..."

Emilio took a silver, egg-shaped necklace from his clothe pocked and entrusted it to Cleo. On it, the insignia of the royal house was engraved.

"This is..."

"You have a gold pendant, don't you? That one belonged to our aunt... can you hand this one to Aleist... the black knight as his payment? You don't need two exchange stones, do you?"

Exchange stone... a force that moved the ancient weapon, and by paying a price, a stone that could grant a proportional reward.

Of course, Emilio didn't seem to understand what basis it worked on.

"U-umm..."

After spitting up blood, Emilio's breathing grew rough as he spoke.

"There are loads I wanted to tell you. But there's no time. Our mother loved you, and aunty did too. That man... when father told mother she was going to die, he was considerably troubled. We wanted to take you when we ran, but... hac!"

Before Emilio's bloodened mouth, Cleo shed tears.

"Emilio... my brother."

Called brother, Emilio made a delighted face.

"Thanks for that. Now I can make a proper report to mother. No, I guess I'm off to hell, so that's not happening."

Smiling, Emilio placed a hand on Cleo's face.

"Cleo... mother and me, we both love you. When you were announced as the next sacrifice, mother was crying. She could no longer move her disease-weakened body, but she said time and again she wanted to meet you... she wanted to apologize. So I'll say it. I'm sorry. Please forgive her."

Without letting out a voice, Cleo nodded. She nodded and nodded, and Emilio spoke up.

"... Thank god. Leave the rest to Aleist..."

Emilio's body ceased with those words, Cleo hung over him and shed tears.

Izumi readied her katana.

"Who is it!?"

The one who ran over was Aleist in his black knight armor.

He looked at the collapsed Emilio. He took off his helmet and raced over to the body.

"W-why! What happened!?"

The one who spoke coldly to a fidgety Aleist was Nate.

"We don't have any time. Senpai, where's Rudel-senpai?"

"He's buying time! We have to get that man to a doctor!"

"It's too late for that. It's already over... now, let's go. There's no telling when an enemy will come."

Nate took Cleo's hand.

Cleo...

"Why... if I just died, it would all have worked out."

When she said that, Aleist struck her with his left hand. Collapsing onto the floor, Cleo gazed up at Aleist in wonder.

"That man! Emilio wanted to save you! He continued to fight all on his own! And over his corpse, over all his effort... don't say you want to die."

To a teary Aleist, Nate spoke.

"Senpai. If you don't want to waste Emilio-san's will, for now,"

"I know!"

Aleist wiped his tears as he walked off, Cleo gazed at his back.

Izumi extended a hand to Cleo. Millia as well.

"... I don't know what I should say at a time like this. But if we keep dawdling here, it surely won't make Emilio-dono happy."

"Now let's go."

Taking both their hands to stand, Cleo walked, turning back a few times to look at Emilio's smile.

Chapter 143

Arriving at Sakuya, Izumi boarded her back.

Around were the fragments of earthen dolls, and flattened soldiers of the mechanized unit.

Once everyone had gotten on her back, Sakuya took to the sky.

'What are we supposed to do after we're in the air?'

To the voice, Izumi.

"Head towards Rudel. But I recommend against helping it out..."

Where Sakuya was had become a mountain of rubble. Each minuscule move of the dragon would destroy surrounding buildings, and if she rampaged for real, Celestia Castle would quickly be leveled to the ground.

Izumi thought.

(So not even a dragon could beat the ancient weapon?)

Brushing aside her hair disheveled by the wind, Izumi looked at the castle down from Sakuya's rising back.

A blazing smoke rose from a number of places.

The black of night was lit with an ominous light, as the giant quadrupedal ancient weapon slowly crashed into Celestia's defensive wall.

And...

"The hell's that..."

As Aleist leaned his body in, the ancient weapon's single eye spouted fire, melting down the surrounding walls and buildings.

Its whole body illuminated by the inferno it spewed, it really did look just like the ornaments sold at the souvenir shops.

Unlike those easy-to-break articles, however, the ancient weapon showed no sign of stopping as it made straight for the palace.

Its movements were dull, the evacuating citizenry made fled in the opposite direction of the weapon.

Seeing the sights from the air, Cleo,

"... Please take me to the guardian deity."

As she said that with a serious face, Millia returned fire.

"Why!? If you go to a place like that, your life—"

"Even so! If you can't get too close, then just as close as you can! This is an order from a princess of Celestia! ... I can't cause any further trouble."

To Cleo who leaked a sob with those words, Aleist spoke.

"You're saying it again... don't you think you're besmirching Emilio!?"

"I'm fully aware I am! But it cannot be helped. This is all I'm capable of. I was born and raised for this sake. Telling me to live a different life at this point... take me to that guardian deity this instant!"

With a face of pure earnesty, she shed tears as she spoke.

There, not from the direction of Sakuya's flight, a different gust blew through.

Rudel skillfully landed on Sakuya's back, removing his helmet to speak.

"Unfortunately, the orders I received were to 'Guard you to the ceremonial alter' tomorrow morning. I cannot follow your orders."

'Ah, Rudel.'

"Rudel, glad you're alright."

Sakuya rejoiced, Izumi was relieved. Izumi looked at the ancient weapon from Sakuya's back.

Cleo spoke.

"It's an order. I beg of you."

"I refuse. I'm a knight of Courtois, after all. Oh, right, perhaps I should say this? I'm a member of the Dragoons, the strongest knights of Courtois. It's an insult for the world to think we remained on a losing streak with this weapon forever. I shall be settling the score."

Rudel looked at the ancient weapon and laughed.

Izumi touched her right hand to her face as she spoke.

"Rudel, show some prudence."

"My apologies. But as long as we defeat that thing, it will all be over. My mission was, from start to finish, to safely deliver Cleo; I was never told not to obliterate any guardian deities or ancient weapons or whatever it is."

Millia was amazed.

"They never said it! Sure enough, they never said it, but...!!"

Nate looked at Rudel and shook her head to the side.

"You haven't changed from your student days, I see. For better or worse, that is."

Aleist was looking at the earth.

"... The small ancient weapons are moving around. I'll deal with those."

As Aleist showed some motivation, Rudel smiled. The black knight's face turned a little sorrowful.

"Rudel, I was Emilio's friend... perhaps not, but I'm sad that he died. While I'm not going out for revenge, I could at least put in some effort 'til it's over."

Understanding from the fact the man wasn't there, Rudel kept it short.

"I see,"

He muttered. And he put down his helmet and turned to Aleist.

"I'll stop that ancient weapon with Sakuya. I'll try to lead the fight outside as much as possible, but there will be collateral damage. Can you take care of evacuation too?"

Aleist, likewise.

"Of course."

Seeing the two of them meet fists, Cleo spoke.

"Why go so far... if only I become a sacrifice, no one has to be hurt."

To that opinion, Izumi.

"It's alright."

"Eh?"

"Rudel's all over the place, but he's a man who's true to his word. Up to now, and from here on... that's the sort of man he is."

Millia grumbled as she added on.

"I'll be on the ground too. Aleist, you'd better give some decent orders."

Aleist, a little nervous.

"L-leave it thoo me!"

He fumbled his words.

Nate uninterestedly muttered.

"Millia-senpai again? Just so you know, everyone's going to hear about this when we get back. Well, it's partly to protect myself, but... sharing information is the ironclad rule of the harem."

Izumi thought.

(He's got it rough, that Aleist.)

Rudel addressed Sakuya.

"Sakuya, land in an adequate place. After that... we're going to be settling the score with that weapon."

He sounded like he was having fun.

(If he didn't have that side to him... if he was just a little settled...)

Izumi grumbled in mild delight.

Cleo stared at the dragoon attempting to challenge the impossible.

◇

After landing on the ground and separating with Aleist's group, Sakuya immediately took to the sky once more.

As the surroundings received a downward gust strong enough to put out the flames, Aleist looked around.

"I'll have Millia relay orders from a high point. Izumi-san will be fighting, so... Nate, you guard the princess."

Nate breathed out a sigh.

"Well, with these members, that sounds about right. Now let's be off."

Cleo handed over the silver pendant to Aleist.

"Oh? And this is?"

"From Emilio to you. Perhaps Emilio thought of you as a friend as well."

"I see... so I've lost a friend."

As Aleist let out a sorrowful voice, Cleo spoke.

"No, Emilio... my brother was happy. I wasn't able to do anything so you have my gratitude as well. It was made from an ore called an exchange stone. I heard something similar was used in the ancient weapon's core."

The hand Aleist used to grip the pendant shook.

(So it's something that dangerous?)

Cleo told him about the stone.

"As the name implies, you can exchange something for a wish. A small price for a small wish, a large one for large... though you're better off not using something like that."

At Cleo's powerless laugh, Aleist tucked the pendant away in his breast pocket.

"... I graciously accept it."

"Thank you."

Nate led Cleo off by the hand and evacuated her from the site.

Aleist drew a sword.

Nearby, dolls just like the ancient weapon, albeit smaller, were beginning to gather.

Izumi took her stance, offering Aleist some advice.

"Cutting them is pointless. Unless you smash them to pieces, they just regenerate."

"Smash... huh."

Aleist protruded a spear from his shadow, reshaping the tip into something like a hammer as he shattered one of them to bits.

"—That's neat."

Despite Izumi's surprise, Aleist let out a sigh.

"If I couldn't do this much, I'd be left in the dust. Now let's go."

Racing off, Aleist and Izumi went around smashing ancient weapons.



High in the sky, Rudel challenged the ancient weapon to battle with Sakuya by his side.

'Jeeerrrk!!'

As Sakuya delivered a punch up front, its surface easily split.

But its insides weren't empty...

'Hooottt!!'

Sakuya instantly drew back her hand, a gush of boiling magma accompanying it.

By the regeneration of its surface armor, the weapon's contents quickly came out of sight.

Rudel.

"What do you think you're doing to my Sakuya!?"

Producing a large shield, he projected it in front of the single eye that had begun to gather light as they spoke.

Just as the shield appeared, a blaze streamed out, lighting everything around in a red.

Sakuya's hand wasn't badly injured.

A dragon that could get off just by complaining magma was hot was fearsome. But if they smacked their foe away here, magma would scatter about their surroundings.

(If we keep blowing it away until it runs out of innards, will it stop moving? No, if that's how it works, then surely the dragoons wouldn't have retreated...)

To Sakuya who was rubbing her right hand with her left, Rudel spoke.

"Sakuya, take to the sky."

'I hate this thing!'

Sakuya voiced her complaints in a child's voice as she rose into the sky.

Thinking it would be troublesome if they applied too much damage, Rudel considered his options.

(If we block off the roads, destroy the surface and control the flow of the magma...)

After he had thought that far through, the movements of the weapon turned strange.

"What is it now?"

'That thing, something's.'

Before Sakuya could say something was squirming inside it, the ancient weapon's surface began to crack.

Spouting magma, the armoring crumbled away bit by bit.

"What's this supposed to mean? Is it broken?"

'No, here it comes.'

As Sakuya rose, the fire from the weapon's split, round torso jetted out in her direction. Not by coincidence, they could feel an intent to attack.

"Kuh! Sakuya, Right!"

Sakuya veered right, but the flames gave chase.

"What is this?"

Just as before, Rudel manifested a large shield. But as the flames collided, the shield broke, and from within the flames, a mass of squirming magma showed itself.

The magma continued to burn a dark red as it took form.

A humanoid shape sprouting wings from its back, it took on quite a sinister shape.

"... Doesn't look like a guardian deity to me."

'Not at all.'

Moving its large one eye, opening its mouth, the monster that emerged from the ancient dragon flew straight at Sakuya.

Rudel amassed a few hundred swords of light and shot them at the enemy.

Those small swords exploded as they stuck into the massive foe in quick succession, but only scattering magma, they didn't seem to be very effective.

"So we should try destroying it all at once with massive firepower... but it's surprisingly fast."

As the monster chasing Sakuya opened its mouth, it fired a number of fireballs from it. Those attacks that followed closely as if each shot held its own will, Rudel crushed them by preparing shields. Looking down, they were distancing themselves from Celestia's castle town.

"Now then, if we want to fight seriously, we'll need to go a little further away."

Searching for an adequate site for battle as he fled, Rudel turned to the beast letting out an uncanny roar.

"Don't be so impatient. We'll properly eliminate you."

For some reason, he found himself saying.

Rudel found it a little perplexing why he said it himself.

'Rudel?'

"No, it just felt as if it was crying out to be eliminated. Sakuya, are you up for it?"

'Yeah!'

Sakuya seemed happy she was being relied on, and Rudel sent a warm smile.

Turning to look at the monster, it was once again about to fire attacks at them.

A mass of fire larger than any before it, it looked almost as if a large boulder had been clad in flames.

"... That one won't end well."

As he said that, Rudel held up his right hand.

Manifesting a large spear of light, he pierced through the boulder before it could be fired, raising a large explosion.

Magma scattered, falling onto the ground.

The monster's upper body had been blown away, but magma quickly welled up from its lower half, regenerating it in the blink of an eye.

'Uwah'

Sakuya reeled back.

"And ancient weapon... it seems we've met a worthy foe!"

While Rudel seemed delighted.

But be that as it may, he also thought over it with a level head.

(Now then, to prepare a large attack, we'll need some distance and time, but that one doesn't look like it'll let us get away. If we close in, Sakuya will...)

Observing the enemy chasing them, Rudel simulated how he would fight with the beast.

Even if Sakuya might be able to blow it away in one attack, if the attack was directed thoughtlessly, some village or town may face casualty.

It would have to be something big enough to change the area's geography.

And considerable time would be needed to store enough power.

They could close in and beating it down until there was nothing left, but the heat was harsh on Sakuya.

"How troublesome. I'm starting to see why my seniors called it a draw. But if we win here..."

'Will Sakuya be praised?'

To the young child desperate for praise, Rudel nodded.

"You'll undoubtedly be praised. Mystith-sama will be delighted!"

'I'll do my best!'

After saying that much, Rudel thought.

"Sakuya, can you produce water?"

'No!'

"As I thought. I doubt I can make enough to stop that one."

Rudel thought about using water to lower the magma's heat and harden it.

But there was no meaning in small amounts.

(I'm sure a water dragon would have an affinitive advantage.)

Thinking he could never say that in front of Sakuya, Rudel reached that conclusion.

Chapter 144

Magma taken on the shape of man, a winged monster gave chase through the dark sky.

Receiving winds so strong the magic barrier couldn't suppress them, Rudel looked behind him.

"Sakuya, it's about time. Begin ascent!"

Rudel's plan was simple.

If the enemy was a monster of magma, he concluded they simply had to fight where there was water.

He led the monster along the night sky to distance it far from Celestia.

Sakuya's four wings swayed grandly.

She rose as large fireballs passed right beneath her.

As the monster closed its large mouth, Rudel looked at his foe's large single large eye.

Under the eyelid as if the eye itself had been divided vertically, what looked to be an eye of flesh... it bore the eye of a lifeform.

Even when its body was made of magma, he questioned why it didn't burn.

'That thing's persistent!'

Sakuya complained at the enemy chasing her.

Rudel observed it with a serious face.

(If we want to take it out in a single blow, our best bet's to get into close combat and drop it into the ocean. How do we hit it down... explosions just blow away parts of its body, the rest isn't affected.)

Looking at the monster of magma, Rudel thought over how he might manage close combat.

Even with Sakuya's fists, their enemy was magma.

Her hands would stick into the monster's body, and Sakuya would be scalded.

But to get off with such little damage, dragons really were amazing after all.

Sakuya entered a cloud.

As his vision grew worse all at once, Rudel issued orders to Sakuya.

"Sakuya, break through the clouds!"

'Yeah.'

Sakuya shot straight up through the clouds.

But there, the monster was waiting for them.

'I hate this thiiiiing!!'

On Sakuya's directional change, Rudel leaned over and gripped the handrail off so as not to be thrown off.

As the scenery around him changed at a dazzling pace, he took a deep breath and closed his eyes.

"Just for a little while. Sakuya, take the wheel... head towards the ocean."

'On my own!?'

Hearing that voice on the brink of tears, Rudel opened his eyes and stomachached his urge to throw out that idea.

Rudel's eyes were magic eyes.

As he closed his eyes, they gradually began to emit heat.

By flowing magic into them, he could imbue them with various effects.

While Sakuya hurried to flee, Rudel waited for his preparations to be readied.

A sudden rise, a sudden turn.

It was hell clinging on to not be thrown off.

(I should've used the belt.)

Repenting on his actions before he closed his eyes, he finished up preparations and opened them.

A red light dwelled in the pupils as he gazed at the monster.

"Kuh!"

Narrowing his eyes, he tried scanning the magma for the monster's true form.

"What's this... hundreds, thousands of people are crying out?"

Hundreds of human souls squirmed and struggled, imprisoned.

Captured by a stone in the monster's chest, they struggled within the magma.

(Are those the sacrifices? And who's that in the center of the stone?)

That soul in the shape of a woman looked at Rudel from within the stone.

His magic eyes focused and showed her form in vivid detail...

"She looks like Cleo... no, I guess it's the opposite."

He recalled the painting in the king's room.

He remembered the painting with an unnatural space left in it. And the painting of the queen as well.

"The previous sacrifice was the queen, was it? Which means."

All the captured, squirming souls were related to the royal house.

A prison of spirit even death couldn't escape.

The monster was a kind of cage.

Rudel took a deep breath.

"... Sakuya, can you see that?"

'If Rudel can see it, then Sakuya can see it too. We're connected.'

To a proud Sakuya, Rudel,

"I see. Then you know what I want to say. Alongside the mission... we'll be destroying that thing."

Rudel touched Sakuya's body with both his palms.

Feeling out Sakuya's beat, he used his own magic to control it.

He still wasn't accustomed to it, it felt all too unnatural, but this was no time for hesitation.

Glaring at the monster, Rudel...

"I'll free you now."

As he put that to mouth, a golden insignia surfaced over Sakuya's body.

Rudel used his own magic to manipulate the mana flowing through her body. Under her four wings, a new gold-glowing smaller pair manifested.

A number of sharp sword blades protruded out of the now six-winged Sakuya's tail.

As if covered in golden gauntlets, masses of energy manifested around her fists.

'I'll show you serious Sakuyaaa!!'

To intercept the monster, Sakuya held her position in the air.

Readying her two large fists, she took on a fighting pose.

As the monster opened its large mouth to produce fireballs, Sakuya opened her mouth as well. She usually gathered stones or fired breath attacks from it, but this one was different.

A number of water orbs formed around her mouth, before shooting right off towards the monster.

The fireballs the monster shot were taken down by water one after the next.

As water and magma collided, a water vapor broke out, rendering everything out of sight.

"It won't go down the same as before."

After saying that, Rudel called out to Sakuya.

"Go!"

'Yeah!'

While she had been running away to that point, Sakuya started straight towards the monster.

Rudel's magic eyes captured its sinister form.

Sharing Rudel's vision, Sakuya slammed her fist into the beast.

The water hit first, and she aimed her attack into the portion that had hardened. The black lump on its surface shattered from the force, but the golden gauntlets had managed to capture the monster without piercing through.

Hurdling back, the monster regained its posture, moving its single eye left and right to search out the dragon's form.

Circling around beneath it with a nosedive, Sakuya went into a steep climb...

'Handed down from Mystith, taste the... what was it called again?'

Having forgotten the name, still oblivious, Sakuya got her large fist into the enemy's body.

The monster bent into an L shape, flying into the air upon receiving the impact.

And with speeds greater than before, Sakuya chased after it, putting both her fists together and lifting them above her head, she came right above the monster to lower them.

Seeing the monster fall towards the earth, Rudel spoke.

"... And that's that. I'll free you now."

Sakuya's gauntlets disappeared, she opened her mouth wide.

There a large mass of mana emerged and Rudel compressed it. Once the forcefully compressed lump of magic swelled again, it was compressed even further.

Drawing out a dragon's power... no, the power Sakuya originally possessed was Rudel's job.

Sakuya turned the mass of magic towards the monster that had fallen into the sea.

Water vapor rose all around, the writhing monster could no longer maintain its form.

It spread and spread, and spread some more.

It was almost as if a single large island was forming.

Sprouting countless hands, it opened its large mouth to cry out.

Water leaked from its large eye, making it look as if it were crying.

"Being sealed away forever, sealing others away, you must've hated it... so this is the end."

Sakuya fired the compressed mass of magic.

Her body shot a bit back from the recoil, as her small light was sucked into the monster's open mouth.

As she left that space, the golden markings disappeared from Sakuya's body.

The color of Rudel's eyes also returned to their usual blue.

Hurriedly fastening on his belt. Rudel clung to the handrail.

"It's the first time we tried going all out."

'Sakuya did her best~.'

Hearing her tired voice, Rudel tried to open his mouth as he looked at the large pillar of light.

From the monster's open mouth, magma erupted into the sky.

It was almost like an endless stream of lava.

As the shockwaves assailed Sakuya, it became difficult to fly properly, sending her barreling through the air.

"The output was too high."

Perhaps it would be best not to use it again.

Rudel thought.

Gradually the pillar receded, and by that time, Sakuya had regained the ability to fly normally. Regaining her position, she commenced hovering on the spot as she looked at the monster.

'It just keeps spreading.'

"Right."

Where the monster had fallen, a black island was born.

The scene of it visibly expanding wasn't one he could witness all too often.

Rudel turned only to suddenly raise his right hand in front of his face.

The morning sun.

"So it's already morning."

'Sakuya is tired. I want to go to the hot spring.'

Rudel was of the same opinion.

"You're right. I'm also worn out this time."

After seeing the son, Rudel turned to the island that continued to expand.

There, from within it, a large blue light in the shape of a human waved its hand. Below it, several hundred waved their hands at Sakuya.

Rudel rubbed his eyes, looking at the island again.

"... They're gone. Was the magic eye's effect still lingering?"

Just as he thought he'd seen a hallucination, Rudel pulled his sword and turned around.

Where he pointed it, a single woman watched the rising sun.

The blue-haired woman closing her eyes, she spread her arms out as if to bask in its light.

And...

'You have our thanks. Foreign knight.'

Seeing that smile, Rudel noticed it was the queen he had seen from the painting in the king's study.

And sheathing away his sword,

"It's dragoon. I'm a dragoon."

'Eh? You're a knight, aren't you?'

"Yes. But I'm more precisely a dragoon. I can't budge on that one."

The other party was successfully confused but as Rudel wouldn't concede that point, she gave a cute clearing of her throat as she started from square one.

Rudel made a satisfied face.

'You have our thanks, foreign dragoon.'

"I was in the neighborhood on a mission. Call it a whimsy. Also."

'Also?'

"With this, I have proven the dragoons are the strongest. This is my victory, so in the end, that last draw has become the dragoons' victory!"

Seeing Rudel's delight, the blank stare of the transparent woman turned to a smile.

Her smiling face was reminiscent of Cleo.

'What an interesting person. To think you'd defeat our guardian deity.'

"It looked more like a monster to me."

As Rudel looked down at the island from Sakuya's back, the woman leaned over to do the same.

Her feet weren't there.

'... It was twisted over the course of a history far too long. At first it was there to bring bounty to our country. Once it was used for war, its power was shown and it became a tool for battle.'

Rudel looked at the woman.

"You're Cleo's mother, aren't you?"

There, the woman smiled and shook her head to the side.

'I'm her aunt. That girl's mother was my sister... I see, so Cleo is safe. That really is wonderful.'

Seeing the woman's delighted smile, Rudel thought back to the unnatural painting in the king's office. The person who was meant to occupy that space, surely it was Cleo's real mother.

(... I guess every royal house has its complications.)

The woman stood and looked at Rudel.

'Thank you, dragoon. With this, Celestia's guardian deity has been freed, and we can return to the stream of souls.'

"I wholeheartedly accept your thanks. Of course, from the country's point of view, I might end up the villain."

'We should have never held a power so far beyond our means. I can see it in hindsight. It was an unnatural, twisted country. But even so, it's my sister and my homeland, so I think it'll recover.'

To the woman gradually becoming fainter, Rudel spoke.

"Anything you want me to pass on to Cleo or the other royals?"

The woman shook her head.

'Nothing personally... just tell them I'm watching over them.'

"Understood."

'And.'

Her face turning serious, the woman looked right at Rudel and spoke.

'... As I am now, I can understand. You'll be coming over to our side in the near future.'

"... Is that so."

With no further words from Rudel, the woman made a praying gesture.

'But please don't forget, you're not alone...'

Turning a smile to Rudel at the end, as the light of the sun grew stronger, she disappeared as if dissolving away.

Sakuya let out her voice.

'Rudel, who were you talking to?'

Rudel opened his mouth to explain it to her, closed it along the way, and smiled as he shook his head.

"No, it's nothing. Now once we get back, it's going to be busy."

Directing Sakuya to return, Rudel turned just once to look at the island that continued to expand.

Chapter 145

From where a destroyed castle town spread out, Cleo looked over her surroundings.

The earthen dolls ceased function, rattling as they began to crumble apart.

Once the sun had fully shown itself, their movements grew strange, and just like that, they stopped moving.

Near Cleo, Nate took off her mask and looked around.

With a whistle from her lips, a hippogryph descended from the sky.

Seeing that, Cleo spoke.

"U-um,"

"Mn? Oh, that's my partner, don't worry about it. See, he can become a horse too."

After landing, the hippogryph gave a shake of its eagle head and took on the form of a normal horse.

And breathing a sigh, Nate looked around.

"But this really will be a pain to report."

"You're... right."

When they saw the red pillar pierce through the sky, that moment they felt the tremor and gale, both Cleo and Nate were surprised. But they could understand it now.

"Do you think Rudel-dono won?"

"I'd quite hope so. Because that would also mean the destruction of Celestia's ancient weapon, or rather guardian deity... who's going to take responsibility for this, I wonder."

Cleo spoke.

"The guardian deity, is it. If I just..."

She had much to think about.

There, Nate cut in.

"... My ancestors, you see, they were once people of Celestia. This blue hair is something of a testament to that."

"Eh?"

As Cleo looked on blankly, Nate...

"Meaning, I'm a survivor of your clan that ran away. Though at present, I've got work in Courtois as you can see."

She kept on talking on the matter, but Cleo worried whether that might bring problems to her position. There, Nate's expression turned serious.

"Well, I'm just trying to say that humans can live anywhere. Don't you think it'd be alright if you just became free? If the threat of Celestia is gone, Courtois should give a public apology and provide some support."

As Cleo hesitated, Nate spelled out her options.

"You could run off somewhere and live, not as a princess but a single young girl. All that's left of the Celestia royal line is you and a few children. It's possible to push it onto someone else."

Cleo gave a bitter smile and shook her head.

She wouldn't choose that option.

"Thank you. But I have my responsibilities and obligations. I could not become a sacrifice, but I cannot abandon my people. Someone will have to take the leading role. Even if it's someone as unreliable as me."

Nate spoke disinterestedly.

"Is that so."

And putting on her mask, she pat her partner's neck a few times. Cleo understood that Nate wasn't particularly angry.

It felt like she already knew which one she would choose.

"I'm just a little envious of you."

"Eh?"

At the end, Nate,

"That you could choose the option not to run, I'm just a little envious."



A few days later.

In the ruins of Celestia, Sakuya moved around heavy loads as if playing with building blocks.

To help out in the reconstruction efforts, Rudel and Aleist worked dawn to dusk.

Izumi and Millia aided them.

Nate alone made for Courtois to report on the incident. Someone had to be told...

"To be totally honest, I think there's something messed up about defeating a god and making an island of it."

Holding a shovel, Aleist looked at Rudel.

"... Aleist, sure enough, I won't deny I had some personal feelings involved. But there was no helping that one!"

Millia looked at the two of them tiredly.

"I understand it was a situation where it couldn't be helped, but... who's going to take responsibility for this?"

Neither Rudel nor Aleist could take responsibility.

Millia looked at Izumi...

"Isn't this his surveillance inspector's liability?"

A startled Izumi spoke.

"I do get the feeling there was nothing that could be done there."

Izumi had hurriedly drafted up a report and handed it to Nate. But just how would the top brass evaluate it...

The four of them put some thought into it, but Rudel,

"Well, whatever will be will be. Once I return, I'm sure I'll be put to work in the outer reaches again, so I don't mind if I'm to aid reconstruction a while longer."

Aleist as well.

"You're right. This feels so much more worthwhile than returning to cleaning duty. Now then, let's give it our best for another day."

Millia looked at the two.

"Isn't it strange to use Courtois' white and black knights like this? Normally, they should have some post or something, and work in the royal palace, right?"

Rudel and Aleist's standings were dubious even in Courtois. When normally it wouldn't be strange if they had much higher ranks, one was sent to the middle of nowhere. The other was treated as a cleaner.

Izumi sighed.

"Well, as long as the ones in question don't raise a ruckus, isn't it fine? If anyone's got any complaints, they can voice them to the higherups."

When he became a dragoon, Rudel knew he would be sent to the outer reaches as he had no complaints; while Aleist might grumble here and there, he was earnest in his work.

Yet the two of them had saved the country called Celestia.

No, perhaps saved was a misunderstanding.

Of all else, the one they fought was the guardian deity of Celestia.

One wrong move and people might say Courtois took advantage of their request to eliminate their deity.

Of course...

"But it's a huge problem if a majority of their important ministers are gone."

It was just as Rudel said.

Almost all of Celestia's ministers and high officials had perished in the castle.

It was because of the mechanized unit, according to Nate.

There were various hands moving behind the scenes, and from Rudel's group's point of view, it was a peculiar mission that ended while they fought

a battle they'd been roped into.

Sakuya looked up at the sky.

'Hey, can I eat that?'

She sought confirmation with Rude, so she followed her eye line.

"The hippogryph? Someone's riding it, so you can't."

Sakuya was downhearted.



What the returned Nate informed them of was everyone's return.

At the same time, she told them, a squadron from Courtois had been dispatched with the intent to provide aid.

Rudel wanted to remain until they had built an extent of a basis. But he had to follow his orders.

He had asked Nate, but it seemed Celestia would officially be treated as Courtois' vassal state. This owed to the fact it didn't have any strengths worthy of forming an equal alliance.

And the new queen of Celestia, Cleo, was to have a discussion over it with the temporary ministers.

The damage was great, if they went against Courtois and could no longer receive aid, it was easy to imagine Celestia's reconstruction taking decades.

There was no guarantee Courtois wouldn't invade in that space.

"Did I do something unnecessary?"

Lying down in a room of the palace, Rudel muttered.

They would depart come the next day, so he took an early rest.

Once he returned, a report to Courtois' palace awaited him.

(I'm sure I'm causing them trouble again.)

Thinking he'd brought even more trouble to his superiors, Rudel closed his eyes.

There, a knock at the door.

"Boss!"

The ones who entered were Ben, Pono and Passan, the party of three. As they had been promoted to knights, they now wore clothing that half-looked the part.

Cleo had appointed them as part of her royal guard.

Their achievements in evacuating citizens all the way to the end, and Cleo's trust for them brought it about.

Of course, that was the public reason.

Truthfully, there was a severe lack of personnel, so things had grown lax in various places, and the three of them were appointed.

"What's wrong? You want to train again?"

"No, today it's work." "That's right!" "t's work!"

As the three of them stuck out their chests, a single woman came out from behind them.

It was Cleo.

"Princess... or no, it's Queen now I see."

As Rudel left the bed and stood, Cleo turned him her tired face curled into a smile.

"Can I have just a little bit of your time?"

"Yes, I don't mind."



The party of three kept watch outside, while Rudel and Cleo went out to the balcony.

The night breeze had a nice feel to it.

"So why have you called me for?"

Cleo was taking deep breaths. And resolving herself, she looked at Rudel, wrung out her voice...

"Rudel-dono, no, Rudel-sama, I've fallen in love with you!"

She confessed.

Rudel spoke with a smile.

"I can't!"

... He refused.

Upon hearing that, Cleo burst into laughter. Perhaps she knew the answer from the start.

"Can I ask for your reasons?"

Rudel spelled it out clearly.

"To start with, I have no freedom in my marriage. And even if I look like this, I've got quite a few restraints placed on me. I doubt the country will recognize a marriage between the two of us. If that's how it's going to be, I concluded I should decline it from the start."

Cleo gave a bitter smile.

"You won't give an answer in regards to my feelings, I see."

"... I already have someone I love. Of course, for the same reasons, I can't tell her I love her."

Rudel got the feeling Cleo had become stronger than before.

"... In this incident. Celestia will put up a strong protest to Courtois for destroying our guardian deity. Of course, the country's circumstance and the feelings of our people are conflicting, so that is simply the public stance. I am personally quite thankful, Rudel-dono."

"So it's going that way after all."

As Rudel said that, Cleo...

"I truly am thankful. Celestia has finally gained the opportunity to stand on its own power... I can think of it like that now."

Cleo was surely troubled over many things, Rudel imagined.

And he surmised she had confessed to get her own feelings in order at the end.

"So have you gotten your feelings in order?"

"You noticed? Well let's see... with this I can be not Cleo the princess, I can become the figurehead queen Cleo. I'll leech as much aid from Courtois as possible."

Rudel laughed.

"It's quite troublesome if you say such things to me. Even like this, I'm one of Courtois'—"

Cleo said it before he could.

"Dragoons, after all. Right? ... You have my thanks. At the end, you even let me hear the words of my mother and aunt. That I was loved. I've been

granted the opportunity to learn that, and I look on it with delight."

Defeating the monster, Rudel had conveyed the words of the existence calling herself Cleo's aunt to Cleo and the surviving royal children.

(Even so, she's become quite strong in the past few days.)

She had lost her brother Emilio, she had lost many things, and Rudel mulled over what he should say to her.

"You'll be off early tomorrow morning, right? I shall see you off from her. Well then, farewell... Rudel."

She dropped the honorific at the end.



The next day.

Looking at Sakuya take to the sky from the balcony, Cleo stroked aside her blue hair.

Around were the party of three and her servants, likewise looking at the dragon soar through the air.

"They've gone, boss and his friends."

The party of three were shedding tears, while the servants pulled back from the sight of them.

To Cleo, those three were idiots but honest, and kind from their hearts. Precious knights to have.

Looking at Sakuya, Cleo sung a song.

(At the very least, even if only in song... thank you, foreign knights. Thank you, dragoon.)

Passan spoke.

"The princess' songs really are the best!"

Ben,

"Fool, it's queen now!"

Pono,

"Quiet down and let me hear the song!"

As Cleo's song voice resounded through Celestia, the white dragon took a leisure circle around the palace. And the knights on its back waved their hands.

The party of three grandly waved back, and Cleo also answered in a wave.

(Thank you, Rudel. .And goodbye.)

Her smile still on her face, Cleo shed tears.

Chapter 146

"And. I'm. Saying. Why didn't he invite me!?"

His ash blonde hair swept back, the tan skinned Eunius Diade had some ale in his system, making him more quarrelsome than usual.

"Don't drag me into this! In the first place, that was a dragoon mission, and you had nothing to do with it!"

"Fighting an ancient weapon, and even Gaia's mechanized unit! I wanted to join in on the fun."

"Like I car!"

His silky blond hair grown out, Luecke Halbades sat across the table from his friend from his academy days.

Two other friends had suddenly returned from a mission, so they got together to drink.

That much was fine.

But Luecke and Eunius were the only ones around that round table downing their glasses.

Turning an eye to the nearby seats, there Rudel and Aleist were both at different tables, accompanied by their female encampments.

When looked upon from the side, both of them were surrounded by lovely ladies, but those around made sure to take their distance. There were even customers who left the shop.

That was simply how tense the restaurant's air was.

"Eunius, if you want to know why you weren't taken along, you can just ask those two."

As Luecke sipped his drink and said that, Eunius reached his hand for a snack as he vetoed the notion.

"Like hell I can do that!"

Having just returned from the Kingdom of Celestia, Rudel Arses was a young man of silver hair and blue eyes.

He was currently surrounded by seasoned warriors of the Dragoon Brigade as he drank. It was quite accurate to say Rudel saw the woman affiliated with the dragoons as his idols.

Luecke looked at Rudel's enjoyable-looking table.

"The ones with him are Major Bennet, Cattleya Ninias, Lilim, Enora Campbell... a brilliant gathering of elite dragoons, that is."

While he said that with a hint of cynicism, ability-wise, those girls truly were elites.

Among the elite dragoons, it was as if they were chosen to be elites among elites.

Before the valorous dragoons putting checks and restraints on one another as they closed in on Rudel, the man in question was happily enjoying his meal.

Perhaps Izumi was in tune with those restraints as she spoke less than usual. Everyone at Rudel's table was smiling, but some part of it birthed a tingling tension.

It seems Rudel spoke of what happened in Celestia, at least to the extent he was free to speak on.

Bennet alone seemed innocently delighted at her subordinate's achievements.

(Compared to that, Aleist's table is...)

Luecke looked at the other pitiful table.

Aleist made a pale face, as he desperately explained how nothing happened with Nate- one of his harem members- while they were alone in Celestia.

Numerically, they were a greater gathering of beauties than Rudel's table, the number was more than double.

There were plenty of drunks at the bar, but no one even thought to pick a fight with the beauty-surrounded Aleist. More than that, they directed eyes of pity.

A harem member from its early days, Seli took charge.

"And so, Alest-sama, you say nothing happened between you and Nate?"

His face increasingly pale, neither food nor drink passing through his throat, Aleist Hardie levelly answered the question.

Curling blond hair, mismatched eyes of blue and green... his features were of the beautiful sort, but some part of him gave off a most unfortunate air.

"Nothing happened. Nothing at all. I was able to get some sound sleep, so I preferred it over there. I want to return to Celestia."

At the end, he leaked his true feelings, causing the other woman to barrage him with questions as well.

Eunius ate his meal as he looked between Rudel and Aleist's table.

"When we just got together to drink, they came in one after the next and casually surrounded them. I'd like to have some stupid banter at least at times like this."

Luecke shared the sentiment.

(Dammit! I wanted to consult with them on Lena! Read the mood, you lot!)

Unable to speak out against Aleist's harem members or the warriors surrounding Rudel, Lucke downed his glass.

For some reason, Millia was present at Aleist's table.

"Hey, I think I'm irrelevant. Can I go over there?"

As Millia pointed at Rudel's table, her sister elf Lilim who heard that waved her hand.

Lilim, whose eyes were closed as per usual, waved with a smile. Seeing that, Millia felt just a little annoyed.

The store had specially prepared the table and chairs, there were quite a few people at Rudel's table, and it didn't look like it would fit anymore.

Eunius looked over the elven sisters.

"Looks like things are getting complicated over there."

Luecke, to his friend who said such a thing.

"Over there as well, you mean. But what's with these members... that blasted Aleist, he's long since past ten. At the rate things are going, in a few years, I won't be surprised with twenty or thirty."

He sighed at Aleist's ever expanding harem.

What was stranger than anything was the fact the man in question was in lover with Millia, who had eyes for Rudel. At present, he had no desire for a harem.

In his student days.

At first he had admired harems, calling out to women, and wasting his efforts in futility. After losing an interest in a harem, he chased after Millia. And yet, from that point onwards, women began to gather around Aleist.

To the one in question, it was nothing more than a bother.

Eunis leaked his real feelings.

"As I thought, Harems are only fun to watch. I do feel jealous, but if you say I'll turn out like Aleist, I'll have to decline."

Luecke was the same.

"My thoughts exactly. I can only handle won... no, if I had to, two at most. Yeah."

While Luecke was zealous towards Rudel's stepsister, given her status as an illegitimate daughter, he might not be unable to take Lena Arses as a legal wife.

Therefore, if he wanted her by his side by all means, she would be treated as a mistress.

Perhaps sensing Luecke's feelings, Eunius spoke tiredly.

"And is that one Lena? You really are... well, I guess you're better off than when you were a straight-laced asshole."

"Don't stick strange names on me!"

Luecke found himself being teased, but there he heard Bennet's voice.

"Eh, no... I mean, I'm the one who graduated first."

At Bennet's great fluster, wondering what had happened, the two of them quietly observed. Rudel explained with a smile.

"What are you talking about, Major? You're the same age as us. Those born to the wolf tribe are considered to be one year old at birth, with age

counting up every New Year, right?"

"Yes, that's right."

"You were born in the twelfth month, right?"

"No, I was definitely smaller than those in my year, they always called me small, but..."

Bennet looked anxious.

"You became two soon after birth, and enrolled in the academy at the same age fifteen as us, right? But that means you were actually thirteen. When you graduated on the two year course, you were fifteen, so you should be younger than Lieutenant Cattleya."

Bennet blankly opened her mouth and looked at Cattleya. Cattleya didn't seem very amused.

"Yeah, yeah, I'm the older one. What's more, I'm a lieutenant, a lower ranking officer!"

Seeing Cattleya down her drink all at once, Bennet started making excuses.

"I-I mean no one ever told me I was supposed..."

Perhaps the drink had put Rudel in a good mood.

"That's got nothing to do with it. I mean, you're a Major. Even if you're not her direct commanding officer, you're still her superior!"

Bennet's ears standing sharply upwards drooped miserably as her face turned red and she hung her head. Covering her face with both hands, her tail began to quiver.

"... When I'm the younger one, I'm sorry for acting condescending. I'm sorry for sticking a -chan on your name. From here on, I'll call you senpai. I'm sorry."

When she said such a thing, Cattleya snapped.

"If a Major talks to me like that, I'll just be troubled."

Lifting up her orange hair, Enora to Rudel.

"Looks like our commanding officers have it rough. Rudel, you want to train together next time? You'll be in the capital a while, right?"

To Enora who asked in a fawning voice, Rudel crossed his arms and looked at the ceiling.

"I think that's possible, but..."

There, Lilim to Enora.

"Yey, brigade member over there! What are you trying to make him promise in the confusion?"

There, Enora spoke with a face of leisure.

"My apologies. I mean, it looks like our superior officers are all busy, and this is the special privilege of his peer in rank. See, me and Rudel are peers."

Lilim gripped the cup in her hand so hard one wondered if it might break. Looking over that, Rudel spoke.

"Izumi, is it alright for me to participate in training?"

Izumi, who had kept careful watch, made an expression as if to say, don't turn this towards me.

Enora spoke.

"Rudel, why are you checking it order with Izumi-san? Let's just let the two of us..."

Rudel smiled.

"No, Captain Oldart told me, 'You should never take any action on your own,' after all. He sounded really disheartened, so breaking those words all of a sudden is a bit..."

It seems the problem with Celestia had the higherups whittle the captain away quite a bit.

As Izumi possessed the title of special inspector, Rudel sought confirmation with her.

Surrounded by these valorous members of the dragoons, Izumi responded.

"No, as long as you're acting alongside other dragoons, I think it should be fine..."

Unable to endure the pressure from Cattleya and Lilim, Izumi spoke nothing more than the truth. Enora heard those words and lightly clenched her hand in victory.

Seeing that, Luecke muttered.

"Looks like they're enjoying themselves more than at Aleist's table."

He gave his honest opinion.

Eunius agreed.

"Only in comparison, that is."



Only a few hours after the drinks with the female camp began, were Rudel's group able to slip out of the pub, flee into a back alley, and drink in peace at a stall.

As if rehearsed, the four of them went up together to pay the tab and slipped out of the back door.

While they did feel bad about it, from the start, it was intended as a drink among men.

Removing their upper coats, the top few buttons of their shirts opened, the four raised their glasses.

"It's that. As I thought, it's nice to take it easy and just have a drink between men."

On that statement from Rudel, Luecke spoke in surprise.

"What's this, you were actually able to read the mood? Well, sure enough, if you asked me to drink in that sort of atmosphere..."

"No, so... it's good to be surrounded by women you admire, but you're always mindful of them, or how should I put it."

Mindful, Rudel put it. With an amazing smile, Aleist strongly slammed down his glass of ale on the table.

"You're lying. I saw how much fun you were having! My stomach was grating, and I could feel all the blood leave me, you know."

Seeing Aleist on the verge of tears, Eunius gave a grand laugh.

"You reap what you sow. And the numbers keep steadily increasing even after you've graduated. So are you still after Millia?"

Not at his drink, Aleist's face reddened at the topic Eunius brought up. Teasing the easy-to-understand Aleist, Eunius reached for the food.

The food wasn't anything refined, but even so, the atmosphere was much better than that pub from before, making everything naturally taste better.

"Oh, this isn't half bad."

As he said that, Luecke reached out a hand as well.

"Then I don't mind if I do. More importantly. Rudel, your little sister... I'm not talking about Lena, this is about Erselica. She came to my place asking around."

Sipping his drink, Rudel made a surprised face. While Rudel and Erselica were siblings, it was hard to say they got along.

Unlike his stepsister Lena, he never really talked with Erselica Arses.

"That's rare, perhaps? I've heard some things from Lena, but I'm relieved she's not moping around anymore."

He said with a swig. Rudel,

"It was while I was having some tea with Lena. She asked me various things about the factions, but do you know her intent?"

Perhaps worried for her, Luecke made a serious face.

Rudel had no idea what Erselica was trying to do.

"Who knows? I haven't heard anything."

"I see," said Luecke, leaving his glass on the table to look at Rudel.

"There have been some unsettling movements in the palace as of late. Especially around Princess Aileen... it was the same when we were at the academy, but I don't know what she's planning this time."

Aileen Courtois had some connection to Rudel's group. Of course, that was only through her favorite young man called Fritz.

Of common descent, Fritz was a knight hailing from the territory governed by the Arses House.

By Aileen's work, he was also the captain who commanded the royal guard.

He held an emotion close to hatred towards Rudel, and often stood against him in their student days. But Rudel himself didn't care about it all too

much.

"The princess, eh. Come to think of it, Fina's about to graduate, isn't she?"

It was time for the second princess Fina Courtois to graduate the academy. To Rudel, that relation was the more important one. Not as man and woman, she was his disciple who pursued the means to pet a dragon by his side.

Hearing of Fina, Aleist joined in on the conversation.

"Graduation... eh. What do you think I should do? How should I put it, there are some new recruits scheduled to join my platoon, but they're all women."

At Aleist who butted into the conversation, Eunius shook his head and shrugged his shoulders.

"I thought it might be more elegant than nothing but men, but after seeing that, I don't want any part."

Luecke was, meanwhile, laughing.

"I'll have to agree."

Rudel looked at Aleist.

"The defenders have it rough. Rather, isn't it strange that the female knight ration is only skewed around Aleist? I'm sure they're all proficient, but Aleist is the only man there."

Looked on from the side, it was a vibrant workplace where he was surrounded by women.

That was Aleist's station in a knight brigade called the defenders. Within that, Aleist was the head of a platoon.

Of course, all he ever did was clean the palace.

"I can't take it anymore! It's grating on my every day, and the talks are all going in strange directions! No one ever listens to my opinion, yet they still come to me to hear it out! What's that supposed to mean!? Asking me who's my number one, don't bring out those questions that only make things worse! They all know my number one is Millia, dammit!"

The drink getting to him, Aleist's tensions were rising.

Eunius poured ale into Aleist's cup as he grinned.

"Hmm, the black knight has it tough. And from the look of it, you're getting more female knights? I'd be envious if I didn't know any better."

Aleist instantly downed the refilled ale.

Taking a few deep breaths after drinking it, he vented the anger he was usually storing up.

"Envious? Then switch out with me! This personnel assignment is definitely the doing of someone with a grudge towards me! What's with this, what did I do to deserve this?"

Rudel also drank some ale as he spoke.

"I get the feeling you were thirsting for women at the start..."

There, Luecke snapped his fingers and nodded.

"Come to think of it, my image of you running around's grown too strong, but Aleist, you really were terrible before that. You're easy to talk to now, but back then, I wouldn't even think of approaching you unless you had some ale in your system. Ah, come to think of it, he used to sound so full of himself."

As Luecke reminisced and nodded, Eunius reached for the food, a tired look on his face.

"You're the one who changed. What's this? Saying whatever you want about noble obligations, you're getting all heated over Rudel's sister. Have you

forgotten how you made a misunderstanding and challenged me back at the academy?"

Luecke was earnest in his student days, no... he was so earnest he let off an air that made people distance themselves.

He and Eunius were like cat and dog, leading along their followers to snarl at once another. From the start, both their houses held the top spots in the factional wars, with enough reason and history to hold a feud.

But like this, the two of them now drank together at the food stalls.

Aleist recalled how he was when he enrolled at the academy, poured himself another glass and downed it at once before looking at Rudel.

"You say that, but I think the one who changed most was Rudel. In the first place, I always thought you were strange from the first time we met."

Rudel tilted his head.

Luecke and Eunius shook their heads and received some water from the man running the stall. Pushing that water onto Aleist, they seemed deeply concerned.

Eunius,

"The one who changed the least was Rudel, right? Going on about dragons and dragons from dawn to dusk, and after graduation, it's still dragons all the way down. You've got to respect that."

Rudel acted a little bashful.

"You think so?"

Sparingly sipping his ale, Luecke cautioned Rudel.

"Eunius wasn't praising you. But I have to agree Rudel hasn't changed. Changing so little in the time since we met, isn't that actually amazing?"

Rather, when I heard him talk about how he was really going to become a dragoon, looking back on it now, I'll say it, but I thought it sounded stupid."

Eunius agreed as he drank.

"Yeah, me too. I thought it was interesting but definitely impossible."

Aleist also nodded.

"Yeah~, I remember that. No one thought you'd make it. You surprised me too."

The drink getting to Rudel again, his face turned a little red.

"Aren't you being terrible? No, but my probability of becoming a dragoon was considerably low. I couldn't get the rights to meet a grey dragon, and my screening forms were..."

Seeing Rudel begin to think to himself, Eunius pat him on the back. That hurts, Rudel said as he looked at Eunius.

"You're a dragoon now, so don't worry about it. Even so, it really was fun. Going to matches, cutting at one another, bashing each other's faces in."

"Yeah, I remember a whole lot of smacking."

Luecke looked at Eunius and Rudel nodding and reminiscing, and made a truly incomprehensive face.

"You muscle heads."

And the one staring intently at a tired Luecke was Aleist.

"No, aren't you the same, Luecke? You butted heads with Aleist over the duel, right? I'll just say it, but just switching out fists for magic doesn't change much in the grand scheme of things. From my point of view, you're all the same sort. Plain old battle maniacs!"

Eunius stood from his chair and pointed at Aleist.

"Don't screw with me! You also exchanged blows with Rudel! What's more, not winning by a paper-thin margin, the only time you ever won was the first time!"

In his matches with Rudel, Aleist only ever won once.

In his first match after enrolling at the academy, Rudel lost to Aleist.

Perhaps recalling that, Rudel seemed delighted.

"And after that, I've got two wins and one draw. Man, both those matches I just barely got through, and we were carted off to the infirmary every time."

Aleist pulled back.

"Why do you sound so happy? You're the only one who gets hospitalized enough to get a reserved bed at the sick room."

Eunius spoke loudly as if recalling.

"Come to think of it, his majesty came too! Back then, we were so frantic to lower our heads through our injuries! Thinking back on it now, you think he would've burst out like that if we were in public?"

Aleist cried out.

"That was lese majeste, you hear! Really, just don't! Rather, I didn't know about that one..."

Luecke put down his glass with a serious face.

"The truth is, I've had to go and lower my head to him quite a few times..."

Aleist held his head.

"Why!? I thought you were the most decent, but why!?"

Rudel addressed Aleist.

"Don't mind it. I've been cautioned more times than I can count, but I'm still just fine!"

Aleist looked to be on the verge of tears.

"You're not fine at all! Why are you still a problem child after graduation!? Hey, let's act a little more grown up."

Looking at Aleist, the three laughed.

Aleist began to laugh as well.

Hitting glasses together, the four of them talked and reminisced over their student days, drinking the night away.



In a room of the palace, the first princess Aileen took a single document in hand.

Confirming its contents in that dark room, she set it ablaze and tossed it in the fireplace for it to burn through.

The document that instantly burned away, it detailed that the plan Aileen brought forth was at a stage where it could be executed.

The sender was an enemy nation, the Gaia Empire.

The knights on standby in the room gazed at Aleist with nervous faces.

And turning away from the fireplace, Aileen directed a smile to those knights.

"Could you call Fritz here? Things are going to get busy, so I'll have to start preparing."

Under Aileen's orders, one of the knights left the room.

The first princess was of kind heart, a beautiful princess.

Despite being of the royal family, she held antipathy towards the corrupt nobility, and made her favorite commoner knight Fritz into captain of the royal guard.

And in order to see Rudel's mortified face, she even granted a gray dragon to Fritz.

In the Kingdom of Courtois, dragons were a valuable war asset. The knights who rode them needed to be elites.

In order to obtain their own dragons, there were knights who sought out wild ones. But even those knights couldn't enter the lands the dragons lived without the kingdom's permission.

Without treading into any of those procedures, a gray dragon managed by the country-born and raised in Courtois, it was smaller than a white dragon- was granted by Aileen unto Fritz.

The young captain of the royal guard, and the young man who obtained a dragon, receiving such special treatment from Aileen, Fritz did have his dissatisfactions.

It could not be said he lacked any talent.

The young man called Fritz definitely did have talent and strength. But for surrounding eyes, that wasn't enough.

Just in his own generation, starting with the White Knight Rudel, there was the Black Knight Aleist, then Eunius and Luecke, the four with strength and fame towering over the rest.

They graduated the academy together, they started work as knights together.

Speaking to position, Fritz was far above any of them.

But Fritz was no noble.

In regards to Rudel's group that all possessed, Aileen thought that might be another large reason her Fritz was looked down upon.

From within the room, one of the knights asked Aileen.

"Princess, from here on, we will be..."

Aileen nodded with a smile.

"Yes, we will be at war. But don't worry. For the empire has agreed to fall back in exchange for a designated portion of land. And there won't be just one battlefield. Once the Gaia Empire lays hand on fertile soil, they will be satisfied."

Unlike the abundant lands of Courtois, the Gaia Empire lay on exceedingly harsh terrain. For that sake, they had challenged Courtois time and again for their soil.

Aileen was a lover of peace.

But...

"On top of falling back after obtaining a portion of land, we will be able to tie friendly relations for times to come. This will be our final battle with them."

... No matter how dearly she held it, she had absolutely no talent. Her little sister Fina had talent in the field, her little sister Fina knew the reality.

But Aileen was different.

Raised sheltered within the palace, she grew up without ever learning how such things worked. She honestly believed the world was gentle and just, she had no doubt the other party would honor their promises.

"With this, Fritz-sama will surely obtain social status. And a better future will come upon Courtois."

The knights held anxiety towards Aileen's joy. But they wouldn't try to stop her. The reason being, Courtois had never once lost to the Gaia Empire.

The dragoons never lost on the battlefield.

To that point, the powerful existences called the dragons had protected Courtois time and again. From the point of view of the knights, they were sure this wouldn't lose this time either.



The Gaia Empire.

His blonde hair that grew to his shoulders swept back, a young man stood.

High in stature, he boasted a trained body. And in his hand, he gripped a single document.

Askewell Gaia...

A prince of the empire, if he was in the battlefield, it was said they were sure to win. The empire's hero.

A girl called Mies Licorise nervously watched over his state. Her long, blonde hair curled at the tips.

Of small build, she was useless as a fighter, but she had come to assist Askewell as a researcher. And her research was finally to see the light of day.

To her side, a pale, slim, old man, Reole, mumbled something in a small voice. Perhaps thinking of his hatred towards the folks who never recognized his magic, perhaps hitting on a new magical discovery entirely, he gave a low chuckle.

When looked at from the side, he looked like a limitlessly dangerous man, but even like that, a proficient magician of the Gaia Empire. No, perhaps it should be said he had been too proficient.

The past tense was what suited him most. Discarding his family name, and calling himself the archwizard, Reole was a strange, one, but he was a man Askewell recognized.

On Mies' opposite side stood a general who'd climbed his way up.

Ban Lochuas stood on many a battlefield with enemy countries, swinging his battleaxe and barrying many an enemy.

Whether it be man or monster, as long as they stood before him, they would be cleaved into two.

He wore full armor over his muscular body, a well-ordered beard as his trademark around his mouth, the general was subordinate to Askewell.

Ban spoke to his leader.

"Have the cowards of Courtois moved yet? They really are taking this easily."

Letting out a light chuckle, Reole made light of Courtois.

"When they haven't offered what we desire, they're nothing but fools for believing in such an agreement. Of could it be they plan to crush us with dragons once we march to invade? That sounds interesting. I need only burn the dragons to death with my magic. Kihihhi!"

Mies broke into a cold sweat.

For this looked to be too unworthy an assortment to follow the rule of one of a prince like Askewell. But there was no doubt they were proficient.

Askewell turned his eyes to the documents as he spoke to Mies.

"Are the preparations in order, Mies?"

"Y-yes! We can move at any moments! We have already started limiting their food, increasing their brutality, and if I may speak to the contrary, it will be dangerous if we keep them on standby any longer."

What Mies had prepared.

It was an army of black monsters. Starting with ogres, they had even prepared wyverns as a countermeasure for the dragoons.

Their knights had already begun training to ride the wyverns she produced.

To that point, they had been one-sidedly attacked from the sky, and with all the losses under its belt, when it came to invading, the Empire couldn't help but take every caution.

And Askewell...

"My brother said he wished to borrow the wyvern unit. If father accepts those conditions, then it can be said we will be attacking on two fronts. Come so far, I've no intent to refuse, but what numbers should I send around to them?"

While Askewell showed a clear lack of motivation as he asked Mies, he had his reasons.

Of all else...

"The Wyvern unit is it? If it's to hold down the dragoons... they might need three hundred. In that case, the number we can bring along ourselves drops to two hundred."

Askewell laughed.

"That's plenty! The Gora's preparations are ready. I'll give him however many wyverns he wants. But my brother truly has a faint heart. When I said I'd lend him Gora, he readily declined."

While Askewell gave a grand laugh, to the people of the Empire, the monster known as Gora were nothing but fear itself.

A normal army couldn't hope to win against one, what's more, their large form and uncanny appearance. They boasted four arms, and when strengthened, they even sprouted wings.

Even with the techniques to control them, they were nothing more than a source of fear when too close.

Standing to his feet, Askewell crushed the document in his hand and made a serious face.

"... Henceforth, we will be going to take Courtois. Trample them down, and attain plentiful land for the empire. I don't know what idiot set this up, but if they intend to catch us in their trap, we'll rip them away and make them regret it."

Mies swallowed her breath, the two on her side laughed.

Thinking Askewell was serious, some part of her wished the researcher he once told her about would come back.

Gentle.

Thinking of the people of the empire, doing his best to bring fertility to their lands, or to secure a source of food, the Askewell of his younger days.

But his research was nothing but failures, and once he was forced to the battlefield, in contrast to his research, he found nothing but success. He won and he won, and got around to being called the hero of the empire.

The man in question, as long as it was for the empire's sake, didn't care if he was a military man or hero, he intended to fulfill his role. And the conclusion Askewell had finally reached...

"We will be invading Courtois! Prepare to depart!"

... To steal fertile soil from the people of Courtois, and save the people of the empire.

Chapter 147

The palace of the Kingdom of Courtois was driven to react to the activity shown by the Gaia Empire.

While the matter with Celestia had them in a hurry about awarding medals, in order to deal with the sudden movements of an enemy country, a meeting had been opened.

King Albach looked at the lines of ministers and yelled.

"What is the meaning of this!? For what reason has such a report not been raised to this point!?"

There, one of the ministers jovially laughed as he spoke.

"Now, now, your highness, please keep it at that. We'll just have to put the dragoons to work. We can decide who's responsible later and replace them. We need to prepare for the ceremony."

Albach lowered his fist on the table.

"What idiocy do you speak of!? Why are we making light of our foe!? Just how much of our blood do you Gaia has made flow? How can you declare the enemy will repeat the same actions as before!? Where is all the information!? I know we have more than enough forts stationed at the border!"

As no report was ever raised, the country was unable to put up any decent countermeasures. Sensing some ill intent, Albach glared at the ministers.

But Courtois had never lost before.

The reason being they had the strongest dragoons. As long as they were there, even if casualties came out, they would surely never lose, the ministers were certain of it. At the same time, Courtois' land was bountiful, leading to a lowered sense of crisis.

"What are you doing!? We must investigate, send scouts...!"

Holding his chest, Albach wiped sweat from his forehead. On top of a pain in his chest, his voice wouldn't come out. Breathing took all his might, his dizziness wouldn't allow him to stand any longer.

"Y-your majesty!"

Those nearby approached him, and the meeting was put on hold.

Albach thought.

(Don't just close it there, fool. Someone take command in my place... anyone!)

As his consciousness grew distant, Albach felt something black and squirmy moving in a corner of the room. But Albach lacked the means to confirm if it was really there.

His voice sealed, from his chest pains, he couldn't move.

With the king unable to do a thing, Courtois was thrust into a state of war.



Fina Courtois.

She awaited her graduation ceremony.

She had acquired all the required elective and class credits, there were no problems were her graduation.

As the second princess of Courtois, Fina had achieved excellent grades, but... with bags under her eyes, she sipped coffee as she looked at the

blinding morning sun.

"... The night has let up again."

The one who built similar bags under her eyes, with her violet hair ruffled up, her glasses out of place, was a woman called Sophina.

Fina's exclusive guard, at present she was a commanding officer of the declining order of high knights.

Regardless of the fact she was in a school dorm, Fina's room luxuriously spread out. In such a room, the floor was littered with documents, and a demi-human of the white cat tribe was pitifully collapsed.

"Don't give me that, the night has let up schtick! Your school days are about to end buried in a sea of paperwork, princess, are you really okay with that?"

Her expressions unchanging from the time of her birth, Fina expressionlessly made a fist and stuck up her thumb.

"I have no regrets. I've made a friend in Mii, fluffed up so many comrades, I was able to meet my master... I'm so happy I think I'm going to go crazy."

While expressionless, her delight was the real thing. Sophina lamented over whether it was really alright for her master to rejoice over such a thing.

"Let's make some better school memories while we still can! You're the only one chased around your room by government papers!"

The bags under her eyes were deep, the ink staining on her hands was terrible. But while Fina was expressionless, she gave off an air as if she had received enlightenment.

"A lifelong friend and a master, what more can I wish for? Once this is over, I'll be satisfied just with controlling the country from the shadows. Right, to one day raise the status of demi-humans, I'll get my hands on all the strings!"

"You really are the worst."

At the sound of Sophina bursting into tears, her subordinates entered the room. They were the subordinates of a high knight, but the problem lay in that Sophina's subordinates would not enter the room over an exchange of that level.

"What happened?"

Their faces were the epitome of severity. Sophina turned her face serious as well as she sought confirmation.

One of her subordinates spoke.

"Captain, a messenger has come from Aileen-sama. We were told to return Fina-sama to the palace at once."

Hearing that, Sophina turned to look at Fina.

She had finished her coffee, and breathing a sigh, Fina looked at the collapsed white cat Mii.

"... Let me put Mii to sleep. I'll get myself ready, so could you please tell them to wait?"

But the female knights brazenly entered the room. This attitude against Fina was a great discourtesy, and on top of that...

"Second princess, Aileen-sama is waiting at the palace. You needn't prepare anything. Please make for the carriage at once."

Fina stood from her seat, placing the cup in her hand on her desk.

"I cannot leave my good friend like this. I'll put her to sleep on my bed, you could at least give me time for that."

There, one of the intruding knights let out their voice.

"A demi-human as a friend? It's because they let you attend this academy that it came to this."

While she heard those words, Fina carried herself calmly. The captain of the knights who came in thought a bit before nodding and approving of Mii's transfer to the bed.

Fina issued the orders, and Sophina lay Mii down.

And...

"Well then, high knights, you will be leaving your weapons behind."

On that further demand, Sophina's eyes went sharp.

"What is the meaning of this? This is almost as if..."

... Almost as if we're being apprehended, as Sophina tried to say it, Fina quieted her down.

Walking up before the captain of the knights, she spoke.

"You're a knight of the royal guard. Very well, take me where you will. But will you provide an explanation of the situation?"

The knight spoke.

"Aileen-sama will personally do so at the palace."

Meaning there wouldn't be any explaining along the way.

(Ah man, so she's finally made her move. That's a bit earlier than I thought. My preparations aren't even complete yet.)

Thinking she hadn't made it in time, Fina had Sophina and her subordinates disarm themselves before leaving the room.

A while later, once everyone was wrong, Mii lifted herself from the bed with a pale face.



Meanwhile.

In the palace, leading her knights, the first princess Aileen showed a smile of leisure before the king and queen.

The king was holding his chest, he tried to rise from the bed, but perhaps he couldn't get any power into his body, as he was failing miserably.

The doctor restrained Albach with a desperate look on her face, the queen threw the fan she usually carried at her daughter.

The one who cut that fan down was Fritz, captain of the royal guard.

Brown hair, wearing the uniform of the royal guard, he made a slightly pale face himself.

The queen cried out.

"Aileen! Do you know what it is you're doing!?"

The queen who usually spat cynicism yet remained unperturbed was enraged. The king remained immobile, his disturbed breath causing him to keel over.

Aileen opened her mouth.

"I do. If father cannot move during this great crisis, then someone will have to take his place. The Gaia Empire is making its move. We will have to erect countermeasures of our own."

The queen's expression wasn't directed at her daughter, she sent it to Fritz standing by her side.

"So the princess of our country has been deceived by a single man... I never liked you, but I never thought you would go so far."

As the queen voiced her displeasure towards Fritz, Aileen flew into a rage.

"What do you mean by that!? Fritz-sama is my splendid knight! If you mean to insult him, then even my mother will have no mercy from me."

As the knights readied their weapons, the knights around the king took their weapons in hand as well. With many knights of the royal guard around, to look at the numbers, they were surrounded.

Aileen continued on levelly.

"Just watch on from here. The day Courtois is reborn anew... where status doesn't matter, I shall show you the actualization of a world where everyone lives equally."

On those words, the queen.

"I don't see you capable of accomplishing such a thing. You'd do well to learn, even if you do something like this, no one will recognize you! The rumors will all say Albach's ailment was surely your doing. The times will resent you."

Albach had collapsed from mysterious illness, even the royal physician was unable to treat him.

Aileen had gone on the offense. Albach had two daughters, Aileen and Fina.

Restraining her mother the queen, she had made preparations to restrain Fina as well.

"... Mother, once everything is over, I'll release you. Fina as well. That child is my sister. From here on, I want her to live more freely."

Hearing that, the queen laughed.

"Aha ahahaha! Aileen, you're under a misconception."

At the queen's words, the knights looked at Aileen. Holding them back with a hand, Aileen conversed with her mother.

"A misconception? What do you mean by that?"

"It's simple. You misunderstand who Fina is. That child properly understands it. Though it seems you've taken a liking to moving in the shadows. The talks of your marriage with Aleist... do you know who it was that brought it forward?"

Aileen looked between Fritz and the queen's face.

"So you mean to tell me that child did such a thing."

The queen spoke to Aileen.

"I'm sure there won't be a next time so remember this. Feuds between siblings are not restricted to the royal house, they're a tale you can find anywhere. The Fina you find so adorable might turn out a wild beast, you know."

Aileen expressionlessly led Fritz and the others out the room, leaving knights to keep watch.

(That child... did such a thing!)

Feeling she'd been betrayed, Aileen walked down the palace corridor. Taking along her knights she called out one order after the next.

"Gather all the main members at once. The white and black knights should be here to receive their medals. They both hold vital roles, make sure to call for them without fail."

Fritz watched as the knights moved on Aileen's orders. While he was supposed to be captain of the royal guard, his men were all moving on Aileen's orders.

"Aileen, what exactly is going on? When the Gaia Empire is invading, why is the palace so..."

She had raised what was almost an insurrection. No, it was insurrection.

Aileen smiled at Fritz.

"It's alright, Fritz-sama. I will definitely make fulfill your dreams."

Come so far, Fritz felt something terrifying in Aileen's smile. But having grown so involved, Fritz had lost the option to run away.



Having ventured to the capital to receive a medal, Rudel had come to the front of the dragoon training facilities.

It was a place he was stopping at for the first in a while, but the ones who awaited him were knights prepared for battle. His brigade captain Oldart Billums and the vice-captain Alejandro Campbell.

The other dragoons were also preparing for battle, waiting for Rudel's arrival.

Rudel could see his colleague Luxheidt Aiguille making an apologetic gesture behind the dragoon brigade in full battle formation.

Bennet who had accompanied him there was also perplexed by the situation.

In the first place, Rudel had dropped by to train with Enora. But when he arrived, he found the dragoons preparing for war.

Of course, it confused him.

Failing to grasp anything, Rudel asked the captain.

"Captain, what's all this about? Do you need me to do anything?"

The self-proclaimed charmer in his prime Oldart made a belligerent smile as he spoke to Rudel.

"No, you see... we're just going to put some restraints on the damn fool who laid hands on the dragoon brigade's idol. We're just going to crush a newbie who's gotten on his high horse just because he's got a bit strong. This isn't a personal grudge or anything."

The vice-captain with a scar on his face, Alejandro spoke.

"... Leading beauties around, a guy who's even in a position to lay hands on my daughter. There's no way I could leave him be. We will be setting things straight here."

Thinking they were misunderstanding something, Rudel sent a glance at Luxheidt, who seemed to be the only one still sane.

"Sorry."

While Luxheidt apologized, he looked like he was enjoying it.

Having been looking forward to her training with Rudel, Enora was deeply irritated as she looked at the other brigade members getting in their way.

"Hey, isn't this a bit too terrible? Did you really need to assemble these numbers to take on Rudel? We're a bit busy here."

Feigning calmness, perhaps Bennet was a little scared as her tail curled up.

"T-that's right. What's more, using dragons for personal affairs is strictly prohibited. Captain, this is surely no good."

Rudel surrounded by women.

And Rudel with women sticking up for him.

The will of the dragoon brigade became one.

Oldart.

"Don't screw with me! Bennet-chan, you have to wake up! That man is a wolf!"

Hearing that, Bennet's ears slumped down. Of all else, Bennet was a demi-human, a wolf, and he made it sound like...

"... I'm part of the wolf tribe."

As she said that, Oldart started making excuses. "Men are all wolved beneath the belt," he said as he broke into a sweat.

Meanwhile, Alejandro,

"You should get a bit of a better eye for me! It's Rudel we're talking about. That Rudel!"

Being called a that, Rudel made a dubious expression as he sent a glance over to Izumi, who kept silent all the way. Trying to keep out of it, Izumi seemed truly reluctant to receive that glance.

"Hey, am I really that terrible?"

Izumi.

"In a different sense, you're considerably terrible. No, I think you're a really good guy, normally."

"I-I see!"

Seeing Rudel delighted at Izumi's praise, Enora seemed displeased and Oldart let out a shout.

"You don't have to sweat the small things! We're right here, and so is Rudel! Then there's only one thing to do!"

"We'll show you hell!"

"Today is the day you die!"

"Bury the bastard!!"

Answering their dragoons' cries, the dragons also roared and soared into the skies. Straddling their dragons, the dragoons danced through the air.

Oldart spoke to Rudel.

"Rudel, we'll take you on. Get on up there."

As he said that, he soared into the sky, and the dragoons began flying around as if to draw a circle.

Seeing that, Rudel's eyes began to sparkle.

Enora,

"Those numbers are a bit much. That's more than twenty dragons. Rudel, just go home for today."

Bennet was also worried.

"This is a personal affair. There won't be a problem if you refuse."

She seemed worried for her subordinate Rudel.

Izumi looked over the worried two as she spoke with a resigned face.

"There's nothing you can do when he gets like that. Rudel, make sure you don't get hurt too badly. It will be bad if you get hospitalized before you get your medal."

Rudel smiled.

"Yeah, heave it to me... it's just when my enemy's so serious, wouldn't it be rude not to get serious myself?"

As he said that, Rudel smiled and whistled.

From a large hole near the facility, the white dragon Sakuya popped out her head and roared. The dragons soaring through the sky weakly roared back in answer.

Sakuya landed before Rudel and turned him her back.

A smiling Rudel boarded her in an instant. As he lifted into the air with Sakuya, Bennet sighed.

"You're at a real disadvantage with those numbers. I'll lend a hand. Heleene."

As Bennet called her dragon, a blue beautiful dragon descended to the ground. In her mouth was a mass of meat she had procured from somewhere.

It seems she was in the middle of a meal.

After crushing that boned meat in her teeth and swallowing it down, she directed her back at Bennet.

Enora as well.

"I-I can also... Falk, get over here!"

Appearing in response to that voice was the wind dragon Falk. Spreading out his large wings, he roared and once Enora had gotten on his back, he took to the sky.

Seeing all that, Izumi breathed out a deep sigh.

"Hah, guess I should start running."

She said as she fled from the spot.

◇

In the sky, the dragoons flocked around the white dragon.

"Dammit! She won't fall!"

"She's way too hard!"

"Oy, someone go stall the other two!"

As a subspecies of gaia dragon, a species that faced difficulties in aerial combat, Sakuya flapped her four large, white wings.

Double the size of the gray dragons that made up a majority of the dragoons, she held a different level of intensity. As this expedition had failed to recruit any gaia or red dragons, they lacked any real means to get damage through.

And such a dragon was being guarded by Bennet and Enora's dragons.

While Bennet could perform well on ground battles, in the air, she exhibited abilities lower than the average dragoon. Regardless, she was accompanied by a wild water dragon.

Enora's wind dragon made use of its speed in aerial combat to stand superior.

Against those three dragoons, Oldart's forces numbered over twenty.

But even with seven times the forces, they were unable to put a dent on Sakuya, who struggled in aerial combat.

"No, she's way too hard! It wasn't like this before!"

The one who answered Oldart's panicked voice was Bennet.

"I did my best to train her!"

Looking at Bennet answer full of confidence, Oldart,

"Bennet-chan really is cute~ but Rudel... I won't forgive you!"

Atop Sakuya's back, Rudel blocked the breath attacks coming in from around with his shields of light. And if a dragon got too close, it would be batted away by Sakuya's large arms.

(I planned to beat him down to show him there are still people better, but... so he grew this strong.)

Even as he raised this stupid ruckus, Oldart was amazed by Rudel's growth. He was convinced his own decision hadn't been mistaken.

(It wasn't a mistake to leave him with the strongest in land and air, Bennet-chan and Keith. God dammit, if only Keith was able to eat him up along the way. But eating up Bennet-chan, really cut me some slack.)

Before Rudel who normal dragoons were no longer a match for, Oldart showed a smile.

(Just how strong will he grow.)

Oldart and his dragon took a round around Sakuya as she kept stagnant, blowing away any dragon that got too close. Looking closely, there was also a wind dragon battle between parent and child going on.

"Enora, call it quits already!"

"You're the one who should call it quits!"

The wind dragons were playing a game of chase.

Turning his eyes to Bennet, he saw she was keeping a moderate distance from three dragons, going on the defense to hold them in place.

(Hah, I wanted to be over there. But we can't leave this one like this.)

Oldart looked at Rudel, issuing orders to his subordinates.

"Don't get close, continue circling and sprinkling attacks! Let's see just how long Rudel can hold out!"

There, with a smile of madness from Sakuya's back, Rudel seemed delighted.

"That's just what I wanted!"

He said such a thing.

(... Oh my, this guy's scary.)

Thought Oldart.



It was a tower to shut away royalty.

Within that prison made by royalty was a luxurious cell for royalty.

The room had a fluffy bed, a carpet spread out. All the furniture was in order, and bookshelves were prepared as well.

But they didn't contain books.

Fina looked over the room.

"Good grief, to shove me into a place like this."

She said and breathed a sigh.

There were iron bars running across the window from which the light streamed in. It was impossible for Fina to leave through them.

Across the entrance door were two female knights on watch. Sitting on the sofa, Fina thought over what would happen now.

"... They'll let me look after animals, won't they? I should put in an order."

In her life of boredom, she thought of what would give her warmth. Showing a surprising amount of leisure, it wasn't as if Fina never considered it would come to this.

"Wait a second... if they're going to lock me away like this, that means I don't have to work and I can spend all my time fluffing up fluffy animals, right? Oh me oh my! That might be amazing!"

The expressionless Fina stood, raising both her hands as she did a jump for joy.

"The first one should be a dog, perhaps? And then a cat..."

Just as her fantasies expanded, a knock came at the door.

Before she could answer, the door opened up.

Standing there was her elder sister Aileen.

Leading along her prided knights, she appeared before Fina with a smile.

(What's this, she's appeared without delay.)

Fina stopped her dance and curtsied to Aileen and Fritz.

"It has been a long while, sister."

Aileen motioned her to sit. There were tables stationed with a sofa in-between, and after Aileen took a seat first, Fritz stood diagonally behind her, keeping wary of Fina.

If anything happened, he seemed ready to cut at her.

(Bringing along her favorite knight, looks like someone's having fun.)

While she wanted to complain, Fina endured and sat before her sister. There, Aileen offered an apology.

"This is all happening so fast we haven't found someone to look after you. I can't serve you any tea, I'm sorry Fina."

Fina shook her head.

"Don't worry about that. And so? Can I ask why you've called me here, sister?"

Knowing Aileen would make a move, Fina knew this day would come. Of course, she intended it to be her sister shut in the royal tower instead of herself.

(Well, family feuds are only good sense for the royals and nobles. Perhaps I was a little too naïve. Thought my preparations have gone a considerable way.)

Aileen's face turned from a smile to serious as she explained the present situation.

"Fina, father has collapsed. Luckily, there is no danger to his life. But he is suffering difficulty speaking. To add to that, the Gaia Empire has made its move. Don't you think someone has to take charge in such a situation?"

Fina listened in expressionlessly.

But she closed her eyes.

(Ah~, I just pulled an all nightery, I'm sleepy. They didn't even let me sleep in the carriage. I want to drink some coffee. A straight shot should get me right up.)

She was thinking over something completely different, but Aileen knew Fina's expression wouldn't change and went on.

Perhaps she thought the girl was taking it meekly.

"If we show weakness in such a crisis, the archdukes will take advantage of us. So I have decided to take command. But even if I can suppress the palace, I can't do anything about the knight brigades or the army. So I'm going to have Fritz-sama do his best."

Aileen's gaze turned to Fritz. Fritz stuck out his chest as he came out before her.

Fina...

(Oy, oy, you really sure about that? He doesn't have any experience leading a large force, does he? Rather, he doesn't have any achievements for anyone to recognize him by.)

Fina opened her mouth.

"... What happened to mother. Also, starting with the three archduke houses, a large number of nobles won't be satisfied with Fritz."

Aileen narrowed her eyes, she took on quite a displeased expression.

"For now, I cannot be bothered to care for such a trifle. What's more, we have many who will cooperate with us. Fina, the current Courtois is mistaken. The nobles only ever think of themselves, ignoring the people..."

Fina thought the same. But all she agreed with was the part about Courtois being mistaken.

Right, themselves included.

(We rely too much on the dragoons. An environment of abundant land watched over by powerful dragoons... the surrounding countries have polished various things to go up against us, yet we do nothing at all. We have no prince to succeed, Courtois is filled with problems... it really is a hassle.)

Aileen informed Fina of just how disappointing Courtois' nobles were, and of the pain they caused their people.

And using this as an opportunity, Aileen...

"With a commoner like Fritz' achievements as an opportunity, Courtois will undergo a large change. It will no longer be people for the country, but a country for the people. We will need to make this a country where everyone's equal, where as long as you're skilled, you'll be recognized."

If Fina could make any expression, she would be laughing. What's more, with a belittling smile on her face.

But the words that came out of her mouth...

"You're right. That is important. I do think to evaluate talented personnel and assign them important roles is important. It's just, I cannot quite agree with Fritz-dono being the representative of that. He does not have any achievements."

Aileen remained displeased.

"... He need only start building them up now."

She said.

"Big sister, there are no absolutes in war. Fritz-dono."

Fina directed her eyes at Fritz. He seemed a little surprised, but he instantly replied.

"What is it?"

"The war this time around... do you think we can win it?"

Fritz stuck out his chest as he clearly declared.

"We will win. Using this chance Aileen has given me to prove even a commoner can rise in the country of Courtois is something of a duty to me."

"Is that so," Fina said and looked down a bit.

Aileen to Fina,

"Fina, you'll cooperate with me, won't you? In the academy, you interacted not only with nobles but with commoners as well. Can you understand how I feel?"

As she sought out Fina's approval, Aileen seemed to be trying to increase her allies.

What Aileen spoke of was correct. Fina also wanted to make the system more meritocratic than it currently stood.

It wasn't as if she didn't see the need to reform Courtois that relied on the dragoons so much it ruined itself.

But this wasn't the time.

It hadn't come to that stage.

That was Fina's conclusion.

Fina expressionlessly looked at her sister Aileen head on as she spoke.

"I'll have to decline, sister (A country for the people, eh. That's wrong, sister)."

Seeing Aileen's expression of disbelief, Fina thought.

(It's not people for the country or a country for the people. It takes both sides for a country to exist. As I thought, the two of us are incompatible.)

Fina decided to give Aileen her farewell.



Rudel brought his feet to the palace.

It was to receive his war medals.

In the past, he had saved a town attacked by monsters. The ruckus about Celestia's ancient weapon was finally dying down, and the Kingdom of Celestia sent over some choice words of gratitude.

Receiving them, Rudel and Aleist would receive some medals as well.

Rudel was rarely ever at the palace, Rudel was unable to settle as he looked around.

His accompanying inspector Izumi posed him the question.

"What's wrong? It's rare to see you so restless."

The surroundings were the same, but Rudel felt a sort of tingling sensation on his skin.

"No, that's not it. It's just, this sort of..."

In the middle of their conversation, Rudel spotted Aleist in the hall and called out to him. Leading along his subordinates, for some reason Aleist was holding cleaning supplies.

"Ah, good morning."

Izumi made a dubious face.

"It's been a while since I last saw you like that. Rather, aren't you supposed to be receiving some medals today, Aleist?"

Aleist nodded.

"That's right. That's why I have to finish up my job before that. After this, I just have to return to the room and get ready."

Leaving the palace's cleaning to the heir of a Count House was quite the peculiar tale.

What's more, Aleist was the black knight.

Rudel spoke up.

"Aleist, the palace feels strange, but did something happen? Does it always feel like this?"

To Rudel's question, Aleist.

"No, I did hear a rumor his majesty collapsed. But there are lots of other strange rumors, and I can't tell you what exactly happened."

As Aleist seemed troubled, "I see," Rudel said as he decided to make for the waiting room.

"I'll go on ahead. You're coming later, right?"

As he said that, Aleist nodded with a smile.

"That's right. But I just can't get used to walking around the palace not in these work clothes."

Seeing Aleist's laugh, is that really alright? Thought Rudel, but he kept silent.

The man in question seemed to enjoy his job, and he got the feeling that wasn't something for an outsider to stick his mouth into.

"I'll be waiting."

As Rudel said that and led Izumi off, Aleist waved his hand.

"Yeah, I'll be there before you know it."

He replied.

As they separated from Aleist's group, Izumi began to chuckle.

Rudel seemed puzzled.

"Something funny happen?"

As he asked, Izumi shook her head with a smile.

"No, I was just thinking you and Aleist really have become friends. I just thought it was strange."

"You think?"

"I do."

Being told that by Izumi, Rudel felt a bit awkward as he scratched his face with his fingertip.

At the same time, the atmosphere of the palace still bothered him for some reason.

(I have a bad feeling about this. I hope it goes without issue.)

Chapter 148: And Aleist the Protagonist

The Gaia Empire and the Kingdom of Courtois.

Near the border, a large formation of troops had gathered.

The soldiers sent creeped-out glances at the monsters stationed nearby, on standby as ordered. The most conspicuous monster, the Gora included, they all had white insignia-like lines racing over their black bodies, making them particularly conspicuous.

The black monsters wore their white symbols uniformly.

“Oy, these things better be safe”

“Like I know. All I can tell you is ‘t they’re part of the third prince’s army.”

“But a look at that, and I know Courtois’ is done for this time.”

A great many knights and soldiers were watching the wyverns flying through the sky. They were great in numbers and would obediently listen to the knights riding them.

Seeing that wyvern brigade soar gallantly through the sky, and those knights and soldiers were enveloped with a sense of elation; they would finally be able to win against the Kingdom of Courtois—nay, the dragoons who had tormented them for hundreds of years.

Their supreme commander- the first prince- walked beside Askewell, the third.

More middle-aged than a young man, the first prince looked over the army of monsters.

“Askewell, this is the real test of your army. But are you alright with this? Using monsters to massacre them... not everyone in our lands has the best look on their faces.”

Rather than worried for his younger brother, his tone was one putting a check on him. In actuality, if this war succeeded, then Askewell would be the closest to the seat of emperor.

Askewell noticed they were words wary of a younger brother who was earning a name as the empire's hero.

“Someone has to do it. The empire is already at its limit. Even if my name alone is to fall to the dirt, if that will save tens of thousands of imperial lives, it is a cheap price to pay.”

To Askewell's declaration,

“I see,”

Was all the first prince curtly replied. But continuing on.

“... This time, my army will serve as bait to draw out the dragoons. But are you alright with leaving us so many of your trump card wyvern units?”

Two armies were preparing to assault separate stretches of the border. The division centered around humans was about to make for the border to attract Courtois' main force.

“We have the Gora. What's more, some wyverns of our own. It will be troublesome for me if you don't return alive, big brother.”

An army of monsters surpassing ten thousand.

As he took the lead, Askewell was certain of his victory. No, he was certain victory was the only path to survival.

(Eventually, the empire will wear down and face internal divide. Before that happens, we must obtain as much of Courtois' plentiful soil as we're capable of.)

The imperial palace was in shambles, and family quarrels ran rampant between his brothers and sisters.

Rather than those ever ending, Askewell's eyes captured a future of the empire's division if the central power fell any lower.

The first prince.

"I see. Askewell."

"Something more?"

Askewell looked at his brother, but the first prince was already on his way off. Showing his back, a few short words.

"Come back alive. I'll crack open a treasured wine."

Hearing that, Askewell immediately grew wary of assassination, but that didn't seem to be the mood. The timing was far too unseemly for his death.

"Yes, if you'll put up with me, I'll happily share a glass."

With those words, the two returned to the armies they commanded.



The royal palace.

An individual came for Rudel.

He was a knight of the royal guard, who read aloud the official papers he carried on his person. Rudel heard them out in the waiting room before the ceremony.

Izumi stood to her feet, her eyes wide as she opened her mouth.

“You want Rudel to head to the site alone? Are you mocking us!?”

The royal guard looked at the high knight Izumi and scoffed.

“This is an official order. What mockery is there to be found?”

If it was an order from his majesty, Rudel had no right to refuse. Even if he hailed from an archduke house, he was now working as a single knight of the kingdom.

On the royal decree—

“Izumi, stand down. If I’m told to investigate Gaia movement on the border, I have no right to refuse. I have received my orders. I shall now head to the site. But if there really is movement, I do think the road will be perilous with myself alone.”

— Rudel was told to take the mission on his own. Normally, this would be an impossible situation.

“Rudel, this is crazy! We’re in the palace at this very moment. Why would you be receiving a written decree!? Why does the king not come order you directly!? And you’re a part of the Dragoon brigade. If you were told by the captain, I could understand, but why are you as an individual...”

After confirming the order had been passed on, the royal guard knight immediately left the room. Left on their own, Rudel and Izumi exchanged a glance.

But Rudel was smiling.

“They’re sending me to the site alone... should I interpret that they expect great things of me?”

Izumi sent a sharp glare to his joke.

“Rudel, inform the others at once. This is wrong. There’s something strange about this decree!”

The papers they accepted were definitely signed by his majesty and stamped with his seal. But Izumi continued explaining to him it was impossible.

Rudel was already well aware.

“If the enemy is moving, it’s a part of my job. And you see, I need to head there, even if I’m alone. At the fortress on that stretch of the border... is Chlust. And if they really did move, then I’m sure the captain will soon follow my lead.”

As Rudel was about to leave the room, Izumi grabbed his arm. With a resolved expression—

“I’m going too. It’s too dangerous alone.”

Rudel sent her a smile and pleaded.

“No, the order specifies I go alone, see. And I have to depart at once. I need you to relay this matter to someone. It can be Luecke or Eunius. Is Aleist somewhere around? I’ll take the vanguard and stall the enemy for them.”

Rudel removed Izumi’s hand from his own, and made straight out of the room.

“I’ll catch up with you soon. Don’t do anything crazy.”

To a serious Izumi, Rudel smiled and waved her hand.

“Well, it’s possible they haven’t begun moving for real yet.”

Though he didn’t truly think so.

(I see... it’s finally come. That was sooner than I thought.)

Recalling everything to that point, he did think it would happen someday. He couldn’t understand it herself, but he got the feeling he had seen it coming.

The three black beasts who got in their way, yet lent a hand at the end—the boar, the bird, and the black fog had told him.

(They knew this day would someday come.)

After leaving the room and closing the door, Rudel thought.

(Fate, huh... now that's interesting.)

He hadn't a clue who had set it up. But he thought he had to go there, and those thoughts hastened his feet down the corridor.

His brother Chlust was stationed where a battlefield was expected.

“Just you wait, Chlust.”



The surrounding civilians had evacuated to a fort overseeing the border. A messenger had already been sent to a town further into the country, sending out orders for others to evacuate.

A boy resembling Rudel took charge of the station.

“How's the evacuation efforts!?”

Wearing heavy armor, his subordinate confirmed the fort's situation before answering.

“It ain't looking good, captain. Those knights from central made off with the horses. Said they would spread the word and fled! If it were just the men, maybe, but with dames, kids, and old folk to look after, we're not going to make it.”

The name of the knight called captain was Chlust Arses—Rudel's younger brother, and a knight forced to graduate from the academy.

Reconciling with his brother Rudel, he had a change of heart and fulfilled his duty as a knight of the fort.

But his superior knights fled before the enemy, and at this point, he was going to be forced to stand in as the one in charge.

Chlust looked out the fort.

A black smoke rising in the distance. The black, writhing army of the empire. A flock of monsters.

Looking at the situation before his eyes, he understood why someone would want to run away. But he could hardly bring that to mouth.

“We’ve already sent messengers around. Hold out until the dragoons arrive, then it’s our win!”

The civilians who’d fled into the fort were also consoled by the fact Courtois’ strongest dragoons would come. For better or worse, the ones who had always kept the Gaia Empire at bay were the dragoons.

Those that fled believed they would surely be saved another time. It was precisely because of that belief, that many refused to flee any further than the fort.

(This is bad. They plan to stay here and return home as soon as the war is over. To think our people are the ones who aren’t running...)

The dragoons’ existence granted peace of mind to the people. By that, while they had their anxieties, they were quite calm at the fort.

Whatever their mindset, that would mean Chlust would have to intercept the empire while shouldering a people who wouldn’t proactively flee.

Chlust had sought support from his little sister Erselica. He thought of what he could do and prepared for the time something happened.

Yet he had no way to foresee this great army before his eyes.

(Hold out until the dragoons come? But why have they amassed such an army at this point... they should be well aware they’ll just fall prey to the dragoons.)

All through history, the Empire had suffered great casualties by the dragoons. Chlust worried the empire might be holding some sort of trump card.

To blow away his anxieties, Chlust smacked his hands against his cheeks.

(It'll be fine. We can at least buy some time.)



In the royal palace of the Kingdom of Courtois, Aileen's preparations were underway. The surrounding attendants dressed her in a dress, a report was read to her as she changed.

"I see. So Rudel headed for the battlefield. Well, that one's the White Knight. There's no mistake he contributes to Courtois' war potential. If he loses, Fritz-sama's military exploits will stand out, so he has my thanks in that regard."

A female knight of the royal guard continued on with the report.

"The empire is invading Courtois with two separate armies as planned. It does seem the site Rudel made for is their main force, and they have a considerable number together."

Aileen spoke somewhat fed-up.

"An army of monsters of all things... the empire sure are savages. What about the preparations for the ceremony?"

The female knight informed her that one wasn't going too well. As Aileen's expression clouded, the knight immediately gave a follow-up.

"There is strong opposition to stationing him as supreme commander. Additionally, if you make him supreme commander, Fritz-dono will not have any opportunities to raise any personal military achievements. It is my humble opinion he should be placed in a position that affords him a little more freedom of movement. Perhaps second in command."

Aileen had a hard time accepting it, but there wouldn't be a problem as long as Fritz could perform, so she reluctantly agreed.

“I'll let your side take care of it. But then who will we appoint as commander?”

Courtois' palace was in a hot haste. Where Aileen couldn't see, the female knight curved the ends of her lips.

(Like hell a commoner knight can fulfill such a role. A decoration should act as a decoration should... it is out of the question for royal blood to mix with common mud. The knights will much sooner accept the Black Knight, the same station as our country's founder.)

The nobles and knights hoisting up Aileen simply wanted themselves as the next major power.

There was a problem with Fina, whose expression never changed. The easy-to-manipulate Aileen was more fitting of a portable shrine.

They had followed her for no reason other than Courtois' internal factional strife. Whether war came and land was taken away, as long as they had the dragoons, they knew they could take it back at any time.

That was simply how large of an existence the dragoons were.

“I recommend Aleist Hardie. The conspicuous Black Knight should do well for supreme commander. His parents have already arrived at a manor in the capital. I'm sure they came to see their son in his finest clothing, but they should suffice to hold against him.”

Aileen was a tad displeased with her dress.

“Wait. This color won't pair well with Fritz... change it at once.”

The female knight looked at Aileen and thought.

(You are a wonderful queen, Aileen-sama. With this, one corner of the three lords will fall, a great many nobles will lose their standing... rarely has

such change befallen Courtois, and you are the perfect statue to rally behind. As long as an heir is born, love a commoner all you want. Not that you'll be leaving this castle.)

As Aileen changed her dress, she suddenly recalled.

“Come to think of it, what are we going to do about the sword we prepared for Fritiz-sama? It was prepared as a sword for the supreme commander.”

The knight smiled.

“You need only hand it to the supreme commander. It's a sword made with the finest craft in Courtois, it should hold up perfectly fine if you lend it out for a short while. It's good for show, and using the weapon one's accustomed to is best on the battlefield. Fritz-dono wouldn't care to test the limits of a borrowed blade, he won't be able to fight to the best of his abilities.”

Aileen tilted her head, but she didn't have any particularly deep thoughts when it came to swords. She took the knight's opinion as-is.

“Then I leave it to you. Please let Fritz-sama play an active role.”

The female knight gave a knight's salute.

“Leave it to me.”



It was just a vague feeling, yet he thought this day would come—

Rudel produced his belongings from a bag on Sakuya's back. There were blue ornaments decorating his white armor. He took out his shield and confirmed its state.

Near the dragoon's dragon stables, Sakuya was eating a meal. She was heartily munching down on a large quantity of meat, filling up for a battlefield ahead.

Watching the feed empty at an alarming rate, the dragon stable workers prepared a successive stream of seconds.

“Keep piling it on!”

“Let the other dragons eat too! I don’t care if you have to empty the storehouse!”

“Hurry and check the refill valve!”

Once Rudel informed them of the Gaia Empire’s large-scale movements the dragoon facilities were as boisterous as a hive of bees. A dragoon immediately headed to the palace to confirm the information, while the dragons were put to eating as preparations began.

In the midst of that, Rudel equipped his own armor. Once a crude, functional piece, it was the gift the black fiendish-looking boar granted him at the end. As he put the armor on, Rudel repeated an action of opening and clenching his hand.

When he looked up, the sky was cloudy. The weather looked like it might turn to rain, but that alone wouldn’t delay the attack.

After Rudel pulled down his helmet, he grabbed someone nearby busily moving around.

“My preparations are complete. I’m going to depart.”

The dragon stable work spoke in a loud voice.

“Understood. Um, this is your first campaign, right? Make sure you’re back in one piece!”

Rudel strongly gripped the hand held out for a handshake. The stablehand smiled.

“To think I was the one who prepared the white knight for his first campaign; I want to brag, so go and do something big.”

After returning a smile, Rudel flew off towards Sakuya's back.

(This isn't my first campaign... no, that part doesn't matter.)

When he landed, Sakuya had just finished eating, as she spread out her four wings wide with a roar. From inside the dragon stables, he heard dragon roars in reply.

Rudel stroked Sakuya's back.

“Are you ready?”

‘My tummy is full so I'm fine! Sakuya will drive them back!’

When Sakuya hoisted up her two large arms and showed her motivation, Rudel pat her twice lightly. With that as the signal, she slowly moved her wings and rose into the sky.

The surrounding people took shelter. Even so, once they had risen to a safe height, Rudel spoke to Sakuya.

“Sakuya, I get the feeling this will be an important battle for both me and you. So I'll say it now. Thank you for becoming my dragon.”

Sakuya tilted her head. She didn't seem to really understand what he meant.

‘I don't get it, but Sakuya is Rudel's dragon, you hear! I'll do my best! Sakuya is strong, she'll take the enemy down in no time!’

Rudel laughed.

“I'm counting on it. Now let's be off... _____ awaits.”

Rudel looked beyond the sky, sensing something fuzzy.

Sakuya violently moved her wings, as she gradually built up speed, a wall of magic formed around her. The wind was being blocked by the wall. As Sakuya headed right off for the battlefield, the people working at the stables waved their hands.



Around the time Rudel headed for the site.

His preparations for the ceremony at the palace complete, Aleist was met by his parents.

“Father, mother! W-why!”

Disregarding his confusion, his parents approached and tapped him on the shoulders. They seemed exceptionally pleased, causing him to act bashful.

Aleist’s father spoke.

“We came to see you in your hour of triumph. An invite came right from the palace.”

Aleist’s mother was moved to tears.

“You’ve grown into a young fine man. You were really worrying us, you haven’t come home at all lately. Are you eating right? Haven’t you lost some weight?”

Aleist gave a bitter smile. He took a bit of distance so the two could calm down.

“I-I’m fine. More importantly, I’m just receiving a medal this time, and I’m something of an extra. The real star this time is Rudel.”

When he said that, his father gave him a blank look. Aleist wondered if he had said something wrong. His mother doubtfully opened her mouth.

“Aleist, the Gaia Empire is invading, so you were appointed supreme commander of the subjugation force, weren’t you? The dragoons will drive them off, so I’m sure it’ll be fine, but it’s an unprecedented large appointment at your age.”

Aleist took on a pose of surprise. At his curious posture, his father fell into confusion.

“The palace is already in a panic. The knights are preparing, and it’s already been decided you’d be appointed supreme commander. Don’t tell me you never heard.”

“B-but! I didn’t hear anything in the morning cleaning! And there was nothing at all yesterday!”

Now something completely different surprised his father.

“C-cleaning? What do you mean!? Weren’t you a commanding officer of the defenders? What do you mean you were cleaning in the morning? I never heard about that!”

Grabbed by the shoulders and shook, Aleist was too disheveled for a proper reply.

“Huh? War? The Gaia Empire!? Seriously, what!? Rather, I’m just on the defender cleaning duty and...”

His mother cried out.

“C-cleaning duty!? My Aleist is!? How could my cute Aleist be...! ...Aah.”

“Dear!”

His father embraced up his mother on the verge of collapse. Aleist verified the two were still getting along as well as ever, but more than that...

(A war at this timing... more importantly, is this an event? No, wrong. This isn’t a game. It’s not a game anymore!)

Thoughts of games and events still crossed his mind, but Aleist cut off that train of thought by telling himself this was a different world.

(That’s right. I became friends with Rudel. Eunius and Luecke too... this is the world I live in!)

Just as he was about to rush out of the room, Izumi raced in. She was out of breath, her hair was a mess.

“Aleist! Rudel was... dispatched on his own.”

Aleist opened his eyes wide, his mouth hung down in mute amazement. That was practically the same development as the game. Strangely, in the game, informing the protagonist of the enemy country's invasion was Izumi's role.

Aleist felt something truly ominous at this turn of events.

(At this rate, Rudel will...)

Izumi grabbed Aleist's arm. She made a petition.

“There was definitely a royal decree. But something's wrong. Rudel was ordered to sortie alone... and something's strange about the palace. It's uncannily calm. I'm begging you, save Rudel.”

Holding his swooning mother, his father stuck his glare on Izumi.

“And just who are you? Aleist has the heavy responsibility of supreme commander in the war against the Gaia Empire. If you're seeking help, can't you ask someone more suitable!? Aleist, I'll hear the explanation later. We're out of time.”

Aleist tried to open his mouth. Right after, the royal guard flooded into the room. And the royal guard knights apprehended Izumi.

The one leading them was Fritz.

“It will be quite troublesome if you run amok. Black Knight Aleist, the appointment ceremony will begin shortly. You may escort your parents to the hall. And throw the high knight in the dungeon.”

After baking the orders, Fritz was gone. When Aleist tried to resist, the royal guard had surrounded his parents. Where his parents couldn't see, there were even some whose hands had reached the hilts of their swords.

“You lot... why are you...”

The royal guard simply grinned, they took Aleist in and led him out of the room.



Alongside his tag-along knights, Eunius headed for the hall to participate in the medal awarding ceremony.

He sensed a strange disturbance in his chest, and a panic in the palace, but shoved into a waiting room and put under surveillance, he was unable to move.

While he could understand something was happening, he couldn't understand what it was. From the other end of the corridor walked Luecke.

When Eunius raised a hand, Luecke looked around and sighed. He approached Eunius to complain.

“Don't speak with me so lightly here. More importantly, there's something I've got to ask you. I was just half shoved into my room, but what in the blazes is going on? If someone's capable of doing that to us, who could they be?”

Luecke had a similarly bad premonition. His tone gave the impression he already knew who he was dealing with. Eunius mouthed the name of the person who instinctually came to mind.

“If we're dealing with the royal guard, it's got to be Princess Aileen. But this is some terrible treatment. I've got to get in at least a complaint.”

Seeing Eunius' ferocious smile, Luecke looked like he wanted to say something, but after breathing a resigned sigh, he walked off towards the hall. While the two walked down the palace hallway, their surroundings were in a flurry. Luecke gave a slight smile.

“Perhaps something's happened to Rudel and Aleist as well. Shall we invite them for a protest?”

Eunius smiled mischievously.

“A protest? Now aren’t you proper. We’ve got to send a message. That’s right, let’s get Rudel to circle the palace with his dragon. I’m sure they’ll be shocked.”

Fed-up as he was, Luecke seemed to be having fun.

“But that way, only Rudel will be punished. Let’s see, I guess I’ll try thinking up some interesting revenge. Not like the ceremony’s going to be interesting anyway.”

Eunius looked at Luecke with a mildly surprised face. But different from the last, he gave a truly mischievous grin.

“You really are better as you are now. If we were fighting, it’d be much more fun with the current you.”

Luecke shrugged.

“Still fighting? You’re one who never changes. But... right. I didn’t participate in our final school year. Thinking back on it now, I do regret it just a bit.”

Eunius raised his voice.

“That’s why I told you. Get in the ring, I said! That would’ve been a blast.”

The smiling two approached the hall. But what awaited them there was—



In the waiting room of the audience chamber that would host the ceremony, Aleist couldn’t believe what he was hearing.

While his parents were still there, Aileen made her appearance and told him on the spot to become supreme commander. And Aleist confirmed it with Aileen.

Where was Rudel?

It was the worst possible possibility. Aleist was a reincarnater. Holding knowledge of a game, he knew what would happen if war broke out with the Gaia Empire. The irredeemable villain Rudel runs off to sell out his country, leaving chaos in his wake.

And Rudel is taken out by a prince of the empire. But the Rudel of this world was idiotically positive.

Aleist wanted to think the future had changed somewhere down the line; yet, come so far, as if to snark at him, the world was throwing bits and pieces together to reform the event.

“Rudel was dispatched to the sie where it’s said the Gaia Empire might invade. We have determined that one to be a diversion. So we sent only one unit. There’s a fort there, I’m sure they’ll be able to hold it. He is one of Courtois’ strongest, a dragoon, after all.”

Hearing the location, Aleist’s expression turned even worse. That was the site of the game’s decisive battle. No matter how he considered it, he felt the enemy’s real force was there.

“Only one unit? That’s... at the very least, send backup!”

Aleist’s parents were surrounded by the royal guard. His mother anxious, his father glaring at the knights.

“Princess Aileen, what is the meaning of this!? Such discourtesy, even if you are a royal princess, don’t think this will be forgiven!”

Aileen ignored Aleist’s father’s opinion and turned to Aleist.

“Aleist-dono, you are the supreme commander. You will be granted a sword prepared by the Kingdom of Courtois. For you to carry out your role splendidly. Well, you just have to be there. Please don’t do a thing.”

“Not a thing?”

Aileen nodded.

“Yes, you are an ornament going by the name of supreme commander. We seek nothing more from you.”

Both Aleist and his father glared at Aileen. The surrounding knights directed their weapons at the two.

Aleist firmly held it in.

“Then I will head out as Rudel’s reinforcements. That site is the critical one. If you want an ornament, it doesn’t have to be...”

Aileen seemed troubled. Yes, it was all so troublesome.

“It has already been decided. Or will you throw away any and everything to go to his aid? Very well. I have no interest in you. Of course, at that time, know you will lose everything. The Hardie House will be done for.”

Once Aileen had left, Aleist’s tears broke out. They fell as he collapsed at the knees. He wanted to save his friend. He wanted to go and help Rudel.

He had a bad feeling.

But thinking of his parents, he couldn’t move. They had raised him with love, an impertinent reincarnator like himself, they were his second family. Aleist didn’t know what he was supposed to do.

And into that space, that waiting room, the royal guard shoved in Aleist’s subordinates. His academy Juniors, Seli and Juju had come to join in on Aleist’s ceremony.

The blue haired Nate was also shoved in, mumbling complaints to herself.

If he ran, then those gathered here—

Aleist had a bad feeling about this. And he was mortified at himself, so unable to move. His parents and harem members nervously watched him as he wept.

It was at that moment. Aleist's mother opened her mouth.

"Aleist, raise your face."

"M-mother?"

And with a smile, she spoke to Aleist.

"You want to go save your friend, don't you?"

Aleist's nodded. His tears spilling all over the place, he opened his mouth.

"He's helped me out again, and again, and again. If he hadn't been there, I'd never be where I am now... I was never able to properly say thank you. And yet, I can't even save him!"

He thought he had become strong. He used his game knowledge to raise his level. But wrapped up in a large flow that wouldn't resolve, Aleist couldn't move.

His mother placed a hand on his shoulder.

"... Now move how you want to."

"What are you..."

Aleist's mother spoke to him with a smile. Hearing that, his father seemed bewildered. To his father, in a tone different from usual.

"What is that? Does the Head of the Hardie House fold to such a paltry threat!? All of you, good god, the Hardie House shall support Aleist's actions. We are prepared to take an aggressive stance against the Kingdom of Courtois. If you understand that, you'd best stop chasing after Aleist... you'll never find happiness."

At the end, his mother showed kindness towards his girlfriends. Aleist looked at his mother's face.

"W-why. I mean, if I run from here..."

“He’s a precious friend, isn’t he? Aleist, as long as I can remember, you always had a screw loose somewhere, always chasing around women, you had me worried. When you went off to the academy, there were days I couldn’t sleep, thinking you might have got some girl pregnant. But I think it was around the end of your second year? You were talking so happily about your friend, the happiest I’d ever seen you. The Aleist who always seemed to be looking for god knows what was actually having fun...”

When he thought of how his mother was properly looking at him, Aleist cast down his eyes. Ever since he reincarnated, he had always looked at his world thinking it was a game, not truly looking at anything at all. He spoke to people practically as if watching characters on a screen.

His mother had noticed.

“Aleist, go. To do such a thing, Courtois must be in a precarious position. Even if you obey her here, Princess Aileen will surely continue to issue the Hardie House unreasonable demands.”

His father gave a strong nod.

“That’s right! His majesty is absent, the queen is nowhere to be seen! This is plain suspicious, is it not! Our Hardie House may be upstarts, but there is no reason for us to be treated like this! Don’t worry about us. Aleist, just do what you want to. There’s no way such tyranny shall be allowed!”

Aleist wiped his tears, he stood and looked at his parents’ faces. And embracing them, he cast his words.

“... Thank you. For loving someone as shoddy as me, thank you. I don’t mind if you disinherit me. I’m going to save my friend of my own will. Thank you for everything.”

He didn’t think an excuse like that would work. But he was definitely going to use his connections to aid his parents to the best of his abilities. Luckily, Aleist was friends with the sons of the three lords.

(I’d rather not use them like this, but...)

Aleist turned to look at his girlfriends. The girls who gathered once he lost interest in a harem. To be completely honest, he didn't know whether or not he loved them.

But they were people he couldn't hate. And traveling with these girls was fun.

“... I'm sorry. I am no longer the heir to a Count House, nor am I a knight of Courtois. As but a single human, I'm going to save a friend. I'm sure I've caused you some trouble, but this is where we part ways. Thank you... and goodbye.”

After incapacitating the royal guard knights on watch with his bare hands Aleist leapt out of the room. He told everyone not to linger as he raced his way of the palace.

He got the feeling he had lost many things. But at the same time, he couldn't overlook the plight of his dear friend who had opened his eyes.

(I'm sure I'll never be anyone important. I'm not a hero. I'm stupid and servile... even so, it can just be for once. Can't I stand up just once for the sake of a friend!? If I run away here, I'll never forgive myself for the rest of my life.)

To save a friend—save Rudel, Aleist rushed down the corridor.

Chapter 149: The Empire's Advance

“So you were brought here too.”

The jail cell the royal guard led Izumi to was already occupied by Sophina. A clammy underground dungeon, she could barely make out her face by the unreliable light.

“U-umm,”

Izumi was a high knight, same as Sophina. But Sophina was her senior and the second princess Fina's guard who headed a unit of her own. Why was she here? As Izumi puzzled over it, Sophina lifted herself off the bed and stretched.

“The princess was taken in too. We were bound and shoved in here. Our weapons were taken, but our clothes were left as is. They must be in quite a hurry.”

Perhaps there was no time to dress them in prison robes, as after taking their weapons and shoving them in the cell, the royal guard knights had already gone off somewhere.

The soldier keeping watch over them seemed restless as well.

“Just what could have... this is just too terrible.”

Sophina fully agreed with Izumi's words. While she agreed, she was keeping somewhat collected.

“There’s been movement in the palace for quite a while now. It’s just, I never imagined they would take it this far.”

“You know something? I need to get out of here fast and save Rudel.”

“... Err, did something happen to Rudel-dono?”

Sophina seemed troubled. Izumi promptly explained he had been sent off to the battlefield as a lone rider. When she described Aleist’s predicament, Sophina seemed surprised.

“So the black knight’s the supreme commander. Not bad. I thought she’d force Fritz into the position, but... did someone stop her? She’s surprisingly brittle.”

“You sure are calm.”

At Izumi’s light sarcasm, Sophina gave a sardonic laugh. After checking her surroundings, she whispered.

“Hey, don’t be like that. I managed to learn this and that was going on thanks to the princess. Sorry, but my lord was taken in too... until the major players at the palace make their move, I doubt she will make hers. That’s the sort of person she is.”

“Then she has something planned? If she doesn’t hurry up with it, something terrible will—”

“It’s already plenty terrible. But see, she intends to use these developments as well. She really is... if she was just a bit more decent of a human being, you can’t imagine how easier my life would be.”

After saying that, Sophina instructed Izumi to lie down and get some rest.



The audience chamber.

The gathered nobles were informed not of medals to be bestowed.

The kingdom of Courtois' audience chamber was a vast room, its make of an extravagance worthy of a major power. The knights and nobles gathered in such a place, Eunius and Luecke included, were mostly struck dumbfounded.

The king wasn't taking part.

The queen nowhere to be seen.

Princess Aileen stood in front of the throne, giving an address.

"The Gaia Empire has yet to learn their lesson, they are once again preparing to invade Courtois soil! Their parch has already begun... the time has come to show your loyalty to Courtois!"

Within all the confusion, upon hearing of the Gaia Empire's march, the nobles were quick to direct their eyes to the dragoons taking part.

While they feigned composure, the dragoon brigade members looked to be holding it in.

"We will prepare to depart at once. But first... we initially intended to request the role of supreme commander in this battle to the Black Knight. However, the black knight has fled like the coward he is. While he might not be a fitting replacement, I appoint the Captain of the Royal Guard, Fritz-dono as Supreme Commander."

The audience chamber fell into chaos. It wasn't because the Gaia Empire had invaded. They had invaded too many times to count, and just as many times, the dragoons had repelled them.

The nobles' interests were drawn to the commoner Fritz appointed as supreme commander of the armed forces. Without any decent deeds of arms, and still young; the voices of dissatisfaction rose against him.

But Eunius didn't let it elude him.

"There are some around who aren't surprised."

From nearby, Luecke nodded.

“Aleist isn’t here, but I don’t see Rudel either. That woman did something. To think she’d go this far.”

Neither Aleist nor Rudel were anywhere to be seen.

A confused gathering of knights and nobles. But among them were some not confused in the slightest, the royal guard, for one.

Eunius didn’t seem amused.

“I doubt they’re dead, but... I’m returning to my territory. I’ll be sending soldiers from my place.”

Luecke glanced at Aileen, giving her address before the throne.

“What a coincidence. Once this farce is over, I’ll be right on my way back ___”

And Fritz walked out before Aileen. As he walked out in front of her, he was gifted the sword, the proof of his station by Aileen’s hand.

Eunius looked at that sword.

“Haven’t I seen that sword somewhere before—”

Aileen, after handing the sword to Fritz.

“This is a sword produced by gathering the best technology Courtois has to offer. Surely it’s worthy of the supreme commander. You have to make sure you bring it back.”

Fritz held the sword high.

“Without fail, I shall return here and report on our victory!”

Luecke, to Eunius’ comment.

“Looks like it’s only just been made. You must be seeing things. Forget that, she hasn’t said a word about Rudel.”

Luecke worried for his friend.



Aleist had come to the basement dungeon.

Showing himself from within the shadows of the dim cells, he restlessly checked his surroundings.

“Izumi-san, are you alright?”

Izumi sprung off the bed, looking at Aleist who had somehow entered her cell in surprise.

“I never knew you could do that.”

“Well you see, as I was chased around by night visits, I learned a thing or two on how to use it. Being the Black Knight sure is convenient... wait, no time to chit-chat. Here.”

Aleist pulled out Izumi’s katana from the shadow and handed it over. He tossed over the key alongside it.

“I’m in your debt. Aleist, what’s the situation right now?”

After accepting the katana and gripping the key tight, she tried to confirm the present situation from Aleist. But he hung his head.

“Sorry. I’ve just been running around. I want to inform Eunius and Luecke of the situation, but it’s not just the royal guard, it seems Princess Aileen’s got some allies in other places... It’s hopeless for me, I just stand out too much. I’ve come for your cooperation...”

Sophina in the cell lifted her body and turned to Aleist.

“... The defenders.”

“Pardon.”

“Seek help from the defenders. Use the princess’ name if you have to. If you just need to deliver a message, they can still move around the castle freely. Can you give me just a few more details on the state of affairs?”

Aleist reported everything he’d managed to learn.



The captain of the dragoon brigade Oldart faced the supreme commander Fritz.

With Princess Aileen stationed to his side, he couldn’t make any rash remarks.

“In short, you’re putting us under the commander’s control? It’s troubling that you’re saying something so blatantly obvious, and it’s also troubling that you arbitrarily sent my subordinate off to the battlefield. You said it was an area of low priority, but in the present state with the empire attacking on two fronts, one unit’s worth of war potential is clearly not up to par. I shall send additional reinforcements.”

Oldart’s discontentment came from Aileen superseding him, sending Rudel to a warzone unassisted. A dragon was certainly powerful. They were powerful, but a battle was also about numbers.

Sending only one rider was something he couldn’t overlook as the captain. And he couldn’t forgive that she ordered around one of his men.

Fritz boldly responded.

“As long as their main force lies elsewhere, it is only natural we concentrate our war potential there.”

Oldart gave a scornful laugh.

“You sound like you already know which one’s their main force... while we haven’t received a lick of information. What could that possibly mean?”

There, Aileen stuck in her mouth. Fritz had faltered ever so slightly, so she was surely to cover for him.

“Now’s not the time to speak of such matters. Under Fritz-sama’s command, the dragoon brigade will band together and drive back the empire. That is an order.”

If she called it an order, he had no choice but to obey.

However—

“If it’s an order, I’ll obey. I want to get this over with already so I can save my subordinate. How about we have a good talk once I’m back?”

Under Oldart’s glare, Fritz.

“Then prepare to depart at once. The dragoon brigade will take the lead to beat down our foe. Based on the speed of their preparations, the main force will depart immediately.”

But Aileen added on.

“Dragoon captain... in the case the enemy crosses the border, I will permit an attack. But I won’t approve of anything else.”

Oldart spoke through a sign.

“I’m well aware. How long do you think we’ve been protecting the border?”

Aileen simply gave a fearless smile. It was more than enough to tip Oldart off that something was up.

(... Now then, what do I do about this? I guess I’ll have Keith move or something.)



It was the Arses House mansion.

Erselica made a desperate plea before her father's room.

“Father, when Chlust-niisama is fighting, why won't the Arses House send reinforcements!?”

No matter how she raised her voice, she never got a response. It wasn't only her father, upon learning of Chlust's predicament, her mother wouldn't attempt any action either.

Having frequently exchanged letters with Chlust, Erselica knew the situation of the border fort in detail. She learned of the Empire's movements from Chlust as well.

On that front, Erselica had supported him to the best of her abilities. But come so far, the notice came that the empire had finally initiated its full mobilization. The Rases House showed no signs of moving.

Around the room, the retainers had gathered.

(If I'd just moved faster.)

A vexed Erselica raised her voice at the door time and again.

“I'm begging you. The preparations are already in order. All that's left is for you to give the order, father, and we will be on our way.”

She had already confirmed her father was in the room, and the Arses House had completed its preparations to sortie. Looking at them as an archduke house, they could only send a minuscule number, but that was all Erselica could prepare with all her might.

“There are other lords who have promised us their cooperation. Why must my own father, an archduke, remain stationary when his country is in a time of crisis!?”

Her desperate pleas wouldn't reach her father in the room. Not only that, to Erselica and the retainers gathered before the room—

“What is the meaning of this, how irritatingly noisy!”

— From the other side of the corridor, her mother appeared leading along her servants.

“Mother! You throw in a word too! The fort Chlust-niisama is stationed at is under attack by the empire. I seek permission to send reinforcements!”

Her mother offered a cold rebuttal to her words.

“... That child is the failure of the Arses House. If he puts up a hard fight at the fort and dies in battle, it will at least somewhat recover the Arses House’s reputation. And even if we don’t move, the likes of the empire can be driven back by those dragons.”

Erselica listened on in terror. She shook her head to the side.

“... I’ve heard enough.”

“What’s with that attitude? Someone lock Erselica up. Good grief, causing such a ruckus...”

As her mother tried to leave, she was surrounded by armed knights and soldiers.

The butler by Erselica’s side didn’t find fault in that.

“What is the meaning of this!? Who do you think I am!”

Turning to her clamoring mother, Erselica shot back.

“If you are to take a watchful stance in this crisis, you have no qualifications to lead this house! Bind and imprison my father and mother! We will be sending reinforcements immediately. Tell the lords who’ve promised assistance to dispatch at once.”

While the knights and soldiers moved around, soldiers with axes appeared in front of the room. They destroyed the door and flooded in.

As the soldiers apprehended her, she looked at Erselica.

“Do you understand what you’re doing!? Such an act... no one will ever recognize it!”

The more Erselica watched her mother, the sadder her expression became.

“... There are no vassals here who will assist you. The only ones here are those discontent with your deeds. The others all ran away when I imparted precise information and asked for their cooperation.”

Erselica had put in a request to Lena to have Luecke look into the factional relations. What factions the surrounding feudal lords pledged allegiance to, and what houses had an invested interest.

There were plenty of lords and palace officials who didn’t think so kindly of the Arses House’s present state that would collapse if things were to go on.

By talking with those people, Erselica had made her own preparations.

“Erselica-sama!”

One of the knights restrained her father and led him out of the room. While he wore a gown, he had nothing but undergarments on underneath.

There were a number of women and it was permeated with the scent of alcohol. Looking down on her father muttering complaints, Erselica spoke.

“Take him away. We don’t have time to waste on him.”



While the manor was in a boisterous commotion, Lena climbed up to the roof and looked up at the sky.

“... Now then, I should get moving.”

Holding her spear, wearing clothing easy to move around in, Lena whistled. That whistle that resounded through the sky, it almost seemed as if it was calling for something.

Sitting right down on the roof, it seemed like Lena was going to stay there and wait until whatever she called for arrived.

“You think that broski of mine’s gonna win against fate?”

Curiously, Lena smiled.

From the start, Lena was a peculiar sister. She was Rudel’s peculiar sister. At the start, Rudel was able to become more human because Lena was there. When Rudel held no interest for other people, he showed interest towards Lena. At the important times, it was Lena who was involved with Rudel.

Not directly, she had always been indirectly tied in.

“Well, he’s my broster, he should be fine.”

Lena said and looked at the sky.



The scene shifts to a fort continuing its resistance.

The army led by Askewell of the Gaia Empire had continued minor attacks as if to torment it.

There were a number of reasons, but while they managed to infiltrate foreign soil well enough, they had advanced without receiving anything that could be classified as resistance.

Dispatching units to the towns and villages in the area, they were scraping together supplies.

Keeping a low profile to Askewell’s side, Mies looked bitterly at the supplies they had gathered.

In the tent, she reported the present situation to Askewell as he sat in his chair.

“Askewell-sama, the enemy has mostly pulled out. While a small portion of villages have ignored the evacuation order and remained, I believe the enemy commander ordered the civilians in this parts to find refuge as soon as our side started moving.”

Askewell quietly muttered.

“I see. Then the monsters must be hungry.”

From the start, the black monsters of his army were disposable pieces. And those pieces had their own role in his forces.

The empire was teeming with people. The plan was to migrate to Courtois’ plentiful soil, and with that goal in mind, the people living on that land were in the way. Taking care of that disposal was the monsters’ job.

“I thought this was a country that could only rely on its dragons, but it looks like it has some staunch men of its own. To let the people flee, and try to hold out at but a small fort.”

Mies confirmed their future course with Askewell.

“What should we do? It would be simple to crush them, but we intended to set up a base of operations there, so that would greatly affect the—”

After Mies had said that much, a messenger soldier entered the tent.

“Your Highness! Enemy dragoons are approaching! Gray in color! Two riders!”

Askewell grinned at that report.

“... Perfect timing. Send out the wyvern unit.”

The moment the messenger left the tent, the surroundings were filled with the voices of monsters.

Askewell stood to his feet; Mies followed him outside. Around them, wyverns took to the sky one after the next, with knights in black armor

straddling their backs.

They were up against two knights, yet their charge consisted of a few dozens.

Gray dragons.

Dragons domesticated by Courtois, they were said to be the weakest, but even so, they had been a threat to the empire as it was. While the soldier seemed anxious, they looked like they had some hope in the wyvern unit's dispatch.

No, one might say they were sending their prayers. To the empire, the dragons were they symbol of fear. In the past, a single blue dragon had been enough to put them through countless terrifying experiences.

That fear was passed from father to child, succeeded by their grandchildren.

In regards to the two dragoons, the dozens of wyverns surrounded them to carry out their attack. Perhaps as expected of a dragon, they put up a good fight against the wyverns, but in the end, before the difference in numbers, one eventually fell to the ground.

Askewell looked over the scene.

"Looks like three on one will be enough to fight. Their aerial maneuvers are rough, but they should be able to fight well enough."

The surrounding black monsters and human soldiers gathered to attack the fallen dragoon.

Raising a cheer, the dragon's head was lopped off and hoisted high into the sky.

"The era of the dragoons is over!"

"Glory to the Empire! Glory to Prince Askewell!"

"Have a look, the other one's running away!"

Overhead, the dragoon surrounded on all sides received attacks as if it were being made a game of. Even so, four allied wyverns took a fall.

“... If they get in some combat experience, the wyvern unit could become a mainstay of the empire’s forces.”

Askewell sent a sorrowful look at his dead subordinates. They were his precious troops and his comrades. Watching Askewell mourn his fallen comrades, Mies was moved.

“Askewell-sama, you’re too kind.”

The final dragoon fell to the ground. Was it the bond between knight and dragon? The dragon followed his rider to the ground as if to protect him. On land, the knights and soldiers raised cried, and the monsters flocked around knight and dragon.

To the empire, this was the scene they had waited so long for. The once-rulers of the sky, the dragoons falling to their earth, the scene of their own wyvern unit becoming the sky’s new sovereigns.

It meant the era of cowering from Courtois was over.

“Show the heads of knight and dragon to the fort! After we chip their fighting spirit, advise them to surrender!”

The surrounding knights raising cheers, they held up their weapons and thrust their fists towards the heavens.

Within that, his golden hair fluttering behind him, his body clad in black armor, Askewell was a picturesque sight to behold.



“Captain!”

In the first, Chlust was woken from his rest by his subordinate.

He hadn't slept in days, and while he attempted to get in just a few hours, the situation had vehemently changed.

Rising from the bed, Chlust slapped his cheeks to wake up as he received the report.

“What happened?”

“The empire... the empire took out a dragoon!”

Hearing the words, Chlust made off without the chance to grab any proper armor. Once he arrived where there was a good view he saw the heads of two dragons, and the terrible state of two knights lined up in the plaza in front of the fort.

Two imperial knights ordering around black ogres loudly demanded their surrender.

“Bear witness to what Prince Askewell's new unit has made of the dragoons you relied upon! Cowards of Courtois! You have been given the option. Fight for this fort to your deaths or surrender and submit to the empire!”

The imperial knight's words threw the local civilians who remained at the fort into a panic. They had never even imagined that a dragoon could lose.

It had never occurred to Chlust that the dragoons who came to their aid would lose so easily.

“How in the... there's something in the sky.”

In the air above them, a dragon-like shadow... no, Chlust was a man born of Courtois. He knew that shadow was different from the dragons of Courtois.

From his knowledge, he could make out what sort of monster it was.

“Why are wyverns... they're supposed to have even harsher temperaments than dragons. No human has ever been able to make a contract with them before!”

Chlust's subordinates were gathered around him, cautiously glancing around.

“Captain, the civilians who didn't flee are demanding an explanation. At this rate, this fortress will become a battle royal!”

The people who fled into the fort and said they wouldn't move until the war was over were beginning to raise a ruckus. They had been certain there was no way they would lose, but hearing of the dragoons' defeat, they were beginning to stir.

“That's why I told them to run... dammit!”

Chlust was cornered into a situation with enemies both inside and out.

It was a small fort.

If the citizens taking refuge inside ran amok, the knights and soldiers would have to fight to save their own skin. When that happened, the fortress insides would turn to hell.

The troops that remained were fighting to protect Courtois. If they had to kill their own citizens, it would lead to a large loss of morale. If it came to that, protecting this fort would be impossible.

Before the fort, the imperial knight yelled.

“If you bring out the fort commander's head, we wouldn't mind setting you up as nobles. Unlike Courtois, the empire pays its dues!”

Loudly, the knight laughed.

Chlust and those around him heard it out in despair. The civilians were beginning to gather around them.

Chlust's subordinate.

“Stand down! Don't try to go out.”

They readied their weapons to threaten the evacuated civilians, but those civilians had gripped farm implements, and whatever weapons they could find around the fort.

“I-it’s your fault for losing, bastards!”

“If I can become a noble in the empire...”

“We just want to live in peace!”

Chlust regretted leaving his armaments in his room.

(To think I would be killed by those I was to protect... sorry, brother. This is as far as I go.)

Chlust had begun considering surrendering himself to the enemy. If that would save his men and the people here.

But something passed over the skies of such a fort.

To the skies where those of both Courtois and Gaia raised their heads, a dragon with four, large white wings was falling towards the ground. Once its large build slammed into the soil, the surrounding imperial knights, soldiers, and a great many black monsters were blown off of their feet.

From above, a wyvern opened its mouth to hammer in its breaths, but that mouth pierced through by a large sword of light, the magic storing in its mouth reacted, exploded, and blew off its head.

While a cloud of dust covered everything, a glimmering something let off an explosion of light.

The sounds of screams chimed out in turn, and at the end, the white dragon’s large wings blew away the dust.

What appeared was a single knight clad in white armor, his blue mantle fluttering in the wind. Imperial knights and monsters gathering around him. That knight in white armor was soon surrounded.

Chlust muttered—

“... Brother.”



Landing on the ground alongside Sakuya, Rudel leaned the sword in his right hand against his shoulders.

Looking around, there was nothing but enemies.

Two gray dragon heads presented before the fort, the husks of knights were stuck up in unsightly states.

One among them was Rudel's contemporary.

Saas Venia—a dragoon, while he had a bad look in his eyes, he had a knack for looking after people.

Rudel had heard he'd been stationed on the border, and after rushing to help, he had died in battle.

“... You're disrespecting a warrior.”

As he sent around a look, the imperial knights and soldiers behind the black monsters raised their voice. Surely they were giving orders for his death. Rudel closed his eyes.

The blue eyes he slowly opened turned red, precisely taking in the movements of his surroundings. Within a sensation as if time was slowly passing by, Rudel spoke.

“I'm sure you all came here knowing you might now return to your fatherland alive.”

Matching Rudel's wrath, Sakuya roared into the sky. As surrounding soldiers covered their ears at that ear-shaking din, Rudel rushed forward and cut down the black ogre that had rushed out before him.

It was the sort of black ogre he encountered in his school days, its body covered in the white insignia of one who had once tried to get in his way.

Rudel took a swipe at the net ogre.

“... I take it you’re serious. But you won’t advance a step further!”

Turning his left hand forward, Rudel manifested a number of swords of light around. The point of each made off towards its own destination, impaling monster and enemy soldier alike.

While one of the knights parried the sword with his blade, it exploded and crumbled his stance. Not letting the opportunity slip by, Rudel closed in and let his sword run from his left shoulder to right hip.

Armor was cut through, blood spouted as a terrible scene spread around.

Sakuya brushed away ogres with her giant arms; she fired off her breath towards the sky. As the airborne wyverns came into contact with her breath, their wings tore, sending them falling to the ground.

In contrast, even if the wyverns’ breath hit Sakuya directly, it didn’t exhibit any particular effect.

The knight taking command in the back.

“R-retreat! Retreeaat!!”

The order cemented the knight in Rudel’s mind as the commanding officer, and closing the distance in an instant, he smacked his foe with the shield in his left hand.

The knight commanding from horseback tolled across the ground, while his horse acted up and ran off elsewhere.

The knights around tried to surround Rudel with their spears and swords. Taking a lance thrust at him from a mounted knight in his left hand, he snatched it away, and stuck it into the torso of a knight with a sword.

Returning his own sword to its scabbard, he used a stolen sword to cut at the nearest soldier. Another swift movement, as he cut down monster and human in succession, his form, his movements were truly close to a beast's.

“You... monster!!”

Blown away by Sakuya, and rapidly sunk into a sea of blood by Rudel, the unit of the empire.

It didn't even take an hour for everything to be over.

The scene was witnessed by the soldiers and knights of the fort, and the evacuated residents in gross fascination.

When it had ended, Rudel apprehended an unconscious enemy leader. With a wave of his hand, he ordered those watching from the fort to collect the commander from him.

Tossing aside the sword he was holding, Rudel walked over to the husk of a comrade.

“... I'll get you down. Sakuya, you take care of the dragons.”

‘... Yeah.’

Sakuya recovered the dragon's heads, and as she gently placed them on the ground, Rudel released his comrade and contemporary from their gruesome fastenings.

To his friend Saas' husk, Rudel made an address.

“I didn't make it in time. I'm sorry... but I'll fight for your share. I shall definitely spread word of your heroism.”

Once soldiers raced in from the fort, Rudel looked around. The monsters and soldiers he had killed were littered around, but strangely, the monster dissolved into black smoke and disappeared.

The black fumes ignored the pull of the wind, making off somewhere.

Rudel's expression was harsh as he looked at the sky, but there he heard a nostalgic voice.

“Brother!”

When he turned, there was Chlust, not in a decent piece of armor. He must have hurried, his breathing was considerably rough.

“... You did well to hold out, Chlust.”

Chlust didn't know what he was supposed to say. But looking at Rudel, he made a serious face.

“Brother, that was only a small portion of the empire's army. Their main force is still ahead, scraping together supplies from the area. I have to ask, how many reinforcements can we expect?”

Seeing Chlust make the face of a commander, Rudel mood lightened just a bit. But the thought couldn't remain.

“Unfortunately, I was sent as the vanguard. I don't have any definite information on reinforcements.”

Chlust hung his head a bit.

“Understood. And thank you... you saved us.”

He gave his thanks.

Chapter 150: Comrade

After entrusting the defenders with a message to Luecke and Eunius, Aleist had come to the gate to slip out of the palace.

Concealing himself in the pillar of a shadow near the gate, he kept a close watch from within its shadow.

(I doubt I'll be able to break through the walls or gate.)

They were bestowed with a special make, an especially high resistance to magic in order to protect the palace.

There were armed soldiers stationed around and an order had been issued for Aleist to be captured on sight.

While he had been able to evade all attempts, the Black Knight's power didn't allow him to teleport. At most, he could sink into and move across shadows.

The sun was high in the sky, leaving little room for him to hide, let alone move. When he hid, only a single stretch formed a conspicuously darker shadow, which might give him off all too easily.

(Drat! I spent so long moving around, that time is... it looks like my parents and the others got away, but...)

Izumi had made for Luecke and Eunius alongside the defenders. It was a stroke of luck that within the uproar of war preparations, it seemed they weren't keeping a proper count of those in the cells.

But Aleist alone was different.

His renown had him on the run from those in the palace affiliated with, or whose superiors were affiliated with Aileen's faction.

(They've sealed the back door and escape ways, so I thought I'd try the gate)

As Aleist considered forcing his way through, the soldiers in front of the gate beckoned to him. He hid himself in surprise, but when one of them removed their helmet, Aleist instantly recognized him as a dear friend from his school days.

It did seem he had known he was hiding in the shadows. The other soldiers couldn't notice, but his friends ended up picking him out.

"Captain, can I go take a piss..." one of them said, separating from his units and racing over towards Aleist.

Circling around the round pillar, Aleist stuck his upper body out from the shadow.

"It's been a while, Aleist."

"Y-yeah, it really has... no, I know now's not the right time to catch up."

It wasn't like Rudel group were Aleist's only associates. While it may be strange to spell it out so plainly, Aleist had a few friends.

Keeping wary of his surroundings,

"Why did you run away? Supreme commander's got to be a huge promotion. Your parents and girlfriends got through... but the palace is going to send someone after them in no time."

Aleist gave a general explanation. That this world was strange, and on top of Aileen running wild he explained in as shortest terms as possible that Rudel was in danger.

His emotions getting the better of him, he didn't know if he was properly getting his thoughts across.

While still confused,

“... Got it. Luckily, the three of us are in the same unit. Makes things convenient.”

“Convenient?”

“We’ll open the front gate just a bit. Use that opening to break through.”

To his friend’s proposal, Aleist shook his head to the side.

“No way. You’ll get yourself killed.”

His friend smiled a bit.

“Play it off well, and it’ll end at the dungeons. And you know,”

“You know?”

As Aleist worried, his friend smiled.

“This is the most we can do. Don’t be such a stranger...”

His friend pulled his helmet back down, and running off from behind the pillar, he immediately informed his captain he had returned. After explaining the situation to the other two, the three immediately sprung to motion.

It was necessary to move a mechanism to open the gate; two of them faced the soldiers protecting the lever, while one of them distracted the captain.

And—

“Bastards! What are you doing!?”

By the time the captain noticed, the gate was already half opened. While Aleist hesitated a bit, he soon leapt out from the shadow and made a dash for the gate. To hurriedly close it, the knights and soldiers had flocked around the lever, letting him run through with ease.

A look back, and his friends were being smacked. But in the moment before it slammed down.

“Go! Aleist!!”

They cried. The troops raised a great ruckus, they’d begun to gather. Aleist made a clenched fist, he grit his teeth as he dived into the shadows beyond the gate and sped away.

While the knights tried chasing Aleist shadow, upon shifting to the shadows cast by the town scape, he easily shook them off.

(I’m sorry. I’ll definitely be back to save you!)

Aleist prayed for the safety of his friends.



Into the basement dungeon, three battered knights were shoved in.

Sophina watched from a cell on the opposite side.

“... What did these three do?”

She confirmed it with the soldiers who took them in; the lead soldiers looked down over the three.

“They helped the black knight escape. Good grief, I can’t comprehend why someone would aid a coward fleeing from war. If they really are friends, they should’ve stopped him.”

With work to do, the soldiers soon left the cell.

“Are you friends of the Black Knight?”

The battered three looked to have been beaten quite brutally. While their bones were probably intact, their faces and bodies were ridden with bruises.

One of them muttered.

“Ha, hahaha, that’s right.”

On that answer, Sophina reached her arm through the iron bars. Her left hand let off a faint light as the three writhed in pain, their injured parts acting up.

“Stay put. It’ll be over soon.”

The dungeon’s watchman raced over.

“What are you doing!? Don’t make any funny moves.”

He held up a spear to intimidate her, so after a scoff,

“It’s already done. Don’t tell me you have a problem with treating their injuries? And it’s not like I’m being kept here for committing a crime.”

As the watchman went off with complaints on his breath, Sophina looked at the three raising their bodies. And—

“Now then, you’ve taken some drastic measures, I see. If luck’s against you, your punishments might reach all the way to your families.”

The three gave thanks for the healing magic.

“The magic was a lifesaver. But to think that guy’d look so serious... and when we heard Princess Aileen was involved, our generation can’t help but be suspicious.”

Rudel and Aleist’s generation was one especially exposed to Aileen’s preferential treatment of Fritz. They had witnessed and formed a doubt.

Sophina had spent a few years at the academy as Fina’s guard. Through that relationship, she was relatively knowledgeable on the academy’s circumstances.

“I see... your year was one with a strong doubt towards Princess Aileen. In that case,”

As Sophina considered adding these three to her war potential, the footsteps of an armed group resounded through the basement dungeon. The shrill sound of scraping metal, and the screams of watchmen.

“W-what are you—!”

The watch instantly fell silent, as a tall gathering peered into to confirm the contents of the cell.

One of the three,

“Tiger tribe? Why are they in a place like...”

A tall, armed tiger tribe young man spotted Sophina. Taking along the two, he walked hunched-up through the narrow-looking passage.

“I take it you are Sophina-san. The princess orders you to get ready.”

Hearing that, Sophina.

“So it’s come. You’re here anyway, so get my subordinates and those three too. It’s best to have as much manpower as possible.”

Once the tiger tribe men opened the lock, Sophina met up with her subordinates in the other cells.

(Now then, the fact that we’re moving means...)

◇

“NUHOHOHOoHoooo!”

Rolling on the bed, Fina was getting her fill of vacation in a room far too luxurious for a prison.

“The seedy cheap fluff of this pillow is irresistible. If it was just a bit fluffier, it would be perfect.”

She was shoved in a cell right after pulling an all-nighter: after eating, she crashed, woke up, took a bath, then fell asleep all over again. Leading such a no-good lifestyle, Fina found there were no lifeforms to her tastes or demi-humans around, so she embraced her pillow and rolled across the bed.

And yet.

“Hah, and now I’m bored. It really doesn’t hold up to real fluff. Rather, I’ll make do with a sewer rat, someone, anyone come out. I just want to give you food and rear you to liven the place up a bit.”

Speaking as if she was scolding who she was up to a moment before to learn some self-reflection, even placed in this situation, Fina was expressionless and calm.

Getting somewhat a feel of the ruckus in the palace, she sensed the main players were moving, so she had gone into preparations.

Moving her expressionless body, Fina went into some warm-up stretches as she spoke.

“My word, when you already know it’s going to happen, it sure is quick to prepare for. Though thanks to that, we can move just as fast.”

Breaking into a peculiar dance, Fina loosened up her body before sitting on the bed. She corrected her posture, keeping as motionless as a doll.

It was at that moment she heard a boisterous voice from the door.

‘W-who are—!’

‘Call for backu—!’

She remained stationary throughout the ruckus. When the door opened, a full-armed Mii popped in her head. She could see other demi-human soldiers and knights through the gap in the door.

“P-princess, we’ve come to save you.”

Fina gave a small, expressionless nod. It wasn't just to Mii, she had to show her surrounding allies the sort of character she was.

“I'm glad you could make it, Mii. I'm sure you've all had a hard time. But here is where the true battle begins.”

The knight and soldier demi-humans directed salutes at Fina. An armored group—before the members of the defenders, Fina laughed within.

(The fluff brigade! The fluffy legion based around the cat tribe... aah, what happiness. If only master were here, it'd be perfect.)

Somehow containing her own writhing, Fina walked down the corridor.

“We will immediately begin suppressing sectors individually. How many troops remain?”

As Fina confirmed it, Mii walking beside her looked over her memo.

“Two thousand have been left at the palace. The royal guard is to remain, and it seems the nobles in Princess Aileen's faction are at the palace as well.”

At Mii reporting in a fluster, Fina endured her urge to drool.

“And our numbers?”

“A-around eight hundred. She took action earlier than planned, so we couldn't gather too great of a number. There are units of ours that were absorbed into the expedition.”

Hearing the personnel she prepared had been added into Fritz army, Fina wanted to click her tongue.

(I thought I could get two thousand with room to spare... well, we're in a race against time. We've got to do a clean sweep of sister's faction and their collaborators. Best done while it still all counts as my own achievement.)

With dark thoughts on his mind, Fina shifted towards enacting a plan she'd been furthering for a long while. It was a means for when her sister took strong measures, and a means Fina didn't want to have to use.

(Now how about we start building my country?)

... If she could make an expression, Fina would surely have a muddy-black smile slathered over her face.



Surrounded by defenders, Izumi managed to come into contact with Luecke and Eunius.

After explaining the situation, the two of them—

“... They're demanding reinforcements from us too. That will put us under Fritz' command.”

As Luecke said that with a sour face, Eunius discontentedly plucked his hair.

“Rudel was sent off alone, and Aleist chased after... those two idiots aren't thinking a thing.”

Eunius labeled Rudel and Aleist as fools, and sure enough, Izumi also thought there might have been a better way they could've gone about it.

But saying that now wouldn't get them anywhere.

“I want to somehow help out those two. Would you be able to lend your strength?”

At Izumi's plea, Luecke reached a prompt verdict.

“There are too many strange points. I'll return to my territory at once, and send troops your way. But the problem is how I'm supposed to persuade father.”

To his quandary, Eunius,

“Just give him a good smack-around. That always seems to work at my place; though admittedly, I’ve never won against him before.”

In the time Izumi wondered if that was alright, Luecke had already shifted to action.

“I’m heading off. Izumi, what are you going to do?”

She touched a hand to her chest.

“I will make for Rudel as a reinforcement. He should be wanting as much war potential as he can get.”

Luecke was about to open his mouth, but seeing Izumi’s serious eyes shut him up.

Eunius spoke in his place.

“You’ve got your own stubborn streak. Throwing units at the enemy one at a time isn’t the efficient way to do war. What’s more, adding a single member to the battlefield accomplishes nothing. Restrain yourself and either come with me or Luecke.”

Izumi shook her head. Her black ponytail swayed.

“If that doesn’t make it in time, I get the feeling I won’t forgive myself for the rest of my life. So even if it’s just the slightest bit faster...”

Before he could finish those words, a single knight entered the room. Dragging along Vargas, who’d been keeping watch outside, the individual who entered with a smile was Oldart.

“Oh, now look who it is. Izumi-chan, the special inspector shouldn’t be abandoning her job. What are you going to do if Rudel goes off the rocker when you’re not watching?”

“Captain Oldart? Umm, I’m—”

Oldart let two knights into the room. One of them was a silver-haired female knight, her ears perked straight up.

The other was a handsome, slender male knight.

Bennet and Keith.

“Keith, Deliver the archdukes’ eldest sons to their territories. And don’t lay a hand on them. Listen, I’m serious!”

On Oldart’s serious expression, Luecke and Eunius retreated a step to look at Keith.

The one in question,

“To save a precious subordinate, and to save a dear friend, I gladly take up this mission to deliver these men home. Ah, what a wonderful day it is. For such beauty is the friendship between men.”

Oldart ignored Keith.

“There are some problems with his personality, but he’s got the top aerial capabilities in the dragoon brigade. Now onto the dragoon brigade’s idol... Bennet-chan, take Izumi-chan with you, and join Rudel in the fray. Ah, if you spot the black knight along the way, pick him up.”

Bennet saluted.

“Understood, captain. He’s a precious subordinate to myself as well, I will certainly make it in time. But whether I find the black knight or not is up to question.”

Oldart scratched his head.

“That one’s a miscalculation on my part. Well, right now, it’s more important to hurry up. There’s no time. We’ll send around our support as quickly as possible... you just have to hold out until then. Don’t push yourself.”

Bennet and Keith answered their usually carefree captain's serious expression with earnest salutes.

Izumi thought to herself.

(I can only hope this is enough... Rudel.)



An army of monster that continued to no end.

As if they didn't know the notion of pause, they continued invading the fort, wave after wave. There was no plan, and the empire had gathered numbers great enough that one wasn't needed.

In the fort, Rudel sheathed his sword, sleeping as if to embrace it.

He sat on a wooden crate, around him, the bonfires were kept alit as the continuing enemy offense was dealt with. In the narrow fort, Sakuya would take the blows of enemies that managed to make it in.

Before hundreds of thousands of monsters, the reason a small fort could hold out was due to the grace of a gaia dragon subspecies, thanks to the defense of Sakuya's tough skin.

Her large arms brushed away the monsters clinging to its walls, but even so before the violence of hundreds of thousands, they were pressed into a hard battle.

A dragon like Sakuya could continue fighting for a few days, but the human Rudel was easily beset by his limits. Even so, he managed to fight on two nights and two days, so he was plenty inhuman himself.

Chlust had stationed trustworthy knights around Rudel.

Around, the civilians from around the fort who'd lost their place to flee raised a ruckus in their terror.

"Why aren't you fighting!? If you're a knight, then fight!"

“Let me out! I’ll get away from the fort, just let me out!”

“I never heard it would be like this! You can’t pin any of this on me!”

Blindly faithful to the dragoons, and feeling betrayed, the anger of the people was directed unto a resting Rudel. Even if he had fought to the edge of his limit, in this state of panic, no matter how they explained, they couldn’t expect understanding.

(That’s why I told them to run. And even if they run now,)

It was too late to run. Far too late. They were surrounded by the empire’s army of monsters, and anyone who stepped out would be no more than monster feed.

The fort’s defense had become a little more reliable with Sakuya’s arrival, but a situation where they had to keep wary of both inside and out still persisted.

A few hours after he began resting, Rudel slowly rose up.

“Brother! You can sleep some more! In that state—”

Seeing Rudel’s stamina and mana expended, Chlust wanted to use every means at his disposal to get his brother just a little more rest. But as Rudel lifted his face.

“The night will soon open up. When that happens, the enemy movements will be even more active than before. Could I have a bit of food?”

Rudel wouldn’t show a pained expression; Chlust ordered one of his men to prepare a meal.



The army led by the first prince of the empire... the crown prince measured out the right timing to advance near the border.

Under a large pavilion, the crown prince was surrounded by his generals.

“The wyvern unit is ready.”

“Crown prince, the time has finally come for us to launch a counteroffensive on Courtois!”

“There are a hundred to two hundred dragoons at most, but the empire’s wyvern unit surpasses five hundred. Even numerically, we hold the advantage.”

Hearing out those statements,

“On this occasion, we are mere decoys. Rather than victory, our priority shall be to shave away their foot soldiers. Hold the dragoons in place with the wyvern unit, and use that space and our numbers to put a dent in their army.”

At the crown prince’s declaration, the surrounding generals quietly nodded. When it came to the battlefield, Courtois places heavy stress on their dragoons. For that sake, their foot soldiers were in short supply.

On the opposite side of the spectrum, the empire had more foot soldiers than they knew what to do with. With Askewell leading his monster army, a majority of the human soldiers came under the crown prince’s command. Put up against Courtois’ soldiers in both quality and quantity, they would win.

And there was meaning in prioritizing chipping down their foot soldiers.

One of the generals,

“If they lose their foot soldiers, it will be impossible for them to occupy their land. No matter how powerful the dragoons may be, foot soldiers are still a necessity.”

The crown prince looked at the table laid out for him and the generals. A map had been spread over it, with the formation of the imperial army waiting intently for Courtois’ main force to come laid out in wooden pieces.

“... There is no need to win. Defeat as many soldiers and commanding officers within our capabilities. In an aerial battle, our wyvern unit will never win against Courtois’ dragoons in technical skills. Then we must knock Courtois down so hard it will take them ten, twenty years to recover. In that time, the empire’s crops will rise from the rich soil we have taken. For that is true victory for the empire!”

When the crown prince stood, the generals stood with him. Their expressions were all the epitome of severity. They could finally get one back at Courtois, who had tormented them for many a long year. The generals also understood this was a single important battle for the empire to make a comeback.

While Courtois had been protected by the dragoons, the empire was placed into the harshest of times. And those times had bred a powerful land force.

Imperial soldiers... their quality was higher than Courtois’ average fighter. Their fighting spirit was higher than it ever could be.

The crown prince gave a slight smile, he gripped his right hand into a fist and held it up high.

“In this battle, the empire’s future hangs on everyone’s performance. And I am certain we will reign victorious... victory to the empire!”

“To the empire!”

The highest ranking of his generals following on from the crown prince’s cry, the generals raised their voices in succession. Far more unified than Courtois, they were a foe one couldn’t drop their guard around.



— Delivered home via Keith, Luecke met with his father, the head of his house at the Halbades House castle.

Vast, apart from the window, every surface off the office his father processed paperwork in was covered with bookshelves reaching up to the

ceiling. Well-set hair and beard, his clothing was also prim and proper, a man who looked visibly high-strung.

He wouldn't even look at his son Luecke who'd come home.

"... So, you're telling me to dispatch Halbades House troops because you want to save a friend? Going as far as to oppose the kingdom? I had my hopes on you, but now I wonder what I was looking at."

At the words of his father, Luecke clenched his fist and grit his teeth. He expected it would come to this, and negotiating with that predetermined result in mind, Luecke had merely reaffirmed it.

He desperately moved his mouth, speaking of profits to the Halbades House.

"There is a high probability Princess Aileen is moving of her own accord, and more unnatural than anything is that—"

"Probability? Unnatural? The moment you move on wishful thinking is the moment you fail. You're not at an age where you can't understand that, are you?"

His paperwork finished, Luecke's father returned his quill to its pen stand and capped off his ink vial. He reviewed the documents as he waited for the ink to dry.

Sitting deep into his chair, he closed his mouth and shut his eyes. Luecke's voice grew rough.

"Then I'll head out alone if I have to."

To Luecke.

"I know you hold affection for the daughter born to an Arses House concubine. Are you throwing away your life for her? Be good, and I wouldn't mind you taking her as a concubine of your own. Give it another thought."

Luecke scoffed at his father's cold words.

"Hah, I'd rather you not belittle me. I'll seduce the woman I love on my own terms. But a friend... Rudel is a dear friend to me. If I let him die, I won't be able to forgive myself."

Resting an elbow on his desk, Luecke's father spoke.

"I see. Then I'll send reinforcements, though I don't know if you'll make it in time. I'm busy over here. The matter's in your hands."

Luecke had turned his back to his father, the head, and was about to leave the room. Seeing that back, the head gave a tired mutter.

"... Good grief, you weren't that sort of kid."

Luecke stopped in his track.

"... Certainly, perhaps I've changed. But I personally take it for the better."

Beaten down by his persistence, the head called out to Vargas, who was stationed outside the room.

"... Vargas, are you there?"

"Y-yes!"

Rudel's upperclassman, Vargas was also Luecke's guard. He was, at present, a knight of the Halbades House leading his own unit. He had been quite worried about Rudel, and perhaps he intended to sortie with Luecke as he was already wearing his armor.

"I shall be heading to the palace on a separate matter. Know you will only have five thousand troops to move. I will require one thousand of my own."

"Father?"

As Luecke turned, the head smiled a bit.

“You’re still a child, Luecke... did you think I didn’t know a thing? I’d long since grasped Princess Aileen’s suspicious movements. I’m sure that Diade will also be moving. And listen well... if you’re a man of an Archduke House, show enough ardor to make your side the one that wins. You go to your friend. I’ll do something about the palace. It seems Princess Fina’s already moving, after all.”

Liecke was a little dumbfounded by his father’s words, but he soon nodded and called to Vargas.

“Let’s go, Vargas!”

“Leave it to me, young master!”

“Don’t call me young master! Dammit, I’m going to reeducate you one of these days!”

Luecke had moved in order to save Rudel.



In the courtyard of the Diade House castle, Eunius was being knocked off his feet by his father.

His strong-muscled father wasn’t as tall as him. But his arms were much thicker, and his body was ridden with large scars.

They were scars of the battlefield. His short hair standing on end, his stiff beard made him more of a brave warrior than a nobleman.

“... Concede the battlefield to you? When did you become more important than me, son?”

When Eunius wiped his mouth with a sleeve, it turned red, but paying no mind, he glared at his father.

“I’m going to save a pal! Why do I have to deal with that pissy Princess Aileen at the palace!? You go take the palace, old man!”

His thick eyebrows twitch, Eunius's father punched Eunius again to blow him away. But this time, Eunius endured and returned the punch.

Smacked by his son, his father spaced out just a bit, but bursting into laughter, this time he smacked Eunius without holding anything back.

Blown all the way into the wall, Eunius fell to the ground.

“Nice fist. Very well, I'll respect that punch and your tongue with the plains of war. But I won't accept anything apart from victory. If you skulk back without any distinguished service, I'm rebuilding you from the ground up.”

Eunius stood and brushed off the dirt clinging to his clothing.

“You old fogey... too strong for your own good.”

Looking at his son Eunius with a smile, Eunius' father barked orders to his subordinates around.

“I'm heading to the palace. You all follow Eunius. If that idiot tries running, give him a kick in the ass towards the battlefield.”

Eunius spat his saliva at that unthinkable line from an archduke. A majority-red spit stuck to the grass, but paying it no mind, Eunius looked at the lines of soldiers.

Stationed close to the border, the elite gathering of Diade House vassals.

Strapping on their armor, they turned to Eunius and stood in file.

“... Run? If I ran and abandoned a friend, I'll regret it for life. This alone is where I won't run.”

And as he walked off towards his vassals, Eunius declared.

“Aight, I'm off to carve the Diade House name into those foolish imperials. You lot, try 'n keep up!”

Eunius' words were followed by a loud response. While the Diade House was rough, that was simply the gathering of warriors they were.

Eunius looked at his men hurriedly moving around.

(Don't know if we'll make it in time. Rudel, don't overdo it.)

And as Eunius looked to the sky, the sun was blocked out by a flying something, making a shadow.



Near the Hardie House estate in the royal capital, Aleist ran into Nate.

“Senpai, the Hardie House manor has already been occupied.”

“Nate? What about my parents!”

To a panicking Aleist, Nate closed one eye in a wink.

“They already got out of the city. Said something about returning to the territory and preparing for war. Your house sure is radical, senpai. I'm worried whether or not I can keep up.”

Aleist half-smiled seeing Nate as her usual self. She wore a robe around her body, and nearby a hippogryph was stationed taking on horse form. It was Nate's partner.

To its side, with long black hair, a monster with red lines running down its horn... the Nightmare Heath stood as well.

Approaching its master Aleist, it touched its horn to him.

“Heath, you waited for me.”

Aleist's armor and baggage were loaded on its back. He had come to collect them, but it did seem Nate was being considerate.

“Nate, you stayed too? What about that nameless knight brigade, or would you prefer shadow brigade?”

As Aleist tilted his head, Nate touched a hand to her brow.

“They’re doing their work. I, well see... I’m your fiancé, so I came to support you. I’ll follow you wherever you go.”

Seeing Nate at her usual tempo, Aleist gave a bitter smile. A voice called from behind him as well.

“Nate, you... are you trying to promote yourself?”

“Dirty. Nate, you’re playing dirty.”

There, Seli and Juju met up with them, wearing their equipment.

“Eh? H-huh?”

To Aleist’s snowballing confusion, the female camp gathered one after another. A woman who was the daughter of a merchant came over to Aleist.

“Aleist-sama, I shall be the one to safely deliver you out of the capital.”

“Oy, that’s the only part you’ll be of any use at all!”

“Rather, isn’t this quite a number?”

“Huh? Didn’t know you were joining in.”

Aleist looked at the gathered members. And despite his confusion.

“Err... I’m putting up a bit of resistance to the kingdom, and no matter how you cut it, I’ll be in a terrible position after this. So anyway, if possible, I’d quite like if you forgot about me and moved on.”

To that, Aleist’s academy junior Seli spoke.

“What are you talking about!? If you folded to such an order and became supreme commander, I’d have cut off our engagement then and there. To save a friend, Aleist-sama who stood in the trust sense against the kingdom’s crisis is the only one worthy of being my husband.”

Juju’s face likewise flushed red.

“Aleist, you really are cool.”

Aleist thought.

(... Huh? Why is everyone following me? Didn’t mom say something about knowing where you stand... rather, why every one of them? I see some people here I’m not even engaged to...)

The females that came there were too numerous to count on two hands.

Chapter 151: The Other Reincarnation

The Arses House manor.

Many armed knights and soldiers crowded into the stretch from the gate to the front door.

In the noisy state, preparations were underway to intercept the Gaia Empire encroaching on the national border. While the troops had gathered, it wasn't the best gathering.

Two thousand had been scraped together, but both their equipment and training fell short.

Sitting atop the roof, Lena Arses looked over them with a stretch and a yawn.

“With our territory, it'll be hard to get any more.”

Their misgovernment was running its course.

When they heard of Courtois' crisis, there were even nobles and knights who fled. The soldiers were few to gather, making it evidently clear how little adoration the Arses House held.

That they could gather two thousand even so must have been their status as Archdukes.

Looking at troop numbers far too low for the scope of their territory, Lena spotted Erselica conversing with a knight.

“Erselica’s gotten around quite a bit, but this is going to be harsh.”

Even if they marched out now, and gained the assistance of the nobles who would cooperate, it would take time to reach the border. Any missteps, and they wouldn’t make it in time.

Lena hung her spear over her shoulder and looked up at the sky.

Nostalgic... a truly nostalgic wind swept over her. Feeling the abnormal flow of air fanned by a dragon’s wings, she leisurely stood.

A blue, beautiful dragon blatantly glaring at her before her eyes—Mystith looked down over Lena.

While the surroundings grew panicked, Lena could be no calmer.

‘I’ve found myself quite the impertinent human, I have. I don’t know where you learned it, but your whistle— reached me.’

She had whistled at the sky. But that was no ordinary whistle.

It was a whistle to summon a dragon. To be more precise, it was the whistle that had been taken up between Marty and Mystith. A whistle that could be heard no matter where the other might be.

Lena turned to Mystith with a smile.

“I don’t really remember the specifics. But you know... I thought I could do it. And I thought you would come for me.”

Flapping her wings, Mystith narrowed her eyes to gaze at Lena.

‘... So that’s how it is.

Opening her mouth in a laugh, Mystith addressed the young girl.’

‘It’s been a while, Marty... you’ve gotten quite cute when I wasn’t looking.’

Lena laughed alongside her.

“Right you are, Mystith. But I’m sorry, but there’s barely anything I remember. Right now I’m Lena... Lena Arses, and a girl. And... I want to save my brother. Could I have your cooperation?”

Mystith slowly lowered herself onto the ground, bringing her eye-level to Lena’s height.

‘So you want me to lend a hand. But Marty—’

“It’s Lena. I’m Lena Arses, Mystith.”

Lena said with a smile.

“I want to save my brother.”

‘To think you were Rudel’s little sister. Is this some sort of fate?’

On Mystith’s words, Lena hung her head a bit in thought.

It wasn’t like she knew everything. She simply had a slight hunch she had a past she didn’t know. It was impossible for her to determine whether that was true or just her delusion.

(I think I remembered when I was with broski. Right, that time when he came over with my—the book the past me wrote.)

While it was vague, it happened when Rudel brought her a book she had written in a past life. At that moment, Lena remembered a time before.

A stranger’s memory. And the fact that a past life self existed, to Lena at the time, it was an exceedingly heavy truth to swallow?

Just who was she? She started to think her own existence was a fabrication. Yet to Lena, Rudel would speak on and on about just how great Marty was. He would preach honest praise, strengthening both their aspirations to be a dragoon—

“... My brother’s an idiot, isn’t he.”

‘... He is.’

Mystith openly agreed with that one.

“When I looked at my brother like that, it felt so idiotic to think too hard about everything. Not like I wasn’t an idiot myself. I decided not to think too hard. It’s a new life after all. Why not have some fun with it? But...”

This time, she was going to live her life as Lena. That’s why she never thought she would involve Mystith in her life.

“Surely, there was some reason I was my brother’s little sister, I think.”

Lena said and stroked Mystith.

Mystith spread her wings wide, she seemed delighted d at Lena’s touch.

‘Welcome back, Marty. And it’s a pleasure to meet you, Lena Arses. You are my third partner.’



At the palace, Fritz looked at the edge of the sword he’d been given.

Looking over that sword, embedded with gemstones and made with the latest technology, he confirmed his preparations were in order before tucking it into its sheath.

“Fritz-sama, the preparations to depart are complete. And it does seem the black knight made it out of the capital.”

“Got it.”

Ritz said and left the room, heading for the palace courtyard where his dragon awaited.

His subordinate following behind made an anxious face.

“Fritz-sama, there’s no need for you to personally subjugate the black knight—”

An irritated Fritz glared at his subordinate before increasing his walking pace.

“Do you think I’ll lose or something?”

Fritz was impatient. It was all well and good that he became Supreme commander, but it was quite clear to him that his surroundings didn’t accept him.

Without any achievements to speak of, Fritz had completely become a decoration. His last ray of hope, Aileen, seemed to be under the impression if that would keep him out of harm’s way, it would be fine.

(Like I could accept that.)

The existences called Rudel and Aleist were a hindrance to him. Defeating Aleist who ran away was his last opportunity to demonstrate his own abilities.

(Even if he’s the black knight, I have a dragon on my side. Like hell I’d lose.)

He’d obtained a new sword.

It was a powerful blade, just by the look of it, and when he actually tried using it, it truly was fearsome. With that might, Fritz would defeat Aleist, demonstrate his own strength, and become supreme commander not only in name alone.

(I won’t let myself become a decorative piece.)

Going out with that on his mind, Fritz looked at the gray dragon on standby in the courtyard. His partner, upon seeing him turned him its back. The surrounding servants looking after it distanced themselves as Fritz jumped on and wrung out his voice.

“We’re striking down the black knight. Now fly!”

Abiding by Fritz’ order, the gray dragon flapped its wings and rose into the sky.



A few horse-drawn carriages left the outer wall of the royal capital.

Out of the luggage loaded into the back of one, Aleist popped his face.

“W-we somehow managed.”

With some peace of mind, having rounded the outermost bounds of the city, Aleist looked around with a relieved expression. His faithful steed Heath was pulling the carriage in disguise.

He remained on guard a while, but there were no signs of enemy attack. A few kilometers away, Aleist showed his whole body from the shadows of the luggage crates.

“Well now, I was worried they would notice, but it looks alright.”

Following on from Aleist, the female members appeared one after the next.

“Even so, at our pace, the time to the border is—”

All of a sudden, Aleist looked up at the cloth stretched over the ceiling, promptly leaping out of the carriage and looking up at the sky.

A gray dragon was headed their way from the castle, and looking around, there was a strange scarcity of passersby using the main road.

It was the road that led to the capital, quite an unnatural state of affairs.

“So they did notice.”

Shedding a cold sweat, Aleist pulled his pair of swords from their sheaths. As the dragon flapped its wings to maintain its position overhead, he heard

Fritz' voice.

“Did you think you left unnoticed? Well so be it. Black Knight Aleist, you are going to die here.”

As the gray dragon opened its mouth about to fire its breath, Aleist enveloped his surroundings in a sphere of his own shadow to harden his defense.

Yet before a dragon's breath, Aleist's defenses were torn down all too easily.

“—!”

With his defenses breached, Aleist looked up to see Fritz' descent.

The women around him readied their weapons, but as they tried to cut at him, the Dragon landed to intimidate them. Aleist redirected his stance at the beast before him.

“What a bother. We're in a hurry here.”

Sensing Aleist's panic, Fritz laughed a bit.

“You're not going to make it regardless. Instead of your useless plight, please just die by my blade.”

When Fritz drew his sword, Aleist looked perplexedly at it.

(Haven't I see that sword somewhere...)

Fritz cut at him. Was it the weapon's specs, or perhaps his own ability?

He had gotten quite a bit stronger than before.

“I always wanted to cut you down like this. I can't forget my grudge from the academy!”

The grudge he spoke of involved Aleist instantly taking him out at the Academy Tournament. Thanks to that, Fritz had been terribly belittled by those around him.

Blocking Fritz' slack with both blades, Aleist kicked forward to destroy his footing. But Fritz took distance and cut in again. Aleist parried it with the sword in his left hand, only for Fritz to contain Aleist's right arm with his own left.

(This bloke's far stronger than last time...)

The gemstone embedded in Fritz' sword let off a light. The sword was strengthening his body.

“It's water under the bridge! What are you even doing here!? You're—the supreme commander, aren't you!?”

Aleist took distance as he fired a few spears made from his own shadow at Fritz, but Fritz cut them down.

An irritated Aleist.

Inside, his anger towards Fritz was welling up

(You're the supreme commander, dammit. What are you doing here!? Go prepare for war or something.)

As the Kingdom of Courtois readied itself for invasion, it was unthinkable that the army's commander personally came out to defeat Aleist.

From Aleist's point of view, he wanted to come to Rudel's aid without a second to lose.

Fritz laughed. But his smile was a dark one.

“Supreme commander? At this rate, I'll be a decoration. No merit or achievement. Who'd seriously listen to my opinion? ... Made light of for being a commoner, mocked by the nobles. They treat me like I'm your replacement... like I can put up with that!”

Rushing at Aleist, Fritz went into a consecutive stream of cuts. Skillfully handling them with two swords, Aleist cried out as the sparks flew around him.

“Like I care! That’s what you asked for!”

From Aleist’s point of view, Fritz’ circumstances were the least of his worries. Diving into his shadow to avoid one of Fritz’ attacks, he moved behind him to cut him down.

Yet in Fritz’ time of crisis, the dragon roared, averting Aleist’s attention.

“Dammit! If the dragon weren’t there, it’d be over in no time!”

Irksomely taking distance, Aleist saw his comrades taking up positions to surrounding Fritz.

(Even if we all go at him at once, the dragon will get in the way. This guy’s out here playing for own merits...)

If Fritz really intended to crush Aleist, he could have managed by riding his dragon and launching breath attacks from that sky.

In that instance, Aleist would make it look like he was blown away, covertly recovering his members to overcome the situation. Contriving a means of escape in a corner of his mind, Aleist turned Fritz a smile.

“Are you satisfied, winning under a dragon’s protection... Fritz?”

In his attempted provocation, Aleist looked at his face to confirm his irritation.

With a furrowed brow, Fritz readied his sword.

“I’m different from a pathetic man who’s protected by his women.”

Aleist laughed.

“Kahah! That so. Never thought I’d hear that from someone protected by Princess Aileen and allowed to do whatever he pleases. You mean to tell me it wasn’t Princess Aileen who appointed you as Supreme Commander in the first place?”

Seeing Fritz grit his teeth, Aleist thought.

(I see, so he noticed. That’s why he’s forcing himself to kill me. But look, kid...)

“... You, you really need to look at a mirror. You prattle on about commoners and nobles, but in the end, you’re only looking out for yourself.”

Aleist said, despite his thoughts.

(Well, not like I’m one to speak.)

For now, enraging Fritz was the priority. Reaching a hand behind his back, he signaled for his comrades to gather behind him.

His comrades slowly moved into position.

“A wealthy bastard like you who’s got everything can’t understand what—”

“Yeah, I can’t. I’m not going to sugarcoat it... but what does that make you? Protected by Princess Aileen, she even made you supreme commander. And yet, people aren’t listening to you, so you go off on your own to take me out? Didn’t you despise those blasted nobles who ignored their people and went off on flights of fancy? Man, you really have it wonderful. I’m sure they’ll sing songs of praise. Of that damn fool out lusting for glory.”

From Aleist’s point of view, the commander going out front and fighting was unthinkable.

Of course, he only thought so because he knew a past life.

As Fritz said, those placed under a knight with no deeds of arms, no real life experience could only be anxious.

Anyone would prefer an achieved soul abundant in experience.

“Fritz, you’re becoming the person you hate most. I can tell. I’m not too different. So—”

“—You’re the same as me? Impossible. That’s definitely impossible!”

In the end, Aleist’s compassion came out. He wanted Fritz to somehow notice, because he got the feeling he was practically looking at himself.

His past self—his past portion so stuck up looked the same as Fritz to him.

But his words wouldn’t reach.

Turning expressionless, Fritz moved to the side of where he was standing.

“That’s enough. Burn away.”

The moment Fritz stepped away, the form of a gray dragon, a breath prepared in its wide-open mouth came into sight.

(Here it comes!)

Measuring out the right time, Aleist was about to move to rescue his party.

But it was there, the dragon suddenly closed its mouth, picked up Fritz, and soared into the sky.

“Wah! Oy, I didn’t order you to—”

It must have been unexpected for Fritz as well. He was panicking.

Where Fritz had been a moment ago, a mass of water—a number of orbs showered down. They burst upon colliding with the ground, soaking Aleist and his cohorts.

Aleist looked to the sky—

“—Bennet-san!”

Riding a dragon with blue scales, the form of a small-built young girl with silver hair.

“Sorry for that. Couldn’t hold back.”

Bennet said, intimidating her opponent with her own dragon. The difference between a wild dragon and a bred one was far too different from the get-go. To add to that, the difference in strength between its partner Bennet and Fritz was great as well.

The gray dragon retrieved Fritz and retreated for the palace.

“Aleist!”

It wasn’t just Bennet on the Dragon’s back. Izumi was there with her.

“Get on. We’re on a direct route to Rudel.”

Aleist nodded, immediately gathered his comrades and put them to preparations.



Having returned to the palace, Fritz immediately reported to Aileen that the dragoon brigade had turned coat.

However—

“Fritz-sama... We have already received a report from Captain Oldart of the Dragoon Brigade that a portion of the dragoons have defected. However, we are in a state of affairs where we are unable to chase after them.”

Around a troubled-sounding Aileen, the knights of good pedigrees waited upon her. Taking the name of guards, the knights who were stationed near Aileen in Fritz’ place.

They looked at Fritz with eyes of scorn.

“You should really get a grip, high and mighty supreme commander. At this very moment, you are the responsible party for all military affairs.”

When he was told it wasn't supposed to be Aileen receiving these reports, Fritz clenched his fists. The knights looked at him and laughed.

Aileen spoke to soothe him.

“They shall receive the appropriate recompense after the war. Does that work out?”

Aileen said as she sought confirmation from the knights around her. With their nods, an order was handed down to Fritz.

“Then Fritz-sama. As our general, why don't you go take down the foolish Gaia Empire invading upon our lands?”

Fritz kneeled and accepted the order.

“Yes, Princess Aileen.”

But he was conflicted inside.

Despite becoming supreme commander, the knights—the young nobles of good households made light of him, and he was being sent off to the battlefield as a mere decoration.

(... What the hell am I even doing here.)

Aleist's words, 'you're becoming the person you hate most,' abruptly flashed through his head.

Chapter 152: Fina's Counterattack

At the dragoon brigade headquarters, preparations to sortie were underway.

Contrary to his usual insincerity, the Captain Oldart was issuing orders with a serious face.

Readied for takeoff, the dragons stood in file, the forms of their partner dragoons on their backs a magnificent spectacle.

Close to a hundred had lined up. The scene that unfolded was one that upon which, it wouldn't be strange if anyone was already convinced of another victory.

"The old empire never learns. Well, I'm sure they have some prospects..."

Oldart groaned, knowing well they were no fools; his vice-captain Alejandro shed a cold sweat as he walked over.

He was followed behind by people who weren't allowed to be there.

(That Alejandro, he's as spineless as ever.)

The one following him was a certain Fina, surrounded by demi-human knights. The dragoons around raised a ruckus.

"Oldart, you have a summons from the princess."

Contrasting Alejandro's panic, Oldart spread out both hands with a smile.

"Well if it isn't her highness, the second princess. What brings you to such a sweltering place?"

The flurried haste of the palace. Added to the unreasonable orders, and Aileen's seemingly suspicious movements—Oldart had an inkling something had happened in the Palace.

He hit upon that Fina coming here must have some sort of meaning.

Fina expressionlessly addressed him.

“I would be very much obliged if you could lend me just a few of your dragoons, Oldart-dono.”

Before Fina's inability to show expression, Oldart knew this was going to be difficult as he scratched his head.

“Dear me, what could you mean by that? Haven't you noticed we're in a bit of a crisis here?”

Fina gave a small nod, touching her right hand to her chest.

“Yes, I am aware. Should I say that is precisely why? A moment ago, I was imprisoned by my sister—Aileen.”

Seeing Alejandro make an unpleasant face, Oldart folded his arms.

“So you'll bring the dragoons into the palace's mess. Are you sure about that? Our dragoons... it is my humble opinion that their power shall only be exercised in defense.”

If they were dragged in, they would have done something there was no taking back. Even so, Fina wasn't moved.

No, it didn't come out on her face, so it was impossible to tell what she was thinking.

“Three dragon riders have sided with Aileen. Did you happen to have three taking separate action? For instance... three who were to remain stationed in the remotest of regions?”

Oldart felt like clicking his tongue. He endured it to make a smile.

(Can't be part of the main force. So some folks sent off to the outskirts were lured in by promotions...)

“You have my apologies for that one. We'll have them caught and thrown in the dungeons in no—”

Fina wouldn't let Oldart finished.

“— The dungeons aren't kept open for dragoons alone. My sister shall go with them. As my personal request.”

Fina told him her plan. Upon hearing it, Alejandro's face turned pale, while Oldart formed a stiff smile.

“Is this really the time for a family quarrel?”

Fina's reply came immediately.

“It's never too rare among royalty. Additionally, could I ask you to send reinforcements to my mast... Rudel-sama? As inconspicuous of a number as possible. Just a few elites, if you can.”

Oldart had already been considering it.

“Are you fine with just a few?”

“If the numbers are too different, I fear it will be seen through. Both fronts of the empire's invasion plan likely have the potential to become their main force. We shouldn't divide our numbers too much. And... I'm sure master will be fine.”

Fina said, established Oldart's cooperation and left. Oldart looked at the girl's back as,

“... The hell's up with master?”

In his head, Rudel had become even more incomprehensible.

◇

After the dragoon brigade had taken flight. From the royal palace, an army of a few tens of thousands passed under the gate of the outer wall on their march.

Fritz set out in magnificent armor, and with so many people leaving the royal palace of the royal capital, it was far more scarcely populated than usual.

Aileen lowered herself into the throne in the audience chamber.

The knights and nobles around her recommended it.

“You’re a perfect fit, Princess Aileen. No, Queen Aileen.”

The nobles continued lifting her up with their words.

“But the empire sure is foolish.”

“Surely. When there’s no way they can win against a dragon.”

“Even if they manage to take land, the dragons will take it back.”

Their optimism lay in just how powerful the dragon’s really were. As a matter of fact, they had protected the kingdom of Courtois like that for hundreds of years.

Aileen breathed a small sigh.

“It may be fine to reclaim it. But if the empire lays hand on fertile soil, perhaps they’ll calm down and stop instigating wars.”

Hearing that, the surrounding knights and nobles were a little flustered.

“No, Aileen-sama, I would never recommend leaving them be. It’s the empire we’re talking about here, if they get one victory, they’ll prepare to invade again—”

“Then we can simply talk the matter out. We do have vast spans of fertile earth. What have you to complain about?”

Her surroundings sent her troubled faces. But she had decided to lift Aileen up even so. From now on, they could make as many excuses to her as they pleased. So they thought.

In fact, it would surely be possible.

However—

“U-urgent message!”

A knight of the royal guard plunged into the audience chamber. The large doors were violently thrown open as he stood, out of breath in a huge panic.

“Princess Fina is—leading the defenders in a rebellion!”

A tension raced across the audience chamber. Aileen stood from her chair, covering her mouth with both hands.

“Fina did... there’s no way...”

The guard knights nearby her issued our orders.

“Suppress it at once. And don’t harm Princess Fina.”

They were the sole two heirs to the royal bloodline, with high utility value. The intent was to quell the rebellion at once, and have someone else take responsibility.

But Fina’s rebellion exceeded their anticipation.

“I-it’s impossible! The number of armed defenders exceeds five hundred. The civilians are joining in to besiege the palace walls!”

As knight and noble alike opened their eyes wide, the vehement sounds of battle came from outside the castle.

“We request reinforcements at—”

As the messenger knight said that, one of the nobles wrung out his voice.

“Calm down. We have the dragoons we called from the—”

Recalling the existence of their trump card, the dragoons, the knights and nobles present regained their composure.

But the knight opened his mouth wide.

“Nay. They have them too... our three dragoons have already been taken in!”



Six dragoon knights had held down the dragoons on Aileen’s side.

Breaching the palace gate, Fina stepped in surrounded by knights of the tiger tribe.

Yet they stood without entering the door to the palace.

“Good on them to anticipate the enemy’s infiltration, but this sure is troublesome.”

Prepared long ago, the door unclear whether it could even move or not was closed. Aileen’s group had locked themselves into a siege, it seemed they intended to endure to the return of their dispatched troops.

It was not the palace of the historic Courtois Kingdom for nothing, its defense couldn’t be dealt with through ordinary means.

The high knight Sophina took command, while in the palace, the defenders continued the fight with the troops of Aileen’s faction.

“Hurry with the siege weapon!”

Aleist’s friends were also taking part, reassembling a siege weapon within the castle walls to use from the inside. But it wasn’t made in the first place to be used indoors.

“Not happening! In the first place, the halls are too narrow to carry it.”

The place was vast enough, but if they wanted to reuse the siege weapon they'd brought, they'd have to downscale it. That would lower its output.

If they took it too far, it might not do anything at all.

“You look exhausted. Should I have a dragon blow it away with breath from the outside?”

When Fina ran her mouth on that, she heard a voice from behind.

“Princess... no, Fina-sama, that would be quite troubling. To burn up the valuable material in the palace, and the many pieces of fine art will surely bring trouble down the line.”

When Fina turned, she made a terribly unpleasant face in her head.

(Dammit, they're already here.)

There, Luecke's father, Archduke Halbades led his own troop to make his way to her.

“You'll be troubled when you take the throne, or perhaps become queen.”

Fina was expressionless to the Archduke... but quite irritated inside, she asked.

“Archduke Halbades. We are in a time of crisis. The fact you have appeared before me with such a statement means...”

The knights around Fina readied their weapon, stepping before Fina and the archduke. Not that Archduke Halbades seemed to mind.

“The Halbades House offers you our assistance. Fret not, with our cooperation, victory is assured. We will see to it that you are queen, be it consort or regnant.”

Fina expressionlessly had the knights around her back down.

“I'm counting on you, Archduke Halbades.”

(Dammit! Dammit! I wanted to suppress the palace already, greatly regulate the nobles and chip away at the power of these archdukes! If he plays a part, my reforms will...)

From inside the palace corridor came the sound of an enemy attack. It seemed they were attempting to destroy the siege weapon.

But a large glass pane in the corridor shattered, and as rugged knights and soldiers clambered in, a bloodbath was immediately raised among the enemy knights.

A red blood expanding across the corridor, the head of the Diade House, Archduke Diade made an appearance toting his prided war hammer.

When he placed it on the ground, it let off a heavy sound.

“Fina-sama! No need to fear, now that the Diade House is here.”

The hardy Archduke Diade proclaimed his alliance with a grand laugh. In her head, Fina burst into dry laughter.

“Aha, ahahahah... how did they get to the palace so fast!? It should have taken more time! This is strange. There’s something fishy here!”

At first, Fina intended to take a large bit of power from the other nobles, but two of the archduke houses had pledged their cooperation.

She thought they might watch and wait some, what’s more, it should have taken more time just to get their soldiers from their territories to the capital.

Fina’s plan was beginning to twist astray.

“... With great pleasure, I do accept the aid of Archduke Diade.”

When they arrived after all was over, Fina intended to give a sarcastic quip and move to reduce their power. Was he aware of that? Archduke Halbades sang praise of Fina.

“But splendidly done, Fina-sama. I’d almost have to assume you’ve been planning this for ages. For even the people of the capital to take your side.”

She had put Mii and the other demi-humans, along with a great many knights at the bottom of the totem pole up to spreading rumors. After the armies departed, she leaked a rumor a portion of the territories were to be abandoned.

Generally speaking, she made it out that the nobles were bad.

“On the way here, we received some considerably harsh looks from the people. Treating us almost as if we were the enemy. No, I wouldn’t dare to imply it was your doing, Fina-sama.”

With that cynicism from Archduke Diade, Fina internally broke into a cold sweat.

(.... Dammit, I’ll have to revise my plan. But now victory is certain.)

Changing her train of thought, for not Fina prioritized winning against Aileen. But there was just one thing bothering her.

On Fina’s query, the two archdukes made slightly troubled faces. And Archduke Diade opened his mouth.

“Well, it’s that. I never thought I’d be riding a dragon at my age.”



The events of the capital.

They were events that happened a few days after Rudel’s arrival at the battlefield.

And—

“That’s enough. You’ve done enough, brother!”

A battered Rudel was trying to leave the fortress. He had fought for days, and after resting only a few hours, he would set out again. Rinse and repeat.

There weren't any serious dents in his armor.

But Rudel's stamina and mana had reached their limit. The one responsible for the fort, his younger brother Chlust had picked up on that.

"... Chlust."

Rudel looked at Chlust, smiling a bit.

"No can do. This is my job. These are lines my superior told me, I took quite a liking to them. A job is how you live your life. I'll fight to protect this point to the end."

He was protecting those that lived in the area, taking refuge in the fort. But they were also those who didn't abide by the evacuation orders.

"... Brother, you've done enough. Take the civilians with you and run."

Chlust hung his head, he clenched his fist.

"Chlust, you..."

Chlust made a face on the verge of tears.

"We'll hold out somehow or another. So... brother, please run. I already know. There's no meaning even if I live on. I'm a human who's already been abandoned. But brother, you're different."

Chlust spoke of just how important Rudel's existence was.

"Your power is necessary to rebuild to Arses House. It's hopeless for me. The same could be said for the country. Brother, you have to be there. You're... you're different from me."

Rudel looked at Chlust.

“I’m unable to abdicate this point. My orders are to protect this fort to my last breath.”

Chlust smiled.

“I’ll do it. I’ll take care of it... brother, you just have to live.”

There, Rudel returned a gentle smile.

“Chlust, you’ve... changed. You’ve changed so much since I saw you at the academy.”

And Rudel punched Chlust out. Chlust was dumbstruck, as his consciousness faded away, he heard Rudel’s voice.

“... But Chlust. This is my battle.”



When Chlust opened his eyes, he was in the sky.

Sprawled out over a large, white back, when he looked around, he saw his subordinates.

“Brother!”

When he hurriedly sprung up, one of his subordinates, a knight looked at him apologetically.

“Captain... I’m sorry. Your brother, he,”

With a sorrowful roar from the dragon, Chlust looked back at the shrinking fort. The black monster army attacking to it, the unresisting fortress was being swallowed whole.

“... Why. Oh god why!!”

Chlust’s cry resounded through the sky.

Chapter 153: Demon King

Standing at a high point of the fort, Rudel saw Sakuya off to the horizon.

Slicing up an ogre climbing up the wall towards him, he muttered.

“Live on, Chlust.”

Sakuya was loaded with the knights and soldiers of the fort, alongside the civilians that had taken refuge.

They were reluctant to leave Rudel’s side. But he forcefully used Sakuya to get them away.

Thanks to that, the fort was in the process of being destroyed. Monster scrambled up the outer wall, while wyverns circled the sky above.

As three wyverns headed for Sakuya, Rudel took a deep lurch forward followed by a large jump. Soaring into the sky, Rudel reached his left hand out towards the wyverns.

“How cold. Your opponent’s right over here... if you get that, have at me!”

Rudel emitted a number of lights around, he formed them into the shape of swords. Those swords of light with a golden glimmer began to spin on the spot.

Looking over his surroundings, Rudel sent his swords flying in all directions. To the wyverns chasing Sakuya, to the wyverns circling in the sky. To the monsters and the imperial army on land.

With a sword flying their way, the wyverns changed direction to avoid it.

“Oh no, you don’t.”

When Rudel clenched his left hand, the fired sword pursued its target and stuck in. Where it impaled, it exploded, and in the sky and on land, explosions rung out in all directions.

Falling towards the ground, Rudel avoided wyvern breath, and magic and arrows as he landed outside the grounds of the fort.

Around him, ogres taller than he could ever hope to be were armed at the ready. An imperial knight who looked to be a commanding officer directed their right hand at Rudel.

“Fool! When dragged to the earth, a dragoon is no more than an ordinary knight! Surround him and beat him down!”

When the commander said that, the monsters assailed Rudel at once.

Readying his blade, and flowing mana into it, Rudel swung his sword one revolution.

“Wha!”

The surrounding ogres were blown back and bisected.

Holding swords of their own, the monsters who knew no fear—no, the monsters who would simply follow orders came at Rudel one after another.

Each and every one of them was laid to rest by the sword in Rudel’s right hand.

“Your words do me ill. Well, it’s true a dragoon is incomplete without his partner by his side.”

As Rudel said that with a smile, the enemy commander hopped on a horse and fled.

“Keep going at him! We have to bring him down while his dragon isn’t here!”

The fact the dragon protecting the fort- Sakuya- had left made the enemy lower their guard.

They had never even imagined Rudel would remain alone.

Rudel laughed before the foes approaching him from all sides.

“Sorry, but I don’t plan on letting the commanders get away.”

He said, disappearing from the spot with his wind magic-based movement. The surrounding monsters were carved up in an instant.

A spurt of blood whirling up in the air, at times the monsters lifted along with it.

The commander raised a scream.

“What is this? What the hell are you!!?”

The monsters were simply bodies to enact orders. In that case, targeting enemy commanders and having them target monsters on him was the simplest means to keep them here.

The commander exclaimed aloud at this strength exceeding his expectations. Right after, his body was split open by Rudel’s hand.



At the Gaia Empire’s main camp, Askewell confirmed the war situation with his adjutants.

His arms folded, Askewell gave a dry laugh.

“Hmm, so he persists even without his dragon. He used that fortress as a decoy to invite the enemy in... looks like things aren’t going my way.”

One of his adjutants, Mies offered Askewell some advice.

“Bahn Rhoshwas and Leor have already taken up their positions... should we call the back?”

Hearing those names, Askewell thought just a bit, before, “No, it’s fine,” he said and stood from his seat.

“He’s just as the rumors say... no, he goes beyond that. Courtois’ white knight. But how far can he go both outnumbered and overwhelmed?”

One of his adjutants shed a cold sweat.

“I can’t think he’s human like me. For the monster army we worked so hard to assemble to be lost this easily... Askewell-sama, should we not implore General Roshwas or Leor-dono to defeat the White Knight in good time?”

Askewell’s expression turned serious.

“That is unnecessary. We had far too many monsters—the plan was to reduce their numbers. These losses are all within expectations.”

Mies gave a slight nod to Askewell’s words.

(Right. Within expectations. Whatever the case, it’s impossible for the empire to maintain these numbers. If they’re not crushed here, even if we obtain fertile soil, it will be meaningless.)

Maintaining this massive monster legion was an exceedingly large burden on the empire. They were an army assembled to be crushed from the get-go. If they weren’t human, it wouldn’t hurt anyone’s heart.

(... But that white knight’s doing a good job holding out.)

While it was within expectations, these losses were far too great to come from a single combatant. They had gone down considerably in only a few days.

However—

“No matter the damages, our main body’s losses are insignificant. There is no problem.”

At Askewell’s words, the adjutants nodded.

Right. Their main body of humans kept behind the monster legions.

What’s more, it was an army that had suffered very little loss.

Askewell touched a hand to his chin.

“But it might just be time for Courtois’ reinforcements to arrive. It wouldn’t be bad to take the white knight’s head before that.”

Mies tilted her head.

“Did we not have a deal with Courtois?”

Askewell laughed.

“If those things held up, we’d have world peace. Well, if they don’t come, then that’s no problem for us... keep sending monsters at him for a while. After that—I’ll personally take his head.”

A warrior of the Gaia Empire and their hero, while the adjutants had some problems with Askewell’s words, they agreed to them.

Mies thought.

(Well, I guess there’s no way Askewell-sama will lose. Even with the white knight as his foe, he need simply tire him to the limit. It’ll also raise morale.)



Just how many hundred, nay, how many thousands of monsters had he butchered?

Their movements were far too simple, too linear. When they all came at him, they were quicker to take down than when they targeted other people or the fort itself.

Rudel breathed roughly as he stuck the sword in his right hand into the ground, surveying his surroundings.

Monster corpses spread over and narrowed the ground, there were places where the bodies piled up. Trampling over those corpses more monsters came at him still.

His shoulders rising in breath, Rudel looked at the sky.

Hefty clouds interrupted the sun, and he had no idea what time it might be.

“.. Looks like rain.”

To receive the monsters coming at him, he forcibly stood his body and drew his sword from the ground.

“A dragoon with no partner is just a knight... huh.”

Recalling the enemy commander's words, Rudel gave a self-deriding laugh. That was definitely no mistake.

He would have liked to fight with Sakuya.

But if the fort's knights and soldiers, and the evacuated civilians remained, he wouldn't be able to fight to the best of his abilities.

Perhaps he could have managed if he abandoned them... but if he did that, Rudel knew he would never be able to look everyone who saved him in the eye.

Moving his dulling body, he cut through enemies as he walked.

His movements without any unnecessary power, at this point, it was almost that the movements drilled into his body were arbitrarily coming out.

Without any waste, he slowly walked forward as he carved up his foes.

The commanders issuing orders to the monsters from behind fearfully looked at Rudel.

“M-monster—”

“There’s no way.”

“Just one person... the dragoons really are monsters.”

Hearing that, Rudel made a smile.

Seeing him laugh, the Gaia Empire Soldiers fears worsened.

“What’s wrong... quit cowering and come at me. Did you not come here for war? I’m sorry I’m on my own, but I, Rudel Arses shall be your enemy. I don’t intend to let a single one of you pass.”

On those words, the imperial knights driven by hears raised their warcries. In voices similar to shrieks, they ordered the monsters to charge.

“Get him!”

“Kill that man. You have to kill him!”

“Are the reinforcements here yet!?”

The number of enemies had decreased greatly from the onset.

An army that buried the entire landscape was now scarce and divided. It had decreased in density... that was simply the amount that Rudel had slain.

(Hopefully one last push.)

Forcing his body already a pain just to move, Rudel poised his sword and cut down all the monsters coming at him.

His form, despite the white armor he war was beginning to look like something else entirely.

The form of him gleefully defeating his foes had even brought upon knights fleeing from the battlefield.

It came at that moment—

“Any more will affect morale. Looks like I can’t overlook him any longer.”

A voice with a sense of presence boomed across the battlefield. Hearing that strong and reassuring voice, the cowering knights regained composure.

When Rudel looked in the direction of the voice, there was the disheartening sight of an enemy leading a host of troops. The numbers he had gone to great lengths reducing were back to their original value.

The enemy looked at the ground, and he turned his gaze to Rudel.

“You’ve done well, to defeat so many. Allow me to give you my honest praise, white knight.”

Rudel leaned his sword on his shoulder.

“Call me dragoon, or White Dragoon. It’s a name a dear friend granted me. I’ve quite a liking for it.”

His gold hair swept back, the tall man in armor looked a little surprised before he gave a grand laugh.

“White Dragoon! I see, a white knight and a dragoon makes a White Dragoon. Makes perfect sense to me.”

A laughing enemy commander—

(His air’s different from the others. Is he a general?)

As Rudel raised his guard, his foe introduced himself.

“My name is Askewell Gaia, and I am in command of this army. White Dragoon... as I recall, you were called Rudel Arses, were you? I shall display your head to the armies of Courtois soon to arrive.”

When his smile went out, Askewell's face was expressionless. Cold to no end, it spoke that he had no mercy to spare for Rudel.

On the contrary, Rudel laughed.

“And what of it? For two enemies, such is only natural. Of course, I do think a certain level of respect is required for an honorable warrior. I can't say I like your means.”

Showing off enemy corpses wasn't quite to Rudel's liking.

Of course, he knew that was effective. In the sense of weakening an enemy's fighting spirit, it was the proper action.

“... Honorable warriors, eh. On the battlefield, such nobility is meaningless.”

Rudel agreed with that point as well.

“You're right. So I don't plan to correct you. Once you take this head, you may do what you want with it. If you can, that is.”

To Rudel's provocations, Askewell assumed they were his final show of courage; he didn't seem all too moved.

“So you know no fear. What brute courage.”

“Brute courage? If I'm brute courage, then you are just a brute. Neither shame nor honor. A monster in human form.”

With a legion of monsters as the vanguard, they would go on a rampage on Courtois' territory.

Perhaps he had something to think about Askewell's means to lower their population, even using monsters as tools.

“... I’m sure you will never understand in your prosperity. Just how the empire pains, and how it hungers.”

Rudel had an inkling Askewell was trying to do something about the Empire’s present state of affairs. The reason they aimed for the Courtois Kingdom was that unlike the empire, the kingdom’s territory was abundant in fertile soil.

If they were living so destitute, with prosperous land nearby, of course they would want it.

“No matter how you despise me. No matter how you scorn me, there is something I must—”

Once Askewell had said that much, Rudel lowered his sword from his shoulders.

He stuck his glare on Askewell—the army behind him.

“Quit your yapping. You came to invade, didn’t you? Saying there’s something you have to do now, do you plan to go into penance? Are you trying to tell me, there’s this great reason you’re invading us so please forgive you?”

While Rudel’s words invoked anger from the imperial army—

“At the point you crossed the border, the war had begun. Cry your heart out in diplomacy if you want our sympathy... but this is already a battlefield. It is only good manners for us to speak life and death with the weapons in our hands. Now... shall we kill one another?”

— At a smiling Rudel’s atmosphere, everyone swallowed their breath.

Almost a vengeful spirit or a demon... no, he gave the air of a demon king.



Bennet boarded Izumi, Aleist and his harem members on the back of her own dragon Heleene, setting out for the battlefield.

“We’re almost there. But to be honest, with these numbers, you can’t quite call us reinforcements.”

While she was a dragoon who protected Courtois, one rider and ten-odd ground combatants were cause for unease.

Izumi cast down a pensive countenance.

“... Even so, if we make it, we may be of the slightest assistance.”

Bennet nodded.

“Well, the situation is considerably terrible, but I’m sure Captain Oldart will send reinforcements. And if the Archduke Houses are moving, as long as we can hold out—”

Aleist’s cry cut her off.

“Bennet-san! Ahead!”

Ahead of them, a giant, white dragon—Sakuya flew with a large load of people on to her back.

Izumi stood.

“Sakuya!”

Surely Rudel was with her. She knew it had to be true, but Sakuya was acting strangely. Bennet looked at the people riding Sakuya’s back—

(Apart from knights and soldiers, civilians too? Don’t tell me they were late to get away?)

There, Sakuya mournfully roared. Hearing her voice, Izumi covered her mouth with both hands.

“That can’t be...”

“W-what’s wrong? You can hear her, right? What happened!?”

Dragons could communicate telepathically with those they had conceded their hearts to. For that reason, there was a high probability Izumi could hear Sakuya's voice.

Meaning it was possible for her to learn what was going on at the border.

Bennet heard Sakuya's tale through way of Heleene.

'This is bad. Looks like that Rudel remained at the fort alone. He had Sakuya carry those late to flee to get them to safety.'

Bennet's expression warped.

"That fool!"

But to Rudel who couldn't run away, this was surely the only way to let the others survive.

"There should have been a smarter way to do it."

Bennet muttered, and inferring from those words and the situation, Aleist's complexion turned pale.

"... Rudel."

Chapter 154: Last Boss

Another battlefield.

There a separate detachment of the Gaia Empire—their supposed main body was locked in a staring contest with the Dragoon Brigade.

The first to arrive at the battlefield, Oldart's dragoons flew to intimidate the unmoving enemy near the border.

If that had them step down, it would be the end, but the enemy was evidently acting strange.

Skirmishes had broken out between the two powers many a time, and they were sure to know just how powerful their dragons were. Yet the army didn't seem the least bit disconcerted.

What's more—

“They're waiting for something.”

As Oldart looked at the enemy camp and muttered, one of his subordinates approached.

“Captain, they show no signs of moving. They're considerably calm.”

The Gaia Empire had invaded on two fronts.

There could be no doubt their main force was the army led by the crown prince before their eyes, but Oldart couldn't help but be curious about the movements of the other prince's army.

“Including Rudel, they have three riders. I think they can hold out...”

Even an army of ten thousand, to a dragoon, was no great threat.

A war could end simply through breath attacks from the sky. At times dragon slayers, and people outside the norm could appear to take them down. But with multiple riders, the possibility of them being taken out drastically fell.

“I’ve got a bad feeling about this. Perhaps I was right to send reinforcements.”

Oldart touched his prided well-kept beard as he muttered; his subordinate’s expression turned grim.

“Captain, wouldn’t we be better off crossing the border first to meet them? There is no need for us to keep such a number stationed here—”

His subordinate prompting him to send half, even a third of his forces, Oldart lightly raised a hand to stop him from saying any further.

The reason was the dragon descending from the sky.

A gray dragon—not under the dragoons’ jurisdiction, the dragon of the royal guard.

“Now that wouldn’t do. Their other force is few in numbers. The enemy’s main body is here. It wouldn’t do for you to take arbitrary action.”

The gray dragon landed before Oldart’s subordinate. Fritz dismounted from its back and came out before Oldart.

“Why if it isn’t the supreme commander. Well, just try and understand the thoughts of someone who cares for his comrade in arms. So anyway, why have you ridden to the battlefield alone?”

What about the army? When Oldart asked, Fritz shrugged his shoulders.

Atop the back of a dragon, my speed far outweighs their march. I wanted to get a prior view of the battlefield.

Oldart was beset by a tiredness. No, rather than tired, a part of him understood how he felt.

(When you're riding a dragon, a normal march feels like a snail's pace... but the supreme commander leaving his army is a big no-no.)

Perhaps his subordinate felt the same, he made a conflicted expression as he looked at Fritz.

(It's the same whether he's there or not? Well, he's the princess' favorite, after all.)

He surely didn't have a place even among his own troops.

As Oldart thought, he looked at the immobile imperials right across the border.



Meanwhile—

The army led by Askewell had suffered large losses from but a single man.

Even if that had been taken into account, the figures were too large to have come from opposing one unit.

“Have the monsters stand down. Surround him with elites.”

By Askewell's orders, knights in uniform full-body armor came out front.

Their footing nimble despite the solid armor over their bodies, they were undoubtedly elites.

Askewell led them to surround Rudel in order to prepare a stage for one-on-one combat.

“White Dragoon, was it. You are strong. Far too strong. That is why... I must personally take you on.”

After picking up his spear and dismounting his horse, he walked over to Rudel.

While Rudel was covered in mud, dead-exhausted, even so, his fighting spirit didn't wither before Askewell.

A sword in his right hand.

A shield in his left.

The knight in white armor fought Askewell's army on his lonesome self.

It was not his intent to show his respect.

(I'll beat you down here. For the morale of the entire army.)

After tiring him out so, Askewell would defeat his tattered opponent in one-on-one combat. He knew they couldn't be called a virtue of the battlefield, but such notions were irrelevant to him.

If he didn't win this battle, the empire had no future.

What's more, he couldn't let Rudel continue to put out casualties. If it came out that one man had taken down several thousands, it would influence morale. Crushing him with numbers would do little to remedy the situation, but if Askewell were to go out and defeat this dragoon, he would be able to completely turn the situation around.

(It would normally be a poor move, but...)

Rudel had stuck fast far harder than anticipated, forcing Askewell to change his objectives a number of times.

When Askewell readied his spear, Rudel's mouth curled into a grin.

(So he laughs in this situation.)

There were at times, those who sought beauty on the battlefield. One on one combat and personal sacrifice—Askewell was unable to understand them.

At his core, he was someone who set out to be a research, not of a nature to look up to war heroes.

(Is he the sort that seeks his place to be on the battlefield?)

Seeing Askewell's stance, Rudel opened his mouth.

"You... are strong. However!"

Rudel instantly closed the distance with a cut; Askewell turned aside his strike with his spear.

Receiving, parrying, he warded off Rudel's attacks.

He had to be worn out, seeing the crudeness sticking out in Rudel's attacks, Askewell was convinced.

(He's close to his limit.)

A large step in, Askewell thrust his spear, and Rudel stopped the attack with his left-hand shield. He tried to divert the face, but it seemed he was unable.

"I'll show you my respect for remaining to fight on your own. I will parade your corpse, but I will erect a monument."

Rudel didn't seem particularly interested.

"Don't go erecting monuments in someone else's country. Do you think you've won?"

— The match was practically decided already.

As he was about to say that, Rudel slammed Askewell's spear hard into the ground.

The impact lifted the dirt, and as it flew through the air, Rudel took distance

—
"You're not getting away!"

When Askewell tried to give chase, Rudel fired off water magic towards the ground. With the moistened earth making it easier to slip, Askewell stopped moving for only a brief moment.

Confirming that, Rudel disappeared from before his eyes.

No, it was as if a gale had broken out with Rudel at the center, he began moving at a tremendous speed.

“W-what are—”

Looking around, Askewell opened his eyes wide.

There a scene of the elites surrounding them being cut down in a moment of distraction unfolded before his eyes.

Askewell regained a strong grip of his spear, turned to Rudel and yelled.

“Your opponent is over here!”

Rudel glanced at him and spoke.

“Wrong. Each and every one of you is my opponent.”



Rudel held up his sword as he looked at Askewell.

(But this guy is strong. Each individual blow is strangely heavy.)

The man coming at him, in comparison, didn't fall short of Rudel in either power or speed. A blessed constitution.

Askewell's talent and mana capacity might even exceed his own.

However—

“You fight way too cleanly.”

Lifting dirt with his foot, he kicked it straight at Askewell's face. While he immediately reacted and avoided it, his movements were unaccustomed.

He had rarely fought against an equal. Or perhaps too many of his fights had been against monsters, and in battles against humans, his blessed talent would end the match far too soon.

To an extent, he looked inexperienced when it came to fighting foes of close strength.

(But perhaps that just means that's simply how talented he was.)

Askewell swiped his spear to the side.

That attack wrapped in the mud on the ground to assail Rudel. What was just a physical attack became a shockwave to come at him.

Springing over it to avoid, Rudel cut down at him from above. Askewell held his spear horizontally to catch the blow.

That powerful strike sunk the third prince's boots into the ground.

(I can't just push through as I am now.)

As he thought that, Rudel's body let off a faint light. Symbols surfaced over his form, covering his entire body to protect him.

Unleashing the power of the white knight, Rudel took a look around.

(Looks like cutting down the elites has set the others in motion.)

Panicking at Rudel's change, the surroundings moved to protect Askewell. Those surroundings were blown back by a bolt of light from Rudel.

"Bastard!"

While Askewell glared at Rudel, from Rudel's point of view, he had no recollection of accepting a one-on-one duel. More so, whilst surrounded by enemies, there was no dishonor to be had in launching an attack.

To add to that, Rudel had noticed Askewell's ulterior motive.

(I see, so his aim is to defeat me and raise morale. That's surprisingly earnest. Is that how far they've been cornered?)

If they kept pushing him back with numbers, Rudel thought he could cut them down, and inflict enough damage that the enemy would retreat when reinforcements came.

"What's wrong? If you don't stop me, your men will die."

When he provoked with a smile, Askewell forcefully swung his spear to knock Rudel back. Purposely flying back, Rudel opened more distance and attacked his surroundings once more.

The imperial army launched magic and arrows at him; but as Askewell was right by him, those attacks were few and far between.

(Should I use him as a shield to lower their numbers?)

As he considered it, Askewell fired off his strongest thrust at him. That blow like an arrow shot from afar looked to be difficult to fend off.

Due to his sheer force, the foothold Askewell kicked sent dirt several meters into the air.

Holding out his left hand, Rudel stationed several dozens of shields of light in the path of his advance. With enough force to pierce through all of them, Askewell's momentum was only decreased by the slightest amount.

But that slight was enough. For at the end of his charge through dozens of shield—Rudel was long gone.

As Askewell hurriedly stopped in his tracks, Rudel circled around to his left—and bashed Askewell with his shield.

"Dammit! If I could circle right..."

That would have settled the match, but enemy soldiers had gathered there, and there was a chance his timing would be off.

He regretted not swinging his sword from an impossible angle.

(I need some more training. It's a severe blow that I didn't take him out with that attack.)

He tried to pursue Askewell, blown back, rolling along the ground, but enemies gathered around him.

They were surely trying to protect him.

While he did have some thoughts on their devotion—

“This is the war you started—”

Rudel cut down any soldier that would stand between himself and Askewell.



Askewell's head was hazy.

(What just...)

When he raised his head, the backs of his men were directed at him, and beyond them a fountain of blood. His head was heavy.

Rudel had smacked him in the head, and the sounds of the battlefield sounded somewhat distant.

“W-what are you doing. Stop. You have to pull back!”

His subordinates died before his eyes. That was something Askewell couldn't bear.

While he would kill his foes, he was too soft on his allies.

As he tried to stand to his feet, he thought he heard a single clear voice.

‘... When I’ve put so much in your favor, you can’t even properly fulfill your role?’

Hearing that disappointed voice, Askewell looked around. Time seemed to flow by ever so slowly.

(What’s happening—)

‘That’s enough.’

Upon that irritated voice, he saw the ground at his feet suddenly overflowing with a pitch-black mud.

(What? This is...)

He tried to run, but his body wouldn’t move.

Yet as the black mud swallowed him down, a sense of delight—he could tell his strength was coming back to him.

Enveloped in a relief that made him want to entrust it his body, he could sense the wariness he had held towards Rudel a moment before was relaxing.

(Aah, this is...)

Askewell was swallowed by the mud, and when it came unstuck, there he was, his entire body covered in a dark ominous armor stuck-fast to his being.

No, rather than armor, perhaps it was closer to skin.

When his form had practically become that of the devil, Askewell looked at Rudel. Within that slowly moving time, Rudel’s eyes were trailed on him.

(... So he noticed. But it’s too late.)

The surrounding time returned to normal, and when the sounds came back vividly, Askewell swiftly approached Rudel and kicked him.

Blown away, Rudel collided where his army of allies was stationed, dragging in the surroundings as he rose a cloud of dust.

His subordinates took in Askewell's form in bewilderment.

“Askewell-sama...”

“That form is...”

“What could have?”

Seeing his perplexed subordinates, Askewell didn't think anything in particular. Walking straight and tall, he held up his right hand a bit.

A black something escaped from his hand, that something was a spear.

Pulling that uncanny black spear from his body, Askewell walked towards Rudel, slowly breaking into a dash.

It was as if he was verifying the movements of his body, and without seeing his men before him as a hindrance, he simply blew them away in his wake.

From the person he had been a moment ago, something fundamental had changed.

“Now, here is your real battle.”

Askewell closed in on Rudel. An unsightly smile spread across his face.

Chapter 155: Dragon and Wyvern

As the demonized Askewell blew him away, Rudel cut the inside of his mouth. Dripping blood, he looked at the beast making towards him as he stood.

“Now this is troublesome.”

He was blown away to where imperial soldiers were in close formation.

For that reason, the impact knocked soldiers off their feet, and around him, the troops had surrounded him to prevent him from escaping, but... he could tell from their faces they were confused at Askewell's transformation.

Shaking off his own subordinate's restraints, he smacked them aside.

“As far as I can tell, he's conscious.”

Looking into Askewell's eyes, apart from malice towards Rudel, it looked like there was some sort of consciousness within them.

“I'll find out if I give it a go.”

Taking his stance, he cut at Askewell.

Unlike before, Askewell violently swung his spear to knock Rudel's sword aside.

Determining that even with the strength of the white knight he would lose in a battle of pure force, Rudel circled around behind him.

He could circle in the blink of an eye. It was easy enough for him to take Askewell's back, but...

“This is—”

He heard the sound of metal colliding.

Rudel had definitely lowered his sword at the point he'd aimed for. The nape of his neck.

Immediately jumping back, he avoided Askewell's lance that came with the same motion as he turned face. The impact brought casualties to the soldiers around him.

That hardened-skin-like armor was almost like metal. Yet be that as it may, it didn't look like it was obstructing his movements.

Askewell looked at Rudel, lackadaisically opening his mouth.

“Is that all you've got? In that case, it won't be long before I kill you and continue the march. With this power, it won't just be this region. We can cut deep into the Kingdom of Courtois. We might make it all the way to the capital.”

He would continue the march, he would make all the way to the capital, Askewell said and laughed.

(He's incapable of rational decision making, I see.)

As Rudel laid down a verdict, Askewell took a stance with his spear.

“Where did all that vigor go, dragoon!”

Kicking the ground, Askewell closed in on him.

Rudel fired a light bolt in his direction. While it met him head on and exploded, it had no visible effect on Askewell's assault.

“If even magic is ineffective, this is going to be troublesome.”

While he was exhibiting the white knight's power, Rudel was being overpowered. Against a foe whose power was no on another plane, Rudel

worked his head on means to counteract.

(Now then, I can't leave him to his own devices, but...)

But some part of him thought back to his student days. He had started out fighting Aleist, at the time a foe on another plane, and had pushed himself in some crazy ways.

(... Compared to that, I don't have it too bad right now.)

And now, the things he was capable of had increased.

With Askewell coming right at him, Rudel closed his eyes. He undid his stance, and without putting up any resistance, the point of Askewell's spear was encroaching on his face.

"Given up!?"

There was just a bit of anger in Askewell's voice. Perhaps he was disappointed in Rudel for giving up having come so far. But Rudel snapped his eyes open.

"Sorry but... I never did know when to give up."

When he opened his eyes, his blue iris had turned red. He was using his magic eyes.

Rudel's armor from the black boar.

Rudel's eyes from the mad bird.

They had left them to him to fight against destiny.

Feeling the time around him pass slowly, Rudel avoided the spear point by a hair's breadth, let go of his weapon, grabbed the spear, and used it as a lever to throw Askewell.

He had used the prince's momentum.

Thrown off of his feet, Askewell slammed into the ground. But he was immediately up.

Rudel's sword and shield were now stuck in the ground. He confronted Askewell barehanded.

“Are you mocking me?”

Askewell must have felt belittled. Casting down one's weapon in this situation was out of the question.

Yet Rudel was serious.

“I'm always serious. This way was simply the optimum method to win against you.”

Rudel smiled.

“I need to train more. There are too many techniques I can't use with a weapon. But hey, if you think you're being belittled, then I must apologize for that.”

Seriously coming to defeat Askewell, Rudel wasn't making light of anyone. Thought how Askewell saw it was a separate issue.

“If that isn't mocking, then—”

Right after, Rudel manifested before Askewell's eyes.

His fist lifted, Rudel swiftly lowered it towards him.

Askewell, making light of Rudel's attack—

“Guhah!”

— Was sent sprawling a long way through the air.

Rudel looked at Askewell blown away, waving his right hand a bit.

“That’s hard. Well, not too hard to get through.”

Askewell brushed a hand against his smacked face. There were no external wounds. In the first place, by demonizing, it became hard to put a dent in his skin.

It was a separate issue if the force could penetrate inside of it.

“W-what did you do?”

Rudel gripped his fist towards Askewell, whose mouth dripped with blood.

“I penetrated the force.”

After only those words, Askewell’s spear was ready to attack Rudel. He stepped in and lowered it from up high.

His speed—it was a blow that was lowered in the time an average fighter would have taken to raise it up. That inconceivable power and speed, a normal person wouldn’t even be able to comprehend they had died if they took it on.

Avoiding the attack, Rudel let his eyes glow red as he laughed.

“Too slow!”

A left straight with his weight behind it sunk into Askewell’s body, the impact passing through his pack and piercing him through.

Askewell spat up blood.

“Guh, damn you!!”

Seeing him lose his composure, Rudel felt just a little disappointed.

“If that’s all it takes, you were stronger before.”

Watching him recklessly swing around his power, Rudel kicked him away.

A deep breath, Rudel took a stance as Askewell stood and tried swinging his spear—

“I told you... too slow.”

— In the next instant, Rudel grabbed Askewell’s face with his right hand and slammed him into the ground. Right after.

“It’s over.”

With those words, a large shockwave broke out with Askewell at the center. The ground caved in to form a crater.

The surrounding imperial soldiers were blown away, Askewell showed the whites of his eyes.

Rudel sluggishly stood.

To put an end to the immobile Askewell—to take his head, he approached, when he felt something was off.



Meanwhile.

The army Fritz led as supreme commander was half on the verge of collapse.

“What are the dragoons doing!?”

“An army of wyvern in the sky—”

“The enemy number surpass three hundred riders—”

The imperial army started up as soon as their own army arrived. It was all going right by the planned scenario. But the imperial army that moved had established their wyvern unit as a countermeasure to the dragoons.

Three hundred knights mounting wyverns, a battle unfolded in the sky above.

Looking to the sky, they were outnumbered and overwhelmed.

Subordinates rushed to Fritz one after the next to report and seek orders.

“The empire’s army has crossed the border and begun hostilities with our forces! But their numbers are higher. We need reinforcements—”

“More than that, we should pull back. The empire boasts three times our land troops!”

Even if they sought reinforcements, there were no reserves to send around.

Having depended on their dragoons, the Kingdom of Courtois couldn’t reach the empire in ground troops. What’s more, on a quality side as well, the empire surpassed Courtois.

Their weapons tempered under the torment of dragons.

They had now turned to torment the knights and soldiers of Courtois.

Fritz was dismayed by this unanticipated situation.

From the very start, he was a decoration of a commander. And yet, for them to seek so much from him now, there was little he could do about it.

Those around watched him with chastising eyes.

“I-immediately request reinf—”

He tried to give an order for reinforcements, but his subordinate denied it.

“Where do you seen the leisure for that!?”

Not even with a grasp of the army’s state of affairs, Fritz didn’t fully understand how many units were stationed where.

(Why... what could have happened?)

Fritz clenched his fist, and the words of the next messenger who surged into the tent turned his face pale.

“U-urgent report! Princess Fina has raised a rebellion at the capital! Both Archduke Diade and Archduke Halbades have turned hostile, and Princess Aileen has been placed in a terrible predicament.”

It wasn't just the battlefield, there was chaos at the palace as well, causing many of those gathered to lose their complexion.

Those here were those who sided with Aileen.

If Aileen were to be overthrown—

“Retreat. Rush to the aid of the palace at once, and subjugate the rebel for —”

“How can we retreat with an enemy before us!? In their pursuit, our army will fall to ruin!”

If they continued the fight with the empire, their prospects of victory looked slim.

But if they didn't return to the capital, their standings would be in danger.

Within all of that, Frit sprinted out of the tent.

He raced over to his own dragon.

(Aileen!)

He acted out of worry for Aileen. If he hurried, he hoped he could make it in time.



Oldart issued orders to his men in the air.

“We can take them on one to three. Just do that and we win.”

The wind dragon flying beside him—Alejandro riding on its back was fed-up.

Avoiding the wyvern breath firing all around him, he yelled at Oldart.

“I don’t care about that. Give some actual precise orders!”

A laughing Oldart continued moving his formation to draw the wyverns further from the ground as he looked at the armies below.

“Well, here should be good.”

If the two armies clashed below, the dragoons wouldn’t be able to fight without reserve. If nothing else, they wouldn’t be able to aim any breath attacks down.

Any accidental shots at allied forces, and the dragoons would be blamed.

“Well then, ladies and gentlemen—how about we teach these imperial knights just how difficult fights in the air can be? Risking our lives to do it.”

Following that with a ferocious smile, the dragoons’ movements changed.

The dragons that had been flying on the run turned face to go on an offense.

Alejandro raised the speed of his wind dragon, circling around a wyvern, and having his dragon crunch its neck.

Oldart’s gray dragon turned to face three encroaching wyverns, continuing to fly backward as it peppered them with flames to drop them one after the next.

Pulling his own weapon, Oldart jumped to switch over to the wyvern that had come right below them.

The imperial knight riding it was surprised by his sudden visitor.

“Royal scum!”

While the knight drew his blade, he didn’t seem very accustomed to combat in the air.

“You’re going weak at the knees. How do you expect to swing a weapon like that?”

He kicked the enemy knight off, the knight raised a scream as he fell. The wyvern began flailing as Oldart stabbed his sword into its back.

After leaping off the wyvern and taking distance, his own dragon came to collect him.

Their high coordination surprised the empire’s wyvern unit. And one after another, the wyverns fell to the ground.

“Real sorry. We’ve got several hundred years of knowhow stacked up. We’re not soft enough to lose to some sudden upstart pans—what?”

Rising his gray dragon’s back, Oldart looked around.

The wyverns began to dissipate into a black smoke and disappear, the fog flying off to somewhere far away. It was rising from the ground as well.

The monsters they’d led with them turned to smoke and headed off somewhere.

The empire’s knights abandoned in the air fell straight down; Oldart promptly recovered one of them.

“Oy, what just happened?”

Grabbing the knight’s weapon and tossing it away, he pressed a knife to their neck to draw information.

“I-I don’t know! We were never told any—”

The knight made truly fearful eyes. Oldart clicked his tongue.

(You can't lie if you were never told to start with. The direction of the smoke is... don't tell me, it's where Rudel is?)

The smoke was flowing to another battlefield.

Upon discerning that, Oldart had a terrible premonition. Alejandro rushed over to him.

“Oldart! The supreme commander up and left. The ground troops are taking to their heels and fleeing!”

Oldart looked at the ground.

Courtois' army on the run. The disappearance of the wyvern unit had prompted the imperial army to prepare to flee as well.

“... Retreat. We'll leave fifty riders, and the rest of us are chasing that smoke.”

Oldart looked at the black smoke drawing a single straight line in the sky as he spoke.

Chapter 156: What's Gone and Done

On the back of a gray dragon, a lone rider made for the capital.

“Hurry...go faster!”

A gray dragon could move hundreds of kilometer in the air, but to Fritz, it felt far too slow.

Even now, Aileen's life could be in danger. When the thought struck him, he wished to save her, pure had honest.

At first, he thought he was lucky. Being liked by the princess and receiving preferential treatment, from captain of the royal guard to supreme commander...

But now, Fritz would throw it all away to go save Aileen.

“I see it!”

The view of the capital from the sky.

Smoke was rising from the palace in the center of the large city. Even seen from afar, it was clear something had gone awry.

“I have to hurry and—”

The dragon flew to the palace for Fritz' sake. On one of the verandas of the palace, there was a cornered Aileen.

Around here were those who saw to her everyday, and knights who were only good for appearance's sake. They wouldn't be of any use at all.

Flames had broken out in various parts of the building, it seemed the battles still raged on.

“Aileen!”

Fritz approached the palace.

Looking up at him, Aileen smiled.

“Fritz-sama!”

But cruel as could be, it was then that enemies flowed into the room where she hid. The defenders and the personal army of an archduke house broke through the royal guard, and the knights of Aileen's fraction to flood in.

The knights and servants by her side were immediately apprehended.

“Kuh! Do it!”

To save Aileen, Fritz ordered his dragon to breath fire. But the gray dragon shook its head to the side. It wasn't that it had ignored Fritz' orders.

If it fired its breath, Aileen would be drawn into its midst.

Before Fritz' eyes, Aileen was taken in.

The enemy used her as a shield, they seemed to be well aware he wouldn't be able to attack.

“Cowards!”

Just as Fritz drew his sword and was about to jump down, the rebel army led by Fina made its appearance. Protected by the high knights around her, Fina expressionlessly looked up at the sky.

Aileen turned to Fina and cried out.

“Why have you done this—Fina! I... I was only trying to make Courtois a better country.”

Fina wouldn't turn to face her. The high knights around readied their shields to solidify Fina's defenses.

“Fina-sama, please step back!”

“The enemy is a dragon!”

“Keep Princess Aileen close!”

Fina brushed off their advice to go out onto the balcony. She stared straight at Fritz.

“Why did you hoist insurrection at such an important time!?”

Receiving his anger, Fina opened her mouth.

“It's precisely because it's this time. Just as you want to save my sister, I want to save my master—Rudel-dono. But if I left you people to your own devices, even if Rudel-dono returned, you'd devise some reason to have him executed, wouldn't you?”

As she plainly stated, “That's why I raised a rebellion,” as if it were the most obvious thing in the world, Fritz was at a loss for words.

“... You're mad. You rebelled for that reason alone!?”

Fina lightly spread out her arms, and expressionlessly, she advised Fritz to surrender.

“I don't think you're one to talk. Well, so be it. Now turn yourself in. Do so now, and you can still be decapitated as a noble knight.”

Perhaps that was compassion to Fina, but to Fritz, there was no way he could accept it.

“Don't mock me!”

Fina lowered a hand.

“I see. That is a shame.”

Holding her right hand up, Fina snapped her fingers.

Aileen looked beyond Fritz, to the skies even higher and cried out.

“Fritz-sama, run!”

When Fritz looked up, there were six dragoons closing in on him. His gray dragon arbitrarily withdrew from the spot.

“W-wait! I still have to save—”

As Fritz was pulled away from the balcony, Aileen looked at him with an expression of despair. Fritz reached out his right hand.

“Aileen...”

He powerlessly muttered.



As Fritz made off to the distance, three dragoons chased after.

Fina saw them off before returning from the balcony to the room.

Sophina beside her wiped her sweat.

“That was way too reckless, no matter how you look at it.”

Sophina candidly chastised her thoughtless conduct. Upon hearing that, Fina answered expressionless and indifferent.

“You’re right. I’m sorry, Sophina.”

“I see you’re not repenting in the slightest.”

She hadn't known her a long time for nothing, Sophina read Fina's emotions.

"Well, at least the dragon had some sense to spare, and I knew they wouldn't attack if we used my sister as a shield. The dragon Fritz rides is a gentle one, after all."

There were individual differences among dragons.

The one Fritz rode was comparatively gentle, and a good dragon that would listen to the orders of its partner knight.

Fritz was afforded a dragon that was easy to handle, so that went without saying.

"A dragon's breath could have easily eradicated two princesses."

There, Fina uninterestedly brushed her hair aside.

"Even so, I wanted to try it. Otherwise, Fritz would—"

Aileen restrained by the knights yelled at Fina.

"Fina! Do you understand what it is you've done!? And what do you think you're doing to Fritz-sama?"

Fina turned back to Aileen.

"... If he was taken in there, he would have his head cut off. I meant precisely what I said. Or would you prefer he be tortured and executed as a heinous criminal?"

Aileen crumbled at the knees.

"T-torture..."

As Fina looked at Aileen, the archdukes Halbades and Diade entered the room.

“If it isn’t Fina-sama, it looks like you’ve managed to accomplish your objective.”

To the two shamelessly approaching, Fina breathed a sigh inside.

(Their timing is impeccable... well whatever.)

They had surely come to confirm Aileen’s safety. Perhaps they needed a proper check if they wanted her to take responsibility at the gallows.

As Fina walked off, the archdukes walked side by side with her.

“Now then, how do you intend to deal with Aileen-sama?”

To Archduke Diade’s question, after thinking a bit.

“... Officially, she’ll be executed. After that, confinement. If we don’t know if I can have kids yet, we’ll need some insurance, won’t we?”

Archduke Halbades nodded. He seemed just a little delighted.

He seemed happy Fina could make a proper judgment as royalty. No, perhaps because there was a spare, he was happy to know Fina would always have a replacement.

(If I’m too stupid, these bastards will pull a fast one, and if I act too smart they’ll come to kill me. Good grief, this is why I wanted to chip away their power.)

If Aileen was killed, Fina would be the only direct descendant of Courtois. In that case, while Fina’s own safety was assured, in the case she didn’t have children, an archduke would be next in line to be enthroned.

In the case of Aileen’s prolonged survival—if Fina used the power of the state against the archdukes, there was a possibility they’d raise Aileen up and have a rebellion of their own.

As to what she wanted to say... no matter which way the ball rolled, Fina was in a harsh situation.

(I'll have to be wary either way. Aaah, this is why I wanted to end it before these guys could arrive.)

Like that, upon confirming her victory at the palace, Fina quickly entered preparations to send reinforcements.

“... Now then, I've secured a place for you to come back to, master.”

A small mutter and Fina had immediately gotten to work.



In the sky, Fritz hit the dragon's back again and again.

“Why did you run!? Get back there at once! Go back!”

Fritz cried and pounded his fist, but it was clear even if he remained, he wouldn't have been able to save Aileen.

Even so, he wanted someone to blame so badly, he couldn't help himself.

This wasn't his fault. He needed to know it wasn't his fault.

“... I.”

Before he realized it, he had deserted under enemy fire, while his last ray of hope Aileen had already been taken in and lost her authority.

As one who had a dragon, the dragoons would be in a mad frenzy to find him. And what awaited him when he was taken in...

“Haha, ahahahah... dammit! What an insignificant life! Come so far... after coming so far.”

All that awaited was despair. Run as he may, there was nowhere to go. As he considered defecting to the empire, a black fog had begun to gather around him.

“W-what's this!?”

As Fritz looked around, the gray dragon roared.

Before him, a winged giant—a Gora was being formed.

A four-armed giant bald only on the head, it was far larger than a gray dragon. The gora's fist smacked into the dragon, slamming it and Fritz onto the ground.

(What is it now...)

Fritz' consciousness grew distant.



(H-huh... I'm alive?)

When Fritz opened his eyes, before them was the form of a gray dragon, its wings plucked off, its body bleeding all over.

Seeing the back of the terribly wounded gray dragon, Fritz lifted his body.

“W-what just...”

Beyond the dragon, a gora with a hole in its chest, collapsed to its knees.

“Did you do it?”

Fritz couldn't believe his own partner had fought that brutal monster and come out on top. The likes of a gray dragon compared to a wild dragon, it was clearly inferior.

Comparing it to Rudel's dragon, he even saw it as shoddy. And yet, that dragon had fought, its life on the line to protect its partner Fritz.

“You... why!?”

It fought to protect an unconscious Fritz, and now afflicted with a fatal blow, it didn't look like it could rise or fly any longer.

Blood flowed from his mouth.

‘... I am a dragon born of the Kingdom of Courtois. One of the first of my kind.’

The dragon that had never conversed with him before was suddenly making a speech.

‘I was raised with love. But my brothers are already all gone. While some died to illness, a great many fell in battle.’

Fritz stroked the gray dragon. He had always found her unsympathetic, he had never tried speaking from his side. For that reason, he didn’t know the first thing about his own partner dragon.

“Then why did you save the likes of me? If you submitted me to them—”

‘I have my own pride. As a dragon... the pride to protect my partner. I’ve lost my partner knights too many times. Each time I would feel regret. Among them, there were terrible knights. But a majority of them treated me as a partner. They treated me dearly. That’s why I swore to protect them, no matter what sort of partner they may be.’

When Frit was about to say something, the Dragon gave her last words—

‘... Let me say one last things. You should look around a bit more. It might be too late, but... you have the talent.’

After one final deep deep breath, the dragon collapsed and died.

When Frit’s tears began to flow, this time, the gora’s mouth moved.

‘How dare a lowly gray dragon... but you are no longer necessary. It’s all going as planned...’

The mouth of the dead gora moved, causing Frit to draw his sword. Upon seeing its blade, the gora’s eyes narrowed.

‘That is not your weapon. And I’m already done with you. It’s time for the stand-in to leave the stage. Your place has already been prepared...’

The gora dissipated into black fog and swallowed Fritz up.

“S-stop it! I still—”

The black fog swallowed Fritz, leaving some parting words, it faded away.

“It’s all according to plan. To deliver the sword to Aleist someday...”



When he came to, the black fog-swallowed Fritz was sitting in the middle of a wasteland.

“... Eh?”

His enemy gora was gone, the husk of his partner nowhere to be found. The place looked a bit different from where he had been before.

In his confusion, Fritz stood, and caught sight of a group on the move. A gathering of merchants and travelers, but it seemed they were being attacked by monsters.

“What’s with that group?”

But seeing the members, Fritz felt something off. They were wearing equipment of quite an old style, and the way they fought was peculiar.

He couldn’t stand and watch.

With that on his mind, Fritz drew his sword and helped out the caravan.

— After that.

The group of horse-drawn wagons offered him a lift, and it was then he learned his words wouldn’t get through. The towns and villages they led him to seemed somewhat off from what he knew.

He felt almost as if he had been flown off to another world.

Left with nothing but a borrowed sword and the clothes on his back, with no people he could speak for, Fritz would spend the rest of his life finding a place for himself in this strange new world.



Years later.

On Rudel's battlefield, a peculiar scene unfolded.

"Well damn."

Before the eyes of Rudel as he gave a troubled laugh, Askewell had been taken in by black fog, and assimilated with a Gora to stand before him.

But that wasn't what bothered him.

Perhaps it could be called ironic... right above the gora, consisting of black and red lines, a sinister dragon beat its large spread wings.

The reason Rudel was so troubled lay in that the black fog had gathered, and changed into a dragon.

The dragon looked down over him.

'This is where you disappear.'

Come this far, Rudel never thought he'd be facing off against a dragon. He smiled a bit.

"Good grief, someone up there must like messing with me..."

The fated foe of one who sought to be a dragoon, at the end would face Rudel in the form of a dragon.

Chapter 157: Events Set in Stone

In Courtois' palace, the knights and nobles who had lost the flag known as Aileen, and a great many soldiers who took part were apprehended.

A portion of the palace had burned up, and the walls were crumbling, but with no time to consider repair costs, Fina led Sophina and her pieces, the defenders to meet with her mother and father.

Albach lay on the bed. He seemed somewhat relieved the ruckus in the palace had died down. But when he heard of Aileen, his expression clouded over.

In place of Alback, whose voice still wouldn't come out, Ciel inquired Fina.

"Fina, I recognize your ability in putting a stop to Aileen's reckless actions. The truth stands that you managed so much while we were unable to do anything. You may become the next queen, regnant or consort, and do whatever you may. However, in regards to Aileen."

Her mother Ciel worried about Aileen as well.

Fina gave a slight nod.

"Understood. However, she will officially be treated as dead. That is the most I am capable of."

She raised a rebellion while the empire was invading. Aileen would henceforth be treated as dead.

"That is plenty. Also, about the war situation—"

Even if they possessed dragoons, if the palace was in shambles, perhaps something terrible was happening on the battlefield.

As Ciel thought so, Fina breathed a sigh within.

(Sister went and dispatched my troops, so I have no forces to send around to master. Albeit I heard Archduke Halbades and Diade sent out reinforcements.)

Fina wouldn't impart Ciel with any wishful thinking. She simply expressed the truth.

"The situation is still being verified."

A wrinkle graced the queen's brow.

"That's a disgrace. Even if you win here, if territory is lost, you'll be the next one up for the executioner's block."

But Ciel couldn't really blame Fina for it. She had, in essence, been shoved by her daughter into house arrest.

Fina turned to Ciel and gave a curtsy.

"I have already taken measures, so no need to worry. Now about what's to come—"

The confusion in the palace would be cleaned up by Fina.

(Alright, I've made a place for master to return, so what's left is the battlefield.)



"What is... this..."

"General Liquorice, what in god's name is this?"

Mies Liquorice— Askewell's adjutant, and a girl who's name was placed in the position of second in command looked at the scene on the battlefield at a loss for words.

The strengthened black monsters she's prepared, dead or alive, dissipated into smoke and gathered at two points.

The first was at Askewell, who'd been defeated by the white knight.

The rest gathered in the sky and took on the form of a dragon.

The Gora Askewell had prepared a dragoon countermeasure to decide the battle.

A giant, four armed, hideous monster. Its enhanced form sprouted wings, so it could even fly through the sky.

But when the white dragon was released, it suffered a large injury and was sent to the backlines.

Taking in such a giant, Askewell has sunk up to his chest in the gora's forehead. All that could be seen was his drooping silhouette.

"I don't know. This isn't... what I..."

From the start, there were too many unnatural points. The monster controlled greeted such success it even made her fearful. And establishing an army of enhanced monsters.

It was a monster army that had been crafted up without any decent research, but even Mies never thought it could do something like this.

Her subordinate, a knight sought confirmation.

"Should we call back the generals?"

The self-proclaimed archmage Leor was preparing a magic circle, so he couldn't move.

Bahn Rhoshwas said he wasn't interested and led his army separate from the main battalion.

Mies wanted to hold her head.

Leor was someone who fixated on preparing his own personal magic circle, and only fighting on top of it. If the enemy did stray over, his magic would most likely blow them away. He could probably even take on a dragon.

But he couldn't move.

Bahn had a distaste for surrounding a single man with a massive army, and showed no signs of moving. No, he might move if he noticed this abnormal state of affairs...

“Send a messenger at—”

As Mies was about to move, a dragon roared overhead.

When she looked to the sky, the white knight had set out his shields and swords of light, leaping up to face it.

“What even is he!?”

Seeing Rudel stand to face the fiendish-looking dragon, Mies cried out with teary eyes.



‘I see. So that is your answer.’

Facing the thorny, sinister dragon, Rudel fired a round of magic. The reason he took on the sky battle was because Askewell wasn't moving.

Embedded into the giant's forehead, he was still slumped down without a twitch.

Therefore, he decided the dragon was a higher priority.

The dragon narrowed its eyes as it took on Rudel's magic. Yet no matter how he fired, it showed no visible effect.

“Don't go arbitrarily closing the curtains. I definitely did mull a bit... but you are my enemy, aren't you?”

While Rudel did love dragons, that didn't mean he was kind enough to concede his life to one.

More than that—

“But I myself do hold a special loathing for such underhanded means.”

He glared at the dragon.

The black smoke had gathered to defeat Rudel and took the form of a dragon. That was something Rudel couldn't forgive.

‘I see. But this is your end. It must be your end. That is the conclusion of the ‘story’, and your fate.’

The sinister dragon—the vile serpent spread its large wings, the atmosphere trembling under its roar. The vibrations alone sent Rudel sprawling, crashing him into the ground.

Quickly getting up, he wiped his mouth.

“The that's just from the roar. And I'm not even scratching it...”

While inside, he did want to ride it just a little bit, Rudel gripped his weapon.

‘You shouldn't keep your eyes on me. The one who will kill you is—’

Rudel lowered his eyes a bit. He had no choice but to.

For there was the form of a black giant, raising tremors in the earth as it made its way for him.

Aiming at Askewell in its foreheads, he didn't hesitate to form and shoot swords of light.

While they hit directly and exploded, the thought of stopping seemed foreign to this four-armed being.

“This... will be harsh.”

Approaching his limit, Rudel murmured to himself, before him a dragon in the air, a gora on the earth.

“... Is this my fate?”

With a small mutter, and a small laugh.

“But not bad. If anything's to best me, it better be ramped up this high...”

For a moment, Rudel recalled Sakuya when she had her human form.

The words Sakuya spoke to him.

“When I'm going to be the strongest dragoon, if I stood down here, she'd laugh at me.”

With overwhelming despair laid out ahead, Rudel slowly took one step forward.

He walked, gradually raising his speed to face the Gora. While it was massive, its balance looked to be precarious, so much balancing on two feet.

“Alright, let's start with the ankles.”

Despite being in the worst situation, Rudel tried searching out the optimum hand. However, the dragon in the air gave a large flap of its wings to obstruct him.

With winds sweeping over him making it difficult to move, Rudel infiltrated the space around the gora's feet, and cut his sword into its ankle.

The giant's skin was too thick, a normal cut didn't seem like it would reach the tendon.

“In that case!”

Magic sword. Light dwelled in his blade as mana formed a sword edge around it, its length growing to a few dozen meters. And one spin.

The gora's leg was severed.

“Start with this guy—!”

Rudel jumped back with great haste as a breath attack was fired from above that would wrap the gora in two. He managed to void.

But the vile serpent in the air didn't seem perturbed.

The ground gouged out, amidst the blazing inferno—the gora that had finished regenerating its leg stood.

He heard the serpent's voice from the sky.

‘Struggle, stand. All that awaits you is death.’

Rudel, upon hearing that, readied his weapon with a smile.

“Perfect.”



Bennet's partner, the water dragon Heleene.

Riding on her back, Izumi and Aleist's party reunited with Sakuya along the way. After lowering the evacuees and entrusting them to Chlust, they made for the battlefield at full speed.

Bennet felt the air tremble from Heleene's back.

“What's this feeling...”

As Bennet felt an unpleasant presence, Heleene was the same.

‘Right. This detestable feeling. How should I put it, it’s pissing me off.’

Leaving Heleene’s remark aside, Bennet knew the battlefield was close, and ordered everyone to prepare for battle.

“We’re nearing the battle. Is everyone ready?”

Izumi nodded; Aleist had put on his black army, he was ready to go.

“I’m fine.”

“All good here. But is Heath okay?”

Gripped in Heleene’s forepaw, Aleist’s trusted steed that was being carried with them. Bennet heard Heath’s condition from Heleene and passed it on to Aleist.

“No problem. You’ve got yourself quite a fine horse. He’s rearing to start running the moment his legs hit the ground.”

Aleist felt relieved. His harem members were finished preparing as well.

But as Bennet faced forward, her expression turned a little bitter.

(The enemy is supposed to have prepared troops in the tens of thousands. In such a battlefield, Rudel alone. What’s more, we his reinforcements number so few.)

The probability of Ridel’s survival, and the damages wrought to their war potential by sending in so small numbers.

With a situation far too harsh before her, Bennet braced herself.

(A battlefield so drastic is a first for me.)

And the field came into view.

“... What’s that?”

The battlefield she saw had its surroundings blown away, the ground was showing its skin as not an army, but a black dragon hovered over the barren land.

On the earth, a large giant swung its four arms and opened its large mouth.

But as a radiant light emitted, three of its arms were lopped off and sent flying.

“It’s Rudel!”

— He was alive.

Upon confirming it so, Izumi cried out, while Aleist made a fist with his right hand in a triumphant pose. Bennet was also relieved, but...

The sinister dragon roared, while the giant’s open mouth emitted hundreds, thousands of needle-like somethings.

The intense sounds of battle that had rung up to that point could no longer be heard.

Behind Heleene, Sakuya who was desperately following roared. It was almost as if she was crying out. When Bennet looked at Izumi, she had collapsed to her knees.

“... So we didn’t make it.”

Those words from Bennet sent Aleist into a shock.

“N-no way. But there’s still a chance he’s alive!”

He might just be injured. That was surely what he wanted to say, but from Sakuya and Izumi’s state, Bennet understood the prospects were grim.

“A dragon has a good understanding of the state of their partner dragoon. Unfortunately... we’re now on a battle of vengeance. Worst case scenario,

we retrieve Rudel's corpse and pull out."

At her cold tone, Aleist grabbed her shoulders.

"H-how can you—!"

Say something so cruel, Aleist wanted to say. But Bennet knew how corpses were treated on the battlefield.

At the very least, wanting to make out with his body was still a show of compassion.

"We'll land soon. If he's alive, you might hear his last words. You and Izumi hurry to Rudel."

Bennet produced an iron boomerang from a bag fastened to Heleen and held it in her hand.

As Heleene neared the battlefield, she fired a breath at the dragon.

While there seemed to be safe troops on both flanks of the imperial army's battle array, the army in the center was in shambles.

While it did look bizarre, it also looked obvious they wouldn't be able to approach the dragon and giant rampaging in the center so easily.

"Those blasted imperials prepared something crazy."

A black dragon and giant.

It wasn't only Heleene who thought they were the work of the empire. Once Aleist parted from Bennet, he cast down his eyes and drew his swords.

(He must've done a toll, that Rudel.)

Knowing her subordinate had fought splendidly, Bennet strengthened the hand gripping her weapon. She continued testing out the black dragon by blasting breathes at it.

“We’re here.”

On the battlefield, imperial soldiers were gathering around Rudel.

Wedging numerous boomerangs in the space between her fingers, Bennet threw them in quick succession.

Heleene flew right up next to the ground to make it easier for everyone to disembark.

And the scene that came into sight was one of Rudel, his chest pierced through by a long spear-like projectile.

“Everyone get down.”

Heleene lowered Heath onto the ground, While Izumi and Aleist’s party jumped off her back one after the next.

What Bennet saw the moment after she jumped was the form of Sakuya punching at the giant.

Chapter 158: The End of the Event

Rudel looked at his own chest.

His white armor slathered in mud, he had incurred various injuries of all shapes and sizes. They were the proof he had managed to stand firm.

But now he was pierced by a black, twisted polearm.

Thousands of similar rods were stabbed into ground all around him, almost like a jail cell to lock him away.

He tried blowing away the rain of black spears from the sky. He had managed to parry a few of them...

“... Is this the limit?”

He let go of the sword in his right hand. Sewn onto the ground, his back arched back, Rudel spat up blood from his mouth.

A single stab to the heart.

A fatal blow.

“He’s got me. I can’t move anymore.”

Looking down on him was the gora, he’d severed three arms from a moment prior. The arms were gradually regenerating, and now it looked down over an immobile Rudel.

The vile serpent was the same.

As if to say their role was over, now they did nothing but stare down at him.

He heard footsteps.

Knights and soldiers of the empire.

While they were wary of the dragon and gora, as the two were no longer moving, they tried to approach. Of course, that was out of hatred of Rudel.

Having brought about such large-scale losses, they walked over to Rudel who had produced this current state of affairs.

“You crazy bastard.”

“Coward of Courtois.”

“How dare you, my brother...”

Comrades and relatives. Those who had them killed by Rudel’s hand took weapons in theirs to close in on him.

Their movements didn’t seem as if they were being led; they were moving on their own.

Rudel laughed.

“Did I crush the chain of command?”

It would be nice if that made them retreat, he thought as he looked at the sky.

The sky was clouded, the sort of weather to bring one down. The vile serpent flapping its wings in such a sky seemed to have already lost interest in him.

It gave off an air as if it was satisfied with this result.

“... Sakuya really is number one.”

Looking at the dark dragon beating its wings, Rudel closed his eyes and took a deep breath.

He heard the imperial soldiers flocking with weapons in hand.

“Did I... manage to resist?”

Rudel didn't know who his words were directed to. Perhaps it was Sakuya, perhaps his dear friends. The superiors and colleagues he trusted—and, Izumi's face came to mind.

With a roar, a breath was fired at the vile serpent.

The winds growing rough, the sound of two large masses colliding opened his eyes.

There was Sakuya.

Swinging her two large arms, she punched at the Gora. Witnessing her in all her glory, Rudel gave a small laugh... as the power drained from his body.



Jumping down from Heleene's back, Izumi drew her katana the moment her feet touched the ground.

Bennet threw her projectiles one after the next to clear away the knights and soldiers approaching Rudel.

In order to reach Rudel, Izumi ignored her foes and plunged straight forward.

As she ran cutting down the large, black bars pierced into the ground, she spotted Rudel, his chest pierced through by one of them.

“Rudel!”

Izumi cried, cutting down all the black bars around him in her advance. The gathered imperial army soldiers directed their weapons towards her.

“Cowards of the kingdom!”

They were removing spears to make their way to Rudel, they numbered a few hundred.

Before such an enemy, Izumi narrowed her eyes.

“You’re in the way.”

A single flash of her sword. Firing a slash, she mowed down black spears and cut down a few enemy soldiers, all while Aleist, whose shadow slipped through the gaps in the bars blew his foe away bars and all.

“Rudel!”

The two raced to Rudel in great haste; by the time they reached him, he had already breathed his last breath.

Izumi immediately severed the spear pierced into him, unpinning him from the spot.

“W-we have to heal him at once—”

Her hand shaking in her fluster, Izumi got to healing Rudel. There, out of boomerangs, a dagger in each hand, Bennet raced over.

“What are you doing? Pick him up and run.”

A glance at the sky, Bennet looked at the gathering imperial soldiers and readied her daggers.

“Even Heleene can’t win against that one. And that one doesn’t seem up to it anymore—”

Confirming Rudel’s death, the black gora and dragon had lost their motivation. However, as the two bodies—looked at Aleist running towards Rudel, they roared.

“W-what!?”

The Imperials were confused as well.

Seeing there were even some who took to their heels, Bennet clicked her tongue.

“So they can’t control it.”

Izumi held Rudel tight. She was shedding tears.

“Major Bennet. Rudel has no pulse... and. And, I can’t feel anything from him.”

Izumi’s shaking voice.

Aleist looked at Rudel in a daze. Unhanding the twin swords he gripped, he stood stock still on the spot.

“You two, get a grip on—”

There, one of Aleist’s harem members rushed over and informed them.

“This is bad, guys! The stationary armies on both flanks are now coming towards us.”

Hearing the armies that had ignored the main body up to that point were now moving, Bennet looked to the sky. There was the form of a serpent treating her partner Heleene’s attacks as if they were nothing at all.

But looking down over them, it was taking a stance for battle.

Izumi held Rudel to her chest.

“This, this can’t...”

He had been put to battle alone under such a hopeless situation, Izumi embraced him as all manner of thoughts passed through her head.

The gora Sakuya was fighting was also strong. To Izumi, it looked as if Sakuya was losing in raw power. Rudel had fought such a foe all alone.

Bennet made her resolve.

“I’ll take up the rear guard. All troops, immediately pull out—”

Aleist picked up his weapons and screamed.

“Don’t screw with me... don’t screw with meeeee!!”

Aleist kicked the ground to propel himself towards the Gora. A sword in each hand, he cut with all his might.

A black mana resided in his blade, it flicked and bent like flames as it grew to swallow the Gora down.

When Sakuya leapt out of the way, an attack with all Aleist’s might poured down on the beast.

An impact great enough to enrapture the surroundings in a sudden gale rung out as smoke hung over all.

Aleist raised his shoulders in breath. Looking at his back, Izumi.

“Aleist, you...”

His shoulders rose, his shoulders fell, soon it was turning into a slight quiver.

“Don’t screw with me. He’s a precious friend. Give him back. You damn—”

But a flap from the dragon and the smoke had cleared.

There stood a gora, burnt on the surface. But new skin soon generated from below that, and the black carbonized flesh fell off in pieces to return it to its unharmed state.

He heard a voice from the Gora.

But it didn’t come from its mouth. He could hear it from the mouth of Askewell, buried in its forehead.

‘I’ve waited so long for this moment.’

Izumi had stood, and shouldering Rudel, she perked her ears to this ominous voice.

Aleist looked a little flustered.

‘It was all for today, for this very moment... and for you to die.’

The one the gora and dragon glared at with the word ‘you’ was undoubtedly Aleist.

“W-what do you mean?”

Izumi looked at Aleist. But Aleist seemed somewhat accepting of this declaration.



Aleist felt as if his heart was being clutched by the voice he heard from the gora.

‘I was born for the very sake of your existence. That was the reason for us to exist... but a reason like that can eat shit.’

The gora pointed at Aleist, the dragon opened its mouth as well.

‘At first, it was a truly minuscule distortion. It all started more than fifteen years ago. When you, in your ignorance, called a dragon to your manor out of pure curiosity.’

Sakuya landed on the ground, and stood to protect Izumi and Aleist. Heleene kept a careful watch on the dragon’s movements.

While the imperial soldiers were running, they would immediately reform their forces and advance on them.

“Back then? Don’t tell me, when I said I wanted to see a dragon on my birthday...”

When Aleist recalled were memories of the day he pleaded to his parents to see a dragon.

This was a world of swords and magic. It was quite inevitable he wished to witness a fantasy. Yet such a meaningless action from Aleist had set it all in motion

‘That small distortion gradually grew in size. That was Rudel. It’s your fault that whelp set out to be a dragoon.’

Aleist turned to look at Rudel being held up by Izumi.

Everyone looked at Aleist.

The dragon continued.

‘We were born in order to correct that distortion. Do you know why? That is because you wished for it.’

That manner of speech almost as if Aleist was related to the monsters before their eyes; Izumi’s expression darkened a bit.

Aleist shook his head.

“Even if that’s true! You killed Rudel!”

The gora indifferently spoke.

‘That’s right. But had you done nothing, that’s where it would end. You are the source of it all. We prepared the stage for you, set up every event, so this final day could come.’

The vile serpent opened its large mouth.

Mana turned to beads of light gathering in its mouth to a sinister black and red hue.

‘The very last event, you can’t imagine how we’ve waited... all that’s left is to erase you, and it will all be over. We may finally be at peace.’

Aleist brandished his weapon.

But the ground and the sky—what’s more, a foe even Rudel couldn’t match before them, the result was laid out from the start.

In addition, Aleist’s head was occupied with thoughts of regret.

(Is it because I wished for it? Because I wished to live in a game world that this—if I just disappeared...)

The regret of the reincarnator Aleist.

His dear friend had died for the world he had wished for, and he would die to it as well.

(Is this the result of reincarnation?)

He thought he had obtained everything. But what he really wanted could never be obtained with cheats.

(How stupid was I.)

Aleist was beginning to give up.

(I finally got what I really wanted. Yet I’m going to die in a place like this?)

The gora, it’s four large arms held aloft, and a vile serpent about to fire a breath from the sky.

With these two bodies before him, Aleist grew desperate and raced forward.

“Like hell I am!!”

Aleist cried.

But his voice was immediately covered by the sound of explosions.

Sakuya stooped over to protect Izumi, and Heleene took her distance.

What rained down on the gora and dragon was tens, hundred of magics and breaths.

“Wai, gyaaaaah!!”

Aleist cried out in a different sense, bracing his body as the wind and smoke swept over him. Surviving the attacks that didn’t take him into account by diving into his shadow, once he could no longer hear the explosions, he protruded out his face.

“W-what just...

Looking over his surroundings and racing his head, there were several hundred dragons flying through the sky.

A rider could be seen on the central existence, a single water dragon.

And before that water dragon, a red dragon and wind dragon followed close. They were equipped with bags, and it was clear the two by its side were the partners of dragons.

However, riding the water dragon’s back was...

“Eh Why!?”

Aleist leapt from his shadow in surprise at the young girl with a spear, whose side ponytail swayed in the wind—the form of Rudel’s little sister.

“The hero is always late to the party... but maybe a little too late this time.”

Looking up at Lena, who said that with a laugh, Aleist was dumbfounded by the legion of wild dragons before him.



Atop the sky.

Riding on Mystith’s head, Lena looked at Rudel being shouldered by Izumi on the ground.

“Brother...”

‘We didn’t make it.’

Lena’s ponytail swept sideways as she turned her eyes to the gora and dragon before her eyes.

“No, not yet. My brother won’t end in a place like this. He’s a man I recognized, after all.”

Mystith laughed.

‘Very well. If that got you down, I’d be beating that black thing to bits by now.’

To Mystith’s side were Cattleya and Lilim. Mystith had grabbed them when they were rushing over as reinforcements.

Cattleya took a glance at Lena.

“Why is she boldly standing in the center?”

Lilim was just as confused.

“Rather, she hasn’t even enrolled in the Academy, yet she’s contracted to Mystith... was the Arses House actually amazing?”

The two looked at the ground.

“Even so, this is already...”

Both Cattleya and Lilim’s expressions turned dark as they inferred Rudel had spent his life supporting the front lines. Thereupon, the vile serpent before their eyes emerged unscathed from the smoke that broke out in their attacks.

‘Another distortion? I shall erase you too. Along with Aleist—’

Lena leaned her spear against her shoulder.

“Oh shut it, you. In short... he pisses you off, so you want to take him down, right? Well I’m the same. I want to tear apart whoever did my brother in.”

Mystith gave an irritated roar.

‘Hey, you, yeah you, blacky! You act like hot stuff for a newborn brat!’

The dragons roared out one after another, obeying their current leader Mystith.

The serpent narrowed its eyes.

‘Accursed lizards. Let me teach you what a real Dragon is. Gora, you erase Aleist.’

Cattleya and Lilim prepared for battle.

“Rather, I really don’t want to fight someone who got out unscathed from so many attacks.”

Perhaps Lilim was the same, as she breathed a sigh.

“Right. I don’t see us winning this one.”

Mystith smacked her right fist into the flat of her left hand, speaking in a low voice.

‘That’s simple. We surround it, gang up, and beat the living daylights out of it. It’s got to pay the toll for calling us lizards.’

Lena seemed just as irritated.

“Ah, how irksome. Me and broski love dragons and all. Well, put all the troublesome stuff aside... and you’re dead.”

Wyverns bubbled up from the serpent’s body. Their sinister forms resembled the serpent.

Even bigger, and more menacing than the enhanced wyverns. They came out one after another.

Lena smiled.

“Bring it on.”

Cattleya and Lilim, upon looking at Lena.

“This kid’s definitely Rudel’s sister.”

“You’re right. I can really see the resemblance.”

In the sky, a dragon dogfight was about to commence.

Chapter 159: Thank you for Everything

In the sky above, an aerial battle of dragon and wyvern unfolded.

Within that, Sakuya fought the gora to help out Izumi's retreat.

The party fled across the battlefield-turned wasteland. No one around knew the right words to call to Aleist. By the enemy's words, Aleist had been the cause of all of this.

(I shouldn't take it at face value, but—)

Izumi thought, yet still ended up raising her guard to the silent Aleist. Whether he noticed her attitude or not, Aleist wouldn't open his mouth.

At times, the breath of a wyvern or dragon would pour down and raise an explosion. Heleene flew to protect the fleeing members, and once they had distanced themselves from the battle, Millia appeared before them.

She had brought allies.

While they were too few in numbers to call reinforcements, it was a reassuring addition.

With a large wave of her hands, Millia faced them and called out.

“Over here!”

Upon crossing a low knoll, they came upon soldiers warily watching the battle between the Gora and Sakuya.

Millia had her fellow demi-human soldiers prepare a station for them. However, upon seeing Rudel's state, she made a terribly frightened face.

"L-lay him down over there. We'll get to treating him—"

But Bennet was quick to inform her.

"That won't be needed. His heart's been pierced. It's fatal."

To a Rudel who was already no longer breathing, Millia desperately held in her tears.

"You idiot. It's because you faithfully honored such ridiculous orders. The palace could have managed just fine."

Upon hearing that, Izumi sought confirmation.

Her hand stroked Rudel, lain over a stretcher.

"Is the palace alright?"

Millia wiped her tears before explaining in a shaking voice.

"Princess Fina used the defenders to suppress the insurrection. The archduke houses helped out too... and yet, why is this guy dead?"

At the end of her sights, Rudel, his eyes closed with a slight smile on his face.

Izumi strongly clenched Rudel's hand. Seeing Millia's tears only made Rudel's death seem all the more real.

"Always bringing us nothing but trouble. Yet in the end of the end, for such a meaning—"

Meaningless, Izumi was about to say, when Bennet plainly interrupted.

"There was a meaning. Rudel held out here alone, he made a literal last stand until the allied army could arrive. Don't say it was meaningless."

It was then that two groups made for Rudel.

Luecke and Eunius, who had only just arrived. The dragons appeared and helped transport their forces, hastening their arrival.

“Move aside.”

Luecke pushed his way through knights and soldiers to arrive at Rudel, opening his eyes wide when he came upon the man laid out.

Eunius was the same, albeit, he had come clearing a path far more roughly.

And looking at Rudel, he spoke.

“... Damn fool. Going off and dying.”

A terrible monologue. But his tone was terribly disappointed and horribly dark. Eunius yanked out the black bar wedged in his heart.

Luecke instantly hung his hands over Rudel’s chest. He was going to use healing magic.

Aleist opened his mouth.

“Luecke, Rudel is already...”

Luecke, the man who looked the most level-headed of the bunch, glared at Aleist and screamed.

“Shut your mouth. When it comes to magic, I’m better than anyone. Better than you, and better than Rudel. I’m number one. So you... hold your tongue.”

It was impossible for healing magic to revive the dead. No matter how many spells he used, the deceased body showed no reaction.

Izumi wanted to get a word in for Luecke to stop, but upon seeing his face, she shut her mouth.

“There’s no such thing as impossible for me. A dear friend or two... who would I be if I couldn’t help them out? I’m Luecke Halbades. I’m better at magic than anyone...”

Shedding tears before Rudel, he desperately continued to cast his magic. Those hands were beginning to burn from the heat of magic overuse.

Eunius grabbed his arm, forcefully wrenching him from Rudel.

“That’s enough! Don’t waste your mana here.”

Luecke cried back.

“Waste? You just called it a waste!? I see. In the end, that’s all Rudel was to you...”

When Luecke saw Eunius face, he couldn’t say anymore. Eunius was crying too.

“Listen here. Neither you nor I can bring back someone who’s died. But you know, isn’t there still something we can do? Fight to avenge him. Those imperial bastards are still here. Then it’s obvious what we’ve got to do!”

On those words, Luecke made a fist with his scalded palms. His subordinate Vargas held in tears, as he ordered those around him to heal him.

Izumi touched a hand to his cheek.

“Rudel, look how many people you’ve made cry... and yet, you’re the only one smiling. You really are a terrible guy.”

There, Aleist exclaimed.

“I-I’ve got it. Rudel can still make it, I think...”



Rudel was in a white, a very white space.

Hazily taking in his surroundings, the words that came out—

“This is the second time I’ve come here. The first was when I parted with Sakuya, perhaps?”

— As he calmly weighed his situation, a cracking sound came from the fist lowered on his head.

There was Sakuya—the former goddess Sakuya, floating in the air in human form. Tears welled in her eyes, her cheeks were puffed up and her face was red.

‘Rudel, you idiot! Idiot, idiot, huge idiot!’

Before the girl who continued smacking both hands into him, Rudel laughed.

“So you came to get me? Guess that means I really am dead.”

Sakuya’s crumbled into tears.

‘How many times did I tell you!? You have to fight together! And yet, why did you leave your own partner? We worked so hard so we could fight together!’

Seeing Sakuya cry, Rudel dimly perceived this was the afterworld.

“Sorry. I tried my best... but it looks like I failed.”

He had lost to fate. While Rudel thought so, he didn’t make a regretful face.

‘Why do you look so refreshed!? Everyone’s crying for you!’

Rudel sent her a bit of a sorrowful smile.

“I won’t say I have no regrets. I fought to triumph over some fate or another. And I’m only half the dragoon I want to be. I hate that I couldn’t use the chance that you gave me. But you know... I fought with my all. I

exerted myself so hard that even looking back, I am certain I couldn't have done better."

If he lost on top of that, there was no space for excuses.

Rudel said so and stroked Sakuya. Despite the nostalgia he felt, it also brought to mind his own partner dragon.

Sakuya looked at Rudel with a serious face.

'Are you satisfied now?'

To that question, Rudel—

"Satisfied? I'm not. I am definitely not satisfied. I wanted to ride a dragon's back through the sky some more. I haven't even become the strongest dragoon. My seniors are strong, see. I won once, but I'm still so far from my ideal/"

'In that case, try looking a bit irritated.'

"You sure are stupid. I'll never be satisfied with myself no matter how far I go. Even if I overcame, to die when the years caught up, I'd never achieve satisfaction"

(But that's fine. Either way, I fought hard enough to think so—)

To Rudel's words, Sakuya floating in the air breathed a big sigh. She scratched up her blonde hair and touched her left hand to her hip.

'There's a possibility of you coming back, but if you're already satisfied, then—'

"Really!"

The moment he heard of a possibility, Rudel snatched Sakuya out of the air.

'Hey! Up to a moment ago, you were all like, I'm not satisfied, but perhaps that's fine!'

“Fool. If I can live, then of course I’m going to live. I’ve only just become a dragoon. I haven’t turned those imperials back. There’s a mountain of stuff left to do.”

As Rudel shook her up, Sakuya’s eyes spun as she forced her way out of his grip and unsteadily teetered into the air.

‘I’m just bringing up a possibility! And, and it’ll need Aleist’s cooperation.’

Rudel tilted his head.

“Aleist’s cooperation?”

Sakuya nodded.

‘That guy has the exchange stone, doesn’t he?’

Exchange stone. It was what Aleist received while carrying out a mission in the Celestia Kingdom.

“Now that you mention it.”

He always had it on him, so Rudel did remember.

‘If that idiot notices, it might work out. But the probability is low. And there’s no telling what he’ll have to give up. Though honestly, he’d be a fool if he didn’t keep it with him.’

Hearing of what would be lost, Rudel asked Sakuya.

“What will Aleist lose?”

Sakuya took her time explaining to him what had happened hitherto. It was the truth of this world, and about Aleist’s existence.



“I-I’ll save Rudel. I can still make it.”

His body clad in black armor, Aleist pulled off his helmet and produced a blue stone from his breast. It was the exchange stone.

Seeing it, Izumi recalled its purpose and turned to Aleist with a shake of her head.

“You can’t. If you use that, there’s no telling what you’ll pay in exchange for Rudel’s life.”

Hearing Izumi’s words, the surrounding faces looked at Aleist. A great many looked on with conflicted faces, But Aleist’s harem members grasped him.

They stared at him sorrowfully.

“Aleist-sama.”

As a representative, Seli tried to stop him.

(There are people who want Rudel to live more than me, but there are some who would choose me too. That’s a bit reassuring.)

The gora’s revelation had raised everyone’s wariness towards him by no small amount. So if he said he would exchange his life, he worried they would happily tell him to do it.

Eunius approached Aleist and grasped his shoulder.

“Give it a rest. You think Rudel would be happy with that? You shut up and fight the empire.”

Those words were his own way of worrying for Aleist. Luecke was the same.

“You’re the worst, to even bring up choosing one or the other. Aleist, think a bit more before you speak.”

Aleist gave a bitter smile.

(Choosing one or the other, huh. Originally, the protagonist was supposed to pick either Eunius or Luecke, but... well, that's not important.)

Aleist removed Eunius' hand and reassured him it would work.

"Don't worry I do have something I can give. It's not my life, and it's borrowed goods, but it'll be enough, I think."

Eunius grimaced at those words.

"So you can't state it definitively to the end. But you should quit while you're ahead with those gambles. The result won't make anyone happy. Rudel is dead. You are alive. That's the result."

Right, Rudel had died.

(The event was definitely carried out. And those guys said they would kill me. Which means what happens here on has nothing to do with the game.)

Aleist approached a lying Rudel and had Izumi concede her spot.

His eyes abruptly met with Millia. Milla's eyes were red and swollen.

(She really does like Rudel, doesn't she. But I'll be granting her wish too.)

However, Millia to Aleist.

"You're really not going to die, right? And does that stone have that much power? If you both end up dead..."

Both ending up dead was the worst case.

(Ah, she's worried about me too. How delightful.)

But Aleist had no conviction he could do it.

(It's not like I never thought about what would happen If this day came. There's far too little I can do... but even so, he's a precious friend.)

When Rudel had helped him out so much, when Aleist thought he could finally repay his debt, he smiled.

(Aah, but in that case, I might become useless. Well, if Rudel's there, that's some reassurance. And this is for the best.)

Gripping the exchange stone over Rudel's body, Aleist closed his eyes.

A blue light enveloped the two of them. Aleist whispered, making sure those around couldn't hear—

“The cheat I have received... I return my abilities. I don't need inexhaustible mana or talent. My noble family... I'm fine as long as they're safe. I don't mind if they forget about me. So... please bring my friend back to life. I don't need anything else.”

The cheat he received on his reincarnation was inexhaustible mana.

(I'm sorry I never managed to master it to the end.)

Along with a talent in various fields, and a charm.

(Talent alone was no good. Without the effort to polish it... thank you for everything.)

To that point, Aleist had been protected by a great many cheats.

“Thank you for all you've given me. Perhaps this can't be called payment. If it's not enough, you can take my existence as well. My friend—please bring Rudel back to life. I'm begging you!”

As he strongly gripped the exchange stone, Aleist could feel the power leave his own body.

All the great powers that had helped, protected, and enhanced him.

Aleist shed a tear.

“Thank you for everything.”

Aleist got the feeling the last bit of power lingered around him. He got the feeling it asked him if he'd be fine without them.

"I'll be alright. I'm sorry I never mastered you. You have my dearest thanks."

The power faded. Aleist could instinctually understand various abilities had disappeared from within him.

He looked at Rudel.

The wound had closed, and with even his armor mended, Rudel opened his eyes.

"Rudel!"

Aleist cried out, as Rudel raised his torso from the stretcher. Delight spread around, Izumi leaped forward to embrace Rudel, and Aleist warmly watched over the scene.

But the one Rudel jumped up and held tight was Aleist.

"Aleist, you really did it!"

"Eh? Wait a second! With the way things were going, why me!?"

To Aleist's confusion, the suspicious eyes of Izumi and the other women gathered.

Chapter 160: I Kinda Don't Really Get it

“You bloody fool!”

Eunius placed a hand on Rudel's head and ruffled up his hair. His voice was filled with true delight, while there were tears visible in his eyes.

“You really did a number on us. You too, Aleist.”

Luecke delightedly stuck up the thumb of his gloved hand, directing a smile towards Aleist.

However, while being embraced by Rudel, and receiving smiles from the boys...

“Hey, way. Seriously, give me a minute! Rudel, I do think there's someone else you should be hugging here!”

As Aleist attempted to peel Rudel off, Izumi looked on with a conflicted expression.

“Don't tell me these two are...” or so Millia even sent them doubtful eyes. Rudel parted, patting his hair in place as he shrugged his shoulders.

“Don't be stupid. It is only natural I give my thanks to my life's savior. Mn? Oh Izumi, I see you're here too.”

A bitter smile from Izumi, upon being treated as an extra.

“I really am happy. Though a part of me can't rejoice...”

For just an instant. A very brief instant, Izumi directed a look of hostility at Aleist. A chill ran down his spine.

In order to overcome this situation, he hurriedly tried assisting Rudel to understand the situation.

“M-more importantly, about where we are now—”

Rudel slowly stepped down from the stretcher he’d been lying on and stretched out his back. He was confirming the state of his body as he received his weapons Aleist’s harem members had secured.

“Oh, that’s right.”

A look at the battlefield, and even now, Sakuya was fighting the Gora to hold it in place.

The imperial army units reformed, with the forces on both flanks headed their way.

Rudel looked at the imperial army and offered a word.

“Now then... let’s go.”

He was going to fight the minute he revived. Aleist hurriedly stepped in to stop him.

“No, I wonder about that! How about some rest? It looks like more forces are gathering as we speak.”

The one who approached them was Chlust.

“Brother!”

“Chlust... you, what about the evacuees?”

Chlust breathed a sigh of relief upon confirming Rudel’s safety. He explained the state of affairs.

“They’re fine. I’ve already handed them off. Joining the reinforcements of the Arses House, I come bearing a force of five thousand. They need a commander. These numbers are impossible for me.”

The reason Chlust deemed it impossible was simply because he had no experience leading so many troops. Additionally, he never received commander training at the academy.

“You’ve all been educated in that field. You have real combat experience to boot. Brother, if you’ll just take command—”

Rudel reached his right hand towards Chlust, opening his palm in the gesture of ‘wait’. And after looking at the sky, he returned his gaze to Chlust.

“I’m sorry, but while I’ve undergone the coursework, I am lacking in experience. I must pass the torch to Major Bennet.”

With the talks suddenly turned her way, Bennet’s hair and ears stood on end as she shook her head.

“Don’t ask the impossible. I have never taken charge of a land force of this scale. Rather, if anyone here is to take the right to command...”

Bennet’s gaze shifted to Rudel, Aleist, Luecke, then Eunius in turn.

— They all averted their eyes.

“Major, I am a dragoon. I lack the experience to command ground troops. I have no idea where to start!”

“Hey, I’m a dragoon too! And wait, you definitely got the education at the academy!”

The reason Aleist looked away was simply because he had no confidence. Having lost his cheat, at this point, even he didn’t know whether or not he had the power to fight.

Eunius looked at Luecke, his gaze speaking, ‘Just do it’.

But Luecke—

“It does seem there is a troublesome unit with a magic circle prepared. Good grief, I doubt anyone but me will be able to handle it. I must head off. I leave the rest to you. Now tally ho, Vargas!”

“H-hey, are you serious!?”

“Like I care. Not my problem, not going to deal with it.”

— He scrambled to be the first one off.

Taken aback, Eunius picked up his weapon and started from the spot.

“O-oh, now that I’ve got a closer look, that’s General Rhoshwas’ flag over there. My house’s got a score to settle with that bloke. Yep. I’ve got to go take care of that.”

Later! Said Eunius, leading his men to take flight.

All eyes gathered on Rudel and Aleist.

“B-brother?”

Chlust looked at Rudel.

(Well, Rudel’s far worthier than me.)

There, Rudel whistled. Reacting to that whistle, Sakuya lifted into the air, and descended beside him.

Rudel cleared his throat.

“It’s that, you know. As long as that black one’s there, it’s meaningless no matter your numbers. So I think someone has to take on the top dragon and bottom giant.”

Once everyone agreed that was a valid point, Sakuya loomed over Rudel, and reached her hand.

Immediately jumping onto its palm, Rudel addressed the rest of them.

“I’m a dragoon, so Chlust, I’m leaving the ground troops to you. Aleist!”

“Me?”

Rudel pointed at the Gora.

“I’ll take on the black dragon up top. You take care of that black thing.”

Aleist hurriedly refuted it.

“No, I don’t have any power any—”

Rudel smiled.

“Don’t worry. Sakuya told me at the entrance to the world beyond. You’ll be just fine. Now onward, Aleist!”

With a large flap of Sakuya’s wings, Rudel was set for the skies. When Izumi jumped up to chase after him, Sakuya carefully caught her and placed her on her back.

“... Huh?”

Hearing he would be fine, Aleist looked at the gora, only to find it was coming right at them. Now that Sakuya was gone, it seemed Aleist was the first on its list.

“Wait a second!!”

In Aleist’s dismay, his faithful nightmare Heath drew close.

“Y-you... where have you been?”

Breathing a sigh, Millia gave it to Aleist.

“Aleist, get a grip. If you don’t do something about that, we’ll all be in danger! Hey, I’ll help out, so just hurry.”

Aleist nodded. Bennet shrugged her shoulders.

“You have my cooperation. I’m sure it’ll be hard for the black knight alone. Still, we’ll need just a bit more manpower.”

To Bennet’s words, Aleist—

“If we had just... one more dragoon.”

A new dragoon made entered the stage from directly overhead.

“Did you call?”

There, the man boasting the number one aerial technique in the dragoon brigade, Keith, looked at Aleist with a glint in his eye.

“Keith-san!”

“It’s a request of my dear Aleist-kun. Yep, how about I lend a hand.”

Bennet’s face twitched.

“Keith... where have you been this whole time?”



High in the sky.

Around were the dragons fighting against the black wyverns.

Soaring through the wide sky filled with tempestuous dogfights, Sakuya was delighted to have Rudel riding her back.

‘I thought I would never see you again!’

Rudel gently stroked the back of the delighted, crying dragon.

“I’m sorry. But it’s alright now.”

Having died once and come back, Rudel made a bit of a liberated face. Izumi took a look at him and posed the question out of curiosity.

“Did something happen?”

Rudel closed his eyes, he recalled what had happened at death’s door.

“I made Sakuya mad.”

“Me?”

To the dragon’s Sakuya’s confusion, “A different Sakuya,” Rudel said, opening his eyes wide to look at the sky. Before his eyes, the form of a wyvern coming at Sakuya, it’s large mouth ajar.

Holding his right hand forward, Rudel produced a sword of light, put a spin on it and fired it at the wyvern.

Receiving the blade, the wyvern’s head was blown off, as it turned to black smoke and faded away.

“A dragoon is complete with human and dragon. Why did I send you away? She asked.”

Izumi smiled just a little sorrowfully.

“I see. So she helped you out.”

Rudel issued orders to Sakuya.

“Sakuya, a dragoon’s true domain is the sky. Let’s show those imperials the power of a true dragoon.”

‘Yeah!’

When Sakuya roared, the wyverns in the sky directed their hostility towards Rudel.

The one directing it most was the vile serpent.

Approaching Sakuya, it opened its large mouth and breathed its breath.

‘You really are obstinate! I’ll send you to the other side, however many times it takes!’

Laughing at the dark dragon’s words,

“Now that would be troublesome. I wouldn’t want Sakuya scolding me too many times. And I’m a dragoon. Now that my partner is here, you’ll soon learn I’m a bit different.”

Issuing orders to Sakuya, he exchanged breath for breath.

When Sakuya used her four wings to suddenly turn, the vile serpent gave chase.

‘You can’t run away!’

When the dragon opened its large mouth towards the back Sakuya showed, Rudel laughed.

“Run? Far from it.”

Holding his right hand straight out at the dragon, Rudel produced a number of extra large swords around them. Rotating them, he hammered them at the moment before it could fire a breath

‘Guuh!!’

The serpent’s head was enveloped in smoke. However, it didn’t seem to take any major damage.

‘Is that all you’ve got!? Get them!’

As the surrounding wyverns began advancing on Sakuya, the swords Rudel produced were fired off towards them.

They pierced, exploded, and disintegrated wyverns into black smoke.

“Is that all you’ve got?”

On Rudel’s provocation, the vile serpent opened its blood-red eyes wide.

‘You blasted irregulars!! ...!’

The serpent opened its large mouth and spread its wings to exclaim. But It was then the surrounding dragons all turned to fire on it at once.

And as it endured, a blue dragon approached from right above.

‘Twas Mystith.

‘You’re top’s wide open!’

Lowering a fist from overhead, she slammed the serpent into the ground head-first. While it was an attack with all of her might, the wounds from butchering any a wyvern stood out on her body.

‘Alright!’

“Alright!”

Mystith cinched it with a pose. And... so did Lena on her back.

Spotting her, Rudel was dumbfounded.

“What are you doing, Lena!?”

Izumi was just as surprised. But Lena sent Rudel a wing, as she raised one arm in greeting.

“I, Lena Arses have from today onward become Mystith’s partner! Best regards, bronin!”

‘That’s how it is.’

Mystith’s acceptance did little to alleviate Rudel’s confusion. But this wasn’t the right place to sit and dawdle.

“I-is that so. There’s plenty I’d like to hear, but that thing comes first.”

Looking down, there was the form of the serpent rising off of the ground. It seemed to be feeling it in the head as it birthed a large new batch of wyverns from its body.

Mystith sounded vexed.

‘Tsk, it multiplied again. I’m not losing to the likes of them, but there are too many. Just approaching the black one’s a pain.’

Rudel looked at the ground.

“Mystith-sama... could you leave it to me and Sakuya? We’ve developed that quite a bit?”

Upon hearing that, Mystith readily nodded.

‘Well why not. But that whelp called us lizards. You’ve got to hammer it home.’

Izumi thought back.

“Rudel, don’t tell me, what you used in Celestia...”

The sinister serpent that rose towards Rudel. As if to invite it in, Sakuya soared higher and higher into the sky.

“Come, I’ll take you on.”

‘Step aside, lowly side character!’

The serpent fired its breath into the sky, but Sakuya avoided on Rudel’s orders. Distancing themselves from the battlefield of dragon and wyvern, they turned to face their challenger.

Breaking through the clouds into the endless sky above.

The two dragons faced off.

‘You never stop getting in our way. If you’ll come back upon death, this time we won’t let even ash remain!’

On the serpent’s vigorous roar, Sakuya slowly took her stance in the air.

“Let me teach you something nice.”

‘... What.’

“Don’t make like of a dragoon. Just one knight and one dragon but... put them together, and I’ll teach you just how troublesome we can be.”

‘Sakuya and Rudel are the strongest!’

With Sakuya’s roar, the serpent lunged at the two, Sakuya opened her four wings wide, and Rudel unleashed the power of the white knight.

“I couldn’t show it on land, but here it won’t be a problem. Sakuya, we’re going all out.”

‘Yeah!’

As the light overflowing from Rudel enveloped Sakuya, symbols began to surface over her body.

Apart from her four wings, another pair made of light...

Forming an armor of light to protect her, giving off a divine light. Further behind the wings, a golden circle formed.

Izumi looked at that form, containing her hair swaying from the breeze as she muttered.

“... Breathtaking.”

The white dragon wore golden armor, and pinned down the serpent coming at them with both hands.

‘W-what!?’

The serpent was surprised. It noticed Sakuya was different than she had been a moment ago.

Sakura roared as she got in a right hook. Reeling back, the serpent disappeared into the clouds, firing a breath off from within them.

A number of golden shields manifested around Sakuya to obstruct it.

The serpent burst out of the clouds, raising its speed to circle around in an attempt to catch Sakuya off guard.

But Sakuya immediately reacted and followed suit. With Sakuya right behind it, maintaining an exact distance and giving chase, the serpent was put on the rung.

‘C-curses. Curse you!!’

It stopped, turned, and fired a breath, but elegantly avoiding it, Sakuya’s sure-fire special—

‘One, two, finish!’

Left, right, tail, three consecutive attacks smashed into the dragon. The impact greatly shifted the clouds and changed their shape. Cracks raced through the serpent’s skin they had never managed to pierce, as dragon blood was shed.

‘M-mocking me...’

The serpent flared at Rudel and Sakuya. It seemed it was unforgivable for a dragon to bring the smackdown.

Izumi seemed to understand those feelings just a bit.

“Well, it certainly is a little unfair.”

Rudel looked at the vile serpent, folding his arms.

“Playtime ends here.”

It was then that the serpent burst into laughter.

‘I see. The exchange stone. Aleist used the powers residing in his body as compensation to bring you back!’

The laughing dragon looked at Rudel, pointing a finger. While it was unknown how it looked into it, it seemed to know the means through which Rudel was brought back.

“Correct.”

Rudel made it short, preparing for his next attack.

‘Then it was a mistake to pull me away. You should have remained. Right around now, the gora will have run them all down. As long as I hold you here, victory is our—’

“... Unfortunately, that’s not happening.”

Interrupting the serpent’s words, Rudel informed it.

“The three who remained on ground, Aleist, Luecke and Eunius are my dear friends. We fought at the academy time and again, and I went through great pains each time.”

Rudel slowly pulled his sword, directing its point at the serpent.

“Don’t you dare make light of them. Even if Aleist loses inexhaustible mana and talent, and a great deal else... what he built up won’t fade away. That guy is strong. He’s the man I’ve recognized.”

The serpent roared and came at Sakuya.

Sakuya spread out her six large wings wide, to meet it.

Chapter 161: Those Who Can't Run

A general in the imperial army, Bahn Rhoshwas had begun his march on a request from the main body.

His army was composed of only humans, for no other reason than that he couldn't trust monsters. As a matter of fact, the monsters from the main force had all gone berserk. One moment, he thought they'd disappeared, and the next they were on a rampage.

"Under a sky of several hundred dragons, they want me to launch an attack on the enemy camp..."

To those of the empire, the dragon could only be a symbol of fear.

The reason they termed those of Courtois as cowards in general was because they were protected by those dragons.

Their own forces had given rise to enhanced monsters, and just when he thought they'd finally reached the stage they'd be able to put up a decent fight against Courtois, they were impossible to control.

"We're retreating after we retrieve Prince Askewell. There is no victory to be found on these fields."

The army's main body was still trying to fight. No, Bahn didn't let it slip his eyes that they weren't properly reigned in.

Yet regardless of what Bahn did, it wasn't long before a Courtois army was drawing near.

“General Rhoshwas! An enemy army is headed our way! That flag... it’s Diade!”

Bahn’s expression turned sour.

“So that Diade comes out at this timing?”

The Diade House could be called the strongest of Courtois’ ground troops.

Bahn had fought them a number of times, and every time had ended inconclusively. Before one side could triumph, the dragoons would storm in, leaving him no choice but to retreat.

Retreat wasn’t an option this time.

“Tear through them to rescue our allies. Drag along those main force fools who’re still up to fight and retreat!”

On Bahn’s words, his tempered legion moved all at once.



Riding a specially prepared carriage, Leor was enraged.

“Each and every one of them, trash that can’t understand magic! What did I tell them? I told them to lure the dragons my way, but not only do they fail to listen, they demand I send reinforcements to them... I’ll make test subjects of the lot of them.”

Muttering complaints, Leor wore a robe over his skin of an unhealthy color. He didn’t wear any armor.

He had his pride as a magician, and he knew protective gear was unnecessary.

A subordinate nearing his carriage informed him of the state of the magic circle.

“Leor-sama, the around seventy percent of the sigils are ready. But there is an army coming towards us.”

He couldn’t exhibit his full might on an incomplete circle. Leor laughed.

“Perfect. It may not be complete, but it’s an anti-dragon magic circle... I’ll blow any human army away. That’s right. They should have just obeyed my orders from the start. His highness so joyed with just enhancing monsters, and that aide girl of his; I’ll show them all. Just how wonderful my magic can be!”

Stepping down from the carriage, he ordered along his men as he made towards the center of the circle. Rescuing Askewell didn’t even occur to him in his eagerness to show off just how superior he was.

“The empire shall know. Rather than relying on monsters, they should have relied on me... Ahahahah!”

While Leor said so, he was supported by subordinates on both shoulders. Through repeated research and experimentation spanning many a year, his bother had grown terribly slender. Stamina-wise, he boasted a considerable problem.



The main force Askewell led was being ordered by Mies.

However, the rampage of his other men was terrible.

“General Mies, the armies on both flanks are rushing to our aid!”

“We’ll hammer down what Courtois’s army in one fell swoop!”

Seeing the knights and soldiers speak with such delight, Mies was distraught.

“What are you talking about? There’s no way we can fight in this situation. We’re retreating. Yes, that’s what we’ll do! We can’t control them anymore!”

One of the knights spoke.

His expression was somewhat suspicious. For a moment, she got a sense his eyes let off a red light.

“It will be fine, General Mies. The gora that Prince Askewell has possessed did not attack any of our men who approached. This is the perfect opportunity. The perfect change to finally win one against Courtois.”

Askewell had been taken in by a gora.

Phrasing it as the opposite, the second-in-command raised the hopes of those around.

In her distress, Mies couldn't notice the knight was different from usual.

“Have both flanks stand down at once! If we don't retreat fast, something terrible will... the sky above is nothing but dragons!”

To the empire's knights and soldiers, dragons were their gods of death. However, in this situation, more than despair, the troops sought out the victory they had long craved.

“We cannot pull back like this! If we retreat, that means we will have lost to a single knight. Not a dragoon, our forces were breached by a lone knight... only hell awaits on our return.”

A collected-looking knight said so, and those around nodded.

They had taken too much time on Rudel alone. That was not coming back to bite them, cornering the imperial army—or rather, those who had actually fought into a state where they couldn't withdraw even if they wanted to.

Mies held her head and cried out.

“All troops prepare to retreat! Your commanding officer is—Eh?”

A few knights and soldiers turned their weapons on her.

“You’ll have to keep quiet a while. There’s nowhere left for us. Do you not understand that? To prepare such an army and yield no results... shall never be forgiven.”

Preparing the monster army alone was a considerable strain on the empire.

On top of that, they formed two armies surpassing ten thousand to attack on two fronts.

If this failed, the empire would be driven to a crisis of possible collapse.

“If the land we took is taken back, the empire will fall apart. I want you to understand that.”

The situation was more urgent than Mies had imagined. As she sat on the spot and hung her head, the soldiers led her off. Finally, the knight,

“Hurry up and reorganize our formation! Let those cowards of Courtois know the grudge of the empire!”

Watching these zealous imperial knights and soldiers- practically dead men walking- who knew there was no future ahead of them, Mies took one last look at the gora that had assimilated Aleist.

(So no one needs him anymore...)



Mounting his faithful steed Heath, Aleist held a sword in one hand and gripped it hard.

He didn’t have the inexhaustible mana he once possessed. He didn’t have talent. Even his charm had been lost.

Could such a man fight the gora coming towards them?

As he cowered over such questions and fears, Millia took a seat behind him with her bow. They were riding the nightmare in tandem.

One of the harem members pointed at Millia.

“That bitch!”

Millia barked back at the rest of them.

“Oh, shut it! If it was any of you, you’d be at each other’s throats, so I got on behind him. So quit your whining, and prepare for battle already!”

Scolded away by Millia, the harem member reluctantly obeyed and prepared to fight the beast.

Behind them, an army to support them stood in rank and file under Chlust’s orders.

Chlust looked like he was going to cry as he issued out orders, entering preparations to hold the army at bay. Upon seeing that, Aleist managed to calm down just a bit.

“Aleist, you’ll be fine, won’t you?”

On Millia’s worried voice, Aleist mulled a smidgen before he nodded.

“I’ll be fine. But honestly, whether we can beat that thing or not is...”

Heath shook his head and neighed. As if he was telling him to do his best.

In the sky, two water dragons awaited his orders to fight.

Millia breathed out a sigh.

“God, have some confidence. Rudel was fighting against that thing the whole time. When you’re able to exchange punches with that very same Rudel, there’s no way you’ll go down too easily.”

Aleist recalled those matches, and the fists he exchanged.

In his battles with Rudel, in the end, it was always their weapons that gave out first. In that case, what was left was a full-on fist extravaganza.

“I wasn’t exchanging punches because I wanted to.”

Aleist personally would have preferred more stylish, more elegant matches. But he was always pushed to the brink and got to thinking he never had the leisure.

However, upon looking around.

“Well, it looks like everyone apart from me is reliable enough.”

In game terms, his harem members were competent pieces. What’s more, in the sky were two dragons supporting him. Two dragoon knights as well.

Game-wise, this was a satisfactory party, or rather, these numbers were greater than what could be deployed at once. Aleist delivered a light kick to Heath’s stomach.

With that alone, Heath made a straight dash for the Gira.

Millia readied her bow.

“Aleist, I’m counting on you.”

“Yeah, it’ll probably work out.”

Hearing his somewhat unreliable response, Millia laughed. Standing up on horseback, she took an arrow in hand, pulled it, and fired.

She had aimed for Askewell taken in by the Gora, yet the arrow was repelled by the gora’s thick finger. Just by spreading its palm, the giant had Askewell completely protected.

“The fact it protected him means that really must be its weak point. But seeing how Rudel couldn’t take aim at it, it must have a solid defense, perhaps?”

As Heath gradually increased speed, the gora lowered two of its four arms down towards him. Heath ran straight at the lowered fists, and cleared them as Millia fired an arrow at the gora from below.

“Oh my, it’s not just a grass skirt.

Carefully observing the gora that was properly wearing pants under that, Millia gave an indifferent analysis before immediately firing an arrow.

“Eep!” Aleist mouthed a small scream. But it didn’t look like it had any effect on the far-too-large Gora.

“How can you just aim at the crotch like that!?”

When Aleist told her that, Millia scoffed.

“Like it or not, it’s a vital point.”

She said, this time taking out multiple arrows and firing them. They all carried more force than the previous one, piercing deep into its nether regions.

The Gora cried out.

“Alright!”

Seeing Millia triumphantly clench her fist, Aleist was beginning to pity the gora.

Gripping the sword he held in one hand, he swung it towards the beast’s ankle.

A black magic flame coiled about the blade, and once he released it, the gora’s foot was severed through.

(I can still fight.)

What he lost was great, yet there was much he had built on his own, and what remained became his strength to overcome this monster.

While the gora tried to deal with Aleist, who was passing right beneath it, the breath attacks of dragons from the sky knocked it back.

Heath moved so as not to be dragged in with its fall as Millia looked around. Imperial knights and soldiers were charging towards them.

“When we’re busy taking on this monster!”

Aleist drew his left-hand sword as well, swinging them from horseback to cut down those closes. It was the perfect unity of horse and rider.

No, rather than that, Heath was the one matching Aleist’s movements. As Milla fired arrows from behind him, the knights wearing iron armor were pierced through.

Aleist’s harem members gathered to occupy the gathering army.

“You’re in the way!”

Seli cut down all before her with her skilled swordplay.

“In the way!”

Juju threw, punched and kicked the knights and soldiers coming close.

Aleist confirmed that before turning back to the gora.

“If it recovers that fast, we won’t be able to chip it down.”

Before the gora that instantly recovered from its injuries, Aleist thought over how he should approach. He thought, but he was never too smart to begin with.

It was inevitable that the long worn-out methods were the first things to hit him.

“Then you either attack it so fast its regeneration can’t keep up, or defeat it in one blow... but I don’t have any attacks as flashy as Rudel’s.”

Lopping off the arms of the gora attempting to stand, Aleist thought. His surroundings were beginning to become a muddled mess of enemy and ally, the field rapidly growing more difficult to fight.

The gora spread the wings on its back, rising into the sky.

“Can’t let it add another dimension to this—Bennet-san, Keith-san!”

On Aleist’s cry, the two dragons attacked so the gora couldn’t rise up. Tearing its wings and smacking it with dragon fist, they removed any means of escape.

Jumping up from Heath’s back, Aleist transferred over to the Gora, tearing open flesh below him as he raced up its body. Despite its large palm’s attempt to capture him, he cut that palm open with a sword in each hand, making for Askewell’s embedded body.

“I see it.”

Racing from the massive gora’s foot to its head, Aleist swung his sword at Askewell the moment he was in sight.

If it had any weakpoint, he thought it had to be there, but the gora stuck its glare on Aleist and opened its large mouth.

It seemed it was going to spit up a large mass of those black spears it used on Rudel. In its mouth opening, he could see the countless tips of spiraling polearms.

Aleist manifested from his shadow a cloth-like black mass, spreading it out to protect himself.

Even if a spear pierced through, the material would wrap around , catch it, and take the blow.

And once the black cloth vanished, Aleist jumped out and pointed his sword at Askewell.

“This is the end!”

At the last moment, Askewell who had been buried to his shoulders opened his eyes; he raised an arm and stopped Aleist’s attack.

Gripping the sword between his fingertips, he looked at Aleist.

“... I see, so you’re the cause of all this.”

After regaining consciousness, Askewell crawled out from the gora, looked at Aleist and spoke.

“It is for the sake of your existence that my people suffer... I shall not forgive you!”

Black smoke poured out of Askewell, as the gora disappeared. Having suddenly lost his footing, Aleist entrusted his body to freefall as he trained his eyes upwards. Askewell’s form remained, standing right where he was in the air.

“So it ain’t over yet?”

After Aleist was recovered by Millia, who had spread out her magic wings, he looked up at the black smoke whirling up, and the prince.

Chapter 162: Sword and Magic

Eunius straddled his horse, commanding the private army he brought with him to face off with the army of General Bahn.

On this chaotic battlefield, both sides had their command in relative order. Albeit, only relative to the rest. The reason they couldn't pay undo mind to keeping formation lay in the black giant nearby—the gora recklessly thrashing around.

Eunius took a glance in its direction.

“I'd like to end this while Aleist is keeping it busy; then I can go help him out.”

Even if the sky was beyond him, he could help as long as it was on land. But regardless of what wanted to do, the matter wouldn't be settled so easily.

Bahn Rhoshwas—a general who had worked his way up, a seasoned veteran of the empire, and a strong opponent in land battles. While he didn't stand out due to the existence of the dragoons, Eunius' father had held a close fight with him more than a few times.

The dragoons would come out before the victor could be decided, so there was no score to keep. Which side was stronger? Both countries likewise regarded the question as wholly inconsequential.

Yet on a battlefield where they couldn't borrow the dragoons' aid, it would hold a large meaning. The quality of troops at Eunius' home the Diade House was high.

But the opponent was a prominent force of the empire.

Eunius licked his lips.

“Go at it making light of them, and we’ll be devoured.”

He said, pulling his sword as he looked at the faces of his enemy—the faces of elite soldiers.

“Run them down!”

The numbers were even, or perhaps the other side had a slight advantage. The empire had supplemented a majority of their forces with monsters. For that sake, the numbers of humans were lower than expected.

The soldiers Eunius led wrung out their voices, gripped their weapons and collided with enemy forces.

The frontmost soldiers clashed, filling the air with the sounds of clanging metal and shouts.

With both sides accustomed to battle, slight casualties didn’t fluster them in the slightest.

But perhaps the opponent’s side was short on time, they came out with hard offensive measures.

A large-build man on a horse grandly brandished his battle axe, butchering soldiers on Eunius’ side.

Swinging around a large axe that- at a glance- made clear the strength of his arms, he made a straight line towards Eunius.

The official to Eunius’ side cried out.

“Young master! He plans to take you out and pierce straight through our army.”

Eunius gave a small laugh.

“Is he mocking me? Or is he out of time... looks like both!”

Kicking his horse's stomach, he had his allies ahead of him stand back as he raced towards the unit led by General Bahn.

Upon seeing that, Bahn performed a wide swing with his axe to cut Eunius down; but Eunius caught the blow with his greatsword. The horses both rode had stopped in their tracks, their hooves sinking into the earth

Once a conspicuously large metallic sound had chimed across the battlefield, both enemy and ally had begun taking distance from the two.

General Bahn glared at Eunius.

“Youngling, are you related to Diade?”

Eunius held up his greatsword in one hand, directing its tip towards the general.

“The eldest son. You're Bahn Rhoshwas, right? I've heard about you. Heard there was some bloke my old man couldn't take out.”

As General Bahn clenched the hilt of his battle axe, it let off a grinding, grating noise. His muscles swelled and raised a sound.

“Oh quit it. You're just another coward protected by the dragon, I'd usually say. But if your Diade's brat, that changes things up a bit. You lot are just about the only ones to hold back my army's charge.”

Each side holding high their weapon of choice, what followed was a simple clash of steel.

Sparks scattered.

“But youngling... now you're in the way. I'll send your old man down afterward. Go wait for him in hell.”

Olding his sword horizontally to block the strike from on high, Eunius grit his teeth.

(What weight. This guy really is strong.)

Eunius felt his own horse's shaking legs and tried to ward the blow aside, yet his attempt had General Bahn forcefully blow him off of his horse.

“Protect the young master!”

The knight who went out front was promptly cut down.

Eunius rolled across the ground before immediately standing and shouting out.

“Don't get in the way! I'll take him down.”

Looking down on Eunius from horseback, Bahn scoffed at those words.

“You look halfway competent, but you'll stand before me with that level of skill? Your head's in the clouds.”

But Eunius had properly measured out his opponent's abilities.

“That so? But I got it with that one. I'd love to have fought you in your heyday, old man.”

It was a provocation, that the aged Bahn was lacking.

“... Youngling, I'll praise your tongue if nothing else!”

General Bahn galloped his horse, lifting his axe, charging at Eunius to slice him in twain. Eunius lowered his hips and watched his movements.

(You're definitely strong, old man. But you know... I'm even stronger. And I know people far stronger than me!)

As he watched his foe's movements, Eunius was overcome by a sensation as if time was passing by in slow motion. He concentrated, and matching General Bahn's motions, he swung his great sword.

The sword was clad in light, and as that light grew stronger, he finished his cut before the general was within sword range.

“You fool. You grew impatient—nngh!!”

General Bahn spat up blood. Holding his mouth, he fell from his horses back; his axe pierced into the ground as he fell to his knees.

A single large wound across his chest.

Eunius’ magic sword has inflicted a blow on him. Seeing that, Bahn sipped his mouth, stood, and took a stance with his axe.

“Hey now, I felt quite some resistance.”

While Eunius felt resistance on his blade, it did seem General Bahn was far tougher than he’d anticipated. The general laughed.

“Gahahahah! Youngling, I’ve been fighting form before you were born. Like hell it’d be so easy to off me. But... I’ll admit you’re not all talk.”

While his subordinates gathered around him, Bahn had them step down.

“... No complaints, having you as my last foe. No, guess you wouldn’t want this old man. I’d have loved to have fought you ten. Nay, twenty years earlier.”

Eunius laughed.

“Don’t be stupid. You’d cross axe with rattle?”

The two laughed, their looks gradually shifting to serious as the surrounding air tense up. Around them, ally and enemy fought, yet their minds were taken by the duel.

And the two stepped in and passed by.

It happened in an instant.

A large cut opened up on Eunius’ arm, leaking some blood.

But General Bahn collapsed right on the spot.

The ground flowed with a heavy torrent of red.

“... Youngling. Your name?”

“Eunius. It’s Eunius Diade.”

“I see. A good name. I’ll be waiting in hell. Until our net match...”

When General Bahn used up the last of his strength, the surrounding imperial soldiers lowered their weapons one after the next. Eunius saw that and shouted out.

“Don’t kill those who’ve surrendered. Spread the word... Bahn Rhoshwas has fallen to Eunius Diade! Cease your resistance!”

His subordinate raced over.

“Young master! The sky!”

Looking in the direction he pointed, the gora had vanished, leaving a scene of black smoke rising up onto the sky.

“I’ve got a bad feeling about this... Rudel, just end this already.”



Meanwhile.

Luecke’s army marched in close formation.

Vargas barked from nearby.

“Maintain formation! Don’t disperse under any circumstances!”

Knights toting shields engraved with magic circles stood at predetermined positions hoisting up their shields. Upon confirming that, Luecke used his magic.

A pale green flame broke out around, his army, dispersing the lightning that rained down from above. An intense explosive sound rose as the earth was gouged out.

“We’re lucky the ground was damp. Otherwise, the dust cloud would be terrible.”

Vargas cried out at Luecke’s words.

“Not that it matters, young master! Do something about this. At this rate, the magic will keep coming down, and we won’t get any closer.”

The enemy was stationed on a low hill, having prepared a circle there, and was firing off magic from it. That alone wasn’t a problem, but the magic output was way too high.

If they took on a single blow, it would be enough to inflict serious damage unto the entirety of Luecke’s forces.

He managed to elude those attacks, utilizing the shields to cast large-scale spellcrafts.

Luecke toughed his hand to his chin.

“But how curious. With that setup I can make out from a distance, they should have a higher output. That’s what I’ve been preparing for with each defensive measure but... is it not yet complete? Still preparing?”

As one who used magic, he held a genuine curiosity. This was despite Vargas’ pleas.

“You can think about it later, but just do something now. If it gets complete, we’re all in danger!”

Luecke felt somewhat let down.

(If this had nothing to do with Rudel and the others, and our motherland wasn’t in peril, I wouldn’t mind waiting for them to complete it... more so, I should invade after insuring it’s complete to thoroughly investigate their

circle. No, there's no such time... what a waste. If Lena weren't here, I'd watch a while longer.)

While he looked the type to prioritize his own interest, at the same time, he was also considering his means of attack.

"... Vargas. The enemy is clearly making light of us. Otherwise, they can only launch incomplete attacks because their magic circle isn't fully prepared. I'd rather it not be number one. That would mean with all that careful preparation, they can only fire magic on this paltry level."

Vargas leaked a sigh. Even in that instant, lightning rained down from the sky to be blocked by Luecke's magic.

"You wouldn't believe how thankful I'd be if they were just putting on a show."

Luecke ignored him and explained.

"Their strength is either equal to, or slightly greater than our magic formation for a simple shield. In that case, it's simple. We will maintain this formation and charge towards the enemy."

Hearing that, Vargas opened his mouth.

"Pardon?"

"Charge, I said. Charge."

Those around couldn't conceal their hesitation either. They couldn't think the heir to the Halbades House actually voiced a word like charge. No, they would indeed charge from time to time.

But that was after they had done something about the opponent, and they wouldn't charge to force through enemy lines like the Diade House.

"... How do you figure?"

With Vargas acting as a representative of surrounding opinion, Luecke spat a sigh.

“Fool. We need only move while keeping the shield up. If our opponent changes the attribute of their magic, we’ll immediately adapt. You’ve all been trained to do so. Simple, right?”

Vargas’ eyes turned teary.

“I’ve said it before, but you know... aren’t you in the wrong family!? Young master, I thought you were kinda... a bit more apt to using your brain!”

“Vargas... don’t think I’m a muscle head like Rudel and the others. I’m an intellectual. All I’m saying is that this is the optimum means of victory. I’ll admit, it vexes me I can’t win over our foe with magic.”

He chose a charge for victory, there wasn’t any particular impatience in Luecke’s eyes. Knowing he didn’t thoughtlessly choose a reckless assault on his first campaign, Vargas didn’t rebut him anymore.

However...

“Alright, you’ve all got to properly fulfill your own roles. We’ll be swiftly changing formation on the move. Everyone’s coordination will be the key.”

Vargas cried out yet again.

“Change formation in transit!? This isn’t any ordinary formation, young master! The spells are reproduced by the positioning of the shield knights, and asking them to—”

Luecke shook his head, placing a hand on Vargas’ shoulder.

“Do it. That is an order, Vargas.”

When he was so kindly informed with a smile, “Yes” was all that was left to say.

And the Halbades House's moving army spread about a bit from its close-knit formation.

Luecke began his move to the center.

As they would have to make delicate adjustments to their positioning, while Luecke rode a horse, the shield knights had to dismount theirs and go on foot.

The march began once Luecke was in place.

This time, a mountainous load of large fireballs was fired off from the enemy camp. While they were many in numbers, they also had a speed, and it was in a rain of fire that Luecke's men were to move.

“Change formation. Water.”

Abiding by his orders, the shield knights hastily moved and took their places as a pale blue light enveloped their surroundings.

The flames that collided directly went out. The places on the ground set ablaze by those that missed faded away as soon as they touched against the pale light.

Luecke watched for his foe's reaction.

(Now then, what's their verdict on our approach... here it comes.)

The soldiers- presumably guards- on standby took up their weapons, and started on their way towards him. As the imperial soldiers approached, Vargas and the others drew their weapons at the ready.

But the enemy troops were few in numbers.

Luecke grimaced.

“... Decoys.”

While the magic from the enemy camp had stopped for a moment, the problem was that they were preparing for another round.

“Vargas, the shield knights shall prioritize maintaining formation. Everyone else, protect the shield knights.”

Drawing his sabre from its sheath, Luecke began commanding his troops.

Vargas retorted.

“It’s supposed to be the other way around! We were brought up to protect you and our allies!”

Luecke shot back.

“Shut it! Just do it! If you guys misstep, we won’t be able to block enemy fire!”

As soon as he had said that, the enemy camp was at it again.

“Next earth!”

As Luecke ordered the shield knights to change formation, the others provided support. The imperial soldiers were few in numbers, and while they fought desperately, they were taken down one after the next.

(They don’t mind firing on allies, eh. Can’t say I respect that. But it’ll pick up the pace.)

“Here it comes!”

The enemy soldiers outside the formation were swept up into a tornado and blown into the air. Upon seeing that, many soldiers gave up their resistance.

Cast down your weapons and surrender. We are increasing our speed to the enemy camp.

Vargas posed Luecke the question.

“Will the enemy wait for us? Shouldn’t they already by—”

But Luecke firmly declared.

“They’ll be there. They can’t move. They’re too fixated on their magic after all.”

And with those words, the Halbades House army continued its advance.

What they came upon once they were right at the camp were the magicians who had still remained on the site.

In chaos, abandoned by their guard knights and soldiers and left behind.

In the center of the magic circle, a single unhealthy-looking man in a robe raised his voice. His ear perked at the chipped and uncanny voice, Luecke urged on his horse.

“Y-you utter fools! Don’t let those brutes into the circle! Don’t step there! What do you take this artistic magic circle for—”

Luecke looked down on the screaming man—Leor.

“It certainly is a work of art. This deployment, and the sheer beauty of the sigils... I’m sure no ordinary man could even imagine it.”

To Luecke’s words, Leur knew he had found a kindred spirit. His expression brightened right up.

“Y-you can tell? I never thought I’d find someone in Courtois who could understand this—”

Luecke’s sabre stuck into Leur’s chest. Witnessing such a scene, the magicians—Leor’s assistants raised screams. Those assistants were quickly apprehended and restrained.

Luecke pulled out his sabre.

“W-why? If you let me live, the secrets of this magic circle could be...”

A portion of the circle was incomplete.

To add to that, there were spots he had erased because the enemy had come.

“You’re right. It really is a pity... but even so, I am a noble, and a knight of Courtois. I have to see beyond the magic. And someday, I’ll unravel the secrets of this circle, just you wait.”

Hearing Luecke’s words filled with confidence, a slight smile crossed Leor’s face.

“That’s impossible. The likes of you... I am a genius...”

Confirming Leor had breathed his last breath, Luecke issued orders to Vargas.

“Vargas, have those with the knowhow accurately copy down the magic circle. The positioning of all the ceremonial equipment as well. Record it all, copy it all, preserve everything important and—”

But before he could finish, Luecke looked at the sky.

In his eyes was a scene of black smoke rising to the sky.

Luecke narrowed his eyes.

“Young master?”

To Vargas’ worried voice, Luecke shook his head.

“Vargas, lead all troops. We’re moving.”

“Are you sure? Isn’t this magic supposed to be amazing?”

Luecke immediately mounted his horse and started off.

“I’ve got something more important to attend to.”

Luecke looked at the sky and muttered.

“Rudel, I can’t really lend a hand if he’s so high up.”

There, Vargas spoke.

“It’d be a whole lot easier if we could attack the sky with this thing.”

Luecke immediately took a look at the circle. It was around sixty percent complete. While a portion had been erased, from what he could see, at the very least, those portions could be reused.

He jumped down from his horse.

“Vargas!”

“Y-yes!?”

“... Well said. Gather up all the shield knights at once. We’re putting this to good use.”

Chapter 163: Versus

Rudel fought the vile serpent through the sky. It could be called a one-sided battle, mostly consisting of his attempts to corner and land a final blow on the beast.

Sakuya opened her large mouth, and as she was about to fire a breath, the serpent laughed. It stopped running to turn towards Rudel and Sakuya.

Before Rudel and Sakuya—a dragoon of one man and one dragon, the tattered serpent. But now a look of triumph spread across its face.

‘You did well making it this far. You have my praise... dragoon.’

While continuously calling Rudel an irregular, here it was, stopping to evaluate him. But Rudel—

“I see, then disappear. Sakuya!”

Rudel had Sakuya fired on it no questions asked.

‘HYAAaaah!!’

Highly condensed mana swelled to a massive size, the light fired off from it drawing a spiral in its flow as it swallowed the dark dragon whole. With that output before her, Izumi narrowed her eyes.

“It’d be hell if that hit the ground.”

It’s output... Rudel was definitely right in his decision, parting from the ground to avoid dragging anyone else in.

All the clouds around them were blown away by the force of that breath, the thick clouds clearing to shine light onto the battlefield.

But the serpent that took the breath, while it had lost a majority of its body, remained floating in the air. Its disintegrating bones showing, it laughed through its ominous visage.

‘You are strong. No, you ‘two’ are strong together. Very well... I shall admit that.’

Feeling a bad premonition, Rudel immediately readied Sakuya for a second shot.

‘It’s too late!’

The black smoke rising from the ground enveloped the serpent. Prince of the Empire Askewell looked at Rudel from his place in the air.

Rudel grimaced.

“You’re a stubborn one. Did Aleist let you slip by?”

While it was a problem that couldn’t be cleaned up with the word stubborn, Rudel was of the simple belief that he need only defeat him again. In essence, that was the only option.

Askewell opened his mouth.

“Aren’t you—”

“Sakuya, fire.”

“Wait! Rudel!”

Izumi stepped in to stop him but she didn’t make it in time.

Before he could hear Askewell’s words, Sakuya fired her second round.

‘Fly awaaay!!’

Sakuya's breath assailed the black smoke and Askewell. Yet, Askewell brushed that blast aside with one hand.

Seeing that, Rudel immediately considered countermeasures.

(He redirected it? Luecke had a magic quite similar to that. Then should I beat him in close combat?)

Askewell showed no surprise, nor did he condemn Rudel for his actions. It was almost as if he had foreseen it happening. He plainly continued to speak.

“Aren't you irritated?”

“... Irritated? That I let your imperial invasion get so far? Or the fact I couldn't win on my own?”

They were both irritating to him. He couldn't fulfill his duty. He couldn't protect his country. That was why he had to take Askewell down and drive the imperial army out of kingdom territory.

That was Rudel's job.

Askewell lightly laughed.

“Aleist, was it? For the sake of such a good-for-nothing existence, both me and you were put through the wringer. You were to be nothing more than a stepping stool in his life... I was forced into the role of enemy. You'll overlook such unreasonability?”

Askewell's voice was the epitome of serious. These were the screams of his soul.

“No matter how I tried to save the empire's people, it was all futile! The reason I kept winning when I went out to the battlefield was all for this day. None of it was my own power! Not a single bit of my life's effort has had any impact on this world! For the sake of that man... for that sort of man, can you imagine how many humans have suffered!? Doesn't it irritate you!?”

Looking at the prince before his eyes, Rudel thought.

(What is he talking about?)

It was a simple, honest question. And he understood the answer.

“I see, so you made it Aleist’s fault that things aren’t going your way. Good for you, you found an excuse.”

Askewell’s eyes opened wide. A vein surfaced on his forehead. In rage and surprise towards Rudel’s words. His face was one of all sorts of emotions swirling about.

“You want me to sympathize? I’ll do plenty of that once this battle is over. So... die.”

When Rudel directed his right arm at Aleist, the black smoke manifested a number of offensive shields around Askewell. Those spiked shields closed in from around as if to crush him whole.

“I see... when you made your dream come true, I...”

Those several hundred large shields crushed Askewell and exploded. His hair ruffled out of place by the blast wave, Rudel narrowed his eyes as he looked at Askewell.

“If you’ll let me have my say, you’re the unreasonable one here.”

At the end of Rudel’s slightly envious expression, was the form of Askewell riding the back of the dark dragon. And now the form it took on was terribly reminiscent of Sakuya’s. A purple halo floating behind its back, six wings, and four large limbs.

The differences that stood out were its aggressive, barbed scales and the look in its eyes.

(... I want to ride it a bit.)

From the point of view of one who had desperately become a dragoon, he had a complaint or two for Askewell, who had mimicked one at the drop of a hat.

Even if he was barking up the wrong tree.

The dark dragon opened its mouth.

‘Don’t think this makes us equal. We surpass you on all fronts. In order to restore these glaring errors, the more your abnormality increases, the stronger we become.’

Rudel folded his arms.

‘I see, so you don’t start out almighty. Then there are ways to go about it.’

Izumi wondered if the calm and collected Rudel had some ingenious idea.

“You have a plan?”

But Rudel offered an immediate reply.

“None! But since it’s come to this, there’s no choice but to grow stronger than we are now. If we do that, we can surpass our enemy.”

Izumi breathed a sigh.

“You heard it, if you get stronger, they’ll also—”

“Then I’ll surpass what comes next. You worry too much... I’m quite used to fighting guys stronger than me.”

As Rudel made a smile, Izumi shut her mouth. She looked in the direction of the dark dragon and Askewell. Gripping the hilt of her katana.

“Got it. I’ll try to help out. I have to make myself at least a little useful.”

Rudel laughed aloud.

“That makes it three against two! It’s our win.”



On the ground, the Kingdom of Courtois fought the imperial army under Chlust’s command. With Aleist fighting on the frontmost lines, they barely managed to hold out without crumbling.

That was the most they could do. A gathering of odds and ends, the Courtois army had no coordination. Even if some was established, before the empire’s trained troops, it was a last-second veneer.

“Keep everything down to the basics. That’s all we can do!”

Chlust issued simple orders. With the quality of the gathered soldiers all over the place, they had to keep their objectives to the absolute basics.

The army moving especially poorly belonged to the Arses House.

Having not done any decent training, they had become a deadweight.

(If the black knight and his elites weren’t here, we’d be screwed.)

Looking up in the sky, two water dragons intercepted the wyverns raining down on them.

They were fighting so they couldn’t bring casualties to the ground troops, and none were to die to stray shots from above. However, because of that, their forces had mixed into a muddled mess with the imperial. This prevented them from receiving dragoon support.

Chlust had been driven off to the outskirts, and there he had learned how to command. Yet when an army far too large was placed under his command, his panic began to show.

“The dragoons will protect the sky! We’re going to do our part!”

At the same time, he thought.

(To think the empire's training would be on this level.)

In one on one, the imperial army surpassed Courtois. They could only fight because they had the black knight. Additionally, the soldiers of the imperial army fought almost as if they were walking death row.

As the fight devolved into a chaotic melee, the dragons couldn't attack. With that in mind, compared to fighting the dragons up high, the Courtoan soldiers before their eyes weren't scary in the slightest.

And they couldn't pull back.

They really were dead men walking.

"... Brother, we won't hold out much longer."

Regardless of the grudge he held towards his brother who shoved command onto him, Chlust could only do what he was capable of.



"Take that!"

Swinging two swords from his horse, cutting down streams of imperial knights and soldiers, Aleist was terribly stained with the blood spurt.

The gora disappeared into black smoke, while Askewell had fled into the sky.

He had no means to give chase, and so he fought on the ground. But these crazed soldiers were cornering him into a close fight. While his harem members were strong, they were flinching before the enemy's death-driven insanity.

"Should they usually withdraw after incurring casualties this high!?"

More than twenty percent of the whole. The imperial army's casualty figures had long since exceeded that, but he couldn't discern any signs of retreat.

More so, these were soldiers who'd lost anywhere to run to.

While the tides were already in Courtois' favor, even so, the rate things were going would leave tremendous casualties on both sides.

As Aleist helped out his allies while gathering enemies towards himself, a giant white mass approached from the sky.

It was Sakuya.

"... Wait a tic."

Falling towards the battlefield, there were traces of burns on her surface. A heavy gray cloud swirled a spiral, and from it, a black dragon resembling Sakuya slowly showed itself.

"Kuh!"

Racing his trusty steed Heath, Aleist tried to part from the course of Sakuya's fall when he caught a glimpse of a flash of light.

The one who fell from the sky was Izumi, holding her Katana.

"Izumi-san!"

Izumi looked at the ground, prepared to draw her blade, and in one flash—

"Hah!"

Slashing up the imperial soldiers around Aleist, she landed out of breath before looking at the sky.

Aleist got down from his horse to hear out the situation.

"What the hell happened up there!?"

Izumi responded at once. Wiping off the grime on her face, she explained the fight in the air.

“Seven times.”

“Seven what?”

“... Rudel and Sakuya, and myself managed to corner that black dragon seven times. But every time, that thing just revives stronger than before. It’s getting beyond our ability to cope.”

Both armies took distance from where Sakuya fell. While that brought a temporary ceasefire, a look at the sky revealed the black malign dragon looking down over them. On its head, Askewell was also visible.

He wore sinister armor, equipped with a lance, his arms folded.

As Sakuya fell, in order to support her from below, Rudel made a great many shields of life, killing her momentum before she landed.

“Rudel!”

While Aleist called out, Rudel seemed considerably vexed.

He heard a voice from on high.

“You did splendid to hold out so long. But this is the end. Once I defeat you, the world will finally be free of your influence.”

Askewell’s bitter expression was directed at Aleist.

Renewing his grip on both his swords, Aleist grimaced. Come so far, would they really fall short?

(It’s my fault... then I should be the one to settle it...)

He would protect his comrades, even if it cost him his life. It happened the moment he thought that.

Slowly standing Sakuya’s massive body, Rudel came over to him. His expression was straightforward to no end—

“As you can see, there’s nothing I can do to take that thing down on my own. Aleist, you’re coming with me. The two of us and Sakuya will kill it.”

Aleist flew into a confusion.

“... Eh? Say what you want, but I have no idea what to do.”

“No worries, no problem. For now, just lend a hand. It’s a bothersome one that immediately revives when you’ve almost got it. I’d love to blow it away before it restores itself, but I’m lacking in firepower.”

For the Rudel-Sakuya combo to have insufficient firepower? From Aleist’s point of view, that was a nightmare. Even with his help, he started to think when.

“Hey, let’s get going. Izumi, I’m sorry, but could you go help out Chlust? I’m going to push my limits a bit, so I wouldn’t recommend riding with me any further.”

Izumi shrugged her shoulders.

“That so? That’s a shame.”

Looking up, Sakuya’s palms were approaching the two of them. With a skillful grip, Sakuya boarded Rudel and Aleist on her back.



Once Rudel was on Sakuya’s back once more, he looked up at the dark dragon alongside Aleist.

“Just a little more to go. When there was just a little left, it restored itself seven times.”

Seeing an irritated Rudel, Aleist shook his head to the side.

“I get that, but it would be troublesome for you to rely on me here. All I can do is control shadows, that sort of thing. To clear things up, I don’t have unlimited mana reserves anymore!”

Rudel directed Aleist a smile.

“Yeah, no problem. When I was dead, Sakuya told me. You won’t lose what you’ve cultivated yourself. And if it’s mana you’re looking for, Sakuya’s got it.”

Rudel looked down at Sakuya and smiled.

“By Sakuya, you mean the goddess, don’t you? To think she’d be waiting at death’s door for you, well how should I put it... no, doesn’t really matter.”

As he slowly raised his head, the dark dragon emitted a stream of wyverns out of his body. That scene was a nightmare in itself.

“Is it not landing a finishing blow because it’s got the leisure?”

Aleist thought the enemy was trying to belittle them, though Rudel begged to differ.

“I wonder. If it had leisure, it would have come to finish us off by now. Perhaps its been weakened so far it’s unable to.”

Sakuya slowly spread her wings and roared, while Rudel felt out the flow of mana in her body.

“Aleist, try manipulating Sakuya’s mana. If you just change it up a bit and form the shape, Sakuya will go and do something.”

Despite his confusion, Aleist leaned over and stroked Sakuya’s back.

“Now that’s arbitrary. Whatever happens, don’t blame me.”

As Rudel and Aleist touched Sakuya’s back, white and black symbols surfaced over her body as mana raced across its surface. The two of them stood, and Rudel’s right hand. Aleist’s left hand. After the two formed fists to bump with one another, Sakuya flapped her large wings and rose into the sky.

The halo appeared behind her back again.

While the golden armor manifested to protect her, this time that wasn't all. Her third pair of wings formed, and from both shoulders, a new set of arms emerged.

Black, and protected in golden armor, those arms gripped weapons of gold.

And as the wyverns approached Sakuya, hundreds of snake heads emerged from the exposed skin of those arms to bite into them and tear them apart.

"That's new. Looks like you get an autonomous intercept."

Ignoring Rudel's delight, Aleist looked around somewhat perplexed.

"Isn't that a bit creepy? No, I get I'm the one who made it, but how to put it..."

As Sakuya rose to the same height as the dark dragon, the two sides exchanged a glare. Askewell looked at Rudel and Aleist, pointing the tip of his spear.

"It's the same no matter how many times you stand. There is no victory for you."

More than a hundred wyverns had already manifested around the dragon once more, and the battles on the ground had already resumed.

Within that, Rudel.

"Pretty much everyone's told me it's impossible too many times to count, but here I am. And how many times have you said those words? I'm starting to lose trust in them."

Rudel's words put Aleist into a panic.

"Could you please stop riling up your opponents just this once?"

The thick clouds drew a spiral, the lightning letting off light and sound. On the battlefield where the rain was about to fall, Rudel looked to the sky.

“... And also. You’ve wasted too much time.”

Turning to Askewell, as if proclaiming his own victory, Rudel pointed at the sky.

Wild dragons shot out from the clouds one after the next, having finished exterminating wyverns, and come over to help.

Askewell’s brow twitched.

“If that’s all the help you’ve rallied, then—”

Rudel smiled.

“No, that’s not all. That’s not all, prince of the empire!”

In addition to the wild dragons, gray dragons with dragoons on their backs entered the stage. Even the dragoons had arrived.

Aleist looked at the ground.

“There are allies below as well...even father.”

Starting with Aleist’s home, the Hardie house, the armies of various regions were gathering.

Rudel urged Askewell to surrender.

“... It’s over. The fact our allies have arrived means we have reigned triumphant on the other battlefield. There is no victory for you. Surrender.”

At the point the dragoons came as relief. Rudel could see their victory was secured on the other field. As a matter of fact, that was precisely the case.

However, Askewell wrung out his voice.

“Not yet. It’s not over yet. I’m right here. Victory to the empire... for the empire’s future, I shall hold victory in these hands!”

Rudel turned to Askewell with a slight mutter.

“I see, that’s unfortunate.”

On Sakuya’s roar, Rudel and Aleist lowered their hips. Sakuya and the dark dragon smashed into one another, the shock wave raising a wind around.

With the two closing in the distance, Askewell jumped over to Sakuya’s back, making his way towards her riders.

Rudel with his sword and shield.

Aleist readied his twin blades, and on Sakuya’s back, their weapons met.

“— I’ll make this the end.”

As Rudel said so, Askewell grit his teeth.

“I’ll be the one ending it. This bad joke of a destiny—and my fate with you two!”

Chapter 164: Last Battle

By the collision of Sakuya and the dark dragon, the sun's light pierced through the battlefield covered in thick clouds.

Neither side could pull back. On that bog of a battlefield, Eunius rushed over to Luecke. The reason being, the enemy had begun to amass around Luecke's forces.

Issuing orders from the center of a magic formation, he seemed to be carrying out some form of preparations.

“What the hell's so important you'd isolate yourself away to do it!? The enemy's at your doorstep!”

Without turning his face to Eunius' yell, taking notes and calculating something out, Luecke indifferently answered.

“This magic formation is anti-dragon. I'm going to use it.”

Recycling the formation the enemy had been using, he would help out Rudel and Aleist. Luecke earnestly carried out his calculations.

Eunius thought.

(No use talking to him. But will this guy's troops hold out?)

The enemy on their last stand, they stood in unity charging straight forward without knowing retreat. Luecke's army detached from the main force was nothing more than an easy target for them.

It was partly due to their lack of a proper offensive that they were trying to reuse their circle in the first place.

The empire's soldiers were strong. Eunius recalled his own honest impression as he gave up on persuading this idiot of a friend.

“... No way around it. I'll buy you some time. How long do I have to hold out?”

Hearing Eunius' voice, Luecke's memo taking hand stopped for a brief moment. Once it had resumed, he made his request.

“... One hour. If we use it once, the enemy will see it coming the next time, so it'll be a one-time thing. But that alone should be plenty for Rudel up there.”

Eunius turned Luecke his back and walked off.

“Then I'll protect you while you get on with this thing. If the time comes, I'll drag you away whether you like it or not, remember that.”

“Thanks,” came a small voice from Luecke.



Her body draped in golden armor, with two new black arms, Sakuya exchanged blows with the dark dragon.

The black arms gripped golden weapons, its right hand the white knight's sword, its left hand the black knight's. Two golden shields floated to protect her, fending off the dragon's fists.

The two grappled, they punched, they cut at one another and exchanged dragon breath. The attacks from these two giants generated massive shockwaves, and in no time at all, the surrounding clouds had almost all been blown off, giving way to a blue sky.

The dark dragon bit into Sakuya's neck. Each and every one of its sharp fangs concealed power greater than a magic sword fashioned to slay dragons.

Opening her mouth in a scream, Sakuya hammered a body blow into the dragon's stomach. A stroke from her thick arms caused cracks to race across the dark dragon's tough skin.

Writhing in pain, the dragon's mouth wretched open as it parted from Sakuya's neck. Before it could get away, Sakuya lowered the golden sword at its head.

While the dragon immediately took evasive action, Sakuya grabbed it with both arms to hold it in place. By turning its head to one side, it contained its injuries at a portion of its horn and one eye.

‘Nggh, my wounds aren’t healing. Why!?’

Even as blood dripped down her nape, Sakuya offered the dragon an answer.

‘Sakuya’s power is being drawn out by Rudel and Aleist. So she won’t lose. Sakuya is strong!’

Young. Terribly young, yet Sakuya gave off the will to never lose.

Spreading its remaining eye wide, the dark dragon opened its large mouth to roar.

‘You sham lizard! When you’re merely a cobbling of sham odds and end, who do you think you’re biting back at!?’

The dragon who would call Sakuya a sham went right on to drive a breath into her. Yet the black and red muddled mana gathering in its mouth found itself bisected by a sword of light, exploding before release.

There stood the enraged form of Rudel.

“Bastard! You got something to say about my Sakuya!? Very well, I’ll answer that deathwish!”

Spitting smoke from its mouth, the dark dragon cried out Askewell’s name.

‘Askewell! What are you doing? Kill him already!’

Sakuya and the dragon. Using both airborne beasts as footing, Rudel, Aleist and Askewell fought.

But Askewell found himself held up by Aleist.

“What do you think I’m doing!? If only, if only you didn’t exist!”

A wrinkle gracing his brow, Askewell swung his lance with the face of a demon. Shockwaves and magic emitted with each revolution before the point abruptly shot towards Aleist.

But Aleist turned it aside with a magic sword, and with his other sword, he cut at his foe. Askewell sacrificed his left arm to take the attack. While the blade cut deep into his flesh, it stopped just short of lopping the limb off.

However, Aleist was a dual blade user, and in the moment Askewell’s attention was occupied, he immediately used his other sword to inflict a followup blow on Aleist’s stomach.

“Kuh!”

He didn’t bleed. Askewell’s body swiftly regenerated, but without faltering, Aleist kept up an offense.

“Rudel! Help out here too! The most I can do is hold him in place!”

And yet, Aleist let out a pathetic voice. It only served to rub Askewell the wrong way.

Askewell forcefully swung his spear to knock Aleist back. But using that intent to take distance, Aleist produced a stream of spears from his own shadow, sending them flying towards him.

While Askewell easily hit them all down, those black spears burst, emitting a smoke that stole away his vision. In that opening, Rudel cut down from above.

Despite him catching it with his spear, Rudel's strike with all his weight behind it bisected the shaft, carving deep from Askewell's right shoulder to his abdomen.

Seeing that, Rudel offered a word.

"Even that won't do it."

Not shedding a drop of blood, Askewell's body had already begun restoring itself, causing Rudel to take distance. With a large lurch of the dark dragon he was using as footing, Askewell's stance was thrown a bit off.

"What are you doing!?"

Askewell grew irritated, however, they were in the sky... with uncertain footing, and the stage being atop a dragon's back, every aspect favored the dragon.

Without a moment's delay, Rudel cut again, and Askewell's leg soared through the sky. Following on, having recovered his footing, Aleist cut in to finish the job with his arm.

Thrown into freefall, Askewell attempted to float on his own while regenerating his body. But right before his eyes came the white approaching fist of a dragon.

"What non—"

He was likely about to question the nonsensical nature of coincidence. But to the dragoons who could communicate telepathically, the knight and dragon existed as a set, and their coordination was to be expected.

Smacked, sent flying, with a large portion of his body crushed, while Askewell continued falling, his body was still regenerating. His healing was gradually growing slower.

"Why. Why are you—"

His body back in order, Askewell stood on the battlefield once more.
Against Rudel and Aleist, a battle of numeric inferiority.



On the ground, Eunius was pushed into a close fight to protect Luecke.

“Don’t let a single one through!”

Swinging down his greatsword, he cut aside an imperial soldier as he cried out; his surrounding subordinates wrung out their voices in response.

A battlefield over which flew mud, flew iron, flew blood, and flew flesh, this truly was a hell on earth. The imperial soldiers pushing in on them wave after wave were driven mad by the fear of inevitable death.

Believing in Luecke, Eunius would protect this point to his last breath, swinging his sword. Before his eyes, a knight-looking man stepped out front.

A glance was enough to know he was strong. Swinging about a large hammer, he mowed away allies as he charged towards Eunius.

“So you’re their commander!”

Eunius laughed at the enemy knight’s words.

“And what if I am!?”

Magic sword. A swing with all his weight and might, the enemy was split in two- hammer and all- no longer able to move. Eunius gasped for breath as he looked forward.

No matter how low their numbers fell, the imperials would even climb over their friends’ corpses to grit their teeth and press on.

“Just surrender already!”

Swiping his great sword to the side, he sliced down another when an impact rang out behind him. Both friend and foe turned an eye towards it.

“What now!?”

“Did Courtois do something!?”

“That light it—”

Behind Eunius’ forces, a light broke out from the magic formation Luecke had been working on.

“The bastard really did it!”

Believing in Luecke’s success, Eunius issued a manifesto to his troops!

“One final push! If we overcome this, it will be our Courtois’ victory!”

A war cry resounding across the battlefield, and the intense collision of two camps.



In the center of the magic circle, Luecke stationed shield knights over various places in and out of it as he looked to the sky.

Light flooded up from the formation, amplifying his magic even further.

A look up to two dragons fighting in the distance.

With a magic called farsight, Luecke confirmed his foe’s positioning before nodding. Vargas sent over a shout.

“Young master, this shield’s at its limit!”

Luecke laughed.

“Vargas, don’t call me that! But this is the end. Rudel, you’d better not waste my aid... my and Eunius’ aid.”

Hoisting his right arm high, when he snapped his finger, an orb of light formed above the formation. With fire, water, wind, lightning, earth attribute magic revolving around it, the round was fired into the sky towards the dark dragon.

After seeing it off, Luecke collapsed at the knees. The light vanished from the circle, Vargas rushed over to him.

“Oy, Luecke!”

With Vargas calling him what he once had before, Luecke smiled.

“You fool. I’m your employer, Vargas. But not bad... Vargas, we’re going to help out Eunius.”

Forcing himself to his feet, Luecke issued out orders to send reinforcements to Eunius.



Rudel clanked down from the sky.

He was in the midst of cutting at Askewell when he noticed something was fired from below. He immediately identified it.

Perhaps it could be called instinct, or perhaps one might say he could trace the thoughts of his close friend from his school days... he understood help was on the way.

“Luecke! I owe you one!”

Rudel’s words greatly irritated Askewell.

“Don’t look away on the battle—”

Rudel kicked Askewell away as he collected up Aleist, making a dash for Sakuya’s shoulder as he cried out.

“Sakuya, get back!”

Sakuya immediately followed his orders to take distance from the dark dragon. The wound-ridden dragon and Askewell thought to use this chance to heal their wounds—

‘What!?’

“From below!?”

A little late to notice the lights encroaching on them from below, they shifted to evasive action. However, the light went right on to capture the dragon, the mana within it exploding, wrapping the prince and dragon in a blazing inferno. Immediately after, water broke out to drown them, and electricity after that.

A harsh wind blew, trapping the two in a storm, and finally large rocks mixed in with the gale smashing into them.

To Rudel’s side, Aleist watched over the scene, reeling back somewhat.

“I’m surprised they’re enduring that one.”

Aleist was tattered too. A portion of his armor had been blown off, he was covered in wounds with blood dripping down his face as well.

Rudel wasn’t much better. Wound-ridden, his shield dented, chips running down his sword.

Rudel took in the surrounding circumstance and determined now was the change to seize victory.

Holding out his left hand, he gripped his fist.

“... Aleist, the next one will be decided.”

His serious voice compelled Aleist to nod.

“Got it. I’ll bet my all on this. We’ve made it this far. With everything I’ve got left— huh! What!? Whaaat!?”

Aleist's surprise was justified. Sakuya suddenly grasped the two riding on her shoulders. Rudel in her right hand, Aleist in her left, she prepared for the next step.

Aleist cried out hysterically.

“Wait! I can see where this is going, but don't tell me!”

Rudel laughed.

“You're quick on the uptake. That's right... Sakuya's going to give us a boost. Wager it all on this one blow, Aleist.”

Sticking up his thumb, Rudel directed Aleist a smile. In the gaps between her fingers, Aleist hung his head, letting out a dry laugh.

“Aha, ahahahah... goddammit! Let's do this shit!”

The two of them had made their resolve just as the magic bolt from the ground faded out.

Askewell and the dark dragon released from it were covered in wounds, their regeneration wouldn't make it in time.

“Sakuya... chuck us.”

‘Yeah!’

Rudel flowed magic into his sword and shield. He poured in the techniques he had forged to that point. As he imbued his armaments with magic, the light waved and flickered like a flame. A wind blew around him, swaying the flames even more.

Aleist similarly flooded his two swords with magic.

His inexhaustible mana was long gone. What he had was what he had cultivated himself, Aleist's own mana. That which Aleist could shape however he liked coursed through his two swords like black lightning.

With their preparations in order, Sakuya swung both her arms at once, throwing them towards the dark dragon.

The dragon roared, Askewell emitted mana from all over his body.

While they readied themselves to intercept, Rudel made for the dragon, Aleist to Askewell, both on a complete offensive.

“This is—”

“— The end!!”

The dragon’s roar shifted into a breath aimed at Rudel, yet from right within its stream, Rudel blocked the damage with his shield as he pressed on. He extended the blade of the sword in his right hand, and cut at the dragon.

‘If only, if only you didn’t exist!!’

Askewell put every ounce of his being into facing Aleist. Sparks flew as his spear met with Aleist’s crossed swords.

“This world went mad because of you... it’s you, it’s all your fault!”

Hearing Askewell’s words now, Aleist no longer had any hesitation.

“I do feel guilty. But, even so... I want to press onwards with my friends! I decided we’re all moving forward together!”

As Askewell heard Aleist’s words, his power softened. Aleist’s swords tore threw his spear and then him.

As the two of them were thrown into the air, Rudel used his air movement to collect Aleist. Returning his sword to his sheath, he directed his right hand at Askewell and the dragon.

Aleist looked over the scene in awe.

“So many dragons...”

Enclosing the dark dragon and Askewell, the dragoons and dragons were stationed, their mouths at the ready to fire their breath.

Sakuya was also at the ready, and with Rudel clenching his open palm as the signal, each and every dragon opened fire at once.

“Not even ash will remain. Rest in peace.”

With Rudel’s whisper, the dragon and Askewell disappeared into the light.

Only Askewell’s severed torso fell towards the ground.

While they wanted to chase after it, both Rudel and Aleist were close to their limit. In the midst of their fall, Sakuya gently caught them, the gold armor and black arms having faded away.

‘Rudel, it’s getting quiet down there.’

‘... So we really did it. The fatigue’s kicking in.’

Rudel said and closed his eyes in Sakuya’s hand.



Askewell lay battered on the ground. What had regenerated of his body was mere human flesh.

Opening his eyes, he saw Mies and his subordinates nearby.

“Askewell-sama! I-I’ll get a doctor at once. So get a grip—”

But while his surface wounds had closed, he couldn’t say the same for underneath. Askewell could sense his own death wasn’t far off.

This had to be the compensation for borrowing that black existence’s power and overexerting himself.

(I see, so this is where I go.)

Askewell grasped Mies' arm. To Mies' surprise, he squeezed out a faint voice.

"Mies... t-the responsibility for this war... is mine."

"Please don't talk, Askewell-sama!"

Spitting up blood, Askewell continued on.

"I-I have to. Someone has to take responsibility. Otherwise... even more chaos..."

Askewell knew of the empire's exhaustion. He knew they needed an existence to smash their discontentment into. It would soften their hatred, if only slightly. And he thought over what he was capable as he was now.

"Y-you just have to take me to the empire. This life will finally find its meaning on the gallows... so... so, take me to the empire. There, before its people..."

As he went on coughing blood, Mies wept.

"Let's run, Askewell-sama. If it's just a few of us, we'll be able to keep low."

"We can't! That won't work, Mies... I'm begging you. Please."

Breaking into tears, Askewell wished for an end executed by the empire. As the criminal who impoverished and brought ruin to the country, he would become the existence for them to alleviate their hatred.

(I see, so I ran away... this all happened because I gave up on my dreams and ran here.)

Askewell spoke.

"Mies, there are rooms full of research material at my manner. They're all on agriculture: nothing but failures, but I'd be happy if you made some use

out of them. I won't say it's for the empire's sake anymore. The empire will eventually fall apart. But for the future... please."

Mies gripped Askewell's hand, and shedding tears, she nodded. With a warm smile at her, he gave the order for his own capture and a retreat back to the empire.



Izumi looked at the retreating imperial army.

Courtois was too exhausted to give pursuit.

Chlust looked up at the sky.

"My brother's coming back. You should go to him."

"you have my gratitude!"

Of the dragons descending to the ground with teetering feet, Izumi picked out the single white dragon among them.

Sakuya slowly descended, gently placing Rudel and Aleist on the ground. As soon as she saw him, Izumi jumped right at him.

Similarly, Aleist's harem members crowded around Aleist. It looked as if Aleist was going to be crushed.

Perhaps he could no longer speak, as Aleist could only entrust his body to the female members.

Izumi embraced Rudel.

"... You keep pushing yourself. You're wounded again."

As Izumi said that, Rudel opened his eyes ever-so-slightly and smiled.

"My bad. But I feel somewhat pleasant."

“... Rudel?”

Upon seeing a smiling Rudel, Izumi grew worried.

“You finally overcame it.”

Her voice was shaking.

“Yeah, so I have to work hard from here on.”

Rudel reached his hand towards Izumi’s face.

“You know... I’ve been thinking.”

“About what?”

“My achievements this time... I think I’d like you as a reward. If Chlust can do a good job with the Arses House, I think I’ll confess my feelings to you.”

Rudel’s hand brushed up against her face. She gripped it.

“Yeah, and I’ll accept them. I’ll always accept them, so...”

Rudel smiled.

“That’s great. Then I have to think of the right words to propose... I’ll consult with Eunius or Luecke... do you think Aleist will do?”

Rudel’s voice turned just a bit dubious. Izumi spoke in jest.

“I don’t know about those three. Rudel, how about you think something up? I won’t be surprised no matter how off-beat it is. So...”

As Izumi shed tears, Rudel wiped one away with his fingers.

“I’ll get thinking... don’t get mad if I fail.”

Rudel closed his eyes.

“I won’t be mad! So... so stay with me!”

Rudel took just one deep breath.

“Yeah, now that the relief’s set in...”

Rudel’s hand slipped out of Izumi’s and fell to the ground. Izumi bawled out her voice as around, starting with Bennet, a great many individuals surrounded Rudel.

Every closed their eyes to offer a silent prayer.

Chapter 165: You're There, and I'm Here

Aleist had lost consciousness at some point.

In a deep sensation as if his body wasn't his own, he heard a voice. A voice he knew, it was the voice of the existence who sent him to the world he was not.

Thinking back on it, he was extremely embarrassed by how he was back then.

‘Did you have fun in the world you wished for?’

Were those words cynicism, or honest curiosity?

Aleist couldn't tell, but he spoke honest as could be.

“It was fun, no I mean, it is and will be fun. They accepted me even as I am after all. Back then... for sending me to this world, truly, thank you.”

When he reincarnated, Aleist wished for status, for power, for everything. Yet when he was supposed to have obtained it all, he hadn't obtained a thing.

“I made friends. I never thought I'd be friends with the side character Rudel. When he was just supposed to be a stepping stone support role, he longed to ride dragons, grew earnest, put his all into each and every day... he was a really radiant existence. I'm the one who ended up the stepping stone side character.”

It was as if their roles were reversed. But the moment he accepted that, Aleist felt he had matured quite a bit.

“I never mastered the cheat you gave me, and yet I went and traded it off... sorry about that.”

The voice sounded somewhat amused.

It must have been considerably pleased with Aleist's answer.

‘It's a power I gave you. Use it however you want. However, I never thought you'd let go of it at the end. You surpassed my expectations, and so too did he. It all stemmed from but a single incident. That unplanned action rewrote everything.’

Action? As Aleist grew curious, the voice spoke.

‘A boy pleaded to his parents to see a dragon on his birthday. His parents heard his wish, and a single dragon that was never to take flight soared through the sky... the one who witnessed it was Rudel.’

A surprise indeed.

“Ahahah, then I'd very much like to thank that boy. Otherwise, who knows where I'd be around now.”

The voice spoke gently.

‘Did your real wish come true?’

Aleist spoke strongly and clearly.

“It has.”

There, the voice told of a world to come.

‘The world was nothing more than a reproduction of a game. I can't guarantee what happens after the game's been cleared. You'll have to

manage. No visible fate, no existences to get in your way. Whether things get better or worse is all up to you.'

Aleist was hard-pressed for words. There was something he had to ask no matter what.

"Umm, did this world distort because of me?"

The voice plainly informed him.

'That's right. But if it weren't for you, this world wouldn't even have existed. I'll leave the rest to you and your friends. This is the most fun I've had in a while.'

After it had said that, the voice really did fade into the distance. Aleist could clearly tell. And at the end.

"... Thank you."

He gave his thanks.



Aleist opened his eyes. He was in a place he recognized all too well, a sickroom he often used in his years as a student.

"... Huh?"

When he looked around, the usual suspects lay on the other beds, their bodies wrapped in bandages. Rudel alone, a red mark on his face... he had the traces of a slap.

Aleist was distraught.

(D-don't tell me I went back in time!? I mean, this is the academy, and there's Izumi-san next to Rudel, and... h-huh!?)

While Aleist wondered if he had been turned into a time traveler this time, Luecke explained from the bed beside him.

“What are you so surprised about? There were so many injured parties, that we were carted around and pushed into any available facility. Good grief, I never thought I’d be in this room’s care after graduation.”

Eunius meanwhile yawned.

“Let’s just take it easy. Rudel’s little brother can take care of cleaning up. Rather, that Clust kid’s got talent. Rallying together such numbers, and even leading them to victory.”

Chlust’s evaluation was on the rise. Aleist looked at Izumi bashfully peeling fruit.

Rudel hung his head in shame.

“Hey, what happened?”

Luecke looked at Rudel and Izumi. Touching a finger to his forehead, he breathed a sigh.

“That Rudel, it seems he barely got any sleep before the battle. So after it was over... he said something misleading, and fell asleep in the most misleading way.”

Rudel had fought alone, day after day through the waves of marching imperials. The effects of his sleep deprivation had him out cold the moment he loosened up.

That ha invited in misunderstandings galore, and apparently Izumi had tears in her eyes as she slapped him. Of course, only after he was healed and had opened his eyes.

Eunius laughed.

“I hear everyone gathered around and gave him a moment of silence. At the center of it, ‘He’s just sleeping, okay!’ Izumi was screaming with her face all red.”

Luecke spat out his words.

“Good grief, what a troublesome guy.”

Aleist looked at Rudel. Rudel was apologizing to Izumi.

“Izumi, please hear me out. Even I have my limits.”

With her face bright red, Izumi shoved a fruit slice into Rudel’s mouth. After chewing and swallowing, Rudel went on.

“I’m sorry. I apologize.”

But perhaps that wasn’t enough, as she shoved another fruit into his mouth. Upon seeing that,

“Maybe I should get a girlfriend,”

Eunius said. Luecke sighed.

“Not you too. Good grief, when I’m still suffering from my failed confession.”

Aleist was somewhat surprised. He thought things were going well enough with Lena.

“Really? She turned you down?”

Eunius immediately yelled at Aleist.

“You fool, don’t touch that one!”

Luecke grinned as he began detailing the circumstance.

“Well now, the truth is, after that, I went over to Lena to confess. I carefully chose out all my words and was going to convey my feelings... but before that, ‘Luecke-san, I like you,’ she told me. My proposal was a complete failure.”

Eunius made a reluctant face at Aleist.

“Aaah, this is going to drag on. Aleist, you take responsibility and listen. He goes on for about two hours. And wait, I can only imagine he’s lying when he says he was confessed to instead, dammit.”

Luecke turned Eunius a smile.

“Hey now, Lena just guessed what was going on when I was trying to set a mood and squeeze out my voice. It was definitely my failing, but it’s true she confessed to me. Don’t be jealous.”

Aleist thought.

(... What is it, this hazy feeling. When Millia is still avoiding me...)

It was at that moment Millia dropped by the sickroom.

“Is everyone doing well? Oh, Aleist you’re up. That’s good.”

Millia looked at Aleist with a smile. With that alone, Aleist found happiness.

(Aah, Millia really is my goddess.)

His heart momentarily ruled by envy cleared to blue skies. Meanwhile, with fruit shoved in his mouth one after the net, Rudel was nearing his limit.

“If you’re well, you’re up for a meeting.”

“Meeting?”

On Millia’s beckoning, wearing a tiara and a garb more extravagant than usual, Fina entered the room.

Aleist’s honest impression,

(Oh right, she was a princess or something.)

His impression of her as a junior at the academy was too strong, he was prone to forgetting. It was also a problem that Aleist himself was so

bothered by other things he didn't pay much attention to Fina.

Rudel's eyes sparkled as he looked at Fina. Surely this would end Izumi's wrath, even temporarily.

Fina grasped the hem of her skirt, deeply lowering her head.

"As a representative of Courtois, I would like to express our thanks for everyone's work on this occasion."

Hearing that, Luecke's and Eunius' faces turned serious. Rudel was the same. Aleist alone didn't notice.

With Fina before him, Rudel climbed off the bed onto his knees. Both Luecke and Eunius followed Suit, and Aleist barely managed to copy.

But Fina stopped them with a hand.

"We are not in an official space."

Rudel spoke as representative.

"Would it be in order to address you as Her Majesty, the Queen?"

Fina shook her head to the side.

"That is still a work in process. In that regard, my master... pardon. Rudel-dono, I have a request to make of you."

Rudel lowered his head.

"Yes, say the word."

Aleist thought.

(I see, if she's representing the country, that means the second princess is becoming queen? That's different from the game... no, this is already a different world.)

Fina spread out her hand.

“I alone am insufficient to reconstruct our dear country. Won’t you shoulder that weight with me? Courtois had prepared a seat on the throne for Rudel Arses.”

Aleist honestly rejoiced at Rudel becoming King, but it was there he noticed.

(Huh? Wait a second. If you say that to Rudel...)

Rudel raised his face and smiled.

“I refused. I am but a lowly dragoon. As a single knight, I swear to my heart I shall continue to support ‘Her Majesty the Queen’. There are those far more worthy than I.”

Saying that, Rudel sent a look around. Before anyone could move, Eunius stood and declared.

“I, Eunius Diade! Swear it on my sword to cut down the enemies of her majesty!”

And Luecke stood as well.

Aleist thought.

(Crap! I’m too late!!)

“I, Luecke Halbades devote an oath of loyalty to her royal highness.”

A rattling sound from the doorway, King Albach made his appearance in a wheelchair. The one pushing the char was Sophina.

“W-wait. Boys, wait a second. Then what is it? ... You’ll decline the position of King!?”

Fina had frozen in place expressionless.

Rudel, Eunius and Luecke were all looking at Aleist.

“... Aleist, I believe in you.”

“Aleist, I ain’t gonna complain if you rise to power.”

“Yeah, you have my full support.”

The three of them shoved the throne on him with wonderful smiles.

Aleist shouted.

“Wait a second! I mean, it’s King, right!? Wouldn’t you want that, normally!?”

Rudel averted his eyes as he spoke.

“O-of course. But I’m not worthy... and so, fare thee well!”

Suddenly sprinting off, Rudel hoisted Izumi over his shoulder and jumped out the window. With Sakuya retrieving him outside, he achieved a perfect escape.

Eunius shouted.

“The bastard got away! Umm, as my first duty to her majesty, I shall chase him down!”

Luecke also jumped aboard the ship.

“And I as well. Good grief, what is that man thinking?”

When the two of them were gone, a dubious air enveloped the sickroom. Albach silently gazed at Aleist.

Aleist looked at Millia. But she turned away his gaze.

Fina sat on the spot, expressionlessly muttering...

“Master, you idiot. I laid all the groundwork, but it’s because sister stirred everything up that it wasn’t perfect yet... now that it’s come to this, I’ll make it an established truth whether you like it or not... no, perhaps I can even fabricate I t. I mean, I’m queen. I am the law.”

Aleist looked at her and thought.

“Huh? What!? Is it just me, or is this kid saying some scary things!?”

Alback opened his mouth.

“Aleist-kun... you won’t run, right?”

Aleist stood, he took a step back.

(No way. With kingship and such, isn’t that normally a position you’d even spill blood to reach!? Why did they all run!?)

With a bitter smile, Aleist slowly retreated further. The door forcefully burst open with the entrance of his harem members.

“Aleist-sama!?”

Faaaaai!

To his surprise, the group had clearly grown in numbers since he last saw them.

“Aleist-sama, we’ve come to a conclusion!”

“D-did you now?”

(I see, so they’ve finally lost interest in me—)

We don’t mind if we’re not your number one. So please, keep us by your side! We came to understand as we watched you fight for the country under that hopeless situation. That you are a hero!

“D-did you now!? ... huh?”

By the time he noticed it, everyone told him they didn't have to be number one. Millia burst into laughter.

“Aleist, you sure are loved.”

But Aleist,

“Now wait! I'll be very upfront here, I can't love you all equally, and there's someone I'm in love with—”

“Even so!”

His harem members' faces were serious.

(I-inconceivable. Don't have to be loved? Don't have to be number one...? That's just wrong, that's just crazy!)

Aleist jumped out of the window in a half-laughing frenzy.

“I'm sorry, it's impossible for me!”

Was it impossible to marry Fina, or impossible to accept his harem... he couldn't accept either.

Chapter 166: Chapter

Having fled the sickroom with Izumi, Rudel looked over the sky from Sakuya's back.

Her four wings drawing grand arcs, Sakuya soared through the wide-open sky. A dragon's body was protected by magic, letting a human endure even at high altitudes.

Izumi sat on Sakuya's back, her back turned towards Rudel.

Rudel sat with his back pressed against hers.

"Izumi, cheer up already."

There, Izumi raised a bashful, embarrassed voice.

"You said you'd think of the words to confess. I haven't heard those words yet!"

Hearing that, Rudel was surprised at first, but then he laughed. He laughed, and drove Sakuya to plunge into a cloud.

"Whoa!"

Once they breached the clouds, Izumi felt a slight chill over her body. A layer of dampness rested on her skin and hair.

Sakuya led the two further and further into the sky, below them a carpet of clouds unfolding.

Rudel lifted Izumi up and held her tight.

“I like you, I’ve fallen in love with you! But I don’t know if I can make you happy. For just as much as I love you... more than that, I’m in love with this sky.”

Boldly, Rudel divulged his true feelings. Izumi nodded.

“I know. It was always your dream to fly on a dragon’s back. I’ve heard that time and again.”

But in five years at the academy—Izumi who’d spend those days with him had come to sympathize with Rudel’s feelings.

“If you said I was number one, I’d be doubtful.”

Rudel spoke.

“How cruel. But still, I want you. I fought with my life on the line. No one will mind if there’s just one thing I have freedom over.”

There was no telling what was to come. Courtois was in great turmoil, and it was possible that Fina would be enthroned as queen.

Disposing of the nobles who raise an insurrection, and as this was the first the empire had ever cornered them so far, military reforms would be needed as well.

No, first and foremost, the country of Courtois itself needed reform.

“Just one, eh. Do what you want. I’ll just follow along.”

As Izumi hugged Rudel back, Sakuya gave a bashful roar. It was as if she was congratulating them, and she sounded exceptionally happy.

And just like that, the dragon swooped down, piercing through the sheet of clouds.



After escaping from the sickroom, Aleist met up with Eunius and Luecke.

Before long, they were drowning their cares at the tavern.

“I can’t do it! That many women is impossible, I tell you!”

He said with a sip, his form prostrate over the table unthinkable of the black knight

“I told them to give up on me. Somehow that increased their numbers. And then comes the throne! It’s inconceivable!”

He proclaimed he would throw everything away, and lost all the cheats he had been blessed with. He lost his unnatural level of charm, he no longer had the talent or mana he had before.

But there were more women around Aleist than ever before.

Eunius and Luecke pat his shoulder to console him.

“Hey, do your best. We’ll do our best to not cause you trouble. Rather, I kinda think it’s not your fault this time. So have at it, your highness.”

“Good for you. If you attain kingship, then no matter who gets thrown into your harem. Queen Fina’s at the top. You’ll never have to worry about ranking.”

Aleist raised his face.

“Don’t give up! You’re all for forcing it on me, aren’t you!”

Eunius scoffed.

“Hah! No shit Sherlock. Who in their right mind would willingly take power in this pain-in-the-ass postwar period? What’s more, we’re definitely entering a pain-in-the-ass era after that.”

The Kingdom of Courtois was trying to change. No, it had no choice but to change. At the same time, what would become of their enemy, the empire... there was a mountain of problems.

The work required would be incomparable to peace times. Both future archdukes fully understood that when they fled from the throne.

But Luecke breathed a sigh.

“From my point of view, Rudel was better off King. Considering my marriage with Lena, that would let me welcome her as the legal wife instead of a mistress... hah.”

While he sighed, his reasons were solely for self-interest. Aleist clung in tears to the man who wouldn't even bring up the country's distress as a formality.

“Didn't you used to go on about nobility or something!? Then save me. Fulfill your duty as a noble and save me!”

Luecke removed Aleist's hand and smoothed out his clothes. Albeit, he was dressed in an infirmary gown.

“You fool. You're just as much a noble yourself. Do something about it on your own... wait, I've got it!”

Aleist and Eunius glanced at Luecke.

But the idea that hit him—

“I can just take her as a mistress, and marry a legal wife. In that instance, for all intents and purposes, wouldn't the mistress be the legal wife!?”

— Was about Lena.

Aleist removed his eyes, Eunius sipped his ale. In a “this guy's hopeless” sort of air, the two opted to just ignore the man.

(So it's true how they say there's a paper-thin line between idiot and genius.)

Eunius poured some ale into Aleist's glass.

“Well, you know. Break a leg.”

After downing the freshly-poured liquid, Aleist spoke.

“This is messed up!”



“Those bloody fools, I’m never gonna forgive them!”

Briskly proceeding her preparations, Rina had put her all into laying the groundwork so she could be enthroned as queen. She was needlessly proficient, and in abilities alone, Fina was the one worthy of the position.

However, the problem lay within.

She had already prepared the papers and was arranging to distribute them to the relevant divisions.

“Just you watch. When I’m queen, I’m dismantling those pesky dragoons of yours! Fwahahahah, I can see my master, crying, begging for forgiveness!”

Looking at Fina were Sophina and Mii.

Seeing her expressionlessly accomplished one job after the next, all while swearing vengeance, they were somewhat creeped out.

Mii spoke.

“Princess, I mean your majesty, don’t you think that’s a bit much.”

Fina looked at her.

“Oh, what’s wrong? It’s alright, Mii... if he cries and grovels, he can have my forgiveness.”

Sophina sounded fed-up.

“No, that’s the same as saying you won’t forgive otherwise. Rather, to be serious for a second...”

Seriously speaking, with the Diade and Halbades Houses assisting her during the time of Aileen’s insurrection, whether she wanted to carry out reform or anything else, she was unable to slight either house.

Moreover, she didn’t hold enough power to do so.

“Goddammit! It’s because these archdukes exist that Courtois’ national power was shaved away! Quit screwing with me, bring out the manager! In this scenario, should we be centralizing power!? You think the empire’s going to wait!?”

Mii tilted her head.

“Umm, but I heard the empire was considerably exhausted in this loss.”

At Mii’s inquisitive gesture, Fina loosed a satisfied drool in her head. And she began speaking in regards to that.

“For now, that is. But just you wait, give them a decade, a century. Their national power will plummet, the way they’re going, either civil war or separation, the empire’s going to change. You think they’re guaranteed to change for the worse? I hate that sort of wishful thinking.”

Sophina spoke to Fina.

“In that case, shouldn’t we launch something from our side—”

“You fool!”

Fina hit her on the forehead. The high knight’s eyes turned teary.

“We don’t have hands to send around as it is! The country’s in tatters, and there’s absolutely no merit in stealing the barren wastelands of the empire! What I’m trying to say is that their side is the one with all the pieces in place for proper reform!”

How much time and energy did they have to deal with the movements of surrounding powers while proceeding reform in the country? The larger the country was, the greater hassle it was to govern its landmass.

With this as an opportunity, there may be lords scheming to gain independence.

“Even if we get rid of as many of those who sided with sister’s rebellion as possible, and increase the kingdom’s national power... AAaaah!! My head hurts!”

Fina’s desire to marry Rudel wasn’t just only of self-interest.

Forming a composition with the nation’s strongest force- Rudel- by her side would be a nightmare to the others.

With Ruel’s strength backing her, it was her aim to force her reforms through.

“... But I, Fina Courtois! I shall be one to stand tall through such times of troubles! I’ll get master on his knees!”

Seeing her return to work with those words, Mii and Fina shook their heads.

At the end, Mii,

“On the contrary, why is it I get the feeling her majesty’s the one who’s going to be groveling to Rudel-san...”

She said, but Fina didn’t hear.



A few years later.

Rudel stood on the soil Askewell had once invaded and brought to ruin.

By the current Queen Fina’s new policies, a majority of nobles were to relinquish their land to the state, instead living in the center off an annual

pay from the kingdom.

A portion of those who opposed were ordered to change territories to the border, and Rudel was there on a mission as a dispatch from the capital.

The renewed fortress had ten dragoon knights stationed.

The empire had fallen into civil war, its division giving rise to the birth and fall of many new countries, and in the midst of that struggle, there were many who marched to claim Courtois' land.

At times, there would be strife with nobles in his own country plotting rebellion against Fina, giving him no shortage of work.

While his life had grown hectic, Rudel was busy in the dragon stables washing Sakuya's back with a deck brush, humming a merry tune. Sakuya looked quite comfortable.

His subordinate, a new dragoon called over to him.

"More letters, Castellan. From her majesty, the capital's black knight, and the Diade House and Halbades House... that's an amazing assortment."

Castellan was Rudel's station. While fulfilling the role of a dragoon, he was concurrently the one in charge of the fort.

After jumping down from Sakuya, Rudel accepted the letters and unsealed them on the spot.

"I don't really care about Fina's. Eunius wants to go drinking, Luecke... oh, his first child! So Lena's a mother now. But does he really plan on not having a legal wife?"

The letter from the queen was a lengthy apology and a plea urging him to return to the center. Rudel personally preferred the border to the center, the letter hit all the usual points, so he immediately read through it and quickly lost interest.

Eunius was an invite to the town, while Luecke reported in great joy how a child had been born.

“Now then, Aleist is... I-I see.”

According to Aleist’s letter, for some reason, his harem members increased and breached thirty. With so many children, he had no idea what to do at this point, or so his screams of anguish were spelled out in paper.

As to be expected, Rudel had no idea what to right back.

“He has it rough. I guess I’ll consult with Izumi and write up a reply.”

Rudel’s subordinate looked at him with a sigh.

“Castellan, if you return to the capital, you’ll be assigned a considerable status. Are you sure you won’t go back? I don’t see anything stopping you.”

While Rudel was in charge of the fort, he would have preferred it if he could assume his duties as a single knight. He even thought he had too many unnecessary duties.

Normally, anyone would want a promotion and a station at the center. But Rudel couldn’t discern any value in that. He had gone as far as to push the status of Arses House head onto his younger brother Chlust he held far too little interest in status or promotion.

“I’m not interested. If you can fly through the sky, everywhere’s pretty much the same. As long as I’ve got Sakuya and my wife, it doesn’t matter where I am.”

Hearing those words, Sakuya delightfully groaned.

His subordinate shrugged his shoulders.

“Bragging? I just think it’s a waste. You should be aiming higher.”

Rudel smiled. From his subordinate’s point of view, life on the border was something he wanted to be done with soon so he could get back to

civilization. Rudel had no intent to deny that way of thinking.

Going off of that, the man asked with deep intrigue.

“Come to think of it, there’s a rumor going ‘round that you refused not only your Archduke position but the throne as well, but is that true?”

Leaning the deck brush over his shoulder, Rudel made back towards Sakuya.

“Who knows? I’m not really interested in that sort of thing. For now and forever, I am but—”

Turning back, Rudel smiled.

“A single dragoon.”

Chapter 167: Epilogue

Several hundred years passed from the time Rudel was in service.

The Kingdom of Courtois left only its name as kings and nobles faded out, the curtain quietly closing on an era.

The forms of the dragoons who once served the country now gone, the view of airships crossing the sky had become standard. With the skies above no longer a land beyond reach, mankind eventually stopped keeping their dragons. The development of technology soon gave rise to propeller planes.

Knight brigades were abolished. Uniform armies became standard, and the know-how to utilize a dragon was lost to time. The dragoons were quick to go. With their high upkeep and the capricious temperament of their mounts, they had become more than they were worth.

Airships, airplanes... once those were in hand, dragons had become unnecessary.

Yet the supreme rulers of the sky still remained, as they had always been, the beasts of legend.



It was only in the past few decades that the vast lands of the dragons' dwellings became a land of dispute among the humans

In a sacred place with a lake, Sakuya watched the small dragons similar to her in appearance playing around her.

Her wings had naturally increased to six, and her large body had grown a size larger. Both the splendid gemstone in her head and her horns had

grown, the young spirit she had held in her days with Rudel nowhere to be found.

Sakuya lifted up her head to look at the sky.

She let out a short and loud roar. With that alone, the Dragons' dwellings gradually grew boisterous as dragons took to the air one after the next.

Sakuya too spread her wings to rise up and face her rude uninvited guests from the country once called the Gaia Empire.

From over thirty airships, the fighter planes took off in orderly succession.

A vast, fertile plot of land, what's more, the Dragons' Dwellings were abundant in natural resources. To humans, dragons were no longer comrades in arms, they had already gotten to recognize them as enemies.

Sakuya looked upon the scene and muttered.

'Have they forgotten what became of the last Courtois Army that tried to invade?'

Wind dragons zoomed between the fighter planes, luring them into a dogfight. One by one, the crafts were shot down to the ground.

The red dragons breathed their fiery breath, sinking the airships behind them. Protruding cannons from their hulls, the airships commenced a bombardment on Sakuya.

The cannon shells failed to scratch her.

Sakuya opened her large mouth, and as her breath was released, it dispersed through the air. The shots assailed airship and airplane alike, bringing them to the ground.

While there were enemies who tried to flee, they were quickly circumvented and crushed.

Similar to Sakuya, a white dragon with four wings approached her.

‘Mama, it’s over. All that’s left is the clean-up.’

Sakuya kept her eyes on the falling crafts as, after a large flap propelling herself up a distance, she took off somewhere.

Perhaps curious, Sakuya’s child tagged along.



It was where the capital of the Courtois Kingdom once stood.

Now ruined and abandoned, not a trace of its former glory remained.

Having brought her feet there, Sakuya mimicked a human form as she descended, her child copying her and changing shape as well.

The form Sakuya took on was as if the once-goddess Sakuya had grown into an adult. Her child boasted the same blue eyes and blond hair- cut short. A blue gemstone embedded in his forehead.

But unlike Sakuya, his hands remained disproportionately large, and it seemed he wasn’t yet completely accustomed to taking human form.

“Mama, why did you come here? There haven’t been any humans here for quite some time.”

“You’re right,” Sakuya muttered, as she walked through the royal capital buried in rubble and sand.

The reason the capital fell. It all lay in the limits of the Kingdom. The kingdom had welcomed in a golden age under Fina Courtois- the great leader who was said to have rejuvenated the dynasty- alongside her prime minister Luecke Halbades.

But from then on came a slow, gradual decline.

They had their share of wise rulers, but in the end, they launched a war on the dragons, and the capital was destroyed by the force led by Sakuya.

Indeed, the one who burnt it down was Sakuya herself.

As she walked through such a place, from all over, the goblins and orcs showed their faces. They seemed to think of Sakuya in her human form as mere food as they approached.

Those goblins and orcs were cleaved through by a single swing of her child's arm.

“Who do you think you raise your blades against, you lowly curs!?”

Sakuya stopped him from chasing and hunting down the ones who fled.

(... I've gotten more children who think of dragons as the strongest race on earth, looking down on the others.)

In their battles with humans, a greater number of dragons were beginning to think of themselves as the true rulers of the land. It was becoming a large worry for Sakuya.

Leading her child by the hand, Sakuya headed towards it.

What was once the very center of the city. In a now-broken fountain, with Fina at the center, then Rudel, Aleist, Luecke and Eunius, the statues of those who had contributed to Courtois' heyday.

Sakuya brushed off the dust and sand, cleaning off only that spot to look at the statue of Rudel. It was dubious to say it resembled him to a great degree, but as long as people considered a representation of him, she couldn't treat it poorly.

“... Rudel, I can barely remember your face anymore.”

Her memories from her youth gradually faded away.

The time she had spent with Rudel and Izumi, to Sakuya, it was no more than an instant. In the times that followed, after the two had gone, a little while later, Mystith and all the dragons who looked after her were gone as well.

Before she knew it, Sakuya was the one leading the dragons, and their relations with humans were breaking down.

It was all far too painful for her.

The child gazed at Sakuya before looking at the statue,

“I can’t believe you ever let some human ride your back. That’s crazy.”

Sakuya hid her face with her right hand, turning to the child.

“You’ve never ridden a human on your back before. No, you’ve never ridden a knight. When dragon and human hearts connect, they become a dragoon. It was once only normal.”

The child’s cheeks puffed up.

“Humans are incompetents with nothing but numbers. If it were up to us, we’d have burnt them all down.”

Sakuya took the words with sorrow; she felt the reality of how wide the gap with humans must have grown for the dragons to develop that mindset.

There, the sky suddenly grew rowdy.

An ominous dark shadow overhead—impossible to make out whether they were living or dead, they had grown in numbers lately, those things that weren’t monsters, and one of them was being chased by a fighter plane.

The child shrugged his shoulders.

“One of those bugs that’ve been multiplying lately? Now that’s a good match for those pesky humans.”

That ominous something with the form of an arthropod was finally cornered and shot to death by the craft. But the plane was also shot and burst into flames.

“It’s going down.”

While the fighter plane continued on a downward trajectory somewhere, the pilot jumped from the cockpit with a parachute strapped on.

Oddly enough, right towards where Sakuya was.

As the pilot landed, the parachute draped over him, and as he squirmed his way out of it, he held a pistol in his hand.

The moment before her child swung his arm, Sakuya saw the pilot's face and lowered a fist on her child's head. She lowered it with enough power a vivid clang rung out.

"Mama, that hurt!"

"... I'm sorry. But wait."

If she used only words, then surely the human before her eyes would be dead. The pilot seemed quite bewildered before Sakuya and the child.

He pulled off the helmet covering his head, removed his goggles and spoke. With distinctive silver hair and blue eyes, the pilot kept his pistol at the ready.

"Civilians? You're in quite an odd place for that."

The young man said, looking at the child's large arms and observing the two of them. From a human's eyes, there was no possible way Sakuya would be able to come here as lightly equipped as she was.

But with the young man before her, Sakuya burst into tears.

"A human life is short. But..."

The young man approached, his gun trained on Sakuya. While the child intimidated him, Sakuya held up a hand to put it to a stop.

"Rudel."

Touching a hand to the young man's cheek, Sakuya muttered a name. The man seemed quite flustered, he jumped back to take distance.

“You're not human. A form of monster? Or a new type of bug? Where did you learn my name?”

Hearing it wasn't just his face but his name as well, Sakuya gave a small smile. She changed to her dragon form on the spot.

Upon seeing that massive dragon, Rudel's eyes opened in surprise. However, he didn't show any fear.

He looked on with pure intrigue.

“A dragon!? Moreover, the lord of the Dragon Den!”

Sakuya rested Rudel on her hand and raised him into the sky.

‘I'll deliver you somewhere close to where humans live. I once rode a fine human on this back. This is the least I could do to return the favor.’

From the palm of her hand, Rudel looked up at Sakuya.

“A dragoon!? I never thought they actually existed... how interesting, then let me ride on your back too.”

How brazen could he be? The child returned to dragon form, flying to Sakuya's side as he complained at Rudel.

‘Don't get in over your head, human! Who do you think you're talking to!? Do you think mama would let a dirty lowlife like you rest on her back!?’

But Sakuya exchanged words with the man.

‘You know of the dragoons, you know of the world, yet still, you wish to ride on my back?’

Rudel struck his right hand to his chest.

“Of course. You’re far stronger than a fighter plane. If I ride you, I can annihilate those blasted bugs!”

Even now, her child was poised to attack at any minute. His fangs bared, his eyes wide open, he would kill the man at the slightest opportunity.

Rudel went on.

“And the small stuff doesn’t really matter. I just want to ride on your back!”

Sakuya laughed.

A human life is short. But they go in cycles... Those were the words of Mystith, who had once lost Marty to gain a new partner in Lena.

Finally understanding what she meant, Sakuya brought her hand to her back and set Rudel onto it.

‘Very well. Then ride me you will... new-age dragoon.’

‘Mama!’ the child cried out.

Once Rudel was on her back, he spread his arms wide and smiled.

“Yes! I feel right at home. Like this, I’ll be able to annihilate any bug that comes my way!”

And so the first dragoon in several hundred years would forge a new legend—but that is another story.